
A PERSONAL MASTER COURSE FOR ICSE

JULIUS CAESAR

Act 1 — Master Course & Study Book

*Text • Roman history • line-by-line teaching • character masterclasses • themes •
devices • keyword vault • quotation bank • scene connections • ICSE examiner
training*

Prepared for an ICSE Class 10 student · Based on the verified Shakespeare text (Folger / Globe editions) ·
Cross-checked against Plutarch and modern Roman history · Aligned to the CISCE Literature in English paper

Act 1 is the Class IX portion of the syllabus; the Class X board paper (Acts III–V) depends on it at every turn. This book
teaches Act 1 from zero to examination standard.

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FRONT MATTER

How to Use This Book (Read This First)

This chapter is the front door to the whole course. It tells you honestly why Shakespeare has felt hard, why this book still teaches from zero while going deeper than any school guide, and exactly where Act 1 sits in the ICSE syllabus. It explains how every fact in the book was verified and how the four accuracy labels work. It teaches the Five-Level Method with a worked example, gives you a practical primer for reading Shakespearean English, settles the question of names and spellings, and lays out every chapter and a four-week study plan. Read it once slowly now, and come back to the plan and the box guide whenever you lose your bearings.

A Letter Before We Begin

You have been told, probably more than once since Class 9, that Shakespeare is 'beautiful' and 'the greatest writer in English'. That is true, and it has not helped you. What you actually experienced was a page of words you half-recognised, arranged in an order that made no sense, about Romans whose names all seemed to begin with C, followed by an examination that asked you to 'explain with reference to the context'. If that left you feeling that Shakespeare was for other people, I want to say plainly: the problem was never your intelligence. The problem was access.

Three things stand between you and this play, and none of them is a mystery. The first is language: this English is roughly four hundred and twenty-five years old, and it keeps its verbs in unexpected places, drops syllables, and uses words that have since changed meaning. The second is the world: the play assumes you know what a triumph is (the victory parade the Senate granted a conquering general), why Romans hated the word 'king', and who Pompey was. The third, and this is the one nobody says aloud, is that most school notes do not teach at all. They summarise. A summary tells you what happened; it cannot tell you why a line is shaped the way it is, and it is precisely the 'why' that earns marks and, more importantly, makes the play come alive.

So this book does two things at once that ordinary guides treat as opposites. It teaches from zero: every hard word is explained the first time it appears, every historical fact is supplied before you need it, and no chapter assumes you understood the last time somebody taught you this. And it goes genuinely deep: you will learn how Cassius builds a temptation sentence by sentence, why the Cobbler's jokes are political, and how a five-word warning in Scene 2 governs the entire play. Depth is only frightening when the foundations are missing; once they are laid, the deep reading becomes the interesting part.

A word about the play itself. *Julius Caesar* is about things you already understand: a friend who flatters you into something you half want to do; a powerful man who cannot afford to look afraid; a crowd that cheers whoever spoke last; the fear of being ordinary while someone your own age becomes a legend. Shakespeare

wrote it in 1599 for an audience many of whom could not read. If they could follow it by ear, you can follow it with a book in your hands and a professor at your elbow. That is what this course is meant to be: several weeks of one teacher talking to one student, never pretending a hard thing is simple or a simple thing is hard.

The Honest Syllabus Note

ICSE EXAM BOX THE HONEST SYLLABUS NOTE

Let us be exact, because a great deal of exam anxiety comes from vagueness. In the ICSE scheme, Acts I and II of *Julius Caesar* are the Class IX portion, examined in your school's internal papers, usually through reference-to-the-context questions on an extract. The Class X board paper (English Paper 2, Literature in English, 80 marks, two hours plus fifteen minutes of reading time) sets its drama extracts from Acts III, IV and V. So you should not expect a board extract to be taken from Act 1.

Why, then, a whole course on Act 1 for a Class 10 student? Because the board paper depends on Act 1 at every turn, in four concrete ways.

Motives. Every strong answer on Acts III–V explains *why* a character does what he does, and the reasons were planted in Act 1. Why does Brutus join the conspiracy in Act 2 and strike in Act 3? In large part because Cassius worked on him at the feast of the Lupercal (the Lupercalia, a Roman festival held on 15 February), telling him "honour is the subject of my story" and holding up a mirror to his "hidden worthiness"; Brutus's own reasoning in his orchard in Act 2 Scene 1 completes the picture, but the seed is Act 1. Why does Antony's funeral oration (formal public speech) in Act 3 Scene 2 land so hard when he reminds the crowd that he offered Caesar a crown three times and Caesar refused it three times? Because Act 1 Scene 2 showed us that event through Casca's sour report. The 2025 paper asked candidates to 'List the three arguments that Antony uses' to prove Caesar was not ambitious. One of those arguments is the crown refusal. You can list it from memory of Act 3; you can only *explain* it if you know Act 1.

Foreshadowing. The Soothsayer's "Beware the ides of March", the storm, Cassius's closing threat that "we will shake him, or worse days endure", Caesar's judgement that Cassius "thinks too much": these are the seeds. When Caesar says at the Capitol in Act 3 that the ides have come and the Soothsayer replies that they have not yet gone, the moment only means something if you were present for the first warning.

MCQs. Section A of the 2025 paper carried sixteen one-mark multiple-choice questions. One asked who formed the Second Triumvirate; a distractor (a wrong option designed to tempt you) was 'Julius Caesar, Crassus, Pompey', which is the *First* Triumvirate of 60 BC, the alliance whose collapse produced the civil war behind Act 1. Another asked whom the mob kills after Antony's speech, offering 'Cinna the conspirator' and 'Cinna the poet'. The conspirator Cinna is the man who arrives with letters in Act 1 Scene 3. Knowing him is what makes the wrong answer *look* wrong.

'What happened earlier' sub-parts. Extract questions routinely reach backwards. The 2025 paper set Brutus's farewell to Cassius from Act 5 Scene 1 and asked candidates to what Brutus refers when he speaks of 'the work which the ides of March begun', and how 'that work' was begun. A full answer travels straight back to Act 1: the Soothsayer names the day, Cassius plans the forged letters at the end of Scene 2 and recruits Casca in the storm of Scene 3, and the conspiracy that ends in Caesar's death is set in motion. The same paper asked about an omen Cassius had described 'Earlier in this scene', a question that rewards you far more if you remember that in Act 1 Scene 3 this same Cassius bared his chest to the lightning and mocked Casca for fearing it.

Two smaller points complete the honesty. First, Act 1 remains directly examinable in Class IX-style reference-to-the-context questions, and this book trains you for those in its extract chapters. Second, the 20-mark Internal Assessment (two or three assignments, not exceeding 1500 words in total, such as a character analysis or thematic study) can draw on any part of the play, and Act 1 is rich ground for it. Nothing here predicts your paper; nothing here is 'guaranteed'. What is certain is that a student who knows Act 1 properly writes better Act 3–5 answers than one who does not.

CROSS-REFERENCE Where the exam thread is picked up

The chapter titled 'The Scene Connection Engine and Where Act 1 Reappears Later' traces each Act 1 moment forward into Acts III–V. The chapter titled 'ICSE Examiner Mode: How Marks Are Earned' turns that knowledge into answer technique. Read this note now; read those two chapters in Week 4.

How This Book Verifies Its Facts

Study guides for this play are full of confident sentences that are not quite true: a quotation with a word changed, a historical 'fact' that is really Shakespeare's invention, a critic's opinion printed as if it were settled. This book was therefore built on a strict source hierarchy. When two sources disagree, the higher one wins, and the disagreement is reported to you rather than hidden.

First, Shakespeare's text. The words of the play, as printed in the Folger Shakespeare Library edition and cross-checked against two further editions carrying the older British spellings (the Globe text as reproduced by MIT, and the Project Gutenberg text). Every quotation in this book was compared word by word against these texts by an automated checker before it was allowed to stand. Where American and British spellings differ (Folger prints 'honor', the British texts 'honour'), we print the British form. The wording is otherwise Folger's.

Second, the prescribed edition. Many ICSE students work from an edition based on A. W. Verity's Cambridge text with a facing paraphrase. This book does not assume which edition you hold, so it never quotes a paraphrase and never prints line numbers (more on that in the note on names below). The play text is the same across editions; only the apparatus (the editor's notes, glossary and paraphrase) differs.

Third, CISCE material. The 2025 board paper (its structure, its instructions, its actual questions) and the Council's published information on prescribed books and assessment. Nothing about paper pattern in this book is invented, and nothing is predicted.

Fourth, academic Shakespeare scholarship. Scholarly editions and their notes, the Folger's commentary, and Shakespeare's own source, Sir Thomas North's 1579 English translation of Plutarch's *Lives*. This is where we learn, for instance, that Caesar's deafness in one ear has no basis in the ancient sources and appears to be Shakespeare's addition, while his epilepsy, the "falling sickness", is in Plutarch.

Fifth, Roman history. Plutarch and Suetonius among the ancients, and standard modern reference works for dates, offices and events. Used to tell you what actually happened, and, more interestingly, where Shakespeare changed it.

Sixth and last, study guides. Popular websites and school guides were consulted only to make sure no standard reading had been overlooked. Nothing has been copied from them, and where they flatten a complex moment into a slogan, this book deliberately slows down.

The four labels

Throughout the book you will meet four bold labels. They are not decoration; they are the single most useful habit you can carry into an examination hall, because examiners reward students who know the difference between what the play says and what people say about the play.

SHAKESPEARE'S TEXT marks what the play actually contains. Casca reports that a crown was offered to Caesar three times and refused three times, and that Caesar then "swooned and fell down at it". That is text: it happened in the play, as reported by a character.

HISTORICAL RECORD marks what the ancient sources and modern historians say. Plutarch describes Antony offering a diadem (a royal headband, the Greek sign of kingship) at the Lupercalia of 44 BC and has it refused twice, not three times; the crowd applauded the refusals; the real Lupercalia fell on 15 February, a full month before the Ides. This label tells you where Shakespeare followed history and where he compressed or altered it.

LITERARY INTERPRETATION marks a reading, however widely held. Casca's remark that Caesar "would fain have had it" (*fain* means gladly) is one cynical witness's opinion. Whether Caesar truly wanted the crown is a question the play leaves open, and this book will never let you write 'Caesar wanted the crown' as though it were a fact. Where scholars disagree you will read 'many critics hold', 'one strong reading is', or 'the text leaves this open', and you should write the same way.

EXAM-ORIENTED ADVICE marks guidance about earning marks: how a sub-question is usually structured, what a three-mark answer needs, which quotation to have ready. It is advice drawn from real papers, never a promise about your paper.

Keep these four apart in your notes from the first day.

The Five-Level Method

Every scene, speech and character in this book is taught in the same five layers, always in the same order. The order matters. Students who have struggled with Shakespeare almost always jump to Level 5 (what do I write in the exam?) before Levels 1 to 4 are secure, and the result is an answer built on sand: confident phrases, no understanding underneath. The method forces you to climb.

Here is the whole method applied to one of the shortest famous lines in the play, so you can see how much a single warning holds.

LEVEL 1 — What happened?

During the festival of the Lupercal, Caesar's procession is about to move on when a voice cuts through the crowd calling his name. Caesar stops: "Ha! Who calls?" He cannot see the speaker and asks "Who is it in the press that calls on me?" (*press* means crowd). The Soothsayer (a fortune-teller, one who claims to see the future) says: "Beware the ides of March." Caesar asks who the man is; Brutus repeats the warning; Caesar has the man brought before him and hears it a second time; then he dismisses him: "He is a dreamer. Let us leave him. Pass." The procession moves off. That is everything that occurs. Notice that Level 1 contains no opinion at all.

LEVEL 2 — What does it mean?

The *ides* were a fixed marker day in the Roman calendar; in March they fell on the 15th. To a Roman ear the phrase was as ordinary as 'the fifteenth'. So the Soothsayer is saying, in plain words, 'Be on your guard on 15 March.' Caesar calls him a *dreamer*: someone who sees visions, not realities; a fantasist to be waved away. Notice also what the warning does not say: it names a day but no danger, no person, no place. It is precise about time and blank about everything else. That blankness is why it frightens.

LEVEL 3 — Why did Shakespeare write it this way?

HISTORICAL RECORD: Plutarch and Suetonius record that a seer named Spurinna warned Caesar of danger coming no later than the Ides. **SHAKESPEARE'S TEXT:** the play strips away the name and makes the seer an anonymous voice in a crowd, sounding, as Caesar says, "shriller than all the music". Compare the two and you can see the dramatist at work. An unnamed voice is not a character; it is fate given a mouth. Five words, spoken twice, unanswered by argument, are more unsettling than a paragraph of prophecy. **LITERARY INTERPRETATION:** many readers see Caesar's dismissal as over-confidence, the first flash of the *hubris* (the arrogant over-confidence that, in tragedy, invites a fall) that will kill him. One strong alternative reading is that Caesar, in public, *cannot* be seen to flinch; the man who later says "for always I am Caesar" is performing fearlessness for an audience. The text leaves room for both, and a good answer says so. Notice, finally, who repeats the warning aloud: Brutus. The man who will strike is the man who passes on the message. Whether you call that dramatic irony (the audience knowing what a character does not) or simply cruelty of design, it is deliberate.

LEVEL 4 — How does it connect to the whole play?

The line plants a clock. Act 2 Scene 2 opens at dawn on the Ides itself, after a night of storm, omens and Calpurnia's dream, and Caesar wavers before Decius Brutus talks him into going to the Senate. In Act 3 Scene 1, at the Capitol, Caesar tells the Soothsayer that the ides of March have come, and is told that they have come but are not yet gone; minutes later he is dead. In Act 5 Scene 1 Brutus speaks of the work that the ides of March began, which this very day must end. The whole tragedy is strung between the warning and its fulfilment. There is a deeper connection too. In Act 1 Scene 3 Cassius does not deny the portents (signs of what is to come); he defies the storm, bares his chest to it, and bends its meaning to his own purpose, telling Casca that heaven has made these wonders "instruments of fear and warning / Unto some monstrous state", by which he means Caesar. Historically Cassius followed Epicurus, a Greek philosopher whose school discounted omens, and in Act 5 Scene 1 Shakespeare has him confess to Messala that he has partly changed his mind and now gives some credit to things that foreshadow the future. The Soothsayer's line is the first move in the play's long argument about fate and free will, an argument Cassius himself states in Act 1 Scene 2 when he insists that "Men at some time are masters of their fates."

LEVEL 5 — How do I use it in an ICSE answer?

EXAM-ORIENTED ADVICE: In a Class IX-style extract question on this passage, the three-mark sub-parts will typically ask who speaks, where and when; what the warning means in your own words; and how Caesar reacts and what that reveals. The Level 1 and Level 2 material answers the first two; the Level 3 material, with its two readings, answers the third at a standard most candidates never reach. In the Class X paper the line arrives as background: a sub-question such as the 2025 paper's question on how 'that work' was begun wants two or three sentences that reach back to this moment, then forward to the conspiracy. Quote the five words exactly, name the speaker and the occasion, and state Caesar's dismissal. That is how Act 1 knowledge earns marks in an Act 5 question.

PROFESSOR'S INSIGHT Caesar asks to see a face, not to hear an argument

Look at what Caesar does with the warning. He does not ask what danger, or from whom. He says "Set him before me. Let me see his face." Having looked, he pronounces: "He is a dreamer." The judgement is made by eye, not by ear, and that is not an accident of the moment but the habit of the man. Later in the same scene, with Antony beside him, Caesar judges Cassius in exactly the same way: "Yond Cassius has a lean and hungry look", "Would he were fatter!", and he wishes for "men about me that are fat, / Sleek-headed men". Caesar reads bodies as if they were documents. School guides call him 'superstitious' or 'arrogant'; the sharper observation is that Shakespeare gives him a consistent method of knowing and then shows that method failing twice in one scene. Read by face, the Soothsayer is dismissed, and the dreamer turns out to be right. Read by face, Cassius is correctly identified as dangerous, and Caesar then throws the finding away: "But I fear him not." The ear that is "deaf" is the fitting emblem of a man who will not take in information in the form of words. When you reach Act 2 Scene 2 and watch Decius Brutus reinterpret Calpurnia's dream to Caesar's face, you will see the same weakness exploited by someone who has studied it. **LITERARY INTERPRETATION**, but one the text supports at every step.

You will meet these five boxes in every scene chapter. Read them in order.

Reading Shakespeare From Zero

This section is a toolkit. Read it now, then return to it each time a line resists you, until the moves become automatic.

Verse and prose, and why it matters

Look at the shape of the text on the page before you read a word. If the lines are of roughly equal length, each beginning with a capital letter, you are reading *verse*. If the words run on to the right margin like a paragraph, you are reading *prose*. Shakespeare's verse is usually *iambic pentameter* (a *metre*, or regular beat pattern): ten syllables, five beats, a weak syllable followed by a strong one. Say this aloud and tap the strong syllables:

Cassius: *The fault, dear Brutus, is not in our stars,*

the FAULT / dear BRU / tus IS / not IN / our STARS. Five taps. You do not need to scan every line, but you do need to hear the heartbeat, because Shakespeare uses the choice between verse and prose to tell you who someone is.

In Act 1 Scene 1 the tribunes (elected officers whose duty was to protect the common people) speak verse and the commoners speak prose. Flavius opens the play in verse: "Hence! Home, you idle creatures, get you home!" The Cobbler answers in prose: "Truly, sir, all that I live by is with the awl." (An *awl* is the pointed tool a cobbler uses to pierce leather; the joke is on 'all'.) Verse marks rank, formality, public speech; prose marks ordinary life, comedy, plain dealing. But Shakespeare is not mechanical. Casca, a nobleman, gives his whole report of the crown-offering in Act 1 Scene 2 in prose, which suits the "sour fashion" Cassius has warned us about; then, in Act 1 Scene 3, terrified by the storm, the same Casca speaks urgent verse: "Are not you moved, when all the sway of earth / Shakes like a thing unfirm?" The switch is a piece of characterisation. Always ask: is this verse or prose, and why has Shakespeare chosen it here?

PROFESSOR'S INSIGHT Prose can be a nobleman's costume

The school rule is 'commoners speak prose, nobles speak verse', and Scene 1 obeys it. Casca breaks it, and the break is the lesson. In Scene 2 Casca, a patrician (a member of Rome's old aristocratic families), tells the whole crown story in prose, calling the ceremony "mere foolery" and the crowd "the rabblement". Brutus is puzzled by him: "What a blunt fellow is this grown to be! / He was quick mettle when he went to school." Cassius's reply is the key that unlocks the prose: "However he puts on this tardy form" (*tardy* here means slow or dull). *Puts on*: the bluntness is worn, like a cloak. The prose is not Casca's nature but his disguise, a way of seeming too dull to be dangerous while noticing everything. Then the storm comes and the costume is torn off. In Scene 3 the same man speaks breathless verse ("Are not you moved...") and, before the scene is half over, has given Cassius his hand. The medium changed before the man declared himself; Shakespeare let the metre tell you first. So when you ask 'verse or prose, and why?', do not stop at rank. Ask what the speaker wants to be taken for. **LITERARY INTERPRETATION**, widely shared among editors, and one you can state in an answer with the text to prove it.

Word order

Modern English keeps a fairly fixed order: subject, verb, object. Shakespeare moves the pieces, partly for the metre, partly for emphasis. Brutus says "Vexèd I am / Of late with passions of some difference": *I am vexed* (troubled) with the adjective thrown to the front so that the trouble is the first thing we hear. Cassius says "Then must I think you would not have it so" where we would say *then I must think*. The hardest kind places the object first. When Cassius tells Casca "Him and his worth and our great need of him / You have right well conceited", the sentence means *You have understood (conceited) him, his worth and our need of him very well*. The rule of thumb: if a sentence seems to have no subject, the subject is probably waiting further along the line.

Elision: the missing letters

An apostrophe in Shakespeare usually marks a swallowed syllable, dropped to keep the metre. You will meet 'tis (it is), *ne'er* (never), *o'er* (over), *e'en* (even), *th'* (the), *i'* (in). In Act 1 alone: Casca will "ne'er look you i' th' face again"; Flavius says "See whe'er their basest mettle be not moved" (*whe'er* is whether; *mettle* is spirit or temperament); Cassius speaks of "Th' eternal devil"; Casca says "I ha' not since put up my sword". Read the shortened form as the full word and the fog lifts. The opposite mark is the grave accent in words such as "touchèd" and "Vexèd": it tells you to *sound* the final syllable (touch-ed, two beats) so the line keeps its rhythm. Your ICSE edition may print these without the accent; the pronunciation rule is the same.

Thou and you

Shakespeare's English had two words for *you*, and the choice carries information. *Thou* (with *thee*, *thy*, *thine*) was used downwards, to servants and inferiors, or inwards, to intimates and to God; *you* was the polite, formal or respectful form between equals or upwards to a superior. Watch it work in Act 1 Scene 1. Flavius addresses the Carpenter with contempt: "Speak, what trade art thou?" Marullus begins with the Cobbler more coolly, "You, sir, what trade are you?", and as his patience goes he drops to "But what trade art thou? Answer me directly." Flavius follows with "What trade, thou knave? Thou naughty knave, what trade?" (*knave* is a rascal; *naughty* here means worthless or wicked, far stronger than the modern word). The commoners, throughout, answer upwards with *you* and *sir*: "Nay, I beseech you, sir, be not out with me."

Now watch it among the nobles. Brutus and Cassius address each other with the courteous *you*: "Brutus, I do observe you now of late." Yet the moment Brutus leaves and Cassius is alone, the pronoun changes: "Well, Brutus, thou art noble." Alone, Cassius speaks of Brutus with a possessive intimacy he does not show to his face. Caesar, who is above everyone, uses *thou* freely to Antony ("tell me truly what thou think'st of him") and to the Soothsayer ("What sayst thou to me now?"). Do not turn this into a rigid law; Shakespeare shifts pronouns for rhythm as well as meaning, and Cassius in the storm moves between *you* and *thee* with Casca within a few lines. But when a speaker changes from one to the other mid-conversation, stop and ask what has changed between them.

How to read a long sentence

Shakespeare's sentences can run for six or eight lines, and the beginner's instinct is to read faster and hope. Do the opposite. First, find the main verb. Second, ask who or what is doing it. Third, bracket off everything else as decoration until the skeleton is clear. Take Cassius in the storm:

Cassius: *Nor stony tower, nor walls of beaten brass, / Nor airless dungeon, nor strong links of iron, / Can be retentive to the strength of spirit;*

Two lines pass before any verb arrives. Bracket the four things listed, find "Can be retentive" (*retentive* means able to hold in), and the skeleton is: *[none of these prisons] can hold the spirit*. Now go back and enjoy the list, because the list is the point: each prison is heavier than the last, and none of them works.

Using the paraphrase without depending on it

If your edition prints a modern paraphrase beside the text, it is a good servant and a terrible master. Use it in this order. Cover the paraphrase. Read the passage aloud once, then apply the four tools above and write your own one-line simple English version in the margin. Only then uncover the paraphrase and compare. Where you were wrong, find the single word or inversion that misled you and note it; that word is now yours. Never memorise the paraphrase itself: in an examination you must quote Shakespeare's words and explain them in *your* words, and an examiner can tell at once when a candidate is reciting an editor. The paraphrase should confirm your reading, not replace it.

CROSS-REFERENCE Building the vocabulary muscle

Every difficult word in this chapter has been glossed on first appearance, and every chapter does the same. For systematic practice, the chapter titled 'Difficult Shakespearean English: The Act 1 Vocabulary System' organises the whole of Act 1's hard vocabulary by scene and by type, and the chapter titled 'The Act 1 Literary-Device Bank' does the same for figures of speech.

A Note on Names and Spellings

TEXT NOTE Names, spellings and why there are no line numbers

Editions of this play do not agree on every name, and a student who meets 'Murellus' in one book and 'Marullus' in another can lose confidence for no good reason. Here is the map.

Marullus / Murellus. The 1623 First Folio prints the tribune's name as Murellus, and the Oxford and Arden editions keep that form. The Folger, Globe and Gutenberg texts, and most ICSE editions, print Marullus, which matches the historical tribune Gaius Epidius Marullus. This book uses **Marullus**. His colleague is Flavius in every edition.

Calpurnia / Calphurnia. The Folio and the Folger print Calphurnia; the Globe text and most ICSE editions print Calpurnia, the historical spelling. This book uses **Calpurnia**.

Antony / Antonius / Mark Antony. All one man. Caesar addresses him by the Latin form, "Forget not in your speed, Antonius", and the Folger's stage directions call him Antony; Casca calls him "Mark Antony". Use **Antony** in your answers, and recognise **Antonius** when Caesar or Casca uses it.

Decius Brutus. Shakespeare's name, taken from North's Plutarch, for the historical Decimus Junius Brutus Albinus, a trusted officer of Caesar who joined the conspiracy. He is not Marcus Brutus, the play's Brutus, and the two must never be confused. Cinna the conspirator, who appears in Act 1 Scene 3, is likewise a different man from Cinna the poet, killed by the mob in Act 3.

The commoners. The Folger names them Carpenter and Cobbler; the Globe text calls them First Commoner and Second Commoner. This book uses **the Carpenter** and **the Cobbler**.

Small variants. You may meet "laughter" or "laugher" in Cassius's speech about not being a common laugher; "glazed" or "glared" for the lion's stare; "chopped" or "chapped" hands; "swooned" or "swounded". These are editorial choices, not errors in your book, and none affects meaning.

No line numbers. This book prints no line numbers and never writes references of the form 'Act, scene, line', because the Folger, the Globe text and ICSE editions all number differently, and a wrong number looks worse than none. We refer instead to Act and Scene and to position in words: 'early in Scene 1', 'just after the Soothsayer's warning', 'Cassius's soliloquy (a speech spoken alone on stage) at the end of Scene 2'. Do the same in your answers; examiners want the Act and Scene, not a line count.

PROFESSOR'S INSIGHT Why the play keeps two Brutuses and two Cinnas

Shakespeare could have renamed Decius Brutus or cut the poet Cinna; Plutarch handed him the duplicates, but he was free to tidy them. He kept both pairs, and made the second one lethal: in Act 3 Scene 3 a man dies because a mob hears a name and will hear nothing else. That scene is the grim answer to a question Cassius asks in Act 1 Scene 2 when he sets two names side by side: "'Brutus' and 'Caesar'—what should be in that 'Caesar'?" His argument is that a name is only sound, that "'Brutus' will start a spirit as soon as 'Caesar.'" He means it as liberation: if names are empty, Caesar is not special. The play's later answer is darker. Names are not empty; they are dangerously full, and a name can kill the wrong man. So the confusion a student feels over 'which Brutus, which Cinna' is not a nuisance to be cleared away but a theme the play planted on purpose, and the theme chapters return to it under appearance and reality. Keep the names straight in your answers, and notice that the characters cannot.

LITERARY INTERPRETATION.

How the Book Is Organised

The course runs in six movements: foundations (chapters 00–02), the text scene by scene (03–06), the people (07–10), the ideas (11–12), the toolkits (13–16 and 20) and the examination, closing with the master map (17–19 and 21). Each chapter stands on the ones before it, so read in order the first time through.

No.	Chapter	What it does for you
00	How to Use This Book (Read This First)	Method, syllabus honesty, reading primer, study plan
01	The Mental Map: What You Must Understand Before Scene 1	The people, the political situation and the questions to hold in mind
02	Roman History Before Act 1: Only What You Need, Taught Properly	Republic, Pompey, the triumph, the Lupercal: the history the play assumes
03	Act 1 Scene 1 — The Street: Commoners, Tribunes and the Fickle Crowd	The opening quarrel; prose against verse; why a crowd matters
04	Act 1 Scene 2 (Part One) — Lupercalia, the Soothsayer, and the Seduction of Brutus	The warning; Cassius begins his work on Brutus
05	Act 1 Scene 2 (Part Two) — Caesar Returns, Casca Reports, Cassius Plots	Caesar judges Cassius; the crown story; the soliloquy and the letters
06	Act 1 Scene 3 — The Storm: Omens, Fear and the Conspiracy Takes Shape	Portents, Cicero's scepticism, Casca recruited, Cinna's errand
07	Caesar in Act 1 — A Character Masterclass	The public Caesar, the private body, the contested question of ambition
08	Cassius — The Manipulation Masterclass	Every persuasive move, named and explained
09	Brutus in Act 1 — Honour, Conflict and Vulnerability	Why the noblest Roman is the easiest to work upon
10	The Soothsayer, the Ides of March, and the Supporting Cast	Antony, Casca, Cicero, Cinna, Calpurnia, the tribunes, the commoners
11	Themes of Act 1 (Part One)	Power, ambition, republicanism, liberty, honour, loyalty, manipulation, rhetoric, public opinion
12	Themes of Act 1 (Part Two)	Fate and free will, omens, appearance and reality, friendship, jealousy, the mob
13	The Act 1 Literary-Device Bank	Every figure of speech with its example, effect and exam use
14	The ICSE Keyword Vault for Act 1	The analytical vocabulary examiners reward
15	The Act 1 Quotation Bank	The quotations to know by heart, with speaker, context and meaning
16	The Scene Connection Engine and Where Act 1 Reappears Later	Act 1 traced forward into Acts II–V
17	ICSE Examiner Mode: How Marks Are Earned	Paper structure, sub-question types, what a full-mark answer contains
18	Extract-Based Training (Part One)	Practice extracts from Scene 1 and the first half of Scene 2, with weak and strong answers
19	Extract-Based Training (Part Two)	Practice extracts from the second half of Scene 2 and Scene 3

No.	Chapter	What it does for you
20	Difficult Shakespearean English: The Act 1 Vocabulary System	Hard words organised for learning, not just glossed
21	The Final Act 1 Master Map and What Shakespeare Is Doing	The whole act on one page, and the dramatist's design

A suggested four-week plan

Four weeks at roughly forty-five minutes a day is realistic alongside school. Adjust the pace, not the order.

Week	Chapters	Focus	Daily habit	Check yourself
1	00, 01, 02, 03; begin 20 as a reference	Foundations and Scene 1	Read the day's scene aloud for ten minutes before studying it	Explain in one paragraph, closed-book, why the tribunes are angry and why the crowd is dangerous
2	04, 05, 06; keep 20 open; start 15	The text, scene by scene	Write a one-line simple English version of every hard speech before looking at any paraphrase	Retell each scene at Level 1 and Level 2 without notes; know ten quotations by heart
3	07, 08, 09, 10, 11, 12, 13	People, ideas and devices	For each character, collect three quotations and one contested reading	State, for Caesar, Cassius and Brutus, one thing the text proves and one thing it leaves open
4	14, 16, 17, 18, 19, 21; all revision boxes	Examination craft	Answer one extract sub-question in timed conditions	Write two full timed extract answers; explain three Act III–V moments using Act 1 knowledge

If you have only two weeks, do Weeks 1 and 2 as written and compress Weeks 3 and 4 into one by reading chapters 07, 08, 09, 16 and 17 and doing one extract chapter. Do not skip the scene chapters to reach the exam chapters faster; that is the sand-foundation mistake this book exists to prevent.

How to Use the Boxes

Coloured boxes break the text throughout. Each has a job, and knowing the job tells you how to read it.

Professor's Insight (insight). Genuine analysis that a school guide would miss: the observation behind the observation. Read these twice, and after the second reading write one sentence in your own words. They are the material that lifts a competent answer to an excellent one.

Quotation Box (quote). A short verse quotation with its speaker, set out so you can memorise it. Learn the words exactly, the speaker, the moment, and the meaning; a quotation without its context is only half learnt.

Keyword Box (keyword). The analytical vocabulary examiners reward: words such as *fickle*, *republican*, *soliloquy*, *dramatic irony*. Each comes with a definition and a sentence showing it in use. Use one or two in every answer, correctly.

Historical Context Box (history). What actually happened in Rome, labelled as **HISTORICAL RECORD**. Read it to understand the play, but never write history in an answer as though it were the plot. The play is the text; history is the background.

ICSE Exam Box (icse). **EXAM-ORIENTED ADVICE**: how this material tends to be asked about and how marks are earned. Every one of these is honest about the Class IX and Class X split, and none of them promises a question.

Cross-Reference Box (crossref). A pointer to another scene, act or chapter. On a first reading, note it and move on; on a second reading, follow it.

Revision Box (revision). Closed-book checks at the end of a chapter. Do them before you look anything up, and treat a blank as useful information about what to reread.

You will also meet three smaller kinds: **Text Note** (textnote) for edition variants such as the ones above; the five **Level** boxes you have already seen; and paired **Weak Answer** and **Excellent Answer** boxes in the examination chapters, where the same question is answered badly and well so that you can see exactly where the marks went.

Turn now to the Mental Map, and read it as a person about to walk into Rome on a festival morning who wants to understand what everybody around him already knows.

CHAPTER 1

The Mental Map: What You Must Understand Before Scene 1

Before you read a single line of Scene 1 you need a map. Students who struggle with Shakespeare rarely struggle because the language is impossible; they struggle because they arrive at the first speech not knowing who is talking, what Rome is, why anyone is angry, or what is at stake. This chapter supplies that missing map: what kind of play this is, the questions Shakespeare is asking, the people you must recognise on sight, the political situation, the history Act 1 silently assumes, and three graded summaries of the whole act. Read it slowly, twice if necessary. Every later chapter in this book stands on it.

A. What Julius Caesar is about

Ask a hundred students what *Julius Caesar* is about and most will answer: a Roman general is murdered by his friends. That is true, and it is almost useless. It describes an event, not a play. A play is built around a question, and the question this play asks has never been settled by any society in history: **what should good people do when one man grows too powerful for the system that made him?**

Here is the situation in plain terms. Rome in 44 BC is a republic. For nearly five centuries it has been governed not by a king but by elected officers and a Senate, and Romans are brought up to loathe the very word *rex* (king). Yet after years of civil war one man, Julius Caesar, has defeated every rival and now holds power that no republican office was ever designed to contain. He is adored by the common people, feared by a section of the nobility, and surrounded by men who cannot decide whether he is Rome's saviour or its destroyer. Act 1 is the act in which that indecision hardens into a plan.

What Shakespeare does with this situation is the real subject. He is not interested in simply staging a famous killing; the killing does not arrive until Act 3. He is interested in how a decision to kill is *made*: how one man, Cassius, persuades another, Brutus, that murder can be honourable; how a crowd can be turned in an afternoon; how omens, rumours, forged letters and flattery all become instruments of persuasion; how the public face of a great man differs from the private body that shakes with fever and cannot hear in one ear. Act 1 contains no violence at all. It contains talk, and the talk *is* the drama, because in this play words are the weapons that go before daggers.

So when you read Act 1, do not sit waiting for something to 'happen'. Something is happening in every line: Rome is being argued into a murder. The plot of Act 1 can be told in a paragraph (two officials scold a crowd; Caesar brushes aside a warning; Cassius works on Brutus; Casca reports a crown refused; a storm rages; conspirators gather). The *meaning* of Act 1 needs a book. That is why this one exists.

One more orientation point. The whole play compresses about two and a half years of history, from the Lupercalia of February 44 BC to the battle of Philippi in October 42 BC, into five acts. Act 1 covers the shortest stretch of that time and yet carries the heaviest load, because every motive that drives Acts 2 to 5 is planted here. If you understand Act 1 properly, the rest of the play unfolds like consequences from a cause. If you do not, the later acts feel like a series of unexplained shocks. That is the practical reason this book devotes an entire course to a single act.

B. What kind of play it is

Three labels are used for *Julius Caesar*, and each tells you something about how to read it.

A tragedy

The First Folio of 1623, the first collected edition of Shakespeare's plays, prints it among the Tragedies under the title *The Tragedie of Julius Caesar*. 'Tragedy' does not simply mean 'a sad story'. In the tradition that descends from the Greek philosopher Aristotle, a tragedy shows a person of high standing brought down through a combination of their own error and forces larger than themselves. Aristotle's word for the error is *hamartia*, which is often translated 'tragic flaw' but is closer to 'a mistake' or 'a missing of the mark'; scholars argue about the translation, and you should never write as if the word had one settled meaning. The fall arouses pity and fear, and it ends in death and a sober recognition of what has been lost.

Shakespeare's tragedies add something the Greeks did not stress: an intense interest in the *inner* life. His tragic figures talk to themselves, argue with themselves, hide from themselves. When Brutus describes himself in Scene 2 as "poor Brutus, with himself at war", he is announcing the subject of Shakespearean tragedy in five words. Keep that phrase near you throughout this course.

A Roman play

Julius Caesar is also grouped with *Antony and Cleopatra* and *Coriolanus* (and sometimes the early *Titus Andronicus*) as one of Shakespeare's 'Roman plays'. The three mature Roman plays draw their stories from the Greek biographer Plutarch, whose *Parallel Lives* Shakespeare read in Sir Thomas North's English translation of 1579. The label matters because Roman plays share a distinctive atmosphere. Their world is *public*: streets, the Capitol, the marketplace, the Senate, rather than bedrooms and gardens. Their values are public too: honour, reputation, service to the state, courage in the face of death, and a Roman idea of manliness that the characters constantly invoke and police. When Cassius in Scene 3 hears a voice in the dark and asks who is there, Casca's whole answer is two words, "A Roman.", as if that were an identity complete in itself. Women are pushed to the margins of the public action: Calpurnia speaks three words in Act 1 and Portia none. There are no clowns of the kind you meet in the comedies, no fairies, no love plot. Even the Cobbler's jokes in Scene 1 are jokes about work.

A political drama

Finally, *Julius Caesar* is a political play in the exact sense: it is about how power is gained, displayed, threatened and lost. It was written and first performed in 1599, almost certainly at the newly built Globe theatre, where a Swiss visitor named Thomas Platter recorded seeing a play about Julius Caesar on 21 September that year. In 1599 Queen Elizabeth I was sixty-six, unmarried, and had named no heir. Official Tudor teaching, preached from pulpits, held that rebellion against a ruler was a grave sin; at the same time, educated humanists across Europe debated whether killing a tyrant could ever be justified. Audiences *may* have felt that a play about one-man rule, succession and the legitimacy of resistance touched questions very

close to home, and that ancient Rome was a safe distance from which to think about them. Be careful here: we cannot know what any Elizabethan felt, and you should never write as if we could. What we can say is that Shakespeare keeps the political debate genuinely open. No character in Act 1 is simply right.

The tragic-hero debate: Caesar or Brutus?

Literary interpretation. Readers have argued for centuries about who the tragic hero of this play is, and you need to know the shape of the argument, not a 'correct answer'.

The case for Caesar. The play bears his name. Every other character defines himself by his relation to Caesar: for him, against him, afraid of him, in love with him. His fall is the event around which the whole structure turns, and even after his death his name and his memory continue to shape what happens. Act 1 already shows a classically tragic combination in him: enormous public greatness alongside a private pride that refuses warnings. "He is a dreamer. Let us leave him. Pass." is the sentence of a man who cannot imagine being wrong.

The case for Brutus. Brutus has the largest part in the play and by far the richest inner life. He alone is shown genuinely torn; he alone acts from an ideal rather than from ambition or grievance; his error (the decision to join the conspiracy, and later to trust Antony) leads directly to his suffering and death; and the play's final tribute is paid over his body, by his enemy, praising his nobility. That is the full arc of a tragic protagonist, and Caesar, who dies before the play is half over, does not have it.

A third view. Some critics argue that the tragedy belongs to neither man but to Rome itself: that Shakespeare is dramatising the death of a republic, and that the individuals are instruments of a larger collapse. On this reading the crowd, the tribunes and the storm are not background but subject.

How should you hold these together? Notice what Act 1 does with each man. Caesar is *talked about* far more than he talks. Brutus is *worked upon*. Cassius, oddly, is the one who gets the act's only soliloquy. Shakespeare seems to be distributing the tragic weight rather than fixing it on a single head, and an answer that recognises this will always outscore one that flatly declares 'Brutus is the tragic hero'. In an examination you may take a position, but you must show that you know it is a position.

C. What Shakespeare is examining

A great play is never 'about' a theme in the way a school essay is; it examines questions by making people live them. Six questions run through Act 1, and you should learn to see each scene as an experiment on one or more of them. The two Themes chapters later in this book develop each in depth; here you need the shape.

Power: where does it actually sit? Officially, power in Rome sits in the Senate and the elected magistrates. Act 1 shows that it now sits in a crowd's affection for one man. Caesar's power is visible only through its effects: a holiday declared, statues dressed with decorations, tribunes who object and are silenced. Flavius understands the mechanism perfectly when he describes Caesar's popularity as "growing feathers" that, if "plucked", will make him "fly an ordinary pitch" (pitch: the height to which a hawk soars). Power here is not a possession but a relationship, and relationships can be interfered with.

Persuasion: how are minds changed? This is the central activity of Act 1. The tribunes shame a crowd into silence. Cassius spends the whole middle of Scene 2 changing Brutus's mind, using a mirror image, two anecdotes, a comparison of names and an appeal to ancestry. Casca's report of the crown offering is itself an act of persuasion, colouring the event with contempt. Cassius ends the scene planning letters that will pretend to be the voice of the people. Even Caesar, when he swoons, manages his audience by blaming his infirmity. Watch every speech as a *move* and ask what the speaker wants it to do.

Honour: what does it permit? Brutus tells Cassius he loves "The name of honour more than I fear death", and Cassius instantly replies, "Well, honour is the subject of my story." The word is a lever, and Cassius has found it. The play will test whether honour can justify killing a friend, and whether a man who prizes the *name* of honour can be led by that very name.

Public image and private self. Caesar is called "immortal Caesar", "this god", and compared to a "Colossus", yet Cassius has seen him nearly drown, heard him groan with fever and cry out for drink "As a sick girl". Caesar declares "for always I am Caesar" and in the next breath asks Antony to come round to his good side because "this ear is deaf". Brutus admits he has "veiled" his look. Casca, according to Cassius, "puts on this tardy form" (tardy: slow, dull). Cassius presents himself as the honest friend while planning forgery. Everyone in Act 1 has a surface and a depth, and the play trains you to look through the surface.

Fate and choice. A Soothsayer knows the date of Caesar's death. A storm fills the sky with wonders. Yet Cassius insists that "The fault, dear Brutus, is not in our stars, / But in ourselves, that we are underlings." The same storm is read three ways in Scene 3: Casca sees the gods' warning, Cicero observes that "men may construe things after their fashion", and Cassius turns it into a portrait of Caesar and a call to arms. Shakespeare never tells you which reading is right.

How republics die. This is the largest question and the one most often missed. The Republic in Act 1 does not fall to an invading army. It is hollowed out from within: its officials cannot control its people, its people prefer a holiday to liberty, its nobles turn to secret conspiracy and forged letters, and the man who claims to defend freedom, Cassius, uses methods that mock it. **Literary interpretation:** one strong reading is that Shakespeare shows the Republic already dying before a single dagger is drawn, so that the assassination is not the cause of its death but a symptom.

D. Who the important people are

You cannot follow a conversation if you do not know who is speaking, and in Act 1 Shakespeare introduces more than a dozen named Romans in under nine hundred lines. The table below is your cast list. The second column is **historical record** (who the real man was); the third and fourth are a mixture of **Shakespeare's text** and **literary interpretation**, and they tell you what each figure wants in Act 1 and the question you should hold in your mind whenever he appears. Learn the names and the one-line descriptions now; the detailed character chapters later in the book will deepen every entry.

Name	Who he is (historical record)	What he wants in Act 1	How to watch him
Julius Caesar	Rome's greatest general and politician; victor of the civil war against Pompey; dictator, and from February 44 BC dictator for life	To be seen as supremely powerful without being seen to grasp at a crown; to keep the crowd's love	Measure the gap between what is <i>said</i> of him and what he <i>does</i> . He is on stage twice, briefly, and is talked about constantly
Marcus Brutus	A senator of ancient republican family, claiming descent from the Brutus who drove out Rome's last king; fought for Pompey, was pardoned by Caesar and promoted by him; urban praetor in 44 BC	To be left alone with his private trouble; to remain honourable; not to see Caesar made king	Watch him being <i>worked upon</i> . Count how little he says compared with Cassius, and notice every word that reveals he is already half-persuaded

Name	Who he is (historical record)	What he wants in Act 1	How to watch him
Caius Cassius	A senator and experienced soldier; survived the disaster at Carrhae; fought for Pompey, was pardoned by Caesar; praetor in 44 BC; married to Brutus's sister	To bring Brutus into a conspiracy against Caesar, by any means that work	Watch his <i>technique</i> . Every speech is a tool chosen for a particular listener: one method for Brutus, another for Casca
Mark Antony	Caesar's loyal officer in Gaul and the civil war; consul alongside Caesar in 44 BC; ran as a priest in the Lupercalia race	To serve Caesar and to be seen serving him	Count his lines in Act 1 (very few) and remember them. Shakespeare is hiding something in plain sight
Casca	A senator; historically the man who struck the first blow on the Ides of March	To appear bored and blunt while telling Brutus and Cassius exactly what they need to know; later, to join Cassius	Watch the mask. Is his bluntness real stupidity or a protective disguise? Brutus and Cassius disagree about this in Scene 2
Flavius and Marullus	Tribunes of the people in 44 BC; historically deposed by Caesar for removing a diadem from his statue	To send the crowd home and strip Caesar's statues of their decorations	They are the Republic's conscience in Scene 1 and are "put to silence" by Scene 2. Ask what their fate tells you about Caesar's power
The Soothsayer	A fortune-teller; Plutarch names a seer, Spurinna, who warned Caesar	To warn Caesar of the Ides of March	He speaks one sentence twice. Watch how Caesar handles him
Calpurnia	Caesar's wife since 59 BC; childless	Nothing in Act 1; she obeys	Her childlessness is made public business in Caesar's first speech. Remember her pale cheek when Caesar returns from the games
Cicero	Rome's greatest orator; not a conspirator	To go home out of the storm, having said something sceptical	He is the one man who refuses to <i>interpret</i> the storm. Cassius does not invite him in
Cinna	A praetor in 44 BC and a conspirator (not the poet of the same name killed later in the play)	To carry Cassius's letters and to see Brutus won over	He voices aloud what Cassius has been thinking: the conspiracy needs Brutus
Decius Brutus, Metellus Cimber, Trebonius	Senators and conspirators; Decius Brutus was one of Caesar's most trusted officers	To wait for Cassius at Pompey's Porch	Names only in Act 1; you will meet them properly in Act 2
The Carpenter and the Cobbler	Ordinary tradesmen; Shakespeare's invention, standing for the Roman people	To take a holiday and cheer Caesar	They are the crowd given faces and voices. Notice that they are funnier and quicker than the tribunes who scold them
Pompey	Caesar's rival, defeated at Pharsalus in 48 BC and murdered in Egypt; dead four years before the play opens	Nothing; he is dead	He is the ghost of Act 1. The tribunes invoke him, the triumph celebrates victory over his sons, and the conspirators meet at his porch

Two people in that table deserve an extra word now, because students regularly confuse them. There are **two Brutuses** among the conspirators: Marcus Brutus, the hero of the play, and Decius Brutus, a different man entirely (historically Decimus Junius Brutus Albinus) who is merely named in Act 1. When Cassius or Cinna say 'Brutus' without a first name, they always mean Marcus. And there are **two Cinnas** in the play: Cinna the conspirator, who appears in Scene 3, and Cinna the poet, who does not appear until Act 3 and is torn apart by the mob for sharing a name. Keep them apart from the start.

HISTORICAL CONTEXT Where Shakespeare found his people

Nearly every named character in Act 1 comes from Plutarch's *Parallel Lives*, written in Greek around AD 100 and translated into English by Sir Thomas North in 1579. Shakespeare read North closely, sometimes lifting whole sentences into verse, and he drew chiefly on three of the Lives: those of Caesar, Brutus and Antony. But he also *changed* what he found. Plutarch's tribunes acted in January 44 BC, weeks before the Lupercalia; Shakespeare puts their protest on the same day as the triumph and the festival. Plutarch's diadem was offered twice; Shakespeare's Casca says three times, which makes the ritual feel more deliberate. Plutarch records that anonymous messages were left for Brutus urging him to act; Shakespeare gives the forgery to Cassius, so that the conspiracy's noblest recruit is won by a lie. Caesar's epilepsy, his "falling sickness", is in Plutarch and Suetonius; his deafness in one ear is not in any ancient source and appears to be Shakespeare's own invention. Whenever you meet a vivid detail in Act 1, it is worth asking: did Shakespeare find this, or make it? The additions are where his purposes show most clearly.

E. What political situation Rome is in

To understand why two city officials are so angry at a crowd in the first scene, you need a working picture of the Roman Republic: not a history lesson, but enough to see what is being threatened.

Historical record. Rome had expelled its last king, Tarquin the Proud, in the year traditionally given as 509 BC, and had governed itself for nearly five centuries since as a *res publica*, 'the public thing', a state that belonged to its citizens rather than to a ruler. Its institutions were designed above all to prevent any one man from holding supreme power for long. Two **consuls**, elected each year, shared the highest office and could each veto the other. The **Senate**, a council of several hundred former magistrates drawn from the wealthy families, debated policy and in practice directed the state. The **tribunes of the people** (there were ten by this period) were officers whose job was to protect the ordinary citizens, the plebeians, against the aristocracy; their persons were sacred and they could veto almost any official act. The office of **dictator** existed for emergencies only and was traditionally limited to six months. Over all of this hung a single shared emotion: a loathing of the title *rex*, king, so deep that a Roman politician could destroy a rival simply by suggesting that he wanted it.

The slogan of this system was *SPQR*, *Senatus Populusque Romanus*, 'the Senate and People of Rome', and its proudest word was *libertas*, liberty, by which Romans meant not personal freedom in our sense but freedom from being ruled by a master. When Cassius in Scene 2 says "I was born free as Caesar", and when he speaks in Scene 3 of delivering himself "from bondage", he is using this vocabulary. The conspirators will call themselves liberators. You need to hear the Roman weight in that word.

Now set against this picture what the opening of the play actually shows. The people are not in the Forum voting; they are in the streets cheering a general. The tribunes, whose office exists to speak for those very people, cannot get them to obey and have to resort to insult. Caesar's statues are being dressed with "ceremonies" (decorations, probably scarves or ribbons) as if he were a god or a king. The tribunes tear the

decorations down, and by the next scene, we are told, they have been removed from office for it. The Senate, we hear in Scene 3, is rumoured to be about to make Caesar a king everywhere but in Italy. Every institution built to prevent one-man rule is shown either failing or bending.

Literary interpretation. It is tempting to say that Caesar has 'seized' power. Shakespeare is more subtle and more disturbing. Nobody seizes anything in Act 1. Power has flowed to Caesar because the crowd loves him, because the Senate is frightened or flattering, and because the republican nobles, for all their talk, have no idea what to do except whisper. The Republic has not been conquered; it has been emptied. The street scene with which the play opens is the political situation of Rome in miniature: an official shouting at citizens who are not listening.

HISTORICAL CONTEXT The late Republic was already breaking

Caesar did not invent the problem; he inherited it. For two generations before him, Rome's wars had been fought by armies loyal to their generals rather than to the state, and those generals had learned to use their soldiers in Roman politics. Marius had held the consulship an unprecedented seven times. Sulla had marched on Rome itself and made himself dictator in 82–81 BC, killing his enemies by published lists. Pompey had been granted extraordinary commands and celebrated three triumphs. In 60 BC Caesar, Pompey and Crassus formed a private alliance, now called the First Triumvirate, that effectively ran the state for several years. By the time Caesar crossed the Rubicon in January 49 BC, the republican constitution had already been bent repeatedly by strongmen. Shakespeare does not stage any of this, but Marullus's reverence for Pompey and Cassius's bitterness that "Rome ... hast lost the breed of noble bloods" only make sense in a Rome that has been losing its republican nerve for decades.

F. What happened before the play begins

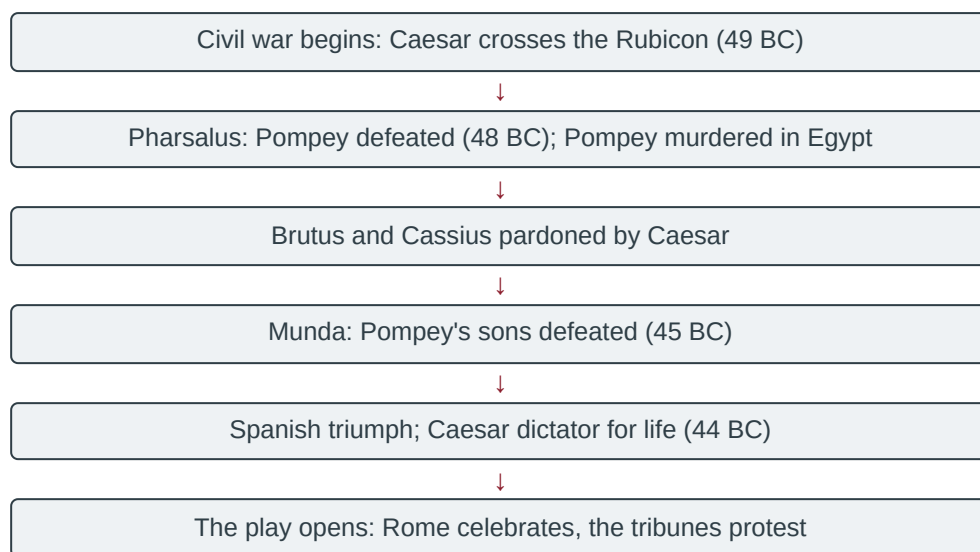
Act 1 opens on a day of celebration, and the first thing to understand is *what* is being celebrated. The Cobbler says the people have made holiday "to see Caesar and to rejoice in his triumph". A triumph was the greatest honour the Republic could grant a general: a procession through the city to the Temple of Jupiter on the Capitoline hill, with the victor in a chariot, captives in chains, spoils on display and soldiers marching behind. But a triumph was supposed to be for victory over *foreign* enemies. Marullus's furious question, "What conquest brings he home? / What tributaries follow him to Rome / To grace in captive bonds his chariot wheels?" (tributaries: conquered peoples who pay tribute), is not rhetorical decoration. He is pointing out that this triumph has no foreign captives, because the enemy Caesar has just defeated was Roman.

Here is the history Act 1 needs, kept to its bones.

Historical record. In 49 BC the alliance between Caesar and Pompey had collapsed, and Caesar, ordered by the Senate to give up his army, instead led it across the Rubicon river into Italy, beginning a civil war. Pompey and most of the Senate fled to Greece. On 9 August 48 BC Caesar destroyed Pompey's army at Pharsalus. Pompey escaped to Egypt and was murdered on arrival, on 28 September 48 BC, by men hoping to please Caesar. Both Brutus and Cassius fought on Pompey's side and were pardoned by Caesar afterwards; this is the uncomfortable fact beneath Cassius's remark in Scene 2 that "Caesar doth bear me hard, but he loves Brutus". The war did not end with Pompey's death. His sons raised new armies, and Caesar had to fight on in Africa and then in Spain. The final battle was at Munda, in southern Spain, on 17 March 45 BC, where Pompey's elder son Gnaeus was killed and the younger, Sextus, escaped. In October 45 BC Caesar celebrated a triumph for this Spanish victory, and Plutarch records that Romans resented it because it honoured the killing of fellow citizens, the sons of a great Roman, rather than the defeat of a foreign enemy. That resentment is Marullus's speech.

Meanwhile Caesar's constitutional position had become something Rome had never seen. He had been named dictator in 49 BC, again in 48–47, dictator for ten years in 46 BC, and in February 44 BC dictator *perpetuo*, for life. The emergency office with a six-month limit had become permanent. He was also consul for 44 BC, with Antony as his colleague. He had not taken the title of king, and he publicly refused a crown, but he held every power a king would have held, and his statues were being treated as a king's.

Shakespeare's text compresses all of this. The triumph of October 45 BC and the feast of Lupercalia on 15 February 44 BC are made into a single day in Scenes 1 and 2. Scene 3 takes place on the night before the Ides of March; a month passes in silence between the second scene and the third, and the only clue is Cicero's question about whether Caesar comes "to the Capitol tomorrow". You do not need to memorise the dates. You need to understand the sequence, because the sequence is the emotional logic of the opening: a civil war has been won; the victor is being honoured as though he had conquered foreigners; the old republican families, many of whom fought on the losing side and owe their lives to his mercy, are watching the celebrations with a mixture of gratitude, humiliation and fear.



Pompey's presence in Act 1 is worth a moment more. He is dead, but Shakespeare keeps him in the air. Marullus remembers the crowds that once waited "The livelong day, with patient expectation, / To see great Pompey pass the streets of Rome" and accuses them of strewing flowers before the man "That comes in triumph over Pompey's blood". Cassius's conspirators, in Scene 3, gather at "Pompey's Porch", the colonnade of the great theatre Pompey built. **Historical record:** Caesar was in fact murdered in the Senate meeting-hall attached to that theatre, beneath Pompey's statue, though Shakespeare moves the assassination to the Capitol. **Literary interpretation:** the dead rival haunts the play as a reminder of what the Republic used to look like and how quickly a crowd forgets.

CROSS-REFERENCE Where to go for the full history

This section gives you only what the first three scenes assume. The chapter *Roman History Before Act 1: Only What You Need, Taught Properly* explains the republican constitution in detail, the careers of Caesar, Pompey, Brutus and Cassius, the meaning of a Roman triumph and of the Lupercalia, the Roman calendar and the Ides, and exactly where Shakespeare followed and departed from Plutarch. Read it after this chapter and before you begin the scene-by-scene teaching; it is the historical companion to this mental map.

G. Why Caesar is so important

Students sometimes complain that Caesar is a disappointing character: he speaks little, he is pompous, he dies early. This is to mistake the man for the part he plays. Caesar's importance in Act 1 does not lie in what he says. It lies in the fact that every other person on stage is defined by his relationship to Caesar, and that the play's whole political question is embodied in his person.

Consider how Shakespeare manages his first appearance. The entire first scene passes without him. We hear his name, we hear of his triumph and his statues, we watch the tribunes undress his images, and he never arrives. When he does enter, at the start of Scene 2, his first word is his wife's name and his first concern is her fertility: he instructs Antony to touch Calpurnia during the Lupercalia race, "for our elders say / The barren, touchèd in this holy chase, / Shake off their sterile curse." This is a man who speaks in public about his private business as if the whole city were his household, and who believes, or wishes to be seen believing, in an old fertility ritual. Antony's reply tells you how he is regarded: "When Caesar says 'Do this,' it is performed." A sentence from Caesar is already a command.

Then comes the Soothsayer. A voice from the crowd, "shriller than all the music", calls his name, and Caesar stops the procession to hear it: "Speak. Caesar is turned to hear." Notice that he refers to himself in the third person, as though 'Caesar' were an institution rather than a man. The warning, "Beware the ides of March", is delivered twice. Caesar dismisses it in nine words: "He is a dreamer. Let us leave him. Pass." That is the whole exchange, and it is one of the most important moments in the act, because it shows the great man's method of dealing with anything he does not wish to hear: he names it, diminishes it and moves on.

His second appearance is just as brief and just as revealing. Returning from the games, he studies Cassius and delivers a character analysis of extraordinary accuracy: Cassius "reads much", is "a great observer", "loves no plays", "hears no music", "Seldom he smiles", and "Such men as he be never at heart's ease / Whiles they behold a greater than themselves". Every word of this is true, and the audience knows it, having just watched Cassius at work. Yet Caesar ends by refusing to act on his own insight: "I rather tell thee what is to be feared / Than what I fear; for always I am Caesar." And then, in the very next line, the god asks for help: "Come on my right hand, for this ear is deaf."

Literary interpretation. That is why Caesar matters. Shakespeare has built him as a living contradiction: supremely perceptive and wilfully blind; a public colossus and a private body subject to fever, epilepsy and deafness; a man who refuses a crown three times while, in Casca's view, longing for it. The debate about whether he is a tyrant or a great leader cannot be settled from Act 1, because Shakespeare has deliberately given you evidence for both. His importance is that he *is* the question. Whatever Rome decides to do about Caesar will decide what Rome becomes.

PROFESSOR'S INSIGHT Why Caesar is kept off-stage in Scene 1

A lesser dramatist would have opened with the triumph: trumpets, chariot, the great man waving. Shakespeare opens with two angry officials and a cobbler, and Caesar is not seen. This is a calculated choice with at least three effects. First, it makes Caesar an *idea* before he is a person. We meet his power through its traces, a holiday, decorated statues, a crowd that has forgotten Pompey, and so we learn to think of him as a force rather than a character, which is exactly how Rome thinks of him. Second, it sets up a comparison that will govern the whole play: the Caesar of reputation against the Caesar of the flesh. The tribunes speak of a man who "would soar above the view of men"; the man who then walks on asks a priest to cure his wife's barrenness and cannot hear on one side. The gap is the point, and it could only be opened by letting us hear the legend first. Third, delaying the entrance teaches the audience how to watch the play. By the time Caesar speaks, we have already been trained to listen for what people *say about* power, and to notice who is absent when it is discussed. Act 1 is, in a sense, a play about a man who is hardly there, and that absence is Shakespeare's first comment on what one-man rule does to a city: it fills every conversation with a person nobody is actually talking to.

H. Why some Romans fear Caesar

If Caesar is so beloved, why is anyone afraid of him? Act 1 gives at least four distinct answers, spoken by different people, and a good reader keeps them separate rather than mashing them into 'they feared his ambition'.

The tribunes' fear is constitutional. Flavius and Marullus do not accuse Caesar of any crime. Their anxiety is about what his popularity is doing to the Republic's structure. Flavius puts it in the image of a hawk whose feathers must be plucked so that it will "fly an ordinary pitch" instead of soaring "above the view of men" to "keep us all in servile fearfulness" (servile: slave-like). The fear is that Rome will come to live in the attitude of servants, looking up. Their reaction is to attack the *symbols* of Caesar's elevation, the decorated statues, because symbols are how a republic turns into a monarchy without anyone voting for it.

Brutus's fear is for the Republic's principle. When he hears shouting, his instant reaction is "I do fear the people / Choose Caesar for their king." He says in the same breath that he loves Caesar. His fear is not of Caesar the man but of the office of king, which his family's whole identity is built on hating. This is why Cassius's reminder of his ancestor, "There was a Brutus once that would have brooked / Th' eternal devil to keep his state in Rome / As easily as a king" (brooked: tolerated), lands so heavily.

Cassius's fear is personal and comparative. Listen to the terms he uses. Caesar "doth bestride the narrow world / Like a Colossus, and we petty men / Walk under his huge legs". Cassius "must bend his body / If Caesar carelessly but nod on him". He had "as lief not be as live to be / In awe of such a thing as I myself" (lief: willingly). What Cassius cannot bear is not tyranny in the abstract but the experience of being made small by an equal. His two anecdotes, the swimming race in the Tiber and the fever in Spain, are both designed to prove that Caesar's body is no better than his own; the question that torments him is "Upon what meat doth this our Caesar feed / That he is grown so great?"

Casca's fear is political gossip made concrete. In Scene 3 he reports that "the Senators tomorrow / Mean to establish Caesar as a king, / And he shall wear his crown by sea and land / In every place save here in Italy." Whether or not this rumour is true (the text never confirms it), it gives the conspiracy a deadline. Fear in Act 1 moves from the general to the specific: from a hawk flying too high, to a shout in the distance, to a rumour with a date attached.

Literary interpretation. Notice what is *not* in Act 1: a single act of tyranny by Caesar. He silences two tribunes, which is harsh but, in the Roman context, within the reach of his legal power. He refuses a crown. He pardons his enemies and promotes them. Shakespeare has given his Romans fears that are entirely reasonable and entirely unproven, and this is the moral trap of the play. One strong reading is that the conspirators act not against what Caesar has done but against what he *might* do, and that the tragedy lies in killing a man for his future.

I. Why Brutus matters

Brutus speaks far fewer lines in Act 1 than Cassius, and the ones he does speak are mostly guarded and brief. Yet everyone in the act, including Caesar's enemies, treats him as the key to Rome. Why?

His name. Brutus carries the most republican surname in the city. The ancestor Cassius invokes, Lucius Junius Brutus, led the expulsion of the last king and founded the Republic. In Scene 3 Cassius sends letters to be fixed "Upon old Brutus' statue". A Brutus against Caesar would make the conspiracy look like history repeating itself in the right direction.

His reputation. Casca says of him, late in Scene 3, "O, he sits high in all the people's hearts, / And that which would appear offence in us / His countenance, like richest alchemy, / Will change to virtue and to worthiness." (alchemy: the medieval dream of turning base metal into gold.) The conspirators know that their act will look like murder unless a man of Brutus's known integrity stands in front of it. This is a cold political calculation, and Shakespeare lets Casca state it with complete frankness.

His inner conflict. Here is what distinguishes him as a dramatic creation. Before Cassius says a word of politics, Brutus has already confessed that he is "Vexèd ... / Of late with passions of some difference" and "with himself at war". The seed is in him before Cassius plants anything. When he hears the crowd shout, he admits both halves of his dilemma in one line: "I would not, Cassius, yet I love him well." He then hands Cassius the exact lever to move him: "Set honour in one eye and death i' th' other / And I will look on both indifferently; / For let the gods so speed me as I love / The name of honour more than I fear death." Watch the word *name*. Brutus loves the *name* of honour, and the whole play will ask whether he can tell the name from the thing.

His vulnerability. The tragedy of Brutus is that his virtues are the handles by which he is lifted. His idealism makes him unable to imagine that Cassius's letters are forged. His modesty, "the eye sees not itself / But by reflection", makes him accept Cassius as his mirror. His seriousness, "I am not gamesome", keeps him away from the games and alone with the one man who wants to use him. By the end of Scene 2 he has promised to think it over and to meet Cassius tomorrow, and he has given Cassius his motto: "Brutus had rather be a villager / Than to repute himself a son of Rome / Under these hard conditions". Cassius, in his soliloquy, is in no doubt: "Three parts of him / Is ours already". Brutus matters because the play's moral weight rests on whether a good man can do a terrible thing for good reasons, and Act 1 is where we watch him begin to believe he can.

J. Why Cassius matters

If Brutus is the conscience of the conspiracy, Cassius is its engine. He speaks more lines than anyone else in Act 1, he gets the act's only soliloquy, and nearly everything that happens after the Soothsayer's warning happens because Cassius makes it happen. Three things make him indispensable to your understanding.

He is the master persuader. The long dialogue in Scene 2 is a lesson in how to change a mind without appearing to try. He begins with a complaint about friendship, not politics: Brutus has grown cold. He offers a mirror: Brutus cannot see his own worth, so Cassius, "I, your glass", will "modestly discover" it to him. He waits for the crowd's shout to do his work for him, and only then asks, "Ay, do you fear it?" He tells stories that humiliate Caesar's body while seeming merely to recall shared adventures. He plays with names: "'Brutus' will start a spirit as soon as 'Caesar.'" He appeals to ancestry, to Rome, to shame: "Age, thou art shamed! / Rome, thou hast lost the breed of noble bloods!" And when Brutus asks for time, he gracefully accepts, having got exactly the promise he needed. The chapter *Cassius: The Manipulation Masterclass* will take this apart move by move; for now, understand that Shakespeare has given you, in Cassius, a complete anatomy of political seduction.

He tells the truth and lies at the same time. This is what makes him more interesting than a simple villain. Almost everything Cassius says about Caesar's body is, within the play, true. Caesar does have the falling sickness; Caesar is deaf in one ear; Caesar is vain. Cassius's complaint that "we petty men / Walk under his huge legs" describes a real political situation. Yet his motive is envy as much as principle, as Caesar sees ("Such men as he be never at heart's ease / Whiles they behold a greater than themselves"), and his method, the forged letters "As if they came from several citizens", is a fraud. He is a man using true facts for a partly false purpose, and the play never lets you rest in a simple judgement of him.

His soliloquy tells you what the act has been. Alone at the end of Scene 2, Cassius drops the mask: "Well, Brutus, thou art noble. Yet I see / Thy honourable mettle may be wrought / From that it is disposed." (mettle: temperament, with a pun on metal that can be worked; wrought: shaped.) Then the question that is really a confession: "For who so firm that cannot be seduced?" He admits that Caesar "loves Brutus" and that he would not himself be so used: "If I were Brutus now, and he were Cassius, / He should not humour me." This is the only moment in Act 1 when a character speaks with no listener to manage, and what we hear is a planner congratulating himself. Cassius matters because he shows you that the conspiracy, from its first hour, rests on a mixture of real grievance and deliberate deceit.

Historical record, briefly. The real Cassius had reason for resentment: ancient sources record that Caesar gave Brutus the more prestigious praetorship in 44 BC and Cassius the lesser one, and Plutarch says Caesar distrusted him. Cassius followed the Epicurean philosophy, which taught that the gods do not interfere in human affairs; it is a nice irony, and perhaps a deliberate one, that in Scene 3 Shakespeare's Cassius reads the storm as a divine message when it suits his argument.

K. Why Antony matters

Antony speaks only a handful of lines in Act 1, and a careless reader will forget him. Do not. Shakespeare is laying a fuse.

Shakespeare's text. In Scene 2 Antony appears first as an athlete, stripped "for the course", the ritual race of the Lupercalia. Caesar gives him an order and he answers with perfect obedience: "I shall remember. / When Caesar says 'Do this,' it is performed." Later, when Caesar confides his suspicion of Cassius, Antony is relaxed and reassuring: "Fear him not, Caesar; he's not dangerous. / He is a noble Roman, and well given." (well given: well disposed, of good character.) Caesar's description of him is affectionate and slightly dismissive: Antony "loves ... plays" and music, and is the sort of man Caesar prefers to have around, "fat, / Sleek-headed men, and such as sleep a-nights". We also learn from Casca that it was Antony who offered Caesar the crown, three times, in the marketplace.

Literary interpretation. Put those facts together and you have a portrait that the rest of the play will overturn. Antony is presented through other men's eyes as a pleasure-lover, a loyal subordinate, and an instrument, the hand that holds out a crown so that Caesar can refuse it. The conspirators will take this picture at face value, and Brutus will later argue that Antony is harmless once Caesar is gone. The audience that knows the play knows how wrong this is; the audience watching for the first time is given only one hint, Antony's own absolute formula of loyalty, which makes clear that if anything happens to Caesar, there is a man whose entire identity is bound up in him. Antony matters in Act 1 precisely because he is underestimated in it. Shakespeare is showing you how a political misjudgement is made: by looking at the surface of a man and assuming it is the whole.

Historical record. The real Antony was no idle companion. He had served under Caesar in Gaul from 54 BC, had been tribune in 49 BC (his vetoes on Caesar's behalf and his flight to Caesar's camp gave Caesar a pretext for crossing the Rubicon), had commanded a wing of Caesar's army at Pharsalus, and in 44 BC was consul alongside Caesar. His reputation for drinking and revelry was also real, which is partly why his enemies misjudged him. When you reach his funeral oration in Act 3 you will see what that misjudgement cost; Act 1 is where the mistake is quietly made.

L. Why the Roman crowd matters

Shakespeare gives the Roman people the first words of the action, or rather, he gives the first words to the men trying to control them. The play opens with Flavius shouting "Hence! Home, you idle creatures, get you home!" and the whole of Scene 1 is a struggle between officials and citizens over whether the people may cheer whom they please. This is not merely a lively opening. The crowd is one of the play's major characters, and its behaviour in Act 1 is a prophecy.

Shakespeare's text. The commoners we meet are not a faceless mob. The Carpenter is briefly spoken; the Cobbler is witty, confident and entirely unafraid of authority. He teases the tribunes with puns ("a mender of bad soles"; "if you be out, sir, I can mend you"), describes himself grandly as "a surgeon to old shoes", and gives a perfectly reasonable account of why he is in the street: "we make holiday to see Caesar and to rejoice in his triumph." Marullus's answer is the long speech of reproach that reminds them how they once waited all day to see Pompey and now strew flowers before the man who comes "in triumph over Pompey's blood". The result, Flavius observes, is that "They vanish tongue-tied in their guiltiness." A speech has turned a crowd.

In Scene 2 the crowd is heard, not seen: three shouts offstage, each of which Brutus and Cassius interpret with anxiety. Casca then describes the people in the marketplace in language of pure contempt, "the rabblement hooted and clapped their chopped hands and threw up their sweaty nightcaps", and notes that they behave towards Caesar exactly as audiences behave towards actors, clapping and hissing "according as he pleased and displeased them, as they use to do the players in the theatre". Cassius, in Scene 3, is still harsher: Caesar would not be a wolf "But that he sees the Romans are but sheep", he "were no lion, were not Romans hinds" (hinds: female deer, and also a word for servants), and Rome itself is nothing but "What trash is Rome, / What rubbish, and what offal", base matter fit only to light a fire for Caesar.

Literary interpretation. Three things are being established. First, the crowd is *fickle*: it loved Pompey and now loves Caesar, and it can be shamed into silence by one speech and roused by another. Second, the crowd is *powerful*: the tribunes' fear, Brutus's fear and Cassius's bitterness are all, at bottom, fears of what the people's affection can do. Caesar is great because they cheer him. Third, the aristocrats on both sides *despise* the people even while depending on them, and the play will punish that contempt. Casca's comparison of politics to theatre is more than a joke: it tells you that in this Rome power is a performance and the crowd is

the audience whose applause decides who rules. When you reach Act 3, and watch the same crowd swing from Brutus to Antony in the space of two speeches, you will recognise what Act 1 has already shown you in miniature.

PROFESSOR'S INSIGHT Why the play opens with the crowd

Shakespeare could have opened in the Senate, or with Caesar, or with the conspirators. He opened with a cobbler making jokes. Consider what this does. The audience at the Globe in 1599 was itself a mixed crowd, with tradesmen and apprentices standing in the yard, and the first thing it saw was a stage full of tradesmen being told to go home by their betters. The comedy of the Cobbler's puns (soles and souls, mending shoes and mending men) invites the audience to side with the commoners against the humourless tribunes; then Marullus's great speech about Pompey swings the sympathy back, and we see the crowd as faithless. In the space of eighty lines Shakespeare has made the audience *feel* the crowd's fickleness from the inside, by making them fickle too. He has also made a structural promise. The play will begin and end with the question of whom the people love, and the Lupercalia shouts of Scene 2, the mob of Act 3 and the battles of Act 5 are all consequences of the fact established here: that in this Rome the people's affection is the real crown, and it can be put on and taken off in an afternoon. The opening is not a warm-up before the serious action. It is the thesis of the play, performed as a street argument.

Three graded summaries, and a warning about them

What follows are three summaries of Act 1 at three different lengths: a single connected page, a ten-minute structured walkthrough, and a one-minute paragraph with a chain diagram. Use them in this order the first time, then use whichever one you need before a revision session or an examination. But understand clearly what they are for. **They do not replace the detailed teaching in the scene chapters, the character chapters and the theme chapters that follow.** A summary tells you what happened; the chapters tell you what it means, why Shakespeare built it that way, how it connects to the rest of the play, and how to write about it. A student who learns only the summaries will write answers that retell the plot, and plot-retelling is the single most common reason for low marks in literature papers. Treat these pages as the skeleton on which the rest of the book hangs flesh.

ACT 1 IN ONE PAGE

It is a holiday in Rome. Caesar has returned victorious from Spain, where he destroyed the last army of Pompey's sons, and the city has turned out to celebrate his triumph; by Shakespeare's compression it is also the feast of Lupercalia. Two tribunes, Flavius and Marullus, find the streets full of tradesmen in their best clothes and are furious. A quick-witted Cobbler fences with them in puns before admitting that the people have come "to see Caesar and to rejoice in his triumph". Marullus explodes. Have they forgotten Pompey, for whom they once waited all day on rooftops? Now they scatter flowers before the man "That comes in triumph over Pompey's blood". The crowd slinks off in shame, and the tribunes split up to strip the decorations from Caesar's statues, Flavius arguing that if Caesar's "growing feathers" are plucked he will fly at "an ordinary pitch" instead of soaring above them all.

Caesar enters in procession with his wife Calpurnia, Antony dressed for the ritual race, Brutus, Cassius, Casca, Cicero and others. He publicly asks Antony to touch Calpurnia during the race, since tradition says this cures barrenness. A Soothsayer calls from the crowd, "Beware the ides of March." Caesar has him brought forward, hears the warning again, and dismisses him: "He is a dreamer. Let us leave him. Pass."

The procession moves on to the games, but Brutus stays behind, saying he is "not gamesome", and Cassius stays with him. Cassius complains that Brutus has grown cold towards him; Brutus confesses that he is troubled by private "passions of some difference" and "with himself at war". Cassius offers to be Brutus's mirror and show him the worth he cannot see in himself. A shout is heard from the games, and Brutus blurts out his fear that the people "Choose Caesar for their king", adding at once that he loves Caesar well. Brutus declares he values honour above death; Cassius seizes the word and makes "honour ... the subject of my story". He tells how Caesar once challenged him to swim the Tiber and had to be rescued, crying "Help me, Cassius, or I sink!", and how Caesar shook with fever in Spain and begged for drink "As a sick girl". A second shout. Cassius pictures Caesar as a "Colossus" under whose legs "we petty men" creep, insists that "The fault, dear Brutus, is not in our stars, / But in ourselves", weighs the names 'Brutus' and 'Caesar' and finds them equal, and reminds Brutus of the ancestor who would have endured the devil in Rome sooner than a king. Brutus, moved but cautious, promises to consider all this and to meet again, adding that he would rather be a villager than a Roman under such conditions.

Caesar returns from the games looking angry, his followers "like a chidden train". He tells Antony he distrusts "lean and hungry" men like Cassius, who think too much, then insists he fears nothing, "for always I am Caesar", and asks Antony to come to his right side because his left ear is deaf. Brutus and Cassius detain Casca, who reports in sour prose that Antony offered Caesar a crown three times, that Caesar refused it each time, though "he would fain have had it", that the stinking crowd cheered the refusals, and that Caesar then fainted in the marketplace, "foamed at mouth and was speechless". Cicero spoke Greek, "it was Greek to me", and the tribunes Marullus and Flavius have been "put to silence" for stripping the statues. Casca agrees to dine with Cassius. Alone, Cassius gloats that Brutus's "honourable mettle may be wrought" and plans to throw forged letters, as if from citizens, through Brutus's windows that night.

A month later, on the night before the Ides of March, a storm of impossible violence breaks over Rome. Casca, sword drawn, tells Cicero of wonders: a slave's hand burning unharmed, a lion by the Capitol, women who saw men of fire in the streets, an owl shrieking at noon. Cicero remarks drily that "men may construe things after their fashion" and goes home. Cassius arrives, boasting that he has bared his chest to the lightning. He reads the storm as heaven's warning about a man "Most like this dreadful night", and Casca names Caesar. Casca reports a rumour that the Senate will crown Caesar king tomorrow. Cassius declares he will free himself with his dagger first, scorns the Romans, who make Caesar a wolf by being "but sheep", and Casca gives his hand to the cause. Cassius reveals that other noble Romans wait at Pompey's Porch. Cinna hurries in, longing for "the noble Brutus" to join them; Cassius gives him the forged letters to plant in Brutus's chair, window and ancestral statue. Casca observes that Brutus's reputation will turn their crime into virtue, and the two set off, after midnight, to secure Brutus before dawn.

ACT 1 IN TEN MINUTES

This walkthrough follows the act scene by scene and, for each movement, tells you what happens and what to notice. 'Notice' points are where the marks live.

Scene 1 — A street in Rome: the tribunes and the crowd

What happens. Flavius and Marullus, tribunes of the people, discover the streets full of working men who have taken an unofficial holiday. They demand to know the men's trades. A Carpenter answers plainly; a Cobbler answers in riddling puns about soles, mending and awls, and finally explains that everyone has come out to cheer Caesar's triumph. Marullus delivers a long, furious speech reminding them of their old devotion to Pompey and condemning their ingratitude; he sends them home to pray that the gods will "intermit the plague"

(intermit: hold back) that such ingratitude deserves. The commoners leave in silence. The tribunes resolve to go through the city removing the "ceremonies" from Caesar's statues, and Flavius closes the scene with the image of Caesar as a hawk whose feathers must be plucked.

What to notice. - The commoners speak **prose**; the tribunes speak **verse**. Shakespeare marks class and tone through the form of the lines before you have understood a word. - The Cobbler is cleverer than his questioners. His puns ("a mender of bad soles"; "I can mend you") are small acts of insolence, and the tribunes' irritation shows that their authority is already weak. - Marullus's speech works by **contrast** and **rhetorical question**: then (Pompey) against now (Caesar), and a chain of "And do you now ... ?" questions that pile up guilt. Learn its shape; it is the first great persuasive speech in a play built of them. - The crowd that was cheering a minute ago leaves "tongue-tied in their guiltiness". This is the first demonstration of the people's fickleness, and you will refer back to it from Act 3. - Caesar never appears. The scene is *about* him, and his absence is deliberate.

Scene 2, first movement — The procession and the Soothsayer

What happens. Caesar enters with his train. He tells Antony, who is about to run the Lupercalia race, to touch Calpurnia so that she may "Shake off their sterile curse". Antony promises obedience. A Soothsayer cries out from the crowd; Caesar stops, has him brought forward, hears "Beware the ides of March" twice, and dismisses him as "a dreamer".

What to notice. - Caesar's first words are about a private matter, his wife's childlessness, spoken as public business. Watch how he treats the city as an extension of himself. - He refers to himself in the **third person**: "Caesar is turned to hear." This habit is a key to his character. - The warning is given, repeated and refused. The Soothsayer is the voice of a future the audience already knows; Caesar's dismissal is the first of many refusals to listen. - Casca is the one calling for silence when Caesar speaks. Note that the man who will strike first is here acting as Caesar's usher.

Scene 2, second movement — Cassius works on Brutus

What happens. Everyone leaves for the games except Brutus and Cassius. In a long dialogue, interrupted twice by offstage shouts, Cassius moves Brutus step by step from friendly puzzlement to a cautious promise. The steps are: a complaint about Brutus's coldness; Brutus's admission of inner conflict; the mirror image; the first shout and Brutus's fear of a king; Brutus's declaration about honour; Cassius's two anecdotes of Caesar's physical weakness (the Tiber, the fever); the second shout; the Colossus image and "The fault, dear Brutus, is not in our stars"; the comparison of names; the appeal to Brutus's ancestor; Brutus's measured reply and his promise to meet again.

What to notice. - Brutus is troubled *before* Cassius begins. His phrase "with himself at war" is the condition Cassius exploits, not something Cassius creates. - Every one of Cassius's arguments attacks the *gap* between Caesar's reputation and his body. He never argues that Caesar has done wrong; he argues that Caesar is no better than they are. - The **offstage shouts** are a stage device that does Cassius's work for him. Each cheer from the crowd makes Brutus more anxious and more receptive. - Brutus says very little, but what he says is decisive: "I would not, Cassius, yet I love him well", and the lines on honour and death. An examiner will expect you to know that Brutus handed Cassius the key. - The scene ends not with a yes but with a promise to think. That restraint is Brutus's character in one gesture.

Scene 2, third movement — Caesar returns; Casca's report; Cassius's soliloquy

What happens. Caesar comes back from the games visibly angry, his train "chidden", Calpurnia pale, Cicero red-eyed. Caesar tells Antony he distrusts Cassius's "lean and hungry look", analyses him with precision, denies any fear, and asks Antony to speak into his good ear. When the procession passes, Brutus and Cassius pull Casca aside. In blunt prose Casca describes how Antony offered Caesar a crown ("one of these coronets") three times, how Caesar refused each time with growing reluctance, how the crowd cheered the refusals, and how Caesar then fainted, foaming at the mouth. He adds that Caesar, before falling, offered the crowd his throat to cut, that Cicero spoke Greek, and that Marullus and Flavius have been silenced. Casca leaves; Brutus departs after arranging to meet Cassius tomorrow; Cassius, alone, reveals his plan to forge letters in several hands and throw them in at Brutus's windows.

What to notice. - Caesar's analysis of Cassius is **correct in every detail** and is then overridden by his vanity. This pattern, insight cancelled by pride, is the Caesar you must be able to describe. - "for always I am Caesar" followed immediately by "this ear is deaf" is one of the sharpest juxtapositions in the play: the public name and the private body in two consecutive lines. - The crown scene is **reported, not shown**. Shakespeare lets us see it only through Casca's contemptuous eyes, so that we never know whether Caesar truly wanted the crown. Casca says "to my thinking, he would fain have had it"; that is an opinion, and you must present it as one. - Casca's prose is a mask. Cassius calls his "rudeness ... a sauce to his good wit"; Brutus remembers him as "quick mettle" at school. The blunt manner hides a sharp observer. - The soliloquy is the only time in Act 1 that a character speaks alone. It tells you the conspiracy will be built on forgery, and it should colour every later claim the conspirators make about honour.

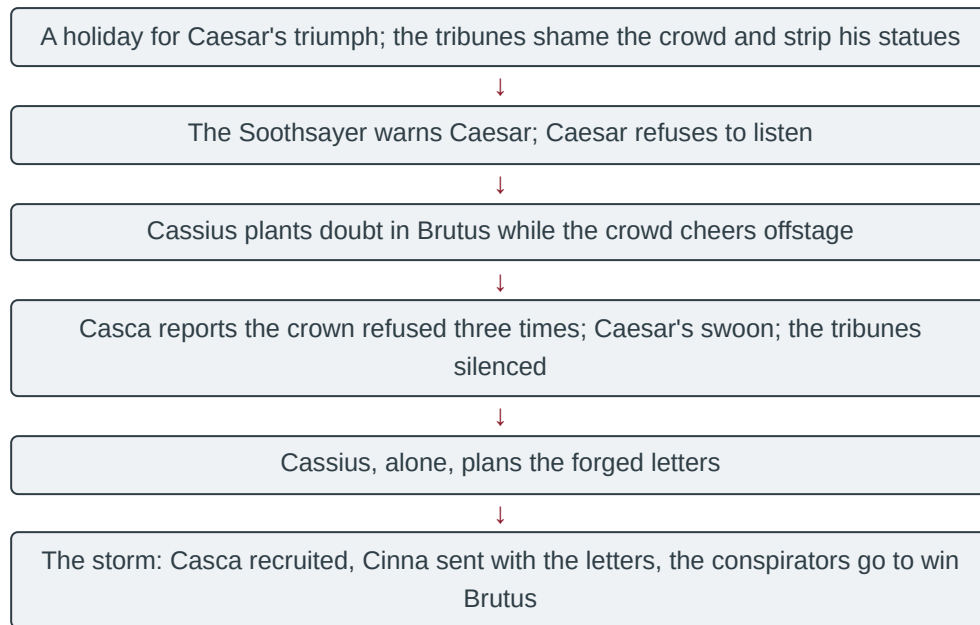
Scene 3 — The storm: Casca, Cicero, Cassius, Cinna

What happens. A month has passed; it is the night before the Ides of March. Thunder and lightning. Casca, sword drawn and breathless, tells Cicero of supernatural sights. Cicero answers that men interpret things to suit themselves, asks whether Caesar will go to the Capitol tomorrow (he will), and leaves. Cassius enters, exhilarated by the storm, and rebukes Casca for fearing it. He explains the portents as heaven's warning against a man grown "prodigious" like the night itself; Casca guesses Caesar. Casca reports the rumour that the Senate will make Caesar king tomorrow. Cassius vows that his dagger will free him from bondage, and launches into a bitter attack on Romans who make Caesar great because "the Romans are but sheep". Casca offers his hand. Cassius reveals that conspirators wait at Pompey's Porch. Cinna arrives, asks whether they can win "the noble Brutus", and is sent to plant the forged letters. Cassius and Casca go to visit Brutus before dawn, Casca noting that Brutus's good name will turn their offence into virtue.

What to notice. - The storm is **read three ways**: as divine anger (Casca), as nothing certain (Cicero), as a political portrait of Caesar and a call to action (Cassius). The scene is a lesson in interpretation itself. - Cassius, who told Brutus that fate is "not in our stars", now uses the heavens as evidence. He is not a consistent philosopher; he is a persuader who uses whatever lies to hand. - The rumour of a crown "In every place save here in Italy" gives the plot a deadline. Act 1 ends with the clock running. - Cassius recruits Casca by a different method from the one he used on Brutus: shame about manliness ("womanish"), contempt for the crowd, and a theatrical display of courage. Compare the two methods; the comparison is the heart of the Cassius chapter. - Everyone agrees that the conspiracy needs Brutus. The act closes with the conspirators going to collect him, and the forged letters already on their way.

ACT 1 IN ONE MINUTE

Rome celebrates Caesar's victory over Pompey's sons, but two tribunes shame the fickle crowd and strip Caesar's statues. At the Lupercalia a Soothsayer warns Caesar to "Beware the ides of March"; Caesar dismisses him as "a dreamer". Cassius works on the troubled Brutus, using Caesar's physical weaknesses, the equality of their names and the memory of Brutus's king-expelling ancestor to argue that "The fault ... is not in our stars, / But in ourselves". Casca reports that Caesar thrice refused a crown and then fainted; the tribunes have been silenced. Alone, Cassius plans forged letters. A month later, in a night of portents, Cassius recruits Casca, sends Cinna to plant the letters, and sets off with the conspirators to secure Brutus before dawn.



CROSS-REFERENCE Where this map leads

Everything above is sharpened in the chapters that follow. The three scene chapters teach the text line by line. *Caesar in Act 1: A Character Masterclass*, *Cassius: The Manipulation Masterclass* and *Brutus in Act 1: Honour, Conflict and Vulnerability* develop sections G to J of this chapter into full studies. *The Soothsayer, the Ides of March, and the Supporting Cast* covers the figures in the lower half of the character table. The two Themes chapters develop section C. *The Scene Connection Engine* and *Where Act 1 Reappears Later* shows how each item in the chain diagram above pays off in Acts 2 to 5, which is where your Class 10 board paper will need it.

ICSE EXAM BOX How this chapter earns marks

Exam-oriented advice. Act 1 is the Class IX portion of the ICSE syllabus; the Class X board paper sets its extract questions from Acts III to V. That does not make this chapter optional. Board extract questions regularly ask what has happened earlier, why a character behaves as he does, or what a phrase refers to, and the answers lie in Act 1: Brutus's divided loyalty, Cassius's envy and forgery, Antony's loyalty, Caesar's refusal of the Soothsayer, the crowd's fickleness. A one-mark MCQ may hinge on knowing who offered the crown or who said "it was Greek to me". The mental map you have built here is what lets you answer those sub-questions quickly and accurately, so that your time and attention go to the longer analytical parts where the real marks are. No question is guaranteed; preparation that covers the causes as well as the events is what the paper consistently rewards.

CHAPTER 2

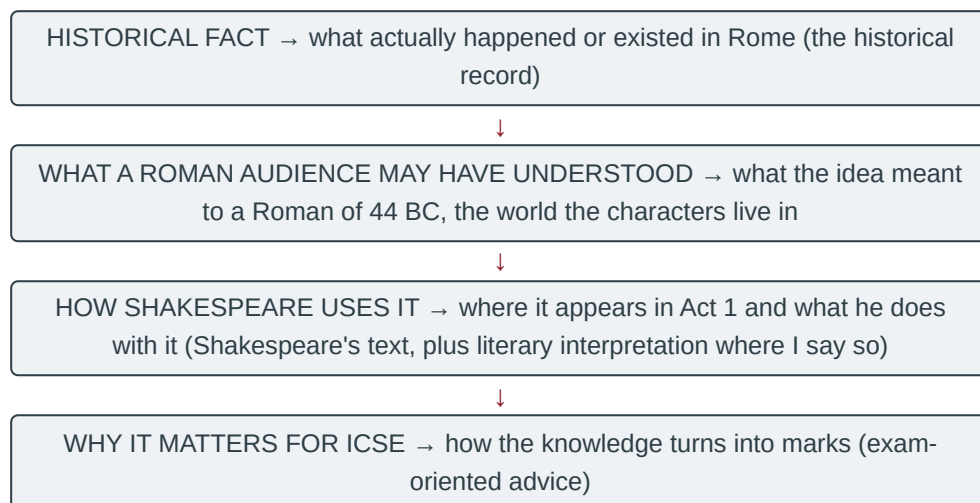
Roman History Before Act 1: Only What You Need, Taught Properly

This chapter gives you the Roman background without which Act 1 looks like a group of grown men panicking over a hat. It teaches only what the three scenes of Act 1 actually depend on: how the Republic worked, what Romans valued and feared, how Caesar climbed to the top, and what two public ceremonies, the triumph and the Lupercalia, meant to the people watching them. Every item is tied back to the play through the same four-step chain, so that history never floats free of the text. At the end, a timeline and a section on what Shakespeare deliberately changed will make you the rare student who can tell the historical record from Shakespeare's invention, which is exactly the habit an examiner rewards.

Why a Literature Student Needs Any of This

Let me be direct about a problem you may have felt since Class 9. When you read Act 1 Scene 1, two officials shout at some workmen for taking a holiday. In Scene 2, you are told that a man has been offered a crown three times and has refused it three times, and the whole city seems to lose its mind. In Scene 3, respectable senators stand in a thunderstorm plotting murder because of a rumour about a crown. If you do not know Rome, all of this looks like over-reaction. If you do know Rome, every one of these moments becomes tense, logical and frightening. That is the difference this chapter makes.

You do not need a history degree. You need roughly twenty ideas, taught properly and always connected to the words Shakespeare actually wrote. For each idea I will use the same four-step chain:



Keep one distinction alive throughout: **HISTORICAL RECORD** is what the ancient sources and modern historians tell us; **SHAKESPEARE'S TEXT** is what the play says; **LITERARY INTERPRETATION** is how critics read the gap between the two. Examiners are impressed by a student who knows which of the three they are talking about. They are unimpressed by a student who writes 'Caesar was killed in the Capitol' as history, because he was not, as you will see.

ICSE EXAM BOX How this chapter earns marks honestly

Act 1 is the Class IX portion of the ICSE syllabus; the Class X board paper sets its drama extracts from Acts III, IV and V. So you will not be asked to write an essay on the Roman Senate. But the Class X questions constantly assume Act 1 knowledge: what motivated Brutus, why Cassius hates Caesar, why the crowd matters, what 'the work the ides of March begun' refers to. Every historical idea in this chapter is chosen because it feeds an Act 3, 4 or 5 answer, and I will say so each time. Treat the history as a tool for reading, not as a separate subject to memorise.

The Machinery of the Republic

The Roman Republic

HISTORICAL RECORD. Rome was, according to its own tradition, ruled by kings for its first two and a half centuries. In 509 BC the last king was driven out, and the Romans built a system designed to make sure that no single person could ever hold that kind of power again. They called it the *res publica*, literally 'the public thing' or 'the public business', the origin of our word 'republic'. The idea was that the state belonged to the citizens collectively, not to one family. Power was divided among many elected officials (magistrates), held for short terms (usually one year), and always shared between colleagues who could block one another. The Senate, a council of senior men, advised; the assemblies of citizens voted; and the whole structure ran for over four centuries before it collapsed in the lifetime of the men you meet in Act 1.

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR THE PLAY. Everything Cassius and Brutus say about 'Rome' assumes that Rome is a Republic and that a Republic is the only honourable form of government for a free people. When Cassius cries "Rome, thou hast lost the breed of noble bloods!", he is not lamenting a lack of aristocrats. He is saying that the Republic has stopped producing men who will defend it. When Brutus says he "had rather be a villager / Than to repute himself a son of Rome / Under these hard conditions as this time / Is like to lay upon us", the 'hard conditions' are the death of the Republic. A 'villager' here means a nobody from a country village; Brutus would rather be a nobody in a free village than a famous man in an unfree Rome.

HISTORICAL FACT → From 509 BC Rome was a republic: power divided among annually elected magistrates, advised by the Senate, with laws voted by citizen assemblies; no king.



WHAT A ROMAN AUDIENCE MAY HAVE UNDERSTOOD → The Republic was not just a system but an identity. To be Roman was to be a citizen of a free state; a Roman who bowed to a single master had stopped being fully Roman.



HOW SHAKESPEARE USES IT → The word 'Rome' in Act 1 always means 'the free Republic'. Cassius's "Rome, thou hast lost the breed of noble bloods!" and Brutus's "Brutus had rather be a villager" only make sense if losing the Republic means losing Rome itself.



WHY IT MATTERS FOR ICSE → When an Act 3 or 4 question asks why Brutus joined the conspiracy, the correct core answer is not 'jealousy' but 'to preserve the Republic'. Act 1 is where the play establishes that Rome and the Republic are the same thing in Brutus's mind.

The Senate

HISTORICAL RECORD. The Senate was the Republic's council of elders, several hundred men who had held public office. Senators were not elected to the Senate; they entered it by winning election to a magistracy and then stayed for life unless expelled. Technically the Senate only 'advised', but in practice its advice controlled money, foreign policy, the assignment of armies and the running of the provinces. It sat in a building called the *Curia* (the Senate house), and it could also meet in any consecrated space, including a temple. One detail you will need later: the old Senate house had burned down in a riot in 52 BC and its replacement was still unfinished in 44 BC, so the Senate was meeting in borrowed halls, among them a hall attached to Pompey's theatre. That is where Caesar actually died. The Senate's authority (*auctoritas*, a word we will return to) rested on tradition and prestige rather than on formal law, which is exactly why a man with a private army could ignore it.

Caesar enlarged the Senate with his own supporters, which the old families resented as a dilution of their dignity. By 44 BC the Senate was full of men who owed Caesar their seats, yet it was also the body through which the conspirators would have to work, and the place where they finally killed him.

SHAKESPEARE'S TEXT. Act 1 refers to senators several times. Brutus describes Cicero looking "with such ferret and such fiery eyes / As we have seen him in the Capitol, / Being crossed in conference by some senators": a 'ferret' has small red angry eyes, so Cicero looks furious; 'crossed in conference' means contradicted in debate. In Act 1 Scene 3 Casca reports the rumour that "the Senators tomorrow / Mean to establish Caesar as a king, / And he shall wear his crown by sea and land / In every place save here in Italy." Notice the odd detail: a king everywhere except Italy. This reflects a real ancient rumour that Caesar might be made king over the provinces while remaining a mere dictator at home; whatever its truth, Shakespeare uses it to show that the Senate, the guardian of the Republic, is itself feared to be about to betray it.

HISTORICAL FACT → The Senate was a lifelong council of ex-magistrates; it advised rather than commanded, but its prestige made it the real centre of government. Caesar packed it with his own men.



WHAT A ROMAN AUDIENCE MAY HAVE UNDERSTOOD → A Senate that voted honours to one man was surrendering the Republic. A rumour that senators would crown Caesar would sound like the guardians handing over the keys.



HOW SHAKESPEARE USES IT → Casca's rumour that "the Senators tomorrow / Mean to establish Caesar as a king" is the fuse that lights Cassius's dagger speech. Shakespeare never confirms the rumour; the conspirators act on fear, not fact.



WHY IT MATTERS FOR ICSE → The Senate meeting on the Ides (Act 3 Scene 1) is the climax of the play. Knowing that the senators were expected to crown Caesar that day explains why the murder happens there and then, and why the conspirators believe they are acting for the Senate's own honour.

Consuls

HISTORICAL RECORD. At the top of the yearly ladder of offices stood two consuls. Two, never one: each could veto the other, and each served for exactly one year, after which he could not normally hold the office again for a decade. The consuls commanded armies, presided over the Senate and gave their names to the year. The whole design is a machine for preventing kingship: split the top job in half and make it expire every twelve months.

Caesar was consul in 59 BC, and again in 48, 46, 45 and 44 BC, the last time with Mark Antony as his colleague. The historical Antony who runs in the Lupercalia in Act 1 Scene 2 is therefore not a young playboy but the serving consul of Rome, one of the two highest officials in the state, stripped for a religious footrace and, according to Plutarch, offering a crown to his colleague. A Roman would have found the sight both comic and alarming.

SHAKESPEARE'S TEXT. Shakespeare never uses the word 'consul' in Act 1, and does not tell you Antony holds the office. Instead he shows you the relationship. When Caesar gives an order, Antony replies, "I shall remember. / When Caesar says 'Do this,' it is performed." Historically the two men were equal in rank; in the play one commands and the other obeys. That is the point. The Republic's most carefully designed safeguard, two equal consuls, has silently collapsed into master and servant.

HISTORICAL FACT → Two consuls, elected annually, each able to block the other; the office existed to make one-man rule impossible. In 44 BC the consuls were Caesar and Antony.



WHAT A ROMAN AUDIENCE MAY HAVE UNDERSTOOD → A consul was the embodiment of shared power. A consul who behaved as another man's servant showed that the safeguard had failed.



HOW SHAKESPEARE USES IT → Antony's "When Caesar says 'Do this,' it is performed" turns a constitutional equal into an instrument. Shakespeare shows the collapse of the system through tone, not through a history lesson.



WHY IT MATTERS FOR ICSE → Antony's absolute loyalty here is the seed of his revenge in Act 3 and his rise in Acts 4 and 5. If a question asks how Antony is presented before the assassination, this single line is your evidence.

Tribunes of the Plebs: Flavius and Marullus

HISTORICAL RECORD. The tribunes of the plebs were the strangest and, for our purposes, the most important office in Rome. They were created after the plebeians, the ordinary citizens, walked out of the city in protest in 494 BC (the 'first secession of the plebs'). To bring them back, the aristocracy agreed that the plebeians could elect their own officers, whose job was to protect them from abuse by magistrates. By the late Republic there were ten tribunes a year, and only a plebeian could hold the office.

Three features made the tribune unique. First, **sacrosanctity**: the person of a tribune was sacred, and anyone who laid hands on him could be killed without trial. Second, the **veto** (Latin *intercessio*, 'stepping between'): a single tribune could halt a law, an election or a decree of the Senate simply by saying no. Third, the **right of help** (*ius auxilii*): any citizen threatened by a magistrate could appeal to a tribune, who would physically interpose himself. The tribune was, in short, the people's shield against the powerful. Ambitious men later discovered that the office could be used for their own ends, and both Caesar and Pompey relied on friendly tribunes, but the original idea never faded: the tribune stood for the ordinary Roman against the great.

In 44 BC two tribunes, Gaius Epidius Marullus and Lucius Caesetius Flavius, removed a diadem (a white royal headband) that someone had placed on a statue of Caesar, and arrested men who hailed Caesar as *rex*, 'king'. Plutarch says the crowd cheered them and called them 'Brutuses', after the man who had expelled the last king. Caesar had them stripped of their office; Suetonius adds that they were removed from the Senate. Note the date: by most modern reconstructions this happened in January 44 BC, before the Lupercalia, though Plutarch narrates the two events together, which is what Shakespeare read.

SHAKESPEARE'S TEXT. Act 1 Scene 1 belongs to the tribunes. They open the play with a rebuke that is really a piece of Roman law: "Hence! Home, you idle creatures, get you home! / Is this a holiday? What, know you not, / Being mechanical, you ought not walk / Upon a labouring day without the sign / Of your profession?" ('Mechanical' means a manual worker; 'the sign of your profession' means the tools and apron that identified a tradesman.) Two guardians of the people are scolding the very people they exist to protect, because those people are cheering a man who threatens the Republic. That is the bitter irony of the scene.

Their method is Roman to the core. Flavius orders: "Disrobe the images / If you do find them decked with ceremonies." ('Images' are statues; 'ceremonies' here are the decorations, scarves and trophies hung on them.) Marullus hesitates, "May we do so? / You know it is the feast of Lupercal", and Flavius overrides him: "It is no matter. Let no images / Be hung with Caesar's trophies." This is precisely what the historical tribunes did: they

stripped royal symbols from Caesar's statues. Their motive is stated in the closing image of the scene: "These growing feathers plucked from Caesar's wing / Will make him fly an ordinary pitch, / Who else would soar above the view of men / And keep us all in servile fearfulness." (A 'pitch' is the height to which a hawk soars; 'servile' means slave-like.) Pull out the feathers of popular support and Caesar will fly at an ordinary height like any other Roman.

Then Shakespeare delivers the consequence with terrible economy. In Scene 2, Casca mentions almost in passing that "Marullus and Flavius, for pulling scarves off Caesar's images, are put to silence." The phrase is deliberately vague. Historically they lost their office; in the play the words could mean dismissal, exile or death, and Shakespeare leaves it open. What is not open is the meaning: the sacred, untouchable protectors of the people have been silenced by one man, and nobody in the play protests. The Republic's immune system has been switched off.

TEXT NOTE The tribunes' names

The historical tribunes were Gaius Epidius Marullus and Lucius Caesetius Flavius. North's Plutarch gave Shakespeare 'Flavius' and 'Marullus'; the First Folio prints 'Murellus', which some modern editions keep. Your ICSE edition almost certainly prints 'Marullus', and that is the form used throughout this book. It is worth knowing the variant only so that a different spelling in another book does not confuse you.

PROFESSOR'S INSIGHT Why the tribunes are the Republic's immune system

A school guide will tell you that Flavius and Marullus 'represent opposition to Caesar'. That is true and shallow. The deeper point is what kind of opposition they represent. A tribune was sacrosanct: to harm him was sacrilege. His veto could stop the Senate itself. He existed for one purpose, to stand between the ordinary Roman and the powerful. If any office could resist a would-be king by legal means, it was this one. So when Shakespeare shows the tribunes acting exactly as the constitution intended, stripping royal decorations from statues and dispersing an illegal holiday, and then has them "put to silence" within a single scene, he is demonstrating that the Republic's legal defences have already failed before the play's third scene begins. This is why Cassius can argue in Scene 3 that the only remedy left is the dagger: "I know where I will wear this dagger then." Read this way, Scene 1 is not a comic warm-up; it is a proof that lawful resistance is dead. Many critics also note the irony that the people's protectors are shouting at the people. One strong reading is that Shakespeare uses this to introduce, in the first minute, the theme that dominates Act 3: the crowd cannot be relied upon to defend its own liberty, and those who try to defend it on the crowd's behalf are destroyed.

HISTORICAL FACT → Tribunes of the plebs were sacrosanct officers with a veto and a duty to protect ordinary citizens. In 44 BC the tribunes Marullus and Flavus removed a diadem from Caesar's statue and were deposed by Caesar.



WHAT A ROMAN AUDIENCE MAY HAVE UNDERSTOOD → Deposing a tribune was an assault on the sacred protection of the people; it showed that Caesar's power now stood above the law itself.



HOW SHAKESPEARE USES IT → Scene 1 shows the tribunes doing their constitutional duty ("Disrobe the images"); Scene 2 disposes of them in one line ("are put to silence"). Lawful resistance is shown to be useless, which drives the conspiracy toward violence.



WHY IT MATTERS FOR ICSE → Class IX extract questions on Scene 1 often ask why the tribunes are angry and what they intend to do about the decorated statues. For Class X, the silencing of the tribunes is your earliest evidence that Caesar is a threat to liberty, which is what Brutus argues in Act 3 Scene 2.

Patricians

HISTORICAL RECORD. The patricians were the old aristocratic clans of Rome, families who claimed descent from the founding fathers of the city. In the early Republic they monopolised the priestships, the Senate and the consulship. Over two centuries the plebeians fought their way into every office, and by the late Republic patrician birth carried prestige rather than legal privilege. Caesar himself was a patrician of the ancient Julian clan, which claimed descent from the goddess Venus through Aeneas. Note the twist for the play: the man accused of wanting to be king was of the most ancient blood in Rome, while Brutus, Cassius and Antony, the men who surround him in the play, belonged to families that had risen from the plebeian side into the nobility.

SHAKESPEARE'S TEXT AND INTERPRETATION. Shakespeare does not use the word 'patrician' in Act 1, but he plays on ancestry constantly. Cassius calls Aeneas "our great ancestor" (Aeneas was the Trojan hero who, in Virgil's *Aeneid*, carried his aged father Anchises out of burning Troy and became the legendary forefather of the Romans) when describing how he carried the exhausted Caesar out of the Tiber "as Aeneas, our great ancestor, / Did from the flames of Troy upon his shoulder / The old Anchises bear". The joke, if you know Rome, is sharp: Aeneas was Caesar's family's special ancestor, and Cassius casts himself as the hero and Caesar as the feeble old father being carried. Cassius steals Caesar's own pedigree.

HISTORICAL FACT → Patricians were the ancient aristocratic clans; by 44 BC their status was prestige, not power. Caesar was a patrician whose family claimed descent from Venus and Aeneas.



WHAT A ROMAN AUDIENCE MAY HAVE UNDERSTOOD → Noble birth gave a man standing, but the Republic expected him to earn his place through service; birth alone was not a licence to rule.



HOW SHAKESPEARE USES IT → Cassius's comparison of himself to "Aeneas, our great ancestor" quietly appropriates Caesar's own family legend and recasts Caesar as the helpless Anchises.



WHY IT MATTERS FOR ICSE → In character questions on Cassius, the Tiber anecdote is standard evidence of his envy; knowing the Aeneas detail lets you add a genuinely analytical point about how he manipulates ancestry.

Plebeians

HISTORICAL RECORD. The plebeians were every Roman citizen who was not a patrician: rich merchants and poor labourers alike. In the early Republic they struggled for legal equality, winning the tribunate, access to the consulship and finally, in 287 BC, the rule that the decisions of the plebeian assembly bound the whole state. By the first century BC, however, 'the plebs' in everyday speech had come to mean the urban poor of Rome: the crowds in the Forum, dependent on the grain supply, entertained by games, and courted by ambitious politicians with money, food and spectacle. Caesar built his career on their support.

SHAKESPEARE'S TEXT. The commoners of Act 1 Scene 1 are Shakespeare's plebeians. The Carpenter and the Cobbler speak prose while the tribunes speak verse, a class marker an Elizabethan audience heard instantly. The Cobbler's puns are cheerful and clever, and he is not stupid. He explains that they "make holiday to see Caesar and to rejoice in his triumph." Marullus's fury is aimed at their fickleness: the same people once cheered Pompey until "Tiber trembled underneath her banks", and now they "strew flowers in his way / That comes in triumph over Pompey's blood". Casca's report in Scene 2 pushes the contempt further. He calls the crowd "the rabblement" (a mob), "the tag-rag people" (ragged riff-raff) and "the common herd", and says they clapped and hissed Caesar "as they use to do the players in the theatre". Note that all of this contempt comes from aristocratic mouths; Shakespeare lets you decide whether it is fair.

HISTORICAL FACT → Plebeians were the non-patrician citizens; by the late Republic the word usually meant the urban poor, whose support Caesar had cultivated for years.



WHAT A ROMAN AUDIENCE MAY HAVE UNDERSTOOD → The plebs were the sovereign people in theory and a manageable crowd in practice; whoever fed and entertained them could count on their cheers.



HOW SHAKESPEARE USES IT → The prose-speaking commoners of Scene 1, and Casca's "rabblement" and "tag-rag people" in Scene 2, establish a crowd that is loud, changeable and easily played to, long before Antony plays to it in Act 3.



WHY IT MATTERS FOR ICSE → The theme of the fickle mob runs from Act 1 Scene 1 to the murder of Cinna the poet in Act 3 Scene 3. Marullus's speech is the first evidence for that theme and should be in your notes for any question on the crowd.

Roman Citizenship

HISTORICAL RECORD. To be a Roman citizen (*civis Romanus*) was a legal status with real content: the right to vote in the assemblies, to stand for office, to make a legally valid marriage, to own property under Roman law, and, most cherished of all, protection against arbitrary punishment by a magistrate. A citizen could not lawfully be flogged or executed without trial; a slave could be. The gulf between citizen and slave was the deepest line in Roman society, and citizenship was jealously guarded, then gradually extended: to all Italians after a bitter war (the Social War of 91–88 BC), and by Caesar to the people of northern Italy in 49 BC.

SHAKESPEARE'S TEXT. Listen to how often Act 1 treats being Roman as a birthright of freedom. Cassius insists, "I was born free as Caesar; so were you". In Scene 3, challenged in the dark with "Who's there?", Casca answers simply, "A Roman." Cassius's whole rhetoric works by contrasting citizens with slaves: he describes Romans "groaning underneath this age's yoke" (a yoke is the wooden bar laid across the necks of oxen), says "Our yoke and sufferance show us womanish" ('sufferance' means patient endurance), and speaks of himself as being in "bondage". To a Roman, a citizen in bondage is a contradiction in terms; that contradiction is what Cassius wants Brutus and Casca to feel.

HISTORICAL FACT → Roman citizenship guaranteed votes, legal marriage, property rights and protection from summary punishment; the citizen-slave divide was absolute.



WHAT A ROMAN AUDIENCE MAY HAVE UNDERSTOOD → A free citizen who had to bow to one man had been reduced to something like a slave; the language of bondage was the strongest insult a Roman could feel.



HOW SHAKESPEARE USES IT → "I was born free as Caesar", "A Roman.", "this age's yoke" and "bondage": Cassius builds his case entirely on the shame of a citizen living like a slave.



WHY IT MATTERS FOR ICSE → When Brutus tells the crowd in Act 3 Scene 2 that Caesar's death was the price of their freedom, he is using exactly the citizen-versus-slave logic Cassius planted in Act 1. Quote Act 1 to show the argument's origin.

The Roman Mind: Values That Drive the Play

Roman Political Culture: *dignitas*, *gloria*, *auctoritas* and the *mos maiorum*

Four Latin words explain more about the behaviour of Caesar, Brutus and Cassius than any plot summary. Learn them simply.

Latin word	Simple meaning	How it drives Act 1
<i>dignitas</i>	A man's standing and worth in the eyes of others; his rank made visible	Caesar went to war in 49 BC rather than lose his <i>dignitas</i> ; Cassius cannot bear to "bend his body / If Caesar carelessly but nod on him"
<i>gloria</i>	Glory won by public deeds, especially in war, and remembered after death	The triumph in Scene 1 is <i>gloria</i> made into a parade; Cassius resents that Caesar should "bear the palm alone"
<i>auctoritas</i>	Moral authority; the weight a man's word carries without force	Brutus has <i>auctoritas</i> : Casca says his "countenance, like richest alchemy, / Will change to virtue and to worthiness" (alchemy: the medieval dream of turning base metal into gold)
<i>mos maiorum</i>	'The way of the ancestors': the unwritten code of how things are done	Cassius's appeal to "our fathers" and the first Brutus; Casca's belief that omens must be feared as "It is the part of men"

HISTORICAL RECORD. Roman politics was a competition for honour among a few hundred families. A Roman noble measured his life by *dignitas* and *gloria*, and the Republic worked because the competition was regulated: offices were shared, terms were short, and the *mos maiorum* set limits that no ambitious man was supposed to cross. Caesar himself wrote that his *dignitas* had always been dearer to him than life; that sentence explains the civil war. *Auctoritas* is subtler: it is the authority a man has because of who he is, so that people follow his lead without being ordered. The Senate had it as a body; a few individuals, such as Cicero, had it personally.

LITERARY INTERPRETATION. Notice how precisely Shakespeare distributes these qualities. Caesar has dignitas and gloria in excess. Cassius has wounded dignitas and no gloria of his own, which is why he keeps measuring himself against Caesar: "Weigh them, it is as heavy". Brutus has auctoritas, the one thing the conspiracy lacks, which is exactly why Cassius and Cinna need him: "O Cassius, if you could / But win the noble Brutus to our party". And the whole conspiracy justifies itself by the mos maiorum, the ancestors' hatred of kings. Once you see this, Act 1 becomes a study in the collision of four Roman values, not a set of personal grudges.

HISTORICAL FACT → Roman nobles competed for dignitas (standing), gloria (glory) and auctoritas (moral authority) within the limits set by the mos maiorum (ancestral custom).



WHAT A ROMAN AUDIENCE MAY HAVE UNDERSTOOD → A man whose dignitas was slighted had a duty to defend it; a man whose gloria outgrew the Republic was a danger to everyone else's.



HOW SHAKESPEARE USES IT → Cassius's resentment ("must bend his body / If Caesar carelessly but nod on him") is wounded dignitas; the conspirators' need for Brutus is a need for auctoritas; their appeal to "our fathers" is the mos maiorum.



WHY IT MATTERS FOR ICSE → These four words give you an analytical vocabulary for character questions that most students lack. Use them sparingly and explain them in one phrase each; examiners reward precision, not Latin for its own sake.

Republicanism

HISTORICAL RECORD. Republicanism, in the Roman sense, is the conviction that the state must belong to its citizens and that no individual may stand above the law. Its practical rules were the ones you have met: shared offices, annual terms, the veto, the Senate's collective wisdom, the people's vote. Its emotional core was pride: Romans believed their Republic had conquered the Mediterranean precisely because it was free, while the kingdoms of the East had fallen because they depended on one man.

SHAKESPEARE'S TEXT. Brutus is the play's republican conscience, and Act 1 gives you his creed in one exchange. Hearing the crowd shout, he says, "I do fear the people / Choose Caesar for their king." Cassius pounces: "Ay, do you fear it? / Then must I think you would not have it so." Brutus's reply is the moral centre of the whole play: "I would not, Cassius, yet I love him well." A republican may love a man and still refuse to let him be king. Brutus then defines his standard: "If it be aught toward the general good, / Set honour in one eye and death i' th' other / And I will look on both indifferently". ('Aught' means anything; 'the general good' means the public interest, which is the res publica itself put into English.)

HISTORICAL FACT → Roman republicanism held that the state belonged to the citizens and that no individual could stand above the law; Romans credited their freedom for their greatness.



WHAT A ROMAN AUDIENCE MAY HAVE UNDERSTOOD → Preferring the public good to private affection was the highest Roman virtue; the Republic's founding legend (below) was built on exactly that choice.



HOW SHAKESPEARE USES IT → "I would not, Cassius, yet I love him well" and "If it be aught toward the general good" make Brutus's republicanism personal and painful: he must choose between a friend and a principle.



WHY IT MATTERS FOR ICSE → Brutus's Act 3 Scene 2 argument that he loved Caesar but loved Rome more is the direct fulfilment of this Act 1 line. A strong Class X answer on Brutus's motives quotes both moments.

Roman Ideas of Liberty: *libertas*

HISTORICAL RECORD. *Libertas* did not mean 'doing as you please'. For a Roman it meant, first, not being a slave, and second, not being subject to the arbitrary will of a master (*dominatio*). A free people lived under laws it had made, spoke its mind in the Senate and the assembly, and could not be punished at one man's whim. The symbol of *libertas* was the *pileus*, the soft cap given to a slave on the day he was freed. After the assassination, Brutus issued a coin showing that cap between two daggers with the legend EID MAR, 'the Ides of March': liberty, in the conspirators' own iconography, was a freed slave's cap won by the knife.

SHAKESPEARE'S TEXT. Shakespeare's Cassius thinks in exactly these terms. He calls himself a slave of Caesar's greatness, "A wretched creature", who must bow "If Caesar carelessly but nod on him". His dagger speech in Scene 3 defines liberty as the power to end one's own subjection: "Cassius from bondage will deliver Cassius" and "That part of tyranny that I do bear / I can shake off at pleasure." Casca answers with the freed slave's logic: "So every bondman in his own hand bears / The power to cancel his captivity." (A 'bondman' is a slave; to 'cancel' a captivity is to annul it as one cancels a debt.) The words 'bondage', 'bondman', 'yoke' and 'tyranny' all belong to the Roman vocabulary of *libertas*.

HISTORICAL FACT → Libertas meant freedom from a master's arbitrary will and from slavery; its symbol was the freed slave's cap, which Brutus later stamped on his coins beside two daggers.



WHAT A ROMAN AUDIENCE MAY HAVE UNDERSTOOD → A citizen living under one man's nod had lost libertas whatever his wealth or rank; regaining it justified extreme action.



HOW SHAKESPEARE USES IT → "Cassius from bondage will deliver Cassius" and "every bondman in his own hand bears / The power to cancel his captivity" turn the conspiracy into an act of self-liberation before it is ever called murder.



WHY IT MATTERS FOR ICSE → The conspirators' cry of liberty after the killing in Act 3 Scene 1 is prepared here. If asked whether the conspirators were patriots or murderers, the Act 1 language of bondage is your evidence for their own self-understanding, which you may then question.

Fear of Monarchy: 509 BC and the First Brutus

HISTORICAL RECORD. Roman tradition held that the seventh and last king, Tarquin the Proud (Tarquinius Superbus), was a tyrant whose son raped a noblewoman, Lucretia. Lucius Junius Brutus, the king's own nephew, led the uprising that expelled the Tarquins in 509 BC, swore the people never to allow a king in Rome again, and became one of the first two consuls. The story continues darkly: when Brutus's own sons plotted to restore the king, he condemned them to death and watched the execution. Whatever its historical truth, this legend was Rome's founding myth of freedom, and it taught two lessons: the word *rex* is poison, and a true Roman puts the Republic above his own family.

Marcus Brutus, Shakespeare's Brutus, claimed descent from this man, and the people of 44 BC expected him to live up to the name. Ancient writers already noticed a difficulty in the pedigree, since the first Brutus was said to have killed his sons, but the claim was made and believed. The graffiti Plutarch reports on Brutus's praetor's chair (a praetor was the second-highest annual magistrate, a senior judge; Brutus and Cassius both held the office in 44 BC) and his ancestor's statue, messages to the effect of 'Brutus, are you asleep?' and 'You are no true Brutus', show how heavily the name weighed on him.

SHAKESPEARE'S TEXT. Cassius ends his great persuasion in Scene 2 with the ancestor: "O, you and I have heard our fathers say / There was a Brutus once that would have brooked / Th' eternal devil to keep his state in Rome / As easily as a king." ('Brooked' means tolerated; 'keep his state' means hold court in majesty.) The first Brutus would as soon have tolerated the Devil himself ruling Rome as a king. In Scene 3 Cassius tells Cinna to set a forged letter "with wax / Upon old Brutus' statue": Shakespeare has taken Plutarch's anonymous graffiti and made Cassius their author. Meanwhile, in Cassius's mouth, 'king' and 'tyrant' are treated as one word: "And why should Caesar be a tyrant, then?"

HISTORICAL CONTEXT The word rex

Rome's hatred of the title *rex* was so deep that even when Rome had emperors, from Augustus onward, they never called themselves kings. They ruled as 'first citizen' (*princeps*) and 'commander' (*imperator*), preserving the forms of the Republic because the word 'king' remained unsayable. Caesar's fatal error, in the eyes of many ancient and modern writers, was not his power but his failure to disguise it: the perpetual dictatorship, the royal-looking honours and the rumours of a crown all touched the one nerve that could not be touched.

PROFESSOR'S INSIGHT Why the hatred of the word king is the engine of the whole play

Ask yourself what the conspirators actually accuse Caesar of in Act 1. Not cruelty: nobody claims he has killed or robbed anyone. Not incompetence: he has just won a war. Not even present tyranny: Brutus himself admits "I would not, Cassius, yet I love him well", and Cassius has to strain to find grievances, ending with an embarrassing swimming race and a fever. The whole case against Caesar rests on a fear about a word. Brutus fears "the people / Choose Caesar for their king". Casca reports a rumour that the senators "Mean to establish Caesar as a king". Cassius invokes the ancestor who would not brook "a king". The word does the work that evidence cannot. This is Shakespeare's most profound use of Roman history: he has understood that in Rome the title itself was a crime, so that a man could be killed for what he might become rather than for what he had done. Every later event grows from this root. Brutus's soliloquy in Act 2, Antony's repeated refrain about Caesar refusing the crown in Act 3, and the tragic irony that killing Caesar produced not liberty but emperors, are all variations on a single theme announced in Act 1: a Republic so terrified of a king that it destroyed itself to prevent one. A literary interpretation, but one that most critics share in some form.

LEVEL 1 — What happened?

In Scene 2 Casca reports that Antony offered Caesar a crown three times at the Lupercalia; Caesar refused it three times, more reluctantly each time in Casca's opinion, and the crowd cheered each refusal. Caesar then fainted. Earlier, Brutus heard the shouts and feared the people were choosing Caesar as king.

LEVEL 2 — What does it mean?

The crowd cheered the refusals, not the offers. Roman citizens, however much they loved Caesar, would not accept a king. Caesar's reluctance to let go, "he was very loath to lay his fingers off it", suggests to Casca and Cassius that Caesar wants the crown and is testing the public mood. Whether Casca's cynical reading is fair, the text leaves open.

LEVEL 3 — Why did Shakespeare write it this way?

He keeps the offering offstage and lets a sour, sarcastic witness describe it. We never see Caesar's face; we see Casca's contempt. The audience is put in the conspirators' position of interpreting rumours. Shakespeare also enlarges Plutarch's two offerings to three, the fairy-tale number, so the refusal feels like a ritual performance rather than a spontaneous act.

LEVEL 4 — How does it connect to the whole play?

The crown refused in Act 1 becomes the crown Antony reminds the crowd of in Act 3 Scene 2, recalling that he offered it three times, to prove Caesar was not ambitious. The same crowd that cheered the refusal will cheer Brutus and then Antony. And the Republic's horror of a king, so evident here, is what Brutus will use to justify the killing.

LEVEL 5 — How do I use it in an ICSE answer?

In a Class X question about Antony's funeral speech or Brutus's motives, one sentence of Act 1 context earns credit: Caesar had publicly refused a crown three times, so the conspirators' fear rested on interpretation of his reluctance, not on any act of kingship. Say 'Casca reports' rather than 'Caesar did', because you are quoting a biased witness, and the examiner will see that you understand the difference.

HISTORICAL FACT → In 509 BC Lucius Junius Brutus expelled King Tarquin and founded the Republic; Marcus Brutus claimed descent from him, and graffiti in 44 BC urged him to act like his ancestor.



WHAT A ROMAN AUDIENCE MAY HAVE UNDERSTOOD → The word rex was the ultimate political crime; a Brutus who allowed a king would betray his own name.



HOW SHAKESPEARE USES IT → "There was a Brutus once that would have brooked / Th' eternal devil to keep his state in Rome / As easily as a king" is Cassius's final and strongest weapon; the forged letters on "old Brutus' statue" dramatise the graffiti.



WHY IT MATTERS FOR ICSE → Brutus's sense of inherited duty is the key to his character across the play. In Act 2 he decides for the Republic; in Act 5 he dies rather than be led in triumph. The ancestor named in Act 1 explains both.

Roman Attitudes Toward Powerful Individuals

HISTORICAL RECORD. Romans admired great men and feared them in equal measure. The Republic honoured its heroes lavishly, with triumphs, statues and titles, but it also invented safeguards against them: term limits, colleagues with vetoes, and the memory of the Tarquins. When a man's greatness grew beyond what the system could contain, Romans tended to see not a saviour but a threat, and their history offered a stock of warnings: the would-be tyrants of the early Republic supposedly struck down for reaching too high. By the first century BC that older suspicion was fighting a new reality, in which armies loved their generals and the poor loved their benefactors more than they loved the constitution.

SHAKESPEARE'S TEXT. Cassius's Colossus image is the play's picture of an individual grown too large for his state: "Why, man, he doth bestride the narrow world / Like a Colossus, and we petty men / Walk under his huge legs and peep about / To find ourselves dishonourable graves." (The Colossus was the giant bronze statue of the sun-god at Rhodes, one of the Seven Wonders of the ancient world; the picture of it straddling the harbour so that ships sailed between its legs is a medieval legend, and it is that legend Shakespeare's image relies on. 'Bestride' means to stand with legs apart over something; 'petty' means small.) He follows it with the crucial republican axiom: "Now is it Rome indeed, and room enough / When there is in it but one only man." A Rome with room for only one man is no longer Rome. Caesar's own words from the other side of the fence

complete the picture: "Such men as he be never at heart's ease / Whiles they behold a greater than themselves". Caesar accepts, without embarrassment, that he is the greater; Shakespeare lets the audience judge the arrogance in "for always I am Caesar."

HISTORICAL FACT → Rome honoured great men with triumphs and statues while fencing them in with term limits, colleagues and the memory of the expelled kings.



WHAT A ROMAN AUDIENCE MAY HAVE UNDERSTOOD → A single individual whose greatness outgrew the Republic's safeguards was a danger by definition, whatever his personal qualities.



HOW SHAKESPEARE USES IT → The Colossus image and "Rome indeed, and room enough / When there is in it but one only man" express the republican fear of the outsized individual; Caesar's "for always I am Caesar" shows he thinks of himself in the third person, as an institution.



WHY IT MATTERS FOR ICSE → Questions on Caesar's character (arrogance, over-confidence) in Act 2 Scene 2 and Act 3 Scene 1 are best answered with his Act 1 self-description. His third-person habit begins here.

The Century That Broke the Republic

You now know how the Republic was meant to work. Here is how it stopped working, told briefly and only as far as Act 1 needs it.

Military Power and Political Power: Marius and Sulla

HISTORICAL RECORD. For most of the Republic's history, the army was the citizen body in arms: farmers who served a campaign and went home. In the late second century BC the general Gaius Marius is traditionally credited with opening the legions to the landless poor, who served for pay, loot and the promise of land, and who therefore looked to their general, not to the Senate, to reward them. Marius held the consulship an unheard-of seven times. His former officer Lucius Cornelius Sulla then did what no Roman had done: in 88 BC he marched his army on Rome itself, and in 82–81 BC he made himself dictator without a time limit, killed his enemies by published lists (the proscriptions), rewrote the constitution and, to general astonishment, resigned. Two lessons were now on the record. A general with a loyal army could take Rome. And a dictator could hold power for as long as he chose. Caesar, as a young man, was on Sulla's wrong side; Suetonius and Plutarch both report that Sulla warned there were many Mariuses in the boy.

SHAKESPEARE'S TEXT. Shakespeare never names Marius or Sulla, but their legacy is the unspoken fact behind Act 1: Caesar's power rests on soldiers, and the crowd in Scene 1 is cheering a military victory. When Marullus asks "What conquest brings he home?" the question exposes the real source of Caesar's standing. Cassius's line that Caesar is "A man no mightier than thyself or me / In personal action, yet prodigious grown" makes the same point in reverse: strip away the army and the aura, and he is only a man. ('Prodigious' here means monstrous, unnatural, like a prodigy or omen.)

HISTORICAL FACT → From Marius onward, Roman soldiers served long terms for pay and land and gave their loyalty to their general; Sulla proved in 88–81 BC that such an army could seize Rome and keep a dictator in power.



WHAT A ROMAN AUDIENCE MAY HAVE UNDERSTOOD → Every great general was now a potential Sulla; a returning victor with a devoted army was as frightening as he was glorious.



HOW SHAKESPEARE USES IT → The triumph in Scene 1 is a military victor's parade; Marullus's "What conquest brings he home?" and Cassius's "prodigious grown" both point to the army-based power behind Caesar's civilian mask.



WHY IT MATTERS FOR ICSE → When Acts 4 and 5 turn into a war between the conspirators' legions and those of Antony and Octavius, you are watching the Marius-and-Sulla pattern repeat. Naming that pattern in one sentence lifts an answer above plot summary.

Political Factions: Optimates, Caesarians and the Pardoned Pompeians

HISTORICAL RECORD. Rome had no political parties in the modern sense, but historians use two convenient labels. The *optimates* ('the best men') were those senators who defended the traditional authority of the Senate and the old families. The *populares* ('the people's men') were politicians who bypassed the Senate by appealing directly to the popular assemblies and the tribunes. Caesar built his career as a popularis; Pompey, though he too had been a popular strongman, ended up as the Senate's champion against Caesar. When civil war came in 49 BC, the optimates and Pompey were on one side and the Caesarians on the other.

Two things about the conspiracy of 44 BC now become clear. First, Brutus and Cassius had fought for Pompey, been defeated at Pharsalus, and been pardoned by Caesar; they held their praetorships in 44 BC by his favour. Second, the conspiracy also included Caesar's own trusted officers, above all Decimus Brutus (Shakespeare's Decius Brutus) and Trebonius. The plot united former enemies and former friends, which is why it was so hard to detect and so lacking in a shared plan for afterwards.

SHAKESPEARE'S TEXT. Shakespeare drops the faction labels but keeps the human situation. Cassius admits "Caesar doth bear me hard, but he loves Brutus" ('bears me hard' means dislikes me, bears a grudge against me), an acknowledgement that the two pardoned men stand in different favour. The meeting place he names, "In Pompey's Porch", is the portico of the theatre built by Caesar's dead rival: the pardoned Pompeians gather, literally, under Pompey's roof. And Cinna's question in the dark, "Who's that? Metellus Cimber?", together with the roll-call of "Decius Brutus and Trebonius", quietly shows an audience that Caesar's own men are among the plotters.

HISTORICAL FACT → Late-Republican politics divided into defenders of senatorial authority (optimates) and those who appealed to the people (populares); after 49 BC the practical split was Pompeians against Caesarians. Brutus and Cassius were pardoned Pompeians; Decimus Brutus and Trebonius were Caesarians.



WHAT A ROMAN AUDIENCE MAY HAVE UNDERSTOOD → A pardoned enemy owed his life and his office to Caesar; a plot by such men would be seen either as the last stand of the Republic or as monstrous ingratitude.



HOW SHAKESPEARE USES IT → "Caesar doth bear me hard, but he loves Brutus" and the meeting at "Pompey's Porch" keep the Pompeian past alive; the names Decius Brutus and Trebonius show the plot reaching into Caesar's own circle.



WHY IT MATTERS FOR ICSE → Antony's charge of ingratitude in Act 3 Scene 2, and Caesar's shock at Brutus in Act 3 Scene 1, both depend on the fact that these men were forgiven enemies and trusted friends. Act 1 plants that fact.

Caesar's Rise: the First Triumvirate, the Consulship and Gaul

HISTORICAL RECORD. In 60 BC Caesar formed a private alliance with the two most powerful men in Rome: Pompey, the greatest general of the age, and Crassus, the richest man in it. Historians call it the First Triumvirate, though it had no legal standing; it was a pact to share influence and get each other what they wanted. It got Caesar the consulship of 59 BC, and then a five-year command in Gaul (roughly modern France), later extended. From 58 to 50 BC Caesar conquered the whole of Gaul, defeated the German tribes on the Rhine, twice invaded Britain and broke the last great Gallic revolt at Alesia in 52 BC. He wrote up his campaigns himself, in plain, powerful Latin, so that Rome read his victories as he wished them read. By 50 BC he had a battle-hardened army, vast wealth and unmatched glory, and a Senate that wanted to prosecute him the moment he laid down his command.

SHAKESPEARE'S TEXT. Cassius sneers at the way Caesar's words were treated as scripture: "that tongue of his that bade the Romans / Mark him and write his speeches in their books". Whatever Shakespeare knew of Caesar's writings, the line catches a truth: Caesar controlled his own image. The Gallic glory hangs over Act 1 without ever being described; the shouting that twice interrupts Brutus and Cassius, and the "new honours that are heaped on Caesar" that Brutus guesses it means, are its consequence. (One caution: the "universal shout" Marullus remembers in Scene 1 was raised for Pompey's chariot, not Caesar's. Do not borrow that phrase for Caesar's popularity.)

HISTORICAL FACT → Caesar's pact with Pompey and Crassus (60 BC) won him the consulship (59 BC) and the Gallic command (58–50 BC), from which he emerged with an army, a fortune and glory the Senate could not control.



WHAT A ROMAN AUDIENCE MAY HAVE UNDERSTOOD → A commander who returned from ten years of conquest with his legions intact was, by the precedent of Sulla, a threat to the constitution no matter what he said.



HOW SHAKESPEARE USES IT → The play begins after the rise is complete; Shakespeare shows its effects, the cheering crowd and the "new honours", and lets Cassius mock the self-made legend: "write his speeches in their books".



WHY IT MATTERS FOR ICSE → You do not need the Gallic Wars in an answer, but you need to know that Caesar's power in the play is real and earned, so that the conspirators' fear is not paranoia about a nobody. This keeps your analysis balanced.

Caesar and Pompey: Alliance, Julia, Breakdown, the Rubicon, Pharsalus, Death

HISTORICAL RECORD. Pompey the Great was Rome's hero before Caesar was. He had cleared the Mediterranean of pirates, conquered the East and celebrated three triumphs, the third and grandest in 61 BC. To bind their alliance, Caesar gave Pompey his only daughter, Julia, in marriage in 59 BC; by all accounts the two were devoted, and Julia's death in childbirth in 54 BC removed the personal bond between the two men. Crassus died in battle at Carrhae in 53 BC, and the triangle collapsed into two rivals. The Senate, fearing Caesar more, drew Pompey to its side and in January 49 BC ordered Caesar to give up his army. Two tribunes who vetoed the order, Antony among them, fled to Caesar, giving him a legal pretext: the sacred tribunes had been violated. Around 10 or 11 January 49 BC Caesar led a legion across the Rubicon, the little river that marked the boundary of Italy, which no commander might cross with troops. Civil war followed. Pompey abandoned Italy for Greece; Caesar chased him and crushed his larger army at Pharsalus on 9 August 48 BC. Pompey fled to Egypt, where on 28 September 48 BC he was murdered as he stepped ashore, on the orders of the boy-king's advisers, who hoped to please Caesar. Caesar is said to have wept when shown the head.

HISTORICAL CONTEXT The Rubicon

The Rubicon was a small stream in northern Italy. Its importance was entirely legal: it marked the line beyond which a provincial governor could not bring his army without committing treason. Crossing it was the moment Caesar chose civil war over prosecution. The phrase 'to cross the Rubicon' still means to take an irreversible step. Shakespeare's play never mentions it, but it stands behind Marullus's grief: the man in the chariot is the man who crossed that line against Pompey.

SHAKESPEARE'S TEXT. Pompey has been dead for nearly four years when the play begins, and yet Act 1 cannot stop talking about him. Marullus's whole speech is a lament for him: "Knew you not Pompey? Many a time and oft / Have you climbed up to walls and battlements, / To towers and windows, yea, to chimney tops, / Your infants in your arms, and there have sat / The livelong day, with patient expectation, / To see great Pompey pass the streets of Rome." The crowd's crime, in Marullus's eyes, is that they now cheer the man who "comes in triumph over Pompey's blood". The conspirators meet at "Pompey's Porch" and "Pompey's Theatre". Shakespeare's Rome is haunted by Pompey, and in Act 3 the haunting will be completed when Caesar falls at the foot of Pompey's statue.

HISTORICAL FACT → Allied in 60 BC and bound by Pompey's marriage to Julia, the two men fell out after her death (54 BC) and Crassus's (53 BC); Caesar crossed the Rubicon in January 49 BC, defeated Pompey at Pharsalus (48 BC), and Pompey was murdered in Egypt.



WHAT A ROMAN AUDIENCE MAY HAVE UNDERSTOOD → Pompey had been Rome's darling; his defeat and squalid death left half of Rome in mourning and made Caesar's victory a family tragedy for the state.



HOW SHAKESPEARE USES IT → Marullus's "Knew you not Pompey?" makes the dead rival the moral yardstick of Scene 1; the conspirators gather at "Pompey's Porch"; the crowd's forgetting of Pompey is the first proof of its fickleness.



WHY IT MATTERS FOR ICSE → The Pompey background explains the setting of the assassination (beneath Pompey's statue) and the crowd's rapid switching of loyalties in Act 3 Scene 2. A sentence on Pompey shows the examiner you understand why the mob's behaviour is shocking.

Caesar's Military Achievements

HISTORICAL RECORD. Between 58 and 45 BC Caesar fought, almost without pause, in Gaul, Germany, Britain, Italy, Spain, Greece, Egypt, Asia Minor, Africa and Spain again, and never lost a war. His reputation for speed became legendary; his three-word dispatch after a lightning victory in Asia Minor in 47 BC, 'I came, I saw, I conquered', was later carried in his triumph. Ancient writers also stress his personal endurance: he swam, rode and marched with his men and shared their hardships. That is worth remembering when you read Cassius.

SHAKESPEARE'S TEXT AND INTERPRETATION. Cassius's strategy in Scene 2 is to attack the one thing Caesar's reputation rested on, his physical toughness. So he tells the Tiber story, in which Caesar "cried 'Help me, Cassius, or I sink!'", and the fever story from Spain: "He had a fever when he was in Spain, / And when the fit was on him, I did mark / How he did shake." He sums up in disbelief that "A man of such a feeble temper should / So get the start of the majestic world / And bear the palm alone." ('Temper' means constitution or physical make-up; 'get the start of' means outstrip in a race; 'bear the palm' means take the victor's prize.) The Tiber race has no source in Plutarch and appears to be Shakespeare's invention. The Spanish fever may grow from Plutarch's remark that Caesar's epilepsy first attacked him at Corduba in Spain, but the shaking, groaning invalid crying out like "a sick girl" is Cassius's picture, not the historian's. Either way, the point is that Cassius must belittle the body of a man whose achievements he cannot deny. Casca's report of the fainting fit, and Brutus's diagnosis "he hath the falling sickness" (epilepsy, which Plutarch does record), serve the same purpose. Set against the historical Caesar's record, Cassius's belittling looks like envy; that is one strong reading, though some critics answer that his underlying point, a mortal man being worshipped as a god, is fair. The text lets you weigh both.

HISTORICAL FACT → Caesar campaigned continuously from 58 to 45 BC across the whole Mediterranean world and never lost a war; ancient sources praise his speed and physical endurance.



WHAT A ROMAN AUDIENCE MAY HAVE UNDERSTOOD → Military virtue (virtus) was the highest Roman excellence; a man with Caesar's record had earned a standing that no rival could match by argument alone.



HOW SHAKESPEARE USES IT → Cassius cannot attack the record, so he attacks the body: the invented Tiber race, the fever in Spain, and "bear the palm alone"; Casca's account of the swoon and "the falling sickness" continue the belittling.



WHY IT MATTERS FOR ICSE → The contrast between Caesar's public greatness and private frailty is a standard Act 1 theme (appearance versus reality). Knowing that the frailty stories are Cassius's and not history lets you evaluate Cassius as a narrator rather than simply repeating him.

Caesar's Return to Rome

HISTORICAL RECORD. After Pharsalus Caesar spent years finishing the war: Egypt and Cleopatra (48–47 BC), the victory at Zela (47 BC), the defeat of the Pompeians in Africa at Thapsus (46 BC), where Cato killed himself rather than accept pardon, and finally the crushing of Pompey's sons at Munda in Spain on 17 March 45 BC. He returned to Rome in the autumn of 45 BC and celebrated a triumph for Spain in October. He then set about reforming the state at breathtaking speed: a new calendar (the Julian calendar, ancestor of ours), debt relief, colonies for veterans and the poor, an enlarged Senate. The Senate, for its part, heaped honours on him that looked increasingly royal: his statue placed among those of the old kings, his image on coins during his lifetime (a first for a living Roman), a golden chair, the right to wear triumphal dress permanently. Which honours he sought and which were forced on him by flatterers is a question the ancient sources already argued about.

SHAKESPEARE'S TEXT. Shakespeare compresses the return into a single day of celebration and stitches it to the Lupercalia. Brutus hears the shouting and guesses "these applauses are / For some new honours that are heaped on Caesar." That word 'heaped' is exactly right for the winter of 45–44 BC. Caesar's own entrance, "Set on and leave no ceremony out", shows a man at ease with public ritual arranged around himself.

HISTORICAL FACT → Caesar returned to Rome in autumn 45 BC after Munda, celebrated a Spanish triumph in October, launched sweeping reforms and received a flood of royal-looking honours from the Senate.



WHAT A ROMAN AUDIENCE MAY HAVE UNDERSTOOD → Reforms were welcome; honours that resembled a king's regalia were not. The two arrived together, and Romans could not easily separate the benefactor from the monarch.



HOW SHAKESPEARE USES IT → "some new honours that are heaped on Caesar" and "leave no ceremony out" set the play in the season of honours; the triumph of Scene 1 is the return itself.



WHY IT MATTERS FOR ICSE → Brutus's Act 2 reasoning that Caesar may change once crowned assumes that he has not yet done real harm. The returning reformer of 45 BC is why that reasoning is honest rather than absurd.

Caesar's Dictatorship: 49 → 46 → February 44 BC

HISTORICAL RECORD. The dictatorship was an ancient emergency office. In a crisis the Republic could appoint one man with supreme power, but for six months at most, after which he stepped down; the legend of Cincinnatus, who left his plough, saved Rome and returned to his plough within sixteen days, taught every Roman child what a dictator should be. Sulla had bent the rule; Caesar broke it. He was named dictator briefly in 49 BC to hold elections, again in 48–47 BC for a year, then in 46 BC for ten years, and in February 44 BC *dictator perpetuo*, dictator for life. A perpetual dictator was a king without the name. The Lupercalia fell on 15 February 44 BC, within days or weeks of that appointment, which is why the crown offered at the festival looked to many like the next logical step.

HISTORICAL CONTEXT The six-month rule

Why did six months matter so much? Because the dictatorship was the one office in which the Republic's safeguards were suspended: no colleague of equal rank, no effective veto, and in the old tradition no appeal to the people. The time limit was the only protection left. A dictator for life had removed the last brake. Cicero's speeches and letters from these months show educated Romans grasping precisely this point.

SHAKESPEARE'S TEXT. Shakespeare never uses the word 'dictator' in Act 1, and he does not date the events. Yet the reality shows through in Casca's report that Caesar "put it by" but "would fain have had it" ('fain' means gladly), and in Cassius's cry "Age, thou art shamed!" A generation that has accepted a perpetual dictator has, in Cassius's eyes, disgraced itself. The vagueness suits Shakespeare's purpose: his Caesar is not a specific constitutional office but a man on the edge of becoming something Rome has no name for except the forbidden one.

HISTORICAL FACT → The dictatorship was a six-month emergency office; Caesar held it in 49, 48–47 and (for ten years) 46 BC, and in February 44 BC became dictator for life.



WHAT A ROMAN AUDIENCE MAY HAVE UNDERSTOOD → A perpetual dictator had abolished the only limit on absolute power; the crown at the Lupercalia looked like the formal name for what already existed.



HOW SHAKESPEARE USES IT → Shakespeare omits the title but keeps the fear: the crown Caesar "would fain have had", the senators who "Mean to establish Caesar as a king", and Cassius's "Age, thou art shamed!"



WHY IT MATTERS FOR ICSE → When you discuss whether Caesar was truly ambitious (a recurring evaluative question in Act 3), you can say honestly that the historical Caesar already held permanent power, while Shakespeare's text leaves his intentions ambiguous. Keep the two labelled and separate.

Two Ceremonies the Play Is Built On

The Roman Triumph

HISTORICAL RECORD. A triumph was the highest honour the Republic could give a general, and the Senate granted it only for a major victory over a foreign enemy. The procession began outside the city on the Campus Martius and wound through the streets to the Temple of Jupiter on the Capitoline hill. First came the senators and magistrates, then wagons of captured treasure and painted boards showing the battles, then the animals for sacrifice, then the chief captives in chains, and finally the general himself in a chariot drawn by four horses, wearing a purple toga embroidered with gold, a laurel wreath on his head and, by tradition, his face painted red like the statue of Jupiter. A slave stood behind him holding a golden crown over his head and, according to a later source, murmuring that he should look behind him and remember he was only a man. His soldiers marched after, singing; the crowd wore holiday clothes and scattered flowers. At the temple the general sacrificed white bulls and laid his laurels in the god's lap.

The rule about a foreign enemy is the key to Act 1. Romans regarded a triumph over fellow Romans as indecent: one did not parade citizens in chains or celebrate the slaughter of one's own people. Caesar's Spanish triumph of October 45 BC was exactly that, a celebration of Munda, where the enemy had been Pompey's sons and their Roman legions. Plutarch records that this triumph displeased Romans more than anything else Caesar had done, because he had destroyed the children and the family of the greatest of Romans, and it was not thought fitting for him to triumph over the misfortunes of his country. (I paraphrase Plutarch; those are not Shakespeare's words.)

SHAKESPEARE'S TEXT. Now reread Marullus with a Roman's eyes: "Wherefore rejoice? What conquest brings he home? / What tributaries follow him to Rome / To grace in captive bonds his chariot wheels?" ('Wherefore' means why; 'tributaries' are conquered peoples who must pay tribute; 'captive bonds' are the chains of prisoners.) Marullus is asking the three questions any Roman would ask about a triumph. What foreign conquest? None. What captive kings walk in chains before the chariot? None, because the defeated were Romans. The triumph, in other words, is a fraud, and the crowd should know it. The answer to his rhetorical questions is the unspoken word 'Pompey', which he then speaks: "Knew you not Pompey?" Everything in the speech turns on the historical rule that you do not triumph over your own countrymen: the

man "That comes in triumph over Pompey's blood" has broken a taboo, and the crowd's flowers make them complicit. Marullus therefore tells them to "Pray to the gods to intermit the plague / That needs must light on this ingratitude" ('intermit' means to suspend or hold off): a triumph that offends the gods invites divine punishment.

QUOTATION The fraudulent triumph

Marullus: *Wherefore rejoice? What conquest brings he home? / What tributaries follow him to Rome / To grace in captive bonds his chariot wheels?*

Three questions that a Roman would recognise as the checklist for a legitimate triumph, each answered by silence.

HISTORICAL FACT → A triumph was the Senate's supreme honour for victory over a foreign enemy: a procession with spoils, chained captives and the laurelled general in a four-horse chariot ending at Jupiter's temple. Caesar's Spanish triumph of October 45 BC celebrated a victory over Romans and was resented.



WHAT A ROMAN AUDIENCE MAY HAVE UNDERSTOOD → No captives and no foreign spoils meant no legitimate triumph; cheering it meant applauding the killing of fellow citizens and forgetting Pompey.



HOW SHAKESPEARE USES IT → Marullus's "What tributaries follow him to Rome / To grace in captive bonds his chariot wheels?" is a Roman legal objection dressed as rhetoric; "in triumph over Pompey's blood" names the taboo directly.



WHY IT MATTERS FOR ICSE → Class IX extract questions on Scene 1 commonly ask what Marullus means by 'tributaries' and why he is angry. For Class X, the fraudulent triumph is the first evidence that Caesar's honours exceed what the Republic allows, which supports Brutus's case in Act 3 even as Antony denies it.

Lupercalia

HISTORICAL RECORD. The Lupercalia was celebrated every year on 15 February, one of Rome's oldest festivals, so old that the Romans themselves were unsure what it meant. It centred on the Lupercal, the cave at the foot of the Palatine hill where the she-wolf was said to have suckled Romulus and Remus. Priests called Luperci sacrificed goats there, cut the skins into strips, and ran through the city wearing little more than goatskin girdles, striking anyone they met with the thongs. Women deliberately stood in their way, because a blow from the goat-thong was believed to cure barrenness and ease childbirth. The festival was at once a purification of the city (the month name February comes from *februa*, the purifying thongs) and a fertility rite. In 44 BC Caesar had a third college of Luperci, the Juliani, created in his honour, and Mark Antony, the serving consul, ran as one of them.

At that festival, according to Plutarch, Caesar sat on the speakers' platform in the Forum on a golden chair, dressed in triumphal robes. Antony ran up carrying a diadem, the white ribbon that Greek kings wore round the head, twined with laurel, and held it out to Caesar. A few people, apparently placed for the purpose,

applauded; when Caesar pushed it away, the whole crowd applauded. Antony offered it again; the same thing happened. Plutarch has two offerings. Caesar then ordered the diadem to be carried to the Capitol and dedicated to Jupiter, as though to say that only the god was king in Rome.

SHAKESPEARE'S TEXT. Shakespeare keeps the festival and moves everything else into it. Caesar's first full speech in the play, once he has called his wife's name, is an instruction about the fertility rite: "Stand you directly in Antonius' way / When he doth run his course", and "Forget not in your speed, Antonius, / To touch Calpurnia, for our elders say / The barren, touchèd in this holy chase, / Shake off their sterile curse." ('Barren' means childless; 'sterile curse' is the curse of infertility.) This is exactly the ancient belief, and Shakespeare uses it to tell us, without a word of explanation, that the master of the world has no heir. Antony's reply, "When Caesar says 'Do this,' it is performed", makes the consul-priest a servant. Then comes the offering, reported by Casca: "there was a crown offered him; and, being offered him, he put it by with the back of his hand, thus, and then the people fell a-shouting." Casca even corrects himself on the object, "'twas not a crown neither; 'twas one of these coronets" (a small crown), which is Shakespeare's way of rendering Plutarch's diadem, a ribbon rather than a crown, in terms an English audience would grasp. And when the crowd delights in the refusal, Casca says Caesar "plucked me ope his doublet and offered them his throat to cut" ('ope' means open; a 'doublet' is a close-fitting jacket, an Elizabethan garment Shakespeare puts on a Roman), a theatrical gesture of surrender. Whether that gesture was sincere or staged is the question Casca's sarcasm plants in Brutus.

PROFESSOR'S INSIGHT Why Shakespeare joins the triumph to the Lupercalia

Historically these two events were four months apart; Shakespeare makes them one day. The gain is enormous. The triumph gives him a cheering crowd, decorated statues and an angry pair of tribunes: the public face of Caesar's power. The Lupercalia gives him a religious festival, a childless ruler asking a priest to touch his wife, a soothsayer in the crowd and a crown offered in public: the private and superstitious face of the same power. By welding them together he can show, in two scenes, Caesar as conqueror, Caesar as would-be father, Caesar as nearly-king, and Caesar as a fainting epileptic, all before the audience has had time to settle on an opinion. He also buys a structural symmetry: the play opens with Caesar refusing a crown before a crowd and moves, in Act 3, to Antony using that refusal before another crowd. Compression is not carelessness; it is the dramatist choosing density over accuracy. This is literary interpretation, but it is the kind that follows directly from comparing the sources with the text.

HISTORICAL FACT → The Lupercalia (15 February) was an ancient purification and fertility festival; the Luperci ran through Rome striking women with goat-hide thongs. In 44 BC Antony ran as a Lupercus and, according to Plutarch, twice offered Caesar a laurelled diadem, which Caesar refused and sent to Jupiter.



WHAT A ROMAN AUDIENCE MAY HAVE UNDERSTOOD → A diadem was the badge of a Greek king; offering it in the Forum, at a festival of Rome's founding, tested whether the people would accept a rex. Their cheers for the refusal gave the answer.



HOW SHAKESPEARE USES IT → Caesar's order to "touch Calpurnia" makes the fertility rite reveal his childlessness; Casca's report of the crown "offered him" three times, refused each time "gentler than other", turns Plutarch's test of the crowd into a test of Caesar's sincerity.



WHY IT MATTERS FOR ICSE → Antony's Act 3 Scene 2 use of the refused crown to prove Caesar's lack of ambition only makes sense if you know what happened at the Lupercalia. One sentence of Act 1 context, correctly attributed to Casca's report, strengthens any answer on the funeral speech.

CHRONOLOGICAL TIMELINE LEADING INTO ACT 1

Read this table from top to bottom once, then use it for revision. Dates are the historical record; the last column tells you why each one matters to the play.

Date	Event	Why it matters to Act 1
509 BC (traditional)	Lucius Junius Brutus expels King Tarquin; the Republic is founded on hatred of the word <i>rex</i>	Cassius's "There was a Brutus once"; the forged letters on "old Brutus' statue"; the horror at "king"
494 BC	First secession of the plebs; tribunes of the plebs created, sacrosanct and armed with a veto	Flavius and Marullus in Scene 1 are exercising this ancient protective office
287 BC	Plebeian assembly's decisions become binding on all Rome; legal equality of plebeians complete	The commoners of Scene 1 are full citizens whose votes and cheers carry political weight
107–100 BC	Marius holds repeated consulships; the legions become long-service armies loyal to their generals	Caesar's power in the play rests on soldiers; the war of Acts 4–5 follows this pattern
88–81 BC	Sulla marches on Rome and rules as dictator beyond the six-month limit	Precedent for a general seizing Rome and for a dictatorship without end
60 BC	Caesar, Pompey and Crassus form the First Triumvirate	Beginning of Caesar's climb; origin of his alliance with Pompey
59 BC	Caesar consul; Pompey marries Caesar's daughter Julia; Caesar marries Calpurnia	Calpurnia is the wife Caesar asks Antony to touch; Julia is the bond that will break
58–50 BC	Galic Wars; Alesia 52 BC	The conquests behind the "conquest" Marullus questions

Date	Event	Why it matters to Act 1
54 BC	Julia dies	The personal tie between Caesar and Pompey is gone
53 BC	Crassus killed at Carrhae	Two rivals remain; Cassius survives the disaster
10–11 January 49 BC	Caesar crosses the Rubicon after tribunes (including Antony) flee to him	Civil war begins; Antony's loyalty to Caesar dates from here
49 BC	Caesar dictator for the first time, briefly	First step in the sequence 49 → 46 → 44
9 August 48 BC	Pharsalus: Pompey defeated; Brutus and Cassius later pardoned	The "pardoned Pompeians" of the conspiracy owe Caesar their lives
28 September 48 BC	Pompey murdered in Egypt	Marullus's "Knew you not Pompey?"; "Pompey's blood"
46 BC	Thapsus; Cato's suicide; four triumphs; Caesar dictator for ten years	Honours begin to look royal; Cato, Brutus's kinsman and later father-in-law, becomes a republican martyr
17 March 45 BC	Munda: Pompey's sons defeated; Gnaeus killed	The Roman-versus-Roman victory that the Scene 1 triumph celebrates
October 45 BC	Spanish triumph, resented as a triumph over Romans	Marullus's "What tributaries follow him to Rome"
1 January 44 BC	Caesar and Antony consuls; Brutus urban praetor, Cassius praetor	"the praetor's chair" in Scene 3; Antony's official standing
January 44 BC (most reconstructions)	Diadem placed on Caesar's statue; tribunes Marullus and Flavus remove it and are deposed	Scene 1's "Disrobe the images"; Casca's "put to silence"
February 44 BC	Caesar named <i>dictator perpetuo</i>	The last constitutional brake removed; "Age, thou art shamed!"
15 February 44 BC	Lupercalia: Antony offers the diadem (twice in Plutarch); Caesar refuses and sends it to Jupiter	Casca's report of the crown refused "thrice"
14 March 44 BC	Eve of the Senate meeting; Plutarch lists portents before the Ides but does not date them to this one night	Act 1 Scene 3 places the storm and omens here: "Comes Caesar to the Capitol tomorrow?"
15 March 44 BC	Caesar assassinated in the Curia of Pompey	"Beware the ides of March"; the day the whole of Act 1 points toward

HISTORICAL CONTEXT What the Ides actually were

The Roman month had three fixed marker days: the Kalends (the 1st), the Nones (the 5th, or the 7th in March, May, July and October) and the Ides (the 15th in those same four months, the 13th in all the others). The Ides were sacred to Jupiter. So "Beware the ides of March" would have sounded to a Roman exactly like 'beware the fifteenth of March': a date, not a riddle. The eeriness is Shakespeare's; to Caesar it is a calendar entry, which is partly why he can dismiss the speaker as "a dreamer". There is a historical root. Plutarch and Suetonius record that a seer named Spurinna warned Caesar of danger coming no later than the Ides of March; Shakespeare strips away the name and gives the warning to a nameless Soothsayer in the crowd. The ICSE 2025 board paper asked candidates what 'the work the ides of March begun' refers to: a student who knows that the Ides is simply 15 March, the day of the assassination, answers in one clean sentence.

WHAT SHAKESPEARE CHANGED

This section is the one that will most distinguish you from other students. Shakespeare read history carefully and then altered it deliberately. Below, each change is set out as **HISTORICAL RECORD** against **SHAKESPEARE'S TEXT**, followed by the likely reason (**LITERARY INTERPRETATION**). Keep these labels in your own notes; confusing the two is the most common error in student writing about this play.

Three events compressed into one day

HISTORICAL RECORD. The Spanish triumph took place in October 45 BC. The tribunes' removal of the diadem from Caesar's statue is placed by most modern reconstructions in January 44 BC. The Lupercalia was 15 February 44 BC. Three separate events, spread over four months.

SHAKESPEARE'S TEXT. In Act 1 Scenes 1 and 2 they all happen on a single day. The commoners "make holiday to see Caesar and to rejoice in his triumph"; Marullus says "it is the feast of Lupercal"; the tribunes strip the statues; Antony runs his course; the crown is offered; and by the end of Scene 2 the tribunes "are put to silence".

LITERARY INTERPRETATION. Compression gives the opening of the play a single, overwhelming day of Caesar's glory, and it lets cause and consequence sit side by side: the tribunes act in Scene 1 and are destroyed in Scene 2. It also means Shakespeare can show the fickle crowd, the childless ruler, the refused crown and the first stirrings of conspiracy within the first forty minutes of stage time.

The silent month before Scene 3

HISTORICAL RECORD. From the Lupercalia (15 February) to the Ides (15 March) is one month.

SHAKESPEARE'S TEXT. Scene 2 ends with Cassius planning to throw letters "this night"; Scene 3 opens in a storm, and Cicero asks "Comes Caesar to the Capitol tomorrow?" Casca replies that Caesar "did bid Antonius / Send word to you he would be there tomorrow." Cassius says "it is after midnight". So Scene 3 is the night of 14 March. A whole month has passed between two consecutive scenes, and nothing in the dialogue marks it. Some editors and readers feel that Scene 3 follows Scene 2 on the same night; the text supports the month-long gap through Cicero's question, but leaves the sensation of continuity intact.

LITERARY INTERPRETATION. Shakespeare wants the conspiracy to feel like a single accelerating movement from the first shout to the first blow. A month of quiet plotting would dissipate that energy. He simply omits it, trusting that an audience feels time as pressure, not as a calendar.

The Capitol versus the Curia of Pompey

HISTORICAL RECORD. Caesar was killed on 15 March 44 BC in the Curia of Pompey, a meeting hall attached to Pompey's theatre complex, beneath a statue of Pompey. He was not on the Capitoline hill.

SHAKESPEARE'S TEXT. Act 1 repeatedly places the coming Senate meeting at the Capitol: Cicero asks "Comes Caesar to the Capitol tomorrow?"; Casca has met a lion "Against the Capitol"; and the assassination in Act 3 takes place there. At the same time, the conspirators meet at "Pompey's Porch" and "Pompey's Theatre", so the real location survives in the play as the plotters' base rather than the murder site.

LITERARY INTERPRETATION. Elizabethan writers commonly imagined the Capitol as Rome's seat of government, much as we say 'Westminster' for Parliament. Shakespeare follows that habit, and gains a symbolic setting: the hill of Jupiter, where triumphs ended, becomes the place where the triumphant man is cut down.

Caesar's deafness

HISTORICAL RECORD. No ancient source says Caesar was deaf in one ear. Plutarch and Suetonius do record epileptic seizures, the "falling sickness" Brutus diagnoses.

SHAKESPEARE'S TEXT. Caesar tells Antony, "Come on my right hand, for this ear is deaf, / And tell me truly what thou think'st of him."

LITERARY INTERPRETATION. The deafness appears to be Shakespeare's invention, and it arrives at a perfectly chosen moment: immediately after Caesar's most penetrating speech about how well he reads men. The man who "looks / Quite through the deeds of men" cannot hear on one side. Many critics read this as a small emblem of the whole character, magnificent in judgement and defective in perception, though the text does not label it so.

Three crown offerings versus Plutarch's two

HISTORICAL RECORD. In Plutarch's account Antony offered the diadem twice, and both times the refusal drew louder applause than the offer.

SHAKESPEARE'S TEXT. Brutus asks Casca "Was the crown offered him thrice?" and Casca answers "Ay, marry, was 't, and he put it by thrice, every time gentler than other" ('marry' is a mild oath meaning 'indeed'; to 'put by' is to push aside). Cassius has already counted the offstage noise: "They shouted thrice."

LITERARY INTERPRETATION. Three is the number of ritual and folk tale, and it lets Casca chart a decline: each refusal "gentler than other", each one, in his telling, more reluctant. Two refusals could be modesty; three graded refusals look like performance. Shakespeare also adds Casca's cynicism that Caesar "would fain have had it", which is nowhere in Plutarch, so the audience receives the event already interpreted by an enemy.

The tribunes' timing and fate

HISTORICAL RECORD. The tribunes removed a diadem from a statue and arrested men who hailed Caesar as king, most probably in January 44 BC. Caesar deposed them from office.

SHAKESPEARE'S TEXT. The tribunes act on the day of the triumph and the Lupercalia, and Casca reports that they "for pulling scarves off Caesar's images, are put to silence."

LITERARY INTERPRETATION. By moving their action onto the festival day and leaving their fate ambiguous, Shakespeare makes the punishment fall with shocking speed and lets the audience fear the worst. The phrase 'put to silence' is deliberately colder than 'removed from office'.

Graffiti into forged letters

HISTORICAL RECORD. Plutarch says that anonymous messages appeared on Brutus's praetor's chair and on the statue of his ancestor, urging him to act. Their authors are unknown.

SHAKESPEARE'S TEXT. Cassius plans the letters himself: "I will this night / In several hands in at his windows throw, / As if they came from several citizens, / Writings, all tending to the great opinion / That Rome holds of his name", and in Scene 3 gives Cinna the papers for "the praetor's chair" and "old Brutus' statue".

LITERARY INTERPRETATION. This is the change that most alters the moral shape of the play. In history, Brutus may have been responding to real public feeling; in Shakespeare, he is deceived by a friend. One strong reading is that the forged letters compromise the conspiracy's claim to honour from the outset, and that the audience, unlike Brutus, knows it.

REVISION The changes in one glance

Triumph (October 45 BC) + tribunes (January 44 BC) + Lupercalia (15 February 44 BC) → one day. One silent month between Scenes 2 and 3. Curia of Pompey → the Capitol. Deafness → invented. Two offerings → three, plus Casca's cynicism. Tribunes deposed → 'put to silence'. Anonymous graffiti → Cassius's forgeries. Learn these seven and you will never again write history as if it were the play, or the play as if it were history.

Shakespeare's Source and the London of 1599

HISTORICAL RECORD. Shakespeare's main source was Sir Thomas North's English translation of Plutarch's *Parallel Lives*, published in 1579, itself translated from a French version. The Lives of Caesar, Brutus and Antony gave him nearly every incident in Act 1: the Lupercalia, the diadem, the tribunes, the omens, the soothsayer's warning, the graffiti, Caesar's remark that he feared lean and pale men rather than fat ones, and Caesar's epilepsy. Where a detail in the play is not in Plutarch, such as the deafness, the Tiber race and Casca's three offerings, you are looking at Shakespeare's own hand. The play was on the London stage by September 1599, when a Swiss visitor recorded seeing a tragedy of Julius Caesar at a Bankside theatre, almost certainly the newly built Globe.

LITERARY INTERPRETATION. In 1599 Queen Elizabeth I was sixty-six, unmarried and without a named heir. The question of who would rule after her was the most dangerous topic in England, and it could not be discussed openly. Official teaching held that rebellion against a monarch was a grave sin; at the same time, educated people knew the classical arguments for killing a tyrant. A play about a Republic destroying itself over the fear of one man's rule, and about the chaos that followed, may well have spoken to those anxieties. Audiences may have felt the parallel; we cannot prove what they felt, and you should never write as though we can. The safe and accurate formulation for an answer is: 'Written in 1599, when Elizabeth was ageing without an heir, the play explores questions of succession and legitimate power that many in its first audience may have found uncomfortably close to home.'

HISTORICAL FACT → North's Plutarch (1579) supplied the incidents of Act 1; the play was performed by September 1599 in a London ruled by an elderly, heirless queen.



WHAT A ROMAN AUDIENCE MAY HAVE UNDERSTOOD → Not applicable here; the audience that matters is Elizabethan, for whom republican Rome was both a classroom classic and a mirror they could not name.



HOW SHAKESPEARE USES IT → He keeps Plutarch's facts, sharpens them (three offerings, forged letters) and adds small inventions (deafness) that turn history into character.



WHY IT MATTERS FOR ICSE → A single well-placed sentence on the source or the 1599 context can earn credit in an evaluative sub-question, but only if phrased as interpretation. Never assert what Elizabethan audiences 'thought'.

Carrying This Into the Scenes

You now hold the twenty or so ideas that make Act 1 legible. Here is how to carry them into the scene-by-scene chapters and, eventually, into the examination room.

CROSS-REFERENCE Where this history is put to work

The Cobbler, the Carpenter and the tribunes are read closely in 'Act 1 Scene 1 — The Street: Commoners, Tribunes and the Fickle Crowd'. The Lupercalia rite, the Soothsayer and Cassius's persuasion are taken line by line in 'Act 1 Scene 2 (Part One) — Lupercalia, the Soothsayer, and the Seduction of Brutus'; Casca's report of the crown is analysed in 'Act 1 Scene 2 (Part Two) — Caesar Returns, Casca Reports, Cassius Plots'. The storm, omens and the dagger speech belong to 'Act 1 Scene 3 — The Storm: Omens, Fear and the Conspiracy Takes Shape'. The values of dignitas, libertas and republicanism are developed thematically in 'Themes of Act 1 (Part One)'. Where the historical background reappears in Acts 3 to 5, see 'The Scene Connection Engine and Where Act 1 Reappears Later'.

ICSE EXAM BOX Using history in an answer without losing marks

Three rules. First, history supports a point about the text; it never replaces one. One sentence of context, then back to Shakespeare's words. Second, label your knowledge: 'historically' for the record, 'in the play' for the text, 'Casca reports' or 'Cassius claims' for biased narrators. Third, never let a historical fact contradict the play in your answer. If you write that Caesar was killed in the Curia of Pompey when the question is about the Act 3 extract set in the Capitol, you have shown knowledge and lost the thread. Examiners mark your reading of the text.

REVISION The ten facts to carry into every Act 1 scene

1. Rome is a Republic founded (509 BC) on hatred of the word 'king'; Brutus is named for its founder.
2. Tribunes were sacrosanct protectors of the people; silencing them shows Caesar above the law.
3. Two consuls shared power; Antony, a consul, obeys Caesar like a servant.
4. Citizens were free by definition; Cassius's language of bondage is meant to shame.
5. Dignitas, gloria, auctoritas and the mos maiorum explain Cassius's envy, Caesar's pride, Brutus's value and the conspirators' appeal to the ancestors.
6. Armies loyal to generals (Marius, Sulla) are the real basis of Caesar's power.
7. Caesar and Pompey were allies, then enemies; Pompey's ghost haunts every scene.
8. A triumph over Romans was a scandal; Marullus's questions are a legal checklist.
9. The Lupercalia was a fertility festival; the diadem was offered twice in Plutarch, thrice in Shakespeare.
10. Caesar was dictator for life by February 44 BC; the crown was the name for what already existed.

The history is now behind you. From the next chapter onward, every time a character says 'Rome', 'king', 'free', 'tribune' or 'Pompey', you will hear what a Roman heard, and you will be able to say, precisely, what Shakespeare kept, what he changed, and why.

CHAPTER 3

Act 1 Scene 1 — The Street: Commoners, Tribunes and the Fickle Crowd

What this chapter does: it takes the shortest scene in Act 1 and teaches it as the professional Shakespearean reads it — as a complete piece of political theatre, not a warm-up. You will first learn what literally happens, then what it means, then why Shakespeare built it this way, then how it wires itself into Acts 2 to 5, and finally how the scene earns marks in an ICSE answer. Every difficult word is explained the first time it appears. Every important passage is taught line by line with the same fixed labels, so you can scan and revise. By the end you should be able to explain the Cobbler's jokes, Marullus's speech and Flavius's falcon image without notes.

Before You Begin: How to Read This Scene Without Fear

You have probably been told that Act 1 Scene 1 is 'just an introduction'. It is not. It is a small, perfectly engineered machine, and once you see how it works, the rest of the play becomes far easier, because almost every large idea in *Julius Caesar* is switched on here in miniature: the power of the crowd, the fear of one man rising above the rest, the clash between the classes, the gap between what people say and what they mean, and the sense that Rome is quietly breaking.

Three practical facts will remove most of your difficulty.

First, who is on stage. Only four people speak: two tribunes, Flavius and Marullus, and two workmen, a Carpenter and a Cobbler. A crowd of other commoners stands with the workmen but says nothing. Caesar never appears; he is only talked about. Neither Brutus nor Cassius appears. So you are not being asked to juggle the famous characters yet — only to watch two officials confront a holiday crowd.

Second, the shape of the language. The commoners speak **prose** (ordinary sentences, printed like a paragraph). The tribunes speak **verse** (lines of roughly ten syllables, printed with a capital letter at the start of each line). Shakespeare uses this split deliberately: the workmen sound quick, earthy and witty; the tribunes sound formal, elevated and angry. When the Cobbler jokes, he does it in prose. When Marullus delivers his great speech about Pompey, he does it in verse. If you notice the switch, you have already begun to read like a critic.

Third, the vocabulary. Most of the difficulty in this scene is a small set of old or specialised words. Learn the table below once, and the scene opens up.

Word or phrase in the scene	What it means here
"Hence!" / "mechanical" / "thy rule"	Away from here! / manual workers, tradesmen / a measuring ruler

Word or phrase in the scene	What it means here
"apparel" / "attire"	clothing, clothes
"thou knave" / "naughty" / "saucy fellow"	rascal / worthless, wicked (much stronger than today) / cheeky, insolent
"bad soles" / "the awl" / "withal"	the bottoms of shoes (heard as 'souls') / a pointed tool for piercing leather (heard as 'all') / nevertheless (heard as 'with awl')
"recover" / "neat's leather" / "proper"	put a new cover on, and also restore to health / cowhide ('neat' is an old word for cattle) / handsome, fine
"wherefore" / "tributaries" / "captive bonds"	why / conquered rulers who pay tribute / the chains of prisoners
"senseless" / "Many a time and oft" / "livelong day"	without feeling / very often / the whole day long
"replication" / "concave shores"	echo / hollowed-out, overhanging river banks
"cull out" / "strew flowers" / "intermit"	pick out, select / scatter / hold back, suspend
"needs must light on" / "your sort"	must inevitably fall upon / your class of people
"whe'er" / "basest mettle" / "tongue-tied"	whether / lowest, most worthless nature (with a pun on cheap metal) / unable to speak
"images" / "decked" / "ceremonies" / "trophies"	statues / decorated / ceremonial decorations / tokens of victory
"the vulgar" / "ordinary pitch" / "servile"	the common people / the height to which a falcon climbs / slave-like
"triumph" / "the feast of Lupercal"	the grand victory parade through Rome that the Senate granted a conquering general / the Lupercalia, a Roman purification and fertility festival held on 15 February

Keep this table beside you. Chapter 20 (Difficult Shakespearean English: The Act 1 Vocabulary System) builds a fuller system, but these are the words that unlock this scene.

The Five Levels: A First Pass Through the Scene

Before we take the scene apart, walk through it five times at increasing depth. This is the method the whole book uses, and it is the method you should use in the exam hall: never write about meaning until you are sure of the facts, and never write about Shakespeare's craft until you are sure of the meaning.

LEVEL 1 — What happened?

It is a public holiday in Rome, and the streets are full of working men in their best clothes. Two tribunes — elected officials whose traditional job is to protect the ordinary people — arrive and are furious. Flavius orders the crowd home, demanding to know why tradesmen are wandering about on a working day without the tools or aprons that mark their trade. Flavius demands a Carpenter's trade and gets a plain answer; Marullus asks where the man's apron and rule are, then turns to a Cobbler, who refuses to answer plainly and instead spins a chain of jokes about mending soles, mending the tribunes themselves, living by the awl and being a 'surgeon' to old shoes. Pressed for the real reason he is out, the Cobbler finally admits it: the people have taken the day off to see Caesar and celebrate his triumph. Marullus explodes. He asks what conquest Caesar has actually won and what foreign captives follow his chariot — the answer being none. He reminds the crowd how they once waited all day on walls and rooftops to cheer Pompey, so loudly that the river Tiber shook; and now they dress up and scatter flowers for the man who triumphs over Pompey's own blood. He calls them ungrateful and tells them to go home and pray that the gods hold back the plague such ingratitude deserves. Flavius sends them off to weep into the Tiber. The commoners leave in silence. Flavius then tells Marullus to split up and strip any decorations from Caesar's statues. Marullus hesitates because it is the feast of Lupercal; Flavius overrules him. The scene ends with Flavius's image of Caesar as a young hawk whose growing feathers must be plucked before he soars beyond the sight of men and keeps everyone in slavish fear.

LEVEL 2 — What does it mean?

Underneath the quarrel about aprons and shoes, the scene is about loyalty and who deserves it. The tribunes are not really angry about a missed day of work; they are frightened that the people of Rome have transferred their love from Pompey — the dead republican hero — to Caesar, the man who destroyed him. To the tribunes, Caesar's triumph is not a national victory but a civil-war victory over fellow Romans, which makes celebrating it a kind of betrayal. The Cobbler's wordplay means something too: a working man can be sharper than the officials who sneer at him, and the class that the tribunes call 'idle' and 'vulgar' is neither stupid nor silent. The crowd's silent exit means that public feeling in Rome is soft and movable — it can be shouted into shame in a few minutes. And Flavius's final image means that at least some Romans already see Caesar as a danger who must be cut down to ordinary size before he becomes untouchable.

LEVEL 3 — Why did Shakespeare write it this way?

Shakespeare had a choice. He could have opened with Caesar in glory, or with Brutus brooding, or with the conspirators plotting. Instead he opened at street level, with nobodies. This does several things at once. It establishes Rome as a divided city before we meet any of the great men, so that when Caesar enters in Scene 2 we already know he is loved by the crowd and feared by the officials. It introduces the crowd as a character in its own right — a character that will decide the fate of Rome in Act 3. It lets comedy do serious work: the Cobbler's puns relax the audience and make the tribunes look pompous, so that when Marullus's anger becomes genuinely eloquent we feel the shift from farce to fear. The prose-verse contrast marks class instantly for the ear. And by keeping Caesar offstage, Shakespeare makes us build our first picture of him entirely from other people's reactions — which is exactly how reputation works in politics. The scene teaches the audience how to watch the play: listen to what the crowd is doing, and ask who is steering it.

LEVEL 4 — How does it connect to the whole play?

Almost every thread pulled here is tied off later. The crowd that switches from Pompey to Caesar will switch from Caesar to Brutus and from Brutus to Antony in Act 3 Scene 2, and will then tear an innocent poet to pieces in Act 3 Scene 3 for having the wrong name. The tribunes' stripping of Caesar's statues has a direct consequence in Scene 2, where Casca reports that Marullus and Flavius have been "put to silence" for pulling scarves off Caesar's images — our first sight of Caesar's power to crush opposition, and a fact that Cassius and Brutus can use. Flavius's fear that Caesar will "soar above the view of men" is exactly the fear Cassius exploits in Scene 2 and Brutus wrestles with in Act 2 Scene 1. The word "Pompey" will echo all the way to the conspirators meeting at Pompey's Porch in Scene 3 and Caesar falling at the foot of Pompey's statue in Act 3 Scene 1. The theme of ingratitude, first flung at the crowd, will return with terrible force when Caesar is killed by men he trusted. In short, Scene 1 is the play's seed-bed.

LEVEL 5 — How do I use it in an ICSE answer?

Be honest with yourself about the exam first. Act 1 is the Class IX portion of the syllabus; the Class X board paper sets its drama extracts from Acts III, IV and V. So you will almost certainly not receive an extract from this scene in the board examination. But you will need this scene constantly, in three ways. First, any question about the crowd in Act 3 — why Antony succeeds, why the mob turns, why Cinna the poet dies — is answered far better by a candidate who can say that Shakespeare established the crowd's fickleness in the very first scene, and who can name the Pompey-to-Caesar shift as the first swing in a pattern. Second, questions about why the conspirators fear Caesar, or whether their fear is justified, can draw on the tribunes' republican anxiety and their punishment for touching Caesar's statues. Third, Class IX internal examinations and 'reference to the context' tests do set this scene directly, and sub-questions such as 'Explain the wordplay of the Cobbler' or 'What does Marullus accuse the commoners of?' are exactly the kind of thing this chapter prepares you for. The rule: quote briefly, explain precisely, connect to the larger pattern.

CROSS-REFERENCE Where this chapter sits in the book

This chapter assumes the background from *Chapter 02 — Roman History Before Act 1*, especially what a tribune was, what a triumph was, and who Pompey was; brief reminders are given here in history boxes, but the fuller story is there. The consequence of the tribunes' actions is reported by Casca in *Chapter 05 — Act 1 Scene 2 (Part Two)*. The crowd's later behaviour is traced in *Chapter 16 — The Scene Connection Engine and Where Act 1 Reappears Later*. Practice extracts from this scene are in *Chapter 18 — Extract-Based Training (Part One)*, and the devices named here are catalogued in *Chapter 13 — The Act 1 Literary-Device Bank*.

The Scene as a Complete Dramatic Unit: Twenty Angles

A professional reader does not read a scene once; he turns it in the light and looks at it from many sides. The twenty short sections below do exactly that. Do not skim them as a checklist — each one is a lens, and the exam rewards candidates who can switch lenses.

1 Setting

SHAKESPEARE'S TEXT gives no scene heading at all in the First Folio; the familiar 'Rome. A street.' was added by later editors, and it is the natural inference from Flavius's order to the workmen to leave the "streets" and Marullus's command to "Run to your houses". So we are outdoors, in public, in the open city — not in a palace, a Senate house or a private home. This matters. Public space in Rome belongs to no one and to everyone; it is where power is displayed (a triumph is a parade through the streets) and where power is contested (the tribunes try to clear those same streets). The time is a festival day: the Cobbler says "we make holiday", and Marullus later reminds Flavius "it is the feast of Lupercal". Shakespeare has quietly fused two occasions — Caesar's triumph and the Lupercalia — into one crowded afternoon, so that the setting itself is saturated with celebration. Every costume detail supports this: the men wear their "best apparel" and "best attire" rather than working clothes. The setting is, in effect, a party that two angry officials are trying to shut down.

2 Characters

Four people speak. **Flavius** and **Marullus** are tribunes of the people (see angle 14 for the office). Flavius opens the scene and closes it; he gives the orders, including the order to strip the statues, and he has the final, image-laden speech. Marullus shares the interrogating (the apron question, "Answer me directly") and delivers the great Pompey speech; he is the orator of the pair, but also the one who hesitates. **The Carpenter** speaks once, plainly and respectfully: "Why, sir, a carpenter." He is the ordinary, obedient workman. **The Cobbler** is the star of the first half: evasive, witty, punning, never quite insolent enough to be arrested, and finally the one who states the real reason for the holiday. Around them stand **the other Commoners**, who never speak but whose silent exit is one of the scene's most important moments. Off stage, but present in every line, stands **Caesar**, and behind him the ghost of **Pompey**. Notice that none of the commoners has a name. They are defined entirely by trade. That anonymity is the point: they are 'the people', a collective, and the play will treat them as one body with one changeable mood.

3 Political situation

HISTORICAL RECORD: Rome in the play's opening is a republic in name that has been ruled for years by military strongmen. Caesar has defeated Pompey at Pharsalus, Pompey has been murdered in Egypt, and Caesar has finished off Pompey's sons in Spain; he holds the dictatorship, an emergency office that was supposed to last six months and that he has held again and again. **SHAKESPEARE'S TEXT** compresses all this into a single sentence of the Cobbler's — the people "rejoice in his triumph" — and a single furious question of Marullus's about a triumph "over Pompey's blood". The tribunes represent the old republican constitution: officers elected to protect the plebeians against the powerful. But in this scene the plebeians do not want protecting; they want a holiday and a hero. That reversal is the political situation in a nutshell. The people and their official guardians have come apart. Caesar's popularity now flows directly from crowd to leader, bypassing the institutions that were meant to stand between them, and the tribunes can feel the ground going. The stripping of the statues is a small, symbolic attempt to reassert institutional control over a personality cult — the worship of one leader as if he were more than a man — that is already outgrowing it.

4 What happens

The action has four movements. **Movement one — confrontation:** the tribunes order the crowd home and demand to know their trades; the Carpenter answers, the Cobbler stalls with wordplay. **Movement two — revelation:** pressed, the Cobbler admits the crowd is out "to see Caesar and to rejoice in his triumph". **Movement three — rebuke:** Marullus's speech about Pompey, followed by Flavius's order to go and weep into the Tiber; the commoners leave without a word. **Movement four — plan:** the tribunes agree to split up,

drive the crowd from the streets and strip Caesar's statues of their decorations, over Marullus's religious scruple about the Lupercal. Shakespeare structures the scene so that the comic energy peaks early (the puns), the emotional energy peaks in the middle (the Pompey speech), and the political energy peaks at the end (the plan and the falcon image). Each movement is shorter and more serious than the one before. That tightening is what gives such a small scene its sense of urgency.

5 Why it happens

On the surface, the tribunes are enforcing a rule about working days. But Shakespeare makes their real motive unmistakable within a few lines. They are not offended by idleness; they are offended by whom the idleness honours. Flavius's first words attack the holiday itself — "Is this a holiday?" — before he knows what it is for, and Marullus's fury only becomes eloquent once Caesar's name is spoken. So the deeper cause of the scene is the tribunes' fear that a triumph over Romans is being celebrated as if it were a triumph over foreigners, and that the people's applause is manufacturing exactly the kind of one-man power the Republic was founded to prevent. There is a further, subtler cause: the tribunes are losing a competition for the crowd's loyalty, and they know it. Their contempt is partly wounded pride. **LITERARY INTERPRETATION:** many critics also see the tribunes acting from a memory of Pompey that is as much political as personal — Pompey stood, however imperfectly, for the Senate's side in the civil war, and to cheer his conqueror is to cheer the defeat of the Senate's cause.

6 What each character wants

Flavius wants the streets emptied and Caesar's public honours removed; more deeply, he wants Caesar brought down to "an ordinary pitch" before it is too late. **Marullus** wants the same, but he also wants to be understood — his speech is an attempt to make the crowd feel shame, not simply to obey — and he wants to avoid offending the gods on a holy day. **The Carpenter** wants to avoid trouble; he answers at once. **The Cobbler** wants to enjoy his holiday, to keep his dignity in front of men who despise him, to score a few points off authority without paying for them, and — he tells us so with a grin — to drum up business, since a crowd walking the streets will "wear out their shoes". **The silent Commoners** want to see Caesar. That is all they want, and Shakespeare lets that simplicity stand as a fact about crowds: they want spectacle and a figure to cheer. Understanding these wants matters because the scene's conflict is not good against bad; it is several legitimate desires colliding in a public square.

7 What changes during the scene

At the start, the street is full of celebrating tradesmen; at the end it is nearly empty and the tribunes are on their way to deface the dictator's statues. That is the visible change. The invisible changes are more interesting. The crowd shifts from festive confidence to guilty silence; the Cobbler, so talkative early on, is not given a single word after Marullus's speech. The tribunes shift from scolding officials to active resisters — they move from words to an act of political defiance. And the audience's mood shifts too: we begin laughing at puns and end with an image of a hawk that must have its feathers plucked. Yet notice what does *not* change. The commoners are not convinced; they are cowed. Nothing in the text says they now hate Caesar. In Scene 2 the crowd is cheering him again within the hour. Shakespeare shows us a mood being suppressed, not a mind being changed, and the difference between those two things is one of the play's great subjects.

8 What the audience learns

We learn, in order: that it is a holiday; that tradesmen are celebrating; that the celebration is for Caesar's triumph; that this triumph is over Pompey's kin rather than foreign enemies; that the same crowd once adored Pompey; that officials exist who regard Caesar's rise as dangerous; that Caesar's statues have been decorated

like idols; that today is also the Lupercal; and that at least one official believes Caesar would "soar above the view of men" if not checked. We learn all this without a single word from Caesar. We also learn something about tone: this is a play in which ordinary people will be allowed to be funny and clever, and in which the great political speeches will be aimed at exactly such people. Finally, and most importantly, we learn how to read the rest of the play: whenever a crowd shouts, ask who has moved it, and how fast.

9 What Shakespeare deliberately withholds

Notice the silences. Caesar is never seen. The commoners never tell us whether Marullus has persuaded them — they simply "vanish". The triumph is never named or described; there is no mention of Spain, of Munda, of the actual battle. The names of the Carpenter and the Cobbler are withheld, so that they remain types. Brutus and Cassius, the men who will actually act on the tribunes' fear, are not even mentioned. We are not told whether the tribunes' fear is justified; the scene gives us their view and no rebuttal. And Shakespeare withholds the consequence of stripping the statues until Casca reports it in Scene 2. Each of these gaps is a deliberate design choice. By withholding Caesar, Shakespeare makes reputation the first thing we experience. By withholding the crowd's reply, he keeps the question 'what does the crowd really think?' open — a question the play will answer, brutally, in Act 3. By withholding a counter-argument, he lets the republican fear stand as the audience's first frame for Caesar, so that when Caesar does appear we are already watching him for signs of the tyrant. Great dramatists control what you do not know as carefully as what you do.

10 Important language

Three registers of language meet in this scene. **The language of command** belongs to the tribunes: "Hence!", "get you home!", "Speak, what trade art thou?", "Answer me directly", "Be gone!", "Run to your houses". Imperatives pile up, and they tell us these men are used to being obeyed — and are alarmed that they may not be. **The language of evasion and wit** belongs to the Cobbler: he answers questions with definitions ("a mender of bad / soles"), with offers ("I can mend you"), with boasts ("a / surgeon to old shoes"), with anything except a straight reply. His speech is dense with double meanings, and its rhythm is quick, colloquial prose. **The language of rhetoric** belongs to Marullus's speech and Flavius's closing lines: rhetorical questions in series, the direct address "O you hard hearts", the ceremonial epithet (descriptive title) "great Pompey", the grand hyperbole (deliberate exaggeration) of a river trembling, and finally the controlled, metaphorical verse of the hawk. The scene therefore teaches you, within a few minutes, to hear three ways of using words: to order, to deflect, and to persuade. All three will return. The last of them — persuasion aimed at a crowd — is the engine of Act 3.

11 Important images

An image is a picture made in words, and this scene has five that you should be able to describe and interpret. **The missing tools:** the "leather apron" and "thy rule" that the workmen should be wearing. Their absence is a picture of order abandoned — a man without the sign of his trade is, to the tribunes, a man out of his place. **The stone crowd:** "You blocks, you stones, you worse than senseless / things!" The people are pictured as lumps of inert matter, incapable of feeling; then the insult is sharpened — they are *worse* than stones, because stones at least cannot be ungrateful. **The trembling river:** the Tiber shaking beneath its banks at the echo of the crowd's shout for Pompey. This turns a river into a frightened body and a cheer into an earthquake — a picture of how enormous public love once was, and therefore how enormous the present betrayal is. **The river of tears:** Flavius's order to the poor to weep into the Tiber until "the lowest stream / Do kiss the most exalted shores of all" — a grotesque hyperbole in which the people's guilt should be large enough to flood Rome. **The plucked hawk:** Caesar as a young bird of prey whose "growing feathers" must be pulled so that he flies "an ordinary pitch". Notice how the images move from the low and physical (aprons, stones) to the elevated and airborne (a hawk above the sight of men). That upward movement is the scene's own picture of ambition.

12 Literary devices

Only devices genuinely present are listed; do not invent others in an exam. **Pun (wordplay):** the Cobbler's soles/souls, out/out, mend/mend, awl/all, withal/with awl, recover/re-cover — see the dedicated section later. **Prose–verse contrast:** commoners in prose, tribunes in verse, marking class and tone. **Rhetorical question:** Marullus's "Wherefore rejoice? What conquest brings he home?" and the triple "And do you now..." — questions that expect no answer because the answer is shaming. **Anaphora (repetition at the start of successive lines):** "And do you now put on your best attire? / And do you now cull out a holiday? / And do you now strew flowers in his way". **Apostrophe (direct emotional address):** "O you hard hearts, you cruel men of Rome". **Metaphor:** the crowd as "blocks" and "stones"; the Cobbler as "surgeon to old shoes"; Caesar as a hawk. **Personification:** the Tiber "trembled" beneath "her banks"; the statues are to be "Disrobe[d]" as though they wore clothes. **Hyperbole:** the trembling river, the flood of tears, the "chimney tops". **Synecdoche (a part standing for the whole):** "Pompey's blood" — blood standing for his kin and his cause. **Antithesis:** "the lowest stream" against "the most exalted shores"; "an ordinary pitch" against soaring "above the view of men". **Extended metaphor:** the falconry image sustained over four lines. **Dramatic irony and foreshadowing** are treated in angles 15 and 16.

KEYWORDS Terms to own from this scene

'Fickleness' (changeable loyalty); 'ingratitude'; 'republican' (loyal to rule by elected officials and the Senate, opposed to kingship); 'tribune'; 'triumph'; 'plebeians' or 'commoners'; 'public opinion'; 'hierarchy' (ranked social order); 'pun' or 'wordplay'; 'rhetorical question'; 'anaphora'; 'apostrophe'; 'hyperbole'; 'personification'; 'extended metaphor'; 'foreshadowing'; 'dramatic irony'; 'prose versus verse'. The full bank, with model sentences, is in *Chapter 14 — The ICSE Keyword Vault for Act 1*.

13 Themes

Public opinion and its fickleness. The crowd's love has moved from Pompey to Caesar; the scene's whole argument turns on that movement. **Power and the fear of one man.** Flavius's hawk speech is the first statement of the republican terror that a single Roman may rise above the rest. **Class and hierarchy.** Officials and workmen collide; the officials assume superiority, the workman quietly proves he is cleverer. **Loyalty, betrayal and ingratitude.** Marullus frames the crowd's behaviour as a moral failure — a betrayal of Pompey's memory. **Appearance versus reality.** Best clothes instead of aprons; statues dressed in decorations; a triumph that looks like conquest but is really civil war. **Language as power.** The scene is a contest of words — the Cobbler's deflections, Marullus's rhetoric — and words do move the crowd, at least for a moment. **Order versus holiday.** The tribunes want a labouring day; the people want a festival; Rome itself seems to be deciding whether it is a working republic or a spectacle for one man. Chapters 11 and 12 develop each of these across the whole Act; here you need only see that every one of them is already alive in the first minutes.

14 Historical context

HISTORICAL CONTEXT Tribunes, triumphs and a troubling victory

HISTORICAL RECORD. *Tribunes of the plebs* were created after the plebeians' first great walk-out from Rome in 494 BC. By the late Republic there were ten of them, elected annually; their persons were sacrosanct (protected by religious law), and they could veto legislation. Their whole purpose was to protect the common people against the power of the great. That is why it is so striking that Shakespeare's tribunes spend the scene abusing the people they exist to defend. A *triumph* was Rome's highest honour, granted by the Senate to a victorious general: a procession from the Campus Martius through the city to the Temple of Jupiter on the Capitoline hill, with captives in chains, wagons of spoils, the general in a four-horse chariot wearing purple and gold and a laurel wreath, and his soldiers following. Traditionally, a triumph celebrated victory over foreign enemies; a triumph over fellow Romans was regarded as improper. Caesar's last triumph, in October 45 BC, celebrated his victory at Munda in Spain over the sons of Pompey — and Plutarch records that Romans resented it precisely because it celebrated the killing of Romans. That resentment is what Marullus voices. Historically, the tribunes Gaius Epidius Marullus and Lucius Caesetius Flavus removed a diadem (a royal headband) from one of Caesar's statues in January 44 BC and were deposed from office for it. Shakespeare moves that episode onto the day of the triumph and the Lupercal (15 February), compressing months into an afternoon. The fuller narrative is in *Chapter 02 — Roman History Before Act 1*.

For the Elizabethan audience of 1599 there was a second layer. **LITERARY INTERPRETATION:** many editors note that the demand that workmen carry the "sign / Of your profession" on a working day sounds more like the regulated London of Shakespeare's own time — with its guilds, apprentices and rules about who might wear what — than anything recorded of ancient Rome. Shakespeare frequently dresses Rome in London clothes, and the Cobbler is as much an Elizabethan tradesman as a Roman one. (The Globe's own holiday audience of tradesmen and apprentices is considered in the insight box on public opinion below.)

15 Foreshadowing

Foreshadowing is a hint of what is to come. This scene is full of it, and the professional habit is to name the hint *and* the fulfilment. The crowd's shift from Pompey to Caesar foreshadows its shift from Brutus to Antony in Act 3 Scene 2. Marullus's prayer that the gods "intermit the plague / That needs must light on this ingratitude" foreshadows the civil war that will indeed fall on Rome after the assassination — a plague of the tribunes' own side's making. The stripping of Caesar's statues foreshadows the tribunes' punishment reported in Scene 2 and, on a larger scale, the conspirators' attempt to strip Caesar of power itself. Flavius's image of plucking Caesar's "growing feathers" foreshadows the conspiracy's logic: act now, before he is beyond reach — the very argument Brutus will make to himself in Act 2 Scene 1 when he decides that a dangerous creature must be dealt with while it is still in the shell. And the tribunes' contempt for "the vulgar" foreshadows the conspirators' fatal underestimation of the people, who will be the instrument of their ruin.

16 Dramatic irony

Dramatic irony occurs when the audience knows something the characters do not. Shakespeare's audience knew the story — the title alone told them Caesar would die. So every line here carries a double charge. The crowd celebrates Caesar; we know his triumph is his last. The tribunes set out to clip Caesar's wings; we know the wings will be clipped by other men, with daggers, and that the tribunes themselves will be silenced first. Marullus accuses the crowd of ingratitude; we know that Caesar will be killed by men who have received his pardons and favours, and that Antony will stand over the body and accuse *them* of exactly this vice. Flavius

fears Caesar will "keep us all in servile fearfulness"; we know that after Caesar's death Rome will fall into a fear far worse than anything he imposed. There is a smaller, sharper irony inside the scene itself: the tribunes reduce the crowd to silence — "tongue-tied" — and in the next scene it is they who are "put to silence". The silencers are silenced. Shakespeare rarely lets an act of contempt go unanswered.

17 Character development

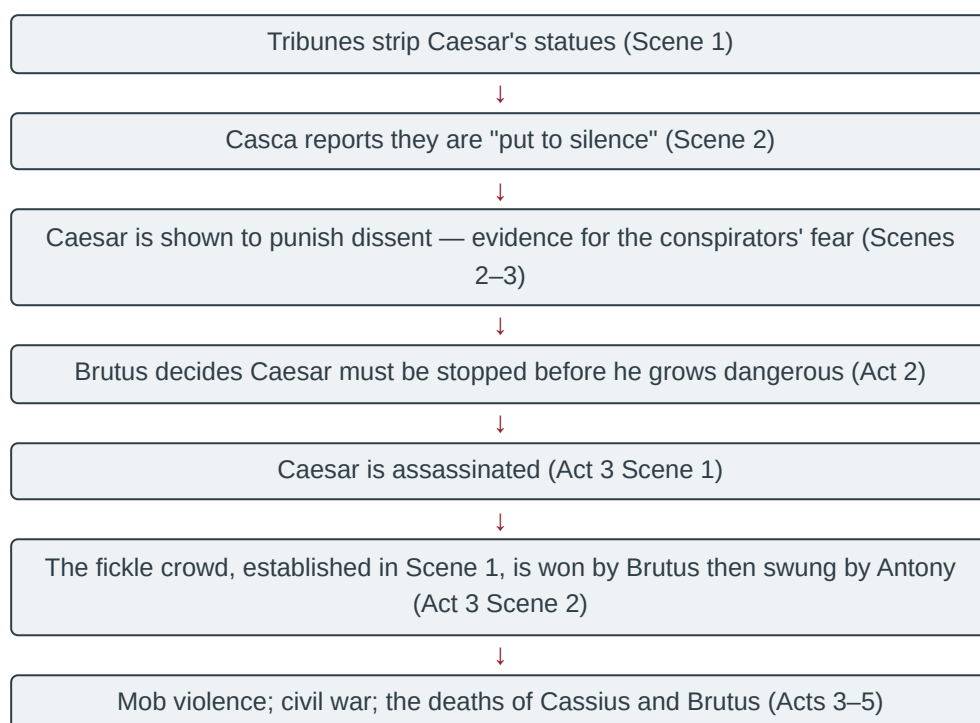
Neither tribune appears again, so their 'development' happens entirely within the scene, and it is real. **Flavius** moves from a bully shouting at workmen to a political thinker capable of the hawk metaphor; the scene lets us discover that his anger is principled. **Marullus** moves from blunt interrogation to soaring rhetoric — and then to hesitation, when he asks "May we do so?" on a holy day. In two lines Shakespeare gives him a conscience and shows that the pair are not identical: one dares, one doubts. **The Cobbler** begins as a comic evader and ends silent; his arc is the crowd's arc in miniature, from confidence to guilt. **The Carpenter** does not develop; he is the baseline of ordinary obedience against which the Cobbler's wit stands out. And **Caesar**, absent, develops in our minds from a name on a holiday to a hawk that must be plucked — the first stage of the play's long argument about who he really is.

18 Scene connections

Scene 1 flows directly into Scene 2: the same day, the same festival, the same crowd — but now the great men enter and the mood is public ceremony rather than street quarrel. The Lupercal that Marullus mentions becomes the race Antony runs. Caesar's "images", stripped here, return when Casca reports the tribunes' punishment. The shouting crowd that Marullus describes from memory becomes the crowd we *hear* shouting offstage in Scene 2 as Caesar refuses the crown. The tribunes' fear of Caesar's flight becomes Cassius's rhetoric of the Colossus (the giant statue a man might walk beneath) and the "narrow world". Scene 3's storm, with its talk of a man grown "prodigious" and "fearful", is the same fear in supernatural dress. Beyond Act 1, this scene's true partner is Act 3 Scene 2, the Forum scene: the same crowd, the same street rhetoric, the same swing of loyalty, but with a corpse on stage and history at stake.

19 Future consequences

Trace the chain of cause and effect that begins here:



The tribunes disappear from the play, but their two acts — the confrontation with the crowd and the defacing of the statues — set both of these chains running. The first exposes the crowd's softness, which the conspirators ignore and Antony exploits. The second exposes Caesar's intolerance of opposition, which the conspirators use as justification. You could argue that Scene 1 quietly supplies the two facts on which the whole tragedy depends.

20 ICSE exam relevance

ICSE EXAM BOX How Scene 1 earns marks — honestly stated

EXAM-ORIENTED ADVICE. For the ICSE Class X board paper, the prescribed portion of *Julius Caesar* is Acts III, IV and V; Acts I and II are the Class IX portion, examined in school. So an extract from Scene 1 in the board paper is not to be expected, and no one can promise you any question. But the Class X drama extract question — worth 16 marks, and in the 2025 paper divided into five sub-questions marked [3], [3], [3], [3] and [4] — repeatedly asks what happened earlier, why a character behaves as he does, and what a moment reveals about character or theme. Those are exactly the places where Scene 1 knowledge lifts an answer from adequate to excellent. Three uses to memorise: (1) any question on the crowd in Act 3 Scene 2 or 3 Scene 3 — cite the Pompey-to-Caesar shift as the first swing of a pattern; (2) any question on the conspirators' motives or on Caesar's tyranny — cite the tribunes' fear of a man who would "soar above the view of men" and their punishment for touching his statues; (3) any question about Antony's or Brutus's rhetoric — note that the play's first orator, Marullus, also used rhetorical questions and shaming to move a crowd, and that it worked only briefly. For Class IX internal tests, reference-to-context questions on the Cobbler's puns, Marullus's speech and Flavius's closing image are the usual fare (though no particular question can be predicted); the line-by-line section later in this chapter is built for those.

Here is the difference between an ordinary and an excellent answer to a typical Class IX-style sub-question: *"Why does Marullus call the commoners "You blocks, you stones, you worse than senseless things"?"* [3 marks]

WEAK ANSWER A weak answer

Marullus is angry with the commoners because they are celebrating Caesar's triumph and not working. He insults them by calling them blocks and stones because they are stupid.

EXCELLENT ANSWER An excellent answer

Marullus is enraged that the commoners are celebrating Caesar's triumph, which he regards as a victory "over Pompey's blood" — over fellow Romans — rather than a true conquest. He calls them "blocks" and "stones" because, like inert matter, they seem incapable of feeling or memory: they have forgotten how they once cheered "great Pompey" until the Tiber trembled. But they are "worse than senseless things" because stones cannot be ungrateful, whereas the crowd has feelings and yet has betrayed its old hero. The insult thus introduces the theme of the crowd's fickleness, which Shakespeare will develop when the same crowd turns from Brutus to Antony in Act 3.

Notice what the strong answer does: it quotes exactly, explains the logic of the insult rather than merely restating it, names a theme, and connects forward. That is the pattern this book will drill into you.

WHY SHAKESPEARE BEGINS WITH COMMONERS

Think of the openings Shakespeare rejected. A trumpet, a procession, Caesar in the chariot: that would have made the play Caesar's from the first second. Brutus alone in his orchard: that would have made it a study of one conscience. Cassius whispering to Casca: that would have made it a thriller. Instead the first face we see is a workman's, and the first voice we hear is an official's shouting at him. The choice is so unusual that we should treat it as the play's first argument.

PROFESSOR'S INSIGHT Why Shakespeare begins with ordinary citizens

One strong reading of *Julius Caesar* — and the reading this chapter follows — is that it is not, finally, the tragedy of one man but the tragedy of a city that cannot decide what it wants. Critics still argue over who the tragic hero is (Caesar? Brutus?), but Shakespeare signals the city's importance from the first line by making the city — in the form of its tradesmen — the first thing on stage. School guides usually say the commoners 'provide comic relief' or 'set the scene'. That undersells the design. The commoners are here because in this play the people are not background: they are the deciding vote. In Act 3 it is the crowd, not the Senate, that determines whether the assassination succeeds politically, and it is the crowd that Antony must win. By giving the people the stage first, Shakespeare tells us where the real power will lie. He also fixes the play's method of judging leaders: we will assess Caesar, Brutus and Antony largely by how they handle exactly this kind of crowd — and by what the crowd does to them. Notice, too, that the workmen are given the play's first jokes and its first act of verbal resistance. Shakespeare refuses to let the people be a faceless mass; he gives them a mind, in the Cobbler, before he shows them behaving like a herd. That order matters. It means that when they later behave like a herd, we cannot excuse it as stupidity. We have seen that they are capable of thought, and chose not to use it.

The political significance of the crowd

LITERARY INTERPRETATION. In a republic, legitimacy — the recognised right to rule — comes from the people; in a dictatorship, it comes from the person. This scene stages the exact moment when Rome's crowd is transferring its allegiance from the first model to the second. The tribunes, who hold their office *from* the people, discover that the people no longer look to them; they look to Caesar. Shakespeare shows political power as something that flows, like a river — the Tiber is not in the scene by accident — and that can be redirected. The crowd's political significance is therefore twofold. As a body, it is the source of Caesar's strength: Cassius will complain in Scene 2 that Caesar has become a god because men bend to him, and here we see the bending in progress. As a body without memory, it is also the source of everyone's weakness: whatever the crowd gives, it can take away. The tribunes attempt to reclaim the crowd by shame; Caesar (we learn in Scene 2) holds it by spectacle; Brutus will try reason and Antony will try tears, gold and a corpse. Scene 1 is the first round of a contest for the same prize, and the prize is a body of people who, in the end, belong to no one.

Flavius

Flavius has the first word and the last, which tells you he is the scene's frame. His opening is pure command — "Hence! Home, you idle creatures" — and his instinct throughout is to act: he interrogates, he dismisses, he assigns routes ("Go you down that way towards the Capitol. / This way will I"), and he issues the order that will destroy him: "Disrobe the images". When Marullus hesitates on religious grounds, Flavius brushes it aside in three words — "It is no matter" — and that brusqueness is a character note. He is a man of practical courage and limited caution. Yet Shakespeare gives *him*, not the eloquent Marullus, the scene's most intellectually serious speech, the falconry image. That is a deliberate surprise: the blunt enforcer turns out to have thought

most clearly about what Caesar is becoming. Flavius is, in miniature, a preview of the conspirators — decisive, principled, contemptuous of the crowd and blind to consequences. Historically his counterpart was Lucius Caesetius Flavius, deposed from the tribunate for the diadem affair; Shakespeare keeps the deposition (as "put to silence") but never lets us see it, so that Flavius simply vanishes, a small warning of how Caesar's Rome deals with dissent.

Marullus

Marullus is the interrogator and the orator. He asks the first sharp question — "Where is thy leather apron and thy rule?" — and he is the one the Cobbler dances around, which makes him slightly ridiculous for a few minutes. Then the Cobbler names Caesar, and Marullus becomes a different man. His speech about Pompey is the scene's emotional centre: it moves from savage insult ("You blocks, you stones") to grieving memory (the crowds on the rooftops) to accusation (the flowers strewn for Pompey's conqueror) to religious warning (the plague that ingratitude deserves). This is genuine rhetoric — structured, escalating, aimed at the feelings — and it is the first demonstration in the play of what a well-made speech can do to a crowd. But Shakespeare also gives Marullus a moment of doubt that Flavius lacks: "May we do so? / You know it is the feast of Lupercal." He will insult the people without a qualm, but he fears offending the gods. **LITERARY**

INTERPRETATION: one strong reading is that Marullus represents the conscience of the old Republic — pious, traditional, articulate — while Flavius represents its nerve. Neither, alone, is enough, and together they achieve nothing but their own removal. Historically his counterpart was Gaius Epidius Marullus; the Folio spells the name 'Murellus', and some editions keep that form.

The Carpenter

The Carpenter speaks a single line, and it is worth asking why Shakespeare bothered with him at all. He is the control in the experiment. Asked his trade, he answers at once and with respect: "Why, sir, a carpenter." He does not joke, does not evade, does not argue. Against this plain obedience the Cobbler's evasions stand out as choices, not as the only way a workman could respond. The Carpenter also establishes the tribunes' expectation — that commoners will answer when questioned — so that the Cobbler's refusal to be pinned down registers as a small act of rebellion. In a scene about how the people can be handled, the Carpenter is the people as the tribunes wish they were: known by their trade, quick to answer, easy to send home. The Cobbler is the people as they actually are.

The Cobbler

The Cobbler is the first fully alive person in the play. Everything about him is double. His trade is double: a 'cobbler' in Elizabethan English meant both a shoe-mender and a clumsy bungler, which is why Marullus, hearing the word, demands again "But what trade art thou?" — he has heard 'I am a botcher', not 'I am a shoemaker'. His answers are double: each one is true on the surface and mocking underneath. His motives are double: he is out to see Caesar *and* to drum up trade. Even his morality is double-edged — he practises a trade he can use "with a safe / conscience", a phrase that quietly asks whether the tribunes can say the same of theirs. What he never does is lose his temper or overstep. He keeps calling the tribunes 'sir'; he begs them not to be angry; he claims he means nothing but shoes. That is the survival wit of the powerless, and Shakespeare admires it. **LITERARY INTERPRETATION:** the Cobbler shows us that the common people of this play are not fools. They are shrewd, verbal and self-interested — and that makes their later behaviour as a mob more disturbing, not less. When the crowd in Act 3 tears a man apart for his name, we cannot say they lacked the intelligence to know better. The Cobbler proved they had it.

PROFESSOR'S INSIGHT**Why Caesar is not placed at the centre of our understanding at once**

A lesser dramatist would have introduced Caesar so that we could judge him for ourselves. Shakespeare makes us meet his reputation before his person — and, crucially, meet it through hostile witnesses. Our first frame for Caesar is the tribunes': a man triumphing over Romans, a man whose statues are dressed like a god's, a hawk to be plucked. Only in Scene 2 do we see him, and by then we are already scanning him for the tyrant. This is a deliberate manipulation of the audience, and it mirrors what the conspirators do to themselves. They too build their Caesar out of fears, reports and images rather than out of the man in front of them. When Caesar does appear he is imperious but also deaf in one ear, superstitious about barrenness, and (Casca tells us) subject to fainting fits — a very human figure who does not quite match the monster of Scene 1. The gap between the reputation and the man is the play's central problem, and Shakespeare plants it by delaying the man. There is a further effect. Because Caesar is a name before he is a body, the play is from the start about 'Caesar' as an idea — the name Cassius will weigh against 'Brutus', the name that will outlive the corpse. Keeping the person offstage lets the name grow first.

Wordplay and puns: getting every joke

A pun is a joke that depends on one sound carrying two meanings. Elizabethan audiences loved them and expected to hear them fast; you have the luxury of slowing down. Here is every pun in the Cobbler's sequence, explained so that you can both get the joke and see its point — which is that the commoner outwits his social superiors while appearing to be perfectly polite.

"a mender of bad / soles". Marullus demands the Cobbler's trade. The Cobbler says he mends bad *soles* — the bottoms of shoes. But the word sounds exactly like *souls*. So he has also claimed to be a mender of bad *souls* — a priest, a moral reformer. The joke is that a humble shoemaker has just described himself in the language of religion, and has also hinted that the tribunes' souls might need mending. It is Flavius who takes it as insolence — his is the next line, "What trade, thou knave? Thou naughty knave, what trade?" — and Marullus has to repeat the question before the Cobbler will go on.

"be not out with me. / Yet if you be out, sir, I can mend you." *Out with me* means 'angry with me'. But *out* also means 'having worn-out shoes' — out at the toes, out at the heels. So the sentence says: 'Do not be angry with me; but if your shoes are worn out, I can repair them.' The tribune hears 'I can fix you', a claim to correct his betters, and asks what he means. The Cobbler innocently replies: "Why, sir, cobble you" — 'patch your shoes'. Once again the working man has said something cheeky and retreated behind the literal meaning.

"all that I live by is with the awl." An *awl* is the pointed tool a cobbler uses to pierce leather. The sentence means 'I earn my whole living with the awl.' But *awl* sounds like *all*, so it also says 'everything I live by is with all' — a nonsense that keeps the tribunes guessing, and a boast that his one small tool is his 'all'. This is the pun a struggling student most often misses, because 'awl' is an unfamiliar word; learn it and the line becomes funny.

"withal". The Cobbler says he meddles with no tradesman's matters nor women's matters, "but withal I am indeed, sir, a / surgeon to old shoes". *Withal* means 'nevertheless' or 'all the same'. Said aloud, however, it is *with awl* — so he is also saying 'but with my awl I am a surgeon to old shoes'. The pun works both ways at once, and it is the third time in a few lines that he has smuggled the tool of his trade into the conversation. (The bracketing about 'women's matters' is a cheeky aside — he protests, with a wink, that he keeps out of other men's business and other men's wives.)

"surgeon to old shoes: when they are in great danger, / I recover them." Here the Cobbler elevates cobbling into medicine. He is a *surgeon*; the shoes are patients in *great danger*; and he *recovers* them — which means both 'restores them to health', as a doctor does, and 're-covers' them, puts a new covering of leather on them, as a cobbler does. The mock-grandeur is the point: he is parodying the way important men (tribunes, for instance) inflate their own work.

"As proper men as ever trod upon / neat's leather have gone upon my handiwork." *Proper* means 'handsome, fine'; *neat's leather* is cowhide; *to tread upon neat's leather* is simply to wear shoes. So: 'the finest men who ever wore shoes have walked in shoes I made.' It is a tradesman's boast — and, glancing at the tribunes' feet, a hint that even they may be standing on his work. The great depend on the small.

"to wear out their shoes, to / get myself into more work." Asked why he leads the crowd about the streets, the Cobbler first gives the self-interested answer: the more they walk, the sooner their shoes wear out, the more business he gets. This is not strictly a pun but a comic inversion: the tribunes expect a political motive and receive a commercial one. It also quietly deflates the whole notion of the crowd's 'loyalty' — some of them, at least, are here for their own reasons.

Put together, the sequence shows a man who is never rude and never straightforward, who answers every question truthfully and none of them helpfully, and who wins every exchange while apparently losing his social position. That is why the tribunes' contempt for "the vulgar" rings false to the audience before it is even spoken: we have just watched a member of the vulgar out-think them.

PROFESSOR'S INSIGHT Why public opinion is introduced immediately

Most tragedies begin with the private lives of the great and only later show the public consequences. *Julius Caesar* reverses the order: the first thing we see is public opinion in action — a crowd choosing whom to cheer. Shakespeare does this because public opinion is not a backdrop to this play's politics; it is the mechanism. Caesar's power rests on the crowd's love, which Casca will describe in Scene 2 as clapping and hissing him like players in a theatre. The conspirators' plan will succeed or fail according to whether the crowd accepts their explanation. Antony's revenge will be accomplished entirely by turning the crowd. By introducing the crowd first, and showing it already halfway through one change of heart, Shakespeare makes us watch every later speech as an attempt to move this same body. There is an uncomfortable edge to this in a theatre. The audience at the Globe in 1599 was itself a paying crowd of tradesmen and apprentices on a holiday afternoon, being 'worked on' by speeches. The scene may be inviting them — and us — to notice how easily we are moved.

PROFESSOR'S INSIGHT **The irony that the protectors of the people despise the people**

The office of tribune existed for one reason: to protect the plebeians from the powerful. Yet Shakespeare's tribunes address the plebeians as "idle creatures", "thou knave", "naughty knave", "saucy / fellow", "blocks", "stones", "worse than senseless / things", "hard hearts", "cruel men" and, finally, "the vulgar". Their sympathy for Pompey is not sympathy for the people; it is sympathy for the Republic's institutions, of which they are officers. This irony is not a slip; on one strong reading it is the play's diagnosis of why the Republic falls. The republicans — the tribunes here, Brutus and Cassius later — claim to act for Rome but hold Romans in contempt, and so they never trouble to win them. Caesar, by contrast, is loved precisely because he gives the crowd what it wants: a triumph, a holiday, decorated statues, a spectacle in the marketplace. Brutus will repeat the tribunes' error on a grand scale in Act 3 Scene 2, assuming that a crowd will follow reason and then walking away, leaving Antony to speak. The tribunes' contempt is therefore the first appearance of the flaw that kills the conspiracy. It is also a real moral question the play leaves open: can you defend liberty on behalf of people you do not respect?

Class

The scene is a collision of ranks, and Shakespeare marks rank by every means available. By *form*: verse for the tribunes, prose for the workmen. By *address*: the tribunes use 'thou' and 'thy' to the workmen — the familiar form used to inferiors, children and servants (Marullus's one polite "You, sir" lasts a single line before he too drops to "thou") — while the Cobbler answers with the respectful 'sir' and 'you'. By *insult*: "thou knave", "naughty knave", "saucy fellow", "the vulgar" all assume the right of the higher to name the lower. By *costume*: the tribunes' first complaint is literally that the workmen are dressed above their station, in "best apparel" rather than the apron and rule that would label them. **LITERARY INTERPRETATION:** the scene exposes a paradox at the heart of Roman (and Elizabethan) order. The upper ranks need the lower to be visibly, legibly (readably, at a glance) lower — hence the demand for the "sign / Of your profession". A crowd in holiday clothes is a crowd that has, for a day, stopped being legible, and that is what frightens the officials before Caesar's name is even mentioned. The Cobbler's wit is a further breach: intelligence is not supposed to run upward from the apron to the toga. Class in this scene is therefore not just background; it is the first source of tension, and it is inseparable from the political fear that follows, because Caesar's power is built on exactly this crowd of the 'wrong' class.

Public opinion

Public opinion in this scene is visible, audible and physical. It has a costume (best attire), a gesture (strewing flowers), a sound (the universal shout that once shook the Tiber) and a location (walls, battlements, towers, windows, chimney tops). Shakespeare never treats it as an abstraction; he shows it as bodies in a street. He also shows its two faces within a few minutes: the confident holiday crowd of the opening and the guilty, "tongue-tied" crowd of the exit. That change is produced by nothing more than one angry speech. The lesson the play draws — and asks us to carry forward to Act 3 — is that public opinion in Rome is a resource anyone with sufficient eloquence can tap, and that no one owns it for long. The tribunes tap it here for a moment; Caesar taps it in Scene 2 with the theatre of refusing a crown; Brutus and Antony will tap it in turn. It is also worth noticing what public opinion is *for* in this scene: it is about honour. The crowd honours Caesar with a holiday; Marullus says the honour belongs to Pompey's memory. Public opinion is thus, from the first, a contest over who deserves Rome's love, and the play never lets that contest rest.

Political loyalty

Loyalty in Scene 1 comes in three kinds, and the exam rewards a candidate who can tell them apart. The **crowd's loyalty** is to a person and a spectacle: whoever is triumphing today. It is warm, real and short-lived. The **tribunes' loyalty** is to an institution — the Republic — and to a dead man who symbolised it. It is principled and durable, but cold towards the actual people it claims to serve. The **Cobbler's loyalty**, if he has one, is to his own livelihood and his own dignity; he will cheer Caesar and sell shoes to Caesar's crowd. Shakespeare places these three side by side without telling us which is right. But he does show which is most powerful: the crowd's. Marullus can shame it for a moment; he cannot redirect it. And by Scene 2 it is shouting for Caesar again. The scene's quiet conclusion is that in Rome political loyalty has come loose from institutions and attached itself to personalities — which is exactly the condition in which a republic turns into a monarchy.

The fickleness of the Roman crowd

'Fickle' means changeable, unreliable in affection. The word is the single most useful keyword this scene gives you, and you must be able to prove it from the text rather than merely assert it. The proof is Marullus's own contrast: the same people who once sat "The livelong day, with patient expectation, / To see great Pompey pass the streets of Rome" now "strew flowers in his way / That comes in triumph over Pompey's blood". Same crowd, opposite hero, no visible embarrassment. Then Shakespeare gives a second proof inside the scene: this loudly celebrating crowd is silenced and sent home by one speech, "tongue-tied in their guiltiness". A body that can be shamed out of a festival in a few minutes is a body that can be shouted into anything. **LITERARY INTERPRETATION:** Shakespeare is not simply sneering at the poor. He is diagnosing a political condition: a people that has lost its institutions has nothing to be loyal to except whoever is most present and most impressive. Fickleness is the symptom; the disease is the collapse of the Republic's structures. Casca's report in Scene 2 (the crowd clapping and hissing Caesar like actors in a theatre) and the Forum scene in Act 3 are the later stages of the same illness. A first-class answer names the symptom, the disease and the later stages.

Pompey

HISTORICAL RECORD. Gnaeus Pompeius Magnus (106–48 BC) — 'Pompey the Great' — was the most celebrated Roman general of the generation before Caesar's. He celebrated three triumphs (in 79, 71 and 61 BC), an almost unheard-of honour, and he was immensely popular in Rome. He was for a time Caesar's political partner, in the alliance historians call the First Triumvirate, and Caesar's son-in-law, having married Caesar's daughter Julia, who died in 54 BC. When the alliance broke down, Pompey led the Senate's side in the civil war; Caesar defeated him at Pharsalus in August 48 BC, and Pompey fled to Egypt, where he was murdered on arrival. His sons carried on the fight until Caesar crushed them at Munda in Spain in March 45 BC. **SHAKESPEARE'S TEXT** uses none of these details. Pompey exists in Scene 1 purely as a memory of love — "great Pompey" whose chariot the people once climbed chimney tops to see. That is deliberate. Shakespeare wants Pompey to stand for what the crowd has forgotten, not for a political programme. But the name will not stay buried. The conspirators will gather at "Pompey's Porch" in Scene 3, and Caesar will fall in Act 3 at the base of Pompey's statue. The dead rival is present at every stage of the play, and this scene is where Shakespeare first plants him.

Caesar's triumph — and why a triumph over "Pompey's blood" is troubling

Marullus's questions define a proper triumph by what this one lacks. "What conquest brings he home?" — a triumph should mark a conquest, new territory for Rome. "What tributaries follow him to Rome / To grace in captive bonds his chariot wheels?" — a triumph should display foreign kings and princes walking in chains behind the general's chariot, the living proof of Rome's victory over outsiders. The implied answer to both

questions is: none. Caesar's victory was over Romans. So what walks behind his chariot, in Marullus's furious phrase, is "Pompey's blood": the defeated sons of Pompey, the blood of Roman citizens spilt by Roman swords, and the bloodline of a man the crowd once worshipped. **HISTORICAL RECORD:** Plutarch reports that Romans did indeed feel that Caesar should not have triumphed for a victory that destroyed the family of a great Roman, and that it grieved them to see him celebrate the ruin of fellow citizens. **LITERARY INTERPRETATION:** Shakespeare makes this the scene's moral core because it turns a party into a question. Is the crowd cheering Rome's glory, or Rome's self-destruction? The word 'blood' also begins the play's long bloodline of imagery — Caesar's blood on the conspirators' hands and swords, the blood Antony will show the crowd — so that the first blood mentioned in the play is the blood of a civil war Caesar has already won, and the last is the blood of the civil war his death will start.

The statues, the "ceremonies" and the "trophies"

Flavius orders: "Disrobe the images / If you do find them decked with ceremonies", and adds: "Let no images / Be hung with Caesar's trophies." Three words need unpacking. *Images* are statues of Caesar standing in public places. *Ceremonies* here means ceremonial decorations — the scarves, garlands and ornaments hung on the statues in his honour (Casca, in Scene 2, calls them "scarves"). *Trophies* are tokens of victory, the spoils and emblems of Caesar's triumph. The verb *disrobe* — to strip of clothing — treats the statues as dressed figures, which is exactly what alarms the tribunes: a decorated statue is a step towards a worshipped one.

HISTORICAL RECORD: the real tribunes removed a royal diadem from a statue of Caesar, which is why the episode had such a charge — a diadem was the emblem of a king, and Rome had hated the very word 'king' since it expelled its last one in 509 BC. Shakespeare softens the diadem into "ceremonies" and "trophies", but the meaning survives: the tribunes are trying to stop a man being turned into an idol. There is a further irony that many critics notice. In stripping the statues, the tribunes are themselves attacking *images* of Caesar, not Caesar — just as, in the Forum, the crowd will attack a poet who merely shares a conspirator's name. Rome is a city that fights over signs.

Removing the decorations

The tribunes' plan is small, physical and symbolic, and it is important to see all three qualities. It is *small*: two men with their hands, pulling cloth off stone. It is *physical*: not a speech in the Senate but an act in the street, in the same public space the crowd occupied. And it is *symbolic*: they cannot strip Caesar of his victory or his dictatorship, so they strip the emblems of them, hoping that to undress the image is to shrink the man. Flavius says so in his falcon speech: these are "growing feathers" to be "plucked". The audience, however, can see what the tribunes cannot — that the man is not the image, and that pulling scarves off statues will not slow a dictator but only provoke him. **SHAKESPEARE'S TEXT** confirms this in Scene 2, when Casca reports that Marullus and Flavius "are put to silence" for exactly this act. The phrase is ambiguous — it could mean removed from office or something worse — and the text leaves it open; historically the tribunes were deposed. Either way, the first act of resistance in the play fails within a scene, and it fails because it mistakes the symbol for the substance. That is a warning the conspirators will not heed.

The tribunes' attitude: contempt, fear and duty

Three attitudes coexist in the tribunes, and the scene's realism comes from the mixture. **Contempt for the crowd** is the loudest — the insults are relentless, and even the softer "good countrymen" is followed by an order to go and weep. **Fear of Caesar** is the deepest; it surfaces in the hawk image, in the anxiety about a man who would "soar above the view of men", and in the phrase that names what they fear for themselves — "servile fearfulness", the condition of slaves. **Republican duty** is what they would say they are acting from: as tribunes they are the constitutional guardians of the people's liberty, and defacing the emblems of one-man rule is, in their eyes, exactly their job. The trouble is that the three do not fit together. Duty to the people is hard to

square with contempt for them. Fear of tyranny is hard to distinguish from resentment at losing influence. Shakespeare does not resolve the contradiction; he displays it, and then lets it reappear, enlarged, in Brutus and Cassius.

Republican concerns

HISTORICAL RECORD. Rome's republican constitution rested on a few principles: no single man should hold supreme power; offices should be shared, elected and time-limited; the Senate should deliberate; the people, through their tribunes, should be protected. The word *libertas* — liberty — summed up the ideal, and the word *rex* — king — summed up its opposite. **SHAKESPEARE'S TEXT** compresses all of this into Flavius's closing quatrain (four-line group). A man who soars "above the view of men" has escaped the shared, level world of the Republic; a Rome kept in "servile fearfulness" has lost its liberty. What makes the passage republican rather than merely hostile is the phrase "us all": Flavius fears not for himself but for the collective. This is the concern Cassius will voice with far more bitterness in Scene 2 — that one man should "bestride the narrow world / Like a Colossus" while others walk beneath — and that Brutus will make the basis of his decision. Scene 1 gives the republican argument in its purest, least personal form, before jealousy (Cassius) and self-doubt (Brutus) have complicated it.

The dramatic purpose of the opening

Gather the threads. The opening (1) establishes setting and occasion economically; (2) introduces the crowd as a character and shows its fickleness in action; (3) supplies the political situation and its danger through hostile witnesses; (4) creates the first image of Caesar as a man to be feared, before we meet him; (5) provides comedy that both relaxes the audience and sharpens the class conflict; (6) demonstrates the power of rhetoric over a crowd, the play's central mechanism; (7) plants the name of Pompey, which will haunt the plot; (8) sets in motion the first act of resistance and its punishment; and (9) tunes the audience's ear to the prose–verse distinction it will need throughout. Above all, it suggests — before we have met a single great man — that the play's subject may be not one man's fall but a city's choice. If you can say all this about a scene in which the protagonist never appears, you have understood why Shakespeare is Shakespeare.

From Pompey to Caesar: what the shift tells us about public loyalty

The scene's argument rests on a before-and-after that Marullus draws for us. Set it out as a table and the pattern becomes a prediction.

The crowd's behaviour	For Pompey (in Marullus's memory)	For Caesar (today, in the scene)	What this predicts for Act 3
Where they went	Climbed "walls and battlements, / To towers and windows", even "chimney tops"	Fill the streets in a "holiday" crowd	They will pack the Forum to hear the conspirators explain the murder
How long they waited	Sat "The livelong day, with patient expectation"	Take a whole day off work to "see Caesar"	They will listen patiently to Brutus — and then, just as patiently, to Antony
What they did with their bodies	Brought "infants in your arms" to watch	Wear "best attire" and "strew flowers in his way"	They will carry Caesar's body, then carry fire to the conspirators' houses
What noise they made	"an universal shout" that made "Tiber trembled underneath her banks"	Shouts heard offstage in Scene 2 as Caesar refuses the crown	They will shout for Brutus to be Caesar, then howl for revenge with Antony

The crowd's behaviour	For Pompey (in Marullus's memory)	For Caesar (today, in the scene)	What this predicts for Act 3
How they responded to a speech	—	Fall silent, "tongue-tied", at Marullus's rebuke	Brutus will silence them with reason; Antony will unleash them with grief

Read across each row and the lesson is the same: the crowd's behaviour is constant; only its object changes. It does not love Pompey less than it loved him or Caesar more than it will love Brutus. It loves *whoever is in the chariot*. That is what Marullus cannot forgive and what the conspirators will fatally forget. When you write about the Forum scene in Act 3, this table is your evidence that Shakespeare set up the crowd's behaviour from the first scene, and that its swing to Antony is not a surprise but a fulfilment.

QUOTATION The two halves of Marullus's contrast

Marullus: *Many a time and oft / Have you climbed up to walls and battlements, / To towers and windows, yea, to chimney tops, / Your infants in your arms, and there have sat / The livelong day, with patient expectation, / To see great Pompey pass the streets of Rome.*

Marullus: *And do you now put on your best attire? / And do you now cull out a holiday? / And do you now strew flowers in his way / That comes in triumph over Pompey's blood?*

Learn the first as the 'then' and the second as the 'now'; the whole theme of fickleness lives in the gap between them.

LINE-BY-LINE TEACHING SYSTEM

This is the part of the chapter to return to before any test on the scene. Ten passages are taught, chosen because they matter to plot, character or theme, are frequently quoted, or feed later events. Each passage is taught under the same sixteen labels so that you can scan for exactly what you need. Trivial lines are deliberately left out; do not waste revision time on them.

Passage 1 — Flavius clears the street

Original line / short passage:

Flavius: *Hence! Home, you idle creatures, get you home! / Is this a holiday? What, know you not, / Being mechanical, you ought not walk / Upon a labouring day without the sign / Of your profession?*

Simple English: Get away from here and go home, you lazy creatures! Is today a holiday? Don't you know that as tradesmen you are not allowed to walk about on a working day without the tools or dress that show what your trade is?

Difficult words: *Hence* — away from here. *Idle* — lazy, unoccupied. *Creatures* — living things; used of people, it is contemptuous, as if they were animals. *Mechanical* — belonging to the class of manual workers (here used as a noun: 'you, being tradesmen'). *Labouring day* — a working day. *Sign of your profession* — the apron, tools or badge that identify a trade.

Literal meaning: The tribune orders the crowd home and claims they are breaking a rule by being out on a working day without the visible marks of their trades.

Subtext: Flavius already knows perfectly well that the crowd regards this as a holiday; the question "Is this a holiday?" is not a request for information but a challenge. He is refusing to recognise the holiday, and therefore refusing to recognise what it celebrates.

Hidden meaning: The rule about the "sign / Of your profession" is a demand that the lower classes remain visibly labelled. A workman in his best clothes has, for a day, escaped his label, and that small liberty is the first thing authority wants to remove.

Character psychology: Flavius is a man who begins with orders, not questions. His contempt ("idle creatures") comes before his argument. He is confident of his authority and irritated that it is being ignored.

Political meaning: The Republic's officials try to control public space and the public's time. A crowd that decides for itself when to celebrate is a crowd that is slipping out of institutional control — and towards Caesar.

Historical context: No Roman law requiring workmen to carry their tools is known; editors generally treat the detail as Elizabethan colouring, reflecting a London of guilds and regulated dress. Shakespeare gives Rome the social texture his audience knew.

Literary devices: Imperative mood (a string of commands); rhetorical question ("Is this a holiday?"); contemptuous epithet ("idle creatures"); the whole speech in verse, marking rank against the prose that will answer it.

Effect: The play opens in the middle of a quarrel, with raised voices, so the audience is instantly alert. The tone is tense and a little absurd — a magistrate scolding shoemakers — which prepares the comedy to come.

Dramatic significance: These are the play's first words. Shakespeare chooses to begin not with grandeur but with conflict between classes over a public celebration, announcing that this will be a play about the crowd and its controllers.

Foreshadowing: Officials failing to control the crowd by shouting at it foreshadows the far greater failure of the conspirators to control the crowd in Act 3.

Scene connection: Flavius will end the scene as he begins it, driving "the vulgar from the streets" — but by then his motive has been made explicit.

ICSE keywords: 'imperative', 'class', 'hierarchy', 'contempt', 'authority', 'public space'.

Exam application: If asked how Shakespeare establishes conflict at the start of the play, you could write: 'The very first line is a command — "Hence! Home, you idle creatures" — spoken by an official to workmen, so that the play opens on a collision between authority and the common people that will define its politics.'

Passage 2 — Marullus and the missing apron

Original line / short passage:

Marullus: *Where is thy leather apron and thy rule? / What dost thou with thy best apparel on?*

Simple English: Where is your leather apron and your ruler? What are you doing dressed in your best clothes?

Difficult words: *Leather apron* — the protective apron worn by craftsmen such as carpenters. *Rule* — a measuring ruler, the carpenter's tool. *Apparel* — clothing. *Thy* and *thou* — the singular 'your' and 'you', used to social inferiors.

Literal meaning: Marullus points out that the Carpenter is not wearing the apron and carrying the ruler that would mark his trade, and is instead dressed for a festival.

Subtext: 'You are out of your place.' The complaint is not about hygiene or safety; it is about a workman being visually indistinguishable from his betters.

Hidden meaning: Clothes are signs, and the scene is obsessed with signs: aprons, tools, best attire, and later the "ceremonies" on Caesar's statues. Marullus wants the workman re-labelled, just as he will want Caesar's statues un-labelled. Both are attempts to control what things *look like*.

Character psychology: Marullus is precise and observant — he notices exactly which items are missing — and he expects deference. He speaks to the Carpenter as a master to a servant.

Political meaning: Social order and political order are one system. A crowd in holiday dress honouring Caesar is a double breach: of class rules and of republican loyalty.

Historical context: The leather apron and rule are the tools of an Elizabethan tradesman as much as a Roman one. The 'thou' of superiority to inferiors was standard Elizabethan usage.

Literary devices: Rhetorical questions; concrete visual imagery (apron, rule, apparel) that lets the audience see the class contrast; the formal 'thou' as a marker of rank.

Effect: The audience sees, through the tribune's eyes, a man dressed above his station, and begins to sense that the tribunes care more about order than about people.

Dramatic significance: This is the moment the Carpenter is dismissed and the Cobbler takes over; Marullus's second question, "You, sir, what trade are you?", opens the pun sequence.

Foreshadowing: The theme of appearance versus reality — best clothes hiding a workman, decorations turning a statue into an idol — will grow into the play's concern with false shows (Cassius's forged letters, Caesar's public modesty over the crown).

Scene connection: The "best apparel" here becomes the "best attire" of Marullus's later speech; the same detail is first a class offence and then a moral one.

ICSE keywords: 'appearance versus reality', 'social order', 'costume as sign', 'class contempt'.

Exam application: In a question about how the tribunes treat the commoners, you might write: 'Marullus's demand "Where is thy leather apron and thy rule?" shows that he sees the workman purely as his trade, and resents any sign that the common people can step outside their allotted place.'

Passage 3 — The Cobbler's pun sequence

Original line / short passage:

Cobbler: *A trade, sir, that I hope I may use with a safe / conscience, which is indeed, sir, a mender of bad / soles.*

Cobbler: *Nay, I beseech you, sir, be not out with me. / Yet if you be out, sir, I can mend you.*

Cobbler: *Truly, sir, all that I live by is with the / awl. I meddle with no tradesman's matters nor / women's matters, but withal I am indeed, sir, a / surgeon to old shoes: when they are in great danger, / I recover them. As proper men as ever trod upon / neat's leather have gone upon my handiwork.*

Simple English: My trade, sir, is one I can practise with a clear conscience: I mend bad soles. Please don't be angry with me — but if your shoes are worn out, I can fix them. Honestly, sir, I make my whole living with my awl; I don't interfere in other tradesmen's business or in women's business, but all the same I am a doctor to old shoes, and when they are in danger I restore them. Some very fine men have walked about in shoes I made.

Difficult words: *Safe conscience* — a clear conscience. *Soles* — shoe bottoms (heard as 'souls'). *Out with me* — angry with me; *out* also means 'worn out at the toes'. *Mend* — repair; also reform morally. *Awl* — a pointed tool for piercing leather (heard as 'all'). *Meddle* — interfere. *Withal* — nevertheless (heard as 'with awl'). *Surgeon* — doctor. *Recover* — restore to health, and re-cover with leather. *Proper* — handsome. *Neat's leather* — cowhide. *Handiwork* — the work of my hands.

Literal meaning: The Cobbler describes his trade in a chain of double meanings, never quite giving the plain word the tribunes want, and ends with a boast about the quality of his customers.

Subtext: Each pun says two things: a humble one to the tribunes and a cheeky one to the audience. The 'mender of bad souls' who can 'mend' angry officials is quietly claiming moral superiority over them.

Hidden meaning: The phrase about a "safe / conscience" implies that there are trades one cannot practise so safely — and the men in front of him are politicians. His boast that fine men have walked on his handiwork hints that the great literally stand on the labour of the small.

Character psychology: The Cobbler is quick, confident, self-protective and proud of his craft. He enjoys the game and knows exactly where the line is: he never drops the "sir", never refuses outright, never gives the tribunes a charge to arrest him on.

Political meaning: The powerless resist power through language. This is the only weapon the crowd has, and the Cobbler wields it with skill — which is what makes the crowd's later silence so significant.

Historical context: Puns were a beloved Elizabethan entertainment; the cobbler-as-witty-underdog is a stock figure of London comedy that Shakespeare transplants to Rome. A 'cobbler' could also mean a bungler, which is why Marullus at first refuses to accept the word as a trade.

Literary devices: Pun (soles/souls, out/out, mend/mend, awl/all, withal/with awl, recover/re-cover); metaphor ("surgeon to old shoes"); mock-heroic exaggeration (grand language for a small matter: "in great danger"); prose, marking the speaker's class and comic register.

Effect: Laughter — and a shift of the audience's sympathy towards the workman and away from the sneering officials. The comedy also slows the scene so that the revelation about Caesar lands harder.

Dramatic significance: This is the play's first display of verbal intelligence, and it belongs to a commoner. Shakespeare establishes that the people are not fools before he shows them behaving like a herd.

Foreshadowing: The clever, self-interested Cobbler foreshadows the plebeians of Act 3, who are equally quick — they interrupt, judge and respond — but whose quickness is turned to violence.

Scene connection: The Cobbler's talkativeness makes his silence after Marullus's speech ("tongue-tied") a measurable change; the same crowd will be heard shouting offstage in Scene 2.

ICSE keywords: 'pun', 'wordplay', 'comic relief' (use with care — the comedy has a purpose), 'prose', 'social inversion', 'wit'.

Exam application: Asked to explain the humour of the Cobbler's replies, you could write: 'When the Cobbler calls himself "a mender of bad soles" he plays on the sound of 'souls', so that a shoemaker appears to claim the priest's role of mending souls; the pun lets a commoner mock the tribunes while seeming perfectly respectful.'

Passage 4 — The real reason for the holiday

Original line / short passage:

Cobbler: *But indeed, sir, we / make holiday to see Caesar and to rejoice in his / triumph.*

Simple English: But truly, sir, we are taking the day off to see Caesar and to celebrate his triumph.

Difficult words: *Make holiday* — take a day off, keep a festival. *Triumph* — the formal victory procession granted to a Roman general.

Literal meaning: After all his jokes, the Cobbler gives the straight answer: the crowd is out to watch Caesar's triumphal procession.

Subtext: The word "indeed" marks the change of register (the level or style of speech) — the joking stops. The Cobbler seems to expect the tribunes to find this reason perfectly acceptable, which tells us how normal Caesar-worship has become on the street.

Hidden meaning: The pronoun *we* is the important word. The Cobbler speaks for the whole crowd; the individual wit has become the voice of a collective loyalty. And "rejoice" is exactly the word Marullus will seize on: rejoicing implies a good outcome, and the tribunes deny there is one.

Character psychology: The Cobbler is genuinely, uncomplicatedly pleased about the holiday. There is no political calculation here; he likes a spectacle and a day off.

Political meaning: The people's affection for Caesar is casual and unreflective — which is both what makes it strong (it asks no questions) and what makes it fragile (it can be shamed).

Historical context: The triumph in question corresponds to Caesar's Spanish triumph of October 45 BC after Munda, though Shakespeare never names it and fuses it with the Lupercal of February 44 BC.

Literary devices: Plain statement after a run of puns — the contrast itself is the device; the pronoun *we* signals collective identity.

Effect: The audience, which has been laughing, is suddenly given the political fact, and the mood changes at once. The line acts as a hinge between comedy and anger.

Dramatic significance: This is the first time Caesar is named in the play, and he is named as the object of the crowd's rejoicing — the object, in other words, of public opinion. Everything before was preparation; everything after is response.

Foreshadowing: A crowd that makes holiday to see Caesar will make a far darker holiday of his funeral in Act 3, and will 'rejoice' with fire.

Scene connection: Marullus's "Wherefore rejoice?" picks up the Cobbler's "rejoice" word for word; the speech that follows is an answer to this line.

ICSE keywords: 'public opinion', 'popularity', 'spectacle', 'collective voice', 'triumph'.

Exam application: To show that Caesar's popularity is established before he appears, write: 'Caesar is first named not by a senator but by a cobbler, who says the people "make holiday to see Caesar and to rejoice in his triumph" — the crowd's love for him is presented as a simple fact of Roman life before we ever see the man.'

Passage 5 — Marullus remembers Pompey

Original line / short passage:

Marullus: *Wherefore rejoice? What conquest brings he home? / What tributaries follow him to Rome / To grace in captive bonds his chariot wheels? / You blocks, you stones, you worse than senseless things! / O you hard hearts, you cruel men of Rome, / Knew you not Pompey?*

Marullus: *Have you not made an universal shout, / That Tiber trembled underneath her banks / To hear the replication of your sounds / Made in her concave shores?*

Simple English: Why rejoice? What conquest has he won? What conquered rulers walk in chains behind his chariot to make his triumph glorious? You lumps of wood, you stones, you things with less feeling than objects that have no feeling at all! You hard-hearted, cruel Romans — did you not know Pompey? ... Didn't you all shout together so loudly that the river Tiber shook beneath its banks at the echo of your voices bouncing off its hollow shores?

Difficult words: *Wherefore* — why. *Conquest* — victory over an enemy, gaining territory. *Tributaries* — defeated rulers or peoples obliged to pay tribute. *Grace* — adorn, do honour to. *Captive bonds* — the chains of prisoners. *Senseless* — without senses or feeling. *Universal* — made by everyone. *Replication* — echo, reverberation. *Concave* — hollowed out, curving inward.

Literal meaning: Marullus argues that Caesar's triumph is empty because it brings no foreign conquest or captives; he insults the crowd for its lack of feeling and reminds them how they once cheered Pompey so loudly that the river seemed to shake.

Subtext: 'You are cheering a man who killed Romans, and you have forgotten the Roman you used to love.' The insults are meant to hurt because the memory that follows is meant to shame.

Hidden meaning: The order of ideas matters. Marullus first tries logic (what conquest? what captives?), then abuse (blocks, stones), then memory (Pompey). The speech is a lesson in how to move a crowd: from reason to feeling. Also, the trembling Tiber is a picture of the crowd's power — a shout that shakes a river is a force any politician would want to own.

Character psychology: Marullus is grief-stricken as much as angry. The detail of the "infants in your arms" and the long wait on the rooftops is remembered lovingly; his contempt for the crowd is the contempt of a man who once saw them do something he admired.

Political meaning: A triumph over Romans is not a triumph; celebrating it is a civic sin. The crowd's shift from Pompey to Caesar is presented as the moment Rome's loyalty came unmoored from its own past.

Historical context: Pompey's three triumphs and popularity, and Plutarch's report that Romans resented the Spanish triumph, are set out in the history box and the Pompey section above. What this passage adds is staging: a triumph passed through the city to the Capitol, so the crowd on walls and rooftops is historically plausible, and the Tiber, Rome's river, was literally within earshot of the route.

Literary devices: Rhetorical questions in series; apostrophe ("O you hard hearts"); metaphor ("blocks", "stones"); climax — the insults intensify to "worse than senseless things"; hyperbole and personification (the Tiber "trembled", with feminine "her banks"); epithet ("great Pompey"); alliteration in "Tiber trembled".

Effect: The scene's temperature soars. The audience feels the force of real oratory for the first time and, whatever it thinks of the tribunes, is made to see the crowd as changeable.

Dramatic significance: This is the first great speech of the play and the first attempt to move the crowd by rhetoric. It sets a pattern that Brutus and Antony will follow in the Forum.

Foreshadowing: The "universal shout" for Pompey foreshadows the shouts for Caesar heard in Scene 2 and the shouts for Brutus and then Antony in Act 3 — the same sound, redirected each time.

Scene connection: Marullus's "Wherefore rejoice?" answers the Cobbler's "rejoice"; his vision of Pompey's chariot is the mirror image of the triumph the crowd has come to see.

ICSE keywords: 'rhetorical question', 'apostrophe', 'hyperbole', 'personification', 'fickleness', 'ingratitude', 'oratory', 'civil war'.

Exam application: When explaining why the tribunes are angry, write: 'Marullus asks "What conquest brings he home?" because a true triumph should display foreign captives; Caesar's, he implies, displays only "Pompey's blood", so the crowd is celebrating the death of fellow Romans and forgetting the Pompey for whom they once shouted until "Tiber trembled underneath her banks".'

Passage 6 — The three accusing questions

Original line / short passage:

Marullus: *And do you now put on your best attire? / And do you now cull out a holiday? / And do you now strew flowers in his way / That comes in triumph over Pompey's blood?*

Simple English: And now you dress up in your finest clothes? And now you pick out a day to make a holiday? And now you scatter flowers in the path of the man whose triumph is built on the blood of Pompey's family?

Difficult words: *Attire* — clothing. *Cull out* — pick out, select (as one picks the best from a heap). *Strew* — scatter. *In his way* — in his path, on the road he travels. *Triumph* — the victory procession. *Pompey's blood* — Pompey's kin (his sons, defeated in Spain) and, by extension, the Roman blood shed in the civil war.

Literal meaning: Marullus turns from the memory of the crowd's love for Pompey to their behaviour today, listing three festive acts — dressing up, taking a holiday, scattering flowers — and naming the man they honour as Pompey's destroyer.

Subtext: Every *now* is an accusation. The word insists on the distance between then and now, between the rooftops crowded for Pompey and the flowers strewn for his conqueror. The speech does not ask the crowd to think; it asks them to remember, and to be ashamed of what remembering reveals.

Hidden meaning: The three acts are the three ways a crowd makes a man great: by its appearance (dressing for him), by its time (giving him a day) and by its gestures (honouring his path). Marullus is describing the manufacture of greatness from below. The hidden point is that Caesar's triumph is not something done *to* the crowd but something the crowd is *doing* — his glory is their gift. If they can give it, they can withdraw it, which is what the whole play goes on to show.

Character psychology: Marullus's anger has found its shape. The first part of his speech was a torrent of insults; this part is disciplined — three parallel questions, each a notch more serious, closing on the one word that cannot be answered. He is a man who, once he has the crowd's attention, knows exactly how to use it.

Political meaning: A triumph is only a triumph if Rome agrees it is. By refusing to agree — by calling it a procession "over Pompey's blood" — Marullus denies Caesar's legitimacy at the level where legitimacy is made: the street. This is a republican official telling the people that their applause is a political act with consequences, not an innocent holiday.

Historical context: HISTORICAL RECORD: flowers and garlands were indeed strewn and worn at Roman festivals and triumphs, and Caesar's Spanish triumph of October 45 BC celebrated his victory at Munda over Pompey's sons, Gnaeus and Sextus; Gnaeus was killed, Sextus escaped. Plutarch records that Romans grieved to see Caesar triumph over the ruin of a great Roman house. Marullus's phrase compresses that grievance into two words.

Literary devices: Anaphora — the repeated opening "And do you now" — building to a climax; a series of rhetorical questions; synecdoche in "Pompey's blood" (blood for kin and for the cause); antithesis between the remembered devotion to Pompey and the present devotion to Caesar; the strong verb *strew* sets a vivid, visual image against the abstract charge of ingratitude.

Effect: The audience hears the speech tighten like a rope. The repetition makes the crowd's actions seem compulsive and thoughtless, and the final question lands with the weight of a verdict. In the theatre this is the moment the laughter of the pun sequence is fully extinguished.

Dramatic significance: This is the rhetorical climax of the scene and the first time in the play that a speaker uses structured repetition to overpower a crowd. Antony will do the same in Act 3 Scene 2 with far greater skill, repeating that Brutus is an honourable man until the word turns against him. Shakespeare shows us the technique in its plain form before he shows it in its masterly one.

Foreshadowing: The crowd that strews flowers for Caesar's chariot will, in Act 3, make a procession of a different kind — carrying his body, then carrying fire. The flowers of the triumph and the flames of the funeral are two ends of the same loyalty.

Scene connection: The "best attire" repeats the "best apparel" that Marullus complained of at the start, but the offence has changed: at first it was a class offence (workmen dressed above their station), now it is a moral one (Romans dressed to honour the killer of Romans). The same detail has been reinterpreted inside a single scene — a small lesson in how Shakespeare makes images grow.

ICSE keywords: 'anaphora', 'rhetorical question', 'climax', 'synecdoche', 'fickleness', 'ingratitude', 'legitimacy', 'civil war'.

Exam application: To prove the crowd's fickleness from the text, write: 'Marullus's repeated "And do you now..." hammers home the contrast between the crowd that once waited all day for "great Pompey" and the crowd that now scatters flowers before the man "That comes in triumph over Pompey's blood"; Shakespeare uses the anaphora to make their change of loyalty sound both mindless and shameful.'

Passage 7 — The prayer against the plague

Original line / short passage:

Marullus: *Be gone! / Run to your houses, fall upon your knees, / Pray to the gods to intermit the plague / That needs must light on this ingratitude.*

Simple English: Go away! Run home, fall on your knees, and pray to the gods to hold back the plague that is bound to fall upon this ingratitude of yours.

Difficult words: *Be gone* — go away at once. *Fall upon your knees* — kneel in prayer. *Intermit* — to suspend, hold off, interrupt for a time. *Plague* — pestilence, a deadly epidemic; also, more generally, any divine punishment. *Needs must* — must necessarily, cannot help but. *Light on* — fall upon, land on. *Ingratitude* — the failure to be grateful; here, forgetting Pompey.

Literal meaning: Marullus dismisses the crowd and tells them to pray that the gods postpone the punishment their ingratitude is certain to bring.

Subtext: Marullus does not say 'pray that there be no plague'; he says pray that the gods *intermit* it — delay it. In his mind the punishment is already deserved and already on its way. The crowd is being told that it has committed not a social error but a sin.

Hidden meaning: Ingratitude is the sin the speech names, and it is the sin the whole play will turn on. Caesar will be killed by men who owe him their lives and offices; Antony will accuse the conspirators of exactly this; the crowd will be ungrateful to Brutus within minutes of applauding him. Marullus thinks he is describing the crowd's fault. He is describing Rome's.

Character psychology: Here Marullus reveals that his politics are religious. He believes the gods take sides in Roman affairs and punish disloyalty with pestilence. This is the same man who, a few lines later, will hesitate to strip Caesar's statues because it is a holy day. He is pious to his core, and that piety makes his contempt for the crowd feel like a priest's rather than a politician's.

Political meaning: By calling the crowd's loyalty to Caesar a sin against the gods, Marullus raises the stakes from politics to religion. This is a powerful rhetorical move — it is hard to argue with heaven — but it also exposes the weakness of the republican position: it has no reward to offer the crowd, only guilt and threats. Caesar offers a holiday. The scene lets us feel which argument will win.

Historical context: HISTORICAL RECORD: Romans did regard plague, famine and prodigies as signs of divine displeasure, to be averted by prayer and ritual. Shakespeare's own London had lived through severe outbreaks of plague in his lifetime — the theatres were closed by plague for long periods in the early 1590s — so an Elizabethan audience would have heard the word with a shudder that we can only partly recover. Whether they connected it to the play's politics is a matter of interpretation, not record.

Literary devices: Imperatives in rapid sequence ("Be gone!", then *Run, fall, Pray*); hyperbole — a plague as the fit punishment for a holiday; personification of the plague as something that will "light on" the crowd like a bird settling; the religious register (*gods, knees, Pray*) lifts the speech from insult to prophecy. The rhythm is worth noticing: the half-line "Be gone!" breaks the verse, as if Marullus's anger has outrun his sentence.

Effect: The speech ends not with a question but with a curse-like prayer, and the crowd, which has been silent throughout, does not answer. The audience is left with a sense of doom hanging over a festive day — the first of many moments in the play where celebration and foreboding are made to share a stage.

Dramatic significance: This is the last thing said to the commoners before they leave, and the play's first explicit linking of Rome's political life to divine punishment. That link will be made again by the storm in Scene 3, by the omens of Act 2, and by the civil war that is the play's actual 'plague'.

Foreshadowing: The plague Marullus prays against does fall on Rome — but not on the crowd for cheering Caesar. It falls as civil war after Caesar's murder, brought about by men on Marullus's own side. **LITERARY INTERPRETATION:** many readers take this as one of the play's sharpest ironies: the republicans curse Rome with a punishment that their own actions deliver.

Scene connection: Flavius immediately echoes and softens the command — "Go, go, good countrymen" — but adds his own grotesque penance, that the poor should weep into the Tiber until the river rises to its highest banks. Marullus asks for prayer; Flavius asks for tears. Together they give the crowd nothing to do but feel guilty, which is why the crowd simply vanishes.

ICSE keywords: 'ingratitude', 'divine punishment', 'hyperbole', 'imperative', 'religious imagery', 'irony', 'foreboding'.

Exam application: If asked what Marullus accuses the commoners of, write: 'He accuses them of "ingratitude" so grave that only prayer can "intermit the plague" the gods must send for it; by turning a political complaint into a religious one, Marullus makes the crowd's new love for Caesar sound like a sin against Rome and heaven alike.'

Passage 8 — The silent exit and the metal of the crowd

Original line / short passage:

Flavius: *Go, go, good countrymen, and for this fault / Assemble all the poor men of your sort, / Draw them to Tiber banks, and weep your tears / Into the channel, till the lowest stream / Do kiss the most exalted shores of all.*

Flavius: *See whe'er their basest mettle be not moved. / They vanish tongue-tied in their guiltiness.*

Simple English: Go, go, my good countrymen, and to make up for this fault, gather all the poor men of your class, lead them to the banks of the Tiber, and weep your tears into the river until the water at its lowest point rises to touch the highest banks of all. ... Look — see whether even their low, worthless natures have not been moved. They slip away in silence, struck dumb by their guilt.

Difficult words: *Countrymen* — fellow Romans. *Fault* — offence, wrongdoing. *Your sort* — your class, your kind. *Channel* — the river bed. *Exalted* — raised high. *Whe'er* — a contraction of 'whether'. *Basest* — lowest, most worthless; also 'base' as in base metal, cheap metal such as lead as opposed to gold. *Mettle* — spirit, temperament, natural quality (with a pun on *metal*). *Moved* — stirred, affected emotionally. *Tongue-tied* — unable to speak. *Guiltiness* — sense of guilt.

Literal meaning: Flavius dismisses the crowd with an order to perform an exaggerated act of penance; after they leave he remarks to Marullus that even such low people have been affected, and that they have gone off silently, ashamed.

Subtext: "good countrymen" sounds kinder than anything Marullus said, but what follows is not kindness. The order to weep until a river floods is impossible, and its impossibility is the point: Flavius is telling the poor that no amount of grief can make up for what they have done. The 'kind' tribune is as contemptuous as the angry one; he is simply quieter about it.

Hidden meaning: "basest mettle" is a small masterpiece of condescension. *Mettle* means spirit or nature; *base metal* is cheap metal. Flavius says, in effect, 'look — even lead can be stirred.' But a second meaning runs under the first. In the next scene Brutus will remark that Casca "was quick mettle when he went to school", and the play will repeatedly test what men are made of. Flavius thinks the crowd is base metal and the republicans are gold. Act 3 will put both to the fire.

Character psychology: Flavius is a reader of crowds, or thinks he is. He watches the commoners leave and *interprets* their silence as guilt. Notice how quickly he moves from observation to conclusion, and how satisfied the conclusion makes him. He is a man who sees what he expects to see — a trait that, in Brutus, will be fatal.

Political meaning: The tribunes have won a round, and the way they have won it is instructive: not by argument but by shame, delivered from above. The crowd has been *silenced*, not *persuaded*. **LITERARY INTERPRETATION:** the text does not tell us why the commoners leave. Flavius says guilt; a director could as easily stage boredom, fear or sullen resentment. Shakespeare leaves the crowd's inner state unreadable, which is exactly how the great men of the play will experience it — as a surface they interpret, never a mind they know.

Historical context: The Tiber was Rome's river and the scene of real public mourning and public spectacle; its flooding was a known danger. Flavius's image of tears raising the river belongs to the same family of hyperbole as Marullus's river trembling at a shout — both tribunes picture the crowd's emotion as a force of nature acting on the city's water.

Literary devices: Hyperbole (tears that flood a river); antithesis ("the lowest stream" against "the most exalted shores"); personification (the stream will *kiss* the shores); pun ("basest mettle" — spirit and base metal); irony in the gentle "good countrymen" that introduces a humiliating command; alliteration in "tongue-tied". The silent exit of the commoners is itself a dramatic device — a stage picture of a crowd unmade.

Effect: The audience sees the holiday crowd drain from the stage without a word, and the sudden emptiness is startling after the noise of the puns and the speech. We are left with two officials congratulating themselves in a cleared street — a picture of a small, hollow victory.

Dramatic significance: This is the first demonstration in the play that the crowd can be moved by words, and the first demonstration that moving it is not the same as winning it. Both facts govern Act 3. Also, "tongue-tied" introduces the motif of silencing; in the next scene Casca will report that the tribunes themselves "are put to silence". Those who silence are silenced.

Foreshadowing: The emotional, movable crowd that leaves "tongue-tied" here will be moved again by Brutus's reason and then by Antony's tears — and after Antony it will not be silent at all. The hyperbole of a river of tears also foreshadows Antony's use of weeping as a political instrument in the Forum.

Scene connection: This is the hinge of the scene. Before it, the tribunes dealt with the crowd; after it, they deal with Caesar's images. With the people gone, their republicanism turns from scolding to action, and the dialogue drops from public rhetoric to a private plan.

ICSE keywords: 'hyperbole', 'pun', 'antithesis', 'condescension', 'silencing', 'mob psychology', 'public opinion', 'contempt'.

Exam application: Asked how the commoners react to the tribunes' rebuke, write: "They do not reply at all; Flavius observes that they "vanish tongue-tied in their guiltiness", and his pun on their "basest mettle" shows that even in victory the tribunes despise the people they have just shamed — a contempt the conspirators will share, to their cost."

Passage 9 — Disrobing the images and the feast of Lupercal

Original line / short passage:

Flavius: *Go you down that way towards the Capitol. / This way will I. Disrobe the images / If you do find them decked with ceremonies.*

Marullus: *May we do so? / You know it is the feast of Lupercal.*

Flavius: *It is no matter. Let no images / Be hung with Caesar's trophies.*

Simple English: You go down that way towards the Capitol; I will go this way. Strip the statues if you find them hung with decorations. — Are we allowed to do that? You know it is the festival of Lupercal. — It does not matter. Let no statue be hung with Caesar's tokens of victory.

Difficult words: *The Capitol* — the Capitoline hill, the religious and political heart of Rome, with the Temple of Jupiter. *Disrobe* — strip of clothing; here, strip of decorations. *Images* — statues. *Decked* — adorned, decorated. *Ceremonies* — ceremonial ornaments (the scarves and garlands Casca mentions in Scene 2). *The feast of Lupercal* — the Lupercalia, the festival of 15 February. *It is no matter* — it does not matter. *Trophies* — tokens or emblems of victory.

Literal meaning: Flavius divides the city between them and orders the removal of any decorations found on Caesar's statues. Marullus asks whether this is permitted on a holy day. Flavius dismisses the objection.

Subtext: Marullus's question is not cowardice; it is conscience. He is asking whether a political act is lawful on a religious festival. Flavius's three-word answer — "It is no matter" — sweeps religion aside for politics. The exchange quietly separates the two tribunes: one still feels the old pieties, the other has decided that the threat of Caesar outranks them.

Hidden meaning: The verb *disrobe* treats the statues as bodies wearing clothes. Earlier the tribunes wanted the workmen *re*-dressed in the signs of their trade; now they want Caesar's images *un*-dressed of the signs of his glory. Both are attempts to control appearance, and both fail — the crowd goes on cheering, and the statues will be dressed again. Rome, the scene suggests, is a city governed by what things look like.

Character psychology: Flavius is decisive to the point of recklessness. Marullus is the more careful, the more religious, and — perhaps — the more frightened. Yet Shakespeare does not let us settle who is wiser. Marullus's scruple would have saved them both; Flavius's boldness is the only act of resistance anyone in Rome manages before the Ides. The scene lets both qualities stand.

Political meaning: Stripping a dictator's statues is a public, visible challenge to his personality cult, carried out by the officers whose job is to defend the people's liberty. It is the Republic's constitution, in the persons of two tribunes, trying to reassert itself over a man who has outgrown it. That Caesar answers by silencing them (reported in Scene 2) tells the audience exactly how much of the Republic is left.

Historical context: HISTORICAL RECORD: the Lupercalia, held on 15 February, was an ancient purification and fertility festival in which priests called Luperci ran through the city striking bystanders, especially women, with strips of goat-hide; Antony ran in it as a Lupercus in 44 BC, which is the race Caesar refers to in Scene 2. The real tribunes' removal of a diadem in January 44 BC, and Shakespeare's relocation of it to this day, is explained in the history box above. **LITERARY INTERPRETATION:** Marullus's religious hesitation is not recorded in the sources Shakespeare used; it appears to be his own dramatic touch, added to distinguish the two men.

Literary devices: Personification of the statues (they can be "Disrobe[d]" and "decked"); a stichomythia-like exchange (stichomythia is rapid, line-for-line dialogue) — short question, short dismissal — marking the shift from oratory to plotting; the brisk, practical imperatives ("Go you down", "Disrobe", "Let no images") show verse at its plainest; the balance of "that way" and "This way" stages the division of the city on the spot.

Effect: After the great public speech, this hushed, hurried planning feels conspiratorial, and the audience senses danger for the first time — not from Caesar yet, but for these two men. Marullus's question plants a doubt that Flavius's answer does not remove.

Dramatic significance: This exchange is the play's first act of resistance to Caesar and its first conspiracy, two men agreeing in a street to deface a dictator's images. It is also the first mention of the Lupercal, which binds this scene to the next: the festival the tribunes nearly respect is the one Caesar is about to use as a stage.

Foreshadowing: The consequence arrives in Scene 2, when Casca reports that "Marullus and Flavius, for pulling scarves off Caesar's images, are put to silence." Beyond that, the plan to strip an *image* of Caesar foreshadows the conspirators' plan to remove the *man*, and both acts share a flaw: they attack what Caesar looks like and leave his power — the crowd's love — untouched. The mob's killing of Cinna the poet for his name in Act 3 Scene 3 is the darkest version of the same confusion between sign and substance.

Scene connection: The Capitol, named here as a direction, will be the destination of Caesar's final walk in Act 3 Scene 1 — Shakespeare relocates the assassination there from its historical site in Pompey's theatre complex. The "ceremonies" return as the ceremony Caesar insists on in Scene 2 — "Set on and leave no ceremony out" — so that within minutes of the tribunes trying to strip ceremony from Caesar's statues, Caesar himself demands it in full.

ICSE keywords: 'personality cult', 'symbol', 'resistance', 'religious scruple', 'personification', 'appearance versus reality', 'consequence'.

Exam application: When explaining why the tribunes are punished in Scene 2, write: 'Flavius ordered Marullus to "Disrobe the images / If you do find them decked with ceremonies", a direct attack on the public honours that made Caesar seem more than a citizen; Casca's report that they "are put to silence" proves that Caesar would not tolerate even this symbolic defiance.'

Passage 10 — The falcon that must not soar

Original line / short passage:

Flavius: *I'll about / And drive away the vulgar from the streets; / So do you too, where you perceive them thick. / These growing feathers plucked from Caesar's wing / Will make him fly an ordinary pitch, / Who else would soar above the view of men / And keep us all in servile fearfulness.*

Simple English: I will go about the city and clear the common people from the streets; you do the same wherever you see them crowding. If we pluck these new feathers from Caesar's wing, he will fly only at an ordinary height — whereas otherwise he would soar so high that men could not see him, and would keep all of us in slavish fear.

Difficult words: *I'll about* — I will go about, make my rounds. *The vulgar* — the common people (from Latin *vulgus*, the crowd; not yet 'rude' in the modern sense, but already contemptuous). *Perceive them thick* — see them gathered densely. *Growing feathers* — new feathers, the plumage a young bird grows as it matures; here, Caesar's newly acquired honours and popular support. *Plucked* — pulled out. *Pitch* — in falconry, the height to which a hawk or falcon climbs before it swoops on its prey. *Ordinary* — normal, usual. *Soar* — fly high. *Above the view of men* — out of men's sight, beyond their power to watch or check. *Servile* — slave-like. *Fearfulness* — the condition of being afraid.

Literal meaning: Flavius plans to clear the streets and explains the purpose of stripping the statues: by removing Caesar's public honours now, the tribunes will keep him at a normal level, instead of letting him rise beyond control and reduce all Romans to frightened slaves.

Subtext: This is the real reason for everything in the scene. The anger about aprons, the sneering at the Cobbler, the shaming over Pompey — all of it was the surface of a fear Flavius only now states plainly: Caesar is becoming something other than a citizen, and there is very little time left to stop him.

Hidden meaning: The metaphor carries a precise political theory. A falcon's *pitch* is the height from which it strikes; a bird that climbs beyond sight is a bird that can strike anywhere, unseen. 'Above the view of men' means more than 'very high' — it means *beyond accountability*, where the Republic's machinery of watching and checking cannot reach. And "feathers" are the right image for honours and applause: they are not the bird, but they are what lets the bird fly. The crowd's love is Caesar's plumage. The tribunes have understood that; what they have not understood is that you cannot pluck a bird by scolding its admirers.

Character psychology: The blunt enforcer of the opening lines turns out to be the scene's most lucid thinker. Flavius speaks here without rage, in a sustained image, and the phrase "us all" shows that his fear is for the community, not for himself. He is also, we notice, a man who believes small actions can alter great outcomes — a hopefulness that the next scene punishes.

Political meaning: This is the republican case in its purest form, before any personal grievance has coloured it: one man must not rise above the level of other men, because a Rome with one man above it is a Rome of slaves. **HISTORICAL RECORD:** the Roman Republic was founded, in its own tradition, on the expulsion of a king in 509 BC, and Romans retained a deep hatred of the word *rex*. Flavius never uses the word 'king', but "servile fearfulness" describes exactly what Romans believed kingship meant.

Historical context: Falconry was a sport of the Elizabethan gentry, and its vocabulary — pitch, stoop, haggard, mew — was common currency in Shakespeare's language; his audience would have grasped the image instantly. **LITERARY INTERPRETATION:** the image is Shakespeare's, not Plutarch's; the sources give the tribunes' action but not this explanation of it. Shakespeare supplies the political reasoning so that the audience enters Scene 2 already equipped with the republican fear.

Literary devices: Extended metaphor (Caesar as a bird of prey, sustained over four lines: feathers, wing, fly, pitch, soar); antithesis ("an ordinary pitch" against soaring "above the view of men"); alliteration in *fly* / *feathers* and in "servile fearfulness"; the inclusive pronoun "us all" widening the stakes from two tribunes to all Rome; the scene's final word, "fearfulness", left ringing — an ending on the emotion that drives the whole play.

Effect: The scene closes not with a joke or a shout but with a thoughtful, frightening picture. The audience, having laughed at puns and winced at a tirade, is now made to think. We leave the empty street carrying an image of Caesar as a hawk, and that image colours everything we see of him in the next scene.

Dramatic significance: These are the scene's last words and the play's first explicit statement of its central political anxiety: that Caesar will rise beyond the reach of ordinary men. Everything the conspirators later say — Cassius's complaint that Caesar does "bestride the narrow world / Like a Colossus" while "we petty men / Walk under his huge legs", Brutus's reasoning in his orchard that Caesar must be stopped before he grows — is a variation on Flavius's falcon. The scene ends by handing the audience the lens through which to watch Caesar's entrance.

Foreshadowing: The attempt to pluck Caesar's feathers fails at once; the tribunes are silenced and Caesar is offered a crown in the same afternoon. But the logic — act before he soars — survives them and becomes the conspiracy. In that sense the falcon speech foreshadows the Ides of March: the conspirators will pluck not feathers but life, and will discover that Caesar's spirit, in Brutus's own later admission, still walks abroad.

LITERARY INTERPRETATION: the deepest irony is that the plucking does not keep Rome at an 'ordinary pitch'; it produces Antony, Octavian and an empire.

Scene connection: The "vulgar" that Flavius drives from the streets are the crowd we will hear shouting for Caesar in Scene 2; his clearing of the streets fails before it begins. The upward imagery — soaring, above the view of men — is answered in Scene 2 by Cassius's Colossus, which also makes Caesar vast and the rest of Rome small. And the tribunes' plan links directly to Casca's report of their silencing, the first proof that Caesar's wings are already too strong to pluck.

ICSE keywords: 'extended metaphor', 'falconry imagery', 'republicanism', 'tyranny', 'ambition', 'liberty versus servitude', 'political fear', 'foreshadowing'.

Exam application: When asked why the conspirators fear Caesar, or whether their fear was shared, write: "The fear is first voiced not by Cassius but by the tribune Flavius, who hopes that "These growing feathers plucked from Caesar's wing / Will make him fly an ordinary pitch"; the falcon image shows that even before the conspiracy, republican officials saw Caesar as a bird of prey rising "above the view of men", able to keep Rome "in servile fearfulness".'

How the ten passages fit together

Read in order, the ten passages trace one movement. The scene begins with authority shouting at the people (Passages 1–2), is interrupted by the people answering back with wit (Passage 3), turns on a single plain sentence naming Caesar (Passage 4), rises to rhetoric and curse (Passages 5–7), empties the stage in silence (Passage 8), and ends with two men agreeing on a small act of resistance and the large fear behind it (Passages

9–10). If you can tell that story in your own words — command, wit, revelation, rhetoric, silence, resistance, fear — you can reconstruct the whole scene from memory, and you can see why Shakespeare called it the beginning of a tragedy rather than a comedy.

CROSS-REFERENCE Where these passages are used again

The pun sequence and Marullus's speech are the usual sources for Class IX extract questions; worked extracts are in *Chapter 18 — Extract-Based Training (Part One)*. The falcon image belongs with Cassius's Colossus in *Chapter 08 — Cassius — The Manipulation Masterclass* and with the treatment of ambition and republicanism in *Chapter 11 — Themes of Act 1 (Part One)*. The crowd's silence and later swings are traced in *Chapter 12 — Themes of Act 1 (Part Two)* under mob psychology, and in *Chapter 16 — The Scene Connection Engine*. Every device named above is defined with examples in *Chapter 13 — The Act 1 Literary-Device Bank*; every quotation is collected in *Chapter 15 — The Act 1 Quotation Bank*.

End-of-Scene Revision Sheet

REVISION ONE-MINUTE REVISION — Act 1 Scene 1

Five must-remember events. (1) The tribunes Flavius and Marullus find tradesmen in holiday clothes on the street and order them home. (2) The Cobbler evades their questions with a chain of puns about soles, mending, the awl and being a surgeon to old shoes. (3) The Cobbler admits the crowd is out to see Caesar and rejoice in his triumph. (4) Marullus denounces the crowd for forgetting Pompey and cheering the man who triumphs over "Pompey's blood"; the commoners leave in silence. (5) Flavius and Marullus split up to strip Caesar's statues of their decorations, despite Marullus's worry that it is the feast of Lupercal.

Five keywords. Fickleness; ingratitude; republicanism; public opinion; hierarchy (class).

Three quotations. "You blocks, you stones, you worse than senseless things!" (Marullus to the crowd). "And do you now strew flowers in his way / That comes in triumph over Pompey's blood?" (Marullus — the proof of fickleness). "These growing feathers plucked from Caesar's wing / Will make him fly an ordinary pitch" (Flavius — the republican fear).

Three character insights. The Cobbler is witty, self-interested and never quite insolent — proof that the common people are not fools. Marullus is the orator and the pious one; he moves the crowd but hesitates on a holy day. Flavius is the man of action and the clearest political thinker; his decisiveness gets both tribunes silenced.

Three themes. The fickleness of public opinion (Pompey → Caesar). The fear of one man rising above the Republic. Class conflict between officials and commoners, marked by verse against prose.

Two literary devices. Pun (soles/souls, awl/all, withal/with awl, recover/re-cover). Extended metaphor (Caesar as a falcon whose feathers must be plucked) — with anaphora ("And do you now...") and rhetorical question as the next two to name.

Two historical points. Caesar's Spanish triumph (October 45 BC) celebrated victory over Pompey's sons at Munda and was resented because it was a victory over Romans. The historical tribunes removed a diadem from Caesar's statue and were deposed; Shakespeare moves the episode to the day of the triumph and the Lupercal.

Three connections. Casca in Scene 2: the tribunes "are put to silence" for pulling scarves off Caesar's images. Cassius in Scene 2: the Colossus speech is Flavius's falcon fear restated with envy. Act 3 Scene 2: the crowd that swung from Pompey to Caesar swings from Brutus to Antony.

One central idea. The crowd's love makes a man great and can be moved by anyone with words — so whoever controls the crowd controls Rome, and the republicans who despise the crowd have already lost it.

CHAPTER 4

Act 1 Scene 2 (Part One) — Lupercalia, the Soothsayer, and the Seduction of Brutus

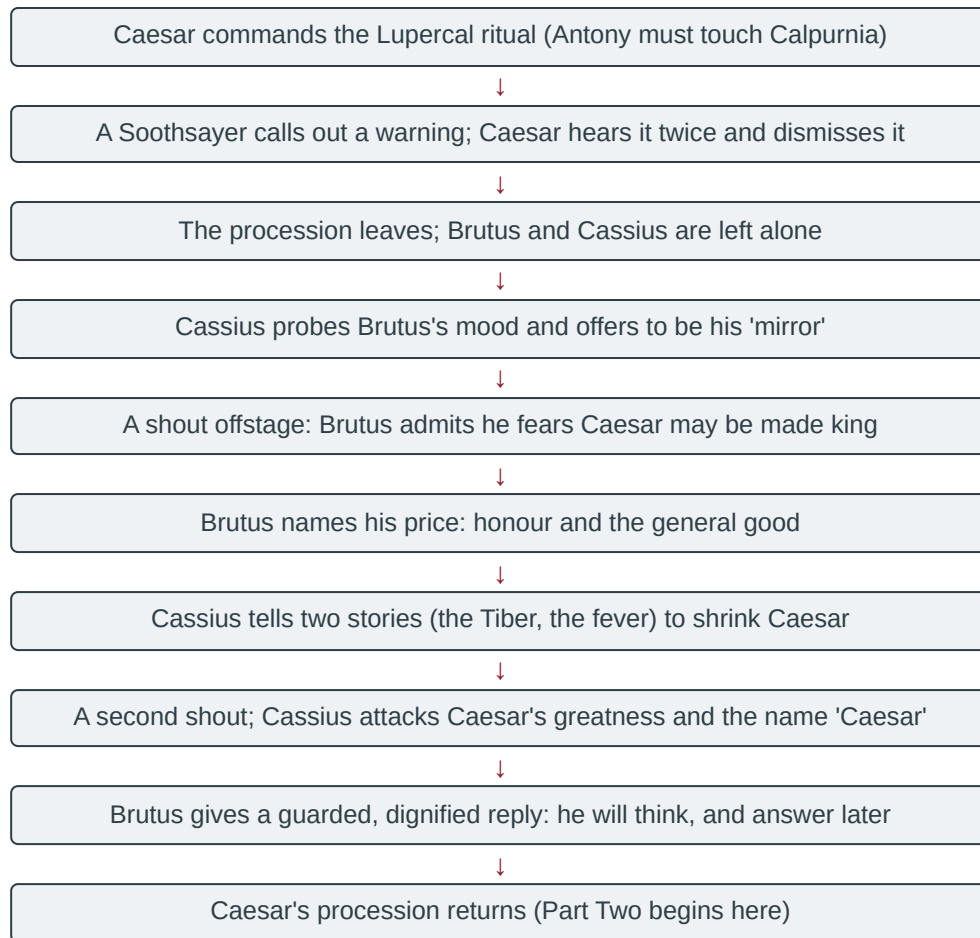
This chapter teaches the first half of Act 1 Scene 2, from Caesar's entrance at the feast of Lupercal to the moment Caesar's procession returns. It is the scene in which the play's two great engines start turning: fate speaks (the Soothsayer) and persuasion begins (Cassius working on Brutus). You will first move through the whole scene in five levels, then examine it from twenty angles as a complete dramatic unit, and then study every important passage line by line with the fixed teaching labels. Part Two of this scene (the next chapter) handles Caesar's return, Casca's report of the crown and Cassius's soliloquy, and it carries the revision sheet for the whole scene.

1. Where You Are Standing

In Scene 1 you watched a street. Two tribunes, Flavius and Marullus, drove holiday-making commoners home and decided to strip the decorations from Caesar's statues. Nobody important appeared. You heard Caesar's name shouted, feared, resented — but you did not see the man.

Scene 2 changes the camera angle. Now the great enter: Caesar himself, his wife Calpurnia, Antony dressed to run in the festival race, the senators Cicero and Decius, and the men who will kill Caesar a month later — Brutus, Cassius and Casca. The Folio stage direction (in single quotes because stage directions are not verified dialogue) reads roughly 'Enter Caesar, Antony for the course, Calpurnia, Portia, Decius, Cicero, Brutus, Cassius, Casca, a Soothsayer'. In a single sweep Shakespeare puts almost the whole cast of the tragedy on stage together, arranged around one man. That picture — Rome as a procession revolving around Caesar — is itself the first thing the scene teaches.

The first half of the scene has a very simple shape, and you should hold it in your head before you learn anything else:



CROSS-REFERENCE Where the other chapters take over

This chapter deliberately stops at the return of Caesar's train. The chapter 'Act 1 Scene 2 (Part Two) — Caesar Returns, Casca Reports, Cassius Plots' teaches Caesar's judgement of Cassius, Casca's report of the crown, and Cassius's soliloquy, and it contains the revision sheet for the whole scene. The full anatomy of Cassius's persuasive method belongs to 'Cassius — The Manipulation Masterclass'; here you get the moves as they happen in this conversation. The Soothsayer's complete foreshadowing map (his reappearance before the Capitol) is in 'The Soothsayer, the Ides of March, and the Supporting Cast'. What the scene tells us about Caesar's character as a whole is gathered in 'Caesar in Act 1 — A Character Masterclass', and Brutus's inner life in 'Brutus in Act 1 — Honour, Conflict and Vulnerability'.

2. The Five Levels: One Pass Through the Whole First Half

Before the twenty angles and the line-by-line work, take the scene in five passes. Do not skip Levels 1 to 4 to reach the exam material: the exam material only makes sense once the earlier levels are secure.

LEVEL 1 — What happened?

It is the feast of Lupercal, a Roman festival in February. Caesar enters in procession and gives an order: his wife Calpurnia must stand in Antony's path during the ritual race, because tradition holds that a barren (childless) woman touched by a runner in this holy race will be cured. Antony promises to obey. As the procession sets off, a voice cries Caesar's name from the crowd. It is a Soothsayer (a fortune-teller who claims to foresee the future), and his message is five words long: "Beware the ides of March." Caesar has the man brought before him, hears the warning a second time, calls him "a dreamer" and moves on. Everyone follows Caesar to watch the games except two men, Brutus and Cassius. Cassius asks Brutus why he has grown cold and distant. Brutus says he is troubled by private thoughts and is 'at war' with himself. Cassius offers to act as Brutus's mirror and show him his own hidden worth. Shouting is heard from the games; Brutus says he fears the people are choosing Caesar as king, yet admits he loves Caesar. He declares that if the public good demands it he will face death for honour. Cassius then tells two stories: how he once had to rescue Caesar from drowning in the Tiber, and how Caesar shook and groaned like a sick girl during a fever in Spain. A second shout is heard. Cassius delivers his great speech against Caesar's greatness: Caesar straddles the world like a Colossus while other men creep beneath him; the fault lies in themselves for accepting it; the name 'Brutus' is as good as the name 'Caesar'; and there was once another Brutus who would sooner have tolerated the devil in Rome than a king. Brutus replies with careful reserve: he guesses what Cassius is driving at, will think about it and answer another day, but he would rather be a villager than a Roman under the conditions he sees coming. Cassius is satisfied that he has struck a spark. Caesar's procession returns.

LEVEL 2 — What does it mean?

Three meanings sit beneath the events. First, Caesar's opening command shows a ruler who governs even the private and the sacred: he arranges his wife's fertility by public order, and he expects ritual to obey him as men do. Second, the Soothsayer episode shows that the same Caesar who trusts the old fertility superstition will not trust a warning about his own life. He is superstitious where it flatters his hopes and sceptical where it threatens his self-image. Third, and most importantly, the long conversation shows how a conspiracy is born not from a plan but from a mood. Brutus has no plot. He has a disturbance — "passions of some difference" — and a fear that the people may make Caesar king. Cassius's whole task is to translate that private disturbance into political action, and he does it by talking not about Caesar first but about Brutus: about Brutus's face, his hidden worth, his name, his ancestor. The scene means this: tyranny is resisted, in Shakespeare's Rome, not by institutions but by persuading one honourable man that his honour requires it.

LEVEL 3 — Why did Shakespeare write it this way?

Consider the choices. Shakespeare could have shown the crown being offered to Caesar; instead he sends the crown offstage and keeps the stage for two men talking, with shouts breaking in. That is a decision to make the drama of Rome's future happen inside Brutus's hearing and reaction, not in a spectacle. He could have had Cassius argue politics directly; instead he gives Cassius the image of the mirror, so that the argument for killing Caesar starts as a conversation about self-knowledge. He could have delayed the Soothsayer until the conspiracy existed; instead he places the prophecy before any plot is spoken, so that the audience knows the date of Caesar's death before the killers have agreed to kill. Each choice serves the same purpose: to make the audience feel that the future is already forming in words, looks and silences before anyone draws a dagger. Shakespeare is also using what Plutarch gave him with great freedom — compressing a triumph of October 45 BC and a festival of February 44 BC into one day, inventing the Tiber swimming story (no ancient source records it), and turning Plutarch's anonymous graffiti urging Brutus to act into Cassius's spoken and, later, written persuasion.

LEVEL 4 — How does it connect to the whole play?

Almost every thread of the tragedy is tied here. The Soothsayer's warning fixes the date that gives the play its clock; Caesar will meet the same man again on the morning of the Ides. Brutus's phrase "with himself at war" names the inner division that his orchard soliloquy in Act 2 will dramatise and that his quarrel with Cassius in Act 4 will inherit. His demand that honour and the "general good" justify any action becomes the exact argument of his speech to the people after the assassination, and honour is the word Antony will turn against him in the funeral oration. Cassius's Tiber and fever stories expose a Caesar whose body is weaker than his myth, preparing us for the deaf ear, the falling sickness and the man who fears nothing and is killed. The Colossus image and the line about fates and stars set up the play's argument between free will and destiny, an argument that Cassius himself will lose at Philippi when a misread report drives him to suicide. Even the crown that is offered offstage returns: Antony will remind the crowd in the funeral speech that he offered Caesar a crown three times at the Lupercal.

LEVEL 5 — How do I use it in an ICSE answer?

Be clear about the syllabus first. Act 1 is the Class IX portion; your Class X board paper examines Acts III to V. So this scene will not appear as a Class X extract. It earns you marks in three other ways. (1) In Class IX internal examinations, this scene is a favourite for extract-based ('reference to the context') questions — the Soothsayer exchange, the mirror passage, the honour speech and the Colossus speech are natural extracts. (2) In the Class X paper, questions on the Act 3 to 5 extracts constantly reach back: 'Why does Brutus join the conspiracy?', 'What had Cassius earlier told Brutus about Caesar?', 'What is the significance of the ides of March?' The 2025 paper, for instance, asked what the phrase 'the work the ides of March begun' refers to — unanswerable without this scene. (3) Character and theme questions on Brutus, Cassius and Caesar need the evidence planted here: Brutus's conflict of love and principle, Cassius's method of flattery and belittlement, Caesar's blend of superstition and pride. When you write, quote short, exact phrases — "He is a dreamer", "with himself at war", "The fault, dear Brutus, is not in our stars" — and always attach a point of analysis to the quotation, never the quotation alone.

3. The Scene as a Complete Dramatic Unit: Twenty Angles

A scene is not a list of events. It is a designed unit with a setting, a set of wants, a change, and a set of consequences. The twenty headings below are the questions a professional reader asks of any scene. Learn to ask them yourself; they will serve you for every scene in the play. (These twenty cover the whole of Scene 2, including the half taught in Part Two, because the scene must be understood as one unit.)

1 Setting

The scene is set in a public place in Rome on the feast of Lupercal. Nothing in the dialogue names a street or square precisely; Shakespeare's stage was bare, and the setting is created by what people say and do. Three things build it. First, ceremony: a procession, trumpets (a 'flourish' is a fanfare; a 'sennet' is a longer ceremonial trumpet signal marking a formal entrance or exit), a ritual race about to begin. Second, a crowd: Caesar speaks of "the press" (the crush of people), Casca shouts for silence, and the shouts that later interrupt Brutus and Cassius come from a mass of people offstage. Third, a calendar: it is the Lupercal, and a voice names another date, the ides of March. The setting is therefore public, crowded and festive — exactly the kind of place where a private conversation stands out. Shakespeare then empties the stage of everyone but two men, so that the setting flips from ceremony to intimacy without a change of place. Historically the Lupercalia was celebrated on 15 February; Shakespeare has moved Caesar's triumph, which took place in October of the previous year, onto the same day, so that the crowd of Scene 1 and the festival of Scene 2 belong to one continuous morning.

2 Characters

Caesar dominates without saying much: he speaks in short commands and refers to himself in the third person. Calpurnia speaks three words ("Here, my lord") and is otherwise a body to be touched and, later, a pale cheek to be read. Antony is defined by one promise of instant obedience. Casca appears first as a crowd-controller ("Peace, ho! Caesar speaks."), later as the sour, prose-speaking reporter. The Soothsayer is a nameless voice with a single sentence. Brutus is reserved, courteous and inwardly troubled. Cassius is watchful, eloquent and relentless. Cicero, Decius and Portia enter with the procession but do not speak in this half; Portia's presence is only in the entry direction. Marullus and Flavius, in the Folger text, follow the procession — a silent reminder of Scene 1 whose meaning becomes clear when Casca reports that they have been silenced. The design is deliberate: the one man with the most power says the least that is thoughtful, and the two men who say the most are already, without knowing it, describing the shape of his death.

3 Political situation

Rome is a republic in name and Caesar's in fact. He has defeated Pompey and Pompey's sons in a civil war and holds the dictatorship — a Roman emergency office, traditionally limited to six months, which Caesar had stretched into a permanent post. The republican institutions still exist: consuls, senators, tribunes of the people, praetors (Brutus and Cassius both held praetorships in 44 BC). But the question hanging over the city is whether Caesar will take the one title Romans had hated since they expelled their last king in 509 BC: 'rex', king. Scene 1 showed the tribunes trying to pull down Caesar's decorations; Scene 2 shows the aristocrats who fear the same thing but are far more dangerous because they have swords and standing. Brutus's fear that the people may "Choose Caesar for their king" is the political centre of the scene. The crown that Antony offers offstage is, in reported form, the test of whether the people want a king, and the reported answer (they cheer the refusal) is unstable and ambiguous. Nobody in the scene knows what Rome wants; that uncertainty is the political situation.

4 What happens

Stripped to actions: Caesar orders Antony to touch Calpurnia in the race; the Soothsayer warns Caesar twice and is dismissed; the procession exits; Cassius questions Brutus's coldness; Brutus confesses inner conflict; Cassius offers to be Brutus's mirror; a shout interrupts; Brutus admits his fear about the kingship and his love for Caesar; Brutus states the terms on which he will listen (honour, the general good); Cassius tells the Tiber and fever anecdotes; a second shout; Cassius attacks Caesar's greatness and the name 'Caesar' and invokes the ancestral Brutus; Brutus promises to consider and answer later; Caesar returns, angry, and judges Cassius dangerous; Casca reports the three offers of the crown, Caesar's swoon and the silencing of the tribunes; Casca agrees to dine with Cassius; Brutus and Cassius part; Cassius, alone, resolves to forge letters. Notice the rhythm: two intrusions of sound (the shouts), each of which pushes the conversation one step further towards treason.

5 Why it happens

Every action has a cause you can name. Caesar orders the touch because he wants an heir and believes the ritual works. The Soothsayer warns because, in the play's world, the future can be read and someone reads it. Caesar dismisses him because a man who calls himself Caesar cannot be seen to flinch at a stranger's words in public. Brutus stays behind because he is "not gamesome" and in no mood for a festival; Cassius stays because he wants Brutus alone. Cassius probes because he has a plan that cannot succeed without Brutus's reputation — the conspirators themselves later say that Brutus's good name will turn what would look like crime into virtue. Brutus opens up because Cassius accuses him of coldness to a friend, and Brutus's sense of courtesy will not let that stand. The shouts happen because the crowd is reacting to the offered crown, and they push Brutus to speak his fear aloud. Cassius tells the anecdotes because Brutus has just said that he loves Caesar; the stories are designed to make Caesar less lovable and less godlike. Brutus stalls because he is honourable and slow, not because he disagrees. Cassius plots the letters because, as he says in his soliloquy, he has seen that Brutus's honourable "mettle may be wrought" — that a noble temperament can be worked upon.

6 What each character wants

Caesar wants an heir, a smooth ceremony and unbroken authority; when the Soothsayer intrudes he wants, above all, to appear unafraid. Calpurnia, so far as the text lets us see, wants to obey; the scene gives her no wish of her own, and that emptiness is itself expressive. Antony wants to please Caesar and to run his race. The Soothsayer wants Caesar to listen. Brutus wants to be left alone with his thoughts and, more deeply, wants to be a man of honour who never has to choose between friendship and Rome. Cassius wants Brutus in the conspiracy, and beneath that he wants an end to living in awe of a man he considers no better than himself: "I had as lief not be as live to be / In awe of such a thing as I myself." Casca wants to be seen as unimpressed by everything. The scene's tension comes from the gap between what Brutus wants (to avoid choosing) and what Cassius wants (to force the choice).

7 What changes during the scene

At the start, Brutus's trouble is private and formless: "passions of some difference", "Conceptions only proper to myself". By the end of the first half he has spoken his fear aloud to another man, admitted he would not have Caesar king, named honour as a value he would die for, and promised to hear Cassius out. That is a large change, even though he agrees to nothing. Cassius changes from tentative to confident: he begins by complaining of Brutus's coldness and ends by declaring himself glad to have struck fire. Caesar changes from the serene master of ceremony to the man who returns with "The angry spot" glowing on his brow, and Casca's

report reveals a Caesar who fainted in public. The crowd's mood, reported rather than seen, has shifted three times with three offers of the crown. Most of all, the audience's relation to the play changes: at the start we watch a public festival; by the end we are inside a secret.

8 What the audience learns

The audience learns the date of Caesar's death; that Caesar is superstitious about fertility but dismissive of prophecy; that Caesar and Calpurnia have no child; that Brutus is troubled and fears Caesar's kingship while loving the man; that Cassius has a hidden purpose and considerable skill; that Caesar's body has failed him at least twice (the Tiber, the fever), and, from Casca, a third time (the swoon); that a crown was offered and refused three times and that Casca believed Caesar wanted it; that the tribunes have been silenced; and that Cassius will forge letters. We also learn the play's method: important events (the crown offering, the tribunes' punishment) reach us through reports by interested witnesses, so we must learn to weigh the speaker as well as the speech.

9 What Shakespeare deliberately withholds

He withholds the crown scene itself — we hear cheering and later get Casca's cynical version, never the thing. He withholds Caesar's inner thoughts: there is no soliloquy for Caesar in this scene or anywhere in the play, so his mind is always deduced from his public voice. He withholds the content of Brutus's "passions of some difference": Brutus never tells Cassius what he has been brooding on, and the audience must wait until the orchard in Act 2 to hear him reason it out. He withholds any explicit proposal of murder; Cassius never says the word, and the nearest he comes is the ancestral Brutus who would not have "brook'd" a king. He withholds Cicero's Greek remark, which even Casca did not understand. And he withholds any reply from the Soothsayer to Caesar's dismissal; the man simply vanishes into the crowd, which makes the warning feel less like a character's opinion and more like the play's own voice.

10 Important language

Notice five kinds of language working at once. Language of command: Caesar's clipped imperatives — "Set on", "Set him before me", "Let us leave him. Pass" — and his habit of naming himself in the third person, as though 'Caesar' were an office rather than a man. Language of sight: eyes, faces, mirrors, reflections, shadows, looks, "the bend" of Caesar's eye; the whole Brutus–Cassius conversation is conducted through metaphors of seeing. Language of the body: barren wombs, a shaking fever, coward lips losing colour, a groan, a swoon, foaming at the mouth — Caesar's greatness is repeatedly measured against his flesh. Language of weighing and measuring: names written, sounded and weighed; Caesar's stature as a "Colossus"; petty men beneath huge legs. Language of honour and its opposites: "honour" is repeated by Brutus and immediately picked up by Cassius as "the subject of my story", while "dishonourable graves" is the fate Cassius holds up as the alternative. Learn to name these families of language; an examiner is far more impressed by 'Cassius conducts the argument through imagery of sight' than by 'Cassius uses good language'.

11 Important images

An image is a picture made in words. The scene's central image is the **mirror**: the eye "sees not itself / But by reflection", Brutus lacks "such mirrors" as would show him his worth, and Cassius appoints himself "your glass". Around it cluster related images of **eyes and shadows**. The second great image is the **Colossus**: Caesar as the giant statue straddling the world, with "petty men" creeping between his legs looking for graves. Third, the **river**: the "troubled Tiber chafing with her shores", the "angry flood", the "torrent" — nature as a test of manhood that Caesar failed. Fourth, **fire from flint**: Cassius's "weak words" have "struck but thus much show of fire" — persuasion as striking a spark. Fifth, **disease and the failing body**: the fever, shaking, pale lips,

groans, and the "sick girl". Sixth, **the yoke**: Rome "groaning underneath this age's yoke", the image of an ox harnessed to a burden, which turns political submission into a physical weight. Seventh, the **conjured spirit**: 'Brutus' will "start a spirit" as readily as 'Caesar' — a picture of names as magic words that raise ghosts, chillingly fulfilled when Caesar's ghost visits Brutus in Act 4.

12 Literary devices

Only name a device where it is genuinely present. In this half you will find: **dramatic irony** (the audience knows what the ides of March will bring; Caesar does not); **foreshadowing** (the Soothsayer; "death i' th' other"); **metaphor** (the glass, the yoke, the palm of victory, chewing on a thought); **simile** (Caesar "Like a Colossus"; groaning "As a sick girl"); **personification** (the Tiber "chafing", the "angry flood", Age and Rome addressed as persons); **apostrophe**, the device of addressing an absent thing directly ("Age, thou art shamed! / Rome, thou hast lost the breed of noble bloods!"); **classical allusion** (Aeneas and Anchises; the Colossus of Rhodes; "the great flood"; the ancestral Brutus); **hyperbole** (Caesar's eye "whose bend doth awe the world"); **antithesis**, the balancing of opposites ("honour in one eye and death i' th' other"; "villager" against "son of Rome"); **rhetorical question** ("Why should that name be sounded more than yours?"; "Upon what meat doth this our Caesar feed"); **parallelism** in the sequence of imperatives ("Write them together... Sound them... Weigh them... conjure with 'em"); **pun** (Rome and "room enough", the two words pronounced alike on the Elizabethan stage); **aphorism**, a compact general truth ("Men at some time are masters of their fates"); **irony** in Cassius's mouth ("this god did shake"; "immortal Caesar"); and **anachronism**, an object out of its historical time ("Th' eternal devil", a Christian idea placed in pagan Rome). The chapter 'The Act 1 Literary-Device Bank' gathers these with definitions and further examples.

13 Themes

Six themes surface in the first half. **Fate and free will**: a prophecy is delivered and rejected, and Cassius insists that "The fault... is not in our stars, / But in ourselves". The scene puts the two positions side by side without settling them. **Public image versus private reality**: Caesar's godlike public self against the shaking, groaning, drowning man of Cassius's stories; Brutus's cold face against his inner war. **Honour**: Brutus's absolute value, immediately made "the subject" of Cassius's story — the theme and the manipulation begin together. **Friendship and its use**: Cassius approaches Brutus as a wounded friend, and the language of love ("your friend that loves you", "yet I love him well") frames every political move. **Republicanism and the fear of kingship**: "Choose Caesar for their king" is the horror that unites Brutus and Cassius; the ancestral Brutus is invoked as the founder of Roman liberty. **Superstition and omens**: the fertility ritual, the Soothsayer, and the question of who believes what. The two 'Themes of Act 1' chapters develop each of these across the whole act.

14 Historical context

Behind the scene stands Plutarch's Life of Caesar, in Sir Thomas North's English translation of 1579. Plutarch records the Lupercalia of 44 BC: young noblemen and magistrates ran through the city striking bystanders with strips of goat-hide, and women placed themselves in their way in the belief that the touch aided fertility and childbirth; Antony, who was consul that year, ran as one of the priests and offered Caesar a diadem, which the crowd applauded feebly and whose refusal they applauded loudly. Plutarch and Suetonius both record a seer who warned Caesar of danger that would come no later than the ides of March; Suetonius names him Spurinna. Shakespeare keeps the warning and makes the seer nameless. Plutarch also records Caesar's epileptic seizures (the "falling sickness" of Casca's report), and that they were said to have first troubled him in Spain — which may lie behind Cassius's "fever when he was in Spain", though the swimming contest in the Tiber has no ancient source and is generally treated as Shakespeare's invention. Caesar and Calpurnia were indeed childless; Caesar's only legitimate child, Julia, had died in 54 BC. Marcus Brutus really did claim descent from Lucius Junius Brutus, who expelled the last king of Rome in 509 BC, and anonymous messages

really were left for him urging him to act, which Shakespeare turns into Cassius's forged letters. Shakespeare compresses time (triumph and Lupercalia in one day) and, in Casca's report, increases Plutarch's two offers of the diadem to three.

15 Foreshadowing

The scene is thick with it. "Beware the ides of March" fixes the day. Brutus's "with himself at war" foreshadows both his internal struggle in the orchard and the literal civil war of Acts 4 and 5. "Set honour in one eye and death i' th' other" foreshadows the choice he will make on the Ides and the death he will choose at Philippi. Cassius's "dishonourable graves" foreshadows the graves the conspirators will actually find. "Men at some time are masters of their fates" will be tested and, for Cassius, contradicted: he dies because he misreads a report and acts as if fate had already decided. "'Brutus' will start a spirit as soon as 'Caesar'" is fulfilled literally when Caesar's spirit appears to Brutus. Cassius's stories of Caesar's weak body prepare the deaf ear, the swoon and the "falling sickness" of Part Two, and the mortal body that twenty-three wounds will open. Even Caesar's "leave no ceremony out" hints at a man for whom ceremony is a shield, a hint Calpurnia's dream and Decius's flattery will exploit in Act 2.

16 Dramatic irony

Dramatic irony exists when the audience knows something a character does not. Shakespeare's first audiences, like you, knew that Caesar was murdered on the ides of March; so every line about that date carries a charge the speakers cannot feel. Caesar's "He is a dreamer" is the scene's sharpest case. There is a further, subtler irony: the man who repeats the warning to Caesar is Brutus — "A soothsayer bids you beware the ides of March" — so that Brutus, the eventual killer, voices the prophecy of his own deed. When Cassius calls Caesar "immortal", he means to mock, but the audience hears a double edge: mortal on the Ides, immortal in reputation for two thousand years. When Cassius says "then hold me dangerous", he means it as a denial, and the audience knows he is precisely the dangerous man Caesar will name in Part Two. And when Brutus fears that "the people / Choose Caesar for their king", the audience will shortly learn from Casca that the people cheered Caesar's refusal — Brutus's fear runs ahead of the facts.

17 Character development

Brutus develops from silence to speech: from a man who will not explain his mood to a man who has named his fear, his love and his principle. He does not decide anything, and his refusal to be "any further moved" for now shows the deliberate, procedural mind that will later insist on doing the murder as a formal sacrifice. Cassius develops from friend to recruiter: watch how his language moves from love to honour to contempt to ancestry. Caesar develops in a different way — not by changing but by being revealed. In the first fourteen lines he is all authority; in the Soothsayer exchange he shows curiosity and then dismissal; in Cassius's stories he becomes a man who nearly drowned and cried out for help; when he returns he is angry; in Casca's report he has fainted. The scene does not change Caesar; it peels him. Antony, in one line of obedience, is established as the loyal instrument, which makes his later independence in Act 3 a genuine development rather than a surprise.

18 Scene connections

Backwards: Scene 1's tribunes reappear silently in the procession and are reported "put to silence"; the crowd that Marullus scolded is the same crowd that shouts three times offstage; Flavius's fear of Caesar's "servile fearfulness" is Cassius's "In awe of such a thing as I myself" spoken by a nobleman. Forwards within Act 1: Cassius's soliloquy at the end of the scene plans the letters that he hands to Cinna in Scene 3; Casca, sounded out here over dinner, is won over in the storm; Cicero's silent presence here becomes his sceptical voice in

Scene 3. Into Act 2: Brutus's inner war becomes the orchard soliloquy; the forged letters arrive; Calpurnia's silent obedience becomes her desperate pleading; Caesar's dismissal of the Soothsayer becomes his dismissal of Calpurnia's dream. Into Act 3: the Soothsayer meets Caesar again on the way to the Capitol; Antony's funeral speech reminds the crowd of the crown offered at the Lupercal; Brutus justifies the killing by honour and the general good. Into Acts 4 and 5: the ghost, the quarrel between the two men who whisper here, and their deaths. The chapter 'The Scene Connection Engine and Where Act 1 Reappears Later' maps these in detail.

19 Future consequences

Because of what happens here: Brutus will receive letters he believes come from Roman citizens and will treat them as Rome's voice; Cassius will be able to bring him into the conspiracy at their next meeting, as Cassius predicts in Scene 3; Caesar, having dismissed the Soothsayer, will establish a habit of dismissing warnings that makes his walk to the Capitol possible; the crowd's fickleness, reported by Casca, will be exploited first by Brutus and then, far better, by Antony; and Brutus's insistence on honour will shape the conspiracy's mistakes — sparing Antony, letting Antony speak, refusing to take money by dishonourable means before Philippi. In a sense, the tragedy is what follows when a man who says he loves "The name of honour more than I fear death" is taken at his word.

20 ICSE exam relevance

EXAM-ORIENTED ADVICE, stated honestly. Act 1 is prescribed for Class IX, and the Class X board paper draws its drama extracts from Acts III, IV and V. This scene will therefore feed your Class X marks indirectly but constantly. When an Act 3 extract asks why Brutus joined the conspiracy, the evidence is here: his fear of kingship, his love for Caesar, his standard of honour and the general good, and Cassius's work on his vanity. When an Antony extract from the funeral scene refers to the crown offered three times at the Lupercal, the examiner expects you to know this is the offstage event of Scene 2. When a Caesar extract from Act 3 mentions the ides of March, you must know who first spoke of them and how Caesar responded. When a question asks what Cassius had said about Caesar's weaknesses, the Tiber and the fever are your answer. For Class IX internal examinations, this scene supplies classic extracts, and the sub-question types you will meet mirror the board pattern: context (who speaks, to whom, what has just happened), explanation of a phrase, reasons for a speaker's words, what a passage reveals of character, what follows, and a short evaluative response. The 2025 board paper's drama question carried sixteen marks split [3], [3], [3], [3], [4]; practise answering Act 1 extracts to that shape, because the skills are identical.

KEYWORDS Keyword box: terms this scene teaches you to use

Dramatic irony — the audience knows what the character does not. **Foreshadowing** — an early hint of later events. **Soliloquy** — a speech by a character alone on stage (Cassius has one at the end of this scene). **Hubris** — excessive pride leading to downfall (use with care: Caesar's "He is a dreamer" is evidence, not proof). **Superstition** — belief in supernatural causes; Caesar's fertility ritual. **Internal conflict** — Brutus "with himself at war". **Manipulation** — steering another person by indirect means; Cassius's method. **Flattery** — praise used as a tool; the mirror. **Republicanism** — the political belief in rule without a king. **Illeism** — speaking of oneself in the third person; Caesar's "Caesar is turned to hear" and Brutus's "poor Brutus". **Anecdote** — a short story told to make a point; the Tiber and the fever. **Allusion** — a reference to a well-known person, story or object; Aeneas, the Colossus. **Antithesis** — balanced opposites. **Apostrophe** — addressing an absent thing as if present. The chapter 'The ICSE Keyword Vault for Act 1' holds the full list with sample sentences.

ICSE EXAM BOX How Act 1 knowledge earns marks in a Class X answer

Suppose a Class X extract from Act 3 shows Brutus telling the crowd that he loved Caesar but loved Rome more, and a sub-question asks what had earlier made Brutus fear Caesar. A weak answer says 'Brutus thought Caesar was ambitious.' A strong answer reaches back to this scene: 'In Act 1 Scene 2, hearing the crowd shout at the Lupercal, Brutus told Cassius that he feared the people would "Choose Caesar for their king", while admitting "yet I love him well". His fear was of kingship, not of Caesar the man, which is why he presents the murder as a sacrifice for Rome.' That is three marks earned with one exact quotation and one point of analysis. Never claim a question is guaranteed; build the habit of carrying Act 1 evidence into Act 3 to 5 answers whenever the question asks for causes, background or character.

4. Caesar at the Lupercal: Ritual, Wife, Prophecy

Lupercalia as staged by Shakespeare

HISTORICAL RECORD. The Lupercalia was one of Rome's oldest festivals, held on 15 February. It was a rite of purification and fertility. Its priests, the Luperci, ran through the city striking the people they met, especially women, with thongs of goat-hide; the touch was believed to promote fertility and easy childbirth. In 44 BC a third college of Luperci, the Juliani, had been created in Caesar's honour, and Antony — consul that year, a man of about forty — ran as one of them. Marullus's protest in Scene 1, "You know it is the feast of Lupercal", tells us the tribunes know they are defacing images on a holy day.

SHAKESPEARE'S TEXT. Shakespeare stages almost none of this. There are no goat-hide thongs, no half-naked runners, no crowd being struck. What he keeps is a single detail — the touch that cures barrenness — and he hands it to Caesar as a command. The festival becomes visible only through Caesar's order to Antony, Antony's promise, and Cassius's later invitation to "go see the order of the course" (the proceedings of the race). Everything else happens offstage, where Antony will also offer the crown.

LITERARY INTERPRETATION. Why so little? Three answers reinforce each other. First, economy: an Elizabethan company could not stage a city festival, and Shakespeare turns the limitation into a method, letting sound (trumpets, shouts) stand for spectacle. Second, focus: by reducing the Lupercal to one command, Shakespeare makes the festival express Caesar rather than Rome — it becomes the setting in which Caesar's private hope for an heir is spoken as public policy. Third, irony: a fertility festival frames a scene about a childless ruler and a state that cannot reproduce its own liberty; Cassius will soon say that Rome "hast lost the breed of noble bloods". The festival's theme of fruitfulness runs against the grain of everything that follows.

HISTORICAL CONTEXT**The Lupercal and the crown: what Plutarch says and what Shakespeare changes**

Plutarch's *Life of Caesar* describes the Lupercalia of 44 BC as the occasion when Antony, running as a Lupercus, brought Caesar a diadem wrapped in laurel. The crowd applauded thinly at the offer and loudly when Caesar pushed it away; the offer was repeated, and Caesar finally sent the diadem to the Temple of Jupiter on the Capitol. Plutarch describes two offers; Shakespeare's Casca will say three. Historically Caesar's Spanish triumph (October 45 BC) and the Lupercalia (15 February 44 BC) were four months apart, and the episode of the tribunes removing a diadem from Caesar's statue came before the Lupercalia; Shakespeare folds all three into one morning. He is not careless. He wants the audience to see, in a single scene, Caesar celebrated, Caesar tempted by a crown, and Caesar's critics punished — the whole political weather of Rome in one day.

Antony's race and Caesar's command to touch Calpurnia

The scene opens with a name called twice. That in itself is a lesson in staging: the first word spoken by the most powerful man in the world is his wife's name, and Casca must silence the crowd so that she can hear it.

Original line / short passage:

Caesar: *Stand you directly in Antonius' way / When he doth run his course.*

Caesar: *Forget not in your speed, Antonius, / To touch Calpurnia, for our elders say / The barren, touchèd in this holy chase, / Shake off their sterile curse.*

Antony: *I shall remember. / When Caesar says 'Do this,' it is performed.*

Caesar: *Set on and leave no ceremony out.*

Simple English: Calpurnia, stand right in Antony's path when he runs the race. Antony, as you run, do not forget to touch Calpurnia: the old people say that a childless woman touched during this sacred race is freed from the curse of childlessness. Antony: I will remember; whatever Caesar orders is done. Caesar: Begin, and do not leave out any part of the ritual.

Difficult words: 'directly' — straight, exactly in the path; 'course' — the race run by the Luperci; 'speed' — haste, running; 'our elders' — the old, the ancestors, tradition; 'barren' — unable to have children; 'touchèd' (two syllables, for the verse rhythm) — touched; 'holy chase' — the sacred race; 'sterile' — infertile; 'curse' — infertility understood as a supernatural affliction; 'Set on' — proceed, go forward; 'ceremony' — ritual observance.

Literal meaning: Caesar arranges for his wife to be touched in the ritual so that she may conceive. Antony agrees. Caesar orders the procession to begin with every rite observed.

Subtext: Caesar wants an heir, and he wants it enough to say so in front of Rome. The politeness of "our elders say" places responsibility for the belief on tradition rather than on himself, but the order is his. Antony's reply is not just agreement; it is a public advertisement of Caesar's absolute authority, spoken by the consul of Rome as though he were a servant.

Hidden meaning: A ruler who can command a fertility miracle by scheduling it is a ruler who believes the world answers to his voice. "Leave no ceremony out" reveals a mind that treats ritual as insurance: perform every part, and the gods are bound. The same mind will refuse the Soothsayer moments later, because a prophecy of death is a ceremony Caesar did not order.

Character psychology: Caesar is anxious beneath the calm. Childlessness in a dynasty-builder is a private grief and a political vulnerability, and his instinct is to master it by public procedure. He speaks of himself in the third person through Antony's mouth ("When Caesar says"), and the habit tells us that 'Caesar' has become for him a public institution rather than a person. Antony's psychology is simpler and telling: he is the willing arm.

Political meaning: Rome watches its dictator try to secure a succession. To a republican ear, an heir is exactly what a republic must not have; magistrates are elected, not born. Caesar's wish for a child is therefore heard, by men like Cassius, as the wish for a dynasty. Antony's line, meanwhile, announces that the consulship has become an instrument of one man's will.

Historical context: Caesar had married Calpurnia in 59 BC; the marriage was childless, and Caesar's only legitimate child, Julia, had died in 54 BC. He would in fact name his great-nephew Octavian as heir in his will. Caesar was also pontifex maximus, Rome's chief priest, so his insistence on complete ceremony is in character for the historical man. Elizabethan audiences may have felt an echo of their own situation: in 1599 Elizabeth I was sixty-six, unmarried and without a named successor, and succession anxiety was a live public fear. Do not overstate this; it is context, not a code.

Literary devices: Metaphor in "sterile curse" (infertility as a curse to be shaken off, like a garment or a burden); the euphemistic 'holy chase' for a festival of running and striking; Caesar's illeism (third-person self-reference) relayed by Antony; the clipped imperative "Set on", which is characteristic of Caesar's command style throughout the play.

Effect: In fourteen short lines Shakespeare establishes hierarchy (everyone falls silent, Antony obeys), intimacy (a husband's hope), and unease (the ruler is not complete). The audience sees a man who governs even the womb.

Dramatic significance: This is Caesar's first appearance, and first appearances define. He is shown commanding, superstitious and childless. Each of the three will matter: command becomes rigidity, superstition becomes selective, childlessness becomes the question of who inherits Rome — a question that Antony and Octavian will answer with civil war.

Foreshadowing: Antony's promise of instant obedience foreshadows his role as Caesar's loyal executor and avenger; his 'performing' of Caesar's will continues after Caesar's death. "Leave no ceremony out" foreshadows Caesar's dependence on ritual and omen in Act 2, where Calpurnia's dream and the priests' sacrifice briefly stop him from going to the Senate.

Scene connection: Marullus's "feast of Lupercal" in Scene 1 is now on stage. The race Antony runs is the occasion of the crown offering that Casca will report in Part Two; the Lupercal will be named again in Antony's funeral speech in Act 3.

ICSE keywords: superstition, dynastic anxiety, authority, obedience, illeism, public versus private, foreshadowing.

Exam application: Asked what Caesar's opening words reveal about him, you could write: 'Caesar's first command — that Antony should "touch Calpurnia" so that she may "Shake off their sterile curse" — reveals a superstitious ruler who treats even his wife's fertility as a matter of public ceremony, and it quietly exposes his greatest weakness: he has no heir.'

Calpurnia

Calpurnia speaks three words in this scene, "Here, my lord", and then falls silent. Later, when Caesar returns, Brutus will read her face — her "cheek is pale" — as a sign that something has gone wrong. That is the whole of her presence in Act 1: a summons, an answer, and a complexion to be interpreted by men.

LITERARY INTERPRETATION. It is tempting to say Shakespeare neglects her. Look more carefully. He gives her an entrance in the procession beside the greatest man in Rome; he has that man's first word be her name; he has the crowd hushed for her; and then he has her body made the object of an order. The silence is not neglect but portraiture. Calpurnia is what Caesar's Rome does to the private life: it turns it into ceremony. Her three words of obedience are exactly matched by Antony's line of obedience that follows — wife and consul answer the same voice in the same way. Only in Act 2 will she speak at length, when she begs Caesar not to go to the Senate, and the contrast will be painful: the woman who said "Here, my lord" in public pleads in private and is overruled.

Historically (HISTORICAL RECORD) Calpurnia was the daughter of Lucius Calpurnius Piso Caesoninus, married Caesar in 59 BC, and was remembered by Plutarch for the ominous dream she had on the night before the Ides. Shakespeare makes that dream the centre of her Act 2 scene. Here he plants only the seed: she is the wife who cannot give Caesar what he wants, in a scene where everyone else gives him everything.

TEXT NOTE The spelling of her name

The Folger text, following the First Folio, prints 'Calphurnia'. The MIT/Globe text and most ICSE editions print 'Calpurnia', which is the historical Roman spelling. This book uses 'Calpurnia' throughout; the two spellings are the same character and either is acceptable in an answer, provided you are consistent.

Caesar's superstition

You must hold two facts together, because examiners love the tension between them. Caesar believes the fertility ritual will work and orders his men to "leave no ceremony out"; moments later he hears a prophecy of his own danger and calls the prophet "a dreamer". Is he superstitious or sceptical?

LITERARY INTERPRETATION. The answer is that Caesar's superstition is selective, and the selection is governed by his self-image. A ritual that promises to give him an heir enlarges Caesar; he embraces it. A warning that he may be struck down diminishes Caesar; he rejects it. He is not choosing between belief and disbelief. He is choosing, in each case, the reading that makes him greater. This is the pattern Act 2 will confirm: Calpurnia's dream and the priests' warning briefly frighten him, but as soon as Decius reinterprets the dream as a vision of Caesar's glory he goes to the Capitol. What he believes is whatever keeps Caesar 'Caesar'.

HISTORICAL RECORD. The ancient biographers give some support for this portrait. Suetonius presents Caesar as a man who was not deterred from his undertakings by religious scruple and who bent unfavourable omens to his own purposes; yet the same tradition records that he took the seer's warning seriously enough to joke about it on the fatal morning. Shakespeare seems to have read this mixture accurately.

PROFESSOR'S INSIGHT Why the Soothsayer appears so early

A school guide will tell you the Soothsayer 'creates suspense'. Ask the better question: why here, at the very start of the second scene, before a single word of conspiracy has been spoken? Consider what the placement does. Cassius has not yet approached Brutus; no plot exists on stage. Yet the date of Caesar's death is already announced. Shakespeare has therefore made fate arrive before free will. When Cassius says a few minutes later that men "are masters of their fates", the audience has already heard the calendar of a murder that no one has yet planned. The prophecy hangs over the persuasion scene and quietly asks: is Cassius the author of these events or their instrument? Second, the placement establishes Caesar's method of hearing before we see anything else of his mind. "Caesar is turned to hear" — he turns, he looks, he asks to hear it again; and then "He is a dreamer". The pattern of attention followed by dismissal is set in five lines, and Act 2 will repeat it at length. Third, notice who relays the message: Brutus. The man who will strike is the man who, unprompted, repeats the warning of his own future deed. The Soothsayer speaks to Caesar, but the play speaks through Brutus. A prophecy that early, that short, delivered through that mouth, is not suspense. It is structure.

The Soothsayer and "Beware the ides of March"**Original line / short passage:**

Caesar: *Who is it in the press that calls on me? / I hear a tongue shriller than all the music / Cry 'Caesar.' Speak. Caesar is turned to hear.*

Soothsayer: *Beware the ides of March.*

Caesar: *What man is that?*

Brutus: *A soothsayer bids you beware the ides of March.*

Caesar: *Set him before me. Let me see his face.*

Caesar: *What sayst thou to me now? Speak once again.*

Soothsayer: *Beware the ides of March.*

Caesar: *He is a dreamer. Let us leave him. Pass.*

Simple English: Who in this crowd is calling me? I can hear one voice, higher and sharper than all the music, shouting 'Caesar'. Speak: Caesar has turned round to listen. Soothsayer: Be on your guard on the fifteenth of March. Caesar: Who is that man? Brutus: A fortune-teller is telling you to be careful on the ides of March. Caesar: Bring him in front of me; I want to see his face. What are you saying to me now? Say it once more. Soothsayer: Be on your guard on the fifteenth of March. Caesar: He is a man who imagines things. Let us leave him. Move on.

Difficult words: 'press' — the crowd, the crush of people; 'shriller' — higher-pitched and more piercing; 'soothsayer' — literally a 'truth-sayer', one who foretells the future; 'ides' — in the Roman calendar the middle marker-day of the month, the fifteenth in March; 'Beware' — be on guard against; 'sayst' — sayest, do you say; 'dreamer' — one who sees visions, a fantasist; 'Pass' — move on, proceed.

Literal meaning: Caesar hears a single voice above the ceremonial music and asks who it is. The Soothsayer warns him to be careful on 15 March. Caesar has him brought forward, looks at his face, hears the warning repeated and dismisses him as a fantasist.

Subtext: Caesar's curiosity is real — he stops a procession for a voice — but it is the curiosity of a man who expects to be able to judge truth by looking at a face. Having looked, he decides. The dismissal is not argued; it is pronounced. Underneath lies a need to be seen not to flinch: a public warning must be publicly waved

away, or Caesar looks afraid.

Hidden meaning: The word "shriller" is telling. Caesar hears the Soothsayer as noise that rises above harmony, an unpleasant interruption of the music of his own celebration. He classifies the warning by its sound before he weighs its sense. "Let me see his face" reveals Caesar's theory of knowledge: character and truth can be read from appearance. He will apply the same theory, with more accuracy, to Cassius's "lean and hungry look" in Part Two — and it will fail him with Decius and Brutus.

Character psychology: Caesar is confident, curious and closed. He gives the man two chances to speak, which shows that he is not simply arrogant; he then decides against him in a single line, which shows that his openness has a very short life. The third-person "Caesar is turned to hear" shows a man performing himself. The Soothsayer's psychology is a blank, and that blankness is the point: he has no motive, no interest, no fear, only the sentence.

Political meaning: A ruler who cannot receive unwelcome information is a ruler whose advisers will learn to bring only welcome information. The scene stages, in miniature, why courts fail. It is also a moment where the crowd, so easily swayed in Scene 1, contains one voice that will not be swayed, and Caesar cannot tolerate it.

Historical context: Plutarch and Suetonius record that a seer (Suetonius names Spurinna) had warned Caesar to beware of danger coming no later than the ides of March, and that on the fatal morning Caesar mocked him: the Ides had come and nothing had happened, to which the seer replied that they had come but not yet gone. Shakespeare will dramatise that later exchange in Act 3; here he gives the warning without a name, which turns a historical individual into something closer to the voice of fate.

Literary devices: Dramatic irony (the audience knows what the Ides will bring); foreshadowing in its purest form — a prophecy; illeism ("Caesar is turned to hear"); the auditory image of a "tongue shriller than all the music"; repetition of the warning, which gives it the weight of an incantation; the curt monosyllable "Pass" as a verbal gesture of dismissal.

Effect: The festive music is pierced by a single sentence, repeated. The audience feels the calendar of the play start ticking. Caesar's dismissal produces the particular unease of watching a man walk past a sign he has read aloud.

Dramatic significance: This is the play's first prophecy and Caesar's first refusal of a warning; the two together define the tragic pattern of the first three acts. It also introduces the Soothsayer as a recurring figure who will meet Caesar again on the morning of the Ides and speak briefly with Portia in Act 2.

Foreshadowing: The date of the assassination is named. Caesar's habit of dismissing warnings is established and will govern his response to Calpurnia, the augurers and Artemidorus. The Soothsayer's own reappearance is prepared.

Scene connection: Brutus's relaying of the warning links him, ironically, to Caesar's death before Cassius has said a word. Caesar's face-reading here connects to his judgement of Cassius when he returns; his "dreamer" connects to Cicero's remark in Scene 3 that "men may construe things after their fashion" — Caesar construes the Soothsayer as a dreamer because that reading suits him.

ICSE keywords: dramatic irony, foreshadowing, omen, prophecy, hubris (with care), dismissal, fate versus free will, illeism.

Exam application: Asked how Caesar's reaction to the Soothsayer reveals his character, write: 'Caesar hears the warning twice, even calling "Let me see his face", yet dismisses the man as "a dreamer" — showing a ruler curious enough to listen but too proud to be seen taking a stranger's warning seriously in public. The audience, knowing what the ides of March will bring, hears dramatic irony in every word.'

Caesar's public image versus his private characteristics as seen so far

Draw up two columns in your mind. In the public column: a man whose name silences a crowd; who speaks in imperatives; whose consul says that whatever "Caesar says" is "performed"; who stops a procession to look a heckler in the face and dismisses him without a tremor; whom Cassius will sarcastically call "immortal Caesar" and describe as having "become a god". In the private column, so far: a husband who cannot father a child and hopes a ritual will help; a man who needs to say "Caesar is turned to hear" rather than 'I am listening'; and — through Cassius's hostile stories — a man who once cried "Help me, Cassius, or I sink!" and who, shaking with fever, begged for a drink "As a sick girl".

LITERARY INTERPRETATION. The scene's method is to build the public column on stage and the private column through report. That asymmetry matters. We see Caesar's greatness directly; we hear about his weakness from a man who hates him. So the audience is not told that Caesar is weak; it is invited to wonder whether the greatness is a performance and whether Cassius's stories are true. Part Two will add evidence from a neutral-hostile witness, Casca — the swoon, the "falling sickness" — and from Caesar himself, who admits that "this ear is deaf". By the end of the scene, both columns are full, and the question 'which Caesar is real?' has become the play's question. For the full portrait, go to 'Caesar in Act 1 — A Character Masterclass'.

5. The Seduction of Brutus: Cassius's First Approach

The word 'seduction' is chosen carefully. Cassius will use it himself at the end of the scene — "For who so firm that cannot be seduced?" — and it captures what happens here better than 'persuasion'. Persuasion works on reasons; seduction works on the self. Cassius barely argues about Caesar until Brutus has already confessed his fear. What he does first is make Brutus look at Brutus.

Brutus — "I am not gamesome"

Original line / short passage:

Cassius: *Will you go see the order of the course?*

Brutus: *Not I.*

Brutus: *I am not gamesome. I do lack some part / Of that quick spirit that is in Antony. / Let me not hinder, Cassius, your desires. / I'll leave you.*

Simple English: Cassius: Will you come and watch the race? Brutus: Not me. I am not fond of sport; I lack some of that lively energy that Antony has. Do not let me stop you doing what you want, Cassius. I will leave you.

Difficult words: 'order of the course' — the proceedings of the race; 'gamesome' — fond of games and sport, playful; 'quick spirit' — lively, energetic temperament; 'hinder' — obstruct; 'desires' — wishes.

Literal meaning: Brutus declines to watch the games, explaining that he is not the sporting type and lacks Antony's liveliness, and he politely tries to leave.

Subtext: Brutus wants solitude. His comparison with Antony is more than modesty; it separates him from the pleasure-loving, physically vigorous world that surrounds Caesar. Cassius's invitation is a test: had Brutus gone to the games, there would have been no conversation.

Hidden meaning: The line quietly divides Rome into two temperaments — the "gamesome" men who run and revel with Caesar, and the reflective men who stand apart and think. Caesar himself will make the same division in Part Two when he says Cassius "loves no plays" and "hears no music". Brutus places himself,

without knowing it, in the dangerous category.

Character psychology: Brutus is honest about a limitation and courteous in withdrawal — two traits that never leave him. He is also, at this moment, slightly withdrawn and low in spirits; a man preoccupied.

Political meaning: In a city where the ruler's favourites are men of appetite and display, the sober man who refuses the festival is already a kind of dissident, even before he dissents.

Historical context: Plutarch's Brutus is studious and philosophical, a reader and a writer of compressed Latin, close to the Stoic tradition through his uncle Cato; Shakespeare's "not gamesome" is a faithful distillation. The historical Antony's reputation for revelry is also well attested.

Literary devices: Contrast (Brutus against Antony); understatement ("some part"), which is characteristic of Brutus's modest self-description.

Effect: The audience registers Brutus as different from the crowd and from Caesar's circle before he has said anything political. The stage empties around two men who did not go to the party.

Dramatic significance: This refusal is the hinge of the scene: it creates the private space in which the conspiracy is conceived. It also introduces the Brutus–Antony contrast that will structure Act 3, when the man without "quick spirit" speaks to the crowd first and the quick-spirited man speaks second, and wins.

Foreshadowing: The comparison with Antony foreshadows their rivalry over the crowd and Brutus's fatal underestimation of Antony as a mere reveller.

Scene connection: Caesar's judgement of Cassius in Part Two — a man who "loves no plays" — echoes Brutus's self-description here; Caesar's instinct about un-gamesome men is right, though he aims it at the wrong one.

ICSE keywords: contrast, characterisation, foil (Antony as a foil to Brutus), introspection.

Exam application: 'Brutus's admission that he is "not gamesome" and lacks Antony's "quick spirit" establishes him as a reflective, withdrawn man — the opposite of Caesar's pleasure-loving favourite — and it is this withdrawal from the games that gives Cassius his opportunity.'

Cassius's opening approach

Original line / short passage:

Cassius: *Brutus, I do observe you now of late. / I have not from your eyes that gentleness / And show of love as I was wont to have. / You bear too stubborn and too strange a hand / Over your friend that loves you.*

Simple English: Brutus, I have been watching you recently. I no longer see in your eyes the kindness and the signs of affection I used to receive from you. You are treating your friend, who loves you, too harshly and too coldly.

Difficult words: 'observe' — watch closely; 'of late' — recently; 'show of love' — outward signs of friendship; 'wont' — accustomed; 'stubborn' — harsh, unyielding; 'strange' — distant, like a stranger; 'bear... a hand over' — to handle, control (an image from managing a horse by the reins, as many editors note).

Literal meaning: Cassius complains that Brutus has recently become cold and distant towards him, a friend who loves him.

Subtext: This is an accusation dressed as a hurt. Cassius does not ask 'what is troubling you?'; he says 'you have wronged me'. A courteous man like Brutus must now defend himself, and to defend himself he must explain — which is exactly what Cassius wants. Note also "I do observe you": Cassius announces that Brutus is under observation.

Hidden meaning: The opening move of the whole conspiracy is a complaint about the "show of love". The play's politics begin in the vocabulary of friendship, and the word 'show' — appearance, display — introduces the theme of appearance and reality on Cassius's own lips. He asks for shows; Brutus, in reply, will confess that he has been forgetting the "shows of love".

Character psychology: Cassius is a watcher (Caesar will say so: "He is a great observer"). He has noticed a change in Brutus and has decided that the change is an opening. His hurt may be partly genuine — the text does not exclude real affection — but it is deployed with precision.

Political meaning: Conspiracies require trust, and trust is built by the language of intimacy. Cassius is establishing that he has a claim on Brutus before he asks anything of him.

Historical context: Plutarch reports that Brutus and Cassius had been estranged over the competition for the more prestigious praetorship of 44 BC, which Caesar awarded to Brutus, and that Cassius sought a reconciliation before approaching Brutus about Caesar. Shakespeare leaves the praetorship out of this scene and converts the reconciliation into a complaint about coldness.

Literary devices: Metaphor of horsemanship in "bear... a hand" (interpretation, not certainty); the emotional appeal of "your friend that loves you" placed at the line-end for emphasis.

Effect: The audience sees a friend reproaching a friend and only gradually realises it is watching a recruitment.

Dramatic significance: It sets the pattern of Cassius's method: begin with Brutus, not with Caesar; begin with feeling, not with argument.

Foreshadowing: The quarrel between the two men in Act 4 will again begin with each accusing the other of wronging a friend; the friendship that starts as a tool becomes, by the end, real.

Scene connection: Cassius's soliloquy at the end of this scene ("Caesar doth bear me hard, but he loves Brutus") reveals that he thinks in terms of who loves whom; his opening here is consistent with that mind.

ICSE keywords: manipulation, emotional appeal, appearance versus reality, friendship, observer.

Exam application: 'Cassius opens not with politics but with a reproach — Brutus no longer shows "that gentleness / And show of love" he once did — forcing the courteous Brutus to explain himself and so handing Cassius the opening he needs.'

Brutus's internal conflict — "passions of some difference", "with himself at war"

Original line / short passage:

Brutus: *Be not deceived. If I have veiled my look, / I turn the trouble of my countenance / Merely upon myself. Vexèd I am / Of late with passions of some difference, / Conceptions only proper to myself, / Which give some soil, perhaps, to my behaviors.*

Brutus: *Nor construe any further my neglect / Than that poor Brutus, with himself at war, / Forgets the shows of love to other men.*

Simple English: Do not misunderstand me. If I have hidden my expression, the trouble in my face is aimed only at myself. Lately I have been troubled by conflicting feelings, thoughts that concern me alone, which perhaps stain my behaviour. Do not read my neglect as anything more than this: poor Brutus, fighting a war inside himself, forgets to show affection to other people.

Difficult words: 'veiled my look' — hidden my expression; 'countenance' — face, expression; 'Vexèd' — troubled, distressed; 'passions of some difference' — conflicting emotions, feelings at odds with one another; 'Conceptions' — thoughts, ideas; 'proper to myself' — belonging to me alone, private; 'soil' — stain, blemish; 'construe' — interpret; 'neglect' — failure of attention to friends; 'shows of love' — outward signs of friendship.

Literal meaning: Brutus reassures Cassius that his coldness is not aimed at him. He is troubled by private, conflicting feelings that have spoiled his manners, and he asks his friends not to read anything more into it.

Subtext: Brutus is telling the truth and concealing it at the same time. He confirms that something is wrong, admits it is a conflict, and refuses to say what it is. To Cassius, this is the best possible answer: a divided Brutus is a recruitable Brutus.

Hidden meaning: "with himself at war" is the most important phrase in Brutus's first long speech. He reaches for the vocabulary of war to describe his mind, in a scene where nobody has yet mentioned violence. The word arrives before the thing. Notice, too, the third person: "poor Brutus". Like Caesar, Brutus has begun to speak of himself as a public figure, a name — the very habit Cassius will exploit when he weighs the names 'Brutus' and 'Caesar'.

Character psychology: Brutus is introspective, scrupulous and secretive. He apologises for a discourtesy he has not really committed; he shields his friends from his moods; and he presents his conflict as a fault of manners rather than a matter of politics. The "passions of some difference" are, we infer, love for Caesar against fear for Rome, but Brutus will not name them even to himself for another act.

Political meaning: The inner division of Rome's most honourable man is the state's division in miniature. A republic whose best citizen cannot decide what he thinks about its ruler is a republic that will be decided by someone less scrupulous.

Historical context: Plutarch describes Brutus in the months before the Ides as sleepless and visibly troubled, so much so that his wife Porcia noticed. Shakespeare transfers that observed trouble to the eyes of Cassius.

Literary devices: Metaphor ("with himself at war"; "veiled my look"; "give some soil"); illeism ("poor Brutus"); inversion ("Vexèd I am") that throws weight on the emotion; the deliberately abstract diction of "passions of some difference" and "Conceptions only proper to myself", which is Brutus's way of naming a thing without naming it.

Effect: The audience learns that Brutus is troubled before it learns why, and is drawn into the same curiosity as Cassius.

Dramatic significance: This speech is the first sight of Brutus's mind, and the phrase it leaves behind — "with himself at war" — becomes the frame for his whole tragedy.

Foreshadowing: Foreshadows the orchard soliloquy of Act 2, where the war is fought in words; the quarrel of Act 4, where the war spills between friends; and the civil war itself.

Scene connection: Cassius's soliloquy at the end of the scene turns this speech into a plan: a man "with himself at war" is a man whose "honourable mettle may be wrought" — a nature that can be shaped.

ICSE keywords: internal conflict, introspection, secrecy, illeism, foreshadowing, private versus public.

Exam application: 'Brutus's confession that he is "with himself at war", troubled by "passions of some difference", reveals the divided conscience that defines him: he already feels the conflict between love for Caesar and duty to Rome, though he will not yet name it, and the military metaphor foreshadows the literal war his decision will bring.'

PROFESSOR'S INSIGHT Why Shakespeare connects private emotion with public politics

Here is something a summary will never tell you. Shakespeare has Brutus describe a private mood — a bad temper, a coldness to friends — in the language of war, and he does it in the one scene where Rome's public future is being decided offstage by shouting crowds. The private and the public are made to speak the same words. Why? Because the play's central claim about politics is that the state is not a machine but a body of persons, and that its convulsions begin as convulsions inside individual men. Brutus's war "with himself" will become the war between Brutus and Cassius, then the war between the conspirators and the triumvirs. Rome will bleed because one man could not reconcile two feelings. Shakespeare presses the parallel throughout: Cassius's political grievance is described as a personal humiliation (he must "bend his body" if Caesar nods); Caesar's political stubbornness is a personal vanity; the crowd's public verdict on the crown is a matter of shouts and "sweaty nightcaps". The lesson for your reading is practical. Whenever a character in this play describes an emotion, ask what public consequence that emotion is about to have; and whenever a public event occurs, ask which private feeling produced it. That double reading is what an examiner means by 'analysis'.

The mirror and the glass: the play's theory of self-knowledge

Original line / short passage:

Cassius: *Tell me, good Brutus, can you see your face?*

Brutus: *No, Cassius, for the eye sees not itself / But by reflection, by some other things.*

Cassius: *And it is very much lamented, Brutus, / That you have no such mirrors as will turn / Your hidden worthiness into your eye, / That you might see your shadow.*

Cassius: *And since you know you cannot see yourself / So well as by reflection, I, your glass, / Will modestly discover to yourself / That of yourself which you yet know not of.*

Simple English: Cassius: Tell me, Brutus, can you see your own face? Brutus: No, because the eye cannot see itself except in a reflection, in something else. Cassius: Exactly. And many people regret that you have no mirror to show your hidden worth to your own eye, so that you could see your own image. Since you know you can only see yourself by reflection, I will be your mirror, and modestly reveal to you the side of yourself you do not yet know.

Difficult words: 'reflection' — a mirrored image; 'lamented' — regretted, mourned; 'hidden worthiness' — unrecognised merit; 'shadow' — reflected image (an older sense; the word also carried its modern sense, which the play lets us hear); 'glass' — mirror; 'modestly' — without exaggeration; 'discover' — reveal, uncover.

Literal meaning: Cassius draws Brutus into agreeing that no one can see himself directly, then offers to be the mirror that shows Brutus his own hidden greatness, which many respected Romans, he claims, wish Brutus could see.

Subtext: This is a piece of logic with a trap in it. Brutus supplies the harmless premise (the eye cannot see itself); Cassius supplies the conclusion (therefore trust me to tell you who you are). Between the two lies the claim that "many of the best respect in Rome" wish Brutus "had his eyes" — that is, could see what they see. Cassius makes himself the channel of Rome's opinion, precisely what the forged letters will do in writing.

Hidden meaning: A mirror shows you reversed, and it shows only what is placed before it. Cassius's mirror is angled: it will show Brutus the nobility that Cassius wants him to act upon, and hide the treason that the action involves. The word "shadow" is double-edged. In Shakespeare's English it means a reflection; but a shadow is also the dark shape a body casts, and an audience may hear that Cassius is offering to show Brutus his shadow side. "Modestly" is itself immodest: the man who says he will be modest is about to compare Brutus with Caesar.

Character psychology: Cassius here is at his most intelligent. He has understood that Brutus cannot be moved by an attack on Caesar but can be moved by an appeal to his own image of himself. He flatters not with praise but with the suggestion of unrecognised worth, which is far more effective on a modest man. Brutus's response — "Into what dangers would you lead me, Cassius, / That you would have me seek into myself / For that which is not in me?" — shows a man who senses the trap, names the danger, and still keeps listening.

Political meaning: Political recruitment in the play works by supplying men with a picture of themselves. The people in Scene 1 were given a picture of ingratitude by the tribunes; Brutus is given a picture of hidden greatness by Cassius; the crowd in Act 3 will be given competing pictures by Brutus and Antony. Whoever holds the mirror holds power.

Historical context: The idea that the eye cannot see itself was a commonplace of Renaissance thought, and the mirror was a favourite Tudor image for instruction: the popular collection of cautionary verse tragedies called *A Mirror for Magistrates* (first printed in 1559) offered rulers examples in which to see themselves. Elizabethan audiences may have heard Cassius offering Brutus exactly such a mirror.

Literary devices: Extended metaphor (eye, reflection, mirror, glass, shadow); rhetorical question used as a trap ("can you see your face?"); aphorism ("the eye sees not itself / But by reflection"); wordplay on "shadow"; irony in "modestly".

Effect: The audience watches a mind being opened with a key made of its own logic. There is intellectual pleasure and dread at once.

Dramatic significance: This passage is the method of the whole conspiracy in one image. It also introduces the theme of self-knowledge that the tragedy will pursue: Brutus never does see himself fully, and his errors of judgement come from trusting reflections — Cassius's, the letters', his own idealised image.

Foreshadowing: Foreshadows the forged letters, which are written mirrors; and the wider pattern in which Brutus acts on how Rome supposedly sees him rather than on what he sees himself.

Scene connection: Connects directly to Cassius's soliloquy ("Writings, all tending to the great opinion / That Rome holds of his name") and to the letters delivered in Scene 3 and read in Act 2.

ICSE keywords: extended metaphor, flattery, self-knowledge, manipulation, appearance versus reality, irony.

Exam application: 'By making himself Brutus's mirror — "I, your glass" — Cassius turns a harmless truth — that "the eye sees not itself / But by reflection" — into a claim on Brutus's trust: only Cassius can show Brutus his "hidden worthiness". The flattery works because it appeals not to vanity but to modesty, and it prepares the forged letters that will play the same role in writing.'

PROFESSOR'S INSIGHT The mirror as the play's theory of self-knowledge

Take the mirror passage seriously as philosophy, not just as flattery. Brutus states a real truth: no one sees his own face directly. We know ourselves through reflections — through what others tell us, what we read of ourselves in their eyes, the reputation that returns to us as report. Julius Caesar is a play in which almost everyone lives by such reflections. Caesar knows himself through the crowd's shouts and the flattery of Decius. Brutus knows himself through Cassius's mirror and then through letters that seem to come from Rome. The crowd knows what it thinks through whoever spoke to it last. The tragedy is not that people trust mirrors; it is that every mirror in the play is held by someone with a motive. Cassius's genius, and his corruption, lie in the phrase "I, your glass": he offers to become the instrument through which Brutus perceives himself, and Brutus accepts. From that moment Brutus's self-image — the descendant of the liberator, the man of honour Rome is waiting for — is partly Cassius's construction. When, in Act 2, Brutus reads the planted letters and hears in them Rome's voice, he is looking into the same angled glass. Shakespeare is proposing something unsettling: that the honourable man is more vulnerable than the cynic, because he believes the reflection shows his duty. Cassius, who trusts no mirror, cannot be flattered; Brutus, who wants to be worthy, can. Keep this in mind whenever an examiner asks why a noble man did a terrible thing.

The shout offstage and Brutus's admission

Before the shout, Cassius has been protesting his own sincerity: he is no "common laughter" (Folger; the MIT text reads 'laugher', a habitual joker), he does not "stale with ordinary oaths" his love, he does not "fawn on men and hug them hard / And after scandal them" — and if Brutus ever finds him doing such things, "then hold me dangerous". The audience, who will shortly hear Caesar call this very man dangerous, enjoys the irony. Then the stage direction — in single quotes, 'Flourish and shout' — breaks in.

Original line / short passage:

Brutus: *What means this shouting? I do fear the people / Choose Caesar for their king.*

Cassius: *Ay, do you fear it? / Then must I think you would not have it so.*

Brutus: *I would not, Cassius, yet I love him well. / But wherefore do you hold me here so long? / What is it that you would impart to me?*

Simple English: Brutus: What is that shouting about? I am afraid the people are choosing Caesar as their king. Cassius: Oh, you fear it? Then I must conclude you would not want it to happen. Brutus: I would not want it, Cassius — and yet I love him dearly. But why are you keeping me here so long? What is it you want to tell me?

Difficult words: 'means' — signifies; 'fear' — am afraid; 'Choose' — elect, make; 'have it so' — wish it to be so; 'wherefore' — why; 'impart' — communicate, tell.

Literal meaning: Hearing the crowd, Brutus voices his fear that Caesar is being made king. Cassius seizes on the word 'fear' to establish that Brutus opposes it. Brutus agrees, adds that he loves Caesar, and asks Cassius to come to the point.

Subtext: Cassius has said nothing about Caesar; Brutus raises him unprompted. That is the moment Cassius has been waiting for, and his reply is a small masterpiece of pressure: he converts an emotion ('fear') into a position ('you would not have it so') and makes Brutus confirm it. Brutus's "yet I love him well" is a plea for the conversation to remain complicated; Cassius will ignore it.

Hidden meaning: The shout is heard, not understood. Brutus interprets it in the direction of his fear. We learn later that the crowd was cheering Caesar's refusal of the crown; Brutus's fear ran ahead of the facts. Shakespeare shows how an anxious mind reads ambiguous sounds, and how a manipulator uses the reading rather than correcting it.

Character psychology: Brutus's mind holds two loyalties at once and states them in one line, with the tiny hinge "yet": "I would not, Cassius, yet I love him well." The whole tragedy of Brutus is in that sentence. His impatience ("wherefore do you hold me here so long?") is not rudeness; it is the discomfort of a man who wants a painful subject either dropped or made explicit.

Political meaning: The republic's fate is being decided by an offstage crowd whose shouts cannot be interpreted. Two senators stand at the edge, guessing. This is the political condition of the whole play: decisions made in public noise, interpreted in private fear.

Historical context: The historical Brutus had been pardoned by Caesar after siding with Pompey and had been advanced by him to the urban praetorship; the "love" he speaks of has a real basis in obligation. The fear of the title 'king' was a genuine Roman reflex dating from the expulsion of the Tarquins.

Literary devices: Dramatic irony (we will learn the shout meant the opposite); antithesis in "I would not... yet I love him well"; the sound effect of the offstage shout as a structural device; Cassius's rhetorical echo ("Ay, do you fear it?").

Effect: The audience feels the conversation lurch from generalities to the forbidden subject. Tension rises with the noise.

Dramatic significance: Brutus's fear and love, spoken in one breath, give Cassius his target and give the audience the terms of Brutus's dilemma. Nothing Cassius says afterwards would matter if Brutus had not said this.

Foreshadowing: Foreshadows the orchard soliloquy, where Brutus reasons from exactly this fear (Caesar may be crowned; a crown may change him) to the decision to kill; and the funeral speech, where he tells the crowd he loved Caesar.

Scene connection: Casca's report in Part Two tells us what the shout meant; Cassius's "They shouted thrice" shows he was counting. Brutus's misreading anticipates Cassius's own fatal misreading of a shout at Philippi.

ICSE keywords: dramatic irony, conflict of loyalties, ambiguity, offstage action, manipulation, republicanism.

Exam application: 'When the crowd shouts, Brutus admits "I do fear the people / Choose Caesar for their king" and immediately adds "yet I love him well" — the single line that contains his whole dilemma. Cassius seizes on the word "fear" to make Brutus confirm his opposition, showing how he converts Brutus's emotion into a political commitment.'

PROFESSOR'S INSIGHT Why Shakespeare lets us hear the shouting but not see the crown

Shakespeare had the crown scene ready-made in Plutarch, and it is spectacular: a consul running through the city, a diadem held up, a dictator refusing, a crowd roaring. He chose not to stage it. Ask why, and refuse the lazy answer about a small company. First, keeping the crown offstage keeps the stage for Brutus's reaction. The scene is not about whether Caesar gets a crown; it is about what the possibility does to Brutus, and Shakespeare wants our eyes on his face when the shout comes. Second, the offstage crown puts the audience in Brutus's position. We too hear noise and must guess; when Casca later explains, we too discover we misread. The play thus trains us in its central lesson — that public events reach us as sounds and reports, coloured by the fears of the hearer and the bias of the reporter. Third, the crown never appears on stage at all. The play's most important object is an absence. Caesar's kingship remains, for the whole tragedy, a matter of rumour, fear and interpretation, never a fact; the conspirators kill him for what he might become. By denying us the sight of the crown, Shakespeare denies us certainty about Caesar's ambition, and forces us to judge the murder without the evidence the murderers claim to have. That is a far more disturbing design than any spectacle.

Honour — "Set honour in one eye and death i' th' other"**Original line / short passage:**

Brutus: *If it be aught toward the general good, / Set honour in one eye and death i' th' other / And I will look on both indifferently; / For let the gods so speed me as I love / The name of honour more than I fear death.*

Cassius: *I know that virtue to be in you, Brutus, / As well as I do know your outward favour. / Well, honour is the subject of my story.*

Simple English: Brutus: If what you want to say concerns the public good, then put honour before one of my eyes and death before the other, and I will look at both without preferring either; for — may the gods favour me only as far as this is true — I love the name of honour more than I fear death. Cassius: I know you have that quality, Brutus, as surely as I know your face. Well then, honour is what my story is about.

Difficult words: 'aught' — anything; 'toward' — concerning, tending to; 'general good' — the public welfare, the good of all; 'indifferently' — impartially, without preferring one; 'so speed me' — so prosper me, so favour me (an oath formula); 'the name of honour' — honour itself, or the reputation of honour; 'virtue' — quality, excellence; 'outward favour' — face, appearance.

Literal meaning: Brutus declares that if the matter concerns Rome's welfare he will weigh honour against death without flinching, because he values honour above life. Cassius says he knew this, and announces that honour is his theme.

Subtext: Brutus is setting conditions — it must be "toward the general good" — but in setting them he tells Cassius exactly which key fits the lock. Cassius's reply is almost comic in its speed: "honour is the subject of my story". He has not chosen his subject; Brutus has chosen it for him.

Hidden meaning: Look at "the name of honour". Brutus does not say he loves honour; he loves the name of it. Many critics read this as an unconscious confession that Brutus is attached to his reputation, to being seen as honourable, as much as to the thing itself. The text leaves it open, but the phrase is a gift to Cassius, who is about to argue entirely in terms of names. Notice also "indifferently": Brutus claims he can look on death and honour without preference — a claim of Stoic detachment that the frightened, sleepless Brutus of Act 2 will not quite sustain.

Character psychology: Brutus's self-image is now fully visible: a man for whom the moral quality of an act, and the public good, outrank his life. This is sincere, and it is also his vulnerability, because a man who has announced that he fears nothing for honour's sake has left himself no honourable way to refuse an honourable-sounding proposal.

Political meaning: Republican virtue, in the Roman sense, meant putting the *res publica* — the public thing — above private life and private feeling. Brutus states the creed in one sentence. Cassius, who has just said he would rather not exist than live in awe of a man like himself, has a different creed: personal dignity. Their alliance is built on the overlap between these two ideas of honour, and their quarrel in Act 4 comes from the gap.

Historical context: The historical Brutus was associated with philosophy and with his uncle Cato, the republican who chose death over submission to Caesar; Brutus's language of honour and indifference to death echoes that tradition, which Shakespeare found in Plutarch.

Literary devices: Antithesis and visual metaphor ("honour in one eye and death i' th' other" — two abstract nouns personified as objects to be looked at); oath formula ("let the gods so speed me"); repetition of "honour", which Cassius immediately picks up — a rhetorical hand-over.

Effect: The audience hears Brutus's terms with respect and with dread, because the phrase "death i' th' other" is spoken in a play whose ending it knows.

Dramatic significance: This is the hinge between Cassius's flattery and his attack on Caesar. Brutus has now supplied the moral framework within which the murder will be argued: honour, the general good, indifference to death.

Foreshadowing: Foreshadows Brutus's speech to the people after the assassination, built on honour and the good of Rome; Antony's ironic repetition of the word in the funeral oration; and Brutus's death at Philippi, where honour and death are indeed looked on together.

Scene connection: Cassius's soliloquy calls Brutus's temperament "honourable mettle" that "may be wrought"; this speech is the moment Cassius learns exactly what that metal is made of.

ICSE keywords: honour, republican virtue, antithesis, Stoicism, the general good, foreshadowing, vulnerability.

Exam application: 'Brutus's declaration that he loves "The name of honour more than I fear death" defines his character and his tragedy: it is sincere republican virtue, but it also tells Cassius precisely which argument will move him, and Cassius replies at once that "honour is the subject of my story".'

CASSIUS'S FIRST APPROACH — MOVE BY MOVE

The table follows the conversation from the exit of the procession to Caesar's return. It shows the surface move, the goal beneath it, and Brutus's response. The full analysis of Cassius's method — its psychology, its rhetoric, its ethics — is in the chapter 'Cassius — The Manipulation Masterclass'; use this table as the map of this one conversation.

Move	What Cassius says (in essence)	What he wants	How Brutus responds
1	Invites Brutus to watch the race: "Will you go see the order of the course?"	To find out whether Brutus is in a festive or a brooding mood	Declines: "I am not gamesome" — and tries to leave
2	Reproaches Brutus for coldness to "your friend that loves you"	To make Brutus explain himself and re-establish intimacy	Apologises; admits he is "with himself at war" but keeps the cause private

Move	What Cassius says (in essence)	What he wants	How Brutus responds
3	Claims he has buried "Thoughts of great value" because of Brutus's coldness	To create curiosity and a sense of missed confidences	Listens; asks nothing yet
4	Asks "can you see your face?" and offers to be "your glass"	To make Brutus receptive to an outside account of his own worth	Senses danger: "Into what dangers would you lead me" — but does not leave
5	Reports that "the best respect in Rome" wish Brutus "had his eyes"	To present the conspiracy's wish as Rome's wish	Silent; the shout interrupts
6	Protests his own sincerity ("then hold me dangerous")	To pre-empt suspicion of flattery	—
7	Echoes Brutus's word: "Ay, do you fear it?"	To turn Brutus's fear into a stated position against Caesar's kingship	Confirms it: "I would not... yet I love him well"
8	Adopts Brutus's term: "honour is the subject of my story"	To frame everything that follows as honourable	Has already offered the frame; waits
9	Declares equality with Caesar: "I was born free as Caesar; so were you"	To reduce Caesar from god to peer	Listens
10	Tells the Tiber story and the fever story	To make Caesar physically contemptible and Brutus's love embarrassing	Interrupts only to note the second shout
11	The Colossus image; "The fault... is not in our stars"	To shame Brutus's passivity and assert free will	Listens
12	Weighs the names 'Brutus' and 'Caesar'	To make Brutus feel he is Caesar's equal in worth	Listens
13	Invokes the ancestral Brutus who would not have "brook'd" a king	To turn family pride into political obligation	Replies at last: "What you would work me to, I have some aim"
14	Accepts the delay gracefully: "my weak words / Have struck but thus much show of fire"	To bank the gain and avoid overpressing	Has promised to consider and to answer later

6. Cassius's Case Against Caesar: Two Stories and a Statue

Once Brutus has named honour as his price, Cassius changes method. Until now he has worked on Brutus's image of himself; from here he works on Brutus's image of Caesar. He does it not with political argument — he never once mentions a law, a tax, a legion or the Senate — but with two anecdotes and one picture: a swimming race, a sickbed, and a giant statue. Every one of them attacks the same target: the gap between the Caesar that Rome worships and the body of the man Cassius has seen up close. Hold on to this as you read. Cassius is not trying to prove that Caesar is a tyrant. He is trying to make Brutus feel that it is absurd — physically, bodily absurd — for a man like Brutus to bow to a man like that.

He opens with a creed, and you should know it before the story begins. "I cannot tell what you and other men / Think of this life; but, for my single self, / I had as lief not be as live to be / In awe of such a thing as I myself." In plain English: I do not know how you or anyone else feels about living, but speaking only for myself, I would as soon not exist as live in fear of a creature no different from me. ('Had as lief' means 'would as willingly'; 'such a thing as I myself' means 'a being of the same kind as me'.) Then the claim of equality: "I

was born free as Caesar; so were you; / We both have fed as well, and we can both / Endure the winter's cold as well as he." Notice how the three verbs — born, fed, endure — reduce Caesar to a biological specimen: birth, food, weather. That is the register in which the whole attack will be conducted.

Cassius's Tiber anecdote and the Aeneas/Anchises allusion

Original line / short passage:

Cassius: *For once, upon a raw and gusty day, / The troubled Tiber chafing with her shores, / Caesar said to me 'Dar'st thou, Cassius, now / Leap in with me into this angry flood / And swim to yonder point?' Upon the word, / Accoutred as I was, I plunged in / And bade him follow; so indeed he did.*

Cassius: *But ere we could arrive the point proposed, / Caesar cried 'Help me, Cassius, or I sink!' / I, as Aeneas, our great ancestor, / Did from the flames of Troy upon his shoulder / The old Anchises bear, so from the waves of Tiber / Did I the tirèd Caesar. And this man / Is now become a god, and Cassius is / A wretched creature and must bend his body / If Caesar carelessly but nod on him.*

Simple English: Once, on a cold, windy day, when the rough Tiber was beating angrily against its banks, Caesar said to me, 'Cassius, do you dare jump into this raging river with me now and swim to that point over there?' The moment he said it, I jumped in fully dressed and armed, and told him to follow — and he did. But before we could reach the agreed spot, Caesar shouted, 'Help me, Cassius, or I'll drown!' And just as Aeneas, the ancestor of all Romans, carried his old father Anchises on his shoulder out of burning Troy, so I carried the exhausted Caesar out of the Tiber. And this is the man who has now become a god, while Cassius is a miserable creature who must bow if Caesar so much as nods carelessly in his direction.

Difficult words: 'raw' — cold and damp; 'gusty' — windy; 'troubled' — rough, agitated; 'chafing with her shores' — rubbing angrily against its banks (the river is imagined as a woman, 'her'); 'Dar'st thou' — do you dare; 'angry flood' — the raging river; 'yonder point' — that spot over there; 'Upon the word' — the instant he said it; 'Accoutred' — dressed and equipped, in armour and clothing (which would weigh a swimmer down); 'plungèd' — two syllables, for the rhythm; 'bade' — told, commanded; 'ere' — before; 'arrive the point proposed' — reach the agreed goal; 'Aeneas' — the Trojan hero and legendary founder of the Roman race; 'Anchises' — Aeneas's aged father; 'tirèd' — two syllables; 'wretched' — miserable, pitiable; 'bend his body' — bow; 'carelessly' — casually, without even noticing; 'nod on him' — nod towards him.

Literal meaning: Cassius recalls a swimming challenge Caesar issued on a stormy day. Cassius accepted at once; Caesar followed but gave up and cried for help; Cassius carried him to shore as Aeneas carried his father out of Troy. Now that same rescued man is treated as a god, and his rescuer must bow to him.

Subtext: The surface is a story about courage; the subtext is a story about debt and reversal. Cassius was the stronger man and the saviour; the natural order, as he sees it, has been turned upside down. The real complaint is not 'Caesar is weak' but 'Caesar is weaker than I am, and yet I bow'. Listen to the rhythm of the verbs at the end — "become a god", "must bend his body", "but nod" — the climax of the speech is Cassius's own humiliation, not Caesar's failure.

Hidden meaning: The Aeneas comparison is doing more than decorating the story. Aeneas carried his *father*; by casting himself as Aeneas, Cassius casts Caesar as a helpless old parent, a burden on younger shoulders. It is a quietly contemptuous image, because it turns the saviour of Rome into dead weight. At the same time, the allusion flatters Cassius: he claims the founding hero's role, the man who carried Rome's future out of a burning past. One strong reading is that Cassius unconsciously reveals his own ambition here — he too would like to be Rome's bearer and founder. Notice also the opposition of elements: Aeneas rescued his father from fire, Cassius rescued Caesar from water. The two great destroying elements frame one man's greatness as borrowed.

Character psychology: Cassius is a man who keeps accounts. He remembers the exact day's weather, the exact words of the challenge, the exact moment Caesar cried out. This is the memory of a man who has turned the episode over for years, nursing it. His bitterness is personal before it is political; the words "wretched creature" are said of himself, and they hurt. Caesar, in the story, is impulsive (he issues a dare), proud (he will not be out-dared) and finally dependent — a portrait that anticipates the Caesar we see later, who insists on going to the Capitol because he will not seem afraid.

Political meaning: This is the republican argument in its most intimate form: rulers are men, their bodies fail like ours, and the worship of one man by his equals is a lie about nature. The phrase "bend his body" turns the question of monarchy into a question of posture — whether a free Roman will bow. In Rome the bow belonged to the East, to the courts of kings; a Roman who bowed had, in his own eyes, stopped being Roman.

Historical context: HISTORICAL RECORD: there is no swimming race with Cassius in Plutarch or any other ancient source; this story appears to be Shakespeare's invention. What the sources do record is that Caesar was a famously strong swimmer — Plutarch and Suetonius both tell how, during the fighting at Alexandria, he swam to safety holding papers out of the water. Shakespeare therefore seems to have taken a known strength of the historical Caesar and reversed it in Cassius's mouth. That tells you something important about how to read the speech: it is Cassius's testimony, not the play's verdict. The Aeneas story comes from Virgil's Aeneid, where Aeneas carries his father Anchises from burning Troy; the Romans, including Caesar's own family, the Julii, claimed descent from Aeneas — which gives Cassius's comparison an extra sting, since he borrows Caesar's own ancestral boast.

Literary devices: Classical allusion (Aeneas and Anchises); extended simile ("as Aeneas... so from the waves of Tiber / Did I"); personification of the river ("troubled Tiber chafing with her shores", "angry flood"); direct speech embedded in narrative, which makes the memory vivid and lets Cassius mimic Caesar's cry; antithesis between "a god" and "A wretched creature"; the bitter irony of "this man / Is now become a god"; alliteration in "bend his body".

Effect: The audience is drawn into a gripping little story and then ambushed by its moral. For a moment Caesar is not the voice that silenced the crowd but a frightened swimmer shouting for help. The effect is to make the audience, like Brutus, see the god's body — and then to feel the sourness of the narrator, which is Shakespeare's safeguard against our believing him entirely.

Dramatic significance: This is the first attack on Caesar's person in the play, and it sets the terms: not 'what has Caesar done?' but 'what is Caesar made of?'. It also discloses the real engine of the conspiracy as Shakespeare presents it — envy clothed as principle — which Caesar himself will diagnose minutes later in his portrait of the lean man who is "never at heart's ease / Whiles they behold a greater than themselves".

Foreshadowing: The image of a man who cries for help and must be carried prepares the audience for the two reports that follow: the fever and the swoon in the marketplace. More distantly, the river that nearly drowns Caesar anticipates the many images of flood and tide in the play, and Caesar's pride in accepting a dare foreshadows his fatal refusal to seem afraid on the Ides.

Scene connection: Marullus in Scene 1 made the Tiber tremble at the people's shouts for Pompey; Cassius now makes the same river the scene of Caesar's weakness. In Scene 3 Cassius will again measure himself against the elements, baring his chest to the lightning — the same temperament that leaps into a storm-swollen river "Accoutred as I was".

ICSE keywords: anecdote, classical allusion, envy, personal grievance, appearance versus reality, the body of the ruler, republican equality, biased narrator.

Exam application: If asked what the Tiber story reveals about Cassius rather than Caesar, you might write: 'Cassius casts himself as Aeneas carrying "The old Anchises" and Caesar as the helpless burden who "cried "Help me, Cassius, or I sink!"' — yet the climax of his story is his own humiliation, that he "must bend his body" to the man he saved. The anecdote exposes a wounded pride that the play presents as the private root of his public republicanism.'

CROSS-REFERENCE Where this argument is taken further

The anatomy of Cassius's whole technique — how he alternates flattery of Brutus with contempt for Caesar, why he never argues from policy, and how his soliloquy at the end of the scene confirms his motives — is in 'Cassius — The Manipulation Masterclass'. The question of how far the play endorses his picture of Caesar is weighed in 'Caesar in Act 1 — A Character Masterclass'. The themes of jealousy and appearance versus reality that these stories raise are treated in 'Themes of Act 1 (Part Two)'.

The fever in Spain — "this god did shake", "As a sick girl"

Cassius does not pause between the river and the sickbed. The second story follows the first without a connecting word, as though one proof of weakness naturally summons another. Where the Tiber story showed Caesar's body failing in action, this one shows it failing in illness — and, more cruelly, shows his voice failing, the very instrument of his authority.

Original line / short passage:

Cassius: *He had a fever when he was in Spain, / And when the fit was on him, I did mark / How he did shake. 'Tis true, this god did shake. / His coward lips did from their colour fly, / And that same eye whose bend doth awe the world / Did lose his lustre. I did hear him groan.*

Cassius: *Ay, and that tongue of his that bade the Romans / Mark him and write his speeches in their books, / 'Alas,' it cried 'Give me some drink, Titinius' / As a sick girl. Ye gods, it doth amaze me / A man of such a feeble temper should / So get the start of the majestic world / And bear the palm alone.*

Simple English: He had a fever when he was in Spain, and when the attack came on I noticed how he trembled. Yes, it is true: this so-called god trembled. His cowardly lips went pale; that same eye whose glance makes the whole world afraid lost its brightness. I heard him groan. And that tongue of his — the tongue that told Romans to pay attention to him and copy his speeches into their notebooks — cried 'Oh no! Give me something to drink, Titinius', like a sick little girl. By heaven, it astonishes me that a man of such a weak constitution should have got ahead of the whole magnificent world and taken the prize of victory for himself alone.

Difficult words: 'fit' — an attack of illness, a seizure; 'mark' — notice, observe (and later 'Mark him' — pay attention to him); 'coward lips' — cowardly lips (the adjective transferred from the man to his lips); 'did from their colour fly' — lost their colour, went pale (the colour is imagined as fleeing like a deserter); 'bend' — glance, direction of the eye; 'awe' — fill with fear and reverence; 'lustre' — brightness, shine; 'bade' — commanded; 'Titinius' — a Roman officer, here imagined as Caesar's companion in Spain; 'feeble temper' — weak constitution, poor physical make-up; 'get the start of' — outstrip, get ahead of; 'the majestic world' — the whole splendid world; 'bear the palm alone' — carry off the prize of victory by himself (the palm branch was the classical symbol of victory).

Literal meaning: Cassius describes watching Caesar in a feverish seizure in Spain: trembling, pale, dull-eyed, groaning, and whimpering for a drink. He marvels that such a physically weak man should have risen above the whole world and taken all the glory for himself.

Subtext: Cassius is not reporting an illness; he is prosecuting a case. Every detail is chosen to contradict a piece of Caesar's public image: the eye that awes the world went dull; the tongue that dictated to Rome begged for water; the god shook. The repeated "did" — "did mark", "did shake", "did from their colour fly", "Did lose", "did hear" — is the rhythm of sworn testimony: I saw, I saw, I heard. Cassius wants Brutus to feel that he, uniquely, has seen behind the curtain.

Hidden meaning: The phrase "As a sick girl" is the most revealing in the speech, and it reveals Cassius more than Caesar. His contempt is gendered: weakness is female, authority is male, and a man who whimpers has forfeited his sex. He will say the same thing in Scene 3 — "we are governed with our mothers' spirits. / Our yoke and sufferance show us womanish." For Cassius, politics is a contest of manliness; tyranny is suffered by the unmanly and overthrown by the manly. That is a very different creed from Brutus's honour, though the two men will act as if it were the same. Notice, too, that the one word Caesar is reported as speaking is "Alas" — the word of lament. Cassius gives the great orator exactly one word, and chooses a word of defeat.

Character psychology: Cassius here is pitiless and precise. There is no sympathy for a sick man, only the satisfaction of a witness to weakness; the ironic stress on "this god" is spoken with relish. Yet the speech also betrays bewilderment — "it doth amaze me" — and the bewilderment is genuine. Cassius cannot understand how a body he has seen fail can command a world. He never grasps what Caesar's authority rests on, which is not muscle but the willingness of others to believe in him. That blind spot governs the whole conspiracy: they kill the body and leave the belief alive, for Antony to use.

Political meaning: The republican case rests on human equality, and illness is the great equaliser; Cassius uses it to argue that nothing in Caesar's nature licenses his position. But note the logical slide. From 'Caesar's body is weak' Cassius moves to 'Caesar should not rule alone'. The premise is about flesh; the conclusion is about power. Shakespeare lets the audience hear the gap, and Brutus — who is a reasoner — never actually accepts this argument. His own reasoning in Act 2 will concern what Caesar may *become*, not what his body is.

Historical context: HISTORICAL RECORD: Plutarch says that Caesar suffered from epilepsy (which Shakespeare, following North's translation, calls the "falling sickness") and that the illness first attacked him at Corduba in Spain. Shakespeare has therefore grounded Cassius's story in a real detail of Caesar's biography, though the scene of whimpering for a drink is dramatic elaboration, not record. The historical Titinius was an officer of Cassius, and he appears in the play's last act in that role; Shakespeare's placing of him at Caesar's side in Spain is a dramatist's convenience, not history. The detail that Romans were told to "write his speeches in their books" reflects Caesar's real fame as an orator and writer, whose Commentaries on the Gallic War were already classics.

Literary devices: Simile ("As a sick girl"); irony and sarcasm ("this god did shake"); transferred epithet ("coward lips" — the cowardice belongs to the man, not the lips); personification of colour fleeing the lips; metonymy in "that tongue of his" (the tongue standing for Caesar's eloquence) and "that same eye" (the eye for his commanding presence); hyperbole ("whose bend doth awe the world"); metaphor of the race and the prize ("get the start of the majestic world / And bear the palm alone"); anaphoric repetition of "did"; reported speech.

Effect: The audience, who has just watched Caesar's imperious handling of the Soothsayer, is given a second Caesar: trembling, pale, calling for water. The two images collide, and the collision produces the question that drives Acts 1–3: which Caesar is the real one? The sarcasm also produces unease about the speaker; an audience can enjoy Cassius's wit while distrusting his pleasure in another man's suffering.

Dramatic significance: This speech prepares the ground for Casca's report, minutes later, that Caesar "swooned and fell down" in the marketplace and "foamed at mouth". When that report comes, Brutus will supply the diagnosis — the "falling sickness" — as though Cassius's story had already lodged in his mind. The speech is thus a planted seed, and the audience watches it grow within the same scene.

Foreshadowing: Caesar's physical frailty, first heard of here, will be confirmed on stage by his own admission that one ear is deaf, and will be at the heart of Calpurnia's fears in Act 2. The exposure of a 'god' as a body foreshadows the assassination itself, in which the body of the man is what the conspirators can reach and the idea of Caesar is what escapes them.

Scene connection: The eye "whose bend doth awe the world" connects to Caesar's own face-reading — "Let me see his face" — and to his later reading of Cassius's "lean and hungry look": the play is full of eyes that judge and eyes that fail. The tongue that commanded Rome connects to the voice that silenced the crowd at the scene's start, and to Antony's tongue in Act 3, which will do what Caesar's can no longer do.

ICSE keywords: sarcasm, irony, transferred epithet, simile, metonymy, physical weakness, appearance versus reality, envy, misogyny (Cassius's equation of weakness with femininity), biased witness.

Exam application: 'Cassius's sneer that "this god did shake" and begged for water "As a sick girl" is designed to collapse the distance between Caesar's public image and his mortal body. It tells us less about Caesar — whose illness is a matter of record — than about Cassius, whose contempt for weakness and whose amazement that such a man should "bear the palm alone" betray envy rather than principle.'

The Colossus speech

A second shout interrupts. Brutus's response is worth hearing on its own before Cassius seizes it: "Another general shout! / I do believe that these applauses are / For some new honours that are heaped on Caesar." Three things to notice. He is still guessing; he cannot see. He now assumes the worst by default ("new honours... heaped") — Cassius's two stories have done their work on his mood even though he has said nothing. And the word "heaped" is an image of excess, piling up — exactly the picture Cassius is about to enlarge into a statue so big the world must pass beneath it.

Original line / short passage:

Brutus: *Another general shout! / I do believe that these applauses are / For some new honours that are heaped on Caesar.*

Cassius: *Why, man, he doth bestride the narrow world / Like a Colossus, and we petty men / Walk under his huge legs and peep about / To find ourselves dishonourable graves.*

Simple English: Brutus: Another shout from the whole crowd! I believe this applause is for some new honours being piled on Caesar. Cassius: Why, man, he stands with his legs astride the whole cramped world like the giant statue at Rhodes, and we insignificant men walk about between his enormous legs, peering around for a place to be buried without honour.

Difficult words: 'general' — from the whole people, universal; 'applauses' — bursts of applause; 'heaped' — piled up; 'bestride' — stand with one leg on each side of; 'narrow' — small, cramped (the world shrinks beside Caesar); 'Colossus' — the gigantic bronze statue of the sun-god at Rhodes, one of the Seven Wonders of the ancient world; 'petty' — small, insignificant; 'peep about' — peer around timidly; 'dishonourable graves' — graves without honour, the deaths of men who did nothing worth remembering.

Literal meaning: Caesar is like a giant statue straddling a shrunken world, while ordinary men walk between his legs looking for nothing better than an obscure, shameful grave.

Subtext: Cassius has turned a shout into a monument. Brutus guessed at 'honours'; Cassius makes the honours into a bronze giant and places Brutus beneath its legs. The move is from the ear to the eye: he gives Brutus a picture to be humiliated by. The real force of the image is in the second half — not Caesar's size but *our* smallness, and the shame of a life spent looking for a grave. To a man who has just said he loves the name of honour more than he fears death, "dishonourable graves" is the precise threat: not death, which Brutus does not fear, but death without honour, which he does.

Hidden meaning: A Colossus is a statue, not a man; it is hollow, made by men, and famously it fell. (The real Colossus of Rhodes collapsed in an earthquake within about sixty years of its building.) Many critics note that the image therefore undermines itself: Cassius means to say Caesar is gigantic, but he has chosen for his comparison the most celebrated fallen monument of antiquity. The audience may also hear a stage picture in it. On the Elizabethan stage, as later, Caesar's body will lie at the foot of Pompey's statue; here Caesar *is* the statue and the conspirators are the small men at its base. The play repeatedly asks what a great man is once he has become an image — Scene 1's "images" "decked with ceremonies", the statues from which scarves are pulled, the Colossus, and finally the corpse Antony displays.

Character psychology: Cassius thinks in images of posture and position — bending, bowing, walking under, peeping about. His politics is spatial: who stands over whom. The intensity of "peep about" suggests how acutely he feels the indignity of smallness; the speech is self-portrait as much as caricature. Brutus's single contribution, that he believes the shouts are for "new honours", shows a mind now disposed to read every sound against Caesar.

Political meaning: This is the sharpest republican image in the scene. A republic is a space in which many men stand upright together; Cassius pictures a Rome in which there is room for only one upright figure, and everyone else is reduced to crawling. The word "narrow" is pointed: Caesar does not merely dominate the world, he shrinks it. The republican fear is that monarchy does not simply put one man on top but diminishes every other citizen into a subject.

Historical context: HISTORICAL RECORD: the Colossus of Rhodes, a bronze statue of the sun-god Helios roughly thirty metres high, was completed around 280 BC and stood for only a few decades before an earthquake brought it down. The picture of the statue straddling the harbour mouth so that ships sailed between its legs is a medieval legend, not ancient fact — but it is exactly the picture Shakespeare's image depends on, and it was the picture his audience knew. The real Rhodes was a place Caesar knew (he had studied there as a young man), though the play does not use that fact.

Literary devices: Epic simile ("Like a Colossus"); classical allusion; hyperbole; antithesis of scale ("huge legs" against "petty men", the "narrow world" against the giant who straddles it); the diminishing verbs "Walk under... peep about"; the oxymoronic sting of "dishonourable graves" for a man obsessed with honour; alliteration ("petty men... peep").

Effect: The image is so vivid that it has become the most quoted picture of Caesar in English, and in the theatre it does what Cassius intends — it makes the audience, for a moment, feel small. It also produces a flash of the grotesque: grown men peering between a statue's legs is both frightening and faintly ridiculous, and the ridicule is aimed at the men, not the statue.

Dramatic significance: The Colossus marks the point where Cassius stops describing Caesar's past and starts describing Brutus's present. From here on his speech is about what *we* are — "we petty men", "we are underlings", "yours is as fair a name". It is the pivot from denigration to incitement.

Foreshadowing: The fallen Colossus foreshadows the fall of Caesar and, beyond it, the collapse of the men who brought him down. Shakespeare returns to the idea of Caesar as a towering body brought low in Antony's funeral oration and in the image of Caesar's spirit walking abroad in Act 3; the conspirators who stood beneath

his legs will find at Philippi that his shadow still covers them.

Scene connection: Flavius in Scene 1 wanted to pluck Caesar's "growing feathers" so that he would "fly an ordinary pitch" rather than "soar above the view of men"; Cassius's statue is the same fear in a different image — a Caesar who has outgrown human scale. The "dishonourable graves" connect to the honour Brutus set in one eye and death in the other, a few lines earlier.

ICSE keywords: simile, hyperbole, classical allusion, antithesis, scale, republicanism, incitement, dishonour, iconic image.

Exam application: 'When Cassius describes Caesar as a Colossus beneath whose "huge legs" the Romans "peep about / To find ourselves dishonourable graves", he is not merely exaggerating Caesar's power. He is aiming at Brutus's one declared fear — a death without honour — and converting Caesar's greatness into Brutus's shame.'

"The fault, dear Brutus, is not in our stars"

QUOTATION The most quoted lines of Act 1

Cassius: *Men at some time are masters of their fates. / The fault, dear Brutus, is not in our stars, / But in ourselves, that we are underlings.*

Spoken by Cassius to Brutus in Act 1 Scene 2, immediately after the Colossus image and before the weighing of the two names. Learn these three lines exactly; they are among the handful of Shakespeare's sentences that have passed into everyday English.

Original line / short passage:

Cassius: *Men at some time are masters of their fates. / The fault, dear Brutus, is not in our stars, / But in ourselves, that we are underlings.*

Simple English: There are moments when men control their own destinies. The blame, dear Brutus, does not lie in the stars under which we were born; it lies in ourselves, because we allow ourselves to be inferiors.

Difficult words: 'at some time' — at certain moments, on some occasions (not 'always'); 'masters of their fates' — in control of their destinies; 'fault' — blame, responsibility (also, as some editors note, a 'fault' in the sense of a flaw); 'stars' — the astrological influence of the heavens at a person's birth, which Elizabethans widely believed shaped a person's fortune; 'underlings' — inferiors, subordinates, people kept beneath others.

Literal meaning: Men are not always helpless before destiny; at certain moments they can seize control of it. Our subjection to Caesar is not fated by the heavens but is our own doing — we have chosen to be inferior.

Subtext: The sentence answers an objection Brutus has not spoken: 'perhaps this is simply how things are; perhaps Caesar's rise is destiny'. Cassius forecloses that excuse. If subjection is a choice, then continuing to submit is also a choice — and a shameful one. The word "underlings" is chosen to sting; it is a servant's word, and it is spoken to a praetor of Rome.

Hidden meaning: Read the first line carefully: "at some time". Cassius does not claim that men are always masters of their fates; he claims that there are moments of opportunity, and his whole argument implies that this is one. That is a subtler and more dangerous claim than simple free will, because it makes inaction at the chosen moment into the fault. There is also a deep irony that the audience hears and Cassius cannot: this speech is made within minutes of a prophecy fixing the date of Caesar's death. The man who denies the stars is

speaking in a play where the stars, or something like them, have already spoken. And in his own last act Cassius will reverse himself, confessing that he has come to believe in omens and dying on his birthday, as though the stars had kept their appointment after all.

Character psychology: Cassius here speaks as a man of will, and it is probably his sincerest moment in the scene; the contempt for passivity is real and is his own, not a performance for Brutus. His philosophy makes him effective and makes him blind: because he believes everything is choice, he cannot credit Caesar's authority with any reality beyond the Romans' cowardice, and he cannot imagine that the plot might fail for reasons outside anyone's control.

Political meaning: This is the founding statement of political agency in the play. A republic depends on citizens who believe they are responsible for their own condition; a monarchy is easier to accept if one believes rulers are given by heaven. Cassius's line is therefore not just a proverb but a republican argument: to blame the stars for Caesar is to accept Caesar. Elizabethan audiences may have heard something more uneasy in it, since the official doctrine of their own state held that rulers were appointed by God and that to rise against them was to rebel against heaven; Cassius's denial of the stars could sound like the voice of sedition itself.

Historical context: HISTORICAL RECORD: the historical Cassius was an Epicurean, a follower of a philosophy that denied that the gods meddle in human affairs and that regarded omens and astrology as superstition. Shakespeare could have found hints of this in Plutarch, and the line fits that temperament exactly. Belief in astrological influence was widespread in Shakespeare's England, and the play elsewhere lets characters speak as if the heavens did govern events — most strikingly in Scene 3, where the storm is read as a sign. The play as a whole does not settle the question; it stages the argument.

Literary devices: Aphorism, a short general truth memorably expressed; antithesis ("not in our stars, / But in ourselves"); metonymy ("stars" standing for fate or destiny); alliteration ("fault... fates"; "stars... ourselves"); the direct address "dear Brutus", which turns a general statement into personal pressure; the humiliating diction of "underlings".

Effect: The lines have the ring of wisdom, and that is their power: an audience and a Brutus nod to the truth of the proverb before noticing what it is being used to justify. Shakespeare gives his manipulator the play's most quotable philosophy, which is one of the ways the play refuses to make judgement easy.

Dramatic significance: This is the thematic hinge of Act 1. The scene began with the Soothsayer (fate) and now gives its most memorable lines to the denial of fate (free will). Everything that follows in the play — omens ignored, dreams reinterpreted, letters forged, a ghost appearing, a misread shout at Philippi — is a test of which of these two voices is right.

Foreshadowing: It foreshadows Cassius's own conversion to belief in omens before Philippi and his death on the day of his birth; and, in the nearer term, it foreshadows the conspirators' confidence that they can control events after the murder — a confidence that Antony's speech destroys within an hour of stage time.

Scene connection: The line directly answers the Soothsayer earlier in the scene, though Cassius did not hear him; the two speeches frame the first half of the scene as a debate between prophecy and will. It also connects forward to Cassius's "Cassius from bondage will deliver Cassius" in Scene 3, where mastery of fate is narrowed to the freedom to die.

ICSE keywords: fate versus free will, aphorism, antithesis, agency, responsibility, dramatic irony, republican argument, manipulation.

Exam application: 'Cassius's claim that "The fault... is not in our stars, / But in ourselves" is the play's clearest statement of free will, placed with deliberate irony in the very scene in which the Soothsayer has fixed the date of Caesar's death. The audience is thus asked, from the start, whether the conspirators are masters of their fates or its instruments — a question that Act 5 answers against Cassius.'

CROSS-REFERENCE The fate-and-free-will debate

The full discussion of fate, free will, superstition and omens across the whole act — how the Soothsayer, Cassius's aphorism, Caesar's selective superstition, Casca's prodigies and Cicero's scepticism fit together — is in 'Themes of Act 1 (Part Two)'. The foreshadowing map that tracks every omen to its fulfilment is in 'The Soothsayer, the Ides of March, and the Supporting Cast'.

The name-weighing passage — 'Brutus' and 'Caesar'

Original line / short passage:

Cassius: *'Brutus' and 'Caesar' — what should be in that 'Caesar'? / Why should that name be sounded more than yours? / Write them together, yours is as fair a name; / Sound them, it doth become the mouth as well; / Weigh them, it is as heavy; conjure with 'em, / 'Brutus' will start a spirit as soon as 'Caesar.'*

Simple English: 'Brutus' and 'Caesar' — what is there in the name 'Caesar'? Why should it be spoken aloud more than yours? Write the two names side by side, and yours is just as handsome; speak them, and yours sits just as well in the mouth; weigh them, and yours is just as heavy; use them in a magic spell, and 'Brutus' will raise a spirit just as quickly as 'Caesar'.

Difficult words: 'sounded' — pronounced, proclaimed, spoken aloud; 'fair' — handsome, fine; 'become the mouth' — suit the mouth, be pleasant to pronounce; 'conjure' — summon spirits by magic words; 'em' — them; 'start a spirit' — raise or call up a spirit (a 'start' is a sudden movement, so the spirit leaps up at the name).

Literal meaning: Cassius argues that there is nothing in the name Caesar that makes it superior to the name Brutus: written, spoken, weighed or used in a spell, the two are equal.

Subtext: This is the mirror passage completed. There, Cassius offered to show Brutus his hidden worth; here he shows it by setting Brutus's name beside Caesar's and finding them equal. The purpose is to make Brutus imagine himself in Caesar's place — not as a tyrant but as a man of equal weight whose name could also be "sounded". It is also an answer to the fear Brutus spoke after the first shout: if the people are choosing a name to shout, why should that name not be Brutus's?

Hidden meaning: Cassius's argument proves the opposite of what he intends, and the audience is meant to notice. Of course there is nothing magical in the letters C-A-E-S-A-R. The power of Caesar's name is not in the name but in what Rome has agreed to attach to it: victories, authority, the habit of obedience. Cassius treats a name as a physical object — something you can write, sound, weigh — because he cannot see that political power is made of belief. Yet the passage is also strangely prophetic. The name Brutus *will* start a spirit: the forged letters will work by appealing to the name, the ancestral Brutus will be summoned in the next lines, and in Act 3 Brutus's reputation will be the thing that gives the murder its credit with the crowd. And the name Caesar will outlast the man so completely that it becomes the title of emperors — a fact Shakespeare's audience knew and the play quietly relies on.

Character psychology: For Brutus, who has just spoken of loving "The name of honour", this is a passage about names addressed to a man who thinks in names. Cassius has listened well. For Cassius himself, the fixation on sound and weight reveals a mind that measures men by rank and reputation, and that cannot bear to be outranked by an equal.

Political meaning: The passage dramatises the republican horror of a *name* that outweighs the law — the thing the tribunes feared in Scene 1 when they stripped Caesar's "trophy" from his "images". A republic is government by offices, which anyone qualified may hold; Caesar threatens to make government a matter of one proper noun. Cassius's levelling of the two names is therefore the republican principle itself: no citizen's name should be "sounded more" than another's. The irony is that his method of levelling is to raise one more name, Brutus's, into a rival magnitude.

Historical context: HISTORICAL RECORD: the Brutus family name carried real political weight in Rome because of its legendary founder, and the historical conspirators did exploit it — Plutarch records anonymous messages reproaching Brutus with his ancestor's example. The idea that names have occult power — that one can "conjure with" them — reflects Elizabethan beliefs about magic and witchcraft that were current in 1599, and should not be read as Roman religion. It is Shakespeare giving a Roman a sixteenth-century image.

Literary devices: Rhetorical questions ("what should be in that 'Caesar'?", "Why should that name be sounded more than yours?"); parallelism and anaphora in the four imperatives ("Write them... Sound them... Weigh them... conjure with 'em"), each followed by a clause of equality; the conceit of treating names as physical objects with weight and sound; the metaphor of magic ("conjure", "start a spirit"); repetition of the two names, which makes the audience hear them as sounds rather than as men.

Effect: The passage has the hypnotic quality of incantation — appropriate, since it ends in conjuring. The audience hears Cassius working the name 'Brutus' like a spell, and may feel the uneasy pleasure of watching persuasion become enchantment.

Dramatic significance: This is the moment the conspiracy's real strategy is spoken aloud: it will trade on the name of Brutus. Cassius says so again in his soliloquy, when he plans letters "tending to the great opinion / That Rome holds of his name", and Casca says so in Scene 3, when he observes that Brutus's "countenance, like richest alchemy", will turn offence into virtue. The conspirators do not want Brutus's judgement; they want his name.

Foreshadowing: Foreshadows the forged letters, which are precisely attempts to "conjure with" the name Brutus; and Antony's funeral oration, which will conjure with the name Caesar — reading the will, displaying the body, repeating the name — far more successfully than Cassius conjures here.

Scene connection: Picks up Brutus's "The name of honour" from a few lines earlier and Caesar's habit, heard at the scene's opening, of using his own name as a title ("Caesar is turned to hear"). The scene is full of people treating 'Caesar' as a word with independent power; Cassius is the one who says so and the one who most resents it.

ICSE keywords: rhetorical question, parallelism, anaphora, conceit, incantation, name and reputation, republican equality, flattery, foreshadowing.

Exam application: 'By demanding why Caesar's name should "be sounded more than yours" and insisting that "'Brutus' will start a spirit as soon as 'Caesar'", Cassius flatters Brutus into imagining himself Caesar's equal. The argument is logically empty — a name has no weight in itself — but it reveals the conspiracy's true strategy: to use the name of Brutus as a spell upon Rome.'

"There was a Brutus once"

Between the names and the ancestor Cassius inserts a lament for Rome that you should know, because it is often set as an extract. "Now, in the names of all the gods at once, / Upon what meat doth this our Caesar feed / That he is grown so great? Age, thou art shamed! / Rome, thou hast lost the breed of noble bloods!" In plain English: in the name of every god together, what food has this Caesar of ours been eating to make him grow so huge? Our era should be ashamed; Rome has lost its stock of noble families. The question about "meat" continues the bodily argument — Caesar's greatness as a matter of diet, not merit — while "breed" and "bloods" shift the ground to ancestry, which is where Cassius is heading. He then complains that no previous age "since the great flood" was "famed with more than with one man", and makes his famous pun: "Now is it Rome indeed, and room enough / When there is in it but one only man." (In Elizabethan pronunciation Rome and room sounded alike; the joke is that the city is now spacious because only one man counts as living in it.) All of this is the run-up to the sentence that finally makes Brutus speak.

Original line / short passage:

Cassius: *O, you and I have heard our fathers say / There was a Brutus once that would have brooked / Th' eternal devil to keep his state in Rome / As easily as a king.*

Simple English: Oh, you and I have both heard our fathers say that there was once a Brutus who would have put up with the devil himself holding court in Rome as readily as he would have put up with a king — that is, he would have tolerated neither.

Difficult words: 'our fathers' — our ancestors, the older generation; 'a Brutus once' — Lucius Junius Brutus, the legendary founder of the Roman Republic; 'brooked' — tolerated, endured; 'Th' eternal devil' — the devil himself, Satan; 'keep his state' — hold court, maintain his royal dignity and power; 'As easily as a king' — as readily as he would have tolerated a king (the sentence is ironic: he would have tolerated neither).

Literal meaning: The ancestral Brutus hated kingship so much that for him a king in Rome was as intolerable as the devil in Rome.

Subtext: This is the last and heaviest weight Cassius places on the scale: not Rome's opinion, not Caesar's weakness, not the equality of names, but *family*. He tells Brutus that his own blood has already decided the question. The appeal to "our fathers" makes the obligation hereditary and oral — something Brutus has heard at home since childhood — and therefore impossible to argue against without disowning his own name.

Hidden meaning: The sentence contains the whole conspiracy in miniature, and it contains the conspiracy's confusion too. The ancestral Brutus expelled a *king*, Tarquin; Caesar is not a king and has, we learn minutes later, refused a crown three times. Cassius's analogy smuggles in the conclusion that Caesar is a king already. Brutus will inherit this confusion in Act 2, reasoning that Caesar must be killed not for what he is but for what the crown "would" make him. The comparison of a king to "Th' eternal devil" is also telling: it treats monarchy not as a policy to be opposed but as an absolute evil to be exterminated, and that absolutism is what makes the murder, rather than opposition, seem to follow.

Character psychology: Cassius saves the ancestor for last because he has measured Brutus accurately: this is the appeal that will work. Brutus's reply confirms it. For the first time he does not deflect; he admits that he has "thought of this, and of these times". The chord Cassius strikes is pride of lineage disguised as duty — a chord Brutus himself will strike in his Act 2 soliloquy, where he recalls that his ancestors drove the Tarquin from the streets of Rome.

Political meaning: Rome's whole political identity rested on a founding act of expulsion: the republic was defined as the state that had no king. To invoke the first Brutus is to invoke the constitution itself. But the invocation also shows how the republican cause has shrunk to a matter of family memory. Cassius does not argue that the republic is good; he argues that the Brutuses are against kings. Politics has become genealogy.

Historical context: HISTORICAL RECORD: Lucius Junius Brutus led the expulsion of the last king of Rome, Tarquin the Proud, traditionally in 509 BC, and became one of the first two consuls; Roman tradition made him the embodiment of republican liberty, and Marcus Brutus's family claimed descent from him (ancient and modern writers have doubted the descent, but the Romans of 44 BC treated it as fact and used it). Plutarch records that the people reminded Brutus of his ancestor by writings left on the praetor's tribunal and on the statue of old Brutus — the historical seed of the letters Cassius will forge. The "eternal devil" is a Christian idea placed in pagan Rome: an anachronism that Shakespeare's audience would not have noticed and that an examiner will be pleased to see you notice.

Literary devices: Historical allusion (to Lucius Junius Brutus); hyperbole and irony (the devil as easily tolerated as a king — meaning neither); anachronism ("Th' eternal devil"); the appeal to authority and tradition ("our fathers say"); the rhetorical climax, since this is the final and strongest point of a long speech; and, in the lines before it, apostrophe ("Age, thou art shamed! / Rome, thou hast lost") and the pun on Rome and "room enough".

Effect: The speech ends not with a flourish but with a quiet sentence about what the fathers used to say — and it is the quiet sentence that lands. The audience senses that Cassius has stopped performing and found the thing that will actually move Brutus.

Dramatic significance: This is the sentence that breaks Brutus's silence. For some fifty lines he has said almost nothing while Cassius talked; now he answers at length. Dramatically, the ancestor is the key that turns the lock.

Foreshadowing: Foreshadows the letters set up "with wax / Upon old Brutus' statue" in Scene 3; Brutus's own appeal to his ancestry in the orchard soliloquy; and the way the conspirators will present the murder as a re-enactment of the founding expulsion of the kings — a story the crowd accepts for exactly as long as it takes Antony to tell a better one.

Scene connection: Connects back to the weighing of names (the name Brutus now acquires its history) and forward to Cinna's wish in Scene 3 that Cassius could "win the noble Brutus to our party"; the ancestor is what makes Brutus's name worth winning.

ICSE keywords: allusion, ancestry, lineage, anachronism, irony, appeal to tradition, republican founding myth, incitement, climax.

Exam application: 'Cassius ends with the one appeal he has held in reserve: "There was a Brutus once" who would no more have "brook'd" a king in Rome than "Th' eternal devil". By turning Brutus's ancestry into an obligation, he makes inaction look like a betrayal of blood — and it is this, not the stories of Caesar's weakness, that finally draws an answer from Brutus.'

HISTORICAL CONTEXT The first Brutus and the hatred of kings

Roman tradition held that in 509 BC Lucius Junius Brutus, a nephew of the king, led the revolt that drove out Tarquin the Proud after the outrage done to Lucretia, and that he swore the Romans never again to allow a king. He became one of the first two consuls and, in the most famous story about him, condemned his own sons to death for plotting to restore the monarchy. From then on 'rex' was the most hated word in Roman politics; to call a man a would-be king was to call for his removal. Marcus Brutus's family kept a statue of the founder among their ancestral images, and the Romans of 44 BC — as Plutarch tells it — left messages at that statue asking whether the living Brutus was asleep. Shakespeare knew all this from North's Plutarch, and he builds the whole appeal of this speech on it. Keep the two Brutuses separate in your answers: 'the ancestral Brutus' (Lucius Junius) and 'Brutus' (Marcus Junius, the character). Confusing them is a common error.

7. Brutus Answers: The Guarded Reply and the Villager

Brutus's guarded reply — "That you do love me, I am nothing jealous"

After all that, Brutus speaks. What he says is a masterpiece of controlled courtesy, and you must read it slowly, because every clause is doing two things at once: acknowledging Cassius and holding him off.

Original line / short passage:

Brutus: *That you do love me, I am nothing jealous. / What you would work me to, I have some aim. / How I have thought of this, and of these times, / I shall recount hereafter. For this present, / I would not, so with love I might entreat you, / Be any further moved.*

Brutus: *What you have said / I will consider; what you have to say / I will with patience hear, and find a time / Both meet to hear and answer such high things.*

Simple English: I have no doubt at all that you love me. I have some idea of what you are trying to persuade me to do. How I have thought about this matter, and about the times we live in, I will tell you later. For now — and I ask this of you as a friend — I would rather not be pressed any further. What you have said I will think over; what you still have to say I will listen to patiently; and I will find a time that is right both for hearing and for answering such weighty matters.

Difficult words: 'nothing jealous' — not at all doubtful, not suspicious (in Shakespeare's English 'jealous' often means 'suspicious, mistrustful'); 'work me to' — persuade me towards, manoeuvre me into; 'aim' — guess, conjecture; 'recount' — relate, tell; 'hereafter' — later; 'For this present' — for the present moment; 'so with love I might entreat you' — if I may ask you as a friend; 'moved' — urged, pressed (also, in the background, 'moved' emotionally); 'with patience' — patiently; 'meet' — fitting, suitable; 'high things' — weighty, serious, dangerous matters.

Literal meaning: Brutus assures Cassius of his trust, admits he understands the drift of Cassius's speech, says he has already been thinking about these matters, declines to be pressed further today, and promises to consider what has been said and to find a proper time to hear and answer the rest.

Subtext: Two words give the game away. "aim" — Brutus knows exactly what Cassius is driving at, and says so without saying it. "hereafter" — he does not refuse; he postpones. A man who intended to refuse would refuse. Brutus has, in effect, agreed to a second meeting on the subject of removing Caesar, while saying

nothing that could be repeated against him. He also tells Cassius something Cassius badly wanted to know: that he had already "thought of this, and of these times" before Cassius said a word. The war within him, in other words, was about Caesar all along.

Hidden meaning: Look at the balance of the sentences — "What you have said / I will consider; what you have to say / I will with patience hear" — and at the pairing "Both meet to hear and answer". Brutus's mind works in symmetries, in weighed clauses; it is the mind of a judge, not a conspirator, and he will bring the same judicial balance to the orchard soliloquy and, fatally, to the decision to spare Antony. Notice also that he describes Cassius's project as "such high things": the phrase dignifies it. Brutus is already, in his diction, treating the overthrow of Caesar as a lofty matter rather than a crime.

Character psychology: This speech shows Brutus's two great qualities and his two great weaknesses in one breath. The qualities: honesty (he will not pretend he has not understood) and self-command (he will not be stampeded). The weaknesses: a tendency to postpone decisions he has already half made, and a trust in friends that he states as a point of honour — "I am nothing jealous" — at the very moment a friend is manipulating him. He is not deceived about Cassius's aim; he is deceived about Cassius's motive, and he never asks about it.

Political meaning: The speech is the republican conscience taking its time. It shows that Brutus will not act on a friend's resentment or a crowd's shout; he needs reasons, and he needs to supply them himself. That is admirable, and it is also the reason the conspiracy will take on Brutus's cast of mind: deliberate, principled, and blind to the practical.

Historical context: HISTORICAL RECORD: Plutarch describes Brutus as a man who weighed the plot against Caesar long and carefully, torn between his obligations to Caesar, who had pardoned and promoted him, and the republican tradition of his family; he also records that Cassius had to approach Brutus more than once. Shakespeare's 'not today, but later' compresses that slow process into a single polite paragraph.

Literary devices: Antithesis and balanced clauses ("What you have said / I will consider; what you have to say / I will with patience hear"); formal, Latinate diction ("recount hereafter", "entreat", "meet"); understatement ("I have some aim"); the courteous conditional ("so with love I might entreat you"); the elevating phrase "high things".

Effect: After fifty lines of Cassius's heat, Brutus's coolness is a relief and a worry at once. The audience admires the restraint and notices that it is not a refusal. The scene's temperature drops, and the plot has nevertheless advanced.

Dramatic significance: This is the first commitment Brutus makes — a commitment to keep listening — and in a tragedy that is enough. Cassius knows it, as his reply shows. From here the question is no longer whether Brutus will be approached again but when.

Foreshadowing: "hereafter" foreshadows the night visit of the conspirators in Act 2 and the orchard soliloquy in which Brutus 'recounts' his thinking to himself; "find a time / Both meet to hear and answer" is fulfilled when the conspirators arrive at his house before dawn.

Scene connection: The earlier admission "with himself at war" is now explained: the war was about "these times". Cassius's soliloquy at the end of the scene will treat this reply as proof that Brutus's "honourable mettle may be wrought" — bent, worked — using the very verb Brutus used here, "work me to".

ICSE keywords: restraint, deliberation, postponement, antithesis, judicial mind, trust, dramatic irony, understatement.

Exam application: Brutus's reply is guarded but not a refusal: he admits "What you would work me to, I have some aim", confesses he has already "thought of this, and of these times", and merely asks not to be "any further moved" for the present. His courteous postponement is, in effect, consent to be approached again —

the first step of his tragedy.'

"Brutus had rather be a villager"

Brutus does not stop at postponement. He gives Cassius something to carry away — a sentence to "chew upon" — and it is the most committed thing he says in the whole scene.

Original line / short passage:

Brutus: *Till then, my noble friend, chew upon this: / Brutus had rather be a villager / Than to repute himself a son of Rome / Under these hard conditions as this time / Is like to lay upon us.*

Cassius: *I am glad that my weak words / Have struck but thus much show of fire from Brutus.*

Simple English: Brutus: Until then, my noble friend, think this over: Brutus would rather be a simple country villager than call himself a citizen of Rome under the harsh conditions that these times are likely to impose on us. Cassius: I am glad that my feeble words have struck even this much of a spark from Brutus.

Difficult words: 'Till then' — until that later time; 'chew upon' — think over, ruminate on (the image is of slow digestion); 'had rather' — would rather, would prefer; 'villager' — an inhabitant of a village, a rustic with no civic standing; 'repute himself' — consider himself, call himself; 'a son of Rome' — a Roman citizen, with the pride the phrase implies; 'hard conditions' — harsh terms (as in the terms of a surrender or a contract); 'Is like to' — is likely to; 'lay upon us' — impose on us; 'weak words' — feeble speech (false modesty); 'struck... show of fire' — produced a visible spark, as steel struck on flint does; 'but thus much' — even this much, only this much.

Literal meaning: Brutus declares that he would rather give up Roman citizenship and live as a nobody in a village than be a Roman under the oppression that seems to be coming. Cassius expresses satisfaction that his words have drawn even this much passion from Brutus.

Subtext: This is as near as Brutus comes to a political statement in Act 1, and it is still oblique. He does not name Caesar; he says "these hard conditions" and "this time". But the meaning is unmistakable to Cassius and to us: Brutus regards the coming kingship as a condition under which Roman life would not be worth living as a Roman. For a man who has just been reminded of his ancestor, 'I would rather be a villager' is the voice of the republican tradition — citizenship under a king is not citizenship. Cassius's reply, meanwhile, is quietly jubilant beneath its modesty. 'Weak words' is a flourish; he knows they were not weak. "Fire" is what he wanted, and he has got a "show" of it.

Hidden meaning: Two images are hidden in the plain words. First, "chew upon this" turns the political thought into food — picking up, with grim appropriateness, Cassius's question about what "meat" Caesar feeds on. Brutus feeds Cassius a thought in return. Second, Cassius's "struck... fire" is an image of flint and steel: Brutus is the flint, hard and cold, from which a spark can be struck only by striking. The image concedes something important — that the fire is Brutus's own, latent in him, and that Cassius's role is only to strike. In his soliloquy minutes later Cassius will reach for a related image, Brutus's "honourable mettle", where 'mettle' means temperament and puns on 'metal'. The two images belong together: a metal that can be struck for fire, and worked into a new shape.

Character psychology: Brutus here shows the idealist's absolutism. He does not weigh degrees of oppression; he poses a stark either-or (villager or son of Rome) and declares his preference. The same cast of mind will make him see the choice about Caesar as absolute in Act 2 and will make him unable to compromise with Cassius in Act 4. Note too the third person once more — "Brutus had rather" — the public self speaking. Cassius, for his part, shows the skill of a man who knows when to stop. He does not press for more; he banks the spark.

Political meaning: The sentence defines what Roman citizenship meant to a republican: not residence in the city but participation as a free equal. Under a king, the "son of Rome" becomes a subject, no better than a "villager" — so one might as well be a villager honestly. This is the *libertas* of the Roman tradition speaking: freedom as the condition of living under laws one shares in making, rather than under the will of one man. Brutus has, without naming him, pronounced Caesar's rule incompatible with Roman life.

Historical context: HISTORICAL RECORD: Plutarch's Brutus, in the months before the Ides, was in fact Caesar's favoured praetor and designated for a consulship; the historical man's alienation was slower and more complex than this sentence suggests, and Shakespeare compresses it. The opposition of city and village had a special resonance for Romans, whose word for citizen (*civis*) and for the state (*civitas*) both came from the city; to leave the city was, in a sense, to leave politics altogether. In Shakespeare's England the word 'villager' also carried the sense of a person of no account, which sharpens the sacrifice Brutus says he would make.

Literary devices: Metaphor ("chew upon this"; "struck... show of fire"); antithesis ("villager" against "son of Rome"); illeism ("Brutus had rather"); euphemism or indirection ("these hard conditions", "this time" for Caesar's rule); ironic understatement in "my weak words"; the double meaning latent in "show of fire" — a genuine flash, but also only a 'show', an appearance.

Effect: Brutus's sentence lands with the weight of a vow, and the audience hears, for the first time, that the honourable man is on the move. Cassius's reply lets the audience share his satisfaction, which is uncomfortable, because it is the satisfaction of a successful fisherman.

Dramatic significance: This closes the first movement of the scene. The procession went out with Brutus unapproached; it returns with Brutus declared, in principle, against the coming kingship. In the space of one offstage race the conspiracy has acquired the man it needs. Caesar's return at this exact moment is Shakespeare's irony: the victim re-enters just as his destroyer has been won over.

Foreshadowing: "a son of Rome" under "hard conditions" foreshadows Brutus's justification of the murder to the crowd — that he loved Rome more than he loved Caesar — and his claim to have killed Caesar for Rome's liberty. The spark Cassius has struck foreshadows the "fire" imagery of the storm scene and the conflagration of Act 3, when the mob carries firebrands through the city. The 'villager' who would rather lose Rome than live under a king will, at Philippi, lose both Rome and his life.

Scene connection: Brutus's "I would not, Cassius, yet I love him well", spoken after the first shout, has now hardened into "Brutus had rather be a villager": the scene traces the movement from divided feeling to stated principle. Cassius's soliloquy at the scene's end — "Well, Brutus, thou art noble; yet I see / Thy honourable mettle may be wrought" — is his private assessment of the "show of fire" he has just struck.

ICSE keywords: republicanism, citizenship, *libertas*, idealism, antithesis, illeism, metaphor (flint and fire; chewing), commitment, turning point.

Exam application: Brutus's parting declaration that he "had rather be a villager / Than to repute himself a son of Rome" under the coming "hard conditions" is his first political commitment in the play: without naming Caesar he pronounces life under a king not worth living as a Roman. Cassius's satisfied reply that his "weak words" have struck a "show of fire" confirms that the first movement of the seduction has succeeded.'

8. Where Part One Ends

Stop here and look back at the ground covered, because the pause is where the learning happens. When Caesar's procession left the stage, Brutus was a troubled man who wanted to be alone. When it returns, he has admitted a fear, confessed a love, defined his honour, heard his ancestor invoked and promised to hear more.

Nothing has been decided; everything has been prepared. That is the pattern of a Shakespearean first act, and Scene 2 is its finest example in this play: a long conversation in which almost nothing happens and the whole tragedy becomes possible.

Three things you should now be able to do without notes. First, trace Cassius's sequence — hurt friend, mirror, shout, honour, Tiber, fever, Colossus, stars, names, ancestor — and say what each move was for. Second, state Brutus's position in his own words at three points: "with himself at war"; "I would not, Cassius, yet I love him well"; "Brutus had rather be a villager". Third, explain why the Soothsayer's one sentence at the start of the scene changes how you hear Cassius's claim that men are "masters of their fates".

ICSE EXAM BOX How this half-scene is used in examination answers

Be clear about what is examined where. Act 1 is the Class IX portion, so a direct extract from this half of the scene — the Soothsayer exchange, the mirror lines, the Tiber story, the Colossus, the names, the ancestral Brutus — belongs in Class IX internal papers, where the usual sub-questions ask who is speaking to whom and where, what has just happened, what a phrase means in your own words, what the lines reveal about the speaker, and what happens next. For the Class X board paper (Acts III–V), this material works as *evidence* rather than as the extract itself. When a question on Act 3 asks why Brutus joined the conspiracy, the honest answer reaches back to his admission here that he feared the people would "Choose Caesar for their king" and that he loved "The name of honour more than I fear death". When a question on Act 4 or 5 asks about Cassius's character or his change of heart about omens, "The fault, dear Brutus, is not in our stars" is the line to set against his later fatalism. When a question asks what Antony means by Brutus's nobility, the mirror, the names and the ancestor explain why the conspirators wanted him. Never claim a question is certain to come; show the examiner that you know where every Act 3–5 motive began.

CROSS-REFERENCE What comes next

The second half of the scene — Caesar's return and his verdict on the "lean and hungry" Cassius, Casca's prose report of the crown and the swoon, and Cassius's soliloquy with its plan of forged letters — is taught in 'Act 1 Scene 2 (Part Two) — Caesar Returns, Casca Reports, Cassius Plots', which also carries the revision sheet for the whole scene. Extract practice on the passages in this chapter is in 'Extract-Based Training (Part One): Scene 1 and the First Half of Scene 2'. Every quotation used here is collected, with its speaker and context, in 'The Act 1 Quotation Bank'.

CHAPTER 5

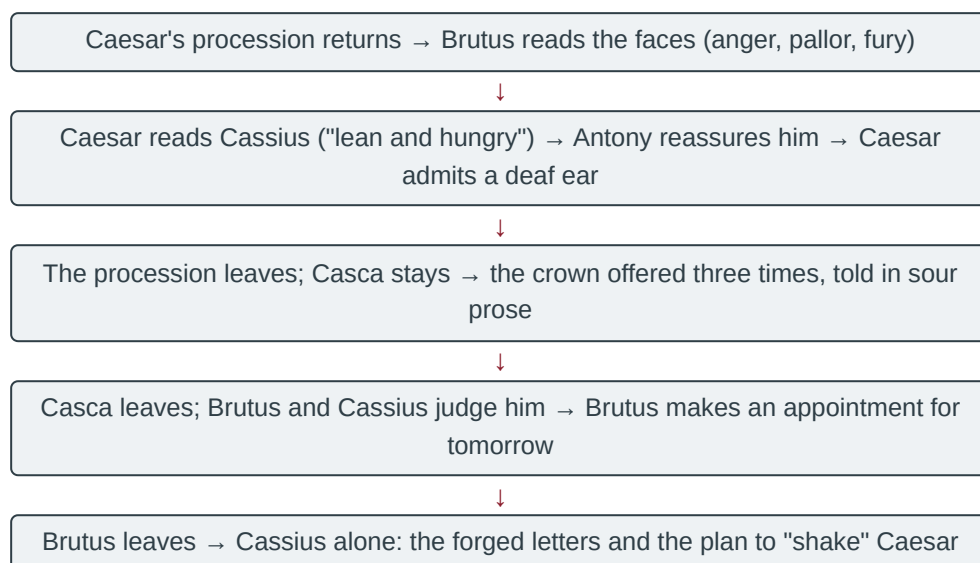
Act 1 Scene 2 (Part Two) — Caesar Returns, Casca Reports, Cassius Plots

This chapter takes you from the moment Caesar's procession comes back on stage to the end of Scene 2, when Cassius is left alone and tells us what he really intends. You will learn to read three things a school guide usually skims: how Brutus and Caesar each read faces; how the most important political event of the day — the offer of a crown — reaches us only through Casca's sneering prose; and how Cassius's closing soliloquy quietly rewrites everything you heard him say in Part One. Every important passage is taught line by line, and the chapter ends with two master tables, an exam section that is honest about the ICSE syllabus, and a one-minute revision sheet.

Where we are when Caesar comes back

At the end of Part One (Chapter 04), Brutus has promised only to think. He has told Cassius to "chew upon this", he has said he would rather be a villager than live as a Roman under the conditions Caesar is about to impose, and Cassius has answered with a sentence of studied modesty: "I am glad that my weak words / Have struck but thus much show of fire from Brutus." Then the stage direction says that Caesar and his train enter. The games are over. The men who have been standing to one side, talking about Caesar, now watch him walk past.

The second half of the scene is built in three movements, and it will help you to hold them in your head as a shape before we go line by line.



Notice what Shakespeare has done with the stage. In Part One, Caesar was present but Brutus and Cassius talked about him from the edge of the crowd. Now the positions reverse: Caesar walks through, notices Cassius, and talks about him. The watchers are watched. That symmetry is not an accident, and by the end of this chapter you will be able to explain why it matters.

LEVEL 1 — What happened?

Caesar returns from the Lupercalia games with a face like thunder. Brutus, who has been talking privately with Cassius, notices that Caesar looks angry, that his followers look as if they have been scolded, that Calpurnia is pale and that Cicero has the fierce look he wears when he loses an argument in the Senate. Caesar, passing, tells Antony that he distrusts thin, thoughtful men like Cassius and prefers contented, well-fed ones; Antony says Cassius is a noble, well-disposed Roman; Caesar insists he fears nobody, then asks Antony to come to his right side because his left ear is deaf. The procession leaves. Casca, pulled back by Brutus, reports in blunt prose that Antony offered Caesar a crown three times, that Caesar refused it each time (though, in Casca's opinion, he wanted it), that the crowd cheered every refusal, and that Caesar then fainted in the marketplace. Casca adds that Cicero spoke Greek, and that the two tribunes from Scene 1 have been silenced for stripping decorations from Caesar's statues. Casca leaves. Brutus and Cassius agree to meet tomorrow. Alone, Cassius reveals that he will throw forged letters through Brutus's windows to push him towards the conspiracy.

Brutus reads the returning procession

Before the procession arrives, Cassius gives Brutus a small instruction that quietly shapes everything that follows:

Cassius: *As they pass by, pluck Casca by the sleeve, / And he will, after his sour fashion, tell you / What hath proceeded worthy note today.*

Two things are worth pausing on. First, Cassius already knows Casca's temperament — his "sour fashion" (bitter, sarcastic manner) — which tells you that Cassius has been studying men for some time; he knows who will talk and how. Second, Shakespeare is preparing you to receive the most important event of the day (the crown) through a witness who is pre-labelled as cynical. Keep that in mind; we will return to it in the first PROFESSOR'S INSIGHT.

"The angry spot doth glow on Caesar's brow" — reading faces from a distance

Original line / short passage:

Brutus: *The angry spot doth glow on Caesar's brow, / And all the rest look like a chidden train. / Calpurnia's cheek is pale, and Cicero Looks with such ferret and such fiery eyes / As we have seen him in the Capitol, / Being crossed in conference by some senators.*

Simple English: Look, Cassius — there is a red flush of anger on Caesar's forehead, and everyone around him looks like a group of people who have just been told off. Calpurnia's face is white, and Cicero's eyes have that sharp, angry, ferret-like glare he gets in the Senate when other senators contradict him in debate.

Difficult words: *spot* — here, a flush or patch of colour (of anger) on the skin; *doth glow* — is burning, is bright (the anger is visible as heat); *brow* — forehead; *chidden* — scolded, rebuked (from the old verb *chide*); *train* — the followers or retinue who walk behind a great man; *ferret* — a small, fierce hunting animal with

reddish, glittering eyes; used here as an adjective, 'ferret-like'; *fiery* — blazing, furious; *the Capitol* — the Capitoline Hill, where Shakespeare (following his sources loosely) imagines the Senate meeting; *crossed* — contradicted, opposed; *in conference* — in debate or discussion.

Literal meaning: Brutus describes the physical appearance of five things in six lines: Caesar's forehead, the followers' collective expression, Calpurnia's colour, Cicero's eyes, and a remembered occasion in the Senate when Cicero looked the same way.

Subtext: Something has gone badly wrong at the games, and Brutus can read the results on every face before anyone has said a word. The people who were meant to be celebrating look punished. This tells him — and us — that the shouting we heard was not a simple triumph for Caesar.

Hidden meaning: The whole group's mood is set by one man's mood. When Caesar is angry, "all the rest" look scolded. That is a picture of a court, not of a republic of equals. Brutus does not say this; he simply observes it, and the observation does part of Cassius's work for him. Shakespeare lets Brutus's own eyes confirm what Cassius has been arguing: Rome has become a place organised around a single temper.

Character psychology: Brutus here is an acute observer — calm, exact, attentive to colour and detail. This matters because a lazy reading of Brutus makes him an unworldly dreamer. He is not; he sees clearly. His tragedy is not that he fails to perceive but that he will later reason himself past what he perceives. Notice too the fairness of his attention: he looks at Calpurnia's suffering as well as Caesar's anger.

Political meaning: Cicero is the great senatorial voice of the old Republic, and Brutus has seen him "crossed" — contradicted — by other senators. The scene thus reminds us that the Senate is not a united body of freedom-lovers; it contains men who oppose Cicero, presumably Caesar's supporters. The Republic is already divided from within, which is exactly the condition that lets a strongman rise.

Historical context: HISTORICAL RECORD — Cicero (106–43 BC) was Rome's greatest orator and a lifelong defender of the senatorial Republic; he was not a member of the conspiracy and was killed on the orders of the triumvirs in December 43 BC. Calpurnia married Caesar in 59 BC and was childless; Plutarch records her ominous dream on the night before the Ides. Shakespeare's picture of the Senate meeting on the Capitol is his own simplification: historically the Senate met in various buildings, and Caesar was killed in the Curia of Pompey, not on the Capitol.

Literary devices: *Metaphor* — anger is an "angry spot" that "doth glow", as if a coal were burning under the skin. *Simile* — the followers "look like a chidden train". *Animal imagery* — Cicero's "ferret" eyes: small, red, restless, predatory; the ferret is a hunter that goes down holes, and Cicero is a debater who pursues an opponent. *Alliteration* — "ferret and such fiery" drives the phrase forward. *Colour contrast* — the red glow on Caesar's brow set against Calpurnia's pale cheek.

Effect: In six lines the audience is told, without a single word of dialogue from the procession, that the celebration has soured. Suspense is created: we want to know what happened, and Shakespeare will make us wait for Casca to tell us.

Dramatic significance: This speech turns the stage into a picture we must interpret. Brutus is doing what the whole play asks its audience to do — reading signs. It also sets up the next exchange, in which Caesar, in turn, reads Cassius's face and body.

Foreshadowing: Calpurnia's pallor anticipates her fear in Act 2 Scene 2, when her dream and the omens make her beg Caesar to stay at home. The "angry spot" anticipates the irritable, absolute Caesar of Act 3 Scene 1, who brushes aside petitions before the murder. Cicero's fierce dissent points forward to Act 2 Scene 1, where the conspirators debate whether to recruit him and Brutus refuses.

Scene connection: Scene 2 is a scene of face-reading from beginning to end. Cassius began by reading Brutus's face ("I have not from your eyes that gentleness"), then offered to be Brutus's mirror; now Brutus reads Caesar's face; in a moment Caesar will read Cassius's. Go back to Chapter 04 and you will see that the mirror motif — "the eye sees not itself / But by reflection" — governs this passage too: each man learns about power by looking at another's face.

ICSE keywords: observation; visual imagery; simile; animal imagery; foreshadowing; court versus republic; dramatic tension.

Exam application: If an extract question asks what Brutus's description reveals, do not simply list the faces. Interpret them: 'Brutus's picture of a "chidden train" shows a Rome in which everyone's mood depends on Caesar's temper, and Calpurnia's pale cheek quietly prepares us for her terror in Act 2 Scene 2.'

Caesar's opinion of Cassius

Caesar does not speak to Brutus or Cassius as he passes. He speaks to Antony — but he speaks about Cassius, and he does so within earshot of the audience. This is the first time in the play we hear Caesar in something like a private register: not giving orders, not dismissing a soothsayer, but confiding. What he confides is a theory of men.

"Let me have men about me that are fat" — the physical description of Cassius

Original line / short passage:

Caesar: *Let me have men about me that are fat, / Sleek-headed men, and such as sleep a-nights. / Yond Cassius has a lean and hungry look. / He thinks too much. Such men are dangerous.*

Simple English: I want the men around me to be well fed, smooth-haired and able to sleep at night. That Cassius over there looks thin and hungry. He thinks too much. Men like that are dangerous.

Difficult words: *fat* — well fed, comfortable, contented (not an insult in this context); *Sleek-headed* — with smooth, glossy, well-groomed hair, the mark of a man at ease with himself; *a-nights* — at night (an old adverbial form); *Yond* — that one over there (short for *yonder*); *lean* — thin, spare; *hungry look* — an appearance of wanting something he does not have; *dangerous* — threatening, a risk to me.

Literal meaning: Caesar states a preference for contented men who sleep well, contrasts Cassius's thin and restless appearance with it, and concludes that a thinker like Cassius is a threat.

Subtext: Caesar has noticed Cassius watching him. The word "hungry" is not about food; it names appetite — for honour, for position, for what Caesar has. Caesar reads that appetite in a body, and he is right.

Hidden meaning: A ruler who wants only fat, sleek, sleeping men around him is asking for a court of flatterers who never think. That is exactly the environment in which a tyrant is both comfortable and blind. Caesar's preference is intelligent as self-protection and disastrous as statecraft: the men who will kill him are the thinkers he wishes to exclude, and the men he wishes to keep (Antony) cannot see the danger.

Character psychology: Here is Caesar the connoisseur of human types. He sorts people by appearance, appetite and sleep — a general's habit, formed over years of judging soldiers. It is also the psychology of a man who has begun to think in terms of 'men about me': a personal circle, a retinue, a court. The republican vocabulary of colleagues and equals has vanished from his speech.

Political meaning: In a republic, a magistrate does not choose the men "about" him; he shares power with elected equals. Caesar's sentence assumes he can select his company like a king choosing courtiers. The line is therefore evidence for Cassius's case even as it warns against Cassius.

Historical context: HISTORICAL RECORD — Plutarch reports Caesar saying that he did not fear fat, long-haired men, but the pale, thin ones — and Plutarch explains that he meant Brutus and Cassius. LITERARY INTERPRETATION — Shakespeare aims the remark at Cassius alone. One strong reading is that this protects Brutus's image (Caesar never suspects him, which makes the betrayal more painful) and sharpens the contrast between the two conspirators.

Literary devices: *Antithesis* — the fat, sleek sleepers against the lean, hungry thinker.

Synecdoche/physiognomy — the body stands for the mind: Cassius's leanness signifies discontent. *Aphorism* — "Such men are dangerous" has the clipped finality of a maxim; Caesar speaks in rules. *Irony* — Caesar diagnoses the disease precisely and then refuses the cure.

Effect: The audience, having spent Part One inside Cassius's resentment, suddenly sees him from the outside, through Caesar's eyes — and Caesar's picture matches what we have just heard. This double view makes Cassius more vivid and Caesar more formidable.

Dramatic significance: For the first time, Caesar is shown to be perceptive. If Shakespeare had made Caesar a fool, his fall would be merely deserved; by making him see the danger and wave it away, Shakespeare makes the fall tragic.

Foreshadowing: The wish for men "such as sleep a-nights" prepares us for Act 2 Scene 1, where Brutus confesses that he has not slept since Cassius first stirred him against Caesar. The sleepless conspirator is the exact opposite of the man Caesar wants near him.

Scene connection: Cassius has just told Brutus "Upon what meat doth this our Caesar feed / That he is grown so great?" — a hungry man's question about another man's feeding. Now Caesar answers, unknowingly, in the same vocabulary: he wants fat men, and he sees that Cassius is hungry. The scene's food imagery (fat, lean, hungry, meat, and later sauce, stomach, appetite and "chew upon this") binds the two conversations together.

ICSE keywords: characterisation through physical description; antithesis; aphorism; irony; physiognomy; foreshadowing; imagery of appetite.

Exam application: A strong answer uses the line to show two things at once: 'Caesar's remark that Cassius "thinks too much" reveals both his shrewd judgement of men and the flaw that destroys him, for a ruler who surrounds himself only with "sleek-headed men" has chosen comfort over truth.'

Antony's reassurance — "He is a noble Roman, and well given"

Original line / short passage:

Antony: *Fear him not, Caesar; he's not dangerous. / He is a noble Roman, and well given.*

Simple English: Do not fear him, Caesar; he is not dangerous. He is a noble Roman with a good disposition.

Difficult words: *Fear him not* — do not be afraid of him; *noble* — of high birth and, by implication, high character; *well given* — well disposed, of good inclination and temperament.

Literary meaning: Antony dismisses Caesar's suspicion and vouches for Cassius's character.

Subtext: Antony either does not see what Caesar sees, or he sees it and chooses to soothe his master in public. Either way, the reassurance is worthless: the audience has just heard Cassius call Caesar "such a thing" and swear he would rather not live than live in awe of him.

Hidden meaning: The word "noble" is doing dangerous work. Cassius is noble in rank; whether he is noble in conduct is precisely what the play will put on trial. Antony uses the word as if rank guaranteed virtue, and Caesar, who prides himself on reading men, hears an empty compliment.

Character psychology: This is the Antony of Act 1 — loyal, easy, quick to comfort, more interested in the games than in political undercurrents. It is a genuine part of him; Caesar will describe him in a moment as a man who loves plays and music. The audience should store this impression, because the Antony of Act 3 — the reader of crowds, the improviser, the avenger — will seem to have been born in the instant he sees Caesar's corpse. Shakespeare plants the easy Antony here so that the transformation later is a shock.

Political meaning: Antony is Caesar's colleague as consul and his most trusted lieutenant, yet his political intelligence in this scene is nil. Caesar's court is loyal but not watchful. The person who could have protected him tells him there is nothing to fear.

Historical context: HISTORICAL RECORD — Mark Antony (83–30 BC) had served under Caesar in Gaul from 54 BC, commanded his left wing at Pharsalus and was his fellow consul in 44 BC; he had a well-known reputation for revelry, which Shakespeare uses. Cassius (c. 86–42 BC) had fought against Caesar under Pompey and had been pardoned by him — a man with every reason, in Roman terms, to resent the mercy that bound him.

Literary devices: *Dramatic irony* — the audience knows what Antony does not. *Antithesis* — the flat denial "he's not dangerous" answers Caesar's "Such men are dangerous" word for word, making the disagreement crisp. *Epithet* — "noble Roman" is a formula, and formulas are what men use when they have not looked closely.

Effect: The audience feels a small chill: the one man in a position to warn Caesar has waved the warning away. Our knowledge is now painfully greater than Caesar's.

Dramatic significance: This exchange establishes the pattern of the whole tragedy — Caesar receives accurate warnings and is talked out of them. Here the talker is loyal Antony; in Act 2 Scene 2 it will be Decius Brutus; in Act 3 Scene 1 Caesar will talk himself out of them.

Foreshadowing: Antony's misjudgement of the conspirators here contrasts with his devastating accuracy about them later: in Act 5 Scene 1 he will remind Cassius and Brutus of how they smiled and fawned on Caesar while planning to kill him. The man who once said Cassius was "not dangerous" becomes the man who understands the conspirators best.

Scene connection: Cassius has spent Part One insisting that he is not a flatterer — that he does not "fawn on men and hug them hard / And after scandal them". Antony's reassurance shows the flatterer's opposite danger: honest good nature that fails to see.

ICSE keywords: dramatic irony; loyalty; misjudgement; characterisation by contrast; the contested word 'noble'.

Exam application: Use this when writing about Antony's development: 'In Act 1 Antony can call Cassius "a noble Roman, and well given"; by Act 3 he has become the play's most penetrating reader of men — Shakespeare plants the easy-going lieutenant so that the avenger's emergence astonishes us.'

Caesar's political intelligence — "He reads much, / He is a great observer"

Original line / short passage:

Caesar: *He reads much, / He is a great observer, and he looks / Quite through the deeds of men. He loves no plays, / As thou dost, Antony; he hears no music; / Seldom he smiles, and smiles in such a sort / As if he mocked himself and scorned his spirit / That could be moved to smile at anything.*

Simple English: He reads a great deal; he watches everything, and he sees straight through what men do to their real motives. He does not enjoy plays the way you do, Antony; he does not listen to music. He rarely smiles, and when he does, it is as though he were laughing at himself and despising his own spirit for being capable of smiling at anything.

Difficult words: *observer* — one who watches and notices; *looks / Quite through* — sees right through, penetrates to the truth beneath; *deeds* — actions; *plays* — theatrical performances; *sort* — manner, way; *mocked* — ridiculed; *scorned* — despised; *spirit* — inner self, temperament; *moved* — stirred, prompted.

Literal meaning: Caesar lists Cassius's habits: reading, observation, penetration into motives, indifference to entertainment and music, rare and self-mocking smiles.

Subtext: Caesar is describing a man who cannot be pleased and cannot be bought, because he takes no pleasure in the things (plays, music, feasting) by which a ruler usually buys men. That makes Cassius immune to Caesar's favour — and therefore uncontrollable.

Hidden meaning: Caesar is also, without knowing it, describing the audience's own experience of Part One. We watched Cassius observe Brutus, read his face, look "Quite through" his silence. Caesar's portrait is a summary of the seduction we have just seen. The dramatist lets his character review the play so far.

Character psychology: This is a brilliant piece of psychological portraiture — and it is Caesar's, not Cassius's. The detail about the smile is extraordinary: Cassius smiles as if he despised himself for smiling. That is the self-mockery of a man who thinks joy is a weakness. It matches everything Cassius has said about not being "a common laughter" and about preferring death to living in awe. Caesar sees the self-contempt at the root of Cassius's envy. The great irony is that a man this perceptive about Cassius sees nothing at all about Brutus.

Political meaning: Caesar's list is a portrait of the ideal conspirator: literate, watchful, sceptical, humourless, unmoved by public spectacle. In a political culture that runs on spectacle — triumphs, festivals, crowns offered in the marketplace — the man who "loves no plays" is the man the spectacle cannot capture. Caesar, whose power depends on performance, instinctively fears the one spectator who refuses to applaud.

Historical context: HISTORICAL RECORD — Cassius was an Epicurean, a philosophical school that valued reasoned observation and was sceptical of superstition (this makes his later reading of the storm in Scene 3 a departure that Chapter 06 examines). Antony's love of entertainment is well attested in the ancient sources. LITERARY INTERPRETATION — the idea that a man who "hears no music" is morally suspect was a familiar Elizabethan notion; in *The Merchant of Venice* Shakespeare gives Lorenzo a speech arguing that a man with no music in himself is not to be trusted. Caesar's remark draws on that shared assumption.

Literary devices: *Accumulation* — the portrait is built from a list of short clauses, each adding a trait. *Contrast* — Cassius set against Antony ("As thou dost, Antony") so that the two men are defined by each other. *Paradox* — a smile that scorns smiling. *Characterisation by report* — we learn Cassius's nature through another character's description, a technique this scene uses repeatedly.

Effect: The audience is unsettled by how right Caesar is. Our sense of Caesar's intelligence rises sharply at the very moment we know his intelligence will not save him.

Dramatic significance: This passage prevents the play from becoming a simple story of a tyrant's blindness. Caesar sees. The tragedy lies in the gap between seeing and acting.

Foreshadowing: Cassius's penetration into "the deeds of men" is exactly what he will use in Scene 3 to recruit Casca and in Act 2 Scene 1 to argue (rightly, as it turns out) that Antony should die with Caesar. Brutus overrules him. The observer is correct and ignored — twice over, by Caesar and by Brutus.

Scene connection: Cassius told Brutus that "the eye sees not itself / But by reflection". Caesar now acts as Cassius's mirror, showing us a face Cassius cannot see: a man who despises his own capacity for pleasure. The mirror motif has passed from Cassius's hands into Caesar's.

ICSE keywords: characterisation by report; perceptiveness; paradox; contrast; the observer figure; irony of the unheeded warning.

Exam application: When asked to compare Cassius and Antony, this passage is your anchor: 'Caesar himself supplies the contrast — Cassius "loves no plays" and "hears no music", while Antony does; the man who cannot be entertained cannot be bought, and Caesar recognises the danger in the very qualities that make Cassius the conspiracy's engine.'

Caesar's fear and his self-contradiction — "for always I am Caesar" and "this ear is deaf"

Original line / short passage:

Caesar: *Would he were fatter! But I fear him not. / Yet if my name were liable to fear, / I do not know the man I should avoid / So soon as that spare Cassius.*

Caesar: *I rather tell thee what is to be feared / Than what I fear; for always I am Caesar. / Come on my right hand, for this ear is deaf, / And tell me truly what thou think'st of him.*

Simple English: I wish he were fatter! But I am not afraid of him. And yet, if the name 'Caesar' were capable of fear, I do not know anyone I would avoid sooner than that thin Cassius. [...] I am telling you what ought to be feared, not what I fear — because I am always Caesar. Come round to my right side, since this ear is deaf, and tell me honestly what you think of him.

Difficult words: *Would he were* — I wish he were; *liable to* — subject to, capable of; *avoid* — keep away from; *So soon as* — as quickly as, sooner than; *spare* — thin, lean; *what is to be feared* — what deserves fear (in general); *always* — at all times, unchangingly; *right hand* — right side; *deaf* — unable to hear; *truly* — honestly.

Literal meaning: Caesar repeats that he is not afraid, then admits that if his name could feel fear Cassius is the man he would most avoid; he claims to be describing fear in the abstract rather than his own; and he asks Antony to move to his hearing side and give an honest opinion.

Subtext: Every denial of fear is followed by a description of fear. "I fear him not" — but here is the man I would avoid. "I rather tell thee what is to be feared / Than what I fear" — but the two are the same man. Caesar is afraid, and the shape of his sentences shows it even as their content denies it.

Hidden meaning: Look at the grammar of "if my name were liable to fear". Caesar does not say 'if I were'. He splits himself into the man and the name. The name 'Caesar' cannot fear; the man, whose ear is deaf, plainly can. Cassius attacked the name in Part One — "what should be in that 'Caesar'?" — arguing that it is only a sound. Caesar now takes refuge inside that sound. He has begun to believe that 'Caesar' is a thing greater than himself, and he speaks of it in the third person: "always I am Caesar".

Character psychology: This is the psychology of a man performing invulnerability to himself. The third-person self-reference is not vanity for its own sake; it is a coping device. A general who has survived civil war cannot afford to look afraid, so he invents a public self that is exempt from fear and then hides the private self

behind it. The request that follows — "tell me truly" — is poignant: the man behind the name does want honest counsel, but he has just told his counsellor that Caesar does not fear, which makes honest counsel almost impossible to give.

Political meaning: Caesar's constancy — "always I am Caesar" — is the foundation of his claim to rule: he is the fixed point around which changeable Rome can organise itself. But a republic distrusts fixed points; its whole design (two consuls, annual elections, tribunes with vetoes) exists to prevent any one man from being 'always' anything. The line is therefore both a boast and, to republican ears, a confession.

Historical context: HISTORICAL RECORD — no ancient source records that Caesar was deaf; the deaf ear appears to be Shakespeare's invention. By contrast, the "falling sickness" that Casca is about to report is in Plutarch and Suetonius. Shakespeare therefore adds a bodily weakness of his own to those his sources gave him.

Literary devices: *Antithesis* — "what is to be feared" against "what I fear". *Illeism* — the habit of referring to oneself in the third person ("always I am Caesar"), which Shakespeare makes Caesar's verbal signature. *Irony* — the assertion of permanence ("always") is followed within a line by the admission of a permanent defect. *Juxtaposition* — the grand abstract claim and the small physical fact placed side by side. *Bathos* — the descent from the majestic to the mundane deflates the boast.

Effect: The audience experiences a double response: awe at the confidence and a flicker of pity or unease at the deaf ear. Shakespeare wants both. A Caesar who was only a tyrant would not need to be pitied; a Caesar who was only a victim would not need to be killed.

Dramatic significance: This is the moment the play defines its Caesar: a colossal public self mounted on a fallible private body. Everything Cassius said about the fever in Spain and the failed swim is confirmed from Caesar's own mouth.

Foreshadowing: "always I am Caesar" is the seed of the great constancy speech of Act 3 Scene 1, in which Caesar compares himself to the northern star, the one fixed point in a moving sky — moments before he is stabbed. The deaf ear anticipates every warning he will fail to hear: the Soothsayer, Artemidorus's letter, Calpurnia's pleading.

Scene connection: In Part One Cassius catalogued Caesar's body — the shaking fever, the coward lips, the cry for help in the Tiber. Caesar now adds an item to Cassius's list himself. The scene has been arranged so that the slander and the confession meet.

ICSE keywords: illeism (third-person self-reference); hubris; antithesis; irony; the body politic and the body natural; foreshadowing; appearance versus reality.

Exam application: This is one of the most useful passages in Act 1 for any later answer on Caesar's character: "When Caesar declares "for always I am Caesar" and in the same breath asks Antony to move to his good ear because "this ear is deaf", Shakespeare sets the immortal name against the mortal body — the same gap that Antony will exploit when he shows the crowd the wounds in Act 3."

PROFESSOR'S INSIGHT**Why Caesar's deaf ear matters — Shakespeare's invention and the great man's body**

No ancient source gives Caesar a deaf ear. Plutarch and Suetonius give him epilepsy; Shakespeare takes that and then adds deafness, on his own authority, at a very precise moment — the instant after Caesar has claimed to be permanently, unchangeably himself. Ask why a dramatist would invent a disability for his title character. One answer is theatrical: the actor must physically turn, so the audience *sees* the great man rearrange himself around a weakness. A second answer is structural: the play is built on the gap between the *name* of Caesar and the *body* of Caesar. Cassius has slandered the body (the fever, the near-drowning); Casca is about to describe it collapsing in the marketplace; Antony will exhibit it, wounded, in the Forum; and in Acts 4 and 5 the name will go on working after the body is dead, as the conspirators feel Caesar's spirit walking abroad. The deaf ear is the smallest, most intimate item in that catalogue, and the only one Caesar reports himself. A third answer is symbolic, and here you must be careful to say 'many readers feel' rather than 'Shakespeare means': a man who cannot hear on one side is a man who will not hear warnings, and Caesar is about to ignore several. The line rewards you in an exam precisely because it is small — it shows you have noticed how Shakespeare undercuts the boast with the body, rather than merely repeating that Caesar was proud.

HISTORICAL CONTEXT **Plutarch's thin men, and how Shakespeare re-aims the remark**

HISTORICAL RECORD — Plutarch, in the *Life of Caesar* that Shakespeare read in Sir Thomas North's 1579 English translation, records that Caesar said he did not fear fat, long-haired men, but the pale and thin ones — and that he meant Brutus and Cassius. Plutarch also records the epilepsy (the "falling sickness"), the Lupercalia offer of a diadem, and the deposition of the two tribunes. **LITERARY INTERPRETATION** — Shakespeare keeps the fat-and-thin idea but points it only at Cassius and removes Brutus from Caesar's suspicion entirely. The effect is to make Caesar's trust in Brutus complete, so that the betrayal in Act 3 lands with full weight, and to make Cassius the play's official 'dangerous man' — a label that his soliloquy at the end of this scene will confirm from the inside.

LEVEL 2 — What does it mean?

The procession passage means three things. First, Rome has become a place where one man's anger scolds a whole crowd of senators — Brutus sees this without being told. Second, Caesar is not blind: he reads Cassius exactly, down to the self-mocking smile, and understands that a man who takes no pleasure in plays or music cannot be bought with favours. Third, Caesar's response to what he sees is to deny fear and take refuge in his name — "always I am Caesar" — while his body, in the same breath, admits a deaf ear. The meaning is not 'Caesar is arrogant'. It is that Caesar has split himself into an unchanging public name and a fallible private man, and has chosen to act as the name. That choice is what makes the warnings of Acts 2 and 3 useless to him.

Casca's report: the crown offered three times

The procession leaves to a trumpet signal (the stage direction calls it a *sennet*), and one man is left behind, because Brutus has caught hold of his cloak. Casca's first words are a grumble — "You pulled me by the cloak. Would you speak with me?" — and from that moment the scene changes key. Brutus and Cassius have spoken

in verse throughout. Casca speaks in **prose**. In Scene 1 prose belonged to the commoners and verse to the tribunes; here a patrician chooses prose, and the choice is a character note. Casca's plainness is a style he puts on, a way of refusing to be impressed. Keep that in mind when Cassius later calls it his "tardy form".

Brutus asks what has happened "That Caesar looks so sad" (*sad* here means serious, grave — not tearful). Casca's first answer is a tease — "Why, you were with him, were you not?" — and only then does he begin the story that the whole first half of the scene has been waiting for.

PROFESSOR'S INSIGHT Why the crown offering is reported by a cynic rather than shown

Shakespeare could have staged the offer of the crown. He had a stage, an Antony, a Caesar and a crowd of hired men. Instead he sends the procession off, brings back one sour witness, and makes us hear the day's central political event second-hand, in prose, from a man who says twice "to my thinking" and once "I did not mark it". Why? Partly economy — a marketplace of thousands cannot be shown — but the deeper reason is that the play is about interpretation. From Scene 1 onward, Rome is a city of people construing signs: the tribunes construe the holiday, Cassius construes Brutus's face, Cicero will say in Scene 3 that "men may construe things after their fashion". By denying us the event itself, Shakespeare places us where every Roman stands: dependent on a report, obliged to judge the reporter. Casca's opinion that Caesar "would fain have had it" is exactly that — an opinion — and Shakespeare flags it as one. We never learn whether Caesar wanted the crown. That uncertainty is the play's engine: Brutus will kill Caesar for an ambition that is never demonstrated on stage, only reported and inferred. A school guide will tell you that Casca 'reveals Caesar's hypocrisy'. The truer statement is that Casca reveals how Rome reads Caesar, and that Shakespeare has deliberately left the man himself unreadable.

"he put it by with the back of his hand" — the first telling

Original line / short passage:

Casca: *Why, there was a crown offered him; and, being offered him, he put it by with the back of his hand, thus, and then the people fell a-shouting.*

Casca: *Ay, marry, was 't, and he put it by thrice, every time gentler than other; and at every putting-by, mine honest neighbours shouted.*

Simple English: Well, someone offered him a crown, and when it was offered he pushed it away with the back of his hand — like this — and then the people started shouting. [...] Yes, indeed it was offered three times, and he pushed it away three times, each time more gently than the last; and every time he pushed it away, my honest neighbours in the crowd cheered.

Difficult words: *put it by* — pushed it aside, refused it; *thus* — like this (Casca demonstrates the gesture on stage); *fell a-shouting* — began to shout; *marry* — a mild oath, 'indeed', 'by the Virgin Mary' (an Elizabethan word in a Roman mouth); *was 't* — was it; *thrice* — three times; *gentler than other* — more gently than the previous time; *putting-by* — act of refusal; *mine honest neighbours* — the people standing near me (heavily sarcastic: Casca despises them).

Literal meaning: Casca states the bare facts — a crown was offered, refused with a backhanded gesture, and cheered — and then, under questioning, adds that this happened three times, each refusal gentler than the one before.

Subtext: The detail "every time gentler than other" is the sting. A man who means his refusal refuses harder each time; a man who is testing the crowd refuses more softly, waiting for the cheers to turn. Casca notices the softening and lets it speak for itself.

Hidden meaning: "with the back of his hand" is a gesture of contempt — the way one brushes off a fly or a beggar. Caesar's public refusal is performed as disdain, which is exactly how a man who wants to be seen as above kingship would perform it. Casca's "thus" turns the actor into a mimic; for a second the stage holds two Caesars, the real one who has just left and the parody one Casca is doing.

Character psychology: Casca answers each question with the minimum — "Why, for that too" — forcing Brutus and Cassius to drag the story out of him. This is not stupidity; it is a man who enjoys making his superiors wait, and who protects himself by pretending indifference to what he has watched very closely.

Political meaning: Three shouts, three refusals, and each shout is for the refusal. The crowd's message is unambiguous: they do not want a king. Whatever Caesar wanted, the people have told him he cannot yet have it. This is the day's real news, and it explains the "angry spot" Brutus saw on Caesar's brow.

Historical context: HISTORICAL RECORD — Plutarch describes Antony, running as a Lupercus at the festival of 15 February 44 BC, offering Caesar a diadem wrapped with laurel; the crowd applauded feebly at the offer and loudly at the refusal, and Caesar finally sent the diadem to the Capitol as an offering to Jupiter. In Plutarch the offer and refusal happen twice. Shakespeare's Casca says three times — a change that gives the episode the shape of a ritual or a fairy-tale test.

Literary devices: *Reported action* — the central event is narrated, not staged. *Repetition* — "Why, for that too" twice, then "thrice" and "every time" build the pattern of three. *Gesture as stage business* — Casca's "the back of his hand, thus" is a written instruction to the actor to mime the gesture. *Sarcasm* — "mine honest neighbours".

Effect: The audience finally understands the three shouts they heard during Part One. Suspense is released, but with a twist: the refusals were greeted with joy, and Caesar is angry. The gap between what the people wanted and what Caesar wanted opens on stage.

Dramatic significance: This is the retrospective key to the whole first half of the scene. Every flourish and shout that interrupted Cassius's seduction now has a meaning, and the meaning is that Rome does not want Caesar crowned — which means the conspirators' fear of a king is, at this moment, unproven.

Foreshadowing: In Act 3 Scene 2, Antony will remind the crowd that Caesar three times refused a kingly crown at the Lupercal, and use the refusal as proof that he was not ambitious. The same event that Casca tells cynically will be retold generously by Antony — and the crowd will believe Antony. Shakespeare plants the fact here so that its later use can be measured.

Scene connection: The three shouts were heard in Part One: "What means this shouting? I do fear the people / Choose Caesar for their king." Brutus feared the opposite of what happened. Cassius made use of Brutus's fear at the time; Casca's report shows the fear was, on that day, misplaced.

ICSE keywords: reported action; sarcasm; pattern of three; gesture; crowd psychology; dramatic irony; public opinion.

Exam application: 'Casca's observation that Caesar refused "every time gentler than other" is the detail an examiner wants you to notice, because it converts a refusal into a test of the crowd — and it is this same triple refusal that Antony will later turn into evidence of Caesar's humility.'

"he would fain have had it" — Casca's reading of Caesar's desire, and the coronet

Original line / short passage:

Casca: *I can as well be hanged as tell the manner of it. It was mere foolery; I did not mark it. I saw Mark Antony offer him a crown (yet 'twas not a crown neither; 'twas one of these coronets), and, as I told you, he put it by once; but for all that, to my thinking, he would fain have had it. Then he offered it to him again; then he put it by again; but to my thinking, he was very loath to lay his fingers off it.*

Simple English: I could no more describe how it happened than I could describe my own hanging. It was pure nonsense; I did not pay attention. I saw Mark Antony offer him a crown — though it was not really a crown, it was one of those small coronets — and, as I said, he pushed it away once; but for all that, in my opinion, he would gladly have taken it. Then Antony offered it again; he pushed it away again; but, in my opinion, he was very reluctant to take his fingers off it.

Difficult words: *as well be hanged as* — I could as easily be hanged as (i.e., it is impossible for me); *the manner of it* — the way it happened; *mere foolery* — utter nonsense, a silly show; *mark* — notice, pay attention to; *coronets* — small or lesser crowns, worn by nobles below the rank of king (Casca belittles the object); *fain* — gladly, willingly; *loath* — reluctant, unwilling; *lay his fingers off it* — take his hand away from it.

Literal meaning: Casca claims he cannot describe the event and did not watch it, then describes it in detail — including the object, the two refusals, and his twice-repeated opinion that Caesar wanted the crown.

Subtext: The man who "did not mark it" marked everything. Casca's pretence of inattention is a shield; behind it is the sharpest political eye in the marketplace. His contradiction — 'I didn't watch, and here is what I saw' — is a small comedy that tells us how to read his whole performance.

Hidden meaning: "to my thinking" appears twice. Shakespeare could have let Casca assert Caesar's desire as fact. He does not. He makes Casca mark his own reading as an interpretation, and he lets the audience hear the marking. Beneath the surface of the comedy is a warning about evidence: the conspiracy will act on a "thinking", not on a proof.

Character psychology: Casca cannot resist diminishing everything — the crown becomes a mere coronet, the ceremony "foolery", the crowd "honest neighbours". This is the psychology of the disappointed aristocrat who protects his pride by refusing to be impressed by anyone: not Caesar, not Antony, not the people. It is also, as the play will show, the psychology of a man who is more moved than he lets on — he is the one who strikes first in Act 3.

Political meaning: The coronet detail is political. A coronet is a lesser crown; if Antony offered a coronet, the ceremony was a step towards kingship rather than kingship itself — a trial, a way of accustoming Rome to the sight. "very loath to lay his fingers off it" makes Caesar's hand tell the truth his gesture denies. Whether or not Casca is right, his account is the version the conspirators will carry into the night.

Historical context: HISTORICAL RECORD — what Antony offered, according to Plutarch, was a diadem: a white band or fillet of Hellenistic kingship, wrapped with laurel. Romans had hated the very word 'rex' since the expulsion of the Tarquin kings in 509 BC, and a diadem was a Greek, eastern symbol; the offer was therefore doubly provocative. Modern historians disagree about whether Caesar staged the episode to test opinion, whether Antony acted alone, or whether Caesar was genuinely embarrassed; the ancient evidence does not settle it. LITERARY INTERPRETATION — Casca's "would fain have had it" is Shakespeare's addition; Plutarch reports the refusal, not the desire.

Literary devices: *Paradox/self-contradiction* — "I did not mark it" followed by minute observation. *Hyperbole* — "I can as well be hanged". *Diminution* — crown → coronet; ceremony → foolery. *Repetition* — "to my thinking" twice, which both stresses his opinion and (for the alert listener) reduces it to opinion. *Prose rhythm* — the loose, tumbling sentences imitate a man talking, not orating.

Effect: Laughter, then unease. The audience enjoys Casca's grumbling, and then registers that the conspiracy's main piece of evidence against Caesar is one sour man's guess about a hand.

Dramatic significance: This is the passage that plants the idea of Caesar's *ambition* in the play. Note how carefully Shakespeare does it: not through Caesar's words or deeds, but through Casca's "thinking". The word 'ambition' will be Brutus's justification in Act 3 Scene 2 and Antony's target in the same scene. Its evidential roots are here, and they are shallow.

Foreshadowing: Cassius's soliloquy at the end of this scene will promise letters in which "Caesar's ambition shall be glanced at" — hinted at obliquely. Casca has just shown how ambition is glanced at: by inference from a gesture. The method of the letters is the method of the report.

Scene connection: In Scene 1 the tribunes accused the commoners of forgetting Pompey and cheering Caesar. Casca's crowd cheers Caesar's *refusal* of a crown. Put the two together and you have the play's picture of the people: they love Caesar the man and reject Caesar the king — a distinction Antony will exploit and the conspirators will ignore.

ICSE keywords: ambition; interpretation versus evidence; unreliable narration; diminution; irony; appearance versus reality.

Exam application: 'Shakespeare makes Casca say "to my thinking" twice, so that the charge of ambition enters the play as an opinion rather than a fact; a careful answer notes that Brutus will later kill Caesar for an ambition the audience has never actually seen.'

The rabblement, the stinking breath and the swoon

Original line / short passage:

Casca: *He put it the third time by, and still as he refused it the rabblement hooted and clapped their chopped hands and threw up their sweaty nightcaps and uttered such a deal of stinking breath because Caesar refused the crown that it had almost choked Caesar, for he swooned and fell down at it.*

Casca: *He fell down in the marketplace and foamed at mouth and was speechless.*

Simple English: He pushed it away the third time, and every time he refused it the mob whooped and clapped their rough, cracked hands and flung their sweaty caps into the air and let out such a quantity of foul breath because Caesar had refused the crown that it nearly suffocated him — for he fainted and collapsed at it. [...] He collapsed in the marketplace, foamed at the mouth and could not speak.

Difficult words: *still* — continually, every time; *rabblement* — the rabble, the mob (a contemptuous word for the common people); *hooted* — shouted, whooped; *chopped* — chapped, roughened and cracked by work and weather (some editions print 'chapped'); *nightcaps* — soft caps worn in bed; the joke is that the commoners are wearing them in the street; *a deal of* — a quantity of; *stinking breath* — foul-smelling breath; *choked* — suffocated; *swooned* — fainted; *foamed at mouth* — frothed at the mouth (a symptom of a seizure); *speechless* — unable to speak.

Literal meaning: At the third refusal the crowd's noise and bad breath were so overwhelming, in Casca's telling, that Caesar fainted and fell, foaming and unable to speak.

Subtext: Casca gives a mock-medical explanation — the crowd's breath choked Caesar — that is really an insult to the crowd. But underneath the joke lies a fact he cannot sneer away: Caesar collapsed in public at the moment of his greatest political exposure.

Hidden meaning: The crowd's applause is *physical* — hands, caps, breath — and it nearly kills Caesar. Shakespeare is making a picture out of a political truth: the people's approval is Caesar's oxygen, and it can also suffocate him. He depends on their breath; their breath brings him down. The swoon at the third refusal is the body's confession that the performance cost him something.

Character psychology: Casca's disgust at the crowd's bodies — their hands, their sweat, their breath — is class contempt of a very physical kind. He literally holds his breath: "I durst not laugh for fear of opening my lips and receiving the bad air." This is a man who would rather suffocate than share air with commoners. Remember this when, in Scene 3, he calls himself simply "A Roman".

Political meaning: Caesar's power rests on the very "rabblement" his aristocratic peers despise. Casca's contempt for the crowd tells you why the conspiracy will fail in Act 3: men who hold their noses at the people cannot win the people. Antony can, because he does not.

Historical context: HISTORICAL RECORD — Caesar's "falling sickness" (epilepsy) is recorded by Plutarch and Suetonius; modern historians debate the exact diagnosis. Nightcaps, like the "doublet" a few lines later, are Elizabethan items: Shakespeare dresses his Roman crowd as a London crowd, which is why we call these details *anachronisms*. They are not mistakes; they are a way of making the Roman mob feel like the audience standing in the yard of the Globe.

Literary devices: *Hyperbole* — the breath that chokes a man. *Sensory imagery* — sight (caps thrown up), sound (hooting), touch (chopped hands), smell (stinking breath). *Anachronism* — nightcaps. *Bathos* — the crown, the cheers, and then a man face-down in the marketplace. *Contemptuous diction* — "rabblement", "tag-rag" (a few lines later).

Effect: Comedy at the crowd's expense, and then a jolt: the man who was "always I am Caesar" a few minutes ago has been lying speechless in the dirt.

Dramatic significance: The swoon completes the catalogue of Caesar's body that Cassius began: the failed swim, the fever, and now the seizure. It also explains the sour faces Brutus read on the returning procession.

Foreshadowing: Caesar collapsed at the feet of a crowd; in Act 3 Scene 1 he will fall at the feet of the Senate, and in Act 3 Scene 2 his body will be laid before the crowd again by Antony. The marketplace swoon is a rehearsal for the corpse.

Scene connection: Cassius had said, of the fever in Spain, "'Tis true, this god did shake." Casca now supplies the public version of the same truth. Brutus, who dismissed Cassius's anecdotes as "these times", now hears a witness he did not choose.

ICSE keywords: hyperbole; sensory imagery; anachronism; bathos; class contempt; the fallible body; mob.

Exam application: 'Casca's picture of the "rabblement" whose "stinking breath" nearly chokes Caesar is comic, but it carries the play's central political image: Caesar lives on the people's applause and can be suffocated by it — which is exactly what happens, in a different sense, in the Forum in Act 3.'

"the falling sickness" — Brutus's diagnosis and Cassius's bitter pun

Original line / short passage:

Brutus: 'Tis very like; he hath the falling sickness.

Cassius: No, Caesar hath it not; but you and I / And honest Casca, we have the falling sickness.

Simple English: Brutus: That is very likely; he suffers from epilepsy. Cassius: No — Caesar does not have it; it is you and I and honest Casca who have the falling sickness.

Difficult words: *'Tis very like* — that is very probable; *the falling sickness* — the old English name for epilepsy, so called because the sufferer falls down during a fit; *hath* — has; *honest* — here partly sincere, partly flattering (Cassius is recruiting).

Literal meaning: Brutus offers a medical explanation for the collapse; Cassius denies it and transfers the disease to himself, Brutus and Casca.

Subtext: Cassius's pun turns 'falling' from a medical word into a political one: we are the ones who have fallen — into servility, into insignificance beneath Caesar. The disease is not in Caesar's brain but in Rome's freedom.

Hidden meaning: The pun reverses the body politic. Traditionally the state is a body and the ruler its head; a sick head means a sick state. Cassius says the opposite: the head is healthy and the limbs are the sick ones, because they have fallen and will not rise. He is diagnosing Rome — and inviting Casca into the diagnosis with the flattering "honest Casca".

Character psychology: Brutus's line is characteristic: the calm, factual, generous explanation. He gives Caesar the benefit of the medical doubt. Cassius's line is equally characteristic: he cannot hear a fact about Caesar without turning it into a weapon, and he cannot be in a room with a possible ally without testing him. The contrast between the two men is complete in two lines.

Political meaning: This is the first time Cassius draws Casca into a "we" — "honest Casca, we have the falling sickness". Casca's reply — "I know not what you mean by that" — may be genuine puzzlement or a careful refusal to commit in public. Either way, Cassius has planted a seed that he will water in Scene 3.

Historical context: HISTORICAL RECORD — Plutarch and Suetonius record Caesar's epilepsy; whether the historical Caesar had a seizure at the Lupercalia is not recorded, and the swoon appears to be Shakespeare's dramatic addition to the Lupercalia episode.

Literary devices: *Pun* (wordplay on 'falling' — medical collapse versus political subjection). *Metaphor* — servility as disease. *Antithesis* — "Caesar hath it not; but you and I". *Irony* — Cassius speaks of falling and will himself fall, by his own sword, at Philippi.

Effect: A flash of bitter wit that turns Casca's comedy into politics. The audience understands Cassius's meaning before Casca admits to it, which puts us on the inside of the conspiracy before it exists.

Dramatic significance: The line converts a medical anecdote into a recruiting speech in eleven words. It shows how the conspiracy grows: not through argument but through the reinterpretation of everything Caesar does.

Foreshadowing: Cassius's pun on falling anticipates the many falls of the play: Caesar's in Act 3 Scene 1, Cassius's own in Act 5 Scene 3, Brutus's in Act 5 Scene 5.

Scene connection: Brutus's medical calm here matches his fairness in reading the procession; Cassius's twist matches his method in Part One, where every fact about Caesar became an argument.

ICSE keywords: pun; wordplay; body politic; antithesis; recruitment; character contrast.

Exam application: If asked to explain the pun, do both halves: 'Brutus means epilepsy; Cassius means that he, Brutus and Casca have "fallen" into slavery under Caesar — the disease, in his view, is political, and by including "honest Casca" he begins to recruit him.'

HISTORICAL CONTEXT Plutarch's Lupercalia: what Shakespeare kept, changed and added

HISTORICAL RECORD — The Lupercalia was celebrated on 15 February; its priests, the Luperci, ran through Rome striking bystanders with strips of goat-hide to promote fertility (which is why Caesar asks Antony to touch Calpurnia early in this scene). In 44 BC a third college of Luperci, named the Juliani in Caesar's honour, had been created, and Antony, though consul, ran as one of them. Plutarch says Antony offered Caesar a diadem wrapped with laurel; the crowd applauded weakly at the offer and loudly at each refusal; Caesar declined twice and sent the diadem to the Capitol. Historically the triumph the commoners celebrate in Scene 1 took place in October 45 BC, four months before the Lupercalia; Shakespeare compresses the two into one day. **LITERARY INTERPRETATION** — Shakespeare kept the offer, the refusals and the crowd's applause; changed twice to thrice; added the swoon at the marketplace, Casca's reading of Caesar's desire, and the coronet; and, most importantly, chose to report it all rather than stage it.

The crowd as a theatre audience — "as they use to do the players in the theatre"**Original line / short passage:**

Casca: *If the tag-rag people did not clap him and hiss him, according as he pleased and displeased them, as they use to do the players in the theatre, I am no true man.*

Simple English: If the ragged common people did not applaud him and hiss at him, depending on whether he pleased or displeased them, exactly as they do to the actors in a playhouse, then I am a liar.

Difficult words: *tag-rag* — ragged, tattered; the riff-raff; *clap* — applaud; *hiss* — express disapproval by hissing (the Elizabethan audience's equivalent of booing); *according as* — depending on whether; *use to* — are accustomed to; *players* — actors; *I am no true man* — I am not honest (i.e., call me a liar if this is not so).

Literal meaning: Casca swears that the crowd responded to Caesar precisely as a theatre audience responds to actors — applause when pleased, hisses when displeased.

Subtext: Caesar is a performer and the people are his audience — and an audience, unlike a subject, is free to hiss. Casca means it as contempt for the crowd's fickleness; it is also an admission that the crowd holds power over the performer.

Hidden meaning: In 1599 the Globe was itself a new theatre, and the people who paid a penny to stand in its yard were exactly the sort of "tag-rag people" Casca describes. A commoner in the audience hears himself described by a Roman patrician as a clapping, hissing spectator — while clapping and hissing. Shakespeare turns the mirror on his own house: Rome's politics is a play, and the London crowd is its Roman mob.

Character psychology: Casca sees through the ceremony to the performance beneath it, which is a form of intelligence; but his contempt for the audience blinds him to the fact that the audience decides the play's fate. The conspirators will make the same mistake in Act 3.

Political meaning: Politics in this Rome is theatrical: crowns are offered in marketplaces, refusals are performed with the back of the hand, throats are bared. Power belongs to whoever can hold the audience. That, not the Senate, is where sovereignty actually sits — and it is a truth the republican conspirators despise and Antony understands.

Historical context: **HISTORICAL RECORD** — public London playhouses such as the Theatre, the Curtain, the Rose and (from 1599) the Globe drew large, socially mixed audiences whose standing spectators were famously vocal. A Swiss visitor, Thomas Platter, saw a play about Julius Caesar at a Bankside theatre —

almost certainly the Globe — on 21 September 1599.

Literary devices: *Extended metaphor / conceit* — politics as theatre; Caesar as a player. *Metatheatre* — the play refers to its own medium. *Hyperbolic oath* — "I am no true man". *Contemptuous diction* — "tag-rag people".

Effect: Laughter of recognition in the theatre, and a lingering thought: if Caesar is an actor, what is genuine about him? And if the audience decides, who really rules Rome?

Dramatic significance: Casca gives the play its governing metaphor for public life. From here on, every public scene — the Forum speeches above all — can be read as a performance judged by an audience.

Foreshadowing: In Act 2 Scene 1 Brutus will tell the conspirators to hide their purposes as Roman actors do; in Act 3 Scene 2 Brutus and Antony will perform in turn before the same crowd, and the crowd will clap one and then the other. Casca has described the rules of the game they will play.

Scene connection: In Scene 1 the tribunes tried to end a performance — Caesar's triumph — by clearing away its audience. In Scene 2 the audience has come back and is clapping. The tribunes' failure and this metaphor belong together.

ICSE keywords: metatheatre; extended metaphor; the fickle crowd; mob psychology; public opinion; politics as performance.

Exam application: 'Casca's comparison of the crowd to spectators who "clap him and hiss him" gives the play its central image of politics as theatre; the Forum scene in Act 3 is that image acted out, with Brutus and Antony as rival players before the same audience.'

PROFESSOR'S INSIGHT The theatre metaphor for politics — and why it cuts both ways

It is tempting to read Casca's theatre comparison as a simple sneer at the mob. Look harder at who holds power in the image. Actors do not command their audience; they court it, and they can be hissed off the stage. If Caesar is a player, then the "tag-rag people" are his judges, and his fainting fit — the body's collapse under the noise of their approval — shows how much the performance costs him. That is one edge of the metaphor. The other edge is turned towards the conspirators. If politics is theatre, then whoever performs best wins, and the men planning to remove Caesar in the name of truth and liberty will need to perform too. Brutus knows this (he will urge the conspirators to act their parts like Roman actors), but he despises the skill and so performs badly in the Forum, in prose, to reason; Antony performs superbly, in verse, to feeling. The metaphor Shakespeare gives to a cynic in Act 1 therefore predicts the outcome of Act 3. Finally, remember where the line is spoken: on the stage of a playhouse, to a standing crowd. Shakespeare is not only describing Rome; he is describing the room, and inviting his own audience to notice that they, too, are being courted. In an exam, you can use this idea whenever a question asks about the crowd, about Antony's success, or about appearance versus reality — but present it as a strong reading, not as the play's only meaning.

"plucked me ope his doublet and offered them his throat to cut" — Caesar's public performance

Original line / short passage:

Casca: *Marry, before he fell down, when he perceived the common herd was glad he refused the crown, he plucked me ope his doublet and offered them his throat to cut.*

Casca: *When he came to himself again, he said if he had done or said anything amiss, he desired their Worships to think it was his infirmity.*

Simple English: Indeed, before he collapsed, when he saw that the common herd was pleased that he had refused the crown, he tore open his jacket and offered them his throat to cut. [...] When he recovered, he said that if he had done or said anything wrong, he begged their honours to put it down to his illness.

Difficult words: *Marry* — indeed; *perceived* — noticed; *the common herd* — the mass of ordinary people (likened to cattle); *plucked me ope* — tore open (the 'me' is a colloquial filler, roughly 'I tell you'); *doublet* — a close-fitting Elizabethan jacket (an anachronism: Romans wore togas); *offered them his throat to cut* — dramatically invited them to kill him; *came to himself* — regained consciousness; *amiss* — wrongly; *their Worships* — a mock-respectful title for the commoners (Casca's sarcasm, and possibly Caesar's); *infirmity* — illness, weakness.

Literal meaning: Casca reports two gestures: before the fit, Caesar bared his throat to the crowd as if inviting them to kill him; after it, he apologised to them, blaming his illness.

Subtext: Both gestures are theatre. Baring the throat says 'I would rather die than be your king'; the apology says 'I am your humble servant'. Casca, who has just called the crowd an audience, is showing us Caesar's two best scenes. Casca's own comment — that if he had been a working man and had not taken Caesar at his word he would deserve to go to hell among the rogues — means: I would have cut his throat, and I do not believe he meant it.

Hidden meaning: The throat bared in the marketplace will be the body pierced in the Senate. Caesar performs his own death as a gesture of humility, and the gesture is later made real by men who believed the humility was false. There is a terrible circularity in it: the performance of vulnerability invites the reality.

Character psychology: Caesar's instinct, when the crowd cheers his refusal, is to over-perform — to convert a setback into a display of Roman self-sacrifice. This is a man who cannot bear to lose a scene. The apology afterwards is more interesting: it is either sincere humility or the shrewdest move of the day, and Shakespeare, through Casca, leaves us unable to decide.

Political meaning: The bared throat is a bid for the people's love. In a republic, a magistrate's life belongs to the law; Caesar offers his to the crowd, as if they were his sovereign and he their servant. The gesture bypasses the Senate entirely. It is the politics of the popular leader, and it works — the women near Casca forgive him "with all their hearts".

Historical context: HISTORICAL RECORD — Plutarch does not report this gesture at the Lupercalia; he does record that Caesar, on a separate occasion, bared his neck to critics and said anyone who wished might strike. Shakespeare fuses such material into one moment. The "doublet" is an Elizabethan garment, like the nightcaps a few lines earlier.

Literary devices: *Dramatic gesture reported* — the report of a performance within a report. *Anachronism* — "doublet". *Animal metaphor* — "the common herd". *Sarcasm* — "their Worships". *Dramatic irony* — the audience knows the throat will indeed be cut.

Effect: A shiver of foreboding beneath the comedy. The image of Caesar's exposed throat stays in the mind until Act 3 answers it.

Dramatic significance: This is the sharpest example in Act 1 of the play's public/private Caesar: the same man who just confessed a deaf ear in private offers his throat to thousands in public.

Foreshadowing: The offered throat foreshadows the assassination; the apology for "infirmity" foreshadows Caesar's later claim, in Act 2 Scene 2, that he is more dangerous than danger itself — the humble and the arrogant Caesar are one man in two performances.

Scene connection: The three or four "wenches" who cry "Alas, good soul!" and forgive him belong to the crowd Casca has just compared to a theatre audience; Casca's verdict that they would have done the same if Caesar "had stabbed their mothers" completes his portrait of a public that judges by feeling. In Scene 1 the tribunes tried and failed to shame that same public.

ICSE keywords: public performance; dramatic irony; anachronism; sarcasm; appearance versus reality; foreshadowing; the fickle crowd.

Exam application: 'Caesar's offering "his throat to cut" is public theatre — a display of humility that Casca refuses to believe — and it acquires terrible irony when the conspirators cut that throat in the Senate, convinced that the humility was false.'

Cicero speaking Greek — "it was Greek to me"

Original line / short passage:

Casca: *Ay, he spoke Greek.*

Casca: *But those that understood him smiled at one another and shook their heads. But for mine own part, it was Greek to me.*

Simple English: Yes — he spoke in Greek. [...] But the people who understood him smiled at one another and shook their heads. As for me, it was Greek to me — I could not follow it.

Difficult words: *To what effect?* (Cassius's question) — with what meaning, saying what?; *an I tell you that* — if I tell you that; *ne'er* — never; *look you i' th' face* — look you in the face; *for mine own part* — as for me; *it was Greek to me* — I could not understand it (now a proverb, and this line is its most famous early appearance).

Literal meaning: Cicero said something in Greek; those who understood smiled knowingly and shook their heads; Casca claims he did not understand.

Subtext: Educated Romans of Cicero's class spoke Greek fluently — and so, almost certainly, did Casca. His "it was Greek to me" is either a deliberate refusal to repeat a dangerous remark ("an I tell you that, I'll ne'er look you i' th' face again") or a pose of ignorance to match his pose of indifference. Many editors take it as a joke against himself; the text allows either.

Hidden meaning: Cicero chose Greek so that the crowd could not follow him. The smiles and headshakes tell us the remark was critical of Caesar, and shared only among those who could decode it. Dissent in this Rome has gone into a foreign language — a sign of how far free speech has retreated.

Character psychology: Casca protects himself twice in one breath: he refuses to report what Cicero said, and then claims not to have understood it. This is a man who has learned to say nothing quotable. His bluntness is a kind of caution.

Political meaning: Cicero, the Republic's greatest voice, can only criticise Caesar in code, in public, to a select few. The "ferret and such fiery eyes" Brutus saw are explained: Cicero has been silenced not by force but by prudence.

Historical context: HISTORICAL RECORD — Greek was the language of learning and of the eastern Mediterranean, and Roman aristocrats were routinely bilingual; Cicero was a distinguished scholar of Greek philosophy. Shakespeare's Cicero speaks briefly with Casca in Scene 3 and is never recruited; historically he was not part of the conspiracy.

Literary devices: *Proverb / idiom in the making* — "it was Greek to me". *Understatement* — Casca reduces a coded political protest to something he 'did not follow'. *Gesture as communication* — smiles and headshakes replace speech.

Effect: A flicker of comedy that, on reflection, shows how careful everyone has become. Even the play's cleverest man cannot speak plainly.

Dramatic significance: It marks the limit of dissent in Caesar's Rome and prepares the news that follows — the tribunes who *did* speak plainly have been silenced.

Foreshadowing: In Scene 3 Cicero will say that men construe things after their fashion — a philosopher's caution that echoes his coded Greek here. In Act 2 Scene 1 the conspirators will consider recruiting him and Brutus will decline: the man who speaks only in code cannot follow another man's beginning.

Scene connection: Brutus described Cicero's eyes; Casca describes his words; together they complete a portrait of a senator who is furious and muzzled — the Republic's condition in miniature.

ICSE keywords: irony; understatement; coded dissent; proverb; characterisation of Casca and Cicero.

Exam application: 'Casca's "it was Greek to me" is comic, but it also records that Cicero could criticise Caesar only in a language the crowd could not follow — a measure of how far open dissent has already been driven underground.'

The fate of the tribunes — "are put to silence"

Original line / short passage:

Casca: *I could tell you more news too: Marullus and Flavius, for pulling scarves off Caesar's images, are put to silence. Fare you well. There was more foolery yet, if I could remember it.*

Simple English: I could give you more news as well: Marullus and Flavius have been silenced for pulling the decorations off Caesar's statues. Goodbye. There was more nonsense too, if only I could remember it.

Difficult words: *scarves* — the decorative bands or hangings placed on the statues (the "ceremonies" and "trophies" of Scene 1); *images* — statues; *put to silence* — silenced (removed from office, forbidden to speak; the phrase is a euphemism whose exact meaning the play leaves open); *foolery* — nonsense, trivial business.

Literal meaning: The two tribunes we met in Scene 1 have been punished for stripping Caesar's statues.

Subtext: Casca drops the news as an afterthought — "I could tell you more news too" — sandwiched between a joke about Greek and a shrug about "more foolery". The casualness is the point: in this Rome, the removal of two elected tribunes is minor gossip.

Hidden meaning: "put to silence" is chilling because it is vague. Deposed? Imprisoned? Killed? Shakespeare does not say, and the vagueness makes Caesar's power feel unbounded. The man who theatrically refused a crown an hour ago has, in the same day, silenced the officers whose job was to protect the people from exactly such power.

Character psychology: Casca's flat delivery reveals a man who has learned not to react in public. His refusal to editorialise is itself an editorial.

Political meaning: Tribunes were, by law, sacrosanct — untouchable. To silence them for defending the Republic's symbols is to announce that the Republic's protections no longer apply. This single sentence is stronger evidence of Caesar's tyranny than anything in the crown episode, and it is delivered as a footnote.

Historical context: HISTORICAL RECORD — in January 44 BC the tribunes Gaius Epidius Marullus and Lucius Caesetius Flavus removed a diadem placed on Caesar's statue on the Rostra and arrested people who hailed Caesar as 'rex'; Caesar had them deposed from the tribunate (and, according to Suetonius, removed from the Senate). Plutarch says the people hailed them as 'Brutuses' — a detail Shakespeare omits but which chimes with Cassius's appeal to the ancient Brutus in Part One. Historically this happened before the Lupercalia; Shakespeare places it on the same day.

Literary devices: *Euphemism* — "put to silence". *Anticlimax / throwaway delivery* — the gravest news is given the lightest weight. *Structural closure* — the thread begun in Scene 1 ("Disrobe the images") is tied off.

Effect: For the audience, who watched the tribunes give their orders in Scene 1, the news lands harder than it does for Casca's listeners. We saw the crime; we now hear the punishment.

Dramatic significance: Scene 1 and Scene 2 are locked together by this line. The tribunes' resistance has failed and been punished; the resistance now passes from elected officers to private conspirators.

Foreshadowing: The silencing of critics foreshadows the fate of dissent in the play — Cinna the poet torn apart in Act 3 Scene 3 for having the wrong name, the proscriptions of Act 4 Scene 1.

Scene connection: Flavius in Scene 1: "Disrobe the images / If you do find them decked with ceremonies." Casca in Scene 2: for pulling scarves off Caesar's images, "put to silence". Cause and consequence, one scene apart.

ICSE keywords: euphemism; tyranny; tribunes; structural link between scenes; irony of tone; suppression of dissent.

Exam application: 'Casca's throwaway news that Marullus and Flavius "are put to silence" closes the thread opened in Scene 1 and gives the conspiracy its only hard evidence of tyranny — delivered, tellingly, as an afterthought between two jokes.'

Casca's character — "quick mettle", "tardy form" and "a sauce to his good wit"

Before leaving, Casca declines supper tonight ("I am promised forth" — I have a prior engagement) and accepts dinner tomorrow with a triple condition: "Ay, if I be alive, and your mind hold, and your dinner worth the eating." The joke is dry and dark. 'If I be alive' is Casca's ordinary sourness, but the audience hears it as something more, and 'your dinner worth the eating' will prove true in a way he cannot yet know: the meal Cassius is preparing is a conspiracy. Then he is gone, and the two friends judge him.

Original line / short passage:

Brutus: *What a blunt fellow is this grown to be! / He was quick mettle when he went to school.*

Cassius: *So is he now in execution / Of any bold or noble enterprise, / However he puts on this tardy form. / This rudeness is a sauce to his good wit, / Which gives men stomach to digest his words / With better appetite.*

Simple English: Brutus: What a blunt, rough man he has become! He was lively and spirited when we were at school together. Cassius: He still is, when it comes to carrying out any bold or noble undertaking, however much he puts on this slow, dull manner. His rudeness is like a sauce on his sharp intelligence — it gives people an appetite to take in what he says.

Difficult words: *blunt* — rough, plain-spoken; *mettle* — spirit, temperament (spelt 'metal' in some editions; the two words were not yet distinguished, and the pun on metal that can be worked will matter in Cassius's soliloquy); *quick* — lively, alert; *execution* — carrying out, performance; *enterprise* — undertaking, venture; *puts on* — assumes, wears like a costume; *tardy* — slow, sluggish; *form* — outward manner, appearance; *rudeness* — roughness; *sauce* — a relish that sharpens the taste of food; *wit* — intelligence; *stomach* — appetite, inclination; *digest* — take in and absorb.

Literal meaning: Brutus is surprised at how rough Casca has become since their schooldays; Cassius replies that Casca is still spirited in action and that his sluggish manner is a disguise, his rudeness making his intelligence more palatable.

Subtext: Cassius is already thinking of Casca as a recruit — a man of "execution" for a "bold or noble enterprise". He has assessed Casca's usefulness before Brutus has finished being puzzled by his manners.

Hidden meaning: "puts on this tardy form" — the theatrical verb again. Casca *wears* dullness as a costume. In a scene about performance, even the blunt man is performing; the sourness is a mask, and Cassius, the observer who looks "Quite through the deeds of men" (Caesar's phrase), sees through it.

Character psychology: Brutus judges by the past and by manners — he remembers the schoolboy. Cassius judges by present usefulness. Casca himself is a man who hides ability under rudeness, either because he is disappointed or because bluntness is safer than eloquence in Caesar's Rome.

Political meaning: Cassius's phrase "bold or noble enterprise" is the conspiracy's vocabulary before the conspiracy exists. He will use "enterprise" again in Scene 3, of the plot itself.

Historical context: HISTORICAL RECORD — Publius Servilius Casca Longus struck the first blow at Caesar on the Ides of March; he was tribune in 43 BC and died after Philippi. Cassius's confidence in his "execution" is historically well founded.

Literary devices: *Food metaphor* — rudeness as sauce, wit as the dish, listeners' "stomach" and "appetite". *Antithesis* — quick mettle against tardy form. *Costume metaphor* — "puts on". *Characterisation by report* — Casca is defined after he has left.

Effect: A moment of relaxed, almost affectionate talk that lets the audience breathe — and quietly finishes the portrait of a future assassin.

Dramatic significance: The exchange confirms Casca as recruitable and Cassius as the recruiter. It also completes the scene's chain of food images: fat men, lean and hungry men, "what meat" Caesar feeds on, "chew upon this", and now sauce, stomach, digestion and appetite. Power in this scene is something men eat or are eaten by.

Foreshadowing: "in execution / Of any bold or noble enterprise" points straight to Casca's first stroke in Act 3 Scene 1.

Scene connection: Brutus's "chew upon this" was an invitation to digest slowly; Cassius now speaks of giving men "stomach to digest his words". The image passes from Brutus to Cassius exactly as the initiative in the scene has.

ICSE keywords: characterisation; food imagery; antithesis; appearance versus reality; recruitment; foreshadowing.

Exam application: 'Cassius's judgement that Casca's rudeness is "a sauce to his good wit" shows the recruiter at work: while Brutus remembers a schoolboy, Cassius weighs a man of "execution" — and Casca will indeed strike the first blow.'

LEVEL 3 — Why did Shakespeare write it this way?

Ask why the crown episode is *reported*, why it is reported by *Casca*, and why in *prose*. Reported, because the play is about how Romans read Caesar rather than about what Caesar is — the audience must be made to depend on a witness, as Brutus does. By Casca, because a cynic's account leaves Caesar's motives permanently uncertain: "to my thinking" is not evidence, and Shakespeare wants the conspiracy to rest on inference. In prose, because prose belongs to the commoners of Scene 1 and to plain speech; Casca's prose lets Shakespeare change the scene's temperature after Cassius's intense verse, and it marks Casca's bluntness as a chosen style — a "tardy form" he "puts on". Notice also the order of the news: the crown first (the spectacular, ambiguous event), then Cicero's Greek (dissent in code), then the tribunes (dissent punished), each item smaller in Casca's voice and larger in meaning. Shakespeare arranges the report so that the gravest evidence of tyranny arrives as an afterthought, which is how tyranny arrives in real life.

Brutus's parting: "chew upon this" and the appointment for tomorrow

Brutus leaves Cassius twice in this scene, and the two partings should be read together. The first comes just before the procession returns, when he closes the long private conversation with a request to be left alone with his thoughts and a sentence for Cassius to digest. The second comes after Casca has gone, when he makes an appointment for the next day and walks off, leaving Cassius alone on the stage. Part One (Chapter 04) traced the argument that led up to the first parting; here we look at the words of the parting itself, because they tell you exactly how far Brutus has moved — and how far he has not.

"Till then, my noble friend, chew upon this" — the first parting

Original line / short passage:

Brutus: *What you have said / I will consider; what you have to say / I will with patience hear, and find a time / Both meet to hear and answer such high things. / Till then, my noble friend, chew upon this: / Brutus had rather be a villager / Than to repute himself a son of Rome / Under these hard conditions as this time / Is like to lay upon us.*

Simple English: I will think about what you have said; I will listen patiently to whatever else you have to say, and I will find a suitable time to hear and reply to such weighty matters. Until then, my noble friend, think carefully about this: Brutus would rather be a peasant in a village than call himself a citizen of Rome under the harsh conditions that this age looks likely to impose on us.

Difficult words: *consider* — think over; *with patience* — calmly, without interrupting; *meet* — fitting, suitable (an adjective here, not the verb); *high things* — grave, important matters (with a hint of danger); *chew upon* — think over slowly, ruminate (the image is of a cow chewing the cud); *had rather* — would rather; *villager* — a country-dweller of no rank, a nobody; *repute himself* — consider himself, call himself; *a son of Rome* — a Roman citizen, with all the pride that title carries; *hard conditions* — harsh terms (as in the terms of a surrender); *Is like to* — is likely to; *lay upon us* — impose on us.

Literal meaning: Brutus postpones his answer, promises to listen further at a proper time, and gives Cassius one thought to take away: he would rather give up his Roman identity than keep it on the terms that the present age seems about to dictate.

Subtext: Brutus is saying 'not yet' — but he is also saying 'yes, in principle'. A man who would rather be a villager than a Roman under Caesar has already decided that Caesar's Rome is intolerable. What he has not decided is what to do about it. The careful future tenses ("I will consider", "I will with patience hear") hold the door open while refusing to walk through it.

Hidden meaning: Notice who is giving whom something to chew on. For a hundred lines Cassius has been feeding Brutus arguments; now Brutus hands one back. It is a quiet reassertion of dignity — Brutus will not be merely worked upon; he will set the terms. But the thought he offers is more radical than anything Cassius has said: Cassius has argued that Brutus is Caesar's equal; Brutus answers that he would surrender Rome itself rather than live beneath Caesar. The pupil has outrun the teacher, and neither of them remarks on it.

Character psychology: Three things define Brutus here. First, deliberation: he will not answer "such high things" on a street corner. Second, honesty: he does not pretend to be unmoved, and he does not hide his conclusion. Third, the third person — "Brutus had rather be a villager" — the same habit Caesar has. Both men speak of themselves as public figures with public names. It is one of the play's quiet signals that Brutus, the man who will kill Caesar for being Caesar, shares more with him than he knows.

Political meaning: "a son of Rome / Under these hard conditions" treats the Republic as a family and Caesar's rule as a surrender imposed on it. The phrase "hard conditions" is the language of a defeated city accepting terms from a conqueror. In Brutus's mind, then, Rome has already been conquered — by one of her own.

Historical context: HISTORICAL RECORD — the historical Brutus had fought on Pompey's side against Caesar in 49 BC, had been pardoned after Pharsalus, and had since been promoted by Caesar to the governorship of Cisalpine Gaul and the urban praetorship for 44 BC. He lived, in other words, very comfortably under the 'conditions' he here says he cannot bear. Shakespeare simplifies this: his Brutus speaks as a pure republican conscience, not as a beneficiary of Caesar's mercy.

Literary devices: *Metaphor* — thought as food to be chewed ("chew upon this"), which joins the scene's long chain of appetite images. *Antithesis* — "villager" against "son of Rome". *Illeism* — "Brutus had rather". *Parallelism* — "What you have said / I will consider; what you have to say / I will with patience hear" balances past speech against future speech. *Euphemism* — "such high things" for the unspoken subject, conspiracy.

Effect: The audience hears a man refusing to be rushed and yet, in his last four lines, declaring a position from which there is no retreat. The effect is suspense of a particular kind: not 'will he?' but 'how long will it take him to admit that he already has?'

Dramatic significance: This is the first time Brutus states, in his own voice, that Caesar's Rome is unacceptable to him. Everything Cassius does afterwards — the dinner with Casca, the letters, the midnight visit — is built on this sentence. Cassius's reply, "I am glad that my weak words / Have struck but thus much show of fire from Brutus", is false modesty with a sharp accuracy underneath: it was a spark, not yet a fire.

Foreshadowing: The villager who would renounce Rome will, in Act 2 Scene 1, reason his way to the conclusion that Caesar must die for what he might become. The postponed answer is given in his orchard, alone, at night.

Scene connection: Cassius had asked, "Upon what meat doth this our Caesar feed / That he is grown so great?" Brutus now offers Cassius something to "chew upon"; Cassius will shortly describe Casca's rudeness as "a sauce to his good wit" that gives men "stomach to digest his words". Thought, in this scene, is always something eaten.

ICSE keywords: deliberation; internal conflict; illeism; antithesis; metaphor of digestion; republican principle; postponement.

Exam application: When asked how far Cassius succeeds in this scene, quote this and measure it: 'Brutus does not agree to anything, yet his parting thought — that he "had rather be a villager / Than to repute himself a son of Rome" under Caesar — shows that Cassius has won the argument about Rome's condition even though he has not yet won Brutus's hand.'

"Tomorrow... Come home to me" — the second parting and "think of the world"

Original line / short passage:

Brutus: *And so it is. For this time I will leave you. / Tomorrow, if you please to speak with me, / I will come home to you; or, if you will, / Come home to me, and I will wait for you.*

Cassius: *I will do so. Till then, think of the world.*

Simple English: Brutus: Quite so. For now I will leave you. Tomorrow, if you would like to talk to me, I will come to your house; or, if you prefer, come to mine, and I will wait for you there. Cassius: I will. Until then, think about the state of the world.

Difficult words: *And so it is* — that is true (agreeing with Cassius's judgement of Casca); *For this time* — for now, for the present; *if you please to* — if you wish to; *come home to you* — come to your house; *wait for you* — be at home expecting you; *the world* — the state of public affairs, Rome and its condition (not the planet).

Literal meaning: Brutus agrees with Cassius about Casca, says goodbye, and offers to meet tomorrow at either man's house. Cassius accepts and tells him to think about the state of the world in the meantime.

Subtext: This is an appointment, and Brutus makes it. He could have let the matter drop; instead he proposes a private meeting at home, out of the street and out of public view. The man who said 'not yet' has arranged the 'when'.

Hidden meaning: "think of the world" is a very large phrase for a very small farewell. Cassius is asking Brutus to carry the scene's whole argument home with him and to frame his private thoughts as public duty: not 'think of Caesar' or 'think of yourself', but think of the world. It is exactly the frame in which Brutus will reason in Act 2 Scene 1, where he decides against Caesar on grounds of what is good for Rome in general rather than anything Caesar has done to him. Cassius has supplied the frame; Brutus will supply the logic.

Character psychology: Brutus's courtesy is complete — he offers to come to Cassius, then offers his own house, and promises to "wait". This is a generous, honourable man who is also, without noticing it, making himself available for recruitment. Cassius's farewell is short because his real speech is about to begin: the moment Brutus leaves, he turns to the audience.

Political meaning: Politics has moved indoors. In Scene 1 it was in the street; at the start of Scene 2 it was in the open, in a festival; now it is a conversation to be held at home tomorrow. The retreat from public to private is how a conspiracy is born.

Historical context: HISTORICAL RECORD — Plutarch's account has Cassius working on Brutus over a period of time and finally visiting him to ask whether he intends to be in the Senate on the Ides of March; Shakespeare compresses this into one meeting and an appointment, and then, in Scene 3, into a midnight visit to Brutus's house. Shakespeare's Cassius does not wait for tomorrow.

Literary devices: *Dramatic irony* — Brutus speaks of an ordinary social call; the audience, about to hear the soliloquy, knows what tomorrow is for. *Understatement* — "think of the world" compresses the whole case against Caesar into four quiet words.

Effect: Relief and unease together. The tone is friendly and domestic; the content is the first fixed step of a plot.

Dramatic significance: Brutus's exit clears the stage for the first soliloquy of the play. Shakespeare has withheld private speech from everyone until now — even Caesar's confidences were to Antony. The first man allowed to speak his mind alone is the manipulator.

Foreshadowing: The invitation "Come home to me" is accepted in a way Brutus does not intend: in Act 2 Scene 1 the conspirators come to his house at night, hooded, and he receives them.

Scene connection: Cassius's "pluck Casca by the sleeve" and Brutus's "You pulled me by the cloak" were about catching men in the street; "Come home to me" moves the action to the house where Act 2 will begin.

ICSE keywords: dramatic irony; understatement; private versus public; recruitment; structural transition; soliloquy prepared.

Exam application: 'Brutus's offer — "Come home to me, and I will wait for you" — is spoken as ordinary courtesy, but it fixes the first appointment of the conspiracy; Shakespeare lets Brutus himself propose the meeting so that his later involvement cannot be blamed on Cassius alone.'

Cassius alone: the soliloquy

A **soliloquy** is a speech spoken by a character who is alone on stage, in which the convention of the theatre allows us to assume we are hearing the character's true thoughts. It is the most powerful instrument a dramatist has for letting an audience know more than the other characters do. Shakespeare has kept it in reserve for the whole of Act 1 so far. Now, with the stage empty, Cassius speaks fifteen lines that change the meaning of everything you have heard him say. Read the whole speech first, slowly; then we will take it in three parts.

QUOTATION The soliloquy in full

Cassius: *Well, Brutus, thou art noble. Yet I see / Thy honourable mettle may be wrought / From that it is disposed. Therefore it is meet / That noble minds keep ever with their likes; / For who so firm that cannot be seduced? / Caesar doth bear me hard, but he loves Brutus. / If I were Brutus now, and he were Cassius, / He should not humour me. I will this night / In several hands in at his windows throw, / As if they came from several citizens, / Writings, all tending to the great opinion / That Rome holds of his name, wherein obscurely / Caesar's ambition shall be glanced at. / And after this, let Caesar seat him sure, / For we will shake him, or worse days endure.*

Spoken by Cassius, alone, at the very end of Act 1 Scene 2. (Some editions print "metal" for "mettle" and "glanced" for "glancèd"; the sense is the same.)

"Thy honourable mettle may be wrought / From that it is disposed" — the verdict on Brutus

Original line / short passage:

Cassius: *Well, Brutus, thou art noble. Yet I see / Thy honourable mettle may be wrought / From that it is disposed. Therefore it is meet / That noble minds keep ever with their likes; / For who so firm that cannot be seduced?*

Simple English: Well, Brutus, you are a noble man. And yet I can see that your honourable nature can be worked — bent away from its natural inclination. That is why it is right that noble minds should always keep company only with their own kind; for who is so steadfast that he cannot be led astray?

Difficult words: *noble* — of high character (Cassius means it; he is not being sarcastic); *mettle* — temperament, spirit; the spelling 'metal' in some editions brings out the hidden image of a metal that can be heated and hammered; *wrought* — worked, shaped (the old past participle of *work*, as in 'wrought iron'); *From that it is disposed* — away from what it is naturally inclined to; *meet* — fitting, proper; *keep ever with their likes* — always associate with people like themselves; *firm* — steadfast, constant; *seduced* — led astray, corrupted (a stronger and more sexual word in Shakespeare's day than 'persuaded').

Literal meaning: Cassius concedes Brutus's nobility, then states as a fact that it can be bent; draws the general rule that noble men should mix only with noble men; and asks, as a rhetorical question, whether anyone is incorruptible.

Subtext: The man who spent the whole scene praising Brutus's "hidden worthiness" now coolly notes that the worthiness can be bent. "Yet I see" is the hinge: everything before it is the public Cassius, everything after it is the private one. And the general rule — noble minds should keep with their likes — is Cassius admitting that *he* is not Brutus's like. He knows that his company is corrupting.

Hidden meaning: The metalworking image is exact. You cannot forge iron that is already the shape you want; you forge it *away from* its shape by heating and striking. Cassius is describing the whole scene as a forge: the anecdotes were the heat, the Colossus speech the hammer, and Brutus's honour the metal that is beginning to bend. The disturbing word is "seduced": Cassius does not say 'persuaded' or 'convinced'. He knows that what he is doing to Brutus is not argument but seduction — and he does it anyway.

Character psychology: Here is Cassius's self-knowledge, and it is formidable. He understands Brutus's nature ("thou art noble"), his own method ("wrought"), the moral status of that method ("seduced"), and the rule he is breaking ("noble minds keep ever with their likes"). He has no illusions about himself. This separates him from Brutus, who will spend Act 2 Scene 1 constructing illusions about why Caesar must die. Cassius is the play's clear-eyed sinner; Brutus is its self-deceived saint. Note too the flash of something like regret in "who so firm" — the question could be a sigh as easily as a sneer, and actors have played it both ways.

Political meaning: Cassius has just identified the weakness of all republican politics in one line: honourable men can be worked upon by less honourable men. The Republic depends on virtue, and virtue can be forged. Caesar's whole case for one-man rule — that the Senate is a quarrelling crowd of men manipulating one another — is quietly confirmed by the leading republican in the play.

Historical context: HISTORICAL RECORD — Plutarch presents Cassius as the instigator of the conspiracy and Brutus as the man whose reputation was needed to make it respectable; Plutarch also records that Cassius had a private grievance, having been passed over for the more prestigious urban praetorship, which went to Brutus. LITERARY INTERPRETATION — Shakespeare omits the praetorship grievance and gives Cassius instead this general theory of seduction, which makes his motives seem both more intellectual and more sinister.

Literary devices: *Metaphor* — the mind as metal to be "wrought"; *pun* — mettle/metal; *aphorism* — "noble minds keep ever with their likes" has the shape of a proverb; *rhetorical question* — "who so firm that cannot be seduced?"; *volta* or turn — "Yet I see" pivots the speech, and the play, from public praise to private calculation.

Effect: A cold shock. The audience, which may have half-believed Cassius's republican fervour, hears him describe his friend as raw material. From this moment we watch Cassius with suspicion and Brutus with pity.

Dramatic significance: This is the first soliloquy of the play and it belongs to the manipulator. Shakespeare could have given the first private speech to Brutus, so that we entered the conspiracy through the honest man's doubts; instead he lets us enter it through the schemer's confidence, so that when Brutus's doubts come in Act

2 we already know they have been engineered.

Foreshadowing: "noble minds keep ever with their likes" is a rule Brutus will break by joining Cassius, and the quarrel of Act 4 Scene 3 — where Brutus accuses Cassius of corruption and Cassius accuses Brutus of not loving him — is what happens when unlike minds have kept company too long.

Scene connection: In Part One Cassius told Brutus, "I, your glass, / Will modestly discover to yourself / That of yourself which you yet know not of." The soliloquy shows what the glass was for: not to reveal Brutus to Brutus, but to reshape him. The mirror was a forge.

ICSE keywords: soliloquy; manipulation; metaphor of metalworking; pun; aphorism; rhetorical question; dramatic irony; self-knowledge.

Exam application: 'The soliloquy's key word is "wrought": Cassius sees Brutus's honour as metal to be hammered out of shape, and his rhetorical question "who so firm that cannot be seduced?" admits that his method is seduction, not persuasion — a confession that colours every compliment he paid earlier in the scene.'

"Caesar doth bear me hard, but he loves Brutus" — the personal motive

Original line / short passage:

Cassius: *Caesar doth bear me hard, but he loves Brutus. / If I were Brutus now, and he were Cassius, / He should not humour me.*

Simple English: Caesar bears a grudge against me, but he loves Brutus. If I were in Brutus's position and he were in mine, he would not be able to work on me the way I am working on him.

Difficult words: *doth bear me hard* — bears me ill will, has a grudge against me, treats me harshly; *humour* — to indulge, manage or win over by playing on someone's moods; here, to manipulate (some editors gloss the line differently — see below).

Literal meaning: Cassius contrasts Caesar's hostility to him with Caesar's love for Brutus, and then imagines the positions reversed.

Subtext: The first half of the first line is the only moment in the scene where Cassius admits a *personal* reason for hating Caesar. All his public arguments were about Rome, liberty and the ancestral Brutus; here, alone, he says that Caesar dislikes him. The second half — "but he loves Brutus" — is the reason Brutus is so valuable: a conspiracy that includes the man Caesar loves cannot be dismissed as the revenge of men Caesar has slighted.

Hidden meaning: The second sentence is one of the most discussed lines in the scene, and you should know that it is genuinely ambiguous. One reading: 'If I were Brutus — loved by Caesar — and Brutus were Cassius, I would not let him manipulate me as I am manipulating him.' On this reading Cassius admits that Brutus is more easily worked on than he himself would be, and perhaps that Brutus is the better man for being so trusting. A second reading: 'If I were Brutus and he were Cassius, he (Caesar) should not win me over with favours as he does Brutus' — that is, Cassius would not let Caesar's love buy him. The text allows both; the first is more widely accepted, and it is the one that makes the line a confession.

Character psychology: Cassius is honest about envy here in a way he was not when speaking to Brutus. He wants what Brutus has — Caesar's love — and he hates Caesar partly for not giving it. This is the psychology Caesar described a few minutes earlier: a man "never at heart's ease / Whiles they behold a greater than themselves". Caesar's reading is confirmed from inside Cassius's own head. The scene has arranged a perfect loop: Caesar diagnoses Cassius; Cassius, alone, proves the diagnosis.

Political meaning: Cassius needs Brutus not for his arguments or his sword but for his relationship with Caesar. The conspiracy's respectability depends on the one conspirator Caesar trusts. That is a cynical calculation, and it is also, in Roman terms, shrewd: Plutarch says the conspirators believed that Brutus's name alone would make the deed appear just.

Historical context: HISTORICAL RECORD — Caesar had pardoned both Brutus and Cassius after Pharsalus and advanced both to praetorships for 44 BC, but ancient sources agree that he favoured Brutus and was suspicious of Cassius; the rumour that Caesar was Brutus's natural father (which modern scholars reject on grounds of chronology) shows how close the two were thought to be. Shakespeare's "he loves Brutus" is well grounded.

Literary devices: *Antithesis* — "bear me hard" against "loves Brutus"; *hypothetical inversion* — the swapping of roles ("If I were Brutus now, and he were Cassius"), a kind of chiasmus of persons; *dramatic irony* — the audience now holds a motive the other characters never hear.

Effect: The audience's sympathy for Cassius drops sharply and then, for some, recovers a little: a man who can say 'he would not do this to me' knows exactly how he is behaving. Shakespeare refuses to make him simply a villain.

Dramatic significance: This line converts the scene from political persuasion into personal drama. Whatever the merits of the republican case, the man making it has a grudge, and the play will never let us forget it.

Foreshadowing: Antony, in Act 5 Scene 1, will accuse the conspirators of fawning on Caesar and then stabbing him; in Act 4 Scene 3 Brutus will accuse Cassius of an itching palm. The suspicion that Cassius's motives are personal, planted here, follows him to his death.

Scene connection: In Part One Cassius said Caesar had become "a god" while Cassius "must bend his body / If Caesar carelessly but nod on him". Now we hear the private version: Caesar does not merely tower over him; Caesar dislikes him. The public grievance was about rank; the private one is about love.

ICSE keywords: envy; personal motive; antithesis; dramatic irony; ambiguity; characterisation through soliloquy.

Exam application: 'Only when alone does Cassius give a personal reason for his hatred — "Caesar doth bear me hard, but he loves Brutus" — and the admission turns his republican rhetoric into something the audience must weigh against envy; an examiner rewards a candidate who can hold both motives together rather than choosing one.'

The forged letters — "in several hands", "glancèd at", "we will shake him"

Original line / short passage:

Cassius: *I will this night / In several hands in at his windows throw, / As if they came from several citizens, / Writings, all tending to the great opinion / That Rome holds of his name, wherein obscurely / Caesar's ambition shall be glancèd at. / And after this, let Caesar seat him sure, / For we will shake him, or worse days endure.*

Simple English: Tonight I will throw in at Brutus's windows letters written in several different handwritings, as if they came from several different citizens, all of them dwelling on the high opinion that Rome has of his name, and in which Caesar's ambition will be hinted at indirectly. And after that, let Caesar make his seat as secure as he can — for we will shake him, or else suffer worse days than these.

Difficult words: *this night* — tonight; *several hands* — different handwritings (*hand* = handwriting; *several* = separate, various); *in at his windows throw* — throw in through his windows; *writings* — letters, papers; *tending to* — aiming at, dwelling on; *the great opinion / That Rome holds of his name* — the high regard in which Rome holds the name Brutus; *obscurely* — indirectly, in veiled language; *glanced at* — hinted at, touched on in passing (the accent marks that the -ed is pronounced as a separate syllable for the metre); *seat him sure* — settle himself securely, make his position firm (the image is of sitting firmly on a throne or in a saddle); *shake him* — dislodge him; *or worse days endure* — or else put up with worse times than these.

Literal meaning: Cassius announces a plan: tonight he will forge letters in different handwritings, pretending they come from various citizens, flattering Brutus's name and hinting at Caesar's ambition, and throw them through Brutus's windows. Then, whatever Caesar does to secure himself, the conspirators will topple him or face the consequences.

Subtext: The whole speech has been building to this. The man who said "I, your glass, / Will modestly discover to yourself / That of yourself which you yet know not of" now plans to manufacture a false reflection: a chorus of Roman voices that is in fact one man with several pens. The mirror is not merely a forge; it is a forgery.

Hidden meaning: Look at how the letters are designed. They do not argue; they flatter — "the great opinion / That Rome holds of his name" — and they accuse only "obscurely". Cassius has learned from the scene itself that Brutus cannot be pushed; he must be invited to push himself. The letters will give Brutus the two things he needs to act: the belief that Rome is asking him, and the freedom to supply the accusation against Caesar from his own mind. In Act 2 Scene 1 he does exactly that, reading the letters and filling in their gaps with his own reasoning. The word "obscurely" is the whole method of the conspiracy in one adverb: ambition is never shown, only glanced at — by Casca's "to my thinking", by Cassius's letters, and finally by Brutus's own imagination.

Character psychology: The man who called Caesar a swimmer who needed rescuing and a sick girl crying for drink now shows what he himself is: a forger. Yet the last couplet — "let Caesar seat him sure, / For we will shake him, or worse days endure" — is not cynical at all. It is the voice of a man who genuinely believes that Caesar must fall and that the alternative is worse. Cassius is both: the manipulator and the believer. The play never lets you separate them.

Political meaning: The conspiracy's first act is a lie to its own most honourable member. That tells you something about the Republic Cassius is trying to save: it can only be defended by methods that betray its values. Many critics see this as the moral centre of the play — the deed may be arguable, but the means are poisoned from the start. Present that as a reading, not a fact; the text invites it without stating it.

Historical context: HISTORICAL RECORD — Plutarch records that anonymous messages appeared on the tribunal where Brutus sat as praetor and on the statue of his ancestor, urging him to wake up and act, and that these were understood to express the people's wish; Plutarch does not say Cassius wrote them, though he says Cassius and Brutus's friends worked on him. LITERARY INTERPRETATION — Shakespeare's decisive change is to make the letters Cassius's personal forgery and to tell us so in advance, so that when Brutus reads one aloud in Act 2 Scene 1 we know he is being deceived. A genuine popular appeal becomes a private fraud.

Literary devices: *Dramatic irony* — the audience knows the letters are forged; Brutus never will. *Rhyming couplet* — "sure / endure" closes the scene with a snap, a common Shakespearean signal that a scene is ending and a decision has been taken. *Metaphor* — "seat him sure" (power as a seat or saddle) and "shake him" (overthrow as physical dislodging). *Antithesis* — "shake him" against "worse days endure". *Alliteration* — "several hands... several citizens" stresses the multiplication of one voice into many.

Effect: The scene ends on a threat spoken directly to the audience, and the audience leaves it complicit — we know a secret that will destroy Brutus and we cannot warn him. The couplet's finality tells us the plot is now in motion.

Dramatic significance: This speech is the hinge between the private persuasion of Scene 2 and the open conspiracy of Scene 3. In Scene 3 we see the letters being distributed — Cassius hands them to Cinna to lay in the praetor's chair, throw in at Brutus's window and fix on the statue of old Brutus — and in Act 2 Scene 1 we see one being read. Shakespeare shows plan, delivery and effect in three consecutive scenes.

Foreshadowing: "we will shake him" is fulfilled in Act 3 Scene 1 — and "or worse days endure" is fulfilled too, in the other direction: the proscriptions, the civil war and Philippi are the worse days that the conspirators bring on themselves. Cassius's either/or turns out to be both.

Scene connection: Cassius began the scene by telling Brutus that the eye "sees not itself / But by reflection, by some other things". The letters are the "other things" — manufactured reflections. The soliloquy closes the circle the mirror speech opened.

ICSE keywords: forgery; manipulation; dramatic irony; rhyming couplet; metaphor; ends and means; plot mechanism.

Exam application: This passage is essential for any answer on how Brutus is drawn in: 'Cassius plans letters "in several hands" in which "Caesar's ambition shall be glanced at" — the ambition is only hinted, the voices are forged, and Brutus will supply the rest himself; the conspiracy begins with a lie to its noblest member.'

PROFESSOR'S INSIGHT

Why Cassius's soliloquy changes how we hear everything he said earlier

A soliloquy placed at the end of a scene works backwards. Until Brutus leaves, you have been hearing Cassius's speeches as a republican might hear them: passionate, exaggerated, perhaps unfair to Caesar, but sincere. The soliloquy obliges you to replay the whole scene in a different key. "I, your glass, / Will modestly discover to yourself" now sounds like the opening move of a confidence trick. "honour is the subject of my story" sounds like a man choosing the subject his listener cannot resist. The Tiber story and the fever in Spain become not memories but exhibits. Even "I am glad that my weak words / Have struck but thus much show of fire from Brutus" becomes a craftsman's note on the progress of the work. Yet — and this is the point a weaker guide misses — the soliloquy does not make the earlier speeches *false*. Cassius really does think Caesar a feeble man grown monstrous; he really would rather die than be a slave; "we will shake him, or worse days endure" is spoken with conviction. What the soliloquy adds is not insincerity but method: we learn that the sincere man is also a calculating one, that his flattery is deliberate and his letters are forged. Shakespeare wants you to carry both truths at once, because the play's judgement on the conspiracy depends on it. If Cassius were merely a hypocrite, Brutus would be merely a dupe and the tragedy would collapse into a crime story. Because Cassius believes what he says *and* manipulates, Brutus is seduced by a genuine argument dishonestly delivered — which is a far more painful thing to watch. In an answer, show that you have heard both: the republican and the forger are the same man, and the soliloquy is where they meet.

LEVEL 4 — How does it connect to the whole play?

Almost every thread of the tragedy is tied here. The public Caesar who refuses a crown three times becomes Antony's evidence in the Forum that Caesar was not ambitious; the private Caesar with a deaf ear and a fit in the marketplace becomes the wounded body Antony shows the crowd. Brutus's "chew upon this" and his appointment for tomorrow lead to the orchard of Act 2 Scene 1, where he reasons alone and reads a forged letter. Cassius's letters, planned here, are handed to Cinna in Scene 3 and read by Brutus in Act 2. Casca, assessed here as a man of "execution", strikes the first blow in Act 3 Scene 1. Antony, dismissed here as a lover of plays who says Cassius is "not dangerous", turns the Forum into a play in Act 3 Scene 2 and names the conspirators' danger exactly in Act 5. The crowd that clapped and hissed "as they use to do the players in the theatre" claps Brutus and then Antony and then tears Cinna the poet apart. The tribunes "put to silence" are the first of many silenced voices. And Cassius's "we will shake him, or worse days endure" is answered, on both sides of the 'or', by Acts 3 to 5.

KEYWORDS Keyword box: terms the second half of the scene teaches you to use

Soliloquy — a speech by a character alone on stage, taken to reveal true thoughts; Cassius's closing speech is the play's first. **Reported action** — an event narrated rather than staged; the crown offering. **Unreliable narrator** — a reporter whose bias colours the account; Casca's "to my thinking". **Metatheatre** — a play drawing attention to its own theatrical nature; the crowd compared to a theatre audience. **Illeism** — speaking of oneself in the third person; "always I am Caesar", "Brutus had rather". **Physiognomy** — judging character from physical appearance; the "lean and hungry look". **Anachronism** — an object out of its time; nightcaps, doublet. **Euphemism** — a mild phrase for a harsh fact; "put to silence". **Pun** — wordplay on two meanings; "the falling sickness". **Rhyming couplet** — two rhymed lines, often closing a scene; "sure / endure". **Dramatic irony** — the audience knows what characters do not; the forged letters. **Forgery** — the letters "in several hands". **Public self / private self** — the gap between the Caesar of the marketplace and the Caesar of the deaf ear. The chapter 'The ICSE Keyword Vault for Act 1' has the full list with sample sentences.

HOW ONE SCENE ESTABLISHES AN ENORMOUS AMOUNT OF THE PLAY

Scene 2 is the longest scene in Act 1 and, by some distance, the most important scene in the play for a student of Acts 3 to 5, because nearly every later event is either planted here or explained by something here. Use the table below as a map. The left-hand columns are SHAKESPEARE'S TEXT; the right-hand column is where the seed grows. Later-act wording is paraphrased in single quotes so that you do not confuse it with Act 1 quotations.

What Scene 2 plants	The words that plant it	What it establishes	Where it pays off in Acts 2–5
Caesar's public image	The crown "put... by with the back of his hand", "thrice"; "offered them his throat to cut"; "always I am Caesar"	A performer who refuses kingship in public and claims to be above fear	Act 2 Scene 2: he goes to the Senate rather than seem afraid. Act 3 Scene 1: the speech comparing himself to the fixed northern star, moments before the stabbing. Act 3 Scene 2: Antony uses the triple refusal as proof Caesar 'was not ambitious'.

What Scene 2 plants	The words that plant it	What it establishes	Where it pays off in Acts 2–5
Caesar's body	"this ear is deaf"; "he swooned and fell down"; "foamed at mouth"; "the falling sickness"	A great name mounted on a fallible body	Act 2 Scene 2: Calpurnia's dream of his statue running blood. Act 3 Scene 1: the body falls at the base of Pompey's statue. Act 3 Scene 2: Antony shows the crowd the wounds and the torn mantle. Act 4 Scene 3: the ghost — the name outlives the body.
Brutus's conflict	"chew upon this"; "Brutus had rather be a villager"; "Come home to me"	A republican who loves Caesar and will not be rushed, yet has already judged Caesar's Rome intolerable	Act 2 Scene 1: the orchard soliloquy deciding Caesar must die for what he 'may' become; the letters read; the conspirators received at his house. Act 3 Scene 2: his Forum speech on loving Rome more. Act 5 Scene 5: his death and Antony's tribute.
Cassius's method	"Thy honourable mettle may be wrought"; "who so firm that cannot be seduced?"; "in several hands... Writings"; "obscurely... glanced at"	Manipulation through flattery, suggestion and forgery, driven by conviction and envy together	Act 1 Scene 3: the letters handed to Cinna. Act 2 Scene 1: Brutus reads one. Act 2 Scene 1 and Act 3 Scene 1: Cassius's correct advice (kill Antony; do not let him speak) overruled. Act 4 Scene 3: the quarrel over corruption. Act 5 Scene 3: his suicide.
Antony's loyalty	"Fear him not, Caesar; he's not dangerous"; "He loves no plays, / As thou dost, Antony"	A devoted, pleasure-loving lieutenant who misreads the danger	Act 3 Scene 1: he shakes the bloody hands and privately vows revenge. Act 3 Scene 2: the funeral oration. Act 4 Scene 1: the proscriptions. Act 5 Scene 1: he taunts the conspirators as flatterers who stabbed.
The crowd	"the rabblement hooted and clapped"; "as they use to do the players in the theatre"; "if Caesar had stabbed their mothers, they would have done no less"	A public that judges by feeling and can be turned by performance	Act 3 Scene 2: they cheer Brutus, then Antony, then riot. Act 3 Scene 3: Cinna the poet killed for his name.
The letters	"In several hands in at his windows throw, / As if they came from several citizens"	The conspiracy's first act is a forgery aimed at its noblest member	Act 1 Scene 3: distribution (praetor's chair, window, statue). Act 2 Scene 1: Brutus reads 'Brutus, thou sleep'st' and resolves to act.
The Ides	"Beware the ides of March" (first half of the scene); "He is a dreamer"	A date fixed in the audience's mind and dismissed by Caesar	Act 2 Scene 2: Calpurnia's warnings dismissed. Act 3 Scene 1: Caesar tells the Soothsayer the Ides have come, and is answered that they have not gone. Act 4 Scene 3 and Act 5 Scene 1: the conspirators date their own doom from 'the ides of March'. Act 5 Scene 3: Cassius dies on his birthday.

How to use this table: do not memorise it as a list. Pick one row and practise writing two sentences that travel from the Act 1 seed to the later payoff. For example: 'Antony's assurance in Act 1 Scene 2 that Cassius is "not dangerous" is the measure of how far he travels: by Act 5 he is the man who understands the conspirators best.' That movement from early to late is exactly what a Class X examiner means by 'knowledge of the whole play'.

PUBLIC CAESAR / PRIVATE CAESAR

Scene 2 is the only scene in the play that shows you both Caesars on the same day, and most of the private evidence comes from Part Two. The table separates what Rome sees from what the audience is allowed to see. Remember the labels: the left two columns are SHAKESPEARE'S TEXT; the right-hand column is LITERARY INTERPRETATION.

Aspect	PUBLIC CAESAR (what Rome sees)	PRIVATE CAESAR (what the audience learns)	What the gap tells you
Fear	"I rather tell thee what is to be feared / Than what I fear"; "always I am Caesar"	He names the one man he "should avoid / So soon as" — Cassius — and asks Antony to "tell me truly"	The denial of fear and the description of fear are the same speech; the public self is a performance for the private self too
The body	He strides at the head of a "chidden train", refuses a crown with "the back of his hand", bares his throat	"this ear is deaf"; he "swooned and fell down"; "foamed at mouth and was speechless"	The name is immortal; the man is not. The play's whole treatment of Caesar lives in this gap
Kingship	Refuses the coronet "thrice, every time gentler than other" while the crowd cheers	Casca's reading: "he would fain have had it"; "very loath to lay his fingers off it"; the "angry spot" Brutus sees afterwards	We are never shown his desire — only a cynic's inference and a flush of anger. Shakespeare keeps the private wish unprovable
Judgement of men	Wants "men about me that are fat, / Sleek-headed men, and such as sleep a-nights"	Reads Cassius exactly: "He reads much, / He is a great observer... Seldom he smiles"	Caesar is perceptive about his enemy and chooses comfort over truth; the tragedy is in the choice, not in blindness
Humility	Apologises to the crowd and asks them to blame "his infirmity"; the wenches forgive him "with all their hearts"	Has the tribunes "put to silence" the same day for touching his statues	Public humility and private absolutism coexist; the apology is theatre, the silencing is power
Relationship to warnings	Dismisses the Soothsayer as "a dreamer" before all Rome	Turns his good ear to Antony because the other is deaf	The man who cannot hear on one side is the man who will not hear; many readers take the deaf ear as an emblem of this
Language	Commands and maxims: "Set on, and leave no ceremony out"; "Such men are dangerous"	Hesitations and reversals: "Would he were fatter! But I fear him not. / Yet..."	In public Caesar speaks in rules; in private his sentences double back on themselves

PROFESSOR'S INSIGHT The two Caesars and the problem of the 'tyrant'

Students are often taught to decide whether Caesar 'is' a tyrant, and to collect evidence on each side. Scene 2 suggests that this is the wrong question, or at least a question Shakespeare deliberately refuses to answer. Look at the evidence the scene actually supplies. For tyranny: a court that looks "chidden", tribunes "put to silence", a Caesar who speaks of having "men about me" as a king speaks of courtiers. Against tyranny: a crown refused three times before a cheering crowd, an apology to the people, a sick and deaf man of middle age. For ambition: a cynic's "to my thinking" and a flush of anger. Against: nothing Caesar says or does on stage. The balance is not accidental. Shakespeare has built a Caesar whose public gestures can be read either way and whose private wishes are never shown, so that the conspirators must act on interpretation — and so must we. This is why Brutus, in Act 2, will have to reason from what Caesar 'may' become rather than from what he has done, and why Antony, in Act 3, will be able to turn the same facts the other way. When you write about Caesar's character, resist the verdict and describe the design: a man built to be construed. That is a far stronger answer than 'Caesar was arrogant' or 'Caesar was not really ambitious', and it is the answer the text supports.

Using the second half of Scene 2 in an ICSE answer

ICSE EXAM BOX Honest exam relevance — where this half of the scene earns marks

EXAM-ORIENTED ADVICE — Act 1 is the Class IX portion of the ICSE syllabus; the Class X board paper (Paper 2, Literature in English) sets its *Julius Caesar* extracts from Acts III, IV and V. So you will not be given Casca's report or Cassius's soliloquy as a board extract. What happens instead is this: the Act 3–5 extracts repeatedly assume you know this half of Scene 2. When Antony tells the Forum that Caesar refused a crown three times, a sub-question may ask what event he is referring to and how it was first described — and the candidate who can say 'reported by Casca, who thought Caesar "would fain have had it"' is answering at a level the others cannot reach. When Brutus reads a letter in Act 2 or speaks of the people's wishes in Act 3, the knowledge that the letters were forged "in several hands" by Cassius changes the whole character answer. When Caesar claims constancy in Act 3 Scene 1, "always I am Caesar" and the deaf ear are the Act 1 roots a strong answer reaches for. In the 2025 paper, one sub-question asked what 'the work the ides of March begun' referred to — a straight test of Act 1 knowledge inside an Act 5 extract. Never claim any of this is guaranteed; it is simply how the paper has behaved. For Class IX internal examinations, this half of the scene is a natural source of reference-to-the-context extracts, and the sub-questions tend to be: who is speaking and to whom; what has just happened; explain a phrase in your own words; what does the speech reveal about the speaker; what happens next. The line-by-line sections above are arranged to answer exactly those questions. Chapter 19, 'Extract-Based Training (Part Two)', gives you practice extracts from this half of the scene with marked answers.

LEVEL 5 — How do I use it in an ICSE answer?

Three rules, then a worked example. **Rule one: quote small and interpret big.** A three-word quotation — "to my thinking", "this ear is deaf", "in several hands" — followed by two sentences of interpretation earns more than a six-line quotation with none. **Rule two: separate the report from the fact.** Whenever you write about the crown, make it clear that Caesar's desire for it is Casca's opinion. Examiners reward candidates who notice that Shakespeare reported the event rather than staged it. **Rule three: travel.** Connect the Act 1 seed to the later payoff in one sentence — that is what 'knowledge of the whole play' means in a mark scheme. Worked example, for a question asking what Cassius's soliloquy reveals about him: 'The soliloquy reveals that Cassius's republicanism and his envy are inseparable. He admits a private motive — "Caesar doth bear me hard, but he loves Brutus" — and describes his method with a metalworker's word, "wrought": Brutus's honour is metal to be hammered. His plan to throw letters "in several hands" through Brutus's windows, in which "Caesar's ambition shall be glanced at", shows that the conspiracy will begin with a forgery, and the closing couplet, "we will shake him, or worse days endure", shows that he nevertheless believes in the cause. Shakespeare makes him both sincere and manipulative, which is why Brutus's later ruin in Acts 4 and 5 feels tragic rather than merely deserved.' That paragraph is about one hundred and twenty words, quotes five short phrases, names a device, states a reading as a reading, and travels forward. It is the shape to aim for.

WEAK ANSWER Weak answer — what not to write about Casca's report

'Casca tells Brutus and Cassius that Antony offered Caesar the crown three times and Caesar refused it three times. The people cheered. Then Caesar fainted because he had epilepsy. Casca also says Cicero spoke Greek and the tribunes were punished. This shows that Caesar was a hypocrite who really wanted the crown.' — This retells the plot, treats Casca's opinion as fact ('really wanted'), quotes nothing, names no device, and makes no connection to the rest of the play. It would earn little beyond the marks for basic recall.

EXCELLENT ANSWER Excellent answer — the same material, properly used

'Shakespeare does not stage the crown offering; he lets Casca report it in sour prose, so that the day's most important political event reaches us filtered through a cynic. Casca twice marks his account as opinion — "to my thinking" — and his claim that Caesar "would fain have had it" is an inference from a hand that was "very loath to lay his fingers off it". The crowd, meanwhile, cheered every refusal "as they use to do the players in the theatre", an image that makes Roman politics a performance judged by its audience. Two further details carry weight: Caesar "swooned and fell down" at the third refusal, completing Cassius's earlier catalogue of the weak body behind the great name, and the tribunes "are put to silence", dropped by Casca as an afterthought though it is the scene's hardest evidence of tyranny. The effect is that the conspiracy will act on interpretation rather than proof — which is exactly what Antony exploits in Act 3 Scene 2 when he turns the same triple refusal into evidence of Caesar's humility.' — Short quotations, the report/fact distinction, a device named and explained, and a connection forward.

CROSS-REFERENCE Where the other chapters take over

This chapter has taught the second half of Scene 2 line by line. For the first half — the Soothsayer, Caesar's superstition, the mirror speech, the Tiber and the fever, the Colossus — go back to Chapter 04, 'Act 1 Scene 2 (Part One) — Lupercalia, the Soothsayer, and the Seduction of Brutus'. For what happens to the letters next, and for Casca's transformation under the storm, read Chapter 06, 'Act 1 Scene 3 — The Storm: Omens, Fear and the Conspiracy Takes Shape'. The public/private Caesar is developed into a full portrait in Chapter 07, 'Caesar in Act 1 — A Character Masterclass'; Cassius's method, including the soliloquy, is anatomised move by move in Chapter 08, 'Cassius — The Manipulation Masterclass'; Brutus's conflict in Chapter 09, 'Brutus in Act 1 — Honour, Conflict and Vulnerability'. Casca and Cicero have their own treatment in Chapter 10, 'The Soothsayer, the Ides of March, and the Supporting Cast'. Appearance versus reality, public opinion and mob psychology are theme chapters 11 and 12. Every device named here is defined with further examples in Chapter 13, 'The Act 1 Literary-Device Bank'; every quotation is collected in Chapter 15, 'The Act 1 Quotation Bank'; and the forward connections in the big table are expanded in Chapter 16, 'The Scene Connection Engine and Where Act 1 Reappears Later'. For practice extracts from this half of the scene with model answers, use Chapter 19, 'Extract-Based Training (Part Two): The Second Half of Scene 2 and Scene 3'.

TEXT NOTE Spellings and small variants you may meet in your edition

Folger prints "Calphurnia"; most ICSE editions and the MIT/Globe text print "Calpurnia", which this book uses. "mettle" (Folger) appears as 'metal' in older editions in both Brutus's "quick mettle" and Cassius's "honourable mettle" — the words were not yet distinguished, and the pun on workable metal is present either way. "chopped hands" is printed 'chapped hands' in some editions; the meaning (roughened by work) is the same. "glancèd" carries an accent in Folger to show that the ending is pronounced as a separate syllable for the metre; your edition may print "glanced". None of these variants changes the meaning, but in an exam quote whichever spelling your prescribed text uses.

REVISION ONE-MINUTE REVISION — Act 1 Scene 2

5 must-remember events 1. Caesar's procession returns angry; Brutus reads the faces — the "angry spot", the "chidden train", Calpurnia pale, Cicero's "ferret and such fiery eyes". 2. Caesar tells Antony he distrusts "lean and hungry" Cassius; Antony calls him "a noble Roman, and well given"; Caesar claims "always I am Caesar" and admits "this ear is deaf". 3. Casca reports that Antony offered Caesar a coronet three times, that Caesar refused it "every time gentler than other", that the crowd cheered the refusals, and that Caesar "swooned and fell down". 4. Casca adds that Cicero "spoke Greek" and that Marullus and Flavius "are put to silence". 5. Brutus and Cassius agree to meet tomorrow; alone, Cassius plans forged letters "in several hands" and vows "we will shake him, or worse days endure".

5 keywords soliloquy · reported action · dramatic irony · illeism · forgery

3 quotations "Yond Cassius has a lean and hungry look. / He thinks too much. Such men are dangerous." (Caesar) "for always I am Caesar. / Come on my right hand, for this ear is deaf" (Caesar) "Thy honourable mettle may be wrought / From that it is disposed" (Cassius)

3 character insights Caesar reads Cassius accurately and acts on comfort rather than truth — a perceptive man, not a blind one. Casca hides a sharp political eye under a "tardy form" of bluntness; his "to my thinking" is opinion, not proof. Cassius is sincere and manipulative at once: he believes Caesar must fall and he forges letters to make Brutus believe it too.

3 themes Appearance versus reality (the public Caesar and the private one) · Manipulation and the ethics of means (the letters) · Public opinion and politics as theatre (the clapping, hissing crowd)

2 literary devices Pun — "the falling sickness" (epilepsy / Rome's political fall) · Rhyming couplet — "let Caesar seat him sure, / For we will shake him, or worse days endure"

2 historical points Plutarch records Caesar's remark about fat and thin men, the diadem offered at the Lupercalia (twice, not thrice) and the deposition of the two tribunes; the deaf ear is Shakespeare's invention. The anonymous messages that historically urged Brutus to act become, in Shakespeare, Cassius's personal forgeries.

3 connections Scene 1 → Scene 2: Flavius's "Disrobe the images" leads to the tribunes "put to silence". Scene 2 → Act 2 Scene 1: "Come home to me" and the forged letters lead to Brutus's orchard and the conspirators at his door. Scene 2 → Act 3 Scene 2: Casca's cynical account of the triple refusal is retold by Antony as proof that Caesar was not ambitious.

1 central idea Rome judges Caesar by signs and reports it cannot verify — and the conspiracy is built on an interpretation, not a proof.

CHAPTER 6

Act 1 Scene 3 — The Storm: Omens, Fear and the Conspiracy Takes Shape

What this chapter does: It takes the shortest and strangest scene of Act 1 — a night of thunder, a burning hand, a lion in the street — and teaches it as a complete dramatic unit, from the plain question 'what happened?' up to the level at which you can use it in an ICSE answer. You will learn how Shakespeare turns weather into politics, how Cassius turns Casca's terror into an oath, how the forged letters compromise the conspiracy before Brutus has even joined it, and why one line given to Cicero is a key to the whole play. Every important passage is taught line by line, and the chapter ends with a one-minute revision sheet.

Before you read: where we are

When you last saw Cassius, he was alone on a daylit street at the end of Act 1 Scene 2, promising himself that he would throw forged letters in at Brutus's windows and that "we will shake him, or worse days endure." That was the afternoon of the Lupercal, 15 February by the Roman calendar. Now, without a word of explanation, Shakespeare drops you into a night of thunder and lightning, and a question asked halfway through the scene — "Comes Caesar to the Capitol tomorrow?" — tells you that a whole month has passed. It is the night of 14 March. Tomorrow is the Ides.

Hold on to three things before you start reading closely.

First, this scene was written for a theatre with no roof and no electric lighting. At the Globe in 1599 the afternoon sun was shining on the stage while the actors spoke of darkness and fire. The night, the flashes, the terror — all of it had to be made out of words, drums and fireworks. That is why the language of this scene is so extreme: it is doing the work that a lighting rig does today.

Second, the scene has four speakers, but the two people it is really about never appear. Caesar has just been escorted home by Casca; Brutus is asleep — or not asleep — in his house, and every plan made in the scene points towards his door. Learn to notice when Shakespeare builds a scene around an absent person.

Third, this is a recruitment scene. Under the noise of the storm, one man is signed up to a murder and a second man is being softened for it with forged paper. If you read the scene only as 'atmosphere', you will miss its politics; if you read it only as politics, you will miss why the atmosphere is there.

CROSS-REFERENCE Where this chapter sits in the book

This chapter assumes you have worked through '05 — Act 1 Scene 2 (Part Two) — Caesar Returns, Casca Reports, Cassius Plots', because Casca's sour report and Cassius's soliloquy about the letters are the seeds that grow here. Cassius's persuasive technique is treated as a whole in '08 — Cassius — The Manipulation Masterclass'; the ideas of fate, omens and superstition are gathered in '12 — Themes of Act 1 (Part Two)'; the storm's later echoes in Acts 2–5 are traced in '16 — The Scene Connection Engine'; and extract practice on this scene is in '19 — Extract-Based Training (Part Two)'. Here the aim is to understand the scene itself, deeply and in order.

The scene as a complete dramatic unit: a twenty-point anatomy

A scene is not a heap of quotations. It is a machine with a setting, a set of people who want different things, a change that happens, and a set of consequences. The twenty headings below are the questions a professional reader asks of any scene. Work through them in order the first time; later you can use them as a checklist.

1 Setting

SHAKESPEARE'S TEXT. The Folio gives one stage direction: thunder and lightning. Everything else about the setting is built from the dialogue. Cicero's greeting "Good even, Casca" tells you it is evening; Cassius's closing words "it is after midnight" tell you the scene has carried us past midnight; Casca's remark that "yesterday the bird of night did sit / Even at noonday upon the marketplace" reaches back a day. So the scene spans the hours from dusk to the small hours of the Ides of March, though it plays in about ten minutes. The place is a street in Rome, near enough to the Capitol for Casca to have met his lion "Against the Capitol" (here 'against' means 'opposite' or 'close by').

Notice how different this is from the two scenes before it. Scene 1 was a festival street in daylight, full of commoners; Scene 2 was a public place full of a shouting crowd. Scene 3 is empty. Cassius says so: "There is no stir or walking in the streets." The crowd that decided everything in the first two scenes has gone indoors, and the men who walk the streets now are the men who intend to decide things without the crowd.

TEXT NOTE Casca's sword

The Folger text opens simply with the thunder direction. The Globe-edition text used in many school editions adds that Casca enters 'with his sword drawn'. This is an editorial direction, not Shakespeare's own, but it is justified by Casca's own words a few lines later: "I ha' not since put up my sword" ('ha' = have; 'put up' = sheathed). Picture him: a senator alone in the street, weapon out, breathless, sweating. The visual image of a drawn sword hangs over a scene that ends with plans for stabbing.

2 Characters

Four men speak. Two others rule the scene from off stage.

Character	Who he is	What he does here	What to watch
Cicero	Rome's most famous orator and a senior senator; historically never part of the conspiracy	Meets Casca, hears the prodigies, doubts what they mean, asks whether Caesar comes to the Capitol tomorrow, goes home	The one voice of reason — and the first to leave

Character	Who he is	What he does here	What to watch
Casca	A senator in Caesar's circle (he called for silence when Caesar spoke in Scene 2 and has just walked Caesar home); the sour cynic of Scene 2	Reports the omens in terror; is recruited by Cassius; gives his hand and swears to go as far as any man	His change from mocker to sworn conspirator
Cassius	Praetor, Brutus's brother-in-law, the organiser of the plot	Walks bare-chested under the lightning, reinterprets the omens as warnings against Caesar, recruits Casca, dispatches the forged letters	Every speech is a tool
Cinna	Lucius Cornelius Cinna, a praetor and conspirator — not the poet of Act 3 Scene 3	Arrives in haste from Pompey's Porch, takes the letters	The messenger whose one wish is Brutus

Absent but present: Caesar, whom Casca "Brought ... home", and Brutus, who is named again and again ("win the noble Brutus", "Where Brutus may but find it", "See Brutus at his house"). **Named but unseen:** Decius Brutus, Trebonius and Metellus Cimber, waiting at "Pompey's Porch"; Antonius, who is to send word to Cicero.

3 Political situation

HISTORICAL RECORD. By March 44 BC Caesar had been made dictator for life (in February of that year), an office that in the old Republic was an emergency post limited to six months. He had pardoned his enemies from the civil war, including Brutus and Cassius, and given them the praetorships of 44 BC. The Senate still met and voted, but everyone understood where power lay.

SHAKESPEARE'S TEXT. The play sharpens this into a crisis with a deadline. Casca reports a rumour: "they say the Senators tomorrow / Mean to establish Caesar as a king, / And he shall wear his crown by sea and land / In every place save here in Italy." Caesar is expected at the Capitol in the morning. The tribunes who tore the decorations from his statues have been "put to silence" (Scene 2). And a group of senators — Cassius, Casca, Cinna, Decius Brutus, Trebonius, Metellus Cimber — has already agreed to act. What the conspiracy lacks is the one man whose name would make the killing look like a Roman duty rather than a private murder. The whole political situation of the scene, then, is a race: crown Caesar tomorrow, or kill him tomorrow, and the deciding factor is whether Brutus can be brought in tonight.

4 What happens

LEVEL 1 — What happened?

1. Thunder and lightning. Cicero meets Casca, who is breathless and staring. Casca says he has never before been through "a tempest dropping fire" and that either there is "a civil strife in heaven" or the gods are punishing a world grown "too saucy" (insolent).
2. Casca lists the prodigies he has seen: a slave whose hand burned like twenty torches and was unhurt; a lion near the Capitol that stared at him and walked past; a hundred terrified women who swore they saw men walking the streets on fire; and an owl hooting in the marketplace at noon.
3. Cicero agrees it is a strange time but warns that men interpret things to suit themselves. He asks whether Caesar will be at the Capitol tomorrow; Casca says yes. Cicero goes home.
4. Cassius enters, recognises Casca by his voice, calls the night "A very pleasing night to honest men", and boasts that he has walked the streets with his shirt open, offering his chest to the lightning.
5. Casca rebukes him for tempting the heavens. Cassius calls him dull and says the omens are heaven's warning against "some monstrous state" — and against a man "Most like this dreadful night". Casca: it is Caesar you mean, is it not?
6. Cassius laments that Romans have become "womanish". Casca gives his news: the senators mean to make Caesar king tomorrow, everywhere except Italy.
7. Cassius says he knows where he will wear his dagger; he will free himself from bondage by suicide if need be. Casca agrees every slave can end his own captivity. Cassius: Caesar is only a wolf because Romans are sheep; "What trash is Rome". He then seems to check himself — perhaps he speaks "Before a willing bondman".
8. Casca gives his hand: he is "no fleering telltale"; he will go as far as anyone. Cassius reveals that other noble Romans are waiting for him at Pompey's Porch.
9. Cinna arrives, wishing aloud that Brutus could be won. Cassius gives him papers to leave in the praetor's chair, to throw in at Brutus's window, and to fix with wax on the statue of old Brutus. Decius Brutus and Trebonius are at the Porch; Metellus Cimber has gone to Cassius's house.
10. Cassius and Casca resolve to visit Brutus before dawn: "Three parts of him / Is ours already." Casca says Brutus's reputation will turn their offence into virtue. Cassius agrees; it is after midnight.

5 Why it happens

LEVEL 2 — What does it mean?

Ask 'why now?' and 'why these people?'. The scene happens because the clock has run out. Scene 2 gave Cassius a month; Casca's news gives him one night. The deadline forces three things at once: the recruitment of Casca (a man close to Caesar, with access), the delivery of the letters (the softening of Brutus), and the gathering at Pompey's Porch (the organisation of the strike).

Why is Casca recruitable tonight when he was merely sour in Scene 2? Because fear has broken him open. The man who found the Lupercal "mere foolery" is now shaking. Cassius's genius is to offer that fear a meaning and a target: the storm is not random terror, it is a warning about Caesar. Terror that has a name can be acted upon; terror without a name only paralyses.

Why does Cicero leave? Because the scene needs to clear the stage of the one man who would have asked awkward questions. Dramatically, Cicero's exit is the removal of scepticism so that persuasion can work.

Why the letters? Because Cassius's honest arguments in Scene 2 produced only "thus much show of fire" from Brutus. Cassius needs Brutus to believe that Rome is asking, not Cassius. So he manufactures Rome's voice.

6 What each character wants

Cicero wants information and safety. His two speeches are a question about the omens and a question about Caesar's movements; his exit line — "This disturbed sky / Is not to walk in" — is the voice of a man who intends to survive. He commits to nothing.

Casca wants, first, to be told what the horror means. Look at how he speaks to Cicero: "Are not you moved ...?" — he needs another man to share his terror. Then, once Cassius has supplied a meaning, he wants a role and an assurance that he will not be exposed: "You speak to Casca, and to such a man / That is no fleering telltale." He wants to be trusted. (A 'fleering telltale' is a sneering informer.)

Cassius wants two men: Casca tonight and Brutus before dawn. Every speech he makes is shaped by that. He also wants — and this is subtler — to own the interpretation of the storm. If the omens mean 'the gods are angry with Rome', men stay indoors and pray; if they mean 'the gods warn us against Caesar', men act. Cassius fights for the second reading.

Cinna wants Brutus. His one substantial line is a wish: "O Cassius, if you could / But win the noble Brutus to our party—". He is the conspiracy's conscience speaking aloud: without Brutus, what we are doing does not feel right.

7 What changes during the scene

Learn to state changes as before → after pairs; examiners reward this because it shows you understand a scene as movement rather than as a list.

- Casca: terrified spectator → sworn conspirator who offers his hand.
- Cassius: the lone plotter of the Scene 2 soliloquy → the leader of an organised group with a meeting place, a messenger and a timetable.
- The conspiracy: a private grievance → a plan with a deadline (tomorrow, the Capitol) and a method (the letters).

- The storm: a terror to be fled (Cicero goes home) → a sign to be welcomed ("A very pleasing night to honest men") → a mirror of the deed itself ("Most bloody, fiery, and most terrible").
- Brutus: a friend Cassius hopes to persuade → a prize whose capture is calculated in fractions ("Three parts of him / Is ours already").
- Time: an unspecified evening → "after midnight", a few hours from the Ides.

8 What the audience learns

An audience learns things in a scene that the characters may not notice themselves learning. Here you learn, first, the date: the Soothsayer's "Beware the ides of March" was a warning without a calendar, and now Cicero's question pins the danger to tomorrow morning. You learn that a conspiracy already exists, that it has a headquarters (Pompey's Porch), members with names, and a courier. You learn that the plan Cassius announced alone in Scene 2 — letters "As if they came from several citizens" — is being carried out tonight. You learn that Casca is in and Cicero is out. You learn the rumour of the crown, which gives the plot its excuse and its urgency.

Less obviously, you learn how Cassius's mind works when he is not talking to Brutus. With Brutus he was gentle and flattering; with Casca he is brisk, insulting ("You are dull, Casca"), theatrical and quick to adapt. The audience is being taught that Cassius has a different voice for every listener — which is exactly what will make his handling of Brutus in Act 2 so dangerous.

9 What Shakespeare deliberately withholds

LEVEL 3 — Why did Shakespeare write it this way?

Good dramatists are defined as much by what they leave out as by what they put in. Notice what this scene refuses to show you.

Brutus. The whole scene is aimed at him, and he never appears. Shakespeare saves Brutus's decision for the orchard scene that opens Act 2, where we watch him reason alone. Had Brutus walked on here, the storm would have swallowed his thinking; kept off stage, he becomes the silent centre the scene circles.

Caesar. Casca has just brought him home. We do not see how Caesar spends this night until Act 2 Scene 2, when Calpurnia's dream and the priests' sacrifices show us the same storm from inside his house. Shakespeare splits the night between two houses and shows you the conspirators' side first.

The letters' words. Cassius hands over "this paper" three times and never reads one aloud. You will hear a letter's contents only when Brutus reads it in his orchard. The withholding matters: we know the letters are forged before Brutus does, so when he takes them as the voice of Rome, we watch him deceived.

Whether the rumour is true. Casca says "they say". Nobody confirms that the Senate really means to crown Caesar. The conspiracy is built on a report, and the play never settles it.

Cassius's sincerity. Does he believe the storm is a warning about Caesar, or is that a line he has found for Casca? The text leaves it open (see the Professor's Insight later in this chapter).

A judge. There is no chorus, no honest bystander, no comment from outside. After Cicero leaves, you hear the conspiracy only from inside it. Shakespeare makes you do the judging.

10 Important language

Casca spoke prose in Scene 2 — the language of gossip and sneering. In Scene 3 he speaks verse, and so does everyone else. Fear has raised his register. This is worth saying in an answer: Shakespeare signals a change of mood partly through a change of form.

Learn these words; the scene turns on them.

Word	Meaning in the scene
"prodigies" / "portentous"	wonders that warn of the future / carrying an omen
"construe"	interpret; read a meaning into
"conjointly"	all together, at the same time
"unbracèd"	with doublet unfastened; shirt open
"thunder-stone"	the thunderbolt, imagined as a stone hurled from the sky
"thews"	muscles, bodily strength
"sufferance"	patient endurance; putting up with something
"bondman"	a slave; one in bondage
"factious"	active in forming a faction, a party
"redress"	remedy, setting right
"incorporate"	joined into one body with; made a member
"hie"	hurry
"conceited"	conceived, expressed (nothing to do with vanity)
"offal"	refuse, waste scraps
"fleering"	sneering, mocking

Two features of Cassius's language deserve a name. The first is **anaphora** — the repetition of an opening word: "Why all these fires, why all these gliding ghosts, / Why birds and beasts from quality and kind, / Why old men, fools, and children calculate". The hammering 'why' makes his interpretation sound like an inevitable answer to an obvious question. The second is speaking of himself in the third person, which rhetoricians call **illeism**: "Cassius from bondage will deliver Cassius." That habit belongs, in this play, to Caesar ("for always I am Caesar"). When Cassius borrows it, he is — consciously or not — measuring himself against the man he hates.

11 Important images

The scene's images run in five families, and the best answers show how they interlock.

Fire. A "tempest dropping fire"; a hand that burned "Like twenty torches joined"; "Men all in fire"; "all these fires"; a "mighty fire" begun "with weak straws"; Rome as base matter that serves "to illuminate / So vile a thing as Caesar"; the night "Most bloody, fiery, and most terrible". Fire is the storm, the omen, the anger and the deed.

Beasts. The "lion" at the Capitol becomes Cassius's roaring Caesar and then the lion that would not exist "were not Romans hinds" (female deer). Caesar is a "wolf", Romans are "sheep". The "bird of night" is the owl. Beasts out of their places — a lion in the street, an owl at noon — mean a world out of order.

Bondage. "yoke", "bondage", "bondman", "captivity", "worldly bars", "stony tower", "walls of beaten brass", "airless dungeon", "strong links of iron". The republican case is made as the imagery of prison.

The body. Cassius bares his "bosom"; the lightning opens "The breast of heaven"; Casca offers "My hand" and "this foot of mine"; Cassius wears a "dagger". Politics is done with bodies here, as it will be on the Ides.

Alchemy. Rome is "base matter" (the alchemist's raw metal); Brutus's face is "richest alchemy" that turns "offence" into "virtue". Both images are about transformation, and both, read carefully, concede that something base is being dressed up.

12 Literary devices

Only the devices genuinely at work here, each with its anchor:

- **Pathetic fallacy** (a term coined by Ruskin in the nineteenth century, used loosely for nature that seems to share human feeling): the "strange impatience of the heavens"; the "scolding winds"; the "ambitious ocean". Careful: Shakespeare's characters believe the correspondence is real, not a fallacy.
- **Foreshadowing:** "opens graves"; "this dagger"; "Most bloody, fiery, and most terrible".
- **Dramatic irony:** "A very pleasing night to honest men".
- **Simile:** "Like twenty torches joined"; "like richest alchemy"; "Shakes like a thing unfirm".
- **Metaphor:** wolf and sheep; lion and hinds; fire and straws; "Our yoke".
- **Personification:** "the scolding winds"; "Th' ambitious ocean"; "But, O grief, / Where hast thou led me?" (which is also **apostrophe**, direct address to an abstraction).
- **Anaphora:** the "Why ..." series; "Therein, you gods ... Therein, you gods".
- **Antithesis and paradox:** "you make the weak most strong".
- **Rhetorical question:** "Who ever knew the heavens menace so?"; "And why should Caesar be a tyrant, then?"
- **Euphemism:** life that "Never lacks power to dismiss itself" — suicide named without the word.
- **Hyperbole:** "a hundred ghastly women"; "all the sway of earth".
- **Illeism:** "Cassius from bondage will deliver Cassius".
- **Synecdoche:** "My hand"; "this foot of mine" — the part standing for the whole man's commitment.
- **Tricolon with repetition:** "Most bloody, fiery, and most terrible".

13 Themes

The scene is a junction where several of the play's great themes meet. **Fate and free will:** Cassius, who told Brutus that "Men at some time are masters of their fates", now reads the heavens for signs. **Superstition and interpretation:** three men, three readings of one storm. **Appearance versus reality:** letters that appear to come from citizens; a storm that appears to be divine anger; a conspiracy that will appear virtuous once Brutus's face is on it. **Liberty and bondage:** Cassius's suicide speech turns the republican slogan into a personal creed. **Honour:** the conspiracy claims it and, in the same breath, forges evidence. **Manliness and Roman virtue:** "womanish", "sparks of life / That should be in a Roman". **Fear as a political instrument:** Cassius converts Casca's fear into loyalty. **Order and disorder:** the storm as the sky's version of what is about to happen in the state.

14 Historical context

HISTORICAL CONTEXT What is Plutarch's and what is Shakespeare's

Shakespeare's source was Sir Thomas North's 1579 English translation of Plutarch. Plutarch's *Life of Caesar* records prodigies before the murder: lights in the sky, crashing noises at night, birds of ill omen settling in the Forum, men who seemed to be walking about on fire, and a slave whose hand poured out flame yet was unharmed when it stopped. Casca's burning slave and "Men all in fire" therefore come straight from the source, as does his owl in the marketplace (Plutarch's 'birds of omen' in the Forum). The lion "Against the Capitol" is not in Plutarch's list of omens so far as can be verified; most editors treat it as Shakespeare's own addition — and an Elizabethan audience knew lions as the exotic beasts kept in the menagerie at the Tower of London. Plutarch also records the rumour Casca reports: that the Senate meant to name Caesar king of the provinces outside Italy, wearing a diadem by land and sea. The bare-chested Cassius, the suicide speech, and the alchemy of Brutus's reputation are Shakespeare's invention.

Two further facts sharpen the scene. Cassius was, historically, an Epicurean — a follower of a philosophy that denied that the gods send omens — which makes his omen-reading here doubly interesting. And Brutus was urban praetor for 44 BC, which is why Cinna can leave a letter "in the Praetor's chair": that chair was Brutus's official seat. Ancient sources say Cassius resented receiving the lesser praetorship; Shakespeare never mentions this, but it lies behind the historical Cassius's bitterness.

The Elizabethan side of the context — why a London audience in 1599 would have taken a storm of omens seriously — is treated in the section 'Why the storm is not simply bad weather' below.

15 Foreshadowing

This scene is the most forward-looking in the act. Every important image points at something that will happen.

- The storm continues into Act 2 Scene 1 (Brutus reads by the light of the flashes) and Act 2 Scene 2, where Calpurnia reports omens of her own and begs Caesar to stay at home. The night begun here does not end until Caesar is dead.
- "opens graves" — Cassius's picture of a Caesar-like night that opens graves anticipates the dead who will not stay buried in this play: Caesar's Ghost visits Brutus in Act 4.
- Casca's drawn sword, unsheathed all night, prepares us for the fact — from Plutarch, and kept by Shakespeare — that Casca strikes the first blow on the Ides.
- "I know where I will wear this dagger then; / Cassius from bondage will deliver Cassius." At Philippi in Act 5 Cassius has himself killed by his own servant with his own sword. The line is fulfilled to the letter.
- Cinna carrying the letters is the conspirator Cinna; in Act 3 Scene 3 a mob tears apart Cinna the poet purely because of his name. A scene about how men "construe things after their fashion" plants the seed of the play's most terrible misreading.
- Cicero's exit foreshadows his exclusion from the conspiracy in Act 2 Scene 1 and, further off, his death in the proscriptions reported in Act 4.
- "Most bloody, fiery, and most terrible" is a three-word forecast of the assassination and the civil war.
- "Pompey's Porch" and "Pompey's Theatre" prepare the moment in Act 3 Scene 1 when Caesar falls at the base of Pompey's statue.

16 Dramatic irony

Dramatic irony is the gap between what the audience knows and what a character knows. The scene is thick with it.

The audience heard Cassius, alone, plan the forged letters; Cinna and Casca handle them as ordinary papers, and Brutus will receive them as the voice of Rome. Casca trembles because the gods "by tokens send / Such dreadful heralds to astonish us" — and the audience, remembering the Soothsayer, suspects the heralds are for Caesar, whom Casca himself will be the first to strike. Cicero reasons calmly that omens mean whatever men make of them, while the audience has already been told the date of the danger. Cassius calls the night "very pleasing ... to honest men" while planning a killing. He boasts that he can "shake off" tyranny by suicide "at pleasure", and anyone who knows Roman history knows he will. Most piercingly, he counts Brutus as three parts won, a possession to be secured — and the audience will watch Brutus, once won, take over the conspiracy and make the decisions (sparing Antony, refusing Cicero, allowing the funeral speech) that destroy it.

17 Character development

Casca is the scene's great change. In Scene 2 he was the man who "after his sour fashion" mocked everything — the crown, the crowd, Cicero's Greek. Brutus remembered him as "quick mettle when he went to school" and Cassius promised he would be quick again "in execution / Of any bold or noble enterprise". Scene 3 makes good on that. The cynic's armour turns out to have been thin; underneath is a frightened man who wants a cause. By the end he is not only sworn but eloquent: the "richest alchemy" speech is the most intelligent thing anyone says about Brutus in Act 1.

Cassius develops from analyst to leader. In Scene 2 he diagnosed the disease (Caesar's greatness, Rome's servility); in Scene 3 he is administering the cure — recruiting, organising, dispatching. We also see him take a risk and check himself ("But, O grief, / Where hast thou led me?"), which shows that the cool manipulator can be carried away by his own passion.

Cicero does not develop; he is a fixed point of reason against which the others are measured, and then he is removed.

Cinna is earnest and practical, the conspirator who says out loud what the others feel: they need Brutus.

18 Scene connections

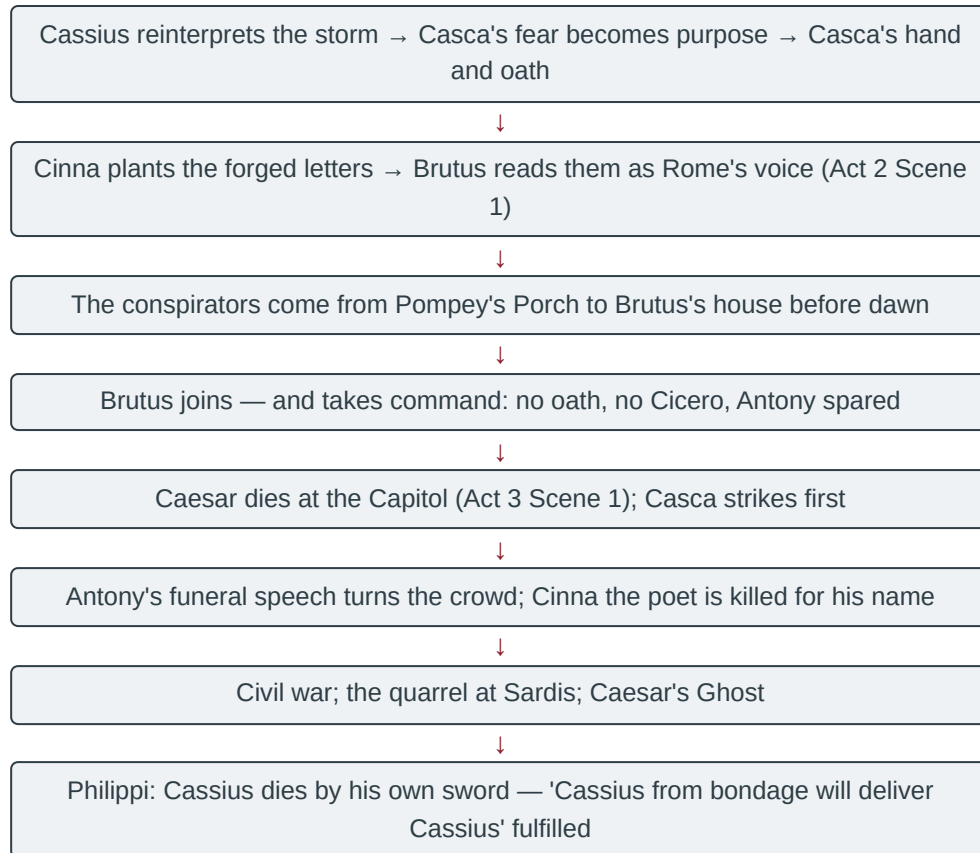
LEVEL 4 — How does it connect to the whole play?

Think of Scene 3 as the hinge of the play's first movement. Behind it stand the two daylight scenes; ahead of it lies a single night and day that runs, without a break in dramatic time, from here to the murder of Cinna the poet.

Backwards: Flavius feared that Caesar would "keep us all in servile fearfulness" (Scene 1) — Cassius now names that servility "bondage" and "yoke". Cassius told Brutus that many were "groaning underneath this age's yoke" (Scene 2) — the yoke returns as "Our yoke and sufferance". Cassius's soliloquy promised writings "wherein obscurely / Caesar's ambition shall be glanced at" — here they are, in Cinna's hands. Casca's sneer that Cicero "spoke Greek" is answered by Cicero speaking, in plain Latin-Roman English, the wisest line of the act. Caesar said Cassius "thinks too much" — Scene 3 shows the thinking turned into action.

Forwards: the storm rolls straight into Brutus's orchard and Caesar's bedroom; the letters are read; the conspirators from Pompey's Porch arrive at Brutus's door; the question of Cicero is raised and refused; Casca's sword falls first; Cinna's name kills a poet; Cassius's dagger turns on Cassius. Everything the scene sets in motion completes itself.

19 Future consequences



20 ICSE exam relevance

Let me be exact about the syllabus, because vagueness here wastes your time. **EXAM-ORIENTED ADVICE.** For the ICSE Class X board examination the prescribed portion of *Julius Caesar* is Acts III, IV and V. Act 1 — this scene included — is the Class IX portion, examined in school through reference-to-context and extract questions. So you will not be handed an extract from Scene 3 in the board paper. But the board paper leans on Act 1 constantly: it assumes you know who the conspirators are and why they conspired, what the storm and omens were, why Casca strikes first, who Cinna the conspirator is when a different Cinna is torn apart, why Cicero is absent, and what Cassius means when his fate at Philippi echoes his old words. In the 2025 paper the Section B drama questions were extract-based, worth 16 marks each, with five sub-questions marked [3], [3], [3], [3], [4]; the sub-questions typically ask what has just happened, what a phrase means, why a speaker says something, what is revealed about character, what happens next, and for a short evaluation. Act 1 knowledge is what lets you answer 'what has just happened' and 'why' with authority when the extract is from Act 3, 4 or 5.

LEVEL 5 — How do I use it in an ICSE answer?

Three uses, in ascending order of value.

(a) Class IX extract questions on this scene. Expect an extract from Casca's prodigies, Cicero's reply, Cassius's bared bosom, the suicide speech, or the letters. You will be asked who is speaking to whom and where; what the prodigies were; what Cicero means by construing "after their fashion"; why Cassius says the night is pleasing to honest men; what Cinna is told to do with the papers; and what happens next.

Answer from the text, in your own words, then quote a phrase.

(b) Context for Act 3–5 extracts. When an Act 3 extract shows Casca striking first, add one sentence: 'Casca, who in Act 1 Scene 3 kept his sword drawn all night and swore to go as far as any man, is fittingly the first to strike.' When an Act 5 extract has Cassius admitting he now half-believes in omens, add: 'This reverses his stance in Act 1 Scene 3, where he treated the storm as a rhetorical weapon rather than a sign.' Such sentences earn the marks reserved for 'understanding of the whole play'.

(c) Character and theme questions. The scene supplies the clearest evidence in Act 1 for Cassius as manipulator, for the theme of superstition, and for the honour problem of the forged letters. Use it as your first example, then move to Acts 2–5.

WEAK ANSWER A weak use of the scene (do not write this)

'In Act 1 Scene 3 there was a big storm and Casca was scared. Cassius was not scared. They decided to kill Caesar. This shows the theme of fate.'

EXCELLENT ANSWER A strong use of the scene

'Scene 3 shows Shakespeare's method of turning atmosphere into argument. Casca reads the storm as divine anger, Cicero warns that men "construe things after their fashion", and Cassius immediately proves Cicero right by construing the same omens as a warning against a man "Most like this dreadful night". The storm does not decide anything; the interpreter does — which is why the scene is about persuasion, not fate.'

The rest of this chapter goes deeper into each of the scene's parts, teaching the key passages line by line.

WHY THE STORM IS NOT SIMPLY BAD WEATHER

A weak reader treats the storm as scenery. A strong reader sees that it does three separate jobs at once — dramatic, symbolic and structural — and can name each.

The dramatic function: atmosphere, pace, night

Remember the Globe: an open roof, an afternoon performance, spectators standing in daylight. Shakespeare had drums and probably rolled cannonballs for thunder, and fireworks for lightning, but the darkness itself could only be spoken into existence. So the first job of the storm language is to build night and terror out of nothing — "what night is this!", "this fearful night", "This disturbèd sky". Every character who enters remarks on the weather, and that repetition is not carelessness: it keeps repainting the darkness for an audience standing in the sun.

The storm also sets the pace. Look at the first exchange: Cicero asks two quick questions; Casca answers in a torrent. Then the dialogue tightens into short, breathless lines — "Who's there?" / "A Roman." / "Casca, by your voice." Nobody has time. The storm is a clock as well as a sky.

Finally, the storm provides cover. Conspiracies belong to night, and this one needs empty streets: "For now, this fearful night, / There is no stir or walking in the streets". The weather that terrifies Casca is, for Cassius, a gift of privacy — and the play makes the point aloud when the thunder answers the suicide speech (the Folio marks it: thunder still). The storm is almost a fifth speaker.

The symbolic function: disorder, divine anger, civil strife in heaven

The storm is a picture of disorder. Casca's phrase is the key: "Either there is a civil strife in heaven, / Or else the world, too saucy with the gods, / Incenses them to send destruction." He offers two readings, and both are political. A 'civil strife' among the gods projects the coming Roman civil war on to the sky. A world "too saucy with the gods" — insolent, presuming above its station — points at a Rome in which a man is being turned into a god; Cassius has already sneered in Scene 2 that Caesar "Is now become a god". Either way, the sky is saying what the characters are about to do.

The symbol is also a test. Put four men under the same storm and each reveals himself: Casca fears and reports, Cicero reasons and goes home, Cinna hurries and wonders, Cassius bares his chest and boasts. The weather is a device for showing character under pressure — which is exactly how Shakespeare will use it again in *King Lear*, where a king's mind and a storm break together.

The structural function: bridging the month

Structurally the storm is a hinge. Scenes 1 and 2 were one public day; Scene 3 begins the one long night that runs — without a break in dramatic time — through Brutus's orchard, Caesar's house, the streets at dawn, the Capitol, the Forum and the killing of Cinna the poet. The month between the Lupercal and the Ides is simply skipped, and the storm covers the join: an audience swept into thunder does not stop to ask what day it is. Cicero's question then quietly supplies the date.

The storm also carries across the act break. The thunder that begins here is still flashing when Brutus reads his letter in Act 2 Scene 1 and when Calpurnia describes her night in Act 2 Scene 2. So Scene 3 is not the end of something; it is the opening of the night that will kill Caesar.

The storm: thunder, lightning, "a tempest dropping fire"

Now the opening passage, line by line. This is the speech that makes the night.

Original line / short passage:

Casca: *Are not you moved, when all the sway of earth / Shakes like a thing unfirm? ... But never till tonight, never till now, / Did I go through a tempest dropping fire. / Either there is a civil strife in heaven, / Or else the world, too saucy with the gods, / Incenses them to send destruction.*

Simple English: Aren't you shaken, when the whole solid, ordered earth trembles like something loose? I have seen storms split oaks and seen the sea rear up to the clouds — but never until tonight have I walked through a storm that rained fire. Either the gods are at war with one another, or the world has grown so insolent towards them that it has provoked them to destroy it.

Difficult words: "moved" — emotionally shaken, not physically; "sway" — the ordered motion and government of the earth (the same root as 'hold sway'); "unfirm" — unsteady; "rived" (in the lines between) — split apart; "knotty" — gnarled; "exalted" — raised up; "saucy" — insolent, presumptuous; "Incenses" —

enrages.

Literal meaning: The earth itself seems to shake; this storm is unlike any Casca has known because it drops fire (lightning so continuous it seems to rain); its cause must be supernatural — either quarrelling gods or gods angered by human pride.

Subtext: The opening is a question, not a statement — "Are not you moved ...?" Casca needs Cicero to share his fear; a frightened man wants company. The whole speech is an appeal for confirmation.

Hidden meaning: "civil strife in heaven" quietly transfers Rome's future on to the sky. The gods are imagined as a Roman state at war with itself. And a world "too saucy with the gods" is a world in which a man has grown god-like — the very complaint Cassius has been making about Caesar.

Character psychology: This is the man who called the Lupercal "mere foolery". The cynic's pose has been stripped off by fear. Notice the hyperbole — "all the sway of earth" — a frightened mind sees everything as total.

Political meaning: Casca's two alternatives are two political diagnoses. 'Strife among the great' is one Roman disease; 'a presumptuous man over-reaching' is the other. He cannot decide which the storm means, and that indecision is exactly the gap that Cassius will fill.

Historical context: HISTORICAL RECORD. Romans took prodigies (prodigia) seriously as official business: unnatural events were reported to the Senate and expiated by priests, because they showed the gods' goodwill had been broken. Plutarch lists prodigies before Caesar's death. Shakespeare's Elizabethan audience had its own habit of reading storms and comets as warnings to the state.

Literary devices: Simile ("Shakes like a thing unfirm"); personification ("the scolding winds", "Th' ambitious ocean"); repetition for emphasis ("never till tonight, never till now"); hyperbole ("all the sway of earth"); the balanced either/or structure that offers two interpretations at once.

Effect: The audience, standing in daylight, is plunged into a night of fire in seven lines. The word "tempest" will echo through the scene ("this fearful night", "this dreadful night"), and "fire" will run through it like a fuse.

Dramatic significance: The scene opens at its highest pitch of fear. Everything Cassius does afterwards depends on the terror this speech establishes.

Foreshadowing: "civil strife" is the whole second half of the play in two words. "Destruction" is what the storm announces and what the conspirators will deliver.

Scene connection: In Scene 2 Cassius mocked Caesar because "this god did shake". Now the earth shakes. The word links the frail body of the man-god to the shaking world around him.

ICSE keywords: omen, portent, pathetic fallacy, hyperbole, disorder, foreshadowing, divine anger.

Exam application: If asked why Shakespeare opens the scene with Casca rather than Cassius, write: 'By giving the terror to Casca — the sneerer of Scene 2 — Shakespeare shows how completely the storm has unsettled Rome; his phrase "a civil strife in heaven" turns the weather into a forecast of the civil war to come.'

Political disorder and natural disorder: the idea of correspondence

LITERARY INTERPRETATION, with historical grounding. Many Elizabethans inherited a way of thinking in which the universe was a set of matching levels: the heavens, the state and the individual human being were built on the same pattern, so that disorder in one showed itself in the others. A king was to his kingdom what the sun was to the sky and reason to the soul. When this ordered chain was broken — by rebellion, usurpation or murder — nature itself was expected to protest. The official Tudor homilies read in

churches taught obedience partly on this ground: the whole creation was arranged in degrees and ranks, and to disturb them was to disturb creation. The scholar E. M. W. Tillyard made this 'world picture' famous in the twentieth century; later critics have rightly warned that not every Elizabethan believed it and that the plays often question it. But as a shared vocabulary it was available to everyone in the Globe, and Shakespeare uses it repeatedly: the night of Duncan's murder in *Macbeth* brings an owl that kills a falcon and horses that eat one another; Lear's madness is played out in a storm.

Apply this to Scene 3 with care. The storm does not prove that the play believes in correspondence; it shows the characters using the belief. Casca is a straightforward believer. Cicero is a sceptic who says the belief tells you about the believer. Cassius uses the belief as a lever. And in Act 2 Scene 2 Calpurnia will use it in the opposite direction, arguing that the heavens are announcing Caesar's death, not his tyranny. The correspondence between sky and state is real inside the play — but its meaning is fought over, which is why the storm is a battlefield rather than a signpost.

PROFESSOR'S INSIGHT

Why the storm mirrors political instability — and why the mirror is cracked

School guides say the storm 'reflects the disorder in Rome'. True, but stop there and you miss what Shakespeare is actually doing. Look at what the storm is made to mean within a single night. Cassius tells Casca that the night is like a man — "Most like this dreadful night, / That thunders, lightens, opens graves, and roars". In his reading, Caesar is the storm: the monstrous growth that has thrown the state out of its "ordinance". Yet in Act 2 Scene 2 Calpurnia will treat the same storm as heaven's announcement of Caesar's death; there Caesar is the storm's victim, not its likeness. One sky; two opposite politics.

That is the point. A stable state has stable meanings: everyone knows what a crown or a comet signifies. An unstable state is one in which even the sky can be read for either side. So the storm mirrors instability not only by being violent but by being *interpretable* — by lending itself to Casca's terror, Cicero's doubt, Cassius's ambition and Calpurnia's dread in turn. The disorder in Rome is, at bottom, a disorder of interpretation: nobody agrees any longer what Caesar is (god? tyrant? friend? "a dreamer"?), and so nobody agrees what the heavens are saying about him. Cassius's own phrase gives the game away: heaven sends warnings "Unto some monstrous state". 'State' means both a condition and *the State* — and the monstrous thing may be tyranny, or the murder that will cure it. Shakespeare lets the word carry both.

THE SUPERNATURAL SIGNS

The prodigies one by one

Cicero asks, "Why, saw you anything more wonderful?" ('wonderful' here means 'astonishing', not 'delightful'). Casca's answer is a catalogue of four prodigies. Learn them as a set; extract questions ask for them, and each carries a meaning.

Prodigy	What Casca reports	Source	What it suggests
The slave's burning hand	"A common slave" held up his left hand, which burned "Like twenty torches joined" yet stayed "unscorched"	Plutarch	Fire that does not consume: nature's first law suspended. A slave — the lowest man — made a vessel of divine fire

Prodigy	What Casca reports	Source	What it suggests
The lion "Against the Capitol"	It "glazed upon me and went surly by / Without annoying me"	Not in Plutarch; apparently Shakespeare's addition	The king of beasts loose at the seat of the state, staring and unhurried — an image many readers connect with Caesar
The "hundred ghastly women"	Huddled "Upon a heap", "Transformèd with their fear", they "swore they saw / Men all in fire walk up and down the streets"	Plutarch (men on fire)	Mass terror; fear that transforms those who feel it — a preview of what fear will do to the crowd
"the bird of night" at noon	An owl sat "Even at noonday upon the marketplace, / Hooting and shrieking"	Plutarch's birds of omen in the Forum	Time inverted: the night bird in the noon sun, in the very marketplace where Caesar swooned in Scene 2

Three details repay attention. First, the lion's strange calm: "glazed" (the Folger reading; other editions print 'glared') means it looked with a fixed, glassy stare and went "surly" — sullenly — past. Casca is not attacked; he is ignored, as a lesser man is ignored by a great one. Second, the women's testimony is hedged — they "swore they saw" — so even inside Casca's report the evidence is second-hand; the play is careful about who saw what. Third, "ghastly" and "Transformèd with their fear" make fear itself the agent of change: the storm does not only frighten people, it alters them. Keep this for Level 4: fear is what transforms the Roman crowd into a mob in Act 3.

TEXT NOTE 'glazed' or 'glared'

The First Folio reads 'glaz'd'. The Folger text keeps "glazed" (stared glassily); the Globe-edition text behind many school editions prints 'glared'. Either is acceptable in an answer; if your edition says 'glared', quote it as your edition has it and do not lose sleep over the variant.

The conclusion of the catalogue, line by line

Original line / short passage:

Casca: *When these prodigies / Do so conjointly meet, let not men say / 'These are their reasons, they are natural,' / For I believe they are portentous things / Unto the climate that they point upon.*

Simple English: When so many wonders happen together like this, nobody should say 'there are natural explanations for them'. I believe they are omens for the country they are aimed at.

Difficult words: "prodigies" — unnatural wonders that warn; "conjointly" — all together; "reasons" — causes, explanations; "portentous" — full of omen, ominous; "climate" — region, country (not 'weather'); "point upon" — are aimed at.

Literal meaning: One marvel might be a coincidence; four at once cannot be. Therefore they are signs, and signs are directed at a particular place — Rome.

Subtext: Casca is arguing with an imagined rationalist before Cicero has spoken — "let not men say". He knows the sceptical reply is coming and tries to block it. The believer is already on the defensive.

Hidden meaning: The word "climate" reveals the political reading buried inside the religious one. Omens 'point at' a country; the country in question is a Rome about to crown a king. Even Casca half-knows what the storm is about.

Character psychology: He reasons from accumulation — 'so many things together cannot be chance'. It is the logic of a frightened but not stupid man; he is trying to make his terror respectable.

Political meaning: The debate 'natural causes or divine warning?' is not academic. If the omens are natural, the state is not in question; if they are portents, something in the state is wrong and must be put right. To accept the omens is already to accept that Rome needs redress.

Historical context: HISTORICAL RECORD. Roman religion regarded the simultaneous occurrence of prodigies as a matter for the Senate and the priestly colleges; Plutarch and later Roman poets (Virgil, Ovid) all record clusters of portents around Caesar's death. The Elizabethan pamphlet press did the same with English storms and monstrous births. Casca's reasoning would have sounded orthodox to both audiences.

Literary devices: An anticipated objection answered in advance (a rhetorical move); the embedded quotation of an imagined opponent; the abstract diction of "portentous things" against the homely "they are natural".

Effect: The catalogue ends not on an image but on an argument, which invites Cicero's reply. Shakespeare turns a list of horrors into a debate about interpretation.

Dramatic significance: This is the cue for the scene's central intellectual moment — Cicero's answer. Without Casca's insistence, Cicero's scepticism would have nothing to bite on.

Foreshadowing: The question 'natural or portentous?' returns in Caesar's house in Act 2 Scene 2, where Caesar first dismisses the omens and is then persuaded by Calpurnia, before Decius Brutus reinterprets her dream and leads him out. The play keeps re-staging this argument until it kills its subject.

Scene connection: Casca in Scene 2 refused to interpret anything — Cicero's Greek "was Greek to me"; the crown business was "mere foolery". Here he insists on interpretation. The mocker has become a reader of signs.

ICSE keywords: omen, portent, superstition, interpretation, rationalism, foreshadowing.

Exam application: On the theme of superstition: 'Casca's refusal to accept natural explanations — "let not men say / "These are their reasons, they are natural"' — sets up the play's running argument about whether the heavens speak, an argument Caesar himself will lose on the Ides.'

Three readings of one storm

The scene stages three responses to the same sky. Learn them as a triangle; it is the most useful single structure in the scene.

	Casca	Cicero	Cassius
What the storm is	The gods' anger or the gods' war; "portentous things"	A "strange-disposèd time" about which men will believe what suits them	Heaven's warning "Unto some monstrous state" — and a portrait of Caesar
What one should do	"fear and tremble"	Go home: "This disturbèd sky / Is not to walk in"	Walk in it, bare-chested; act
Type of mind	Believer, frightened	Sceptic, prudent	Opportunist, defiant
Fate or free will?	The gods decide	Men decide what the gods mean	Men decide — and use the gods to recruit
Later echo	Casca strikes first at the Capitol	Excluded from the plot; killed in the proscriptions	Half-believes in omens by Act 5; dies by his own sword

Casca: terror against the cynicism of Scene 2

Put Casca's two scenes side by side and you have a small masterclass in how Shakespeare builds a minor character. In Scene 2 he is all prose, all sneer: the crowd are "tag-rag people" with "sweaty nightcaps" and "stinking breath"; Caesar's swoon was "mere foolery"; he would not laugh "for fear of opening my lips and receiving the bad air". His weapons are contempt and distance; he watches Rome as if it were a bad play.

In Scene 3 the distance collapses. He is "breathless", he stares, his sword is out, he speaks verse, and his first words beg another man to share his fear. When Cassius boasts of walking in the lightning, Casca answers with an appeal to piety that would have astonished his Scene 2 self: "It is the part of men to fear and tremble / When the most mighty gods by tokens send / Such dreadful heralds to astonish us." ('Tokens' are signs; 'heralds' are messengers who announce what is coming; to 'astonish' is to stun.) The cynic turns out to have been a believer all along; the mockery was a way of not looking.

LITERARY INTERPRETATION. Why does Shakespeare give the terror to Casca? Partly for contrast: fear is more frightening in a man who mocked. Partly because Casca is the recruit, and a frightened man is the easiest man to recruit — he wants meaning, and Cassius sells meaning. And partly because Casca is Caesar's man. In Scene 2 it was Casca who cried "Peace, ho! Caesar speaks"; tonight Cicero asks him "Brought you Caesar home?" He has walked Caesar to his door and then, in the same night, given his hand to Caesar's killers. The betrayal is from inside the household, and the play wants you to feel that. Remember, too, Cassius's promise in Scene 2 that Casca is quick "in execution / Of any bold or noble enterprise, / However he puts on this tardy form" — 'execution' is a grim pun the play will pay off when Casca strikes first.

CICERO: THE SCEPTICAL RATIONALIST

Cicero speaks four times in the whole play, all of them here. Two of his speeches are questions; one is a warning; one is a goodnight. Yet what he says is, in my judgement, one of the keys to the whole play.

The line, taught line by line

Original line / short passage:

Cicero: *Indeed, it is a strange-disposèd time. / But men may construe things after their fashion, / Clean from the purpose of the things themselves. / Comes Caesar to the Capitol tomorrow?*

Simple English: Yes, these are strange, unsettled times. But people interpret events to suit their own way of thinking, and their interpretations may have nothing to do with what the events really mean. Is Caesar coming to the Capitol tomorrow?

Difficult words: "strange-disposèd" — strangely arranged, abnormally inclined; "construe" — interpret, explain; "after their fashion" — in their own way, according to their own bent; "Clean from" — entirely away from; "purpose" — real meaning, intention.

Literal meaning: Cicero neither denies the prodigies nor accepts Casca's reading of them. He grants that the time is strange and then makes a general point: interpretation reveals the interpreter. Then he changes the subject to practical business.

Subtext: The change of subject is the point. Cicero's real question is not about the sky but about Caesar's movements. The rationalist has one eye on the weather and both eyes on politics.

Hidden meaning: The line is a warning that the play's characters will ignore. Casca construes the storm as divine wrath; Cassius construes it as an indictment of Caesar; Calpurnia will construe it as Caesar's death; Decius Brutus will construe her dream into a compliment; Brutus will construe forged letters as the voice of Rome; the mob will construe a poet's name as a conspirator's. Every catastrophe in the play is a construing "Clean from the purpose of the things themselves".

Character psychology: Cicero is calm, dry and detached. He does not argue with Casca's fear; he steps around it. Notice "Indeed": he agrees before he disagrees, the orator's courtesy.

Political meaning: Cicero's scepticism is politically neutral, which in a crisis is itself a position. He will not read the heavens for a party. That is why the conspirators, in Act 2 Scene 1, will consider him and reject him; he is not a man who follows.

Historical context: HISTORICAL RECORD. The real Cicero wrote a treatise on divination that examines omens, dreams and prophecy with a sceptic's eye, so Shakespeare's portrait — whether or not he knew that work directly — fits the man. He was not part of the conspiracy, though he approved of it afterwards, and he was killed on the triumvirs' orders in December 43 BC. In Scene 2 Casca reported that at the Lupercal Cicero "spoke Greek": the man of learning who talks over the heads of the crowd.

Literary devices: Aphorism (a compact general truth); antithesis between "their fashion" and "the purpose of the things themselves"; the abrupt shift of register from philosophy to a plain question — a kind of bathos that is dramatically deliberate.

Effect: For a moment the temperature drops. Amid fire and terror one man speaks quietly and sensibly, and the audience is invited to stand where he stands — outside the interpretations, watching men construe.

Dramatic significance: This is the play's statement of its own epistemology (its theory of how we know things). It is also the only cool head in the scene, and Shakespeare removes it at once: "Good night then, Casca." The moment reason leaves, Cassius enters.

Foreshadowing: Every misreading in the play, from Brutus's letter to Cinna the poet's death to Cassius's misreading of the battle at Philippi, is foreshadowed by this line.

Scene connection: Brutus used the same verb in Scene 2 — "Nor construe any further my neglect" — asking Cassius not to over-interpret his coldness. Cassius did exactly that. The play's characters keep asking not to be construed and keep construing others.

ICSE keywords: scepticism, rationalism, interpretation, appearance versus reality, dramatic irony, aphorism.

Exam application: In a theme answer on appearance and reality or on superstition: 'Cicero's warning that "men may construe things after their fashion, / Clean from the purpose of the things themselves" is proved true within minutes, when Cassius construes the same storm as a portrait of Caesar; the line is the play's own comment on how its characters misread signs, letters, speeches and even names.'

The question that fixes the date

"Comes Caesar to the Capitol tomorrow?" does quiet, essential work. Until this moment the play has had a warning without a date; the Soothsayer said "Beware the ides of March" and Caesar called him "a dreamer". Now a bystander's practical question tells the audience that tomorrow is the day and the Capitol is the place. Casca's answer — Caesar "did bid Antonius / Send word to you he would be there tomorrow" — adds two more facts: Caesar is still using Antony as his messenger and manager, and Caesar still counts Cicero among the senators he expects to see. From this line onward every speech in the scene is spoken under a deadline.

HISTORICAL RECORD. Shakespeare relocates the killing: historically Caesar died in the Curia of Pompey, part of Pompey's theatre complex, not on the Capitol. The play's "Capitol" is a poet's Rome, where the seat of the state and the scene of the killing are one.

PROFESSOR'S INSIGHT Why Cicero is given the sceptic's line and then removed

Shakespeare had a famous man at his disposal — the greatest orator Rome produced — and used him for forty lines and a single idea. Why waste Cicero so?

Because the idea needs a voice the audience will trust and the plot cannot use. Trust first: Cicero's authority makes "men may construe things after their fashion" sound like wisdom rather than cynicism; from Casca it would be fear, from Cassius a tactic. But the plot cannot use a sceptic. Conspiracies run on conviction, and the scene's whole business — turning a storm into a mandate — depends on nobody asking Cicero's question. So Shakespeare has him ask it once, lets it hang in the air, and sends him indoors: "This disturbèd sky / Is not to walk in." The rational man goes home; the men who stay out in the storm make history.

There is a second, sadder reason. In Act 2 Scene 1 the conspirators will discuss recruiting Cicero and Brutus will veto him on the grounds that he will never follow anything other men have begun — a compliment disguised as a rejection. In Act 4 we learn he has been killed in the proscriptions. Cicero's arc in this play is: speak the truest line, be excluded by the good men, be murdered by the bad ones. That is Shakespeare's judgement on what happens to independent reason in a time of faction, and it is delivered almost entirely through absence. When you write about the storm, do not forget the man who refused to walk in it.

CASSIUS IN THE STORM

Cicero goes in; Cassius comes out. The stage direction is simple, but the substitution is the hinge of the scene: the man who would not walk in the sky is replaced by the man who has been walking in it on purpose. Everything Cassius says from here to Cinna's entrance is one continuous act of persuasion, and the best way to study it is to watch his tactics change as Casca changes.

"A very pleasing night to honest men": the entrance

The first exchange is in fragments — "Who's there?" / "A Roman." / "Casca, by your voice." Casca does not give his name in the dark; he gives his nationality, and the word will be thrown back at him within a minute ("those sparks of life / That should be in a Roman you do want"). Cassius knows him by ear: "Your ear is good," says Casca — a small, telling compliment, because the whole scene turns on how well Cassius listens.

Then Casca asks the question the whole of Rome is asking — "what night is this!" — and Cassius gives the answer nobody else would give: "A very pleasing night to honest men." Hear the dramatic irony. Casca means 'what a terrible night'; Cassius hears 'what kind of night is this?' and answers as if it were a riddle. To the frightened it is terror; to "honest men" — the conspirators' word for themselves, which the play will test to destruction — it is pleasing, because the streets are empty and the sky seems to agree with them. When Casca presses — "Who ever knew the heavens menace so?" — Cassius answers with a line that quietly moves the cause of the storm from the sky to the city: "Those that have known the Earth so full of faults." The heavens threaten because the earth deserves it. In two lines he has turned a weather report into a political judgement, and he has not yet mentioned Caesar.

Baring his bosom to "the thunder-stone"

Original line / short passage:

Cassius: *And thus unbracèd, Casca, as you see, / Have bared my bosom to the thunder-stone; / And when the cross blue lightning seemed to open / The breast of heaven, I did present myself / Even in the aim and very flash of it.*

Simple English: And with my doublet undone, Casca, as you can see, I have bared my chest to the thunderbolt; and when the forked blue lightning seemed to split open the sky, I stood exactly where it was aimed, right in the flash.

Difficult words: "unbracèd" — with the fastenings of the doublet (the close-fitting Elizabethan jacket) undone; "bosom" — chest, breast; "thunder-stone" — the thunderbolt, which popular belief imagined as a stone hurled from the clouds; "cross" — forked, zigzag; "the breast of heaven" — the sky imagined as a body that the lightning cuts open; "present myself" — place myself deliberately; "aim" — the target line of the bolt.

Literal meaning: Cassius has spent the storm walking the streets half-dressed, deliberately standing where the lightning struck, and he has not been harmed.

Subtext: This is a performance for an audience of one. "as you see" makes Casca look; "I did present myself" makes him picture it. Cassius is showing, before he argues, that he is not afraid — and that a man who is not afraid of heaven need not be afraid of Caesar.

Hidden meaning: A bared chest offered to a blow is, in this play, the gesture of a man inviting death on his own terms. In Scene 2 Casca reported that Caesar "plucked me ope his doublet and offered them his throat to cut". Cassius now makes the same gesture to the sky. Two rivals, two bared breasts: Caesar's a piece of crowd-theatre, Cassius's a piece of recruitment-theatre. And there is a grim symmetry ahead — a bosom bared tonight, daggers in a body tomorrow.

Character psychology: The hunger for risk that Caesar diagnosed — "He thinks too much. Such men are dangerous." — here takes physical form. Cassius needs to prove to himself, as much as to Casca, that fear does not govern him. There is also vanity in it: he has made himself the hero of a story and is telling it.

Political meaning: To stand in the lightning is to deny that the gods are on Caesar's side. If heaven wanted to punish the enemies of its favourite, here was its chance; it did not take it. Cassius's unburnt body is offered as evidence that the storm's anger is aimed elsewhere.

Historical context: HISTORICAL RECORD. The real Cassius followed the philosophy of Epicurus, which taught that the gods take no interest in human affairs and that thunder has natural causes. A historically minded reader therefore sees a man acting out his philosophy — defying signs he does not believe in. Shakespeare never names the philosophy, but Plutarch's Cassius is an Epicurean and the play's Cassius behaves like one here. **LITERARY INTERPRETATION.** Whether Shakespeare intended the allusion is uncertain; what is certain is the stage image of a bare-chested man under a stormy sky, which an Elizabethan audience would have found both heroic and impious.

Literary devices: Personification and bodily metaphor — the lightning opens "The breast of heaven" as Cassius opens his own breast, so sky and man mirror each other; the sharp visual adjective "cross blue"; the deliberate self-dramatisation of "I did present myself".

Effect: The audience, who have just watched Casca shake, now see his opposite. The contrast is the point: fear and defiance under the same sky.

Dramatic significance: This speech announces Cassius's reading of the storm before he states it. His body has already argued that the heavens are not against him.

Foreshadowing: The man who offers his chest to the lightning will, at Philippi, offer it to his own sword. Defiance of death is Cassius's constant; it ends by consuming him.

Scene connection: In Scene 2 Cassius proved his courage with a story — the swim in the Tiber, with Caesar crying "Help me, Cassius, or I sink!" Here he proves it with a live demonstration. Both times the lesson is the same: Cassius is braver than the god.

ICSE keywords: defiance, hubris, dramatic irony, foreshadowing, characterisation through action, impiety.

Exam application: On Cassius's character: 'Cassius's boast that he has "bared my bosom to the thunder-stone" shows a man who treats even the heavens as a rival to be outfaced; the gesture both proves his courage to Casca and reveals the recklessness that will end with his own sword at Philippi.'

Reinterpreting the omens: "a man / Most like this dreadful night"

Casca's reply to the boast is pious horror: "But wherefore did you so much tempt the heavens? / It is the part of men to fear and tremble / When the most mighty gods by tokens send / Such dreadful heralds to astonish us." ('Wherefore' means 'why'; to 'tempt' the heavens is to provoke them; 'the part of men' is men's proper role.) This is the moment Cassius has been waiting for. Casca has stated the orthodox view — omens are heaven's messengers; men should tremble — and Cassius does not deny it. He accepts that the omens are messages and then changes the address on the envelope.

He begins with an insult: "You are dull, Casca, and those sparks of life / That should be in a Roman you do want, / Or else you use not." Casca "want[s]" (lacks) the Roman fire, or has it and does not use it; the word "sparks" picks up the fire imagery and turns it inward — the real fire should be in the man, not in the sky. Then comes the catalogue of "Why ..." questions already discussed under Important language, and finally the claim that "heaven hath infused them with these spirits / To make them instruments of fear and warning / Unto some monstrous state." Now the portrait:

Original line / short passage:

Cassius: *Now could I, Casca, name to thee a man / Most like this dreadful night, / That thunders, lightens, opens graves, and roars / As doth the lion in the Capitol; / A man no mightier than thyself or me / In personal action, yet prodigious grown, / And fearful, as these strange eruptions are.*

Simple English: I could name you a man, Casca, who is exactly like this terrible night — who thunders, flashes lightning, opens graves and roars like the lion at the Capitol; a man no stronger than you or me in what he can personally do, yet who has grown into something monstrous and frightening, just like these strange outbreaks in nature.

Difficult words: "name to thee" — name for you; "Most like" — most resembling; "opens graves" — splits the earth so the dead are exposed (an earthquake image); "personal action" — individual physical capacity; "prodigious" — monstrous, portent-like (the adjective of "prodigies"); "fearful" — causing fear (not 'afraid'); "eruptions" — violent outbreaks.

Literal meaning: Caesar — unnamed — is compared to the storm: as the night has grown unnaturally violent, so an ordinary man has grown unnaturally great.

Subtext: Cassius does not say the name. He makes Casca say it — "'Tis Caesar that you mean, is it not, Cassius?" — and then refuses to confirm: "Let it be who it is." A recruiter who makes the recruit speak the treason first has protected himself and committed the other man. It is the same technique Cassius used on

Brutus, drawing out "I do fear the people / Choose Caesar for their king" before saying anything of his own.

Hidden meaning: "A man no mightier than thyself or me / In personal action" is the Scene 2 argument in miniature: "I was born free as Caesar". The storm image adds something new, though. A storm is not wicked; it is simply out of proportion. Cassius's deepest charge against Caesar is not vice but scale — a man has become a weather system.

Character psychology: Notice how quickly Cassius moves from mocking Casca's fear to exploiting it. He does not want Casca unafraid; he wants Casca's fear pointed at Caesar. The insult ("dull") and the flattery of being trusted with a secret ("Now could I ... name to thee") work together, as a hard word followed by a confidence often does.

Political meaning: By making Caesar the storm, Cassius makes the removal of Caesar the restoration of calm. The political killing is reframed as a return to natural order — which is exactly how Brutus will later justify it to himself.

Historical context: HISTORICAL RECORD. Caesar was dictator for life by February 44 BC and was being voted extraordinary honours by a Senate that had largely stopped resisting him; a contemporary could reasonably describe his power as having grown out of all proportion to the old offices. The lion "in the Capitol" refers back to Casca's own prodigy; Cassius is turning Casca's evidence into Cassius's argument.

Literary devices: Extended simile shading into metaphor (Caesar as the night that "thunders, lightens, opens graves, and roars"); asyndeton in the four verbs, which gives the line a pounding rhythm; antithesis between "no mightier ... In personal action" and "prodigious grown"; the deliberate withholding of the name, which is a kind of periphrasis.

Effect: The storm, which a minute ago was simply frightening, is now 'about' something. The audience experiences the same conversion that Casca does — chaos acquires a cause.

Dramatic significance: This is the central act of interpretation in the scene — the moment Cicero's warning is proved true. Men "construe things after their fashion", and here is the construing, performed in front of us, by a master.

Foreshadowing: "opens graves" anticipates Caesar's Ghost in Act 4 and, nearer at hand, Calpurnia's report in Act 2 Scene 2 of graves yielding up their dead. Shakespeare uses the same prodigy on both sides of the argument.

Scene connection: The "lion in the Capitol" carries Casca's prodigy forward and prepares Cassius's later "He were no lion, were not Romans hinds." The lion is Caesar in both places, but in the second the blame has shifted from the lion to the deer.

ICSE keywords: extended simile, interpretation, manipulation, Caesar's greatness, natural order, foreshadowing.

Exam application: On the theme of superstition and manipulation: 'Cassius never denies that the omens are heaven's warnings; he simply redirects them, calling Caesar a man "Most like this dreadful night" so that Casca's terror of the sky becomes terror of Caesar. The storm thus serves not fate but rhetoric.'

PROFESSOR'S INSIGHT Why Cassius, who says men master their fates, now reads omens

In Scene 2 Cassius gave the play its most famous statement of free will: "Men at some time are masters of their fates. / The fault, dear Brutus, is not in our stars, / But in ourselves, that we are underlings." A month later he stands in a thunderstorm telling Casca that "heaven hath infused" the beasts and the fires "with these spirits / To make them instruments of fear and warning". Has he changed his mind?

Read the two speeches as tactics and the contradiction disappears. Brutus is a philosopher who respects reason; to him Cassius talks reason — stars do not rule us, we do. Casca is a frightened believer who has just said that it is "the part of men to fear and tremble"; to him Cassius talks omens. Cassius does not believe or disbelieve the storm; he uses it. That is why he can call the night "very pleasing" in one breath and a divine warning in the next. He is the opposite of Casca, who believes what he says, and of Cicero, who says what he believes. Cassius says what will work.

But Shakespeare does not leave it there, and this is the detail a school guide misses. Twice in the scene Cassius's control slips: once when his bitterness carries him into "What trash is Rome" and he has to pull himself back ("But, O grief, / Where hast thou led me?"), and once at the end when the sky becomes, for him too, a sign — "the complexion of the element / In favour's like the work we have in hand". The man who uses the omens begins, very slightly, to be used by them. By Act 5 he will confess that he has changed his mind about signs. The play's judgement is quietly made: nobody in a superstitious time stays an unbeliever by will alone, and the manipulator of fear is not immune to it. When you write about Cassius and fate, do not say he 'contradicts himself'. Say that his two speeches are two tools, and that the second tool begins, by the end of the scene, to turn in his hand.

"Our yoke and sufferance show us womanish"

Original line / short passage:

Cassius: *Let it be who it is. For Romans now / Have thews and limbs like to their ancestors. / But, woe the while, our fathers' minds are dead, / And we are governed with our mothers' spirits. / Our yoke and sufferance show us womanish.*

Simple English: Never mind who I mean. Romans today have muscles and bodies like their forefathers; but — alas for these times — the spirit of our fathers is dead, and we are ruled by the spirit of our mothers. The yoke we wear, and the patience with which we bear it, prove us unmanly.

Difficult words: "Let it be who it is" — leave the name unspoken; "thews" — sinews, muscular strength; "like to" — like; "woe the while" — alas for the age, grief for these times; "governed with" — ruled by; "spirits" — temperaments; "yoke" — the wooden bar laid on oxen; by metaphor, servitude; "sufferance" — patient endurance; "womanish" — effeminate, weak (in the Roman and Elizabethan sense of the word).

Literal meaning: The Romans have not degenerated physically; they have degenerated in spirit. Their willingness to be ruled is a failure of manliness.

Subtext: This is a challenge disguised as a lament. Cassius is not mourning Rome; he is daring Casca to prove he is his father's son. The 'we' is generous — Cassius includes himself in the shame — but the arrow is aimed at the listener.

Hidden meaning: The word "sufferance" is doing double work. It means 'endurance', but it also contains 'suffering'. To bear the yoke patiently is both to endure and to be hurt, and Cassius wants Casca to feel the hurt he has been numbing with cynicism.

Character psychology: Cassius thinks in terms of manhood and shame; it is his deepest register. In Scene 2 the proof of Caesar's unfitness was that he cried "As a sick girl"; here the proof of Rome's unfitness is that it is "womanish". For Cassius, politics is a contest of virility, and a Rome that submits has lost it. Keep this in mind when you judge him: it is a narrow and, to modern readers, an uncomfortable way of thinking, but it is coherent and it is his.

Political meaning: The republican ideal is here equated with ancestral masculinity: the "fathers" who expelled kings had "minds" that the sons have lost. This is Roman nostalgia of a kind the historical Cato and Cassius really felt — a belief that the Republic was a system for free men and that submitting to one man was a form of slavery.

Historical context: HISTORICAL RECORD. Roman moralists habitually blamed political decline on a loss of ancestral virtue (the *mos maiorum*, the custom of the forefathers), and the Latin word *virtus* — 'manliness', 'excellence' — ties courage to maleness in exactly the way Cassius's speech does. An Elizabethan audience, ruled by a queen, might have heard the misogyny differently; the play does not endorse it, but gives it to the character to whom it belongs.

Literary devices: Antithesis (fathers' minds / mothers' spirits; thews and limbs / minds); the exclamatory interjection "woe the while"; metaphor ("yoke"); the compact summarising line "Our yoke and sufferance show us womanish", in which abstract nouns are made to deliver a verdict.

Effect: Shame is a stronger recruiting tool than fear, because fear makes men hide and shame makes them act. Casca, who a moment ago was defending the gods, now volunteers news that helps the plot. The speech has worked.

Dramatic significance: This is the turn. Up to here Casca has been resisting Cassius; from here he is feeding him. Watch for the speech after which a character changes sides — examiners love you to find it.

Foreshadowing: The language of manly firmness versus womanish softness returns when Portia, in Act 2 Scene 1, insists that she is more than an ordinary woman and wounds her own thigh to prove her constancy. Shakespeare lets a woman answer Cassius's slur.

Scene connection: "yoke" was Cassius's word in Scene 2 for the condition of Rome's nobles, "groaning underneath this age's yoke". He returns to it because it worked. Note also how Scene 2's "underlings" has become Scene 3's "womanish" — the same servility, a harsher name.

ICSE keywords: rhetoric, shame, manliness, republican nostalgia, antithesis, persuasion.

Exam application: On how Cassius persuades: 'Having failed to shame Casca out of his fear with the insult "You are dull", Cassius shames him more deeply with "Our yoke and sufferance show us womanish", converting political submission into a failure of manhood; it is after this speech that Casca begins to help rather than resist him.'

CASCA'S NEWS, THE DAGGER AND THE OATH

The middle of the scene is a negotiation, though neither man calls it that. Casca offers information; Cassius offers a creed; Cassius risks a confession; Casca gives his hand. Read it as four moves.

Casca's news: a king "In every place save here in Italy"

Original line / short passage:

Casca: *Indeed, they say the Senators tomorrow / Mean to establish Caesar as a king, / And he shall wear his crown by sea and land / In every place save here in Italy.*

Simple English: Yes — people are saying that tomorrow the senators intend to set Caesar up as a king, and that he will wear his crown everywhere, over sea and land, except here in Italy itself.

Difficult words: "Indeed" — truly, yes; "they say" — it is rumoured; "establish" — set up formally, by decree; "by sea and land" — throughout the empire; "save" — except.

Literal meaning: A rumour reports that the Senate will tomorrow grant Caesar the title of king over the provinces, with Italy alone excluded.

Subtext: Casca is offering this to Cassius as a gift — notice "Indeed", which agrees with the shaming speech just before. He has changed from arguing against Cassius to supplying him. The rumour is his way of saying 'I am with you' before he dares to say it in words.

Hidden meaning: The exemption of Italy is not a softening; it is the whole scandal. Romans could tolerate a king over foreigners; the title rex inside Italy was the one thing the Republic had been founded to forbid. So the proposal is a fig leaf — kingship everywhere that matters militarily, with a legal fiction at home. Cassius does not even bother to discuss the exemption; to him a crown anywhere is a crown.

Character psychology: Casca is a gossip by temperament (remember his Scene 2 report), and under stress he reverts to type: he knows what people are saying. But look at the shift in what he does with gossip. In Scene 2 he passed on news to amuse; here he passes it on to arm.

Political meaning: This is the play's deadline. Whatever the senators intend, the conspirators believe that tomorrow Caesar becomes a king — so the killing must be tomorrow. Everything that follows, including the hurried visit to Brutus before dawn, is governed by this one piece of hearsay.

Historical context: HISTORICAL RECORD. Plutarch reports exactly this rumour — that a Sibylline prophecy was to be cited to the Senate saying that only a king could conquer the Parthians, and that Caesar would therefore be offered the title of king over the provinces outside Italy. Caesar was indeed preparing a Parthian campaign for 44 BC. Whether the Senate would actually have voted this on the Ides is unknown; the murder forestalled it, and historians disagree about how far the plan had gone. **SHAKESPEARE'S TEXT.** The play keeps it as "they say" and never confirms it.

Literary devices: The repeated 'they say' construction (reported speech as evidence); the pairing "by sea and land" as a merism — two opposites that together mean 'everywhere'; the ironic qualification "save here in Italy".

Effect: The audience feels the clock start. From here to the end of the scene every verb is in the future tense of urgency — "tomorrow", "ere day", "after midnight".

Dramatic significance: This is the information that converts a plot into an emergency. Without it the conspirators might have waited; with it, they cannot.

Foreshadowing: The crown returns on the Ides: Caesar will be killed on the day he is rumoured to have been about to receive it, and Antony will use the refused crown in the Forum as proof that Caesar was not ambitious. Both halves of the play's argument about kingship pass through this rumour.

Scene connection: Scene 2's crown was a coronet offered three times in the marketplace and refused; Scene 3's crown is a decree in the Senate. The theatre of refusal in public is about to become the fact of kingship in law — or so Casca believes.

ICSE keywords: rumour, kingship, republicanism, urgency, deadline, dramatic tension.

Exam application: On why the conspiracy acts when it does: 'Casca's report that the senators "Mean to establish Caesar as a king" the next day gives the plot its deadline; the conspirators move not because Caesar has become a tyrant but because they believe tomorrow he will, and Shakespeare pointedly leaves the rumour unconfirmed — "they say".'

The suicide and liberty speech: "Cassius from bondage will deliver Cassius"

Original line / short passage:

Cassius: *I know where I will wear this dagger then; / Cassius from bondage will deliver Cassius. / Therein, you gods, you make the weak most strong; / Therein, you gods, you tyrants do defeat.*

Cassius: *But life, being weary of these worldly bars, / Never lacks power to dismiss itself. / If I know this, know all the world besides, / That part of tyranny that I do bear / I can shake off at pleasure.*

Simple English: Then I know where I will wear this dagger — in my own heart. Cassius will free Cassius from slavery. In that power, you gods, you make the weak strongest of all; in that power you defeat every tyrant. (No tower, no brass wall, no dungeon, no iron chain can imprison a strong spirit.) Life, when it is weary of these worldly prison-bars, never lacks the power to end itself. If I know this, let the whole world know it too: the share of tyranny that falls on me, I can throw off whenever I choose.

Difficult words: "wear this dagger" — a grim pun: a dagger is 'worn' at the belt, but he means he will wear it in his breast; "bondage" — slavery; "deliver" — set free; "Therein" — in that respect, by that means; "beaten brass" — hammered bronze; "retentive to" — able to hold in; "worldly bars" — the prison of earthly life; "dismiss itself" — release itself, end; "shake off" — throw off, as a yoke is shaken off.

Literal meaning: If Caesar is crowned, Cassius will kill himself rather than live as a subject. Suicide is the ultimate freedom: no prison can hold a man who is willing to die, and therefore no tyrant can truly enslave him.

Subtext: This sounds like despair but functions as a boast. Cassius is telling Casca that he is beyond fear, and therefore beyond Caesar's power to frighten. A man who holds his own death in his hand cannot be bought or threatened — the ideal recruiter's credential.

Hidden meaning: "Cassius from bondage will deliver Cassius" is self-reference three times over: the speaker names himself twice and makes himself both rescuer and rescued. In Scene 2 he complained that Caesar's name was "sounded more than yours"; now he sounds his own name as Caesar sounds his. The liberator is already imitating the man he would destroy.

Character psychology: This is the Cassius of the lean and hungry look turned inward: proud, absolute, in love with the idea of mastery. Note the lack of middle ground — either Rome is free or Cassius dies. It is magnificent and it is dangerous, because a man who has decided he can always escape by death is a man with nothing to lose.

Political meaning: The speech makes liberty a personal, not a civic, possession. Earlier the republican case was about Rome; here it is about one man's refusal to be ruled. That is a narrowing, and the play notices it: Casca immediately broadens it again — "So every bondman in his own hand bears / The power to cancel his captivity" — and Cassius has to turn the thought from suicide to tyrannicide with "And why should Caesar be a tyrant, then?"

Historical context: HISTORICAL RECORD. The idea that a free man can always escape tyranny by death was a commonplace of Stoic philosophy, and it had a recent Roman hero: Cato the Younger, Brutus's uncle and father-in-law, who killed himself at Utica in 46 BC rather than accept Caesar's pardon. The historical Cassius

was an Epicurean, not a Stoic, but the sentiment was Roman property, not the possession of one school. Both Brutus and Cassius did in fact die by their own hands after Philippi in 42 BC. **LITERARY**

INTERPRETATION. The euphemism for suicide, and the dignity given to it, reflect a Roman value an Elizabethan Christian audience would have found troubling; Shakespeare lets the Roman speak as a Roman.

Literary devices: Anaphora ("Therein, you gods ... Therein, you gods"; "Nor ... nor ... Nor ... nor"); paradox ("you make the weak most strong"); illeism ("Cassius ... Cassius"); the accumulating catalogue of prison images; euphemism ("dismiss itself"); the pun on "wear"; the thunder that follows (the Folio's thunder still) as a stage-level answer to the speech.

Effect: The speech lifts the scene from gossip to creed. For a moment the conspiracy sounds like a philosophy rather than a plot — which is what it needs to sound like to win men such as Casca and, tomorrow, Brutus.

Dramatic significance: This is the first time in the play that a dagger is named. It appears not as a weapon against Caesar but as a weapon against the self; Shakespeare introduces the blade through the idea of suicide, and the play will end with that idea fulfilled.

Foreshadowing: Exact and terrible. At Philippi Cassius will have his servant run him through with the very sword he used against Caesar, and he will speak of freeing himself from the world. "Cassius from bondage will deliver Cassius" is a promise he keeps.

Scene connection: The prison imagery answers Scene 2's Colossus: there "we petty men / Walk under his huge legs"; here no "stony tower" nor "walls of beaten brass" can hold the spirit. The giant has become a gaoler, and the answer to the gaoler is the dagger.

ICSE keywords: liberty, bondage, suicide, Stoicism (as context), paradox, anaphora, foreshadowing, illeism.

Exam application: When an Act 5 extract shows Cassius's death: 'His end fulfils his own words in Act 1 Scene 3 — "Cassius from bondage will deliver Cassius" — where he claimed that no tyranny could bind a man willing to die; the dagger he first named as the instrument of his freedom becomes exactly that.'

Wolf and sheep, lion and hinds, fire and straws, "What trash is Rome"

Original line / short passage:

Cassius: *Poor man, I know he would not be a wolf / But that he sees the Romans are but sheep; / He were no lion, were not Romans hinds. / Those that with haste will make a mighty fire / Begin it with weak straws. What trash is Rome, / What rubbish, and what offal when it serves / For the base matter to illuminate / So vile a thing as Caesar!*

Simple English: Poor Caesar — I know he would never be a wolf if he did not see that the Romans are only sheep; he could not be a lion if the Romans were not timid deer. People who want to build a great fire quickly start it with flimsy straws. What rubbish Rome is — what refuse, what waste — when it serves only as the cheap fuel that lights up something as worthless as Caesar!

Difficult words: "Poor man" — contemptuous pity; "But that" — except that; "hinds" — female deer, timid creatures; "with haste" — quickly; "straws" — dry stalks, kindling; "trash", "rubbish", "offal" — three words for waste, the last the inedible scraps of a slaughtered animal; "base matter" — the alchemist's term for cheap, impure material; "illuminate" — light up, make glorious; "vile" — worthless, low.

Literal meaning: Caesar's tyranny is not his own achievement but Rome's gift: predators exist because prey consents. A great blaze is started with trivial fuel; Rome has become that fuel, burned up to make Caesar shine.

Subtext: Cassius is shifting the blame from Caesar to the Romans — and therefore to Casca, who is a Roman standing in front of him. 'You made him' is a far more painful accusation than 'he is wicked', and it carries an implied remedy: unmake him.

Hidden meaning: The pity in "Poor man" is real as well as ironic. Cassius's wolf is not evil; it is a wolf because sheep are available. This is the most honest moment of his political analysis — tyranny as a relationship, not a character — and it is also the moment his contempt for Rome breaks through. He despises Caesar; he despises the Romans more.

Character psychology: The three nouns — "trash", "rubbish", "offal" — are too many. A controlled speaker would stop at one. Cassius is being carried by his own disgust, and in the next line he knows it: "But, O grief, / Where hast thou led me?" The passage shows the manipulator losing control of his instrument, which is his own eloquence.

Political meaning: The crowd of Scene 1, who worshipped Pompey and now worship Caesar, and the "rabblement" of Scene 2, who clapped and hissed as Caesar pleased them, are the sheep. Cassius's republicanism has no love for the people; it is an aristocrat's liberty, the freedom of nobles not to have a master. Keep this when you read Brutus in the Forum promising to die for Rome's liberty: the conspiracy's idea of Rome never included the Romans.

Historical context: HISTORICAL RECORD. The historical conspirators were senators and ex-Pompeians, and ancient sources are clear that the urban populace was largely pro-Caesar; after the murder, the plebs turned on the assassins. Cassius's scorn for "sheep" reflects a real gap between the senatorial idea of *libertas* and the people's experience of Caesar as a benefactor. **LITERARY INTERPRETATION.** The alchemical colouring of "base matter" and "illuminate" belongs to Shakespeare's London, where alchemy was a living (and much-mocked) pursuit; Casca will pick the same vocabulary up at the end of the scene.

Literary devices: Paired animal metaphors (wolf/sheep, lion/hinds) in parallel lines; the proverbial-sounding fire-and-straws image; climactic tricolon ("trash ... rubbish ... offal"); alchemical metaphor ("base matter ... illuminate"); exclamatio ("What trash is Rome"); apostrophe to grief.

Effect: The fire that began the scene as lightning is now Caesar's glory, fed by Rome's degradation. The audience feels the imagery of the storm being pulled, image by image, into the argument for killing.

Dramatic significance: This is the speech that nearly goes too far — and its excess is what prompts the risk Cassius takes next. Shakespeare shows that recruitment is not a smooth operation but a thing that can slip.

Foreshadowing: The Romans as sheep and the alchemy of "base matter" both point at Act 3 Scene 2, where Antony will light the mob as straws and the people who were "sheep" become wolves who tear Cinna the poet apart. Cassius is right that Rome is kindling; he is wrong about who will hold the match.

Scene connection: The lion was Casca's prodigy and Cassius's image for Caesar; now it needs "hinds" to exist. Within forty lines one animal has been a sign from heaven, a portrait of a tyrant and a proof that the tyrant is the people's fault. Trace that lion in an answer and you will have shown how the scene's imagery thinks.

ICSE keywords: metaphor, tricolon, animal imagery, contempt for the mob, aristocratic republicanism, fire imagery, alchemy.

Exam application: On Cassius's attitude to the people: 'Unlike Brutus, Cassius has no faith in the Romans; his wolf-and-sheep metaphor and his outburst "What trash is Rome" blame tyranny on the cowardice of the ruled, so that the conspiracy, from its first night, despises the very people in whose name it will act.'

"Before a willing bondman": the risk test of Casca

Original line / short passage:

Cassius: *But, O grief, / Where hast thou led me? I perhaps speak this / Before a willing bondman; then, I know / My answer must be made. But I am armed, / And dangers are to me indifferent.*

Simple English: But oh, my grief — where have you carried me? Perhaps I have said all this in front of a man who is content to be a slave; if so, I know I shall have to answer for it. But I am armed, and I do not care about danger.

Difficult words: "grief" — passionate sorrow, here almost 'indignation'; "led me" — carried me away; "willing bondman" — a man who accepts slavery, a contented subject of Caesar — and therefore a potential informer; "My answer must be made" — I shall be called to account, I shall have to answer the charge; "armed" — carrying a weapon, and also morally prepared; "indifferent" — matters of no concern.

Literal meaning: Cassius appears to realise he has spoken treason to a man whose loyalty he has not tested. He acknowledges the danger of denunciation and declares himself ready to meet it.

Subtext: Is this a genuine lapse or a calculated move? **LITERARY INTERPRETATION.** The text supports both readings, and a strong answer says so. Read one way, Cassius's passion really has outrun his prudence and he is recovering his balance. Read the other way, the 'slip' is the oldest trick in recruitment: by saying 'perhaps you are not with me', he forces Casca to say 'I am'. The suspicion "willing bondman" is an insult Casca cannot let stand, and the boast "I am armed" tells him that betrayal would be dangerous.

Hidden meaning: "I am armed" is literally true — he wears the dagger he has just promised to turn on himself — and the double sense of 'armed' against informers and 'armed' against Caesar lets the threat hang in the air between the two men. Cassius has, in effect, told Casca: inform on me and you will find I am not easy to arrest.

Character psychology: Whichever reading you prefer, the speech shows a man who converts weakness into strength instantly. Exposed, he does not retreat; he raises the stakes. That reflex — attack when threatened — is Cassius all through the play, from his quarrel with Brutus at Sardis to his death.

Political meaning: Conspiracy is a world of informers. The word "telltale" in Casca's answer, and Cassius's fear of being denounced, remind the audience that under Caesar a free conversation about freedom is already a crime. Shakespeare's own London, with its network of informers and its laws against seditious words, knew this atmosphere well.

Historical context: HISTORICAL RECORD. The real conspiracy numbered some sixty men and was kept secret for weeks — a remarkable fact that ancient writers remark on. Plutarch stresses that the conspirators swore no formal oath and relied on mutual trust; Shakespeare's Brutus will make the same point in Act 2 Scene 1 when he refuses to let the conspirators swear. Casca's informal handclasp here is the play's version of that trust.

Literary devices: Apostrophe and personification ("O grief, / Where hast thou led me?"); dramatic pause marked by the broken line; understatement ("dangers are to me indifferent"); the loaded term "bondman", which makes acceptance of Caesar equal to slavery.

Effect: The tension rises for the first time inside the conversation itself. Until now the danger was the sky; now it is the other man. The audience waits to see which way Casca will jump.

Dramatic significance: This is the test that produces the oath. Shakespeare makes Casca commit himself under challenge rather than by invitation, so that his commitment looks like courage rather than compliance.

Foreshadowing: Cassius's readiness to be 'called to account' and his armed indifference to danger look ahead to the Capitol, where he will whisper to Brutus to be ready, and to the quarrel scene, where he will offer Brutus his dagger and his breast.

Scene connection: The "bondman" picks up the "bondage" of the suicide speech, and Casca's own "bondman" from his reply. The word has moved from 'slave of Caesar' to 'possible traitor to us' in a dozen lines — a sign that the conspiracy already has an inside and an outside.

ICSE keywords: risk, recruitment, informer, test of loyalty, calculated ambiguity, apostrophe.

Exam application: On Cassius's methods: 'Cassius's apparent lapse — "I perhaps speak this / Before a willing bondman" — may be genuine or feigned, but its effect is the same: challenged as a possible slave and informer, Casca must either betray or join, and he joins. Shakespeare shows recruitment working through pressure, not invitation.'

Casca's oath: "no fleeing telltale. Hold. My hand."

Original line / short passage:

Casca: *You speak to Casca, and to such a man / That is no fleeing telltale. Hold. My hand. / Be factious for redress of all these griefs, / And I will set this foot of mine as far / As who goes farthest.*

Simple English: You are talking to Casca — to a man who is no sneering informer. Here: take my hand. Form a party to put right all these wrongs, and I will go as far as the man who goes farthest.

Difficult words: "fleeing" — grinning mockingly, sneering; "telltale" — informer, tattler; "Hold" — here, take this (an offer), with a secondary sense of 'wait, stop'; "factious" — active in forming a faction or party (not yet the purely negative modern sense); "redress" — remedy, setting right; "griefs" — grievances, wrongs; "set this foot of mine" — commit myself, go.

Literal meaning: Casca denies that he is an informer, offers his hand as a pledge, and commits himself to go to any length the conspiracy requires.

Subtext: "You speak to Casca" — he names himself as Cassius named himself; the two men are now speaking the same language of self-assertion. The word "fleeing" is a confession: it describes exactly the man he was in Scene 2, the mocker. He is saying: I know what I have seemed; I am not that.

Hidden meaning: "Be factious" is a startling phrase from a man who has just been defending the gods and the proper fear of men. To be 'factious' is to divide the state; Casca asks for it as a remedy. The Republic's enemies were always called a faction; now its defenders ask to be one. The vocabulary of the play's politics has already been turned inside out.

Character psychology: The pledge is physical — "My hand", "this foot of mine" — because Casca's conversion is bodily, not intellectual. He has not been argued into the plot; he has been frightened, shamed and then challenged, and his body answers before his mind. "As who goes farthest" is a competitive promise: he will not be outdone. That competitiveness, under Cassius's shaming, is what has been recruited.

Political meaning: Casca attaches a condition: "for redress of all these griefs". The conspiracy is framed as a remedy for wrongs, not as murder. This is the formula every conspirator will use, and it is the formula that lets honourable men do what they are about to do.

Historical context: HISTORICAL RECORD. Publius Servilius Casca Longus was indeed a member of the conspiracy and, by all ancient accounts, struck the first blow. Shakespeare therefore makes the man who will begin the killing also the first man we see being recruited — a neat compression that is his own choice, not

Plutarch's, since Plutarch does not stage Casca's recruitment at all.

Literary devices: Synecdoche ("My hand", "this foot of mine" — parts of the body standing for the whole man's commitment); the broken, emphatic monosyllables "Hold. My hand."; the superlative construction "as far / As who goes farthest"; the euphemistic political phrase "redress of ... griefs".

Effect: Relief, and a shiver. The audience has watched a man join a murder plot in a thunderstorm by shaking hands, and the ordinariness of the gesture is more disturbing than any speech.

Dramatic significance: The scene's first objective is achieved: Casca is in. From here Cassius can move from recruiting to organising.

Foreshadowing: The hand that is given here is the hand that will strike first at the Capitol. Casca's own earlier phrase for Caesar — he "offered them his throat to cut" — now acquires a terrible literalness: Casca will accept the offer.

Scene connection: Cassius in Scene 2 asked Brutus to "chew upon this"; Brutus promised to hear more later and committed nothing. Casca commits everything in five lines. Shakespeare sets the two recruitments side by side so that you feel the difference between a man who thinks and a man who is swept.

ICSE keywords: oath, pledge, synecdoche, conversion, faction, redress, foreshadowing.

Exam application: When an Act 3 extract shows the stabbing: 'Casca strikes first because Shakespeare has prepared us for it: in Act 1 Scene 3 he was the first man recruited, pledging "I will set this foot of mine as far / As who goes farthest". His blow at the Capitol is that oath kept.'

"There's a bargain made": the conspiracy revealed

Cassius closes the deal in four words — "There's a bargain made" — and the word 'bargain' is worth pausing on. Casca has spoken of griefs and redress; Cassius answers in the language of trade. For him it is a transaction, and the thing bought is a man. Only now, with the hand given, does Cassius reveal what he withheld during the whole persuasion: "Now know you, Casca, I have moved already / Some certain of the noblest-minded Romans / To undergo with me an enterprise / Of honourable-dangerous consequence." Learn the order. First he tested Casca; only then did he tell him there were others. A recruiter who reveals the network before the recruit is committed has endangered the network. Cassius does it properly.

The phrase "honourable-dangerous" is a compound Shakespeare makes for the occasion, and it is the conspiracy in a single hyphen: the two adjectives are yoked because the conspirators cannot separate them, and the hyphen quietly asks whether they can be joined at all. Then the meeting place — "they stay for me / In Pompey's Porch" — and the storm's last transformation: "the complexion of the element / In favour's like the work we have in hand, / Most bloody, fiery, and most terrible." The sky's 'complexion' (its appearance, its colouring) resembles, 'in favour' (in face, in look), the deed to come. The night that was divine anger for Casca and a strange time for Cicero is now the conspiracy's own face reflected in the clouds. Cassius has finished with the storm as a tool and begun — almost without noticing — to see it as an omen for himself.

QUOTATION The storm becomes the deed

Cassius: *And the complexion of the element / In favour's like the work we have in hand, / Most bloody, fiery, and most terrible.*

Three adjectives, two of them weighted by "Most", the middle one carrying the whole scene's fire. This is the line to quote if you are asked how the storm reflects the conspiracy: the conspirators themselves say that it does.

CINNA, THE CONSPIRACY AND THE FORGED LETTERS

The last third of the scene changes gear. Persuasion is over; logistics begin. The language becomes plain — names, places, errands, times — and that plainness is itself expressive: this is what a murder looks like the night before, when it is still a list of things to do.

Cinna

Casca sees a figure first — "Stand close awhile, for here comes one in haste" ('stand close' means 'hide, keep still') — and his instinct is to conceal himself: the new conspirator has already acquired the reflexes of one. Cassius identifies the newcomer by his walk — "'Tis Cinna; I do know him by his gait. / He is a friend." — just as he identified Casca by his voice. In the dark, the conspirators know each other by body and sound; Shakespeare keeps reminding you that the stage is supposed to be black.

Cinna's first words are a mistake that tells you a great deal: "Who's that? Metellus Cimber?" He expects to meet a conspirator and names one, so the audience learns a new name and learns that the plot is large enough for its members to be mistaken for each other. Cassius corrects him with a phrase that formally enrolls Casca: "No, it is Casca, one incorporate / To our attempts." To be 'incorporate' is to be made part of one body — the conspiracy is imagined as a corporation, a single organism of which Casca is now a limb. It is the political version of the handclasp.

Then Cinna, like everyone else, remarks on the weather — "What a fearful night is this! / There's two or three of us have seen strange sights." — and Cassius, impatient, cuts across him: "Am I not stayed for? Tell me." (Is nobody waiting for me?) He asks twice. The leader wants to know that his men are assembled; the omens no longer interest him. Finally Cinna says the thing the whole conspiracy is thinking: "Yes, you are. O Cassius, if you could / But win the noble Brutus to our party—". The dash is Shakespeare's: Cassius interrupts him. He does not need to be told.

LITERARY INTERPRETATION. Why give this wish to Cinna, the least important speaker in the scene? Because it is more powerful as a general feeling than as Cassius's private calculation. When the messenger blurts it out, you understand that the need for Brutus is not one man's strategy but the conspiracy's shared anxiety: they do not feel legitimate without him. Cinna's adjective matters too — "the noble Brutus". Nobody in Act 1 calls Cassius noble to his face.

HISTORICAL CONTEXT Two Cinnas, one name

HISTORICAL RECORD. The Cinna of this scene is Lucius Cornelius Cinna, praetor in 44 BC, a brother-in-law of Caesar and nonetheless a supporter of the assassins. The Cinna of Act 3 Scene 3 is Gaius Helvius Cinna, a poet and a friend of Caesar, whom the mob killed by mistake on the day of the funeral because he shared the conspirator's name. Plutarch tells the story of the poet's death; Shakespeare stages it. The scene you are studying introduces the first Cinna so that the second Cinna's death can land with full force two acts later: the man torn apart for a name is torn apart because of the man who carried the letters tonight. Keep the two distinct in any answer; confusing them is a common and costly error.

The conspiracy: Pompey's Porch and the names

By the end of the scene you can draw the conspiracy's organisation chart, and you should, because the Class X paper will assume you know who these men are when they appear at the Capitol.

Name	What Scene 3 tells you	Role later in the play
Cassius	Organiser; has "moved already / Some certain of the noblest-minded Romans"	Co-leader with Brutus; dies at Philippi
Casca	Recruited tonight; "one incorporate / To our attempts"	Strikes the first blow at the Capitol
Cinna	Courier; carries the letters; wishes for Brutus	Among the assassins; his name kills the poet
Decius Brutus	Waiting at Pompey's Porch	Reinterprets Calpurnia's dream and brings Caesar to the Senate
Trebonius	Waiting at Pompey's Porch	Draws Antony away from the Capitol during the killing
Metellus Cimber	Has gone "To seek you at your house"	Presents the petition that gives the signal for the attack
Brutus	Absent; the object of every plan	Joins in Act 2; becomes the moral leader

The headquarters is named three times — "In Pompey's Porch", "Repair to Pompey's Porch", "repair to Pompey's Theatre" — and the repetition is not carelessness. **HISTORICAL RECORD.** The Theatre of Pompey, built in 55 BC, was Rome's first permanent stone theatre; its great colonnaded portico ('porch') was a public walk, and the Senate-house attached to the complex, the Curia of Pompey, was where Caesar was actually killed on 15 March 44 BC. **SHAKESPEARE'S TEXT.** The play moves the killing to the Capitol, but it keeps Pompey's name on the conspirators' meeting place and, in Act 3, has Caesar fall at the foot of Pompey's statue. **LITERARY INTERPRETATION.** The effect is to make the conspiracy gather in the shadow of the man Caesar defeated. Marullus's reproach in Scene 1 — "Knew you not Pompey?" — is answered: these men did know Pompey, and they meet under his roof to avenge him. Whether that makes them patriots or merely the losing side of the civil war is one of the questions the play never settles.

Notice also what the meeting place says about class. Scene 1's commoners were in the street; Scene 2's crowd was in the marketplace; the conspirators meet in a colonnade attached to a theatre built by a great aristocrat. The geography of the act is a social map.

The forged letters

Original line / short passage:

Cassius: *Be you content. Good Cinna, take this paper, / And look you lay it in the Praetor's chair, / Where Brutus may but find it; and throw this / In at his window; set this up with wax / Upon old Brutus' statue. All this done, / Repair to Pompey's Porch, where you shall find us.*

Simple English: Don't worry. Good Cinna, take this paper and make sure you lay it on the praetor's official chair, where only Brutus will find it; throw this one in at his window; fix this one with wax on the statue of his ancestor, the old Brutus. When all that is done, go back to Pompey's Porch, where you will find us.

Difficult words: "Be you content" — be satisfied, set your mind at rest; "look you" — see to it that; "Praetor's chair" — the official seat of the praetor, the senior magistrate below consul (Brutus held the urban praetorship for 44 BC); "may but find it" — may be the only one to find it; "set ... up with wax" — fix it with wax to the stone; "old Brutus" — Lucius Junius Brutus, who drove out the last king of Rome; "Repair" — go, return.

Literal meaning: Cassius hands over three papers and gives three delivery points — Brutus's official seat, his private house and his ancestor's public statue — then names the rendezvous.

Subtext: "Be you content" answers Cinna's wish for Brutus with the papers themselves: here is how we win him. Cassius is also displaying competence to his new recruit Casca, who stands watching. The brisk imperatives ("take", "lay", "throw", "set", "Repair") are a leader's voice.

Hidden meaning: The three places are three aspects of Brutus. The praetor's chair is his public office — Rome's magistrate is being asked to act. The window is his private self — the citizen at home is being disturbed. The statue of old Brutus is his ancestry — the descendant is being summoned by the founder of the Republic. Cassius has designed a campaign aimed at the whole man, and the audience knows, because they heard the Scene 2 soliloquy, that all three voices will be one voice: his.

Character psychology: Compare the soliloquy's plan — "In several hands, in at his windows throw, / As if they came from several citizens" — with its execution. Cassius has done exactly what he said. He is a man whose plans become actions; that reliability is a virtue in a general and a danger in a plotter. Note also his certainty that Brutus will read anonymous paper as the voice of Rome: Cassius has studied his brother-in-law and knows that Brutus's weakness is his honour.

Political meaning: This is the moment the conspiracy stops being a group of men who agree and becomes an operation that deceives one of its own members. The letters are aimed not at Caesar but at Brutus. The first victim of the plot's dishonesty is the man who will give it its honour.

Historical context: HISTORICAL RECORD. Plutarch records that Brutus's praetor's tribunal and the statue of his ancestor were covered with anonymous messages — 'Brutus, are you asleep?', 'You are no true Brutus' — urging him to act. Plutarch does not say Cassius wrote them, though he describes Cassius working on Brutus by other means. Shakespeare's decisive change is to make the letters Cassius's forgeries, announced in advance to the audience. The history offers an awakening of Brutus by the people; the play offers a manipulation of Brutus by his friend. **SHAKESPEARE'S TEXT.** The statue is "old Brutus' statue" — the ancestor Cassius invoked in Scene 2: "There was a Brutus once that would have brooked / Th' eternal devil to keep his state in Rome / As easily as a king."

Literary devices: Tricolon of commands (chair, window, statue), each beginning with a verb; the anaphora-like repetition of "this paper ... this ... this"; dramatic irony, since the audience alone knows the papers are forged; symbolic setting in the three locations.

Effect: The audience watches a deception being physically handed from one man to another. The papers are props, and props make abstractions concrete: 'manipulation' is now something you can see crossing the stage.

Dramatic significance: This is the execution of the plan announced in the Scene 2 soliloquy and the direct cause of the first event of Act 2, where Brutus reads one of these letters by the light of the storm. The two scenes are hinged on these papers.

Foreshadowing: Brutus will read a letter in his orchard and fill in its gaps himself, promising Rome that he will give it what it asks. The letters will then disappear from the play — nobody ever discovers the forgery — which is Shakespeare's quiet way of saying that the deception worked completely.

Scene connection: Scene 2 ended with the plan; Scene 3 ends with its delivery; Act 2 Scene 1 opens with its reception. Across the three the audience's knowledge stays one step ahead of Brutus's — the longest sustained dramatic irony in the first half of the play.

ICSE keywords: forgery, manipulation, dramatic irony, honour, deception, appearance versus reality, ancestry.

Exam application: When an Act 2 extract shows Brutus reading the letter: 'The letter Brutus takes as the voice of Rome is one of the papers Cassius gave Cinna in Act 1 Scene 3 to "lay ... in the Praetor's chair" and "throw ... / In at his window"; the audience, knowing it is forged, watches Brutus's honour being used against him.'

PROFESSOR'S INSIGHT The honour problem of the forged letters

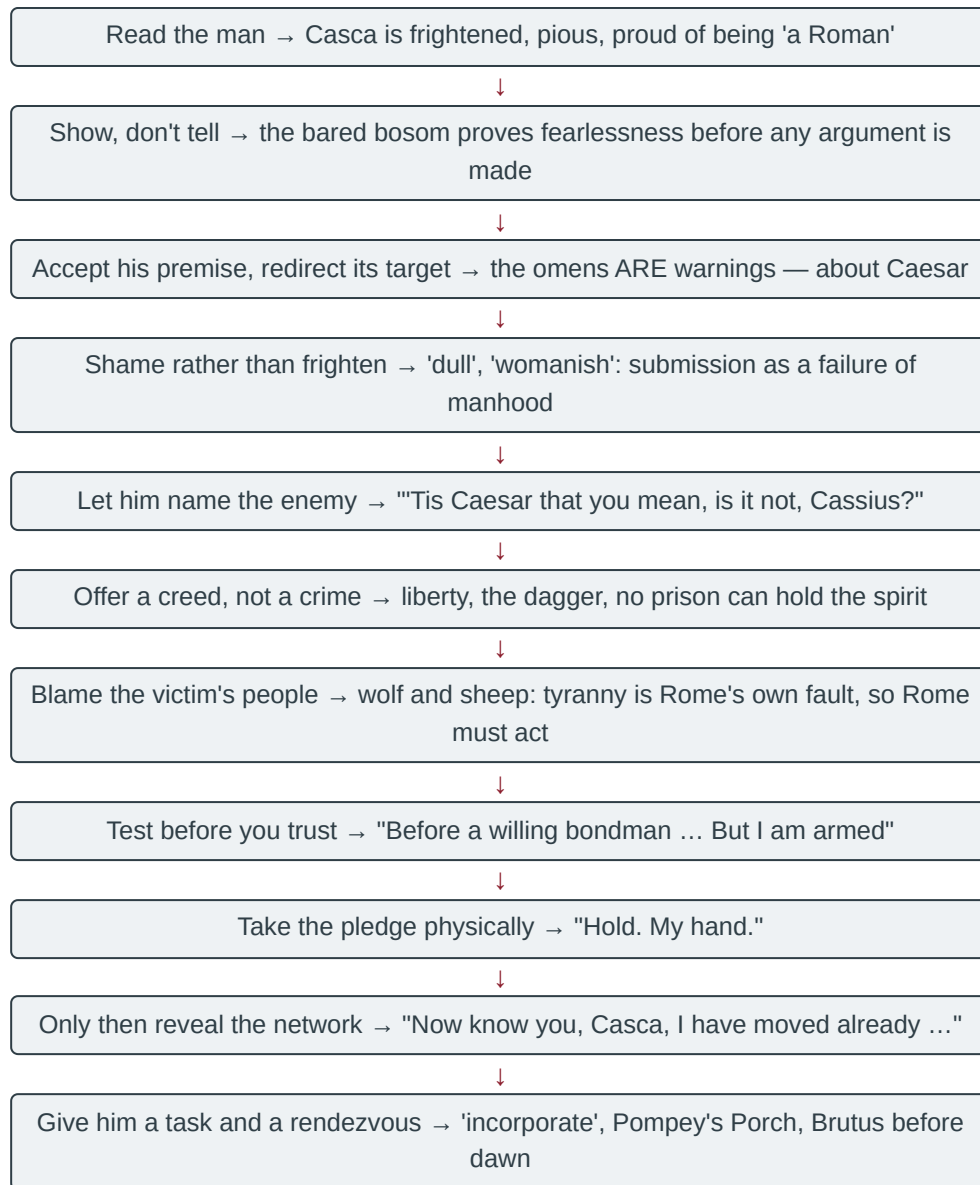
Brutus will say, in his orchard and in the Forum, that he acts for honour and for Rome. The conspiracy's whole claim to be something better than a murder rests on that word. Yet the night before Brutus joins, the conspiracy forges documents to deceive him. That is the honour problem, and it is not a small one.

Consider what the letters do. They do not lie to Caesar, the enemy; they lie to Brutus, the friend. They do not persuade him by argument — Cassius tried argument in Scene 2 and got only "thus much show of fire" — but by counterfeiting the one voice Brutus cannot refuse, the voice of the Roman people. The forger knows that Brutus would not kill Caesar for Cassius; he must think he is killing him for Rome. So the honourable man's honour is used as the handle by which he is lifted into a dishonourable act. Casca's image at the end of the scene — Brutus's face as "richest alchemy" that turns "offence" into "virtue" — is honest about the chemistry: the conspirators know their deed looks like offence, and they want Brutus's reputation to launder it.

Here is the point a school guide misses. Shakespeare never has anyone discover the forgery. Brutus goes to his grave believing Rome called him. The play does not punish the lie; it lets it work and lets the consequences unfold — the sparing of Antony, the funeral speech, the mob, the civil war — all of them flowing from decisions Brutus makes because he thinks he is the people's instrument. The honour problem is therefore not that the conspirators are hypocrites (though Cassius is, a little). It is that honour itself, in this play, is a thing that can be forged, and that the man most certain of his own is the man most easily deceived. When you write about Brutus's tragic flaw, this is where the evidence starts: not in Act 2, when he reasons himself into the murder, but here, in the wax and paper that make sure he will.

Conspiracy recruitment as a method

Step back from the particular speeches and look at the shape of what Cassius has done to Casca, because it is a method, and the same method is applied to Brutus across Scene 2 and Act 2. Being able to describe the method — rather than merely saying 'Cassius is manipulative' — is what separates a Level 3 answer from a Level 2 one.



Three features of the method deserve comment. First, Cassius never asks for anything directly. Casca volunteers his hand; Casca volunteers Caesar's name; Casca volunteers the rumour. A good recruiter makes the recruit feel that he has chosen. Second, the method is tailored. With Brutus in Scene 2 Cassius used mirrors, honour and the names ("Brutus" and "Caesar"); with Casca he uses lightning, shame and the dagger. The constant is not the argument but the attention — Caesar was right that Cassius "looks / Quite through the deeds of men". Third, the method depends on secrecy about its own structure: Casca does not know that his fear has been managed, and Brutus will never know that the letters were forged. Recruitment, in this play, is persuasion that hides the persuader.

LITERARY INTERPRETATION. Shakespeare was writing in a decade when conspiracies against the English state were a lived reality and the government's own methods — informers, forged correspondence, entrapment — were widely known. The play does not make a topical allegory of this, and you should not claim that it does; but an audience of 1599 knew what a recruitment looked like, and would have recognised Cassius's craft as craft.

KEYWORDS Vocabulary for writing about recruitment and manipulation

- **Manipulation** — steering another person's choices while hiding the steering. Use it for Cassius, but always say *how* he manipulates.
- **Rhetoric** — the art of persuasion; name the devices (anaphora, rhetorical question, antithesis) when you use the word.
- **Dramatic irony** — the audience knows the letters are forged; Casca and Cinna do not; Brutus will not.
- **Appearance versus reality** — letters that appear to come from citizens; a storm that appears to be about Caesar; a plot that will appear virtuous.
- **Legitimacy** — the quality of being rightful; what the conspiracy lacks and what Brutus's name supplies.
- **Faction** — Casca's own word for the party he joins ("Be factious"); a term with a negative weight the conspirators try to reverse.
- **Redress** — the setting right of a grievance; the conspirators' preferred name for what they are doing.
- **Incorporate** — made one body with; Cassius's word for Casca's new status.

THE PRIZE: WHY THE CONSPIRACY NEEDS BRUTUS

The scene ends where it has been pointing all along — at Brutus's door. Cinna's errand is explained — "Is Decius Brutus and Trebonius there?" / "All but Metellus Cimber, and he's gone / To seek you at your house. Well, I will hie / And so bestow these papers as you bade me." — and Cassius sends him on ("That done, repair to Pompey's Theatre."). Then he turns to Casca, and the two last speeches of the scene state, more clearly than anywhere else in Act 1, what Brutus is for.

"Three parts of him / Is ours already"

Original line / short passage:

Cassius: *Come, Casca, you and I will yet ere day / See Brutus at his house. Three parts of him / Is ours already, and the man entire / Upon the next encounter yields him ours.*

Simple English: Come, Casca — before daybreak you and I will go and see Brutus at his house. Three quarters of him is already ours, and at our next meeting the whole man will give himself over to us.

Difficult words: "yet ere day" — still before dawn; "Three parts" — three quarters, three parts out of four; "Is ours" — the singular verb with a plural subject is normal Elizabethan grammar; "the man entire" — the whole man; "encounter" — meeting; "yields him" — surrenders himself.

Literal meaning: Cassius judges that Brutus is nearly won and that one more conversation will finish the work.

Subtext: This is said to Casca, the new recruit, and it is partly reassurance: the man you are all worrying about is as good as ours. It is also Cassius's own confidence speaking — the analyst's satisfaction at a calculation coming right.

Hidden meaning: Listen to the vocabulary. Brutus is measured in fractions, like a cargo or a sum; he is "ours", a possession; he "yields", as a city yields to a siege. Cassius does not speak of persuading a friend but of completing an acquisition. The man who hates being Caesar's subject speaks of Brutus as something to be

owned. The play lets you hear that without comment.

Character psychology: Cassius's confidence is both earned and misplaced. Earned, because his reading of Brutus's "honourable mettle" was accurate and the letters will work. Misplaced, because he imagines that a Brutus who yields will remain his. In fact the whole man, once he comes in, will take over, and the three quarters Cassius thinks he owns will outvote him on every decision that matters.

Political meaning: The arithmetic reveals how the conspiracy understands itself. Casca is a hand; Cinna is a courier; Brutus is three parts of a legitimacy that the rest of them cannot supply. The plot is a body searching for a head it can put a famous face on.

Historical context: HISTORICAL RECORD. Plutarch says that the conspirators believed the deed required Brutus — that men would not accept the killing as just unless he were part of it — and that Cassius worked hard to bring him in, partly through the anonymous messages, partly in person. Shakespeare keeps the substance and compresses the courtship into a month and a night.

Literary devices: Metaphor of possession and fractions; the contrast between the mathematical "Three parts" and the humane "the man entire"; the military colouring of "yields".

Effect: The scene has built towards Brutus for ten minutes, and this line fixes the next scene's agenda: before dawn, Brutus's house. The audience knows where Act 2 will open.

Dramatic significance: It closes Scene 3's second objective. Casca is won; Brutus is scheduled. The conspiracy now has a timetable from midnight to the Ides.

Foreshadowing: "yields him ours" is the forecast; the reality in Act 2 Scene 1 is a Brutus who, within minutes of joining, overrules Cassius on the oath, on Cicero and on Antony. The man who was supposed to yield commands.

Scene connection: The soliloquy of Scene 2 said that Brutus's mettle "may be wrought / From that it is disposed" — may be worked, like metal, out of its natural shape. "Three parts" is the smith reporting progress. Then Casca, in the next speech, changes the metal-working image to a far richer one.

ICSE keywords: possession imagery, legitimacy, overconfidence, dramatic irony, foreshadowing.

Exam application: On the relationship between Brutus and Cassius: 'Cassius ends Act 1 Scene 3 counting Brutus as "Three parts ... ours already", as if he were a prize to be collected; the irony is that once Brutus joins, it is he, not Cassius, who commands — the acquired man becomes the leader.'

Casca's "richest alchemy" speech and Cassius's reply

Original line / short passage:

Casca: *O, he sits high in all the people's hearts, / And that which would appear offence in us / His countenance, like richest alchemy, / Will change to virtue and to worthiness.*

Cassius: *Him and his worth and our great need of him / You have right well conceited. Let us go, / For it is after midnight, and ere day / We will awake him and be sure of him.*

Simple English: Oh, he is held very high in all the people's affections; and what would look like a crime if we did it, his support — like the finest alchemy — will transform into virtue and worth. — Cassius: You have expressed him, his worth and our great need of him exactly right. Let's go: it is past midnight, and before daybreak we will wake him and make sure of him.

Difficult words: "sits high" — is placed high, is honoured; "offence" — crime, wrongdoing; "countenance" — his face, and also his support or approval (to 'countenance' a thing is to sanction it); "alchemy" — the medieval and Renaissance pursuit of turning base metals into gold; "richest" — most precious, most potent; "worthiness" — merit, honour; "conceited" — conceived, understood and expressed (not 'vain'); "be sure of him" — make certain of him, secure him.

Literal meaning: Casca says that Brutus's popularity will make the killing look virtuous. Cassius agrees that Casca has understood exactly why they need Brutus, and sets the time: before dawn.

Subtext: Casca's speech is an admission. "that which would appear offence in us" — he knows how the deed will look. The conspirators are not deceived about themselves; they are planning how to be seen. Cassius's reply, "our great need of him", is the frankest statement in Act 1 that the conspiracy cannot stand on its own.

Hidden meaning: Alchemy was both a hope and a byword for fraud. To the Elizabethans the alchemist was the man who promised gold from lead and usually produced nothing but smoke — Ben Jonson built a whole comedy on the swindle. So when Casca calls Brutus's face "richest alchemy", the image praises Brutus and, at the same time, quietly admits that the transformation is a kind of trick: lead will still be lead; it will only look like gold. **LITERARY INTERPRETATION.** Whether Casca intends the second sense is doubtful; the play, I think, does. The word "appear" has already given it away: what alchemy changes here is appearance.

Character psychology: This is the most intelligent thing Casca says in the play, and it comes from the man who, in Scene 2, pretended not to understand Greek. The cynic's eye for how things look has found its true use: he can see how Rome will see the murder. Cassius's "right well conceited" is the teacher's praise to a pupil who has grasped the lesson — and perhaps a flicker of surprise.

Political meaning: Here is the conspiracy's theory of legitimacy in four lines: power to kill they have; the right to kill must be borrowed from a man "high in all the people's hearts". It is also the conspiracy's fatal miscalculation. Brutus's countenance will indeed turn the deed to virtue — for about an hour, in the Forum, until Antony speaks and the people's hearts, which Casca thought were fixed, turn.

Historical context: HISTORICAL RECORD. Brutus's reputation for integrity was real and was the conspirators' chief asset; Plutarch says the people trusted him and that his name lent the plot its appearance of justice. Shakespeare's 'alchemy' is his own metaphor, drawn from the London of 1599 where alchemical practice and alchemical fraud were both familiar.

Literary devices: Simile ("like richest alchemy"); metaphor of transformation (offence into virtue); the pun on "countenance" (face / sanction); antithesis of "offence" and "virtue"; the tricolon of Cassius's reply, "Him and his worth and our great need of him", which puts the man, his value and their lack in one line; the closing rhyme-like insistence of "ere day" / "be sure of him".

Effect: The scene ends on the word "him" — Brutus — spoken twice in two lines. The audience leaves the storm looking towards a house and a sleeping man.

Dramatic significance: This is the thematic key to the whole recruitment of Brutus and the reason the forged letters exist. It tells the audience how to understand everything the conspirators do to Brutus in Act 2: they are mining his reputation.

Foreshadowing: The alchemy works and then fails. Brutus's speech in the Forum turns the murder into virtue in the people's eyes; Antony's speech turns it back. Casca was right about Brutus's gold and wrong about how long the people would believe in it.

Scene connection: Cassius's "base matter" that illuminates "So vile a thing as Caesar" and Casca's "richest alchemy" that gilds the conspiracy are the same vocabulary used in opposite directions. Rome is base metal that makes Caesar shine; Brutus is the elixir that makes murder shine. The scene's two alchemies belong in one

paragraph of any good essay.

ICSE keywords: alchemy, reputation, legitimacy, appearance versus reality, pun, antithesis, public opinion.

Exam application: On why the conspirators need Brutus: 'Casca puts it in a single simile — Brutus's "countenance, like richest alchemy, / Will change to virtue and to worthiness" what would otherwise "appear offence" — and Cassius confirms "our great need of him". The conspiracy does not seek Brutus's judgement but his reputation, and that is why it is willing to deceive him to get it.'

ICSE EXAM BOX How Scene 3 earns marks — honestly stated

EXAM-ORIENTED ADVICE. Act 1 Scene 3 is Class IX material; it will not appear as a board-paper extract. It earns marks in three indirect ways, and you should practise all three.

1. **Context sentences in Act 3–5 answers.** When an extract shows Casca striking, Cinna the poet dying, Cassius dying by his own sword, Brutus speaking of honour, or any conspirator at the Capitol, one precise sentence from this scene shows the examiner you know the whole play. Keep these ready: Casca's oath; the forged letters; "Three parts of him"; "richest alchemy"; "Cassius from bondage will deliver Cassius".
2. **Theme and character answers.** For superstition and omens, this scene gives you three readings of one storm. For Cassius as manipulator, it gives you the complete method. For honour, it gives you the forgery. For appearance versus reality, it gives you alchemy.
3. **Class IX extract practice.** Expect the prodigies, Cicero's reply, the bared bosom, the dagger speech and the letters. Answer the factual sub-questions in your own words first, then quote a short phrase in support. Never write the storm off as 'atmosphere' — say what it does.

Do not claim that any of this is 'sure to come'. Prepare it because it makes every other answer stronger.

CROSS-REFERENCE Where to go next

- The whole of Cassius's technique, including his handling of Brutus in Act 2, is analysed in '08 — Cassius — The Manipulation Masterclass'.
- Brutus's honour and its vulnerability — the target of the letters — is the subject of '09 — Brutus in Act 1 — Honour, Conflict and Vulnerability'.
- Fate, omens and superstition, with Calpurnia's dream and the Soothsayer alongside this storm, are gathered in '12 — Themes of Act 1 (Part Two)'.
- The devices used here (anaphora, illeism, pathetic fallacy, synecdoche) are catalogued with Act-wide examples in '13 — The Act 1 Literary-Device Bank'.
- Every quotation taught in this chapter appears, with its uses, in '15 — The Act 1 Quotation Bank'.
- Extract practice on this scene is in '19 — Extract-Based Training (Part Two)'.

REVISION ONE-MINUTE REVISION — Act 1 Scene 3

5 must-remember events 1. A night of thunder and "a tempest dropping fire": Casca, sword drawn, reports four prodigies to Cicero (burning hand, lion at the Capitol, women who saw men on fire, owl at noon). 2. Cicero warns that men construe things "after their fashion", fixes the date by asking whether Caesar comes to the Capitol tomorrow, and goes home. 3. Cassius, bare-chested in the lightning, reinterprets the storm as a warning against a man "Most like this dreadful night"; Casca reports the rumour that the senators will crown Caesar tomorrow. 4. Cassius vows suicide before slavery, blames Rome's sheep for Caesar's wolf, tests Casca ("Before a willing bondman"), and Casca gives his hand and his oath. 5. Cinna arrives; Cassius sends him with forged letters for Brutus's chair, window and ancestor's statue; the conspirators plan to visit Brutus before dawn.

5 keywords — portent (omen) · construe (interpret) · bondage / bondman · factious / redress · alchemy (transformation of appearance).

3 quotations - "men may construe things after their fashion, / Clean from the purpose of the things themselves" (Cicero). - "Cassius from bondage will deliver Cassius" (Cassius). - "His countenance, like richest alchemy, / Will change to virtue and to worthiness" (Casca, of Brutus).

3 character insights - Casca: the sneer of Scene 2 was armour; under it is a frightened believer who is recruited through fear and shame and will strike first. - Cassius: he does not believe or disbelieve the omens — he uses them; yet by the scene's end he reads the sky as his own omen, and his control twice slips. - Cicero: the only cool head, given the truest line and removed before it can interfere — reason's fate in a time of faction.

3 themes — Superstition and interpretation (three readings of one storm) · Liberty versus bondage (the dagger as freedom) · Honour and deception (forged letters to win an honourable man).

2 literary devices — Extended simile/metaphor (Caesar as the storm; wolf and sheep) · Dramatic irony ("A very pleasing night to honest men"; the letters the audience knows are forged).

2 historical points — Plutarch supplies the prodigies, the rumour of kingship outside Italy and the anonymous messages to Brutus; Shakespeare adds the lion, makes the messages Cassius's forgeries, and moves the killing from the Curia of Pompey to the Capitol · The historical Cassius was an Epicurean who did not believe omens were divine messages — which colours his use of them here.

3 connections — Backwards: the letters execute the plan of Cassius's Scene 2 soliloquy · Forwards: the storm runs on into Brutus's orchard and Caesar's house (Act 2), and "opens graves" prepares Caesar's Ghost · Fulfilment: the dagger named here kills Cassius at Philippi; the hand given here strikes first at the Capitol.

1 central idea — The storm decides nothing; the interpreter does. Scene 3 is about how fear is given a meaning and a target, and how a conspiracy that calls itself honourable begins with a forgery.

CHAPTER 7

Caesar in Act 1 — A Character Masterclass

What this chapter does: It takes the one character everybody thinks they understand — Caesar, the man who gives the play its name — and shows you how little of him you have actually been shown, and how much Shakespeare makes you infer. We examine seventeen characteristics one by one, each with its evidence, its explanation, the counter-evidence that complicates it, and its dramatic purpose. Then we look at Caesar from three angles, work through the idea of his 'two bodies', trace every Act 1 seed into Acts 2 and 3, and finally learn to write about him in examination English that never falls back on the word 'arrogant'.

Before We Begin: How to Read a Character Who Barely Speaks

Here is a fact that surprises most students when they count. In the whole of Act 1 Caesar speaks fewer than forty lines. All of them fall in Scene 2. He is absent from Scene 1 and from Scene 3, and he is never given a soliloquy — not here, and not anywhere in the play; the three lines he speaks alone at the opening of Act 2 Scene 2, before he calls his servant, are the nearest thing to one. Yet ask anyone what Act 1 is about and they will answer 'Caesar'. The tribunes in Scene 1 set out to strip his decorations from the statues before we have seen his face. Cassius spends the long middle of Scene 2 building a hostile biography of him. The storm of Scene 3 is read, by Cassius, as a portrait of him. Caesar is the subject of almost every sentence in the act and the speaker of very few.

This tells you how to read him. Most of what you 'know' about Caesar in Act 1 reaches you second-hand, through witnesses who have reasons to shade the truth: two tribunes loyal to the memory of Pompey; a rival who once carried Caesar out of a river and has never forgiven him for it; a reporter whom Cassius himself describes as speaking "after his sour fashion". Only in one short passage — Caesar's return from the games, when he turns to Antony and anatomises Cassius (dissects him, part by part) — do we hear him think aloud. Everything else is ceremony, command or rumour.

So the discipline of this chapter is to keep three kinds of knowledge apart and to say which one you are using. There is what Caesar himself says and does (direct SHAKESPEARE'S TEXT). There is what others say about him (mediated testimony, whose bias you must weigh). And there is what you conclude from the gap between the two (LITERARY INTERPRETATION, which must be argued, never merely asserted). An examiner rewards the student who can tell these apart. A weaker student writes 'Caesar is weak because he has epilepsy'. A stronger one writes 'Casca, a hostile witness, reports a swoon; Brutus, a sympathetic one, gives it a medical name; Cassius turns the name into a political metaphor'. That is one fact handled three ways, and the handling is where the marks are.

PROFESSOR'S INSIGHT**Why Shakespeare gives Caesar so few lines yet lets him dominate Act 1**

LITERARY INTERPRETATION. Power in this play is measured not by how much a man speaks but by how much is spoken about him. Shakespeare builds Caesar the way the Romans of the play experience him: as a name before a body, a rumour before a voice. Scene 1 quarrels over "Caesar's trophies" and "Caesar's images" while the man is elsewhere; when he finally enters, a single word from him — his wife's name — is enough to stop a festival, and Casca has to hush the crowd so that Caesar can be heard at all. The rationing is deliberate. A character who talks constantly becomes familiar, and familiarity shrinks a man; Caesar has to stay large enough to fill Cassius's image of a Colossus. By giving him few lines Shakespeare also makes each one disproportionately heavy, so that "for always I am Caesar" and "this ear is deaf", in consecutive lines, can carry an entire theory of the man. There is a further effect. Because we hear so much about Caesar from his enemies before he says anything of substance, we arrive at his one real speech already primed to look down on him — and the speech quietly overturns the priming, for the supposed dotard (a feeble old man) reads Cassius with a precision nobody else in the act can match. Shakespeare gives Caesar so few lines because the play is about the space between a name and a man, and that space is exactly where the conspirators do their work.

CROSS-REFERENCE **Where this chapter sits in the book**

This chapter assumes you have read the scene-by-scene chapters: 'Act 1 Scene 1 — The Street: Commoners, Tribunes and the Fickle Crowd', 'Act 1 Scene 2 (Part One) — Lupercalia, the Soothsayer, and the Seduction of Brutus' and 'Act 1 Scene 2 (Part Two) — Caesar Returns, Casca Reports, Cassius Plots'. Cassius's methods are dissected in 'Cassius — The Manipulation Masterclass', and Brutus's side of the Caesar–Brutus bond in 'Brutus in Act 1 — Honour, Conflict and Vulnerability'. The devices named here (dramatic irony, third-person self-reference, hyperbole) are catalogued in 'The Act 1 Literary-Device Bank', and the quotations are gathered in 'The Act 1 Quotation Bank'.

The Method in Miniature: Five Levels on One Speech

Before the trait-by-trait work, let me show you the whole method on the single passage where Caesar thinks aloud. He has just returned from the games. Brutus notes that "The angry spot doth glow on Caesar's brow" and that his followers "look like a chidden train" ('chidden' means scolded — the whole entourage looks as if it has been told off). Caesar calls Antony to him.

QUOTATION **Caesar reads Cassius**

Caesar: *Let me have men about me that are fat, / Sleek-headed men, and such as sleep a-nights. / Yond Cassius has a lean and hungry look. / He thinks too much. Such men are dangerous.*
Antony: *Fear him not, Caesar; he's not dangerous. / He is a noble Roman, and well given.*
Caesar: *Would he were fatter! But I fear him not. / Yet if my name were liable to fear, / I do not know the man I should avoid / So soon as that spare Cassius.*

Difficult words first, because the speech turns on them. 'Sleek-headed' means smooth-haired, well-groomed, and by extension untroubled. 'A-nights' means at night. 'Yond' is 'that one over there'. 'Well given' means well-disposed, of good character. 'Liable to' means open to or subject to. 'Spare' means thin. The speech continues:

Cassius "reads much", is "a great observer", looks "Quite through the deeds of men", loves no plays, hears no music, and "Seldom he smiles, and smiles in such a sort / As if he mocked himself and scorned his spirit / That could be moved to smile at anything." Then the conclusion: "Such men as he be never at heart's ease / Whiles they behold a greater than themselves, / And therefore are they very dangerous." And the coda: "I rather tell thee what is to be feared / Than what I fear; for always I am Caesar. / Come on my right hand, for this ear is deaf, / And tell me truly what thou think'st of him."

LEVEL 1 — What happened?

Caesar, returning from the games in a bad temper, tells Antony he distrusts Cassius because of his lean, brooding look. Antony says Cassius is harmless. Caesar disagrees, describes Cassius's habits in detail, insists that he personally fears nobody, and then draws Antony to his right side — because his left ear is deaf — and asks him privately for his honest opinion of Cassius.

LEVEL 2 — What does it mean?

The fat/lean opposition is a theory of politics. Fat, sleek, well-slept men are contented; they have appetite for food, not for power. The lean man is hungry in every sense. Caesar's portrait of the dangerous man is precise: he reads (he is educated in ideas), he observes (he is watching you), he sees through deeds to motives, he takes no pleasure in plays or music (he cannot be distracted or softened), and when he smiles it is at himself, bitterly. Above all, he "be never at heart's ease" while anyone is above him. In one word: envy. Caesar is diagnosing the psychology of a conspirator before there is a conspiracy.

LEVEL 3 — Why did Shakespeare write it this way?

Placement is everything. We have just watched Cassius work on Brutus for over a hundred lines, so every clause of Caesar's diagnosis lands on the audience as already proven: this is dramatic irony (the audience knowing more than a character) turned inside out, because here the character knows almost as much as we do and still does nothing. Shakespeare also changes his source. HISTORICAL RECORD: Plutarch reports Caesar saying he did not fear fat, long-haired men but pale, thin ones — meaning Brutus and Cassius together. Shakespeare narrows the remark to Cassius alone and leaves Brutus out. That single edit gives Caesar a blind spot exactly the shape of the man who will strike the deepest blow. Finally, the movement from "I fear him not" to "this ear is deaf" in the space of two lines is a small masterpiece of construction: the boast and the frailty are stitched together so that neither can be heard without the other.

LEVEL 4 — How does it connect to the whole play?

In Act 2 Scene 2 Caesar will fail to read Decius Brutus, who flatters him into going to the Capitol; in Act 3 Scene 1 he will fail to read the kneeling conspirators around him. The one man he reads perfectly in Act 1 is the one who is not deceiving him at all — Cassius is openly lean and hungry. Antony's misjudgement here ("he's not dangerous") is mirrored by Brutus's misjudgement of Antony in Act 2 Scene 1, where the conspirators decide he is no threat. And Cassius's "lean and hungry look" becomes the play's permanent image of envious intelligence, against which Brutus's honourable slowness is measured.

LEVEL 5 — How do I use it in an ICSE answer?

EXAM-ORIENTED ADVICE. Be honest with yourself about the syllabus: Act 1 is the Class IX portion, and the Class X board paper examines Acts III–V. You should therefore not expect an extract from this speech in the board paper. But it is one of the most useful Act 1 passages for Class X answers, because any question on Caesar's fall in Act 3 Scene 1 — why he ignores warnings, whether he is blind or wilful — can be sharpened with a sentence like: 'Caesar is not blind; in Act 1 he reads Cassius exactly, calling him one who "looks / Quite through the deeds of men", and his tragedy is that his insight never becomes action because "always I am Caesar" forbids him to act on fear.' In a Class IX extract question on this passage, the marks lie in explaining the fat/lean contrast, identifying what Caesar gets right about Cassius, and noticing the deaf ear.

Caesar Trait by Trait

Now the systematic work. Each characteristic below is examined under four fixed headings. **Textual evidence** gives you the words to quote. **Explanation** tells you what they mean and why they matter. **Contradiction** gives the counter-evidence or the tension — because a character trait in Shakespeare is never a flat fact; it is always in argument with something. **Dramatic significance** tells you what Shakespeare is doing with the trait for the play as a whole.

Authority

Textual evidence: His first word is a name — "Calpurnia" — and it is enough to stop a festival: "Peace, ho! Caesar speaks." Everything that follows is a command: "Stand you directly in Antonius' way", "Forget not in your speed, Antonius", "Set on and leave no ceremony out", "Set him before me. Let me see his face", "He is a dreamer. Let us leave him. Pass." Antony gives the formula of that authority in a single line: "When Caesar says 'Do this,' it is performed."

Explanation: Caesar's authority is grammatical before it is political. He speaks almost entirely in the imperative mood — the form of the verb that gives orders — and the few questions he asks ("Ha! Who calls?", "What man is that?") are demands for information, not requests. Notice how he names people. He calls his friend "Antonius", the full Latin form, where the stage directions and most other speakers say 'Antony': in Caesar's mouth even a friend's name becomes formal. The ceremonial trumpets that frame his appearances — the 'flourish' (a fanfare announcing a person of rank) and the 'sennet' (a longer trumpet signal for a procession's entry or exit) — wrap his words in sound designed to signal power. And his authority is enacted through other people. He does not hush the crowd; Casca does it for him, twice ("Bid every noise be still. Peace, yet again!"). A man of real power does not raise his own voice.

Contradiction: The same passage shows the limits of that authority. Caesar cannot control who speaks to him. A nameless Soothsayer's voice, "shriller than all the music", cuts through the ceremony, and Caesar has to halt the whole procession to deal with it. Authority that needs Casca to do the shushing is authority that depends on staff. Meanwhile Scene 1 has shown us two tribunes stripping his decorations from statues in his absence: his authority, like his name, is being contested where he cannot see it. By the end of Scene 2 Casca reports that Marullus and Flavius "are put to silence" — which restores the authority but exposes its method. Authority in this Rome works by silencing.

Dramatic significance: Shakespeare needs the audience to feel, within a dozen lines, exactly the Caesar the tribunes feared in Scene 1 — the man who would "soar above the view of men / And keep us all in servile fearfulness". The clipped imperatives achieve that. But by making the authority so visibly staged — trumpets,

hushing, ritual — he also plants the question the whole act pursues: is this power, or the performance of power? Cassius will later insist that the man is "no mightier than thyself or me / In personal action", and the audience, having watched authority manufactured by trumpets and by Casca's voice, has already been handed reasons to wonder.

Confidence

Textual evidence: Told twice to "Beware the ides of March", Caesar's verdict is instant: "He is a dreamer. Let us leave him. Pass." Warned about Cassius, he insists: "Would he were fatter! But I fear him not." And he grounds that fearlessness in his own name: "for always I am Caesar."

Explanation: Confidence in Caesar is not loudness; it is speed. He hears the prophecy, looks at the face, hears it again and disposes of it in nine words. 'Dreamer' is a precise insult — it labels the Soothsayer a man who sees things that are not there — and "Let us leave him. Pass." is the whole procession ordered forward as if nothing had happened. The confidence has a theory behind it. 'Caesar' is treated as a condition rather than a name, and a condition of that kind cannot be "liable to fear". This is what critics mean when they say that Caesar has begun to believe his own legend: the man has adopted the public estimate of himself as a private certainty.

Contradiction: Look at what he actually does with the Soothsayer. A genuinely indifferent man would not stop. Caesar halts the procession, demands "Set him before me. Let me see his face", and asks to hear the warning a second time: "What sayst thou to me now? Speak once again." That is four lines of close attention paid to a man he then calls a dreamer. The Cassius speech follows the same pattern: he says "I fear him not" and then spends seventeen lines describing, with great care, exactly why Cassius ought to be feared. Confidence that talks this much about the thing it is not afraid of begins to look like its opposite. The text does not settle which it is; it lets the boast and the behaviour stand side by side.

Dramatic significance: The gap between the confident sentence and the anxious behaviour is Shakespeare's engine of dramatic irony throughout Caesar's part. The audience knows that the ides of March will matter — the history was famous — so every dismissal is heard twice, once as Caesar means it and once as the audience knows it. Act 1 also teaches the rhythm that Act 2 Scene 2 and Act 3 Scene 1 will repeat with mounting dread: a warning is attended to, weighed, and overridden. By the time Caesar overrides Calpurnia's dream and then brushes aside Artemidorus's letter at the Capitol, we have already watched him do it once, and we know what the pattern costs.

KEYWORDS Terms you will need for this chapter

Imperative mood — the verb form used for commands ("Set on and leave no ceremony out"). **Third-person self-reference** — a speaker naming himself as if describing someone else ("Caesar is turned to hear"). **Public persona** — the version of himself a person presents to others, as distinct from the private self. **Self-mythologising** — building a legend about oneself and then living inside it. **Dramatic irony** — when the audience knows something a character does not. **Mediated testimony** — information that reaches us through a witness rather than directly, and which therefore carries that witness's bias. **Hubris** — a Greek critical term for the overconfidence that invites a fall; use it sparingly and only with evidence.

Pride

Textual evidence: "Speak. Caesar is turned to hear." "I rather tell thee what is to be feared / Than what I fear; for always I am Caesar." Cassius's caricature (a mocking, exaggerated portrait) of the same quality: "that tongue of his that bade the Romans / Mark him and write his speeches in their books".

Explanation: The clearest signature of Caesar's pride is that he speaks of himself in the third person, like a chronicler recording the movements of a great man. This is not simple pomposity. He is announcing that 'Caesar' is a public office he occupies and a standard he must maintain. The Roman word for what he is protecting is *dignitas* — the standing a man had earned and was expected to defend — and HISTORICAL RECORD suggests the real Caesar took it with deadly seriousness: in his own account of the civil war he presented the defence of his *dignitas* as a reason for fighting. Pride here, then, is a Roman virtue pressed to its dangerous edge. What Cassius mocks — the tongue that told Romans to write his speeches down — is a man who knows he is already history and behaves accordingly.

Contradiction: Pride and courtesy coexist in the same scene. Caesar's handling of the Soothsayer is oddly gentle for a supposed tyrant: he asks to see the man's face, hears him twice, and calls him a dreamer rather than a traitor. And Casca's report tells us that after the swoon Caesar apologised to the crowd — "he desired their Worships to think it was his infirmity" — a proud man asking working people to excuse him and addressing them by an honorific (a title of respect). Pride in Caesar is a public posture; the man who has just fainted in the marketplace is capable of humility, or at least of performing it convincingly. Casca's contempt for the wenches who forgave him should not blind you to the fact that the apology worked.

Dramatic significance: Shakespeare makes the pride audible in grammar so that the audience can hear it grow. In Act 1 the habit appears only once in its pure form — "Caesar is turned to hear" — with "always I am Caesar" as its first-person cousin, where the 'I' is swallowed at once by the name; in Act 2 Scene 2 and Act 3 Scene 1 it thickens until Caesar seems to speak almost entirely as 'Caesar', and his last words in Act 3 Scene 1 name himself rather than say 'I'. Act 1 is where the habit is planted quietly enough to be noticed but not yet to be absurd. That restraint matters: if Caesar were ridiculous here, his death could not be tragic.

PROFESSOR'S INSIGHT Why Caesar speaks of himself in the third person

HISTORICAL RECORD first. The real Caesar wrote his account of the wars in Gaul in the third person, referring to himself as 'Caesar' throughout, as though a neutral observer were recording his deeds.

Whether or not Shakespeare knew this, he gives his Caesar the same habit. LITERARY

INTERPRETATION: the habit does three things at once. First, it splits the man from the name. When Caesar says "Caesar is turned to hear", the speaker reports on 'Caesar' as an institution — and the whole tragedy lives in that split, because the conspirators will kill the man in the belief that they are abolishing the institution. Second, it is self-mythologising: the speaker steps into the position of posterity (future generations) and describes himself as future generations will. Third — and this is the point students miss — it is a defence. "I rather tell thee what is to be feared / Than what I fear; for always I am Caesar" uses the name as a shield: fear can be discussed as a topic because 'Caesar', by definition, does not experience it. The third person is where Caesar goes to hide. Notice that even in "always I am Caesar" the 'I' is absorbed at once into the name, whereas the one weakness he confesses directly, "this ear is deaf", is left in plain first person with no name attached: the body is 'I', the legend is 'Caesar'. When you write about this, do not say Caesar is 'arrogant'; say that he has adopted the public estimate of himself as a private identity, and that the grammar shows it.

Superstition

Textual evidence: "Forget not in your speed, Antonius, / To touch Calpurnia, for our elders say / The barren, touchèd in this holy chase, / Shake off their sterile curse." "Set on and leave no ceremony out." Against these: "He is a dreamer. Let us leave him. Pass."

Explanation: Caesar's first substantive act on stage is a fertility rite. At the Lupercalia the runners — the 'course' is their race — struck bystanders, especially women, with strips of goat-hide, and the touch was believed to cure barrenness. Caesar positions his wife to be struck. The phrase 'sterile curse' shows that childlessness is being understood as a supernatural affliction with a ritual remedy. Notice, though, the care of the wording: "our elders say". He attributes the belief to tradition rather than to himself, keeping a small distance from it even as he acts on it. Then "leave no ceremony out": the man who governs Rome wants every rite complete. This is a mind that takes ritual seriously — either because it believes, or because it knows that a watching city expects its leader to be seen believing.

Contradiction: The same man, within thirty lines, waves away a direct prophecy about his own death. One reading is that Caesar's superstition is selective: he trusts the ritual that promises what he wants (an heir) and dismisses the omen that threatens what he has (his life). Another reading is that this is not superstition at all but public piety — a head of state observing the civic religion, much as a modern politician attends a ceremony without necessarily believing in it, and that a Soothsayer in a crowd is simply beneath the notice of such a man. The text leaves both open. What is certain is that Shakespeare has placed belief and disbelief so close together that you cannot fail to notice the inconsistency, and inconsistency in a character is always an invitation to think.

Dramatic significance: This is the seed of Act 2 Scene 2, where Caesar orders a sacrifice, hears the augurers' bad report, yields to Calpurnia's fears, and then reverses himself under Decius's flattering reinterpretation of her dream — the whole scene is a longer version of the wavering we see here in miniature. It also feeds the play's largest argument, between fate and free will, which the chapter 'Themes of Act 1 (Part Two)' takes up in full. Caesar's relationship with omens is the hinge on which that argument turns: a man who half-believes is more dramatically interesting than either a believer or a sceptic, because his choices remain genuinely his own.

HISTORICAL CONTEXT The Lupercalia touch and Caesar's childlessness

HISTORICAL RECORD. The Lupercalia fell on 15 February and was an ancient purification and fertility festival. Its priests, the Luperci, ran through the city striking bystanders — women especially — with thongs of goat-hide to promote fertility; a third college of Luperci, the Juliani, had been created in Caesar's honour in 44 BC, and Antony ran as a Lupercus while serving as consul. Calpurnia had married Caesar in 59 BC and the marriage was childless. Caesar's only legitimate child, his daughter Julia, had died in 54 BC. When his will was read after his death it adopted his great-nephew Gaius Octavius, the future Augustus. So the 'sterile curse' was a real dynastic anxiety — and in a Republic, where power was not supposed to be inherited, that anxiety was itself politically suspect. Elizabethan resonance: in 1599 Elizabeth I was sixty-six, unmarried and without a named heir. Audiences may have felt the question of succession pressing on this moment, but we should say 'may have felt', not assert what they thought.

Vulnerability

Textual evidence: From Caesar's own mouth: "Come on my right hand, for this ear is deaf". From Cassius: "Caesar cried 'Help me, Cassius, or I sink!'" From Casca: the crowd's noise "had almost choked Caesar, for he swooned and fell down at it". From Brutus, reading faces: "The angry spot doth glow on Caesar's brow" and "Calpurnia's cheek is pale".

Explanation: Caesar is vulnerable in three distinct ways, and a good answer separates them. He is bodily vulnerable — a deaf ear he volunteers himself, a seizure others report. He is dependent — his knowledge of Cassius rests on Antony's counsel ("tell me truly what thou think'st of him"), his fertility hopes rest on Antony's touch, his crowd management rests on Casca's hushing. And he is socially vulnerable: the swoon happens in the marketplace before the common people. Casca's grotesque explanation — that the crowd's

"stinking breath" choked him — is comic exaggeration, but it carries a poetic truth. The people's approval or disapproval is literally the air Caesar breathes; when they roar, he falls. Brutus's remark about the "angry spot" belongs here too: a man whose feelings show on his brow so plainly that a bystander can read them is not in complete command of himself.

Contradiction: Caesar converts vulnerability into display. The deaf ear is stated without embarrassment, as a fact of logistics, and in the same breath as "always I am Caesar" — weakness announced by a man who does not appear to think it diminishes him. Offering his throat to the crowd is vulnerability turned into a dare. And nearly all the evidence of weakness reaches us from hostile witnesses — Cassius, who wants Brutus to despise Caesar, and Casca, who despises everyone. The only weakness we hear from Caesar himself is the one he chooses to tell.

Dramatic significance: A tragedy needs a victim vulnerable enough to be killed and grand enough that killing him feels like sacrilege. Act 1 supplies both halves. It also establishes the pattern by which the conspirators will justify themselves: they collect Caesar's frailties as though frailty were an argument about fitness to rule. The play invites you to test that logic. By Act 3 Scene 2, Antony will display Caesar's wounded body to the crowd and turn its vulnerability into the most powerful political weapon in the play.

Physical Weakness (Epilepsy, Deafness, the Swoon, the Fever in Spain)

Textual evidence: Cassius on Spain: "He had a fever when he was in Spain, / And when the fit was on him, I did mark / How he did shake. 'Tis true, this god did shake." And: "His coward lips did from their colour fly, / And that same eye whose bend doth awe the world / Did lose his lustre." And the cry: "'Alas,' it cried 'Give me some drink, Titinius' / As a sick girl." Casca on the marketplace: "He fell down in the marketplace and foamed at mouth and was speechless." Brutus's diagnosis: "'Tis very like; he hath the falling sickness." Caesar himself: "this ear is deaf".

Explanation: Four ailments, four sources, and you must weigh each source. The fever in Spain comes from Cassius, the most hostile witness in the act, and every detail is chosen to unmake the god: the shaking, the colour fleeing the lips ('coward lips' is Cassius's adjective, not a fact), the famous eye losing its 'lustre' (brightness; 'bend' means the direction of a glance), the groan, the childlike cry for a drink, and the humiliating simile 'as a sick girl'. That simile belongs to Cassius's obsession with manliness — in Scene 3 he will call Roman submissiveness "womanish" — and tells you as much about the speaker as the subject. The swoon comes from Casca, who was present but claims "I did not mark it" and then recounts every detail. The medical name comes from Brutus, who is neither hostile nor cynical; 'the falling sickness' was the ordinary English term for epilepsy, and Brutus supplies it in a tone of sympathy. The deaf ear comes from Caesar alone. Gloss the harder words: a 'fit' is a seizure; 'feeble temper' means a weak constitution; to "get the start of the majestic world" is to outrun everyone; to "bear the palm alone" is to take the prize unshared.

Contradiction: The Tiber episode cuts both ways, and Cassius does not seem to notice. It was Caesar who proposed the swim — "Dar'st thou, Cassius, now / Leap in with me into this angry flood" — and a man with a weak body who dares a rival into a torrent is reckless, but he is not feeble in spirit. The fever is a fever: a soldier on campaign in Spain fell ill, which proves nothing about his fitness to govern. And Cassius's own conclusion — that "A man of such a feeble temper should / So get the start of the majestic world / And bear the palm alone" amazes him — is less evidence of Caesar's weakness than of Cassius's bewilderment at his own inferiority. Meanwhile the deaf ear is Shakespeare's invention, and inventions must be asked what they are for. One strong reading: it lets the audience hear the pun when a man who cannot hear on one side turns his other ear and asks to be told the truth. Caesar's deafness is literal and figurative at once.

Dramatic significance: Cassius performs the crucial move when Brutus names the disease: "No, Caesar hath it not; but you and I / And honest Casca, we have the falling sickness." He transfers the illness from Caesar's body to the body of Rome — the Romans are the ones who have 'fallen', into servility. This is the act's method in one line: physical weakness is converted into a political argument. The play then spends four more acts testing whether the argument was sound. The dead Caesar of Acts 3 to 5 turns out to be mightier than the living one, which is a way of saying that the conspirators mistook the body they were attacking.

TEXT NOTE Editions differ on a few words in these reports

Where Folger has "he swooned and fell down at it", the Globe-based text many ICSE editions follow reads 'swounded' — the older spelling of the same word. Folger's "clapped their chopped hands" appears in other editions as 'chapped hands'; both mean cracked and roughened by work. Folger prints "theater" where British editions print "theatre". The 'falling sickness' is the same in all editions. None of these variants changes the meaning; if your school edition has the older spelling, use it.

HISTORICAL CONTEXT What the ancient sources actually say about Caesar's body

HISTORICAL RECORD. Caesar's epilepsy — the 'falling sickness' — is attested in Plutarch and Suetonius, though modern historians debate the diagnosis. His deafness has no basis in any ancient source; it appears to be Shakespeare's addition. Plutarch's account of the Lupercalia contains the diadem offered and refused, but no fainting fit; editors generally trace Caesar's excuse of illness to a separate episode in Plutarch, when Caesar gave offence by failing to rise for the Senate and afterwards blamed his condition, and they suggest Shakespeare folded that episode into the crown scene. Treat this last point as the consensus of editors rather than as a certainty.

Political Intelligence (His Reading of Cassius)

Textual evidence: "He reads much, / He is a great observer, and he looks / Quite through the deeds of men." "Seldom he smiles, and smiles in such a sort / As if he mocked himself and scorned his spirit / That could be moved to smile at anything." "Such men as he be never at heart's ease / Whiles they behold a greater than themselves, / And therefore are they very dangerous."

Explanation: This is the most accurate character sketch anyone gives of anyone in Act 1, and you can test it against what you have just watched. Cassius has indeed looked "Quite through" Brutus, observing him "now of late" and reading the trouble in his face. He has delivered a long speech of bitter self-mockery, calling himself "A wretched creature". And the motive Caesar names — the inability to bear a greater — is exactly what Cassius confessed to Brutus: "I had as lief not be as live to be / In awe of such a thing as I myself." Even the small details hold. While the games were on and the crowd shouted, Cassius was not watching or listening; he was working on a man. Caesar's portrait is not prejudice. It is diagnosis, and the play has already supplied the symptoms.

Contradiction: Intelligence without action is the tragic form of intelligence. Caesar diagnoses and then does nothing: "But I fear him not." Worse, he asks the wrong adviser. Antony — the man Caesar himself teases as a lover of plays and music — has just pronounced Cassius "well given", and Caesar overrides that judgement, then turns and asks for it again. Worst of all is the blind spot. **HISTORICAL RECORD:** in Plutarch, Caesar's remark about not fearing fat men but pale, lean ones pointed at Brutus and Cassius both. Shakespeare's Caesar names only Cassius. His intelligence works perfectly right up to the edge of the man who loves him, and stops there. Love, in this play, is what disables perception.

Dramatic significance: This is dramatic irony at its most concentrated — the audience, fresh from Cassius's seduction of Brutus, hears every clause confirmed — but it also reframes the tragedy. If Caesar were simply blind, his death would be pathetic. Because he sees clearly and chooses to remain 'Caesar' anyway, his death becomes something graver: a man destroyed not by ignorance but by the refusal to let knowledge alter conduct. Hold on to this when you reach Act 3 Scene 1, where he refuses to read a letter that would have saved him.

Public Performance (the Crown Refusals, Offering His Throat)

Textual evidence: Casca's report: "he put it by with the back of his hand, thus, and then the people fell a-shouting"; "he put it by thrice, every time gentler than other"; "to my thinking, he would fain have had it"; "to my thinking, he was very loath to lay his fingers off it"; "he plucked me ope his doublet and offered them his throat to cut"; and the crowd behaved "as they use to do the players in the theatre".

Explanation: The most important thing about the crown scene is that you do not see it. Shakespeare keeps it offstage and gives it to Casca to narrate, so that Caesar's most public act reaches us through the least generous eyes in Rome. Gloss the words: to 'put by' is to push aside; 'fain' means gladly; 'loath' means reluctant; a 'coronet' is a small crown (Casca is careful to reduce even the object); the 'rabbblement' is the mob; 'chopped' hands are chapped from work; 'nightcaps' are the common people's caps; a 'doublet' is an Elizabethan jacket; 'ope' is open. Casca reads the three refusals as theatre — each "gentler than other", as though the hand were increasingly unwilling to push the thing away — and the throat gesture as a further piece of stagecraft: a dare to the crowd, meaning 'kill me if you think me ambitious'. The theatre simile completes the picture: Caesar is a player, the crowd an audience who "clap him and hiss him, according as he pleased and displeased them". The anachronistic 'doublet' — a Roman in an Elizabethan jacket — quietly reminds the Globe audience that they too are watching an actor play a man who is acting.

Contradiction: The performance is interrupted by a body. Shakespeare places the seizure at the exact climax of the show, so that the script Caesar is following is torn up by the one thing he cannot direct. And the reading of the performance as insincere rests entirely on Casca, who says "to my thinking" twice and has been described by Cassius as speaking "after his sour fashion"; even Brutus is struck by how "blunt" he has become. An alternative reading is available and you should give it: a man who wanted the crown had three chances to take it and took none; the crowd cheered each refusal; Caesar read their mood and correctly declined. The play does not adjudicate (act as judge between the two). It hands you a cynic's account and asks whether you trust the cynic.

Dramatic significance: The whole of Julius Caesar is about political theatre — Brutus and Antony will perform to this same crowd in Act 3 Scene 2 — and Act 1 establishes the Roman people as an audience and Caesar as the first performer they judge. Casca's verdict that the crowd would have forgiven Caesar even "if Caesar had stabbed their mothers" is the play's first statement of the mob's malleability (how easily it can be shaped), which Cassius understands ("he sees the Romans are but sheep") and Antony will exploit. Note the historical shift, too: HISTORICAL RECORD says Plutarch's diadem was offered and refused twice; Shakespeare's Casca makes it three times, the folk-tale number, so that the refusals themselves feel like a rehearsed routine.

Fear (What He Fears and How He Hides It)

Textual evidence: In the exchange with Antony the word 'fear' sounds five times in under twenty lines: Antony's "Fear him not, Caesar", then Caesar's "But I fear him not", "Yet if my name were liable to fear", and "I rather tell thee what is to be feared / Than what I fear". Then the private request: "Come on my right hand, for this ear is deaf, / And tell me truly what thou think'st of him."

Explanation: What Caesar fears is specific: the thin, reading, observing man who cannot bear a superior — envy with a brain. He may also fear the future, since he does stop for the Soothsayer. How he hides it is the more interesting question, and the text shows four techniques. He uses the third person, so that 'Caesar' cannot fear even if the man does. He converts fear into a lecture — "I rather tell thee what is to be feared" makes him the teacher of fear rather than its sufferer. He uses conditional grammar: "if my name were liable to fear" admits the hypothesis only in order to deny it. And he takes the conversation private, drawing Antony to his good ear and away from the train. A man who whispers his question about Cassius is a man who does not want the answer overheard.

Contradiction: Fear is not cowardice, and you must not let Cassius's phrase "coward lips" settle the matter. A man who dares a rival into an angry flood and bares his throat to a mob does not lack physical courage. Caesar's fear is political, and it is accurate: the man he fears is the man who is at this moment plotting his death. The hiding, moreover, fails only for the audience, who know too much; Antony, standing beside him, plainly does not perceive it, since he calls Cassius harmless. Caesar hides his fear well from his friends and badly from us.

Dramatic significance: The pattern — denial that reveals — is the key the audience needs for Act 2 Scene 2, where Caesar will speak at length about cowardice and danger while visibly wavering over whether to leave the house. Act 1 trains us to read those later speeches correctly: the louder the denial, the deeper the fear. It also sets up a bitter irony of structure: the play's most fearless-sounding character is the one who dies, while the man who feared nothing openly — Cassius, presenting himself to the lightning — ends, in Act 5, half-believing the omens he once scorned.

Leadership

Textual evidence: "When Caesar says 'Do this,' it is performed." The Cobbler: "we make holiday to see Caesar and to rejoice in his triumph." Casca on the crowd: they forgave him "with all their hearts". Cassius: "he sees the Romans are but sheep". Brutus: "all the rest look like a chidden train".

Explanation: Act 1 shows Caesar leading in three modes. There is command, captured in Antony's formula of instant obedience. There is ceremony — the procession, the trumpets, the ordered ritual — which is leadership through spectacle. And there is popularity: working men take an unlicensed holiday to see him, and women forgive him for fainting. Marullus's insults ("You blocks, you stones") cannot break that hold. Brutus's observation about the "chidden train" adds a fourth element: the leader's mood governs the mood of everyone around him. When Caesar is angry, Rome's great men look scolded.

Contradiction: The leader is led. Casca's account has the crowd applauding and hissing "according as he pleased and displeased them", and the refusals shaped by the crowd's reaction — Caesar reads the room and gives it what it cheers. Cassius's animal image says the same thing from the other side: Caesar "would not be a wolf / But that he sees the Romans are but sheep"; the followers make the leader. Add two further shadows: leadership by suppression (the tribunes "put to silence") and leadership by delegation (Antony runs the course, offers the crown, is asked for judgement). Strip these away and how much of Caesar's leadership is Caesar?

Dramatic significance: Act 1 sets the baseline against which the play measures the leadership vacuum after the assassination — Brutus's inability to hold the crowd and Antony's mastery of it in Act 3 Scene 2. It also puts a question that the whole play refuses to answer simply: whether a republic of 'sheep' deserves any better than a wolf. The chapter 'Themes of Act 1 (Part One)' pursues that under 'Leadership' and 'Public Opinion'.

Ambition (What the Text Shows versus What Cassius Alleges)

Textual evidence: What is shown or reported as fact: a triumph, a ceremonial procession, a crown refused three times, an apology to the crowd, and — in the passive voice, with no agent named — the tribunes "are put to silence". What is alleged: Cassius's forged letters, in which "obscurely / Caesar's ambition shall be glanced at"; Cassius's question to Casca, "And why should Caesar be a tyrant, then?"; and Casca's hearsay, "they say the Senators tomorrow / Mean to establish Caesar as a king".

Explanation: Keep this distinction razor-sharp, because it is the one that separates a thinking answer from a copied one. The noun 'ambition' is applied to Caesar exactly once in Act 1 — by Cassius, in the same breath as a forgery, and with the word "obscurely" (hinted at, not stated). Casca's belief that Caesar "would fain have had it" is prefaced twice with "to my thinking". The report of the Senate's plan begins "they say". Every piece of evidence for Caesar's ambition is either inference, rumour or fabrication, and every piece is voiced by someone who wants Brutus or Casca to believe it. What Caesar visibly does is refuse a crown. HISTORICAL RECORD adds a twist: the real Caesar had been made dictator for life in February 44 BC, and Shakespeare never mentions the title in Act 1. The play's Caesar is judged on less evidence than the historical one.

Contradiction: The mediated evidence is not nothing, and a fair answer says so. Refusing "every time gentler than other" is at least suggestive. Marullus's charge that Caesar "comes in triumph over Pompey's blood" — celebrating victory over fellow Romans — is a fact of the play's world, not a rumour. The silencing of the tribunes happened. "Caesar is turned to hear" is the speech of a man who has already crowned himself in language. And Brutus — no cynic and no forger — fears that "the people / Choose Caesar for their king", which shows that the anxiety about monarchy is in Rome's air and not only in Cassius's mouth.

Dramatic significance: Shakespeare keeps ambition unproven in Act 1 so that Act 3 Scene 2 can stage its trial: Brutus asserting to the crowd that Caesar was ambitious, Antony asking whether the man's conduct looked like ambition. The audience must judge with the same incomplete evidence the Romans have. Had Act 1 shown Caesar grasping at a crown, the play would be a melodrama about a tyrant; because it shows only refusal and rumour, it becomes a tragedy of interpretation. EXAM-ORIENTED ADVICE: when a Class X question on Act 3 Scene 2 asks whether Caesar was ambitious, the strongest answers say that Act 1 supplies no direct proof and that both orators are arguing over a gap.

Reputation

Textual evidence: Cassius: "Except immortal Caesar"; "this man / Is now become a god"; and the tests he runs on the name — "Write them together, yours is as fair a name; / Sound them, it doth become the mouth as well; / Weigh them, it is as heavy". Flavius: "Let no images / Be hung with Caesar's trophies." Casca's wench: "Alas, good soul!"

Explanation: Caesar's reputation has detached from his body and become a thing in itself — a name that can be written, sounded, weighed and conjured with, a set of trophies hung on statues, a public event people take a holiday to see. Cassius's sarcastic 'immortal' and 'god' are testimony to a reputation so inflated that it has become theological, and his need to prove that "Brutus" will "start a spirit as soon as 'Caesar'" shows that he knows reputation, not soldiers, is the real power in Rome. The wench's "Alas, good soul!" shows the other face of it: genuine popular affection, which Casca cannot bear and cannot deny.

Contradiction: Reputation is exactly what the conspiracy plans to fight with — but by attacking Caesar's through the manipulation of Brutus's: the forged letters play on "the great opinion / That Rome holds of his name". In this play reputations are made of paper and shouting, and can be counterfeited. Caesar's own is double: the same man is a Colossus in one Cassius speech and a "sick girl" in the previous one. A reputation that can be both is a reputation that other people are writing.

Dramatic significance: Act 3 Scene 2 is a battle over Caesar's posthumous reputation, won by Antony with a will and a bloodied cloak. Act 1 shows why reputation is the true throne of Rome: nobody in the act fights over Caesar's armies or offices; they fight over his images, his name and what the crowd thinks of him.

Mortality

Textual evidence: "Beware the ides of March." Cassius's memory: "Caesar cried 'Help me, Cassius, or I sink!'" Casca: "foamed at mouth and was speechless". Flavius's image of "growing feathers plucked from Caesar's wing". Cassius in the storm: a man like the night "That thunders, lightens, opens graves, and roars".

Explanation: The Soothsayer names a date, and from that moment the play has a clock. Everything in Act 1 then circles Caesar's mortality without naming it: the swoon is a rehearsal of death (speechless, foaming, fallen in the marketplace); the Tiber episode is a near-drowning; Flavius's image plucks a soaring bird down to "an ordinary pitch" — the height of ordinary men, which is also the height at which men die; and Cassius's storm 'opens graves'. The act is full of Caesar's death before anyone has proposed it.

Contradiction: Set against all this is a vocabulary of deathlessness: "immortal Caesar", "Is now become a god" and above all "always I am Caesar" — 'always' is a claim against time itself. The man tells his procession to move on past the one person who has told him when he will die. The contradiction is not resolved; it is the tragedy in miniature.

Dramatic significance: Because the audience knows the history, every mention of the ides produces double vision — the man who cannot die and the date on which he does. Act 3 Scene 1 will pay this off when Caesar, entering the Capitol, reminds the Soothsayer that the ides have come and receives the reply that they have not yet gone. The chapter 'The Soothsayer, the Ides of March, and the Supporting Cast' traces the date through the play.

Succession (No Heir; Touching Calpurnia)

Textual evidence: "Stand you directly in Antonius' way / When he doth run his course." "The barren, touchèd in this holy chase, / Shake off their sterile curse."

Explanation: Caesar's first anxiety on stage is dynastic (about founding a line of heirs): before he has spoken to the crowd, before the Soothsayer, he is arranging for a child. Why does Shakespeare open his part this way? Because in a republic there is nothing to inherit. A man who worries publicly about an heir is a man already thinking like a king, and the anxiety is itself a political tell — a small, human, damning detail placed before any accusation has been made. Notice too that it is performed in public: a private grief made into civic ritual, with Antony — historically the consul of that year — running the course and the crowd watching the wife.

Contradiction: The play's Caesar wants an heir while refusing a crown. If he has no ambition for kingship, why does the heir matter so much? One answer is that Shakespeare is quietly exposing the monarch beneath the republican performance. Another is that the desire for a child is simply human, and the moment is there to make Caesar a man before Cassius makes him a monster. Both readings are available; a good answer offers both and says which it finds stronger. HISTORICAL RECORD, for context: Brutus's mother Servilia was Caesar's long-time mistress, and the ancient rumour that Caesar was Brutus's father is rejected by modern scholars on grounds of chronology. Shakespeare never mentions it, and you should not import it into the play as fact.

Dramatic significance: 'Barren' and 'sterile' open the play's imagery of fertility and blood that Act 2 will develop. Caesar's childlessness also deepens the betrayal to come: the man he "loves" is a younger Roman who might have been a son, and the news at the end of Act 3 Scene 2 that Octavius has arrived in Rome will begin to answer the succession question this moment raised — by adoption, not by birth.

Relationship with Antony

Textual evidence: "Antonius." — "Caesar, my lord." "When Caesar says 'Do this,' it is performed." "He loves no plays, / As thou dost, Antony; he hears no music". "Come on my right hand, for this ear is deaf, / And tell me truly what thou think'st of him." Casca: "Who offered him the crown?" — "Why, Antony."

Explanation: The relationship is master and instrument, but it is also intimacy. Caesar knows Antony's tastes well enough to tease him — the playgoer, the music-lover — and the teasing is affectionate, not contemptuous. He confides in him alone, and he trusts him with the most delicate public act of the day, the offering of the crown. Antony's side is total loyalty expressed as total obedience: his formula makes Caesar's word and its performance a single event.

Contradiction: Caesar overrules Antony's judgement of Cassius and then asks for it again, which suggests either that he values Antony's honesty more than his accuracy, or that he is looking for reassurance rather than counsel. And Antony's loyalty formula is precisely the "servile fearfulness" the tribunes dreaded — the free Roman reduced to a hand that performs. The friend who loves Caesar best is the clearest evidence of what Caesar's Rome is becoming.

Dramatic significance: Antony's misjudgement of Cassius here is matched by the conspirators' misjudgement of Antony in Act 2 Scene 1, when Brutus argues he is harmless. Caesar's playful dismissal of the pleasure-lover thus foreshadows the conspirators' fatal underestimate of the same man. Everything Antony does in Act 3 — the grief, the negotiation, the oration — grows from the loyalty planted in these few Act 1 lines.

Relationship with Cassius

Textual evidence: Cassius: "Caesar doth bear me hard" ('bears a grudge against me'); "If Caesar carelessly but nod on him"; the Tiber dare, "Dar'st thou, Cassius, now / Leap in with me into this angry flood"; and the rescue, "so from the waves of Tiber / Did I the tirèd Caesar". Caesar: "Yond Cassius has a lean and hungry look"; "I do not know the man I should avoid / So soon as that spare Cassius."

Explanation: This is a relationship of mutual, unequal watching. Cassius remembers saving Caesar's life and resents having done it; his comparison of himself to Aeneas carrying old Anchises out of Troy casts Caesar as an aged burden on a younger man's back. Caesar, for his part, has studied Cassius closely enough to describe his reading habits and his smile. HISTORICAL RECORD supplies a grievance the play never names: for 44 BC Brutus received the more prestigious urban praetorship and Cassius the lesser one, and ancient sources treat this as a source of Cassius's resentment.

Contradiction: Cassius claims Caesar barely notices him — a careless nod is all he gets — yet Caesar has noticed him more precisely than anyone in Rome. The contempt Cassius feels is answered not by indifference but by attention. And Cassius's contempt is shot through with awe: the "eye whose bend doth awe the world" is his phrase, and the sarcasm of "this god" cannot quite hide that he once believed in the god.

Dramatic significance: This is the one relationship in which Caesar's political intelligence functions completely — and it changes nothing. Cassius ends Scene 2 with "we will shake him", and the shaking he mocked in Spain ("this god did shake") returns as a threat. The conspiracy begins with a man Caesar has correctly identified and chosen not to remove.

Relationship with Brutus

Textual evidence: Cassius: "Caesar doth bear me hard, but he loves Brutus." Brutus: "I would not, Cassius, yet I love him well." The one direct exchange between them: "A soothsayer bids you beware the ides of March." Cassius, weighing the love: "If I were Brutus now, and he were Cassius, / He should not humour me."

Explanation: Caesar and Brutus speak directly to each other exactly once in Act 1, and the content is a warning: the man who will strike him tells him to beware. Everything else about their bond exists in other people's mouths. Cassius vouches for Caesar's love; Brutus vouches for his own. Both use the strong word 'love'. Cassius treats that love as a lever, and his sentence is ambiguous in a way editors still debate — either 'if Caesar loved me as he loves Brutus, I would not let his favour soften me' or 'if our roles were reversed, Brutus could not work on me as I am working on him'. On either reading Cassius regards Caesar's affection for Brutus as a weakness to be exploited. **HISTORICAL RECORD:** Brutus had fought for Pompey and been pardoned by Caesar after Pharsalus; Caesar then advanced him to the urban praetorship for 44 BC. The love had a history of mercy behind it.

Contradiction: Brutus's sentence puts the political refusal first and the love second — "I would not, Cassius, yet I love him well" — and that 'yet' is the hinge of his tragedy: the love is real, but it is already conditional. Caesar's love is unconditional and therefore blind; he fears Cassius and never thinks of Brutus. In this play love disables intelligence on both sides — it stops Caesar seeing his killer and it stops Brutus seeing what he is becoming.

Dramatic significance: Caesar's dying words to Brutus in Act 3 Scene 1, and Antony's insistence in Act 3 Scene 2 that Brutus's blow was the cruellest, depend entirely on this seed. **EXAM-ORIENTED ADVICE:** when a Class X question asks why Caesar's death at Brutus's hand is the play's deepest betrayal, this is the Act 1 evidence to cite — one line from Cassius, one from Brutus, both using 'love', and the fact that Brutus was the one who relayed the warning.

CROSS-REFERENCE The other side of these relationships

Cassius's Tiber and Spain speeches are taken apart as manipulation in 'Cassius — The Manipulation Masterclass'; Brutus's 'yet I love him well' is the centre of 'Brutus in Act 1 — Honour, Conflict and Vulnerability'; and the thematic pairing of friendship with betrayal is treated in both theme chapters.

Caesar from Three Angles

The trait-by-trait work gives you the parts. Now assemble them from three standpoints, because an examiner's question about Caesar is nearly always, underneath its wording, a question about *whose* Caesar you mean: the one he projects, the one his observers construct, or the one the audience pieces together from the gap between those two.

Caesar as He Presents Himself

Take only the thirty-nine lines Caesar speaks and ask what self they advertise. The first thing they advertise is order. He arranges bodies in space — "Stand you directly in Antonius' way" — and arranges the day's ritual — "Set on and leave no ceremony out" — like a man for whom Rome is a procession he is directing. The second is completeness: nothing about him is allowed to be casual, which is why the deaf ear is presented not as a lapse but as a logistical fact to be managed by walking round to the other side. The third is fearlessness, stated as a definition rather than a feeling: "for always I am Caesar". He never says 'I am brave'; he says 'I am Caesar', and leaves you to deduce the bravery. The fourth is discernment. The one long speech he is given is an act of judgement — a man weighing another man — and he wants to be seen judging well. The fifth, quieter than the rest, is piety: the elders' custom is honoured, the ceremonies observed. What he does not present is appetite. In Act 1 Caesar never asks for anything for himself — not the crown, not applause, not even

sympathy after the swoon, where (on Casca's report) he asks only to be excused. The self Caesar presents is finished, public and unwanted: a monument that happens to walk and speak. Hold on to that word 'unwanted', because everyone else in the act is going to insist that he wants a great deal.

Caesar as Others See Him

Flavius and Marullus. To the tribunes Caesar is a threat to the Republic measured in bird-flight: "Who else would soar above the view of men / And keep us all in servile fearfulness". They never mention his virtues, his victories against foreigners or his popularity except as a danger; their Caesar is the man who "comes in triumph over Pompey's blood", a Roman celebrating the killing of Romans. Notice that their hostility is institutional, not personal. They are tribunes, officers whose historic job was to protect the people against overmighty men, and they see in Caesar the office-holder's nightmare: a single man growing larger than the constitution. Their Caesar is a political abstraction with feathers. The ironic answer to them comes offstage, in a single sentence of Casca's: "Marullus and Flavius, for pulling scarves off Caesar's images, are put to silence."

The Cobbler. To the working man Caesar is a holiday. "We make holiday to see Caesar and to rejoice in his triumph" — the triumph is an event, like a festival or a fair, and the man at its centre is a spectacle to be enjoyed. The Cobbler's Caesar has no politics attached; he knows nothing of Pompey's blood and is baffled to be told he should. He also, in his jokes, treats the whole occasion as good for trade ("to wear out their shoes, to get myself into more work"). This is the Caesar of the crowd that will shout three times at the games: adored, uncomprehended, and loved as entertainment rather than as a ruler. The tribunes think this is a disgrace. The play is less sure: the Cobbler's affection is real and the tribunes' republic is already a memory.

Cassius. Cassius's Caesar is a construction built for a purpose, and you must always read it as such. It has two faces that the speaker never reconciles. One is the Colossus who "doth stride the narrow world" — gigantic, deified, the man whose name can be conjured with. The other is the sick swimmer who cried "Help me, Cassius, or I sink!" and the fever patient with "coward lips" who whimpered like "a sick girl". Cassius needs both: the giant to make Brutus feel the humiliation of being an underling, the invalid to make the giant seem a fraud. The join between them is the confession that gives the game away — "I had as lief not be as live to be / In awe of such a thing as I myself" — because it tells you Cassius's real complaint is not that Caesar is unfit but that Caesar is not Cassius. In Scene 3 his Caesar changes shape again, becoming a monster "Most like this dreadful night" and then, in the next breath, a "Poor man" who is only a wolf because Romans are sheep. A portrait that alters this often is a portrait of the painter.

Brutus. Brutus's Caesar is almost invisible, and the invisibility is the point. He never describes Caesar's character; he describes his own feelings about Caesar's position. "I do fear the people / Choose Caesar for their king" — the fear attaches to the people's choice and to the word 'king', not to anything Caesar has done. "I would not, Cassius, yet I love him well" — the love is stated and the objection is to a hypothesis. The one time he reads Caesar's face, he sees a mood — "The angry spot doth glow on Caesar's brow" — and, when he hears of the swoon, he gives it a medical name without malice. Brutus's Caesar is a friend who happens to stand where a king might stand. This is why Cassius must work so hard: there is no resentment in Brutus to inflame, only a principle to exploit.

Casca. Casca's Caesar is an actor, and a poor one. Everything in his report reduces the man: the crown is "one of these coronets", the refusal is a routine performed "every time gentler than other", the ambition is visible to anyone with eyes ("to my thinking, he would fain have had it"), the collapse is almost comic. Yet Casca cannot help reporting things that contradict his contempt — the throat offered to the crowd, the apology, the women who "forgave him with all their hearts" — and he shields himself from his own evidence with "It was mere

foolery; I did not mark it." His Caesar is the Caesar of a man who despises everybody, the crowd most of all, and whose cynicism (the habit of assuming the worst motive) is a way of never being impressed. The audience is meant to enjoy him and to distrust him in equal measure.

Antony. Antony's Caesar is simply 'my lord'. He answers to his name with the title, promises obedience in the famous formula — "When Caesar says 'Do this,' it is performed" — and, asked about Cassius, answers with loyal optimism: "Fear him not, Caesar; he's not dangerous." Antony's Caesar is a master worth serving without question, and the view is so uncomplicated that the act gives him no reason to examine it. It is also, in Act 1, the view that is most wrong about the immediate danger and most right about the man's worth — a combination that will make Antony's grief in Act 3 both sincere and politically devastating.

Caesar as the Audience Gradually Discovers Him

Shakespeare releases Caesar to the audience in a controlled sequence, and the order of discovery is itself an argument. First we hear the *name* in Scene 1, fought over by tribunes and commoners, so that before Caesar exists he is already a dispute. Then we see the *ceremony* at the start of Scene 2: trumpets, hush, commands, a wife positioned for ritual. Then we hear the *warning* and watch him examine and dismiss it — our first glimpse of the mind behind the ceremony, and it looks confident to the point of carelessness. Then, for the long middle of the scene, Caesar is absent and Cassius builds the *biography*: the swimmer, the fever, the Colossus. Because we have no other information, this biography fills the vacuum. Then Caesar returns, and for the first time we hear him *think*, and the thinking is sharper than anything Cassius led us to expect; the audience, having been taught to look down on him, is made to look up again. Then Casca's report gives us the *spectacle* we were not allowed to see, filtered through contempt, and finally Scene 3 gives us Caesar as *weather*: a storm that other men interpret.

What the audience discovers, then, is not a character but a method of character-making: the realisation that every account of Caesar is a performance by someone with an interest, including Caesar's own. By the end of Act 1 you know less about Caesar than about the people describing him — which is precisely the knowledge you need for Acts 2 and 3, where the question 'was Caesar ambitious?' is decided not by evidence but by who speaks last.

The Two Bodies of Caesar

LITERARY INTERPRETATION. Medieval and Tudor political thought held that a king has two bodies: a 'body natural', which ages, sickens and dies like anyone's, and a 'body politic', the undying public office that passes from one holder to the next. The historian Ernst Kantorowicz gave this idea its classic description in *The King's Two Bodies* (1957), drawing on Elizabethan lawyers who wrote in exactly these terms. Shakespeare had no need of the treatise; the doctrine was in the air of his time, and *Julius Caesar* dramatises it with unusual clarity — in a republic, where there is officially no king at all.

Caesar's body politic is the Colossus. It is built of a name that can be conjured with, images hung with trophies, a procession that moves at "Let us leave him. Pass", a people that takes a holiday to see it, and a grammar in which "Caesar is turned to hear" and "always I am Caesar". This body does not swim, sweat or shake. It is the thing Cassius means when he sneers at "immortal Caesar" and the thing the tribunes fear when they see a man soaring "above the view of men". Caesar's body natural is the one Cassius dragged from the Tiber, the one that shook in Spain and "foamed at mouth and was speechless" in the marketplace, the one with a deaf ear and no child. Act 1 is constructed so that we meet the two bodies in alternation: ceremony, then the Soothsayer; the Colossus speech, then the fever; the man who fears nobody, then the man who cannot hear on one side.

The brilliance of the design is that Caesar himself lives in the public body and treats the natural one as an inconvenience to be announced and ignored. "Come on my right hand, for this ear is deaf" is the body natural speaking; "for always I am Caesar", in the previous line, is the body politic. He does not seem to feel the contradiction, and that is his tragedy in miniature: a man who has moved house into his own legend. Cassius, meanwhile, makes the opposite mistake — he believes that if he can expose the natural body (the sick girl, the swooner) the political body will collapse with it. Casca's report tells us that this does not happen: the crowd saw Caesar fall, foam and apologise, and loved him more.

PROFESSOR'S INSIGHT The conspirators kill the wrong body

LITERARY INTERPRETATION. Here is what a school guide will not tell you about Act 1: it is a long demonstration that Caesar's power does not live in Caesar's body, delivered to men who are about to stab the body. Every piece of evidence the conspirators gather — the near-drowning, the fever, the deafness, the swoon — belongs to the body natural, and every piece of evidence of his power — the name, the images, the holiday, the shouting, the silenced tribunes — belongs to the body politic. Cassius's own tests prove the point against him: he asks Brutus to "Write them together", "Sound them", "Weigh them", and the whole exercise is about names, not men. So when the daggers go in during Act 3 Scene 1 they go into the only Caesar that was ever killable, and the other Caesar — the name, the will, the wounds displayed in the marketplace, the spirit that haunts Brutus to Philippi — proves to be the one that mattered. This is why the man who speaks fewer than forty lines in Act 1 gives the play its title: the title names the body politic, which is on stage for five acts, not the body natural, which leaves in the third. When you write about Caesar's weakness, make this move: show that the weaknesses are real, then show that they are beside the point, and your answer will have done what Cassius could not.

Caesar in Act 1 → Caesar in Acts 2–3

Every trait examined above is a seed. The table shows where each one comes up. Later-Act wording is given in single quotes because it lies outside the Act 1 text this book verifies against; check it in your own edition.

Trait	Act 1 seed	Where it returns
Authority by command	"Set on and leave no ceremony out"; Antony's "When Caesar says 'Do this,' it is performed."	Act 2 Scene 2: 'Caesar shall forth' — the commands continue, but now a wife, a servant and a flatterer are all pulling at them.
Confidence as identity	"He is a dreamer. Let us leave him. Pass." / "for always I am Caesar"	Act 2 Scene 2: 'Danger knows full well / That Caesar is more dangerous than he'; Act 3 Scene 1: Caesar 'constant as the Northern Star', refusing to be moved — minutes before he is.
Pride in the third person	"Speak. Caesar is turned to hear."	Act 2 Scene 2 and Act 3 Scene 1, where he speaks almost wholly as 'Caesar'; his last words, 'Then fall, Caesar', name the body politic as the body natural dies.
Superstition versus overconfidence	"The barren, touchèd in this holy chase, / Shake off their sterile curse." against "He is a dreamer."	Act 2 Scene 2: sacrifice ordered, augurers heard, Calpurnia's dream believed and then explained away by Decius; Cassius in Act 2 Scene 1 notes he 'is superstitious grown of late'.
Physical weakness	"this ear is deaf"; the fever; "he hath the falling sickness"	Act 2 Scene 1: Brutus argues Antony 'can do no more than Caesar's arm / When Caesar's head is off'; Act 3 Scene 2: the body itself, with its wounds, becomes Antony's chief exhibit.

Trait	Act 1 seed	Where it returns
Political intelligence and its limit	"He thinks too much. Such men are dangerous." — Cassius read, Brutus unseen	Act 2 Scene 1: Decius boasts he can 'give his humour the true bent', and in Act 2 Scene 2 he does; Act 3 Scene 1: 'Et tu, Brute?' — the blind spot of Act 1 is where the fatal blow lands.
Public performance	The crown refused "thrice"; the throat offered to the crowd	Act 3 Scene 2: Antony reminds the crowd 'I thrice presented him a kingly crown, / Which he did thrice refuse' — Casca's cynical report becomes Antony's proof of innocence.
Fear denied	"I rather tell thee what is to be feared / Than what I fear"	Act 2 Scene 2: 'Cowards die many times before their deaths' — the loudest denial in the play, spoken by a man deciding whether to leave his house.
Ambition unproven	Only "obscurely / Caesar's ambition shall be glanced at" — in a forgery	Act 3 Scene 2: Brutus's 'as he was ambitious, I slew him' against Antony's 'Ambition should be made of sterner stuff'; the Act 1 gap becomes the trial.
Reputation as power	"Except immortal Caesar"; the name that can be conjured with	Act 3 Scene 1: Antony's 'Caesar's spirit, ranging for revenge'; the name outlives the man and wins the crowd through the will.
Mortality foretold	"Beware the ides of March."	Act 3 Scene 1: 'The ides of March are come' — 'Ay, Caesar, but not gone'; Artemidorus's letter refused with 'What touches us ourself shall be last served'.
Succession	"To touch Calpurnia ... Shake off their sterile curse."	Act 3 Scene 2: the will names the people as heirs of his gardens and money; a servant reports that 'Octavius is already come to Rome' — the heir arrives by adoption.
Antony	"Fear him not, Caesar; he's not dangerous."	Act 2 Scene 1: the conspirators make the mirror-image error about Antony; Act 3 Scene 1 and 2: the loyal instrument becomes the avenger.
Cassius	"Yond Cassius has a lean and hungry look."	Act 2 Scene 1 and Act 3 Scene 1: Cassius drives the plot, urges killing Antony too, and is overruled by Brutus — the danger Caesar diagnosed, made real.
Brutus	"Caesar doth bear me hard, but he loves Brutus." / "yet I love him well"	Act 3 Scene 1: Caesar's dying words to Brutus; Act 3 Scene 2: Antony calls Brutus's wound 'the most unkindest cut of all'.

Writing About Caesar in the Examination

EXAM-ORIENTED ADVICE. First, the honest frame. Act 1 is the Class IX portion; the Class X board paper sets its drama extracts from Acts III–V, and no question can be predicted or guaranteed. The Caesar of Act 1 earns you marks in two ways: directly, in Class IX reference-to-the-context questions on this act; and indirectly but constantly in Class X, where any sub-question about Caesar's fall, Brutus's motives or Antony's oration (an extract question is worth 16 marks, split in the 2025 paper into sub-parts of 3, 3, 3, 3 and 4) is answered better by a student who can reach back to the seeds planted here. The second thing to get right is vocabulary. 'Arrogant' is the word every weak answer reaches for, and it fails for a precise reason: it describes a mood, not a mechanism. The examiner wants to see you explain *how* Caesar's self-regard works and *what it costs him*. The bank below gives you words that do that.

ICSE EXAM BOX How to write about Caesar without saying 'arrogant'

Authority — the power to command and be obeyed. *Sample:* 'Caesar's authority is shown in the grammar of his speech: nearly every line is an order, and Antony's "When Caesar says 'Do this,' it is performed" turns his word and its execution into a single event.'

Self-mythologising — building a legend about oneself and living inside it. *Sample:* 'Caesar has adopted Rome's estimate of him as his private identity; "for always I am Caesar" treats the name as a condition that cannot admit fear.'

Third-person self-reference — speaking of oneself by name, as an outsider would. *Sample:* 'When Caesar says "Caesar is turned to hear", he reports on himself as if on an institution, splitting the man from the office — the split the conspirators will fatally misunderstand.'

Public persona — the self presented to others, as distinct from the private man. *Sample:* 'The crown refusals, the offered throat and the apology to the crowd are all parts of a public persona; Casca's "to my thinking" reminds us that we see the performance only through a hostile critic.'

Vulnerability — openness to harm, bodily or political. *Sample:* 'Caesar's vulnerability is announced by himself ("this ear is deaf") and reported by his enemies (the fever, the swoon); the play asks whether a frail body is any argument against a man's fitness to rule.'

Superstition versus overconfidence — the tension between observing omens and dismissing them. *Sample:* 'The man who wants "no ceremony" left out of a fertility rite dismisses the Soothsayer as "a dreamer" within thirty lines; Act 2 Scene 2 will replay this wavering at length.'

Political intelligence — the ability to read men and motives. *Sample:* 'Caesar's reading of Cassius — one who looks "Quite through the deeds of men" — is the most accurate judgement in Act 1; his tragedy is that insight never becomes action.'

Mediated testimony — evidence reaching us through a biased witness. *Sample:* 'Almost everything we know of Caesar's weakness is mediated by Cassius and Casca, so a careful answer weighs the witness before it weighs the evidence.'

Two cautions. Use **hubris** only if you also show the fall it invites; otherwise it is 'arrogant' in Greek. And never write that Caesar 'is' ambitious in Act 1: write that ambition is *alleged* and show by whom.

Now watch the vocabulary at work on a question that is set, in one form or another, in many Class IX papers and that underlies every Class X debate about the assassination: 'Is Caesar a tyrant in Act 1?' The weak paragraph is not foolish; it is what most students write. Compare it with the strong one and notice exactly what the difference consists of.

WEAK ANSWER Is Caesar a tyrant in Act 1? — a weak paragraph

Caesar is shown as an arrogant and ambitious tyrant in Act 1. He speaks of himself in the third person and he ignores the Soothsayer's warning "Beware the ides of March", which shows his pride. Cassius tells Brutus that Caesar is weak and had a fever in Spain, and that he nearly drowned in the Tiber, so he is not fit to rule Rome. Casca says the crown was offered three times and Caesar wanted it. The tribunes are punished for taking down his decorations. All this shows that Caesar is a proud tyrant who wants to be king and that is why the conspirators decide to kill him.

EXCELLENT ANSWER Is Caesar a tyrant in Act 1? — an excellent paragraph

Act 1 gives us the materials for calling Caesar a tyrant but is careful never to confirm the charge, and a precise answer must keep the two apart. The strongest direct evidence is the fate of Marullus and Flavius, who "are put to silence" for pulling scarves off his images — the one act of repression in the act, reported in a passive voice that names no agent. Beyond that, the case rests on witnesses with motives. Cassius, who confesses he cannot bear to live "In awe of such a thing as I myself", supplies the physical frailties and the Colossus image; Casca, whose every judgement is prefaced "to my thinking", reads three public refusals of a crown as disguised desire; and the only use of the word 'ambition' in the whole act is Cassius's plan to have it "glanced at" in forged letters. What Caesar himself shows us is authority rather than tyranny: a grammar of command, a self-mythologising confidence — "for always I am Caesar" — and a public persona that gives the crowd back what it cheers. Even his superstition is civic piety as much as weakness. The honest conclusion is that Shakespeare presents a man whom republicans fear as a potential king and whom the text declines to convict, so that when Brutus kills him in Act 3 for what he 'may' become, the audience has been trained by Act 1 to notice the gap between evidence and verdict.

The difference is five moves. The strong paragraph separates what Caesar does from what others say he does; it names and weighs its witnesses; it quotes short and exact, each quotation making a point; it uses the bank's words where the weak one uses 'arrogant', 'proud' and 'ambitious' as if they were facts; and it ends with a judgement of its own, tied to what the play does next. Practise those moves until they are automatic.

REVISION Caesar in Act 1 — what to carry away

1. Caesar speaks thirty-nine lines, all in Scene 2, and is given no soliloquy; most of what we 'know' of him is testimony from interested witnesses.
2. His own words show authority (imperatives), confidence ("He is a dreamer"), self-mythologising ("for always I am Caesar") and one volunteered frailty ("this ear is deaf").
3. His reading of Cassius is the most accurate judgement in the act — and it changes nothing, because 'Caesar' cannot act on fear.
4. His weaknesses (fever, Tiber, swoon, deafness) come from Cassius and Casca; the deafness is Shakespeare's invention, the epilepsy is in Plutarch.
5. The crown scene is reported, not staged; Casca's three refusals replace Plutarch's two, and his reading of them is opinion.
6. Ambition is alleged, never shown: one forged hint, one "to my thinking", one "they say".
7. Caesar wants an heir while refusing a crown — a human wish and a political tell at once.
8. He loves Brutus and fears Cassius; love is the blind spot where the fatal blow will land.
9. The two bodies: Caesar lives in the public one; the conspirators will kill the natural one and discover their mistake.
10. Write with the bank — authority, public persona, self-mythologising, vulnerability, mediated testimony — and never settle for 'arrogant'.

CHAPTER 8

Cassius — The Manipulation Masterclass

What this chapter does: it takes the single most skilful piece of private persuasion in Act 1 — Cassius working on Brutus while the games are going on offstage — and slows it down until you can see every move. You will learn to read the seduction of Brutus as thirteen distinct stages, each with its own aim and technique; to name Cassius's tools with the precise vocabulary an examiner rewards; to watch him change his method completely when he turns to Casca in the storm; and to weigh, honestly and without oversimplifying, what actually drives him. By the end, you should be able to explain not just what Cassius says but why it works, why Shakespeare lets us see through it, and how this knowledge earns marks in Class 10 answers on Acts 3 to 5.

Why Cassius is the best teacher of persuasion you will ever meet

Most students meet Cassius as a label: 'the envious conspirator', 'the manipulator', 'the practical one'. Labels are the enemy of good literature answers. What makes Cassius worth several weeks of a scholar's attention is that Shakespeare shows us a persuader *at work*, in real time, on a man who is intelligent, suspicious and morally serious. Brutus is not a fool. He sees what Cassius is doing — he says so, in so many words, near the end of their talk. And yet Cassius still gets what he came for. That is the puzzle this chapter solves.

Hold on to one idea from the start. Cassius almost never *argues*. He does not produce evidence that Caesar has broken a law, ordered an execution or abolished an office. Instead he works on Brutus's picture of himself: his honour, his name, his ancestry, his fear of what Rome thinks of him. This is why the play's own word for what happens is not 'persuasion' but something darker. Alone on stage afterwards, Cassius asks, of Brutus, "who so firm that cannot be seduced?" Keep that word in mind; we shall return to it.

A note of honesty before we begin. Act 1 belongs to the Class IX portion of the ICSE syllabus, and your Class 10 board paper examines Acts 3, 4 and 5. But the paper constantly assumes you know how the conspiracy was born, why Brutus joined it, and what kind of man Cassius is when you meet him again quarrelling with Brutus in Act 4 or dying in Act 5. Everything you learn here is foundation, and the analytical vocabulary of persuasion you will build here is exactly what you need to analyse Antony's funeral oration in Act 3.

LEVEL 1 — What happened?

After the Soothsayer's warning, Caesar's procession leaves for the games. Brutus and Cassius stay behind. Cassius complains that Brutus has been cold to him lately; Brutus explains that he is troubled by private thoughts. Cassius offers to be Brutus's 'mirror' and show him how highly Rome thinks of him. Two offstage shouts interrupt them; Brutus admits he fears the people are making Caesar king. Cassius then tells two stories against Caesar — a swimming race in the Tiber in which Caesar nearly drowned, and a fever in Spain during which Caesar shook and groaned — and argues that Caesar is no better a man than either of them. He reminds Brutus of his ancestor who drove out Rome's last king. Brutus promises to think it over and to meet again. Left alone, Cassius admits that he means to trick Brutus with forged letters. In Act 1 Scene 3, during the storm, Cassius recruits Casca by very different means and sends Cinna to plant the letters.

LEVEL 2 — What does it mean?

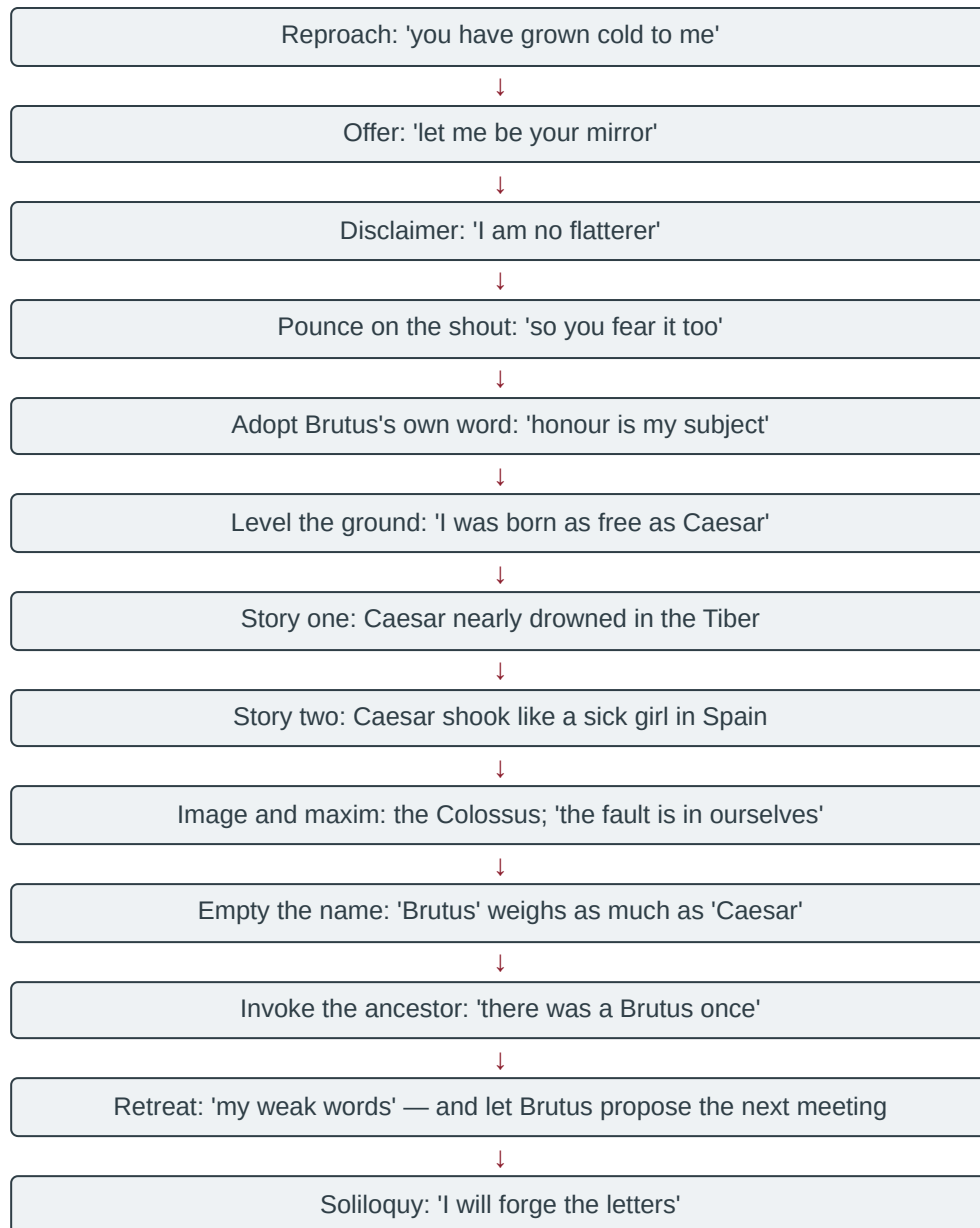
The conversation is a recruitment. Cassius is the instigator of a conspiracy that already exists (he tells Casca in Scene 3 that others are waiting at Pompey's Porch), and he needs Brutus because Brutus's reputation for honour will make the killing look like a public service rather than a private murder. Every stage of the talk is designed to lower Brutus's guard, raise his sense of his own importance, lower Caesar in his eyes, and make refusal feel like cowardice or betrayal of his family name. The soliloquy that closes the exchange tells us, in Cassius's own voice, that he knows he is bending an honourable man away from his natural disposition. Shakespeare therefore gives us a double view: we see the persuasion working on Brutus, and we see the persuader's private contempt for the very honour he is exploiting.

KEYWORDS Words you must own before the stages

The passage is dense with words whose meanings have shifted since 1599. Learn these now; each is glossed again when it appears.

Shakespeare's word	Meaning in this scene
wont	accustomed
construe	interpret
jealous (on)	suspicious (of), doubtful
favour	face, outward appearance
lief ('I had as lief')	gladly ('I would as soon')
accoutred	fully dressed, in armour
bend	glance, look
temper	physical constitution, make-up
brookd	tolerated, put up with
aim	guess, idea
mettle / metal	spirit, temperament (punning on the substance)
wrought	worked, shaped (as metal is)
meet	fitting, proper
humour	indulge, win over by pleasing
several hands	different handwritings

Here is the whole movement of the scene as a ladder, so that you have the shape before the detail:



The seduction of Brutus in thirteen stages (Act 1 Scene 2)

Setting the moment. The procession has just swept off to the Lupercal running, taking Caesar, Antony, Calpurnia and the rest. Cassius makes a light social opening — "Will you go see the order of the course?" (the running of the race) — and Brutus declines: "I am not gamesome. I do lack some part / Of that quick spirit that is in Antony." He even tries to leave. Notice that Brutus has already separated himself from Antony's kind of man, the athlete and reveller, and from the festive crowd. He is a man who stays behind. Cassius, who "is a great observer" in Caesar's later phrase, has noticed this too, and it is precisely on the man who stays behind that he goes to work.

Stage 1 — The complaint about lost gentleness

What Cassius says: He stops Brutus from leaving with a personal reproach: "Brutus, I do observe you now of late. / I have not from your eyes that gentleness / And show of love as I was wont to have. / You bear too stubborn and too strange a hand / Over your friend that loves you." ('Wont' means accustomed; 'gentleness' here is friendly warmth; the 'hand' is a rider's hand on the rein.)

What Cassius means: 'You have been avoiding me, and I am hurt. You are treating your friend like a horse held on a tight, unfamiliar rein.' The metaphor quietly accuses Brutus of coldness and control.

What Cassius wants: He wants Brutus to stop, to explain himself, and to feel that he owes his friend an account of his inner life. A man who has just apologised is a man whose guard is down. Cassius also wants information: what is really troubling Brutus?

How Brutus receives it: He immediately reassures and apologises. "Be not deceived. If I have veiled my look, / I turn the trouble of my countenance / Merely upon myself." He is "Vexèd I am / Of late with passions of some difference" (conflicting emotions) and "Conceptions only proper to myself" (private thoughts), and begs his friends not to "construe" (interpret) his neglect as anything more than "poor Brutus, with himself at war". He even counts Cassius among his "good friends".

Rhetorical technique: The reproach-as-invitation. Cassius takes the position of the injured party so that Brutus must come towards him to make amends. The equestrian (horse-riding) metaphor ('a stubborn and strange hand') is aristocratic and intimate at once — a nobleman's image, used between equals.

Emotional effect: Brutus is put on the defensive and made to confess that he is inwardly divided. He does not say what about; he does not need to. Cassius, who has observed him "now of late", can guess.

Political effect: Before a single word about Caesar has been spoken, Cassius has learned the one thing he most needed to know: the ground is already disturbed. Brutus is not contented. A discontented Brutus can be worked.

Important keywords: gentleness, wont, stubborn and strange hand, countenance (face, expression), passions of some difference, construe, "with himself at war".

Later consequence: Brutus's admission of inner war is the seed of his great orchard soliloquy in Act 2, where that private conflict becomes the reasoning by which he talks himself into killing a man he loves. Cassius did not create the conflict; he found it and fed it.

Stage 2 — The mirror: "I, your glass"

What Cassius says: He pretends to have misread Brutus, and to have therefore kept back "Thoughts of great value, worthy cogitations" (weighty reflections). Then comes the question that changes everything: "Tell me, good Brutus, can you see your face?" Brutus answers with a commonplace of the age — "No, Cassius, for the eye sees not itself / But by reflection, by some other things." Cassius agrees, and laments that Brutus has "no such mirrors as will turn / Your hidden worthiness into your eye". He adds that "many of the best respect in Rome, / Except immortal Caesar", have been "groaning underneath this age's yoke" and have "wished that noble Brutus had his eyes". When Brutus asks into what "dangers" he is being led, Cassius answers: "I, your glass, / Will modestly discover to yourself / That of yourself which you yet know not of."

What Cassius means: 'Rome's best men are suffering under Caesar and wish you could see yourself as they see you — as the man who should act. I will be the mirror that shows you that.'

What Cassius wants: To make Brutus see himself not with his own eyes but with a reflection Cassius controls. Note the sly move from 'I think' to 'Rome thinks': Cassius's opinion becomes the opinion of "the best respect in Rome". He is testing whether Brutus is moved by reputation. He is.

How Brutus receives it: With a flash of alarm and modesty: "Into what dangers would you lead me, Cassius, / That you would have me seek into myself / For that which is not in me?" The word "dangers" shows he already senses where this leads. But he does not walk away.

Rhetorical technique: Flattery disguised as service; the extended metaphor of the mirror. There is also a teasing withholding of information ('I have thoughts of great value — but I misjudged you, so I kept them buried'), which makes Brutus curious. And the phrase "Except immortal Caesar" is a small masterpiece of mock-reverence: it excludes Caesar from the honourable Romans while appearing to honour him.

Emotional effect: Brutus is told that he is admired more than he knows and that good men are waiting on him. For a man who loves "the name of honour", as he will shortly confess, nothing could be more pleasant to hear or harder to dismiss.

Political effect: The conspiracy acquires its justification: it is what 'Rome' wants. This is the germ of the forged letters, which will literally manufacture the voice of Rome that Cassius here merely claims to have overheard ("I have heard").

Important keywords: glass (mirror), reflection, shadow (image), "hidden worthiness", "the best respect in Rome", yoke (a wooden bar laid on the necks of oxen — here, servitude), "modestly discover" (reveal).

Later consequence: A mirror shows a reversed image, and Cassius's mirror shows Brutus a flattering, distorted Rome. In Act 3 Brutus will address the real Roman crowd, expecting the gratitude Cassius promised; Antony will show him what Rome actually thinks. The mirror was a lie, and the play makes Brutus pay for believing it.

Stage 3 — The protest of sincerity: "Were I a common laughter"

What Cassius says: Before revealing anything, he defends his own character: "And be not jealous on me, gentle Brutus. / Were I a common laughter, or did use / To stale with ordinary oaths my love / To every new protester; if you know / That I do fawn on men and hug them hard / And after scandal them, or if you know / That I profess myself in banqueting / To all the rout, then hold me dangerous." ('Jealous on' is suspicious of; a 'common laughter' is a joker or object of ridicule; to 'stale' is to cheapen; a 'protester' is someone who professes friendship; to 'scandal' is to slander; 'the rout' is the rabble.)

What Cassius means: 'If I were the kind of man who swears friendship to everybody, flatters people and then slanders them behind their backs, and shouts my loyalties at drunken parties, then you would be right to distrust me. I am not that man.'

What Cassius wants: To neutralise the suspicion Brutus has just voiced with the word "dangers". He must establish his credit before he spends it.

How Brutus receives it: He has no time to reply — the first offstage shout interrupts. But the disclaimer clearly works: from this point Brutus never again questions Cassius's motives, only his own readiness.

Rhetorical technique: The disclaimer, sometimes called apophasis — mentioning the very things you wish to deny. Cassius lists the behaviour of a manipulator in vivid detail (fawning, hugging, slandering) precisely so as to distance himself from it. Rhetoricians have always known that a speaker who begins by establishing his own honesty gains a hearing for everything that follows.

Emotional effect: Reassurance. Brutus is invited to feel that this is intimate, serious talk between two austere (severe, self-denying) men who despise the flatterers and the crowd — a shared aristocratic contempt for "the rout".

Political effect: Cassius has separated himself from the ordinary, noisy politics of the festival and positioned this conversation as something graver. He has also spoken the word "dangerous" of himself — a word Caesar will use of him within the hour.

Important keywords: jealous (suspicious), common laughter, stale, protester, fawn, scandal, rout, "hold me dangerous".

Later consequence: The irony is total. In his soliloquy Cassius will admit that he is doing exactly what he here denies — winning Brutus by pleasing him and working on his nature. And in Act 3 a far greater speaker, Antony, will use the same move in his funeral oration, protesting to the crowd that he is a plain, blunt man with no gift for stirring people — a claim he makes while doing exactly that. Shakespeare's most effective persuaders always begin by denying that they are persuaders at all.

TEXT NOTE Laughter or laughter?

The Folger text prints "Were I a common laughter"; the MIT and Gutenberg texts, following older editors, print 'laughter'. 'Laughter' would mean a laughing-stock or a buffoon; 'laughter' would mean a man who laughs easily and cheaply. Either reading gives the same sense: 'were I a frivolous man'. Both are legitimate; do not lose sleep over which your edition prints, but quote whichever your edition gives.

Stage 4 — Exploiting the shout and Brutus's fear

What Cassius says: A flourish and a shout come from the offstage crowd. Brutus reacts first: "What means this shouting? I do fear the people / Choose Caesar for their king." Cassius pounces: "Ay, do you fear it? / Then must I think you would not have it so."

What Cassius means: 'You said *fear*. A man does not fear what he wants. So you are against Caesar being king — you have just told me so.'

What Cassius wants: A commitment from Brutus's own mouth, before any argument has been made. He wants Brutus to hear himself take a side.

How Brutus receives it: He concedes, with the qualification on which the whole tragedy will turn: "I would not, Cassius, yet I love him well." Then impatience: "But wherefore do you hold me here so long? / What is it that you would impart to me?" Brutus wants the point, and wants it framed as public duty — he will listen only "If it be aught toward the general good" ('aught' is anything; the 'general good' is the public welfare).

Rhetorical technique: Seizing the interruption. Cassius could not have scripted the shout, but he uses it as a third speaker in the conversation, letting the crowd 'say' what he dare not. Then a forced inference — "Then must I think" — which dresses a leap as a logical necessity.

Emotional effect: Brutus's anxiety about Caesar's kingship, which he has been carrying privately, is now spoken aloud and shared. A fear shared with a sympathiser becomes a bond.

Political effect: Cassius has not yet made one open charge against Caesar, and already Brutus has declared himself against a crown. The persuader has made the target supply the conclusion.

Important keywords: fear, king, "the general good", aught, impart.

Later consequence: "yet I love him well" is the half-line Brutus never escapes. In Act 2 he reasons that he has no personal grievance against Caesar and must kill him for what he *might* become; in Act 3 he tells the crowd he loved Caesar; at Philippi he still speaks of him. Cassius heard the love in this line and worked around it rather than against it — a sign of real skill.

Stage 5 — The honour pledge: "honour is the subject of my story"

What Cassius says: Brutus lays down his terms: "Set honour in one eye and death i' th' other / And I will look on both indifferently; / For let the gods so speed me as I love / The name of honour more than I fear death." ('Indifferently' is impartially; 'speed' is prosper.) Cassius answers: "I know that virtue to be in you, Brutus, / As well as I do know your outward favour. / Well, honour is the subject of my story." ('Favour' is face.)

What Cassius means: 'I know your inner character as well as I know your face — and honour is exactly what I want to talk about.'

What Cassius wants: To make his cause and Brutus's ruling value appear identical. Whatever Cassius was going to say, it is now going to be called 'honour'.

How Brutus receives it: He has been given what he asked for — a matter of honour — and settles in to listen. He speaks only once more before the ancestor passage.

Rhetorical technique: Vocabulary mirroring. Brutus uses the word honour twice in four lines; Cassius adopts it instantly and makes it his title. Persuaders who echo the target's own words seem to be agreeing with him even while leading him. Note also the last word of "honour is the subject of my story": Cassius announces a narrative, not an argument, and a story is far harder to refute than a claim.

Emotional effect: Brutus feels understood and respected. His most serious self has been addressed.

Political effect: The conspiracy is now labelled, in Brutus's hearing, as honourable. From this moment the word will cling to it — through Cassius's later phrase to Casca about an enterprise "Of honourable-dangerous consequence", to Brutus's speeches in Act 3.

Important keywords: honour, "the name of honour", virtue, favour, indifferently, story.

Later consequence: Look hard at what Brutus actually said: he loves "The *name* of honour". Not honour alone — its name, its reputation. Cassius has just discovered that Brutus can be reached through what people say about him. The forged letters, "all tending to the great opinion / That Rome holds of his name", are the direct application of this discovery.

Stage 6 — Equality: "I was born free as Caesar"

What Cassius says: "I cannot tell what you and other men / Think of this life; but, for my single self, / I had as lief not be as live to be / In awe of such a thing as I myself. / I was born free as Caesar; so were you; / We both have fed as well, and we can both / Endure the winter's cold as well as he." ('I had as lief not be' means 'I would as soon not exist'.)

What Cassius means: 'I would rather die than stand in awe of a man who is no more than I am. Caesar was born free, exactly as we were; he eats the same food and feels the same cold. What is he that we should bow?'

What Cassius wants: To remove Caesar's halo by placing him in the plain category of 'a man like us', and to make continued submission feel like a personal humiliation for Brutus too — "so were you".

How Brutus receives it: In silence. Shakespeare gives him no line for over forty verses. Silence on stage is not absence: Brutus is listening, and the actor must show the words landing.

Rhetorical technique: Levelling by a triad of shared human facts: birth, food, cold. Cassius also speaks in the first person — "for my single self" — so that the idea arrives as personal conviction rather than as a demand on Brutus, which would provoke resistance.

Emotional effect: Shame. The word that does the work is awe ("In awe of such a thing as I myself"): awe is what one feels before a god, and to feel it before an equal is degrading.

Political effect: This is the aristocratic republican creed in miniature. Rome's nobles were meant to be equals in a shared enterprise; one man "grown so great" that others feel awe is, by definition, a violation of the republic. Cassius's motive here may be pride as much as principle, but the principle is real and Brutus shares it.

Important keywords: free, awe, "for my single self", lief, equality.

Later consequence: 'I would as soon not exist as live in awe' is the first sounding of a note that grows louder: in Act 1 Scene 3 Cassius will say "Cassius from bondage will deliver Cassius", meaning suicide, and at Philippi he acts on it, ordering his bondman Pindarus to kill him. The freedom he preaches is finally the freedom to die.

Stage 7 — The Tiber anecdote

What Cassius says: On "a raw and gusty day", with "The troubled Tiber chafing with her shores", Caesar challenged him: "Dar'st thou, Cassius, now / Leap in with me into this angry flood / And swim to yonder point?" Cassius leapt in "Accoutred as I was" (fully dressed, in his gear) "And bade him follow; so indeed he did." They fought the torrent "With lusty sinews", but "ere we could arrive the point proposed, / Caesar cried 'Help me, Cassius, or I sink!'" Cassius carried him out as "Aeneas, our great ancestor" carried "The old Anchises" from burning Troy. Then the turn: "And this man / Is now become a god, and Cassius is / A wretched creature and must bend his body / If Caesar carelessly but nod on him."

What Cassius means: 'The man you are all cheering could not finish a swim he himself proposed. I saved his life. And now I have to bow if he so much as glances at me.'

What Cassius wants: To replace the public image of Caesar — the triumphant general in the chariot — with a private image of Caesar helpless and crying for help; and to make the present order (Cassius bowing, Caesar nodding) look absurd.

How Brutus receives it: Still in silence. Notice that the story is not about Brutus at all. Cassius has drifted from his target to himself.

Rhetorical technique: The exemplum, or illustrative anecdote — the oldest tool in the orator's kit, because a story is remembered when an argument is forgotten. Inside it sits an epic simile: Cassius as Aeneas, founder-hero of Rome, and Caesar as Anchises, the aged father who must be carried. The simile is flattering to the speaker and quietly ageist about Caesar. The line ends on antithesis (the setting of opposites side by side for contrast): "Is now become a god" against "A wretched creature".

Emotional effect: Intended to arouse contempt for Caesar's frailty. But there is a second, unintended effect on an alert listener: Cassius's resentment is showing. The "wretched creature" who "must bend his body" is a man burning with humiliation.

Political effect: Cassius has attacked not Caesar's policies but his body. This becomes the play's quietest argument against the deification (treating as a god) of any man: gods do not sink.

Important keywords: Tiber, "angry flood", accoutred, "hearts of controversy" (spirits eager to contend), Aeneas, Anchises, "become a god", "bend his body".

Later consequence: HISTORICAL RECORD: the swimming race appears nowhere in Plutarch; scholars generally treat it as Shakespeare's invention. **LITERARY INTERPRETATION:** that choice matters. Shakespeare could have given Cassius a documented grievance; instead he gives him a story that reveals the storyteller's vanity as much as Caesar's weakness. When Caesar, minutes later, describes Cassius as a man never "at heart's ease / Whiles they behold a greater than themselves", we have just heard the proof.

Stage 8 — The fever: "this god did shake"

What Cassius says: "He had a fever when he was in Spain, / And when the fit was on him, I did mark / How he did shake. 'Tis true, this god did shake. / His coward lips did from their colour fly, / And that same eye whose bend doth awe the world / Did lose his lustre. I did hear him groan." Caesar's tongue, which "bade the Romans / Mark him and write his speeches in their books", cried "Give me some drink, Titinius" — "As a sick girl." Then the summing-up: "it doth amaze me / A man of such a feeble temper should / So get the start of the majestic world / And bear the palm alone." ('Fit' is seizure; 'bend' is glance; 'temper' is constitution; to 'get the start of' is to outstrip; the 'palm' is the victor's prize.)

What Cassius means: 'I watched this so-called god tremble, turn pale, groan and whimper for water like a sick little girl. How has such a weakling come to hold the whole world's prize by himself?'

What Cassius wants: To finish the demolition of Caesar's divinity begun in the Tiber, and to make Caesar's supremacy seem not merely unjust but unnatural — an inversion of the order in which the strong lead.

How Brutus receives it: Silence again, until the second shout.

Rhetorical technique: The body as argument. Each detail is physical — lips, eye, tongue, groan — and each is set against a claim of divinity. Look closely at "His coward lips did from their colour fly": the lips are cowards, and the blood leaving them is imagined as soldiers deserting their regimental colours. Caesar the general is betrayed by his own face. The simile "As a sick girl" is deliberate gender-shaming, and the mockery of a man who wanted Romans to "write his speeches in their books" turns Caesar's fame as a writer against him.

Emotional effect: Disgust and indignation. Brutus is meant to feel that awe of Caesar is a kind of category error.

Political effect: Cassius here fuses two ideas the play will keep apart and together: Caesar's physical frailty and Caesar's political monopoly. The republican objection is contained in the final word of "And bear the palm alone" — honour in Rome was meant to be shared among colleagues, not carried off by one man.

Important keywords: fever, fit, "this god did shake", "coward lips", colour, lustre, "As a sick girl", "feeble temper", "bear the palm alone".

Later consequence: HISTORICAL RECORD: Plutarch does say that Caesar suffered from epileptic seizures and that the illness first attacked him in Corduba, in Spain; Shakespeare's 'fever in Spain' has that seed, though making Cassius an eyewitness is the dramatist's addition. **SHAKESPEARE'S TEXT:** within minutes Casca will report that Caesar "swooned and fell down" in the marketplace and Brutus will diagnose "the falling sickness". Cassius's private story is publicly confirmed, which is why the audience leaves the scene half-believing him. The feminising of weakness also prepares his Act 1 Scene 3 taunt to Casca that Romans have become "womanish".

Stage 9 — The Colossus and "The fault, dear Brutus, is not in our stars"

What Cassius says: The second shout comes. Brutus: "Another general shout! / I do believe that these applauses are / For some new honours that are heaped on Caesar." Cassius: "Why, man, he doth bestride the narrow world / Like a Colossus, and we petty men / Walk under his huge legs and peep about / To find ourselves dishonourable graves. / Men at some time are masters of their fates. / The fault, dear Brutus, is not in our stars, / But in ourselves, that we are underlings."

What Cassius means: 'Caesar stands over the world like a giant statue while we scurry between his legs looking for somewhere shameful to die. There are moments when men can control their destiny. Our slavery is not fate's doing — it is our own fault for accepting it.'

What Cassius wants: To turn shame into responsibility. If servitude were fate, Brutus could sigh and accept it; if it is a fault "in ourselves", inaction becomes a moral failure — Brutus's failure.

How Brutus receives it: Silence still, but the maxim is aimed at exactly the kind of mind Brutus has — philosophical, self-examining, hard on itself.

Rhetorical technique: A hyperbolic (deliberately exaggerated) image followed by a sententia (a compact moral maxim). The picture of the Colossus reduces the Roman nobility to insects, and the phrase "dishonourable graves" tells Brutus that even his death will be shameful if he does nothing. Then the register (the level and tone of the language) changes completely: from grotesque image to calm philosophy, and to the intimate "dear Brutus". Cassius's rhythm — heat, then cool reason — is itself persuasive.

Emotional effect: Humiliation ("underlings" is a word for servants), then a bracing sense of agency: "masters of their fates".

Political effect: The argument has moved from 'Caesar is weak' to 'we are guilty'. This is a call to action disguised as a philosophical observation.

Important keywords: Colossus, "petty men", "dishonourable graves", "masters of their fates", stars (astrological destiny), underlings.

Later consequence: HISTORICAL RECORD: the historical Cassius was an Epicurean, a school that denied that gods or stars direct human affairs, and this speech is the purest Epicurean moment in the play. Yet the same Cassius in Act 1 Scene 3 will read the storm as a warning from heaven, and at Philippi (Act 5) he will confess that he has begun to credit omens. The line about our stars is therefore also a trap Shakespeare sets for its speaker: the man who denies fate is the one fate destroys.

HISTORICAL CONTEXT The Colossus of Rhodes

The Colossus was a gigantic bronze statue of the sun-god Helios at the harbour of Rhodes, built around 280 BC and counted among the Seven Wonders of the ancient world. The image of it straddling the harbour mouth, with ships sailing between its legs, is a medieval legend rather than ancient fact — but it is that legend Shakespeare's image relies on. For your purposes: the Colossus means overwhelming, monumental size, and the picture of men walking between its legs means the shrinking of everyone else.

Stage 10 — The weighing of names

What Cassius says: "'Brutus' and 'Caesar'—what should be in that 'Caesar'? / Why should that name be sounded more than yours? / Write them together, yours is as fair a name; / Sound them, it doth become the mouth as well; / Weigh them, it is as heavy; conjure with 'em, / 'Brutus' will start a spirit as soon as 'Caesar.'" Then: "Upon what meat doth this our Caesar feed / That he is grown so great? Age, thou art shamed! / Rome, thou hast lost the breed of noble bloods!" and the bitter pun, "Now is it Rome indeed, and room enough / When there is in it but one only man."

What Cassius means: 'Take the two names and test them any way you like — written, spoken, weighed, used in magic — and Brutus is the equal of Caesar. So what has Caesar been eating to grow so monstrously? This age is disgraced; Rome has run out of noble men. Rome is only *room* — empty space — when it holds just one man.'

What Cassius wants: To empty Caesar's name of its magic and fill Brutus's with equal power; to make Brutus feel that his own name is a public resource he is failing to use.

How Brutus receives it: Silence, but this is the passage that most directly flatters the thing Brutus has admitted he loves: "The name of honour" — his name.

Rhetorical technique: A run of imperatives — write, sound, weigh, conjure — as if conducting a scientific demonstration. Rhetorical questions ("what should be in that 'Caesar'?"). Apostrophe (direct address to an abstraction) in "Age, thou art shamed!" and "Rome, thou hast lost". The food image, "Upon what meat doth this our Caesar feed", picks up "We both have fed as well" and makes Caesar's greatness look like an unnatural, monstrous growth — an idea Cassius will repeat in Act 1 Scene 3 with "prodigious grown". And a pun: in Elizabethan pronunciation *Rome* and *room* sounded alike.

Emotional effect: Pride. Brutus is told that his name can "start a spirit" — raise a ghost — as readily as Caesar's. Nothing in the scene is more seductive to a man who loves the name of honour.

Political effect: Cassius delegitimises Caesar's authority by treating it as a mere sound. If the name is empty, the power that rests on it is an illusion that only lasts as long as men consent to be awed.

Important keywords: name, sound, weigh, conjure, "start a spirit", meat, "grown so great", "breed of noble bloods", Rome/room.

Later consequence: This is the argument the play most cruelly overturns. After the Ides, Caesar's name proves mightier dead than alive: Antony conjures with it before the crowd, Caesar's spirit walks at Sardis and Philippi, and Brutus, dying, still speaks to Caesar. Cassius said the name was empty; the last two acts show that it was not.

Stage 11 — The ancestor: "There was a Brutus once"

What Cassius says: "O, you and I have heard our fathers say / There was a Brutus once that would have brooked / Th' eternal devil to keep his state in Rome / As easily as a king." ('Brooked' is tolerated; to 'keep his state' is to hold court like a monarch.)

What Cassius means: 'Your ancestor would as soon have let the devil himself rule Rome as let a king. What would he say of you?'

What Cassius wants: To make the case personal in the deepest possible way: not 'Rome needs a hero' but 'your blood obliges you'. Refusal is now not caution but a betrayal of the family name.

How Brutus receives it: This finally draws him out, and his reply is remarkable for its self-awareness: "That you do love me, I am nothing jealous. / What you would work me to, I have some aim." ('Nothing jealous' is 'not at all doubtful'; 'aim' is a guess.) He knows he is being worked on. He asks for time — "What you have said / I will consider" — and then gives Cassius more than he asked for: "Brutus had rather be a villager / Than to repute himself a son of Rome / Under these hard conditions as this time / Is like to lay upon us." ('Repute himself' is 'consider himself'.)

Rhetorical technique: Appeal to lineage, using a historical exemplum. The hyperbole "Th' eternal devil" is an anachronism — the Christian devil in pagan Rome — but Shakespeare's audience would have felt its force: even Satan would be preferable to a king. The framing "you and I have heard our fathers say" makes the memory shared, so that Cassius seems to be reminding, not preaching.

Emotional effect: Brutus is made to stand in his ancestor's shadow. His answer — he would rather be a nobody from the countryside than a Roman under a king — shows how completely the appeal has landed, even as he insists on thinking further.

Political effect: The conspiracy acquires its founding legend. The republic began when a Brutus expelled a king; it can be saved when a Brutus stops one.

Important keywords: ancestor, brooked, "keep his state", "eternal devil", villager, "son of Rome", "work me to", aim.

Later consequence: HISTORICAL RECORD: Lucius Junius Brutus led the expulsion of Tarquin the Proud in 509 BC, and Marcus Brutus claimed descent from him; Plutarch records that anonymous messages — 'Brutus, art thou asleep?', 'Thou art not really Brutus' — were left on his praetor's tribunal (the raised platform from which he gave judgement). **SHAKESPEARE'S TEXT:** Cassius will convert those messages into letters, one of which Cinna is to fix "Upon old Brutus' statue". The ancestor is not a passing flourish; it is the target Cassius keeps aiming at.

Stage 12 — The retreat: "my weak words"

What Cassius says: "I am glad that my weak words / Have struck but thus much show of fire from Brutus." Caesar's train returns; Cassius quietly hands over the next task: "pluck Casca by the sleeve, / And he will, after his sour fashion, tell you / What hath proceeded worthy note today." After Casca's report, it is Brutus who proposes the next meeting: "Tomorrow, if you please to speak with me, / I will come home to you; or, if you will, / Come home to me, and I will wait for you." Cassius accepts with a parting shot: "I will do so. Till then, think of the world."

What Cassius means: 'I have said little, and clumsily, and yet look how much fire it has struck from you — so the fire was already in you.' And at parting: 'Think about the state of things.'

What Cassius wants: To stop while ahead. Having drawn Brutus's declaration, he must not push into a refusal. He also wants Brutus to feel that any spark of rebellion is Brutus's own.

How Brutus receives it: The target now pursues the persuader. Brutus, who tried to leave at the start, is the one arranging the next conversation and offering to wait for Cassius at his house.

Rhetorical technique: False modesty — the old orator's trick of calling one's words weak so that the listener credits the ideas to himself. The image is flint and steel: "struck" fire from Brutus, whose "honourable mettle" (spirit, punning on metal) Cassius will name in the soliloquy. Then a deliberately vague parting line, "think of the world", which plants without pressing.

Emotional effect: Relief and respect. Brutus is not being hustled. He has been treated as the senior partner whose judgement is awaited.

Political effect: A second meeting is fixed and the recruit has volunteered for it. The conspiracy now has a calendar.

Important keywords: "weak words", fire, struck, "sour fashion", "think of the world".

Later consequence: The meeting takes place in Act 2, when the conspirators come to Brutus's house before dawn — and by then Cassius's letters have done their work, so that Brutus greets them already decided. Everything about this scene's ending is engineered to make that later scene possible.

Stage 13 — The soliloquy

What Cassius says: Alone: "Well, Brutus, thou art noble. Yet I see / Thy honourable mettle may be wrought / From that it is disposed. Therefore it is meet / That noble minds keep ever with their likes; / For who so firm that cannot be seduced? / Caesar doth bear me hard, but he loves Brutus. / If I were Brutus now, and he were Cassius, / He should not humour me." Then the plan: "I will this night / In several hands in at his windows throw, / As if they came from several citizens, / Writings, all tending to the great opinion / That Rome holds of his name, wherein obscurely / Caesar's ambition shall be glanced at." And the couplet: "And after this, let Caesar seat him sure, / For we will shake him, or worse days endure."

What Cassius means: 'Brutus is noble, but his noble nature can be worked away from its natural bent, the way metal is worked. Noble men should keep to their own kind — because anyone can be seduced. Caesar dislikes me but loves Brutus. Tonight I will throw letters through his windows in different handwritings, as if from many citizens, all about how highly Rome regards him, and hinting indirectly at Caesar's ambition. Let Caesar make himself secure — we will shake him, or suffer worse.'

What Cassius wants: Now the honest answer: Brutus, by any means. Where Rome's voice does not exist, Cassius will manufacture it.

How Brutus receives it: He is not there — that is the point. This is the one moment in the scene when we hear Cassius unperformed.

Rhetorical technique: The soliloquy convention: alone on stage, a character tells the audience the truth. Cassius speaks in maxims ("who so firm that cannot be seduced?") and in a plan, and he closes on a rhyming couplet whose verb — 'shake' — echoes his own "this god did shake". The letters use indirection ("obscurely", "glanced at"): a hint works on a proud man where a demand would fail.

Emotional effect: On the audience, a complicated one: admiration for the skill, unease at the cynicism, and a new pity for Brutus, who has just walked off thinking himself the wiser man.

Political effect: The conspiracy that will call itself honourable is founded, at this instant, on forgery. Public opinion — the force that will decide everything in Act 3 — is here first faked.

Important keywords: mettle, wrought, disposed, meet, "keep ever with their likes", seduced, "bear me hard" (bear a grudge against), humour, "several hands", "great opinion", obscurely, glanced at.

Later consequence: In Act 1 Scene 3 Cassius hands the letters to Cinna with precise instructions; in Act 2 Brutus reads one and completes its hints himself. And the whole play is shaped by what Cassius says here about noble minds keeping "with their likes": he knows that Brutus's nobility is a different substance from his own, and the Act 4 quarrel is the sound of those two metals grinding.

TEXT NOTE A genuine crux: "He should not humour me"

Editors disagree about who 'he' is in "If I were Brutus now, and he were Cassius, / He should not humour me." Reading one: 'if I were in Brutus's place, loved by Caesar, Caesar's affection would not win me over' — 'he' is Caesar, and 'humour' means to indulge or please into compliance. Reading two: 'if our positions were swapped, Cassius would not be able to work on me as I am working on Brutus' — 'he' is the imagined Cassius. The first is the more common; the second makes Cassius admit that Brutus is easier to lead than he is. Both are defensible. In an answer, you may say 'the line is ambiguous, but on either reading Cassius is confessing that Brutus is being led'.

LEVEL 3 — Why did Shakespeare write it this way?

Shakespeare had a simpler option: Plutarch's anonymous messages could have done the recruiting, and Brutus could have agonised alone. Instead he stages a two-hander of some hundred and fifty lines in which one man works on another. Three reasons. First, drama needs pressure between people, and this scene lets us watch pressure being applied and absorbed, with the offstage shouts as a pulse. Second, by giving Cassius stories (the Tiber, the fever) rather than charges, Shakespeare makes the case against Caesar personal and uncheckable — which is exactly how real political persuasion works. Third, by ending with the soliloquy, he refuses to let the audience be seduced along with Brutus. We are made wiser than the tragic hero at the very moment he thinks himself wisest. That gap between what Brutus knows and what we know is where the tragedy lives.

PROFESSOR'S INSIGHT

Why Cassius's honesty about his own dishonesty is dramatically brilliant

A lesser playwright would have kept Cassius's cynicism hidden, or revealed it late as a twist. Shakespeare reveals it at once, and the effect is far richer. First, it splits our response: we have just admired a superb performance, and now we are shown the performer counting the take. Admiration and distrust must live in us together, and that is what makes Cassius a character rather than a villain. Second, it makes Brutus's tragedy visible from the start. He leaves believing he has been asked, honourably, to reflect; we know he is about to be flooded with counterfeit letters. Every later scene in which Brutus insists on the conspiracy's purity is shadowed by our knowledge of how it began. Third — and this is the point most school notes miss — the soliloquy does not make Cassius's arguments false. Caesar *did* fall down in the marketplace; the Republic *was* in danger. Shakespeare separates the truth of a case from the honesty of the man who makes it, and leaves the audience holding both. Finally, the confession is itself a clue to Cassius's motives: the one grievance he names when no one is listening is not liberty but "Caesar doth bear me hard". Alone, he speaks of himself.

Cassius's toolkit: the techniques, named and analysed

The stages showed you the sequence. Now separate the tools, because an examiner's question — 'How does Cassius persuade Brutus?' — is asking you to name techniques and show them working. Each entry below gives a definition you can reuse, the best textual evidence, and one observation that lifts your answer above a list.

Flattery

Flattery is praise offered to gain influence. Cassius's is of a superior kind: he never praises Brutus directly for long, because Brutus would recoil. Instead he *reports* praise — "many of the best respect in Rome" wish "that noble Brutus had his eyes" — and offers to be the 'glass' in which Brutus can see his own "hidden worthiness". The flattery is attributed to others and framed as a service. Observation: the one time Cassius praises Brutus sincerely is when Brutus cannot hear it — "Well, Brutus, thou art noble" — and even that is the prelude to planning his corruption.

Comparison

Comparison sets two things side by side so that one is diminished. Cassius compares Caesar to himself (the swimmer who sank against the swimmer who saved him), Caesar to Brutus (the two names written, sounded and weighed), Caesar to a god he plainly is not ("this god did shake"), and Caesar to a Colossus beside "petty men". Observation: notice that every comparison has the same hidden premise — that Caesar and other nobles are *the same kind of thing*, so that any elevation of him is theft from them. That premise is the aristocratic republican creed, and it is also the voice of a man who cannot bear to be second.

Anecdote

An anecdote is a short story told to prove a point. Cassius's two — the Tiber and the fever — do what no argument could: they let Brutus *see* Caesar helpless. Their power is also their weakness. Both rest on Cassius's word; both cast Cassius as the strong man and Caesar as the weakling; and neither is told by Plutarch in this form — the Tiber race is absent from the ancient sources altogether, and the fever, though Plutarch places Caesar's first seizure in Spain, acquires its eyewitness only in Shakespeare — which suggests the dramatist wanted us to sense the teller shaping the tale. Observation: an anecdote is a form of selective truth. Even if every word were accurate, choosing to remember Caesar sinking rather than Caesar conquering Gaul is a choice about what Brutus should picture.

Rhetorical questions

A rhetorical question is asked not for an answer but to make the hearer supply one. "Tell me, good Brutus, can you see your face?" opens the mirror; "Ay, do you fear it?" traps Brutus into a stance; "what should be in that 'Caesar'? / Why should that name be sounded more than yours?" invite Brutus to answer 'nothing' and 'it should not'; "Upon what meat doth this our Caesar feed?" makes greatness sound like gluttony. Observation: the questions cluster where Cassius wants Brutus to feel he has *reached* a conclusion rather than been given one. A conclusion you think you reached yourself is one you defend.

Appeals to honour

Honour, for a Roman noble, meant public recognition of virtue. Cassius does not argue that resisting Caesar is honourable; he simply announces "honour is the subject of my story" the moment Brutus names honour as his price, then fills the story with things Brutus will find dishonourable — awe of an equal, "dishonourable graves", being "underlings". Observation: Cassius's appeal is to honour as *reputation*, which is what Brutus confessed to loving ("The name of honour"). Brutus's own idea of honour is more inward — conscience, consistency, the "general good". The gap between these two honours is invisible in Act 1 and enormous by Act 4.

Appeals to Roman liberty

Liberty (Latin *libertas*) was the Republic's founding value: no Roman should be subject to another Roman's will. Cassius invokes it as "I was born free as Caesar", as "this age's yoke", and through the ancestor who would not tolerate a king. Observation: Cassius's liberty is aristocratic. It is the freedom of noblemen not to bow, not the freedom of the crowd, whom he despises as "the rout". When Brutus later speaks of liberty, he means something closer to the freedom of all Rome. Same word, different content — and the conspiracy never notices.

Appeals to Brutus's reputation and ancestry

These are the most personal weapons in the scene, and Cassius saves them for late. Reputation: "the great opinion / That Rome holds of his name" is, by his own admission, the lever of the forged letters. Ancestry: "There was a Brutus once". Observation: both appeals work by making Brutus answerable to people who are not present — dead ancestors and imagined citizens — so that the actual man present, Cassius, seems merely to be their messenger. That is why Brutus never treats Cassius as the source of pressure: the pressure appears to come from Rome and from his own blood.

Caesar's weaknesses — the body as argument

Cassius's most original tactic is to argue against Caesar's *body*: the near-drowning, the shaking, the pale "coward lips", the groan, the cry for drink "As a sick girl". This works because the case for Caesar's supremacy rests on his being more than a man — "immortal Caesar", "this god". Every physical failure is a refutation. Observation: Shakespeare confirms and complicates the tactic within the same scene. Casca reports the swoon in the marketplace; Caesar himself mentions his deaf ear. The body really is weak. But the play's later acts insist that Caesar's *spirit* is the thing that matters, and against a spirit Cassius's argument has no purchase.

Shared Roman identity — "We both have fed as well"

Cassius keeps constructing a 'we' — "so were you", "We both have fed as well", "you and I have heard our fathers say", "we petty men", "we are underlings". Shared identity is the soil in which persuasion grows: one accepts from a fellow what one would reject from a stranger. Observation: the 'we' shifts its meaning as the scene goes on. At first it is 'we two friends'; then 'we equals of Caesar'; then 'we shamed Romans'; and finally, in the soliloquy, the 'we' of the couplet — "we will shake him" — is the conspiracy, which Brutus has not yet joined. Cassius has been speaking for a group all along and only reveals it when alone.

Forged letters — the Scene 2 soliloquy and the Scene 3 instructions

In Scene 2 the plan is stated: letters "In several hands" (different handwritings) "As if they came from several citizens", praising Brutus and hinting "obscurely" at Caesar's ambition. In Scene 3 it is executed with care: Cinna is to "lay it in the Praetor's chair, / Where Brutus may but find it", to "throw this / In at his window", and to "set this up with wax / Upon old Brutus' statue". Each placement is chosen for meaning — the chair of Brutus's office, the privacy of his house, the statue of his ancestor — so that Rome seems to speak from every direction. Observation: the letters are the mirror stage made literal. In Scene 2 Cassius claimed to be a glass reflecting Rome's opinion; in Scene 3 he manufactures the reflections. Note the moral cost he accepts without a flicker: a conspiracy 'for honour' begins in fraud.

Selective truth — what Cassius leaves out

Selective truth is the use of accurate facts arranged to mislead by omission. Consider what Brutus never hears in this scene. That Cassius fought against Caesar in the civil war and was pardoned by him (**HISTORICAL RECORD**: Cassius commanded Pompey's fleet, was forgiven after Pharsalus and made praetor by Caesar in 44 BC — as was Brutus). That Caesar's clemency (his mercy to defeated enemies) was itself famous. That Caesar's public conduct can be read in his favour — as Casca is about to report, Caesar has been refusing a crown while they talk, and when the report comes Cassius instantly turns the refusal into another charge, "we have the falling sickness". That a conspiracy already exists and men are waiting at "Pompey's Porch". That the 'voice of Rome' is about to be forged. Observation: so far as we can tell, Cassius tells Brutus no outright lie in Scene 2. He simply arranges true and half-true things so that only one conclusion is visible, and saves the outright fraud for paper.

Emotional manipulation

All of the above are forms of it, but it is worth naming the emotional sequence as such, because it is the real architecture of the scene: guilt (the neglected friend) → curiosity (the buried thoughts) → reassurance (the disclaimer) → anxiety (the shouts) → pride (honour, the names) → contempt (Caesar's body) → shame (underlings) → obligation (the ancestor) → relief (the retreat). Each emotion opens the door for the next. Observation: nowhere does Cassius ask Brutus to *decide*. He works only on feeling and identity and leaves the decision to Brutus's own reasoning — which is why Brutus will always believe the decision was his.

PROFESSOR'S INSIGHT Persuading and seducing: "who so firm that cannot be seduced?"

Persuasion, in the classical sense, addresses the reason: it offers grounds and invites judgement. Seduction addresses desire and self-image: it offers a flattering picture of who you are and lets the picture do the reasoning. Cassius uses the second word of himself, and the choice is exact. Look back at the thirteen stages and ask a simple question: at what point does Cassius give Brutus a *reason* to believe Caesar is a tyrant? He never does. No law broken, no citizen wronged, no office abolished. What Brutus receives instead is a series of pictures — Brutus admired, Brutus's name weighed equal, Caesar sinking, Caesar shaking, the ancestor watching — and a series of feelings attached to them. The word 'firm' matters too. Brutus's firmness — his constancy, his refusal to be moved by pressure — is his chief virtue, the thing the whole play admires in him. Cassius regards it as a lock to be picked. That is what seduction does: it treats a person's best quality as an obstacle. And here is the cruel joke of the line: Cassius's question assumes that *no one* is beyond seduction, himself included. He may be right about himself too: in Act 1 Scene 3 the sceptic either exploits a storm he does not believe in or is half-seduced by it — the section on his motives below weighs the two readings.

Second case study: the recruitment of Casca (Act 1 Scene 3)

A month has passed (Cicero asks whether Caesar comes to the Capitol "tomorrow" — the Ides, the 15th of March). It is night — "it is after midnight", Cassius will say before the two men leave — in a storm that drops fire. Shakespeare has just let Cicero say what may be the wisest thing in the play about omens — "men may construe things after their fashion, / Clean from the purpose of the things themselves" — and then sends Cicero home. What follows is a live demonstration of his warning: Cassius construing the heavens to his own purpose. Watch how completely his method changes when the material changes.

Move one: the omen reinterpreted

Casca is terrified. He has his sword out; he has seen a slave's hand burn unharmed, a lion by the Capitol, women who swore they saw men on fire, an owl at noon. He believes "there is a civil strife in heaven" or that the world, "too saucy with the gods", has provoked them. Cassius enters, calls out "Who's there?", and gets the answer "A Roman" — Casca's fear has made him cling to his identity, and Cassius will use it. Then the first stroke: "A very pleasing night to honest men." Casca: "Who ever knew the heavens menace so?" Cassius: "Those that have known the Earth so full of faults." In two lines the storm has been turned from a threat into a verdict — heaven's anger at wrongdoing on earth.

Cassius then performs his own fearlessness: he has walked the streets "unbracèd" (doublet unfastened), "bared my bosom to the thunder-stone", and stood "Even in the aim and very flash of it". This is theatre, and it is meant to be; a frightened man is shamed by a fearless one. When Casca protests that "It is the part of men to fear and tremble" before the gods' "tokens", Cassius attacks: "You are dull, Casca, and those sparks of life / That should be in a Roman you do want" ('want' is lack). Then the reinterpretation proper: the prodigies

(unnatural wonders, taken as warnings) are "instruments of fear and warning / Unto some monstrous state" — where 'state' means both 'condition' and 'government'. The omens are not about the gods; they are about Caesar. Cassius clinches it with a riddle: a man "Most like this dreadful night", who "thunders, lightens, opens graves, and roars", yet is "no mightier than thyself or me / In personal action" — "prodigious grown". Casca names the answer: "'Tis Caesar that you mean, is it not, Cassius?" And Cassius, exactly as with Brutus, lets the target supply the conclusion, adding a layer of deniability: "Let it be who it is."

Move two: the manliness taunt

"For Romans now / Have thews and limbs like to their ancestors. / But, woe the while, our fathers' minds are dead, / And we are governed with our mothers' spirits. / Our yoke and sufferance show us womanish." ('Thews' are muscles; 'sufferance' is patient endurance.) The ancestor argument returns, but where Brutus received a named forefather, Casca gets a collective shaming: Roman bodies are as strong as ever, Roman spirit has turned female. **LITERARY INTERPRETATION:** this is the crudest instrument in Cassius's kit, and he does not use it on Brutus. He judges, rightly, that Casca — 'blunt', in Brutus's word, and 'sour', in Cassius's own — can be moved by an insult to his manhood where Brutus would have been repelled. Casca's response shows the taunt working: he volunteers intelligence, that the senators "Mean to establish Caesar as a king" tomorrow. The recruit is now contributing.

Move three: the suicide-as-freedom speech

"I know where I will wear this dagger then; / Cassius from bondage will deliver Cassius." Notice the third-person self-naming: Cassius speaking of Cassius as if of a hero in a history. The gods, he says, "make the weak most strong" and "you tyrants do defeat" through this one power. Then the catalogue, driven by the repeated 'nor': "Nor stony tower, nor walls of beaten brass, / Nor airless dungeon, nor strong links of iron, / Can be retentive to the strength of spirit; / But life, being weary of these worldly bars, / Never lacks power to dismiss itself." ('Retentive' means able to hold in.) The idea — that the free man always holds the exit of death — was a Roman commonplace, and Cassius states it magnificently. Its function here is tactical: it sets a standard of fearlessness that Casca must match or be shamed. Casca matches it at once: "So can I. / So every bondman in his own hand bears / The power to cancel his captivity." Watch the follower echo the leader's rhythm and image — the surest sign that recruitment is working.

Cassius then converts the philosophy into politics: "And why should Caesar be a tyrant, then?" If death is always available, servitude is chosen; therefore Caesar is a tyrant only because Romans allow it — "he would not be a wolf / But that he sees the Romans are but sheep; / He were no lion, were not Romans hinds." ('Hinds' are female deer, and also servants.) This is the Brutus argument again — "The fault... is not in our stars, / But in ourselves" — in animal fur. He goes further, into contempt: Romans are "weak straws" for Caesar's fire, 'trash', "rubbish", 'offal' (butcher's waste), the "base matter" that makes "So vile a thing as Caesar" shine. Fire imagery links Caesar to the tempest "dropping fire": the man is the storm.

Move four: the risk test — "Before a willing bondman"

Here is the most cunning moment in the scene. Cassius pretends to catch himself: "But, O grief, / Where hast thou led me? I perhaps speak this / Before a willing bondman; then, I know / My answer must be made. But I am armed, / And dangers are to me indifferent." ('My answer must be made' means 'I shall have to answer for it'.) The feigned slip does three things at once. It flatters Casca by suggesting Cassius was carried away by grief in his presence. It challenges him: are you a willing slave who will report me? And it displays Cassius's own readiness to die — "I am armed" — as the price of speaking freely. Casca has no honourable option but to prove he is not that man, and does: "You speak to Casca, and to such a man / That is no fleering telltale." ('Fleering' is sneering, grinning falsely.) The test was rigged, and Casca passes it gratefully.

Move five: the handshake bargain

"Hold. My hand. / Be factious for redress of all these griefs, / And I will set this foot of mine as far / As who goes farthest." ('Factious' means active in forming a faction; 'redress' is remedy.) Cassius: "There's a bargain made." Weigh that word. Not 'oath', not 'faith' — a *bargain*, the language of the market. Only now, with the hand in his, does Cassius reveal what he withheld throughout: that a conspiracy already exists, that he has "moved already / Some certain of the noblest-minded Romans" to "an enterprise / Of honourable-dangerous consequence", and that they wait at "Pompey's Porch". Sequence is everything: information is released after commitment, never before. And in a final flourish he takes the very storm Casca feared and makes it the badge of the deed: "the complexion of the element" is "like the work we have in hand, / Most bloody, fiery, and most terrible." The omen he mocked ten minutes earlier is now his banner.

HOW CASSIUS WORKS ON BRUTUS vs ON CASCA

Dimension	On Brutus (Act 1 Scene 2)	On Casca (Act 1 Scene 3)
Setting he exploits	Daylight festival; offstage cheering for Caesar	Midnight storm; terrifying prodigies
Opening move	A hurt friend's reproach	A paradox: a "pleasing night to honest men"
His self-presentation	Modest "glass"; "my weak words"	Fearless hero who "bared my bosom to the thunder-stone"
Main emotional lever	Honour, reputation, ancestry, pride in a name	Fear, shame, manliness ("womanish")
Tone	Patient, gentle, indirect	Blunt, insulting ("You are dull, Casca")
How Caesar is attacked	Openly, through stories of his weak body	By riddle; Casca must name him
Handling of doubt	Reassurance (the disclaimer)	Challenge (the "willing bondman" test)
What he withholds	The existing conspiracy and the letters	The conspiracy — until the handshake
Result	"What you have said / I will consider"; a meeting fixed	"Hold. My hand." — immediate commitment
Why it fits the man	A philosopher must feel the decision is his own	A soldier answers to dare and shame

The lesson for your analysis is this: Cassius has no single 'method'. He reads each man and fits the instrument to the material — which is precisely what Caesar means when he says Cassius "looks / Quite through the deeds of men". The one constant is that Cassius never lets the target hear the whole truth until the target has committed.

PROFESSOR'S INSIGHT Why Cassius needs Brutus: Casca's "alchemy" speech

When Cassius says the conspirators will "See Brutus at his house" before dawn, because "Three parts of him / Is ours already", Casca explains the arithmetic: "O, he sits high in all the people's hearts, / And that which would appear offence in us / His countenance, like richest alchemy, / Will change to virtue and to worthiness." Alchemy was the dream of turning base metal into gold. Casca's image is exact and damning: without Brutus the deed is base metal — a murder by resentful men; with Brutus's face on it, the same deed becomes gold. Cassius accepts the analysis without a blush: "Him and his worth and our great need of him / You have right well conceited" ('conceited' means understood). This is political pragmatism in its purest form. Cassius knows what he looks like — Caesar has already called him "lean and hungry" — and knows a conspiracy of Cassiuses would be seen as what it partly is. Note how Cassius thinks of Brutus in fractions and possessives: "Three parts", "ours", "be sure of him". Brutus is an asset to be secured. Note, too, the pun that runs through Act 1: Brutus's "honourable mettle", "wrought" by Cassius, is now to be the alchemist's gold. And note the tragic irony the play will unfold: the gold comes with Brutus's judgement attached — his refusal to kill Antony, his permission for Antony to speak — and it is Brutus's virtue, not Cassius's cunning, that finally destroys the conspiracy. They needed his face; they got his conscience too.

CASSIUS'S STATED MOTIVES vs CASSIUS'S POSSIBLE PERSONAL MOTIVES

Here is the question that separates a competent answer from an excellent one: *why* does Cassius do all this? The weak answer has a one-word reply — jealousy — and treats the whole seduction of Brutus as a cover story. The strong answer notices that Shakespeare has made the question genuinely hard, and shows the examiner that it is hard. You need two columns in your head: what Cassius says he wants, when other people are listening, and what the text *lets slip* about what he wants when they are not. Then you need the honesty to admit that the two columns may both be true at once.

What Cassius says he wants: the stated case

Everything Cassius says in public is organised around one word, liberty, and its Roman meaning: that no Roman noble should live subject to another man's will. "I was born free as Caesar" is its first statement; "groaning underneath this age's yoke" its image of the present; "Cassius from bondage will deliver Cassius" its last, desperate form. Beside liberty stands equality among the nobility — the whole point of the weighed names, and of the lament "Rome, thou hast lost the breed of noble bloods!" when Rome contains "but one only man". Beside equality stands the founding legend: "There was a Brutus once" who would not tolerate a king. And over all of it Cassius lays the word he borrowed from Brutus: "honour is the subject of my story", an enterprise "Of honourable-dangerous consequence".

Do not make the mistake of treating this case as a mere disguise. **SHAKESPEARE'S TEXT** gives the same creed, in Act 1 Scene 1, to Flavius, who has no personal quarrel with Caesar at all and fears a man who would "soar above the view of men / And keep us all in servile fearfulness". **HISTORICAL RECORD:** the hatred of the title of king, and the conviction that a perpetual dictatorship was a violation of the Republic, were real and widespread among Romans of Cassius's class. The play's later acts, which are outside this chapter, go on to show Caesar behaving in ways that partly confirm the danger. So the first reading must be allowed its full weight: Cassius may be a sincere republican whose analysis is correct.

What the text lets slip: the personal evidence

Now read the same scenes for what Cassius reveals without intending to.

The soliloquy names only a personal grievance. Alone, with every reason to remind himself of Rome's liberty, Cassius says "Caesar doth bear me hard, but he loves Brutus." That is the sum of his private case against Caesar in the scene's one moment of truth: Caesar dislikes *me*.

The stories are about Cassius. The Tiber anecdote exists to show Caesar sinking, but its emotional centre is the speaker: "Cassius is / A wretched creature and must bend his body / If Caesar carelessly but nod on him." Weigh "carelessly". What burns is not tyranny but neglect — that Caesar barely notices the man he once begged for help. Both anecdotes make Cassius the stronger man and Caesar the weakling, which is a strange shape for a political argument and a natural shape for a wounded ego.

The sting is in being second to an equal. "I had as lief not be as live to be / In awe of such a thing as I myself." Not 'in awe of a tyrant' but of 'such a thing as I myself' — a man of the same kind. And the climax of the fever speech is "bear the palm alone": the offence is that the prize is not shared, which is a grievance only a competitor feels.

Caesar's diagnosis. Within minutes, Caesar will describe men like Cassius as "never at heart's ease / Whiles they behold a greater than themselves" — placed, as the portrait section below shows, while the Tiber and the fever are still fresh in our ears.

Contempt for the people. Cassius's liberty is not everyone's liberty. He calls the crowd "the rout", and tells Casca that Romans are "sheep", "hinds", "weak straws", "rubbish". A man who despises the people he claims to be freeing may still be sincere about freedom, but his freedom is the freedom of his own class not to bow.

The range of readings

LITERARY INTERPRETATION — scholars and directors genuinely divide here, and your answer may choose any reading provided it argues from the text.

Reading of Cassius	Strongest evidence	What it explains	What it struggles with
The principled republican: an ideological motive	"I was born free as Caesar"; the ancestor; the willingness to die rather than bow	Why Brutus, Casca and Cinna respect him; why his arguments contain truth; why he can be so brave in the storm	Why, alone, he names only "Caesar doth bear me hard"; why his stories are about himself
The envious rival: a personal motive	"bear me hard"; "bear the palm alone"; Caesar's portrait of a man never at ease before "a greater"	The heat of the anecdotes; the readiness to forge letters; the hunger imagery	His genuine courage, and the fact that the play confirms Caesar's ambition
The wounded pride of a former equal	"such a thing as I myself"; "now become a god"; "carelessly but nod on him"	The obsession with Caesar's body — a former comrade remembers him as flesh	It makes Cassius a case study in humiliation rather than a political actor
Principle energised by envy (a widely held reading)	All of the above, read together	Why the arguments are true <i>and</i> the arguer untrustworthy; why Shakespeare gives us the soliloquy	Students must resist collapsing it back into 'he is just jealous'

Two further complications deserve their own paragraph.

The Epicurean who uses omens. HISTORICAL RECORD: Cassius followed the Epicurean school, which held that gods do not meddle in human affairs and that portents mean nothing. **SHAKESPEARE'S TEXT:** in Scene 2 he speaks like a perfect Epicurean — "The fault, dear Brutus, is not in our stars, / But in ourselves". In

Scene 3, a month later, he tells Casca that heaven has made the prodigies "instruments of fear and warning / Unto some monstrous state", and that the storm's "complexion" is "like the work we have in hand".

LITERARY INTERPRETATION: there are two ways to read the reversal. Either Cassius is a cynic who will use any instrument, including a theology he does not believe, to move a frightened man — which fits Cicero's warning that "men may construe things after their fashion" — or Cassius is himself unsettled, and the sceptic is being drawn, against his philosophy, into the storm's meaning. The play does not settle it in Act 1; it returns to the question at Philippi, where Cassius admits that his opinion of omens has changed. For your purposes, the safe formulation is: 'in Scene 3 Cassius either exploits the omens he does not believe in, or begins to believe them; both readings expose a gap between his philosophy and his practice.'

The thing he never mentions. HISTORICAL RECORD: Cassius fought on Pompey's side in the civil war, commanding part of the Pompeian fleet, and after Pharsalus Caesar pardoned him and later made him praetor for 44 BC — while giving Brutus the more prestigious urban praetorship, which ancient writers treat as a grievance of Cassius's. **SHAKESPEARE'S TEXT** never lets Cassius speak of the pardon. **LITERARY INTERPRETATION:** that silence may be Shakespeare streamlining his source, or it may be characterisation — the omission a resentful man would make. Either way, it is why 'selective truth' is the right technical phrase for his method, and why you should never write 'Cassius is evil'. Shakespeare gives a questionable motive to a man whose political analysis the play half-endorses, and leaves you to hold both.

HISTORICAL CONTEXT Plutarch's lean men and the historical Cassius

Plutarch, in the Life of Caesar that Shakespeare read in Sir Thomas North's 1579 translation, records Caesar saying that he did not fear fat, long-haired men but the pale, thin ones — meaning Brutus and Cassius. Shakespeare keeps the thought and gives it entirely to Cassius, so that the 'lean' man becomes one character and Brutus is spared the suspicion. The historical Gaius Cassius Longinus was a capable soldier: quaestor (a junior magistrate in charge of finances) under Crassus, he survived the disaster at Carrhae in 53 BC and defended Syria. He was tribune in 49 BC, commanded a Pompeian fleet, was pardoned by Caesar and became praetor in 44 BC. He was an Epicurean, and he was Brutus's brother-in-law, married to Brutus's sister Junia Tertia — a kinship the play makes nothing of in Act 1, where the two men are presented simply as friends. He died by suicide at Philippi in October 42 BC. Hold these facts loosely in an answer: they explain why Shakespeare *could* make Cassius both a genuine republican and a man with private scores to settle, but the play, not Plutarch, is your evidence.

Caesar's portrait of Cassius: an ironically accurate character sketch

Shakespeare does something unusual in the middle of Act 1 Scene 2. Having let us watch Cassius work on Brutus at length, he brings Caesar back on stage and has him describe Cassius — a man he has not just been listening to — with a precision that makes the audience catch its breath. Read the whole sketch first.

Caesar: *Let me have men about me that are fat, / Sleek-headed men, and such as sleep a-nights. / Yond Cassius has a lean and hungry look. / He thinks too much. Such men are dangerous.*

Antony brushes it aside — "Fear him not, Caesar; he's not dangerous. / He is a noble Roman, and well given" ('well given' is well disposed) — and Caesar presses on:

Caesar: *He reads much, / He is a great observer, and he looks / Quite through the deeds of men. He loves no plays, / As thou dost, Antony; he hears no music; / Seldom he smiles, and smiles in such a sort / As if he mocked himself and scorned his spirit / That could be moved to smile at anything. / Such men as he be never at heart's ease / Whiles they behold a greater than themselves, / And therefore are they very dangerous.*

Testing the portrait against what we have seen

Take the sketch clause by clause and set each against the evidence Act 1 has already given you. This is exactly the kind of cross-checking an examiner rewards, because it shows you reading the play as a whole rather than scene by scene.

Caesar's phrase	What it claims	Where Act 1 has already shown it
"a lean and hungry look"	A man starved of something he wants	Cassius's own imagery is of feeding and appetite: "We both have fed as well"; "Upon what meat doth this our Caesar feed"
"He thinks too much"	A plotter, a mind that will not rest	The "worthy cogitations" he claims to have buried; the detailed plan of the letters, "In several hands"
"He reads much"	A bookish, learned man	His speech is full of learning: Aeneas and Anchises, the Colossus, the Epicurean maxim about our stars
"He is a great observer"	He watches people	His very first move: "Brutus, I do observe you now of late"
"looks / Quite through the deeds of men"	He sees motives beneath behaviour	He reads Brutus's "passions of some difference" before Brutus explains them, and later fits a wholly different method to Casca
"He loves no plays... he hears no music"	He takes no pleasure in shared festivity	He is the man who stays behind from the games while the city shouts for Caesar
"Seldom he smiles, and smiles in such a sort / As if he mocked himself"	Bitter, self-mocking humour	The pun on Rome and "room enough"; "we have the falling sickness"; "A very pleasing night to honest men"
"never at heart's ease / Whiles they behold a greater than themselves"	He cannot bear a superior	"Cassius is / A wretched creature and must bend his body"; "bear the palm alone"

Every clause lands. The portrait is not Caesar's prejudice; it is a summary of the scene we have just watched, placed in the mouth of the one man who did not watch it.

Why the accuracy is ironic

Irony one: the seer who will not act. Caesar sees Cassius exactly, and does nothing. Listen to the frame around the insight: "Would he were fatter! But I fear him not. / Yet if my name were liable to fear, / I do not know the man I should avoid / So soon as that spare Cassius." And the close: "I rather tell thee what is to be feared / Than what I fear; for always I am Caesar." The judgement is correct and the conclusion is suicidal, because Caesar has made his own name a thing that cannot admit fear. Notice how close this is to the weakness Cassius has just exploited in Brutus. Brutus loves "The name of honour"; Caesar is ruled by the name of Caesar — "if my *name* were liable to fear" — and speaks of himself in the third person as if the name were a separate, invulnerable being. The two men Cassius most needs to understand are both prisoners of their own names, and he understands it. Caesar, who understands Cassius, does not understand himself.

Irony two: the deaf ear. The speech ends: "Come on my right hand, for this ear is deaf, / And tell me truly what thou think'st of him." **HISTORICAL RECORD:** no ancient source gives Caesar a deaf ear; it appears to be Shakespeare's invention. **LITERARY INTERPRETATION:** many readers take the invention as emblematic. At the very moment of his sharpest insight, the man who 'hears' the truth about Cassius turns a deaf ear towards it and asks the wrong adviser for a second opinion. The frail body Cassius has just mocked — the shaking, the sick girl — is confirmed on stage, in Caesar's own voice, not as a swoon but as a sense that does not work.

Irony three: Antony is wrong and we know it. "He is a noble Roman, and well given." The audience has heard Cassius plan to be a "glass" that distorts, and will shortly hear him plan the letters. Antony's reassurance is dramatic irony in its pure form: we know what the speaker does not. And it is also a first glimpse of Antony's own limitation — the man of plays and music misjudges the man of books. The play will later give Antony his revenge in a scene of persuasion that outdoes Cassius; here he is simply the worse observer.

Irony four: a word changes hands. Cassius, protesting his sincerity to Brutus, said "then hold me dangerous". Caesar, within the hour, says of him "Such men are dangerous" and "therefore are they very dangerous". The word Cassius used to deny a charge becomes the charge. Shakespeare lets the audience hear the echo and the two speakers never do.

Irony five: the portrait indicts the painter. Caesar's ideal companions are "men about me that are fat, / Sleek-headed men, and such as sleep a-nights" — the contented, the untroubled, the unreflective. A ruler who wants only such men around him is a ruler who wants no one to think. Cassius's charge was that Rome had become "room enough" for "one only man"; Caesar's wish for sleek, sleeping courtiers quietly confirms it. The sketch of Cassius is accurate, and the sketch of the man who wants no Cassiuses near him is accurate too.

PROFESSOR'S INSIGHT What the portrait does to our view of Cassius

The portrait is a trap for the careless reader as much as for Caesar. Because every clause is confirmed by what we have seen, it is tempting to adopt it as Shakespeare's verdict: Cassius is the envious intellectual, case closed. Resist that. Caesar is describing the type of man who is dangerous *to Caesar* — and the qualities he lists (reading, observing, thinking, seeing through deeds, refusing easy pleasures) are, in any other context, the qualities of a serious citizen. A republic needs men who look "Quite through the deeds of men"; a monarch does not. So the portrait works in two directions at once. It confirms the personal reading of Cassius's motives — the man "never at heart's ease" beside a superior — and at the same time it exposes the political problem Cassius has been describing, by showing us a Caesar who classifies thought itself as a threat. Shakespeare gives us the sketch at the exact midpoint between the seduction of Brutus and Casca's report of the crown, so that we must hold three things together: Cassius is envious; Cassius is right that Caesar wants no equals; and Caesar is right that Cassius is dangerous. A tragedy, not a morality play, is built from truths that do not cancel.

LEVEL 4 — How does it connect to the whole play?

Cassius's method in Act 1 is the template against which every later act of persuasion in the play is measured. In Act 2 the forged letters do their work and Brutus, alone in his orchard, completes Cassius's hints with his own reasoning — which is exactly what the 'seducer' intended: the decision is Brutus's, so the guilt is Brutus's. In Act 3 Antony takes Cassius's tools — the disclaimer of eloquence, the manipulation of the crowd's feelings, the 'mirror' that shows an audience a flattering image of itself — and uses them on a far larger audience with far greater effect; the analytical vocabulary you have built here (flattery, insinuation, selective truth, rhetorical question, appeal to honour) is precisely the vocabulary you will need for the funeral oration. In Act 4 the two kinds of honour that this chapter kept separating — Cassius's honour as reputation, Brutus's honour as conscience — collide in the quarrel at Sardis. And in Act 5 the sceptic who told Brutus the fault was not in our stars confesses that he has begun to credit omens, and dies by the Roman freedom he preached to Casca: "Cassius from bondage will deliver Cassius". Caesar's portrait, meanwhile, becomes the play's first lesson in the gap between insight and action — a gap that will kill Caesar and, later, the conspirators who inherit his overconfidence. Act 1 plants every one of these seeds, and the Class 10 paper on Acts 3 to 5 is, in effect, an examination on how they grew.

Writing about Cassius for ICSE

ICSE EXAM BOX The vocabulary of manipulation — precise terms and how to use them

EXAM-ORIENTED ADVICE. Act 1 is examined in your Class IX internal papers, usually through extract questions; the Class 10 board paper sets Acts 3 to 5 but repeatedly asks what characters are doing *and why*, which sends you back to Act 1 for Cassius's motives and methods. In either setting, the terms below let you say in one word what a weak answer takes a paragraph to fumble. Learn the definitions exactly; an imprecise term is worse than none.

Term	Precise meaning	Sample sentence for an answer
manipulation	controlling someone's thoughts or actions by indirect, often unfair means, so that the person believes the choice is his own	'Cassius's manipulation of Brutus lies in never asking him to decide; he works on Brutus's self-image and lets Brutus reach the conclusion himself.'
insinuation	suggesting something unpleasant indirectly, by hint rather than statement	'The letters are pure insinuation: Caesar's ambition is to be, in Cassius's own word, "glanced at", never stated.'
rhetoric	the art of using language to persuade; also the techniques themselves	'Cassius's rhetoric moves from anecdote to maxim: the Tiber story is followed by "Men at some time are masters of their fates".'
flattery	insincere or excessive praise offered to gain influence	'Cassius disguises flattery as service when he offers to be the 'glass' that reveals Brutus's "hidden worthiness".'
resentment	lasting bitterness at being treated unfairly or slighted	'Resentment surfaces when Cassius remembers that he "must bend his body / If Caesar carelessly but nod on him".'
envy	discontent at another's advantages, with a wish to have them oneself	'Caesar diagnoses envy without naming it: such men are "never at heart's ease / Whiles they behold a greater than themselves".'
ideological motive vs personal motive	acting from a principle or political belief, as against acting from private grievance or gain	'Cassius's stated motive is ideological — Roman liberty — but his soliloquy reveals a personal motive: "Caesar doth bear me hard, but he loves Brutus."'
selective truth	using accurate facts, arranged and edited so that only one conclusion is visible	'Cassius practises selective truth: the fever in Spain is true, but Caesar's clemency and Cassius's own pardon are never mentioned.'
political pragmatism	judging actions by their practical results rather than by principle	'Cassius's political pragmatism is clearest in Scene 3, when he accepts that the conspiracy needs Brutus because his "countenance, like richest alchemy, / Will change to virtue" what would otherwise look like crime.'

Three habits that earn marks with these words. First, define as you use: 'Cassius uses insinuation — hinting rather than stating — when...'. Second, attach each term to a quotation of no more than a line or two; the term is the claim, the quotation is the evidence. Third, never let a term do your thinking for you: 'Cassius is a manipulator' is a label, but 'Cassius manipulates Brutus by echoing his own word, honour, so that his cause and Brutus's ruling value appear identical' is analysis.

LEVEL 5 — How do I use it in an ICSE answer?

Whatever the question, structure your material on Cassius in four moves. (1) **Situation:** fix the moment precisely in words, never in line numbers — 'after the procession leaves for the games, while two offstage shouts are heard'. (2) **Method:** name two or three techniques with the precise vocabulary above and show each working through a short, exact quotation. (3) **Effect:** say how Brutus (or Casca) receives it — "What you would work me to, I have some aim" is your proof that the persuasion is both visible and effective. (4) **Judgement:** end with the soliloquy or Caesar's portrait, which lets you weigh stated against personal motive without pretending the text settles it. For an extract question, the sub-parts will usually ask what has just happened, what a phrase means in your own words, why the speaker says it, what it reveals of character, and what follows — the four moves above map onto those sub-parts almost exactly. For the Class 10 paper, the same four moves answer the recurring 'why' questions about the conspirators in Acts 3 to 5: when you are asked why Brutus joined, or what kind of man quarrels with him at Sardis, you are being asked for this chapter.

A worked comparison: two answers to the same question

The question is a classic Class IX one and a frequent silent presence behind Class 10 questions: *How does Cassius persuade Brutus in Act 1 Scene 2?*

WEAK ANSWER A weak answer

Cassius persuades Brutus by flattering him and telling him that Caesar is weak. He says that Brutus cannot see his own face and that he will be his mirror. Then he tells Brutus two stories. In the first story Caesar challenged Cassius to swim in the Tiber but Caesar could not swim and Cassius had to save him. In the second story Caesar had a fever in Spain and shook and asked for water like a girl. Cassius says that Caesar is like a Colossus and that Brutus's name is as good as Caesar's. He also reminds Brutus about his ancestor who drove out the kings. He tells Brutus that he will write letters to him pretending to be from the citizens. Brutus says he will think about it and they agree to meet. Cassius is a very jealous and evil man who hates Caesar because Caesar does not like him, and he manipulates Brutus because Brutus is honourable and everyone loves him.

Why this earns little. It is a retelling, not an analysis: the stages are listed in order but no technique is named, so the word 'how' in the question is never answered. There is not one exact quotation, so nothing can be credited as evidence. It contains an error — Cassius does *not* tell Brutus about the letters; that is the soliloquy, spoken when Brutus has gone, and the whole point is that Brutus never knows. It also garbles the Tiber story: Caesar proposed the swim and swam it; he tired and cried for help — the text never says he 'could not swim'. It states a contested interpretation ('evil') as fact and offers the single word 'jealous' where the text offers a tangle of motives. And it never once mentions Brutus's response, so the reader cannot tell whether the persuasion worked or why.

EXCELLENT ANSWER An excellent answer

Cassius persuades Brutus not by argument but by working on Brutus's picture of himself — his honour, his name and his ancestry — while the offstage shouts for Caesar supply the pressure that Cassius himself dare not apply directly.

He begins with a reproach, complaining that he has not had from Brutus's eyes "that gentleness / And show of love as I was wont to have". This puts Brutus on the defensive and makes him confess that he is "with himself at war", which tells Cassius that the ground is already disturbed. Cassius then offers flattery disguised as service: since "the eye sees not itself / But by reflection", he will be Brutus's 'glass' and reveal his "hidden worthiness". The praise is attributed to others — "many of the best respect in Rome" — so that Brutus cannot refuse it as flattery. Before going further Cassius protects his credit with a disclaimer, listing the behaviour of a flatterer only to deny it: "then hold me dangerous".

The first shout lets Cassius trap Brutus into a position. When Brutus says "I do fear the people / Choose Caesar for their king", Cassius seizes the word: "Ay, do you fear it? / Then must I think you would not have it so." Brutus's reply — "I would not, Cassius, yet I love him well" — fixes the conflict that Cassius must work around. He does so by echoing Brutus's own values: the moment Brutus declares that he loves "The name of honour more than I fear death", Cassius announces that "honour is the subject of my story".

The body of the persuasion attacks Caesar's body rather than his policies. Two anecdotes — the Tiber, where Caesar cried "Help me, Cassius, or I sink!", and the fever in Spain, where "this god did shake" and begged for drink "As a sick girl" — turn the god of the procession into a frail man. Cassius then shames Brutus with the hyperbole of the Colossus and the maxim "The fault, dear Brutus, is not in our stars, / But in ourselves, that we are underlings", converting servitude from fate into guilt. Rhetorical questions empty Caesar's name of magic — "Why should that name be sounded more than yours?" — and the appeal to ancestry, "There was a Brutus once", makes refusal a betrayal of Brutus's blood.

Finally Cassius retreats, calling his speech "my weak words" so that Brutus credits the fire to himself. The method works: Brutus admits "What you would work me to, I have some aim", yet declares he "had rather be a villager / Than to repute himself a son of Rome" under such conditions, and himself proposes the next meeting.

The soliloquy exposes the method as seduction rather than persuasion. Cassius calls Brutus's "honourable mettle" something that "may be wrought", asks "who so firm that cannot be seduced?", names a personal grievance — "Caesar doth bear me hard" — and plans forged letters "In several hands". Shakespeare thus lets us admire the skill while withholding our trust, and makes Brutus's tragedy visible from the moment it begins.

Why this earns highly. It answers 'how' with named techniques — reproach, flattery as service, the disclaimer, seizing the shout, echoing the target's values, anecdote, hyperbole and maxim, rhetorical question, appeal to ancestry, false modesty — and shows each working through a short, exact quotation. It tracks Brutus's responses, so the effect of the persuasion is demonstrated rather than asserted. It places the soliloquy correctly, as the moment the audience learns what Brutus never learns, and it uses the soliloquy to weigh motive without flattening it: a personal grievance is *named*, not declared the whole truth. It has a thesis in its first sentence and a judgement in its last, and it never retells the plot for its own sake. It is also long enough for a full-mark long answer; for a three- or four-mark extract sub-part, you would lift the single relevant paragraph and let it stand alone.

CROSS-REFERENCE Where this chapter connects

For the scene-by-scene walk through the seduction with every line paraphrased, see *Act 1 Scene 2 (Part One) — Lupercalia, the Soothsayer, and the Seduction of Brutus*; for Casca's report and the soliloquy in their scene context, *Act 1 Scene 2 (Part Two) — Caesar Returns, Casca Reports, Cassius Plots*; for the storm and the recruitment of Casca in full, *Act 1 Scene 3 — The Storm: Omens, Fear and the Conspiracy Takes Shape*. Caesar's side of the portrait is developed in *Caesar in Act 1 — A Character Masterclass*, and the man being seduced is the subject of *Brutus in Act 1 — Honour, Conflict and Vulnerability*. The techniques named here are catalogued with definitions in *The Act 1 Literary-Device Bank*, the terms in the ICSE box recur in *The ICSE Keyword Vault for Act 1*, and the quotations are collected in *The Act 1 Quotation Bank*. For how to turn this material into marks, read *ICSE Examiner Mode: How Marks Are Earned* and practise with the Cassius extracts in both *Extract-Based Training* chapters. The themes of manipulation and political rhetoric are drawn together in *Themes of Act 1 (Part One)*, and the Act 4 quarrel and the Act 5 omens are traced forward in *The Scene Connection Engine and Where Act 1 Reappears Later*.

REVISION Cassius in one page

The thirteen stages (Act 1 Scene 2): reproach about lost "gentleness" → the 'glass' → the disclaimer ("hold me dangerous") → the shout seized ("Ay, do you fear it?") → "honour is the subject of my story" → "I was born free as Caesar" → the Tiber ("Help me, Cassius, or I sink!") → the fever ("this god did shake") → the Colossus and "not in our stars" → the weighed names → "There was a Brutus once" → "my weak words" → the soliloquy ("who so firm that cannot be seduced?").

The twelve tools: flattery as service; comparison; anecdote; rhetorical question; appeal to honour; appeal to liberty; appeal to reputation and ancestry; the body as argument; the constructed 'we'; forged letters; selective truth; emotional sequencing.

Casca (Act 1 Scene 3): reinterpret the omens → the "womanish" taunt → suicide as freedom → the "willing bondman" test → "There's a bargain made". Fear and shame for a soldier; honour and name for a philosopher.

Motives: stated — liberty, equality, the ancestor, honour; let slip — "Caesar doth bear me hard", "bend his body", "bear the palm alone". Write 'principle energised by envy', never 'evil'.

Caesar's portrait: every clause accurate; every irony against Caesar — "I fear him not", "this ear is deaf", Antony's "well given".

Three insights to carry: the conspiracy needs Brutus as "richest alchemy"; the soliloquy is honest about dishonesty and that is why it is brilliant; what Cassius does is seduction — it treats Brutus's firmness as a lock, not a virtue.

CHAPTER 9

Brutus in Act 1 — Honour, Conflict and Vulnerability

What this chapter does: it takes the one character in Act 1 whom everybody praises and nobody fully understands — Brutus — and studies him facet by facet, using only what the text of Act 1 actually gives us. You will learn how to separate what Brutus says from what others say about him, how to find the crack inside each of his virtues, and why Shakespeare builds the play's tragedy out of a good man's goodness. The chapter ends with the historical Brutus, a comparison of his language with Cassius's, and an honest guide to how this Class IX material earns marks in the Class X paper on Acts III–V.

First, the plain facts: what Brutus does in Act 1

Before we analyse anything, you need a clear, unglamorous account of what Brutus actually does. Students who have struggled with Shakespeare often skip this step and go straight to adjectives ('noble', 'idealistic', 'confused'), and the adjectives float free because they are not anchored to moments. So here is the anchor.

Brutus speaks only in Act 1 Scene 2. In Scene 1 he is not present, and in Scene 3 he is talked about but never appears. Within Scene 2 his part falls into a clear sequence:

1. **His first words in the play** are not about himself. When Caesar asks "What man is that?", Brutus answers: "A soothsayer bids you beware the ides of March." The man who will kill Caesar is the man who relays the warning to him.
2. **He declines to watch the race.** Asked by Cassius "Will you go see the order of the course?", he replies with a flat "Not I." and explains: "I am not gamesome. I do lack some part / Of that quick spirit that is in Antony."
3. **He explains his recent coldness.** Cassius complains that Brutus has been distant; Brutus says the trouble is inward: "poor Brutus, with himself at war, / Forgets the shows of love to other men."
4. **He is offered a mirror.** Cassius asks "can you see your face?" and hints that Rome wishes Brutus could see his own "hidden worthiness". Brutus asks, warily, "Into what dangers would you lead me, Cassius" — and only then does Cassius offer himself as the mirror ("I, your glass").
5. **A shout is heard.** Brutus reacts instantly: "What means this shouting? I do fear the people / Choose Caesar for their king." Pressed, he admits "I would not, Cassius, yet I love him well", and then delivers the speech on honour and death.
6. **He listens** to Cassius's two stories about Caesar (the Tiber swim, the fever in Spain). A second shout: "Another general shout!"

7. **After the Colossus speech he pulls back.** "That you do love me, I am nothing jealous. / What you would work me to, I have some aim." He asks not to be pressed further, promises to think, and ends with the villager sentence.
8. **He reads Caesar's returning procession** with a sharp eye: "The angry spot doth glow on Caesar's brow".
9. **He interrogates Casca** about the crown, and diagnoses Caesar's collapse: "he hath the falling sickness."
10. **He comments on Casca**, agrees with Cassius's correction, arranges to meet Cassius tomorrow, and leaves.
11. **Cassius, alone, tells us what he intends to do to Brutus** — the soliloquy that ends the scene.

In Scene 3 Brutus becomes the conspiracy's missing piece: Cinna longs to "win the noble Brutus to our party", Cassius sends the forged letters to his window, chair and ancestor's statue, and Casca explains why his "countenance" is worth more than all of theirs.

KEYWORDS The words you need before you read Brutus

Word or phrase	Meaning in context
gamesome	fond of sport and games
quick spirit	lively, energetic temperament
wont	accustomed
veiled my look	hidden my true expression
countenance	face, expression (later in Act 1: approval, backing)
passions of some difference	conflicting feelings pulling in different directions
conceptions only proper to myself	private thoughts that belong to me alone
soil	stain, blemish
construe	interpret
shows of love	outward signs of affection
glass	mirror
shadow	reflected image
jealous	suspicious, distrustful
aught	anything
the general good	the common good, the welfare of the whole community
speed me	prosper me, give me success
aim	guess, inkling
work me to	persuade me towards
meet	fitting, suitable
repute himself	consider himself
chidden	scolded
falling sickness	epilepsy
coronet	a small crown (Casca's word for what Antony offered)
praetor	a senior elected magistrate (official) who acted as a judge; Brutus's office
soliloquy	a speech made by a character alone on stage, revealing true thoughts to the audience
quick mettle	lively spirit (mettle: temperament, like metal that can be shaped)
wrought	worked, shaped (as metal is worked)
bear me hard	bears a grudge against me
humour me	indulge me, go along with me
several hands	different handwritings

One structural fact matters more than any single line. **SHAKESPEARE'S TEXT:** Brutus has no soliloquy in Act 1 — no speech alone on stage in which a character tells the audience the truth about himself. Cassius has one; Brutus does not. We never hear Brutus alone. Everything we know of him comes either from what he says to other people — carefully, with reserve — or from what other people say about him. Cassius calls him noble ("thou art noble") and speaks of his "honourable mettle"; Casca says "he sits high in all the people's hearts"; Cinna calls him "the noble Brutus". Caesar, who analyses Cassius at length, never mentions Brutus at all.

LITERARY INTERPRETATION: many readers feel that Shakespeare deliberately keeps Brutus's inner life sealed in Act 1 so that the audience, like Cassius, has to read him from the outside — and so that when the seal breaks (in Act 2, where Brutus does soliloquise; a glance ahead) the effect is far stronger. Keep that in mind: in Act 1, Brutus is the most discussed and the least disclosed character on stage.

The Masterclass: Twelve Facets of Brutus

Each facet below is treated in the same four steps, and you should learn to think in these four steps yourself whenever you write about character. **Textual evidence** gives you the words. **Explanation** tells you what they mean and imply. **The tension** finds the contradiction or fault-line inside the quality — because in Shakespeare every virtue has a shadow, and examiners at every level reward the student who can see it. **Dramatic significance** asks why Shakespeare wanted this quality in this man at this point of the play.

1. Honour — 'I love / The name of honour more than I fear death'

Textual evidence:

QUOTATION The honour speech

Brutus: *If it be aught toward the general good, / Set honour in one eye and death i' th' other / And I will look on both indifferently; / For let the gods so speed me as I love / The name of honour more than I fear death.*

Spoken to Cassius in Act 1 Scene 2, just after the first offstage shout and just after Brutus has admitted that he loves Caesar.

Explanation: Brutus is telling Cassius what kind of proposal he is prepared to hear. If what Cassius wants to say concerns the welfare of Rome as a whole, then Brutus will weigh honour and death as if they were two objects held up before his two eyes, and he will look at them "indifferently" — that is, without preferring the safe one. He then swears (that is what "let the gods so speed me" does: it calls on the gods to favour him only if what he says is true) that he loves honour more than he fears death. Notice how compact this is. In five lines he sets a condition (the general good), names the two things at stake (honour, death), promises a method (equal-eyed judgement), and takes an oath.

The tension: Look at the exact phrase: not 'honour' but "The name of honour". A name is a word, a reputation, a thing other people say about you. Is Brutus saying he loves the reality of honourable conduct, or that he loves being called honourable? The text does not settle it, and the ambiguity is the most important thing about the line. Cassius certainly hears the opening he needs: within three lines of his reply he announces, "Well, honour is the subject of my story." Brutus has, in effect, told a skilled persuader which word will move him. There is a second tension. Brutus offers to look on honour and death "indifferently" — yet indifference to

death is not the same as clear judgement about what is honourable. He has established how brave he is; he has not established how he will tell an honourable action from a dishonourable one dressed in honour's clothes. Cassius's soliloquy, and Scene 3's forged letters, exploit exactly this gap.

Dramatic significance: Shakespeare makes honour the first big abstract word Brutus utters, and he makes Cassius seize it at once. The whole seduction is thereby framed as an argument about honour rather than about power or envy, which is precisely what allows a good man to enter it. **EXAM-ORIENTED ADVICE:** if you learn one Brutus quotation from Act 1 by heart, learn this one, because the word honour is the thread that the Class X portion of the play (Acts III–V) keeps pulling — in the reasons Brutus gives the crowd, in what Antony does with the word afterwards, and in how Brutus ends. You do not need to quote those later scenes to make the point; you need to know that the word begins here.

LEVEL 1 — What happened?

A shout is heard offstage. Brutus fears it means the people are making Caesar king. Cassius notices the fear and says Brutus must therefore not want it. Brutus agrees he does not want it, though he loves Caesar, and then asks Cassius what he is getting at. Before Cassius can answer, Brutus lays down his terms: if the matter concerns Rome's good, he will face honour and death with equal steadiness, because he loves honour more than he fears death.

LEVEL 2 — What does it mean?

Brutus is announcing a hierarchy of values: above everything sits "the general good"; beneath it, honour is the value he serves and death the price he will pay. He is also, without quite knowing it, describing his own self-image — a man who cannot be frightened, only persuaded. (Facet 10 lays out the full anatomy of this speech as an argument.)

LEVEL 3 — Why did Shakespeare write it this way?

Shakespeare needs Brutus to join the conspiracy without becoming a villain. So he lets Brutus state his principles before he has heard any argument, and lets Cassius shape the argument to fit the principles ("honour is the subject of my story"). The balanced construction — one eye, the other eye; honour, death; love, fear — makes Brutus sound measured and judicial, which is how he wants to sound. The dramatic point is that measured men can be led, provided you speak their language.

LEVEL 4 — How does it connect to the whole play?

Within Act 1, this speech is the key that fits Cassius's lock: the soliloquy that ends the scene ("Thy honourable mettle may be wrought") is Cassius reflecting on exactly what he has just learned. Beyond Act 1 (a labelled glance ahead): honour is the word by which Brutus will justify the assassination to himself and to Rome, and the word whose meaning the play then tests to destruction. Every later use of the word by any character is heard against this first, sincere declaration.

LEVEL 5 — How do I use it in an ICSE answer?

In a Class IX extract question on this passage, quote the two central lines exactly, explain "indifferently" and "speed me", and then make the analytical point that Brutus loves "The name of honour" — the reputation as well as the reality — and that Cassius immediately takes up the word. In the Class X paper, where the extracts come from Acts III–V, you will not be asked to quote this speech, but you can say in your own words that Brutus's actions flow from a principle he stated to Cassius in Act 1: that he valued honour above life. That sentence, used correctly, shows an examiner that you understand the whole arc of the character rather than the extract alone.

2. Idealism

Textual evidence: "If it be aught toward the general good"; "Brutus had rather be a villager / Than to repute himself a son of Rome / Under these hard conditions as this time / Is like to lay upon us"; and, on a smaller scale, "the eye sees not itself / But by reflection, by some other things."

Explanation: An idealist measures the world against an idea of how it ought to be. Watch Brutus's mind at work. Asked a simple question — "can you see your face?" — he does not answer 'no, of course not'; he states a general truth about eyes and reflection. Asked what he thinks of the times, he does not name a grievance; he imagines an alternative identity (a villager) and prefers it to a Rome that fails its own standard. His conditions are always principles: the general good, honour, what a son of Rome should be able to expect. He thinks upward, from the particular to the ideal.

The tension: The idealist's strength is also his exposure. Because Brutus responds to ideas rather than to persons, anyone who can present an idea in the right form can move him; and because he prefers the idea of Rome to the actual Rome, he can be persuaded to act against actual Romans (including one he loves) on behalf of a Rome that exists in his mind. Cassius understands this perfectly. The letters he plans are "Writings, all tending to the great opinion / That Rome holds of his name" — appeals to an idealised Rome speaking to an idealised Brutus. Not one of them will be a real citizen's voice.

Dramatic significance: Shakespeare gives the play a moral centre that is also its most manipulable point. In Act 1 we are shown the idealism and shown the man who has learned how to feed it; we are not yet shown the cost. That deferral is what gives the later acts their weight.

3. Patriotism — 'the general good'

Textual evidence: "If it be aught toward the general good"; "a son of Rome"; "these times"; and his instant reading of the shouts: "I do believe that these applauses are / For some new honours that are heaped on Caesar."

Explanation: Brutus's patriotism is not a feeling about flags and festivals — he will not even go to watch the Lupercal race. It is a feeling about the public thing itself, what the Romans called the *res publica* (the chapter 'Roman History Before Act 1: Only What You Need, Taught Properly' explains the term). "The general good" means the good of all as distinct from the good of any one man, and the phrase is chosen with care: it is the standard against which a single man growing "so great" (Cassius's phrase) must look like a disorder. When Brutus calls himself "a son of Rome" he speaks of the city as a parent to whom duty is owed. Note, too, that he listens to the shouting and interprets it politically at once — new "honours", the people, a king. His ear is tuned to the state.

The tension: He loves Rome and fears the Romans. "I do fear the people / Choose Caesar for their king": the enemy in that sentence is not Caesar but the people's choice. The crowd whose "sweaty nightcaps" Casca describes is, to Brutus, both the Rome he serves and the Rome he cannot trust. This is patriotism for an idea of the city that the city's actual inhabitants may not share. **LITERARY INTERPRETATION:** many critics see here the seed of a later problem: a man who acts 'for Rome' but has not asked Rome what it wants. The text of Act 1 does not resolve the problem; it plants it.

Dramatic significance: By making Brutus's patriotism abstract and the crowd's enthusiasm concrete (shouts, coronets, nightcaps), Shakespeare stages two different Romes in one scene. Brutus belongs to the first; Caesar, whatever his faults, knows how to play to the second. That gap between the patriot and the populace will matter enormously later.

4. Republicanism — 'I do fear the people / Choose Caesar for their king'

Textual evidence:

QUOTATION The fear of a king

Brutus: *What means this shouting? I do fear the people / Choose Caesar for their king.* **Cassius:** *Ay, do you fear it? / Then must I think you would not have it so.* **Brutus:** *I would not, Cassius, yet I love him well.*

Act 1 Scene 2, at the first offstage flourish and shout.

Explanation: Republicanism in this play means the belief that Rome must have no king — that power must stay divided among magistrates (elected officials who held office for a fixed term) and the Senate under the law. For a Roman aristocrat of Brutus's family the word 'king' was not neutral; it named the thing his ancestor had driven out of Rome (see the historical record box below and the chapter on Roman history). So when Brutus says the word *king*, he is naming the one outcome he cannot accept. Cassius's reply is a small masterpiece of listening: he does not argue; he simply draws the inference aloud — "Then must I think you would not have it so" — and lets Brutus confirm it.

The tension: First, Brutus's republicanism is triggered by a sound, not an act. He has not seen Caesar do anything; he has heard a crowd cheer. Everything he fears is prospective (lying in the future) — what Caesar may become — and Act 1 gives him no example of Caesar behaving as a tyrant that he himself cites. Second, and more uncomfortably, he fears "the people" choosing. A republic is supposed to rest on the people; Brutus's republicanism distrusts the people's likely decision. He is, in Act 1, a republican for the Republic rather than for the Romans.

Dramatic significance: Shakespeare could have given Brutus a grievance; instead he gives him a fear. This makes the eventual conspiracy a pre-emptive strike — an attack made to prevent a harm that has not yet happened — against a possibility, and that is a far more troubling moral situation than revenge for a wrong. The play's tragedy is set up here, in the gap between the word *fear* and the word *king*.

5. Loyalty

Textual evidence: To Cassius: "But let not therefore my good friends be grieved / (Among which number, Cassius, be you one)"; "Till then, my noble friend". To Caesar: "yet I love him well". To Rome: "a son of Rome"; "the general good".

Explanation: Brutus in Act 1 is pulled by three loyalties, and he is faithful to all three at once. He reassures Cassius that their friendship is intact even while he has been neglecting it. He declares love for Caesar in the same breath as he opposes Caesar's kingship. He speaks of Rome as a parent. None of these is insincere. The word that best describes him is not 'disloyal' but 'over-committed': he owes more than any one man can pay.

The tension: The three loyalties cannot all be honoured if the political situation is as Cassius describes it. Loyalty to Rome (as Brutus understands Rome) may require disloyalty to Caesar; loyalty to Cassius the friend draws him towards Cassius the plotter; loyalty to Caesar makes him hesitate, and hesitation is what Cassius must overcome. Shakespeare shows the collision in a single line — "I would not, Cassius, yet I love him well" — where the two halves belong to two different loyalties. Notice also a quieter irony: the loyalty Brutus shows Cassius ("Among which number, Cassius, be you one") is repaid, within the same scene, by Cassius's plan to deceive him with forged letters.

Dramatic significance: Shakespeare does not build this tragedy out of a villain betraying a hero. He builds it out of competing loyalties inside a decent man. That is why the audience can neither simply condemn Brutus nor simply admire him — and why, when you write about him, you should never reach for one adjective when the text gives you two in tension.

6. Friendship — 'yet I love him well'

Textual evidence: "I would not, Cassius, yet I love him well." Also Cassius's characterisation of their own bond — "your friend that loves you" — and Brutus's returned warmth: "my good friends", "my noble friend". And, reported by Cassius in soliloquy: "Caesar doth bear me hard, but he loves Brutus."

Explanation: The single word *yet* carries the whole play. Brutus has just said he does not want Caesar to be king; *yet* swings the sentence back to affection. Caesar is not, for Brutus, a political abstraction; he is a man he loves, and (if Cassius is to be believed) a man who loves him back. Friendship runs the other way too: Brutus's bond with Cassius is real enough that Cassius can complain, like a hurt friend, of missing "that gentleness / And show of love as I was wont to have", and Brutus takes the complaint seriously enough to explain himself.

The tension: Friendship is, in Act 1, both what protects Caesar and what endangers him. It protects him because Brutus hesitates. It endangers him because Cassius knows the hesitation can be overcome, and because friendship with Cassius is the channel through which the conspiracy reaches Brutus at all. There is a further sting. Cassius, alone, contrasts himself with Brutus: "If I were Brutus now, and he were Cassius, / He should not humour me." **LITERARY INTERPRETATION:** editors read the line two ways. On one reading *he* is Brutus: if their positions were reversed, Brutus would not be able to work on Cassius as Cassius is working on him — so Cassius is admitting that Brutus is the better friend and resolving, in the same breath, to talk him round. On the other, *he* is Caesar: Caesar's favour would not soften Cassius as it softens Brutus. Either way, Cassius knows that what he is about to do to Brutus could not be done to himself.

Dramatic significance: Shakespeare places "yet I love him well" before any argument against Caesar has been made, so the audience carries the knowledge of that love through every accusation Cassius brings. The conspiracy is thereby framed, from the start, as a story about friendship under pressure — for Brutus and Caesar, and for Brutus and Cassius.

7. Internal conflict — 'with himself at war', 'passions of some difference'

Textual evidence:

QUOTATION The civil war inside Brutus

Brutus: *Vexèd I am / Of late with passions of some difference, / Conceptions only proper to myself, / Which give some soil, perhaps, to my behaviors. / But let not therefore my good friends be grieved / (Among which number, Cassius, be you one) / Nor construe any further my neglect / Than that poor Brutus, with himself at war, / Forgets the shows of love to other men.*

Act 1 Scene 2, Brutus's reply to Cassius's complaint about his coldness.

Explanation: Take the phrases one at a time. "Vexèd I am" means I am troubled. "Passions of some difference" means feelings that differ from one another — that is, feelings in conflict. "Conceptions only proper to myself" means thoughts that belong to him alone: he is insisting that they are private. "Some soil, perhaps, to my behaviors" means a stain on his conduct; note the two hedging words, *some* and *perhaps*, which are typical of the way Brutus softens every statement about himself. Then the great metaphor: "with himself at war". Before there is any civil war in Rome, there is a civil war inside Brutus, and the effect of it is that he "Forgets the shows of love" — the outward signs of affection — towards others. He is not saying he loves his friends less; he is saying the inner conflict has consumed the attention that friendship's outward forms require.

The tension: Brutus opens this speech with "Be not deceived" — do not misread me — and asks Cassius not to "construe any further" than he has explained. The irony is double. First, Cassius will do precisely what he is asked not to do: he will construe Brutus's trouble as an invitation, and he will deceive Brutus in return. Second, Brutus insists these thoughts are "only proper to myself", private — and the whole movement of the scene is to make them public property, first Cassius's, then the conspiracy's. What Brutus wants to keep as a personal struggle becomes a political resource. **SHAKESPEARE'S TEXT:** later in the scene Brutus confirms that the struggle predates this conversation — "How I have thought of this, and of these times, / I shall recount hereafter." **LITERARY INTERPRETATION:** on the strongest reading, Cassius does not plant the thought of resisting Caesar in Brutus; it is already there, and Cassius's skill is to cultivate rather than to create. The text supports this reading, though it does not tell us how far Brutus's private thinking had gone.

Dramatic significance: Shakespeare gives us the conflict before he gives us its content. We learn that Brutus is at war with himself several minutes before we learn what the war is about (the shout and the word *king* supply the content). This is characteristic of the whole Act 1 treatment of Brutus: the audience is shown the surface of a disturbance whose depths remain hidden until later.

8. Political judgement

Brutus is not a fool, and any answer that presents him as one will be marked down by any competent examiner. Act 1 gives three clear demonstrations of his judgement, and one quiet warning about its limits.

Textual evidence (a) — how he reads the procession: "The angry spot doth glow on Caesar's brow, / And all the rest look like a chidden train. / Calpurnia's cheek is pale, and Cicero / Looks with such ferret and such fiery eyes" — and the comparison that follows: "As we have seen him in the Capitol, / Being crossed in conference by some senators."

Explanation: This is a superb piece of observation. In six lines Brutus reads four faces and infers a whole event. Caesar's flushed anger; the courtiers looking "chidden" (scolded) like a school class; Calpurnia's pallor; Cicero's eyes red and fierce as a ferret's, exactly as he looks "in the Capitol" when "crossed" (contradicted) by other senators. Brutus does not yet know about the crown, but he has correctly deduced that something has gone wrong and that Caesar is furious. He is the kind of man who watches faces and understands them.

Textual evidence (b) — his shrewd reading of Casca: Brutus asks the right questions — "Was the crown offered him thrice?", "Tell us the manner of it, gentle Casca", "What said he when he came unto himself?" — and when Casca describes the collapse, Brutus offers a plain diagnosis: "'Tis very like; he hath the falling sickness." After Casca leaves he remarks, "What a blunt fellow is this grown to be! / He was quick mettle when he went to school."

Explanation: Notice two things. Brutus wants facts, in order, from a witness; he is doing what a careful magistrate does. And his reading of Caesar's fit is literal and medical — an epileptic seizure — where Cassius instantly turns it into political metaphor ("we have the falling sickness", meaning that the Romans have fallen into servility). Brutus sees a sick man; Cassius sees a sick state. His reading of Casca is half right: Casca is indeed putting on a blunt manner, and Brutus remembers the lively schoolboy underneath. But it is Cassius who explains the disguise — "So is he now in execution / Of any bold or noble enterprise, / However he puts on this tardy form" — and Brutus simply agrees: "And so it is." It is a small moment, but it is the first time in the play that Brutus accepts Cassius's judgement of a man in place of his own.

Textual evidence (c) — his caution: "That you do love me, I am nothing jealous. / What you would work me to, I have some aim." And: "I would not, so with love I might entreat you, / Be any further moved. What you have said / I will consider; what you have to say / I will with patience hear, and find a time / Both meet to hear and answer such high things."

Explanation: Brutus knows exactly what is happening to him and says so. "What you would work me to, I have some aim": I have a fair idea of what you are trying to persuade me to. He then refuses to be "any further moved" now, and sets his own timetable — he will consider, he will hear, he will find a fitting time. This is a man declining to be rushed. Politically, it is exactly the right instinct: never decide a matter of life and death in the excitement of a festival with shouts in the background.

The tension: Every one of these judgements is a judgement about *other people's* faces, moods and manners. Brutus is a fine reader of surfaces around him. Yet the scene has already established, in his own words, that "the eye sees not itself / But by reflection". His judgement has a blind spot precisely where Cassius intends to operate: himself. And his caution, admirable as it is, rests on one assumption he never questions — "That you do love me, I am nothing jealous." He is not suspicious of Cassius's love. He is right that Cassius loves him, as the soliloquy shows; he is wrong to assume that love will stop Cassius deceiving him. **EXAM-ORIENTED ADVICE:** when a question asks whether Brutus is naïve, the honest Act 1 answer is 'not about others, only about himself and about the friend who loves him'. That distinction is worth marks because it is precise.

Dramatic significance: Shakespeare takes care to make Brutus intelligent. If Brutus were stupid, his fall would be merely sad. Because he is perceptive, cautious and honest, and is still led, the play becomes an inquiry into how good judgement fails — through a blind spot rather than through a lack of sight.

PROFESSOR'S INSIGHT The mirror image and self-knowledge

Cassius's first probing move, once Brutus has explained his coldness, is a question about mirrors: "can you see your face?" Brutus answers like a philosopher — "the eye sees not itself / But by reflection, by some other things" — and Cassius turns the philosophy into an offer: "I, your glass, / Will modestly discover to yourself / That of yourself which you yet know not of." Stop and consider what has been agreed. Brutus has accepted, as a general truth, that a man cannot know himself directly and must rely on others to show him what he is. That is a humble and rather beautiful idea. It is also the most dangerous thing he says all day, because he has just handed the job of telling him who he is to a man with a purpose. A mirror reflects; a glass held by Cassius selects. The image Cassius will show him is a "hidden worthiness" — a Brutus grander than Brutus knows — and the forged letters of Scene 3 are simply more mirrors, "As if they came from several citizens", all showing the same flattering face. Notice the irony that runs through the whole scene: the man who reads Caesar's brow and Cicero's eyes so accurately has agreed that he cannot read his own. Brutus's self-knowledge is real — he knows he is at war with himself — but it stops at the border of his own motives, and that is exactly where Cassius sets up his glass.

9. Susceptibility to persuasion — 'Thy honourable mettle may be wrought'**Textual evidence:****QUOTATION** Cassius alone, after Brutus leaves

Cassius: *Well, Brutus, thou art noble. Yet I see / Thy honourable mettle may be wrought / From that it is disposed. Therefore it is meet / That noble minds keep ever with their likes; / For who so firm that cannot be seduced?*

The soliloquy that closes Act 1 Scene 2.

Add to this Cassius's earlier, public verdict on his own progress — "I am glad that my weak words / Have struck but thus much show of fire from Brutus" — and his later arithmetic in Scene 3: "Three parts of him / Is ours already, and the man entire / Upon the next encounter yields him ours."

Explanation: The soliloquy is the one place in Act 1 where a character speaks the truth about Brutus with no one to persuade. Cassius's judgement is precise and, as far as the play goes, correct. "Mettle" means temperament, and the word is a pun on *metal*: Brutus's nature is a fine metal, but a metal can be "wrought" — worked, hammered, shaped — away from the form it naturally takes ("From that it is disposed"). Then the general law: "who so firm that cannot be seduced?" Nobody is unshapeable; the question is only who holds the hammer. The remark that "noble minds" should "keep ever with their likes" is Cassius admitting that he is *not* Brutus's like — that Brutus's danger is the company he keeps, namely Cassius himself. The fire image ("show of fire") belongs to the same metal-working picture: Cassius has been striking Brutus like flint and steel and is pleased with the sparks.

The tension: The most important thing to grasp is that Brutus is susceptible *through* his virtue, not despite it. A cynic could not be worked by talk of honour; a man who loves "The name of honour" can. A man indifferent to Rome could not be moved by the fear of a king; a republican patriot can. Cassius plans to feed him nothing but his own ideals, in his own city's handwriting: "Writings, all tending to the great opinion / That Rome holds of his name, wherein obscurely / Caesar's ambition shall be glanced at." Every ingredient is drawn from what

Brutus already believes. And Brutus half-knows it. He uses the same verb as the soliloquy — "What you would work me to, I have some aim" — and still arranges to meet Cassius tomorrow, still promises to "consider". The susceptible man is not blind; he is a man who has decided to trust.

Dramatic significance: By placing the soliloquy immediately after Brutus's dignified exit, Shakespeare creates a sharp dramatic irony (the audience knowing something a character does not): the audience now knows what Brutus does not — that the friend who has just spoken of love intends to forge letters. Every later scene with Brutus in it is watched through this knowledge. It also fixes, in the audience's mind, the play's central question about him: is a man who is deceived into a deed responsible for it? Act 1 asks; it does not answer.

PROFESSOR'S INSIGHT Why Brutus is politically vulnerable despite being morally serious

Moral seriousness and political safety are not the same thing, and Act 1 is a demonstration of the difference. Brutus's seriousness makes him predictable: he has told Cassius what he values (honour, the general good), what he fears (a king), and how he decides (by looking on honour and death "indifferently"). A predictable man is a man who can be planned for, and Cassius plans. Brutus's seriousness also makes him trusting in a particular way — he judges others by his own standard, so when Cassius protests that he is no flatterer ("Were I a common laughter... then hold me dangerous"), Brutus answers not with suspicion but with a declaration of trust ("That you do love me, I am nothing jealous"). A man who would never forge a letter does not readily imagine that one is being forged for him. Finally, seriousness draws him to abstract questions and away from concrete ones. He never asks Cassius, in Act 1, the practical questions a politician asks: who else is involved, what exactly is proposed, what happens afterwards. He asks, instead, whether the matter concerns the general good. Cassius, who is politically astute, needs him for reasons that have nothing to do with virtue and everything to do with cover — his "countenance", as Casca puts it in Scene 3. The good man is recruited for what he looks like; what he is only makes the recruitment easier.

10. Moral reasoning — the structure of Brutus's ethics

Textual evidence: the honour speech again — "If it be aught toward the general good, / Set honour in one eye and death i' th' other / And I will look on both indifferently" — together with "Brutus had rather be a villager / Than to repute himself a son of Rome / Under these hard conditions".

Explanation: Lay the speech out as an argument and you will see the shape of Brutus's ethics. There is a *condition*: the matter must serve "the general good". There is a *value*: honour. There is a *cost*: death. And there is a *method*: look on value and cost with equal steadiness, which is possible because he loves the value more than he fears the cost. Three terms — the general good, honour, death — and the whole moral machine runs on them. Cassius's ethics, by contrast, run on a different engine: "Cassius from bondage will deliver Cassius", he says in Scene 3 — the self freeing the self from a personal yoke. Brutus never once frames the matter as his own liberation. His question is always what a good man owes to a good city.

The tension: Now notice what the machine lacks. There is no term for *Caesar's actual guilt*: the condition is the general good, not any proven wrong. There is no term for *means*: honour and death are weighed, but the method by which the general good is to be served is left blank, to be filled in by someone else. And there is no term for *consequences*: the speech is about what kind of man Brutus will be (steadfast, honourable, unafraid), not about what will happen to Rome after he acts. **LITERARY INTERPRETATION:** many critics describe Brutus's ethics as an ethics of character — the question 'what does an honourable man do?' — rather than an

ethics of outcome. The strength of such an ethics is integrity; its weakness is that it can be satisfied by the honourable gesture even when the outcome is disastrous. The text of Act 1 gives us the structure; it withholds the test.

Dramatic significance: Shakespeare lets Brutus define the terms of the play's moral argument before the plot has produced anything to argue about. The audience therefore has a ruler in hand — Brutus's own — with which to measure every later action, including his. **A labelled glance ahead:** the missing terms (guilt, means, consequences) are exactly the places where Acts II–V will hurt him. You will study those scenes in Class X; what you need now is to see that the gaps were already visible in Act 1.

11. Relationship with Caesar — love, and fear of what Caesar may become

Textual evidence: Brutus's first line, "A soothsayer bids you beware the ides of March"; his confession, "I would not, Cassius, yet I love him well"; his fear, "I do fear the people / Choose Caesar for their king"; and, from the other side, Cassius's report in soliloquy: "Caesar doth bear me hard, but he loves Brutus."

Explanation: Brutus stands close enough to Caesar to be the man who passes on a stranger's warning, and Caesar accepts the intervention without comment — a small sign of intimacy. He loves Caesar and says so without being asked. What he fears is not Caesar as he is but the office the people may give him: the kingship.

SHAKESPEARE'S TEXT: notice a careful asymmetry. We hear Brutus on Caesar directly; we hear Caesar on Brutus only through Cassius. Caesar's own long speech about dangerous men is entirely about Cassius — "He thinks too much. Such men are dangerous." — and Brutus is never named. **LITERARY**

INTERPRETATION: most readers take Cassius's "he loves Brutus" as reliable, since Cassius has no reason to flatter Brutus in private; but you should be exact in an answer and say that in Act 1 Caesar's love for Brutus is reported, not shown.

The tension: Love and fear are aimed at the same man, and neither cancels the other. Brutus does not love Caesar less because he fears the crown, nor fear the crown less because he loves the man. The two feelings simply coexist, which is what "with himself at war" means in practice. And the fear is, strictly, not of Caesar but of what Caesar may *become* — a future Caesar who does not yet exist. Brutus is preparing to judge a friend for a crime not yet committed. That is the moral knot the rest of the play will pull tight.

Dramatic significance: Shakespeare ensures that when the conspiracy reaches Brutus it will be a betrayal as well as a political act — and that Caesar's blindness is aimed at the wrong man. Caesar watches the "lean and hungry" Cassius and never looks at the friend beside him. The audience, holding both halves of the picture, waits.

PROFESSOR'S INSIGHT**Why Brutus's love for Caesar makes him more, not less, dangerous to Caesar**

It seems obvious that a man who loves Caesar is safer for Caesar than a man who hates him. Act 1 quietly shows the opposite. First, love gives access. Cassius's own words fix the point: "Caesar doth bear me hard, but he loves Brutus." Caesar keeps Cassius at a distance and studies him; he keeps Brutus close and does not study him at all. A blow from Brutus would come from inside the guard. Second, love supplies the conspiracy with something no amount of hatred can supply — legitimacy, the appearance of rightful authority. Casca says it in Scene 3: what "would appear offence in us / His countenance, like richest alchemy, / Will change to virtue and to worthiness." Only a man known to love Caesar can make killing Caesar look like duty rather than envy; that is precisely why Cassius needs him and why Cinna sighs to "win the noble Brutus to our party". Third, love makes Brutus's own resistance to the deed a resistance he can be proud of overcoming. A man who hates Caesar and kills him has merely indulged himself; a man who loves Caesar and kills him can tell himself he has sacrificed his feelings to the general good — the very structure of the honour speech, where death and honour are weighed and love is not in the scale at all. The love, in other words, is what will allow Brutus to experience the act as noble. Cassius, whose motives are partly personal, understands all this; Caesar, who fears the wrong man, understands none of it. The affection that ought to protect him is the thing that will be used against him.

12. Relationship with Cassius — kinsman, friend, and the man who will 'seduce' him

Textual evidence: Cassius's language of intimacy — "your friend that loves you", "good Brutus", "gentle Brutus", "dear Brutus"; Brutus's response — "Among which number, Cassius, be you one", "my noble friend"; Brutus's wariness — "Into what dangers would you lead me, Cassius"; Brutus's trust — "That you do love me, I am nothing jealous"; and Cassius alone — "who so firm that cannot be seduced?" and "If I were Brutus now, and he were Cassius, / He should not humour me."

Explanation: HISTORICAL RECORD: Cassius was married to Brutus's sister, which makes the two men brothers-in-law; the play does not spell this out in Act 1, but the ease of address between them fits it. In the text, the friendship is warm and real on both sides. Cassius is hurt by Brutus's coldness and says so; Brutus apologises and includes Cassius by name among his "good friends". They arrange, like friends, to visit each other's houses tomorrow. Yet the same Cassius, alone, describes what he is doing as seduction and admits that Brutus, in his position, would not do it.

The tension: This is the play's most unsettling relationship because it is both a genuine friendship and an operation. The love is not faked — Brutus is right that Cassius loves him — but it is put to use. Cassius's soliloquy contains a moral self-portrait in a single conditional: "If I were Brutus now, and he were Cassius, / He should not humour me." Whichever way the pronoun is taken (see facet 6), the sentence measures Cassius against Brutus and finds Cassius the harder, less persuadable man — and he proceeds anyway. On Brutus's side, trust is a decision rather than an oversight: he sees the danger ("Into what dangers would you lead me"), names the persuasion ("What you would work me to"), and chooses to believe in the love.

Dramatic significance: Shakespeare stages the seduction of Brutus as a friendship story, not a villain's plot. It is Cassius's affection that gives him the right to complain of coldness, to ask about mirrors, to be heard. Had a stranger said "honour is the subject of my story", Brutus would have walked away. That is why this relationship, more than any other in Act 1, deserves the word *tragic*: the good in it is what does the harm.

Why Cassius Believes Brutus Is Essential

Cassius does not need Brutus's dagger. By the end of Scene 3 he has Casca sworn in and Cinna running his errands, Decius Brutus and Trebonius are waiting at "Pompey's Porch", Metellus Cimber is out looking for him, and he has described himself as one who has "moved already / Some certain of the noblest-minded Romans / To undergo with me an enterprise / Of honourable-dangerous consequence." The plot exists without Brutus. Why, then, does the whole conspiracy behave as if Brutus were the one man it cannot do without — Cinna breaking off mid-sentence with "if you could / But win the noble Brutus to our party", Cassius planning to "awake him and be sure of him" before dawn? Act 1 gives four reasons in the text, and a fifth that Cassius keeps to himself.

1. His reputation is 'richest alchemy'. The clearest statement comes not from Cassius but from Casca, and Cassius endorses it: "Him and his worth and our great need of him / You have right well conceited." Casca's words are these:

QUOTATION Casca on what Brutus is for

Casca: *O, he sits high in all the people's hearts, / And that which would appear offence in us / His countenance, like richest alchemy, / Will change to virtue and to worthiness.*

Act 1 Scene 3, as Cassius and Casca set off to visit Brutus before dawn.

Alchemy was the dream of turning base metal into gold. Casca is saying that the deed the conspirators intend "would appear offence" — would look like a crime — if they did it alone, and that Brutus's "countenance" (here meaning his approval and public backing, not merely his face) would transmute (change, as the alchemist hoped to change lead to gold) it into "virtue" and "worthiness". Read that admission carefully. The conspirators know their act looks like a crime. They need Brutus not to make it right but to make it *look* right. This is the most honest thing anyone in Act 1 says about why Brutus matters, and it is the reason his reputation, rather than his judgement, is the prize.

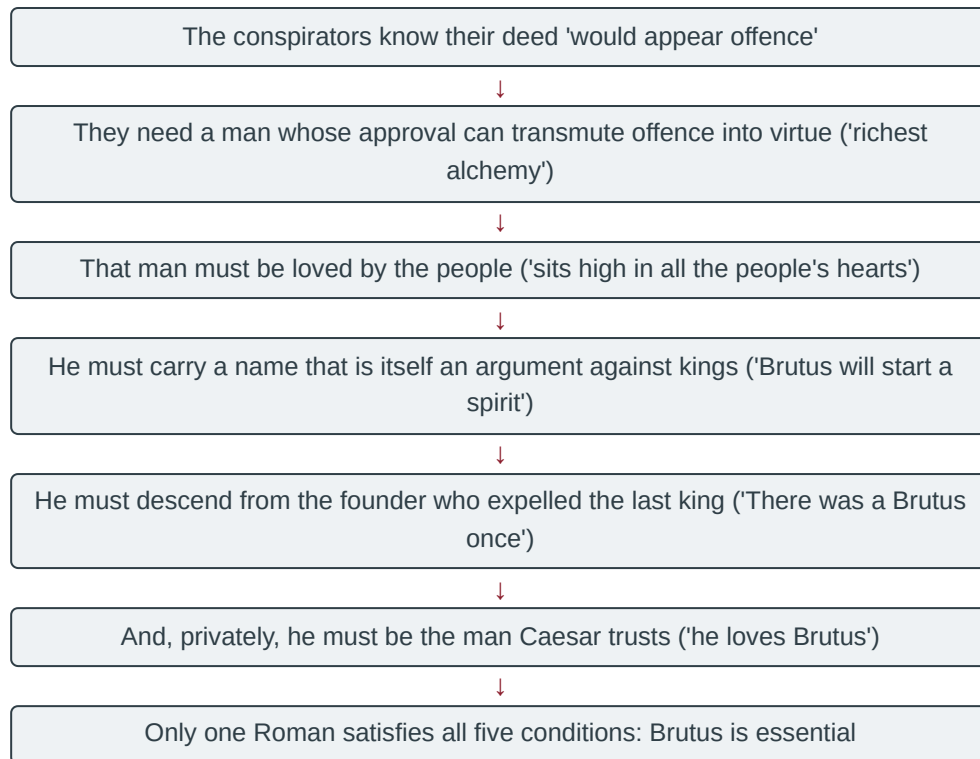
2. The people love him. "He sits high in all the people's hearts", says Casca; Cassius has already claimed that "many of the best respect in Rome, / Except immortal Caesar, speaking of Brutus / And groaning underneath this age's yoke, / Have wished that noble Brutus had his eyes." Whether or not that second claim is literally true (Cassius is persuading when he says it), the play treats Brutus's standing as a fact. In a city where the crowd decides — the same crowd that cheered Pompey, then Caesar, then Caesar's refusals — the one conspirator whom the crowd already trusts is worth more than a dozen daggers.

3. The name Brutus. Cassius makes the name itself an argument: "'Brutus' and 'Caesar'—what should be in that 'Caesar'? / Why should that name be sounded more than yours?" and, most strikingly, "conjure with 'em, / 'Brutus' will start a spirit as soon as 'Caesar.'" To conjure is to summon a spirit by speaking a magic word. Cassius is saying the name Brutus has that power in Rome — that it is, in itself, a political programme. He is right, and the conspirators know it: in Scene 3 the forged letters are to be laid where the name will be read — in "the Praetor's chair, / Where Brutus may but find it", and fixed "with wax / Upon old Brutus' statue".

4. The ancestor. "O, you and I have heard our fathers say / There was a Brutus once that would have brooked / Th' eternal devil to keep his state in Rome / As easily as a king." That "Brutus once" is Lucius Junius Brutus, who (**HISTORICAL RECORD**) led the expulsion of Rome's last king and founded the Republic; the statue in Scene 3 is his. Cassius's sentence is a challenge dressed as a memory: the first Brutus would sooner have

tolerated the devil in Rome than a king — what will the present Brutus tolerate? To bear the name and stand by while a king is made would be, in Cassius's framing, a betrayal of blood. This is why the ancestor is not decoration; he is the conspiracy's oldest recruiting officer.

5. The reason Cassius keeps to himself. Alone, Cassius says: "Caesar doth bear me hard, but he loves Brutus." Brutus has access. Brutus is not watched. Brutus is the man Caesar will not see coming. Cassius never says this to the others, and he certainly never says it to Brutus; it lives only in soliloquy. Pair it with his cold arithmetic — "Three parts of him / Is ours already" — and you see the strategist behind the friend.



EXAM-ORIENTED ADVICE: when a question asks why the conspirators want Brutus, weaker answers say 'because he is noble'. Stronger answers distinguish the reasons — reputation, popularity, name, ancestry, access — and notice that not one of them is about what Brutus thinks. The conspiracy wants his face, not his mind. That observation is the beginning of the next section.

Brutus's Moral Character vs Brutus's Political Effectiveness

Students often write as if a good man must be a good politician, or as if a man who fails politically must have been secretly bad. Shakespeare's Brutus refutes both ideas, and you must learn to hold the two measures apart.

Moral character asks: what does this man value, and does he act on it honestly? By that measure Brutus in Act 1 scores very high. He states his principles openly, he admits his love for Caesar even when it complicates his position, he refuses to be rushed, he distinguishes his private thoughts from his public conduct, and he extends to Cassius the trust he himself deserves.

Political effectiveness asks: does this man's conduct produce the results he intends, in the world as it actually is? Act 1 does not yet test Brutus by that measure — he has decided nothing — but it shows, with great care, the habits that will be tested. Three of them matter.

He judges people by his own honesty. Brutus assumes that others mean what they say because he means what he says. When Cassius protests that he is not a flatterer, Brutus accepts it. When Cassius describes Casca's roughness as a disguise, Brutus accepts that too ("And so it is"). He never asks what Cassius gains. An

honest man's picture of other people is drawn from the inside of his own character, and it is systematically too generous. In politics, that is not a small flaw; it is the flaw.

He can be led through his ideals. We have seen this at length: honour, the general good, the fear of a king, the name Brutus — each is a handle, and Cassius takes hold of each in turn. Political skill includes the ability to notice when one's own ideals are being used as instruments. Brutus notices the persuasion ("What you would work me to, I have some aim") but not that his ideals are being used as tools; he thinks Cassius is appealing to his principles, which is true, and does not think Cassius is *using* them, which is also true.

He mistrusts theatre — in a city that runs on it. Brutus is "not gamesome"; he lacks Antony's "quick spirit"; he will not watch the race. He is, temperamentally, the least theatrical man in Act 1. Yet Act 1 shows, through Casca's report, exactly how Roman politics works: a crowd that claps and hisses Caesar "as they use to do the players in the theatre", a crown offered and refused three times to rising cheers (so Casca says; the audience never sees it), a leader who bares his throat for effect. Caesar and Antony are performers; the people are an audience. A man who despises the show is at a disadvantage in a state where the show decides. **LITERARY INTERPRETATION:** many critics see this as the deepest of Brutus's political limitations — not stupidity, but a principled refusal to compete for the crowd — and Act 1 lays it out in the contrast between the man who stays away from the games and the men who win them.

Moral quality (Act 1 evidence)	Political consequence it invites
Honesty — he says what he thinks ("I would not, Cassius, yet I love him well")	Predictability: an opponent, or a friend, can plan around a man who announces his values
Trust — "That you do love me, I am nothing jealous"	Blindness to manipulation by those who genuinely love him
Idealism — "If it be aught toward the general good"	He can be led by anyone who frames a proposal as the general good
Caution — "Be any further moved"	Admirable, but it postpones decisions rather than testing the persuader
Dislike of display — "I am not gamesome"	Weakness in a politics run on spectacle and crowd feeling

A labelled glance ahead (not Act 1 evidence): every entry in the right-hand column becomes an event later in the play, and you will meet them in the Class X portion — the decisions Brutus takes about who should be spared and who should speak, the way the crowd is won and lost, the quarrel with Cassius over means, the choices before Philippi. Do not learn those events from this chapter; learn from this chapter the habits that produce them, so that when you reach Acts III–V you can write, truthfully, that the tragedy was already visible in Scene 2.

CROSS-REFERENCE Where this analysis connects

The seduction itself, line by line, is taught in 'Act 1 Scene 2 (Part One) — Lupercalia, the Soothsayer, and the Seduction of Brutus'. Cassius's methods are the subject of 'Cassius — The Manipulation Masterclass'. The crowd whose theatre Brutus despises is analysed in 'Act 1 Scene 1 — The Street: Commoners, Tribunes and the Fickle Crowd' and in the mob-psychology section of 'Themes of Act 1 (Part Two)'. For how Act 1 material reappears in Acts III–V, see 'The Scene Connection Engine and Where Act 1 Reappears Later'.

Brutus's Language

You can identify Brutus with your eyes shut. Nobody else in Act 1 talks like him, and the way he talks is the most reliable evidence of the kind of man he is. Four habits define his speech.

He speaks of himself in the third person. "poor Brutus, with himself at war"; "Brutus had rather be a villager". Other characters do this too — Caesar most of all ("always I am Caesar"), and Cassius in Scene 3 ("Cassius from bondage will deliver Cassius") — but Brutus's version is different in tone. Caesar's third person is a monument; Brutus's is a kind of distance, as if he were describing a man he is trying to judge fairly. It goes with the hedges — "some soil, perhaps", "some part", "some aim" — which soften almost every claim he makes about himself. **LITERARY INTERPRETATION:** many readers hear in this a man observing himself from outside, consistent with the mirror exchange; some hear also a touch of self-regard, the sound of a man conscious of his own name. The text permits both.

His nouns are abstract. Honour, death, the general good, "passions", "conceptions", "high things", "these times", "hard conditions". Where Cassius's Caesar has lips, an eye, a tongue, a fever and a body that has to be dragged out of the Tiber, Brutus's Rome has no body at all. Even his one vivid passage — the reading of Caesar's procession, with its "angry spot" and "ferret" eyes — is vivid about other people; about himself and his cause he stays with abstractions.

His syntax (sentence structure) is conditional and balanced. "If it be aught toward the general good, / Set honour in one eye and death i' th' other / And I will look on both indifferently". The *if* comes first; the two eyes are balanced against each other; the verb of judgement comes last. Compare "What you have said / I will consider; what you have to say / I will with patience hear" — two matched clauses, past and future, weighed like the two eyes. This is the grammar of a judge, and it is no accident that his register (the kind of vocabulary a speaker chooses) is often legal: "construe", "repute", "recount hereafter", "find a time / Both meet to hear and answer". He uses words that belong to hearings.

His imagery, when it comes, turns inward or domestic. War inside the self; a mirror; and, at the end, food: "chew upon this". The one striking metaphor he chooses for Cassius's arguments is that of something to be slowly digested — the opposite of Cassius's sparks and fire. Even his diagnosis of Caesar is literal ("the falling sickness") where Cassius's is figurative.

Cassius's rhetoric is the mirror opposite, and the chapter 'Cassius — The Manipulation Masterclass' treats it fully. Here is the comparison in one table.

Feature	Brutus	Cassius
How he refers to himself	Third person, distanced and hedged: "poor Brutus, with himself at war"; "some soil, perhaps"	First person, physical and heroic: "so from the waves of Tiber / Did I the tired Caesar"
Kind of noun	Abstract: honour, death, "the general good", "passions", "high things"	Concrete: "angry flood", "coward lips", "huge legs", "meat", "Colossus"
Sentence shape	Conditional and balanced: "If it be aught... Set honour in one eye and death i' th' other"	Interrogative (question-asking) and accumulating: "Upon what meat doth this our Caesar feed / That he is grown so great?"
Imagery	Sparse, inward, domestic: "with himself at war"; "chew upon this"	Vivid, bodily, mythic: Aeneas carrying old Anchises out of burning Troy, the giant Colossus, Caesar crying out "As a sick girl"
Attitude to time	Deferring: "I shall recount hereafter"; "find a time"	Urgent: "Men at some time are masters of their fates"

The effect of the contrast is exact. Brutus sounds like a man reasoning in public with himself; Cassius sounds like a man working on an audience. One is trying to be fair; the other is trying to win. In Act 1, the second style is put entirely at the service of moving the first — and the first, being fair, listens.

TEXT NOTE Small variants in Brutus's lines

Editions differ in tiny ways in this part of the scene. Cassius's "Thy honourable mettle may be wrought" is printed with *metal* in some texts (the Globe-based texts used alongside Folger for this book have *metal*): the two spellings were interchangeable in Shakespeare's time and the pun on shaping metal is present either way. In Cassius's protest "Were I a common laughter", some editions print *laugher* (one who laughs) and others, including Folger, *laughter* (a laughing-stock); the sense of the whole sentence is unaffected. The word *behaviors* in Brutus's speech is printed in the American spelling by all the texts used for this book; your own edition may modernise or anglicise it. None of these variants changes meaning, and none will be tested; you simply should not be alarmed when your school text differs by a letter from a quotation here.

HISTORICAL CONTEXT The historical Brutus — and how Shakespeare reshaped him

HISTORICAL RECORD. Marcus Junius Brutus lived from about 85 to 42 BC. His mother, Servilia, was for many years Caesar's mistress, which produced an ancient rumour that Caesar was Brutus's father; modern historians reject it on grounds of chronology (Caesar would have been about fifteen when Brutus was born), but the rumour tells you how close the two houses stood. Brutus's uncle was Cato the Younger, the most uncompromising defender of the Republic and a byword for Stoic austerity (the Stoics taught self-control and indifference to pleasure, pain and death); when Brutus later married Cato's daughter Porcia (after Cato's death), he bound himself to Cato's house a second time. The label 'Stoic' is often attached to Brutus himself, and it fits his temper; strictly, it belongs more exactly to Cato. In the civil war of 49 BC Brutus sided with Pompey, against Caesar, even though, as Plutarch records, Pompey had been responsible for the death of Brutus's own father; after Pompey's defeat at Pharsalus in 48 BC Caesar pardoned him, gave him the governorship of Cisalpine Gaul in 46 BC, and in 44 BC made him urban praetor — the more prestigious of the two praetorships, over Cassius, who received the lesser one and, according to ancient sources, resented it. Cassius, meanwhile, was married to Brutus's sister Junia Tertia. Ancient writers record that in the months before the Ides anonymous messages appeared, on the tribunal (the raised platform from which Brutus as praetor gave judgement) and on the statue of the first Brutus, urging him to act — in effect 'Brutus, are you asleep?' and 'You are no true Brutus'. He killed himself after the defeat at Philippi in October 42 BC.

How Shakespeare converts the record. The anonymous messages become, in Scene 3, Cassius's *forged* letters — placed, with great fidelity to the record's locations, "in the Praetor's chair", "in at his window" and "with wax / Upon old Brutus' statue", and written "In several hands... As if they came from several citizens". Where history has a spontaneous public appeal, Shakespeare has a deliberate deception by a friend. The change is enormous: it makes Brutus's decision rest partly on a lie, and it hands the audience knowledge that Brutus never has. The pardon and the praetorship, which in the record bind Brutus to Caesar by gratitude, appear in the play only as Cassius's bare remark that Caesar "loves Brutus". Porcia is present in Scene 2's opening stage direction as 'Portia' but does not speak in Act 1. And Caesar's remark, recorded by Plutarch, that he did not fear fat, long-haired men but pale, thin ones — meaning Brutus and Cassius — is given by Shakespeare to Caesar as a judgement on Cassius alone, so that Brutus disappears from Caesar's field of suspicion entirely.

Brutus in Act 1 and the ICSE Examination

ICSE EXAM BOX How this chapter earns marks

The honest position first. Act 1 belongs to the Class IX portion of the ICSE syllabus, and is normally examined in school through reference-to-the-context or extract questions. The Class X board paper sets its drama extracts from Acts III, IV and V (each extract question carries 16 marks; in the 2025 paper every one had five sub-parts marked 3, 3, 3, 3 and 4). So you will not be asked, in the board examination, to explain the honour speech as an extract. What the board paper does do — and the 2025 paper is an example — is assume that you know Act 1: it asked what 'the work the ides of March begun' referred to, which is unanswerable without the Soothsayer and the conspiracy of Act 1. Character sub-questions in Act III–V extracts ('What does this reveal about Brutus?') are answered far better by a student who knows where Brutus's honour, idealism and trust came from.

Three ways Act 1 Brutus enters an Act III–V answer. First, as origin: when an extract shows Brutus justifying or regretting the assassination, one sentence tracing the principle back to his Act 1 declaration that he loved honour more than he feared death shows the examiner you know the arc. Second, as contrast: when Brutus and Cassius disagree in Act IV, the Act 1 pattern — Cassius vivid and practical, Brutus abstract and principled — is the same pattern, and naming it earns analysis marks. Third, as irony: any extract in which Brutus trusts someone he should not can be illuminated by the fact that in Act 1 he told Cassius "That you do love me, I am nothing jealous" while Cassius was planning forged letters.

For Class IX extract questions on Scene 2 the typical sub-parts are: who is speaking to whom and what has just happened; explain a phrase in your own words (phrases that lend themselves to this kind of question include "with himself at war", "passions of some difference", "Set honour in one eye and death i' th' other", and "Brutus had rather be a villager"); what the lines reveal about Brutus; and what follows. Practise these in 'Extract-Based Training (Part One)'. Do not predict the paper; prepare the character.

What never to write. Do not call Brutus stupid, weak or a traitor without qualification — every such word contradicts a piece of Act 1 evidence. Do not say he 'decides to kill Caesar' in Act 1 — he decides nothing in Act 1. Do not attribute the 'richest alchemy' speech to Cassius; it is Casca's, endorsed by Cassius. Do not quote lines from later acts as if they were in Act 1.

KEYWORDS Vocabulary for writing about Brutus

Term	Meaning	Where it applies in Act 1
political idealism	judging politics by what ought to be rather than what is	"If it be aught toward the general good"; the villager sentence
moral conflict	two values, both held sincerely, pulling in opposite directions	"I would not, Cassius, yet I love him well"; "with himself at war"
civic duty	the obligation a citizen owes to the state above private interest	"a son of Rome"; the honour speech
political naïveté	inexperience or over-trust in reading political motives (a term to use carefully; in Act 1 it applies to Brutus's reading of Cassius, not of others)	"That you do love me, I am nothing jealous"
integrity	wholeness of character; acting on stated principles	he declares his principles before hearing the proposal
stoic restraint	self-control, refusal to display emotion or be hurried	"I am not gamesome"; "Be any further moved"; hedged self-description
susceptibility	openness to being influenced	"Thy honourable mettle may be wrought"; "who so firm that cannot be seduced?"

The question below is a Class IX-style character question; it is also, in disguise, the question that every Act III–V answer about Brutus quietly depends on.

WEAK ANSWER**'What do we learn about Brutus in Act 1 Scene 2?' — an answer that would score poorly**

Brutus is a very noble and honourable man. In this scene he talks to Cassius who tells him that Caesar is becoming too powerful. Brutus does not want Caesar to be king because he loves Rome. He is confused and does not know what to do. Cassius tells him stories about Caesar swimming and being ill. Brutus says he will think about it. He is very idealistic and patriotic and he wants the best for Rome. Cassius decides to write letters to Brutus. In the end Brutus decides to kill Caesar because Cassius convinces him. Brutus is a tragic hero because he is too trusting and weak.

Why it scores poorly: it is a summary with adjectives attached. There is not one quotation. 'Noble and honourable' is asserted, not shown. It contains a factual error (Brutus decides nothing in this scene) and a misreading (he is not 'confused' — he knows exactly what Cassius is doing). It never mentions his love for Caesar, his reading of the procession, his questioning of Casca, or his caution. It ends with a label ('tragic hero') the scene has not yet earned.

EXCELLENT ANSWER**'What do we learn about Brutus in Act 1 Scene 2?' — an answer that would score highly**

Act 1 Scene 2 shows Brutus almost entirely through conversation with Cassius, and what we learn is a set of qualities that are admirable and dangerous at once. He is a man in conflict before anyone has spoken to him: he describes himself as "poor Brutus, with himself at war", troubled by "passions of some difference". When the crowd shouts, we learn what the war is about — "I do fear the people / Choose Caesar for their king" — and, in the same breath, that he loves the man he fears for: "I would not, Cassius, yet I love him well." That word *yet* is the scene's centre. He is a man of principle who states his terms before hearing Cassius's proposal: if the matter serves "the general good" he will weigh honour and death "indifferently", loving "The name of honour more than I fear death". He is perceptive about others — he reads Caesar's anger, Calpurnia's pallor and Cicero's "fiery eyes" in the returning procession, and questions Casca precisely about the crown — and he is cautious: "What you would work me to, I have some aim", he tells Cassius, refusing to be "any further moved" that day. Yet the scene also shows his vulnerability. He accepts as a general truth that "the eye sees not itself / But by reflection" and lets Cassius be his glass; he trusts Cassius's love without question; and his idealism makes him prefer to be "a villager" than a Roman under a king. Cassius's closing soliloquy confirms what we have half seen — "Thy honourable mettle may be wrought" — so that we leave the scene knowing Brutus to be honourable, intelligent and loving, and knowing too that these very qualities are the handles by which he will be moved.

Why it scores highly: it is organised by qualities, not by plot; every quality is pinned to a quotation; it distinguishes what Brutus says from what Cassius says about him; it notices the tension inside each virtue; and it stays strictly within the scene while pointing, in its final sentence, to why the scene matters for the rest of the play.

REVISION Brutus in Act 1 — what to carry with you

1. He appears only in Scene 2 and has no soliloquy; we see him from outside and through others' praise.
2. His first line relays the Soothsayer's warning to Caesar.
3. Inner conflict before any argument: "with himself at war", "passions of some difference".
4. Republican fear triggered by a sound: "I do fear the people / Choose Caesar for their king".
5. Love and fear for the same man: "yet I love him well".
6. The honour speech: condition (general good), value (honour), cost (death); he loves "The name of honour".
7. Sharp reader of others (procession, Casca), poor reader of himself (the mirror).
8. Knows he is being persuaded — "What you would work me to, I have some aim" — and trusts anyway.
9. Cassius's verdict: "Thy honourable mettle may be wrought"; "who so firm that cannot be seduced?"
10. Why he is essential: reputation as "richest alchemy", the people's love, the name, the ancestor, and access to Caesar.
11. Language: abstract, conditional, third-person, judicial (like a judge weighing a case) — against Cassius's vivid, bodily, urgent rhetoric.
12. History into drama: public graffiti become a friend's forged letters.

CHAPTER 10

The Soothsayer, the Ides of March, and the Supporting Cast

This chapter takes the people of Act 1 whom school notes usually rush past, and shows you why Shakespeare put each of them there. Part A is a slow, professor-level reading of a single line, "Beware the ides of March": what it literally says, what the Ides were in the Roman calendar, and how one sentence spoken by a nameless man in a crowd sets the clock for the whole tragedy and opens the play's great argument about fate and free will. Part B turns to the supporting cast — Antony, Casca, Cicero, Cinna, the tribunes, the Cobbler and Carpenter, Calpurnia and the crowd itself — and asks of each one: what is the evidence, what is the function, and what will an examiner expect you to know? A foreshadowing map and a full character map close the chapter.

PART A — THE SOOTHSAYER AND THE IDES OF MARCH

The moment itself: what actually happens

Before we analyse anything, you must be able to see the moment. Read it as a director would.

Caesar has just entered Rome's public square in procession. It is the feast of Lupercal (the Lupercalia, a February festival of purification and fertility at which young men ran through the city striking bystanders with goat-hide thongs). He gives two brisk domestic orders: Calpurnia must stand in Antony's way as he runs the ritual race, and Antony must remember to touch her so that she may "Shake off their sterile curse". Antony answers with a line of total obedience. Caesar closes the business with "Set on and leave no ceremony out." The procession begins to move.

Then a single voice cuts through the trumpets:

Soothsayer: *Caesar.*

Caesar stops. "Ha! Who calls?" Casca, who has already once shouted the crowd into silence, does it again: "Bid every noise be still. Peace, yet again!" Caesar, now attending, speaks a line that tells us he has actually heard something unusual: "I hear a tongue shriller than all the music / Cry 'Caesar.' Speak. Caesar is turned to hear." And the Soothsayer says the five words that the entire play will circle:

Soothsayer: *Beware the ides of March.*

Caesar does not understand at first — or pretends not to: "What man is that?" It is Brutus, of all people, who repeats the warning to him: "A soothsayer bids you beware the ides of March." Caesar demands to look at the man — "Set him before me. Let me see his face." — and it is Cassius, the future instigator, who fetches him: "Fellow, come from the throng. / Look upon Caesar." Caesar gives the man a second chance: "What sayst thou to me now? Speak once again." The Soothsayer simply repeats himself, word for word: "Beware the ides of March." And Caesar delivers his verdict in three short sentences:

Caesar: *He is a dreamer. Let us leave him. Pass.*

A trumpet call (the stage direction says *Sennet*) and everyone leaves except Brutus and Cassius. The whole exchange is fifteen lines long. Shakespeare spends more time on the Cobbler's puns than on the prophecy of Caesar's death. That brevity is itself a choice, and we will come back to it.

Difficult words in this passage (learn them now; they recur in exam extracts):

Word / phrase	Simple meaning	Note
soothsayer	a truth-teller; a fortune-teller or prophet	Old English <i>sooth</i> = truth. The word itself claims that what he says is true.
the press	the crowd, the crush of people	Not a newspaper. Caesar asks who "in the press" is calling him.
shriller	higher and more piercing	The voice is thin and sharp enough to cut through music.
ides	the middle marker-day of a Roman month	Explained fully below.
throng	crowd	Cassius tells the man to "come from the throng".
dreamer	someone who sees visions; also, dismissively, someone whose head is in the clouds	Caesar's word deliberately allows both meanings.
Sennet	a set of trumpet notes announcing a ceremonial entrance or exit	A stage direction, not spoken.

Literal meaning: what the sentence actually says

Take the sentence at its plainest. **Beware** means 'be on your guard against'. **The ides of March** is a date, and only a date: the fifteenth of March. So the literal instruction is: 'be careful on 15 March'.

Notice what the sentence does *not* say. It does not say what to fear, or from whom, or where, or how. It names a time and nothing else. This is the classic shape of a prophecy in literature — precise about one thing and silent about everything that would allow the hearer to act on it. A warning that only names a day is almost useless as advice; Caesar could stay at home on 15 March (and in Act 2 he very nearly does), but he cannot know what he is avoiding. **LITERARY INTERPRETATION:** many critics observe that the vagueness of the warning is exactly what allows the play to test Caesar's character rather than his information. He is not given a fact to check; he is given a choice about whether to take a stranger seriously.

Notice, too, that the Soothsayer says it twice, in identical words. When Caesar asks him to "Speak once again", a lesser dramatist would have had the man elaborate. Shakespeare has him repeat. The effect is of a message that cannot be negotiated, expanded or bargained with. It simply is. The repetition is also practical stagecraft: an Elizabethan audience in a noisy open-air playhouse hears the key line twice, so no one misses it.

Finally, look at the grammar of the name. **Ides** looks like a plural, and in Latin (*Idus*) it is a plural noun — yet it names a single day. English keeps the plural form: we say 'the Ides of March *are* come', never 'is'. When you meet this in Act 3, do not think it is a mistake.

Historical meaning: the Ides of March in the Roman calendar

HISTORICAL CONTEXT How Romans dated a month: Kalends, Nones, Ides

HISTORICAL RECORD. Romans did not count the days of a month from 1 to 30 as we do. Each month had three fixed marker-days, and every other date was reckoned by counting *backwards* from the next marker:

- **Kalends** — the first day of the month. The word comes from the Latin verb meaning 'to call out', because the priests originally announced the new month aloud. Our word *calendar* descends from it.
- **Nones** — the fifth day of most months, but the seventh in March, May, July and October. The name means 'ninth', because the Nones fell nine days before the Ides by the Roman inclusive way of counting.
- **Ides** — the thirteenth day of most months, but the **fifteenth** in March, May, July and October (the four months that were originally longer). In the oldest Roman calendar, which followed the moon, the Ides marked the full moon.

The Ides of every month were sacred to **Jupiter**, the king of the gods; a sacrifice was offered to him on that day. So the Ides of March means the fifteenth of March, a holy day of Jupiter, in the middle of what had once been the first month of the Roman year.

In **44 BC** the Ides of March was the day on which the real Julius Caesar was assassinated at a meeting of the Senate held in the Curia of Pompey, a hall attached to Pompey's great theatre complex — not, as Shakespeare has it, on the Capitol. The ancient biographers record that a seer — Suetonius names him **Spurinna**; Plutarch leaves him nameless — had warned Caesar that he faced danger which would come no later than the Ides of March. Shakespeare's Soothsayer has no name; he is Spurinna stripped down to a voice.

Why does this matter to you as a reader? Because Shakespeare's Soothsayer is not inventing a superstition; he is naming a date that every educated person in the 1599 audience already knew. The Ides of March was, and remains, one of the few dates from antiquity that ordinary people can recite. That fact changes everything about how the line works in the theatre, which brings us to dramatic irony.

TEXT NOTE The word 'ides' in your edition

Some school editions print 'Ides' with a capital letter, some without; Folger and the MIT text both use lower case within the line. Neither is wrong. In an answer, either is acceptable, but be consistent. What matters is never to write 'Ide of March' in the singular.

Dramatic irony: the audience knows the date; Caesar does not

Dramatic irony is the gap between what a character knows and what the audience knows. It is not the same as sarcasm or verbal irony (saying one thing and meaning another). It is a structural device: the playwright arranges for us to hold knowledge that the person on stage lacks, so that we watch every word and gesture with a double awareness.

Here the gap could hardly be wider. Caesar hears 'the ides of March' as an empty date — one more day in a busy calendar. We hear it as the day of his death. When he says "He is a dreamer", we know that the dreamer is the one person on stage who is fully awake to reality. When he says "Pass", he is dismissing not a beggar but the truth. And there is a further twist that repays close reading: Caesar says "Caesar is turned to hear" and then does not, in any meaningful sense, hear. He demands to see the man's face — "Let me see his face" — and, having looked, sees nothing. The whole exchange is built around eyes and ears that do not do their job.

LITERARY INTERPRETATION: this is one of the reasons the exchange sits so close to Cassius's mirror speech a few lines later, in which Brutus admits that "the eye sees not itself / But by reflection, by some other things." Act 1 Scene 2 is full of failures of sight: Caesar looks at the Soothsayer and sees a dreamer; Brutus cannot see himself; Caesar reads Cassius's danger correctly but then boasts he does not fear him. The Soothsayer scene is the first and clearest instance of a leader looking straight at a warning and not seeing it.

The word **dreamer** rewards a second look. To an Elizabethan, a 'dreamer' could be a visionary — someone to whom truths are revealed in dreams — or simply an idle fantasist. Caesar means the second; the play proves the first. And there is a sting the audience may feel that Caesar cannot: the man who dismisses a dreamer will, in Act 2, be given a true dream by his own wife, and will dismiss that too. The pattern is set here.

There is one more layer. Dramatic irony works only if the audience genuinely knows. Shakespeare could rely on it because the death of Caesar was among the best-known stories in Europe: grammar-school boys read Caesar in Latin, Plutarch's *Lives* had been available in Sir Thomas North's English translation since 1579, and the title of the play itself promised a tragedy. In this play, then, dramatic irony is not a trick played on a few sharp spectators. It is the play's basic condition, shared by everyone in the house. You, reading it in Class 10 already knowing how Act 3 ends, are in exactly the position Shakespeare designed the play for. That is not a disadvantage; it is the intended experience.

Foreshadowing: the difference between a prophecy and a plant

Students often use 'foreshadowing' and 'prophecy' as if they were the same thing. They are not, and the distinction earns marks.

A **prophecy** is something a *character* does: the Soothsayer predicts the future inside the story.

Foreshadowing is something the *author* does: Shakespeare plants a hint early so that a later event feels prepared, inevitable, and rich with meaning when it arrives. The Soothsayer's line is both at once — a prophecy inside the fiction and a piece of foreshadowing in the design — which is why it is such a useful example to write about.

But the Soothsayer is only the loudest of several plants in Act 1. Some are spoken warnings; some are images; some are small facts that will grow. Flavius's fear that Caesar will "soar above the view of men / And keep us all in servile fearfulness" foreshadows the tyranny the conspirators claim to prevent. Brutus's confession that he is "with himself at war" foreshadows the sleepless orchard soliloquy (a speech spoken alone on stage, thinking aloud) of Act 2 and, ultimately, his self-destruction. Cassius's plan to throw "Writings, all tending to the great opinion / That Rome holds of his name" through Brutus's windows foreshadows the moment Brutus reads them. Casca's storm foreshadows Calpurnia's omens. Even the offhand news that Marullus and Flavius "are put to silence" foreshadows how this Rome will deal with dissent — with a knife, in the end, in both directions.

You will find all of these gathered in the **FORESHADOWING MAP** later in this chapter, with a third column telling you exactly what to say about each in an answer. For now, hold on to the principle: *foreshadowing is not a guessing game about the plot. It is the way a tragedy teaches its audience to feel that what happens had to happen.*

Fate: the reading in which the Soothsayer is the voice of destiny

LITERARY INTERPRETATION. One strong and long-established reading treats the Soothsayer as the voice of **fate** — the Roman *fatum*, the thing that has been 'spoken' by the gods and cannot be unspoken. On this reading, the play's universe is one in which the future is fixed, the signs of it are everywhere (the Soothsayer, the storm, the lion, the owl at noon, Calpurnia's dream, the birds that will hover over Cassius's army before the battle of Philippi in Act 5), and human beings are free only to read the signs well or badly. Caesar reads them badly and dies. Cassius, who begins by denying the signs, ends by half-believing them, and also dies. Brutus pays the signs almost no heed until Caesar's ghost visits him in Act 4, and dies. The Soothsayer, in this reading, is the still point around which the whole machine turns: he knows, and knowing does him no good, because knowledge cannot alter fate.

There is a real philosophical puzzle buried here, and a good student should be able to state it. *Why warn a man of something that cannot be avoided?* A warning only makes sense if the future is open. Yet the play never gives Caesar a realistic chance of avoiding the Ides — every attempt to keep him home is overturned. So the Soothsayer's warning is at once an invitation to choose and a proof that choice is useless. Tragedy lives in exactly that contradiction. You do not have to resolve it. You have to be able to see it and say it.

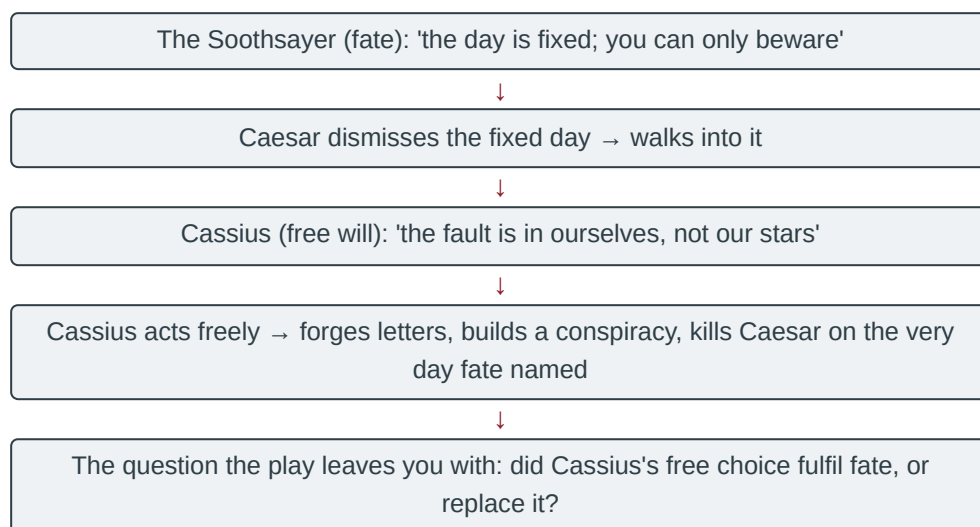
Free will: Cassius's counter-claim, and the play's central tension

Now set against the Soothsayer the most famous sentence Cassius speaks in Act 1, in the middle of his long attempt to win Brutus:

Cassius: *Men at some time are masters of their fates. / The fault, dear Brutus, is not in our stars, / But in ourselves, that we are underlings.*

Stars here means astrological destiny — the belief, very much alive in 1599, that the positions of the planets at one's birth shaped one's life. **Underlings** are inferiors, people beneath others. Cassius is saying: the reason we are Caesar's inferiors is not written in the heavens; it is our own fault, and therefore our own to correct. This is a declaration of **free will** — the doctrine that human beings choose and are responsible for their choices.

Here is the shape of the tension, laid out as a chain:



LITERARY INTERPRETATION — presented as interpretation, not fact. Notice that the Soothsayer and Cassius never meet or argue, yet the play sets them side by side within a hundred lines of each other, as if to stage a debate without telling us who wins. Three observations are worth making in any essay:

1. *Cassius's free will produces exactly what fate predicted.* The conspirators choose the Ides of March for their own practical reasons, yet by choosing it they make the Soothsayer right. Free action and destiny arrive at the same place. Many critics read this as Shakespeare's refusal to decide between the two — or as his suggestion that human choices *are* the instrument through which fate works.
2. *Cassius does not even believe his own doctrine consistently.* In Act 1 Scene 3, on the night of the storm, the man who said the fault is not in our stars is busily reading the heavens: he tells Casca the prodigies (unnatural, ominous happenings) are heaven's way of making "instruments of fear and warning / Unto some monstrous state", and that the night resembles a man — Caesar. He uses omens when they are useful to his argument. **HISTORICAL RECORD:** the real Cassius was a follower of Epicurus, a philosophy that dismissed omens; Shakespeare seems aware of this, because (GLANCE AHEAD to Act 5) Cassius will admit before Philippi that he has begun to give some credit to things that presage. The 'master of his fate' ends up superstitious.
3. *Brutus stands between them.* He belongs to neither camp: he is not a reader of signs like the Soothsayer and Casca, nor a proud denier of fate like Cassius. He simply acts on what he believes to be right and lets consequence follow. (GLANCE AHEAD) This is why his last words in Act 5, in which he speaks of the Ides of March as the beginning of a 'work' that the day of Philippi must end, are so moving: he adopts the Soothsayer's date as the name of his own free choice.

This is the tension that teachers and examiners usually label 'fate and free will', and *The Themes of Act 1 (Part Two)* chapter develops it across every scene. What you should take from this chapter is the pairing itself: the Soothsayer and Cassius are the two poles, and Caesar and Brutus are the men crushed between them.

Caesar's response: three sentences and a gesture

Caesar: *He is a dreamer. Let us leave him. Pass.*

Read this aloud. Eleven words, three sentences, almost every word a single syllable. After the ceremonial fullness of "Set on and leave no ceremony out" and the alert curiosity of "Caesar is turned to hear", the rhythm snaps shut. Each sentence is shorter than the one before: a judgement, a decision, a command. The last word, "Pass", is an order to the whole procession — and to the future — to move along.

What does this reveal? Three things, which you can use in any question on Caesar's character.

First, the public Caesar. He speaks of himself in the third person — "Caesar is turned to hear" — a habit that will grow through the play until he talks about 'Caesar' as if the name belonged to a statue rather than a man. The Soothsayer scene is where you first hear it clearly. It is the voice of a man who has become his own public image.

Second, the judge by appearances. Caesar's instinct, faced with a warning, is to *look at the man* — "Set him before me. Let me see his face." He believes that he can read danger in a face; he will say so at length about Cassius later in the scene, when he calls for "men about me that are fat, / Sleek-headed men, and such as sleep a-nights." His reading of the Soothsayer's face produces the word 'dreamer'. It is the wrong reading, and the audience knows it; the play has quietly told us that Caesar's confidence in his own eye is misplaced, a full act before it kills him.

Third, the man who cannot afford to be seen fearing. Consider where he is: in the public square, on a feast day, with the crowd watching. A leader who stops a procession because a stranger shouted a date would look frightened. "Pass" protects the image. **LITERARY INTERPRETATION:** many readers feel that Caesar's

dismissiveness is not stupidity but performance — that he must be seen to disdain fear because, as he says later of himself, "always I am Caesar". This reading makes his fate more tragic, not less: he dies of the role he has to play.

HISTORICAL RECORD, for a deeper point: the real Caesar held the office of *pontifex maximus*, the chief priest of Rome, who presided over the state religion — including the colleges of priests whose business was the reading of omens. Shakespeare does not mention this, but the historically informed reader sees an additional irony: the head of Rome's official religion brushing aside a reader of signs.

Now look at who else speaks in this exchange, because it is the detail that separates a good answer from an excellent one.

Brutus: *A soothsayer bids you beware the ides of March.*

Why Brutus? Shakespeare had a stage full of people who could relay the words; he chose the man who will strike Caesar on that day. There is nothing sinister in Brutus's tone — he is simply being helpful, standing close enough to Caesar to answer for him, which tells us how intimate the two men are. But the audience hears the future assassin pronouncing the sentence of death in the form of a courtesy. And then Cassius, the instigator, physically brings the prophet forward: "Fellow, come from the throng. / Look upon Caesar." The warning is framed between the two men who will make it come true. **LITERARY INTERPRETATION:** the text leaves their inner states unreadable here — this is before Cassius has said a word of temptation — and that is precisely why the framing works. Neither man yet knows he is the danger being announced.

Audience knowledge: why a play with no suspense is still gripping

A film director once distinguished between *surprise* and *suspense*. Surprise is a bomb going off under a table without warning: a few seconds of shock. Suspense is showing the audience the bomb under the table and then letting two characters chat about the weather for ten minutes: every trivial word becomes unbearable, because we know and they do not. *Julius Caesar* is a suspense play in this sense, and the Soothsayer is the moment Shakespeare shows us the bomb.

From this line onward the audience carries a date. Every scene in Acts 1 and 2 is measured against it. When Cicero asks Casca in the storm, "Comes Caesar to the Capitol tomorrow?", the word *tomorrow* lands with a weight it would not otherwise have, because we can count. When Cassius tells Cinna it is "after midnight", we know which day has just begun. Shakespeare has turned his entire audience into soothsayers: we all know what Caesar does not, and we watch him with the helpless clarity of the man he called a dreamer.

PROFESSOR'S INSIGHT Why the Soothsayer appears so early

Caesar has been on stage for barely a dozen lines — a summons to his wife, an order where she should stand, an instruction to Antony, a command to the procession — when the Soothsayer's voice interrupts. Shakespeare gives us the prophecy of the death before we have properly met the man who will die. Why not save it, build Caesar up, and then puncture him?

Three answers. First, *the play is not a mystery*. Shakespeare knows that his audience knows the ending; pretending otherwise would be false. By announcing the date at once he converts a plot into a countdown, and a countdown creates a far more intense kind of attention than a puzzle does. Second, *character before biography*. Shakespeare never shows us Caesar's conquests; he shows us Caesar dismissing a warning. The first substantial thing this Caesar does is refuse to listen, and that single act tells us more about why he will die than any account of Gaul could. Third, and most subtly, *the source of the warning*. The voice comes from "the press", from the anonymous crowd, not from a senator or a priest. Truth in this play speaks from below — a nameless man, later a poet in the street — and the great men do not hear it. Placing the Soothsayer in the first minutes of Caesar's entrance establishes the pattern that will destroy him: the people at the top of Rome are surrounded by information they are too grand to use.

The five levels: how to hold this moment in your head**LEVEL 1 — What happened?**

During the Lupercal procession, a soothsayer in the crowd calls out to Caesar and warns him, twice, to beware the ides of March. Brutus repeats the warning; Cassius brings the man forward; Caesar looks at him, calls him "a dreamer", and orders the procession to move on.

LEVEL 2 — What does it mean?

The Ides of March is 15 March, the historical day of Caesar's assassination. The warning names the day without explaining the danger. Caesar's dismissal shows his public confidence, his reliance on reading faces, and his refusal to appear afraid in front of the crowd.

LEVEL 3 — Why did Shakespeare write it this way?

Because the audience already knows the date, the scene creates dramatic irony rather than suspense about *what* will happen; the interest shifts to *how* and *why*. The brevity and repetition make the warning feel absolute. Giving the relaying line to Brutus and the fetching line to Cassius quietly frames the warning between the two men who will fulfil it. Placing it in Caesar's first minutes on stage makes dismissal of warnings the very first thing we learn about him.

LEVEL 4 — How does it connect to the whole play?

It opens the fate-versus-free-will argument that Cassius answers with "Men at some time are masters of their fates." It begins Caesar's pattern of ignoring warnings (Calpurnia's dream, the augurers — the priests who read omens — and Artemidorus's letter in Act 2). The Soothsayer returns in Act 2 Scene 4 and Act 3 Scene 1, where Caesar's remark that the Ides have come is answered with the reminder that they have not yet gone. Brutus, in Act 5, names the Ides of March as the beginning of the 'work' his death must finish.

LEVEL 5 — How do I use it in an ICSE answer?

In a Class IX extract question on this passage, the sub-questions are likely to ask where the scene is set and what is happening, what the Soothsayer's words mean, why Caesar reacts as he does, what his reaction reveals about him, and what happens immediately afterwards (Brutus and Cassius are left alone). For Class X use, see the exam box below. In either case, always connect: 'Caesar's dismissal of the Soothsayer in Act 1 is the first of several warnings he ignores.'

ICSE EXAM BOX Where this actually earns marks

EXAM-ORIENTED ADVICE. Act 1 belongs to the Class IX portion of the syllabus, so the Soothsayer passage itself is a school-examination extract, not a board-paper one. But the 2025 ICSE board paper asked candidates to explain what 'the work the ides of March begun' refers to — a Class X question that cannot be answered without this Act 1 scene. Expect the phrase 'the ides of March' to surface in Acts III and V extracts, and be ready to explain in one clean sentence: the Soothsayer's warning in Act 1 Scene 2, the date of the assassination in Act 3 Scene 1, and Brutus's use of the phrase before Philippi. No question is guaranteed; the knowledge is.

WEAK ANSWER A weak answer to 'Why does Caesar dismiss the Soothsayer?'

'Caesar dismisses the Soothsayer because he is arrogant and does not believe in fortune-tellers. He calls him a dreamer and goes away. This shows he is overconfident.'

EXCELLENT ANSWER An excellent answer to the same question

'Caesar dismisses the Soothsayer with three short, dismissive sentences — "He is a dreamer. Let us leave him. Pass." — after insisting on looking at the man's face. His response reveals his habit of judging by appearances and his need, in a crowded public square on a feast day, not to be seen taking fright at a stranger's words; he speaks of himself in the third person as "Caesar", the public image rather than the man. Because the audience knows that the Ides of March is the day of his death, the dismissal is heavy with dramatic irony: the man he calls a dreamer is the only one awake to the truth. It is also the first instance of a pattern — he will later brush aside Calpurnia's dream and the augurers — so the moment characterises Caesar and foreshadows his fall at once.'

Notice what the strong answer does that the weak one does not: it quotes exactly, it names the device (dramatic irony) and explains *how* it works here, it reads a detail (the third person, the demand to see the face), and it connects forward. Four moves, one paragraph.

Relationship to later events: where the Ides of March goes next

Everything below is a **GLANCE AHEAD** beyond the verified Act 1 text. Later-act wording is given only as paraphrase in single quotes; do not quote these as if they were exact.

GLANCE AHEAD — Act 2 Scene 1. Brutus, unable to sleep, has his servant check the calendar for the date; the conspirators gather in his orchard before dawn. The Ides are now hours away, and Brutus is the one counting.

GLANCE AHEAD — Act 2 Scene 2. Calpurnia — the woman whose pale cheek Brutus noticed in Act 1 — has dreamt of Caesar's death and begs him not to go to the Capitol. The priests' sacrifice yields a bad omen. Caesar wavers, then lets Decius Brutus reinterpret the dream as a lucky one, and goes. This is the Soothsayer scene replayed at length: warning, hesitation, dismissal. What Act 1 did in fifteen lines, Act 2 does in a whole scene, so that the audience can watch the pattern harden into fate.

GLANCE AHEAD — Act 2 Scene 3 and Scene 4. Artemidorus writes Caesar a letter naming the conspirators — a warning that, unlike the Soothsayer's, gives real information — and Caesar will not read it. Then the Soothsayer himself returns, met by Portia in the street; he tells her he fears what may happen to Caesar and goes to find a place from which to speak to him again. Shakespeare brings back the nameless man so that the Ides do not arrive without their prophet.

GLANCE AHEAD — Act 3 Scene 1. On the way to the Senate, Caesar sees the Soothsayer and, in effect, taunts him: the Ides of March have come. The Soothsayer answers that they have come, but not yet gone. Within a few minutes Caesar is dead. The exchange is the direct payoff of Act 1 Scene 2, and examiners writing on Act 3 extracts assume you know its origin.

GLANCE AHEAD — Act 5 Scene 1. Before Philippi, Brutus tells Cassius that this same day must end 'that work the ides of March begun'. The date has become the name of the entire enterprise — the assassination, the civil war, and his own approaching death. The Soothsayer's five words have travelled from a warning to Caesar into the epitaph (the words written over a grave) of the men who killed him.

THE FORESHADOWING MAP

Act 1 warning / omen	How it gains meaning later (GLANCE AHEAD)	What you should say about it
The Soothsayer: "Beware the ides of March." (Act 1 Scene 2)	Caesar is killed on that date in Act 3 Scene 1, having mocked the Soothsayer moments before; Brutus names the date as the beginning of his 'work' in Act 5.	Prophecy inside the story and foreshadowing in the design; dramatic irony because the audience knows the date; the play's first statement of fate.
Caesar: "He is a dreamer. Let us leave him. Pass." (Act 1 Scene 2)	Caesar dismisses Calpurnia's dream, the priests' omen and Artemidorus's letter in Act 2, and the Soothsayer again in Act 3.	Establishes a pattern of ignored warnings; shows the public Caesar who cannot be seen to fear; characterises and foreshadows at once.
Brutus: "Calpurnia's cheek is pale" (Act 1 Scene 2)	Calpurnia's terrified pleading and her dream in Act 2 Scene 2.	The silent, watchful wife is a barometer of danger; her paleness anticipates her fear.
Antony: "When Caesar says 'Do this,' it is performed." (Act 1 Scene 2)	Antony's total loyalty drives the funeral oration in Act 3 Scene 2 and the pursuit of the conspirators.	Loyalty as Antony's defining trait; ironic because the man of pure obedience will become the most independent actor in Rome.

Act 1 warning / omen	How it gains meaning later (GLANCE AHEAD)	What you should say about it
Brutus: "I do lack some part / Of that quick spirit that is in Antony." (Act 1 Scene 2)	Brutus underestimates Antony, spares him in Act 2 Scene 1, and lets him speak at the funeral in Act 3.	Brutus reads Antony as a mere sportsman; that misjudgement is fatal to the conspiracy.
Cassius: "Writings, all tending to the great opinion / That Rome holds of his name" (Act 1 Scene 2)	Brutus reads the forged letters in his orchard in Act 2 Scene 1 and is pushed over the edge.	Deception at the root of the 'honourable' conspiracy; Cinna carries the papers in 1.3.
Casca: "Marullus and Flavius... are put to silence." (Act 1 Scene 2)	Caesar's intolerance of dissent; the mob's silencing of Cinna the poet in Act 3 Scene 3.	Casual delivery of a chilling fact; the first casualty of Caesar's power; the republican tribunate under attack.
Casca on the crowd: "as they use to do the players in the theatre" (Act 1 Scene 2)	The crowd is swayed by Brutus, then reversed by Antony, in Act 3 Scene 2; it tears a poet apart in 3.3.	The crowd as an audience that applauds whoever performs best; the decisive force of the play has no fixed loyalty.
The storm and prodigies (Act 1 Scene 3)	Calpurnia lists the same kind of portents in Act 2 Scene 2; Caesar's ghost appears in Act 4.	The supernatural as warning; characters 'construe' the signs to suit themselves.
Cicero: "men may construe things after their fashion" (Act 1 Scene 3)	Decius construes the dream; Brutus construes Caesar's ambition; the crowd construes Antony's speech.	The interpretive key to the whole play: meaning is made by the reader of the sign.
Cassius: "Men at some time are masters of their fates." (Act 1 Scene 2)	Cassius dies at Philippi on his birthday, having misread a battlefield report; he admits he has begun to credit omens.	The free-will pole of the play's central tension; ironically fulfilled and undercut at once.
Casca: "he sits high in all the people's hearts... like richest alchemy" (Act 1 Scene 3)	Brutus's reputation legitimises the murder in Act 3 and briefly wins the crowd.	The conspiracy needs Brutus's name more than his sword; explains why Cassius works so hard on him.

PART B — THE SUPPORTING CAST OF ACT 1

A supporting character is not a minor character. In a play as economical as this one, every named person who speaks is doing a job the protagonists cannot do for themselves. For each figure below you will find the same three things: the **evidence** (what the text actually gives you), the **function** (why Shakespeare needs this person here), and the **exam value** (what an examiner reasonably expects you to know, with honesty about the Class IX / Class X split).

Antony: the loyal executor

SHAKESPEARE'S TEXT. Antony speaks four times in Act 1, six lines in all, and is spoken *about* far more than he speaks. The stage direction brings him on "for the course" — stripped for the ritual race of the Lupercal. Caesar addresses him by the formal 'Antonius' and gives him a task; Antony's reply is the defining line:

Antony: *I shall remember. / When Caesar says 'Do this,' it is performed.*

Later in the scene, Caesar calls him again — "Antonius." — "Caesar." — and confides his suspicion of Cassius. Antony answers, "Fear him not, Caesar; he's not dangerous. / He is a noble Roman, and well given." (**well given** = well disposed, of good character.) Caesar's reply tells us what Caesar sees in Antony: "He loves no plays, / As thou dost, Antony; he hears no music" — Antony is a lover of plays and music, a man of

pleasure. Brutus has already contrasted himself with him: "I am not gamesome. I do lack some part / Of that quick spirit that is in Antony" (**gamesome** = fond of sport; **quick spirit** = liveliness). And in Casca's report the crown was offered by "Mark Antony" — Casca's plain answer to "Who offered him the crown?" is "Why, Antony." In Act 1 Scene 3 he is Caesar's messenger even offstage: Caesar "did bid Antonius / Send word" to Cicero about the Senate meeting.

FUNCTION. Antony in Act 1 is the executor — the man who turns Caesar's words into deeds. Notice that his defining line is grammatically impersonal: not 'I perform it' but "it is performed", as if the doing were automatic, without an agent. He is Caesar's body in public (the runner in the race), Caesar's hand in ceremony (the crown-offerer), Caesar's ear in private (the confidant told to "Come on my right hand"). Everyone else in the scene defines him by contrast: Brutus is grave where Antony is playful; Cassius is lean and reads much where Antony loves plays and sleeps at night — Caesar's ideal of the safe man, "Sleek-headed men, and such as sleep a-nights", is more or less a portrait of Antony.

There is one moment where the executor's judgement is tested, and he fails: "he's not dangerous." Antony misreads Cassius. **LITERARY INTERPRETATION:** the text leaves open whether this is genuine naivety or the soothing diplomacy of a man who tells his master what calms him. Either way it matters: in Act 1, the shrewdest political mind in the play appears to be Caesar's, not Antony's.

What Act 1 plants for Act 3. Three seeds. First, *loyalty as identity*: the funeral oration is Antony doing, on a vast scale, what he promised in one line — performing Caesar's will after Caesar can no longer speak it. Second, *the theatre-lover*: Caesar's remark that Antony loves plays is, in retrospect, a professional description; the man who will hold up Caesar's torn mantle (cloak) and make a crowd weep understands performance as Brutus does not. The crown-offering in Casca's report is his rehearsal — a public show staged for a crowd, with Caesar as the actor. Third, *Brutus's misreading*: because Brutus sees in Antony only "quick spirit" and gamesomeness, he will (GLANCE AHEAD) refuse to have him killed in Act 2 and allow him to speak in Act 3. Act 1 shows you exactly why Brutus makes that mistake.

EXAM VALUE. In Class X board questions on Antony's oration (Act 3 Scene 2), sub-questions asking what Antony had done for Caesar 'earlier', or why Brutus underestimated him, are answered from Act 1: he offered the crown, he was Caesar's loyal executor, he was known as a lover of plays and sport. Be able to quote "When Caesar says 'Do this,' it is performed" and explain that Antony's obedience in Act 1 becomes his vengeance in Act 3.

PROFESSOR'S INSIGHT Why Antony's few Act 1 lines are enough to set up Act 3

Six lines seem a slender foundation for the man who will turn the play upside down. But Shakespeare is not building Antony's *character* in Act 1; he is building everyone else's *misreading* of him, and that is what Act 3 needs.

Watch how the information arrives. We do not see Antony offer the crown — we hear it through Casca, who thinks the whole affair was "mere foolery". We do not hear Antony reason — we hear Caesar say that he loves plays and music, a remark meant as a compliment to Antony's harmlessness. We hear Brutus set himself apart from Antony's "quick spirit" as a serious man distances himself from a sportsman. Every lens through which we see Antony in Act 1 diminishes him, and every lens belongs to a man who will pay for the error. The one line he speaks in his own voice, "it is performed", sounds like servility. Only afterwards does it read as a promise.

This is the technique: plant a character in the *blind spot* of the other characters. The audience, who knows the story, registers the irony; the conspirators, who do not, walk past him. When Antony finally speaks at length in Act 3, the shock is theirs, not ours — and Act 1 is the reason we were never fooled.

Casca: cynic in the sunlight, coward in the storm, first recruit at midnight

SHAKESPEARE'S TEXT. Casca has three faces in Act 1, and the exam wants you to know all three.

In the procession he is Caesar's crowd-controller, the officious (self-importantly busy) voice twice demanding quiet: "Peace, ho! Caesar speaks." and "Bid every noise be still. Peace, yet again!"

After the games, alone with Brutus and Cassius, he is the play's first narrator, and a sour one. Cassius has warned that Casca will tell the news "after his sour fashion". His account of the crown-offering is dripping with contempt for everyone involved: "It was mere foolery; I did not mark it." Caesar "put it by with the back of his hand, thus" — a gesture Casca mimics. The crown "'twas not a crown neither; 'twas one of these coronets" (a **coronet** is a small, lesser crown) — he belittles even the object. Yet Casca is a sharp observer despite himself: "to my thinking, he would fain have had it"; Caesar "was very loath to lay his fingers off it" (**fain** = gladly; **loath** = reluctant). His contempt for the crowd is physical — "the rabblement hooted and clapped their chopped hands and threw up their sweaty nightcaps and uttered such a deal of stinking breath" — and so is his joke: "I durst not laugh for fear of opening my lips and receiving the bad air." Asked about Cicero, he claims ignorance: "Ay, he spoke Greek", and "for mine own part, it was Greek to me." Even his acceptance of a dinner invitation is grudging: "Ay, if I be alive, and your mind hold, and your dinner worth the eating."

Once he is gone, Brutus and Cassius supply the key to him. Brutus: "What a blunt fellow is this grown to be! / He was quick mettle when he went to school." (**quick mettle** = lively spirit, keen temperament.) Cassius: "So is he now in execution / Of any bold or noble enterprise, / However he puts on this tardy form. / This rudeness is a sauce to his good wit" (**tardy form** = a sluggish manner; **sauce** = seasoning that sharpens). The sullenness, Cassius says, is a costume.

In the storm of Act 1 Scene 3 the costume falls away. Casca enters with his sword drawn — "I ha' not since put up my sword" — and breathless: "Are not you moved, when all the sway of earth / Shakes like a thing unfirm?" The prose cynic now speaks verse, and frightened verse. He believes the portents (signs of coming disaster) mean something: "It is the part of men to fear and tremble / When the most mighty gods by tokens send / Such dreadful heralds to astonish us." And yet, when Cassius works on him, he pledges himself first of anyone we actually see recruited on stage: "You speak to Casca, and to such a man / That is no fleering telltale. Hold. My hand. / Be factious for redress of all these griefs, / And I will set this foot of mine as far / As who goes farthest." (**fleering** = sneering, mocking; **telltale** = informer; **factious** = active in forming a faction.) He also shows he understands why Brutus matters: "he sits high in all the people's hearts", and his reputation, "like richest alchemy", will turn the crime into virtue.

FUNCTION. Casca does two jobs no one else can. First, he is the *filter* through which we receive the crown scene. Shakespeare could have staged Antony offering the coronet; he chose instead to have it *reported*, by the most jaundiced (bitter, prejudiced) witness available. The result is that the audience never sees Caesar refuse the crown — it sees Casca's Caesar, who "would fain have had it", performing for a herd. Whether that is fair to Caesar is something the text deliberately leaves open. Second, Casca is the *weather-vane of Roman nerve*: the man who scorned the crowd's fear is himself terrified by the storm, and it is fear, as much as principle, that Cassius turns into commitment. Watching Casca recruited is watching how a conspiracy actually grows: not by argument alone but by shared dread and the offer of a hand.

The prose–verse shift is a genuine textual fact worth a sentence in any answer: Casca reports the games in prose (the register — the level and tone of language — of cynicism and gossip) and describes the storm in verse (the register of awe). The form changes because the man does.

On 'Greek to me'. Educated Romans of Cicero's class spoke Greek fluently; it was the language of philosophy and high culture. When Casca says Cicero's remark "was Greek to me", he may be confessing genuine ignorance, or — given Brutus's memory of his schooldays — playing the blunt soldier who will not admit to learning. The phrase has since become an English idiom for anything incomprehensible, and this line did more than any other to fix it in the language.

HISTORICAL RECORD and GLANCE AHEAD. The historical Publius Servilius Casca Longus struck the first blow at the assassination, and Shakespeare keeps this: in Act 3 Scene 1 it is Casca who strikes first. The first recruit becomes the first hand. In an Act 3 extract question, being able to say that Casca's readiness was already visible in his pledge to Cassius in Act 1 Scene 3 marks you out.

EXAM VALUE. Class IX extracts on Casca's report are common in school papers: expect sub-questions on why he calls the offering "foolery", what "Greek to me" means, what the report reveals about Caesar and about the crowd, and how Brutus and Cassius describe Casca afterwards. In Class X, Casca's first blow and his role in the storm scene are the usual points of contact.

Cicero: the sceptic who is never asked

SHAKESPEARE'S TEXT. Cicero is on stage throughout Act 1 Scene 2 and never speaks. We see him only through Brutus's eyes when the procession returns: "Cicero / Looks with such ferret and such fiery eyes / As we have seen him in the Capitol, / Being crossed in conference by some senators." (**ferret** eyes = small, red and angry, like the animal's; **crossed in conference** = contradicted in debate.) Casca reports that at the games "he spoke Greek", and that "those that understood him smiled at one another and shook their heads" — an educated, coded disapproval that the crowd, and Casca, could not follow.

In Act 1 Scene 3 he speaks at last, and every line is cool where Casca's is hot. He opens with plain questions — "Good even, Casca. Brought you Caesar home? / Why are you breathless? And why stare you so?" — and, when Casca pours out the prodigies, he answers with the most quietly important sentence in the scene:

Cicero: *Indeed, it is a strange-disposèd time. / But men may construe things after their fashion, / Clean from the purpose of the things themselves.*

(**construe** = interpret; **clean from** = entirely away from.) Then a practical question — "Comes Caesar to the Capitol tomorrow?" — and a sensible exit: "Good night then, Casca. This disturbèd sky / Is not to walk in." He leaves before Cassius enters. He is never in the same conversation as the conspiracy.

FUNCTION. Cicero is, for most readers, the play's voice of reason, and Shakespeare uses him to state, once, the rule by which the whole play operates: signs mean what their readers decide they mean. Casca reads the storm as divine anger; Cassius, minutes later, reads it as a portrait of Caesar and a licence to kill; (**GLANCE AHEAD**) Decius will read Calpurnia's dream as good fortune, Brutus will read Caesar's future as tyranny, the crowd will read Antony's tears as truth. Cicero names the mechanism and then walks out of the play's action, leaving everyone else to demonstrate it. **LITERARY INTERPRETATION:** many critics see in his exit a judgement — that the one man capable of standing outside the fever of interpretation has no place in the story that follows. The text does not say this; the staging suggests it.

His Greek matters too. It marks him as the intellectual, the man whose criticism of Caesar takes the form of a witty remark in a learned language rather than a dagger. **HISTORICAL RECORD:** the real Cicero (106–43 BC) was Rome's greatest orator, fluent in Greek, and was not part of the conspiracy; he was killed on the orders of the triumvirs (the three men — Antony, Octavius and Lepidus — who seized power after Caesar's death) in December 43 BC.

GLANCE AHEAD — his exclusion. In Act 2 Scene 1 the conspirators debate whether to invite Cicero; Brutus rejects him on the grounds that he will never follow anything other men begin. The sceptic of Act 1 Scene 3 is kept out for exactly the quality Act 1 showed us: he thinks for himself.

EXAM VALUE. Class IX extracts from the storm scene regularly ask what Cicero means by construing things "after their fashion" and how his attitude differs from Casca's. In Class X, the question of why Cicero was left out of the conspiracy touches Act 2, but the character evidence for the answer is here.

Cinna: the messenger of the letters (not the poet)

SHAKESPEARE'S TEXT. Cinna enters Act 1 Scene 3 late and in a hurry. Cassius identifies him in the dark by his walk — "'Tis Cinna; I do know him by his gait. / He is a friend." — and Cinna's first words show a nervous man checking who is present: "To find out you. Who's that? Metellus Cimber?" He has felt the night's terror too: "What a fearful night is this! / There's two or three of us have seen strange sights." Then he says the thing the entire conspiracy is thinking: "O Cassius, if you could / But win the noble Brutus to our party—". Cassius cuts him off and loads him with the forged letters — "take this paper, / And look you lay it in the Praetor's chair, / Where Brutus may but find it; and throw this / In at his window; set this up with wax / Upon old Brutus' statue." Cinna obeys: "Well, I will hie / And so bestow these papers as you bade me." (**hie** = hurry; **bestow** = place.)

FUNCTION. Cinna is the hand that makes Cassius's soliloquy real. At the end of Act 1 Scene 2 Cassius *planned* to throw writings "in at his windows" as if "from several citizens"; in Act 1 Scene 3 the plan becomes paper in a man's hands, and the three placements — the praetor's chair (Brutus's official seat), his window (his private house), the statue of his ancestor who drove out the kings — are aimed at Brutus's public role, his private conscience and his family honour in turn. Cinna's line about winning "the noble Brutus" also confirms, from a second mouth, that the conspiracy wants Brutus's *name*. He and Casca ("richest alchemy") say the same thing in the same scene; Cassius's whole campaign is thus shown to be the will of the group, not one man's obsession.

Distinguish him from Cinna the poet. This Cinna is **Lucius Cornelius Cinna**, a conspirator (**HISTORICAL RECORD:** praetor in 44 BC). (GLANCE AHEAD) In Act 3 Scene 3 an entirely different man, Cinna the poet, is seized by the mob after the funeral; he protests that he is not the conspirator, and the crowd kills him for his name anyway. **LITERARY INTERPRETATION:** this is one of the play's cruellest ironies, and it reaches straight back to Act 1 Scene 2, where Cassius argued that a name is only a sound — "'Brutus' and 'Caesar'—what should be in that 'Caesar'?" The mob answers him: a name is enough to kill for. Students who confuse the two Cinnas lose marks on an easy MCQ; students who *connect* them gain marks on a hard essay.

EXAM VALUE. Multiple-choice and short recall questions ('Who was given the letters to place for Brutus?') are the likeliest form. Any Act 3 Scene 3 extract on Cinna the poet expects you to say who the other Cinna was and what he did in Act 1.

Flavius and Marullus: the tribunes who are 'put to silence'

The tribunes are examined at length in *Act 1 Scene 1 — The Street*; here we look only at what Act 1 does with them *after* their scene. In Act 1 Scene 1 they scatter the holiday crowd — "Hence! Home, you idle creatures, get you home!" — and set off to strip Caesar's statues: "Disrobe the images / If you do find them decked with ceremonies." Their motive is republican fear: to pluck the "growing feathers" from Caesar's wing before he can "soar above the view of men".

Then they disappear, and their end arrives as an afterthought in Casca's mouth: "I could tell you more news too: Marullus and Flavius, for pulling scarves off Caesar's images, are put to silence." (**scarves** = the decorations on the statues; **put to silence** = deprived of the power to speak in public — deposed from office, or worse.)

FUNCTION. Two things. First, the *manner* of the telling. Casca treats the destruction of two tribunes as gossip, on a level with "more foolery". The offhandedness is Shakespeare's point: in this Rome, the silencing of elected officials is a small item after the sports report. Second, the *institution*. **HISTORICAL RECORD:** tribunes of the plebs were sacrosanct — their persons were protected by religious law — and their office existed to shield the people from the powerful; the historical tribunes Marullus and Flavius were deposed by Caesar in 44 BC after removing a diadem (a royal headband, the Greek sign of kingship) from his statue and arresting men who hailed him as king. Whatever "put to silence" means precisely (the text does not say, and you should not pretend it does), the fact that Caesar can silence tribunes at all is the clearest evidence in Act 1 that the Republic's safeguards are failing. It is the only concrete exercise of Caesar's power inside Rome that we hear of in the whole act — and it is exactly the kind of act the conspirators claim to be preventing.

TEXT NOTE The tribunes in the Act 1 Scene 2 stage direction

The Folger text, following the First Folio, brings Marullus and Flavius on at the start of Act 1 Scene 2 "after them" — silently trailing Caesar's procession, moments after they had told the crowd to disperse. The MIT (Globe) text omits them. Editors differ about whether they should appear; if they do, the staging is pointed: the two men who tried to stop the celebration walk in the celebrant's train, and by the end of the scene they have been silenced. Your school edition may or may not list them; do not build an answer on the stage direction alone.

EXAM VALUE. Class IX extracts from Act 1 Scene 1 almost always ask what the tribunes fear and what they decide to do; being able to add, from Act 1 Scene 2, what happened to them — and that we learn it only through Casca's throwaway report — turns a plot answer into a character-and-theme answer. In Class X, the tribunes are the first evidence to cite whenever a question on Acts III–V asks whether the conspirators' fear of Caesar's tyranny was justified.

The Cobbler and the Carpenter: the crowd with faces

They are fully treated in the Scene 1 chapter; here is the point that matters for Act 1 as a whole. The Cobbler and the Carpenter are the *only* ordinary Romans in Act 1 who speak. They speak prose, in their "best apparel", on a working day, and their reason is simple: "we make holiday to see Caesar and to rejoice in his triumph." The Cobbler is witty — "a mender of bad soles", "I can mend you", a "surgeon to old shoes" — and he holds his own against two magistrates for a dozen lines. Then Marullus turns the full force of oratory on the crowd — "You blocks, you stones, you worse than senseless things!", "Knew you not Pompey?" — and they fold: "They vanish tongue-tied in their guiltiness."

FUNCTION. Shakespeare gives the crowd a face and a voice *before* he turns it into a roar. Because we have met a cobbler who can pun and reason, we know that the crowd is not stupid. Because we have watched him fall silent under a well-made speech, we know it is movable. That double knowledge — intelligent, pliable — is what Act 1 Scene 2 and (GLANCE AHEAD) Act 3 Scene 2 depend on. Without the Cobbler, the "tag-rag people" of Casca's report would be a mere caricature; with him, they are us.

EXAM VALUE. For Class IX, the Cobbler's exchange with the tribunes is a natural Act 1 extract for school papers: expect to explain his puns ("soles", "mend you", "recover", "awl"), to say why the tribunes are angry, and to describe the mood of the crowd before and after Marullus speaks. For Class X, the Cobbler is the face

you should give the crowd whenever an Act 3 Scene 2 or Act 3 Scene 3 question asks what the plebeians are like — intelligent, good-humoured, easily swayed — because the board extracts on the mob assume you already know this.

Calpurnia: three words and a pale cheek

SHAKESPEARE'S TEXT. Calpurnia speaks three words in Act 1: "Here, my lord." Caesar summons her twice by name, positions her in the runners' path, and explains why in front of the whole procession: "The barren, touchèd in this holy chase, / Shake off their sterile curse." Later Brutus notes, in the returning train, that "Calpurnia's cheek is pale".

What she stands for. Four things, each of which can anchor a paragraph.

1. *The heir Caesar does not have.* Caesar announces his wife's childlessness publicly, as a matter of state ritual. **LITERARY INTERPRETATION:** a republican magistrate does not need an heir; a *king* does. Caesar's anxious concern with fertility is, to many readers, the first quiet sign that he already thinks dynastically — of founding a ruling family — before anyone has offered him a crown. **HISTORICAL RECORD:** the marriage was indeed childless; Caesar's only legitimate child, Julia, had died in 54 BC, and his will would adopt his great-nephew Octavius. Audiences in 1599 may also have felt the resonance with their own ageing, unmarried, heirless queen, though you should say 'may have felt', not 'felt'.
2. *The private Caesar.* Calpurnia is the only glimpse Act 1 gives of Caesar at home. The glimpse is not tender: he commands, she answers, and her body is made the site of a public ritual.
3. *Obedient silence.* "Here, my lord." is total submission. (GLANCE AHEAD) In Act 2 Scene 2 she will find a voice — pleading, arguing, kneeling — and lose. Act 1 shows the silence that Act 2 breaks.
4. *The barometer.* Her pale cheek is the first sign the audience receives that something has gone wrong at the games, before Casca tells us what. Calpurnia registers danger in her body before anyone speaks of it; her dream in Act 2 is the same instinct raised to prophecy. She and the Soothsayer are the play's two readers of danger whom Caesar overrules.

EXAM VALUE. In Class X, Act 2 Scene 2 is not on the board paper either, but Calpurnia's dream is referred to in Acts III–V; for Class IX, extract questions on the opening of Act 1 Scene 2 may ask why Caesar wants Antony to touch her and what this reveals. The word "barren" and the phrase "sterile curse" should be explained exactly.

The Crowd as a character

Treat the Roman crowd as a single character with an arc, because Shakespeare does.

Act 1 Scene 1 — celebration, then shame. The crowd is on holiday, in its best clothes, to "rejoice in his triumph". The tribunes remind it of Pompey and it slinks home; Flavius reads the retreat as guilt — "See whe'er their basest mettle be not moved."

Act 1 Scene 2 — the crowd as sound. Now the crowd never appears. It is a noise offstage — the stage directions say *Flourish and shout, Shout. Flourish* — and Brutus and Cassius interpret the noise: "What means this shouting? I do fear the people / Choose Caesar for their king." ... "Another general shout!" The crowd has become a force, felt through walls. Then Casca gives it back its body in the ugliest terms in the play: "the rabblement hooted and clapped their chopped hands and threw up their sweaty nightcaps"; "the tag-rag people"; "the common herd"; the "Three or four wenches" who "cried 'Alas, good soul!' and forgave him with all their hearts" — and of whom Casca says, "if Caesar had stabbed their mothers, they would have done no less." His sarcastic "mine honest neighbours" seals the contempt.

The theatre metaphor. Casca's most important sentence is this: "If the tag-rag people did not clap him and hiss him, according as he pleased and displeased them, as they use to do the players in the theatre, I am no true man." The crowd is an *audience*; Caesar is a *player*. This is why he "plucked me ope his doublet and offered them his throat to cut" (a **doublet** is a close-fitting Elizabethan jacket — Shakespeare dresses his Romans in the clothes of his own London) — a theatrical gesture to a house — and why, recovering from his fit, "he desired their Worships to think it was his infirmity": a performer apologising to his public in mock-humble language (calling commoners 'Worships' as if they were magistrates). **LITERARY INTERPRETATION:** the Globe's own audience, standing in the yard in their own sweaty caps, was being described to itself. The play knows that political power in Rome — and perhaps in London — is a matter of who performs best for the crowd. Casca despises the crowd; the play does not, because it knows the crowd decides.

Decisive without a face. Everything that matters in Act 1 is a reaction to what the crowd wants: Brutus fears they will "Choose Caesar for their king"; Cassius needs Brutus because "he sits high in all the people's hearts". Caesar, in Casca's report, offers the crowd his throat the moment he perceives that "the common herd was glad he refused the crown" — he is reading the room. (GLANCE AHEAD) In Act 3 the same crowd will be talked into approving the murder and then talked into avenging it in the space of a single scene.

EXAM VALUE. The crowd is the Act 1 'character' most likely to matter in the Class X paper, because Act 3 Scene 2 — the funeral orations — is a mob scene, and sub-questions on it often ask what the crowd's behaviour reveals. A sentence of Act 1 evidence — the holiday crowd shamed by Marullus, the offstage shouts, Casca's "players in the theatre" — shows the examiner that you understand the crowd as a consistent character across the play, not a fresh invention of Act 3.

PROFESSOR'S INSIGHT

Why Shakespeare gives the crowd no individual names in 1.2 yet makes it decisive

In Act 1 Scene 1 we meet a Cobbler and a Carpenter — men with trades, jokes and a reason to be in the street. In Act 1 Scene 2 those men are gone. The crowd is "the press", "the throng", an offstage shout, "the rabblement", "the tag-rag people", "the common herd", "wenches". Not one commoner speaks.

The change is deliberate and it works in two directions at once. Towards the *patricians* (the aristocratic families who ran Rome), it shows us how they see the people: as a mass, a noise, a smell — Casca's "stinking breath" is the aristocrat's whole political philosophy in two words. Brutus, Cassius and Casca never once refer to a citizen as an individual, and their conspiracy to save 'Rome' will be made without consulting a single Roman of the kind who makes shoes. Towards the *audience*, it shows us the crowd's real nature: it is not a person but a weather-system, and the men on stage are constantly checking the sky. Every shout changes the conversation between Brutus and Cassius; Caesar's every gesture at the games is calibrated to it.

So the crowd is nameless *and* decisive for the same reason: it is the medium in which power exists. Give it a face and it becomes a character who can be argued with. Take the face away and it becomes the thing that everyone is arguing *about*. (GLANCE AHEAD) When individual voices return in Act 3 — 'First Plebeian', 'Second Plebeian' — they are still nameless, and the first person they name, they kill.

CHARACTER MAP OF ACT 1

Where a cell records an inference rather than something stated in the text, it is marked (*inferred*).

Character	Wants	Fears	Relationship to Caesar	Relationship to Brutus
Caesar	Public honour; to be seen as fearless; an heir (<i>inferred from the Lupercal ritual</i>)	Nothing, he claims ("always I am Caesar"); privately, lean men like Cassius, who "thinks too much"	—	Trusts him; Brutus stands close enough to answer for him
Brutus	To act honourably for "the general good"; to be left alone with his thoughts	That the people "Choose Caesar for their king"; loss of honour more than death	Loves him: "I love him well"	—
Cassius	To pull Caesar down; to win Brutus	Living "In awe of such a thing as I myself"	Resents his rise; saved him from the Tiber; Caesar "doth bear me hard"	Old friend; flatters and manipulates him
Antony	To serve Caesar; sport and pleasure	(<i>none shown</i>)	Executor and confidant: "When Caesar says 'Do this,' it is performed"	Contrasted with him by Brutus as "gamesome"
Casca	To seem unimpressed; later, safety and "redress"	The storm and the gods' "dreadful heralds"	Attendant in his train; contemptuous witness of his fit	Old schoolfellow; recognises his value to the plot
Cicero	To keep his head clear	Bad weather, not bad omens: the sky "Is not to walk in"	Critical: angered in the Senate; mocks in Greek	(<i>none in Act 1</i>)
Cinna	To win "the noble Brutus"	The "fearful night"	Conspirator against him	Places the letters aimed at him
Calpurnia	(<i>unspoken</i>) to obey; a child (<i>inferred</i>)	(<i>shown only as a pale cheek</i>)	Wife; publicly named "barren"	(<i>none</i>)
The Soothsayer	To be heard by Caesar	The ides of March	Warns him; is dismissed as "a dreamer"	Brutus relays his warning
Flavius and Marullus	To strip Caesar's images and disperse his supporters	Caesar soaring "above the view of men"	Opponents; "put to silence"	(<i>none</i>)
The Crowd (Cobbler, Carpenter, "the rabblement")	A holiday; a hero to cheer	The tribunes' anger, briefly	Cheers him, is shamed for it, cheers him again	Later, its love for Brutus is the plot's "richest alchemy"

ICSE EXAM BOX How Act 1's supporting cast earns marks in the Class X paper

EXAM-ORIENTED ADVICE. Since Acts III–V are the examined portion, Act 1 knowledge about these figures surfaces indirectly: Antony's oration (Act 3 Scene 2), Casca's first blow (Act 3 Scene 1), Cinna the poet (Act 3 Scene 3), any extract containing 'the ides of March', the omens recalled in later acts, and Cicero's death in the proscriptions (the triumvirs' death-lists) reported in Act 4 — each section above ends with the specific Act 1 evidence to bring. In the 16-mark drama extract question (sub-parts of 3, 3, 3, 3 and 4 marks), the 'what had happened earlier' and 'what does this reveal about character' sub-parts are precisely where a sentence of Act 1 evidence lifts a 2-mark answer to full marks. For Class IX, Act 1 extracts on any of these figures are the direct target. No question is guaranteed; every one of these connections is fair game.

REVISION Ten things to carry out of this chapter

1. The Ides of March = 15 March, a marker-day sacred to Jupiter; Caesar died on it in 44 BC.
2. The Soothsayer speaks the warning twice, in identical words; Brutus relays it; Cassius fetches the man.
3. "He is a dreamer. Let us leave him. Pass." — three shrinking sentences; the public Caesar; judging by faces.
4. Dramatic irony: the audience knows the date; Caesar hears only a date.
5. Prophecy is what a character does; foreshadowing is what the author does. The Soothsayer is both.
6. Fate (the Soothsayer) versus free will (Cassius: "The fault, dear Brutus, is not in our stars") is the play's central tension, and the conspirators' free choice fulfils the fated date.
7. Antony: four speeches, six lines; the executor whom everyone underestimates.
8. Casca: prose cynic in 1.2, verse coward in 1.3, first recruit, first blow in Act 3.
9. Cicero: "men may construe things after their fashion" — the key to how every sign in the play is read; excluded later for thinking for himself.
10. The crowd: named and witty in 1.1, nameless and decisive in 1.2; an audience that claps and hisses "the players in the theatre".

CROSS-REFERENCE Where to go next in this book

The tribunes, the Cobbler and the Carpenter are read line by line in *Act 1 Scene 1 — The Street: Commoners, Tribunes and the Fickle Crowd*. The Soothsayer exchange in its full context, and Cassius's mirror speech, are in *Act 1 Scene 2 (Part One) — Lupercalia, the Soothsayer, and the Seduction of Brutus*; Casca's report is in *Act 1 Scene 2 (Part Two)*; the storm, Cicero and Cinna in *Act 1 Scene 3 — The Storm*. Fate, free will, superstition and mob psychology are developed as themes in *Themes of Act 1 (Part Two)*. The forward links in the Foreshadowing Map are traced act by act in *The Scene Connection Engine and Where Act 1 Reappears Later*. Practice extracts on the Soothsayer passage and Casca's report are in the two *Extract-Based Training* chapters, and the marking logic behind the weak and strong answers above is set out in *ICSE Examiner Mode: How Marks Are Earned*.

CHAPTER 11

Themes of Act 1 (Part One): Power, Ambition, Republicanism, Liberty, Patriotism, Honour, Loyalty, Betrayal, Manipulation, Political Rhetoric, Public Opinion

What this chapter does: It takes the eleven political themes of Act 1 — the ones about who rules, who obeys, who is trusted and who is talked into things — and teaches each one properly: what the word means, where exactly Act 1 shows it, which characters carry it, what a careful reader notices that a hurried one misses, how the history behind it works, and how the theme grows into Acts 2 to 5. Every section ends with the vocabulary an ICSE examiner rewards. The chapter closes by showing how the themes collide with one another in Act 1 and how to turn any one of them into a paragraph that earns marks.

How to read the theme sections

A theme is not a topic. 'Power' is a topic; a theme is what the play keeps *doing* with power — testing it, doubting it, showing it from an angle you did not expect. So when you read a section below, do not look for a definition to memorise. Look for the *pressure* the play puts on the word.

Every theme section uses the same ten labels, and they are arranged to follow the five levels this course has used since Chapter 1. **Definition**, **Act 1 evidence**, **Important scenes** and **Characters** are Levels 1 and 2 — what happened, and what it means. **Quotations** is your evidence store; each one has been checked against the text, and you should learn them exactly. **Hidden significance**, **Historical context** and **Literary significance** are Level 3 — why Shakespeare built the theme this way and not another. **Connection to later Acts** is Level 4 — how Act 1 plants what Acts 2 to 5 harvest. **ICSE keywords** and the closing box are Level 5 — how the theme is turned into marks. Read them in order. A student who jumps to the keywords first produces an answer full of correct words attached to nothing.

One honesty note before we begin. Act 1 is the Class IX portion of the syllabus; the Class X board paper examines Acts III, IV and V. But every theme below is one the board paper will expect you to *already understand*: an answer about the crowd in the Forum, or about Brutus's reasons, or about Antony's loyalty, is judged partly on whether you know where those things began. This chapter is where they began.

CROSS-REFERENCE Where the other pieces of this picture live

The second half of the thematic map — fate, free will, superstition, omens, appearance versus reality, friendship, jealousy, political anxiety, leadership, the individual against the state and mob psychology — is in the chapter 'Themes of Act 1 (Part Two)'. For the two men who carry most of this chapter's themes, see 'Cassius — The Manipulation Masterclass' and 'Brutus in Act 1 — Honour, Conflict and Vulnerability'. The devices named below are catalogued in 'The Act 1 Literary-Device Bank'; the vocabulary in 'The ICSE Keyword Vault for Act 1'; the full set of learnable lines in 'The Act 1 Quotation Bank'. For how a theme answer is actually marked, read 'ICSE Examiner Mode: How Marks Are Earned' after this chapter, not before.

1. Power

Definition: In everyday language, power is the ability to make things happen and to make other people do what you want. Political thinkers split this into two words you should keep apart. 'Power' is the raw capacity to compel: an army, a crowd, a threat. 'Authority' is power that people accept as legitimate: a consul elected for a year, giving orders the law allows him to give. *Julius Caesar* is a play about the moment when one man's power has outgrown any authority the Republic can lawfully give him. In Act 1 the precise question is this: what happens inside a state when power and authority stop matching?

Act 1 evidence: Look first at how little Caesar has to do to be obeyed. His opening lines are a string of commands about a fertility rite — where Calpurnia should stand, what Antony should not forget — and Antony's answer is a maxim: "When Caesar says 'Do this,' it is performed." A stranger calls his name from the crowd; Caesar has him brought forward, looks at him, and dismisses him — "He is a dreamer. Let us leave him. Pass." That final single syllable is power in miniature — the ability to decide who is worth hearing. Behind him, the tribunes of Scene 1 have already told us what this power looks like from below: Caesar is a bird who, unless his "growing feathers" are plucked, will "soar above the view of men / And keep us all in servile fearfulness" (servile means slave-like). By the end of Scene 2 those tribunes have been "put to silence" for taking scarves off his statues — the phrase is deliberately vague, and editors differ over whether it means removed from office or worse; either way, the power that silences its critics is a power that no longer needs to argue. Meanwhile Casca has reported the crown offered and refused before a roaring crowd, and Caesar himself has described his own rule in a sentence that has no subject but himself: "for always I am Caesar." In Scene 3 Casca brings the last piece: the senators tomorrow "Mean to establish Caesar as a king". Power is about to be made permanent.

Important scenes: The end of Act 1 Scene 1 (Flavius's bird image — power as height); the opening of Act 1 Scene 2 (Caesar's commands — power as speech); Caesar's assessment of Cassius in the same scene (power as watchfulness); Casca's report of the crown (power tested before the crowd); and Casca's news of the Senate in Act 1 Scene 3 (power about to be legalised).

Characters: Caesar holds power; Antony is its instrument; the tribunes are the constitutional check that fails; Cassius offers the rival reading of what Caesar's power is made of; the crowd is the power nobody owns; and the Soothsayer represents the one power Caesar cannot command — knowledge of what is coming.

Quotations: - "When Caesar says 'Do this,' it is performed." — Antony, Act 1 Scene 2. Obedience so complete it has become a proverb. - "he doth bestride the narrow world / Like a Colossus" — Cassius to Brutus, Act 1 Scene 2. Power as a statue you walk beneath (bestride means to stand with a leg on each side). - "I rather tell thee what is to be feared / Than what I fear; for always I am Caesar." — Caesar to Antony, Act 1 Scene 2. - "Marullus and Flavius, for pulling scarves off Caesar's images, are put to silence." — Casca, Act 1 Scene 2.

Hidden significance: Caesar performs no powerful act on stage in the whole of Act 1. He arranges a ritual, asks who called him, dismisses a stranger, and talks to Antony about Cassius. Every mighty deed — the triumph, the crown, the swoon, the silencing of the tribunes — reaches us as report. This is LITERARY INTERPRETATION, but it is a strong one: Shakespeare shows power as it mostly exists in the world, as reputation plus other people's compliance. A second layer: power in Act 1 works increasingly through silence. The tribunes shame the commoners until they "vanish tongue-tied"; the regime then silences the tribunes; and Cassius plans to reach Brutus through anonymous letters he can never answer. Each stage of the Act removes a voice. A third layer is the body. Caesar's political body is a Colossus; his physical body, in Cassius's account and Casca's, shakes, groans, foams and falls, and Caesar himself admits "this ear is deaf". Whether that admission is plain honesty or a way of controlling which side Antony stands on, the text leaves open — and an examiner will reward you for saying so rather than deciding for Shakespeare.

Historical context: HISTORICAL RECORD: in February 44 BC Caesar had been made *dictator perpetuo*, dictator for life. The dictatorship was an emergency office, traditionally limited to six months; making it permanent broke the Republic's central safeguard. He was also consul for 44 BC with Antony as his colleague, so Antony's obedience in Scene 2 is the obedience of a consul to his equal — which tells you how unequal things had become. The real tribunes, Gaius Epidius Marullus and Lucius Caesetius Flavus, were deposed after they removed a diadem from Caesar's statue and arrested men who hailed him as king; historically this happened in January 44 BC, before the Lupercalia, and Shakespeare folds it into a single day. The triumph the commoners celebrate corresponds to Caesar's Spanish triumph of October 45 BC, which honoured victory over Pompey's sons — fellow Romans — and Plutarch records that people did not think it fitting. Marullus's outrage is therefore not invented; it is Roman.

Literary significance: The theme is carried by imagery of height and flight — Caesar would "soar above the view of men", he must be made to "fly an ordinary pitch" (pitch is the height a falcon climbs to), he is a Colossus, and Brutus, by contrast, "sits high in all the people's hearts". It is also carried by imagery of feeding: "Upon what meat doth this our Caesar feed / That he is grown so great?" Notice, too, Caesar's habit of speaking of himself in the third person — "Caesar is turned to hear", "for always I am Caesar" — a device called *illeism*, which makes a man sound like an institution. Structurally, Shakespeare withholds Caesar: he has few lines in Act 1 and is absent from Scene 3 entirely. Absence is a way of showing power; everyone talks about the man who is not there. All of this is shadowed by dramatic irony, because the power he asserts is precisely what is about to be taken from him.

ICSE keywords: power, authority, legitimacy, autocracy, tyranny, dictatorship, *illeism*, imperative, hubris, dramatic irony, reported action, hierarchy.

Connection to later Acts: Glance ahead to Act 2 Scene 2, where Caesar's power over himself is tested: Calpurnia pleads with him to stay at home and Decius talks him out of it. Glance ahead to Act 3 Scene 1, where the Colossus falls in a handful of lines and power immediately becomes the question of who can hold the crowd. Glance ahead to Act 3 Scene 2, where Antony demonstrates that in Rome the decisive power is power over the crowd's feelings, and to Act 4 Scene 1, where three men divide the world on a list of names. In Act 5 Brutus and Cassius die believing that Caesar's power has outlived his body. The arc of the whole play, planted here, is that power moves from a man to a name.

2. Ambition

Definition: Ambition is a strong desire to rise — to gain power, rank or fame. In modern English it is usually a compliment. In Rome, and in this play, it is closer to an accusation. The Latin *ambitio* originally described 'going around' to canvass for votes, and it acquired the sense of grasping for office by improper means. The

Republic admired the man who served his year and stepped down; it feared the man who wanted to stay. So when a Roman calls Caesar 'ambitious' he means something exact: Caesar wants what a citizen must not want — to be king. The precise sense you need is 'aspiration to unconstitutional, permanent, personal power'.

Act 1 evidence: Begin with a fact that surprises most students. The noun 'ambition' occurs once in the whole of Act 1, and the adjective 'ambitious' once. The noun belongs to Cassius, alone on stage, planning forged letters in which "Caesar's ambition shall be glanced at" (glanced at means hinted at). The adjective belongs to Casca, describing a storm: "Th' ambitious ocean swell and rage and foam". The only thing openly called ambitious in Act 1 is the sea. Everything else is inference. Brutus hears a shout and fears "the people / Choose Caesar for their king". Casca reports that Caesar refused the crown three times but adds, twice, "to my thinking" — and his thinking is that Caesar "would fain have had it" (fain means gladly) and was "very loath to lay his fingers off it" (loath means reluctant). Casca also undercuts his own evidence: it "was not a crown neither; 'twas one of these coronets", a lesser circlet. In Scene 3 the rumour hardens: the senators "Mean to establish Caesar as a king". And set beside all this the ambition that Act 1 *does* show us directly — Cassius's. He tells Brutus he "had as lief not be as live to be / In awe of such a thing as I myself" (lief means gladly), and he tells us, alone, that "Caesar doth bear me hard" (bears me hard means bears a grudge against me). The man who cannot bear to bow is the man who accuses another of wanting a crown.

Important scenes: Act 1 Scene 2 throughout — the three offstage shouts, where ambition is heard as noise before it is explained; Casca's report, where ambition is read through a hostile witness; and Cassius's soliloquy, where ambition is scripted for delivery. Then Act 1 Scene 3, where Casca's news about the Senate turns the rumour into tomorrow's business.

Characters: Caesar is the accused. Casca is the witness — sour, contemptuous of the crowd, and openly guessing. Cassius is the prosecutor, with an ambition of his own that he never calls by that name. Brutus is the juror who fears the verdict before he has heard the case. Antony is the man who actually offers the crown; Act 1 gives him no motive, and you should not invent one.

Quotations: - "Caesar's ambition shall be glanced at" — Cassius, soliloquy, Act 1 Scene 2. - "he would fain have had it" — Casca, Act 1 Scene 2. The whole case against Caesar rests on the phrase before it: "to my thinking". - "I do fear the people / Choose Caesar for their king." — Brutus, Act 1 Scene 2. - "Mean to establish Caesar as a king" — Casca, Act 1 Scene 3.

Hidden significance: The word "obscurely" in Cassius's soliloquy is the key to the theme. He knows the charge cannot be proved, so it must be hinted at, in several handwritings, as if from many citizens. Ambition in Act 1 is manufactured evidence. The second hidden point concerns Antony's offer. Was the crown a real offer, a test of the crowd, or a piece of theatre arranged to be refused? SHAKESPEARE'S TEXT does not say; Casca's suspicion is a reading, and Brutus and Cassius accept it because it suits them. The third point is the most useful for an advanced answer: Shakespeare places *confessed* ambition in the accuser and *alleged* ambition in the accused. Cassius's Tiber story and fever story are not really evidence about Caesar's fitness to rule; they are the memories of a man who cannot endure that a rival he once carried should now receive his bow.

Historical context: HISTORICAL RECORD: Plutarch's account of the Lupercalia has Antony offer Caesar a diadem wrapped in laurel; the crowd applauded feebly at the offer and loudly at each refusal, and Caesar sent the diadem to Jupiter on the Capitol. Plutarch describes two offers and refusals; Shakespeare's Casca says three, which is a dramatist's number — a pattern needs three beats. Ancient writers also report a rumour that the Senate would grant Caesar the title of king for territories outside Italy, connected to a planned eastern campaign; that rumour is the source of Casca's line about a crown worn "by sea and land / In every place save here in Italy". Modern historians still disagree about how much Caesar wanted the title — which means the argument Act 1 stages was never settled. An ELIZABETHAN note: in 1599 England had an ageing, unmarried

queen with no named heir. Ambition to seize a crown was a live public fear, yet the Tudor Homilies preached that rebellion was a grave sin. An audience may have felt the pull of both anxieties at once — suspicious of Caesar's rising and uneasy about the men who would stop it.

Literary significance: The crown is a prop that never appears; the theme's central object exists only in speech. Casca's prose is a study in unreliable narration — he hedges, sneers, and admits "I did not mark it" while describing it in detail. The "ambitious ocean" is a small pathetic fallacy, nature charged with the same vice as the man, and it prepares Cassius's later claim that the storm is a portrait of Caesar. Above all, 'ambition' is a keyword planted in Act 1 that Act 3 will detonate: Shakespeare gives the word to a forger first, so that when it is spoken over Caesar's body the audience already knows its history.

ICSE keywords: ambition, allegation, insinuation, hearsay, unreliable narrator, coronet, diadem, forgery, dramatic irony, foreshadowing, envy, motive.

Connection to later Acts: Glance ahead to Act 2 Scene 1, where Brutus, alone in his orchard, reasons about what Caesar *might* become rather than what he is, admits he knows no present wrong in him, and is then handed the forged letter that finishes the argument for him. Glance ahead to Act 2 Scene 2, where Decius tempts Caesar to the Senate with the promise of a crown — the ambition bait used on its target. Glance ahead to Act 3 Scene 2, where Brutus's whole public justification is Caesar's ambition and Antony repeats the word until it turns against the man who used it, producing the will and the wounds as counter-evidence. Act 1 is where the charge is manufactured; Act 3 is where it is tried before the people and loses.

3. Republicanism

Definition: A republic is a state that belongs to its citizens and is governed through elected officers and laws rather than by a hereditary ruler. The Latin is *res publica*, 'the public thing' — the property of everyone and therefore of no one. Republicanism is the conviction that no single person may own the state. In Rome this was almost a physical reflex: the title *rex* (king) had been hated since the last king was driven out, and the whole constitution — two consuls checking each other, tribunes with a veto, offices held for a year — existed to stop one man rising above the rest. The precise term you need is 'republican constitutionalism': government by shared, temporary, lawful office.

Act 1 evidence: The Act opens with republicanism in action. Two tribunes exercise a constitutional office, clear the streets, and order Caesar's decorations stripped from the statues: "Disrobe the images / If you do find them decked with ceremonies." Marullus's speech is a republican sermon on memory — "Knew you not Pompey?" — accusing the crowd of forgetting a general whose triumphs were lawful in order to cheer one who "comes in triumph over Pompey's blood". Cassius's seduction of Brutus is republican argument from equality: "I was born free as Caesar; so were you". Free birth, not wealth or virtue, is the ground of the claim. He then appeals to the founding story: "There was a Brutus once that would have brooked / Th' eternal devil to keep his state in Rome / As easily as a king" (brooked means tolerated) — the ancestor who expelled the kings would sooner have put up with the devil than a monarch. He measures the present against a plural past: "When could they say, till now, that talked of Rome, / That her wide walks encompassed but one man?" Brutus's answer is republican in a quieter key — he would "rather be a villager / Than to repute himself a son of Rome / Under these hard conditions". In Scene 3 Cassius turns the republic into a question of manhood: "our fathers' minds are dead, / And we are governed with our mothers' spirits. / Our yoke and sufferance show us womanish" (sufferance means patient endurance). Casca replies in the vocabulary of party: "Be factious for redress of all these griefs" (factious means forming a faction; redress means putting right).

Important scenes: Act 1 Scene 1, where the tribunes are the last working organ of the republic; Cassius's two long speeches in Act 1 Scene 2, the argument from equality and the argument from ancestry; and Act 1 Scene 3 from the dagger speech to the handshake, where republicanism becomes conspiracy.

Characters: Flavius and Marullus are institutional republicans and pay for it. Cassius is a republican by conviction and by grievance, and the play never lets you separate the two. Brutus is a republican by inheritance — the name itself is a programme. Casca and Cinna are recruits. The commoners are the citizens in whose name the republic exists, and they show no interest in it whatever.

Quotations: - "I was born free as Caesar; so were you" — Cassius, Act 1 Scene 2. - "There was a Brutus once that would have brooked / Th' eternal devil to keep his state in Rome / As easily as a king." — Cassius, Act 1 Scene 2. - "Now is it Rome indeed, and room enough / When there is in it but one only man." — Cassius, Act 1 Scene 2. - "Brutus had rather be a villager / Than to repute himself a son of Rome / Under these hard conditions" — Brutus, Act 1 Scene 2.

Hidden significance: Republicanism in Act 1 is entirely retrospective. Every argument points backwards — to Pompey, to the first Brutus, to "our fathers", to the age since the great flood. Nobody describes what a restored republic would *do*; they describe what has been lost. That is why the theme sounds like grief rather than a programme, and why Cassius, in the middle of his own speech, stops to ask "But, O grief, / Where hast thou led me?" A second hidden point: the republicans never appeal to the people. The men Cassius says are "groaning underneath this age's yoke" are "many of the best respect in Rome" — aristocrats. The letters will pretend to come from "several citizens", which means the citizens' voice has to be forged because it does not exist. The republic being defended is a republic of "noble bloods". Hold that thought for the insight box that follows this section.

Historical context: HISTORICAL RECORD: the Republic was traditionally founded in 509 BC when Lucius Junius Brutus led the expulsion of King Tarquin the Proud, and Marcus Brutus claimed descent from him — which is why Cassius's ancestral appeal lands so hard. Two consuls were elected annually, each able to veto the other. The tribunes of the plebs, created after the plebeian secession of 494 BC, were sacrosanct and could veto legislation; there were ten by the late Republic. The Senate, a council of ex-magistrates, was the central organ of government. The dictatorship, limited to six months, was the emergency exception, and Caesar had made it perpetual. The state's own abbreviation was SPQR, *Senatus Populusque Romanus*, the Senate and People of Rome — note that the people are in the name. Sulla's dictatorship of 82–81 BC had already shown that a general with a loyal army could override the constitution; Caesar was the culmination of a long crisis, not its beginning.

Literary significance: The theme's chief devices are allusion — the first Brutus, and Aeneas as "our great ancestor" — and apostrophe, direct address to something absent or abstract: "Age, thou art shamed! / Rome, thou hast lost the breed of noble bloods!" Editors regularly note that in Elizabethan pronunciation 'Rome' sounded close to 'room', which gives Cassius's line a bitter pun: Rome has become 'room enough' for one man. Rhetorical questions carry the argument ("Why should that name be sounded more than yours?"). Note also the prose-and-verse divide of Scene 1: the republic's officers speak verse and its citizens speak prose, so the form itself marks the gap between the idea of the republic and the people it claims to serve.

ICSE keywords: republic, res publica, libertas, constitution, tyranny, rex, oligarchy, patrician, plebeian, allusion, apostrophe, nostalgia.

Connection to later Acts: Glance ahead to Act 2 Scene 1, where Brutus re-founds the conspiracy on republican principle — no oath, no killing beyond Caesar himself — and thereby makes its practical failure likely. Glance ahead to Act 3 Scene 1, where the conspirators proclaim liberty through the streets, and to Act 3 Scene 2, where Brutus's reasoned prose is answered by Antony's appeal to feeling, and the people, in whose

name the republic was saved, set off to burn the conspirators' houses. Glance ahead to Act 5, where the republic dies with its two last defenders and the play's closing lines belong to Octavius, the man who will end it for good. Act 1 gives the republic a voice; it never gives it a constituency.

PROFESSOR'S INSIGHT The republicans of Act 1 do not like the people

Here is a point a school guide will not make. The tribunes of Scene 1 hold the one Roman office created to protect the common people; historically the tribune of the plebs existed for no other purpose. Yet listen to how these tribunes speak to the plebs: "you idle creatures", "You blocks, you stones, you worse than senseless things!", "the vulgar" (Flavius's word for the crowd he means to "drive away"). They defend the republic by clearing its citizens off its streets. Cassius, the republic's most eloquent voice, is worse: Rome is "What trash is Rome, / What rubbish, and what offal"; Romans "are but sheep" and deer — "He were no lion, were not Romans hinds"; the crowd that cheered Caesar is, in Casca's report, "the rabblement" and "the tag-rag people". The conspirators want a Rome without a master, but the Rome they have in mind is one in which noble men are equal to each other and everyone else stays quiet. This is LITERARY INTERPRETATION, but the evidence is thick enough to state confidently: Shakespeare has built a republican movement that shares Caesar's contempt for the people and differs from him only in wanting no one to sit above the nobles. It explains why the conspiracy never once tries to persuade the crowd before the assassination, and why the crowd, when it is finally addressed in Act 3, is so easily taken from them. The republic of Act 1 has officers, principles and ancestors. It has no public.

4. Liberty

Definition: Liberty is freedom from domination — the condition of not living under another person's will. Students often assume it means 'doing what you like'. Roman *libertas* meant something narrower and stronger: the status of a citizen who lives under law rather than under a master. Its opposite is not 'order' but *servitus*, slavery. That is why every liberty speech in Act 1 is assembled from the vocabulary of the slave-market — yoke, bondage, bondman, underlings. The precise term you need is 'political liberty': freedom as the absence of a master, not the presence of choices.

Act 1 evidence: Flavius closes Scene 1 by naming the stake: Caesar unchecked will "keep us all in servile fearfulness". Cassius tells Brutus that the best men in Rome are "groaning underneath this age's yoke" (a yoke is the beam laid across the necks of oxen to make them pull). He gives liberty a birth-certificate — "I was born free as Caesar" — and ends the Colossus speech on the word "underlings", a word for those who exist beneath someone. His own condition is that he "must bend his body / If Caesar carelessly but nod on him". In Scene 3 the theme reaches its extreme. Told that Caesar will be crowned tomorrow, Cassius answers: "I know where I will wear this dagger then; / Cassius from bondage will deliver Cassius". The freedom he is sure of is the freedom to die: "Nor stony tower, nor walls of beaten brass, / Nor airless dungeon, nor strong links of iron, / Can be retentive to the strength of spirit" (retentive means able to hold in). Casca agrees — "So every bondman in his own hand bears / The power to cancel his captivity" — and Cassius at once turns the argument outward: if any man can free himself, "why should Caesar be a tyrant, then?" His answer is that Romans have consented to their own servitude: "the Romans are but sheep".

Important scenes: The last speech of Act 1 Scene 1; Cassius's appeal in Act 1 Scene 2, from "born free" to "underlings"; and the dagger speech and its aftermath in Act 1 Scene 3, which is the fullest treatment of liberty in the Act.

Characters: Flavius treats liberty as the tribune's duty; Cassius as personal dignity, shading into the freedom to die; Casca as something every man privately owns; Brutus as the "general good", though he never speaks the word 'liberty' in Act 1. The commoners, and the "common slave" of Scene 3, are the unfree — present, and voiceless.

Quotations: - "keep us all in servile fearfulness" — Flavius, Act 1 Scene 1. - "groaning underneath this age's yoke" — Cassius, Act 1 Scene 2. - "Cassius from bondage will deliver Cassius" — Cassius, Act 1 Scene 3. - "So every bondman in his own hand bears / The power to cancel his captivity." — Casca, Act 1 Scene 3.

Hidden significance: Look closely at what kind of liberty Cassius is actually certain of. Not the liberty of a free Rome — he has no plan for that yet — but the liberty of a man with a dagger to end his own life. The great liberty speech of Act 1 is a speech about suicide. This is LITERARY INTERPRETATION, but it is hard to unsee: from its first night the conspiracy's idea of freedom is bound up with death, and the play will hold Cassius and Brutus to exactly that bargain. A second point: the liberty argument sits beside contempt for the unfree. Liberty, in Cassius's mouth, is the possession of the strong-spirited; the rest have earned their yoke. A third: the one literally unfree person in Act 1 — the slave whose hand burns "Like twenty torches joined" and is "Not sensible of fire" — appears as a portent, not a person. The Act talks constantly about bondage and never once about slaves.

Historical context: HISTORICAL RECORD: *libertas* and *res publica* were the twin values of the Roman aristocracy, and both were defined against kingship; Brutus's family tradition made him the heir of the man who had won that liberty in 509 BC. The Stoic school taught that a wise man may rationally end his own life when it can no longer be lived with dignity. Cato the Younger, whose daughter Porcia Brutus married, killed himself in 46 BC rather than accept Caesar's pardon after the African campaign, and became the Republic's martyr. Curiously, the historical Cassius was an Epicurean rather than a Stoic; Shakespeare nonetheless gives him the Stoic doctrine of the dagger. Slavery was everywhere in Rome — bondmen were property — and a Roman gentleman's horror of 'bondage' drew its force from what he saw daily in his own house.

Literary significance: The theme is built from imagery of confinement — yoke, bondage, bars, tower, dungeon, "strong links of iron" — set against an imagery of spirit that no wall can hold. Cassius's list uses anaphora ("Nor stony tower, nor walls of beaten brass, / Nor airless dungeon") so that the prison grows heavier with each item before the escape. The heart of the speech is paradox: the gods "make the weak most strong" by giving them death. The stage direction for continuing thunder immediately after it lets the storm underline the line.

ICSE keywords: liberty, libertas, bondage, servitude, tyranny, Stoicism, dignity, paradox, anaphora, foreshadowing.

Connection to later Acts: Glance ahead to Act 3 Scene 1, where the conspirators, having killed Caesar, cry liberty through a city that does not answer, and Brutus reasons that Caesar's death has spared him years of fearing death — the dagger speech's logic applied to its victim. Glance ahead to Act 5 Scene 3 and Act 5 Scene 5, where first Cassius and then Brutus claim exactly the liberty the dagger speech promised — on themselves. The freedom Act 1 argued for turns out to be the only freedom the conspirators ever secure.

5. Patriotism

Definition: Patriotism is love of one's country and a readiness to put its good before one's own. That sounds simple until you ask what 'the country' is. Is it the land, the people living on it, the laws, or an idea of what it ought to be? In Act 1 the characters give different answers, and most of their quarrels are really quarrels about

which Rome deserves their love. The precise term you need is *patria* — the Latin for fatherland, the Rome of the ancestors — and the useful distinction is between loving Rome as a *place and people* and loving Rome as an *inherited ideal*.

Act 1 evidence: The first patriot on stage is Marullus, and his patriotism takes the form of anger. He calls the commoners "you cruel men of Rome" and accuses them of "ingratitude" so grave that heaven must punish it. What he loves is Rome's memory — the Rome that climbed to "chimney tops" to see Pompey — and he treats the present Rome as a traitor to it. The commoners' patriotism is simpler: "we make holiday to see Caesar and to rejoice in his triumph". They love the city's victories and the man who won them. Brutus gives the theme its noblest statement and its most dangerous one in the same breath. He will listen to Cassius only "If it be aught toward the general good" (aught means anything), and he would "rather be a villager / Than to repute himself a son of Rome / Under these hard conditions" — a man who would rather give up the name of Roman than be a Roman on Caesar's terms. Cassius's patriotism is a lament: "Rome, thou hast lost the breed of noble bloods!" In Scene 3 the word 'Roman' becomes a test. Challenged in the dark, Casca answers "A Roman", and Cassius tells him he lacks "those sparks of life / That should be in a Roman". The conspirators are "the noblest-minded Romans". To be Roman, in their mouths, is to be against Caesar.

Important scenes: Act 1 Scene 1, where two kinds of love for Rome collide in the street; the honour exchange in Act 1 Scene 2, where Brutus ties his patriotism to "the general good"; Cassius's apostrophe to Rome in the same scene; and the night of Act 1 Scene 3, where 'Roman' is used as a password.

Characters: Marullus and Flavius love Rome's past; the Cobbler and Carpenter love Rome's holiday; Brutus loves Rome as a principle larger than any man, including a man he also loves; Cassius loves a Rome of equals that may never have existed; Casca adopts the vocabulary on the spot. Caesar, notice, never speaks of Rome at all in Act 1 — he speaks of Caesar.

Quotations: - "O you hard hearts, you cruel men of Rome, / Knew you not Pompey?" — Marullus, Act 1 Scene 1. - "If it be aught toward the general good, / Set honour in one eye and death i' th' other" — Brutus, Act 1 Scene 2. - "Rome, thou hast lost the breed of noble bloods!" — Cassius, Act 1 Scene 2. - "those sparks of life / That should be in a Roman you do want" — Cassius to Casca, Act 1 Scene 3 (want means lack).

Hidden significance: Every patriot in Act 1 loves a Rome that is not in front of him. Marullus loves the Rome of Pompey's triumphs; Cassius loves the Rome of the first Brutus and "our fathers"; Brutus loves a Rome of the "general good" that he has never seen governed. The only people who love the Rome actually present — the city with Caesar in it, on a holiday — are the commoners, and they are driven off the stage as traitors. This is LITERARY INTERPRETATION, but it is well supported: Shakespeare shows patriotism as a love of an idea so strong that it becomes contempt for the real thing. Cassius proves the point himself when his love of Rome collapses into "What trash is Rome, / What rubbish, and what offal". The second hidden point concerns Brutus. His patriotism is the one feeling in Act 1 that can be set *against* a personal love — "yet I love him well" — and Cassius knows it. Everything Cassius says is designed to make love of Rome and love of Caesar look like a choice. The play will never again let Brutus believe they were not.

Historical context: HISTORICAL RECORD: Roman public morality rested on the *mos maiorum*, 'the custom of the ancestors' — the belief that the old ways were the right ways and that a good Roman measured himself against his forebears. This is why so much of the Act's patriotic language is backward-looking. Caesar's Spanish triumph of 45 BC offended precisely this feeling: a triumph was meant to celebrate victory over foreigners, and this one celebrated the defeat of Pompey's sons, fellow Romans, which Plutarch says many did not think fitting. An ELIZABETHAN note: the play is usually dated to 1599, a year of invasion scares and war in Ireland, and Shakespeare's history plays of the same period are full of the language of national love. Audiences may have heard in the Romans' arguments about who truly loves the fatherland something close to their own debates — but say 'may have', not 'did'.

Literary significance: The chief device is personification. Rome is addressed as a woman who has "lost the breed"; the Tiber "trembled underneath her banks"; the city itself becomes a person who can be loved, betrayed and mourned. This lets the dramatist treat patriotism as a love-triangle — Rome, Caesar and the Roman in between. Note also the pattern of *naming*: 'Roman' and 'Rome' recur as touchstones, and the repetition turns an ordinary word into a test of identity. Marullus's rhetorical catalogue of where the people stood to see Pompey (walls, battlements, towers, windows, chimney tops) is an example of amplification — piling up detail to make the past vivid and the present shameful.

ICSE keywords: patriotism, patria, the general good, civic duty, mos maiorum, personification, apostrophe, idealism, nostalgia, identity, love versus duty.

Connection to later Acts: Glance ahead to Act 2 Scene 1, where Brutus justifies the conspiracy entirely in terms of Rome's good and refuses an oath because, he argues, Romans need none. Glance ahead to Act 3 Scene 2, where Brutus asks the crowd to weigh his love of Caesar against his love of Rome, and Antony immediately offers them a different patriotism — one made of Caesar's conquests, Caesar's will and Caesar's wounds. Glance ahead to Act 5, where the word 'Roman' is spoken over the dead as the highest praise anyone can give. Act 1 plants the question that the ending answers: when the Rome you love and the Rome you live in are different things, which one do you die for?

6. Honour

Definition: In student language, honour is being good and being known to be good. Those are two different things, and the whole theme lives in the gap between them. The first sense is inner integrity — doing right whether or not anyone sees. The second is reputation — the esteem others give you, the 'honours' you can be awarded or stripped of. Latin had separate words: *virtus* for inner excellence and *honor* for the public office or distinction that recognised it; *dignitas* was a man's standing, which he was expected to defend. The precise term you need is 'the honour code': a value system in which a man's worth is measured by how far he will go to keep his name clean.

Act 1 evidence: Brutus introduces the word, and he introduces it in its most exalted form: "Set honour in one eye and death i' th' other / And I will look on both indifferently; / For let the gods so speed me as I love / The name of honour more than I fear death." Read that sentence slowly. He does not say he loves honour; he loves "The name of honour". Cassius seizes the word within four lines: "I know that virtue to be in you, Brutus, / As well as I do know your outward favour. / Well, honour is the subject of my story." Then he tells two stories — the Tiber and the fever — that are not about honour at all but about Caesar's body. The honour he offers Brutus is the honour of not being an underling: "we petty men / Walk under his huge legs and peep about / To find ourselves dishonourable graves." Alone, he describes Brutus's honour as a substance to be worked: "Thy honourable mettle may be wrought / From that it is disposed" (mettle means temperament, with a pun on metal; wrought means shaped). Set beside this the other sense of the word. Brutus hears a shout and guesses it is "For some new honours that are heaped on Caesar" — honours, plural, the kind a Senate votes. Antony tells Caesar that Cassius "is a noble Roman, and well given" (well given means well disposed). In Scene 3 Cassius names the conspiracy "an enterprise / Of honourable-dangerous consequence", and Casca explains why Brutus is needed: "that which would appear offence in us / His countenance, like richest alchemy, / Will change to virtue and to worthiness."

Important scenes: The honour exchange in Act 1 Scene 2, from Brutus's vow to Cassius's "subject of my story"; Cassius's soliloquy at the end of that scene, where honour becomes raw material; and the closing lines of Act 1 Scene 3, where Casca spells out what Brutus's honour is *for*.

Characters: Brutus possesses honour and, fatally, loves its name. Cassius uses the word as a tool and, in private, as a metallurgist's term. Caesar collects honours and is accused of wanting the greatest one. Antony speaks the plain language of a decent man's reputation. Casca is the realist who sees that honour, in politics, is a currency. The commoners have no honour in anyone's eyes but their own.

Quotations: - "For let the gods so speed me as I love / The name of honour more than I fear death." — Brutus, Act 1 Scene 2. - "Well, honour is the subject of my story." — Cassius, Act 1 Scene 2. - "Thy honourable mettle may be wrought / From that it is disposed." — Cassius, soliloquy, Act 1 Scene 2. - "His countenance, like richest alchemy, / Will change to virtue and to worthiness." — Casca, Act 1 Scene 3.

Hidden significance: The first hidden point is the one in Brutus's own words: he loves "The name of honour". A man who loves the name of a virtue can be moved by anyone who can make a deed *sound* honourable, and that is exactly what Cassius does. LITERARY INTERPRETATION, but close to the surface. The second point is Casca's alchemy. Alchemists claimed to turn base metal into gold; Casca says Brutus's face will turn "offence" into "virtue". In plain terms, the conspirators need Brutus not for his judgement but for his reputation — his honour will launder their act. The third point is the quiet opposition between honour and honours. Caesar is heaped with honours; Brutus has honour; and the play suggests, without ever stating it, that the man with the inner thing is more easily manipulated than the man with the public ones, because he can be flattered through his conscience rather than his vanity. A fourth: Antony's one-line defence of Cassius — "He is a noble Roman, and well given" — is the Act's only disinterested use of the honour vocabulary, and it is wrong.

Historical context: HISTORICAL RECORD: a Roman aristocrat's *dignitas* — his rank, record and standing — was something he was culturally obliged to defend, and Caesar himself claimed in his writings on the civil war that he fought to protect his *dignitas* from his enemies. Honour was not a private feeling; it was a public possession that could be injured. The historical Cassius had a genuine grievance in this register: in 44 BC Brutus received the urban praetorship, the more prestigious of the two, and ancient sources treat Cassius's resentment as a motive. Shakespeare does not mention it, but it illuminates the man who says "Caesar doth bear me hard". An ELIZABETHAN note: Shakespeare's audience lived inside a nobility that duelled over insults and treated reputation as a kind of property; they would have recognised Brutus's sentence instantly.

Literary significance: The theme runs on two devices. The first is the metal conceit: *mettle*/metal, "wrought", and then Casca's alchemy, so that Brutus's honour is described as ore, worked iron, and finally the philosopher's stone that turns other men's crime to gold. The second is Cassius's borrowed vocabulary — he calls the conspiracy "honourable-dangerous", a compound that yokes together two things that do not belong together, and the hyphen is the sound of a word being bent. Dramatic irony governs the whole: the audience hears Brutus's vow about death and honour knowing how the play ends.

ICSE keywords: honour, honours, virtue, dignitas, reputation, integrity, honour code, mettle, alchemy, conceit, dramatic irony, idealism.

Connection to later Acts: Glance ahead to Act 2 Scene 1, where Brutus's honour dictates every tactical decision — no oath, no Cicero, no Antony — and so decides the conspiracy's fate. Glance ahead to Act 3 Scene 2, where Brutus asks the crowd to believe him for his honour, and Antony's refrain about honourable men takes Brutus's dearest word and wears it out in public until it means its opposite. Glance ahead to Act 4 Scene 3, where the quarrel between Brutus and Cassius is a quarrel about honour and money, and to Act 5, where the word is pronounced over Brutus's body by his enemy. The honour that Act 1 shows being worked like metal is, by the end, the only thing Brutus has left.

PROFESSOR'S INSIGHT The key to Brutus is a word Brutus hands over himself

School guides say that Cassius 'appeals to Brutus's honour'. True, but look at the order of events, because it is cleverer than that. Cassius does not introduce honour. Brutus does. He asks what Cassius wants to tell him and then, unprompted, swears that for "the general good" he would set "honour in one eye and death i' th' other" and love "The name of honour more than I fear death". Cassius has spent twenty lines fishing — complaining of Brutus's coldness, offering to be his mirror, hinting at what "the best respect in Rome" are saying — and has got nothing. Then Brutus, in a moment of candour, tells him exactly which word opens the lock. Cassius's genius is speed: "Well, honour is the subject of my story." It was not; his story is about swimming and fever. He relabels his material in the instant Brutus names the price. This is LITERARY INTERPRETATION, but it changes how you read the whole seduction. Brutus is not tricked by a stranger who guessed his weakness; he is read by a friend to whom he has just confessed it. The lesson for your answers is precise: Cassius's power lies less in his arguments than in his *listening*. He hears the shouting and times his speeches to it; he hears "honour" and renames his story; later he hears "I love him well" and never attacks Caesar's character directly again that day, only his body. Manipulation in this play is an art of the ear before it is an art of the tongue.

7. Loyalty

Definition: Loyalty is faithfulness — staying true to a person, a group or a cause when it would be easier not to. The difficulty, and the theme, is that loyalties can point in different directions at once. You can be loyal to a friend and to a country, and the day they disagree you discover which loyalty is the deeper one. The precise terms you need are 'personal loyalty' (to a man) and 'civic loyalty' or 'allegiance' (to the state), and the Roman word that sits behind both is *fides* — good faith, the trust that holds obligations together.

Act 1 evidence: The Act's purest loyalty is Antony's, and it is expressed in a single line: "When Caesar says 'Do this,' it is performed." Antony's second appearance confirms the pattern — asked about Cassius he answers at once and protectively, "Fear him not, Caesar; he's not dangerous", and Caesar in turn trusts him enough to ask, "tell me truly what thou think'st of him". Brutus's loyalty is divided and he says so: he would not have Caesar king, "yet I love him well". Cassius knows this is the obstacle — "Caesar doth bear me hard, but he loves Brutus" — and his whole approach is framed as a rival loyalty, the loyalty of friendship: he is "your friend that loves you", wounded that Brutus has withheld "that gentleness / And show of love" he used to receive. He even swears he is no false friend who will "fawn on men and hug them hard / And after scandal them" (scandal means slander). Scene 1 shows loyalty from below. Marullus's charge against the commoners is a charge of disloyalty — they once loved Pompey and now strew flowers for the man who "comes in triumph over Pompey's blood". In Scene 3 a new loyalty is made on stage. Casca gives Cassius his hand — "Hold. My hand." — and his word: "I will set this foot of mine as far / As who goes farthest." A faction is formed by a handshake in the dark.

Important scenes: The opening of Act 1 Scene 2 (Antony's obedience); Cassius's complaint and Brutus's "I love him well" in the same scene; the Caesar–Antony exchange about Cassius; Marullus's accusation of ingratitude in Act 1 Scene 1; and the handshake in Act 1 Scene 3.

Characters: Antony is loyal to a man, simply and completely. Brutus is loyal to a man and to an idea, and the Act is the story of the idea gaining ground. Cassius demands loyalty in the name of friendship while planning to deceive the friend. Casca transfers his loyalty in a night. The commoners are accused of having none, though what they actually show is loyalty to whoever is winning. Caesar expects loyalty and tests it — "Come on my right hand... And tell me truly" — which tells you he is not certain of it.

Quotations: - "When Caesar says 'Do this,' it is performed." — Antony, Act 1 Scene 2. - "I would not, Cassius, yet I love him well." — Brutus, Act 1 Scene 2. - "Caesar doth bear me hard, but he loves Brutus." — Cassius, soliloquy, Act 1 Scene 2. - "And I will set this foot of mine as far / As who goes farthest." — Casca, Act 1 Scene 3.

Hidden significance: Count the loyalties in Act 1 and notice which kind wins. Antony's loyalty to Caesar is personal; it asks no questions and it is the only loyalty in the Act that is never tested, never argued for and never betrayed. Every loyalty to an *idea* — the tribunes' to the republic, Brutus's to the general good, Cassius's to liberty — is shown either failing, or being manufactured, or being mixed with grievance. This is LITERARY INTERPRETATION, but it is a pattern the rest of the play confirms: in *Julius Caesar* the men who are loyal to a person outlast the men who are loyal to a principle. A second point: Brutus's "yet I love him well" is the only sentence in Act 1 in which anyone admits to loving Caesar. Cassius hears it and does not answer it. He cannot argue against love; he can only wait for it to be outweighed. A third: the word "love" is everywhere in the Cassius–Brutus scene — "show of love", "shows of love", "your friend that loves you", "That you do love me" — and it is being used as a lever. Loyalty is the language in which the betrayal is proposed.

Historical context: HISTORICAL RECORD: Roman society was knitted together by the patron–client bond, in which a greater man protected a lesser and the lesser owed him support; loyalty was a public obligation, not a private sentiment. Both Brutus and Cassius had fought for Pompey in the civil war, both were pardoned by Caesar after Pharsalus in 48 BC, and both were advanced by him — Brutus to a provincial governorship and then the urban praetorship of 44 BC. By Roman standards they owed Caesar a debt of *fides*, which is why the conspiracy was felt by many contemporaries as ingratitude as well as politics. Antony had served under Caesar in Gaul from 54 BC and as tribune in 49 BC had fled to Caesar's camp, giving Caesar a pretext for crossing the Rubicon; his loyalty in the play has a long history behind it. An ELIZABETHAN note: Shakespeare's England treated allegiance to the monarch as a religious duty, and its official Homilies condemned rebellion as a sin. An audience may well have felt Brutus's divided loyalty as a far more dangerous thing than a modern reader does.

Literary significance: The theme's central device is the gesture — Antony's run, Casca's offered hand — set against the Act's torrent of speech. Loyalty, when it is real, is shown by what people do rather than say; the loyalty that is talked about at length is the loyalty being bought. Note the repetition of "love" as a motif word, the contrast between Antony's one-line obedience and Cassius's hundred-line persuasion, and the dramatic irony of Caesar asking the one man who will stay loyal for a truthful opinion of the one man who will not.

ICSE keywords: loyalty, allegiance, fides, divided loyalty, friendship, obedience, gratitude, ingratitude, faction, motif, dramatic irony, foil.

Connection to later Acts: Glance ahead to Act 2 Scene 1, where Brutus settles his divided loyalty by deciding that love of Rome must outweigh love of Caesar, and where Portia's demand to share his secret tests a different loyalty, that of marriage. Glance ahead to Act 3 Scene 1, where Caesar's last words register the shock of Brutus's blow, and where Antony offers his own life beside Caesar's body before shaking the conspirators' bloody hands — loyalty and strategy in a single gesture. Glance ahead to Act 4 Scene 3, where the loyalty of Brutus and Cassius to each other is nearly broken and then mended, and to Act 5, where the servants and soldiers — Pindarus, Titinius, Lucilius, Strato — show loyalty to their masters to the death. The handshake in the storm is the first of many; the play ends by asking which hands were honest.

8. Betrayal

Definition: Betrayal is the breaking of a trust — harming someone who had a right to rely on you. It is loyalty's shadow, and it needs loyalty to exist: a stranger cannot betray you. That is why the theme sits so close to friendship in this play. The precise terms you need are 'treachery' (betrayal of a person or state) and 'perfidy' (breach of faith), and the Roman opposite of *fides* was *perfidia*.

Act 1 evidence: No betrayal is completed in Act 1. Several are begun. The first, in Scene 1, is the one Marullus alleges: a whole city has betrayed the memory of Pompey, and he calls heaven's "plague" down on "this ingratitude". The second is Cassius's, and it is directed not at Caesar but at Brutus. In the soliloquy he asks, "For who so firm that cannot be seduced?" — the verb he chooses for what he is doing to his friend — and then makes an admission most students pass over: "If I were Brutus now, and he were Cassius, / He should not humour me" (humour means indulge or manipulate). He knows he is doing to Brutus what he would not permit to be done to himself. The forged letters are the instrument: "Writings... As if they came from several citizens". The third betrayal is the one Brutus is being prepared for. He loves Caesar "well"; he is being led to his death. The fourth is Caesar's own account of whom to trust — he fears "that spare Cassius" and asks Antony to speak "truly", and the audience knows the warning will not be acted on. In Scene 3 the conspiracy's own anxiety about betrayal surfaces: Cassius checks himself — "I perhaps speak this / Before a willing bondman; then, I know / My answer must be made" — and Casca swears he is "no fleeing telltale" (fleeing means sneering, mocking).

Important scenes: Marullus's accusation in Act 1 Scene 1; Caesar's warning about Cassius in Act 1 Scene 2; Cassius's soliloquy at the end of that scene, which is the Act's one openly treacherous speech; and the moment of mutual testing in Act 1 Scene 3 before Casca gives his hand.

Characters: Cassius is the betrayer-in-waiting, and the play lets him tell us so. Brutus is the man to be betrayed first and made a betrayer second. Caesar is the eventual victim, who in Act 1 identifies the right man and draws the wrong conclusion. Casca must prove he is not an informer. The commoners are accused of betraying a dead man's memory, which is the only betrayal a crowd can commit.

Quotations: - "Pray to the gods to intermit the plague / That needs must light on this ingratitude." — Marullus, Act 1 Scene 1 (intermit means hold off). - "For who so firm that cannot be seduced?" — Cassius, soliloquy, Act 1 Scene 2. - "If I were Brutus now, and he were Cassius, / He should not humour me." — Cassius, soliloquy, Act 1 Scene 2. - "You speak to Casca, and to such a man / That is no fleeing telltale." — Casca, Act 1 Scene 3.

Hidden significance: The first point is structural, and it is the most important thing this section can teach you. The play's famous betrayal is Brutus's of Caesar. But the *first* betrayal, in order of performance, is Cassius's of Brutus — a friend deceiving a friend with forged letters while calling him "noble". The conspiracy is founded on a betrayal before it commits one. This is LITERARY INTERPRETATION, but it is anchored in Cassius's own words, and it is why the conspirators' later claim to honourable motives never quite stands up. The second point concerns the soliloquy as a device. By letting Cassius speak alone, Shakespeare makes the audience the only people in Rome who know the truth; we watch Brutus walk towards the trap from a position he cannot share. Betrayal in this play is something the audience is made to witness, not something it discovers. A third point: Caesar's "this ear is deaf" sits in the middle of a speech about whom to fear. Whether or not you read it as symbolic, Shakespeare has placed an admission of not-hearing next to the one warning Caesar most needed to hear.

Historical context: HISTORICAL RECORD: the ancient sources make Caesar's murder a betrayal in the strict sense — the killers included men he had pardoned (Brutus, Cassius), men he had promoted and men he trusted; Decius Brutus, Shakespeare's Decius, was named in Caesar's will. Plutarch records anonymous

messages left for Brutus urging him to act, which Shakespeare converts into letters that Cassius forges — a change that shifts the deception from the people to the conspirator and darkens Cassius considerably. The real Caesar is reported to have dismissed warnings about Brutus and Cassius; the saying Plutarch preserves, that he feared pale, thin men rather than fat, long-haired ones, is the seed of the "lean and hungry look". An ELIZABETHAN note: treason was the gravest crime in Tudor law, and plots against the queen were a constant public anxiety through the 1580s and 1590s; an audience watching men forge letters by night may have felt a very contemporary chill.

Literary significance: The soliloquy is the theme's home. Note the vocabulary of craft and seduction — "wrought", "seduced", "humour", letters in "several hands" — which treats betrayal as a skilled trade. Note too the dramatic irony that stretches from Caesar's warning about Cassius to the end of the play, and the proleptic weight (prolepsis means anticipation) of Brutus's phrase "with himself at war": the man who will betray a friend is already, in Act 1, betraying his own peace. Shakespeare also uses a small but telling contrast of settings — the plotting happens at night, in a storm, after midnight — against the daylight festival where loyalty was performed.

ICSE keywords: betrayal, treachery, perfidy, deception, forgery, trust, ingratitude, soliloquy, dramatic irony, prolepsis, complicity, conscience.

Connection to later Acts: Glance ahead to Act 2 Scene 1, where Brutus receives the forged letter and treats it as the voice of Rome — the betrayal of Act 1 bearing fruit. Glance ahead to Act 3 Scene 1, where the stabbing is staged as a sequence of greetings turned into blows, and where Antony's apparent reconciliation with the killers is itself a kind of counter-betrayal, revealed in his soliloquy over the body. Glance ahead to Act 3 Scene 2, where Antony names Brutus's wound as the cruellest because it came from the man Caesar loved. Glance ahead to Act 4 Scene 3, where Cassius accuses Brutus of wronging him and Brutus accuses Cassius of corruption — the betrayers turning on each other — and to the appearance of Caesar's ghost, which many readers take as betrayal returning in person. Act 1 shows betrayal as a plan; the rest of the play shows it as a debt.

9. Manipulation

Definition: Manipulation is getting someone to do what you want without their realising how they were brought to it. Persuasion offers reasons and leaves the listener free; manipulation works on feelings, vanity, fear or trust and hides its own method. The precise terms you need are 'psychological manipulation' — the shaping of another person's self-image so that they choose what you have chosen for them — and 'rhetorical manipulation', the use of language to produce an effect the speaker does not openly admit to wanting.

Act 1 evidence: The master text is Cassius's seduction of Brutus, which the chapter 'Cassius — The Manipulation Masterclass' dissects line by line; here you need its skeleton. Cassius opens with a grievance that puts Brutus on the defensive — he has not had from Brutus's eyes "that gentleness / And show of love" he once had. He offers himself as a mirror: "I, your glass, / Will modestly discover to yourself / That of yourself which you yet know not of." He reports unnamed admirers — "many of the best respect in Rome" — so that the flattery seems to come from elsewhere. He disclaims his own methods in advance: were he a "common laughter" who would "fawn on men and hug them hard", then Brutus should "hold me dangerous". He times his speeches to the offstage shouts. He tells stories that lower Caesar's body rather than attack his conduct. He weighs the two names — "Write them together... Sound them... Weigh them" — until "Brutus" is as heavy as "Caesar". He ends with the ancestor. Brutus half sees it: "What you would work me to, I have some aim." Then, alone, Cassius states the method in a metal-worker's verb — Brutus's "honourable mettle may be wrought" — and plans the forged letters. In Scene 3 the technique changes with the target. With Casca he does

not flatter; he shames — "You are dull, Casca", Romans are "womanish", "sheep", "hinds" — and bares his chest to the lightning to prove his courage. Manipulation is not confined to Cassius. Marullus works the commoners through guilt until they "vanish tongue-tied". And Casca's report of Caesar in the marketplace describes a politician managing a crowd: he "offered them his throat to cut", then asked them "to think it was his infirmity", and the "wenches" forgave him "with all their hearts".

Important scenes: The whole of the Cassius–Brutus dialogue in Act 1 Scene 2 and the soliloquy that follows it; Casca's account of Caesar before the people in the same scene; and Cassius's handling of Casca in Act 1 Scene 3, which shows the same craftsman using different tools.

Characters: Cassius is the Act's manipulator-in-chief, and the only one who explains his technique to the audience. Brutus is the target who partly knows it and consents anyway. Casca is both a second target and the witness who reports Caesar's own crowd-management. Marullus manipulates through shame. Caesar, if Casca is to be believed, manipulates through theatre. The commoners are manipulated by everyone and manipulate no one.

Quotations: - "I, your glass, / Will modestly discover to yourself / That of yourself which you yet know not of." — Cassius, Act 1 Scene 2. - "What you would work me to, I have some aim." — Brutus, Act 1 Scene 2. - "Thy honourable mettle may be wrought / From that it is disposed." — Cassius, soliloquy, Act 1 Scene 2. - "You are dull, Casca, and those sparks of life / That should be in a Roman you do want" — Cassius, Act 1 Scene 3.

Hidden significance: The first point is the one Brutus's own line gives you: he is not deceived about the fact of manipulation, only about its extent. "I have some aim" means he knows roughly where he is being led — and he agrees to think about it. Manipulation in this play succeeds not by blinding its target but by offering him a version of himself he would like to be true. The second point is the mirror. Cassius's image is accurate as well as flattering: a man cannot see his own face. What Cassius conceals is that a glass can be angled. The third point, LITERARY INTERPRETATION, is that Act 1 presents manipulation as the normal mode of Roman politics rather than as Cassius's private vice. Tribunes manage crowds; Caesar manages crowds; conspirators manage each other. The question the Act raises is not whether politics can be free of manipulation but whether anyone in it is manipulated *well* — towards something true. The forged letters answer that question before Act 2 begins.

Historical context: HISTORICAL RECORD: Plutarch reports that anonymous writings were left on the praetor's tribunal and on the statue of the first Brutus, urging Brutus to wake and act; he presents them as the voice of popular feeling. Shakespeare makes Cassius their author and tells us so, converting an ambiguous historical detail into a deliberate deception. Plutarch also records that Cassius had private reasons for hating Caesar alongside his political ones. The two-way flow of influence between Brutus and Cassius — the ancient sources show Brutus's reputation drawing others into the plot — is faithfully carried into Casca's "alchemy" speech. An ELIZABETHAN note: boys in Shakespeare's grammar schools were trained in rhetoric, including the technique of arguing both sides of a question; an educated audience may have recognised Cassius's moves as textbook figures put to work.

Literary significance: The theme's devices are the ones that make language act on a listener: rhetorical questions that supply their own answers, anaphora that builds pressure, flattery disguised as modesty ("my weak words"), and the controlling metaphors of mirror and metal. The soliloquy is the structural device that turns the audience into informed witnesses, and dramatic irony follows from it: every later word Cassius says to Brutus is heard twice, once as Brutus hears it and once as we do. Note also the contrast of registers — Cassius's verse to Brutus is elevated and allusive; his verse to Casca is blunt and insulting — which shows a speaker shaping his instrument to the ear in front of him.

ICSE keywords: manipulation, persuasion, flattery, insinuation, psychological pressure, forgery, soliloquy, dramatic irony, rhetorical question, mirror image, consent, complicity.

Connection to later Acts: Glance ahead to Act 2 Scene 1, where the forged letter reaches Brutus and he fills its gaps with his own reasoning — manipulation completed by its victim. Glance ahead to Act 2 Scene 2, where Decius reinterprets Calpurnia's dream and dangles a crown to bring Caesar to the Senate, a Cassius-style seduction turned on the other side. Glance ahead above all to Act 3 Scene 2, where Antony manipulates the crowd with the will, the mantle and the wounds, and does openly to thousands what Cassius did privately to one man. Act 1 teaches the method; Act 3 shows it at the scale of a city.

PROFESSOR'S INSIGHT

Cassius condemns in Caesar the trick he performs himself

Here is a connection most readers never make because the two moments are a scene apart. In Act 1 Scene 2 Casca describes Caesar's performance before the crowd: when he saw that the people were glad he had refused the crown, "he plucked me ope his doublet and offered them his throat to cut". It is pure theatre — a display of vulnerability designed to produce love, and it works: the women cry "Alas, good soul!" and forgive him. Cassius and Brutus listen to this with contempt. Then, in Act 1 Scene 3, Cassius walks through the storm, as he tells Casca, "unbracèd" (with his doublet open), having "bared my bosom to the thunder-stone" and presented himself "Even in the aim and very flash of it". He has opened his doublet and offered his chest to danger in front of an audience of one, in order to be admired. The gesture is Caesar's gesture. This is LITERARY INTERPRETATION, and you should present it as such, but the textual parallel is exact enough to be worth a paragraph in any essay on manipulation or on appearance and reality: both men stage their own fearlessness; both use an exposed body as an argument; both are rewarded with the loyalty they were fishing for. The difference is scale and honesty. Caesar's performance is reported second-hand by a hostile witness, so we cannot be sure how calculated it was. Cassius's is performed before us, and he tells us at once what it was for — to prove that Casca lacks the "sparks of life / That should be in a Roman". The man who despises Caesar for working a crowd works a man the same way, in the same costume, one scene later.

10. Political rhetoric

Definition: Rhetoric is the art of using language to persuade. Political rhetoric is that art applied to public power — to winning a crowd, a Senate, or a single powerful friend. It is not the same as lying; a true thing can be said rhetorically, and the art lies in arrangement, emphasis and timing. The precise terms you need are the classical three: *ethos* (persuading through the speaker's character — 'trust me, I am honest'), *pathos* (persuading through the listener's feelings) and *logos* (persuading through reasoning). Act 1 is a laboratory in which you can watch all three.

Act 1 evidence: The Act opens with a set-piece. Marullus's speech to the commoners is built from rhetorical questions — "Wherefore rejoice? What conquest brings he home? / What tributaries follow him to Rome" — and then from anaphora, the repetition of an opening phrase: "And do you now put on your best attire? / And do you now cull out a holiday? / And do you now strew flowers in his way". Each question is unanswerable, so the crowd falls silent. That is pathos: the engine is shame. Cassius's speeches to Brutus are a second kind. He establishes ethos first — he is not a flatterer, not one who will "fawn on men" — and then supplies logos of a peculiar sort: an argument by comparison. "Write them together, yours is as fair a name; / Sound them, it doth become the mouth as well; / Weigh them, it is as heavy" — three parallel clauses, three tests, one conclusion. He ends with an apostrophe to absent things, "Age, thou art shamed! / Rome, thou hast lost the breed of noble bloods!" and, when Brutus responds, with false modesty: "my weak words". Caesar's rhetoric is different

again. He speaks of himself in the third person — "Caesar is turned to hear", "for always I am Caesar" — and in short declaratives, the rhetoric of a man who no longer needs to persuade. Then there are two anti-rhetoricians. Casca speaks prose, hedges with "to my thinking", and deflates everything; and Cicero — the greatest orator Rome ever produced, present on stage — says almost nothing, "spoke Greek" at the Lupercal, and in Scene 3 offers the Act's one theory of interpretation: "men may construe things after their fashion, / Clean from the purpose of the things themselves" (construe means interpret). Finally, Cassius's letters are rhetoric in writing, designed to look like many voices.

Important scenes: Marullus's speech in Act 1 Scene 1 (public oratory to a crowd); Cassius's speeches in Act 1 Scene 2 (private oratory to one man); Caesar's speech about Cassius in the same scene (the rhetoric of command); Casca's prose report (anti-rhetoric); and Cicero's exchange with Casca in Act 1 Scene 3 (rhetoric observed by a professional).

Characters: Marullus is the orator of shame. Cassius is the orator of flattery and comparison. Caesar is the orator who has stopped arguing. Casca is the plain speaker whose plainness is itself a style — Brutus notes that "This rudeness is a sauce to his good wit". Cicero is the silent expert. Brutus, in Act 1, is mostly a listener, and his few speeches are measured and conditional — the rhetoric of a man reserving judgement.

Quotations: - "And do you now put on your best attire? / And do you now cull out a holiday? / And do you now strew flowers in his way" — Marullus, Act 1 Scene 1 (cull out means pick out). - "Write them together, yours is as fair a name; / Sound them, it doth become the mouth as well; / Weigh them, it is as heavy" — Cassius, Act 1 Scene 2. - "I rather tell thee what is to be feared / Than what I fear; for always I am Caesar." — Caesar, Act 1 Scene 2. - "men may construe things after their fashion, / Clean from the purpose of the things themselves." — Cicero, Act 1 Scene 3.

Hidden significance: The first hidden point is Cicero's. His line about construing things "after their fashion" is placed in the middle of a night of omens, but it describes everything in Act 1: Casca construes a crown-refusal as ambition, Cassius construes a fever as unfitness to rule, the tribunes construe a holiday as treason. Shakespeare gives the play's most sceptical sentence to its most famous rhetorician, and then has him leave the stage before the plotting begins. LITERARY INTERPRETATION, but it is widely shared: Cicero's near-silence is a comment on how little truth has to do with what the orators are about to achieve. The second point is that the Act contains no public speech that succeeds by argument. Marullus wins silence, not agreement; Cassius wins a promise to think; Caesar wins obedience he already had. The rhetoric that will actually move Rome is deferred to Act 3, and Act 1 quietly lowers your expectations of what it will be made of. A third point: the prose-verse divide in Scene 1 is itself rhetorical. The tribunes' verse cannot stop the Cobbler's puns; the two registers simply fail to meet, and the scene ends with the crowd dispersed rather than persuaded.

Historical context: HISTORICAL RECORD: oratory was the central skill of Roman public life; a career was made in the law courts and the people's assemblies, and the Cicero of history was its supreme practitioner, author of treatises on the art. He was not part of the conspiracy and was killed on the triumvirs' orders in December 43 BC — the fate of the orator in a world turning to force. Shakespeare's source, North's Plutarch, is itself a rhetorically shaped text, full of speeches. An ELIZABETHAN note: Shakespeare's own schooling almost certainly included Latin rhetoric — figures like anaphora and the rhetorical question were drilled by name — and the London theatre audience of 1599 was accustomed to sermons and public speeches as entertainment; they heard rhetoric with trained ears.

Literary significance: This theme is where the device bank and the themes meet, so be precise. Rhetorical question (Marullus, Cassius), anaphora ("And do you now..."), parallelism and tricolon ("Write them... Sound them... Weigh them"), apostrophe ("Rome, thou hast lost"), antithesis ("what is to be feared / Than what I fear"), illeism (Caesar's third person), hyperbole (the Colossus), allusion (Aeneas, the first Brutus). Beyond individual figures, notice the structural rhythm of Scene 2 — speech, offstage shout, speech — which turns the

crowd's noise into punctuation for Cassius's argument. And notice that Shakespeare writes anti-rhetoric as skilfully as rhetoric: Casca's prose, with its sneers and hedges, is a style built to make other men's grandeur look foolish.

ICSE keywords: rhetoric, oratory, persuasion, ethos, pathos, logos, rhetorical question, anaphora, tricolon, antithesis, apostrophe, illeism.

Connection to later Acts: Glance ahead to Act 2 Scene 1, where Brutus's orchard soliloquy is a speech of self-persuasion built on the figure of the serpent's egg — reasoning used to reach a conclusion already felt. Glance ahead to Act 2 Scene 2, where Decius's reinterpretation of the dream is rhetoric in its most practical form. Glance ahead to Act 3 Scene 2, the play's great rhetorical contest: Brutus's balanced prose, which appeals to reason and honour, against Antony's verse, which appeals to grief, curiosity and greed, and wins. Every figure you learn in Act 1 you will meet again in the Forum, wielded by a master. Glance ahead to Act 4 Scene 3, where rhetoric fails between friends and only the news of Portia's death stops the quarrel.

11. Public opinion

Definition: Public opinion is what the people, taken together, think and feel about those who govern them — and, more importantly for this play, what the powerful *believe* the people think. In a republic, public opinion is in theory the source of all authority. In practice it is a force that can be flattered, frightened, bought and faked. The precise terms you need are 'popular opinion' or 'the popular will' and its negative shadow, 'the mob' — the same crowd seen with respect and with contempt.

Act 1 evidence: Public opinion is the first thing on stage and the last thing anyone trusts. Scene 1 shows it in motion: the commoners who once made "an universal shout" for Pompey now hold holiday for Caesar, and after Marullus's speech they "vanish tongue-tied". The crowd has changed its mind twice in one scene and never spoken a political word. Scene 2 is organised around public opinion heard but not seen. Three shouts come from offstage; Brutus fears they mean "the people / Choose Caesar for their king"; Cassius uses each one as a cue. Casca's report then explains them, and his vocabulary is a lesson in how the ruling class regards the ruled: "the rabblement", "the tag-rag people", "the common herd", who "clap him and hiss him, according as he pleased and displeased them, as they use to do the players in the theatre". The people, in Casca's picture, are an audience, and Caesar is an actor who knows it — he offers his throat, apologises for his "infirmity", and is forgiven. Casca's verdict on the forgiving women is savage: "if Caesar had stabbed their mothers, they would have done no less." Then comes the Act's deepest move. Alone, Cassius plans letters "all tending to the great opinion / That Rome holds of his name" — that is, he will *forge* public opinion to move Brutus, because real public opinion is cheering Caesar. In Scene 3 Casca reminds us why Brutus matters: "he sits high in all the people's hearts".

Important scenes: Act 1 Scene 1 entire (the crowd as fickle); the three offstage shouts and Casca's report in Act 1 Scene 2 (the crowd as audience); Cassius's soliloquy (public opinion forged); and Casca's closing speech in Act 1 Scene 3 (Brutus's standing with the people as the conspiracy's asset).

Characters: The commoners are public opinion embodied — present only in Scene 1, and thereafter a noise. Marullus and Flavius try to correct it and are destroyed. Caesar performs for it. Casca despises it and describes it best. Cassius fears it, fakes it and plans to borrow Brutus's share of it. Brutus holds it without seeking it. Cicero, who in history spent a life addressing it, speaks Greek over its head.

Quotations: - "They vanish tongue-tied in their guiltiness." — Flavius, Act 1 Scene 1. - "I do fear the people / Choose Caesar for their king." — Brutus, Act 1 Scene 2. - "Writings, all tending to the great opinion / That Rome holds of his name" — Cassius, soliloquy, Act 1 Scene 2. - "O, he sits high in all the people's hearts" —

Casca, Act 1 Scene 3.

Hidden significance: The first hidden point is a stage fact: after Scene 1 the people are never seen in Act 1, only heard. Their three shouts are the loudest sounds in the Act and we are never shown the faces that make them. Shakespeare keeps public opinion offstage so that we receive it exactly as the politicians do — as a roar to be interpreted. The second point is the paradox at the heart of the conspiracy, and it deserves a place in any essay: the men who are about to kill Caesar in the people's name regard the people as "trash", "sheep" and "rabblement", while the man they accuse of tyranny is the only one shown courting the people's love.

LITERARY INTERPRETATION, but the evidence is plentiful. The third point is Cassius's forgery. He does not try to change what Rome thinks; he fabricates what Rome thinks and delivers it to the one man who will believe it. Public opinion in Act 1 is thus already the thing it will be in the Forum: not a judgement but a material. A fourth, smaller point: Casca's theatre comparison is spoken in a theatre, to an audience that has just been clapping and hissing. The Globe's own crowd is being described to its face.

Historical context: HISTORICAL RECORD: the Roman people had real constitutional power — they voted in assemblies, elected magistrates and passed laws — and politicians of Caesar's stamp, the *populares*, built careers on championing popular causes against the senatorial elite. Caesar's popularity was genuine and was fed by games, grain, land for veterans and spectacular triumphs. Plutarch's account of the Lupercalia makes the crowd's reactions the measure of Caesar's intentions: feeble applause at the offer, loud applause at the refusal. The tribunes Marullus and Flavus were, in history, popular for a moment — Plutarch says the people hailed them as 'Brutuses' — before Caesar removed them. An ELIZABETHAN note: the Globe's audience was itself a mixed crowd of citizens and apprentices standing in the yard, and theatre-owners, preachers and magistrates argued constantly about whether such crowds were a public or a mob. Shakespeare was writing about public opinion for a public.

Literary significance: The theme's governing device is the offstage sound — the stage directions 'Flourish and shout' and 'Shout. Flourish' — which makes the crowd a presence without a body. The second is the theatre metaphor, which is metatheatrical (a play drawing attention to its own nature as a play). The third is the collective noun as insult — "rabblement", "herd", "tag-rag" — which lets you trace a character's politics through his nouns. Prose for the commoners and verse for their rulers marks the social divide in the very texture of the language. And the conspirators' plan to fake "the great opinion / That Rome holds" is a dramatic irony that reaches all the way to the Forum, where real opinion will be shown to be as movable as the forged kind pretended.

ICSE keywords: public opinion, the populace, fickleness, the mob, mob psychology, popularity, spectacle, metatheatre, offstage action, reported action, collective noun, demagogue.

Connection to later Acts: Glance ahead to Act 2 Scene 1, where Brutus reads the forged letter as Rome's plea and so lets fabricated public opinion decide him. Glance ahead to Act 3 Scene 2, the scene this whole theme exists to prepare: the crowd, now on stage and speaking, is persuaded by Brutus in minutes and un-persuaded by Antony in minutes more, and the play finally shows the faces behind the shouts. Glance ahead to Act 3 Scene 3, where the same crowd kills Cinna the poet for his name, and to Act 4 Scene 1, where the triumvirs govern without consulting anyone. Act 1 teaches you to hear the crowd as the politicians hear it; Act 3 lets you watch what they were right to fear.

PROFESSOR'S INSIGHT Act 1 is a drama of tongues and silences

Follow one word through the Act and the theme of public opinion reorganises itself around it. The word is 'tongue'. Flavius watches the commoners "vanish tongue-tied in their guiltiness" — the people silenced. Caesar hears the Soothsayer as "a tongue shriller than all the music" — the one voice that will not be managed, and he silences it with "Pass". Cassius remembers "that tongue of his that bade the Romans / Mark him and write his speeches in their books" crying for drink "As a sick girl" — Caesar's public voice reduced to a private whimper. Caesar falls in the marketplace and is "speechless"; Cicero speaks Greek, which is to say he speaks and is not understood; the tribunes are "put to silence". And the Act ends with letters — speech without a speaker — to be left in a chair and thrown through a window. This is LITERARY INTERPRETATION, but the chain is in the text, and it tells you what public opinion is in this play: a contest over who is permitted to have a voice. Each political faction in Act 1 spends its energy stopping someone else's mouth — the tribunes the crowd's, Caesar the tribunes', Cassius (by forgery) the real citizens', whose actual opinion is replaced with a counterfeit. When the people do finally speak at length in Act 3, nobody on stage has practised listening to them. For an examiner, this is the kind of observation that lifts a theme answer from description to analysis: not 'the crowd is fickle' but 'Shakespeare dramatises public opinion as a struggle over speech, and shows every party in Act 1 trying to silence another'.

How the themes interlock

No theme in Act 1 stands alone, and the examiner's highest marks go to the student who can show two themes pressing on each other in a single line. The table below pairs the themes that actually collide in Act 1 — not every possible pairing, only the ones the text stages. Read each row as a small essay plan: the collision, where to find it, the words that prove it, and the sentence that turns it into analysis.

Themes in collision	Where in Act 1	The line that shows the collision	What to say in an answer
Honour vs Manipulation	Cassius hears Brutus's vow and relabels his story, Act 1 Scene 2	"Well, honour is the subject of my story."	The highest value in the play is the handle by which its noblest man is moved; honour makes Brutus persuadable, not safe.
Liberty vs Public opinion	The dagger speech and the sheep image, Act 1 Scene 3	"he sees the Romans are but sheep"	Cassius wants liberty for Rome and despises the Romans; the freedom he imagines has no room for the people's actual wishes.
Loyalty vs Republicanism	Brutus's admission to Cassius, Act 1 Scene 2	"I would not, Cassius, yet I love him well."	Brutus's republicanism and his love for Caesar occupy one sentence; the comma between them is the fault-line of the tragedy.
Patriotism vs Loyalty	The same exchange, and the Scene 1 quarrel	"If it be aught toward the general good"	Love of Rome is offered as the reason to abandon love of a man; the commoners are condemned for loving Caesar more than Pompey's memory.
Power vs Liberty	Flavius's last speech, Act 1 Scene 1	"And keep us all in servile fearfulness"	Every increase in Caesar's height is described as a decrease in Roman freedom; the Act never lets power and liberty rise together.
Ambition vs Honour	Brutus hears the second shout, Act 1 Scene 2	"For some new honours that are heaped on Caesar"	Caesar's 'honours' are public gifts; Brutus's 'honour' is inner; the alleged ambition is the desire for the one kind by a man who, Cassius claims, lacks the other.

Themes in collision	Where in Act 1	The line that shows the collision	What to say in an answer
Betrayal vs Honour	Cassius's soliloquy, Act 1 Scene 2	"Thy honourable mettle may be wrought"	The plan to deceive Brutus is phrased as admiration of him; the conspiracy's honour is built on a forgery.
Political rhetoric vs Public opinion	Marullus and the commoners, Act 1 Scene 1	"They vanish tongued in their guiltiness."	Oratory produces silence rather than agreement; the people are moved without being persuaded, which is the Forum in miniature.
Republicanism vs Public opinion	Casca on the crowd, Act 1 Scene 2	"the rabblement hooted and clapped their chopped hands"	The republic's defenders describe its citizens as a mob; the gap between the ideal republic and the real populace is never closed.
Manipulation vs Loyalty	Cassius's protestation of friendship, Act 1 Scene 2	"your friend that loves you"	Friendship is the register in which the deception is conducted; the Act makes loyalty the manipulator's best disguise.

Two cautions about using the table. First, never write the collision as a formula ('this shows the theme of honour versus manipulation'). Write the line, say what each theme contributes, and then say what the collision *does* — to Brutus, to the audience, to the rest of the play. Second, the collisions are not symmetrical. In Act 1 manipulation defeats honour, contempt defeats liberty's good name, and personal love is losing to civic love in Brutus. By Act 3 several of these reverse. An answer that knows the direction of the collision in Act 1, and can glance ahead to its reversal, is doing exactly what the board's 'analysis' and 'evaluation' skills ask for.

CROSS-REFERENCE Where to go next

For the devices named across this chapter — anaphora, apostrophe, illeism, soliloquy, dramatic irony, the mirror and metal conceits — see 'The Act 1 Literary-Device Bank'. For the keyword lists expanded with definitions and example sentences, see 'The ICSE Keyword Vault for Act 1'. For every quotation above in its context, with speaker and position, see 'The Act 1 Quotation Bank'. For how these Act 1 themes resurface in Acts 3 to 5 — the Forum, the quarrel, Philippi — see 'The Scene Connection Engine and Where Act 1 Reappears Later'. For the second half of the thematic map, including fate, superstition, appearance versus reality and mob psychology, see 'Themes of Act 1 (Part Two)'.

ICSE EXAM BOX WRITING A THEME PARAGRAPH

EXAM-ORIENTED ADVICE. Act 1 belongs to the Class IX portion of the syllabus, so you are unlikely to be asked for an Act 1 theme essay in the Class X board paper; the drama section there is extract-based and set on Acts III to V. But the same paragraph pattern earns the marks in a Class IX examination on Act 1, in a Class X extract sub-question that asks what a speech 'reveals' or 'why' a character speaks as he does, and in the Internal Assessment thematic study. Learn the pattern, not the paragraph.

The pattern has four moves — Point, Evidence, Analysis, Significance.

Point: one sentence that makes a claim about the theme, not a sentence that names it. 'Act 1 presents public opinion as a force everyone fears and no one respects' is a point. 'Public opinion is an important theme in Act 1' is not.

Evidence: a short, exact quotation, with speaker and scene, placed so that it proves the point rather than decorates it. One quotation per paragraph is usually enough; two is the maximum.

Analysis: two or three sentences that work on the words of the quotation — a device, a connotation, a contrast — and show how the words produce the effect you claimed. This is where most marks are won and most students stop too early.

Significance: one sentence that says why it matters — to a character, to the play's design, or to what happens later. A labelled glance ahead ('in Act 3 Scene 2 this...') is the quickest route to the evaluation marks, provided it is accurate.

A worked paragraph on 'public opinion in Act 1':

Shakespeare presents public opinion in Act 1 as a power that every politician depends on and none of them respects. In Act 1 Scene 2 the aristocrat Casca reports that the crowd applauded Caesar's refusal of the crown and that "the rabblement hooted and clapped their chopped hands and threw up their sweaty nightcaps". The collective noun 'rabblement' reduces the citizens to a disorderly mass, and the physical details — chopped hands, sweaty nightcaps — make the people a matter of smell and labour rather than judgement; Casca then compares them to a theatre audience who "clap him and hiss him", so that popular opinion becomes mere applause for a performer. Yet the same crowd's shouts are the loudest sound in the scene, and Brutus's fear that "the people / Choose Caesar for their king" shows that the men who despise the crowd still take its voice as the measure of Rome's future. The significance is structural: Cassius's plan to forge letters expressing "the great opinion / That Rome holds of his name" shows the conspirators treating public opinion as a material to be manufactured rather than consulted, and this contempt prepares the irony of Act 3 Scene 2, where the crowd they never addressed is taken from them in a single afternoon.

Three checks before you move on from any theme paragraph. Is the first sentence an argument? Does every quotation have a sentence of analysis after it that mentions a specific word? Does the paragraph end by looking outward — to a character's fate, to a later scene, to the play's design — rather than by repeating the point? If the answer to all three is yes, you have written a paragraph that examiners of any syllabus year recognise as literature, not notes.

CHAPTER 12

Themes of Act 1 (Part Two): Fate, Free Will, Superstition, Omens, Appearance vs Reality, Friendship, Jealousy, Political Anxiety, Leadership, Individual vs State, Mob Psychology

What this chapter does: Part One dealt with the themes about ruling and obeying. This chapter deals with the themes about knowing — what a Roman in Act 1 can know about the future, about the heavens, about his friends and about himself, and how badly he can be wrong. Eleven themes are taught in full, each with the same ten labels, and each as a genuine piece of literary analysis rather than a list. In between, the chapter stages the argument that holds the whole play together — fate against free will — by setting four Act 1 voices against one another, and it builds a table for appearance versus reality. It closes by showing you, sentence by sentence, how a theme paragraph is actually written.

How to read this chapter

The themes in Part One were mostly about what people *do* to one another: seize power, flatter, betray, persuade. The themes here are mostly about what people *believe* — and the uncomfortable discovery Act 1 keeps making is that belief and action do not line up. The man who says the heavens are warning Rome does nothing; the man who says there is no such thing as fate goes out and makes one. The man who scorns superstition asks his wife to stand in a fertility runner's path. The friend who speaks most warmly of love is composing forged letters within the hour.

So the habit I want you to practise throughout this chapter is a single question: *what is the gap between what this character says he believes and what he does?* That gap is where Shakespeare puts his meaning, and it is where an examiner's best marks are hidden.

Each theme section again uses ten bold labels in a fixed order, following the course's five levels. **Definition**, **Act 1 evidence**, **Important scenes** and **Characters** are Levels 1 and 2. **Quotations** are verified against the text; learn them exactly, with the speaker and scene. **Hidden significance**, **Historical context** and **Literary significance** are Level 3. **Connection to later Acts** is Level 4, and it is written as labelled glances ahead rather than quotation, because later Acts are not this book's text. **ICSE keywords** are Level 5. Where I say LITERARY INTERPRETATION, I am telling you that careful readers disagree; where I say HISTORICAL RECORD, I am telling you a fact from the sources; where I say SHAKESPEARE'S TEXT, I am pointing at the words themselves.

A reminder you have read before and will read again, because it matters: Act 1 is the Class IX part of the syllabus. The Class X board paper sets Acts III, IV and V. None of these themes will be asked about *as Act 1 themes* in that paper. But every one of them is a thread the examiner expects you to be able to pull: an answer on Caesar's ghost, on Cassius's death, on the eagles and ravens before Philippi, on the storm of guilt in Brutus's tent, is an answer about fate and omens that began in Act 1. You are learning the roots so that you can explain the tree.

CROSS-REFERENCE Where the neighbouring material lives

The political themes — power, ambition, republicanism, liberty, patriotism, honour, loyalty, betrayal, manipulation, rhetoric and public opinion — are in 'Themes of Act 1 (Part One)'. The storm scene that supplies most of this chapter's evidence is taught line by line in 'Act 1 Scene 3 — The Storm: Omens, Fear and the Conspiracy Takes Shape'. The Soothsayer has his own chapter: 'The Soothsayer, the Ides of March, and the Supporting Cast'. For Cassius's psychology, which drives the themes of jealousy and free will here, see 'Cassius — The Manipulation Masterclass'. The imagery named below is catalogued in 'The Act 1 Literary-Device Bank'; the vocabulary in 'The ICSE Keyword Vault for Act 1'; and for how a thematic answer is marked, read 'ICSE Examiner Mode: How Marks Are Earned'.

1. Fate

Definition: Fate is the idea that what will happen to a person has been fixed in advance by a power outside them — the gods, the stars, destiny — and cannot be changed by anything they choose to do. Keep it distinct from two neighbours. *Fortune* is luck, which turns without reason and can be good or bad. *Providence* is a plan with a purpose, usually a divine one. Fate in *Julius Caesar* is neither comfort nor plan: it is simply the future arriving on schedule, whether or not anyone listens. The exam-useful shape of the theme in Act 1 is this: the future is announced in the very first scene in which Caesar appears, and the whole of the rest of the Act is a set of people choosing not to hear it.

Act 1 evidence: The Soothsayer speaks eleven words in Act 1, and five of them twice: "Beware the ides of March." Notice how Shakespeare stages this. Caesar is in the middle of a public ceremony; a single voice cuts through the music; Caesar himself stops the procession and commands the man forward — "Set him before me. Let me see his face." He looks at the face of fate, hears the warning a second time, and pronounces judgement: "He is a dreamer. Let us leave him. Pass." The warning is not disproved, not argued with, merely classified as unimportant. The second strand is Cassius's famous denial — "Men at some time are masters of their fates" — which we shall examine on its own below. The third strand is the storm of Scene 3. Casca reads it as the gods' message; Cicero says men read into things what suits them; Cassius turns it into a portrait of Caesar. Between these three strands sits a small, easily missed moment. Cassius invites Casca to dinner tomorrow and Casca replies, "Ay, if I be alive, and your mind hold, and your dinner worth the eating." It is a sour joke; it is also the only line in Act 1 in which a Roman admits that tomorrow is not his to promise.

Important scenes: The Soothsayer exchange early in Act 1 Scene 2; Cassius's speech about stars and underlings in the same scene; the whole of Act 1 Scene 3, where the storm becomes a disputed text about the future.

Characters: The Soothsayer is fate's voice — nameless, without rank, unable to do anything but repeat. Caesar is the man fate addresses and who declines to listen. Cassius is the man who says fate does not exist. Casca is the man who believes it does and is terrified. Cicero is the man who says that whatever is coming, you cannot read it off the sky. Brutus, notably, says nothing about fate in Act 1 at all; his struggle is with himself, not the heavens, and that silence is worth noticing.

Quotations: - "Beware the ides of March." — the Soothsayer to Caesar, Act 1 Scene 2, spoken twice. - "He is a dreamer. Let us leave him. Pass." — Caesar, Act 1 Scene 2. - "The fault, dear Brutus, is not in our stars, / But in ourselves, that we are underlings." — Cassius to Brutus, Act 1 Scene 2. - "Ay, if I be alive, and your mind hold, and your dinner worth the eating." — Casca to Cassius, Act 1 Scene 2.

Hidden significance: The deepest thing to see is that fate in this play never *does* anything. There is no god on stage, no oracle's riddle fulfilled by trickery. The Soothsayer names a date, and then men — not stars — fill that date with knives. LITERARY INTERPRETATION, but a strong one: Shakespeare constructs fate so that it is indistinguishable from the sum of human choices. If Caesar had listened, if Brutus had refused, if the letters had not been thrown in at the window, the Ides of March would have been a Wednesday. This is why the audience's position is so strange. We know the date is real; Caesar does not. The device is dramatic irony, but it has a moral weight here: we watch a man dismiss the one piece of true information he will be given, and we also watch the man who says there is no fate set about constructing it. A second hidden point: Caesar's word "dreamer" is not a random insult. It accuses the Soothsayer of belonging to the world of sleep and imagination rather than of politics and daylight. The whole play will test whether that division holds — the storm, Calpurnia's dream and Caesar's ghost all come from the side he dismisses.

Historical context: HISTORICAL RECORD: Plutarch and Suetonius both report that a seer, named by Suetonius as Spurinna, warned Caesar that danger would come to him no later than the Ides of March. The Ides was one of the three fixed marker days in every Roman month — the Kalends, the Nones and the Ides — falling on the 15th of March, May, July and October and the 13th of the other months, and it was sacred to Jupiter. So "the ides of March" is not a mystical phrase; to a Roman ear it is simply a calendar date, like saying 'the fifteenth'. That is precisely what makes the warning sinister: fate here speaks in the plainest possible terms, and is still ignored. The Romans took the reading of the future extremely seriously as a public matter — see the history box on augury below — which means Caesar's dismissal would have looked less like rational scepticism to his own people than it does to us.

Literary significance: The theme is built on repetition and anticlimax. The warning is repeated so that no one in the audience can miss it, and then brushed aside with a monosyllable, so that the gap between what we know and what Caesar knows opens like a trapdoor. The Soothsayer's lack of a name is itself a device: he is a function, not a person, the way a chorus is in Greek tragedy. His voice is "shriller than all the music" — Caesar's own words — which gives fate a sound: thin, high, cutting through ceremony. Against this Shakespeare sets Cassius's astrology image, "our stars", drawn from the belief that the position of the planets at birth governed a life; Cassius uses the image only in order to reject it. Structurally, the fate theme is a frame: it opens Caesar's first scene and will close his last.

ICSE keywords: fate, destiny, foreshadowing, dramatic irony, prophecy, soothsayer, portent, inevitability, hubris, tragic warning, anticlimax, chorus-like figure.

Connection to later Acts: Glance ahead to Act 2 Scene 2, where fate speaks again through Calpurnia's dream and the priests' sacrifice, and Caesar again overrules it. Glance ahead to Act 2 Scene 3 and Act 2 Scene 4, where Artemidorus's letter and the Soothsayer's second appearance give Caesar further chances he does not take. Glance ahead to the opening of Act 3 Scene 1, where Caesar taunts the Soothsayer that the Ides have come and is told, in effect, that they have not yet gone — the exact completion of the warning you have just read. Glance ahead to Act 4 Scene 3 and Act 5, where Caesar's ghost and the omens before Philippi turn fate's attention from the victim to the killers, and where Cassius, the man of "our stars", dies on his own birthday.

2. Free Will

Definition: Free will is the belief that human beings genuinely choose their actions and are therefore responsible for them — that the future is open, and that what a man becomes depends on what he decides. Philosophically it is the opposite pole from fate. In this play it has a political edge: if men are not "underlings" by destiny, then the man who bows to Caesar has *chosen* to bow, and can choose to stop. Free will in Act 1 is not a comfortable idea about freedom. It is a demand: get up and act.

Act 1 evidence: The theme is almost entirely Cassius's property in Act 1, and he states it twice, in two different keys. To Brutus, in daylight, the key is reasonable and flattering: men are at some time masters of their fates; the fault is not in our stars but in ourselves. To Casca, in the storm, the key is defiant and physical. Cassius claims he has walked the streets with his clothing open — "thus unbracèd" (unbraced means with the doublet unfastened) — and offered his chest to the lightning. When Casca reports that the Senate means to crown Caesar, Cassius answers that he knows where he will wear his dagger: "Cassius from bondage will deliver Cassius." He then develops the idea into a hymn to the free will of the suicide: no tower, wall, dungeon or chain "Can be retentive to the strength of spirit" (retentive means able to hold in); life "Never lacks power to dismiss itself." Casca catches the idea at once — "So every bondman in his own hand bears / The power to cancel his captivity" (a bondman is a slave). Observe, though, that this is the free will of self-destruction before it becomes the free will of rebellion. The first liberty Cassius names is the liberty to die.

Important scenes: Cassius's stars speech in Act 1 Scene 2; Cassius's soliloquy at the end of that scene, where his own theory of free will is quietly applied to Brutus; the dagger speech and the handshake with Casca in Act 1 Scene 3.

Characters: Cassius is the theorist and the practitioner. Casca is the convert, and his conversion is suspiciously fast. Brutus is the test case: a man whose will Cassius publicly praises as free and privately plans to steer. Caesar, oddly, is also a free-will figure in Act 1: his "Pass" is a man choosing, in full knowledge, to disregard a warning.

Quotations: - "Men at some time are masters of their fates." — Cassius to Brutus, Act 1 Scene 2. - "Cassius from bondage will deliver Cassius." — Cassius to Casca, Act 1 Scene 3. - "Therein, you gods, you make the weak most strong; / Therein, you gods, you tyrants do defeat." — Cassius, Act 1 Scene 3. - "For who so firm that cannot be seduced?" — Cassius, alone, Act 1 Scene 2.

Hidden significance: Read the soliloquy and the stars speech side by side and the theme turns inside out. To Brutus's face, Cassius says the fault is in ourselves, that is, in our wills. Alone, he says that Brutus's "honourable mettle may be wrought / From that it is disposed" — that his noble metal can be beaten into a new shape (wrought means worked, as a smith works iron) — and that no one is so firm he cannot be seduced. In other words, the great preacher of free will does not believe that Brutus's will is free at all; he believes it can be engineered. That is the hidden argument of Act 1: free will is proclaimed as a principle and treated as a mechanism. A second layer concerns the gods. Cassius thanks them — "Therein, you gods" — for making the weak strong through suicide. The man who says the fault is not in our stars still addresses the heavens when it suits his rhetoric. A third layer is dramatic irony: when Cassius says his dagger will deliver him from bondage, the audience that knows the story hears a prophecy of Philippi, where the same hand and a dagger will end his life. His theory of free will is true in the one way he did not intend.

Historical context: HISTORICAL RECORD: the real Cassius was an Epicurean — a follower of the Greek philosopher Epicurus, whose school taught that the gods, if they existed, took no interest in human affairs, and that omens were superstition. The Brutus of history leaned towards Stoicism, which taught that a wise man accepts what he cannot change and keeps his virtue under any fortune. Shakespeare does not label either man in Act 1, but his Cassius's contempt for fate fits what the sources say about him, and his Brutus's silence on the

subject fits a Stoic's indifference to omens. **HISTORICAL RECORD** also: Roman thought honoured suicide as a free man's last exercise of will against tyranny — Cato the Younger, Brutus's uncle by marriage, had killed himself in 46 BC rather than accept Caesar's pardon, and that death was still fresh when the play's events take place. Cassius's "bondage" speech would have sounded to a Roman like a reference to a very recent example.

Literary significance: The theme is carried by imagery of metal and of binding. Brutus's nature is "mettle" (spirit; but the word puns on metal, and the MIT text actually spells it 'metal'), which can be "wrought"; freedom is the absence of "walls of beaten brass" and "strong links of iron". Cassius's dagger speech is built on anaphora — "Nor stony tower, nor walls of beaten brass, / Nor airless dungeon, nor strong links of iron" — a piling-up of impossibilities that makes the single "But" which follows feel like a door opening. Notice, too, the grammar of "Cassius from bondage will deliver Cassius": the subject and the object are the same man, which is the whole idea of free will compressed into a line. And Shakespeare gives the free-will speeches to the storm, not to the sunshine: the man insisting that men control events is shouting over thunder he did not make.

ICSE keywords: free will, agency, autonomy, self-determination, Stoicism, Epicureanism, bondage, tyrannicide, anaphora, dramatic irony, soliloquy, manipulation.

Connection to later Acts: Glance ahead to Act 2 Scene 1, where Brutus's orchard soliloquy is the play's great exercise of a will choosing — and choosing on hypotheses about what Caesar *might* become. Glance ahead to Act 3 Scene 1, where the conspirators act as 'masters of their fates' and immediately discover that the act has consequences none of them chose. Glance ahead to Act 5 Scene 1, where Cassius admits that he once held Epicurus's opinion and now partly believes the birds, and where Brutus debates whether a Roman should take his own life — the Stoic and the Epicurean positions you have just met, finally spoken aloud. Glance ahead to Act 5 Scene 3 and Act 5 Scene 5, where both men use the freedom Cassius described in the storm.

FATE AND FREE WILL: THE PLAY'S CENTRAL ARGUMENT

Most school guides tell you that *Julius Caesar* is 'about' fate versus free will and leave it there, as if naming the two sides were the same as understanding the fight. It is not. The argument is worth a section of its own because Act 1 does something unusual: it gives the argument four voices, lets none of them win, and then shows you what each voice does with its hands.

Voice one: the Soothsayer. His position is the simplest. The future exists and can be known; his job is to say it. He does not explain, persuade or plead. He says "Beware the ides of March" twice and is gone. If you take him at his word, the universe has already decided, and the only freedom left to men is whether to listen.

Voice two: Cicero. In Scene 3, Casca pours out his catalogue of horrors and Cicero replies with two of the most intelligent lines in the Act: "men may construe things after their fashion, / Clean from the purpose of the things themselves" (construe means interpret; clean from means entirely apart from). Cicero does not deny that the night is strange — he calls it "a strange-disposed time". He denies that anyone can safely say what it *means*. His is the voice of the sceptic: the sky may be full of signs, but every reading of a sign is made by a man with a motive. Then he asks the only practical question in the scene — "Comes Caesar to the Capitol tomorrow?" — and goes home, because the sky "Is not to walk in". Cicero is the one Roman in Act 1 who separates knowledge from interpretation, and Shakespeare removes him from the stage before the conspiracy forms. That exit is a choice by the dramatist, and you may read it as a judgement: there is no room in this plot for the man who refuses to over-read.

Voice three: Cassius. He takes the opposite position to the Soothsayer — "The fault, dear Brutus, is not in our stars, / But in ourselves" — and yet, watch him in the storm. He tells Casca that heaven "hath infused them with these spirits / To make them instruments of fear and warning / Unto some monstrous state" — the

prodigies are messages after all, and the message is about Caesar. So which is it? Does the sky mean nothing, or does it mean Caesar? The honest answer is that Cassius believes whichever is useful at the moment. To Brutus, who needs to feel responsible, the stars are empty. To Casca, who is already frightened of the heavens, the heavens are recruiting for the conspiracy. Cassius is exactly the man Cicero was describing: he construes things after his fashion.

Voice four: Casca. He is the believer. "It is the part of men to fear and tremble / When the most mighty gods by tokens send / Such dreadful heralds to astonish us." For Casca the storm is unambiguous — "Either there is a civil strife in heaven, / Or else the world, too saucy with the gods, / Incenses them to send destruction" (saucy means insolent; incenses means enrages). And here is the thing to notice: the man who most believes the gods are speaking is the man who most quickly agrees to kill. Terror of fate does not make Casca passive; it makes him available. Within a hundred lines of saying men should tremble, he has shaken Cassius's hand.

Now put the four voices in a row. The Soothsayer says the future is fixed and does nothing but speak. Cicero says you cannot read the future and goes to bed. Cassius says there is no fixed future and manufactures one. Casca says the gods are furious and becomes an instrument of other men. Shakespeare does not tell us who is right. What he shows is that the *belief* a man holds about fate predicts almost nothing about what he will do, while the *use* he makes of that belief predicts everything. That is the central argument of the play in miniature, and it is why a good answer never says 'the play shows that fate controls everything' or 'the play shows that men make their own destiny'. The play shows men arguing about fate while they make it.

PROFESSOR'S INSIGHT Why the man who denies fate is the one who plots

There is a logic to Cassius's position that is easy to miss because it is so familiar to us. If you believe the gods have already written the ending, conspiracy is pointless: whatever you do, the Ides will come or they will not. If you believe the ending is open, then every hour you spend not acting is an hour in which you are choosing Caesar. Denial of fate is therefore not a philosophical ornament on Cassius; it is the fuel of his plot. He has to believe the fault is in ourselves, because otherwise there is nothing for him to do with his dagger except wear it. But the deeper point is this. Cassius's denial of fate does not extend to other people. He treats Brutus as a thing to be "wrought" and Casca as a man who will "set this foot of mine as far / As who goes farthest" once his pride is touched. Free will, for Cassius, is something he has and others do not. That is not a philosophy; it is the psychology of a manipulator who has found a philosophy that flatters him. And Shakespeare quietly turns the knife: the one man in Act 1 who most insists that he controls his fate is the one the audience knows will die by the dagger he is boasting about. LITERARY INTERPRETATION — but it is the reading that explains why the Act's fate speeches and its plotting are given to the same mouth.

3. Superstition

Definition: Superstition is belief in supernatural causes and cures that has no rational basis — a belief that an action or object can bring luck, ward off harm or reveal the future. The word is unfair to the Romans, for whom many of these practices were official religion, and you should use it carefully: what one culture calls superstition another calls piety. For exam purposes, treat superstition as the *personal* side of the theme (what an individual does to protect himself from the unseen) and omens as the *public* side (what the unseen is thought to be saying). Act 1 shows both, and shows them in the same man.

Act 1 evidence: Caesar's first instructions in the play are superstitious. He tells Calpurnia to stand in Antony's way as he runs the Lupercal course, and tells Antony "Forget not in your speed, Antonius, / To touch Calpurnia, for our elders say / The barren, touchèd in this holy chase, / Shake off their sterile curse." He wants

a childless wife struck by a runner because the old men say it works, and he ends with "Set on and leave no ceremony out." Within fifteen lines he dismisses a soothsayer as a dreamer. That juxtaposition is the whole theme. In Scene 1, Flavius orders the tribunes to strip Caesar's statues and Marullus hesitates — "You know it is the feast of Lupercal" — a flicker of religious scruple that Flavius overrides. In Scene 3, superstition becomes a flood: Casca's hand on his sword, his insistence that these are not natural things, his conviction that men should tremble. Cassius mocks him — "You are dull, Casca" — and then, within the same speech, offers his own supernatural reading. And in the smallest detail of all, Caesar asks Antony to speak into his good ear: "this ear is deaf". A man who trusts ceremonies to cure barrenness cannot hear a warning given on his left.

Important scenes: The opening of Act 1 Scene 2 (the Lupercal instructions and the Soothsayer); the exchange about the images at the end of Act 1 Scene 1; the whole of Act 1 Scene 3.

Characters: Caesar is the superstitious sceptic — the contradiction is the character. Casca is the frank believer. Cassius is the man who scorns belief and exploits it. Marullus has one line of scruple. Calpurnia is silent in Act 1, a woman whose body is the object of a ritual; her own fears belong to Act 2.

Quotations: - "The barren, touchèd in this holy chase, / Shake off their sterile curse." — Caesar to Antony, Act 1 Scene 2. - "Set on and leave no ceremony out." — Caesar, Act 1 Scene 2. - "He is a dreamer. Let us leave him. Pass." — Caesar, Act 1 Scene 2, a few lines later. - "It is the part of men to fear and tremble / When the most mighty gods by tokens send / Such dreadful heralds to astonish us." — Casca, Act 1 Scene 3.

Hidden significance: Caesar's superstition is selective, and the selection tells you about him. He accepts the ritual that promises him an heir — that is, that promises to extend his power into the next generation — and rejects the prophecy that threatens to end it. **LITERARY INTERPRETATION:** superstition in Caesar is not credulity; it is appetite. He believes what enlarges him. This is why "leave no ceremony out" is a politically loaded line: the ceremonies Caesar insists on are the ones that place him at the centre of Rome's religious life, and the tribunes' 'ceremonies' on his statues are the ones that make him look like a king. The second hidden point is about Casca. His superstition is real, but the sword he has not sheathed since meeting the lion is also real, and so is his hand when he offers it to Cassius. Fear of the gods and readiness to kill live comfortably together in him. The third point: the Lupercal rite is a fertility cure, and Caesar is childless. A line that sounds like local colour is actually telling you that the most powerful man in the world has no son — which is one reason the question of what happens after him is so urgent to everyone in the Act.

Historical context: **HISTORICAL RECORD:** the Lupercalia fell on 15 February and was an ancient purification and fertility festival. Its priests, the Luperci, ran through the city striking bystanders, especially women, with strips of goat-hide, and the touch was believed to promote fertility and ease childbirth. In 44 BC a new college of Luperci, the Juliani, had been created in Caesar's honour, and Antony, who was consul that year, ran as one of its members. So Caesar's instruction is not a private eccentricity; it is a public rite he had just personalised. **HISTORICAL RECORD** also: Calpurnia had married Caesar in 59 BC and the marriage was childless. For how Roman religion read the heavens as a matter of state, see the box below.

Literary significance: The theme is built on juxtaposition: the fertility rite and the death warning sit within a single short passage, so that the audience sees Caesar's two faces in one glance. The vocabulary is religious — "holy chase", "sterile curse", "ceremony" — and Shakespeare lets it rhyme with the political: "ceremonies" on statues, "Caesar's trophies". The deaf ear is a stage image as much as a line; a director can make Caesar physically turn away from the side the warning came from. Casca's speeches are prose in Scene 2 and verse in Scene 3, and the shift matters: the sardonic reporter of the crown becomes the shaken believer of the storm, and verse is the register of a man no longer in control of his tone.

ICSE keywords: superstition, ritual, ceremony, piety, scepticism, credulity, juxtaposition, hubris, selective belief, fertility rite, Lupercalia, dramatic irony.

Connection to later Acts: Glance ahead to Act 2 Scene 2, where Caesar sends for the augurers to sacrifice and then rejects what they find, and where he swings from granting Calpurnia's plea to overturning it on Decius's flattering reinterpretation of her dream — the selective superstition of Act 1 played out in full. Glance ahead to Act 2 Scene 1, where Cassius proposes they swear an oath and Brutus refuses: the conspiracy itself argues about ceremony. Glance ahead to Act 5 Scene 1, where Cassius, the mocker of Casca, confesses that he has begun to credit the omens of birds.

HISTORICAL CONTEXT Roman augury and omens (background)

HISTORICAL RECORD, offered as background so that you can judge how Caesar's dismissal of the Soothsayer would have sounded to Romans. The Roman state took the will of the gods seriously as a matter of public procedure. A college of augurs — Cicero himself was a member — interpreted the auspices: the flight, calls and feeding of birds, and other signs such as lightning. No assembly met and no magistrate took up major business without the auspices being taken, and an unfavourable sign could lawfully halt public action. A second class of specialists, the haruspices, of Etruscan origin, examined the entrails of sacrificed animals; it was in this tradition that the seer Spurinna, who warned Caesar about the Ides, stood. Beyond these were *prodigia* — prodigies, unnatural events such as rains of stones, speaking animals or fire in the sky — which were reported to the Senate, officially recorded and then 'expiated' by sacrifice as warnings that the peace between Rome and its gods had been disturbed. Caesar was himself *pontifex maximus*, Rome's chief priest, from 63 BC until his death. Plutarch's account of the days before the assassination records lights in the sky, birds settling in the Forum, men who seemed to walk about on fire, and a slave whose hand blazed without being burned — the last of which Shakespeare gives directly to Casca. Two cautions. First, educated Romans disagreed about all this: Cicero wrote a treatise, *On Divination*, in which the case against omens is argued as strongly as the case for them. Second, the lion that Casca meets near the Capitol has no clear counterpart in Plutarch's account and is generally regarded as Shakespeare's own addition; do not present it as history.

4. Omens

Definition: An omen is an event taken as a sign of what is to come — a comet, a strange birth, an animal where it should not be. Shakespeare's own words for it in Act 1 are "prodigies" (unnatural wonders), "portentous things" (things that foretell) and "tokens" (signs). The crucial feature of an omen, as distinct from a prophecy, is that it does not speak. A soothsayer tells you to beware; a burning hand simply burns, and somebody has to decide what it means. This is why the theme of omens is really the theme of *interpretation*, and why it belongs next to appearance versus reality rather than merely next to fate.

Act 1 evidence: Scene 3 opens with thunder and lightning and Casca's catalogue, which you should learn as a list of five. A slave's left hand "did flame and burn / Like twenty torches joined" and was unscorched. Near the Capitol he "met a lion, / Who glazed upon me and went surly by" (glazed means glared; surly means sullenly). A hundred terrified women "swore they saw / Men all in fire walk up and down the streets." Yesterday "the bird of night did sit / Even at noonday upon the marketplace, / Hooting and shrieking." And the night itself is "a tempest dropping fire". Casca's reasoning follows: "When these prodigies / Do so conjointly meet, let not men say / 'These are their reasons, they are natural'". Cassius then produces a second list, more abstract — fires, "gliding ghosts", birds and beasts acting against their kind, old men, fools and children who "calculate" (prophecy) — and reads them all as a warning "Unto some monstrous state". Later he says the sky's complexion "In favour's like the work we have in hand, / Most bloody, fiery, and most terrible." Cinna, entering, adds a third witness: "What a fearful night is this! / There's two or three of us have seen strange sights." Three men, three readings, one sky.

Important scenes: Act 1 Scene 3 from beginning to end. Nothing before it is an omen in the strict sense; the Soothsayer is a prophecy, and the swoon in the marketplace is a symptom that Cassius chooses to treat like a sign.

Characters: Casca is the frightened witness whose evidence is vivid and whose reasoning is simple. Cicero is the sceptic who declines to interpret. Cassius is the interpreter who turns omens into a recruiting speech. Cinna is the ordinary conspirator, scared and useful.

Quotations: - "Against the Capitol I met a lion, / Who glazed upon me and went surly by / Without annoying me." — Casca, Act 1 Scene 3. - "the bird of night did sit / Even at noonday upon the marketplace, / Hooting and shrieking." — Casca, Act 1 Scene 3. - "men may construe things after their fashion, / Clean from the purpose of the things themselves." — Cicero, Act 1 Scene 3. - "In favour's like the work we have in hand, / Most bloody, fiery, and most terrible." — Cassius, Act 1 Scene 3.

Hidden significance: Casca's omens are all inversions: fire that does not burn, a wild beast that does not attack, a night bird at noon, men made of flame. Each is a thing behaving against its nature — and that is exactly what Cassius will accuse Rome of a few minutes later: a city whose fathers' minds are dead, governed by "our mothers' spirits". LITERARY INTERPRETATION: the omens are a picture of a state turned upside down, and the question Act 1 refuses to answer is *who* has turned it — Caesar by rising, or the conspirators by what they are about to do. Cassius says the sky is "like the work we have in hand". He means it as encouragement. Hear it as a confession: the bloody, fiery, terrible thing the heavens are warning about may be the conspiracy itself. A second point is about "the lion in the Capitol". Casca met a lion; Cassius turns it into a simile for Caesar, who "roars / As doth the lion in the Capitol". Within fifty lines a thing seen has become a thing meant. That is how omens work in politics: a report becomes an argument.

Historical context: HISTORICAL RECORD: Plutarch, Shakespeare's source through North's translation, lists prodigies before the assassination, including the slave whose hand flamed harmlessly and birds in the Forum; Shakespeare takes these, intensifies them, and adds a lion. The Roman habit of reading unnatural events as warnings to the state is described in the history box above. For how Shakespeare's first audience might have received this scene, read the box below — and notice that Cicero's scepticism had a respectable home in both worlds.

Literary significance: The omens are the play's great set piece of imagery, and almost all of it is fire: torches, a tempest "dropping fire", men "all in fire", "fires", a sky "fiery". The storm is pathetic fallacy on a civic scale — the weather expressing not one man's mood but a nation's crisis — and it is also a theatrical necessity, since on a daylight stage the thunder, the breathlessness and the staring eyes are what tell an audience it is night and something is wrong. Casca's verse here is full of sibilants and hard consonants — "scolding winds", "Shakes like a thing unfirm" — and the women are "Transformèd with their fear". Structurally, the scene is a debate about reading, and Shakespeare arranges the readers in order of increasing self-interest: Casca (frightened), Cicero (detached), Cassius (motivated).

ICSE keywords: omen, portent, prodigy, pathetic fallacy, foreshadowing, inversion of nature, interpretation, scepticism, fire imagery, atmosphere, foreboding, supernatural.

Connection to later Acts: Glance ahead to Act 2 Scene 1, where the same storm is still raging when Brutus's conspirators arrive and the men dispute, absurdly, where the sun rises. Glance ahead to Act 2 Scene 2, where Calpurnia reports a new list of prodigies — a lioness whelping in the streets, graves yielding their dead, warriors fighting in the clouds — and Caesar answers that these signs are for the world in general, not for him. Glance ahead to Act 5 Scene 1, where Cassius reads his own omen in eagles replaced by ravens, crows and kites above his army, and becomes, at the end, the Casca he mocked.

HISTORICAL CONTEXT Elizabethan attitudes to portents (background)

HISTORICAL RECORD as background, with the caution that we cannot know what any one spectator in 1599 thought. Shakespeare's audience lived in a culture in which the heavens were widely held to comment on human affairs. Comets and eclipses were recorded as warnings; almanacs predicting the weather, illness and public events were among the most widely sold printed books; and Elizabeth I's court had consulted the astrologer and mathematician John Dee, who is said to have chosen a propitious date for her coronation. The official Church of England discouraged astrology and divination, yet the government's own Homilies — sermons read in parish churches — taught that order in the state mirrored order in creation, so that rebellion was a kind of disorder in nature. Audiences may therefore have felt that a storm over Rome on the eve of a murder was not decoration but doctrine. At the same time, sceptical voices existed: Reginald Scot's *Discoverie of Witchcraft* (1584) attacked belief in witches and wonders, and Cicero's own treatise against divination was read in schools. In 1599, with an ageing, unmarried queen and no named heir, a play in which the sky protests the fall of a ruler, and in which the interpretation of signs is itself shown to be political, had an obvious contemporary charge. State it as 'may have', never as 'did'.

5. Appearance vs Reality

Definition: The theme of appearance versus reality concerns the gap between how things seem and how they are — and, just as importantly, who is able to see across that gap. In most plays the gap is a matter of disguise or lies. In *Julius Caesar* it is subtler: almost nobody in Act 1 lies outright. Instead people perform, interpret, report, and are misread. The theme is therefore inseparable from the play's interest in sight: eyes, mirrors, glasses, reflection, looking "Quite through" a man.

Act 1 evidence: Start with Caesar's performance in the marketplace, which we never see. Casca reports that the crown was refused three times, "every time gentler than other", and that to his thinking Caesar "would fain have had it"; he also tells us "'twas not a crown neither; 'twas one of these coronets". Whether the refusal was real modesty, a test of the crowd or a show, SHAKESPEARE'S TEXT leaves undecided — we have only a hostile witness's reading of a scene that happened offstage. Then Cassius's mirror. Brutus admits that "the eye sees not itself / But by reflection, by some other things", and Cassius offers to be that reflection: "I, your glass, / Will modestly discover to yourself / That of yourself which you yet know not of." A mirror that chooses what to show is not a mirror. By the end of the scene, Cassius is planning letters "As if they came from several citizens" — appearance manufactured to produce a reality. Set against all this one man who does see through surfaces: Caesar on Cassius, "he looks / Quite through the deeds of men". Antony, by contrast, sees only the surface — "He is a noble Roman, and well given." And Casca, whom Brutus takes for a blunt fool, is described by Cassius as a man who "puts on this tardy form" (puts on a slow, dull manner); the sourness is a costume.

Important scenes: The mirror dialogue in Act 1 Scene 2; Casca's report in the same scene; Caesar's reading of Cassius; Cassius's soliloquy; and, in Act 1 Scene 3, Casca's prediction that Brutus's reputation will make the conspiracy look virtuous.

Characters: Cassius is the maker of appearances. Caesar is the one true reader in the Act — and the one who is going to be fooled. Brutus is the man who cannot see himself and is offered a crooked glass. Casca is a man wearing a mask of dullness. Antony is the surface-reader. The crowd sees only what is shown to it.

Quotations: - "the eye sees not itself / But by reflection, by some other things" — Brutus to Cassius, Act 1 Scene 2. - "I, your glass, / Will modestly discover to yourself / That of yourself which you yet know not of." — Cassius to Brutus, Act 1 Scene 2. - "he looks / Quite through the deeds of men" — Caesar on Cassius, Act 1 Scene 2. - "His countenance, like richest alchemy, / Will change to virtue and to worthiness." — Casca on Brutus, Act 1 Scene 3.

Hidden significance: The most important hidden point is that the only character who reads others accurately is also the character most wrong about himself. Caesar diagnoses Cassius perfectly — the lean look, the reading, the mirthless smile, the inability to be at ease while a greater man exists — and then adds "for always I am Caesar", as if the name were armour. Reality is available to him and he declines to apply it. A second point: Casca's alchemy image tells you that the conspirators themselves know the difference between their appearance and their reality. They need Brutus not because he will fight better but because his "countenance" (face, and also approval) will turn what "would appear offence in us" into "virtue". That is a confession that the enterprise, seen plainly, looks like a crime. **LITERARY INTERPRETATION:** Act 1 is a study in how a republic of watchers — "a great observer", "I do observe you now of late" — nevertheless manages to see almost nothing true.

Historical context: **HISTORICAL RECORD:** the real Brutus did receive anonymous messages urging him to act — Plutarch records graffiti and notes asking whether he was asleep and telling him he was no true Brutus. Shakespeare's change is to give them an author. In Plutarch they come from the people; in the play they are forged by Cassius. That single alteration converts a historical fact about public opinion into a theme about manufactured appearance, and it is the strongest piece of evidence that Shakespeare wanted this theme in his Act.

Literary significance: The theme's vocabulary is optical: "eyes", "see", "reflection", "mirrors", "glass", "shadow", "looks", "observer". Cassius's mirror speech is an extended metaphor, and it is also a paradox, since a mirror that "modestly" discovers what you do not know is doing the opposite of reflecting. Casca's "alchemy" is a metaphor from the pseudo-science of turning base metal to gold — Brutus's face as the philosopher's stone that turns murder to virtue. The structural device is report: the crown scene reaches us second-hand so that we, like Brutus, must take appearance on trust. And the Act's final line is Cassius's promise to "be sure of him" — the language of certainty closing an Act in which nothing has been certain.

ICSE keywords: appearance, reality, perception, illusion, manipulation, extended metaphor, mirror image, paradox, reported action, dramatic irony, deception, self-knowledge.

Connection to later Acts: Glance ahead to Act 2 Scene 1, where Brutus tells the conspirators to hide their purposes behind smiles and 'formal constancy', making concealment an official policy of the honourable men. Glance ahead to Act 2 Scene 2, where Decius reinterprets Calpurnia's dream of blood as a vision of Rome's revival — the mirror trick worked on Caesar himself. Glance ahead to Act 3 Scene 2, where Antony, the surface-reader of Act 1, turns out to be the play's master of appearances, calling the murderers honourable men until the word means its opposite.

APPEARANCE VS REALITY IN ACT 1

Use this table as a revision instrument. The third column is the one examiners reward, because it forces you to say *who* in the play can see the truth, and so to connect the theme to character.

What appears	What is real	Who sees through it
A triumph that all Rome celebrates with flowers and holiday clothes	A victory over Pompey's sons — Romans — with no foreign captives to show	Marullus and Flavius; the commoners do not
A cobbler who cannot answer a straight question	A quick wit running rings round two officials in puns	The audience; the tribunes hear only insolence
Caesar refusing a crown three times before a cheering crowd	A gesture whose sincerity the text never confirms; a "coronet", not a crown	Casca suspects; Cassius and Brutus accept his suspicion; the crowd takes the refusal at face value
Cassius as a mirror offering Brutus his own hidden worth	A recruiter selecting the image he needs Brutus to see	Caesar, who reads Cassius exactly; Brutus does not
Brutus's coldness to Cassius as a cooling of friendship	A man "with himself at war" over Caesar	Cassius, once Brutus explains — and he exploits it at once
Caesar as a god who bestrides the world	A man who nearly drowned, shook with fever and foams in the marketplace	Cassius presses this case; the crowd forgives the swoon
Letters from many citizens urging Brutus to act	One hand in "several hands" — Cassius's forgeries	No one on stage; only the audience
Casca as a blunt, slow, sour fellow	A man of "quick mettle" wearing "this tardy form"	Cassius; Brutus is surprised by the change
A storm as the gods' judgement on Rome	A sky that men "construe" to suit themselves	Cicero
Caesar's "always I am Caesar" — the man as institution	A man with a deaf ear who has just ignored a true warning	The audience, armed with history; Cassius in part

Two cautions about using the table. First, never write that Caesar 'was pretending' to refuse the crown: the text does not know, and an answer that pretends to know loses the mark for interpretation. Second, notice that the right-hand column is nearly empty of Brutus. The most honourable man in the Act sees through nothing, and that is a fact about his tragedy, not a flaw in your table.

6. Friendship

Definition: Friendship, in the Roman sense Shakespeare inherited through Plutarch, was not merely affection; *amicitia* was a public bond of mutual obligation between men of standing, and to call a man friend was to make a claim on him. In Act 1 the word 'friend' and the word 'love' are used almost interchangeably, and almost always by someone who wants something. The theme to track is therefore not whether these men like one another but what the language of friendship is *doing* in each scene.

Act 1 evidence: The long dialogue between Brutus and Cassius opens as a quarrel between friends. Cassius complains that he no longer receives from Brutus's eyes "that gentleness / And show of love as I was wont to have" and that Brutus is harsh "Over your friend that loves you." Brutus's answer is one of the Act's most moving passages: his trouble is inward, "poor Brutus, with himself at war, / Forgets the shows of love to other men." He then says the sentence the whole play depends on: "I would not, Cassius, yet I love him well." Brutus loves Caesar. He also loves Cassius — he parts with "Till then, my noble friend, chew upon this" — and Cassius, alone, admits the asymmetry at the heart of it: "Caesar doth bear me hard, but he loves Brutus." Caesar's own friendship is on display too: he confides in Antony, asks him to walk on his right side, and

receives in return loyalty so fast it is a reflex — "Fear him not, Caesar; he's not dangerous." In Scene 3, friendship becomes a handshake in the dark: "Hold. My hand." The Act begins with Cassius mourning a lost "show of love" and ends with him certain of Brutus as if the man were a possession.

Important scenes: The opening of the Brutus–Cassius dialogue in Act 1 Scene 2; Caesar and Antony in the same scene; Cassius's soliloquy; the Casca–Cassius pact in Act 1 Scene 3.

Characters: Brutus loves both sides and will have to betray one. Cassius uses the word love as a lever and believes himself unloved by Caesar. Caesar trusts Antony and is right to; he does not count Brutus among his dangers, and that silence is terrible. Antony is loyalty without analysis — in Act 1.

Quotations: - "I have not from your eyes that gentleness / And show of love as I was wont to have." — Cassius to Brutus, Act 1 Scene 2. - "I would not, Cassius, yet I love him well." — Brutus, Act 1 Scene 2. - "Caesar doth bear me hard, but he loves Brutus." — Cassius, alone, Act 1 Scene 2. - "Fear him not, Caesar; he's not dangerous." — Antony to Caesar, Act 1 Scene 2.

Hidden significance: Notice the word "shows". Brutus speaks of "the shows of love"; Cassius of "show of love". Both men assume that love has an outward performance that can be given or withheld, and Cassius's whole method is to treat the performance as the thing itself: if Brutus will *show* love, Cassius can work with it. LITERARY INTERPRETATION: friendship in Act 1 is the medium through which manipulation travels — nobody could be seduced by a stranger. The second point is the one students miss: Caesar's great mistake in Act 1 is not that he trusts the wrong friend but that he studies the wrong enemy. He reads Cassius flawlessly and never looks at Brutus, because Brutus is a friend and friends are not read. "He loves Brutus" is the most dangerous sentence in the Act.

Historical context: HISTORICAL RECORD: Brutus had fought for Pompey against Caesar and been pardoned after Pharsalus; Caesar then advanced him, making him governor of Cisalpine Gaul and, in 44 BC, urban praetor — the senior praetorship — over Cassius, which ancient sources record as a grievance of Cassius. Brutus's mother Servilia had long been Caesar's mistress. So the friendship between Caesar and Brutus was real, recent and generous, and Cassius's jealousy of it had a specific cause. Shakespeare keeps the emotional shape and drops the details.

Literary significance: The theme is carried by direct address — "good Brutus", "gentle Brutus", "dear Brutus", "my noble friend" — a texture of endearments that makes the soliloquy's cold "Well, Brutus, thou art noble" land like a change of temperature. The eye image belongs here as much as to appearance versus reality: a friend is supposed to be the mirror in which you see yourself truly, and Shakespeare makes Cassius claim precisely that role while abusing it. Structurally, friendship frames the Act's two recruitments: the slow, loving one of Brutus and the fast, handshaken one of Casca.

ICSE keywords: friendship, love, loyalty, trust, betrayal, intimacy, manipulation, confidant, obligation, asymmetry, pathos, dramatic irony.

Connection to later Acts: Glance ahead to Act 2 Scene 1, where Caesar's friends arrive at Brutus's house to plan his death, and where Brutus insists that they carve Caesar as a dish fit for the gods — love attempting to control the manner of a murder. Glance ahead to Act 3 Scene 1 for the moment this theme is built towards: Caesar's last words to Brutus. Glance ahead to Act 3 Scene 2, where Antony calls Brutus Caesar's angel, and to Act 4 Scene 3, where Brutus and Cassius quarrel and reconcile in a tent — the Act 1 friendship tested to breaking and mended.

7. Jealousy

Definition: Jealousy is pain at another's possession of what you believe should be yours — rank, love, reputation. Distinguish it from envy, which wants what another has, and from ambition, which wants to rise; jealousy is specifically the wound of comparison. A warning about the word itself: in Shakespeare's English 'jealous' often means suspicious, and that is what Brutus means by "I am nothing jealous" and Cassius by "be not jealous on me". The theme is present in the Act's emotions long before it is present in its vocabulary.

Act 1 evidence: Cassius's two stories about Caesar are not evidence of unfitness to rule; they are the memories of a man who cannot bear a comparison. The Tiber story ends not with Caesar's weakness but with Cassius's status: "this man / Is now become a god, and Cassius is / A wretched creature and must bend his body / If Caesar carelessly but nod on him." The fever story circles the same wound — "'Tis true, this god did shake" — and ends with Caesar crying for drink "As a sick girl". The name speech is jealousy made musical: "Why should that name be sounded more than yours?" And Caesar, from the other side, diagnoses the condition in a single sentence: "Such men as he be never at heart's ease / Whiles they behold a greater than themselves". Cassius's own soliloquy supplies the motive in the plainest words: "Caesar doth bear me hard, but he loves Brutus." That is two jealousies in one line — of Caesar's power and of Brutus's place in Caesar's affection.

Important scenes: The Tiber and fever narratives and the name speech in Act 1 Scene 2; Caesar's assessment of Cassius in the same scene; Cassius's soliloquy.

Characters: Cassius is the Act's embodiment of jealousy and, importantly, never names it in himself; he calls it honour. Caesar is both its object and its best analyst. Brutus is innocent of it — his "nothing jealous" is literally true — and that innocence is what makes him usable.

Quotations: - "And this man / Is now become a god, and Cassius is / A wretched creature and must bend his body / If Caesar carelessly but nod on him." — Cassius, Act 1 Scene 2. - "Why should that name be sounded more than yours?" — Cassius to Brutus, Act 1 Scene 2. - "Such men as he be never at heart's ease / Whiles they behold a greater than themselves" — Caesar on Cassius, Act 1 Scene 2. - "Yond Cassius has a lean and hungry look." — Caesar, Act 1 Scene 2.

Hidden significance: The crucial point is that Cassius's jealousy is *accurate*. Everything he says about Caesar's body may be true; Caesar may well have the falling sickness and may well have cried for water in Spain. Jealousy here is not delusion but a lens that selects the true facts which hurt. That makes it far more dangerous dramatically than a lie, because Brutus can check the facts and find them sound. **LITERARY INTERPRETATION:** Shakespeare shows that a republic can be destroyed by a man telling the truth for the wrong reason. A second point: Caesar's "lean and hungry look" is a physical description of jealousy — a man eaten thin by comparison — and Caesar's prescription, men "that are fat" and "such as sleep a-nights", is a portrait of the contented. Caesar understands the disease precisely and misjudges only its reach.

Historical context: **HISTORICAL RECORD:** Plutarch reports that Caesar said he did not fear fat, long-haired men but the pale, thin ones, meaning Brutus and Cassius — Shakespeare moves the remark to apply to Cassius alone, which sharpens the theme and protects Brutus. Plutarch also records the praetorship grievance mentioned above. Ancient writers themselves differed about Cassius's motive: some saw principle, some private hatred of Caesar, and Shakespeare preserves that uncertainty.

Literary significance: Jealousy is written in antithesis — "this man" against "Cassius", "a god" against "A wretched creature", "that name" against "yours". The posture words do the emotional work: "bend his body", "nod", "underlings", "Walk under his huge legs". Cassius's rhetoric constantly measures: write the names,

sound them, weigh them. A jealous man is a man with scales in his head. Caesar's description, meanwhile, is a character sketch in the manner of a Theophrastan 'character' — a type drawn from the outside — and it is one of the finest in Shakespeare.

ICSE keywords: jealousy, envy, resentment, comparison, inferiority, rivalry, antithesis, motive, rationalisation, lean and hungry, self-deception, character sketch.

Connection to later Acts: Glance ahead to Act 4 Scene 3, where Cassius's resentment turns on Brutus himself, in the quarrel over Lucius Pella and the gold, and where he says in effect that Brutus loved Caesar more than he ever loved Cassius — the Act 1 wound reopened. Glance ahead to Act 5 Scene 3, where Cassius's misreading of Titinius, the comrade he named in the fever story, ends his life.

PROFESSOR'S INSIGHT Jealousy as a political engine

The Republic's constitution ran on jealousy. Two consuls, each able to veto the other; ten tribunes; annual elections; a horror of any man standing above his peers — the whole machine was designed on the assumption that aristocrats would watch one another with suspicious eyes and that this mutual watchfulness would keep anyone from becoming a king. Cassius's jealousy is, in that light, not a private vice but the republican reflex working as designed: a senator who feels sick when he sees a greater man than himself is exactly the senator the system needs. The tragedy is that by 44 BC the system had been overtaken by one man, so that the reflex no longer had a lawful outlet — no veto could touch a dictator for life — and it turned into a dagger. This is why Cassius can experience his jealousy as patriotism without lying to himself: in Rome, for five centuries, they had been the same feeling. The reading is LITERARY INTERPRETATION built on HISTORICAL RECORD, and it is the one that lets you write about Cassius without the schoolroom choice between 'villain' and 'patriot'. He is a republican organ working in a body that has already changed.

8. Political Anxiety

Definition: Political anxiety is the fear that the state is about to change in a way you cannot control — fear not of a particular event but of an unknown future. It is the emotional weather of Act 1. Nobody in the Act is in power except Caesar, and even Caesar is anxious; everyone else is listening for shouts, reading faces, asking what happened. The theme is closely tied to the fact that almost every important event in the Act is *heard about* rather than seen.

Act 1 evidence: Listen to the Act's sounds. Brutus interrupts Cassius at the first shout — "What means this shouting? I do fear the people / Choose Caesar for their king" — and again at the second, guessing at "some new honours". Fear here precedes information. When Caesar's train returns, Brutus reads it like a weather report: "The angry spot doth glow on Caesar's brow, / And all the rest look like a chidden train" (a chidden train is a scolded retinue); "Calpurnia's cheek is pale"; Cicero has "ferret and such fiery eyes". Caesar himself, who should be the Act's one secure man, wants "men about me that are fat, / Sleek-headed men, and such as sleep a-nights" — an anxious man's wish for untroubled company — and then walks away talking about the man he does not fear. Casca's news that the tribunes "are put to silence" lands quietly, but it is the Act's first proof that disagreement now carries a cost. In Scene 3 anxiety becomes atmosphere: a sky nobody should walk in, a challenge in the dark — "Who's there?" "A Roman." — and men who hide when footsteps approach: "Stand close awhile, for here comes one in haste." Cassius's soliloquy ends the second scene on the Act's keynote: "let Caesar seat him sure, / For we will shake him, or worse days endure."

Important scenes: The shouts and Caesar's return in Act 1 Scene 2; Casca's news of the tribunes; the opening and the furtive meetings of Act 1 Scene 3.

Characters: Brutus is the Act's most anxious man, and his anxiety is about Rome rather than himself. Caesar is anxious and will not admit it. Casca carries the rumours. Cassius converts anxiety into action. Cicero's "ferret" eyes show that even the detached man is disturbed.

Quotations: - "What means this shouting? I do fear the people / Choose Caesar for their king." — Brutus, Act 1 Scene 2. - "Let me have men about me that are fat, / Sleek-headed men, and such as sleep a-nights." — Caesar, Act 1 Scene 2. - "Indeed, they say the Senators tomorrow / Mean to establish Caesar as a king" — Casca, Act 1 Scene 3. - "let Caesar seat him sure, / For we will shake him, or worse days endure." — Cassius, Act 1 Scene 2.

Hidden significance: Brutus's fear arrives before Cassius's persuasion. He hears a shout and fears a king without a word of prompting — so Cassius does not plant the anxiety; he harvests it. **LITERARY INTERPRETATION:** the conspiracy is less Cassius's creation than the organised form of a fear that was already general, and Act 1 is careful to show the fear in Brutus, in Caesar, in Casca and in the tribunes before it shows it in a plot. A second point: "they say" — Casca's rumour of a crowning is unsourced. The Act's decisive political fact is hearsay, and no one checks it. A third: Caesar's anxiety and the conspirators' are the same anxiety. He fears thin, watchful men; they fear a Colossus. Both are frightened of the other's future.

Historical context: **HISTORICAL RECORD:** in early 44 BC Caesar had just been made dictator for life, a diadem had been placed on his statue and removed by the tribunes, and rumours circulated of a plan to make him king outside Italy — Shakespeare's Casca repeats a version of that rumour. It is also **HISTORICAL RECORD** that in 1599 England was governed by a queen of sixty-six with no named heir; audiences may have recognised the sensation of a state waiting for a change it could not name. Do not claim more than 'may have'.

Literary significance: The theme is created by offstage sound — the Folio's flourishes and shouts — and by the device of reported action, so that the audience shares the characters' position of guessing. Faces become texts to be read: "spot", "cheek", "eyes". Scene 3's night setting, the challenge-and-password exchange and the whispered names give the Act a conspiratorial register that it did not have in the daylight of Scene 1. The rhyming couplet that closes Scene 2 — "sure" / "endure" — is a formal signal: a decision has been reached.

ICSE keywords: anxiety, instability, rumour, hearsay, uncertainty, foreboding, tension, reported action, offstage sound, conspiratorial atmosphere, suspense, succession.

Connection to later Acts: Glance ahead to Act 2 Scene 1, where Brutus's anxiety becomes insomnia and a reasoning that condemns Caesar for what he might become. Glance ahead to Act 2 Scene 4, where Portia's panic in the street is political anxiety at its most physical. Glance ahead to Act 3 Scene 1, where the conspirators' fear that Popilius Lena knows their plan nearly undoes them, and to Act 4 and Act 5, where anxiety becomes the mood of two armies waiting for a battle neither is sure of.

9. Leadership

Definition: Leadership is the capacity to make others follow — by command, by example, by reputation or by persuasion. The theme in Act 1 is a comparison of *kinds*: Caesar leads by presence and command, Cassius by argument in private, Brutus by a reputation he has not yet used, the tribunes by shaming a crowd. The question the Act poses is not 'who is the best leader?' but 'what does each kind of leadership cost, and what does it fail to see?'

Act 1 evidence: Caesar's leadership is a grammar of imperatives — "Set on", "Set him before me", "Pass" — answered by Antony's maxim, "When Caesar says 'Do this,' it is performed." It is also a performance of invulnerability: "I rather tell thee what is to be feared / Than what I fear; for always I am Caesar." Yet in the same breath he says "Come on my right hand, for this ear is deaf" — the leader who claims to fear nothing has to arrange where his advisers stand so that he can hear them. Casca's report shows the public face of this leadership: Caesar offers the crowd his throat, falls, and then asks "their Worships to think it was his infirmity" — a leader managing his own weakness as theatre, and succeeding, since "Three or four wenches where I stood cried 'Alas, good soul!'" . Cassius's leadership is the opposite: private, patient, tailored to each listener. Brutus's leadership is the Act's great unused asset — "he sits high in all the people's hearts" — and Cassius's arithmetic of it, "Three parts of him / Is ours already", shows a leader being acquired like territory.

Important scenes: Caesar's commands and his conversation with Antony in Act 1 Scene 2; Casca's report of the marketplace; Cassius's handling of Brutus and then Casca; the end of Act 1 Scene 3.

Characters: Caesar — command and performance. Cassius — persuasion and organisation. Brutus — reputation without yet a single act of leadership. Antony — the perfect subordinate, which is a kind of leadership in waiting. Flavius and Marullus — leadership by rebuke, which clears a street and costs them their voices.

Quotations: - "When Caesar says 'Do this,' it is performed." — Antony, Act 1 Scene 2. - "I rather tell thee what is to be feared / Than what I fear; for always I am Caesar." — Caesar, Act 1 Scene 2. - "he sits high in all the people's hearts" — Casca on Brutus, Act 1 Scene 3. - "Three parts of him / Is ours already, and the man entire / Upon the next encounter yields him ours." — Cassius, Act 1 Scene 3.

Hidden significance: Caesar's leadership is shown to depend on *not being seen closely*. From the crowd's distance he is a god; at Cassius's distance he is a man who nearly drowned; at Antony's distance he is a man with a deaf ear. LITERARY INTERPRETATION: Shakespeare constructs leadership as a function of distance, which is why the Act never puts Caesar in a private, equal conversation — the nearest thing is his aside to Antony, and it is about fear. A second point: Brutus's leadership is entirely reputational, and reputational leadership can be *borrowed*. Casca's alchemy speech makes that explicit — the conspirators want his name to make their deed look like virtue. A leader whose authority is his good name is a leader who can be spent by others.

Historical context: HISTORICAL RECORD: Caesar's authority in 44 BC rested on offices he held — dictator for life, consul, *pontifex maximus* — on an army personally loyal to him, and on an immense popularity with the urban plebs built on games, grain and the spectacle of triumphs. Plutarch records his epilepsy, and Shakespeare preserves it; the deafness is Shakespeare's addition and has no basis in the ancient sources, which makes it a deliberate piece of characterisation rather than a historical fact.

Literary significance: The imperative mood is Caesar's signature, and his illeism — speaking of himself as "Caesar" — makes the man sound like his office. The Colossus is the Act's governing image of leadership-as-height, and Flavius's falcon image in Scene 1 gives the same idea a predatory edge: a leader who would "soar above the view of men". Shakespeare arranges a structural contrast between Caesar's public leadership, which we only hear about, and Cassius's private leadership, which we watch in detail — so that the audience knows the conspiracy far better than it knows the dictator.

ICSE keywords: leadership, authority, command, charisma, reputation, imperative, illeism, performance, public image, subordinate, acquisition, distance.

Connection to later Acts: Glance ahead to Act 2 Scene 1, where Brutus takes command of the conspiracy on his first night in it and overrules Cassius three times — the leader by reputation becoming a leader by decision, with consequences. Glance ahead to Act 3 Scene 2, where leadership passes, in a single afternoon, to whoever

can hold the Forum. Glance ahead to Act 4 Scene 3 and Act 5 Scene 1, where Brutus's instinct to overrule Cassius on tactics decides the war.

10. Individual vs State

Definition: This theme concerns the claims a state can make on a person and the claims a person can make against it: when should a citizen put Rome before his own peace, his friendships and his life — and when does a man's refusal to bow become not selfishness but a public duty? In Rome the conflict had a special shape, because the Republic's whole identity was the refusal to let one individual stand above the community. Act 1 therefore contains two versions of the theme at once: Caesar as the individual who has outgrown the state, and Brutus as the individual the state is about to consume.

Act 1 evidence: Brutus states the theme in a single sentence of self-sacrifice: "If it be aught toward the general good, / Set honour in one eye and death i' th' other / And I will look on both indifferently" (aught means anything; indifferently means impartially). His parting shot to Cassius chooses Rome over comfort: "Brutus had rather be a villager / Than to repute himself a son of Rome / Under these hard conditions as this time / Is like to lay upon us." Cassius's attack on Caesar is framed entirely as individual against community: "Now is it Rome indeed, and room enough / When there is in it but one only man" — the pun on Rome and room says that one man has taken all the space. His appeal to ancestry — "There was a Brutus once that would have brooked / Th' eternal devil to keep his state in Rome / As easily as a king" (brooked means tolerated) — turns Brutus's family into a public obligation. And his contempt for the present — "Our yoke and sufferance show us womanish" (sufferance means patient endurance) — says that individuals who submit have ceased to be Romans. Casca's pledge in the storm is the theme in action: "Be factious for redress of all these griefs, / And I will set this foot of mine as far / As who goes farthest" (factious means ready to form a faction).

Important scenes: Brutus's honour declaration and the villager speech in Act 1 Scene 2; Cassius's Rome-and-room and ancestral-Brutus passages; the dagger speech and Casca's pledge in Act 1 Scene 3.

Characters: Brutus is the individual who will subordinate himself to the state — and who has not yet seen that the state, as Cassius presents it, is an abstraction that will demand his friend. Caesar is the individual the state can no longer contain. Cassius argues for the community while serving a private wound. The Cobbler and his friends are individuals for whom the state is simply a holiday.

Quotations: - "If it be aught toward the general good, / Set honour in one eye and death i' th' other" — Brutus, Act 1 Scene 2. - "Brutus had rather be a villager / Than to repute himself a son of Rome / Under these hard conditions" — Brutus, Act 1 Scene 2. - "Now is it Rome indeed, and room enough / When there is in it but one only man." — Cassius, Act 1 Scene 2. - "That part of tyranny that I do bear / I can shake off at pleasure." — Cassius, Act 1 Scene 3.

Hidden significance: The two words Brutus uses — "the general good" — are an abstraction, and the Act gives him no concrete content for it; he never says what Caesar has actually done to Rome. **LITERARY INTERPRETATION:** Brutus's commitment to the state is sincere and empty at the same time, and Cassius's genius is to pour his own material into it. The second point concerns Cassius's "I can shake off at pleasure": the individual's ultimate weapon against the state, in his account, is his own death — which means that the republican resistance Act 1 describes is, at its root, a willingness to die rather than a plan to govern. Nobody in Act 1 says a word about what Rome will be after Caesar.

Historical context: **HISTORICAL RECORD:** the Republic was founded, by tradition, in 509 BC when Lucius Junius Brutus drove out the last king, and Marcus Brutus claimed descent from him; the Roman hatred of the title *rex* was a cultural fact, not a slogan. Caesar's perpetual dictatorship had broken the one rule that kept

individuals subordinate to the state — the time limit on power. Cato the Younger's suicide in 46 BC, which Brutus's family circle revered, had made death-rather-than-submission a living republican example. The 1599 audience, by contrast, lived under a doctrine that placed the monarch above individual judgement; the play's sympathy for republican individuals may have been felt as daring. Say 'may have'.

Literary significance: The theme is written in antithesis and in puns: Rome/room, honour/death, villager/son of Rome. Cassius's "yoke" is the Act's image of the state as something an individual wears — an ox's harness — and his "bondage" and "bondman" extend it. Brutus's "villager" is a small, concrete word placed against the grand abstraction "son of Rome", and the modesty of it is the point. Structurally, Shakespeare gives the two most selfless-sounding speeches in the Act — Brutus's honour declaration and Cassius's dagger speech — to the two men whose private motives are most different, so that the audience learns to hear the same public language in two keys.

ICSE keywords: individual, state, citizenship, public duty, private conscience, republicanism, tyranny, self-sacrifice, abstraction, pun, antithesis, tyrannicide.

Connection to later Acts: Glance ahead to Act 2 Scene 1, where Brutus resolves the theme in favour of the state in his orchard — and where Portia, kneeling, insists that his private self has claims too. Glance ahead to Act 3 Scene 2, where Brutus tells the crowd he loved Rome more than Caesar, which is this Act's honour speech turned into a public defence. Glance ahead to Act 5 Scene 5, where the individual pays the state's bill in full.

11. Mob Psychology

Definition: Mob psychology is the study of how people in a crowd think and feel differently from the way they do alone — more emotionally, more suggestibly, more quickly, and with a loss of individual judgement. Shakespeare had no such term; what he had was a set of Elizabethan words — "rabblement", "the vulgar", "tag-rag people", "the common herd" — and an extraordinary ear for how a crowd sounds. The Act's crowd is heard far more than it is seen: in Scene 1 it stands before us as two tradesmen and their friends; after that it is a noise offstage and a report.

Act 1 evidence: The commoners in Scene 1 have come to cheer Caesar; Marullus reminds them that they once sat all day on walls and chimney-tops to cheer Pompey, making "an universal shout, / That Tiber trembled underneath her banks / To hear the replication of your sounds" (replication means echo). His insult — "You blocks, you stones, you worse than senseless things!" — is a theory of the mob: it is matter without mind. And it works: the crowd that arrived laughing leaves in silence, "tongue-tied in their guiltiness". In Scene 2 the crowd is three shouts offstage, and then Casca's report, which is the Act's most savage description of a crowd: "the rabblement hooted and clapped their chopped hands and threw up their sweaty nightcaps" and produced such "stinking breath" that Caesar swooned. They cheer Caesar for refusing a crown, forgive him for fainting, and would, Casca says, have done the same "if Caesar had stabbed their mothers". His comparison is theatrical: they clap and hiss "as they use to do the players in the theatre". Cassius's version is animal: Caesar would not be a wolf "But that he sees the Romans are but sheep; / He were no lion, were not Romans hinds" (hinds means female deer — and, punningly, servants). Rome is "trash", "rubbish", "offal" — kindling for one man's fire.

Important scenes: The whole of Act 1 Scene 1; the shouts and Casca's report in Act 1 Scene 2; Cassius's sheep-and-lion speech in Act 1 Scene 3.

Characters: The Carpenter and the Cobbler are the mob with faces — witty, cheerful, immovable in their wish for a holiday. The tribunes are the crowd's would-be masters. Casca is its contemptuous observer, and his disgust is physical. Cassius is its theorist, and his theory conveniently excuses the people he intends to lead.

Quotations: - "You blocks, you stones, you worse than senseless things!" — Marullus, Act 1 Scene 1. - "They vanish tongue-tied in their guiltiness." — Flavius, Act 1 Scene 1. - "If the tag-rag people did not clap him and hiss him, according as he pleased and displeased them, as they use to do the players in the theatre, I am no true man." — Casca, Act 1 Scene 2. - "he sees the Romans are but sheep; / He were no lion, were not Romans hinds." — Cassius, Act 1 Scene 3.

Hidden significance: Every description of the crowd in Act 1 comes from someone who despises it — tribunes, Casca, Cassius — and every one of those men wants to use it. The only crowd members who speak for themselves, in Scene 1, are not senseless at all; the Cobbler out-talks two magistrates. **LITERARY INTERPRETATION:** Shakespeare lets the elite describe the mob as stupid while showing us a mob that is quick, humorous and perfectly aware of what it wants. The gap between the crowd's reputation and its reality is itself a piece of appearance versus reality. A second point: the crowd's fickleness is demonstrated twice before it is ever named — shamed out of its holiday by Marullus, then cheering and forgiving Caesar an hour later. The Act establishes that the Roman crowd can be *turned*, and turned fast, by whoever speaks to it last. That is not a detail; it is the mechanism of the whole play.

Historical context: **HISTORICAL RECORD:** Plutarch's account of the Lupercalia says the crowd applauded feebly when the diadem was offered and loudly when Caesar refused it — the historical crowd, in other words, was republican in sentiment, and Shakespeare's Casca sneers at exactly the behaviour Plutarch records as sound. The urban plebs of the late Republic were a political force courted with grain, games and triumphs, and Caesar's popularity with them was real. London's own apprentices and playgoers in 1599 were a crowd Shakespeare knew from the inside of the theatre, which may be why Casca's comparison is to "players".

Literary significance: The crowd is created by sound effects — the offstage flourishes and shouts — and by a lexicon of contempt: "rabblement", "vulgar", "tag-rag", "herd", "rout". Marullus's rhetorical questions and tricolon of "And do you now..." show how a skilled speaker moves a crowd by shame; Casca's prose shows how a cynic turns the same crowd into comedy; Cassius's animal imagery shows how a conspirator turns it into an excuse. Three registers, one crowd. The prose/verse division in Scene 1 — commoners in prose, tribunes in verse — is the class structure of Rome made audible.

ICSE keywords: mob, fickleness, crowd psychology, manipulation, demagogue, rhetorical question, tricolon, contempt, animal imagery, prose and verse, public opinion, volatility.

Connection to later Acts: Glance ahead to Act 3 Scene 2, the scene the whole of this theme exists to prepare: the crowd that is turned by Brutus and then turned back by Antony inside a quarter of an hour. Glance ahead to Act 3 Scene 3, where the mob tears Cinna the poet apart for his name — the "blocks" and "stones" of Scene 1 become killers. Glance ahead to Act 4 Scene 1, where the men who used the crowd divide the world among themselves without consulting it.

PROFESSOR'S INSIGHT **The crowd as a mirror of the leaders' anxieties**

Watch what each leader sees when he looks at the crowd, and you will learn more about the leader than about the crowd. Marullus sees ingratitude, because he is a tribune whose office exists to speak for a people that has stopped listening to him. Casca sees a theatre audience, because he is a man who performs — his bluntness is "tardy form", a costume — and he suspects everyone else of acting too. Cassius sees sheep and kindling, because he needs the people to be passive in order to believe that one strong will can change Rome, and he needs them to be base so that his contempt for Caesar's popularity has somewhere to go. Caesar, in Casca's report, sees a crowd whose forgiveness he can win by offering his throat, because he is a man who has learned to turn weakness into theatre. Not one of them sees the Cobbler: a tradesman with a safe conscience and a day off, who wants to see a triumph and then go home. LITERARY INTERPRETATION: Shakespeare gives the crowd no interior of its own in Act 1 precisely so that it can function as a glass in which the ruling class looks at its own fears — fear of being forgotten, of being fooled, of being outnumbered, of being seen to fall. In Act 3 the glass will show them something they did not expect.

ICSE EXAM BOX WRITING A THEME PARAGRAPH

EXAM-ORIENTED ADVICE. First, the honesty. Act 1 belongs to Class IX, and a Class X board question will not ask for 'superstition and omens in Act 1' as such. But a question on Calpurnia's dream, on Caesar's rejection of the augurers, on Cassius's eagles and ravens, or on the ghost will expect you to show where the play's omens began, and a good paragraph about Act 1 is the model for the paragraph you will write about Act 2, Act 4 or Act 5. The recipe is the same at every level: a *claim* about what the play does with the theme; *evidence*, meaning a short quotation with speaker and scene; *analysis* of how the words work and what they reveal; a *link* back to the claim or forward to the play. Avoid two habits that lose marks: retelling the storm as if it were a story, and ending with a moral ('this shows that superstition is bad'). Here is a worked paragraph.

'Shakespeare uses superstition and omens in Act 1 not to show whether the gods speak but to show how men choose what to hear. Caesar is the first example: he insists that Antony touch Calpurnia during the Lupercal race so that she may "Shake off their sterile curse", yet within a few lines dismisses the Soothsayer's "Beware the ides of March" with the single word "Pass". The juxtaposition reveals a selective believer — he accepts the ritual that promises an heir and rejects the warning that threatens his life. The storm of Act 1 Scene 3 widens this into a debate. Casca reads the burning hand and the lion as proof that men should "fear and tremble" before the gods' "tokens"; Cicero replies that "men may construe things after their fashion", warning that every reading of the sky is made by a man with a motive; and Cassius proves Cicero right by declaring the prodigies "instruments of fear and warning" aimed at Caesar, so that an omen becomes a recruiting speech. The fire imagery running through the scene — torches, men "all in fire", a tempest "dropping fire" — creates an atmosphere of a world turned against its nature, which mirrors a Rome where fathers' minds are dead. By the end of the Act, therefore, the omens have told the audience less about the future than about the readers: Caesar's pride, Casca's fear and Cassius's design. This is the pattern the play will repeat when Caesar overrules Calpurnia's dream and when Cassius, who mocked Casca, comes to credit the ravens over his own army.'

Notice what that paragraph does. It opens with an argument, not a topic. Every quotation is short, attributed by implication to a speaker and a scene, and followed by a comment on the words themselves — "selective", "recruiting speech". It names one device — juxtaposition, imagery — and says what it achieves. It connects the theme to character, because the examiner's descriptors reward analysis of theme *through* character. It looks forward to later Acts without quoting them, which is exactly the kind of connection a Class X answer needs when it reaches back to Act 1. And it never claims to know what Shakespeare 'believed' about fate. Reproduce the shape, not the sentences.

CHAPTER 13

The Act 1 Literary-Device Bank

This chapter is a working reference, not a list to memorise. For every literary device that genuinely appears in Act 1 of Julius Caesar it gives you the same seven things in the same order: the term, a plain definition, one verified Act 1 example with speaker and scene, what the words mean, what effect they create, why Shakespeare needed the device at that exact moment, and a model sentence showing how to name and analyse it in an ICSE answer. A finder table of about twenty-five quotations follows, then a worked lesson on writing about Cassius's Colossus image. Use the bank alongside the scene chapters: the device is only ever a tool for explaining what the play is doing.

How to use this bank

Students who have struggled with Shakespeare usually make one of two mistakes with devices. The first is to treat the name of a device as the answer: they write 'This is a metaphor' and stop, as though the label were the insight. The second is the opposite: they describe an effect vividly but never name the technique, so the examiner cannot tell whether the student actually knows what Shakespeare did. This chapter trains you to do both at once, and to do them in the right order.

Every entry below follows the same ladder, and the ladder is the Level 1 to Level 5 method used throughout this book. **Meaning** is Levels 1 and 2 (what the words say and what they mean). **Effect** and **Dramatic purpose** are Levels 3 and 4 (why Shakespeare wrote it this way, and how it connects to the whole play). **ICSE application** is Level 5. Never write a Level 5 sentence about a device until you can honestly do Levels 1 to 4 in your head, because an examiner can tell within one sentence whether the device name is attached to understanding or floating free.

Three rules of accuracy govern this chapter. First, every quotation is drawn from the verified text of Act 1 and is given with speaker and scene; you may trust the wording. Second, when an entry says what a device *means*, that is a reading of Shakespeare's text; when it says what the device *does*, that is **literary interpretation**, and where critics genuinely disagree the entry says so. Third, wherever the chapter talks about examinations, remember the honest position: Act 1 is the Class IX portion of the ICSE syllabus; the Class X board paper examines Acts III to V, but it constantly assumes you know Act 1, and the devices you learn here are the very ones Antony, Brutus and Cassius use again in the later acts.

CROSS-REFERENCE Where the devices are taught in context

This chapter isolates devices so you can recognise them anywhere. For how they work inside a living scene, read 'Act 1 Scene 1 — The Street' (the Cobbler's puns and Marullus's rhetoric), 'Act 1 Scene 2 (Part One)' (the mirror conceit and the Tiber story), 'Act 1 Scene 2 (Part Two)' (Casca's prose report and Cassius's soliloquy) and 'Act 1 Scene 3 — The Storm' (storm, fire and animal imagery). For the vocabulary of difficult words, see 'Difficult Shakespearean English: The Act 1 Vocabulary System'. For how device analysis earns marks in extract questions, see 'ICSE Examiner Mode: How Marks Are Earned'.

Part One: The Three Ironies

Irony is the most important device in Act 1 and the most often misused. In every kind of irony there is a gap between two things: between what is said and what is meant, between what is expected and what happens, or between what a character knows and what the audience knows. Name the gap and you have understood the irony. Fail to name it and you have only used a word.

Dramatic irony

Term: Dramatic irony.

Definition: A situation in which the audience knows something that a character on stage does not, so that the character's words or actions carry a meaning the character cannot see.

Act 1 example: Caesar, Act 1 Scene 2, dismissing the Soothsayer after hearing the warning "Beware the ides of March" twice: "He is a dreamer. Let us leave him. Pass."

Meaning: Caesar hears a stranger in the crowd warn him about a specific date. He has the man brought before him, hears the warning repeated, and then dismisses him as a fantasist (a 'dreamer', someone whose head is full of visions) and orders the procession to move on.

Effect: Shakespeare's first audience knew, as every audience since has known, that Caesar was murdered on the Ides of March. The line therefore does two things at once: on stage it shows a confident ruler brushing aside superstition; in the auditorium it produces a chill, because we are watching a man walk past the one piece of information that could save him. The word "Pass" is particularly sharp: Caesar is commanding the crowd to move on, but the audience hears him moving on from his own survival.

Dramatic purpose: Dramatic irony is how Shakespeare makes a play about a famous death suspenseful when everyone already knows the ending. Instead of asking 'Will Caesar die?' the play asks 'How will he fail to see it coming?' Every confident statement Caesar makes in Act 1 is shadowed by this irony, most of all "for always I am Caesar" in the same scene, spoken in the same breath as the admission "this ear is deaf". It also shapes how we hear Brutus: when he tells Cassius "I would not, Cassius, yet I love him well", we know, as Brutus does not, that the man beside him is already planning to forge letters in his name.

ICSE application: 'Caesar's dismissal of the Soothsayer as "a dreamer" is dramatic irony: the audience knows that the Ides of March will be the day of his death, so his confident command "Pass" exposes the gap between his self-image as a man who cannot be touched by fear and the vulnerability the play has already made visible to us.'

TEXT NOTE Common misidentification — dramatic irony versus foreshadowing

Students often write 'dramatic irony' for any line that hints at the future. The two overlap but are not the same. **Foreshadowing** is a hint planted by the playwright that something will happen; it works whether or not anyone on stage understands it. **Dramatic irony** requires a character to be *ignorant* of something the audience *knows*. "Beware the ides of March" is foreshadowing when the Soothsayer says it; it becomes dramatic irony when Caesar responds "He is a dreamer." The irony lives in the response, not in the warning. If you want full credit, point to the character's blindness, not merely to the hint.

Verbal irony

Term: Verbal irony.

Definition: Saying one thing while meaning another, usually the opposite, so that the listener (or the audience) is expected to hear the real meaning underneath the surface words. Sarcasm is its bitter, mocking form.

Act 1 example: Cassius, Act 1 Scene 3, as Casca marvels at the terrifying storm: "A very pleasing night to honest men."

Meaning: The sky is dropping fire, a lion has walked past the Capitol and a slave's hand has burned without being hurt. Cassius calls this a pleasant evening. He does not mean it is pleasant in the ordinary sense; he means that for a man planning what he is planning, a night of omens is exactly the right weather, and that an 'honest' man, by which he means a true Roman republican, should welcome it.

Effect: The irony reveals character faster than any direct statement could. Casca is frightened; Cassius is exhilarated. By inverting the obvious meaning of the night, Cassius signals that he reads the omens not as warnings but as encouragement, and the word "honest" quietly redefines honesty as willingness to act against Caesar. The audience also hears an irony Cassius does not intend: the man who calls himself honest will, within a few hours, have forged letters delivered to Brutus.

Dramatic purpose: Verbal irony is Cassius's natural idiom throughout Act 1, and Shakespeare uses it to mark him as the play's great manipulator of language. Earlier in Act 1 Scene 2 he refers to "immortal Caesar" while cataloguing Caesar's fever and near-drowning, and calls the stricken Caesar "this god" in the very line that says "this god did shake". Each time, the surface praise carries a hidden sneer. The device trains the audience to listen for double meanings, which is exactly the skill Brutus lacks.

ICSE application: 'Cassius's description of the storm as "A very pleasing night to honest men" is verbal irony: he welcomes what terrifies Casca, and by calling conspirators "honest men" he redefines the word to suit his purpose, revealing both his fearlessness and his habit of bending language to manipulate.'

Situational irony

Term: Situational irony.

Definition: A contradiction between what is expected to happen (or what would be fitting) and what actually happens, built into the situation itself rather than into anyone's words.

Act 1 example: Caesar, Act 1 Scene 2, having just given the most accurate character sketch in the play: "I rather tell thee what is to be feared / Than what I fear; for always I am Caesar. / Come on my right hand, for this ear is deaf."

Meaning: Caesar has identified Cassius as a man who "thinks too much", who "looks / Quite through the deeds of men" and who is "never at heart's ease / Whiles they behold a greater than themselves". Having diagnosed the danger perfectly, he refuses to act on it, because fear is not something Caesar admits to; then he

asks Antony to speak into his good ear because the other one is deaf.

Effect: The situation itself is ironic in two ways. The man who sees through everyone cannot hear properly. The man who correctly names his future killer dismisses the knowledge in the same breath. Shakespeare places the deaf ear immediately after "for always I am Caesar" so that the public image and the private body collide within three lines. (**Historical record:** the deafness has no basis in the ancient sources; it appears to be Shakespeare's invention, which makes the irony deliberate.)

Dramatic purpose: Act 1 is full of situations that turn against expectation. The tribunes who strip Caesar's decorations are themselves "put to silence". Brutus's honour, which ought to protect him from conspiracy, is precisely the lever Cassius uses: "honour is the subject of my story." Casca reports that the crowd cheered Caesar for refusing the crown, so that the ruler who wanted power was applauded for appearing not to want it.

Literary interpretation: one strong reading is that these reversals prepare the audience for the play's largest situational irony, that killing Caesar to save the Republic destroys the Republic.

ICSE application: 'There is situational irony in Caesar's "Come on my right hand, for this ear is deaf", spoken moments after he claims "always I am Caesar": the ruler who boasts of seeing through men and of being beyond fear is revealed as physically impaired and unwilling to act on his own accurate judgement.'

TEXT NOTE Common misidentification — irony versus coincidence or mere contrast

Not every unexpected event is situational irony, and not every opposition is irony at all. Situational irony needs a *reversal of expectation that comments on the situation*. Caesar being deaf is not ironic in itself; it becomes ironic because he has just presented himself as all-seeing. If you cannot say what expectation is reversed, call it 'contrast' instead (see the entry on contrast below), which is a legitimate and separately creditable device.

Part Two: Figurative Language

Metaphor

Term: Metaphor.

Definition: A direct comparison that describes one thing as if it *were* another, without using 'like' or 'as'. The reader is asked to transfer the qualities of the second thing on to the first.

Act 1 example: Flavius, Act 1 Scene 1, closing the scene: "These growing feathers plucked from Caesar's wing / Will make him fly an ordinary pitch, / Who else would soar above the view of men / And keep us all in servile fearfulness."

Meaning: Caesar is a bird of prey, a falcon or hawk, whose 'feathers' are the decorations and popular support that let him rise. If the tribunes pluck them (by pulling the scarves off his statues and dispersing the crowd), he will fly only at an ordinary height ("pitch" is the falconry term for the height a hawk reaches) instead of soaring out of sight and holding everyone below in frightened slavery ("servile fearfulness").

Effect: The metaphor turns a small act of civic vandalism into a political theory. Caesar's greatness is not innate but assembled from borrowed plumage; take away the people's adulation and he is a man of ordinary size. The hunting-bird image also carries menace: a hawk high above "the view of men" is a predator, and the fear it produces is the fear of prey.

Dramatic purpose: This is the first sustained metaphor in the play and it establishes the method the conspirators will follow: cut Caesar down to size. Cassius's Colossus simile and his question "Upon what meat doth this our Caesar feed / That he is grown so great?" are the same idea in different images. The metaphor also quietly tells the audience that the tribunes' plan will fail: feathers grow back, and Casca's report in the next scene shows the people cheering Caesar anyway.

ICSE application: 'Flavius's metaphor of "growing feathers plucked from Caesar's wing" presents Caesar as a hawk whose height depends on the plumage of popular support; the image argues that his power is removable, which establishes the political logic the conspirators will follow, while "servile fearfulness" reveals the tribunes' genuine republican dread.'

Other metaphors you should be able to recognise in Act 1 include Cassius's "I, your glass" (he is a mirror that will show Brutus his hidden worth), "this age's yoke" (Rome is an ox harnessed to Caesar), "Thy honourable mettle may be wrought / From that it is disposed" (Brutus's character is metal that can be reshaped by a smith) and Brutus's own "This rudeness is a sauce to his good wit" (Casca's bluntness is seasoning that makes his intelligence easier to digest).

TEXT NOTE

Common misidentification — metaphor versus simile

The commonest error in the whole of Act 1 is to call Cassius's Colossus image a metaphor. It is not: "he doth bestride the narrow world / Like a Colossus" uses "Like", so it is a simile. Students make the error because the image is so vivid that it *feels* like a metaphor. The test is mechanical: look for 'like' or 'as'. If present, simile; if absent, metaphor. "I, your glass" has neither word, so it is a metaphor. Examiners notice the distinction.

Simile

Term: Simile.

Definition: An explicit comparison between two different things using 'like' or 'as' (or 'than'), so that the reader is told to see a resemblance while remaining aware that the two things are separate.

Act 1 example: Cassius, Act 1 Scene 2, after the second shout from the games: "Why, man, he doth bestride the narrow world / Like a Colossus, and we petty men / Walk under his huge legs and peep about / To find ourselves dishonourable graves."

Meaning: Caesar stands with his legs apart ("bestride") across the whole world, which has become "narrow" because he fills it, like the giant statue of Rhodes. Everyone else is tiny, walking between his legs and peering around for nothing better than a disgraceful burial place.

Effect: The simile makes size into a moral argument. Caesar's greatness is not admirable but monstrous and unnatural; the Romans' smallness is not natural but shameful ("petty", "dishonourable"). The word "peep" is deliberately undignified: grown senators reduced to children peering about. Because the image is so vivid and physical, it bypasses argument; Brutus is made to *see* his own humiliation rather than reason about it.

Dramatic purpose: The Colossus is the hinge of the whole temptation. Immediately afterwards Cassius turns from image to doctrine, "The fault, dear Brutus, is not in our stars, / But in ourselves, that we are underlings", so the simile does the emotional work that lets the abstract claim land. **Literary interpretation:** many critics note that the image is also self-revealing: it is Cassius, not Brutus, who feels dwarfed, and the envy that drives the conspiracy is nowhere clearer than in "we petty men".

ICSE application: 'In the simile "he doth bestride the narrow world / Like a Colossus", Cassius makes Caesar's power grotesque by comparing him to the giant statue of Rhodes, while the diminutive "petty men" who "peep about" for "dishonourable graves" shames Brutus into feeling his own smallness, which is precisely the feeling Cassius needs him to have.'

Further similes worth knowing: Cassius's sneer that the feverish Caesar cried out "As a sick girl"; Casca's slave whose hand burned "Like twenty torches joined"; Casca's earth that "Shakes like a thing unfirm"; Brutus's observation that Caesar's followers "look like a chidden train" (a scolded group of attendants); and Casca's closing image that Brutus's reputation, "like richest alchemy", will turn the conspirators' crime into "virtue". Notice how often the similes in Act 1 belong to Cassius and Casca, the two men most committed to making others see Caesar differently.

Imagery

Term: Imagery.

Definition: Language that appeals to the senses or builds a picture in the mind, usually through a cluster of related metaphors and similes. A play's imagery is best studied in *families*: when the same kind of picture keeps returning, it is carrying meaning.

Act 1 example: Cassius, Act 1 Scene 3, describing the storm as a portrait of Caesar: "a man / Most like this dreadful night, / That thunders, lightens, opens graves, and roars / As doth the lion in the Capitol".

Meaning: Cassius says he could name a man who is exactly like this terrifying night: a man who thunders and flashes, who splits open graves and who roars like the lion Casca has just reported seeing near the Capitol. He means Caesar, and Casca immediately says so.

Effect: Storm, fire and animal imagery fuse into one picture, so that the whole disordered sky becomes a description of a single human being. The effect is to make Caesar seem not merely powerful but unnatural, a disturbance in the order of things, which is exactly how Cassius wants Casca to feel about him.

Dramatic purpose: Act 1 has six image families, and you should be able to name all of them with an example:

Family	Verified Act 1 example	Speaker and scene	What the family carries
Bodily	"that same eye whose bend doth awe the world / Did lose his lustre"; "Yond Cassius has a lean and hungry look"	Cassius, 1.2; Caesar, 1.2	Politics is read off the body: eyes, lips, tongue, hands, legs, throat. Caesar's body is weak; Cassius's is lean; Brutus's face is a mirror.
Animal	"he would not be a wolf / But that he sees the Romans are but sheep; / He were no lion, were not Romans hinds"	Cassius, 1.3	Predator and prey: Caesar's power exists only because the Romans consent to be herd animals. Also "ferret", "the bird of night", "Caesar's wing", "the common herd".
Fire	"Those that with haste will make a mighty fire / Begin it with weak straws"; "my weak words / Have struck but thus much show of fire from Brutus"	Cassius, 1.3 and 1.2	Rebellion as kindling; sparks of Roman spirit; the burning hand and the "tempest dropping fire". Fire is energy that can purify or destroy.
Storm	"the cross blue lightning seemed to open / The breast of heaven"	Cassius, 1.3	The heavens as a body torn open; disorder in nature mirroring disorder in the state.
Disease	"Pray to the gods to intermit the plague / That needs must light on this ingratitude"; "we have the falling sickness"	Marullus, 1.1; Cassius, 1.2	Rome is sick: ingratitude is a plague, Caesar's epilepsy becomes everyone's political paralysis, the Cobbler is "a surgeon to old shoes".

Family	Verified Act 1 example	Speaker and scene	What the family carries
Theatre	"as they use to do the players in the theatre"	Casca, 1.2	Public life as performance: Caesar performs refusal, the crowd behaves like an audience, Brutus forgets "the shows of love", Casca "puts on this tardy form".

Literary interpretation: these families converge in Act 3. The bodily imagery becomes Caesar's actual wounds; the disease imagery becomes Brutus's claim to be a healer; the theatre imagery becomes the funeral orations played to a fickle crowd; the fire imagery becomes the mob burning the conspirators' houses. A student who can trace one family from Act 1 into Act 3 is doing exactly what the Class X paper rewards.

ICSE application: 'Shakespeare's animal imagery in Act 1 Scene 3, where Caesar "would not be a wolf / But that he sees the Romans are but sheep", shifts blame from the tyrant to the citizens: the predator exists only because the prey consents, so the imagery turns Cassius's hatred of Caesar into an accusation against Roman passivity.'

PROFESSOR'S INSIGHT

Why Shakespeare gives the finest imagery to the least honest speaker

Count the memorable images of Act 1 and most belong to Cassius: the mirror, Aeneas carrying Anchises, the Colossus, the fault in our stars, the wolf and the sheep, the fire and the straws, the stony tower and the walls of beaten brass. Brutus, the man of honour, speaks plainly; Caesar speaks in short, sculpted maxims; the poetry goes to the manipulator. Shakespeare does this deliberately, and the soliloquy at the end of Act 1 Scene 2 tells us why. The moment Brutus leaves, Cassius drops every image and speaks in flat, practical verse: "I will this night / In several hands in at his windows throw ... Writings". The imagery, we realise, was equipment. Caesar's own analysis confirms the pattern: Cassius "loves no plays" and "hears no music", yet he is the most theatrical and musical speaker in the act. **Literary interpretation:** the play is teaching its audience to distrust beauty of language, a lesson it repeats on a larger scale in Act 3 when Antony's imagery moves the crowd to burn and kill. For the ICSE student the practical point is this: when you identify a brilliant image in Act 1, always ask who is speaking and what they want from the listener. Imagery in this play is almost never decoration; it is persuasion, and the finest examples are the most suspicious.

Symbolism

Term: Symbolism.

Definition: The use of a concrete object, action or event to stand for an abstract idea beyond itself. Unlike a metaphor, a symbol is usually a *thing in the story*, not a comparison in a sentence.

Act 1 example: Casca, Act 1 Scene 2, on what Antony offered Caesar: "yet 'twas not a crown neither; 'twas one of these coronets".

Meaning: Antony held out a crown, or, Casca corrects himself, not a full crown but a small coronet (a lesser circlet). Caesar pushed it away three times, each time more reluctantly in Casca's view.

Effect: The crown is the single most charged object in the Roman world: it stands for the kingship the Republic was founded by abolishing. Casca's correction, "one of these coronets", matters because it suggests a test, a smaller version offered to see how the people react. The object carries the whole political question of the play: does Caesar want to be king?

Dramatic purpose: Shakespeare keeps the crown offstage and lets Casca describe it, so that the symbol reaches us already interpreted by a cynic; the audience never sees Caesar's face as he refuses. Other Act 1 symbols include the "scarves" and "trophies" on Caesar's statues (public adulation made visible, and removable), the storm (**literary interpretation:** read by Casca as divine anger, by Cassius as a portrait of Caesar, by Cicero as nothing certain, so the storm symbolises the problem of interpretation itself) and Cassius's dagger, "I know where I will wear this dagger then", which stands for the Roman freedom to die rather than submit.

ICSE application: 'The crown that Casca describes is the central symbol of Act 1: Caesar's thrice-repeated refusal, each time "gentler than other", turns an object into a question about his ambition, and the fact that we see it only through Casca's cynical report means the audience inherits his suspicion.'

Personification

Term: Personification.

Definition: Giving human qualities, feelings or actions to something non-human: an object, an animal, a place, a force of nature or an abstract idea.

Act 1 example: Marullus, Act 1 Scene 1, recalling the crowds that once cheered Pompey: "That Tiber trembled underneath her banks / To hear the replication of your sounds / Made in her concave shores?"

Meaning: The people's shout was so loud that the river Tiber shook beneath its banks, hearing its own echo ("replication") thrown back from the curved ("concave") shores.

Effect: The river becomes a frightened woman trembling at the noise. This does two things: it magnifies the crowd's former devotion to Pompey into something that moved nature itself, and it gives Rome's river a feminine, almost maternal presence that the people are now betraying. The personification is also hyperbole (see below), and the two devices work together.

Dramatic purpose: Personified nature runs through the act. Cassius describes "The troubled Tiber chafing with her shores" (the river fretting angrily against its banks) just before telling how he saved Caesar from it; Casca speaks of "the scolding winds" and "Th' ambitious ocean"; Cassius calls the storm "the strange impatience of the heavens". **Literary interpretation:** when rivers, winds and skies have tempers, the natural world seems to be a participant in Roman politics, which prepares the audience to take the omens of Act 1 Scene 3 and Act 2 seriously even while Cicero reminds us that men "construe things after their fashion".

ICSE application: 'Marullus personifies the river in "Tiber trembled underneath her banks", so that the crowd's former love for Pompey seems to have shaken nature itself; the image shames the commoners by measuring their present fickleness against a devotion the whole city once felt.'

TEXT NOTE Common misidentification — personification versus apostrophe

Students confuse these because both involve treating non-human things as people. The test is *direction of address*. **Personification** describes something non-human as if it had human qualities ("Tiber trembled").

Apostrophe speaks *to* something absent or non-human as if it could hear ("Rome, thou hast lost the breed of noble bloods!"). An apostrophe usually involves personification, but personification is not apostrophe unless the speaker is addressing the thing directly. Look for 'thou', 'you' or 'O'.

Apostrophe

Term: Apostrophe.

Definition: A figure in which the speaker turns away from the people present to address directly someone absent, something non-human or an abstract idea, as if it could hear.

Act 1 example: Cassius, Act 1 Scene 2, at the climax of his tirade: "Age, thou art shamed! / Rome, thou hast lost the breed of noble bloods!"

Meaning: Cassius stops speaking to Brutus and addresses the present age and the city of Rome itself, accusing the age of disgrace and the city of having run out of the noble families ("breed of noble bloods") that once produced men who would never tolerate a king.

Effect: The sudden turn from a private conversation to a public, almost ceremonial address raises the emotional temperature. It also flatters Brutus indirectly: if Rome has 'lost' its noble blood, Brutus, descendant of the Brutus who expelled the kings, is being invited to prove the age wrong. The exclamation marks and the pronoun "thou" make the lines sound like a lament spoken over a grave.

Dramatic purpose: Cassius uses apostrophe at the moments when argument gives way to passion, real or performed. In Act 1 Scene 3 he cries "But, O grief, / Where hast thou led me?" immediately after calling Rome "trash" and "offal", pretending that his own sorrow has carried him into dangerous speech. **Literary interpretation:** this second apostrophe is almost certainly calculated, a way of testing whether Casca will betray him, and it shows how a device that normally signals overwhelming feeling can be used as a tactic. He also addresses the gods, "Therein, you gods, you make the weak most strong", turning a political vow into something like a prayer.

ICSE application: 'Cassius's apostrophe "Rome, thou hast lost the breed of noble bloods!" turns a private persuasion into a public lament, and by mourning the loss of noble Romans in front of a descendant of the Brutus who expelled the Tarquins, he challenges Brutus to prove the accusation false.'

Part Three: Structural and Rhetorical Devices

Antithesis

Term: Antithesis.

Definition: The placing of opposite or strongly contrasting ideas side by side in a balanced grammatical structure, so that each half sharpens the other.

Act 1 example: Brutus, Act 1 Scene 2, stating his principle before Cassius has even made his case: "Set honour in one eye and death i' th' other / And I will look on both indifferently".

Meaning: Put honour on one side and death on the other, and Brutus will regard both equally ("indifferently" here means without preferring one), because, as he goes on, he loves "The name of honour more than I fear death".

Effect: The balance of the line enacts the balance of Brutus's mind: two eyes, two values, perfectly weighed. The antithesis makes him sound like a Roman statue, calm and symmetrical, and it tells Cassius everything he needs to know. Honour, not freedom or envy, is the word that will move this man.

Dramatic purpose: Antithesis is the grammar of a divided Rome. Cassius structures his whole appeal on oppositions: "I was born free as Caesar" against "A wretched creature"; the gods who "make the weak most strong"; "our fathers' minds are dead, / And we are governed with our mothers' spirits". Caesar's "I rather tell thee what is to be feared / Than what I fear" balances public warning against private fear. **Literary interpretation:** Brutus's own antithesis, "I would not, Cassius, yet I love him well", is the hinge of his character: the two halves of that line are the two halves of the play's tragedy.

ICSE application: 'Brutus's antithesis "Set honour in one eye and death i' th' other" shows a mind that weighs values with perfect, almost rigid balance; the structure reveals the idealism that Cassius will exploit, since a man who prizes honour above life can be persuaded to kill in honour's name.'

TEXT NOTE Common misidentification — antithesis versus paradox versus oxymoron

These three sit close together. **Antithesis** sets opposites side by side but each remains true in its own half ("honour in one eye and death i' th' other"). **Paradox** is a statement that seems self-contradictory yet contains a truth ("Cassius from bondage will deliver Cassius"). **Oxymoron** compresses two contradictory words into one phrase: Cassius's "honourable-dangerous consequence" in Act 1 Scene 3 is the one clear oxymoron in the act, yoking a word of virtue to a word of threat. Students often write 'paradox' for all three. Ask: are the opposites balanced (antithesis), is the whole statement seemingly impossible (paradox), or are two clashing words glued together (oxymoron)?

Repetition

Term: Repetition.

Definition: The deliberate reuse of a word, phrase or structure for emphasis, rhythm or emotional pressure. Anaphora (below) is one specialised type; this entry covers repetition in general.

Act 1 example: The Soothsayer, Act 1 Scene 2, when Caesar has him brought face to face and commands him to speak again: "Beware the ides of March."

Meaning: The Soothsayer says exactly the same five words he said from the crowd. He adds nothing, explains nothing, softens nothing.

Effect: Repetition without variation gives the warning the quality of an oracle rather than an opinion. A man who repeats himself word for word under the gaze of the most powerful person in Rome is either mad or certain; Caesar chooses to believe the first. For the audience, hearing the date twice fixes it in memory and makes the title of the play's catastrophe ring like a bell.

Dramatic purpose: Shakespeare uses repetition in Act 1 to mark obsession and ritual. Casca's doubled "Why, for that too" flattens the three shouts into one bored shrug, undercutting their importance. Casca's "never till tonight, never till now" in Act 1 Scene 3 and Cassius's "Therein, you gods, you make the weak most strong; / Therein, you gods, you tyrants do defeat" build incantatory force. Cassius's repeated sounding of the names "Brutus" and "Caesar" treats the names as objects to be written, sounded and weighed. **Literary interpretation:** each repetition tells you what a speaker cannot leave alone.

ICSE application: 'The Soothsayer's unaltered repetition of "Beware the ides of March" gives the warning the fixed, impersonal authority of prophecy; by refusing to elaborate even when brought before Caesar, he makes Caesar's dismissal of him as "a dreamer" seem all the more wilfully blind.'

Anaphora

Term: Anaphora.

Definition: The repetition of the same word or phrase at the *beginning* of successive clauses, lines or sentences, building rhythm and accumulating force.

Act 1 example: Cassius, Act 1 Scene 3, on the freedom to die: "Nor stony tower, nor walls of beaten brass, / Nor airless dungeon, nor strong links of iron, / Can be retentive to the strength of spirit".

Meaning: No stone tower, no wall of hammered brass, no dungeon without air, no iron chain can hold back ("be retentive to") a determined spirit, because a life that is tired of these worldly prisons always has the power to end itself ("dismiss itself").

Effect: Each "Nor" adds another wall and another lock, so that the sentence itself becomes a prison with four barriers, and then the main verb breaks through them. The device makes Cassius's doctrine, that a Roman can always escape tyranny by suicide, feel like a triumphant demolition rather than a grim admission. **Historical record:** Cassius did in fact die by suicide after Philippi, so the anaphora foreshadows his end.

Dramatic purpose: Marullus's "And do you now put on your best attire? / And do you now cull out a holiday? / And do you now strew flowers in his way" uses anaphora to hammer the commoners with their own ingratitude; each "And do you now" is another blow. Cassius's "Why all these fires, why all these gliding ghosts, / Why birds and beasts from quality and kind" piles up prodigies until the storm seems to demand a single explanation, which he then supplies: Caesar. Anaphora in this play belongs to speakers who are trying to overwhelm a listener.

ICSE application: 'Cassius's anaphora "Nor stony tower, nor walls of beaten brass, / Nor airless dungeon, nor strong links of iron" stacks four images of imprisonment before the spirit breaks free of them all, so that the rhythm itself performs the liberation he is preaching and makes suicide sound like victory.'

TEXT NOTE Common misidentification — anaphora versus plain repetition

Anaphora is repetition *at the start of successive units*. "Therein, you gods ... Therein, you gods" is anaphora; "Beware the ides of March" said twice at different moments is repetition but not anaphora; Cassius's "Write them together ... Sound them ... Weigh them" is parallelism (repeated structure) rather than anaphora, because the opening words differ. Naming the more precise device shows the examiner you have actually looked at the lines.

Rhetorical question

Term: Rhetorical question.

Definition: A question asked for effect, to which no answer is expected because the answer is assumed to be obvious, or because the speaker intends to supply it.

Act 1 example: Marullus, Act 1 Scene 1, when the Cobbler says they have come to see Caesar's triumph: "Wherefore rejoice? What conquest brings he home? / What tributaries follow him to Rome / To grace in captive bonds his chariot wheels?"

Meaning: Why are you celebrating? What foreign land has he conquered? What conquered peoples who must pay tribute ("tributaries") are walking in chains behind his chariot? The implied answer to each is 'none', because Caesar's victory was over Pompey's sons, fellow Romans.

Effect: Three questions in a row, each more specific, back the commoners into silence. The device lets Marullus make an argument (this triumph is illegitimate) without stating it, so that the crowd seems to convict itself by having no reply. **Historical record:** a triumph for victory over Romans was indeed regarded as improper, which gives Marullus's questions real force.

Dramatic purpose: Rhetorical questions are how Act 1's persuaders control a conversation. Cassius asks Brutus "Upon what meat doth this our Caesar feed / That he is grown so great?" and asks himself "For who so firm that cannot be seduced?"; Cassius asks Casca "And why should Caesar be a tyrant, then?" and answers with the wolf and the sheep. Brutus, by contrast, asks real questions ("What means this shouting?"), which marks him as the listener rather than the manipulator.

ICSE application: 'Marullus's string of rhetorical questions, "Wherefore rejoice? What conquest brings he home?", forces the commoners to confront the fact that Caesar's triumph celebrates victory over Romans; by asking rather than asserting, he makes their silence the admission of guilt.'

Paradox

Term: Paradox.

Definition: A statement that appears self-contradictory or absurd but, on reflection, expresses a truth.

Act 1 example: Cassius, Act 1 Scene 2, correcting Brutus's remark that Caesar "hath the falling sickness": "No, Caesar hath it not; but you and I / And honest Casca, we have the falling sickness."

Meaning: Caesar has literally fainted in the market-place, so Brutus is literally right. Cassius denies it and claims that the healthy men standing around are the ones who are sick, because they have 'fallen' politically, collapsing before Caesar's power.

Effect: The paradox forces a second reading of a plain fact. Epilepsy becomes a metaphor for servility, and the man who really fell is reinterpreted as the man who stands over everyone. The move is typical of Cassius: take an event, invert it, and hand it back charged with his own meaning.

Dramatic purpose: Act 1's paradoxes cluster around freedom and bondage. "Cassius from bondage will deliver Cassius" makes one man both prisoner and liberator; "Therein, you gods, you make the weak most strong" makes weakness a source of power through the freedom to die. Cassius's "Now is it Rome indeed, and room enough / When there is in it but one only man" is a paradox built on a pun (editors note that 'Rome' was then pronounced much like 'room'), so that a city with room for only one man is both vast and suffocating.

Literary interpretation: paradox suits a play whose central act is a murder committed in the name of love and honour.

ICSE application: 'Cassius's paradox that Caesar "hath it not; but you and I / And honest Casca, we have the falling sickness" turns Caesar's literal collapse into an image of Rome's political collapse, revealing Cassius's gift for converting every fact about Caesar into an argument against him.'

Hyperbole

Term: Hyperbole.

Definition: Deliberate exaggeration, not meant to be taken literally, used for emphasis or emotional effect.

Act 1 example: Marullus, Act 1 Scene 1, remembering how the crowd waited for Pompey: "Many a time and oft / Have you climbed up to walls and battlements, / To towers and windows, yea, to chimney tops, / Your infants in your arms".

Meaning: Again and again you climbed on to walls, towers, windows and even chimneys, carrying your babies, and sat all day to watch Pompey pass.

Effect: The list climbs as the people climbed, ending at the absurd height of chimney tops, and the babies in their arms add a touch of reckless devotion. The exaggeration makes the crowd's past love for Pompey enormous so that their present love for Caesar seems a grotesque betrayal. The following lines, in which the shout makes "Tiber trembled", extend the hyperbole into personification.

Dramatic purpose: Hyperbole is the natural mode of public oratory and of fear. Casca's prodigies, a hand burning "Like twenty torches joined" and "a hundred ghastly women", may be exaggeration or honest report; Shakespeare leaves it open, and Cicero's scepticism invites us to wonder. Cassius exaggerates systematically: a

man "grown so great" that "her wide walks encompassed but one man". **Literary interpretation:** Act 1 asks the audience to notice when size is being inflated for a purpose, which is why the Colossus, the ultimate hyperbole of scale, is also the ultimate manipulation.

ICSE application: 'Marullus's hyperbole, in which the commoners once climbed "to chimney tops" with "infants" in their arms to see Pompey, magnifies their former loyalty so that their present celebration of Caesar appears as monstrous ingratitude rather than innocent holiday-making.'

Allusion

Term: Allusion.

Definition: A brief reference to a person, event, story or text outside the work, which the audience is expected to recognise and which imports its associations into the present moment.

Act 1 example: Cassius, Act 1 Scene 2, on rescuing Caesar from the Tiber: "I, as Aeneas, our great ancestor, / Did from the flames of Troy upon his shoulder / The old Anchises bear, so from the waves of Tiber / Did I the tired Caesar."

Meaning: Just as Aeneas, the Trojan hero whom Romans regarded as their ancestor, carried his aged father Anchises out of burning Troy on his shoulders, so Cassius carried the exhausted Caesar out of the river.

Effect: The allusion casts Cassius as the pious hero of Rome's founding legend and Caesar as the feeble old man who had to be carried. It dignifies Cassius and infantilises Caesar in one stroke, and it does so by appealing to a story Brutus has known since childhood. The comparison is also faintly ridiculous if examined (Caesar was not Cassius's father, and the Tiber is not Troy), which is why Cassius moves quickly on to "And this man / Is now become a god".

Dramatic purpose: Act 1 has three allusions every student must know. The **Aeneas and Anchises** story comes from Virgil's *Aeneid*. The **Colossus** is the giant bronze statue of Helios at Rhodes, one of the Seven Wonders; Shakespeare's picture of it straddling the harbour is a medieval legend, not ancient fact, but the image depends on it. "**There was a Brutus once**" refers to Lucius Junius Brutus, who led the expulsion of King Tarquin in 509 BC and from whom Marcus Brutus claimed descent; Cassius says this ancestor would have tolerated "Th' eternal devil" in Rome as readily as a king. Each allusion recruits Roman history and legend as a witness against Caesar. Editors also gloss "since the great flood" as the classical flood of Deucalion.

ICSE application: 'Cassius's allusion to "a Brutus once" who would not have "brook'd ... a king" invokes Lucius Junius Brutus, founder of the Republic, so that Brutus's family name itself becomes an argument: to tolerate Caesar is to betray the ancestor whose statue stands in Rome.'

TEXT NOTE Common misidentification — "Th' eternal devil" and anachronism

Students sometimes list "Th' eternal devil" as a classical allusion. It is not: the devil is a Christian concept with no place in republican Rome, and the phrase is one of Shakespeare's anachronisms (like the "doublet" Caesar wears in Casca's report and the striking clock in Act 2). Call it anachronism, not allusion, and note that Elizabethan audiences would not have noticed or minded.

Foreshadowing

Term: Foreshadowing.

Definition: A hint or warning, planted earlier in a work, of something that will happen later. It may be a prophecy, an image, a line of dialogue or an event.

Act 1 example: Cassius, Act 1 Scene 3, when Casca reports that the Senate means to crown Caesar: "I know where I will wear this dagger then; / Cassius from bondage will deliver Cassius."

Meaning: If Caesar is made king, Cassius knows where his dagger will go. The surface meaning is suicide (he will free himself from slavery by killing himself), and the following lines about towers and dungeons confirm that reading; but the audience hears the other possibility, that the dagger is for Caesar.

Effect: The line is deliberately double. It lets Cassius sound like a Stoic hero while planting the image of a dagger that will, in Act 3, be used on Caesar. The ambiguity also tests Casca, who takes up the theme of suicide ("So every bondman in his own hand bears / The power to cancel his captivity") before Cassius turns the conversation to Caesar as tyrant.

Dramatic purpose: Act 1 is thick with foreshadowing because its job is to load the play's gun. "Beware the ides of March" names the date. Cicero's casual "Comes Caesar to the Capitol tomorrow?" fixes the place. Cassius's description of the night as "Most bloody, fiery, and most terrible" names the mood of the deed, and his couplet "let Caesar seat him sure, / For we will shake him, or worse days endure" ends Act 1 Scene 2 with a threat and a prophecy of civil war. Marullus's prayer that the gods "intermit the plague / That needs must light on this ingratitude" is, in retrospect, a forecast of the bloodshed of Acts 3 to 5. Even the lion "Against the Capitol" places a predator where Caesar will die.

ICSE application: 'Cassius's "I know where I will wear this dagger then" foreshadows the assassination through deliberate ambiguity: he speaks of suicide, yet the audience, knowing the Ides of March, hears the dagger pointed at Caesar, so the line reveals both his readiness to kill and his skill at saying dangerous things safely.'

Contrast

Term: Contrast.

Definition: The deliberate placing of two characters, scenes, speeches or images side by side so that their differences illuminate each other. Unlike antithesis, contrast need not be compressed into one balanced sentence; it can span a scene or the whole act.

Act 1 example: Caesar, Act 1 Scene 2: "Let me have men about me that are fat, / Sleek-headed men, and such as sleep a-nights. / Yond Cassius has a lean and hungry look. / He thinks too much. Such men are dangerous."

Meaning: Caesar wants companions who are plump, well-groomed and sleep soundly, in other words contented men. Cassius is thin and looks hungry; he thinks too much; men like that are a threat.

Effect: Fat against lean, sleep against thought, contentment against hunger: Caesar builds his whole theory of loyalty on a physical contrast, and the audience, who has just watched Cassius work on Brutus for two hundred lines, knows he is right. The contrast also characterises Caesar: a ruler who judges men by their waistlines is both shrewd and dangerously superficial.

Dramatic purpose: Act 1 is constructed from contrasts. Prose commoners against verse tribunes. Brutus, who is "not gamesome", against Antony's "quick spirit". Caesar's public "always I am Caesar" against the private deaf ear and the reported fainting fit. Casca's panic in the storm against Cicero's cool "men may construe things after their fashion". Cassius's fire against Brutus's stillness. **Literary interpretation:** the play's method is comparative; it asks the audience to weigh men against one another, which is exactly what Cassius asks Brutus to do with the names "Brutus" and "Caesar".

ICSE application: 'Caesar's contrast between "fat, / Sleek-headed men" and the "lean and hungry" Cassius reveals a ruler who reads character through the body; the irony is that his reading is accurate, yet pride prevents him from acting on it.'

Pun

Term: Pun.

Definition: A play on words that exploits two meanings of the same word, or two words that sound alike, so that a sentence means two things at once, usually for comic effect.

Act 1 example: The Cobbler, Act 1 Scene 1, asked his trade: "A trade, sir, that I hope I may use with a safe / conscience, which is indeed, sir, a mender of bad / soles."

Meaning: He mends worn-out shoe soles; he also, by sound, claims to mend bad souls, which would make him a kind of priest, and the joke is aimed at the tribunes who are lecturing him about conscience.

Effect: The pun lets a working man score off his social superiors without quite saying anything punishable. Flavius and Marullus hear the insolence but cannot pin it down, which is why Flavius loses his temper ("Thou naughty knave"). Comedy also relaxes the audience before the serious verse of Marullus's speech, so that the tribune's anger lands harder.

Dramatic purpose: The Cobbler's speech is a chain of puns, and you should know them all: "be not out with me" (angry with me / with worn-out shoes) and "if you be out, sir, I can mend you"; "all that I live by is with the awl" (awl, the cobbler's pointed tool, and 'all'); "withal" (with all / with awl); "a surgeon to old shoes" who can "recover them" (restore them / put a new cover on them). **Literary interpretation:** the puns matter politically because they show that the common people are not stupid; they are quick, sceptical and hard to govern by shouting, which is exactly the problem Caesar, Brutus and Antony will face in Act 3.

ICSE application: 'The Cobbler's pun on "a mender of bad / soles" lets him mock the tribunes' concern with conscience while appearing to describe his trade; Shakespeare uses the wordplay to establish a crowd that is witty and irreverent rather than simply ignorant, which complicates the tribunes' contempt for them.'

TEXT NOTE Common misidentification — pun versus metaphor

"A surgeon to old shoes" is often labelled a metaphor, and it is one: the Cobbler compares himself to a surgeon. But its force comes from the pun on "recover", so in an answer name both: a metaphor sustained by a pun. Similarly, "mettle" in "quick mettle" and "honourable mettle" carries a pun on 'metal' (spirit and the substance that can be forged); some editions print 'metal'. When two devices operate at once, saying so earns more credit than choosing one.

Wordplay

Term: Wordplay.

Definition: The broader category to which puns belong: any deliberate manipulation of words for their sound, shape, double sense or associations, including name-play, extended conceits and sly redefinition.

Act 1 example: Cassius, Act 1 Scene 2, on the two names: "Write them together, yours is as fair a name; / Sound them, it doth become the mouth as well; / Weigh them, it is as heavy; conjure with 'em, / 'Brutus' will start a spirit as soon as 'Caesar.'"

Meaning: Put the names side by side and Brutus's looks as handsome; speak them and Brutus's sounds as well in the mouth; weigh them and it is as heavy; use them in a magic spell and the name Brutus will summon a spirit as quickly as the name Caesar.

Effect: Cassius treats names as physical objects that can be written, sounded, weighed and used in magic, which is itself a kind of wordplay: he empties the name 'Caesar' of its aura by handling it like a coin. The passage is more than a pun because it works on the whole idea of what a name is. It is also flattery disguised as

logic.

Dramatic purpose: Wordplay in Act 1 is a sign of a mind that controls language. Cassius's "Cassius from bondage will deliver Cassius" plays on one man as both captive and rescuer; Brutus's "chew upon this", followed by Cassius's remark that Casca's rudeness gives men "stomach to digest his words", turns thinking into eating. **Literary interpretation:** the Cobbler's puns and Cassius's name-play are the same skill at two social levels, and the play seems to say that whoever handles words best handles Rome.

ICSE application: 'Cassius's wordplay on the names, "Sound them, it doth become the mouth as well; / Weigh them, it is as heavy", reduces "Caesar" to a mere word that can be handled like any other, so that the sacred aura of the name is dismantled before Brutus's eyes.'

Euphemism

Term: Euphemism.

Definition: A mild, vague or indirect expression substituted for one that is blunt, harsh or frightening.

Act 1 example: Casca, Act 1 Scene 2, reporting the fate of the tribunes: "Marullus and Flavius, for pulling scarves / off Caesar's images, are put to silence."

Meaning: The two tribunes have been silenced. The phrase does not say how: dismissed from office, exiled, imprisoned or killed. **Historical record:** Caesar had the historical tribunes deposed from the tribunate. Shakespeare's phrase is deliberately vaguer than history.

Effect: The softness of the phrase is more chilling than a plain statement would be. Casca drops it in passing, as gossip, and the audience is left to imagine what 'silence' means under Caesar. The euphemism also tells us about Rome's political atmosphere: people have learned to speak carefully.

Dramatic purpose: Act 1's conspirators speak almost entirely in euphemism about what they intend. Cassius calls the assassination "an enterprise / Of honourable-dangerous consequence" and "the work we have in hand"; Brutus speaks of "such high things"; Casca asks Cassius to "Be factious for redress of all these griefs"; Cassius's "life ... Never lacks power to dismiss itself" softens suicide into a polite dismissal. Caesar, after his fit, asked the crowd to blame "his infirmity". **Literary interpretation:** the play never lets the conspirators say 'kill Caesar' in Act 1, and the gap between their language and their intention is one of its deepest subjects.

ICSE application: 'Casca's euphemism that the tribunes "are put to silence" conveys the menace of Caesar's Rome precisely by its vagueness: the audience is left to imagine the punishment, and the casual tone shows how quickly the suppression of dissent has become ordinary news.'

Alliteration

Term: Alliteration.

Definition: The repetition of the same consonant sound at the beginning of nearby words.

Act 1 example: Marullus, Act 1 Scene 1: "That Tiber trembled underneath her banks".

Meaning: The river shook beneath its banks at the crowd's shout.

Effect: The repeated hard 't' in "Tiber trembled" gives the line a physical shudder, so that the sound enacts the trembling. This is the only kind of alliteration worth mentioning in an answer: alliteration that *does* something audible.

Dramatic purpose: Shakespeare rarely alliterates for its own sake in this play, and you should resist listing every pair of matching consonants. The two further cases worth knowing are Cassius's "walls of beaten brass" and "the breed of noble bloods", where the heavy 'b' sounds give weight to images of solidity and nobility.

ICSE application: 'The alliteration in "Tiber trembled" makes the line itself shudder, reinforcing Marullus's personification of the river and the sheer force of the crowd's former devotion to Pompey.' Use this device only when you can describe the sound's effect; a bare 'this is alliteration' earns nothing.

Part Four: Dramatic Devices

Prose and verse

Term: Prose and verse distinction.

Definition: Shakespeare writes some speeches in blank verse (unrhymed lines of roughly ten syllables with a regular beat) and others in prose (ordinary sentences with no metrical pattern). The choice is a device: it signals who is speaking, in what mood and at what social level.

Act 1 example: In Act 1 Scene 1 the Carpenter and Cobbler speak prose ("Truly, sir, all that I live by is with the / awl") while Flavius and Marullus answer in verse ("Wherefore rejoice? What conquest brings he home?"). In Act 1 Scene 2 the patrician Casca delivers his whole report of the crown-offering in prose ("he put it by with the back of his hand, / thus, and then the people fell a-shouting").

Meaning: The commoners' prose is quick, punning and conversational; the tribunes' verse is formal, rhythmic and public. Casca's prose is sour and deflating; it refuses the dignity of verse to an event that Caesar wanted to be dignified.

Effect: The shift from prose to verse in Scene 1 is audible even to an audience that could not define either term: the tribunes sound like authority, the commoners like the street. In Scene 2 the effect is reversed. Casca, a nobleman surrounded by verse-speakers, drops into prose to describe Caesar's performance, and the prose itself becomes a judgement: the "rabblement", the "sweaty nightcaps", the "stinking breath" belong to a world without poetry.

Dramatic purpose: Shakespeare uses the medium to control how seriously we take an event. Had Casca reported the crown-offering in verse, it would have sounded heroic; in prose it sounds like a farce staged for a crowd that hisses and claps "as they use to do the players in the theatre". The same Casca speaks tense, frightened verse in Act 1 Scene 3 ("Are not you moved, when all the sway of earth / Shakes like a thing unfirm?"), which shows that the prose of Scene 2 was a chosen manner, the "tardy form" Cassius says he "puts on", rather than a limitation.

ICSE application: 'Shakespeare gives Casca's account of the crown-offering in prose rather than verse, so that Caesar's carefully staged refusal is reported in the flat, cynical register of gossip; the choice of medium strips the event of grandeur and prepares Brutus to see Caesar as a performer rather than a hero.'

PROFESSOR'S INSIGHT How prose and verse encode class and mood

The simple rule, that commoners speak prose and nobles speak verse, is true of Act 1 Scene 1 and is worth stating in an answer, because it shows you know that the medium is meaningful. But the rule is a starting point, not a law, and the interesting cases are the exceptions. Casca is a patrician who speaks prose in Scene 2 and verse in Scene 3. **Literary interpretation:** one strong reading is that prose is his armour, the blunt, mocking manner Brutus calls "rudeness", and that the storm frightens him out of it; another is that Shakespeare simply needs the crown-offering reported in a register that denies it dignity. Either way, the shift tells you that prose can encode *mood* (deflation, cynicism, intimacy, comedy) as well as *class*. The pattern continues in the later acts in a way the Class X student must know: in Act 3 Scene 2 Brutus addresses the crowd in prose, reasoning with them as equals, while Antony answers in verse that sweeps them away. The commoners who began the play in prose end up moved by poetry, and the man of honour who chose prose loses Rome. When you write about prose and verse, therefore, never stop at 'this shows he is a commoner'; ask what the medium is doing to the moment.

Soliloquy

Term: Soliloquy.

Definition: A speech delivered by a character alone on stage, revealing private thoughts directly to the audience. By convention a soliloquy is truthful: the character has no one to deceive.

Act 1 example: Cassius, Act 1 Scene 2, after Brutus leaves: "Well, Brutus, thou art noble. Yet I see / Thy honourable mettle may be wrought / From that it is disposed."

Meaning: Brutus is noble, but his noble nature, like metal, can be worked away from its natural shape. Cassius goes on to say that Caesar "doth bear me hard, but he loves Brutus", that he would never let himself be manipulated as he is manipulating Brutus ("If I were Brutus now, and he were Cassius, / He should not humour me"), and that he will throw forged letters in at Brutus's windows that night.

Effect: This is the only soliloquy in Act 1, and it changes the meaning of everything before it. For two hundred lines Cassius has spoken of honour, friendship and Rome; alone, he speaks of technique. The word "wrought" turns Brutus into raw material. The audience, which may have been half-persuaded by the Colossus and the Tiber, is suddenly placed outside the persuasion, looking at the machinery.

Dramatic purpose: Shakespeare ends the scene with the soliloquy so that the audience carries its knowledge into the storm scene and into Act 2, where Brutus will read the letters and believe them. The soliloquy also establishes a question the play never fully answers: is Cassius a patriot who uses dishonest means, or an envious man who uses patriotic language? The lines "Caesar doth bear me hard" (Caesar bears a grudge against me) and "we will shake him, or worse days endure" can support either reading, and a good answer says so.

ICSE application: 'Cassius's soliloquy reveals the gap between his public and private selves: the man who has just appealed to Brutus's honour now plans to have that "honourable mettle ... wrought" through forged letters, so the device exposes the manipulation and ensures the audience cannot share Brutus's trust.'

TEXT NOTE Common misidentification — soliloquy versus long speech versus aside

Cassius's Tiber story and his Colossus speech are *long speeches addressed to Brutus*; they are not soliloquies, however personal they sound. A **soliloquy** requires the speaker to be alone (or to believe himself alone). An **aside** is a brief remark meant for the audience, or for one other character, which the rest of the stage does not hear. The Folger text of Act 1 marks no asides at all. Brutus and Cassius talking quietly while Caesar's train passes is a split-stage conversation, not an aside, because each speaker is heard by the person he addresses.

Aside and reported action

Term: Reported action (the messenger device), with a note on the aside.

Definition: Reported action is the technique of having an event that happens offstage described by a character who witnessed it, instead of staging it. The describer's personality colours the report.

Act 1 example: Casca, Act 1 Scene 2: "I saw Mark / Antony offer him a crown (yet 'twas not a crown / neither; 'twas one of these coronets), and, as I told / you, he put it by once; but for all that, to my / thinking, he would fain have had it."

Meaning: Casca saw Antony offer Caesar a crown, or rather a coronet; Caesar pushed it away, but in Casca's opinion he would gladly ("fain") have accepted it.

Effect: The audience never sees the crown-offering. We hear only the shouts, and then Casca's version, interrupted by Brutus and Cassius, hedged with "to my / thinking", and soaked in contempt for the crowd. The event reaches us already interpreted, and the interpretation is Casca's. We cannot check whether Caesar really wanted the crown, and that uncertainty is the point.

Dramatic purpose: Staging the offer would have forced Shakespeare to decide what Caesar's face showed. Reporting it keeps Caesar's ambition a question rather than a fact, which the whole play depends on. It also lets the audience experience the shouts as Brutus experiences them, from outside, fearing that "the people / Choose Caesar for their king". The same device operates when Casca reports the omens in Act 1 Scene 3: the burning hand, the lion and the owl are described, not shown, so that the audience receives them through a frightened man's eyes while Cicero reminds us that witnesses "construe things after their fashion". **Historical record:** Plutarch says the diadem was offered and refused twice; Shakespeare's Casca says three times, and the cynical reading that Caesar wanted it is Shakespeare's addition.

ICSE application: 'Shakespeare presents the crown-offering only through Casca's report, so that the audience, like Brutus, receives a filtered account coloured by phrases such as "to my / thinking, he would fain have had it"; the device keeps Caesar's true ambition uncertain and demonstrates how political reality in this play is always somebody's version.'

DEVICE FINDER TABLE

Use this table in two directions. Reading left to right, it tells you what to call a quotation you already know. Reading right to left, it gives you a verified example for any device the question names. Where a quotation carries more than one device, the primary one is listed first; in an answer, name the primary device and mention the second only if you can explain its contribution.

Quotation	Device(s)	Speaker	Scene
"a mender of bad / soles"	Pun (soles/souls)	Cobbler	1.1

Quotation	Device(s)	Speaker	Scene
"a surgeon to old shoes: when they are in great danger, / I recover them"	Metaphor sustained by pun	Cobbler	1.1
"Wherefore rejoice? What conquest brings he home?"	Rhetorical question	Marullus	1.1
"You blocks, you stones, you worse than senseless / things!"	Metaphor; repetition (tricolon)	Marullus	1.1
"That Tiber trembled underneath her banks"	Personification; hyperbole; alliteration	Marullus	1.1
"And do you now put on your best attire? / And do you now cull out a holiday?"	Anaphora; rhetorical question	Marullus	1.1
"Pray to the gods to intermit the plague / That needs must light on this ingratitude"	Disease imagery; foreshadowing	Marullus	1.1
"They vanish tongue-tied in their guiltiness"	Imagery (bodily); verse contrasting with the commoners' prose	Flavius	1.1
"These growing feathers plucked from Caesar's wing / Will make him fly an ordinary pitch"	Extended metaphor (falconry); animal imagery	Flavius	1.1
"Beware the ides of March"	Foreshadowing; repetition	Soothsayer	1.2
"He is a dreamer. Let us leave him. Pass."	Dramatic irony	Caesar	1.2
"the eye sees not itself / But by reflection, by some other things"	Imagery (bodily); the mirror conceit begins	Brutus	1.2
"I, your glass, / Will modestly discover to yourself / That of yourself which you yet know not of"	Metaphor; dramatic irony (we later learn the glass distorts)	Cassius	1.2
"Set honour in one eye and death i' th' other"	Antithesis	Brutus	1.2
"I, as Aeneas, our great ancestor, / Did from the flames of Troy upon his shoulder / The old Anchises bear"	Allusion; simile	Cassius	1.2
"'Tis true, this god did shake"	Verbal irony; antithesis (god/shake)	Cassius	1.2
"He had a fever when he was in Spain ... As a sick girl"	Disease imagery; simile; hyperbole	Cassius	1.2
"he doth stride the narrow world / Like a Colossus, and we petty men / Walk under his huge legs"	Simile; allusion; hyperbole	Cassius	1.2
"The fault, dear Brutus, is not in our stars, / But in ourselves, that we are underlings"	Antithesis; metaphor (stars as fate)	Cassius	1.2
"Rome, thou hast lost the breed of noble bloods!"	Apostrophe; alliteration	Cassius	1.2
"There was a Brutus once that would have brooked / Th' eternal devil to keep his state in Rome"	Allusion (L. Junius Brutus); anachronism	Cassius	1.2
"Yond Cassius has a lean and hungry look"	Contrast; bodily imagery	Caesar	1.2
"for always I am Caesar. / Come on my right hand, for this ear is deaf"	Situational irony; dramatic irony	Caesar	1.2
"as they use to do the players in the / theatre"	Theatre imagery; simile; prose report	Casca	1.2
"are put to silence"	Euphemism	Casca	1.2
"we have the falling sickness"	Paradox; disease imagery	Cassius	1.2
"Thy honourable mettle may be wrought / From that it is disposed"	Metaphor; pun (mettle/metal); soliloquy	Cassius	1.2

Quotation	Device(s)	Speaker	Scene
"a tempest dropping fire"	Storm and fire imagery	Casca	1.3
"men may construe things after their fashion, / Clean from the purpose of the things themselves"	Contrast (scepticism against superstition); aphorism	Cicero	1.3
"A very pleasing night to honest men"	Verbal irony	Cassius	1.3
"Nor stony tower, nor walls of beaten brass"	Anaphora; alliteration	Cassius	1.3
"he would not be a wolf / But that he sees the Romans are but sheep"	Animal imagery; metaphor	Cassius	1.3
"Of honourable-dangerous consequence"	Oxymoron; euphemism	Cassius	1.3
"Most bloody, fiery, and most terrible"	Foreshadowing; tricolon	Cassius	1.3
"His countenance, like richest alchemy, / Will change to virtue and to worthiness"	Simile; imagery of transformation	Casca	1.3

ICSE EXAM BOX What device questions actually look like

Exam-oriented advice. In the Class X board paper the drama extracts come from Acts III to V, and the sub-questions (in the 2025 paper, five parts marked 3, 3, 3, 3 and 4) mostly ask you to explain a phrase, say why a speaker says something, describe what is revealed about character, or give a supported personal response. A sub-question rarely says 'name the figure of speech' and stops there; more often the device is the *means* by which you explain a phrase well. So the skill this chapter builds is not labelling but explaining-through-labelling: 'Antony's repeated "honourable man" is verbal irony because ...' is the shape of a full-mark sentence. Act 1 itself is examined in Class IX, usually through reference-to-the-context questions where device recognition is more directly tested; the table above is your bank for those. Nothing here is a prediction of what any paper will ask.

HOW TO WRITE ABOUT A DEVICE IN AN ICSE ANSWER

Every strong sentence about a device has four parts, in this order: **quote** the words (briefly and exactly), **name** the device, **explain** what the words mean, and **analyse** what the device does for the speaker, the character or the play. Students usually manage the first two and skip the last two. The last two are where the marks are.

LEVEL 5 — How do I use it in an ICSE answer?

Suppose the question asks, about Cassius's speech after the second shout, 'Explain the comparison Cassius makes here. What does it reveal about his attitude to Caesar and to the Romans?' This is a Level 5 task, but you can only do it if Levels 1 to 4 are already secure: you know what a Colossus is (Level 1), you can paraphrase the lines (Level 2), you can say why Shakespeare chose an image of size at this moment (Level 3), and you can connect the image to the play's larger argument about greatness and consent (Level 4). Watch the difference below.

WEAK ANSWER A weak answer on the Colossus image

Cassius uses a metaphor and compares Caesar to a Colossus. A Colossus is a very big statue. This shows that Caesar is very powerful and everyone else is small. Cassius is jealous of Caesar and wants Brutus to join him. The imagery is very effective and makes the audience understand Cassius's feelings.

What is wrong with it? The device is misnamed (the line uses "Like", so it is a simile). Nothing is quoted. 'Very big', 'very powerful', 'very effective' are not analysis. The answer names Cassius's jealousy without showing where in the words it can be seen, and it never asks what the image does to Brutus, who is the person being spoken to. It would be awarded for basic understanding and little else.

EXCELLENT ANSWER A strong answer on the Colossus image

Cassius's simile, "he doth bstride the narrow world / Like a Colossus", compares Caesar to the giant statue of Rhodes, which legend said stood astride the harbour so that ships passed between its legs. The comparison makes Caesar's power monstrous rather than admirable: the world has become "narrow" because one man fills it. The real force of the image, however, lies in what it does to everyone else. Romans are "petty men" who "Walk under his huge legs and peep about / To find ourselves dishonourable graves"; the verb "peep" turns senators into children, and "dishonourable graves" tells Brutus that to live under Caesar is to die in disgrace. By making smallness shameful, Cassius turns a description into an accusation, and the plural "we" and "ourselves" include Brutus in the humiliation. The image therefore reveals Cassius's envy, since it is he who feels dwarfed, but it also reveals his skill: he does not argue that Caesar is dangerous, he makes Brutus feel small, and then supplies the doctrine that follows, "The fault, dear Brutus, is not in our stars, / But in ourselves, that we are underlings." The simile prepares the ground for that claim by making the Romans' inferiority seem a matter of their own consent.

Notice what the strong answer does that the weak one does not. It quotes exactly and briefly. It names the device correctly and glosses the allusion in one clause. It explains meaning before effect. It picks out individual words ("narrow", "peep", "dishonourable", "we") and says what each does. It keeps asking who is being spoken to and what the speaker wants. And it ends by connecting the image to the lines that follow, which shows that the device has been understood as part of a design rather than as an isolated ornament. The strong answer is longer, but every sentence earns something; length without analysis would not.

REVISION The device bank in one minute

Irony needs a gap: dramatic (audience knows, character does not: "He is a dreamer"), verbal (says one thing, means another: "A very pleasing night to honest men"), situational (expectation reversed: "always I am Caesar" beside "this ear is deaf"). Metaphor says *is* ("I, your glass"); simile says *like* ("Like a Colossus"). Imagery runs in six families: body, animal, fire, storm, disease, theatre. Personification describes ("Tiber trembled"); apostrophe addresses ("Rome, thou hast lost"). Antithesis balances; paradox contradicts; oxymoron compresses ("honourable-dangerous"). Anaphora repeats openings ("Nor ... nor ... nor"). Allusion borrows a story (Aeneas, Colossus, "a Brutus once"). Euphemism softens ("put to silence"). Prose for commoners and for Casca's cynicism; verse for authority and feeling. One soliloquy, Cassius's, and no marked asides. Always: quote, name, explain, analyse.

CROSS-REFERENCE Where to go next

For the quotations in this chapter arranged by theme and character, see 'The Act 1 Quotation Bank'. For the technical vocabulary examiners expect ('conceit', 'blank verse', 'tricolon'), see 'The ICSE Keyword Vault for Act 1'. For how the same devices return in the funeral orations and the quarrel scene, see 'The Scene Connection Engine and Where Act 1 Reappears Later'. For full practice on extract questions that test device recognition, see the two 'Extract-Based Training' chapters.

CHAPTER 14

The ICSE Keyword Vault for Act 1

What this chapter does: It gives you the words. Not a glossary of hard Shakespearean vocabulary (that is the business of the chapter 'Difficult Shakespearean English: The Act 1 Vocabulary System'), but two armouries of terms that earn marks. Type A holds Shakespeare's own words and phrases from Act 1, each one explained as a small piece of argument you can quote. Type B holds the analytical vocabulary of politics, rhetoric, drama and Roman history that lets you name precisely what the play is doing. Every entry follows one fixed format, so you can revise it like a deck of cards, and the chapter ends with a conversion table that turns the weak words students reach for into the strong words examiners reward.

How to Use the Vault

Students who struggle with Shakespeare usually believe their problem is understanding. Very often their real problem is expression. They have seen what Cassius is doing to Brutus; they simply cannot say it in fewer than forty words, so they write 'Cassius tricks Brutus into joining him by saying nice things about him', and the examiner, who was waiting for the word 'insinuates' or 'flatters' or 'manipulates', gives the point half its value. The idea was there. The word was not.

This chapter fixes that. It is built in two parts.

Type A entries are Shakespeare's own words. When you quote "lean and hungry" or "servile fearfulness" you are not decorating your answer; you are borrowing the play's own analysis, because the characters of this play are themselves analysts of one another, and their chosen words carry judgements. To quote the word is to quote the judgement.

Type B entries are the analytical terms: 'republicanism', 'manipulation', 'dramatic irony', 'tribune'. They are the words you supply, from outside the text, to classify what the text is doing. The danger with Type B words is that they can be fired off without aim. So each entry tells you exactly where in Act 1 the term genuinely applies, and several carry a caution where the term is anachronistic or contested.

Every entry uses the same eight labels. **Keyword** names it. **Meaning** explains it in plain English, including the Elizabethan sense where that differs from ours. **Where it applies** fixes it to a moment in Act 1. **Textual evidence** gives you verified words to quote. **Character/Theme** tells you which answer the word belongs in. **How to use it in an ICSE answer** gives you one sample sentence, written at the standard an examiner rewards. **Common weak substitute** names the word students usually write instead, and **Better word** gives you the upgrade. Learn the entry; practise the sentence; the upgrade will become your habit.

PROFESSOR'S INSIGHT Why precise vocabulary is itself analysis

LITERARY INTERPRETATION and EXAM-ORIENTED ADVICE together. There is a common belief that analysis is a mental act and vocabulary is merely its clothing: first you understand, then you find words. In literary study this is false, and knowing why will change how you write. Consider the difference between 'Caesar is proud' and 'Caesar is self-mythologising'. The first is a feeling about him. The second makes a claim with moving parts: that Caesar has constructed a public image, that he speaks of that image rather than of himself, and that the image is doing political work. The moment you choose the second word you are obliged to look for evidence of all three parts, and Act 1 supplies it, because Caesar refers to himself in the third person and tells Antony "for always I am Caesar", as though 'Caesar' were an office and not a man. The precise word forced you to see something the vague word let you ignore. This is why examiners treat vocabulary as evidence of thought: a student who writes 'the fickle plebeians' has demonstrated that she has noticed the crowd's reversal from Pompey to Caesar and classified the people correctly; a student who writes 'the people were bad' has demonstrated neither. Strong vocabulary is not a reward for analysis finished elsewhere. It is the instrument with which the analysis is performed, and the shortest possible proof that it has been.

ICSE EXAM BOX Where these words earn their marks

EXAM-ORIENTED ADVICE. Be clear about the examination position. Act 1 is the Class IX portion of the ICSE Julius Caesar syllabus, examined in school through extract-based ('reference to the context') questions. The Class X board paper sets its drama extracts from Acts III, IV and V. So you will not be handed an Act 1 extract in the board examination. But the Class X paper relies on Act 1 at every turn: it asks what earlier events a line refers to, why a character behaves as he does, what has motivated the conspiracy, and it rewards answers that trace a character's trait back to its origin. The words in this vault are therefore double-purpose. They answer Act 1 questions in Class IX, and they supply the explanatory vocabulary ('republicanism', 'manipulation', 'the fickle plebeians', 'portentous') that Act 3, 4 and 5 answers need. No question is guaranteed; the vocabulary is useful whatever is set.

Type A, Group One: The Street. Class, Crowd and Contempt (Scene 1)

The first scene teaches the play's political vocabulary before it introduces a single patrician. The tribunes' words for the commoners, and their words for Caesar's honours, are the seedbed of everything later.

Keyword: mechanical

Meaning: In Elizabethan English a 'mechanical' was a manual worker, a tradesman who worked with his hands. It is a class label, not an insult in itself, but Flavius turns it into one by using it to say the men have no right to be where they are.

Where it applies: The opening speech of the play, as Flavius drives the holidaying tradesmen off the street.

Textual evidence: "Being mechanical, you ought not walk / Upon a labouring day without the sign / Of your profession"

Character/Theme: Flavius; class division; the tribunes' contempt for the people they are supposed to protect.

How to use it in an ICSE answer: 'Flavius's first word of classification, "mechanical", reduces the commoners to their trade and their tools; the tribune of the plebs opens the play by telling the plebs they are out of place.'

Common weak substitute: 'workers', 'poor people'

Better word: 'the mechanicals', 'the artisan class', 'tradesmen'

Keyword: idle creatures

Meaning: 'Idle' means both unemployed and worthless; 'creatures' denies them full humanity. The phrase is the very first thing spoken in the play.

Where it applies: Flavius's first line.

Textual evidence: "Hence! Home, you idle creatures, get you home!"

Character/Theme: Flavius; the crowd as a political object; the gap between the tribunes' office and their attitude.

How to use it in an ICSE answer: 'The play begins with an insult: "idle creatures" is not addressed to Caesar's enemies but to Rome's own working men, and it tells us that the republican cause is defended, from its first line, by men who despise the republic's citizens.'

Common weak substitute: 'lazy people'

Better word: 'dehumanising address', 'contempt for the commons'

Keyword: vulgar

Meaning: The 'vulgar' were simply the common people (Latin vulgus, the crowd). The modern sense of coarse or indecent is a later narrowing, though the contempt is already audible in Flavius's mouth.

Where it applies: Flavius's closing instructions to Marullus.

Textual evidence: "I'll about / And drive away the vulgar from the streets"

Character/Theme: Flavius; the plebeians; public opinion as a thing to be herded.

How to use it in an ICSE answer: 'Flavius does not argue with "the vulgar"; he drives them, as one drives cattle, and the verb exposes how little the tribunes believe in the people's judgement they claim to defend.'

Common weak substitute: 'the people', 'the public'

Better word: 'the populace', 'the commons', 'the plebeians'

Keyword: tributaries

Meaning: Conquered peoples or rulers who pay tribute to Rome. In a proper triumph, foreign captives walked before the general's chariot. Marullus's point is that Caesar's victory was over Romans, so there are no tributaries to show.

Where it applies: Marullus's great rebuke, the moment the Cobbler mentions Caesar's triumph.

Textual evidence: "What tributaries follow him to Rome / To grace in captive bonds his chariot wheels?"

Character/Theme: Marullus; the illegitimacy of a civil-war triumph; Pompey's memory.

How to use it in an ICSE answer: 'Marullus's rhetorical question about "tributaries" is a legal objection disguised as grief: a triumph without foreign captives is a triumph over fellow Romans, and therefore no triumph at all.'

Common weak substitute: 'prisoners', 'enemies'

Better word: 'tributaries', 'captives in chains', 'conquered foreigners'

Keyword: captive bonds

Meaning: The chains of the prisoners paraded in a triumph. The phrase carries the whole Roman theatre of victory in two words.

Where it applies: The same rhetorical question.

Textual evidence: "To grace in captive bonds his chariot wheels"

Character/Theme: Marullus; triumph; the ceremony of power.

How to use it in an ICSE answer: 'The chains that should "grace" Caesar's wheels are absent, and the absence is Marullus's whole case: Caesar has borrowed the ceremony of conquest for a victory that was really a bloodletting among Romans.'

Common weak substitute: 'chains'

Better word: 'captive bonds', 'the spectacle of conquest'

Keyword: replication

Meaning: Here, an echo; the river's banks threw the crowd's shout back. (The word is unrelated to its modern scientific sense.)

Where it applies: Marullus's memory of the people cheering Pompey.

Textual evidence: "That Tiber trembled underneath her banks / To hear the replication of your sounds / Made in her concave shores?"

Character/Theme: Marullus; the fickle crowd; memory versus the present.

How to use it in an ICSE answer: 'Marullus recalls a Rome whose shout for Pompey made the Tiber tremble with its "replication"; the echo is the point, because the same voices now echo for Pompey's conqueror.'

Common weak substitute: 'noise', 'cheering'

Better word: 'the echoing acclamation', 'the crowd's replicated shout'

Keyword: Pompey's blood

Meaning: Literally the blood of Pompey's family, since the triumph celebrated victory over Pompey's sons; more broadly, the Roman blood shed in civil war.

Where it applies: The climax of Marullus's rebuke.

Textual evidence: "And do you now strew flowers in his way / That comes in triumph over Pompey's blood?"

Character/Theme: Marullus; civil war; ingratitude; the crowd's reversal.

How to use it in an ICSE answer: 'The flowers strewn for Caesar fall, in Marullus's phrase, on "Pompey's blood", and the collision of the two images turns a festival into a desecration.'

Common weak substitute: 'Pompey's defeat'

Better word: 'the blood of fellow Romans', 'a triumph over Roman dead'

Keyword: images, ceremonies, trophies

Meaning: The 'images' are Caesar's statues; 'ceremonies' here are the decorations (scarves, diadems) hung upon them; 'trophies' are the tokens of victory. Together they are the visible furniture of Caesar's rising status.

Where it applies: The tribunes' decision to strip the statues at the end of Scene 1; recalled by Casca in Scene 2.

Textual evidence: "Disrobe the images / If you do find them decked with ceremonies." and "Let no images / Be hung with Caesar's trophies."

Character/Theme: Flavius and Marullus; political symbolism; the war of signs that precedes the war of daggers.

How to use it in an ICSE answer: 'The tribunes' first act of resistance is symbolic: by disrobing the "images" they attack not Caesar's person but his public meaning, which is exactly where his power is being manufactured.'

Common weak substitute: 'statues with decorations', 'things'

Better word: 'Caesar's images', 'the emblems of his honour', 'the iconography of power'

Keyword: ordinary pitch

Meaning: From falconry. A hawk's 'pitch' is the height it climbs before stooping on its prey; an 'ordinary' pitch is a normal, unexceptional height. Flavius imagines plucking Caesar's feathers so he can fly no higher than other men.

Where it applies: Flavius's closing couplets in Scene 1.

Textual evidence: "These growing feathers plucked from Caesar's wing / Will make him fly an ordinary pitch"

Character/Theme: Flavius; ambition; the republican ideal of equality among the nobility.

How to use it in an ICSE answer: 'Flavius's falconry image states the republican creed in miniature: no Roman should "soar above the view of men", and the honours stripped from the statues are the "growing feathers" that would carry Caesar out of reach.'

Common weak substitute: 'normal level'

Better word: 'an "ordinary pitch"', 'the level of his equals'

Keyword: servile fearfulness

Meaning: The fear of slaves. 'Servile' comes from the Latin for slave; the phrase names the condition the tribunes dread, a Rome in which free men live in the fear proper to the unfree.

Where it applies: The final line of Scene 1.

Textual evidence: "Who else would soar above the view of men / And keep us all in servile fearfulness."

Character/Theme: Flavius; liberty versus bondage; the republican fear of a king.

How to use it in an ICSE answer: 'Scene 1 ends on "servile fearfulness", the phrase that Cassius will spend two scenes expanding, for his "bondage" and "bondman" are the same fear given a sharper edge.'

Common weak substitute: 'being scared of Caesar'

Better word: 'servile fearfulness', 'the subjection of free men'

Type A, Group Two: Ceremony, Omen and the Body of Caesar (Scene 2)

These words belong to Caesar himself, or to the way others describe his body. Keep them separate from Cassius's hostile vocabulary: these are the words that show Caesar's power and vulnerability side by side.

Keyword: sterile curse

Meaning: Barrenness, imagined as a curse that the Lupercal runners' touch can remove. The phrase makes Caesar's childlessness a public and ritual matter.

Where it applies: Caesar's first full speech, instructing Antony to touch Calpurnia during the race.

Textual evidence: "The barren, touchèd in this holy chase, / Shake off their sterile curse."

Character/Theme: Caesar; superstition; the private anxiety of a public man; the question of an heir.

How to use it in an ICSE answer: 'Before he dismisses the Soothsayer, Caesar has already shown that he believes in ritual, publicly asking Antony to lift Calpurnia's "sterile curse"; his later scepticism is therefore selective, not principled.'

Common weak substitute: 'not being able to have children'

Better word: 'barrenness', 'the "sterile curse"', 'the want of an heir'

Keyword: ides

Meaning: HISTORICAL RECORD: in the Roman calendar the Ides fell on the fifteenth of March, May, July and October and the thirteenth of other months. In the play 'the ides of March' is the appointed day, the fixed point towards which everything moves.

Where it applies: The Soothsayer's warning and Caesar's dismissal of it.

Textual evidence: "Beware the ides of March." and "He is a dreamer. Let us leave him. Pass."

Character/Theme: The Soothsayer; Caesar; fate; dramatic irony; foreshadowing.

How to use it in an ICSE answer: 'The Soothsayer's "Beware the ides of March" is the play's clock; from this line onward every scene is dated by its distance from a day the audience already knows to be fatal.'

Common weak substitute: 'the fifteenth of March', 'the day'

Better word: 'the ides', 'the appointed day', 'the fatal date'

Keyword: falling sickness

Meaning: Epilepsy, in its Elizabethan name. HISTORICAL RECORD: Plutarch and Suetonius record Caesar's seizures; the diagnosis is debated by modern historians. In the play the term is passed from Brutus (medical) to Cassius (political).

Where it applies: Casca's report of Caesar's swoon in the marketplace, and the exchange that follows.

Textual evidence: "'Tis very like; he hath the falling sickness." and "No, Caesar hath it not; but you and I / And honest Casca, we have the falling sickness."

Character/Theme: Caesar's mortality; Cassius's wit; appearance versus reality.

How to use it in an ICSE answer: 'Brutus names Caesar's "falling sickness" as a doctor would; Cassius seizes the phrase and turns it into a political diagnosis of Rome, whose citizens have "fallen" into servitude while Caesar stands.'

Common weak substitute: 'fits', 'illness'

Better word: 'the falling sickness', 'his infirmity', 'the body's betrayal of the god'

Keyword: this ear is deaf

Meaning: Caesar's admission that he cannot hear on one side. Scholars note that the deafness has no basis in the ancient sources and appears to be Shakespeare's addition.

Where it applies: The end of Caesar's assessment of Cassius, as he turns to Antony.

Textual evidence: "Come on my right hand, for this ear is deaf, / And tell me truly what thou think'st of him."

Character/Theme: Caesar; the gap between the public colossus and the private body; appearance versus reality.

How to use it in an ICSE answer: 'Within one speech Caesar declares "always I am Caesar" and confesses "this ear is deaf"; Shakespeare places the invented infirmity beside the boast so that the audience hears the man and the myth in the same breath.'

Common weak substitute: 'he can't hear properly'

Better word: 'his physical frailty', 'the deaf ear as an emblem of the man who will not listen'

Keyword: lean and hungry

Meaning: Thin and, by implication, unsatisfied and ambitious. HISTORICAL RECORD: Plutarch reports Caesar saying he feared pale, thin men rather than fat, long-haired ones; Shakespeare sharpens the remark into a portrait.

Where it applies: Caesar's aside to Antony as he returns from the games.

Textual evidence: "Yond Cassius has a lean and hungry look. / He thinks too much. Such men are dangerous."

Character/Theme: Caesar's political insight; Cassius's envy; dramatic irony.

How to use it in an ICSE answer: 'Caesar reads Cassius with perfect accuracy ("lean and hungry", "thinks too much") and then overrules his own reading, so that the speech demonstrates both his penetration and the self-image that makes the penetration useless.'

Common weak substitute: 'thin and jealous'

Better word: 'lean and hungry', 'ascetic and resentful', 'the discontented observer'

Keyword: well given

Meaning: Well disposed, of good inclination. Antony's phrase of reassurance about Cassius.

Where it applies: Antony's reply to Caesar's suspicion.

Textual evidence: "Fear him not, Caesar; he's not dangerous. / He is a noble Roman, and well given."

Character/Theme: Antony's misjudgement; dramatic irony; appearance versus reality.

How to use it in an ICSE answer: 'Antony's "well given" is the play's first instance of a loyal friend being wrong about a conspirator, and it quietly establishes that Caesar, not Antony, is the better reader of men in Act 1.'

Common weak substitute: 'a good man'

Better word: 'well disposed', 'of good inclination', 'honourable in appearance'

Type A, Group Three: Brutus's Inner War (Scene 2)

Brutus's vocabulary is the vocabulary of division: of a self at odds with itself, of eyes that cannot see their own face, of honour weighed against death. Cassius's words for Brutus belong here too, because they are chosen to fit the cracks.

Keyword: gamesome

Meaning: Fond of sport and amusement; playful. Brutus uses it of what he is not.

Where it applies: Brutus's excuse for not watching the Lupercal race.

Textual evidence: "I am not gamesome. I do lack some part / Of that quick spirit that is in Antony."

Character/Theme: Brutus; temperament; the contrast with Antony.

How to use it in an ICSE answer: 'Brutus's "I am not gamesome" is a self-portrait in three words: grave, withdrawn, and already measuring himself against Antony, the man who will later outplay him before the crowd.'

Common weak substitute: 'fun-loving', 'not sporty'

Better word: 'gamesome', 'convivial', 'light-spirited'

Keyword: quick spirit

Meaning: 'Quick' means lively, alive, animated. Brutus credits Antony with a vitality he lacks.

Where it applies: The same line.

Textual evidence: "that quick spirit that is in Antony"

Character/Theme: Antony as foil to Brutus; temperament and politics.

How to use it in an ICSE answer: 'By granting Antony the "quick spirit" he himself lacks, Brutus unknowingly names the quality that will defeat him: the conspirators' failure to take Antony seriously begins in this admiring, dismissive phrase.'

Common weak substitute: 'energy', 'liveliness'

Better word: 'quick spirit', 'animal vitality', 'liveliness of temper'

Keyword: passions of some difference

Meaning: Conflicting emotions; feelings at variance with one another. 'Passions' in Shakespeare's English means strong feelings of any kind, not only love.

Where it applies: Brutus's apology to Cassius for his coldness.

Textual evidence: "Vexèd I am / Of late with passions of some difference, / Conceptions only proper to myself"

Character/Theme: Brutus; moral conflict; the private self.

How to use it in an ICSE answer: 'Brutus's "passions of some difference" is deliberately vague, and the vagueness matters: he is a man who has not yet named his own conflict, and Cassius enters precisely through that unnamed space.'

Common weak substitute: 'mixed feelings', 'confused'

Better word: 'conflicting passions', 'inward division', 'unresolved conflict'

Keyword: with himself at war

Meaning: Internally divided; Brutus pictures his own mind as a battlefield.

Where it applies: The close of the same speech.

Textual evidence: "poor Brutus, with himself at war, / Forgets the shows of love to other men."

Character/Theme: Brutus; moral conflict; the public cost of private struggle.

How to use it in an ICSE answer: 'The military metaphor in "with himself at war" is prophetic: the civil war Brutus will help to start in Rome is first fought, and lost, inside him.'

Common weak substitute: 'confused', 'upset'

Better word: 'inwardly divided', 'self-divided', 'at war with himself'

Keyword: mirror, glass, shadow

Meaning: 'Mirror' and 'glass' both mean a looking-glass; 'shadow' here means reflection or image. Cassius offers to be the mirror that shows Brutus his hidden worth.

Where it applies: The central movement of Cassius's seduction, from the question about Brutus's face to the offer to be his 'glass'.

Textual evidence: "That you have no such mirrors as will turn / Your hidden worthiness into your eye, / That you might see your shadow." and "I, your glass, / Will modestly discover to yourself / That of yourself which you yet know not of."

Character/Theme: Cassius's manipulation; Brutus's self-knowledge; appearance versus reality.

How to use it in an ICSE answer: 'When Cassius offers to be Brutus's "glass", he claims the power of a mirror to show the truth while reserving the power of a painter to choose the image; the metaphor is the manipulation.'

Common weak substitute: 'Cassius says he will show Brutus who he really is'

Better word: 'the mirror conceit', 'Cassius as a distorting glass', 'reflected selfhood'

Keyword: honour

Meaning: For Brutus, a man's inner worth and public integrity, valued above life. Cassius uses the same word as the announced subject of a speech that is really about envy. (British spelling throughout; the Folger text prints 'honor'.)

Where it applies: Brutus's declaration after the first shout, and Cassius's reply.

Textual evidence: "For let the gods so speed me as I love / The name of honour more than I fear death." and "Well, honour is the subject of my story."

Character/Theme: Brutus; Cassius; the word's double life as ideal and as bait.

How to use it in an ICSE answer: 'Brutus loves "the name of honour", and Cassius, hearing the word, instantly makes it "the subject of my story"; the whole seduction is an act of translation in which Cassius's grievance is rendered into Brutus's language.'

Common weak substitute: 'being good', 'pride'

Better word: 'honour', 'integrity', 'his sense of noble duty'

Keyword: general good

Meaning: The public welfare, the good of the whole state; the republican test by which Brutus says he will judge any proposal.

Where it applies: Brutus's conditional offer to Cassius.

Textual evidence: "If it be aught toward the general good, / Set honour in one eye and death i' th' other / And I will look on both indifferently"

Character/Theme: Brutus; civic duty; political idealism.

How to use it in an ICSE answer: 'Brutus's one condition, "the general good", is the hinge of his character: it is the principle that makes him incorruptible by bribery and, for that very reason, corruptible by argument.'

Common weak substitute: 'for everyone', 'for Rome'

Better word: 'the general good', 'the public weal', 'the welfare of the republic'

Keyword: villager

Meaning: A country-dweller of no rank; for a Roman patrician, the lowest imaginable station. Brutus says he would rather be one than live as a Roman under tyranny.

Where it applies: Brutus's parting words before Caesar returns.

Textual evidence: "Brutus had rather be a villager / Than to repute himself a son of Rome / Under these hard conditions as this time / Is like to lay upon us."

Character/Theme: Brutus; liberty; the first sign that Cassius has succeeded.

How to use it in an ICSE answer: 'In preferring to be a "villager" rather than "a son of Rome" under Caesar, Brutus for the first time states a price he will not pay, and Cassius rightly hears it as "fire".'

Common weak substitute: 'a nobody', 'a peasant'

Better word: 'a villager', 'a man without rank', 'an exile from Roman dignity'

Keyword: honourable mettle

Meaning: 'Mettle' is temperament or spirit; the word was spelt interchangeably with 'metal', so Cassius's phrase also pictures a noble metal that can be 'wrought', hammered into a new shape.

Where it applies: Cassius's soliloquy, once Brutus has left.

Textual evidence: "Well, Brutus, thou art noble. Yet I see / Thy honourable mettle may be wrought / From that it is disposed."

Character/Theme: Cassius's cynicism; Brutus's vulnerability; the ethics of the conspiracy.

How to use it in an ICSE answer: 'The pun in "honourable mettle may be wrought" turns Brutus's virtue into raw material; Cassius admits in soliloquy that nobility is, to him, a metal to be forged.'

Common weak substitute: 'good nature', 'character'

Better word: 'honourable mettle', 'noble temper', 'malleable virtue'

Keyword: seduced

Meaning: Led astray, drawn from one's proper course; in Elizabethan usage not primarily sexual. Cassius uses it of what he intends to do to Brutus.

Where it applies: The same soliloquy.

Textual evidence: "For who so firm that cannot be seduced?"

Character/Theme: Cassius; manipulation; the gap between the conspiracy's language of honour and its method.

How to use it in an ICSE answer: 'Cassius's own verb for his project is "seduced": the man who has just told Brutus that "honour is the subject of my story" privately describes that story as a seduction.'

Common weak substitute: 'convinced', 'tricked'

Better word: 'seduced', 'subverted', 'drawn from his disposition'

Type A, Group Four: Cassius's Arsenal (Scene 2)

Cassius's images are the most quoted in Act 1, and the most misquoted. Learn these exactly.

Keyword: Colossus

Meaning: The giant bronze statue of Helios at Rhodes, one of the Seven Wonders. HISTORICAL RECORD: the picture of it straddling the harbour is a medieval legend, which Shakespeare's image relies on. Cassius makes Caesar the statue and Romans the ships beneath.

Where it applies: Cassius's response to the second shout.

Textual evidence: "Why, man, he doth bestride the narrow world / Like a Colossus, and we petty men / Walk under his huge legs and peep about / To find ourselves dishonourable graves."

Character/Theme: Cassius; Caesar's magnitude; envy; the diminishment of free men.

How to use it in an ICSE answer: 'The "Colossus" image does two things at once: it magnifies Caesar to inhuman scale and shrinks the Romans to "petty men", so that the resentment is built into the proportions of the picture.'

Common weak substitute: 'a giant', 'very powerful'

Better word: 'colossal', 'bestriding', 'a monument that dwarfs its citizens'

Keyword: underlings

Meaning: Subordinates, inferiors; those who are under another. Cassius's word for what Romans have allowed themselves to become.

Where it applies: The most famous lines of the scene.

Textual evidence: "The fault, dear Brutus, is not in our stars, / But in ourselves, that we are underlings."

Character/Theme: Cassius; free will against fate; self-reproach as persuasion.

How to use it in an ICSE answer: 'By blaming "ourselves, that we are underlings" rather than the stars, Cassius flatters Brutus with responsibility: if the fault is in them, the remedy is in them too.'

Common weak substitute: 'servants', 'followers'

Better word: 'underlings', 'subordinates', 'men who have consented to inferiority'

Keyword: masters of their fates

Meaning: In control of their own destiny. The line is Cassius's statement of free will against astrological fate.

Where it applies: The same speech.

Textual evidence: "Men at some time are masters of their fates."

Character/Theme: Cassius; fate and free will; the rhetoric of action.

How to use it in an ICSE answer: 'Cassius's claim that men are "masters of their fates" is a philosophy offered as a provocation, and its irony is slow: the man who denies the stars will spend Act 1 Scene 3 reading omens.'

Common weak substitute: 'in charge of their lives'

Better word: 'masters of their fates', 'agents rather than victims', 'self-determining'

Keyword: breed of noble bloods

Meaning: The stock or lineage of noble families; Cassius laments that Rome has stopped producing great men.

Where it applies: Cassius's apostrophe to Rome and the age.

Textual evidence: "Age, thou art shamed! / Rome, thou hast lost the breed of noble bloods!"

Character/Theme: Cassius; the degeneration of Rome; ancestry (the old Brutus).

How to use it in an ICSE answer: 'The lament for "the breed of noble bloods" is aimed at Brutus's lineage, and Cassius completes the aim moments later by naming the ancestor who expelled a king.'

Common weak substitute: 'great men', 'brave people'

Better word: 'noble bloods', 'the patrician stock', 'the degenerate age'

Keyword: several hands

Meaning: Different handwritings. Cassius will forge letters in various hands so they seem to come from many citizens.

Where it applies: The plan announced in Cassius's soliloquy.

Textual evidence: "I will this night / In several hands in at his windows throw, / As if they came from several citizens, / Writings"

Character/Theme: Cassius; manipulation; the forged voice of the people.

How to use it in an ICSE answer: 'The letters "in several hands" counterfeit public opinion itself: Brutus, who will act only for "the general good", is to be shown a general good that Cassius has written out by hand.'

Common weak substitute: 'fake letters'

Better word: 'forged letters', 'counterfeit petitions', 'a manufactured public voice'

Type A, Group Five: Casca's Tongue (Scene 2)

Casca speaks prose in Scene 2 and verse in Scene 3, and his Scene 2 prose is the play's most contemptuous account of the crowd. His words give you the vocabulary of mob psychology and of political silencing.

Keyword: rabblement

Meaning: A rabble, a disorderly mob; the suffix makes the contempt heavier. It is Casca's word for the crowd at the crown-offering.

Where it applies: Casca's narration of the third refusal.

Textual evidence: "the rabblement hooted and clapped their chopped hands and threw up their sweaty nightcaps"

Character/Theme: Casca; mob psychology; the crowd as spectacle.

How to use it in an ICSE answer: 'Casca's "rabblement", with its "chopped hands" and "sweaty nightcaps", reduces the Roman people to a smell and a noise; his report is evidence about the crowd but also about the patrician who watched it.'

Common weak substitute: 'the crowd', 'the mob'

Better word: 'the rabblement', 'the unruly populace', 'the hooting crowd'

Keyword: tag-rag people

Meaning: The ragged, lowest sort; riff-raff. Casca compares their behaviour to a theatre audience applauding or hissing actors.

Where it applies: Casca's explanation of why Caesar fell.

Textual evidence: "If the tag-rag people did not clap him and hiss him, according as he pleased and displeased them, as they use to do the players in the theatre, I am no true man."

Character/Theme: Casca; fickleness; politics as performance.

How to use it in an ICSE answer: 'In likening the "tag-rag people" to playgoers, Casca exposes the crown-offering as theatre, with Caesar as the actor whose refusals were played for applause; the image makes the crowd fickle and the ruler a performer in one stroke.'

Common weak substitute: 'ordinary people', 'poor people'

Better word: 'the tag-rag people', 'the fickle audience', 'the common herd'

Keyword: put to silence

Meaning: Silenced; deprived of their office and voice. HISTORICAL RECORD: the tribunes were deposed from the tribunate. Shakespeare's phrase leaves the method chillingly unspecified.

Where it applies: Casca's last item of news.

Textual evidence: "Marullus and Flavius, for pulling scarves off Caesar's images, are put to silence."

Character/Theme: Caesar's power; tyranny; the fate of dissent.

How to use it in an ICSE answer: 'The tribunes who opened the play are "put to silence" in a subordinate clause of gossip; the casualness is the point, since it shows how routinely dissent is now erased in Caesar's Rome.'

Common weak substitute: 'punished', 'removed', 'killed'

Better word: 'silenced', 'stripped of office', 'suppressed'

Keyword: Greek to me

Meaning: Incomprehensible. Casca did not understand Cicero's Greek, or pretends not to.

Where it applies: Casca's reply when Cassius asks what Cicero said.

Textual evidence: "But for mine own part, it was Greek to me."

Character/Theme: Casca's affected bluntness; Cicero's exclusion; knowledge as a closed circle.

How to use it in an ICSE answer: 'Casca's "it was Greek to me" is a pose of ignorance from a man Brutus remembers as "quick mettle"; the phrase marks the gap between what the educated elite say to one another and what they let the people hear.'

Common weak substitute: 'he didn't understand'

Better word: 'affected incomprehension', 'a performed bluntness'

Keyword: quick mettle, tardy form

Meaning: 'Quick mettle' is a lively spirit; 'tardy form' is a slow, sluggish manner. Brutus and Cassius use the two phrases to distinguish the real Casca from the one he performs.

Where it applies: The exchange immediately after Casca leaves.

Textual evidence: "He was quick mettle when he went to school." and "However he puts on this tardy form. / This rudeness is a sauce to his good wit"

Character/Theme: Casca; appearance versus reality; the conspirators' assessment of one another.

How to use it in an ICSE answer: 'Cassius's "tardy form" is a theatrical word, something "put on"; Casca's rudeness is a costume, and Cassius values it because a man who seems dull is a man who is not watched.'

Common weak substitute: 'rude', 'slow'

Better word: 'an affected sluggishness', 'his "tardy form"', 'a mask of bluntness'

Type A, Group Six: The Storm, Bondage and the Beasts (Scene 3)

Scene 3 changes the register. The words become those of omen, slavery and animal nature, and Cassius's images turn from statues to wolves.

Keyword: prodigies

Meaning: Extraordinary, unnatural happenings taken as signs. Casca's list (the burning hand, the lion, the women, the owl at noon) is a catalogue of prodigies.

Where it applies: Casca's report to Cicero.

Textual evidence: "When these prodigies / Do so conjointly meet, let not men say / 'These are their reasons, they are natural'"

Character/Theme: Casca; the supernatural; the correspondence between nature and state.

How to use it in an ICSE answer: 'Casca insists the "prodigies" are not "natural", and that insistence is a political act: to call the storm a sign is to say that something in Rome has broken the order of things.'

Common weak substitute: 'strange things', 'weird events'

Better word: 'prodigies', 'unnatural signs', 'portents'

Keyword: portentous

Meaning: Carrying a warning of the future; ominous. 'Portent' and 'portentous' are the exact words for the storm's political meaning.

Where it applies: The same speech.

Textual evidence: "For I believe they are portentous things / Unto the climate that they point upon."

Character/Theme: Casca; foreshadowing; omen.

How to use it in an ICSE answer: 'The storm is "portentous" rather than merely violent: Casca reads it as pointing at a particular "climate", Rome, and the audience, who know the date, reads it as pointing at the Ides.'

Common weak substitute: 'scary weather', 'bad weather'

Better word: 'portentous', 'ominous', 'a storm of signs'

Keyword: construe

Meaning: To interpret, to put a meaning upon. Cicero's word for how men read the world to suit themselves; Brutus has already used it earlier of his own behaviour.

Where it applies: Cicero's sceptical reply to Casca; and Brutus's apology to Cassius in Scene 2.

Textual evidence: "But men may construe things after their fashion, / Clean from the purpose of the things themselves." and "Nor construe any further my neglect"

Character/Theme: Cicero; scepticism; interpretation as a theme.

How to use it in an ICSE answer: 'Cicero's warning that men "construe things after their fashion" is the key to the whole scene, for within fifty lines Cassius will construe the same storm as a portrait of Caesar.'

Common weak substitute: 'understand', 'see'

Better word: 'construe', 'interpret', 'read into'

Keyword: thunder-stone

Meaning: A thunderbolt, imagined in Elizabethan belief as a stone hurled with the lightning. Cassius claims to have offered his bare chest to it.

Where it applies: Cassius's account of walking through the storm.

Textual evidence: "Have bared my bosom to the thunder-stone"

Character/Theme: Cassius; defiance; the performance of courage.

How to use it in an ICSE answer: 'Cassius's bared bosom before the "thunder-stone" is a theatrical self-presentation, courage staged for Casca's benefit, and it works: the frightened man is shamed into the conspiracy within the same scene.'

Common weak substitute: 'lightning'

Better word: 'the thunder-stone', 'the bolt of heaven'

Keyword: womanish

Meaning: Weak and submissive, in Cassius's gendered insult. LITERARY INTERPRETATION: Cassius equates manliness with resistance and submission with women; the play lets the equation stand unchallenged here, though Portia will complicate it in Act 2.

Where it applies: Cassius's complaint about present-day Romans.

Textual evidence: "our fathers' minds are dead, / And we are governed with our mothers' spirits. / Our yoke and sufferance show us womanish."

Character/Theme: Cassius; rhetoric of shame; Roman masculinity.

How to use it in an ICSE answer: 'Cassius's "womanish" is a rhetorical goad rather than a description: by making submission feminine he leaves Casca no way to stay neutral that does not also unman him.'

Common weak substitute: 'weak', 'cowardly'

Better word: 'womanish (Cassius's gendered insult)', 'unmanned', 'servile'

Keyword: yoke and sufferance

Meaning: The yoke is the wooden bar placed on oxen; 'sufferance' is patient endurance. Together: the burden Romans carry and their willingness to carry it.

Where it applies: The same line.

Textual evidence: "Our yoke and sufferance show us womanish."

Character/Theme: Cassius; bondage; the complicity of the governed.

How to use it in an ICSE answer: 'In "yoke and sufferance" Cassius blames not only the yoke but the suffering of it: tyranny, in his account, is a partnership between the man who imposes and the men who endure.'

Common weak substitute: 'oppression', 'putting up with it'

Better word: 'the yoke', 'servile endurance', 'consented subjection'

Keyword: bondage, bondman

Meaning: Slavery; a slave. Cassius's language in Scene 3 repeatedly casts Romans as slaves and the dagger as the key to freedom.

Where it applies: Cassius's response to the news that the senators mean to crown Caesar; Casca's echo; Cassius's wary aside.

Textual evidence: "Cassius from bondage will deliver Cassius." and "So every bondman in his own hand bears / The power to cancel his captivity." and "I perhaps speak this / Before a willing bondman"

Character/Theme: Cassius and Casca; liberty versus slavery; suicide as the last freedom.

How to use it in an ICSE answer: 'Cassius's "bondage" is a word of absolute politics: there is no middle condition between the free Roman and the "bondman", and so there is no middle course between killing Caesar and consenting to slavery.'

Common weak substitute: 'being controlled', 'not free'

Better word: 'bondage', 'servitude', 'enslavement'

Keyword: wolf, sheep

Meaning: Predator and prey. Cassius says Caesar would not be a wolf if the Romans were not sheep.

Where it applies: Cassius's answer to his own question about why Caesar should be a tyrant.

Textual evidence: "Poor man, I know he would not be a wolf / But that he sees the Romans are but sheep"

Character/Theme: Cassius; tyranny as a relationship; the people's responsibility.

How to use it in an ICSE answer: 'The wolf-and-sheep image is Cassius's theory of tyranny in one line: Caesar's appetite is created by Roman timidity, so the cure lies in the sheep, not the wolf.'

Common weak substitute: 'Caesar is like a predator'

Better word: 'the predator-prey image', 'the tyrant as wolf', 'the populace as sheep'

Keyword: hinds

Meaning: Female deer, timid and hunted; the word also meant farm servants, and both senses of weakness are active.

Where it applies: The same speech.

Textual evidence: "He were no lion, were not Romans hinds."

Character/Theme: Cassius; animal imagery; the degeneration of Rome.

How to use it in an ICSE answer: 'Cassius's "hinds" doubles the insult, for the word means both the deer that lions hunt and the servant who tends another man's fields; Romans are at once prey and peasantry.'

Common weak substitute: 'deer', 'weaklings'

Better word: 'hinds', 'timid prey', 'the hunted'

Keyword: offal

Meaning: Refuse, waste, the discarded parts of a butchered animal. Cassius's most violent word for Rome.

Where it applies: Cassius's outburst that Rome has become fuel for Caesar's fire.

Textual evidence: "What trash is Rome, / What rubbish, and what offal when it serves / For the base matter to illuminate / So vile a thing as Caesar!"

Character/Theme: Cassius; contempt; the paradox of a patriot who despises his city.

How to use it in an ICSE answer: 'When Cassius calls Rome "offal", the republican's love of his city has curdled into disgust, and Shakespeare lets us hear that the conspiracy is fuelled as much by contempt as by principle.'

Common weak substitute: 'rubbish', 'garbage'

Better word: 'offal', 'base matter', 'the refuse of a degraded Rome'

Keyword: factious

Meaning: Forming a faction, a party of resistance. Casca's word, as he commits himself.

Where it applies: Casca's pledge, with his hand.

Textual evidence: "Be factious for redress of all these griefs, / And I will set this foot of mine as far / As who goes farthest."

Character/Theme: Casca; conspiratorial politics; the conspiracy's self-description.

How to use it in an ICSE answer: 'Casca's "Be factious" is revealing in its honesty: he names the conspiracy as a faction, a party pursuing its own grievances, at the very moment Cassius is dressing it as the salvation of Rome.'

Common weak substitute: 'rebellious', 'start a group'

Better word: 'factious', 'form a faction', 'conspiratorial'

Keyword: redress

Meaning: Remedy, the setting-right of a wrong. Casca speaks of redress of griefs; the word gives the conspiracy the colour of legal grievance.

Where it applies: The same line.

Textual evidence: "Be factious for redress of all these griefs"

Character/Theme: Casca; the conspiracy's justification; grievance as motive.

How to use it in an ICSE answer: 'The conspirators' word for assassination is "redress", a term from the law courts; the vocabulary shows them translating murder into the language of remedy before a blow has been struck.'

Common weak substitute: 'fixing things', 'revenge'

Better word: 'redress', 'remedy of grievances', 'restitution'

Keyword: honourable-dangerous

Meaning: Cassius's compound: an enterprise at once honourable and dangerous. The hyphen fuses the two ideas so that neither can be separated from the other.

Where it applies: Cassius's revelation that others are already committed.

Textual evidence: "an enterprise / Of honourable-dangerous consequence"

Character/Theme: Cassius; the moral ambiguity of the conspiracy; honour as recruitment.

How to use it in an ICSE answer: 'Cassius's compound "honourable-dangerous" is the conspiracy's whole self-image in a hyphen: it offers Casca the honour as payment for the danger, and never asks whether the two are compatible.'

Common weak substitute: 'risky but good'

Better word: 'honourable-dangerous', 'a perilous honour', 'noble hazard'

Keyword: alchemy

Meaning: The medieval art of turning base metal into gold. Casca says Brutus's reputation will transform the conspirators' crime into virtue.

Where it applies: Casca's final speech of the act.

Textual evidence: "His countenance, like richest alchemy, / Will change to virtue and to worthiness."

Character/Theme: Brutus's reputation; appearance versus reality; the conspiracy's need for legitimacy.

How to use it in an ICSE answer: 'Casca's "alchemy" is a confession dressed as a compliment: what the conspirators do would "appear offence", and only Brutus's face can transmute it, which means they know it is base metal.'

Common weak substitute: 'make it look good'

Better word: 'alchemy', 'transmutation', 'the laundering of a crime through reputation'

Keyword: conceited

Meaning: Here, conceived or understood; expressed as a conceit (an idea). Not the modern sense of vain.

Where it applies: Cassius's reply to Casca's alchemy speech.

Textual evidence: "You have right well conceited."

Character/Theme: Cassius; the conspirators' shared understanding of Brutus's use.

How to use it in an ICSE answer: 'Cassius's approving "right well conceited" shows that the use of Brutus as a moral cover is not Casca's private cynicism but the conspiracy's agreed plan.'

Common weak substitute: 'vain', 'proud' (a misreading of the word)

Better word: 'conceived', 'understood', 'aptly expressed'

CROSS-REFERENCE Where these Type A words are taught in full

The words above are explained here only as tools for answers. For the full teaching of each passage see 'Act 1 Scene 1: The Street' (mechanical, tributaries, ordinary pitch), 'Act 1 Scene 2 (Part One)' (the mirror conceit, honour, Colossus), 'Act 1 Scene 2 (Part Two)' (Casca's report, honourable mettle), and 'Act 1 Scene 3: The Storm' (prodigies, bondage, wolf and sheep, alchemy). For the grammar of the hard words themselves, use 'Difficult Shakespearean English: The Act 1 Vocabulary System'. For how each quotation sits in a full answer, use 'The Act 1 Quotation Bank'.

Type B, Group One: The Politics of Rome

These are the terms that let you say what kind of state Rome is, what Caesar threatens to make it, and what the conspirators think they are defending. Several are HISTORICAL RECORD and must be used with their Roman meanings, not their modern ones.

Keyword: republicanism

Meaning: The belief that the state belongs to its citizens and must be governed by elected magistrates, shared power and law, never by one man. HISTORICAL RECORD: Rome's republic dated its birth from the expulsion of King Tarquin, traditionally 509 BC, and Romans held a deep cultural hatred of the title 'rex'.

Where it applies: The tribunes' resistance in Scene 1; Brutus's fear that the people "Choose Caesar for their king"; Cassius's appeal to the old Brutus.

Textual evidence: "There was a Brutus once that would have brooked / Th' eternal devil to keep his state in Rome / As easily as a king."

Character/Theme: Brutus; Flavius and Marullus; the ideological core of the conspiracy.

How to use it in an ICSE answer: 'Brutus's republicanism is inherited as well as reasoned: Cassius invokes the ancestor who expelled a king precisely because the name "Brutus" carries a political obligation.'

Common weak substitute: 'wanting democracy', 'being against Caesar'

Better word: 'republicanism', 'republican principle', 'the libertas of the res publica'

Keyword: tyranny

Meaning: Rule by one man above the law, exercised in his own interest. In Act 1 the word is used by Cassius and Casca of the Caesar they fear, not of the Caesar we see; the play keeps the question of whether Caesar is a tyrant open.

Where it applies: Cassius's storm speech and Casca's reply.

Textual evidence: "That part of tyranny that I do bear / I can shake off at pleasure." and "And why should Caesar be a tyrant, then?"

Character/Theme: Cassius; the conspiracy's justification; the gap between fear and fact.

How to use it in an ICSE answer: 'Cassius speaks of the "tyranny" he bears as a present fact, but Shakespeare shows us a Caesar who has refused a crown three times; the word is an anticipation disguised as a description.'

Common weak substitute: 'being a bad king', 'dictatorship' (used loosely)

Better word: 'tyranny', 'autocratic rule', 'arbitrary power'

Keyword: autocracy

Meaning: Government by a single ruler with unlimited authority. Useful as the neutral term where 'tyranny' would prejudge the question.

Where it applies: The crown-offering; the rumour that the senators will make Caesar king "In every place save here in Italy".

Textual evidence: "Indeed, they say the Senators tomorrow / Mean to establish Caesar as a king"

Character/Theme: Caesar; the drift of the state; political anxiety.

How to use it in an ICSE answer: 'Act 1 shows Rome sliding towards autocracy by rumour and ceremony rather than by decree, which is why the conspirators act on what "they say" the Senate will do.'

Common weak substitute: 'one-man rule' (acceptable), 'kingship' (too narrow)

Better word: 'autocracy', 'personal rule', 'monarchy in all but name'

Keyword: political legitimacy

Meaning: The recognised right to hold power. Marullus's objection to the triumph, the tribunes' silencing and Casca's 'alchemy' speech are all arguments about legitimacy: who has the right to rule, to celebrate, to resist.

Where it applies: Marullus's rebuke; Casca on Brutus's reputation.

Textual evidence: "Wherefore rejoice? What conquest brings he home?" and "that which would appear offence in us / His countenance, like richest alchemy, / Will change to virtue"

Character/Theme: The tribunes; the conspiracy; Brutus as a source of legitimacy.

How to use it in an ICSE answer: 'Both sides in Act 1 hunger for legitimacy: Caesar borrows it from ceremony and acclamation, while the conspirators plan to borrow it from Brutus's face.'

Common weak substitute: 'having the right', 'being allowed'

Better word: 'legitimacy', 'sanction', 'constitutional right'

Keyword: dictator

Meaning: HISTORICAL RECORD: an emergency Roman office, traditionally limited to six months. Caesar held it repeatedly and, in February 44 BC, was made dictator for life, breaking the limit. The play never uses the word in Act 1, so use it as historical background, not as Shakespeare's term.

Where it applies: Background to every reference to Caesar's "new honours".

Textual evidence: "I do believe that these applauses are / For some new honours that are heaped on Caesar."

Character/Theme: Caesar; the collapse of republican limits.

How to use it in an ICSE answer: 'Historically Caesar was already dictator for life when the Lupercal was held; Shakespeare omits the title and lets Brutus's vague "new honours" register the same unease.'

Common weak substitute: 'dictator' used in the modern sense of tyrant

Better word: 'dictator (in the Roman sense of an emergency magistrate)', 'perpetual dictator'

Keyword: tribune

Meaning: HISTORICAL RECORD: a tribune of the plebs was an elected officer whose person was sacrosanct and whose task was to protect the common people, with the power to veto legislation. Flavius and Marullus hold this office, which makes their contempt for the commoners a dramatic irony of its own.

Where it applies: Scene 1, and Casca's report that they "are put to silence".

Textual evidence: "Go, go, good countrymen, and for this fault / Assemble all the poor men of your sort"

Character/Theme: Flavius and Marullus; the people's protectors against the people.

How to use it in an ICSE answer: 'The irony of Scene 1 depends on knowing what a tribune was: the officers created to protect the plebeians spend the opening of the play scolding them, and are then themselves silenced by the man the plebeians cheer.'

Common weak substitute: 'officials', 'soldiers', 'guards'

Better word: 'tribunes of the plebs', 'the people's magistrates'

Keyword: plebeian

Meaning: HISTORICAL RECORD: a Roman citizen not of the old patrician families; by the late Republic plebeians could hold all offices, but the word kept its sense of the common mass. In the play, the commoners of Scene 1 and the crowd of Casca's report.

Where it applies: Scene 1; Casca's narrative; Casca's praise of Brutus's popularity.

Textual evidence: "O, he sits high in all the people's hearts"

Character/Theme: The crowd; public opinion; class.

How to use it in an ICSE answer: 'Shakespeare gives the plebeians prose and wit in Scene 1 and then lets Casca describe them as a stinking "rabblement" in Scene 2; the student's task is to notice that we see them twice, once directly and once through patrician eyes.'

Common weak substitute: 'the people', 'the public', 'commoners' (acceptable)

Better word: 'the plebeians', 'the populace', 'the commons'

Keyword: patrician

Meaning: HISTORICAL RECORD: a member of Rome's old aristocratic families. Brutus, Cassius, Casca and Caesar belong to the governing class; the conspiracy is an aristocratic affair.

Where it applies: Cassius's lament for "the breed of noble bloods"; the whole Scene 2 dialogue between men of rank.

Textual evidence: "Rome, thou hast lost the breed of noble bloods!"

Character/Theme: Cassius; class; the conspiracy as a quarrel within the elite.

How to use it in an ICSE answer: 'The conspiracy is a patrician project: Cassius's grievance is that one noble has risen above his peers, not that the plebeians are unfree, and his contempt for the "sheep" confirms it.'

Common weak substitute: 'rich people', 'nobles' (acceptable)

Better word: 'patrician', 'the senatorial class', 'the aristocracy'

Keyword: triumph

Meaning: HISTORICAL RECORD: a procession granted by the Senate to a victorious general, with captives, spoils and a laurel-crowned general in a chariot; a triumph for victory over fellow Romans was considered improper. Caesar's Spanish triumph of 45 BC celebrated the defeat of Pompey's sons.

Where it applies: The occasion of Scene 1.

Textual evidence: "we / make holiday to see Caesar and to rejoice in his / triumph" and "That comes in triumph over Pompey's blood?"

Character/Theme: Caesar; Marullus; ceremony and legitimacy.

How to use it in an ICSE answer: 'Marullus does not object to triumphs; he objects to this one, because a triumph over "Pompey's blood" parades Roman defeat as foreign conquest.'

Common weak substitute: 'victory parade', 'celebration'

Better word: 'triumph', 'the triumphal procession', 'a civil-war triumph'

Keyword: liberty

Meaning: Freedom from domination; for a Roman, the condition of being a citizen rather than a subject or slave. HISTORICAL RECORD: libertas was a core republican value.

Where it applies: Scene 1's "servile fearfulness"; Cassius's "born free as Caesar"; the bondage speeches of Scene 3.

Textual evidence: "I was born free as Caesar; so were you"

Character/Theme: Cassius; Brutus; the conspiracy's declared cause.

How to use it in an ICSE answer: 'Cassius defines liberty negatively, as not being "In awe of such a thing as I myself"; his liberty is equality with Caesar, which is why it is impossible to tell where his love of freedom ends and his envy begins.'

Common weak substitute: 'freedom' (acceptable), 'rights'

Better word: 'liberty', 'libertas', 'republican freedom'

Keyword: civic duty

Meaning: The obligation of a citizen to put the state before himself. Brutus's governing principle; the standard by which he says he will judge Cassius's proposal.

Where it applies: Brutus's "general good" speech.

Textual evidence: "If it be aught toward the general good, / Set honour in one eye and death i' th' other"

Character/Theme: Brutus; political idealism; the ethics of the conspiracy.

How to use it in an ICSE answer: 'Brutus frames the decision as civic duty from the first moment, and Cassius learns from this that the way to Brutus runs through Rome, not through Brutus's own interest.'

Common weak substitute: 'doing the right thing', 'patriotism' (close but vaguer)

Better word: 'civic duty', 'public obligation', 'service to the republic'

Keyword: dignitas

Meaning: HISTORICAL RECORD: the Roman concept of a nobleman's personal standing, the honour and rank he had earned and was entitled to defend; ancient sources, including Caesar's own account of the civil war, present him as fighting to protect his dignitas. In the play the word is not used, but the idea underlies

Cassius's humiliation at having to "bend his body".

Where it applies: Cassius's Tiber and fever anecdotes.

Textual evidence: "And this man / Is now become a god, and Cassius is / A wretched creature and must bend his body / If Caesar carelessly but nod on him."

Character/Theme: Cassius; resentment; the aristocratic code.

How to use it in an ICSE answer: 'Cassius's grievance is best described as wounded dignitas: not that Rome is oppressed, but that a man he once rescued now receives the bow that Cassius's rank should spare him.'

Common weak substitute: 'pride', 'ego'

Better word: 'dignitas', 'standing', 'aristocratic self-worth'

Keyword: authority

Meaning: The acknowledged power to command. Caesar's authority in Act 1 is shown as instantaneous obedience: he speaks and it is done.

Where it applies: Antony's reply to Caesar's instruction about Calpurnia.

Textual evidence: "When Caesar says 'Do this,' it is performed."

Character/Theme: Caesar; power; Antony's loyalty.

How to use it in an ICSE answer: 'Antony's "it is performed" defines Caesar's authority as the collapse of the gap between word and deed, and the whole conspiracy can be read as an attempt to reopen that gap.'

Common weak substitute: 'power' (acceptable but vaguer), 'control'

Better word: 'authority', 'command', 'the force of his word'

Type B, Group Two: Persuasion and the Crowd

Act 1 is a play about how minds are moved: Brutus's by Cassius, Casca's by Cassius, the crowd's by Caesar. These terms let you name the methods.

Keyword: manipulation

Meaning: Influencing someone by indirect, concealed or dishonest means so that they act as you wish while believing the choice is their own. The exact word for Cassius's method with Brutus.

Where it applies: The whole Brutus-Cassius dialogue; the forged letters.

Textual evidence: "I, your glass, / Will modestly discover to yourself / That of yourself which you yet know not of."

Character/Theme: Cassius; Brutus's vulnerability; appearance versus reality.

How to use it in an ICSE answer: 'Cassius's manipulation works by concealment of its own purpose: he never asks Brutus to do anything, only to see himself, and leaves Brutus to draw the conclusion that Cassius has arranged for him to draw.'

Common weak substitute: 'tricks', 'convinces', 'brainwashes'

Better word: 'manipulates', 'insinuates', 'works upon'

Keyword: rhetoric

Meaning: The art of persuasive speech: the use of questions, repetition, imagery and appeals to emotion to move an audience. Marullus, Cassius and Caesar are all rhetoricians in Act 1.

Where it applies: Marullus's rebuke (rhetorical questions and repeated "And do you now"); Cassius's weighing of names.

Textual evidence: "And do you now put on your best attire? / And do you now cull out a holiday? / And do you now strew flowers in his way"

Character/Theme: Marullus; Cassius; political rhetoric.

How to use it in an ICSE answer: 'Marullus's rhetoric builds through triple repetition of "And do you now", each question tightening the charge of ingratitude until the final line names the crime.'

Common weak substitute: 'speech', 'talking well'

Better word: 'rhetoric', 'oratory', 'rhetorical questioning'

Keyword: persuasion

Meaning: The open attempt to change someone's mind by argument. Distinguish it from manipulation: persuasion declares its goal; manipulation hides it. Cassius's storm speech to Casca is closer to open persuasion than his Scene 2 seduction of Brutus.

Where it applies: Cassius and Casca in Scene 3.

Textual evidence: "Now could I, Casca, name to thee a man / Most like this dreadful night"

Character/Theme: Cassius; Casca; political rhetoric.

How to use it in an ICSE answer: 'With Casca Cassius persuades; with Brutus he manipulates. The difference in method measures the difference in the men: Casca can be frightened into action, Brutus must be led to believe the action is his own.'

Common weak substitute: 'convincing'

Better word: 'persuasion', 'open argument', 'exhortation'

Keyword: populism

Meaning: Politics that claims to speak for 'the people' against an elite, and courts the crowd directly. Use with care: the term is modern. In Act 1 it describes the crown-offering as a bid for popular acclamation outside the Senate.

Where it applies: Casca's report of Caesar offering his throat to the crowd.

Textual evidence: "he plucked me ope his doublet and offered them his throat to cut"

Character/Theme: Caesar; public opinion; politics as theatre.

How to use it in an ICSE answer: 'Caesar's offer of his throat to the "common herd" is populist theatre: he seeks his sanction from the crowd's forgiveness rather than from the Senate's vote, and the conspirators understand the threat.'

Common weak substitute: 'showing off', 'being popular'

Better word: 'populist gesture', 'courting the crowd', 'direct appeal to the populace'

Keyword: public opinion

Meaning: What the mass of people think and will applaud. In Act 1 it is a force that every faction tries to read, shape or forge.

Where it applies: The shouts offstage in Scene 2; Cassius's letters "all tending to the great opinion / That Rome holds of his name".

Textual evidence: "Writings, all tending to the great opinion / That Rome holds of his name"

Character/Theme: Cassius; Brutus; the crowd.

How to use it in an ICSE answer: 'Public opinion in Act 1 is heard before it is seen: Brutus and Cassius interpret the offstage shouts, and Cassius then decides to manufacture an opinion of his own in "several hands".'

Common weak substitute: 'what people think'

Better word: 'public opinion', 'popular sentiment', 'the voice of Rome (real or forged)'

Keyword: demagoguery

Meaning: Winning power by appealing to the crowd's emotions and prejudices rather than its reason. In Act 1 the word fits Caesar's theatrical refusals and foreshadows Antony in Act 3.

Where it applies: Casca's report of the crown scene.

Textual evidence: "the rabblement hooted and clapped their chopped hands"

Character/Theme: Caesar; the crowd; the rhetoric of power.

How to use it in an ICSE answer: 'Casca's account shows a demagogue at work: Caesar reads the crowd's mood, refuses the crown when they cheer the refusal, and turns his own collapse into an appeal for pity.'

Common weak substitute: 'playing to the crowd' (acceptable), 'lying'

Better word: 'demagoguery', 'demagogic appeal', 'crowd-pleasing manipulation'

Keyword: fickleness

Meaning: Changeability of loyalty; the readiness to switch allegiance. The defining charge against the Roman crowd from Scene 1 onward.

Where it applies: Marullus's contrast of the people's love for Pompey with their cheers for Caesar.

Textual evidence: "Knew you not Pompey?" and "Pray to the gods to intermit the plague / That needs must light on this ingratitude."

Character/Theme: The plebeians; mob psychology; the instability of power built on applause.

How to use it in an ICSE answer: 'The crowd's fickleness is established in Scene 1 as a kind of original sin, and the play will return to it when the same populace is turned by Antony in Act 3.'

Common weak substitute: 'changing their minds', 'disloyal'

Better word: 'fickle', 'inconstant', 'mutable'

Keyword: conspiratorial politics

Meaning: Politics conducted secretly, by a faction, outside legitimate institutions. Scene 3's night-time meeting, the passwords, the letters and "Pompey's Porch" are its furniture.

Where it applies: The whole of Cassius's Scene 3 recruitment.

Textual evidence: "Who's there?" and "A Roman." and "And I do know by this they stay for me / In Pompey's Porch."

Character/Theme: Cassius, Casca, Cinna; secrecy; the conspiracy takes shape.

How to use it in an ICSE answer: 'The exchange "Who's there?" and "A Roman." marks the moment the play's politics go underground: men who should debate in the Senate now identify themselves by voice in a storm.'

Common weak substitute: 'plotting', 'secret plans'

Better word: 'conspiratorial politics', 'clandestine faction', 'the conspiracy's night-world'

Keyword: political anxiety

Meaning: The pervasive fear that the state is about to change, felt before anything has actually happened. Act 1 is saturated with it: the tribunes fear, Brutus fears, Casca fears, and even Caesar fears.

Where it applies: Brutus's reaction to the first shout; Caesar on Cassius.

Textual evidence: "What means this shouting? I do fear the people / Choose Caesar for their king."

Character/Theme: Brutus; the mood of the act; anticipation as a dramatic device.

How to use it in an ICSE answer: 'Act 1 dramatises political anxiety rather than political events: no crown is accepted, no blow is struck, but every character interprets the shouts, the storm and one another as signs of a change already under way.'

Common weak substitute: 'worry', 'tension'

Better word: 'political anxiety', 'foreboding', 'the fear of a change of state'

Type B, Group Three: Character and Mind

These terms describe motive and inner life. They are the words that lift a character answer from a list of adjectives to an account of a person.

Keyword: political idealism

Meaning: Acting from principle about how the state ought to be, rather than from interest or calculation. Brutus's defining quality, and (LITERARY INTERPRETATION) the source of his vulnerability.

Where it applies: Brutus's "general good" and "villager" speeches.

Textual evidence: "Brutus had rather be a villager / Than to repute himself a son of Rome / Under these hard conditions"

Character/Theme: Brutus; honour; the ethics of the conspiracy.

How to use it in an ICSE answer: 'Brutus's political idealism is genuine, but idealism is exactly what Cassius's forged letters are designed to feed: an idealist can be moved by an idea, and Cassius supplies the idea in writing.'

Common weak substitute: 'being noble', 'good intentions'

Better word: 'political idealism', 'principled commitment', 'devotion to the republic'

Keyword: political naïveté

Meaning: A failure to see how power and people actually work, often caused by assuming others share one's own honesty. In Act 1 Brutus's trust in Cassius, and his inability to see that he is being handled, are its first signs.

Where it applies: Brutus's reply to Cassius's seduction.

Textual evidence: "That you do love me, I am nothing jealous. / What you would work me to, I have some aim."

Character/Theme: Brutus; manipulation; dramatic irony.

How to use it in an ICSE answer: 'Brutus's "I am nothing jealous" is the sentence of a politically naive man: he half-sees what Cassius "would work" him to, yet never suspects that the working itself is dishonest.'

Common weak substitute: 'stupid', 'innocent', 'too trusting' (acceptable)

Better word: 'political naïveté', 'misplaced trust', 'an idealist's blindness to method'

Keyword: resentment

Meaning: Bitter indignation at being treated unfairly, nursed over time. The best single word for Cassius's motive in Scene 2, where personal injury keeps surfacing through political argument.

Where it applies: The Tiber and fever anecdotes.

Textual evidence: "'Tis true, this god did shake." and "As a sick girl."

Character/Theme: Cassius; envy; the private roots of public action.

How to use it in an ICSE answer: 'Cassius's resentment leaks through his politics: the man who claims to speak of "honour" cannot resist recalling that Caesar cried for drink "As a sick girl", a detail that serves no republican argument and every personal one.'

Common weak substitute: 'jealous', 'hates Caesar'

Better word: 'resentful', 'envious', 'aggrieved'

Keyword: ambition

Meaning: The desire for power and greatness beyond one's present station. In Act 1 'ambition' is what Caesar's enemies attribute to him; the text shows a man who refuses a crown and a reporter who thinks the refusal was reluctant.

Where it applies: Casca's report; Cassius's plan to glance at "Caesar's ambition" in the letters.

Textual evidence: "to my thinking, he would fain have had it" and "Caesar's ambition shall be glanced at"

Character/Theme: Caesar; Cassius; appearance versus reality.

How to use it in an ICSE answer: 'In Act 1 Caesar's ambition exists chiefly as other men's inference: Casca thinks he "would fain have had" the crown, and Cassius plans letters in which it "shall be glanced at", so that the charge is built from hints before it is ever proved.'

Common weak substitute: 'wanting to be king', 'greedy'

Better word: 'ambition', 'aspiration to monarchy', 'the hunger for sovereignty'

Keyword: honour (as an analytical term)

Meaning: Used analytically, honour is a code: the set of values by which a Roman noble measures himself and expects to be measured. Different characters mean different things by it, and your job is to say which.

Where it applies: Brutus (inner integrity); Cassius (standing and equality); Casca ("honourable-dangerous").

Textual evidence: "I know that virtue to be in you, Brutus, / As well as I do know your outward favour. / Well, honour is the subject of my story."

Character/Theme: Brutus; Cassius; the contested meaning of the play's central word.

How to use it in an ICSE answer: 'Honour in Act 1 is not one idea but a battleground: Brutus's honour is a private conscience, Cassius's a public rank, and the conspiracy is formed in the space where the two meanings are allowed to blur.'

Common weak substitute: 'respect', 'being honest'

Better word: 'the honour code', 'competing conceptions of honour'

Keyword: self-mythologising

Meaning: Constructing and performing a legendary version of oneself. Caesar speaks of 'Caesar' in the third person as though describing a public institution.

Where it applies: Caesar's speeches on the Soothsayer and on Cassius.

Textual evidence: "I rather tell thee what is to be feared / Than what I fear; for always I am Caesar."

Character/Theme: Caesar; public persona; hubris (with caution).

How to use it in an ICSE answer: 'Caesar's self-mythologising reaches its purest form in "for always I am Caesar", where the name has become a standard he must live up to, and the sentence that follows, admitting a deaf ear, shows the standard already failing.'

Common weak substitute: 'proud', 'arrogant', 'full of himself'

Better word: 'self-mythologising', 'assured of his authority', 'performing his own legend'

Keyword: public persona

Meaning: The self a figure presents to the world, as distinct from the private person. Caesar's persona is the invulnerable 'Caesar'; Casca's is the blunt cynic; Cassius's, in Scene 3, is the fearless Roman.

Where it applies: Caesar's return from the games; Casca's "tardy form".

Textual evidence: "Would he were fatter! But I fear him not."

Character/Theme: Caesar; Casca; appearance versus reality.

How to use it in an ICSE answer: 'Caesar's public persona requires him to say "I fear him not" immediately after describing exactly why Cassius should be feared; the persona overrides the perception.'

Common weak substitute: 'image', 'how he acts in public'

Better word: 'public persona', 'the performed self', 'the mask of office'

Keyword: private self

Meaning: The inner person beneath the persona: the body that shakes, the mind at war with itself, the grievance behind the principle. Act 1 repeatedly lets the private self show through.

Where it applies: Caesar's deaf ear; Brutus's "with himself at war"; Cassius's soliloquy.

Textual evidence: "Caesar doth bear me hard, but he loves Brutus."

Character/Theme: Caesar, Brutus, Cassius; appearance versus reality.

How to use it in an ICSE answer: 'Shakespeare gives Cassius the only soliloquy in Act 1, and in it the private self speaks plainly: "Caesar doth bear me hard" is a personal wound, confessed only when the stage is empty.'

Common weak substitute: 'his real feelings', 'inside'

Better word: 'private self', 'inner life', 'the man behind the name'

Keyword: hubris (use with caution)

Meaning: In Greek thought, overweening pride that offends the gods and invites downfall. CAUTION: the term belongs to Greek tragedy and religion. Julius Caesar is a Roman play built from Plutarch, and it never says that Caesar's death is a divine punishment. Use 'overconfidence' or 'self-mythologising' unless you define 'hubris' and show you know its origin.

Where it applies: Caesar's dismissal of the Soothsayer; "always I am Caesar".

Textual evidence: "He is a dreamer. Let us leave him. Pass."

Character/Theme: Caesar; fate; the limits of a classical label.

How to use it in an ICSE answer: 'Caesar's dismissal of the Soothsayer is often called hubris, but the Greek word imports a theology the play does not supply; it is more exact to say that Caesar's self-image as "Caesar" forbids him to be seen heeding a street prophet.'

Common weak substitute: 'arrogance' (vaguer but at least not anachronistic)

Better word: 'overconfidence', 'self-mythologising', 'the refusal to appear afraid'

Keyword: moral conflict

Meaning: A struggle between two things a person believes to be good or two duties he owes. Brutus's conflict is between love for Caesar and love for Rome.

Where it applies: Brutus's reply to Cassius's question about Caesar as king.

Textual evidence: "I would not, Cassius, yet I love him well."

Character/Theme: Brutus; friendship versus duty.

How to use it in an ICSE answer: 'Brutus's moral conflict is stated in a single line, "I would not, Cassius, yet I love him well", whose "yet" is the hinge on which the rest of the play turns.'

Common weak substitute: 'confused', 'torn' (acceptable), 'doesn't know what to do'

Better word: 'moral conflict', 'divided loyalty', 'a conflict of duties'

Keyword: ideological conflict

Meaning: A clash between systems of political belief, here between republicanism and the drift towards one-man rule. Distinguish it from Brutus's moral conflict, which is personal; the ideological conflict is between Rome's past and its possible future.

Where it applies: The tribunes against the holiday crowd; the "two Brutuses" (the ancestor and the descendant).

Textual evidence: "Now is it Rome indeed, and room enough / When there is in it but one only man."

Character/Theme: The whole act; republicanism versus autocracy.

How to use it in an ICSE answer: 'Cassius's pun on "Rome" and "room" states the ideological conflict as a matter of space: a republic has room for many men, an autocracy for one.'

Common weak substitute: 'disagreement', 'different opinions'

Better word: 'ideological conflict', 'a clash of political creeds', 'republic against monarchy'

Keyword: stoicism (Brutus, cautiously)

Meaning: The philosophy that the wise man governs his passions by reason and regards external fortune, including death, with calm. **HISTORICAL RECORD:** Brutus was the nephew by marriage of Cato the Younger, a famous Stoic-leaning Roman. **CAUTION:** Act 1 never names the philosophy, and in Act 5 Brutus's own remarks about suicide do not fit a simple Stoic label; say 'Stoic-leaning' or 'a temper many critics call Stoic'.

Where it applies: Brutus's willingness to look on honour and death "indifferently".

Textual evidence: "Set honour in one eye and death i' th' other / And I will look on both indifferently"

Character/Theme: Brutus; honour; self-command.

How to use it in an ICSE answer: 'Brutus's promise to look on honour and death "indifferently" has a Stoic colouring that many critics note, though Act 1 never names the school; the safer claim is that he values principle above survival.'

Common weak substitute: 'calm', 'brave', 'doesn't care about dying'

Better word: 'Stoic-leaning', 'self-governed', 'indifferent to fortune'

Keyword: epicureanism (Cassius, cautiously)

Meaning: The philosophy that the gods do not intervene in human affairs, so omens are meaningless. **HISTORICAL RECORD:** the historical Cassius was an Epicurean. **CAUTION:** Act 1 never names Epicurus, and in Scene 3 Cassius reads the storm as a sign, whether sincerely or as a tool to move Casca. In Act 5 he says he once held Epicurus's opinion strongly and now changes his mind. Use the term only to point out the gap between Cassius's reputation and his behaviour.

Where it applies: Cassius's reading of the storm as "instruments of fear and warning".

Textual evidence: "heaven hath infused them with these spirits / To make them instruments of fear and warning / Unto some monstrous state."

Character/Theme: Cassius; scepticism versus superstition; rhetoric.

How to use it in an ICSE answer: 'Whether Cassius believes the storm is a warning or merely uses it is left open; a student who knows his Epicurean reputation can argue that the omens are, for him, a rhetorical instrument rather than a conviction.'

Common weak substitute: 'not religious', 'doesn't believe in signs'

Better word: 'Epicurean (by reputation)', 'sceptical of omens', 'instrumental use of the supernatural'

Type B, Group Four: The Supernatural and the Reader's Toolkit

The last group holds the terms of dramatic technique and of the play's supernatural layer. Two carry cautions that examiners will respect you for knowing.

Keyword: dramatic irony

Meaning: The gap between what a character knows and what the audience knows. Because the audience knows that Caesar will die on the Ides of March, almost everything said about the future in Act 1 is charged with it.

Where it applies: The Soothsayer; Caesar on Cassius; Antony's "well given".

Textual evidence: "He thinks too much. Such men are dangerous." and "Fear him not, Caesar; he's not dangerous."

Character/Theme: Caesar; the Soothsayer; fate.

How to use it in an ICSE answer: 'The dramatic irony of Caesar's exchange with Antony is doubled: Caesar is right about Cassius and wrong to dismiss his own rightness, while Antony, who will later avenge him, is simply wrong.'

Common weak substitute: 'irony' (undefined), 'the audience knows'

Better word: 'dramatic irony', 'proleptic irony', 'the audience's foreknowledge'

Keyword: foreshadowing

Meaning: Hints that prepare for later events. In Act 1 the Soothsayer's warning, the storm, Cassius's "worse days", and Brutus's "with himself at war" all look ahead.

Where it applies: The end of Cassius's soliloquy; Scene 3's omens.

Textual evidence: "And after this, let Caesar seat him sure, / For we will shake him, or worse days endure."

Character/Theme: Structure; fate; the conspiracy's trajectory.

How to use it in an ICSE answer: 'Cassius's couplet foreshadows with a double edge: "we will shake him" anticipates the assassination, and "worse days endure" anticipates, without his knowing it, the civil war that follows it.'

Common weak substitute: 'hints at the future', 'shows what will happen'

Better word: 'foreshadows', 'anticipates', 'prefigures'

Keyword: supernatural imagery

Meaning: Language drawn from omens, spirits and divine anger. In Act 1 it is concentrated in Scene 3, but note that the supernatural is reported and interpreted, never shown directly on stage.

Where it applies: Casca's prodigies; Cassius's storm speech.

Textual evidence: "Either there is a civil strife in heaven, / Or else the world, too saucy with the gods, / Incenses them to send destruction."

Character/Theme: Casca; Cassius; the correspondence between heaven and state.

How to use it in an ICSE answer: 'Casca's supernatural imagery offers two readings of the storm, "civil strife in heaven" or divine anger at a "saucy" world, and both are political metaphors before they are religious ones.'

Common weak substitute: 'scary stuff', 'magic'

Better word: 'supernatural imagery', 'omen imagery', 'the language of portent'

Keyword: political symbolism

Meaning: Objects or gestures that stand for political meanings: the crown, the scarves on the statues, the triumph itself. Act 1's politics are conducted almost entirely through symbols.

Where it applies: The decorated images; the coronet; Caesar's bared throat.

Textual evidence: "yet 'twas not a crown neither; 'twas one of these coronets"

Character/Theme: Caesar; the tribunes; appearance versus reality.

How to use it in an ICSE answer: 'Casca's correction, "'twas not a crown neither; 'twas one of these coronets", is a lesson in political symbolism: the object matters less than what it is seen to mean, and Caesar's refusal is a performance with a symbol as its prop.'

Common weak substitute: 'things that represent'

Better word: 'political symbolism', 'emblem', 'the iconography of power'

Keyword: pathetic fallacy (use with caution)

Meaning: The attribution of human feelings to nature ('the angry sky'). CAUTION: the term was coined by John Ruskin in the nineteenth century and describes a habit of poetic description. The storm of Scene 3 is not nature sharing a character's mood; it is read by the characters as a portent, a sign of disorder in the state. Prefer 'omen', 'portent' or 'correspondence between nature and state'.

Where it applies: The storm, if at all.

Textual evidence: "the scolding winds / Have rived the knotty oaks"

Character/Theme: The storm; the limits of a critical term.

How to use it in an ICSE answer: 'Casca's "scolding winds" might tempt one to call the storm pathetic fallacy, but the characters do not treat the weather as feeling; they treat it as meaning, and the apt term is portent.'

Common weak substitute: 'the weather matches the mood'

Better word: 'portent', 'omen', 'the disordered macrocosm'

Keyword: correspondence between nature and state

Meaning: The Elizabethan belief that the natural world (the macrocosm) and the human body or the state (the microcosm) mirror one another, so disorder in one appears as disorder in the other. Many critics read the storm of Scene 3 through this belief.

Where it applies: Casca's prodigies; Cassius's comparison of Caesar to the night.

Textual evidence: "A man no mightier than thyself or me / In personal action, yet prodigious grown, / And fearful, as these strange eruptions are."

Character/Theme: The storm; Caesar; political disorder.

How to use it in an ICSE answer: 'Cassius exploits the correspondence between nature and state by making Caesar "Most like this dreadful night": if the heavens are disordered, then by Elizabethan logic the state must be, and Caesar is named as the disorder.'

Common weak substitute: 'the storm shows something bad will happen'

Better word: 'correspondence of macrocosm and microcosm', 'the disordered heavens as political sign'

Keyword: omen, portent, prodigy

Meaning: Three near-synonyms with different weights. An omen is any sign of the future; a portent is a sign that warns; a prodigy is an unnatural happening (a lion in the street, a hand that burns unscorched) that is itself the sign. Act 1 uses 'prodigies' and 'portentous'.

Where it applies: Scene 3 throughout; the Soothsayer in Scene 2.

Textual evidence: "It is the part of men to fear and tremble / When the most mighty gods by tokens send / Such dreadful heralds to astonish us."

Character/Theme: Casca; the Soothsayer; fate and superstition.

How to use it in an ICSE answer: 'Casca's "dreadful heralds" are prodigies read as portents: he moves from the events themselves to the warning they carry, and his fear is the proper Roman response that Cassius will shame him out of.'

Common weak substitute: 'signs', 'warnings'

Better word: 'omen', 'portent', 'prodigy' (choose the exact one)

Keyword: scepticism

Meaning: The refusal to accept a claim without good evidence, especially about the supernatural. Cicero is the act's sceptic; Caesar's "dreamer" is a sceptic's dismissal, though undercut by his earlier faith in the Lupercal ritual.

Where it applies: Cicero's reply to Casca.

Textual evidence: "Indeed, it is a strange-disposèd time. / But men may construe things after their fashion"

Character/Theme: Cicero; interpretation; the play's refusal to settle the question of fate.

How to use it in an ICSE answer: 'Cicero's scepticism is the play's own hedge: by letting one character warn that men "construe things after their fashion", Shakespeare keeps the storm's meaning open and makes every interpreter of it, Cassius included, a suspect.'

Common weak substitute: 'not believing', 'doubtful'

Better word: 'scepticism', 'rational caution', 'interpretive doubt'

Keyword: rationalism

Meaning: The habit of explaining events by natural causes and reason rather than by divine agency. In Act 1 it is the position Casca argues against ("These are their reasons, they are natural") and Cicero gently represents.

Where it applies: Casca's refusal of natural explanation; Cicero's reply.

Textual evidence: "let not men say / 'These are their reasons, they are natural,' / For I believe they are portentous things"

Character/Theme: Casca; Cicero; superstition against reason.

How to use it in an ICSE answer: 'Casca anticipates the rationalist objection in order to reject it, and the fact that Shakespeare gives the rationalist position a voice at all shows how carefully the play balances superstition against reason.'

Common weak substitute: 'being logical', 'scientific'

Better word: 'rationalism', 'naturalistic explanation', 'reasoned doubt'

WEAK WORD → STRONG WORD: The Conversion Table

EXAM-ORIENTED ADVICE. Read the left column and recognise yourself; then practise the right column until it is reflex. The third column tells you where in Act 1 the stronger word honestly fits.

Weak word students write	Stronger alternatives	Where it fits in Act 1	Sample phrase
jealous	resentful, envious, aggrieved	Cassius's Tiber and fever anecdotes	'Cassius's resentment at having to "bend his body" to a man he once rescued'
proud	self-mythologising, assured of his authority, overconfident	Caesar on the Soothsayer and on Cassius	'Caesar's self-mythologising "for always I am Caesar"'
tricks	manipulates, insinuates, works upon, flatters	Cassius with Brutus	'Cassius insinuates Brutus's hidden worth through the mirror conceit'
bad weather	portentous storm, prodigies, omens	Scene 3	'the portentous storm that Casca reads as a warning'
the people	the plebeians, the populace, the fickle crowd, the commons	Scene 1; Casca's report	'the fickle plebeians who once cheered Pompey'
says	asserts, concedes, insinuates, confesses, protests	Any speech	'Brutus concedes "yet I love him well"'
shows	reveals, exposes, betrays, dramatises	Any analysis	'the deaf ear betrays the man behind the myth'
good man	man of honour, principled, idealistic, high-minded	Brutus	'Brutus's idealistic devotion to "the general good"'
bad	tyrannical, illegitimate, base, cynical	Caesar (as the conspirators see him); Cassius	'Cassius's cynical plan to forge letters'
scared	apprehensive, fearful, filled with foreboding	Brutus at the shouts; Casca in the storm	'Brutus's apprehension that the people "Choose Caesar for their king"'
angry	indignant, aggrieved, incensed	Marullus; Cassius on Rome	'Marullus's indignation at the crowd's ingratitude'
wants to be king	aspires to monarchy, ambitious for the crown, courts sovereignty	Caesar, as inferred by others	'Caesar's inferred ambition for the crown he refuses'
plan to kill	conspiracy, assassination plot, tyrannicide (as they would call it)	Scene 3	'the conspiracy taking shape at "Pompey's Porch"'
friends (of the plot)	confederates, conspirators, allies, a faction	Casca's "factions"	'Casca pledges himself to the faction'
thinks a lot	reflective, introspective, brooding, self-divided	Brutus; Cassius ("He thinks too much")	'the brooding Cassius whom Caesar distrusts'
nice things	flattery, blandishments, appeals to vanity	Cassius with Brutus	'Cassius's flattery of Brutus's "hidden worthiness"'
makes him feel	plays upon, appeals to, exploits	Cassius with Brutus and Casca	'Cassius exploits Casca's fear of the heavens'
weird things	prodigies, unnatural signs, portents	Scene 3	'the prodigies Casca lists to Cicero'
the crowd changed sides	the crowd's fickleness, inconstancy, mutability	Scene 1	'the inconstancy of a populace that forgets Pompey'

Weak word students write	Stronger alternatives	Where it fits in Act 1	Sample phrase
it means that	it implies, suggests, signals, anticipates	Any analysis	'the hyphen in "honourable-dangerous" signals a fusion of motives'

ICSE EXAM BOX Do not force a keyword where it does not fit

EXAM-ORIENTED ADVICE. The vault is a set of precise tools, and a precise tool used in the wrong place does more harm than a blunt one. Three rules. First, a Type A word belongs only to the moment it comes from: do not describe the crowd in Scene 1 as a "rabblement", because that is Casca's word for a different crowd on a different occasion, and the examiner who knows the text will mark the confusion. Second, a Type B word must be earned by evidence in the same sentence: 'Cassius manipulates Brutus' is an assertion; 'Cassius manipulates Brutus by offering to be his "glass"' is an analysis. Third, the cautions in this chapter are not optional. Calling the storm 'pathetic fallacy', calling Caesar's death 'hubris' or labelling Brutus 'a Stoic' as if the play said so will be read as reaching for impressive words without understanding them, and in a Class X answer on Acts III to V that habit costs more marks than plain English would. If the only word you are sure of is the plain one, use the plain one and add the evidence. Vocabulary is scored as a sign of thought, never as a substitute for it.

REVISION How to drill the vault

Work through one group a day, covering the right-hand side of each entry and reconstructing it from the keyword alone: the meaning, one piece of verified evidence, the character or theme, and a sentence of your own in the style of the sample. Then reverse the drill: read the sample sentence and name the keyword it is built around. Finally, take any paragraph you wrote in Class IX about Act 1, underline every word in the left-hand column of the conversion table, and rewrite the paragraph with the right-hand column. The rewritten paragraph will be shorter, sharper and worth more. For the quotations themselves in longer form, pair this chapter with 'The Act 1 Quotation Bank'; for the devices the Type B terms often accompany (rhetorical question, metaphor, soliloquy), pair it with 'The Act 1 Literary-Device Bank'; for how an examiner actually awards the marks these words earn, read 'ICSE Examiner Mode: How Marks Are Earned'.

CHAPTER 15

The Act 1 Quotation Bank

What this chapter does: It gathers the thirty-two lines of Act 1 that carry the most analytical weight — from the Cobbler's puns to Casca's alchemy — and treats each one as a small lesson rather than a label to memorise. For every quotation you get the verified wording, who says it to whom and at what moment, a plain-English meaning, a deeper reading, the subtext underneath, what it reveals of character, theme and device, its roots in the Roman record, its connections across the play, the examination vocabulary it unlocks and a model sentence that embeds it. A quick-index table and a box on how to embed a quotation close the chapter, so that what you have learned can be carried straight into an answer.

How to Use This Bank

A quotation bank is not a list to be learned by heart and emptied onto the page. Examiners can tell at once when a student has memorised twenty lines and is hunting for somewhere to put them; the quotations arrive like guests at the wrong party. The purpose of this chapter is the opposite. Each entry is built so that you understand the line so thoroughly that you could never misuse it — you know what has just happened when it is spoken, what the speaker is really doing with it, and which argument it can carry.

Read the entries in order the first time, because they follow the act from the street to the storm, and the connections between them (Scene 1's "Pompey's blood" answered by Scene 2's tribunes "put to silence"; Scene 2's "I, your glass" answered by Scene 3's forged letters) only show themselves in sequence. On a second reading, use the Quick-Index at the end to pull out the lines you need for a particular theme or character.

Two honest notes before we begin. First, on the examination: Act 1 is the Class IX portion of the ICSE syllabus, and the Class X board paper examines Acts III–V. So the sentences offered under **Possible answer use:** are of two kinds — the sort you would write in a Class IX extract-based answer on Act 1 itself, and the sort you would write in a Class X answer on a later act, where an Act 1 line supplies the motive, the irony or the earlier context that lifts a reply from adequate to excellent. No question is guaranteed; what is guaranteed is that a student who understands these lines understands why the later acts happen. Second, on wording: every quotation below has been checked against the verified text. Where you see a label marked LITERARY INTERPRETATION, it is a reading I am defending, not a fact; where scholars disagree I say so.

CROSS-REFERENCE Where the raw material for this bank lives

The devices named here are defined and catalogued in 'The Act 1 Literary-Device Bank'. The examination terms listed under **ICSE keywords:** are explained with worked examples in 'The ICSE Keyword Vault for Act 1'. The scene-by-scene chapters ('Act 1 Scene 1 — The Street', 'Act 1 Scene 2 (Part One)', 'Act 1 Scene 2 (Part Two)', 'Act 1 Scene 3 — The Storm') walk through each line in its full setting; the character masterclasses on Caesar, Cassius and Brutus develop the character notes given briefly here; and 'The Scene Connection Engine and Where Act 1 Reappears Later' extends every **Scene connection:** into Acts 2–5. For how an examiner actually rewards an embedded quotation, see 'ICSE Examiner Mode: How Marks Are Earned'.

Scene 1 — The Street

1. "Hence! Home, you idle creatures" — Flavius clears the street

Exact quotation:

Flavius: *Hence! Home, you idle creatures, get you home! / Is this a holiday? What, know you not, / Being mechanical, you ought not walk / Upon a labouring day without the sign / Of your profession?*

Speaker: Flavius, a tribune of the people.

Listener: A crowd of commoners (the Carpenter and the Cobbler will answer for them).

Act/Scene: Act 1 Scene 1, the very first words of the play.

Context: Nothing has happened yet. The stage fills with working men in their best clothes, and two tribunes — officials whose whole purpose is to protect the common people — begin the play by ordering those very people off the street.

Simple meaning: 'Get out of here and go home, you lazy people. This is not a holiday. Do you not know that as tradesmen you are not allowed to walk about on a working day without wearing the tools or dress of your trade?'

Deep meaning: The play opens with a question of law and class. 'Mechanical' (a manual worker) is spat out as an insult; 'the sign of your profession' means the leather apron and rule that would mark these men as what they are. Flavius's objection is not merely that they are idle but that they are out of place — dressed above their station, celebrating a man he regards as a threat to the Republic. The first thing we see in Rome is an argument about who owns the public street.

Subtext: Underneath the bluster is fear. The tribunes will shortly reveal that they dread Caesar's rise; sending the crowd home is the only power they have left, and they exercise it on the people they are meant to serve. The scolding is displacement — anger at Caesar vented on cobblers.

Character: Flavius is decisive, contemptuous of the commons, and republican to the bone. He is also, in a sense the play will make bitter, brave: he acts against Caesar's popularity in the open and pays for it offstage.

Theme: Public opinion and the fickle crowd; class; the collapse of the republican bond between tribune and people.

Device: Imperative mood piled on imperative ("Hence!", "get you home!") creates urgency; the rhetorical question ("Is this a holiday?") shows contempt; opening a play in the middle of a quarrel (in medias res) throws the audience straight into unrest.

Historical connection: HISTORICAL RECORD — tribunes of the plebs were created to shield the plebeians from the aristocracy and were sacrosanct. Shakespeare inverts the office: his tribunes bully the plebs. The dating is compressed, too: the triumph being celebrated (October 45 BC) and the Lupercalia (15 February 44 BC) were months apart, but the play makes them one day.

Scene connection: The crowd Flavius drives away is the same crowd that will cheer Caesar's refusals of the crown in Scene 2 (as Casca reports) and, in Act 3, be swung by Antony's oration. Flavius's own fate is reported by Casca: he and Marullus "are put to silence".

ICSE keywords: in medias res; exposition; fickle mob; class conflict; republicanism; dramatic foreshadowing.

Possible answer use: 'From its very first line — "Hence! Home, you idle creatures, get you home!" — the play presents the Roman people as a crowd to be commanded, a view Antony will exploit far more skilfully than the tribunes in Act 3.'

2. "a mender of bad soles" — the Cobbler's first pun

Exact quotation:

Cobbler: *A trade, sir, that I hope I may use with a safe conscience, which is indeed, sir, a mender of bad soles.*

Speaker: The Cobbler (Folger's name; some editions call him the Second Commoner).

Listener: Marullus, who has demanded, "But what trade art thou? Answer me directly."

Act/Scene: Act 1 Scene 1, early, as the tribunes interrogate the crowd.

Context: Marullus has asked the Cobbler's trade and received a teasing non-answer ('in respect of a fine workman, I am but, as you would say, a cobbler' — where 'cobbler' also meant a bungler). Pressed to answer directly, the Cobbler produces this.

Simple meaning: 'My trade is one I can practise with a clear conscience: I mend worn-out shoe soles.' The joke is that 'soles' sounds like 'souls', so he also claims to be a mender of bad souls — a kind of priest.

Deep meaning: The pun is a small act of rebellion. The Cobbler cannot defy a tribune openly, so he plays with language until the tribune cannot pin him down. 'Safe conscience' is barbed: the man who mends souls is implying that the tribunes, who are about to scold their own people, might need mending. The exchange that follows deepens the joke — "Nay, I beseech you, sir, be not out with me. / Yet if you be out, sir, I can mend you." — where 'out' means both 'angry' and 'out at the toes'.

Subtext: The commoners are cleverer than their rulers think. The tribunes speak in verse and expect obedience; the Cobbler speaks in prose and runs rings round them. Shakespeare is quietly refusing the idea that the people are mere "blocks" and "stones".

Character: The Cobbler is witty, self-possessed, and politically shallow — he will say in a moment that they are out simply "to see Caesar and to rejoice in his triumph". Quick with words, unreflective about power: that combination is the Roman crowd in miniature.

Theme: Appearance versus reality (what a 'trade' is); the gap between the rulers' contempt and the people's intelligence; mob psychology.

Device: Pun (soles/souls; out/out); prose for the commoners against the tribunes' verse; comic relief that is also exposition.

Historical connection: HISTORICAL RECORD — the scene is Shakespeare's invention in detail; Plutarch gives no cobbler. The humour is Elizabethan rather than Roman: London apprentices and artisans would have recognised the type. LITERARY INTERPRETATION — many critics think the mingling of a Roman street with a London one is deliberate, inviting the 1599 audience to see itself in the crowd.

Scene connection: The Cobbler's gift for turning words links him, oddly, to Cassius, who will "conjure with" the names Brutus and Caesar later in the act; both treat language as a tool rather than a mirror of truth. The scene's pattern — commoners won over by whoever speaks to them — is repeated with the Plebeians in Act 3.

ICSE keywords: pun; wordplay; comic relief; prose versus verse; social hierarchy.

Possible answer use: 'The Cobbler's claim to be "a mender of bad soles" is more than a joke: the pun on "souls" lets a commoner mock the tribunes' moral authority while appearing to answer them politely.'

3. "a surgeon to old shoes" — the Cobbler's boast

Exact quotation:

Cobbler: *Truly, sir, all that I live by is with the awl. I meddle with no tradesman's matters nor women's matters, but withal I am indeed, sir, a surgeon to old shoes: when they are in great danger, I recover them. As proper men as ever trod upon neat's leather have gone upon my handiwork.*

Speaker: The Cobbler.

Listener: Flavius, who has just asked, "Thou art a cobbler, art thou?"

Act/Scene: Act 1 Scene 1, the climax of the comic exchange, just before the tribunes learn why the crowd is out.

Context: Having been accused of being a 'naughty knave' and asked his trade for the fourth time, the Cobbler finally confesses it — and then dresses it up grandly.

Simple meaning: 'All I earn, I earn with my awl (the pointed tool for piercing leather). I do not interfere in other men's trades or other men's wives; all the same I am a surgeon to worn-out shoes — when they are in danger of dying I bring them back to life. Some of the finest men who ever walked in cowhide have walked on shoes I mended.'

Deep meaning: Every phrase has two edges. 'With the awl' sounds like 'withal' (nevertheless), and he promptly uses 'withal' in the next clause, so the ear hears the same sound twice with two meanings. 'Recover' means both 'cure' and 're-cover' (put a new sole on). 'Neat's leather' is cowhide; 'proper men' are handsome, worthy men. The Cobbler inflates a humble trade into medicine, and in doing so gently satirises every grand man who inflates himself — in a play about one man who has "grown so great".

Subtext: The claim to 'meddle' in nobody's matters is the Cobbler's defence against the tribunes' real charge, which is political: that the people are meddling in Rome's affairs by celebrating Caesar. He is saying, in effect, 'I am only a shoemaker; politics is not my business' — which is precisely the attitude that lets a Caesar rise.

Character: Shrewd, proud of his craft, apolitical by choice. He represents the citizen who would rather be entertained than govern.

Theme: Public opinion; the people's abdication of political responsibility; appearance versus reality.

Device: Extended pun (awl/withal, recover/re-cover); mock-heroic inflation ('surgeon'); prose; irony (the man who 'meddles' with nothing is part of the crowd meddling with the Republic's future).

Historical connection: HISTORICAL RECORD — nothing in Plutarch; the whole exchange is Shakespeare's dramatic invention, built on London humour. The underlying historical reality it dramatises is sound: Caesar's popularity with the urban poor was real and was one reason the senatorial class feared him.

Scene connection: The Cobbler's 'surgeon' who 'recovers' things in 'great danger' foreshadows, with grim comedy, the conspirators who will call themselves healers of a sick Rome in Act 2 and Act 3; the question of who is a surgeon and who is a butcher is one Brutus himself raises later in the play.

ICSE keywords: pun; mock-heroic; irony; comic relief; characterisation of the commoners.

Possible answer use: 'When the Cobbler calls himself "a surgeon to old shoes", Shakespeare lets the lowest character in the play rehearse, comically, the claim the conspirators will make seriously — that they are healers of a diseased Rome.'

4. "You blocks, you stones, you worse than senseless things!" — Marullus's rebuke

Exact quotation:

Marullus: *Wherefore rejoice? What conquest brings he home? / What tributaries follow him to Rome / To grace in captive bonds his chariot wheels? / You blocks, you stones, you worse than senseless things! / O you hard hearts, you cruel men of Rome, / Knew you not Pompey?*

Speaker: Marullus, the second tribune.

Listener: The commoners, chiefly the Cobbler, who has just said they are out "to rejoice in his triumph".

Act/Scene: Act 1 Scene 1, the turning point of the scene, where comedy gives way to passion.

Context: The Cobbler has explained, innocently, that the holiday is to see Caesar's triumph. The word 'triumph' detonates. Marullus, loyal to the dead Pompey, erupts into the first great speech of the play.

Simple meaning: 'Why are you rejoicing? What conquest has he brought home? Which conquered foreign rulers follow him to Rome, chained, to decorate his chariot? You are blocks of wood, lumps of stone, worse than things without feeling! You hard-hearted, cruel Romans — did you not know Pompey?'

Deep meaning: A Roman triumph was granted for victory over a foreign enemy, and its spectacle included captive kings in chains. Caesar's 'triumph' here celebrates Munda, a victory over Pompey's sons — over Romans. Marullus's three questions expose the hollowness: there are no "tributaries" (subject peoples paying tribute) because the defeated were fellow citizens. The insult 'worse than senseless things' says the crowd is below stone: stone at least cannot be expected to remember, but these men can, and will not.

Subtext: The anger is also grief. 'Knew you not Pompey?' is a bereaved man's question — how can you have forgotten him so quickly? There is fear too: a people with no memory can be led anywhere.

Character: Marullus is passionate, loyal, eloquent and politically doomed — he mistakes rhetoric for power, as the conspirators will later mistake a killing for a cure.

Theme: The fickleness of the crowd; loyalty and betrayal (to Pompey); the civil war beneath the festival; political rhetoric.

Device: Rhetorical questions in a rising series (tricolon); apostrophe and direct address ("O you hard hearts"); metaphor ("blocks", "stones"); alliteration on hard consonants that makes the contempt audible.

Historical connection: HISTORICAL RECORD — Caesar's Spanish triumph (October 45 BC) was indeed resented because it celebrated the defeat of Romans; Plutarch records that people thought it unfitting. Pompey had been enormously popular and had celebrated three triumphs of his own.

Scene connection: The crowd's amnesia here prepares us for the Plebeians of Act 3 who turn from Brutus to Antony within minutes; Marullus's method — scolding the people — is the one Antony will pointedly refuse, flattering them instead.

ICSE keywords: rhetorical question; apostrophe; tricolon; fickleness; triumph; loyalty.

Possible answer use: 'Marullus's "You blocks, you stones, you worse than senseless things!" establishes in the first scene the view of the crowd that the whole play tests: a people without memory, who will later be as easily swung by Antony as they were by Caesar's procession.'

5. "That Tiber trembled underneath her banks" — the memory of Pompey

Exact quotation:

Marullus: *Have you not made an universal shout, / That Tiber trembled underneath her banks / To hear the replication of your sounds / Made in her concave shores?*

Speaker: Marullus.

Listener: The commoners.

Act/Scene: Act 1 Scene 1, in the middle of the great rebuke, just after "Knew you not Pompey?"

Context: Marullus reminds the crowd how they used to wait all day — on "walls and battlements", "chimney tops", "Your infants in your arms" — to watch "great Pompey pass the streets of Rome". This is the climax of that memory.

Simple meaning: 'Did you not raise such a united shout that the river Tiber shook beneath its banks when it heard your cheering echoed back from its curved shores?'

Deep meaning: The image makes the crowd's voice a natural force, so loud it moves a river. 'Replication' means echo; 'concave shores' are the hollowed, curving riverbanks that throw the sound back. Marullus's point is double-edged: he praises the crowd's old devotion to Pompey, but in doing so he describes exactly the kind of mass emotion that is now being poured out for Caesar. The shout that once shook the Tiber for Pompey is the same shout we will hear, three times, offstage in Scene 2.

Subtext: Marullus thinks he is describing loyalty; he is actually describing the raw power of the mob, which has no fixed object. Whoever is in the chariot gets the shout.

Character: A man living in the past — a Pompeian in Caesar's Rome, whose eloquence is nostalgic rather than practical.

Theme: Public opinion and mob psychology; the transfer of loyalty; memory and forgetting.

Device: Hyperbole and personification (the river "trembled"); auditory imagery; the river as a recurring Roman symbol.

Historical connection: HISTORICAL RECORD — Pompey's triumphs (79, 71 and 61 BC) were among the most spectacular Rome had seen; his popularity was real. LITERARY INTERPRETATION — the personified Tiber recalls Marullus's own civic ideal: Rome as a living body that feels what its citizens do.

Scene connection: The Tiber returns almost at once, in Scene 2, as the "angry flood" into which Cassius and Caesar leap — a river that in Scene 1 echoed the people's love and in Scene 2 nearly drowns their idol. Flavius will send the commoners to "weep your tears / Into the channel" of the same river.

ICSE keywords: personification; hyperbole; auditory imagery; symbol; fickle crowd.

Possible answer use: 'The shout that once made "Tiber trembled underneath her banks" for Pompey is the shout that greets Caesar offstage in Scene 2: Shakespeare lets the same sound serve two masters, and so shows us that the crowd's loyalty belongs to no one.'

6. "That comes in triumph over Pompey's blood" — the charge of ingratitude

Exact quotation:

Marullus: *And do you now put on your best attire? / And do you now cull out a holiday? / And do you now strew flowers in his way / That comes in triumph over Pompey's blood? / Be gone!*

Speaker: Marullus.

Listener: The commoners.

Act/Scene: Act 1 Scene 1, the end of the rebuke, immediately followed by the order to pray that the gods "intermit the plague / That needs must light on this ingratitude".

Context: Having recalled the crowd's love for Pompey, Marullus turns on their present behaviour.

Simple meaning: 'And now you dress in your finest, now you pick out a holiday, now you scatter flowers in the path of a man who returns in triumph having shed Pompey's blood? Go away!'

Deep meaning: 'Pompey's blood' means both Pompey's family (his sons, defeated at Munda) and the literal blood of the civil war. The anaphora — 'And do you now' three times — hammers the word 'now' against the 'then' of the remembered devotion. The flowers strewn for Caesar are, in Marullus's eyes, laid on Pompey's grave as an insult. His closing instruction to 'pray to the gods to intermit the plague' makes ingratitude a sin that heaven itself will punish — an idea the storm of Scene 3 will seem to confirm.

Subtext: Marullus cannot stop the triumph; he can only shame its spectators. The speech is magnificent and futile, and its futility is the point: words alone do not restore a Republic.

Character: Principled and rash. He pays for this speech with his office and, Casca implies, perhaps more.

Theme: Ingratitude; betrayal; the moral reading of politics (ingratitude brings "plague"); the fall of Pompey as the shadow over Caesar's rise.

Device: Anaphora ("And do you now..." repeated); rhetorical questions; metonymy ("Pompey's blood" for his family and cause); juxtaposition of festival imagery (flowers, "best attire") with blood.

Historical connection: HISTORICAL RECORD — Munda (17 March 45 BC) saw Caesar defeat Pompey's sons Gnaeus and Sextus; Gnaeus was killed. Pompey himself had been murdered in Egypt in 48 BC. A triumph over fellow Romans was regarded as improper, which is exactly Marullus's complaint.

Scene connection: 'Pompey's blood' is the first blood in a play that will fill with it; the conspirators meet at "Pompey's Porch" in Scene 3, and the assassination itself, in Act 3, takes place in the shadow of Pompey's statue. The ingratitude Marullus condemns in the crowd is the ingratitude Antony will later accuse the conspirators of.

ICSE keywords: anaphora; metonymy; ingratitude; juxtaposition; foreshadowing.

Possible answer use: 'Marullus's accusation that the people "strew flowers in his way / That comes in triumph over Pompey's blood" plants the Pompeian grievance that Cassius will exploit and that will literally frame the murder in Act 3.'

7. "These growing feathers plucked from Caesar's wing" — Flavius's plan

Exact quotation:

Flavius: *These growing feathers plucked from Caesar's wing / Will make him fly an ordinary pitch, / Who else would soar above the view of men / And keep us all in servile fearfulness.*

Speaker: Flavius.

Listener: Marullus (the crowd has left).

Act/Scene: Act 1 Scene 1, the closing lines of the scene.

Context: The commoners have slunk off — Flavius notes with satisfaction, "They vanish tongue-tied in their guiltiness." He now tells Marullus to go towards the Capitol and strip Caesar's statues: "Disrobe the images / If you do find them decked with ceremonies." Marullus hesitates because "it is the feast of Lupercal"; Flavius overrules him — "Let no images / Be hung with Caesar's trophies" — and explains why.

Simple meaning: 'If we pluck these new feathers (his decorations and his supporters) from Caesar's wing, he will fly only at an ordinary height; otherwise he would soar out of sight of ordinary men and keep us all in frightened slavery.'

Deep meaning: The metaphor is from falconry: 'pitch' is the height to which a hawk climbs before it stoops on its prey. Caesar is a bird of prey still growing its flight feathers; the tribunes hope to clip it in time. The image concedes a great deal — Caesar is already airborne, already above the "view of men" — and offers a pitifully small remedy: tearing scarves off statues. 'Servile fearfulness' is the first naming of the play's central dread, the fear of Romans becoming slaves.

Subtext: Flavius knows the crowd is the real feather, and the crowd has only been shooed, not changed. His confidence is whistling in the dark.

Character: Flavius is the practical tribune, Marullus the emotional one. He makes a plan, however inadequate, and takes a risk for it.

Theme: Power and the fear of tyranny; liberty versus slavery ("servile"); the republican instinct to cut down whoever grows too tall.

Device: Extended metaphor from falconry; symbolic action (disrobing the images); couplet-like finality closing the scene.

Historical connection: HISTORICAL RECORD — the tribunes Marullus and Flavius did remove a diadem from Caesar's statue and arrest men who hailed him as king; Caesar had them deposed. Shakespeare moves the incident on to the day of the triumph and the Lupercalia. The 'images' are statues hung with decorations in Caesar's honour.

Scene connection: The feathers are plucked and the pluckers are punished: Casca will report that the two tribunes "are put to silence". Cassius's whole project in Scenes 2 and 3 is Flavius's project carried to its logical end — not plucking feathers, but killing the bird. Caesar as something that soars above men becomes Cassius's "Colossus" that bestrides the world.

ICSE keywords: extended metaphor; falconry imagery; tyranny; liberty; foreshadowing; symbolic action.

Possible answer use: 'Flavius's hope that "These growing feathers plucked from Caesar's wing / Will make him fly an ordinary pitch" is the Republic's first, failed attempt to cut Caesar down to size; Cassius's conspiracy is the same impulse armed with daggers.'

Scene 2 — Lupercalia, the Soothsayer and the Seduction of Brutus

8. "When Caesar says 'Do this,' it is performed" — Antony's obedience

Exact quotation:

Antony: *I shall remember. / When Caesar says 'Do this,' it is performed.*

Speaker: Antony, stripped for the Lupercal race.

Listener: Caesar, in front of the whole procession.

Act/Scene: Act 1 Scene 2, the opening ceremony, before the Soothsayer speaks.

Context: Caesar has told Calpurnia to stand in Antony's path and instructed Antony, "Forget not in your speed, Antonius, / To touch Calpurnia, for our elders say / The barren, touchèd in this holy chase, / Shake off their sterile curse." Antony replies with this.

Simple meaning: 'I will remember. Whatever Caesar orders is as good as done.'

Deep meaning: Antony's one line in the ceremony is a public creed of loyalty. It is also a statement about Caesar's power: his word is already an act. 'Performed' is a theatrical word, and the whole opening is a performance — Caesar directing his wife, his consul and the festival itself. The request that prompts it reveals Caesar's superstition and his private wound (he has no heir), so Antony's smooth obedience also covers an embarrassment.

Subtext: LITERARY INTERPRETATION — Antony is the courtier the tribunes feared: a man who makes Caesar's will seamless. Yet the line also quietly seeds the Antony of Act 3, whose devotion to Caesar is real and will turn into something far more dangerous than obedience.

Character: Loyal, graceful, apparently uncomplicated — which is why the conspirators underrate him. Caesar's "He loves no plays, / As thou dost, Antony" later confirms the pleasure-lover's image.

Theme: Loyalty; power as command; superstition (the fertility rite).

Device: Antithesis of word and deed ('says... performed'); dramatic irony (Antony's obedience will outlive Caesar); the ceremony as spectacle.

Historical connection: HISTORICAL RECORD — at the Lupercalia (15 February) the Luperci ran through the city striking bystanders with goat-hide thongs to promote fertility; Antony, consul in 44 BC, ran as a Lupercus. Caesar and Calpurnia were childless.

Scene connection: The man who performs Caesar's word here will, in Scene 2's reported crown-offering, perform it again — Casca says "Why, Antony" offered the coronet. In Act 3 he will perform something Caesar never commanded.

ICSE keywords: loyalty; dramatic irony; characterisation; superstition; antithesis.

Possible answer use: 'Antony's "When Caesar says 'Do this,' it is performed" seems in Act 1 the motto of a mere follower; by Act 3 it has become a vow, and the conspirators' failure to take it seriously destroys them.'

9. "Beware the ides of March" — the Soothsayer and Caesar's dismissal

Exact quotation:

Soothsayer: *Beware the ides of March.* **Caesar:** *He is a dreamer. Let us leave him. Pass.*

Speaker: The Soothsayer; then Caesar.

Listener: Caesar, with Brutus, Cassius, Casca and the whole train watching.

Act/Scene: Act 1 Scene 2, just after the Lupercal procession is set in motion.

Context: A voice calls "Caesar" from the crowd — "a tongue shriller than all the music". Caesar demands "Set him before me. Let me see his face." Brutus relays the warning ("A soothsayer bids you beware the ides of March"), Cassius brings the man forward, Caesar hears it a second time, and dismisses him.

Simple meaning: 'Be on your guard on the fifteenth of March.' And Caesar's reply: 'He is a fantasist. Leave him. Move on.'

Deep meaning: The warning is the play's central prophecy and its plainest. Caesar's response shows the two sides of him in four words apiece: he is curious enough to stop a festival and look the man in the face, and proud enough to wave the warning away. 'Dreamer' means one who deals in idle fancies; the irony is that the Soothsayer is the one character in Act 1 who sees clearly.

Subtext: Caesar is performing fearlessness before an audience. Having summoned the man publicly, he cannot now be seen to heed him. The dismissal is about image, not belief — which is why, in Act 2, Calpurnia's dream will nearly keep him at home.

Character: The Soothsayer: anonymous, unrewarded, right. Caesar: imperious, curious, trapped by his own public self.

Theme: Fate and free will; omens and superstition; appearance versus reality; pride.

Device: Prophecy; dramatic irony (the audience knows the date); contrast between the shrill single voice and the "music" of the procession; the monosyllabic command "Pass."

Historical connection: HISTORICAL RECORD — Plutarch and Suetonius name the seer Spurinna, who warned Caesar of danger coming no later than the Ides. In the Roman calendar the Ides fell on the fifteenth of March, May, July and October. Caesar was killed on 15 March 44 BC.

Scene connection: The warning is repeated by the Soothsayer in Act 2 and Act 3, and Caesar will mock him on the morning of the murder. Here it also silently marks Brutus — he is the one who repeats the words aloud, an unknowing herald of his own deed.

ICSE keywords: prophecy; dramatic irony; foreshadowing; hubris; fate versus free will.

Possible answer use: 'In Act 1 Caesar hears "Beware the ides of March" and answers "He is a dreamer"; the Class X extracts on the assassination gain their full irony only when this early dismissal is remembered.'

10. "poor Brutus, with himself at war" — Brutus admits his trouble

Exact quotation:

Brutus: *Nor construe any further my neglect / Than that poor Brutus, with himself at war, / Forgets the shows of love to other men.*

Speaker: Brutus.

Listener: Cassius, alone with him after the procession has gone.

Act/Scene: Act 1 Scene 2, the first exchange of the long Brutus–Cassius dialogue.

Context: Brutus has declined to watch the race — "I am not gamesome. I do lack some part / Of that quick spirit that is in Antony." Cassius complains that Brutus has lately lost "that gentleness / And show of love" he used to show. Brutus explains that the trouble is internal: he is "Vexèd" with "passions of some difference".

Simple meaning: 'Do not read any more into my coldness than this: poor Brutus is fighting a battle inside himself, and has forgotten to show his friends the affection he feels.'

Deep meaning: Brutus names the condition of the whole play: civil war begins inside one man. 'Construe' (interpret) is a word Cicero will use of the storm, and it fits — Brutus is a text that others will read for their own ends. His speaking of himself in the third person ('poor Brutus') shows a man already standing outside himself, judging. The phrase 'shows of love' concedes that love has an outward performance which he has let slip; the inner feeling, he insists, is intact.

Subtext: Brutus is telling Cassius, without meaning to, exactly what Cassius needs to know: that he is divided, and about matters of 'some difference' — political matters, we infer. A man at war with himself is a man waiting for an ally to take one side.

Character: Introspective, honest, troubled, self-dramatising in a gentle way. The soldier's metaphor ('at war') is natural to him.

Theme: Inner conflict; honour versus love; appearance versus reality (the 'shows' of love).

Device: Metaphor (the mind as a battlefield); third-person self-reference; understatement; the word 'construe' as a thematic key.

Historical connection: HISTORICAL RECORD — Plutarch describes Brutus as thoughtful and reserved; his Stoic-leaning family (he was Cato's nephew) prized self-command, which is what Brutus here admits is failing. Caesar had pardoned him after Pharsalus and promoted him, which gives his unease a real foundation.

Scene connection: The inner war declared here becomes the soliloquy of Act 2 and, at the last, the sword at Philippi. Cassius seizes on it immediately: his next move is the mirror speech.

ICSE keywords: inner conflict; third-person self-reference; metaphor; introspection; tragic hero.

Possible answer use: 'Brutus's confession that he is "with himself at war" is the moment the conspiracy becomes possible; Cassius needs only to supply the enemy that Brutus's divided mind is looking for.'

11. "I, your glass" — Cassius offers to be Brutus's mirror

Exact quotation:

Cassius: *And since you know you cannot see yourself / So well as by reflection, I, your glass, / Will modestly discover to yourself / That of yourself which you yet know not of.*

Speaker: Cassius.

Listener: Brutus.

Act/Scene: Act 1 Scene 2, soon after Brutus admits his inner war.

Context: Cassius has asked, "Tell me, good Brutus, can you see your face?" and Brutus has answered that "the eye sees not itself / But by reflection, by some other things." Cassius laments that Brutus has no mirror to show him his "hidden worthiness" and claims that many of the best men in Rome wish "that noble Brutus had

his eyes". Brutus asks, warily, "Into what dangers would you lead me, Cassius". Cassius presses on.

Simple meaning: 'Since you agree that you can only see yourself in a reflection, I will be your mirror and modestly reveal to you the part of yourself you do not yet know.'

Deep meaning: This is the manipulator's charter. A mirror claims to add nothing; it only shows what is there. By calling himself a 'glass', Cassius disguises persuasion as revelation — whatever he says about Brutus will seem to come from Brutus. 'Modestly' is wonderfully dishonest: a mirror cannot be modest, and Cassius is about to flatter. The idea that the eye "sees not itself" is a philosophical commonplace which Cassius turns into a weapon.

Subtext: Cassius has heard the word 'war' and is now choosing Brutus's side for him. He will end the speech by insisting that he is no flatterer — "then hold me dangerous" — which is exactly what a flatterer would say.

Character: Cassius: subtle, patient, intellectually agile, dishonest in method even where sincere in grievance. Brutus: alert to danger but unable to refuse an appeal to his own virtue.

Theme: Manipulation; appearance versus reality (reflection, image); self-knowledge; friendship used as a tool.

Device: Extended metaphor of the mirror; irony ('modestly'); the pattern of question and answer that makes Brutus seem to lead the conversation he is being led through.

Historical connection: HISTORICAL RECORD — Plutarch reports that friends and anonymous messages urged Brutus to live up to his ancestor's name; Shakespeare gives that whole chorus of voices to one man and a bundle of forged letters. LITERARY INTERPRETATION — the mirror image also belongs to Renaissance thinking about counsel: a good adviser was supposed to be a 'glass' showing a prince his faults. Cassius borrows the honest adviser's language.

Scene connection: The false mirror becomes literal at the end of the scene when Cassius plans the letters "As if they came from several citizens", and in Scene 3 when Cinna is sent to place them. Both show Brutus a reflection of himself that Cassius has painted.

ICSE keywords: manipulation; extended metaphor; irony; self-knowledge; appearance versus reality; flattery.

Possible answer use: 'When Cassius offers to be Brutus's "glass", he disguises persuasion as reflection; the forged letters of the same scene are the mirror made of paper.'

12. "The name of honour more than I fear death" — Brutus's creed

Exact quotation:

Brutus: *If it be aught toward the general good, / Set honour in one eye and death i' th' other / And I will look on both indifferently; / For let the gods so speed me as I love / The name of honour more than I fear death.*

Speaker: Brutus.

Listener: Cassius.

Act/Scene: Act 1 Scene 2, immediately after the first offstage shout.

Context: A flourish and a shout interrupt them. Brutus blurts out, "What means this shouting? I do fear the people / Choose Caesar for their king." Cassius pounces — "Ay, do you fear it? / Then must I think you would not have it so." Brutus admits, "I would not, Cassius, yet I love him well", then asks what Cassius wants of him, and sets his conditions.

Simple meaning: 'If what you have to say concerns the public good, then put honour before one of my eyes and death before the other, and I will look at both with equal calm; for, so help me gods, I love the name of honour more than I fear death.'

Deep meaning: Brutus states his values in a single balanced sentence, and the sentence gives Cassius his key. Note what Brutus actually says: not 'honour' but 'the name of honour' — reputation, how a thing is called.

LITERARY INTERPRETATION — many readers find this telling: Brutus loves honour partly as a word, and a man who loves the word can be persuaded that a dishonourable act is honourable if it is named correctly. Cassius replies at once, "Well, honour is the subject of my story."

Subtext: Brutus has just confessed, in two consecutive speeches, that he fears Caesar's kingship and that he loves Caesar. Cassius now knows the exact shape of the lever: the love must be made to yield to the fear in the name of honour.

Character: Idealistic, Stoic, courageous; also vain in the precise sense that his self-image matters to him more than consequences do.

Theme: Honour; the "general good" (republican duty); love versus duty; death.

Device: Antithesis (honour/death; love/fear); balanced syntax that performs the 'indifference' it describes; the key word 'name' that echoes Cassius's coming speech on names.

Historical connection: HISTORICAL RECORD — the historical Brutus was Cato's nephew and later his son-in-law, and Cato's Stoic indifference to death was legendary. Plutarch presents Brutus as the one conspirator moved by principle rather than private grievance.

Scene connection: Everything Cassius says next is built to this specification: the Tiber story (Caesar's weakness), the Colossus (Rome's shame), the names (Brutus's ancestor). In Act 2 Brutus will reason his way to the murder in exactly these terms, and in Act 3 his insistence on the conspirators' honour — sparing Antony, letting Antony speak — will undo them.

ICSE keywords: honour; antithesis; idealism; tragic flaw; Stoicism; republican duty.

Possible answer use: 'Brutus's declaration that he loves "The name of honour more than I fear death" supplies Cassius with his method and the play with its tragedy: every later error of Brutus is made in honour's name.'

13. "I, as Aeneas, our great ancestor" — Cassius carries Caesar from the Tiber

Exact quotation:

Cassius: *Caesar cried 'Help me, Cassius, or I sink!' / I, as Aeneas, our great ancestor, / Did from the flames of Troy upon his shoulder / The old Anchises bear, so from the waves of Tiber / Did I the tired Caesar. And this man / Is now become a god*

Speaker: Cassius.

Listener: Brutus.

Act/Scene: Act 1 Scene 2, the first long speech of Cassius's persuasion.

Context: Cassius has declared he "had as lief not be as live to be / In awe of such a thing as I myself", and insisted "I was born free as Caesar; so were you". He then tells the story: on a "raw and gusty day" Caesar dared him — "Dar'st thou, Cassius, now / Leap in with me into this angry flood / And swim to yonder point?" — and Cassius, fully dressed ("Accoutered as I was"), plunged in. Caesar followed, tired, and cried for help.

Simple meaning: 'Caesar shouted for me to save him from drowning. Just as our ancestor Aeneas carried his old father Anchises out of burning Troy on his shoulders, so I carried the exhausted Caesar out of the Tiber. And this same man has now become a god.'

Deep meaning: The comparison is a trap Cassius sets for himself. Aeneas carrying Anchises is the great Roman image of piety — a son saving a father. By casting himself as Aeneas, Cassius casts Caesar as the aged, helpless father, which flatters his own strength and belittles Caesar's. But it also makes Caesar a father, and the play will punish the sons who kill him. The story's point is physical: the 'god' is a man with a body that fails. Cassius follows it with the fever in Spain — "'Tis true, this god did shake" — and the pitiless detail of Caesar crying for water "As a sick girl".

Subtext: Every sentence says 'I am stronger than Caesar, and yet I must bow to him.' The grievance is personal, not constitutional; Cassius dresses envy in republican clothes. He also repeats his own name in Caesar's mouth, savouring it.

Character: Cassius: proud, physically brave, resentful, a storyteller who shapes facts to purpose. LITERARY INTERPRETATION — the detail that he plunged in first and Caesar merely 'followed' subtly reverses the dare, so that even the story's beginning favours him.

Theme: Jealousy; the body of the ruler versus his public image; appearance versus reality ('god' versus drowning man); the Roman past as a standard.

Device: Epic simile (Aeneas and Anchises); anecdote as rhetorical proof; bathos ('a god' who cannot swim); direct speech within speech.

Historical connection: HISTORICAL RECORD — Aeneas, legendary ancestor of the Romans, carries his father from burning Troy in Virgil's Aeneid; the Julian family claimed descent from Aeneas, so Cassius is stealing Caesar's own ancestor. The swimming contest is Shakespeare's invention, though Plutarch and Suetonius do record Caesar's epilepsy; the fever in Spain has no specific ancient source.

Scene connection: The failing body reappears within minutes in Casca's report — Caesar "swooned and fell down" — and in Caesar's own admission "this ear is deaf". The Tiber that Marullus made tremble for Pompey is here the flood that nearly kills Caesar.

ICSE keywords: epic simile; classical allusion; jealousy; bathos; anecdote; appearance versus reality.

Possible answer use: 'Cassius's self-portrait as "Aeneas, our great ancestor" rescuing a drowning Caesar reveals the private root of a public conspiracy: the man who claims to fight for Rome cannot forgive having once been the stronger swimmer.'

14. "Like a Colossus" — Cassius's image of Caesar

Exact quotation:

Cassius: *Why, man, he doth bstride the narrow world / Like a Colossus, and we petty men / Walk under his huge legs and peep about / To find ourselves dishonourable graves.*

Speaker: Cassius.

Listener: Brutus.

Act/Scene: Act 1 Scene 2, immediately after the second offstage shout.

Context: Brutus has guessed that "these applauses are / For some new honours that are heaped on Caesar." Cassius seizes the moment.

Simple meaning: 'He stands astride the whole little world like the giant statue of Rhodes, and we small men walk between his enormous legs, looking about for somewhere shameful to be buried.'

Deep meaning: The image shrinks Rome ('narrow world') and inflates Caesar to a statue — not a man but a monument, hollow bronze. 'Petty men' (small, insignificant) is a calculated humiliation of Brutus as much as of Cassius; it invites him to resent his own smallness. 'Peep about' is a verb for mice. The 'dishonourable graves' touch Brutus where he has just told Cassius he is most sensitive — the "name of honour".

Subtext: Cassius's Caesar is not a tyrant doing wrong but a size doing wrong by existing. The grievance is scale, and the remedy implied is to cut the statue down.

Character: Cassius's gift for the vivid, physical image, and his habit of mixing self-pity ('we petty men') with contempt.

Theme: Power; jealousy; honour; the individual against the overwhelming state.

Device: Simile and hyperbole; classical allusion; visual imagery of scale; the pointed word 'dishonourable' aimed at Brutus's creed.

Historical connection: HISTORICAL RECORD — the Colossus was the bronze statue of the sun-god at Rhodes (c. 280 BC), one of the Seven Wonders; the idea that it straddled the harbour so ships sailed between its legs is a medieval legend, which Shakespeare's picture depends on.

Scene connection: Flavius's soaring bird in Scene 1 has become a statue; in Scene 3 Cassius will call Caesar "prodigious grown". The hollow-monument idea pays off when Caesar is cut down in Act 3 and proves, as Antony says over the body, to be flesh.

ICSE keywords: simile; hyperbole; classical allusion; visual imagery; jealousy; power.

Possible answer use: 'Cassius's picture of Caesar bestriding "the narrow world / Like a Colossus" makes Caesar's greatness a personal insult to every Roman, which is exactly the feeling he must create in Brutus.'

15. "The fault, dear Brutus, is not in our stars" — the most famous line

Exact quotation:

Cassius: *Men at some time are masters of their fates. / The fault, dear Brutus, is not in our stars, / But in ourselves, that we are underlings.*

Speaker: Cassius.

Listener: Brutus.

Act/Scene: Act 1 Scene 2, directly after the Colossus image.

Context: Having shown Caesar as a giant, Cassius must prevent Brutus from shrugging ('that is simply how things are'). So he denies fate.

Simple meaning: 'There are moments when men control their own destinies. The blame for our being inferiors, dear Brutus, lies not in the stars we were born under but in ourselves.'

Deep meaning: The line states the play's great question — fate or free will? — and takes the free-will side. 'Underlings' (subordinates, small people) is the sting. Elizabethans widely believed the stars influenced human fortune; Cassius says, in effect, 'stop blaming astrology and act.' Note 'at some time': even Cassius does not claim men are always masters of their fates — only that now is such a time.

Subtext: It is a call to action disguised as a philosophy. 'Dear Brutus' is intimate and manipulative at once.

Character: Cassius the rationalist and Epicurean, who believes in human agency — a belief the play will test to destruction.

Theme: Fate versus free will; responsibility; liberty.

Device: Aphorism (a compact general truth); antithesis (stars/ourselves); direct address; astrological imagery.

Historical connection: HISTORICAL RECORD — the historical Cassius followed Epicurean philosophy, which denied that the gods interfered in human affairs; the line is true to that. LITERARY INTERPRETATION — the play's events seem to answer him, since the omens, the Soothsayer and later Caesar's ghost all suggest a design larger than men.

Scene connection: The same Cassius will, in Scene 3, read the storm as a divine message and bare his breast to the lightning; and in Act 5 the sceptic will admit that his beliefs have changed. Brutus's own fatalism in the final acts is the mirror image of this speech.

ICSE keywords: aphorism; antithesis; fate versus free will; dramatic irony; Epicureanism.

Possible answer use: 'Cassius's insistence that "The fault, dear Brutus, is not in our stars, / But in ourselves" is the conspiracy's founding belief, and the play's omens, ghost and defeats test it to breaking point.'

PROFESSOR'S INSIGHT Why the most famous line in the play is also its most ironic

LITERARY INTERPRETATION. Students quote "The fault, dear Brutus, is not in our stars" as if it were Shakespeare's own motto, a stirring declaration that we make our own fates. Look at where it sits and who says it, and it begins to curdle. It is spoken by a manipulator in the act of manipulating: Cassius is not inviting Brutus to freedom but steering him towards a murder Cassius has already decided on. The man who says we are masters of our fates is busy mastering someone else's. Then look at what follows. Within a scene, this same rationalist is walking bare-chested through a supernatural storm and announcing that heaven has sent the prodigies as "instruments of fear and warning"; the sceptic has become a reader of signs. And the play's later shape seems to side against him — the Ides arrive exactly as warned, the conspirators are driven to the fates they tried to escape, and Cassius dies on his birthday, by his own hand, having misread what his eyes reported. Finally, the line's grammar deserves a second look: 'that we are underlings' is the fault Cassius locates in 'ourselves', but the remedy he proposes is not to rise by one's own merit — it is to remove the man above. The famous assertion of free will is a plan to make one Roman's fate the instrument of another's envy. It remains a magnificent line. But in an answer it is far more impressive to show that it is magnificent and false than to quote it as simple wisdom.

16. "'Brutus' will start a spirit as soon as 'Caesar'" — the argument from names

Exact quotation:

Cassius: 'Brutus' and 'Caesar'—what should be in that 'Caesar'? / Why should that name be sounded more than yours? / Write them together, yours is as fair a name; / Sound them, it doth become the mouth as well; / Weigh them, it is as heavy; conjure with 'em, / 'Brutus' will start a spirit as soon as 'Caesar.'

Speaker: Cassius.

Listener: Brutus.

Act/Scene: Act 1 Scene 2, continuing directly from the lines on fate.

Context: Cassius turns from philosophy to the one thing Brutus prizes most — his name — and ends by invoking the ancestor who expelled the kings: "There was a Brutus once that would have brooked / Th' eternal devil to keep his state in Rome / As easily as a king."

Simple meaning: 'What is so special about the name Caesar? Why should it be spoken more loudly than yours? Written side by side, yours is as fine; spoken, it suits the mouth as well; weighed, it is as heavy; use them as spells, and Brutus will raise a ghost as quickly as Caesar.'

Deep meaning: Cassius treats names as objects that can be written, sounded, weighed and used in magic — four tests, each of which Brutus's name passes. The method is an auction of vanity. 'Start a spirit' means summon a ghost: names in this play have real power, and Brutus's name is precisely what the conspiracy needs. Cassius then asks "Upon what meat doth this our Caesar feed / That he is grown so great?" and cries "Rome, thou hast lost the breed of noble bloods!" — making Brutus's ancestry a reproach.

Subtext: Cassius has found that honour, for Brutus, is partly a word; so he works on the word. The speech also quietly reveals Cassius's own obsession with names (he keeps saying his own).

Character: Cassius: rhetorically relentless, appealing to lineage because argument alone will not move Brutus.

Theme: Honour and reputation; the burden of ancestry; the power of language; republican memory.

Device: Rhetorical questions; parallel imperatives ('Write... Sound... Weigh... conjure'); the conjuring metaphor; allusion to Lucius Junius Brutus.

Historical connection: HISTORICAL RECORD — Lucius Junius Brutus led the expulsion of King Tarquin in 509 BC, founding the Republic; Marcus Brutus claimed descent from him. Plutarch records that anonymous messages reminded Brutus of this ancestor — 'You are no true Brutus' is the sense of them.

Scene connection: The spirit Cassius 'starts' with Brutus's name becomes, grimly, the ghost of Caesar in Act 4. The ancestor's statue is used in Scene 3, where Cinna is told to fix a letter "Upon old Brutus' statue".

ICSE keywords: rhetorical question; parallelism; allusion; vanity; manipulation; the power of names.

Possible answer use: 'By weighing the two names and declaring that "'Brutus' will start a spirit as soon as 'Caesar'", Cassius makes Brutus's honour depend on acting; the forged letters that follow are this argument in writing.'

17. "Brutus had rather be a villager" — Brutus's conditional promise

Exact quotation:

Brutus: *Brutus had rather be a villager / Than to repute himself a son of Rome / Under these hard conditions as this time / Is like to lay upon us.*

Speaker: Brutus.

Listener: Cassius.

Act/Scene: Act 1 Scene 2, Brutus's reply to the long persuasion, just before Caesar's train returns.

Context: Brutus answers with care: "That you do love me, I am nothing jealous. / What you would work me to, I have some aim." He asks not to be pressed further now, promises to "consider" and to "find a time", and then, telling Cassius to "chew upon this", offers this.

Simple meaning: 'Brutus would rather be an insignificant villager than call himself a Roman under the harsh conditions this age is likely to impose on us.'

Deep meaning: It is a promise wrapped in a refusal. Brutus will not be rushed ('I have some aim' — I partly guess what you want), yet the closing sentence tells Cassius he has already lost the argument he pretends to postpone: he would rather give up Rome than live in it enslaved. The third person again ('Brutus had rather') shows him measuring himself against a public standard. 'Son of Rome' answers Cassius's "breed of noble bloods".

Subtext: Brutus believes he is keeping control; Cassius hears consent. Cassius's satisfied reply — "I am glad that my weak words / Have struck but thus much show of fire from Brutus" — confirms that a little fire is all he needed.

Character: Cautious, dignified, honourable in intention, and already committed in feeling.

Theme: Republicanism and liberty; honour; patriotism; the individual against the state.

Device: Third-person self-reference; antithesis (villager / son of Rome); conditional phrasing that hides a decision; the metaphor of fire struck from flint in Cassius's reply.

Historical connection: HISTORICAL RECORD — Brutus had served Pompey against Caesar, been pardoned, and then accepted high office from him (urban praetor for 44 BC); the discomfort of a republican flourishing under a near-king is historically grounded.

Scene connection: Act 2 opens with Brutus's soliloquy, where the 'hard conditions' are reasoned into a death sentence; Cassius's closing soliloquy here plans the letters that will complete the work.

ICSE keywords: third-person self-reference; antithesis; patriotism; liberty; characterisation.

Possible answer use: 'Brutus's declaration that he "had rather be a villager / Than to repute himself a son of Rome" under tyranny is the conditional that Cassius's letters will convert into a decision.'

18. "a lean and hungry look" — Caesar reads Cassius

Exact quotation:

Caesar: *Let me have men about me that are fat, / Sleek-headed men, and such as sleep a-nights. / Yond Cassius has a lean and hungry look. / He thinks too much. Such men are dangerous.*

Speaker: Caesar.

Listener: Antony (Brutus and Cassius are watching from a distance).

Act/Scene: Act 1 Scene 2, as Caesar returns from the games with "The angry spot" glowing on his brow.

Context: Caesar has refused a crown three times offstage and fainted; his train "look like a chidden train". Catching sight of Cassius, he calls Antony to him.

Simple meaning: 'Give me plump, well-groomed men around me who sleep soundly at night. That Cassius over there looks thin and hungry. He thinks too much. Men like that are dangerous.'

Deep meaning: Caesar's political theory in four lines: contented men are safe, and the discontented show it in their bodies. 'Hungry' is literal and metaphorical — hunger for power. The judgement is acute; it is also the judgement of a man who prefers courtiers who do not think. Antony's "Fear him not, Caesar; he's not dangerous. / He is a noble Roman, and well given" is the first of several occasions on which Antony misjudges the conspirators.

Subtext: Caesar has seen what Brutus has not: Cassius's envy written on his face. The irony is that the one man in the play who reads Cassius correctly will do nothing about it.

Character: Caesar: shrewd, observant, vain about his own fearlessness, surrounded by flatterers of his own choosing.

Theme: Appearance and reality (the body as a sign of the mind); leadership; jealousy.

Device: Physiognomy as characterisation; antithesis (fat/lean); dramatic irony (the audience has just watched Cassius being dangerous); epigrammatic short sentences.

Historical connection: HISTORICAL RECORD — Plutarch reports Caesar saying he did not fear fat, long-haired men but the pale, thin ones, meaning Brutus and Cassius. Shakespeare keeps the thought and sharpens it into verse.

Scene connection: Caesar goes on — "He reads much, / He is a great observer, and he looks / Quite through the deeds of men" — and the portrait matches what we have just seen. In Scene 3 Cassius's 'hunger' becomes action, and in Act 3 the man Caesar should have avoided helps to kill him.

ICSE keywords: dramatic irony; physiognomy; antithesis; characterisation; appearance versus reality.

Possible answer use: 'Caesar's diagnosis that Cassius "has a lean and hungry look" is the sharpest piece of character-reading in Act 1 — and the play's irony is that the man who sees the danger most clearly refuses to act on it.'

19. "for always I am Caesar" — the public self and the deaf ear

Exact quotation:

Caesar: *I rather tell thee what is to be feared / Than what I fear; for always I am Caesar. / Come on my right hand, for this ear is deaf, / And tell me truly what thou think'st of him.*

Speaker: Caesar.

Listener: Antony.

Act/Scene: Act 1 Scene 2, the end of Caesar's speech about Cassius, as the train moves off.

Context: Caesar has insisted, "Would he were fatter! But I fear him not", then described Cassius at length — a man who "Seldom he smiles" and is "never at heart's ease / Whiles they behold a greater than themselves". He closes with these lines.

Simple meaning: 'I am telling you what deserves to be feared, not what I fear — because I am always Caesar. Come round to my right side, since this ear is deaf, and tell me honestly what you think of him.'

Deep meaning: Two consecutive lines contain the whole man. 'For always I am Caesar' claims that the name is a role above fear; 'this ear is deaf' admits a failing body. He speaks of himself in the third person, as a public institution, and in the same breath reveals a private defect. The deaf ear is also a metaphor the audience cannot miss: Caesar hears the right things on the wrong side and misses what matters.

Subtext: The request to "tell me truly" shows that behind the public mask Caesar does want counsel — and that he asks it of the one man who will tell him what he wants to hear.

Character: Caesar: self-mythologising, physically vulnerable, surprisingly candid in private.

Theme: Appearance versus reality; the public and private self; leadership and its isolation; pride.

Device: Third-person self-reference; antithesis ('what is to be feared' / 'what I fear'); symbolic physical detail; dramatic irony.

Historical connection: HISTORICAL RECORD — Caesar's deafness has no basis in the ancient sources; it appears to be Shakespeare's addition, while the epilepsy mentioned by Brutus and Casca is in Plutarch and Suetonius. LITERARY INTERPRETATION — the invented deafness is Shakespeare's way of making a political blindness physical.

Scene connection: Cassius has just mocked the body that cannot swim or hold off a fever; Caesar now confirms the body's weakness himself. In Act 2 and Act 3 'always I am Caesar' hardens into his refusal to yield to anyone's plea.

ICSE keywords: third-person self-reference; dramatic irony; symbolism; hubris; public versus private self.

Possible answer use: 'The gap between "for always I am Caesar" and "this ear is deaf" in consecutive lines is Shakespeare's compact portrait of a ruler whose public name has outgrown the man who bears it.'

20. "he would fain have had it" — Casca reports the crown

Exact quotation:

Casca: *he put it by once; but for all that, to my thinking, he would fain have had it. Then he offered it to him again; then he put it by again; but to my thinking, he was very loath to lay his fingers off it.*

Speaker: Casca.

Listener: Brutus and Cassius.

Act/Scene: Act 1 Scene 2, after Caesar's train has left; Brutus has plucked Casca by the cloak.

Context: Casca has already said, "there was a crown offered him; and, being offered him, he put it by with the back of his hand, thus, and then the people fell a-shouting." Pressed for "the manner of it", he protests that "It was mere foolery; I did not mark it", corrects himself ("twas not a crown neither; 'twas one of these coronets"), and gives this account before describing how "the rabblement hooted and clapped their chopped hands and threw up their sweaty nightcaps" until Caesar "swooned and fell down at it".

Simple meaning: 'He pushed it away once, but in my opinion he would gladly have taken it. Antony offered it again; he refused again; but in my opinion he was very reluctant to take his fingers off it.'

Deep meaning: The crucial words are 'to my thinking', twice. Casca gives facts (three offers, three refusals) and then an interpretation (Caesar wanted it), and he is honest enough to mark where one ends and the other begins. The "rabblement" (rabble), the "sweaty nightcaps" and the "stinking breath" show a patrician's disgust for the crowd. We never see the offer; we receive it through a witness who despises everybody involved.

Subtext: Casca's sourness is useful to Cassius — Caesar as a hypocrite who performs modesty — but the report also undercuts the conspirators' case, since Caesar did, three times, refuse.

Character: Casca: blunt, cynical, snobbish, more observant than he pretends ('I did not mark it' is followed by a detailed account).

Theme: Ambition; appearance versus reality; public opinion; political theatre.

Device: Reported action (teichoscopy, the narrating of an offstage event); prose; irony; sensory imagery of the crowd.

Historical connection: HISTORICAL RECORD — Plutarch describes Antony offering Caesar a diadem at the Lupercalia, with feeble applause for the offer and loud applause for the refusal; in Plutarch it happens twice, in Casca's account three times. The cynical reading that Caesar wanted the crown is Shakespeare's addition through Casca.

Scene connection: The three shouts that interrupted Cassius's persuasion are here explained. In Act 3 Antony will use the same refusal as proof that Caesar was not ambitious — the one event, read two ways.

ICSE keywords: reported action; irony; ambition; point of view; prose; unreliable witness.

Possible answer use: 'Casca's "to my thinking, he would fain have had it" is the Act 1 evidence that Antony turns upside down in his funeral oration, and a student writing on Act 3 who recalls it can show how one refusal serves two opposite arguments.'

PROFESSOR'S INSIGHT Why Casca's prose is quotable

LITERARY INTERPRETATION. Students often assume that only verse is 'quotable' and skip Casca's report as mere plot. The opposite is true, and understanding why makes you a better reader of the whole play. Casca is the only patrician in Act 1 who speaks prose, and he does it deliberately — Cassius calls it his "sour fashion", Brutus says he "puts on this tardy form". The prose is a disguise: a clever man playing the blunt soldier so that nobody expects anything of him. That gives his sentences a special texture. They are concrete where the verse is abstract — "sweaty nightcaps", "chopped hands", "stinking breath", a crown that is "one of these coronets", Caesar who "plucked me ope his doublet". While Cassius talks of Colossi and stars, Casca tells you what the air smelled like. They are also rhythmically memorable because they are built on repetition and tagging: "to my thinking... to my thinking", "put it by... put it by... put it by", and the famous throwaway "it was Greek to me". And they are judgements pretending to be reports — every noun carries contempt. For the examination this matters practically: Casca gives you the only eyewitness account of the crown-offering, and the phrases are short, exact and easy to embed. For analysis it matters more: his prose is where the play lets a sceptic puncture everybody's rhetoric, Caesar's included. When the same man speaks terrified verse in Scene 3, the change of register tells you how frightening the night is.

21. "as they use to do the players in the theatre" — Casca on the crowd

Exact quotation:

Casca: *If the tag-rag people did not clap him and hiss him, according as he pleased and displeased them, as they use to do the players in the theatre, I am no true man.*

Speaker: Casca.

Listener: Brutus and Cassius.

Act/Scene: Act 1 Scene 2, after Cassius's joke about the "falling sickness".

Context: Casca has reported that Caesar "fell down in the market-place and foamed at mouth and was speechless". He adds this, then describes Caesar offering the crowd "his throat to cut", the women crying "Alas, good soul!" and his verdict that "if Caesar had stabbed their mothers, they would have done no less". Later in the same speech he reports Cicero spoke Greek — "it was Greek to me" — and that "Marullus and Flavius, for pulling scarves off Caesar's images, are put to silence."

Simple meaning: 'If the ragged crowd did not applaud and boo him exactly according to whether he pleased or displeased them, just as they do actors in a playhouse, then I am not an honest man.'

Deep meaning: Casca names the play's recurring idea: politics is theatre and the people are its audience. 'Tag-rag' (ragged, worthless) is a snob's word; but the comparison is precise — the crowd's applause is bought by performance, and Caesar's offer of his throat is a stage gesture. The audience in a London theatre in 1599, hearing this, was being told that it, too, could be played upon.

Subtext: The sceptic who sees through Caesar's acting is himself performing bluntness; nobody in this scene is quite what he seems.

Character: Casca's contempt for the commons and sharp eye for hypocrisy.

Theme: Mob psychology; appearance versus reality; political theatre; public opinion.

Device: Simile (crowd as theatre audience); metatheatre (a play commenting on playgoing); prose; hyperbole in the oath "I am no true man".

Historical connection: HISTORICAL RECORD — Plutarch records Caesar's epilepsy and the crowd's reactions at the Lupercalia; the offered throat is in Plutarch's account of a different occasion, which Shakespeare folds in here. The fate of the tribunes (deposed from office) is historical; "put to silence" leaves their exact fate deliberately vague.

Scene connection: The news about the tribunes closes the loop with Scene 1 — the feather-pluckers have been punished. The theatre simile predicts the Forum scene of Act 3, where two speakers compete for the same audience's applause.

ICSE keywords: simile; metatheatre; fickle crowd; mob psychology; irony; prose.

Possible answer use: 'Casca's comparison of the crowd to playgoers who "clap him and hiss him" according to his performance prepares us for Act 3, where Antony treats the Forum as a stage and wins the audience Brutus loses.'

22. "we have the falling sickness" — Cassius's grim pun

Exact quotation:

Cassius: *No, Caesar hath it not; but you and I / And honest Casca, we have the falling sickness.*

Speaker: Cassius.

Listener: Brutus and Casca.

Act/Scene: Act 1 Scene 2, in the middle of Casca's report.

Context: Cassius, startled — "But soft, I pray you. What, did Caesar swoon?" — hears that Caesar fell and foamed at the mouth. Brutus explains kindly, "'Tis very like; he hath the falling sickness." Cassius turns the diagnosis into a political joke.

Simple meaning: 'No — Caesar does not have the falling sickness. We do: you and I and honest Casca are the ones who are falling (losing our standing) while he rises.'

Deep meaning: 'Falling sickness' was the ordinary name for epilepsy; Cassius makes it mean Rome's political collapse. The pun is cruel and brilliant — it refuses pity for Caesar and converts his weakness into a charge against everyone who tolerates him. Casca's reply, "I know not what you mean by that", shows that the joke is above the blunt soldier's head, or that he pretends it is.

Subtext: Cassius cannot let a fact about Caesar stand without turning it against him. The 'honest' before Casca's name is a first touch of recruitment.

Character: Cassius: quick, bitter, incapable of sympathy for Caesar; Brutus: humane, naming the illness without malice.

Theme: Jealousy; the ruler's body as a political sign; manipulation.

Device: Pun; antithesis (Caesar/we); irony; the contrast between Brutus's compassion and Cassius's wit.

Historical connection: HISTORICAL RECORD — Plutarch and Suetonius both report Caesar's epilepsy; modern historians debate the diagnosis. The word 'falling sickness' is the Elizabethan term.

Scene connection: Cassius's earlier "this god did shake" and Casca's swoon together build the theme of Caesar's fragile body that Act 2's superstitious, hesitating Caesar will continue. The word 'fall' is reclaimed by Caesar's enemies when he literally falls in Act 3.

ICSE keywords: pun; irony; antithesis; characterisation by contrast; political metaphor.

Possible answer use: 'Cassius's retort that it is "you and I / And honest Casca" who "have the falling sickness" shows how he converts every fact about Caesar into a grievance — here turning Brutus's compassion into a political diagnosis.'

23. "Thy honourable mettle may be wrought" — Cassius alone

Exact quotation:

Cassius: *Well, Brutus, thou art noble. Yet I see / Thy honourable mettle may be wrought / From that it is disposed. Therefore it is meet / That noble minds keep ever with their likes; / For who so firm that cannot be seduced? / Caesar doth bear me hard, but he loves Brutus.*

Speaker: Cassius, in soliloquy.

Listener: No one; the audience.

Act/Scene: Act 1 Scene 2, the closing speech, after Brutus has gone home.

Context: Brutus has left, agreeing to meet tomorrow; Cassius's parting instruction was "think of the world". Before this Brutus remarked that Casca "was quick mettle when he went to school", and Cassius explained that "This rudeness is a sauce to his good wit".

Simple meaning: 'Brutus, you are noble; but I can see that your honourable nature can be worked (like metal) away from its natural shape. So noble men should keep company only with their equals — for who is so steadfast that he cannot be led astray? Caesar bears a grudge against me, but he loves Brutus.'

Deep meaning: This is the only moment in Act 1 when Cassius tells the truth about what he is doing. 'Mettle' (temperament) puns on 'metal' that can be 'wrought' — hammered into a new shape. The word 'seduced' is his own choice for his method. He then plans the forgeries: letters "In several hands", thrown in at Brutus's windows "As if they came from several citizens", in which "Caesar's ambition shall be glanced at", and closes, "let Caesar seat him sure, / For we will shake him, or worse days endure."

Subtext: 'If I were Brutus now, and he were Cassius, / He should not humour me' — Cassius knows Brutus would never do to him what he is doing to Brutus. That knowledge is as near to a conscience as Cassius comes.

Character: Cassius: candid with himself, admiring of Brutus, entirely unscrupulous about means; resentful that Caesar "doth bear me hard".

Theme: Manipulation; honour as something that can be forged; betrayal of friendship; appearance versus reality.

Device: Soliloquy; metaphor and pun (mettle/metal, wrought); rhetorical question; rhyming couplet to close the scene (sure/endure).

Historical connection: HISTORICAL RECORD — Plutarch reports anonymous notes left on Brutus's praetor's chair and his ancestor's statue urging him to act; Shakespeare makes Cassius their author, turning a popular movement into one man's deceit.

Scene connection: The letters are handed to Cinna in Scene 3 and read by Brutus in Act 2, where they tip him into the conspiracy. The idea of noble metal 'wrought' from its true shape is the play's image for what happens to Brutus.

ICSE keywords: soliloquy; pun; metaphor; manipulation; dramatic irony; forgery.

Possible answer use: 'Only in soliloquy does Cassius admit that Brutus's "honourable mettle may be wrought / From that it is disposed"; the forged letters are the hammer, and Brutus's Act 2 decision is the new shape.'

Scene 3 — The Storm

A word on time before the quotations. Scene 2 ended in the afternoon of the Lupercalia; Scene 3 opens on the night before the Ides of March. HISTORICAL RECORD — that is a month later, and Shakespeare simply does not mention the gap. Cicero's question "Comes Caesar to the Capitol tomorrow?" is the only clue. Keep this in mind when you write about Cassius: the man who stood on the Tiber bank in Scene 2 has had four weeks to recruit, and the storm gives him his last and best night.

24. "a tempest dropping fire" — Casca's terror

Exact quotation:

Casca: *But never till tonight, never till now, / Did I go through a tempest dropping fire. / Either there is a civil strife in heaven, / Or else the world, too saucy with the gods, / Incenses them to send destruction.*

Speaker: Casca, sword drawn, breathless.

Listener: Cicero, who has met him in the street and asked why he is "breathless" and why he stares so.

Act/Scene: Act 1 Scene 3, the opening lines of the scene.

Context: Thunder and lightning. Casca has asked, "Are not you moved, when all the sway of earth / Shakes like a thing unfirm?" and has recalled ordinary storms in which "the scolding winds / Have rived the knotty oaks". This storm is of another order.

Simple meaning: 'Never before tonight have I walked through a storm that rained fire. Either the gods are fighting a civil war among themselves, or the world has grown so insolent towards the gods that it has provoked them to destroy it.'

Deep meaning: The blunt prose-speaker of Scene 2 now speaks shaken verse, and the shift of register is itself the meaning: what frightens Casca is not weather but the sense that the order of things has broken. Both his explanations are political. 'Civil strife in heaven' projects Rome's own civil wars on to the sky; a world 'too saucy with the gods' names the sin of a man who has let himself be treated as one. The word 'saucy' (insolent, presumptuous) is deliberately small for a cosmic charge — it is Casca's instinct to deflate.

Subtext: Casca has not yet said the name 'Caesar', but every image points to him. The storm has done Cassius's work before Cassius arrives: it has made a sceptic believe that something monstrous is loose.

Character: Casca: superstitious under the cynicism, physically brave (he has drawn his sword against the sky) and morally pliable — fear will make him join a conspiracy within fifty lines.

Theme: Omens and superstition; the disorder of nature mirroring disorder in the state; fear; the gods' displeasure.

Device: Pathetic fallacy (the heavens express the political crisis); hyperbole ('dropping fire'); antithesis of the two explanations ('Either... Or else'); repetition ('never till tonight, never till now').

Historical connection: HISTORICAL RECORD — Plutarch's Life of Caesar lists portents before the assassination: lights in the sky, crashing noises at night, birds in the Forum, and a slave whose hand blazed without burning. Shakespeare gives those portents to Casca and lets the audience hear the storm in the theatre's own thunder effects.

Scene connection: The 'civil strife in heaven' is the civil war of Acts 4 and 5 forecast in the sky. The same storm rages on through Act 2, where Calpurnia reports the night's horrors and Caesar at first decides not to go to the Capitol.

ICSE keywords: pathetic fallacy; omen; portent; hyperbole; change of register (prose to verse); foreshadowing.

Possible answer use: 'Casca's "tempest dropping fire" is the first voice in the play to read the weather politically — "a civil strife in heaven" — and his fear is the soil in which Cassius plants the conspiracy a few lines later.'

25. "let not men say / 'These are their reasons, they are natural'" — the catalogue of prodigies

Exact quotation:

Casca: *When these prodigies / Do so conjointly meet, let not men say / 'These are their reasons, they are natural,' / For I believe they are portentous things / Unto the climate that they point upon.*

Speaker: Casca.

Listener: Cicero.

Act/Scene: Act 1 Scene 3, at the end of Casca's list of wonders.

Context: Cicero has asked, calmly, whether Casca saw "anything more wonderful". Casca lists four: a slave whose hand "did flame and burn / Like twenty torches joined" yet "remained unscorched"; a lion near the Capitol that "glazed upon me and went surly by"; "a hundred ghastly women" who swore they saw "Men all in fire walk up and down the streets"; and "the bird of night" — the owl — sitting "Even at noonday upon the market-place, / Hooting and shrieking." Then he draws his conclusion.

Simple meaning: 'When so many unnatural signs happen together, nobody should say, 'There are natural explanations for each of these.' I believe they are omens aimed at the very country where they appear.'

Deep meaning: Casca's argument is one of accumulation: one wonder might be explained away, but four at once ('conjointly') cannot be. 'Prodigies' are unnatural events taken as omens; 'portentous' means foreshadowing disaster; 'climate' here means region. Notice that Casca anticipates the rationalist objection and forbids it — which tells us that the rationalist objection exists, and is about to be voiced by Cicero. The owl at noon is the most telling image: a creature of darkness in the public square in daylight, which is what a dictator is to a republic.

Subtext: Casca is frightened of his own perceptions and wants them confirmed. He is, in effect, asking Cicero to tell him the world has gone mad. Cicero will decline.

Character: Casca: an observer, as Caesar said of Cassius — he saw the slave, the lion, the women, the owl — but an observer who interprets by fear.

Theme: Superstition versus reason; omens; fate; the unnatural as a sign of political disorder.

Device: Catalogue (a list building to a climax); simile ("Like twenty torches joined"); symbolism (the owl, the lion); anticipation of a counter-argument (a form of rhetorical pre-emption).

Historical connection: HISTORICAL RECORD — the burning slave is in Plutarch almost word for word; the lion and the owl are Shakespeare's additions, though both carried traditional meanings (the lion of kingship, the owl of death). LITERARY INTERPRETATION — the lion that passes Casca "Without annoying me" is often read as Caesar himself, dangerous but not yet striking; the text leaves it open.

Scene connection: Cassius will reuse the lion within minutes — a man who "roars / As doth the lion in the Capitol" — and Caesar in Act 2 will boast that danger and he are 'two lions'. The 'ghastly women' and 'men all in fire' recur in Calpurnia's report of the night in Act 2.

ICSE keywords: prodigy; portent; catalogue; symbolism; superstition; rational versus supernatural reading.

Possible answer use: 'Casca insists the prodigies are "portentous things" and refuses the natural explanation in advance; Cicero's reply, that men "construe things after their fashion", is the play's own warning against believing him too quickly.'

26. "men may construe things after their fashion" — Cicero's calm

Exact quotation:

Cicero: *Indeed, it is a strange-disposed time. / But men may construe things after their fashion, / Clean from the purpose of the things themselves. / Comes Caesar to the Capitol tomorrow?*

Speaker: Cicero, the orator and senator.

Listener: Casca.

Act/Scene: Act 1 Scene 3, Cicero's only substantial speech in Act 1, after Casca's catalogue.

Context: Casca has just forbidden anyone to say the prodigies are natural. Cicero's answer is cool, brief and sceptical. Having asked his practical question and heard that Caesar will attend ("he did bid Antonius / Send word to you he would be there tomorrow"), Cicero leaves: "Good night, then, Casca. This disturbèd sky / Is not to walk in."

Simple meaning: 'Yes, it is a strangely unsettled time. But people interpret events according to their own inclinations, quite apart from what the events actually mean. Is Caesar coming to the Capitol tomorrow?'

Deep meaning: These are among the wisest lines in the play, and nobody on stage listens to them. 'Construe' means interpret; 'after their fashion' means in their own way; 'clean from' means entirely apart from. Cicero does not deny that the night is strange; he denies that Casca's fear is knowledge. Then he changes the subject to the one fact that matters. The move from omens to 'Comes Caesar to the Capitol tomorrow?' is the move from superstition to politics — Cicero is, in effect, the only character who keeps the two apart.

Subtext: LITERARY INTERPRETATION — Cicero's question suggests he already suspects that tomorrow is decisive; his departure suggests he intends to be nowhere near it. He is the intelligent man who sees and declines to act, which is why the conspirators in Act 2 decide to leave him out.

Character: Cicero: urbane, rational, detached, a touch patronising, politically careful. Casca said in Scene 2 that Cicero "spoke Greek" at the Lupercal — a man whose cleverness is above the crowd.

Theme: Appearance versus reality; interpretation and misreading; reason against superstition; the limits of intellect in a crisis.

Device: Aphorism; antithesis (men's 'fashion' against 'the things themselves'); a deflating change of subject; dramatic irony (the audience knows the omens are, in this play, accurate).

Historical connection: HISTORICAL RECORD — Marcus Tullius Cicero (106–43 BC) was Rome's greatest orator and a defender of the Republic; he was not part of the conspiracy, though he welcomed Caesar's death, and he was killed on the triumvirs' orders in December 43 BC. His speaking Greek is plausible: educated Romans were bilingual.

Scene connection: Cicero's warning about construing is the key to the whole play's pattern of misreading — Brutus construing the forged letters as the voice of Rome in Act 2, Caesar accepting Decius's flattering construction of Calpurnia's dream, and Cassius misreading what he sees at Philippi in Act 5. Brutus used the same verb of himself in Scene 2: "Nor construe any further my neglect".

ICSE keywords: aphorism; dramatic irony; scepticism; interpretation; appearance versus reality; foil (Cicero as foil to Casca).

Possible answer use: 'Cicero's observation that "men may construe things after their fashion, / Clean from the purpose of the things themselves" is a one-sentence theory of the whole tragedy, since every disaster that follows begins with somebody misreading a sign.'

27. "Have bared my bosom to the thunder-stone" — Cassius defies the storm

Exact quotation:

Cassius: *For my part, I have walked about the streets, / Submitting me unto the perilous night, / And thus unbracèd, Casca, as you see, / Have bared my bosom to the thunder-stone; / And when the cross blue lightning seemed to open / The breast of heaven, I did present myself / Even in the aim and very flash of it.*

Speaker: Cassius.

Listener: Casca (Cicero has gone).

Act/Scene: Act 1 Scene 3, immediately after the two men identify each other — "Who's there?" "A Roman." "Casca, by your voice."

Context: Casca has asked, "Cassius, what night is this!" Cassius replies with this account of what he has been doing while Casca cowered.

Simple meaning: 'As for me, I have been walking the streets, exposing myself to this dangerous night; with my doublet unlaced, as you see, I have bared my chest to the thunderbolt, and when the forked blue lightning seemed to tear open the sky I stood directly in its path.'

Deep meaning: Cassius makes himself the opposite of Casca: where Casca trembles, Cassius dares. 'Unbracèd' means with his clothing unfastened; the 'thunder-stone' was the stone that Elizabethans believed fell with a lightning strike. The gesture is a piece of theatre — he has been standing in the rain preparing an entrance — and it works. Casca's reaction is the pious one: "It is the part of men to fear and tremble / When the most mighty gods by tokens send / Such dreadful heralds to astonish us." Cassius's reply is the rebuke of a recruiting officer: "You are dull, Casca, and those sparks of life / That should be in a Roman you do want".

Subtext: The Epicurean who told Brutus that the fault is not in our stars is now using the stars. He does not say the storm means nothing; he says it means Caesar. The sceptic has become a prophet because prophecy is useful tonight.

Character: Cassius: fearless, theatrical, adaptable in belief, contemptuous of weakness in others. LITERARY INTERPRETATION — some readers find real exaltation here, a man who feels the night is on his side; others see pure calculation. Both are probably present.

Theme: Fate and free will (now entangled); manliness and fear; the manipulation of belief; the individual against the heavens.

Device: Hyperbole; personification ('the breast of heaven'); visual imagery ('cross blue lightning'); contrast between the two men; the symbolic gesture of the bared chest.

Historical connection: HISTORICAL RECORD — the historical Cassius was an Epicurean, and Epicureans held that gods did not send signs; Shakespeare knows this and makes the contradiction a character trait. Plutarch records that Cassius, before Philippi, spoke of his philosophy wavering.

Scene connection: The bared breast returns in Act 4, when Cassius offers Brutus his dagger and his 'naked breast' in the quarrel; and in Act 5 the same man admits that he has begun to give credit to omens. The contradiction with the "fault, dear Brutus" speech of Scene 2 is the chief reason that line is ironic.

ICSE keywords: hyperbole; personification; contrast; characterisation; symbolic gesture; inconsistency as character.

Possible answer use: 'When Cassius boasts that he has "bared my bosom to the thunder-stone", the rationalist of Scene 2 reinvents himself as a man in league with the storm, and the change tells us that his beliefs serve his purposes rather than the reverse.'

28. "yet prodigious grown / And fearful" — the unnamed man

Exact quotation:

Cassius: *Now could I, Casca, name to thee a man / Most like this dreadful night, / That thunders, lightens, opens graves, and roars / As doth the lion in the Capitol; / A man no mightier than thyself or me / In personal action, yet prodigious grown / And fearful, as these strange eruptions are.*

Speaker: Cassius.

Listener: Casca.

Act/Scene: Act 1 Scene 3, after Cassius has rebuked Casca's fear.

Context: Cassius has told Casca that the gods have sent the prodigies "instruments of fear and warning / Unto some monstrous state". Now he lets Casca guess the man he means. Casca does: "'Tis Caesar that you mean, is it not, Cassius?" Cassius: "Let it be who it is."

Simple meaning: 'I could name you a man who is exactly like this terrible night — who thunders, flashes, opens graves and roars like the lion at the Capitol; a man no stronger than you or me in his own body, yet grown unnaturally huge and frightening, just like these strange outbursts of nature.'

Deep meaning: Cassius does to the storm what he did to the Tiber: he turns a fact into a portrait of Caesar. The storm becomes a metaphor for a man; the man becomes a prodigy (an unnatural growth). The brilliance lies in 'no mightier than thyself or me / In personal action' — the Scene 2 argument about the drowning

swimmer, now compressed to a line. The refusal to say the name ('Let it be who it is') is itself persuasion: Casca must speak the name himself, and so commit himself.

Subtext: Cassius tests whether Casca is safe. By making Casca say 'Caesar', he gets a confession before he has made one. His follow-up — "Our yoke and sufferance show us womanish" — shames Casca into manliness, the same lever he used on Brutus's honour.

Character: Cassius: a master of the indirect approach, who never asks a man to join him but arranges for the man to offer.

Theme: Tyranny as unnatural growth; manipulation; the equality of men's bodies against the inequality of their power; manliness as a political value.

Device: Extended metaphor (Caesar as the storm); simile (the lion); periphrasis (describing without naming); verbal series ('thunders, lightens, opens graves, and roars').

Historical connection: HISTORICAL RECORD — Casca adds the news that "the senators tomorrow / Mean to establish Caesar as a king", to wear his crown "In every place save here in Italy". Shakespeare takes this from Plutarch and Suetonius, who report a rumour that a Sibylline prophecy said only a king could conquer Parthia, and that Caesar would be named king outside Italy. It was a rumour, not a decree, but the play treats it as the trigger.

Scene connection: Flavius's soaring hawk and Cassius's Colossus reach their third form here: Caesar as a storm. All three are images of unnatural size. The lion 'in the Capitol' links Casca's omen to Caesar's own boast in Act 2 and to the Capitol where the play's Caesar dies.

ICSE keywords: extended metaphor; periphrasis; manipulation; tyranny; imagery of unnatural growth; rhetorical strategy.

Possible answer use: 'By describing Caesar as a man "no mightier than thyself or me / In personal action, yet prodigious grown", Cassius converts the storm from an omen into an argument, and Casca's naming of Caesar is the first step of his recruitment.'

29. "Cassius from bondage will deliver Cassius" — the dagger and the self

Exact quotation:

Cassius: *I know where I will wear this dagger then; / Cassius from bondage will deliver Cassius. / Therein, you gods, you make the weak most strong; / Therein, you gods, you tyrants do defeat.*

Speaker: Cassius.

Listener: Casca.

Act/Scene: Act 1 Scene 3, directly after Casca reports that the Senate means to crown Caesar tomorrow.

Context: The rumour of a crown provokes Cassius's most passionate outburst. He goes on: "Nor stony tower, nor walls of beaten brass, / Nor airless dungeon, nor strong links of iron / Can be retentive to the strength of spirit; / But life, being weary of these worldly bars, / Never lacks power to dismiss itself." Casca agrees — "So every bondman in his own hand bears / The power to cancel his captivity."

Simple meaning: 'Then I know where I shall carry this dagger — into my own heart. Cassius will free Cassius from slavery. In that way, gods, you make the weak strongest; in that way you defeat tyrants.'

Deep meaning: On its surface this is a Stoic commonplace: no tyrant can enslave a man who is willing to die, because death is always available. 'Bondage' is slavery; 'retentive to' means able to hold in. But listen to the grammar — 'Cassius... will deliver Cassius', the name twice, the self rescuing the self. It is the Tiber story again, with Cassius as both the drowning man and the saviour. The threat of suicide is also a rhetorical feint: a man who says he will kill himself rather than live under Caesar is a breath away from saying he will kill Caesar instead, and that is the step Casca takes for him.

Subtext: The speech sounds like despair and functions as recruitment. It shows Casca the exit from fear — act, or die — and dares him to be less brave than Cassius. There is real feeling in it, too: Cassius's hatred of 'bondage' is the one constant in him.

Character: Cassius: proud to the point of self-worship, genuinely contemptuous of servility, and already, in Act 1, rehearsing the death he will choose at Philippi.

Theme: Liberty versus slavery; tyranny; free will (death as the last freedom); the Roman ideal of the noble suicide.

Device: Repetition of the name (a form of antimetabole, the same word at both ends); apostrophe to the gods; anaphora ('Therein, you gods'); the list of prisons ('stony tower... walls of beaten brass... airless dungeon... links of iron') as rhetorical amplification.

Historical connection: HISTORICAL RECORD — Roman culture honoured suicide as an escape from dishonour; Cato's death at Utica (46 BC), rather than accept Caesar's pardon, was the model. The historical Cassius died by his own hand at Philippi on 3 October 42 BC. LITERARY INTERPRETATION — the lines read as a deliberate forecast of that end.

Scene connection: The dagger Cassius says he will turn on himself is turned on Caesar in Act 3 and finally on Cassius in Act 5. The idea that life 'never lacks power to dismiss itself' returns in Brutus's debate about suicide before the battle and in his own death.

ICSE keywords: antimetabole; apostrophe; anaphora; liberty versus bondage; Stoicism; foreshadowing.

Possible answer use: 'Cassius's vow that "Cassius from bondage will deliver Cassius" is at once a Stoic creed and a recruiting speech; for a student writing on Act 5, it is the earliest statement of the death he eventually chooses.'

30. "Hold. My hand." — Casca joins

Exact quotation:

Casca: *You speak to Casca, and to such a man / That is no fleeing telltale. Hold. My hand. / Be factious for redress of all these griefs, / And I will set this foot of mine as far / As who goes farthest.*
Cassius: *There's a bargain made.*

Speaker: Casca; then Cassius.

Listener: Cassius; then Casca.

Act/Scene: Act 1 Scene 3, the moment the conspiracy gains its first recruit on stage.

Context: Cassius has gone further than he intended — "What trash is Rome, / What rubbish and what offal, when it serves / For the base matter to illuminate / So vile a thing as Caesar!" — and then checked himself: "I perhaps speak this / Before a willing bondman; then I know / My answer must be made. But I am armed, / And dangers are to me indifferent." Casca answers the implied challenge.

Simple meaning: 'You are talking to Casca, and to a man who is no sneering informer. Stop — here is my hand. Form a party to put right all these wrongs, and I will go as far as the man who goes farthest.'

Deep meaning: Three monosyllables — 'Hold. My hand.' — do what three hundred lines of persuasion did for Brutus. Casca's pledge is physical, a handshake, and absolute: he will go 'as far / As who goes farthest'. 'Fleering' means sneering or grinning falsely; 'telltale' is an informer; 'factious' here means forming a faction, which in Elizabethan ears was a loaded, dangerous word. Casca is swearing loyalty to a faction without yet knowing its plan or its members. Cassius's reply, 'There's a bargain made', is the language of the market: a deal has been struck, and the price is to be paid in blood.

Subtext: Casca's offended dignity ('no fleering telltale') shows that Cassius's apparent fear of informers was the final lever: nobody wants to be suspected of cowardice or treachery. Casca joins partly to prove he is not what Cassius pretended to fear.

Character: Casca: impulsive, proud, brave, easily led; the man who will strike the first blow in Act 3 is recruited in a sentence. Cassius: closing the deal with businesslike speed and at once telling Casca the others "stay for me / In Pompey's Porch".

Theme: Loyalty and faction; manipulation; honour as a lever; the speed with which fear becomes violence.

Device: Monosyllabic, broken syntax ('Hold. My hand.') for decision; commercial metaphor ('bargain'); the handshake as symbolic action; contrast with Brutus's slow consent.

Historical connection: HISTORICAL RECORD — Publius Servilius Casca Longus struck the first blow on the Ides of March; Plutarch says he struck Caesar in the neck. Shakespeare's Casca, recruited here, fulfils that record in Act 3. Cassius's words that the night's "complexion" is like "the work we have in hand, / Most bloody, fiery, and most terrible" make the plan explicit for the first time.

Scene connection: Casca's 'foot' that will go farthest is the hand that strikes first in Act 3. The 'bargain' here contrasts with Brutus's refusal, in Act 2, to let the conspirators swear an oath — Cassius trades, Brutus trusts.

ICSE keywords: symbolic action; monosyllables; commercial metaphor; recruitment; faction; characterisation by contrast.

Possible answer use: 'Casca's "Hold. My hand." seals the conspiracy in three words and sets Casca's impulsiveness against Brutus's month of agonising; Cassius's "There's a bargain made" reveals how he sees the enterprise — as a transaction.'

31. "O Cassius, if you could / But win the noble Brutus to our party" — Cinna's plea

Exact quotation:

Cinna: *Yes, you are. O Cassius, if you could / But win the noble Brutus to our party—*

Speaker: Cinna, a conspirator, arriving in haste.

Listener: Cassius, with Casca listening.

Act/Scene: Act 1 Scene 3, after Casca's pledge, as the conspirators begin to gather.

Context: Cassius knows Cinna "by his gait". Cinna, nervous — "What a fearful night is this! / There's two or three of us have seen strange sights" — confirms that the others are waiting for Cassius ("Am I not stayed for? Tell me." "Yes, you are."), and then blurts out the thing the whole conspiracy wants.

Simple meaning: 'Yes, they are waiting for you. Oh, Cassius, if only you could bring the noble Brutus over to our side—'

Deep meaning: The sentence breaks off — Cassius interrupts with "Be you content" — and the break is eloquent: the wish is so large that Cinna cannot finish it. 'Party' means faction. The adjective 'noble' is fixed to Brutus like a title; the conspirators do not want Brutus's sword but his reputation. This is the Scene 2 argument about the name 'Brutus' heard from the other side: Cassius said the name was as good as Caesar's, and here are men who agree. The plea also confirms what Cassius's soliloquy implied — the plot already exists without Brutus and knows it is incomplete.

Subtext: Cinna's anxiety ('two or three of us have seen strange sights') shows that fear is general among the conspirators; they need Brutus partly as a cure for their own nerves. Cassius's brisk reply — handing out the forged papers — shows that he has already done the work Cinna begs for.

Character: Cinna: eager, nervous, a follower; useful to Shakespeare as the voice of the ordinary conspirator. Cassius: in command, dealing out tasks like a general.

Theme: Honour as political capital; reputation; the conspiracy's dependence on one man; fear.

Device: Aposiopesis (a sentence deliberately broken off); the fixed epithet 'noble'; dramatic irony (we know the letters are forged).

Historical connection: HISTORICAL RECORD — this is Lucius Cornelius Cinna, praetor in 44 BC and a conspirator, not to be confused with Cinna the poet whom the mob kills in Act 3. Plutarch confirms that the conspirators sought Brutus because his name would make the deed appear just rather than factious.

Scene connection: Cassius's instructions follow at once: "Good Cinna, take this paper, / And look you lay it in the praetor's chair, / Where Brutus may but find it; and throw this / In at his window; set this up with wax / Upon old Brutus' statue." These are the letters planned in the Scene 2 soliloquy and read in Act 2. Cinna's wish is granted in Act 2 when Brutus takes the conspirators' hands.

ICSE keywords: aposiopesis; epithet; reputation; dramatic irony; the conspiracy's dependence on Brutus.

Possible answer use: 'Cinna's unfinished plea — "if you could / But win the noble Brutus to our party—" — shows that the conspirators value Brutus for his name, which is exactly why Cassius's forged letters are addressed to that name.'

32. "like richest alchemy" — Casca on what Brutus is for

Exact quotation:

Casca: *O, he sits high in all the people's hearts, / And that which would appear offence in us / His countenance, like richest alchemy, / Will change to virtue and to worthiness.* **Cassius:** *Him and his worth and our great need of him / You have right well conceited.*

Speaker: Casca; then Cassius.

Listener: Cassius; then Casca.

Act/Scene: Act 1 Scene 3, the closing lines of the act.

Context: Cinna has gone to deliver the papers. Cassius has just said, "Three parts of him / Is ours already, and the man entire / Upon the next encounter yields him ours." Casca explains why Brutus is worth the trouble, and Cassius agrees before they leave, "For it is after midnight, and ere day / We will awake him and be sure of him."

Simple meaning: 'He is held in great esteem by all the people, and what would look like a crime if we did it, his approval — like the finest alchemy — will turn into virtue and honour.' And Cassius: 'You have understood him, his value, and how badly we need him, exactly right.'

Deep meaning: Alchemy was the supposed art of turning base metal into gold. Casca's simile is brutally honest: the deed is an 'offence' — he uses the word — and Brutus's 'countenance' (his face, his approval, his public support) is wanted to transmute it. This is the clearest statement in the act of what the conspiracy is: a crime in search of a respectable face. 'Conceited' means conceived, understood. Cassius's 'Three parts of him / Is ours already' treats Brutus as a thing to be acquired in fractions — the mirror, the mettle to be wrought, the names, and now the purchase.

Subtext: Neither man believes the deed is virtuous in itself; they believe Brutus can make it look so. The irony is that Brutus will believe it is virtuous, and his honest conviction will lead him to the errors — sparing Antony, allowing the funeral speech — that destroy them.

Character: Casca: shrewder than his bluntness suggests, and cynical about appearances. Cassius: already counting Brutus as won.

Theme: Appearance versus reality; honour as a commodity; public opinion; manipulation.

Device: Simile (alchemy); the metal imagery that links 'mettle', 'wrought' and 'alchemy' across the act; metaphor of possession ('ours'); closing rhymeless couplet of resolve.

Historical connection: HISTORICAL RECORD — Plutarch states plainly that the conspirators believed Brutus's reputation would make the deed seem honourable, and that without him it would seem merely a plot; Shakespeare gives Plutarch's judgement to Casca as an image. Alchemy was a living Elizabethan pursuit, so the simile would have sounded modern, not quaint.

Scene connection: The act ends where Scene 2's soliloquy pointed: at Brutus's door before dawn. Act 2 opens with Brutus awake in his orchard. The alchemy fails in Act 3, when the 'offence' is not transmuted but exposed by Antony, and the 'people's hearts' Casca counts on are won away in an afternoon.

ICSE keywords: simile; alchemy; appearance versus reality; reputation; metal imagery; dramatic irony.

Possible answer use: 'Casca's hope that Brutus's "countenance, like richest alchemy, / Will change to virtue and to worthiness" an act he himself calls an "offence" exposes the conspiracy's dependence on appearances, and Antony's oration in Act 3 is the moment the gold turns back to lead.'

QUOTATION QUICK-INDEX

Use this table on the second and later readings. 'Best use' names the kind of answer in which the line does most work: an Act 1 extract question (Class IX), a character or theme question, or an Act 3–5 answer (Class X) where the Act 1 line supplies motive, irony or earlier context. Themes are given in their shortest form; the full entries above carry the detail.

No.	First words	Speaker	Theme	Best use
1	"Hence! Home, you idle creatures"	Flavius	Public opinion; class	Opening of the play; the crowd as something to be commanded
2	"a mender of bad soles"	Cobbler	Appearance vs reality; wordplay	Pun and comic relief; the commoners' wit
3	"a surgeon to old shoes"	Cobbler	Public opinion; irony	Mock-heroic; the apolitical citizen

No.	First words	Speaker	Theme	Best use
4	"You blocks, you stones"	Marullus	Fickle crowd; loyalty	The crowd's amnesia; link to Act 3 Forum
5	"That Tiber trembled"	Marullus	Mob psychology; memory	The shout that serves two masters
6	"That comes in triumph over Pompey's blood"	Marullus	Ingratitude; betrayal	The Pompeian grievance; Pompey's statue in Act 3
7	"These growing feathers"	Flavius	Tyranny; liberty	First attempt to cut Caesar down; link to the conspiracy
8	"When Caesar says 'Do this,'"	Antony	Loyalty; power	Antony underrated; Act 3 revenge
9	"Beware the ides of March"	Soothsayer / Caesar	Fate; omens; pride	Prophecy and dismissal; irony of the assassination
10	"poor Brutus, with himself at war"	Brutus	Inner conflict	The tragic hero's division; Act 2 soliloquy
11	"I, your glass"	Cassius	Manipulation; reflection	Persuasion disguised as revelation; the letters
12	"The name of honour more than I fear death"	Brutus	Honour; idealism	Brutus's creed; every later error made in honour's name
13	"I, as Aeneas, our great ancestor"	Cassius	Jealousy; Caesar's body	The private root of the conspiracy
14	"Like a Colossus"	Cassius	Power; jealousy	Caesar's size as insult; imagery of unnatural growth
15	"The fault, dear Brutus, is not in our stars"	Cassius	Fate vs free will	The founding belief, and its irony
16	"'Brutus' will start a spirit"	Cassius	Names; honour; ancestry	The auction of vanity; old Brutus's statue
17	"Brutus had rather be a villager"	Brutus	Republicanism; liberty	Conditional consent; link to Act 2 decision
18	"a lean and hungry look"	Caesar	Appearance vs reality; danger	Caesar's shrewdness and his failure to act
19	"for always I am Caesar"	Caesar	Public vs private self	The deaf ear; Caesar's self-mythology
20	"he would fain have had it"	Casca	Ambition; point of view	The crown-offering; Antony's reversal in Act 3
21	"as they use to do the players in the theatre"	Casca	Mob psychology; theatre	Politics as performance; the Forum scene
22	"we have the falling sickness"	Cassius	Jealousy; Caesar's body	The grim pun; Brutus's compassion contrasted
23	"Thy honourable mettle may be wrought"	Cassius	Manipulation; forgery	Soliloquy of intent; the letters
24	"a tempest dropping fire"	Casca	Omens; disorder	Pathetic fallacy; change of register
25	"let not men say / 'These are their reasons'"	Casca	Superstition vs reason	The catalogue of prodigies

No.	First words	Speaker	Theme	Best use
26	"men may construe things after their fashion"	Cicero	Misreading; scepticism	The play's theory of misinterpretation
27	"Have bared my bosom to the thunder-stone"	Cassius	Fate; manliness	The rationalist turned prophet
28	"yet prodigious grown"	Cassius	Tyranny; manipulation	Caesar as the storm; Casca names him
29	"Cassius from bondage will deliver Cassius"	Cassius	Liberty vs bondage; suicide	Stoic creed; forecast of Act 5
30	"Hold. My hand."	Casca / Cassius	Faction; recruitment	Casca joins; contrast with Brutus's slow consent
31	"But win the noble Brutus to our party"	Cinna	Reputation	Why the conspiracy needs Brutus
32	"like richest alchemy"	Casca / Cassius	Appearance vs reality	A crime in search of a face; Act 3 exposure

REVISION The ten lines to know if you can know only ten

EXAM-ORIENTED ADVICE. If time is short, make sure of numbers 4, 9, 11, 12, 14, 15, 18, 20, 26 and 32. Between them they cover the crowd, fate, manipulation, honour, Caesar's two selves, the crown, misreading and the conspiracy's dependence on Brutus — and each of them is a line that a later act answers. Learn them with their speaker, their listener and the sentence that precedes them, not as bare words.

HOW TO EMBED A QUOTATION

ICSE EXAM BOX How to embed a quotation so that it earns marks

EXAM-ORIENTED ADVICE. Examiners reward quotations that are *used*, not displayed. Three rules, each with a worked example from this bank.

Rule 1 — Quote short and embed. A quotation should sit inside your own sentence, grammatically, and be no longer than the point needs. Compare: 'Cassius says: "Why, man, he doth bestride the narrow world / Like a Colossus, and we petty men / Walk under his huge legs and peep about / To find ourselves dishonourable graves."' That is four lines of Shakespeare and no marks, because nothing has been argued. Now: 'Cassius makes Caesar's greatness a personal insult, shrinking Brutus to one of the "petty men" who "peep about" beneath a "Colossus".' Three fragments, one sentence, and the analysis is already under way.

Rule 2 — Never let a quotation speak for itself. Every quotation must be followed by analysis: what the word choice does, what it reveals, where it leads. The pattern is claim → quotation → comment. Example: 'Caesar's self-image is a role rather than a man (claim); he insists "for always I am Caesar" even as he admits "this ear is deaf" (quotation); the gap between the public name and the failing body in consecutive lines is Shakespeare's compact portrait of a ruler who can no longer hear what he needs to (comment).' A quotation without the comment is a quotation left to do your work for you, and the examiner will not do it either.

Rule 3 — Show line breaks with a slash. When you quote more than one line of verse inside your prose, mark the end of each line with a forward slash with a space on either side, and keep the capital letter that begins the new line: "The fault, dear Brutus, is not in our stars, / But in ourselves, that we are underlings." If you set out three or more lines, you may instead write them as separate lines, indented, exactly as printed. Casca's prose needs no slashes — quote it as ordinary sentences: "to my thinking, he would fain have had it".

Three further habits. Name the speaker and the listener the first time ('Cassius tells Brutus that...'), because the same words from a different mouth would mean something else. Put a single word in quotation marks when the word itself is the point — Brutus loves "The name of honour", and the word 'name' is where the analysis lies. And keep your own words in single quotation marks and Shakespeare's in double, so the examiner can see at a glance where the text ends and your thinking begins.

An honest note on marks. In the current ICSE paper the drama extract carries 16 marks in sub-parts, and the higher sub-parts reward the explained link — context to meaning, meaning to theme, theme to the wider play. Act 1 itself is examined in Class IX; in the Class X paper on Acts III–V an embedded Act 1 line is the surest way to show that you understand why a later moment matters. Nothing here guarantees a question; everything here raises the quality of whatever answer you write.

CROSS-REFERENCE Where to go next

Every **Scene connection:** in this bank is followed through Acts 2–5 in 'The Scene Connection Engine and Where Act 1 Reappears Later'. To practise embedding under examination conditions, work through 'Extract-Based Training (Part One)' and '(Part Two)', where these same lines appear inside full extract questions with weak and excellent model answers. The devices named here are defined in 'The Act 1 Literary-Device Bank', and the terms under **ICSE keywords:** are unpacked in 'The ICSE Keyword Vault for Act 1'.

CHAPTER 16

The Scene Connection Engine and Where Act 1 Reappears Later

This chapter stops treating Act 1 as three separate scenes and teaches it as one machine, in which every event is a cause of something later and an echo of something earlier. Part A gives you a compact 'connection block' for eighteen events, from the Cobbler's holiday to the last line of Scene 3, and then draws the nine threads that run through the whole play as vertical chain diagrams. Part B tracks thirteen Act 1 ideas forward into Acts 2 to 5, showing exactly what changes when each one reappears and why that change matters. You finish able to explain any moment of the later play by reaching back to its Act 1 root.

Why 'connection' is the skill that separates grades

Most students who struggle with Shakespeare learn scenes as beads on a string: Scene 1 is the commoners, Scene 2 is the crown, Scene 3 is the storm. That is Level 1 knowledge, and it is not useless. But the examiner who reads an answer on Act 3 Scene 2 is looking for something else: a student who can say *why* the crowd behaves as it does at the funeral, and who can trace that behaviour back to the Cobbler laughing at the tribunes in the first thirty lines of the play. Shakespeare built *Julius Caesar* as a system of echoes. Almost nothing happens in Acts 3 to 5 that is not planted in Act 1, and almost nothing is planted in Act 1 that does not pay off later. Learning the connections is therefore not an extra; it is the difference between retelling and analysing.

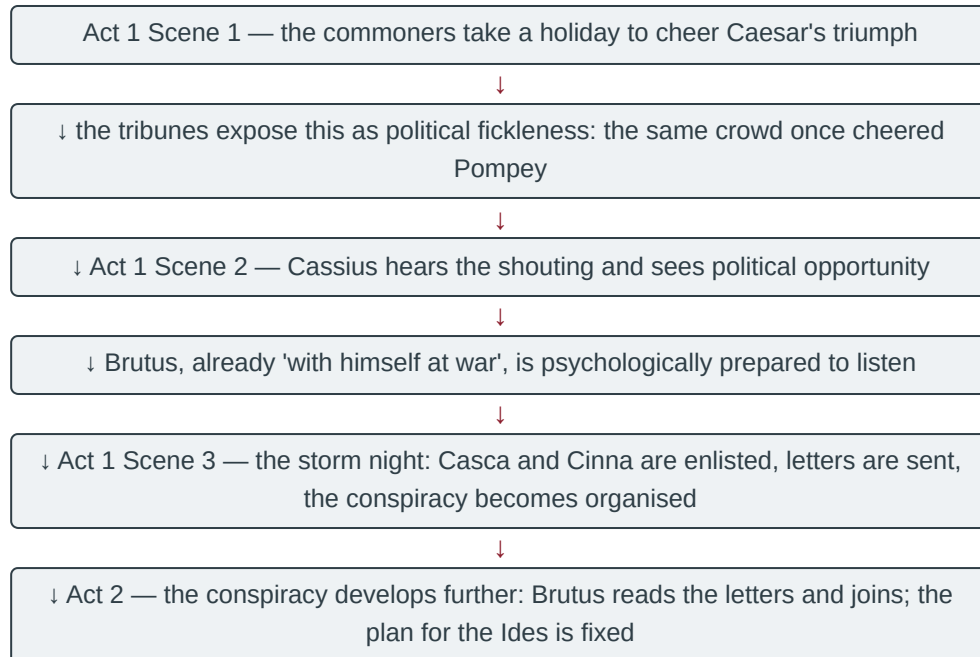
The chapter works in two directions. Part A looks *within* Act 1: how a line in Scene 1 prepares a line in Scene 3. Part B looks *beyond* it: how a line in Act 1 prepares a scene in Act 5. Throughout, a few conventions apply. Anything in double quotation marks is Shakespeare's verified wording from Act 1. Anything from a later act is paraphrased or put in single quotation marks, because this book verifies Act 1 word for word and will not pretend to the same certainty about lines it has not printed. Where I offer a reading that critics dispute, I say so.

CROSS-REFERENCE Where this chapter sits in the book

This chapter assumes you have already worked through the three scene chapters ('Act 1 Scene 1 — The Street', 'Act 1 Scene 2 (Part One)', 'Act 1 Scene 2 (Part Two)', 'Act 1 Scene 3 — The Storm') and the three character masterclasses on Caesar, Cassius and Brutus. It does not re-explain what happens; it explains how what happens fits together. 'The Final Act 1 Master Map and What Shakespeare Is Doing' prints a shorter version of the chains here as a revision spine. 'ICSE Examiner Mode: How Marks Are Earned' shows how to turn a connection into a scoring paragraph. 'Themes of Act 1 (Part One)' and '(Part Two)' give the full discussion of each theme that Part B of this chapter only traces forward.

The engine in one picture

Before the detail, here is the example that the whole chapter grows from. Read it downward, one step at a time, and notice that every arrow is a *because*: each step is possible only because the step above it has happened.



Notice what this chain teaches that a plot summary cannot. The crowd's fickleness is not just a theme 'shown' in Scene 1; it is the *fuel* Cassius burns in Scene 2, because a people who can be turned from Pompey to Caesar can be turned from Caesar to anyone, and that is exactly the fear he plants in Brutus when the shouts are heard. Brutus's inner war is not just a character trait; it is the *condition* that makes Cassius's words land. And the storm is not just atmosphere; it is the *cover* under which the plot stops being talk and becomes paper, names and a meeting-place. Every chain in this chapter works like this: a sequence of conditions, each created by the last.

PART A — The Scene Connection Engine

How to read the connection blocks

Each important event of Act 1 gets a block with five fixed labels. **What it introduces** names something that appears for the first time. **What it develops** names something already present that the event pushes further. **What it foreshadows** names what the event prepares, inside Act 1 or beyond. **What it contrasts with** names the moment Shakespeare has set it against, because he teaches by juxtaposition as much as by sequence. **What it connects to later** names the scene in Acts 2 to 5 where the event pays off. Read the blocks in order the first time; afterwards, use them as a lookup table when you are writing about any later scene.

Scene 1

EVENT 1 — THE COMMONERS' HOLIDAY

The play opens with working men in their best clothes, idling in the street because, as the Cobbler says, "we make holiday to see Caesar and to rejoice in his triumph."

What it introduces: The Roman people as a character in their own right: cheerful, witty, unpolitical, and present in the street before any great man appears. It also introduces the social gap of the play — prose for the commoners, verse for the tribunes — which is a gap of power as much as of language.

What it develops: Nothing yet, since this is the first event; but it establishes the baseline against which every later crowd will be measured.

What it foreshadows: A people who gather to celebrate whoever is winning. The holiday mood will become the triple shout of Scene 2, and the triple shout will become the funeral crowd of Act 3.

What it contrasts with: The tribunes' anger that follows at once, and, further off, Cassius's bitter vision of the people as "sheep" in Scene 3. Shakespeare gives us the crowd as harmless fun before anyone calls it dangerous, so that we can judge both views.

What it connects to later: Act 3 Scene 2, where the same kind of crowd is addressed by Brutus and then Antony, and Act 3 Scene 3, where its good humour has curdled into murder.

EVENT 2 — THE TRIBUNES' REBUKE AND THE POMPEY SHIFT

Marullus turns the holiday into an accusation: "Knew you not Pompey?" He reminds the crowd that they once climbed to "chimney tops" to see Pompey pass, and now "strew flowers in his way / That comes in triumph over Pompey's blood".

What it introduces: Pompey, the dead rival whose name will haunt the play; the idea of *ingratitude* as a political crime; and the first act of political rhetoric in the play, a speech designed to change what a crowd feels.

What it develops: The commoners' holiday, by revealing what it means: the people have transferred their love from one strong man to another without noticing.

What it foreshadows: Every later attempt to move a crowd by speech. Marullus's method is reproach — shaming the people with their own memory. Antony will use the same memory of past love in Act 3, but he will add gifts and grief, and he will succeed where Marullus merely clears the street.

What it contrasts with: The Cobbler's puns a moment earlier. Prose jokes about mending soles are answered by verse about "Pompey's blood"; the switch of register tells the audience that the stakes have risen.

What it connects to later: Act 3 Scene 1 and Act 3 Scene 2, where Caesar falls at the base of Pompey's statue and Antony reminds the crowd of it; Act 5 Scene 1, where Cassius, forced to stake everything on one battle, compares himself to Pompey at Pharsalus.

EVENT 3 — STRIPPING THE IMAGES

Flavius orders: "Disrobe the images / If you do find them decked with ceremonies", and overrides Marullus's worry about the feast of Lupercal: "It is no matter. Let no images / Be hung with Caesar's trophies." He ends with the falconry image of plucking "growing feathers" from Caesar's wing.

What it introduces: Direct action against Caesar's rising power, and the play's obsession with Caesar's *image* — statues, trophies, the public picture of the man as distinct from the man himself.

What it develops: The tribunes' republican fear, turning it from words to deeds.

What it foreshadows: The punishment of the tribunes, reported by Casca in Scene 2; and the far more violent 'undressing' of Caesar's image that the conspirators attempt with daggers.

What it contrasts with: Caesar's own command in Scene 2 to "leave no ceremony out". The tribunes strip ceremony away; Caesar insists on it. The two attitudes to ceremony are the two attitudes to Caesar's greatness.

What it connects to later: Act 2 Scene 2, where Calpurnia dreams of Caesar's statue running with blood — the image attacked in a dream before the body is attacked in fact; and Act 3 Scene 2, where Antony displays Caesar's torn mantle and wounded body to the crowd, the last and most devastating 'disrobing' of the play.

PROFESSOR'S INSIGHT The two tribunes are the conspiracy in miniature

It is tempting to treat Scene 1 as a warm-up, but Flavius and Marullus do, in forty lines, what Brutus and Cassius will spend four acts doing: they diagnose Caesar as a danger to liberty, they act against his symbols, and they are destroyed for it. **LITERARY INTERPRETATION:** many critics read the tribunes as a dress rehearsal for the conspirators, and the reading is strong because Shakespeare makes the parallel structural. Flavius's falconry image — clip the wing now, or Caesar will "soar above the view of men / And keep us all in servile fearfulness" — is Cassius's argument before Cassius makes it. The crucial difference is scale: the tribunes attack decorations and are "put to silence"; the conspirators attack the man and start a civil war. Shakespeare seems to be asking whether the problem was ever Caesar's images at all, or whether the real power lay in the crowd that hung them there. Notice too that the tribunes vanish from the play without a farewell. Their silencing is delivered as an afterthought in Casca's gossip, which tells us how cheaply opposition is disposed of in Caesar's Rome — and how little the great men on stage care about two officials who stood where they now stand.

Scene 2 — the first half

EVENT 4 — CAESAR'S INSTRUCTION ABOUT CALPURNIA

Caesar's first business in the play is to position his wife in Antony's path during the Lupercal race: "Forget not in your speed, Antonius, / To touch Calpurnia, for our elders say / The barren, touchèd in this holy chase, / Shake off their sterile curse."

What it introduces: Caesar as a man who commands even intimate matters in public; Caesar's childlessness, which is a political fact (no heir) as well as a private one; Caesar's reliance on what "our elders say" — tradition and superstition; and Antony as the obedient instrument ("When Caesar says 'Do this,' it is performed").

What it develops: The idea of Caesar's power already glimpsed in the tribunes' fear. We saw the images; now we see the man, and his very first words are orders.

What it foreshadows: Caesar's later wavering between belief and bravado when the omens turn against him; the question of succession that Octavius will eventually answer; and Antony's role as the man who performs Caesar's will even after Caesar is dead.

What it contrasts with: The Soothsayer, who speaks seconds later. Caesar accepts a fertility rite on the authority of "our elders" and dismisses a warning about his own death as a dream. He is superstitious where it costs nothing and sceptical where it costs everything.

What it connects to later: Act 2 Scene 2, where Calpurnia, now the one who believes in signs, begs Caesar to stay home, and he yields to her and then overrides her; Act 3 Scene 2, where Antony reads Caesar's will and the childless man's legacy is distributed to the crowd.

EVENT 5 — THE SOOTHSAYER

A voice from the crowd, "shriller than all the music", cries out and twice delivers the warning: "Beware the ides of March." Caesar looks at the man and rules: "He is a dreamer. Let us leave him. Pass."

What it introduces: The supernatural dimension of the play; fate as a voice that speaks plainly and is not heard; the date that will become the play's centre of gravity.

What it develops: Caesar's habit of command, now turned on the future itself. He does not argue with the warning; he dismisses it as a thing beneath him.

What it foreshadows: The whole catastrophe. It is the clearest foreshadowing in the play, and Shakespeare makes it clear on purpose: the audience is to know what Caesar refuses to know.

What it contrasts with: Caesar's own "Set on and leave no ceremony out" a moment earlier. The man who will not omit a ritual omits the one warning that matters. It also contrasts with Brutus, who repeats the warning aloud to Caesar — the future assassin is, for a moment, the messenger who tries to save him.

What it connects to later: Act 2 Scene 4, where the Soothsayer waits in the street to try again; Act 3 Scene 1, where Caesar taunts him that the Ides have come and is told, in effect, that they have come but not gone; Act 4 Scene 3 and Act 5 Scene 1, where the Ides are remembered by the men who made them fatal.

EVENT 6 — BRUTUS 'WITH HIMSELF AT WAR'

Left alone with Cassius, Brutus explains his coldness: he is "vexèd" by "passions of some difference", and "poor Brutus, with himself at war, / Forgets the shows of love to other men."

What it introduces: Brutus's inner conflict, stated by Brutus himself before anyone has tried to recruit him. This is the most important single fact about the conspiracy: it does not begin in Cassius's mouth but in Brutus's mind.

What it develops: Brutus's earlier admission that he is "not gamesome" and lacks "that quick spirit that is in Antony" — the sense of a man standing apart from the festival of Caesar's Rome.

What it foreshadows: Brutus's orchard soliloquy in Act 2 Scene 1, where the war within him is fought to a conclusion; the quarrel with Cassius in Act 4; and his final conviction that he has found no man untrue to him, which only a man at war with himself could say after killing his friend.

What it contrasts with: Cassius's clarity. Cassius knows exactly what he wants; Brutus does not yet know what he feels. Shakespeare gives the most decisive act of the play to its least decided man.

What it connects to later: Act 2 Scene 1 (the soliloquy and the decision), Act 4 Scene 3 (the quarrel and the ghost, where the war inside Brutus takes visible form), Act 5 Scene 5 (the suicide that ends it).

EVENT 7 — THE OFFSTAGE SHOUTS

Twice the dialogue is broken by a flourish and a shout from the games. Brutus: "What means this shouting? I do fear the people / Choose Caesar for their king." Cassius seizes the word: "Ay, do you fear it? / Then must I think you would not have it so."

What it introduces: The technique of the *offstage crowd*, whose noise reaches the stage without its meaning. Also the word 'fear' in Brutus's mouth, and the word 'king', which neither man has dared to say until the crowd forces it.

What it develops: The public opinion thread from Scene 1. The commoners' holiday cheer has become a roar that the aristocrats on stage cannot interpret and can only dread.

What it foreshadows: Casca's report, which will finally explain the shouts; and the Act 3 crowd, which will shout for Brutus and then for Antony with the same lungs.

What it contrasts with: The silence in which Brutus has been keeping his thoughts. The crowd's noise drags his private fear into the open, and Cassius pounces on the word the instant it is spoken.

What it connects to later: Act 3 Scene 2, where the crowd's shouts are heard on stage and their meaning is all too plain; the offstage roar of Act 1 becomes the onstage mob of Act 3.

EVENT 8 — CASSIUS'S TIBER AND FEVER ANECDOTES

Cassius tells two stories: Caesar challenged him to swim the flooded Tiber and had to be rescued ("Help me, Cassius, or I sink!"), and Caesar shook with fever in Spain ("Tis true, this god did shake") and begged for drink "As a sick girl".

What it introduces: Caesar's *body* as an argument. For the first time the man the tribunes feared as a soaring bird is shown as weak flesh. It also introduces Cassius's method of persuasion by anecdote — vivid, personal, unverifiable.

What it develops: Brutus's declared love of "the name of honour". Cassius has just said "honour is the subject of my story", and the stories are built to make Brutus feel that bowing to a weak man is dishonourable.

What it foreshadows: Casca's report of Caesar's swoon minutes later, which will confirm the picture of frailty from an independent mouth; and Caesar's own insistence on his constancy in Act 3, which the audience will hear against the memory of the sick girl.

What it contrasts with: Caesar's "for always I am Caesar" later in the same scene. Cassius says the god shook; Caesar says the god does not fear. The scene puts the two claims side by side and lets Casca's report decide between them.

What it connects to later: Act 2 Scene 2, where Caesar's body is the subject again (the dream, the omens, the decision to go out); Act 3 Scene 1, where the body is finally destroyed; Act 5 Scene 3, where Cassius, who boasted of saving Caesar from the river, dies saying Caesar is revenged.

EVENT 9 — THE COLOSSUS SPEECH

After the second shout Cassius rises to his great image: "he doth bestride the narrow world / Like a Colossus, and we petty men / Walk under his huge legs", then the turn to responsibility — "The fault, dear Brutus, is not in our stars, / But in ourselves, that we are underlings" — and finally the game with names, in which 'Brutus' weighs as much as 'Caesar', and the reminder of the ancestor who drove out a king.

What it introduces: The philosophical claim that men make their own fates; the comparison of names; and the appeal to Brutus's ancestry, the republican founding-story that gives the conspiracy its legitimacy.

What it develops: The honour argument of the anecdotes, lifting it from Caesar's weakness to Brutus's duty. The anecdotes said Caesar is small; the Colossus speech says *you* are allowing him to be big.

What it foreshadows: The letters, which will repeat the appeal to the first Brutus in writing; Brutus's soliloquy, which borrows Cassius's logic of 'what he may become'; and the irony of 'masters of their fates' in a play where the Soothsayer has just been proved more reliable than any master.

What it contrasts with: The Soothsayer's "Beware the ides of March." Within a hundred lines the play has offered fate as a spoken warning and free will as a spoken philosophy. The tragedy is built on the collision.

What it connects to later: Act 2 Scene 1 (the letter's appeal to the old Brutus), Act 3 Scene 3 (where a man dies for his *name* alone — Cinna the poet), Act 5 Scene 1 (where Cassius, who denied the stars, reads his fate in birds).

EVENT 10 — CAESAR'S JUDGEMENT OF CASSIUS

Returning from the games, Caesar tells Antony: "Yond Cassius has a lean and hungry look. / He thinks too much. Such men are dangerous." He adds that Cassius "reads much", "looks / Quite through the deeds of men", "hears no music" and is "never at heart's ease / Whiles they behold a greater than themselves", and then: "I rather tell thee what is to be feared / Than what I fear; for always I am Caesar. / Come on my right hand, for this ear is deaf."

What it introduces: Caesar's political intelligence — this is the most accurate character reading anyone gives in Act 1 — and, in the same breath, the self-image that makes the intelligence useless: he will not fear what he has just described. The deaf ear is the body's confession that the public Caesar is not the whole man.

What it develops: The body thread begun by Cassius's anecdotes, now from Caesar's own mouth; and the appearance-versus-reality thread, since Caesar judges by looks ("Would he were fatter!").

What it foreshadows: Antony's underestimation of Cassius ("he's not dangerous") is the mirror of the conspirators' later underestimation of Antony. Each side misreads the other's most dangerous man.

What it contrasts with: The Soothsayer scene. Caesar can read Cassius but not the warning; he hears gossip on his good ear and fate on his deaf one.

What it connects to later: Act 2 Scene 1, where Brutus dismisses Antony as harmless, echoing Antony's dismissal of Cassius; Act 3 Scene 1, where Caesar's 'always I am Caesar' becomes the speech about his own constancy moments before he falls.

EVENT 11 — CASCA'S CROWN REPORT

Casca explains the shouts: Antony offered Caesar a crown three times, Caesar refused it each time "every time gentler than other", and to Casca's eye "he would fain have had it". The crowd "hooted and clapped their chopped hands", Caesar "swooned and fell down", "foamed at mouth and was speechless", and before falling "plucked me ope his doublet and offered them his throat to cut".

What it introduces: The crown as a physical object, the question of Caesar's real ambition, and Casca's cynical voice — the first speaker who treats the whole of Roman politics as "foolery".

What it develops: Three threads at once: public opinion (the crowd applauds refusal, so Caesar refuses); Caesar's body (the swoon confirms Cassius's anecdotes); and appearance versus reality (the refusal may be a performance — Casca compares the crowd to a theatre audience who "clap him and hiss him" as they do "the players").

What it foreshadows: Brutus's agonised conclusion in Act 2 that Caesar must be judged by what the crown *would* make him; and Antony's use of the same three refusals in Act 3 as proof that Caesar was *not* ambitious. The same fact will be read two opposite ways.

What it contrasts with: Cassius's heroic rhetoric. Cassius spoke of Colossus and Aeneas; Casca speaks of sweaty nightcaps and stinking breath. The two styles describe the same Rome, and the audience must decide which is truer.

What it connects to later: Act 3 Scene 2, where Antony reminds the crowd that Caesar thrice refused a crown on the Lupercal; Act 3 Scene 1, where Casca, the mocking reporter, becomes the man who strikes first.

EVENT 12 — THE TRIBUNES 'PUT TO SILENCE'

Almost as an afterthought Casca adds: "Marullus and Flavius, for pulling scarves off Caesar's images, are put to silence."

What it introduces: The cost of opposing Caesar, stated for the first time. The phrase is deliberately vague — deposed, exiled or killed, the text does not say — and the vagueness is part of its menace.

What it develops: Scene 1, which it closes like a trapdoor. The two men who opened the play have been removed from it in a single clause.

What it foreshadows: Caesar's refusal in Act 3 to hear any plea, and the proscriptions of Act 4, in which the victors silence their enemies with a list of names.

What it contrasts with: Caesar's public refusal of the crown moments earlier in the same report. A man who will not wear a crown has nevertheless silenced two elected officers for touching his decorations; the contrast is the whole argument for the conspiracy, delivered by accident.

What it connects to later: Act 3 Scene 3 (a poet silenced by the mob for his name), Act 4 Scene 1 (the triumvirs' death-list, which includes Cicero), and Act 4 Scene 3 (news that many senators are dead).

EVENT 13 — CASSIUS'S SOLILOQUY AND THE LETTERS

Alone, Cassius judges his friend: "Well, Brutus, thou art noble. Yet I see / Thy honourable mettle may be wrought / From that it is disposed." He asks, "For who so firm that cannot be seduced?", notes that "Caesar doth bear me hard, but he loves Brutus", and announces the plan to throw writings "in at his windows", "As if they came from several citizens", in which "Caesar's ambition shall be glanced at".

What it introduces: The letters, the first act of outright deception in the play; and Cassius's private voice, which the audience hears with a shock after a whole scene of his public one.

What it develops: The manipulation thread to its logical end. Cassius has used stories, images and flattery; now he will use forgery. It also develops the public opinion thread in a new key: Cassius will *fabricate* public opinion to move Brutus.

What it foreshadows: Brutus's reading of the letter in Act 2 Scene 1 and the instructions to Cinna in Scene 3, which show the plan in execution.

What it contrasts with: Everything Cassius said to Brutus's face. 'Honour is the subject of my story,' he said; alone, the subject is seduction. **LITERARY INTERPRETATION:** many readers take the soliloquy as proof that Cassius is a villain; others note that he also says Brutus is noble and that noble minds should keep with their likes, and read him as a sincere republican who believes the end justifies the method. The text supports both and settles neither.

What it connects to later: Act 2 Scene 1 (the letter read aloud), Act 4 Scene 3 (the quarrel, where the gap between Cassius's methods and Brutus's ideals finally breaks open), Act 5 Scene 3 (Cassius's death by his own misreading of a scene, the manipulator deceived).

Scene 3

EVENT 14 — THE STORM AND THE PRODIGES

A month has passed in silence. Casca, sword drawn, tells Cicero of "a tempest dropping fire" and wonders whether "there is a civil strife in heaven" or "the world, too saucy with the gods, / Incenses them to send destruction". He lists the signs: the slave's burning hand "Not sensible of fire", the lion that "went surly by" near the Capitol, the women who saw "Men all in fire walk up and down the streets", the owl "at noonday upon the marketplace".

What it introduces: The supernatural made visible. Scene 2 gave us a voice of fate; Scene 3 gives us a sky of it. The phrase "civil strife in heaven" introduces the idea that the heavens mirror Rome — and civil strife is exactly what Rome is about to have.

What it develops: Casca himself: the "blunt fellow" who laughed at "foolery" is now trembling, a change that measures how far events have moved since the Lupercal.

What it foreshadows: Calpurnia's report of the same night's horrors, the omens before Philippi, and the night-time setting of the orchard and the ghost.

What it contrasts with: The sunlit public festival of Scenes 1 and 2. Daylight Rome was shouts and games; night-time Rome is fire and lions. Shakespeare moves the play from the forum to the dark the moment the plot moves from talk to action.

What it connects to later: Act 2 Scene 1 (Brutus reads by the light of the meteors), Act 2 Scene 2 (Calpurnia's night of omens and the heartless beast), Act 5 Scene 1 (Cassius's birds).

EVENT 15 — CICERO'S SCEPTICISM

Cicero grants that "it is a strange-disposed time" but warns: "men may construe things after their fashion, / Clean from the purpose of the things themselves." He then asks the practical question — "Comes Caesar to the Capitol tomorrow?" — and leaves, since "This disturbed sky / Is not to walk in."

What it introduces: The rational voice, and with it the play's central problem of *interpretation*: signs do not carry their own meanings; men supply them.

What it develops: The appearance-versus-reality thread, which until now has concerned Caesar's performances. Cicero widens it to the universe: even the sky can be misread.

What it foreshadows: Cassius, who enters next and immediately 'construes' the storm as a portrait of Caesar — proving Cicero right within twenty lines. It also foreshadows Decius's reinterpretation of Calpurnia's dream and the fatal misreading on the battlefield at Philippi.

What it contrasts with: Casca's terror and Cassius's exhilaration, the two emotional readings of the same storm that Cicero's calm sentence stands between.

What it connects to later: Act 2 Scene 1 (Cicero is proposed as a conspirator and rejected by Brutus), Act 2 Scene 2 (Decius 'construes' the bloody statue as a fountain of renewal), Act 4 Scene 3 (Cicero's death by proscription is reported), Act 5 Scene 3 (Pindarus misreads Titinius's capture and Cassius dies of the error).

EVENT 16 — CASSIUS'S RECRUITMENT OF CASCA

Cassius has walked bare-chested in the storm, baring his "bosom to the thunder-stone". He tells Casca he is dull, reads the storm as a warning "Unto some monstrous state", describes "a man / Most like this dreadful night" who is "no mightier than thyself or me / In personal action, yet prodigious grown", declares that "Cassius from bondage will deliver Cassius", and when Casca offers his hand says, "There's a bargain made."

What it introduces: The conspiracy as a *group* rather than a conversation; the dagger as an object; and the equation of Roman manhood with resistance ("Our yoke and sufferance show us womanish").

What it develops: Cassius's method, now adapted to a different man. With Brutus he spoke of honour and mirrors; with Casca he speaks of fear, shame and the storm. The adaptability is the point: he reads his listener and changes the key.

What it foreshadows: Casca's first blow in Act 3 Scene 1 — the man who promises to set his foot "as far / As who goes farthest" keeps his word with a dagger.

What it contrasts with: Cassius's seduction of Brutus, which took a whole scene and ended in 'I will consider'. Casca is won in a hundred lines with a handshake. The contrast tells you how much harder Brutus is to move, and therefore how much more he is worth.

What it connects to later: Act 3 Scene 1 (Casca strikes first), Act 2 Scene 1 (the conspirators gather, and the handshake becomes Brutus's refusal of an oath).

EVENT 17 — THE LETTERS GIVEN TO CINNA

Cinna arrives wishing Cassius "could / But win the noble Brutus to our party". Cassius hands over the papers: "lay it in the Praetor's chair, / Where Brutus may but find it; and throw this / In at his window; set this up with wax / Upon old Brutus' statue", and names the meeting-place, "Pompey's Porch".

What it introduces: The three targets of the letters — Brutus's office (the praetor's chair), Brutus's home (the window) and Brutus's ancestry (the statue) — and the conspirators' headquarters at Pompey's theatre.

What it develops: The soliloquy's plan, now in motion; and the Pompey thread from Scene 1, since the plot against Pompey's conqueror is hatched under Pompey's own portico.

What it foreshadows: Act 2 Scene 1, where the letter is delivered and read; and the location of Caesar's death at the base of Pompey's statue, which makes the meeting-place feel like a verdict.

What it contrasts with: Cassius's claim to Brutus that "many of the best respect in Rome" wish Brutus had his eyes. The 'many' turns out to be Cassius, Cinna and some wax.

What it connects to later: Act 2 Scene 1 (the letter), Act 2 Scene 3 and Act 3 Scene 1 (Artemidorus's true letter, which Caesar refuses to read — the forged letter is read and the honest one is not), Act 3 Scene 3 (another Cinna, torn apart for his name).

EVENT 18 — 'THREE PARTS OF HIM IS OURS'

Cassius closes the act: "Three parts of him / Is ours already, and the man entire / Upon the next encounter yields him ours." Casca explains why Brutus is needed — "he sits high in all the people's hearts", and his "countenance, like richest alchemy, / Will change to virtue and to worthiness" what would otherwise seem offence. Cassius: "it is after midnight, and ere day / We will awake him and be sure of him."

What it introduces: The conspiracy's dependence on Brutus's *reputation*, stated openly: he is wanted not for his judgement but for his face.

What it develops: The public opinion thread, in its most sophisticated form so far. The crowd that cheered Pompey and Caesar also reveres Brutus; the conspirators plan to borrow that reverence.

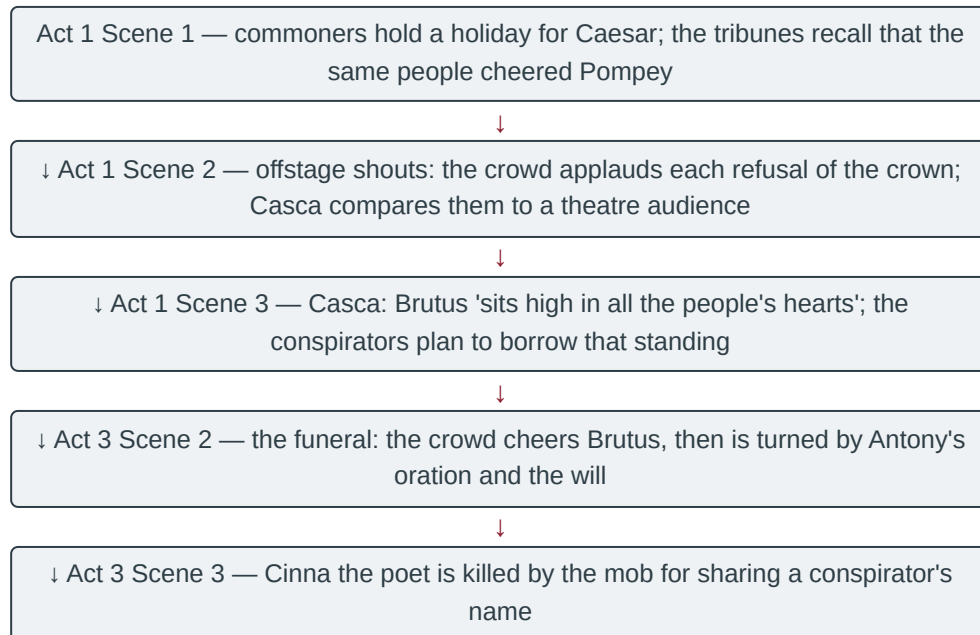
What it foreshadows: The fatal paradox of Acts 2 and 3: the man recruited for his public standing will make every strategic decision, and the crowd whose love he was meant to supply will turn on him in an afternoon.

What it contrasts with: The opening of the act. The play began at dawn-of-holiday with a crowd in the street; it ends after midnight with three men in a storm, planning to wake a fourth. The movement from open day to secret night is the movement of the whole act.

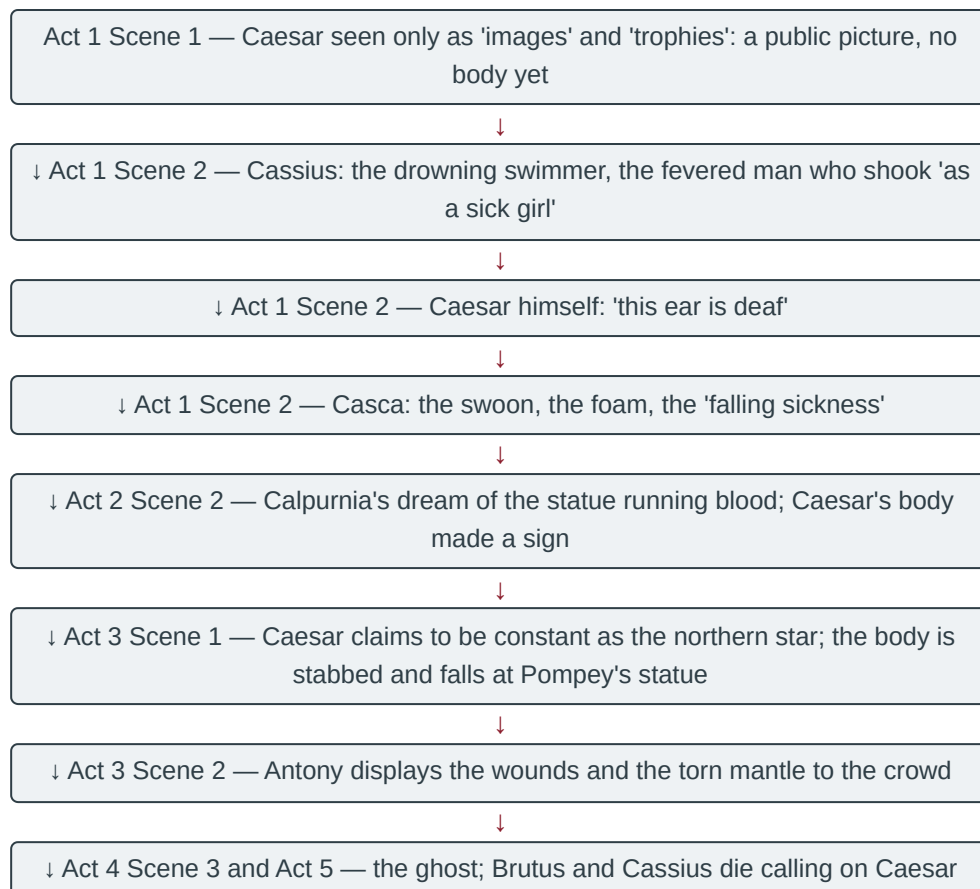
What it connects to later: Act 2 Scene 1 (the knock at Brutus's door, the entire man won), Act 3 Scene 2 (the alchemy tested on the crowd and found to work for exactly as long as Antony allows), Act 5 Scene 5 (Antony's tribute to Brutus as the one conspirator who acted for the general good — the alchemy acknowledged, too late, by the enemy).

The thread chains

The eighteen blocks above give you the events in order. The chains below give you the *threads*, each one running through all three scenes and on into the later play. Learn them vertically: each line is a step, each arrow a consequence. Later-act steps are paraphrased, not quoted.

THREAD 1 — PUBLIC OPINION

The lesson of the chain: the people never change their nature between Scene 1 and Act 3. What changes is who is speaking to them. Marullus reproaches, Caesar performs, Brutus reasons, Antony weeps and gives. Only the last works, and it works because Antony has understood what Scene 1 showed us.

THREAD 2 — CAESAR'S BODY

Shakespeare's irony is strict. The body that Cassius mocked as weak proves, in death, stronger than it was in life: a corpse and a ghost accomplish what the living Caesar could not.

THREAD 3 — BRUTUS'S CONFLICT

Act 1 Scene 2 — 'with himself at war': conflict declared before any temptation



↓ Act 1 Scene 2 — 'I would not, Cassius, yet I love him well': the two sides named
— republic and friendship



↓ Act 1 Scene 2 — 'What you have said / I will consider': the war is postponed, not
ended



↓ Act 1 Scene 3 — 'Three parts of him is ours': the conspirators believe the war is
nearly won



↓ Act 2 Scene 1 — the orchard soliloquy: Brutus decides Caesar must die for what
he might become



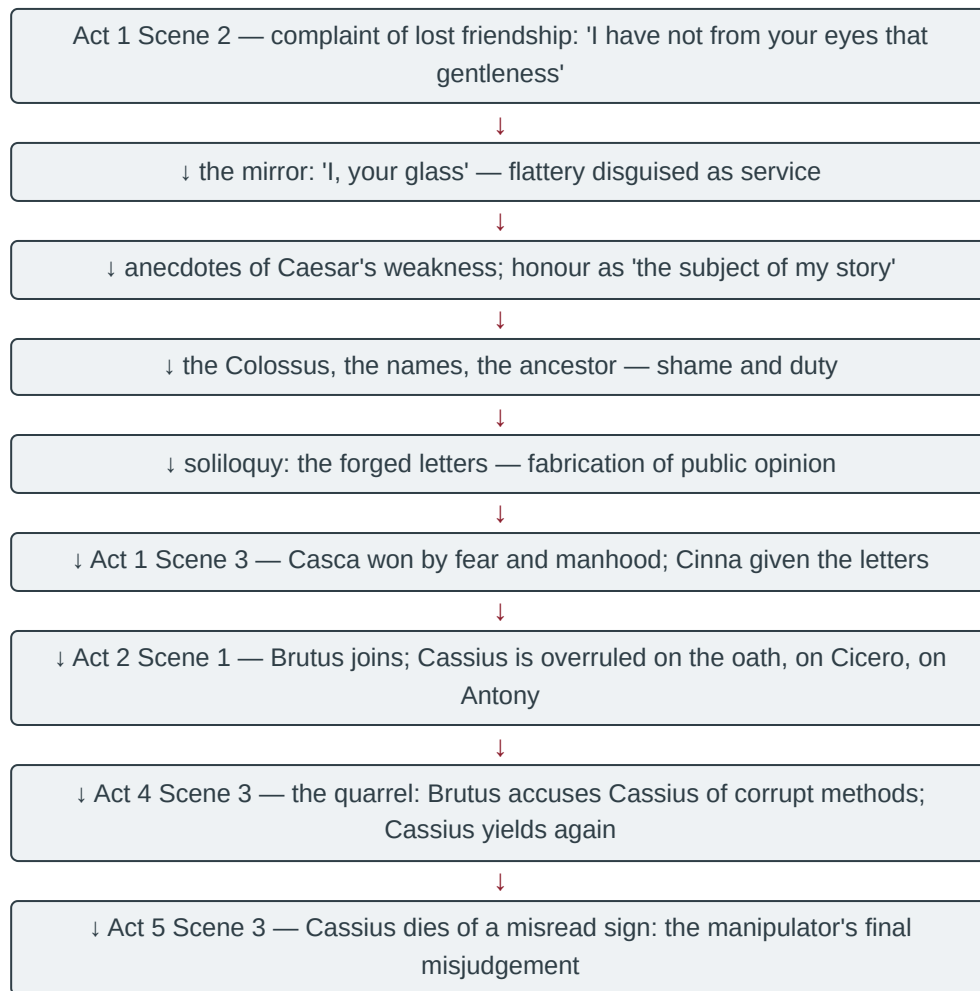
↓ Act 3 Scene 1 — the assassination; Caesar's last words name Brutus



↓ Act 4 Scene 3 — the quarrel and the ghost: the war inside Brutus takes outward
form



↓ Act 5 Scene 5 — suicide; he dies believing he has been true to everyone

THREAD 4 — CASSIUS'S METHOD

THREAD 5 — OMENS

Act 1 Scene 2 — the Soothsayer: 'Beware the ides of March'; Caesar: 'He is a dreamer'



↓ Act 1 Scene 3 — the storm; Casca's prodigies; Cicero: 'men may construe things after their fashion'



↓ Act 1 Scene 3 — Cassius construes the storm as Caesar



↓ Act 2 Scene 1 — Brutus reads by the meteors' light; a sign used as a lamp



↓ Act 2 Scene 2 — Calpurnia's dream; the beast without a heart; Decius reinterprets the dream



↓ Act 3 Scene 1 — the Ides arrive; the Soothsayer's second warning; the assassination



↓ Act 4 Scene 3 — the ghost promises to meet Brutus at Philippi



↓ Act 5 Scene 1 — Cassius, once a sceptic, reads the ravens, crows and kites as his doom

THREAD 6 — THE IDES

Act 1 Scene 2 — the warning spoken twice and dismissed



↓ Act 2 Scene 1 — Brutus asks the date; the Ides are tomorrow



↓ Act 2 Scene 4 — the Soothsayer waits in the street to try once more



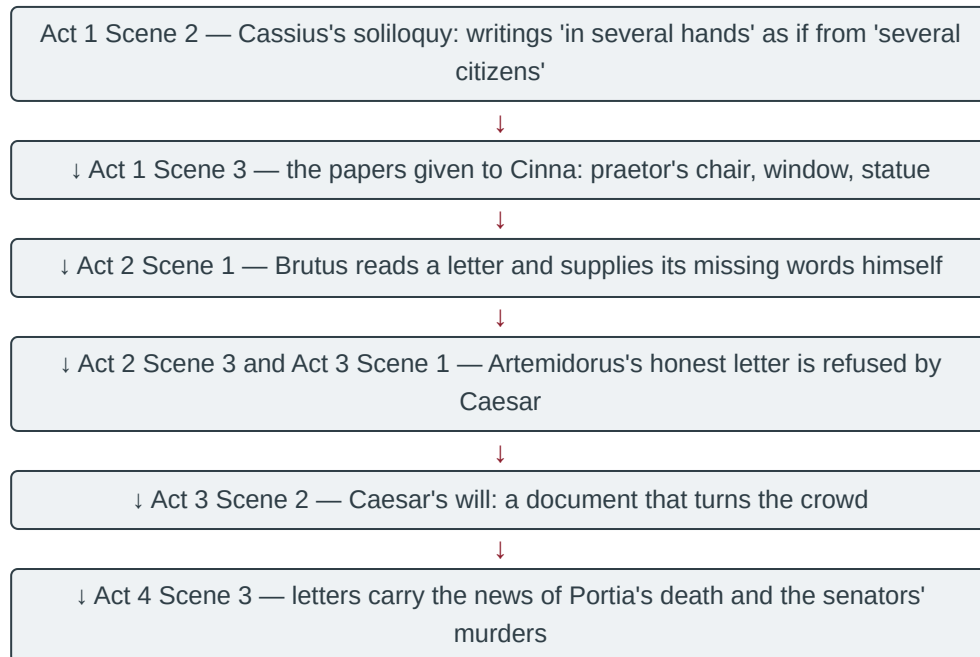
↓ Act 3 Scene 1 — Caesar: the Ides are come; Soothsayer: come, but not gone



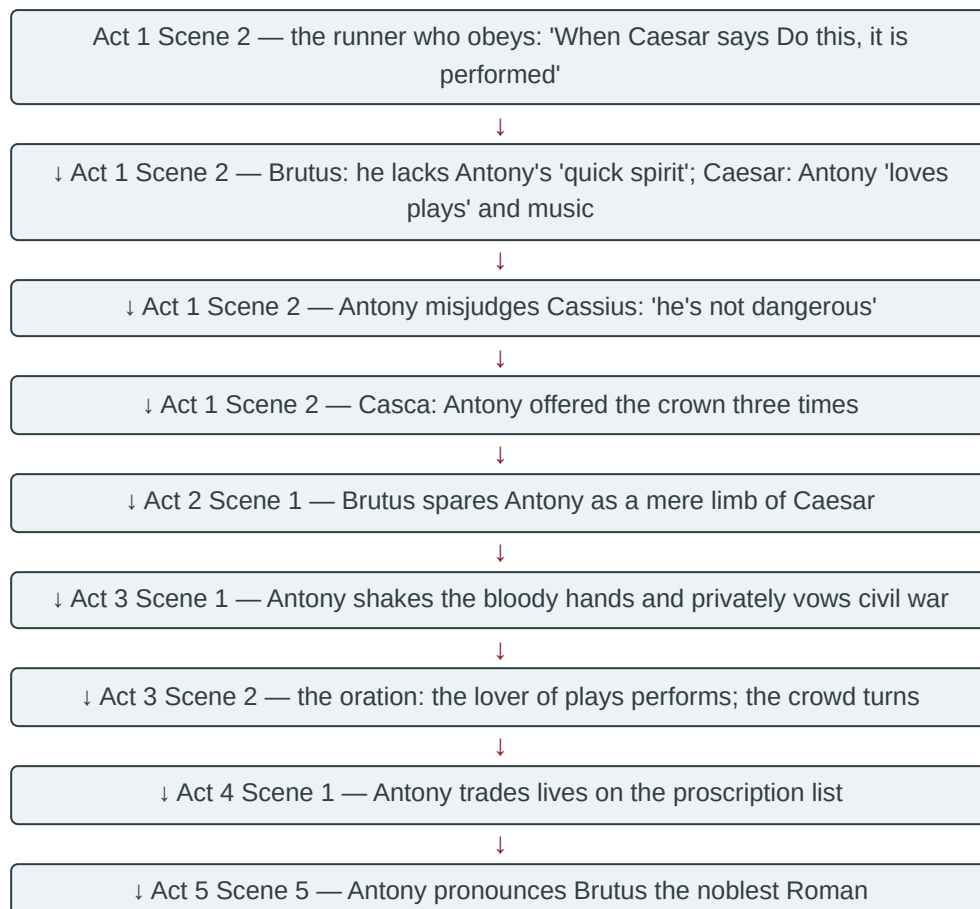
↓ Act 4 Scene 3 — Brutus reminds Cassius of the Ides to shame him over bribes



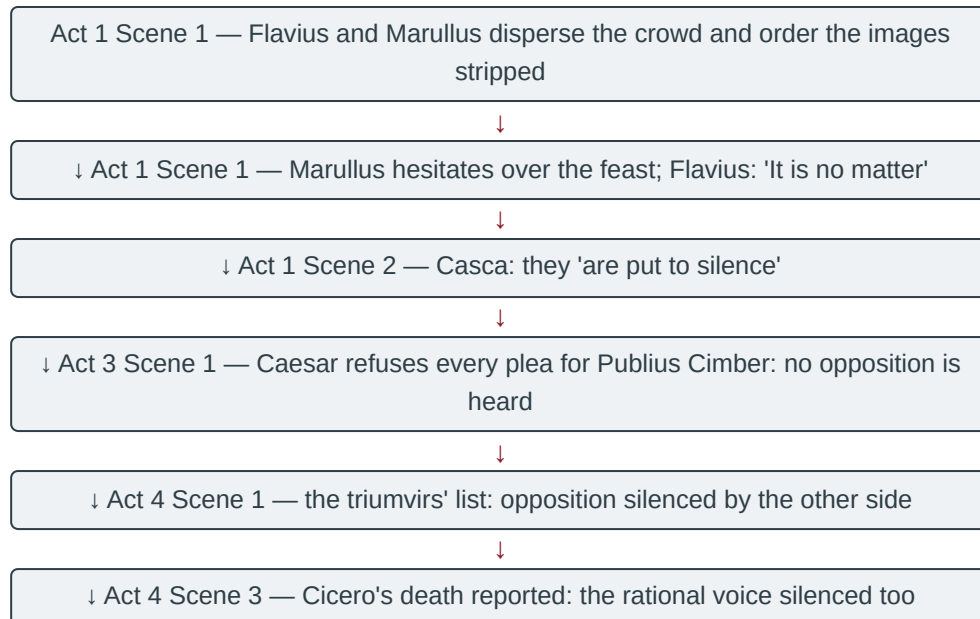
↓ Act 5 Scene 1 — Brutus says this day must finish the work the Ides began

THREAD 7 — THE LETTERS

Papers run through the play as the other way of speaking: the forged letter persuades the honest man, the honest letter is ignored by the proud one, and the dead man's will out-argues every living orator.

THREAD 8 — ANTONY

THREAD 9 — THE TRIBUNES



PROFESSOR'S INSIGHT Why Shakespeare builds the play as a set of echoes

A play of two and a half hours cannot afford to explain itself; it must *rhyme*. Shakespeare's method in *Julius Caesar* is to establish a pattern early, cheaply, with minor characters, and then to repeat it at full cost with major ones. The tribunes oppose Caesar and are silenced; the conspirators oppose Caesar and are destroyed. Marullus harangues a crowd and empties a street; Antony harangues a crowd and empties a city. Caesar dismisses the Soothsayer; Caesar dismisses Calpurnia, Artemidorus and the Soothsayer again. Cassius misreads the storm as Caesar; Pindarus misreads a cheer as a capture, and Cassius dies of it. **LITERARY INTERPRETATION:** one strong reading is that the echoes express the play's fatalism — that Rome keeps re-enacting the same scene because none of its actors understands the pattern they are in. Another is that the echoes are Shakespeare's way of testing an idea under different conditions, as a scientist repeats an experiment: *what does a crowd do when spoken to?* is asked four times with four speakers, and only the fourth answer is complete. Either way, the practical consequence for you is this: every later scene has an Act 1 rehearsal, and naming the rehearsal is the fastest route from describing to analysing. When you meet a moment in Act 3, ask where its smaller version is in Act 1. The answer is nearly always there.

PART B — Where Act 1 Reappears Later

How to use this part

Each block below takes one idea planted in Act 1 and follows it to the scene where it returns. **Act 1 introduction** gives the root in verified wording. **Later scene** names the act and scene where it reappears, with the event described, not quoted. **What changes** is the heart of the block: an echo is only worth writing about if something has altered between the first sounding and the second. **Why the connection matters** tells you what the change proves about the play, and therefore what an examiner would reward you for noticing. **EXAM-ORIENTED ADVICE:** for the Class 10 board paper, which examines Acts 3 to 5, these blocks are the bridge from the portion you were taught in Class 9 to the portion you will be asked about; a 'what has happened earlier' or 'what does this remind you of' sub-question is answered from exactly this material.

1. Caesar's ambition

Act 1 introduction: Never shown directly. Flavius fears Caesar will "soar above the view of men"; Brutus fears the people "Choose Caesar for their king"; Casca thinks "he would fain have had it"; Cassius plans letters in which "Caesar's ambition shall be glanced at". Ambition in Act 1 is entirely a matter of other men's inference.

Later scene: Act 2 Scene 1, where Brutus admits in soliloquy that he has no personal cause against Caesar and must reason from what the crown *might* do to him; Act 3 Scene 2, where Antony repeats the word 'ambitious' against Brutus's charge and offers the thrice-refused crown and the will as evidence of the opposite.

What changes: The inference becomes first a justification for murder and then a disputed claim before a jury of commoners. The evidence Casca gave cynically in Act 1 — three refusals — is turned by Antony into proof of modesty.

Why the connection matters: The play never settles whether Caesar was ambitious; it shows how the *word* was used. A student who knows that Act 1 supplies only suspicion, not proof, can explain why Brutus's funeral argument is so vulnerable and why Antony's rebuttal lands.

2. Caesar's vulnerability

Act 1 introduction: Cassius's Tiber and fever stories ("this god did shake"); Caesar's "this ear is deaf"; Casca's swoon and "falling sickness"; and, against all this, Caesar's "for always I am Caesar".

Later scene: Act 2 Scene 2, where Caesar is frightened by Calpurnia's dream and the augurers, agrees to stay at home, and is then flattered out of his fear by Decius; Act 3 Scene 1, where he proclaims his unshakeable constancy and is stabbed within moments.

What changes: In Act 1 the gap between Caesar's body and Caesar's self-image is reported by enemies. In Acts 2 and 3 we watch it ourselves: the man who calls himself the northern star changes his mind twice in one morning. The vulnerability also shifts from physical to psychological — it is flattery, not fever, that kills him.

Why the connection matters: It explains why the assassination is so easy to accomplish and so hard to justify. Caesar is weak enough to be killed and great enough that killing him unmakes Rome. Both halves are in Act 1.

3. The Soothsayer's warning

Act 1 introduction: "Beware the ides of March", spoken twice; Caesar's "He is a dreamer."

Later scene: Act 2 Scene 4, where Portia meets the Soothsayer on his way to the Capitol, still hoping to speak to Caesar; Act 3 Scene 1, where Caesar remarks that the Ides have come and is answered that they have not yet gone.

What changes: The warning moves from the margin of a festival to the threshold of the Senate, and from a stranger's shout to a direct exchange. Caesar's dismissal becomes a taunt, and the taunt becomes the last joke of his life.

Why the connection matters: It is the clearest case of the play's structure: fate speaks plainly, and the great man's confidence, not ignorance, prevents him hearing. A Class 10 answer about the assassination that cannot place the Act 1 warning is missing its beginning.

4. Omens

Act 1 introduction: Casca's "tempest dropping fire", the burning hand, the lion, the fiery men, the noonday owl; Cicero's "men may construe things after their fashion"; Cassius's reading of the night as Caesar.

Later scene: Act 2 Scene 2 (Calpurnia's dream and the sacrifice without a heart; Decius's reinterpretation); Act 4 Scene 3 (the ghost); Act 5 Scene 1 (Cassius's eagles replaced by birds of prey on the march to Philippi).

What changes: In Act 1 the omens are *read* by men who want something — Cassius wants a revolution, so the storm is Caesar. By Act 5 the omens are read by a man who wants to disbelieve them and cannot: Cassius, who has told Messala he once held Epicurus's view and now half-credits the birds. The sceptic becomes the believer, and dies that day.

Why the connection matters: Cicero's sentence in Act 1 is the key to every later omen. Each one is construed by someone, and the construing — not the sign — decides the action.

5. Cassius's manipulation

Act 1 introduction: The mirror ("I, your glass"), the anecdotes, the Colossus, the soliloquy's "who so firm that cannot be seduced?", the forged writings, the recruitment of Casca.

Later scene: Act 2 Scene 1, where the man he has seduced takes over and overrules him three times; Act 4 Scene 3, the quarrel, where Brutus accuses him of selling offices and refusing money, and Cassius, outmanoeuvred, offers his dagger and his heart.

What changes: The manipulator loses control of what he made. In Act 1 Cassius chooses every word; in Act 4 he is reduced to pleading. The relationship inverts: the glass that showed Brutus his hidden worth now has to look at Brutus's contempt.

Why the connection matters: It is the moral engine of the tragedy's second half. The conspiracy's founding dishonesty, planted in the soliloquy, returns as the subject of the quarrel, and the quarrel is where the republican cause falls apart from within.

6. Brutus's honour

Act 1 introduction: "Set honour in one eye and death i' th' other"; "I love / The name of honour more than I fear death"; Cassius's "honour is the subject of my story"; Casca's "richest alchemy".

Later scene: Act 2 Scene 1, where Brutus refuses an oath because honest Romans need none and refuses to kill Antony because the deed must not look like butchery; Act 3 Scene 2, where he tells the crowd he loved Rome more than Caesar; Act 5 Scene 5, where Antony calls him the only conspirator who acted for the common good.

What changes: Honour moves from a value Brutus holds to a strategy he imposes — and every strategic decision made in the name of honour (no oath, no Cicero, no killing Antony, letting Antony speak) damages the cause. Then, at the end, the enemy who destroyed him confirms the honour was real.

Why the connection matters: Note the phrase from Act 1: Brutus loves the *name* of honour. **LITERARY INTERPRETATION:** some critics hear in that word a man more attached to reputation than to consequences; others hear simple Roman idealism. Either way, Act 1 tells you in advance that honour will be both Brutus's glory and his blind spot.

7. Public opinion

Act 1 introduction: The holiday; "Knew you not Pompey?"; the shouts; the crowd that "hooted and clapped"; Casca's "tag-rag people" who treat Caesar as "the players in the theatre"; Brutus who "sits high in all the people's hearts".

Later scene: Act 3 Scene 2, the funeral: the plebeians applaud Brutus and even propose crowning him, then are turned by Antony into a mob that burns houses; Act 3 Scene 3, where they kill Cinna the poet.

What changes: The crowd's fickleness, a joke in Scene 1 and a worry in Scene 2, becomes an instrument of civil war. And the irony sharpens: the people are so moved by Brutus's republican speech that they offer him the very kingship he killed to prevent.

Why the connection matters: The 2025 and earlier board papers have asked candidates to judge which oration had the greater effect and why. The complete answer begins in Act 1: Antony succeeds because he understands the crowd Shakespeare showed us there — one that follows the latest strong voice and loves gifts and grief more than argument.

8. Roman republicanism

Act 1 introduction: The tribunes' fear of "servile fearfulness"; Cassius's "I was born free as Caesar"; the ancestor Brutus who "would have brooked / Th' eternal devil to keep his state in Rome / As easily as a king"; the letters placed on "old Brutus' statue".

Later scene: Act 2 Scene 1 (Brutus's soliloquy and the letter's appeal to the old Brutus); Act 3 Scene 1 (the conspirators proclaim liberty and bathe their hands in blood); Act 5 Scene 1 (Brutus swears never to go bound to Rome); Act 5 Scene 5 (the republic's last defenders die; Octavius and Antony inherit).

What changes: The republican ideal is sincere in Act 1 and triumphant for one hour in Act 3; thereafter every act in its name produces the tyranny it feared. The three-man rule of Act 4 is a worse version of what the tribunes dreaded from one man.

Why the connection matters: Shakespeare does not mock republicanism; he shows it defeated by its own means. Your analysis of Act 5 is stronger if you can say what the ideal originally was, in the words of the men who opened the play with it.

9. Forged letters

Act 1 introduction: "In several hands in at his windows throw, / As if they came from several citizens"; the papers for the praetor's chair, the window and the statue.

Later scene: Act 2 Scene 1, where Lucius brings Brutus a letter found at the window, and Brutus reads its broken phrases and completes them aloud, taking them as Rome's voice.

What changes: The lie becomes effective — and, crucially, Brutus co-authors it. The letter says little; Brutus supplies the rest. The forgery works because it gives a man at war with himself permission to decide.

Why the connection matters: It is the single most important fact for judging Brutus's choice. He acts on manufactured evidence, and he never learns this. The audience, which heard the soliloquy, knows what he does not. That gap is the definition of dramatic irony, and Act 1 creates it.

10. Caesar's relationship with Antony

Act 1 introduction: Antony the runner, who obeys "Do this"; Caesar's confidence that Antony "loves plays" and hears music, unlike the dangerous Cassius; Caesar asking Antony's opinion and Antony getting it wrong.

Later scene: Act 3 Scene 1, where Antony sends a servant to kneel before the killers, shakes their hands, and then, alone with the body, promises civil war; Act 3 Scene 2, the oration.

What changes: The follower becomes the heir. The man Brutus thought lacked seriousness turns out to have been studying Caesar's methods all along, and he performs them better than Caesar did — he, too, refuses to read a will and then reads it, exactly as Caesar refused and accepted crowns.

Why the connection matters: Everyone in Act 1 misreads Antony, including Caesar, who thinks his love of pleasure makes him safe. The misreading is the conspirators' fatal error in Act 2 and the audience's great surprise in Act 3.

11. Political conspiracy

Act 1 introduction: A private conversation (Scene 2), a soliloquy, then a night meeting with handshake, dagger, letters, named members and a headquarters at "Pompey's Porch" (Scene 3).

Later scene: Act 2 Scene 1, where the conspirators come muffled to Brutus's house and the plan takes final shape; Act 3 Scene 1, the execution.

What changes: The conspiracy acquires a leader who is not its author. Everything Cassius organised in Act 1 is reorganised by Brutus in Act 2 according to a different logic — honour instead of security.

Why the connection matters: The Act 1 conspiracy is efficient and cynical; the Act 2 conspiracy is noble and doomed. The change of hands is the change of fate.

12. Crowd psychology

Act 1 introduction: The Cobbler's good humour; the tribunes' ability to send the crowd home "tongue-tied in their guiltiness"; the thrice-repeated shout; Casca's observation that the crowd forgave Caesar's swoon because he blamed his "infirmity" and that "if Caesar had stabbed their mothers, they would have done no less".

Later scene: Act 3 Scene 2 and Act 3 Scene 3.

What changes: Casca's cynical generalisations are tested and proved. A crowd that forgave Caesar anything forgives his killers for an hour and then tears a poet to pieces. What was observation in Act 1 becomes action in Act 3.

Why the connection matters: Shakespeare gives us the theory of the mob before he gives us the mob. That is why the funeral scene feels inevitable rather than arbitrary — and why your answer on it should cite the theory.

13. Supernatural imagery

Act 1 introduction: "a civil strife in heaven"; the slave's hand "Like twenty torches joined"; "Men all in fire"; Cassius's man who "thunders, lightens, opens graves, and roars"; the storm whose colour, Cassius says, matches "the work we have in hand, / Most bloody, fiery, and most terrible".

Later scene: Act 2 Scene 2 (graves yielding their dead, blood drizzling on the Capitol, the lioness whelping in the streets, as Calpurnia reports the night); Act 4 Scene 3 (Caesar's ghost); Act 5 Scene 1 (the carrion birds).

What changes: Imagery becomes event. The 'opened graves' of Cassius's rhetoric in Act 1 become a literal dead man standing in Brutus's tent in Act 4. The fire that fell in Act 1 is matched by the fire the mob carries in Act 3.

Why the connection matters: The supernatural in this play is never decoration. Each image planted in Act 1 is cashed later as a plot event, and tracing the exchange is exactly the kind of analysis that marks a Level 4 reader.

The Hinge: Act 1's Last Line

PROFESSOR'S INSIGHT Why 'be sure of him' is the hinge of the tragedy

Act 1 ends with Cassius's promise that before dawn "We will awake him and be sure of him." Read the phrase slowly, because it holds the whole play in tension. 'Be sure of him' means, on the surface, 'make certain of Brutus's commitment'. But 'sure' in Shakespeare's English also carries the sense of 'safe, secured' — the sense Cassius used a few hundred lines earlier when he said "let Caesar seat him sure" and promised to shake him. The two uses frame the act: Caesar is to be made unsafe, Brutus is to be made safe for the plot. **LITERARY INTERPRETATION:** one strong reading is that this line is the moment the play's engine changes gear. Everything before it is persuasion — words, stories, letters, a handshake. Everything after it is consequence. The conspirators believe that securing Brutus secures the outcome; the rest of the play shows that securing Brutus is precisely what *un*-secures it, because the man they wake will refuse the oath, spare Antony, let him speak at the funeral, and march to Philippi against Cassius's advice. 'Be sure of him' is therefore the most ironic promise in the play: the one certainty the conspirators achieve is the one that destroys them. Notice, too, that the line is spoken 'after midnight' — the Ides of March are a month away, but the night of the storm is the night the plot acquires its leader, and Shakespeare lets Act 1 close on the knock at Brutus's door that we will hear in Act 2 Scene 1. The hinge turns in the dark, and the audience, unlike Brutus, has heard the hand on the handle.

From Connection to Marks

LEVEL 1 — What happened?

Take the public opinion thread. The commoners celebrate Caesar; the tribunes shame them with Pompey's memory; the crowd shouts three times at the crown; Casca says Brutus is loved by the people; the conspirators want that love. Stating these five facts in order is Level 1, and it is where most answers stop.

LEVEL 2 — What does it mean?

The crowd follows whoever is strongest and most recent. Its love for Pompey, Caesar and Brutus is the same love, redirected. Casca's theatre comparison names this: the people are an audience, not a judge.

LEVEL 3 — Why did Shakespeare write it this way?

He shows the crowd's nature early, through minor figures and comedy, so that when the stakes become mortal in Act 3 the audience already understands the material Antony is working with. The offstage shouts of Scene 2 are a deliberate withholding: we hear the crowd before we see it, and we learn to distrust its noise.

LEVEL 4 — How does it connect to the whole play?

The funeral of Act 3 Scene 2 is the Act 1 crowd at full volume. Brutus, recruited because "he sits high in all the people's hearts", discovers that the height is temporary; Antony, dismissed as a pleasure-lover, understands the crowd that Scene 1 showed us and uses memory, gifts and grief where Marullus used reproach. Cinna the poet in Act 3 Scene 3 is the thread's terminus: the crowd of the Cobbler's holiday kills a man for his name.

LEVEL 5 — How do I use it in an ICSE answer?

In an Act 3 extract question asking why the plebeians turn, open with the Act 1 root in one sentence ('Shakespeare has already shown this crowd transferring its love from Pompey to Caesar in the first scene'), quote Act 1 only where you are sure of the words, then analyse the Act 3 passage in front of you. One accurate backward reference, placed early, signals to the examiner that you know the play as a whole; three vague ones signal that you are avoiding the extract. Keep the proportion right: the extract is the question, Act 1 is the context.

ICSE EXAM BOX How Act 1 connections earn marks in a Class 10 paper

EXAM-ORIENTED ADVICE. Be clear about the syllabus: Act 1 belongs to the Class IX portion, and the Class X board paper sets its drama extracts from Acts III, IV and V. You will not be given an Act 1 extract in the board examination. But the 2025 paper asked what 'the work the ides of March begun' refers to — a question that cannot be answered without the Soothsayer's warning and the assassination it foreshadowed — and sub-questions of the 'what has happened earlier' and 'what does this reveal about character' type routinely reward a candidate who can reach back accurately. Use this chapter in two ways. First, when revising an Act 3 to 5 scene, find its row in Part B and learn the **What changes** sentence; that sentence is a ready-made analytical point. Second, when a sub-question asks about character or motive, remember that Brutus's honour, Cassius's methods, Antony's loyalty and the crowd's fickleness were all *established* in Act 1, so a one-line reference to the establishing moment strengthens the answer. No question is guaranteed, and no examiner rewards Act 1 material that is not relevant to the extract set. The skill is proportion: context in one sentence, analysis of the given passage in the rest.

REVISION The connection engine in ten lines

1. Act 1 is a system: every event is a cause of something later and an echo of something earlier.
2. Scene 1 plants the crowd's fickleness and the cost of opposing Caesar; both return in Act 3.
3. Scene 2 plants Caesar's body, Brutus's inner war, Cassius's method and the Soothsayer's date.
4. Scene 3 turns talk into organisation: dagger, handshake, letters, headquarters, and the plan to secure Brutus.
5. The nine threads to know by heart: public opinion, Caesar's body, Brutus's conflict, Cassius's method, omens, the Ides, the letters, Antony, the tribunes.
6. Every omen is *construed* by someone; Cicero's sentence is the key to all of them.
7. The forged letters make Brutus co-author of his own deception; he never finds out.
8. Antony is misread by everyone in Act 1, and the misreading is the conspiracy's fatal error.
9. 'Be sure of him' is the hinge: securing Brutus is what unsecures the plot.
10. In the exam, Act 1 is context, not subject: one accurate backward reference, early, then analyse the extract.

CROSS-REFERENCE Where to go next

For the full character arguments behind the threads, return to 'Caesar in Act 1 — A Character Masterclass', 'Cassius — The Manipulation Masterclass' and 'Brutus in Act 1 — Honour, Conflict and Vulnerability'. For the omens and Cicero, 'The Soothsayer, the Ides of March, and the Supporting Cast' and 'Themes of Act 1 (Part Two)'. For turning a connection into a paragraph that scores, 'ICSE Examiner Mode: How Marks Are Earned' and the two 'Extract-Based Training' chapters. The compressed spine of these chains is reprinted in 'The Final Act 1 Master Map and What Shakespeare Is Doing'.

CHAPTER 17

ICSE Examiner Mode: How Marks Are Earned

This chapter stops teaching you the play for a moment and teaches you the examiner. You will learn the five mental operations an ICSE literature paper tests, what separates a weak answer from an excellent one on eight measurable qualities, how a 3-mark and a 4-mark sub-answer are actually built, how to cure the habit of retelling the story, and how to turn Act 1 knowledge into marks on Act 3–5 questions. Seven important Act 1 questions are answered twice, weakly and excellently, and then dissected. Twelve MCQs and a catalogue of common errors close the chapter. Read it after Chapters 3 to 16; it assumes you know the text.

The Honest Starting Point: Where Act 1 Sits in Your Examinations

Before any technique, one fact must be perfectly clear, because a student who misunderstands it will prepare for the wrong examination.

EXAM-ORIENTED ADVICE: Act 1 of *Julius Caesar* is prescribed for Class IX. Your school examines it, usually through reference-to-the-context or extract questions. The ICSE Class X board paper examines Acts III, IV and V. Act 1 is therefore never set as an extract in the board paper. Yet the board paper leans on Act 1 constantly: the 2025 paper asked candidates what 'the work the ides of March begun' refers to, a question that cannot be answered by a student who does not remember the Soothsayer's warning in Act 1 Scene 2. Every character motive, every piece of foreshadowing and every relationship that Acts III–V exploit was planted in Act 1. So this chapter trains you for two examinations at once: the Class IX paper that sets Act 1 directly, and the Class X paper that assumes it.

ICSE EXAM BOX The 2025 paper structure in one glance

The Literature in English paper (Paper 2) carries 80 marks and lasts 2 hours, plus reading time; 20 further marks come from internal assessment. In the 2025 board paper the structure was: Section A, compulsory, Question 1 with 16 one-mark MCQs across drama, prose and poetry; Sections B (Drama), C (Prose) and D (Poetry), each with extract-based questions of 16 marks. Candidates had to attempt one question from each of B, C and D, and one more from any section. Each 2025 drama extract question had five sub-parts marked [3], [3], [3], [3], [4]. The four 3-mark parts typically moved from context and recall through explanation to character; the 4-mark part asked for judgement or personal response supported from the text. Nothing in this chapter predicts what will be set. It describes what has been set and how marks were earned on it.

Keep the shape [3][3][3][3][4] in your head as you read. Almost every piece of advice below is calibrated to it.

WHAT THE EXAMINER IS TESTING

An examiner marking literature is not asking 'Has this student read the play?' That is assumed. The examiner is asking which mental operation the student can perform on the text, and the sub-questions are deliberately graded so that each one tests a different operation. CISCE describes these skills, in substance, as recall of the text, understanding of meaning, application and interpretation, analysis of character, theme and device, and evaluation or personal response supported by the text. Think of them as five gears. A weak student stays in first gear, retelling, no matter what the question asks. A strong student hears the verb in the question and shifts into the gear it demands.

Below, each level is defined, matched to the question words that signal it, and demonstrated with an Act 1 question and a model answer of realistic exam length.

Level 1: Recall

Recall is the retrieval of textual fact: who speaks, to whom, where, what has just happened, what is said next. It is tested by the first sub-question of nearly every extract ('Where are the speakers? What has just happened?') and by MCQs. Marks are lost here not through ignorance but through imprecision: the right event in the wrong order, the right line given to the wrong speaker.

Example question (Recall, 3 marks): 'According to Casca, who offered Caesar the crown, how many times was it offered, and how did Caesar respond each time?'

Model answer: Casca reports that Mark Antony offered Caesar the crown in the marketplace during the Lupercal games. It was offered three times, and Casca adds that it was not a true crown but "one of these coronets". Caesar refused it each time, but Casca notices that he "put it by thrice, every time gentler than other", so the refusals grew weaker. At the third refusal the crowd's shouting and foul breath so overwhelmed Caesar that he "swooned and fell down at it".

Notice what earns the three marks: the offerer (Antony), the number (three), and the manner of refusal (progressively gentler, ending in a swoon), each pinned by a short exact quotation. Nothing is interpreted. Interpretation here would waste time without earning marks.

Level 2: Understanding

Understanding is the ability to say what the words mean, in your own words, with the metaphors unpacked. It is tested by 'Explain the lines...', 'What does X mean by...?', 'Give the meaning of...'. The commonest failure is to repeat the quotation in slightly rearranged form and call it an explanation.

Example question (Understanding, 3 marks): 'Explain in your own words what Cassius means when he tells Brutus that "The fault, dear Brutus, is not in our stars, / But in ourselves, that we are underlings."'

Model answer: Cassius is rejecting the idea that Caesar's supremacy is fated. Romans believed the stars at a person's birth shaped his destiny; Cassius says that if he and Brutus are now inferiors ('underlings') under Caesar, the blame lies not with destiny but with their own failure to act. The line is an argument for free will: men become subjects only by allowing themselves to be subjected. It also carries an unspoken accusation, because if the fault is in 'ourselves', then Brutus, by remaining passive, is partly responsible for Caesar's rise.

The three marks are earned by (1) unpacking 'stars' as fate, (2) unpacking 'underlings' and the idea of self-caused inferiority, and (3) identifying the implied point, that inaction is a choice. The answer never wanders into Cassius's motives or into Act 3.

Level 3: Application and Interpretation

Application asks you to use your understanding to answer a 'why' question that the text does not answer in so many words. 'Why does the speaker say this?', 'Why is X anxious?', 'What is the speaker trying to achieve?' You are reasoning from evidence to purpose. The commonest failure is to answer 'why' with 'what': asked why Cassius tells the Tiber story, the weak student retells the Tiber story.

Example question (Application, 3 marks): 'Why does Cassius tell Brutus the story of swimming the Tiber with Caesar?'

Model answer: Cassius tells the story to destroy the gap between Caesar and ordinary men in Brutus's mind. He has just claimed "I was born free as Caesar; so were you", and the anecdote is his proof: in the flooded Tiber Caesar's strength failed and he cried "Help me, Cassius, or I sink!", so that Cassius had to carry him ashore as Aeneas carried his father from Troy. The purpose is to make Caesar's godlike status look absurd: "this man / Is now become a god, and Cassius is / A wretched creature". By casting himself as the rescuer and Caesar as the rescued, Cassius argues that Rome's hierarchy has been turned upside down and that Brutus should feel the same resentment.

The marks come from naming the purpose (to shrink Caesar), showing the mechanism (the rescue inverts the hierarchy) and tying it to the surrounding argument (born equal, therefore no cause for awe).

Level 4: Analysis

Analysis is the examination of how something works: how a speech reveals character, how a device creates effect, how a scene builds a theme. Signal words: 'What does this reveal about...?', 'How does Shakespeare...?', 'Comment on...', 'What impression do you form of...?' Analysis is where terminology (irony, imagery, foreshadowing, dramatic irony) becomes useful, provided each term is attached to a quotation and an effect.

Example question (Analysis, 3 marks): 'What does Caesar's description of Cassius reveal about Caesar himself?'

Model answer: Caesar's reading of Cassius is acute. He notices that Cassius "reads much", is "a great observer" and "looks / Quite through the deeds of men", and that he "loves no plays" and "hears no music", so Caesar correctly identifies a brooding, restless intelligence that cannot be "at heart's ease / Whiles they behold a greater than themselves". Yet the speech reveals Caesar's fatal self-image more than it reveals Cassius. He insists "I fear him not" and claims to speak only of "what is to be feared / Than what I fear; for always I am Caesar", as though the public name had replaced the private man. The irony is sharpened by his next words: "Come on my right hand, for this ear is deaf". The man who sees through others is physically unable to hear a warning, a bodily emblem of the political deafness that will kill him.

Three marks: Caesar's perceptiveness (with evidence), his vanity and third-person self-image (with evidence), and the dramatic irony of the deaf ear. Each point is a quotation plus an inference, never a quotation alone.

Level 5: Evaluation and Personal Response

Evaluation asks for judgement: which argument is most persuasive, whether a character deserves sympathy, how far you agree with a statement, what you would have done. It is the usual territory of the 4-mark final sub-part. The examiner is not looking for a particular opinion. The examiner is looking for an opinion that is stated clearly, supported from the text, and aware of the other side.

Example question (Evaluation, 4 marks): 'By the end of Act 1 Scene 2, do you think Cassius has already won Brutus over? Give reasons based on the text.'

Model answer: I think Cassius has opened a door without yet walking through it. Brutus's own words show how far he has moved: he admits he fears the people "Choose Caesar for their king", he says that for "the general good" he will "Set honour in one eye and death i' th' other", and he ends by declaring that he "had rather be a villager / Than to repute himself a son of Rome / Under these hard conditions". These are the words of a man already arguing himself towards action. But Brutus also refuses to be hurried: "What you have said / I will consider", and he still says of Caesar "I love him well". Cassius himself measures the result modestly: his "weak words / Have struck but thus much show of fire". In his soliloquy he then plans the forged letters, which he would not need if Brutus were already won. So the scene shows a Brutus persuaded in principle but not yet committed, which is exactly why Cassius turns from argument to deception.

Four marks: a clear judgement, evidence for movement (two or three quotations), evidence for resistance (two quotations), and a resolution that uses the soliloquy as a test of the judgement. The conclusion is not 'both sides have a point'; it is a precise position ('persuaded in principle, not committed') that the evidence has earned.

PROFESSOR'S INSIGHT What an examiner actually reads in the first two lines of an answer

Examiners mark quickly and in volume, and the first two lines of a sub-answer set an expectation that the rest of the answer either confirms or struggles against. In those two lines the examiner is reading for three signals. First, the verb of the question answered back: if the question asked why, the first line should contain a reason, not a narration ('Cassius tells the story in order to...', not 'Cassius and Caesar once went swimming...'). Second, a textual anchor: a name, a precise moment, or a short quotation that proves the student knows where in the play this is ('after the Soothsayer's warning', 'in his soliloquy once Brutus has left'). Third, the absence of stalling: no 'In this extract the speaker is speaking about...', no repetition of the question, no 'Shakespeare was a great writer who...'. An answer that opens with a reason, an anchor and no stalling has, in the examiner's mind, already earned its first mark, and the examiner reads the rest looking for the remaining two. An answer that opens with a story summary has planted the suspicion that the student does not know the difference between retelling and answering, and the examiner reads the rest looking for evidence that the suspicion is wrong. Both answers may end up containing the same points. They will not receive the same marks, because the second one made the examiner hunt for them.

WHAT MAKES AN ANSWER WEAK / AVERAGE / STRONG / EXCELLENT

Examiners do not mark by instinct alone. Whether or not they use a printed grid, they are judging an answer on a small number of qualities, and each quality can be present at four strengths. The table below names eight of those qualities and describes what each looks like at each strength. Use it diagnostically: after writing a practice answer, find the row for each quality and ask honestly which column you are in.

Quality	Weak	Average	Strong	Excellent
Textual precision	Vague or wrong: 'Antony gives Caesar a crown'; speakers confused; events misordered	Correct in outline, but approximate ('Cassius says something about a Colossus')	Exact: right speaker, right moment, short accurate quotation	Exact and selective: the quotation chosen is the one word or phrase that proves the point ("coronets", "put it by thrice")

Quality	Weak	Average	Strong	Excellent
Context	None, or the whole plot retold from Scene 1	Where and when stated, but loosely ('in Rome, during a festival')	Precise placement: 'just after Caesar's train has left the stage, Casca pulled by the cloak'	Placement plus relevance: the context is used ('because this is reported, not shown, we see it through Casca's cynicism')
Analysis	Absent: the answer describes what happens	A single general observation ('this shows Cassius is clever')	Each point moves from evidence to inference ('the rescue inverts the hierarchy, so...')	Inference with awareness of alternatives ('one reading is..., though Cassius's own bitterness colours the account')
Evidence	No quotation, or a long block copied from the extract	One quotation, often too long and not explained	Short quotations woven into sentences, each followed by a comment	Quotations chosen for a key word and the key word itself discussed ('fain' tells us Casca is guessing Caesar's desire)
Terminology	None, or wrong ('simile' for a metaphor)	Terms named but not used ('there is irony here')	Term, quotation and effect linked ('dramatic irony: we know what Caesar does not')	Terms used only where they sharpen the point; never decoration
Cause and effect	Events listed in sequence with 'then... then...'	One cause noted ('Brutus is worried so he is distant')	Chains traced: 'because X, Y; and Y makes Z possible'	Chains traced and weighed: the main cause distinguished from contributing ones
Character motivation	Labels: 'Cassius is jealous', 'Brutus is good'	Label plus one reason	Motive derived from the character's own words and actions	Motive shown as mixed or contested, with the text left open where it is open ('envy and principle are both present in the soliloquy')
Significance	Not addressed, or 'this is very important'	'This foreshadows what happens later' without saying what	Specific link to a later moment or a theme ('the deaf ear anticipates his refusal of the Soothsayer and Calpurnia')	Significance that explains why Shakespeare placed it here, in this form, through this speaker

Two patterns in this table deserve attention. First, the move from Weak to Average is usually about accuracy; the move from Average to Strong is about linking evidence to inference; the move from Strong to Excellent is about selectivity and judgement. Most students who have 'done the notes' sit in the Average column on every row. Second, the Excellent column never requires more writing than the Strong column. It requires better choices. The excellent answer is often shorter than the strong one.

THE ANATOMY OF A 3-MARK SUB-ANSWER

A 3-mark sub-answer is the basic unit of the ICSE literature paper; four of them make up three-quarters of an extract question. Build it to a fixed design and you will never again stare at a question wondering how much to write.

Structure

Think of three marks as three distinct, markable points, each of which must be visible to a tired examiner at reading speed. The cleanest design is:

1. **Direct answer in the first sentence.** The question's verb answered immediately: the reason, the meaning, the speaker and moment.
2. **Development with evidence.** The second and third sentences each add a point, and each point is pinned to a short quotation or an exact textual detail.
3. **A closing clause of significance or effect,** only where the question invites it ('What does this reveal...?' invites it; 'Who is being addressed?' does not).

Length

Five to seven sentences, roughly 70 to 110 words. If you are writing a second paragraph on a 3-mark question, you are either repeating yourself or answering a question that was not asked. If you have written two sentences, you have probably made one point and are hoping it counts for three.

How many points

Three. Not one point explained three ways, which examiners spot instantly, and not five points, which crowds out the explanation each one needs. If the question has two clear parts ('What does Brutus fear, and how does Cassius respond?'), split the marks accordingly: usually two points for the larger part and one for the smaller.

When to quote

Quote when the exact word matters, and always quote short: a phrase, half a line, at most a line and a half. For a recall question, quotation is confirmation ('Casca calls it "one of these coronets"'). For an understanding question, quote the phrase you are unpacking and then put it into your own words; do not paraphrase around the quotation and leave it unexplained. For a 'why' or 'what does this reveal' question, quote the words that carry the evidence for your inference. If you cannot remember the exact words, do not invent them: a precise paraphrase ('Caesar admits that his ear is deaf') earns the point; an invented quotation can lose it, because the examiner knows the text.

A worked 3-mark answer, annotated

Question: 'Why does Brutus say he is "not gamesome"? What does his reply reveal about his state of mind?'

Answer: Brutus declines Cassius's invitation to watch the race because he lacks the appetite for sport, admitting "I do lack some part / Of that quick spirit that is in Antony" [point 1: the direct reason, with the exact words]. The reply reveals a man turned inward: he has, by his own confession, been "with himself at war", troubled by "passions of some difference", so that he has neglected his friends [point 2: state of mind derived from his own words]. The contrast with Antony, the man of "quick spirit" who runs in the games, quietly sets up the opposition between the reflective Brutus and the physical, pleasure-loving Antony that the whole play will exploit [point 3: significance, kept to one sentence].

Three points, three pieces of evidence, six sentences. That is the shape.

THE ANATOMY OF A 4-MARK EVALUATIVE SUB-ANSWER

The final sub-part of a drama extract in the 2025 paper carried 4 marks and asked for judgement: which argument had the greatest impact, whether a character is justified, how far a statement is true, what the extract reveals about a relationship. It is marked differently from a 3-mark part, and students who write it as a longer recall answer lose marks they could easily have had.

What the extra mark is for

The fourth mark is for judgement. Three marks can be earned by making well-supported points; the fourth is earned by committing to a position and defending it against the obvious objection. An answer that says 'both Cassius and Brutus have good reasons' and stops has refused to evaluate. An answer that says 'Cassius's strongest argument is the appeal to Brutus's ancestor, because it attacks Brutus's honour rather than Caesar's weakness; the Tiber story is vivid but it reveals Cassius's envy more than Caesar's unfitness' has evaluated.

Structure

1. **Position, stated in the first sentence.** 'The argument with the greatest impact is...'; 'Caesar is not justified in dismissing the Soothsayer because...'; 'I agree only partly, because...'.
2. **Two supporting points, each with evidence.** These are the same evidence-plus-inference moves as in a 3-mark answer.
3. **The counter-consideration.** One sentence acknowledging the strongest fact against your view, and one sentence showing why your view survives it.
4. **A closing sentence that sharpens the position,** not merely repeats it.

Length

Eight to ten sentences, roughly 120 to 160 words. A 4-mark answer is not twice a 3-mark answer in length; it is one-third longer and differently shaped.

How many points

Two main points and one counter-consideration. Three or four thin points are weaker than two developed ones, because evaluation is about depth of reasoning, not breadth of coverage.

When to quote

Quote to support each main point and, ideally, once for the counter-consideration, since an objection you can support from the text is far more convincing than one you merely mention. Keep every quotation short. The 4-mark answer is the one place where the examiner wants to hear your voice; do not drown it in the text's.

The two words that save the fourth mark

'Because' and 'although'. 'Because' forces you to give a reason for your judgement. 'Although' forces you to acknowledge the other side. A 4-mark answer that contains both words, each doing real work, has almost always evaluated. An answer that contains neither has almost always described.

HOW TO STOP WRITING STORY SUMMARIES

The single most common cause of lost marks in literature answers is retelling. It is not laziness. Students retell because retelling feels safe, because it fills the space, and because for years 'tell me what happened' was the question they were asked. The examiner at this level is asking a different question, and the cure is to learn to hear the difference.

Diagnosing the habit

You are summarising when your sentences begin with a character's name followed by a past- or present-tense action verb ('Cassius then tells Brutus...', 'Caesar comes back and says...') and are joined by 'then', 'after that', 'next'. You are answering when your sentences begin with a reason, a quality, a judgement or a textual word ('Cassius's purpose is...', 'The word "fain" shows...', 'This is ironic because...').

A quick test: delete the question from the top of your answer. If a reader could not reconstruct what was asked from your first two sentences, you have summarised.

The rewrite exercise

Below is a weak answer to a Scene 1 question, followed by the same material rewritten. Read both slowly, then do the exercise that follows.

Question (3 marks): 'Why are Flavius and Marullus angry with the commoners in Act 1 Scene 1?'

Before (summary):

'In the beginning of the play, some commoners are walking on the street. Flavius and Marullus are two tribunes. They see the commoners and ask them what their trade is. The carpenter says he is a carpenter. Then the cobbler makes jokes and says he is a mender of bad soles. Flavius and Marullus get angry and ask them why they are not working. The cobbler says they have come to see Caesar. Then Marullus gives a long speech about Pompey and tells them to go home. Flavius tells Marullus to pull down the decorations from Caesar's statues. This shows the tribunes are angry with the commoners.'

This is 113 words, accurate, and worth perhaps one mark. Every sentence narrates. The word 'why' is never answered until the last sentence, and that sentence does not answer it either; it merely restates the question as a conclusion.

After (answer):

'The tribunes are angry for two connected reasons. The first is political: the commoners are celebrating Caesar's triumph over Pompey's sons, a victory over fellow Romans, and Marullus is disgusted that the very people who once climbed "to chimney tops" to see "great Pompey pass the streets of Rome" now "strew flowers in his way / That comes in triumph over Pompey's blood". Their rejoicing is, to him, ingratitude and a betrayal of Pompey's memory. The second reason is fear: Flavius sees Caesar's popularity as "growing feathers" that must be plucked before he can "soar above the view of men / And keep us all in servile fearfulness". The commoners' holiday is dangerous because it feeds the power of a man the tribunes believe threatens the Republic. Their anger at the idle workmen is really anger at Rome's forgetfulness and alarm at Caesar's rise.'

This is 143 words and worth three marks. Compare the openings: 'In the beginning of the play, some commoners are walking' against 'The tribunes are angry for two connected reasons'. Compare the use of the text: the first version mentions Pompey; the second quotes the exact contrast Marullus builds between past devotion and present fickleness. Compare the endings: the first restates the question; the second names what the anger is really about.

Your turn

Take this question and write a summary answer deliberately, then rewrite it: 'Why does Cassius want to recruit Casca in Act 1 Scene 3?' Your rewrite must open with a reason, must quote Casca's own pledge ("Be factious for redress of all these griefs") or Cassius's description of the men waiting at "Pompey's Porch", and must not contain the word 'then'. When you have finished, check your first two sentences against the insight box above. If an examiner could not tell from them that the question was 'why', start again.

The three sentence-openers that cure retelling

Train yourself to begin sub-answers with one of these shapes until it becomes reflex:

- **The reason-first opener:** 'X does this because...' / 'The purpose of this speech is...'
- **The quality-first opener:** 'The speech reveals a man who...' / 'What stands out is...'
- **The word-first opener:** 'The key word is "fain", which...' / 'Casca's phrase "mere foolery" tells us...'

Each of these makes narration grammatically awkward. You cannot comfortably follow 'The purpose of this speech is' with a plot summary. The sentence shape does the discipline for you.

WEAK VS EXCELLENT ANSWERS

Seven questions follow, each of a kind that Act 1 extract papers regularly ask and that Act 3–5 questions silently depend on. Each is answered twice. The weak answer is not a bad student's answer; it is the answer a reasonably prepared student writes under time pressure when technique fails. The excellent answer is what the same knowledge looks like when it is organised to earn marks. The dissection after each pair uses six fixed labels so that you can see exactly which move earns which mark. Treat all seven as 3-mark answers unless marked otherwise.

Question 1: Why do the tribunes drive the commoners home?

WEAK ANSWER Weak answer

Flavius and Marullus are tribunes who do not like Caesar. At the start of the play they find the commoners in the street on a working day and scold them. The cobbler makes jokes and says he is a surgeon to old shoes. The tribunes are angry because the people have come to see Caesar's triumph. Marullus reminds them about Pompey and says they are ungrateful. Then they send them home and go to remove decorations from the statues because they are jealous of Caesar's power.

EXCELLENT ANSWER Excellent answer

The tribunes drive the commoners home because the crowd's celebration is both a betrayal and a danger. It is a betrayal because the triumph honours a victory "over Pompey's blood", and Marullus is appalled that people who once waited "The livelong day, with patient expectation, / To see great Pompey pass" now "cull out a holiday" for the man who destroyed Pompey's cause; his insult "You blocks, you stones, you worse than senseless things!" treats their fickleness as a failure of memory and feeling. It is a danger because, as Flavius makes explicit after they leave, popular adoration is the material of tyranny: Caesar's "growing feathers" must be "plucked" or he will "soar above the view of men / And keep us all in servile fearfulness". Sending the crowd home and stripping the images are therefore the same act, an attempt to deny Caesar the public worship that the tribunes, as guardians of the people's liberty, believe will end the Republic.

DISSECTION

Textual evidence: The weak answer has one accurate detail ("surgeon to old shoes") that is irrelevant to the question, and no quotation that bears on motive. The excellent answer selects three: the Pompey contrast, the insult, and the feathers metaphor, each of which is a reason rather than an event.

Keyword: 'Ingratitude' and 'liberty' are the two concepts the examiner expects. The weak answer gestures at the first ('ungrateful') and replaces the second with 'jealous', which is a misreading of the tribunes' office. The excellent answer names betrayal and danger and explains both.

Analysis: The weak answer narrates in sequence; its only analytical sentence attributes jealousy, for which the text offers no support. The excellent answer reads the feathers image as a political theory of how tyranny grows, which is what the image is.

Explanation: The excellent answer explains why removing decorations and dispersing a crowd are the same action, a connection the weak answer never makes because it treats them as consecutive events.

Significance: The excellent answer's closing phrase, 'guardians of the people's liberty', tells the examiner the student knows what a tribune is for. That is the difference between a student who knows the plot and one who understands the scene.

Connection: Casca's later report that Marullus and Flavius "are put to silence" completes this scene's argument: the men who tried to pluck Caesar's feathers are themselves plucked. The excellent answer leaves room for that connection in a 4-mark version; the weak answer has no framework into which it could fit.

Question 2: How does Cassius persuade Brutus?

WEAK ANSWER Weak answer

Cassius is jealous of Caesar and wants Brutus to join the conspiracy. He tells Brutus that he has noticed he has been distant. Then he says he will be a mirror to Brutus. He tells the story of how Caesar nearly drowned in the Tiber and how he had a fever in Spain and shook like a girl. He says Caesar is like a Colossus and that Brutus's name is as good as Caesar's. He also mentions Brutus's ancestor who drove out the kings. Brutus says he will think about it. So Cassius uses many arguments to persuade Brutus.

EXCELLENT ANSWER Excellent answer

Cassius persuades Brutus by working on his self-image rather than on his politics. He begins by offering himself as a mirror, "I, your glass, / Will modestly discover to yourself / That of yourself which you yet know not of", so that whatever follows will seem to Brutus like self-discovery rather than persuasion. Having heard Brutus declare that he loves "The name of honour more than I fear death", Cassius announces "honour is the subject of my story" and tailors every argument to it. The Tiber and the fever anecdotes degrade Caesar into a man who cried "Help me, Cassius, or I sink!" and groaned "As a sick girl", so that bending to him becomes dishonourable. The Colossus image then makes Brutus's passivity shameful: "we petty men / Walk under his huge legs and peep about / To find ourselves dishonourable graves". Finally he turns to ancestry, reminding Brutus of "a Brutus once" who would have endured "Th' eternal devil" in Rome "As easily as a king". The sequence moves from flattery to disgust to shame to inherited duty, and each step is an appeal to honour, which is why Brutus, who is unmoved by envy, is moved.

DISSECTION

Textual evidence: Both answers mention the same four episodes. The weak answer mentions them; the excellent answer quotes the operative phrase from each and tells the examiner what the phrase does.

Keyword: 'Honour' is the keyword, and the excellent answer shows it is Cassius's keyword too ("honour is the subject of my story"). The weak answer's keyword is 'jealous', which describes Cassius's motive and leaves the question (how does he persuade?) unanswered.

Analysis: The weak answer's final sentence ('uses many arguments') is a list disguised as a conclusion. The excellent answer identifies a method (flattery, then disgust, then shame, then duty) and a reason the method works (every step targets honour).

Explanation: The excellent answer explains the mirror image as a technique for disguising persuasion as self-knowledge. The weak answer reports that Cassius 'will be a mirror' without saying why that matters.

Significance: The excellent answer's last clause, that Brutus is unmoved by envy but moved by honour, prepares the student for the soliloquy, where Cassius admits that Brutus's "honourable mettle may be wrought". Persuasion and manipulation are shown as the same process seen from two sides.

Connection: In Act 3 Brutus will justify the killing to the people on exactly these terms, as a matter of honour and the general good. A student who has written the excellent answer already understands why Brutus's funeral speech sounds the way it does.

Question 3: What does Caesar's speech about Cassius reveal?

WEAK ANSWER Weak answer

Caesar tells Antony that he wants fat men around him who sleep at night. He says Cassius has a lean and hungry look and thinks too much. Antony says Cassius is not dangerous. Caesar says he is not afraid of Cassius but if he were afraid of anyone it would be Cassius, because he reads a lot and does not like plays or music and rarely smiles. Then he tells Antony to come to his right side because his left ear is deaf. This shows Caesar is a good judge of character but also proud.

EXCELLENT ANSWER Excellent answer

The speech reveals a Caesar who sees others clearly and himself not at all. His portrait of Cassius is exact: a man who "reads much", who "looks / Quite through the deeds of men", who "loves no plays" and "hears no music", and who "Seldom he smiles, and smiles in such a sort / As if he mocked himself". Caesar understands the psychology of envy perfectly when he says such men "be never at heart's ease / Whiles they behold a greater than themselves". But every insight is cancelled by his need to be seen as fearless: "I fear him not"; "I rather tell thee what is to be feared / Than what I fear; for always I am Caesar". The third-person self-naming shows that Caesar has begun to believe in 'Caesar' as a public institution immune to private danger. Shakespeare then undercuts the whole speech with one physical detail, "Come on my right hand, for this ear is deaf", so that the great reader of men ends by admitting he cannot hear on one side. The deafness is not in the historical record; it is Shakespeare's emblem for a ruler whose perceptiveness is defeated by his vanity.

DISSECTION

Textual evidence: The weak answer paraphrases the whole speech evenly, giving equal weight to every detail. The excellent answer quotes selectively and places the heaviest weight on the two lines that matter most for the question, "for always I am Caesar" and the deaf ear.

Keyword: 'Irony' and 'self-image' (or 'hubris', used carefully) are the terms the examiner expects. The weak answer offers 'proud', which is correct but unexplained.

Analysis: The weak answer's last sentence contains the right two ideas (good judge, proud) but does not relate them. The excellent answer's opening sentence relates them at once: sees others, not himself. That one relation is the analysis.

Explanation: The excellent answer explains why the third-person 'Caesar' is significant (a man becoming an institution), and what the deaf ear does dramatically (undercuts the speech). The weak answer records the deaf ear as a stage instruction.

Significance: The excellent answer notes that the deafness is Shakespeare's invention, labelled as such, which signals to an examiner that the student can separate the play from history. That is a mark of genuine understanding, not decoration.

Connection: The same pattern, acute perception defeated by self-regard, governs Caesar's refusal of Calpurnia's warnings in Act 2 and his speech to the Senate in Act 3. The excellent answer has defined the pattern; the weak answer has only listed the symptoms.

Question 4: What is the significance of the Soothsayer?

WEAK ANSWER Weak answer

The Soothsayer is a fortune teller who appears in Act 1 Scene 2. When Caesar is going to the games, the Soothsayer calls out to him and warns him to beware the ides of March. Caesar asks who it is and Brutus repeats the warning. Caesar calls the Soothsayer before him and the Soothsayer repeats the warning. Caesar says he is a dreamer and ignores him. This is significant because Caesar is killed on the ides of March, so the Soothsayer was right. It shows the theme of fate.

EXCELLENT ANSWER Excellent answer

The Soothsayer is significant for what he says, how he is answered, and where he is placed. His warning, "Beware the ides of March", is the play's first naming of the date on which Caesar will die, so from this moment the audience watches every scene against a deadline that the characters do not know they are living under; this is the source of the play's dramatic irony. His voice is unmistakable even in a crowd, "a tongue shriller than all the music", which suggests a truth that cuts through ceremony. Caesar's response is the second significance: he gives the man a full hearing, "Set him before me. Let me see his face", and then dismisses him, "He is a dreamer. Let us leave him. Pass." The dismissal shows that Caesar's failure is not deafness to warnings but refusal of them, a choice rather than an accident. Finally, the placement matters: the warning interrupts the Lupercal procession, so that Caesar's hope for an heir, voiced a moment earlier in his instruction to Antony to touch Calpurnia, is immediately shadowed by a prophecy of his death. The text leaves open whether the Soothsayer speaks for fate or merely for shrewd observation of Rome's mood; Shakespeare gives him no explanation, and that silence is part of his power.

DISSECTION

Textual evidence: The weak answer quotes nothing; the excellent answer quotes the warning, the "shriller" line and both halves of Caesar's response, each quotation attached to a point.

Keyword: 'Dramatic irony' and 'foreshadowing' are expected, and the excellent answer uses the first exactly: the audience knows what the characters do not. The weak answer offers 'the theme of fate' without showing how the Soothsayer creates it.

Analysis: The weak answer's analysis is 'the Soothsayer was right'. The excellent answer analyses the dismissal as a choice, which converts Caesar from victim of fate to agent of his own fall, the central question of the play.

Explanation: The excellent answer explains why the placement next to the fertility ritual matters (hope for heirs against prophecy of death). This is Level 3 thinking, 'why did Shakespeare put it here?', and it is what separates Strong from Excellent.

Significance: The excellent answer closes by refusing to settle what the text leaves unsettled (fate or observation), and says so. Examiners reward this precision; it is the opposite of vagueness.

Connection: The 2025 board paper's question about 'the work the ides of March begun' is answerable only by a student who can place this warning and its fulfilment. The excellent answer has already done the placing.

Question 5: How does Casca describe the crown offering, and what does it reveal about Caesar and the crowd?

WEAK ANSWER Weak answer

Casca tells Brutus and Cassius what happened at the games. Antony offered Caesar a crown three times and Caesar refused it three times. The people shouted every time he refused. Then Caesar fainted because of the bad smell of the crowd and fell down foaming at the mouth. When he woke up he said sorry to the people. Casca also says Cicero spoke Greek and that Marullus and Flavius have been punished. This shows that Caesar wanted the crown and the people are foolish.

EXCELLENT ANSWER Excellent answer

Casca describes the offering in deliberately contemptuous prose, calling it "mere foolery" and insisting the crown was really "one of these coronets". The description is slanted at every point, and that slant is the evidence. Of Caesar he says that although he "put it by thrice", he did so "every time gentler than other", that "to my thinking, he would fain have had it" and was "very loath to lay his fingers off it". The repeated 'to my thinking' tells us this is Casca's interpretation of Caesar's desire, not a fact, but the interpretation reveals a Caesar performing reluctance before a crowd whose approval he needs, and whose disapproval literally fells him, since he "swooned and fell down" when the "rabblement hooted". Of the crowd, Casca is merciless: they "clapped their chopped hands and threw up their sweaty nightcaps", and they praised and hissed Caesar "as they use to do the players in the theatre". That simile is the key: Rome's politics has become a performance, Caesar an actor who even "offered them his throat to cut" for effect, and the people an audience whose love is as cheap as their applause. The report thus reveals a Caesar whose power depends on the mob and a mob that can be played.

DISSECTION

Textual evidence: The weak answer is factually sound but quotes nothing and treats the report as neutral. The excellent answer quotes the words that carry Casca's bias ("fain", "loath", "to my thinking") and the words that carry his contempt ("rabblement", "sweaty nightcaps").

Keyword: 'Reported, not staged' and 'fickle' are the two keywords. The excellent answer builds its whole argument on the first (the slant is the evidence) and earns the second through the theatre simile rather than asserting it.

Analysis: The weak answer's conclusion ('Caesar wanted the crown') states as fact what Casca offers as guess. The excellent answer separates Casca's inference from the event, which is exactly the discipline the examiner is testing.

Explanation: The excellent answer explains the theatre simile, the most quotable line in the report, as a diagnosis of Roman politics. The weak answer omits it.

Significance: Caesar's dependence on the crowd, and the crowd's dependence on performance, are the two facts that make Antony's funeral oration in Act 3 possible. The excellent answer has stated both.

Connection: The weak answer wastes a sentence on Cicero's Greek and the tribunes, which are not part of the question. Relevance is itself a marked quality: an examiner reads an irrelevant sentence as a sign the student is unsure what was asked.

Question 6: Why is the storm in Scene 3 significant?

WEAK ANSWER Weak answer

In Act 1 Scene 3 there is a big storm with thunder and lightning. Casca is very frightened and tells Cicero about the strange things he has seen, like a slave whose hand was on fire, a lion near the Capitol, women who saw men on fire and an owl in the daytime. Cicero is calm and goes home. Then Cassius comes and says he is not afraid of the storm. He uses the storm to convince Casca to join the conspiracy. The storm is significant because it shows something bad is going to happen.

EXCELLENT ANSWER Excellent answer

The storm is significant because Shakespeare uses it as a test of how each man reads the world, and the readings predict the men. Casca reads it as divine anger: "Either there is a civil strife in heaven, / Or else the world, too saucy with the gods, / Incenses them to send destruction", and his catalogue of prodigies, the slave's burning hand "Not sensible of fire", the lion that "went surly by", the owl "Even at noonday", is the frightened piety of a man who believes the gods still speak. Cicero reads it sceptically: "men may construe things after their fashion, / Clean from the purpose of the things themselves", a warning that omens mean whatever the interpreter wants, which is precisely what Cassius then proves. Cassius calls the storm "A very pleasing night to honest men" and construes it as "instruments of fear and warning / Unto some monstrous state", then makes the tempest an image of Caesar himself, "a man / Most like this dreadful night". The storm is thus significant on three levels: as atmosphere it makes the conspiracy feel like a convulsion of nature; as foreshadowing it anticipates the violence Cassius names when he calls the night's "complexion" "Most bloody, fiery, and most terrible"; and as a study of interpretation it dramatises the theme that signs are made, not found. Whether the heavens truly warn Rome is left open; Cicero's sentence is the play's own caution.

DISSECTION

Textual evidence: The weak answer lists the prodigies accurately but cannot use them. The excellent answer quotes one phrase from each reader of the storm, so the structure of the answer is the structure of the scene.

Keyword: 'Pathetic fallacy' (nature mirroring human disorder) and 'omen' are expected; 'interpretation' is the keyword the best students add. The excellent answer earns all three without listing them as labels.

Analysis: The weak answer's analysis is 'something bad is going to happen', which is foreshadowing at its vaguest. The excellent answer analyses the storm as a device for contrasting three minds.

Explanation: The excellent answer explains Cicero's line and then shows Cassius illustrating it, which converts a quotation into an argument. The weak answer notes only that Cicero 'is calm'.

Significance: The three-level structure (atmosphere, foreshadowing, interpretation) is a reusable template for any question about setting or weather in Shakespeare. The weak answer offers nothing reusable.

Connection: Calpurnia's dream and the augurers' findings in Act 2 continue this argument about reading signs, as does the Soothsayer's reappearance on the morning of the Ides. The excellent answer has given the student the thread; the weak answer has given a list of frightening things.

Question 7: What does Cassius's soliloquy reveal?

WEAK ANSWER Weak answer

After Brutus leaves, Cassius speaks alone. He says Brutus is noble but can be influenced. He says Caesar does not like him but likes Brutus. He plans to write letters in different handwriting and throw them through Brutus's window pretending they are from citizens, saying how much Rome respects Brutus and hinting at Caesar's ambition. This shows that Cassius is cunning and jealous and will do anything to bring down Caesar.

EXCELLENT ANSWER Excellent answer

The soliloquy reveals the gap between what Cassius has said to Brutus and what he thinks. He grants Brutus's virtue, "Well, Brutus, thou art noble", but immediately turns it into material: "Thy honourable mettle may be wrought / From that it is disposed", where 'wrought' is a metalworker's word, so that Brutus's honour becomes something to be heated and bent. His general maxim, "For who so firm that cannot be seduced?", shows a man who believes no integrity is proof against skilled pressure. Personal grievance surfaces in "Caesar doth bear me hard, but he loves Brutus", and the contrast that follows, "If I were Brutus now, and he were Cassius, / He should not humour me", admits that Cassius would not be swayed as Brutus is being swayed, a confession that he sees Brutus as weaker. The plan for forged letters, "In several hands", "As if they came from several citizens", in which "Caesar's ambition shall be glanced at", reveals a conspiracy that will secure its noblest member by fraud. Yet the soliloquy also contains a principle: the fear that Caesar will "seat him sure" unless Rome acts. The text leaves envy and republican conviction intertwined, and the honest reading is that both are real.

DISSECTION

Textual evidence: The weak answer paraphrases the plan correctly. The excellent answer quotes the words that reveal attitude rather than action: 'wrought', 'seduced', 'humour', 'as if'.

Keyword: 'Manipulation' and 'soliloquy as truth' are expected, and the excellent answer uses the convention of the soliloquy (a character alone speaks his mind) as its organising idea: the gap between said and thought.

Analysis: The weak answer's analysis is the label 'cunning and jealous'. The excellent answer analyses the metalworking metaphor and the hypothetical reversal, each of which yields a specific insight about how Cassius sees Brutus.

Explanation: The excellent answer explains why forged letters are needed (argument has produced only "thus much show of fire") and what they cost (the conspiracy's honour). The weak answer records the letters as a plan.

Significance: The excellent answer refuses to reduce Cassius to envy and says so explicitly, while giving envy its full weight. Examiners reward the writer who can hold two motives in view; they do not reward the writer who picks the simpler one.

Connection: When Brutus accuses Cassius of corruption in their quarrel in Act 4, the audience remembers that the conspiracy was founded on a forgery. A student who has written the excellent answer can bring this soliloquy to an Act 4 question and earn marks with it.

CROSS-REFERENCE Where these seven questions are taught in full

The scene-by-scene reasoning behind each answer is in Chapter 3 (the tribunes), Chapters 4 and 5 (Cassius's persuasion, the Soothsayer, Casca's report, the soliloquy), Chapter 6 (the storm) and Chapter 7 (Caesar's speech about Cassius). The exact wording for every quotation used above is collected in Chapter 15, The Act 1 Quotation Bank, and the terms the dissections rely on are defined in Chapter 14, The ICSE Keyword Vault for Act 1.

HOW ACT 1 KNOWLEDGE EARNS MARKS IN ACT 3–5 QUESTIONS

This section is the honest answer to a question students ask constantly: 'If the board paper only sets Acts III–V, why am I studying Act 1 so carefully?' The answer is that an extract from Act 3, 4 or 5 is a surface; the marks lie underneath it, in motives, relationships and promises that Act 1 established. The five worked examples below each take a kind of question the board paper could set from Acts III–V and show precisely where an Act 1 fact or quotation converts an average answer into a strong one. In each case the Act 3–5 material is paraphrased, not quoted, so that you are not tempted to learn later-act lines from this book rather than from your text.

Worked example 1: A Brutus funeral-speech extract

The kind of sub-question: 'What reason does Brutus give the people for killing Caesar? How far is this reason consistent with what you know of him?'

The Act 1 key: In Act 3 Scene 2 Brutus tells the crowd, in prose, that he loved Caesar but loved Rome more, and that Caesar died because he was ambitious. He asks the citizens whether they would rather live as slaves under a living Caesar or as free men with Caesar dead, and he stakes the whole speech on his own honour. An average answer explains this reasoning from the extract. A strong answer shows that it is not new: Brutus announced the principle in Act 1 Scene 2 when he told Cassius that for "the general good" he would "Set honour in one eye and death i' th' other" and that he loved "The name of honour more than I fear death". He also declared he "had rather be a villager / Than to repute himself a son of Rome / Under these hard conditions". The funeral speech is these two sentences spoken to a crowd. The strong answer therefore earns its consistency mark by proof rather than assertion, and can add the sharper point that the word 'ambitious' comes to Brutus from Cassius, whose forged letters were designed so that "Caesar's ambition shall be glanced at".

Worked example 2: An Antony funeral-oration extract

The kind of sub-question: 'How does Antony use the word honourable in this extract? What does his success reveal about the crowd?'

The Act 1 key: Antony's oration turns the conspirators' claim to honour into a weapon by repeating that Brutus is an honourable man until the phrase means its opposite. An average answer identifies the irony. A strong answer brings two Act 1 facts to it. First, Caesar's own estimate of Antony in Act 1: Cassius "loves no plays, / As thou dost, Antony", so Caesar saw Antony as a lover of pleasure, and Antony's own earlier words were those of a loyal subordinate, "When Caesar says 'Do this,' it is performed". The orator of Act 3 is therefore a man everyone, including Cassius, has underestimated, and the student can say so. Second, the crowd Antony turns is the crowd Shakespeare characterised in Act 1: the commoners who switched from Pompey to Caesar so completely that Marullus called them "blocks" and "stones", and the mob Casca saw clap and hiss Caesar "as they use to do the players in the theatre". Antony's success reveals nothing new about the crowd; it confirms the diagnosis Act 1 made. That sentence, properly supported, is worth a mark in itself.

Worked example 3: The 'ides of March begun' question

The kind of sub-question: The 2025 paper asked what 'the work the ides of March begun' refers to. The words are Cassius's, spoken to Brutus at Philippi in Act 5 before the battle, as they contemplate that this day may finish what the assassination started.

The Act 1 key: The answer is the assassination of Caesar on 15 March, and a mark is earned simply by knowing that. But the fuller answer shows where the date entered the play: the Soothsayer's "Beware the ides of March" in Act 1 Scene 2, repeated when Caesar demanded "Speak once again", and dismissed with "He is a dreamer". The student can then explain the weight of Cassius's phrase: 'the work' began on a day the conspirators were warned about through the man they meant to kill, and it is still unfinished at Philippi, so that the Soothsayer's date has become the measure of the whole tragedy. A question that looks like simple recall becomes, for the prepared student, an opportunity to show understanding of the play's architecture.

Worked example 4: The quarrel scene in Act 4

The kind of sub-question: 'What does this quarrel reveal about the relationship between Brutus and Cassius?'

The Act 1 key: In the tent at Sardis Brutus accuses Cassius of taking bribes and of having an itching palm, and Cassius, wounded, protests that Brutus has wronged him; the quarrel exposes Brutus's rigid honour against Cassius's practical corruption. An average answer describes this clash. A strong answer explains why it was inevitable, using the soliloquy of Act 1 Scene 2. Cassius said there that Brutus's "honourable mettle may be wrought / From that it is disposed", and that "If I were Brutus now, and he were Cassius, / He should not humour me". The alliance was built by a realist bending an idealist. In Act 4 the idealist, now awake, is judging the realist by the standard the realist used to recruit him. The strong answer can add that Cassius's "Caesar doth bear me hard, but he loves Brutus" showed from the start that Cassius needed Brutus more than Brutus needed Cassius, which is why, in the quarrel, it is Cassius who finally yields.

Worked example 5: Caesar's last speech in the Senate (Act 3 Scene 1)

The kind of sub-question: 'What impression of Caesar do you form from his refusal of the conspirators' petition? Is it consistent with the Caesar we have seen earlier?'

The Act 1 key: Moments before he is stabbed, Caesar refuses to recall Publius Cimber, comparing himself to the fixed northern star and declaring that he alone of men is unshakeable. An average answer calls this arrogance. A strong answer shows the arrogance has a history. In Act 1 Scene 2 Caesar spoke of himself in the third person, "for always I am Caesar", and claimed to be above fear while admitting a deaf ear in the same

breath. He dismissed the Soothsayer as "a dreamer". He told Antony what "is to be feared" rather than what he feared. The Senate speech is the end point of a self-image the student has watched forming since the Lupercal. The strong answer also notes who strikes first: Casca, the man Brutus remembered as "quick mettle when he went to school" and whom Cassius described as swift "in execution / Of any bold or noble enterprise". A student who knows Act 1 can explain why it is Casca's hand that begins the killing; a student who does not can only report it.

ICSE EXAM BOX Using Act 1 in a board answer: the rule of proportion

Act 1 material in an Act 3–5 answer is a key, not a second answer. One precise reference, with a short quotation and a sentence showing its relevance, earns the mark. A paragraph on Act 1 in an Act 3 question signals that the student would rather answer a different extract, and examiners read it that way. Bring the Act 1 fact, use it, and return to the extract in front of you.

MCQ TRAINING

Section A of the 2025 paper carried 16 one-mark MCQs across the three genres, and MCQs on the drama can reach back to earlier acts for context. The twelve questions below are written in the ICSE manner: a short stem, four options, one correct answer, and distractors built from the errors students actually make. Answer all twelve before reading the key. A score below ten means the Common Errors section that follows is urgent reading.

1. Who speaks the first line of the play? (a) Marullus (b) Flavius (c) the Cobbler (d) Caesar
2. The Cobbler describes himself as a "surgeon to old shoes". He means that he (a) treats injured feet (b) repairs worn footwear (c) sells leather to surgeons (d) mends the tribunes' tempers
3. Marullus reminds the commoners of the days when they waited "To see great Pompey pass the streets of Rome" in order to (a) praise Caesar's generosity (b) expose the crowd's fickleness (c) describe Pompey's triumph over Caesar (d) explain the feast of Lupercal
4. Caesar asks Antony to touch Calpurnia during the race because (a) she is ill (b) the elders say it cures barrenness (c) Antony has asked to meet her (d) it is a sign of Caesar's authority
5. Caesar's response to the Soothsayer's warning is (a) to arrest him (b) to ask Brutus to question him (c) to call him a dreamer and move on (d) to postpone the games
6. When Cassius tells Brutus "I, your glass, / Will modestly discover to yourself", he means he will (a) show Brutus his own hidden worth (b) protect Brutus from Caesar (c) report Brutus's words to Caesar (d) reflect Caesar's greatness
7. The crown Casca describes was offered by (a) Brutus (b) Casca himself (c) Antony (d) the Senate
8. According to Casca, Caesar refused the crown (a) once (b) twice (c) three times (d) four times
9. Casca says that Caesar "foamed at mouth and was speechless". Brutus explains this as (a) poison (b) the falling sickness (c) exhaustion from the race (d) a trick to win sympathy
10. "It was Greek to me" is said by Casca about (a) Cicero's words (b) Antony's speech (c) the Soothsayer's warning (d) Caesar's apology
11. In Act 1 Scene 3, Cassius asks Cinna to place one of the papers (a) on Caesar's statue (b) in Antony's house (c) in the praetor's chair (d) at the Capitol
12. Which of the following is NOT one of the prodigies Casca reports to Cicero? (a) a slave's hand burning without harm (b) a lion near the Capitol (c) an owl hooting at noon in the marketplace (d) blood raining on the Capitol

Answer key with one-line justifications

1. **(b) Flavius.** His "Hence! Home, you idle creatures, get you home!" opens the play; Marullus speaks second. Students confuse the two because they share one role.
2. **(b) Repairs worn footwear.** The joke is that he 'recovers' (re-covers) shoes "when they are in great danger", a surgical pun on his trade.
3. **(b) Expose the crowd's fickleness.** The memory of their devotion to Pompey is set against their present rejoicing "over Pompey's blood".
4. **(b) The elders say it cures barrenness.** Caesar says "The barren, touchèd in this holy chase, / Shake off their sterile curse"; the detail reveals his wish for an heir.
5. **(c) Call him a dreamer and move on.** "He is a dreamer. Let us leave him. Pass." He does look the man in the face first, which option (a) and (b) ignore.
6. **(a) Show Brutus his own hidden worth.** Cassius will "discover to yourself / That of yourself which you yet know not of".
7. **(c) Antony.** Casca answers "Why, Antony" when Cassius asks who offered it; students who answer (a) have confused the offerer with the questioner.
8. **(c) Three times.** "he put it by thrice, every time gentler than other". Plutarch records two offers; Shakespeare's Casca says three.
9. **(b) The falling sickness.** Brutus: "'Tis very like; he hath the falling sickness." Cassius's reply turns the phrase into a metaphor for Rome.
10. **(a) Cicero's words.** Casca says Cicero "spoke Greek" and that those who understood "smiled at one another and shook their heads".
11. **(c) In the praetor's chair.** "lay it in the Praetor's chair, / Where Brutus may but find it"; the others go in at Brutus's window and on old Brutus's statue, not Caesar's.
12. **(d) Blood raining on the Capitol.** Casca reports the burning hand, the lion, the women who saw men in fire, and the "bird of night" at noon; raining blood is not among them.

ICSE EXAM BOX Reading an MCQ the examiner's way

Distractors are built from predictable confusions: the two tribunes swapped, the questioner for the offerer, Caesar's statue for Brutus's, Plutarch's two offers for Shakespeare's three. Before choosing, ask which confusion each wrong option is testing. If you can name the confusion, you have usually found the answer.

COMMON ERRORS

Each error below has cost real students real marks. Each is stated, corrected from the text, and followed by the habit that prevents it.

1. Attributing Casca's report of the crown to Antony or Brutus. Antony offered the crown; Casca reported the offering; Brutus and Cassius listened and asked questions. Students write 'Antony tells Brutus that Caesar refused the crown' or 'Brutus saw Caesar refuse the crown'. Neither happened. Brutus and Cassius were off-stage in conversation when the offering occurred, which is why Brutus must ask "Tell us the manner of it, gentle Casca". Prevention: whenever you write about the crown, write 'Casca reports' before anything else.

2. Calling the Cobbler a carpenter. There are two commoners who speak. The Carpenter answers Flavius's question in one line; the Cobbler makes all the puns, including "a mender of bad soles" and "all that I live by is with the awl". Students who merge them write 'the carpenter jokes about mending souls', which an examiner

marks as a textual error. Prevention: the pun on soles belongs to the man who makes soles.

3. Saying the crown was offered on stage. The offering happens in the marketplace while Brutus and Cassius talk elsewhere; the audience hears only shouts and flourishes, and learns what happened from Casca afterwards. This is not a technicality. Shakespeare chose to show us the event through Casca's cynical eyes so that we cannot know whether Caesar truly wanted the crown. A student who writes 'we see Caesar refuse the crown' has missed the dramatic method. Prevention: write 'reported, not staged' in the margin of your notes on this scene.

4. Treating Caesar's deaf ear as history. "Come on my right hand, for this ear is deaf" is Shakespeare's addition; no ancient source records it. Students write 'Caesar was historically deaf in one ear', which is an invented fact. Caesar's falling sickness, by contrast, is in Plutarch. Prevention: label the deafness as Shakespeare's dramatic emblem and the epilepsy as recorded, and keep the two separate.

5. Saying Cicero joins the conspiracy. In Act 1 Cicero speaks with Casca during the storm and leaves before Cassius arrives; he is never recruited, and in Act 2 the conspirators decide against including him. Historically he was not a conspirator. Students write 'Cicero and Casca plan the conspiracy' because both are in Scene 3. Prevention: remember that Cicero's exit line, "This disturbed sky / Is not to walk in", removes him from the stage before any plotting begins.

6. Writing 'jealous' for Cassius without analysis. 'Cassius is jealous of Caesar' is true and earns nothing on its own. The mark comes from showing how the jealousy appears (the Tiber rescue, the fever, "this god did shake"), what it is mixed with (republican conviction, the fear that Caesar will "seat him sure"), and where the text lets the two motives show at once (the soliloquy). Caesar himself gives the analysis the student should give: such men "be never at heart's ease / Whiles they behold a greater than themselves". Prevention: never write 'jealous' without a 'because' and a quotation following it.

7. Saying Brutus joins the conspiracy in Act 1. He does not. He agrees to listen, "What you have said / I will consider", and Cassius's soliloquy and the forged letters exist precisely because Brutus is not yet won. His decision comes in Act 2. Prevention: track Brutus's commitment scene by scene; in Act 1 it is 'moved, not committed'.

8. Placing the storm on the night of the Lupercal. Cicero's question "Comes Caesar to the Capitol tomorrow?" fixes Scene 3 on the eve of the Ides, so a month passes silently between Scenes 2 and 3. Students who write 'that same night' miscount the play's time scheme. Prevention: write the date beside each scene when revising.

9. Confusing the two Cinna's. The Cinna of Act 1 Scene 3 is a conspirator who carries Cassius's letters. The Cinna torn apart by the mob in Act 3 is a poet who shares the name. Prevention: 'Cinna the conspirator' and 'Cinna the poet' in your notes, always with the label.

10. Inventing quotations. Under pressure students produce lines that sound Shakespearean but are not in the play, or splice two lines together. Examiners know the text. A paraphrase introduced with 'Cassius says that...' is safe; an invented quotation in quotation marks is a visible error. Prevention: learn fewer quotations and learn them exactly; Chapter 15 gives you the set.

REVISION The examiner-mode checklist

Before you write any sub-answer: find the verb in the question and name the level it demands (recall, understanding, application, analysis, evaluation). First sentence: answer the verb, with a textual anchor, no stalling. Three-mark answer: three points, three short pieces of evidence, five to seven sentences. Four-mark answer: a position, two supported points, one 'although', one 'because', eight to ten sentences. Never begin with a character's name and an action verb. Never write 'jealous', 'proud', 'important' or 'foreshadows' without the evidence that earns it. In an Act 3–5 answer, use Act 1 as a key, in one precise sentence, and return to the extract. And remember what the examiner reads first: the first two lines.

CROSS-REFERENCE Where to go next

Chapter 18, Extract-Based Training (Part One), and Chapter 19, Extract-Based Training (Part Two), apply everything in this chapter to twelve full Act 1 extracts with marked model answers. Chapter 16, The Scene Connection Engine, maps every Act 1 moment that resurfaces in Acts 3–5, and is the natural companion to the worked examples above. Chapter 14, The ICSE Keyword Vault, supplies the terminology the dissections used.

CHAPTER 18

Extract-Based Training (Part One): Scene 1 and the First Half of Scene 2

This chapter turns everything you have learned about Act 1 into the one skill that examiners actually reward: reading a short passage and answering five graded questions on it. It takes six extracts from Scene 1 and the first half of Scene 2, works each one through a fixed thirteen-label analysis, then sets a full ICSE-style question with model answers and an explanation of exactly why each answer scores. You will also learn a 90-second method for an unseen extract. Work through the extracts in order; each one trains a move the next one assumes.

How This Chapter Trains You

An extract question hands you ten to fourteen lines and five sub-questions. In the 2025 ICSE board paper the drama extracts carried 16 marks, split [3], [3], [3], [3], [4]. The first sub-questions test whether you know where you are in the play; the middle ones test whether you understand the words and can explain why they are spoken; the last one asks you to judge, compare or respond. The skill is the same whether the extract comes from Act 1 or Act 5.

EXAM-ORIENTED ADVICE: Be clear about the syllabus split. Act 1 belongs to the Class IX portion of the ICSE syllabus, examined by your school, usually through 'reference to the context' questions. The Class X board paper examines Acts III, IV and V. So the six extracts in this chapter are not board extracts. They matter for two honest reasons. First, the technique of reading an extract is identical, and Act 1 passages are the ideal training ground because you already know the story. Second, the board paper constantly assumes Act 1: the 2025 paper, for instance, asked candidates what 'the work the ides of March begun' referred to, which is unanswerable without the Soothsayer, the Lupercal and the conspiracy of Act 1. Every Act 3 question about why Brutus joined, why Cassius hates Caesar or why the crowd is fickle is really an Act 1 question in disguise.

The thirteen labels and the five levels

Every extract below is worked through the same thirteen labels. They are not a ritual; each one answers a question an examiner is silently asking. The table shows how they map onto the five levels this book teaches.

Label	Level	What the examiner is really testing
Context, Speaker, Listener, Before, After	Level 1 — What happened?	Can you place the lines precisely and know what surrounds them?
Meaning	Level 2 — What does it mean?	Can you turn Shakespeare's English into your own clear English?

Label	Level	What the examiner is really testing
Subtext, Character, Device	Level 3 — Why did Shakespeare write it this way?	Can you see what is not said, what the words reveal, how the effect is built?
Theme, Historical context, Scene connection	Level 4 — How does it connect to the whole play?	Can you link a moment to the play's ideas, its sources and its later scenes?
Keywords	Level 5 — How do I use it in an ICSE answer?	Do you own the precise vocabulary that makes an answer sound like literature?

Do the labels in order when you practise. A student who jumps to 'theme' before securing 'before' and 'after' writes clever answers about the wrong moment, and loses marks for accuracy that no amount of insight can win back.

PROFESSOR'S INSIGHT How to read an unseen extract in 90 seconds

Trained readers do not read an extract from the first word to the last and then hope. They interrogate it in four passes, and the whole process takes about a minute and a half.

First pass (0–15 seconds) — the labels. Read only the speaker labels and any names inside the speech. Who is talking, to whom, and who is named? If Pompey is named, you are in Scene 1; if a shout is heard, you are outside the Lupercal games in Scene 2; if the ides are named, the Soothsayer is near.

Second pass (15–35 seconds) — the hinge. Every extract has one line the paper will hang a question on: usually an image (feathers, mirror, Colossus) or a proverb-like statement (the fault is not in our stars). Find it and underline it. This is where the 'explain' question and the 'device' question will come from.

Third pass (35–60 seconds) — the edges. Look at the first and last lines and ask what must have just happened and what must happen next. The 'before' and 'after' marks live at the edges.

Fourth pass (60–90 seconds) — the margin note. Write three words in the margin: one character quality, one theme, one device. You now have the skeleton of all five answers before you write a sentence. Only then do you read the questions, because you read them as someone who already knows what the passage is for.

ICSE EXAM BOX How marks are distributed across a five-part extract question

In the 2025 paper the pattern was [3][3][3][3][4]. Read the pattern as a ladder. The two or three 3-mark questions at the top are usually recall and understanding: where are we, what has just happened, what does a phrase mean. A 3-mark question in the middle is often application or analysis: why does the speaker say this, what does it reveal about him, what is the tone. The final 4-mark question is evaluative or comparative: how far do you agree, which argument was strongest, what does the passage prepare us for. A 3-mark answer needs three distinct, correct points; a 4-mark answer needs four, or three developed points with a supported judgement. Never write one long paragraph for a 3-mark question and one line for the 4-mark one. Nothing in this box is a promise about a future paper; it is a description of a verified paper and the habits that fit it.

CROSS-REFERENCE Where this chapter leans on other chapters

The scene-by-scene chapters ('Act 1 Scene 1 — The Street: Commoners, Tribunes and the Fickle Crowd' and 'Act 1 Scene 2 (Part One) — Lupercalia, the Soothsayer, and the Seduction of Brutus') give the full close reading that the labels here compress. 'ICSE Examiner Mode: How Marks Are Earned' explains the marking logic that the **Why this answer earns marks** paragraphs apply. 'The Act 1 Literary-Device Bank' and 'The ICSE Keyword Vault for Act 1' hold the terms you will see under **Device** and **Keywords**. 'Extract-Based Training (Part Two)' continues with Casca's report, Caesar on Cassius, and the storm scene.

Extract 1 — The Tribunes Meet the Cobbler

EXTRACT Extract 1 — Act 1 Scene 1, the opening lines of the play

Flavius: *Hence! Home, you idle creatures, get you home!*

*Is this a holiday? What, know you not,
Being mechanical, you ought not walk
Upon a labouring day without the sign
Of your profession?—Speak, what trade art thou?*

Carpenter: *Why, sir, a carpenter.*

Marullus: *Where is thy leather apron and thy rule?
What dost thou with thy best apparel on?—
You, sir, what trade are you?*

Cobbler: *Truly, sir, in respect of a fine workman, I am but, as you would say, a cobbler.*

Marullus: *But what trade art thou? Answer me directly.*

Cobbler: *A trade, sir, that I hope I may use with a safe conscience, which is indeed, sir, a mender of bad soles.*

Context: These are the first words of the play. The setting is a street in Rome on a public holiday. Working men have put on their best clothes and come out to see Julius Caesar return in triumph; Shakespeare's Rome is celebrating the victory over the sons of Pompey and, on the same day, keeping the feast of Lupercal. Two tribunes, Flavius and Marullus, are trying to clear the streets. Nothing has been explained to the audience yet; we learn who is who, and what the holiday is for, by watching this quarrel.

Speaker: Flavius opens; Marullus takes over the questioning; the Carpenter and the Cobbler answer. Note the division of labour between the tribunes: Flavius gives orders, Marullus interrogates. Both are officials, and both are angry.

Listener: The commoners on stage, and behind them the theatre audience, who are in exactly the same position as the crowd: idle, festive, and about to be told that their holiday is a disgrace.

Before: Nothing precedes this exchange in the play. What precedes it in the story is Caesar's victory at Munda in Spain over the sons of Pompey, the triumph granted for it, and the death of Pompey himself years earlier. All of this the tribunes will pour out in a moment, but here it is only implied by the words holiday and triumph.

After: The Cobbler keeps sliding out of Flavius's grip with puns: he begs him "be not out with me", adds "Yet if you be out, sir, I can mend you", claims "all that I live by is with the awl" and calls himself "a surgeon to old shoes". Flavius finally asks the useful question, "But wherefore art not in thy shop today?", and the Cobbler tells the truth: "we make holiday to see Caesar and to rejoice in his triumph." That single sentence releases Marullus's furious speech about Pompey (Extract 2) and the tribunes' plan to strip Caesar's images (Extract 3).

Meaning: In plain English, Flavius says: 'Get out of here, go home, you lazy people. Is this a holiday? Do you not know that as working men you are not allowed to walk about on a working day without wearing the tools and clothes of your trade? You, what is your job?' The Carpenter answers straight. Marullus then demands to know why he is not wearing his leather apron and carrying his rule (a measuring stick), and why he has his best clothes on. The Cobbler's first answer is a joke at his own expense: compared with a really fine craftsman, he is only what you would call a cobbler, a word that in Shakespeare's English meant both a shoe-mender and a clumsy bungler. Told to answer directly, he says his trade is one he can practise with a clear conscience, because he mends bad soles. Difficult words: mechanical (a manual worker, someone who works with his hands), apparel (clothing), rule (a measuring rule), in respect of (compared with), directly (plainly, without evasion).

Subtext: The tribunes are not really angry about aprons. The clothes are a pretext for a political objection that they cannot yet say aloud to a crowd: that celebrating this triumph means celebrating the defeat of Romans by a Roman, and that a man who is cheered like a king soon becomes one. The Cobbler's evasions are not stupidity. He understands perfectly that he is being bullied, and he answers a bullying question with a slippery one. When he says he works with a safe conscience, he is quietly claiming the moral high ground: his trade harms no one, unlike, perhaps, the trade of politics. The exchange dramatises a Rome in which those who should speak for the people are shouting at the people, and the people are answering back with wit rather than obedience.

Character: Flavius is peremptory (commanding in an abrupt way): four imperatives in his first line and a half. Marullus is the sharper questioner, but he too resorts to insult when the Cobbler resists. The Carpenter is the plain, obedient citizen. The Cobbler is the scene's most intelligent presence: self-mocking, unhurried, unafraid, and entirely in control of the words. Shakespeare gives the wit to the working man and the temper to the officials.

Theme: The extract opens three of the play's great themes at once. Public opinion and the crowd: Rome's people are already seen as fickle, dressing up for the man who beat their former favourite. Authority and liberty: the tribunes' power to order citizens off the street is the republic's power, and the crowd's cheerful disobedience is its weakness. Appearance versus reality: the argument is literally about clothing, about what a man wears and what he is, and this question of surfaces will run through the whole play.

Device: The most important device is the contrast of prose and verse. Flavius and Marullus speak blank verse (unrhymed iambic pentameter, ten syllables with a rising rhythm); the Carpenter and Cobbler speak prose. Shakespeare uses this contrast to mark class and also temperature: verse for public authority and passion, prose for street-level realism and humour. Within the prose the Cobbler puns: soles and souls sound alike, so a mender of bad soles is also a mender of bad souls, a joke that turns him into a kind of priest to the tribunes. Flavius's opening is built from imperatives and a rhetorical question ("Is this a holiday?"), which is not a request for information but a rebuke.

Historical context: HISTORICAL RECORD: Tribunes of the plebs were Roman officers created, by tradition, in 494 BC to protect ordinary citizens against the aristocracy; they were sacrosanct and could veto legislation. That is the irony of the opening: the people's protectors are scolding the people. The real tribunes Gaius Epidius Marullus and Lucius Caesetius Flavus did clash with Caesar in 44 BC, removing a diadem that had been placed on his statue and arresting men who hailed him as king; Caesar had them deposed. Caesar's

Spanish triumph, celebrated in October 45 BC for the victory at Munda, was resented because it celebrated a victory over fellow Romans. Shakespeare compresses that triumph and the Lupercalia of 15 February 44 BC into one day. **LITERARY INTERPRETATION:** The rule that a working man must wear the sign of his trade on a working day sounds more like Shakespeare's London than ancient Rome; Shakespeare habitually dresses Roman commoners in Elizabethan habits so that his audience will recognise themselves.

Scene connection: The crowd that dresses up here is the crowd Casca will describe hooting and clapping at Caesar's refusal of the crown later in Scene 2, the crowd Antony will turn against the conspirators in Act 3, and the mob that tears Cinna the poet apart. The tribunes who clear the streets here are, by the end of Scene 2, reported as "put to silence" for pulling scarves off Caesar's images: the first hint that opposing Caesar has a cost. And Flavius's fear that Caesar will keep Rome "in servile fearfulness" is the seed of Cassius's argument to Brutus that Romans have become underlings.

Keywords: exposition; tribunes; plebeians; mechanicals; prose versus blank verse; pun; class tension; fickle crowd; peremptory; evasion; comic relief with political weight; sumptuary detail; anachronism.

QUESTIONS Extract 1 — ICSE-style questions

Read the extract and answer the following questions.

- (i) Where does this scene take place, and on what occasion? Who are Flavius and Marullus, and why are they angry with the men they meet? [3]
- (ii) Explain in your own words what Flavius means by "Being mechanical, you ought not walk / Upon a labouring day without the sign / Of your profession". What do Marullus's questions about the "leather apron" and "best apparel" add to the argument? [3]
- (iii) The Cobbler calls himself "a mender of bad soles". Explain the pun, and show, with reference to what the Cobbler says immediately after the extract, how he continues to play with words. [3]
- (iv) Contrast the way the tribunes speak with the way the commoners speak in this extract. What does Shakespeare achieve through this contrast? [3]
- (v) Flavius calls the commoners "idle creatures" and treats them as fools. How far does the rest of Act 1 justify the tribunes' low opinion of the Roman crowd? Support your answer with reference to the text. [4]

Reference to the context (Class IX style)

- (a) "Hence! Home, you idle creatures, get you home!" Who speaks these words, to whom, and on what occasion? What tone does the line set for the play?
- (b) "A trade, sir, that I hope I may use with a safe conscience". Who is speaking? Explain the phrase safe conscience and say what it suggests about the speaker's attitude to the man questioning him.

Multiple-choice questions

1. In this extract the word mechanical means: (a) a person skilled with machines (b) a working man or tradesman (c) a soldier on leave (d) a slave belonging to the state
2. Flavius and Marullus hold the office of: (a) consul (b) senator (c) tribune (d) priest of the Lupercal
3. The commoners have taken the day off in order to: (a) mourn the death of Pompey (b) watch the Lupercal race only (c) protest against Caesar (d) see Caesar and celebrate his triumph

MODEL ANSWER Model answer (i)

The scene is set in a street in Rome. It is a public holiday: Caesar is returning to the city in triumph after defeating the sons of Pompey, and the feast of Lupercal is being kept on the same day. Flavius and Marullus are tribunes, elected officers whose duty is to protect the interests of the common people. They are angry because the working men have left their shops on what should be a working day, and are walking about in their best clothes without the tools or dress of their trades. Beneath this lies a deeper anger: the men are celebrating Caesar, whose growing power the tribunes fear.

Why this answer earns marks: It gives the three things the question asks for in three clear sentences: place and occasion (context), the office of the two speakers (recall with the correct term tribune), and the reason for their anger. It then adds the one piece of insight that lifts a full-mark answer, the political motive behind the complaint about clothes, without wandering into the later speech.

MODEL ANSWER Model answer (ii)

Flavius is telling the men that, as manual workers, they have no right to be wandering the streets on a working day unless they are dressed for work and carrying the signs of their trade. In his view a holiday declared by the crowd for itself is no holiday at all. Marullus sharpens the point with specific details: the Carpenter should have on his leather apron and should be carrying his rule, the measuring stick of his craft, but instead he is wearing his best clothes. The two questions turn a general rebuke into a piece of evidence. The men's fine clothes prove that they have deliberately chosen to treat Caesar's return as a festival, and it is this choice, not the clothes themselves, that the tribunes resent.

Why this answer earns marks: The first half is a genuine paraphrase in the student's own words, which is what an 'explain' question demands; simply repeating the quotation would earn nothing. The word mechanical is correctly glossed. The second half answers the second part of the question directly, explaining what the apron and rule add (specific evidence), and ends with a short piece of analysis about what the tribunes really object to.

MODEL ANSWER Model answer (iii)

The pun rests on the identical sound of soles and souls. A cobbler mends the soles of shoes; but a mender of bad souls is a priest or a moral reformer. The Cobbler therefore answers an insulting question with a joke that makes him sound like a spiritual doctor to the very officials who are bullying him. He goes on in the same vein. When Flavius grows angrier, he says "be not out with me", meaning do not be angry, but adds "Yet if you be out, sir, I can mend you", where out now means having worn-out shoes. He says that "all that I live by is with the awl", playing on awl and all, and calls himself "a surgeon to old shoes" who can "recover" them, which means both to heal and to re-cover with new leather.

Why this answer earns marks: It explains the pun precisely (terminology: pun, two meanings named), it obeys the instruction to refer to the lines immediately after the extract, and it quotes short, accurate phrases rather than long chunks. Each quotation is followed by an explanation of the double meaning, which shows understanding rather than memory. Three developed points comfortably cover three marks.

MODEL ANSWER Model answer (iv)

The tribunes speak in blank verse, the elevated rhythm Shakespeare gives to people of rank and to moments of passion; their lines are full of commands and angry questions, such as "Is this a holiday?" and "Speak, what trade art thou?". The commoners answer in prose, the everyday language of the street, and the Cobbler's prose is relaxed, witty and full of puns. Through this contrast Shakespeare marks the social gap between officials and workers, and at the same time reverses our expectations: the men with power lose their tempers, while the man without power keeps his head and controls the conversation with words. The contrast also sets the play's tone, beginning a tragedy about the fate of Rome with comedy from the very Romans whose opinion will decide that fate.

Why this answer earns marks: It names the device accurately (blank verse versus prose), supports the contrast with short quotations, and then answers the harder second part with two distinct effects, social and dramatic, rather than one. The final sentence connects the technique to the play as a whole, which is the move that separates a competent answer from an excellent one.

MODEL ANSWER Model answer (v)

To a large extent Act 1 confirms the tribunes' poor view of the crowd, though not their contempt. Marullus reminds the people that they once climbed to "chimney tops" with their "infants in your arms" to cheer Pompey, and now "strew flowers" for the man who triumphs "over Pompey's blood"; their loyalty has simply changed sides with success. When rebuked, they "vanish tongue-tied in their guiltiness", too ashamed to argue, which suggests they had not thought about what they were celebrating. Later in Scene 2 Casca reports the same crowd hooting, clapping and throwing up their sweaty nightcaps as Caesar refuses the crown, behaving, he says, as they do to the players in the theatre. The people respond to spectacle, not to principle. Yet the Cobbler's wit shows that individual commoners are far from stupid, and the tribunes' own aggressive behaviour hardly earns them the people's trust. Act 1 justifies the fear that the crowd can be swayed by anyone with a chariot or a crown; it does not justify calling them senseless.

Why this answer earns marks: A 4-mark evaluation needs a clear judgement, evidence from more than one place, and a balancing point. This answer gives a verdict in the first sentence, supports it with three pieces of evidence from Scene 1 and Scene 2 (quotation and connection), and then qualifies it with a counter-argument drawn from the extract itself. The closing sentence returns to the exact wording of the question, distinguishing fickle from senseless, which shows the examiner that the student is answering the question set and not a general one about the mob.

MODEL ANSWER Model answers — reference to the context and MCQs

(a) Flavius, one of the two tribunes of the people, speaks these words to a group of working men in a Rome street on the day of Caesar's triumph, which coincides with the feast of Lupercal. The line is a string of commands and an insult; it sets a tone of public disorder and official irritation, and tells the audience at once that this Rome is a divided city in which the people and their officers want different things.

(b) The Cobbler is speaking to Marullus, who has ordered him to name his trade plainly. A safe conscience is a clear conscience: he means his work is honest and harms no one, so he need not be ashamed of it. The remark is quietly pointed. He implies that he, unlike some, has nothing to hide, and he turns a demand for information into a small assertion of his own respectability.

Why these answers earn marks: Both give speaker, listener and occasion in one sentence before explaining, which is the shape a 'reference to the context' answer must take. Each ends with one sentence of interpretation, so the answer shows understanding as well as recall.

MCQ key: 1 (b); 2 (c); 3 (d). Distractors to notice: (a) in question 1 is the modern meaning of mechanical, not Shakespeare's; (b) in question 3 is a half-truth, since the Lupercal is mentioned but the Cobbler names Caesar's triumph as the reason.

Extract 2 — Marullus Remembers Pompey

EXTRACT Extract 2 — Act 1 Scene 1, Marullus turns on the crowd

Marullus: *Wherefore rejoice? What conquest brings he home?
What tributaries follow him to Rome
To grace in captive bonds his chariot wheels?
You blocks, you stones, you worse than senseless things!
O you hard hearts, you cruel men of Rome,
Knew you not Pompey? Many a time and oft
Have you climbed up to walls and battlements,
To towers and windows, yea, to chimney tops,
Your infants in your arms, and there have sat
The livelong day, with patient expectation,
To see great Pompey pass the streets of Rome.
And when you saw his chariot but appear,
Have you not made an universal shout,*

Context: Still the opening scene, moments after Extract 1. The Cobbler has finally given a straight answer to the tribunes' question about why the shops are shut: "we make holiday to see Caesar and to rejoice in his triumph." The word rejoice detonates this speech. Marullus, who has so far only interrogated, now delivers the play's first passionate verse oration.

Speaker: Marullus, tribune of the people.

Listener: The assembled commoners, with Flavius beside him. The speech is public, and that is its point: Marullus is trying to shame a crowd into remembering.

Before: Flavius has asked "But wherefore art not in thy shop today?" and "Why dost thou lead these men about the streets?"; the Cobbler has joked that he leads them about "to wear out their shoes, to get myself into more work", then admitted the truth about Caesar's triumph.

After: Marullus finishes the picture of the old days, when the people's shout was so loud "That Tiber trembled underneath her banks / To hear the replication of your sounds / Made in her concave shores?" He then hammers the contrast with a triple question: "And do you now put on your best attire? / And do you now cull out a holiday? / And do you now strew flowers in his way / That comes in triumph over Pompey's blood?" He dismisses them with orders to go home, kneel and "Pray to the gods to intermit the plague / That needs must light on this ingratitude." Flavius adds a gentler command to weep into the Tiber, and the commoners leave without a word.

Meaning: 'Why celebrate? What conquest has he brought home? What conquered peoples, paying tribute, walk behind him to Rome as chained prisoners decorating his chariot? You blocks of wood, you stones, you things with even less feeling than that! You hard-hearted, cruel Romans, did you not know Pompey? Time and again you climbed up walls and battlements, towers and windows, even chimney tops, carrying your babies, and sat there all day waiting patiently just to watch great Pompey pass through the streets. And the moment his chariot came into view, did you not all shout together...' Difficult words: tributaries (subject peoples or rulers who pay tribute to a conqueror), captive bonds (the chains of prisoners of war), grace (adorn), senseless (without the power to feel), livelong (the whole, long), replication (echo), concave shores (hollowed, curving river banks).

Subtext: The first two questions are an accusation in disguise. A triumph was meant to display foreign captives and foreign wealth; there are none here, because Caesar has defeated Romans, the sons of Pompey. Marullus cannot say 'this triumph is illegal' to a festive crowd, so he asks them to notice what is missing from the procession. The reminder of Pompey is also a charge of betrayal: the crowd has transferred its love to the man who destroyed its old hero. But the speech contains an irony Marullus does not intend. His own picture of the people climbing chimneys to watch a chariot proves that they have always loved the spectacle more than the man. They cheered Pompey's chariot; now they cheer Caesar's. The very memory he uses to shame them shows that they cannot be relied on by either side.

Character: Marullus is passionate, eloquent and brave, and he has a sense of history that the crowd lacks. He is also a partisan: his grief for Pompey is personal, and his contempt for the crowd is open. He attacks the people he ought to be winning over, calling them stones and cruel men, and he ends by predicting divine punishment for them. He is the republic at its most sincere and least skilful.

Theme: Public opinion and its fickleness; ingratitude as a political sin; the illegitimacy of power won over fellow citizens in civil war; the contest between memory (Pompey) and spectacle (Caesar's chariot). Beneath all of these lies the play's central anxiety: a republic whose survival depends on a crowd that changes its mind.

Device: Marullus begins with a barrage of rhetorical questions, which demand agreement rather than information. He turns to invective (violent abuse) and apostrophe (direct address) in "You blocks, you stones", a metaphor that reduces men to lifeless objects, then intensifies it: they are "worse than senseless things", because stones at least cannot be ungrateful. The list of vantage points is a climax, an ascending order from walls to battlements to towers to windows to chimney tops, so that the crowd's devotion seems to rise physically before our eyes. The detail of infants in arms is pathos, an appeal to feeling. In the lines that follow, the personified Tiber trembling at the echo is hyperbole, and the repeated "And do you now" is anaphora, the repetition of an opening phrase, which turns the contrast between then and now into a drumbeat.

Historical context: HISTORICAL RECORD: A Roman triumph was granted by the Senate for victory over a foreign enemy. The procession moved from the Campus Martius through the city to the Temple of Jupiter on the Capitoline hill: captives in chains and the spoils of war went before, and the general rode in a four-horse chariot wearing a purple-and-gold toga and a laurel wreath. A triumph for a civil-war victory was considered improper, and Plutarch records that Caesar's Spanish triumph of October 45 BC, which celebrated the defeat of Pompey's sons at Munda, was resented for exactly this reason. Pompey the Great had celebrated three triumphs and was for years the most popular man in Rome; he was defeated by Caesar at Pharsalus in 48 BC and murdered in Egypt shortly afterwards. **LITERARY INTERPRETATION:** Shakespeare places this triumph on the day of the Lupercalia, which historically fell four months later; the compression lets the tribunes' grievance and the crown-offering collide in a single afternoon.

Scene connection: The appetite for spectacle Marullus describes is exactly what Casca reports later in Scene 2, when the crowd claps and hisses Caesar "as they use to do the players in the theatre". The fickleness will become the engine of Act 3, where the same crowd is turned by Brutus and then by Antony within minutes. Pompey's name keeps returning: the conspirators gather at Pompey's Porch in Scene 3, and Caesar's death in Act 3 is staged in Pompey's shadow. Marullus's contempt for the people also anticipates Cassius's outburst in Scene 3 that Rome has become trash and rubbish for serving as fuel to Caesar's fire: the republicans of this play never quite respect the republic's citizens.

Keywords: rhetorical question; invective; apostrophe; metaphor; climax; anaphora; hyperbole; personification; pathos; fickle; ingratitude; tributaries; triumph; civil war; partisan; Pompeian.

QUESTIONS Extract 2 — ICSE-style questions

- (i) Who is the speaker, and to whom is he speaking? What has just been said that provokes this outburst, and on what occasion? [3]
- (ii) Explain the lines "What tributaries follow him to Rome / To grace in captive bonds his chariot wheels?" Why can this question be called a hidden accusation against Caesar? [3]
- (iii) What picture does Marullus paint of the people's former devotion to Pompey? Select two details from the extract and explain the effect of each. [3]
- (iv) Identify two rhetorical devices used in the extract and show how each one strengthens Marullus's attack on the crowd. [3]
- (v) Marullus calls the people "worse than senseless things". In your view, does his own speech prove or disprove this judgement? Refer to what happens immediately after the speech and to the crowd's behaviour later in Act 1. [4]

Reference to the context (Class IX style)

- (a) "Knew you not Pompey?" Who was Pompey, and what had happened to him? Why does the speaker bring up his name at this moment?
- (b) "You blocks, you stones, you worse than senseless things!" Who is being addressed? Name the figure of speech and comment on the tone of the line.

Multiple-choice questions

- In the extract, tributaries means: (a) small rivers flowing into a larger one (b) conquered peoples who pay tribute to Rome (c) members of the Roman Senate (d) Caesar's veteran soldiers
- In the play, Caesar's triumph celebrates his victory over: (a) the tribes of Gaul (b) the sons of Pompey (c) the Parthians (d) the Egyptians
- When Marullus finishes speaking, the commoners: (a) argue with him (b) attack the tribunes (c) leave in silence (d) begin to cheer for Pompey

MODEL ANSWER Model answer (i)

The speaker is Marullus, one of the two tribunes of the people, and he is addressing the crowd of working men whom he and Flavius have stopped in a street of Rome. The occasion is the public holiday for Caesar's triumphal return after defeating the sons of Pompey, which falls on the feast of Lupercal. The Cobbler has just admitted that the men have shut their shops in order to see Caesar and to rejoice in his triumph, and it is the idea of rejoicing at such a victory that provokes Marullus's anger.

Why this answer earns marks: Speaker, listener and occasion are given precisely (context and recall). The trigger for the speech is identified from the text, with the key word rejoice picked out, so the examiner sees that the student has located the extract exactly and understood why it begins with the question Wherefore rejoice.

MODEL ANSWER Model answer (ii)

Marullus asks what conquered peoples are walking behind Caesar to Rome as prisoners in chains, decorating his chariot as trophies of victory. In a proper Roman triumph the general displayed foreign captives and plunder to prove that he had enlarged the power of Rome. Marullus's question expects the answer none, because Caesar has not conquered a foreign enemy; he has defeated fellow Romans, the sons of Pompey, in a civil war. The question is therefore an accusation in disguise. Without ever saying that the triumph is improper or that Caesar is dangerous, Marullus invites the crowd to see for themselves that there is nothing to celebrate, and that the man they are cheering has spilt Roman blood.

Why this answer earns marks: The paraphrase is accurate and glosses the two hard words (tributaries, captive bonds). The answer then explains the historical logic of a triumph, which is needed to see why the question wounds, and finally answers the second part directly, explaining what is hidden and why it is an accusation. Understanding, context and analysis are all present.

MODEL ANSWER Model answer (iii)

Marullus describes a people so devoted to Pompey that they would climb to any height and wait any length of time for a glimpse of him. Two details stand out. First, the rising list of places, from "walls and battlements" up to "chimney tops": the climax makes the crowd's eagerness seem to grow taller as he speaks, and the comic exaggeration of the chimney tops mocks how far they were once willing to go. Second, "Your infants in your arms": the people brought their babies, as if to a family festival, and this detail adds pathos, reminding them that their love for Pompey was tender and shared, not merely political. Both details make the present celebration of Pompey's conqueror look like a betrayal of something intimate.

Why this answer earns marks: The question asks for two details and their effects, and the answer delivers exactly that structure with short accurate quotations. Each effect is explained in terms of a named device (climax, pathos) and linked to Marullus's purpose. The last sentence draws the two points together into the argument of the speech, which shows analysis rather than description.

MODEL ANSWER Model answer (iv)

The first device is the rhetorical question. Marullus opens with a volley of them: "Wherefore rejoice? What conquest brings he home?" and so on. They are not requests for information but challenges; each one forces the crowd to supply an answer that condemns them, so that they seem to accuse themselves. The second device is apostrophe combined with metaphor: in "You blocks, you stones, you worse than senseless things!" he addresses the people directly and reduces them to lifeless objects, then intensifies the insult by saying they are worse than stones, since stones cannot be ungrateful. The direct address makes the attack personal and inescapable, and the metaphor strips the crowd of the very humanity, memory and feeling, that he is about to appeal to when he recalls Pompey.

Why this answer earns marks: Two devices are correctly named (terminology), each is quoted, and each is explained in terms of its effect on the listener, which is what the word strengthens in the question demands. The answer does not stop at identification, the commonest way to lose marks on a device question; it says what the device does.

MODEL ANSWER Model answer (v)

Marullus's speech comes closer to proving his charge than he might wish, though not in the way he means. Immediately after it the commoners do not defend themselves; as Flavius observes, they "vanish tongue-tied in their guiltiness". Their silence suggests that they had never thought about what they were celebrating, and that they can be shamed out of a mood as easily as they were talked into it. Later in Scene 2 Casca describes the same crowd shouting at every refusal of the crown, throwing up their sweaty nightcaps, and then forgiving Caesar "with all their hearts" when he faints, behaving, in Casca's words, like an audience at a play. Their reactions are instant and emotional, driven by spectacle rather than judgement. Yet senseless is the wrong word. The Cobbler shows quick intelligence, and the crowd's love of Pompey, which Marullus himself recalls, was real while it lasted. The truth Act 1 establishes is that the people feel strongly but remember briefly, which makes them dangerous rather than stupid. Marullus's speech proves their fickleness; it disproves the claim that they have no feeling at all.

Why this answer earns marks: The verdict is stated at once and then argued. The answer uses the immediate aftermath (connection to the lines after the extract), a second piece of evidence from Scene 2 (quotation and connection), and a counter-argument from the extract and the Cobbler. It distinguishes between fickle and senseless, which is the precise judgement the question invites, and it closes with a balanced conclusion in one sentence.

MODEL ANSWER Model answers — reference to the context and MCQs

(a) Pompey the Great was Caesar's former ally and later his rival, a hugely popular general who had celebrated three triumphs and whom the Roman people had adored. He was defeated by Caesar in the civil war and afterwards killed in Egypt; the triumph being celebrated in this scene is for Caesar's victory over Pompey's sons. Marullus raises his name to shame the crowd: the people who once climbed to chimney tops to see Pompey pass are now dressing in their best to cheer the man who destroyed him and his family.

(b) Marullus addresses the commoners of Rome. The line is an apostrophe, a direct address, built on metaphors that compare the people to blocks of wood and stones, objects without the power to feel. The tone is contemptuous and furious; the repeated you strikes like a series of blows, and the escalation to "worse than senseless things" shows a speaker who has abandoned argument for abuse.

Why these answers earn marks: Each identifies the speaker, the listener and the situation before interpreting. Answer (a) supplies the historical fact the question expects (who Pompey was and what happened to him) and then explains the speaker's purpose. Answer (b) names the devices correctly and describes tone with precise adjectives rather than vague ones.

MCQ key: 1 (b); 2 (b); 3 (c). The distractor in question 1 is the modern geographical meaning of tributary; in question 2, (a) is a real Caesarian victory but not the one the play's triumph celebrates.

Extract 3 — Flavius and the Feathers of Caesar's Wing

EXTRACT Extract 3 — Act 1 Scene 1, the closing lines of the scene

Flavius: *They vanish tongue-tied in their guiltiness.*

Go you down that way towards the Capitol.

This way will I. Disrobe the images

If you do find them decked with ceremonies.

Marullus: *May we do so?*

You know it is the feast of Lupercal.

Flavius: *It is no matter. Let no images*

Be hung with Caesar's trophies. I'll about

And drive away the vulgar from the streets;

So do you too, where you perceive them thick.

These growing feathers plucked from Caesar's wing

Will make him fly an ordinary pitch,

Who else would soar above the view of men

And keep us all in servile fearfulness.

Context: The end of Scene 1. The commoners have slunk away without a word after Marullus's tirade and Flavius's order to go and weep into the Tiber. For the first time the two tribunes are alone on stage, and the tone changes from public scolding to private planning.

Speaker: Flavius, with one anxious interruption from Marullus.

Listener: Each other. There is no crowd to persuade now, so what we hear is what the tribunes actually think and intend.

Before: Flavius has just watched the crowd leave and remarked "See whe'er their basest mettle be not moved", meaning: see whether even their low-grade spirit is not stirred by shame. That line is the hinge between the two halves of the scene.

After: The scene ends and the stage fills at once with Caesar's procession for the Lupercal, the very feast Marullus has just named. We never see the tribunes again. Near the end of Scene 2 Casca reports, almost in passing, that "Marullus and Flavius, for pulling scarves off Caesar's images, are put to silence." The plan we hear made here is carried out, and it destroys the men who make it.

Meaning: 'They have disappeared, struck dumb by guilt. You go down that way towards the Capitol, and I will go this way. Strip the statues if you find them decorated with festive ornaments.' Marullus asks whether they are permitted to do this, since it is the sacred feast of Lupercal. Flavius replies: 'That does not matter. No statue is to be hung with tokens of Caesar's victories. I will go about and clear the common people out of the streets; you do the same wherever you find them gathered thickly. Caesar's power is like a bird's feathers that are still growing; pluck them out now and he will fly at an ordinary height, whereas otherwise he would soar so high that men could no longer see him, and keep us all in the fear of slaves.' Difficult words: tongue-tied (unable to speak), images (statues), decked with ceremonies (decorated with ceremonial ornaments such as scarves or garlands), trophies (tokens or memorials of victory), the vulgar (the common people), pitch (in falconry, the height to which a hawk climbs before it stoops on its prey), servile (slave-like).

Subtext: Flavius's plan is symbolic politics. He believes that if you strip the decorations from Caesar's statues you diminish Caesar, as if power were made of scarves. Marullus's hesitation is partly religious, since interfering with a sacred festival is sacrilege, and partly fearful; Flavius's "It is no matter" tells us how far his hostility outruns his caution. The falconry image betrays something the tribunes may not fully realise about themselves: they do not accuse Caesar of any crime. Their fear is that he will rise beyond the sight of ordinary men, beyond scrutiny, beyond control. That is a republican fear of altitude, not a moral judgement of the man. It is also an admission that Caesar is by nature a bird of prey who "would soar"; only artificial clipping can keep him low.

Character: Flavius is decisive, bold and unafraid of religious scruple; he is also politically naive, mistaking ornaments for power and making an enemy of the crowd he needs. Marullus, so fiery a moment ago, is here the cautious one, which shows that even the republic's defenders are divided about how far they dare go. Together they are the play's first portrait of opposition to Caesar: sincere, courageous, and doomed.

Theme: Liberty and tyranny, stated for the first time in the play's own vocabulary, servile fearfulness against the freedom of Romans. The theme of checking power early, before it is too high to reach, which Cassius will turn into a whole philosophy. Appearance versus reality, in the tribunes' faith that removing the appearance of kingship will remove the thing. Religion against politics, in Marullus's scruple. And fear, the emotion that Caesar's rise produces in almost everyone who watches it.

Device: The governing device is an extended metaphor drawn from falconry: feathers, wing, fly, pitch and soar all belong to the hawk. Caesar is the bird, his honours are his growing plumage, and the tribunes are the falconers who mean to clip him. The image is vertical: the whole danger is expressed as height, and the whole remedy as bringing him down to the level of other men. There is a pun in the earlier line on mettle and metal, spirit and base material. The scene closes on a sententious, summarising statement rather than a rhyme, a common Shakespearean way of ending a scene, and it carries dramatic irony, because the audience knows that Caesar will indeed be brought down, though not by tribunes and not by plucking feathers.

Historical context: HISTORICAL RECORD: The Lupercalia, held on 15 February, was an ancient festival of purification and fertility in which priests called Luperci ran through the city striking bystanders, especially women, with strips of goat-hide; a new college of Luperci had recently been created in Caesar's honour. The historical tribunes Marullus and Caesetius Flavius removed a diadem from Caesar's statue on the Rostra and arrested men who hailed him as king; Caesar had them deposed from office. Plutarch adds that the people hailed the tribunes as Brutuses, after the founder of the republic. Historically this happened in January 44 BC, before the Lupercalia; Shakespeare fuses the two events. **LITERARY INTERPRETATION:** Falconry was an aristocratic sport in Shakespeare's England, and pitch is an English technical term; the image is Elizabethan, and the audience would have felt its precision.

Scene connection: Marullus's mention of Lupercal is the bridge into Scene 2, which opens with Caesar arranging the "holy chase". The images decked with ceremonies become the scarves Casca reports, and the report of the tribunes being silenced is the first hard evidence in the play that Caesar punishes opposition, evidence that Brutus and Cassius hear together. Flavius's picture of a Caesar who soars above the view of men is answered within a scene by Cassius's Colossus who bestrides the world while petty men peep about beneath him; the tribune's feathers and the conspirator's giant are two images of the same fear. And "servile fearfulness" is the first sounding of the note Cassius will strike in Scene 3 when he swears that "Cassius from bondage will deliver Cassius."

Keywords: extended metaphor; falconry imagery; iconoclasm; symbolic politics; sacrilege; scruple; servile; republican; dramatic irony; foreshadowing; sententious close; trophies; images; the vulgar.

QUESTIONS Extract 3 — ICSE-style questions

- (i) Where are Flavius and Marullus at this point, and what have the commoners just done? What does Flavius mean when he says they "vanish tongue-tied in their guiltiness"? [3]
- (ii) What instructions does Flavius give? Why does Marullus hesitate, and how does Flavius deal with his hesitation? [3]
- (iii) Explain the metaphor in "These growing feathers plucked from Caesar's wing / Will make him fly an ordinary pitch". What do the feathers stand for, and what does the word pitch add? [3]
- (iv) What do these lines reveal about the tribunes' understanding of politics and of Caesar? Do you consider their plan wise? Give reasons. [3]
- (v) The tribunes disappear from the play after this scene. With close reference to what Casca later reports about them, discuss what Shakespeare achieves by opening his play with two characters whom he then removes. [4]

Reference to the context (Class IX style)

- (a) "You know it is the feast of Lupercal." Who says this, to whom, and why? What does the remark reveal about the speaker?
- (b) "And keep us all in servile fearfulness." Who is us? Explain the phrase servile fearfulness and say what fear it expresses.

Multiple-choice questions

- The word pitch in "fly an ordinary pitch" is a term borrowed from: (a) music (b) cricket (c) falconry (d) sailing
- "Disrobe the images" means: (a) undress the statues (b) strip decorations from the statues (c) break the statues (d) carry the statues away
- According to Casca later in Act 1, the tribunes were: (a) rewarded by Caesar with new honours (b) executed in the marketplace (c) put to silence for pulling scarves off Caesar's images (d) sent into exile in Spain

MODEL ANSWER Model answer (i)

The tribunes are still in the street where they confronted the working men; the commoners have just left, and the two officials are alone. The men have gone without a word of reply after Marullus's angry reminder of their old love for Pompey and Flavius's command to go home and weep for their fault. When Flavius says they vanish tongue-tied in their guiltiness, he means that shame has silenced them: they cannot defend what they were doing, so they have slipped away speechless, and their silence is itself a confession of guilt.

Why this answer earns marks: Place and situation are given (context), the commoners' action is described accurately (recall), and the phrase is paraphrased in plain English with its implication drawn out (understanding). The answer notes that silence functions as confession, which is the small interpretative step that secures the third mark.

MODEL ANSWER Model answer (ii)

Flavius tells Marullus to go one way towards the Capitol while he goes the other, and to strip Caesar's statues of any festive decorations he finds on them. He adds that no statue is to be hung with tokens of Caesar's victories, and that they should both drive the common people out of the streets wherever they gather. Marullus hesitates because it is the feast of Lupercal, a sacred festival, and interfering with its decorations might be an act of sacrilege as well as a political risk. Flavius brushes the objection aside with "It is no matter", showing that his fear of Caesar outweighs his respect for religious custom.

Why this answer earns marks: All three parts of the question are answered in order: the instructions (with the additional detail about clearing the streets, which shows full reading), the reason for hesitation (with the term sacrilege), and Flavius's response, quoted exactly. The final clause interprets the response rather than merely reporting it.

MODEL ANSWER Model answer (iii)

Flavius compares Caesar to a hawk whose feathers are still growing. The feathers stand for the honours, decorations and popular acclaim that are steadily being added to Caesar, the trophies on his statues and the cheers in the streets. If these are plucked out now, while they are new, Caesar will only be able to fly at an ordinary height; if they are left to grow, he will soar so high that ordinary men lose sight of him and live in slavish fear beneath him. The word pitch is a falconry term for the height to which a hawk climbs before it dives on its prey. It adds a note of danger: a bird at its pitch is about to strike, so the image suggests not only that Caesar is rising but that his height will be used against those below.

Why this answer earns marks: The metaphor is unpacked in both halves, image and meaning (terminology and explanation). The feathers are identified concretely, with a link to the statues in the scene (connection). The final part answers the question about pitch precisely and adds the interpretative point about the hawk's strike, which is the kind of detail that distinguishes a literary reading from a dictionary gloss.

MODEL ANSWER Model answer (iv)

The lines reveal tribunes who understand the danger of Caesar but not its nature. They see that his power is growing and that it must be checked early, before he is beyond reach, which is shrewd. But they believe his power lives in its symbols, in scarves and trophies on statues, and that removing the ornaments will bring the man down. They also treat the people, whose support is the real source of Caesar's height, as vulgar to be driven off the streets, rather than as citizens to be won over. The plan is brave but unwise. It offends religion, alienates the crowd, and provokes Caesar without weakening him; the result, as Casca later reports, is that the tribunes are silenced and Caesar's statues are decorated anyway.

Why this answer earns marks: The answer separates what the tribunes get right from what they get wrong, which gives it analytical structure. It uses the extract's own words (vulgar, trophies) as evidence, states a clear opinion as the question requires, and supports the judgement with the outcome reported later in the Act (connection). Three developed points fill three marks.

MODEL ANSWER Model answer (v)

Shakespeare uses the tribunes as a warning and a measuring rod. In the opening scene they are the only characters who openly oppose Caesar, and they oppose him in the name of the republic, reminding the people of Pompey and stripping the images that make Caesar look like a king. Then they vanish. When Casca mentions, almost as gossip, that "Marullus and Flavius, for pulling scarves off Caesar's images, are put to silence", the audience learns that legitimate, public, constitutional opposition has been crushed off-stage, without drama, by a Caesar we have only just watched refuse a crown. Several effects follow. The republic's ordinary defences are shown to be useless before the play's main action begins. Brutus and Cassius hear the news together, so the fate of the tribunes becomes part of the pressure on Brutus and part of Cassius's case. And the casual tone of the report, which Casca passes over quickly, is more chilling than a scene of punishment would be; it suggests that silencing opponents has become routine. By opening with men who are then removed, Shakespeare makes the audience feel the tightening of Caesar's grip before any conspirator has drawn a sword, and turns the tribunes' falconry image into dramatic irony: they set out to clip Caesar's wings and are themselves brought down.

Why this answer earns marks: A 4-mark discussion question rewards a clear line of argument supported by the text and developed through several distinct points. This answer quotes Casca exactly, identifies three separate effects (structural, dramatic, tonal), connects the tribunes' fate to the Brutus plot, and closes by tying the discussion back to the extract's own image, which demonstrates that the student is thinking about the whole design of the Act, not retelling it.

MODEL ANSWER Model answers — reference to the context and MCQs

(a) Marullus says this to Flavius, who has just told him to strip the decorations from Caesar's statues. He is asking whether they are allowed to interfere with ornaments put up for a sacred festival. The remark shows that Marullus, for all his fury at the crowd, has a religious scruple and a sense of the risk they are taking; it also shows that the two tribunes are not equally bold, which makes their opposition to Caesar look fragile.

(b) Us means Flavius and Marullus, and beyond them the free citizens of Rome. Servile fearfulness is the fear felt by slaves before a master, a dread that makes men obedient. Flavius fears that if Caesar's honours keep growing he will rise so far above other men that Romans will no longer be his fellow citizens but his subjects, living in fear of him. It is the republican terror of one man's supremacy, expressed for the first time in the play.

Why these answers earn marks: Each locates the line, explains the phrase in plain words, and adds a sentence of interpretation about character or theme. Answer (b) is careful to define us, which the question explicitly asks, before moving to meaning.

MCQ key: 1 (c); 2 (b); 3 (c). Watch the wording of question 3: options (b) and (d) invent punishments the text never mentions; the play says only that the tribunes are put to silence, and a careful reader should not add to it.

Extract 4 — Caesar, Antony and the Soothsayer

TEXT NOTE About the length of this extract

This passage is a little longer than a board extract usually is, because the three moments named in it, the fertility instruction, the warning and the dismissal, form one dramatic unit and are best trained together. In an examination you would be given ten to fourteen lines from within it; the labels and questions below would apply to any such window.

EXTRACT Extract 4 — Act 1 Scene 2, the opening of the scene

Caesar: *Forget not, in your speed, Antonius,
To touch Calpurnia, for our elders say
The barren, touchèd in this holy chase,
Shake off their sterile curse.*

Antony: *I shall remember.
When Caesar says 'Do this,' it is performed.*

Caesar: *Set on, and leave no ceremony out.*

Soothsayer: *Caesar.*

Caesar: *Ha! Who calls?*

Casca: *Bid every noise be still. Peace, yet again!*

Caesar: *Who is it in the press that calls on me?
I hear a tongue shriller than all the music
Cry 'Caesar.' Speak. Caesar is turned to hear.*

Soothsayer: *Beware the ides of March.*

Caesar: *What man is that?*

Brutus: *A soothsayer bids you beware the ides of March.*

Caesar: *Set him before me. Let me see his face.*

Cassius: *Fellow, come from the throng. Look upon Caesar.*

Caesar: *What sayst thou to me now? Speak once again.*

Soothsayer: *Beware the ides of March.*

Caesar: *He is a dreamer. Let us leave him. Pass.*

Context: The opening of Scene 2, moments after the tribunes have left. A flourish of trumpets and the stage fills: Caesar enters with his train, Antony stripped for the race, Calpurnia, Portia, Decius, Cicero, Brutus, Cassius, Casca and a crowd, among whom stands a Soothsayer. It is the feast of Lupercal, and Antony is about to run the ritual course. This is our first sight of Caesar, and Shakespeare shows him doing two things in quick succession: giving a domestic order in public, and receiving a warning in public.

Speaker: Caesar dominates; Antony, Casca, Brutus and Cassius each speak a line; the Soothsayer speaks four words, twice.

Listener: Antony and Calpurnia are addressed, but the true audience is the whole crowd. Everything Caesar says here is said to be overheard.

Before: Caesar has twice called "Calpurnia", and Casca has silenced the crowd with "Peace, ho! Caesar speaks." Caesar has told his wife to "Stand you directly in Antonius' way / When he doth run his course."

After: A sennet sounds and the whole procession leaves for the games. Only Brutus and Cassius remain, and Cassius opens the conversation of Extract 5 by asking "Will you go see the order of the course?" While they talk, off-stage, Antony offers Caesar the crown three times; we learn of it only from Casca's report later in the scene.

Meaning: Caesar tells Antony not to forget, as he runs, to touch Calpurnia, because the old belief is that childless women touched during this sacred race are freed from the curse of barrenness. Antony answers that he will remember, and adds that whatever Caesar commands is done. Caesar orders the procession forward with instructions to omit no part of the ritual. A voice calls his name; he asks who it is, Casca calls for silence, and Caesar says he hears one voice, sharper than all the festival music, crying his name, and that he has turned to listen. The Soothsayer tells him to beware the fifteenth of March. Caesar asks who the man is; Brutus repeats the warning; Caesar demands to see the man's face; Cassius brings him forward. Caesar asks him to speak again, hears the same four words, and dismisses him as a dreamer before ordering the procession on. Difficult words: speed (haste; here, the running itself), elders (people of former times), barren (childless), holy chase (sacred race), sterile curse (the curse of childlessness), set on (go forward), press (crowd), shriller (more piercing), soothsayer (a foreteller of the future, literally a truth-sayer), ides (the fifteenth day of March), dreamer (a man who sees visions; a fantasist).

Subtext: Caesar's first public act announces before all Rome that his wife is barren. **LITERARY**

INTERPRETATION: many readers take this as a hint of dynastic thinking, a ruler who wants an heir; the text does not say so, and leaves the motive open. What is certain is that Caesar treats a private matter as a public ceremony, and that Antony's reply is the language of a servant, not of a fellow consul. It tells us how power now works in Rome: Caesar speaks, and things happen. The Soothsayer episode is then a study in performance. Caesar hears one thin voice through the music, which suggests a man alert to threat; he demands to see the face, which suggests curiosity, even unease; he asks to hear the warning again, which suggests he has taken it in. Then, having listened in full view of the crowd, he dismisses it. He cannot be seen to fear, so he performs not fearing. The dismissal is as much for the onlookers as for himself.

Character: Caesar is commanding, ceremonious and image-conscious; he refers to himself by name, as if Caesar were a public office he occupies. He is superstitious enough to insist on every detail of a fertility rite, yet dismisses a warning about his own life, a contradiction the play will return to. Antony is devoted, athletic and obedient, the loyal lieutenant. The Soothsayer is calm, nameless and unmoved: he does not argue, he repeats. Casca plays the officious herald, silencing the crowd for the man he will be the first to stab. Brutus is the one who relays the warning to Caesar, and Cassius the one who brings the Soothsayer face to face with him: the two future conspirators literally deliver the prophecy.

Theme: Fate and free will, in the first prophecy of the play and the first refusal to heed it. Superstition and omens, and the inconsistency with which Caesar treats them. Appearance versus reality, in the gap between the public Caesar who fears nothing and the private man who turns to listen. Power and obedience, in Antony's reply. Leadership, in the question of whether a great man can afford to be seen taking advice from a stranger in a crowd.

Device: The dominant device is dramatic irony: the audience knows what the ides of March will bring, so Caesar's confident dismissal is heard against knowledge he lacks. The warning itself is foreshadowing, made heavier by repetition, since the Soothsayer says the identical words twice and Brutus repeats them a third time.

Caesar's third-person self-reference, "Caesar is turned to hear", is sometimes called *illeism*; it separates the man from his public role. There is contrast between the loud festival music and the single shrill voice that cuts through it, an aural image of truth interrupting celebration. The dismissal ends in anticlimax: one word, "Pass", closes an episode that the audience knows to be the most important warning in the play.

Historical context: HISTORICAL RECORD: The Lupercalia was held on 15 February. The Luperci ran through the city striking bystanders, especially women, with strips of goat-hide, which was believed to promote fertility; Antony, consul in 44 BC, ran as one of them. Calpurnia had married Caesar in 59 BC and the marriage was childless; Caesar's only legitimate child, Julia, had died in 54 BC. Plutarch and Suetonius both record that a seer named Spurinna warned Caesar of a danger that would come no later than the *ides* of March. The *ides* were one of the three fixed marker days of the Roman month, falling on the fifteenth of March, May, July and October and on the thirteenth of the other months; they were sacred to Jupiter. Caesar was killed on 15 March 44 BC. **LITERARY INTERPRETATION:** Shakespeare makes the seer anonymous, moves the warning into a public crowd, and fuses it with the Lupercalia, so that celebration and doom occupy the same minute of stage time.

Scene connection: Antony's promise of instant obedience prepares for Caesar's later request in this scene that Antony tell him truly what he thinks of Cassius, and for Antony's loyalty after Caesar's death in Act 3. Caesar's dismissal of the Soothsayer is the first in a series: in Act 2 he will brush aside Calpurnia's dream and the priests' warnings, and on the *ides* he will meet the Soothsayer again. The barren Calpurnia of this extract is the frightened Calpurnia of Act 2. Casca's cry for silence is the first thing this man does for Caesar; the last is to strike him. And the warning about the *ides* is the thread that the Class X paper picks up in Act 5, when the conspirators speak of the work begun on the *ides* of March.

Keywords: dramatic irony; foreshadowing; omen; prophecy; soothsayer; *ides*; Lupercal; fertility rite; *illeism*; public persona; superstition; dismissal; anticlimax; fate versus free will.

QUESTIONS Extract 4 — ICSE-style questions

- (i) What festival is being celebrated in this scene? What does Caesar ask Antony to do, and what belief lies behind the request? [3]
- (ii) Explain Antony's reply, "When Caesar says 'Do this,' it is performed." What does it tell us about Antony, and about Caesar's position in Rome? [3]
- (iii) Trace, step by step, how Caesar reacts to the Soothsayer's warning. What is the effect of his final words, "He is a dreamer. Let us leave him. Pass."? [3]
- (iv) Caesar says "Caesar is turned to hear", speaking of himself by name. What does this habit reveal about him? Support your answer with one other example of Caesar's self-presentation from Act 1. [3]
- (v) The Soothsayer's warning is spoken twice and dismissed in a few seconds. What dramatic purposes does this brief exchange serve for the play as a whole? In your view, is Caesar's dismissal more a sign of strength or of weakness? Give reasons. [4]

Reference to the context (Class IX style)

- (a) "Beware the ides of March." Who speaks, to whom, and where? What are the ides of March, and why is the warning important?
- (b) "Forget not, in your speed, Antonius, / To touch Calpurnia". Explain the custom Caesar refers to. What does the request reveal about Caesar?

Multiple-choice questions

- The ides of March fall on: (a) 1 March (b) 13 March (c) 15 March (d) 31 March
- In this scene Antony is about to: (a) deliver a speech to the Senate (b) run in the Lupercal race (c) fight in the games (d) offer a sacrifice to Jupiter
- The person who repeats the Soothsayer's words to Caesar is: (a) Antony (b) Casca (c) Brutus (d) Cassius

MODEL ANSWER Model answer (i)

The festival is the feast of Lupercal, an ancient Roman celebration in which young men ran a ritual race through the streets. Caesar asks Antony, who is one of the runners, not to forget to touch Calpurnia, his wife, as he passes her. The belief behind the request is the traditional one Caesar himself quotes: that childless women who are touched by the runners during this holy race are freed from the curse of barrenness. Caesar has already told Calpurnia to stand directly in Antony's path so that the touch will not be missed.

Why this answer earns marks: The festival is named with a brief accurate description (recall and context), the request is stated, and the belief is explained in the student's own words with the supporting detail from just before the extract (connection). Three clean points for three marks, with no drifting into interpretation that the question did not ask for.

MODEL ANSWER Model answer (ii)

Antony means that whatever Caesar commands is carried out at once; a wish of Caesar's is as good as an accomplished fact. The reply shows Antony as utterly loyal and obedient, a lieutenant who takes pride in serving, and who is happy to say so in front of a crowd. It also reveals the reality of power in Rome. Antony is himself a consul, in law Caesar's equal, yet he speaks like a servant to a master. His words announce, before Caesar has done anything on stage, that one man's will has become the law of the city, which is exactly what the tribunes feared in the previous scene and what Cassius will complain of in a moment.

Why this answer earns marks: The line is paraphrased, then the two parts of the question are answered separately and explicitly: what it shows about Antony and what it shows about Caesar. The point about consuls being equals supplies the historical understanding that makes the second point sharp, and the closing sentence connects the reply to Scene 1 and to the coming conversation, showing awareness of the scene's design.

MODEL ANSWER Model answer (iii)

Caesar first hears a single voice through the festival music and asks who is calling; the fact that he picks out one shrill tongue shows how alert he is. When Brutus repeats the warning, Caesar orders the man to be brought before him so that he can see his face, which suggests curiosity, and perhaps a flicker of unease. He then asks the Soothsayer to say the words again, so he hears the warning twice in full. Only then does he dismiss it: the man is a dreamer, they will leave him, the procession must pass. The final words are brisk and contemptuous, and their effect is double. To the crowd they display a Caesar above fear; to the audience, who know what the ides will bring, they are heavy with dramatic irony, and the single word Pass, closing so grave a warning, sounds like a man waving away his own death.

Why this answer earns marks: The question says step by step, and the answer follows the sequence exactly, interpreting each step briefly. The comment on the final words names the device (dramatic irony), distinguishes the effect on the crowd from the effect on the audience, and ends with a precise observation about a single word, which is the kind of close reading that earns the full mark.

MODEL ANSWER Model answer (iv)

By speaking of himself as Caesar rather than I, Caesar treats his own name as a title and himself as a public institution. It suggests a man who watches himself from the outside, conscious of how he appears, and who has begun to think of Caesar as something larger than the individual who bears the name. The habit is both grandeur and self-protection: the institution Caesar cannot be frightened by a stranger in a crowd, even if the man might be. The same self-presentation appears later in the scene when, having told Antony that thin men like Cassius are dangerous, he insists "I rather tell thee what is to be feared / Than what I fear; for always I am Caesar." There too he claims that the name itself rules out fear, moments before admitting that one of his ears is deaf.

Why this answer earns marks: The habit is explained in terms of character (public role, self-consciousness) rather than merely noticed, and the analysis is balanced, seeing both grandeur and defence. The second example is quoted accurately from Act 1 as the question requires (quotation and connection), and the closing remark about the deaf ear shows that the student can see the gap between the name and the man.

MODEL ANSWER Model answer (v)

The exchange does far more than its few seconds suggest. First, it plants the play's central prophecy: from now on the audience measures every scene against the ides of March, and the phrase returns in Act 2, on the day of the murder in Act 3 and in the conspirators' words as late as Act 5. Second, it establishes Caesar's relationship with fate, a man who is warned and chooses not to hear, which is repeated with Calpurnia's dream and the priests in Act 2. Third, it arranges the future conspirators around the warning: Brutus repeats it, Cassius escorts the Soothsayer, Casca silences the crowd, so that the men who will fulfil the prophecy are shown delivering it. Fourth, it gives the first sample of Caesar's public manner, the third-person grandeur and the refusal to show fear. As for the dismissal itself, it is strength in one sense: a ruler who trembled at every stranger's cry would not be Caesar, and his composure before the crowd is real courage. But it is weakness in a deeper sense. He listens carefully, asks to hear the warning twice, and still rejects it, not because he has weighed it but because Caesar must be seen to be above it. The public image decides what the man may believe. That is the flaw the play will punish: not superstition, and not scepticism, but the inability to let the private man act on what the public man has heard.

Why this answer earns marks: The first half answers what dramatic purposes with four distinct, textually grounded points and connections forward through the play. The second half gives a genuine evaluation, granting the case for strength before arguing for weakness, and ends with a precise formulation of Caesar's flaw. Structure, evidence, terminology and judgement are all visible, which is what a 4-mark evaluative question rewards.

MODEL ANSWER Model answers — reference to the context and MCQs

(a) A Soothsayer, a nameless fortune-teller in the crowd, speaks these words to Caesar in a public place in Rome during the feast of Lupercal, and repeats them when Caesar has him brought forward. The ides of March are the fifteenth of March in the Roman calendar. The warning is important because it is the play's first prophecy: Caesar will be murdered on that day, so his dismissal of the Soothsayer as a dreamer is the first of several refusals to hear the truth.

(b) Caesar refers to the belief that a childless woman touched by one of the runners during the sacred Lupercal race would be cured of barrenness; he wants Antony, who is running, to touch Calpurnia. The request reveals a Caesar who observes ritual scrupulously, who is willing to speak of his wife's childlessness before the whole city, and who expects his personal wishes to be carried out as part of a public ceremony. Many readers also hear in it a ruler's wish for an heir, though the text does not say so.

Why these answers earn marks: Both fix speaker, listener and place before explaining, both gloss the difficult term (ides; the fertility custom), and both end with an interpretative sentence that is careful to separate what the text states from what readers infer.

MCQ key: 1 (c); 2 (b); 3 (c). Question 1 tests a fact students often misremember: the ides fall on the fifteenth in March, not the thirteenth, which is the date in most other months.

Extract 5 — The Mirror and the Oath of Honour

TEXT NOTE About the shape of this extract

The mirror conversation and Brutus's oath of honour are separated by about thirty lines of Cassius's talk, so this extract is printed as two windows with the gap marked. An examination would give you one continuous window of ten to fourteen lines from either half; the labels and the questions below are written so that they serve whichever window you are given. Note also a small edition variant in the gap: where Cassius denies being "a common laughter", some editions print 'laugher'; the sense in both is a man who is a general joke, not to be taken seriously.

EXTRACT

Extract 5 — Act 1 Scene 2, Brutus and Cassius alone after the procession has left

Cassius: *Tell me, good Brutus, can you see your face?*

Brutus: *No, Cassius, for the eye sees not itself
But by reflection, by some other things.*

Cassius: *'Tis just.
And it is very much lamented, Brutus,
That you have no such mirrors as will turn
Your hidden worthiness into your eye,
That you might see your shadow.*

(A little later, as a flourish of trumpets and a shout are heard from the games off-stage.)

Brutus: *What means this shouting? I do fear the people
Choose Caesar for their king.*

Cassius: *Ay, do you fear it?
Then must I think you would not have it so.*

Brutus: *I would not, Cassius, yet I love him well.
But wherefore do you hold me here so long?
What is it that you would impart to me?
If it be aught toward the general good,
Set honour in one eye and death i' th' other
And I will look on both indifferently;
For let the gods so speed me as I love
The name of honour more than I fear death.*

Context: Scene 2, in the same public place, immediately after Caesar's procession has swept off to the Lupercal games and Caesar has dismissed the Soothsayer. For the first time in the play two men are alone and speaking privately, and the two men are Brutus and Cassius. Everything that follows in the tragedy begins in this conversation. Shakespeare gives it to us in real time while, off-stage and unseen, Antony is offering Caesar a crown; the shouts that interrupt the talk are the sound of that offer.

Speaker: Cassius leads in the first window; Brutus speaks the longest and most revealing lines in the second. The balance matters. Cassius asks questions and supplies images; Brutus, believing himself guarded, supplies the two confessions Cassius needs.

Listener: Each other, with no one else on stage. This is the play's first fully private exchange, so the audience hears both men without their public manners. Brutus, however, is still partly performing, for himself as much as for Cassius; his language stays formal and careful even here.

Before: Cassius asked Brutus whether he would go and watch "the order of the course"; Brutus refused, saying "I am not gamesome; I do lack some part / Of that quick spirit that is in Antony." Cassius then complained that Brutus has lately withheld "that gentleness / And show of love as I was wont to have." Brutus replied that the trouble is in himself, that he is "Vexèd" by "passions of some difference", private thoughts that may have spoilt his manners, and asked Cassius to read nothing more into his coldness than that "poor Brutus, with himself at war, / Forgets the shows of love to other men." Cassius seized on that: he says he has "much mistook" Brutus's mood and has therefore kept buried "Thoughts of great value, worthy cogitations". The mirror question is how he begins to dig them up. Between the two windows, Brutus asks warily "Into what dangers would you lead me, Cassius", and Cassius promises that he, as Brutus's "glass", will "modestly discover to yourself / That of yourself which you yet know not of", and insists that he is no flatterer who fawns on men and then slanders them.

After: Cassius answers the oath at once: "I know that virtue to be in you, Brutus, / As well as I do know your outward favour. / Well, honour is the subject of my story." He has taken Brutus's own word and made it his title. He then declares "I was born free as Caesar; so were you", and tells the two stories that fill the next thirty lines: the swimming match in the Tiber, when Caesar cried "Help me, Cassius, or I sink!" and Cassius carried him out as Aeneas carried Anchises from Troy; and the fever in Spain, when "this god did shake" and begged for drink "As a sick girl." A second shout brings Extract 6, the Colossus speech.

Meaning: Cassius asks Brutus whether he can see his own face. Brutus answers, correctly and a little pedantically, that he cannot: the eye does not see itself except by reflection, in a mirror or in other surfaces. Cassius agrees, and regrets that Brutus has no mirror of the right kind, one that would show him his own hidden worth, so that he could see his reflection as others see it. In the second window Brutus hears the shout and says he fears the people are choosing Caesar as king. Cassius pounces: 'You fear it? Then I must take it that you do not want it.' Brutus admits he does not want it, though he loves Caesar well, and asks Cassius to come to the point. Then he states his terms: if what Cassius has to say concerns the public good, he will look at honour with one eye and death with the other and regard both without preference, because, as surely as he hopes the gods will favour him, he loves the name of honour more than he fears dying. Difficult words: lamented (regretted, mourned), worthiness (merit, value), shadow (here, a reflected image), impart (tell, communicate), aught (anything), the general good (the welfare of the whole community), indifferently (impartially, without favouring either), speed (prosper, favour), the name of honour (the reputation and idea of honour).

Subtext: Cassius's mirror is a trap disguised as a compliment. A mirror shows you what is there; Cassius proposes to show Brutus what Cassius wants him to see, and to call it Brutus's hidden self. The image is well chosen for its victim. A vain man would be flattered to be told he is admired; Brutus is not vain, so Cassius flatters his modesty instead, telling him he undervalues himself. The word shadow is quietly double-edged: it means reflection, but it also means something less than the real thing, and the play will ask whether the Brutus that Cassius reflects is the real man or his shadow. Then the shout does Cassius's work for him. Notice that Cassius never says the word king; Brutus does. The sound from the games makes Brutus confess a fear he had kept to himself, and Cassius turns the confession into an admission of political will with one deft question. Brutus's "yet I love him well" is the whole tragedy in five words, a man already divided before anyone has

asked him to act. His oath is meant as a defence, a way of saying 'I will hear you only on honourable terms', but it hands Cassius the key, because now Cassius knows exactly which word opens Brutus. **LITERARY INTERPRETATION:** many readers have noticed that Brutus loves "The name of honour", not simply honour, and have read in it a man more attached to the idea of himself as honourable than to the hard reality of right action. The text supports this reading without compelling it; a generous reader hears only the idiom of the time.

Character: Brutus is reserved, courteous and philosophical; he answers a loaded question with a piece of Stoic-sounding wisdom about the eye and reflection, and he refuses to be led anywhere without conditions. He is also already troubled, already fearing kingship, already loving the man he fears. His honour is sincere and his self-knowledge is incomplete, which is exactly the combination a manipulator needs. Cassius is patient, observant and endlessly adaptive. He has clearly been waiting for an opening; he tests with the mirror, retreats when Brutus asks about dangers, denies being a flatterer in a speech that is itself flattery, and then lets the shout speak. He is also, in his own way, sincere: his hatred of Caesar's elevation is real, and his claim to be Brutus's true glass is not wholly false, since he does see in Brutus a republican who has not yet admitted what he is.

Theme: Honour, named here for the first time as Brutus's governing value and immediately adopted by Cassius as a weapon. Appearance versus reality, in the mirror, the shadow and the veiled look of a man at war with himself. Self-knowledge and its limits, in Brutus's correct statement that no one sees himself unaided and his failure to ask who is holding the glass. Friendship and manipulation, which the extract refuses to separate. Republicanism and the fear of kingship, voiced by Brutus, not Cassius. The private man and the public role, since Brutus's love for Caesar is personal and his fear of Caesar is civic.

Device: The governing device is the extended metaphor of the mirror: face, eye, reflection, mirrors, shadow and later glass all belong to it, and Cassius's offer to be the glass turns metaphor into a plan of action. Brutus's reply is an aphorism, a general truth compactly stated, which Shakespeare often gives him to mark his reflective habit of mind. The off-stage flourish and shout are a dramatic device of sound: an unseen event punctuates the dialogue, and each interruption advances Cassius's argument more than any speech could. Brutus's oath is built on antithesis, honour against death, one eye against the other, and on the balance of "look on both indifferently". There is dramatic irony throughout, since the audience watches the trap being laid and watches Brutus walk towards it. Cassius's "Ay, do you fear it?" is an echo question, repeating the victim's own word back to him, a classic technique of persuasion.

Historical context: HISTORICAL RECORD: Marcus Brutus was pardoned by Caesar after siding with Pompey at Pharsalus, was made governor of Cisalpine Gaul and then urban praetor for 44 BC, the more prestigious of the two praetorships, and had close family ties to the Stoic-leaning Cato, whose daughter Porcia he married. Cassius, who had married Brutus's sister, received the lesser praetorship, and ancient sources count this among his grievances against Caesar. Plutarch records that anonymous messages urging Brutus to act appeared on his praetor's chair and his ancestor's statue; Shakespeare will turn these into the forged letters Cassius plans at the end of the scene. **LITERARY INTERPRETATION:** The mirror was a favourite Renaissance figure for self-knowledge and for moral instruction; a mirror in a book title promised a warning picture in which readers would see themselves. Shakespeare's audience would have caught the double sense at once: Cassius offers a glass, and a glass can be an honest reflection or a flattering portrait.

Scene connection: The oath is the hinge on which the whole scene turns, because Cassius's reply, "honour is the subject of my story", shows him reshaping his argument around Brutus's word. At the scene's end, alone, Cassius states the method in cold blood: Brutus's "honourable mettle may be wrought / From that it is disposed", and the letters he will throw in at Brutus's window will be paper mirrors, "all tending to the great opinion / That Rome holds of his name". Brutus's fear that the people "Choose Caesar for their king" is

confirmed within minutes by Casca's report of the crown. The divided love of "yet I love him well" is the seed of Brutus's orchard soliloquy in Act 2, of his claim in the Forum in Act 3 that he loved Rome more than Caesar, and of the ghost that visits him in Act 4; and the honour that Cassius praises here is the honour Brutus will throw back at him in their quarrel in Act 4, when the subject of Cassius's story has become the standard by which Brutus judges him.

Keywords: extended metaphor; mirror and glass; reflection; shadow; aphorism; antithesis; echo question; off-stage sound; dramatic irony; flattery disguised as candour; honour; the general good; divided loyalty; manipulation; self-knowledge; Stoic.

QUESTIONS Extract 5 — ICSE-style questions

- (i) Where are Brutus and Cassius, and why are they alone? What has Brutus just told Cassius about his recent coldness towards him? [3]
- (ii) Explain Brutus's reply, "the eye sees not itself / But by reflection, by some other things." How does Cassius turn this answer to his own purpose in the lines that follow? [3]
- (iii) What is the shouting that interrupts the conversation? What does Brutus's reaction to it reveal, and how does Cassius make use of that reaction? [3]
- (iv) Explain the lines "Set honour in one eye and death i' th' other / And I will look on both indifferently". What do they show about Brutus's values, and why is it dangerous for him to say this to Cassius? [3]
- (v) Is Cassius, in this extract, a sincere friend or a manipulator? Weigh the evidence of the extract against what Cassius says when he is left alone at the end of the scene, and give your own judgement. [4]

Reference to the context (Class IX style)

- (a) "Tell me, good Brutus, can you see your face?" Who asks this, of whom, and in what situation? What is the speaker's purpose in asking it?
- (b) "I would not, Cassius, yet I love him well." Explain the conflict contained in this line. How does it prepare us for Brutus's later conduct?

Multiple-choice questions

1. In the extract, shadow means: (a) a ghost (b) a reflected image (c) darkness (d) a follower
2. The shouting heard by Brutus and Cassius comes from: (a) the Senate house (b) the crowd at the games, where Caesar is being offered a crown (c) soldiers returning from Spain (d) the tribunes and the commoners
3. In "I will look on both indifferently", indifferently means: (a) carelessly (b) impartially, without preferring either (c) unwillingly (d) coldly

MODEL ANSWER Model answer (i)

Brutus and Cassius are in a public place in Rome on the feast of Lupercal. Caesar and his whole train have just gone off to watch the ritual race, and Brutus has declined Cassius's invitation to go with them, saying he is not gamesome and lacks Antony's quick spirit; so the two men are left alone on stage. Brutus has just explained that if he has seemed cold it is not Cassius's fault: he is vexed by private troubles, thoughts proper only to himself, which have soiled his behaviour, and he is a man at war with himself who has forgotten to show his love to his friends.

Why this answer earns marks: Place and occasion are stated (context), the reason for the two men being alone is traced to a specific exchange (recall), and Brutus's explanation is given in close paraphrase, with the memorable phrase about a man at war with himself picked out. The answer stays within what has actually been said before the extract and does not leap ahead to the conspiracy.

MODEL ANSWER Model answer (ii)

Brutus means that a person cannot see his own face directly; the eye can see everything except itself, and knows itself only through a reflection in a mirror or some other surface. It is a modest, general truth about the limits of self-knowledge. Cassius turns it into an opening. He agrees, and then regrets that Brutus has no mirror that could show him his hidden worthiness, the high opinion in which the best men in Rome hold him. A little later he offers to be that mirror himself: he, Brutus's glass, will reveal to Brutus what Brutus does not yet know about himself. In other words, Cassius uses Brutus's own admission that he cannot see himself to claim the right to tell Brutus who he is.

Why this answer earns marks: The line is paraphrased accurately and its tone noted (understanding). The second part follows Cassius's reasoning step by step and names the key move, the offer to be the glass, with a short quotation from just after the extract (connection). The final sentence states the manipulative logic in one line, which is analysis rather than retelling.

MODEL ANSWER Model answer (iii)

The shouting comes from the crowd at the Lupercal games, where, as Casca later reports, Antony is offering Caesar a crown and the people are cheering each time he refuses it. Brutus does not know this, and his first thought is the worst one: he fears that the people are choosing Caesar as their king. The reaction reveals that Brutus has been brooding on exactly this danger and that his private trouble is political. Cassius uses it instantly. He repeats Brutus's own word back to him, "Ay, do you fear it?", and draws the conclusion for him: if Brutus fears it, then Brutus does not want it. Brutus has been made to confess a political position without being asked for one, and Cassius has learnt that the word king is the one that moves him.

Why this answer earns marks: The source of the shout is identified with the later evidence from Casca (connection), Brutus's reaction is interpreted rather than described, and Cassius's technique is quoted and named. The closing sentence explains what Cassius gains, which answers the question's how exactly and shows awareness of persuasion as a skill.

MODEL ANSWER Model answer (iv)

Brutus says that if what Cassius wants to tell him concerns the public good, he will place honour before one eye and death before the other and look at both without preferring either; honour will not tempt him and death will not frighten him, because he loves the name of honour more than he fears dying. The lines show that honour is Brutus's supreme value and that he measures every proposal by whether it serves the general good rather than himself. They also show a man who thinks of politics in terms of moral absolutes, honour and death, rather than of practical consequences. It is dangerous to say this to Cassius because it tells him precisely how Brutus can be reached. Cassius replies at once that honour is the subject of his story, and from this moment every argument he makes, and every forged letter he plans, is dressed as an appeal to Brutus's honour. Brutus has given his most skilful friend the password to his conscience.

Why this answer earns marks: The paraphrase handles the image concretely (one eye, the other eye) and glosses indifferently correctly, which many students miss. The question has two further parts, values and danger, and each gets its own developed point, the second supported by Cassius's reply, quoted exactly. The last sentence is a crisp analytical formulation rather than a repetition.

MODEL ANSWER Model answer (v)

The extract shows Cassius as both, and the play does not let us choose cleanly. On the side of friendship, his first complaint is personal: he misses the gentleness and show of love he used to receive, and there is real hurt in it. His fear of Caesar's kingship is sincere, and when he says he will be Brutus's glass he does, in one sense, reflect something true, for Brutus confesses in this very extract that he fears a king and would not have one; Cassius has read him correctly. On the side of manipulation, almost every move in the extract is a technique. He asks a loaded question about the mirror, flatters Brutus's modesty rather than his vanity, denies being a flatterer in words that flatter, waits for the shout and then echoes Brutus's own word back to him. The decisive evidence comes when he is alone. In his soliloquy at the end of the scene he says plainly that Brutus's honourable mettle may be wrought from what it is disposed to, that noble minds should keep with their likes because anyone can be seduced, and that he will throw forged letters in at Brutus's window to work on him. A friend does not forge letters to his friend. My judgement is that Cassius is a sincere republican who treats his friend as an instrument, and that his sincerity makes him more dangerous, not less, because it lets him believe that the glass he holds up is honest.

Why this answer earns marks: A 4-mark evaluation needs both sides argued from evidence and a clear verdict. The answer gives three points for friendship and four techniques for manipulation, all grounded in the extract, then uses the soliloquy as the question requires, paraphrasing it accurately and drawing the conclusion. The final judgement is personal, stated firmly, and sharpened by the paradox that sincerity increases danger, which shows evaluation rather than a safe both-sides answer.

MODEL ANSWER Model answers — reference to the context and MCQs

(a) Cassius asks this of Brutus when the two are left alone after Caesar's procession has gone to the Lupercal games. Brutus has just excused his recent coldness by saying he is troubled by private thoughts. Cassius's purpose is to open a path into Brutus's mind. By getting Brutus to agree that no man can see himself except by reflection, he can offer to be the mirror that shows Brutus his own greatness, and so begin to persuade him that Rome needs him to act against Caesar.

(b) Brutus has just admitted that he fears the people are making Caesar king and that he would not wish it, yet in the same breath he says he loves Caesar well. The line holds his civic principle and his personal affection in open conflict: the republican in him dreads what Caesar may become, while the man loves his friend. It prepares us for a Brutus who will join the conspiracy only when he has convinced himself that the public good demands it, who will insist that the killing be a sacrifice and not a butchery, and who will claim that he struck Caesar out of love for Rome rather than hatred of the man.

Why these answers earn marks: Both answers give speaker, listener and situation first, then explain, then interpret, which is the required shape. Answer (a) explains purpose in terms of what the speaker does next (connection). Answer (b) names the two sides of the conflict precisely and looks forward with concrete, accurate references to later acts without inventing details.

MCQ key: 1 (b); 2 (b); 3 (b). In question 1, (a) is a tempting modern association but the context of mirrors fixes the meaning; in question 3, (a) is the everyday meaning of indifferently and is exactly wrong for Brutus, who means that he will weigh both with equal seriousness.

Extract 6 — The Colossus

TEXT NOTE About the length of this extract

The Colossus speech runs to nineteen lines and is printed here whole, because the giant, the stars and the two names form a single argument that is best learnt as one. An examination window would take ten to fourteen of these lines, most often beginning at "Why, man" and ending somewhere between "underlings" and "noble bloods". Everything below applies to any such window.

EXTRACT Extract 6 — Act 1 Scene 2, Cassius answers the second shout

Cassius: *Why, man, he doth bestride the narrow world
Like a Colossus, and we petty men
Walk under his huge legs and peep about
To find ourselves dishonourable graves.
Men at some time are masters of their fates.
The fault, dear Brutus, is not in our stars,
But in ourselves, that we are underlings.
'Brutus' and 'Caesar'—what should be in that 'Caesar'?
Why should that name be sounded more than yours?
Write them together, yours is as fair a name;
Sound them, it doth become the mouth as well;
Weigh them, it is as heavy; conjure with 'em,
'Brutus' will start a spirit as soon as 'Caesar.'
Now, in the names of all the gods at once,
Upon what meat doth this our Caesar feed
That he is grown so great? Age, thou art shamed!
Rome, thou hast lost the breed of noble bloods!*

Context: Still Scene 2, still the two men alone, a few minutes after Extract 5. Cassius has told his two stories against Caesar, the near-drowning in the Tiber and the fever in Spain, and has ended on his amazement that "A man of such a feeble temper should / So get the start of the majestic world / And bear the palm alone." A second shout and flourish come from the games. Brutus says "Another general shout! / I do believe that these applauses are / For some new honours that are heaped on Caesar." Cassius answers with this speech, the most famous passage in Act 1.

Speaker: Cassius, uninterrupted. Brutus says nothing for the whole speech and for the eleven lines that follow it, and his silence is part of the drama; we watch him listen.

Listener: Brutus alone. But the speech is shaped for two ears at once: for Brutus the Roman, who is told that Rome has shrunk to one man, and for Brutus the descendant, who is told that his name is as good as Caesar's.

Before: The Tiber and fever stories were personal: a Cassius who saved Caesar's life and watched him shake with fever, now forced to bow if Caesar "carelessly but nod on him". Brutus's remark about "new honours" turns the talk from the man to the city, and Cassius follows him there.

After: Cassius goes on without pause. He asks when any age "since the great flood" was famous for only one man, and plays on the city's name: "Now is it Rome indeed, and room enough / When there is in it but one only man." Then he reaches for the ancestor: "There was a Brutus once that would have brooked / Th' eternal devil to keep his state in Rome / As easily as a king." Only then does Brutus speak, and his reply is cautious and dignified: "That you do love me, I am nothing jealous. / What you would work me to, I have some aim." He asks not to be pressed further for the present, promises to consider what has been said, and leaves Cassius with a sentence to "chew upon": "Brutus had rather be a villager / Than to repute himself a son of Rome / Under these hard conditions as this time / Is like to lay upon us." Cassius is satisfied: "I am glad that my weak words / Have struck but thus much show of fire from Brutus." Caesar then returns with his train, "The angry spot" glowing on his brow, and the scene moves to Caesar's judgement of Cassius and Casca's report.

Meaning: 'Why, man, Caesar straddles this cramped world like the Colossus, and we small men walk about between his enormous legs, peering around for a place to be buried without honour. There are moments when men control their own destinies. The blame, dear Brutus, does not lie in the stars under which we were born; it lies in ourselves, that we accept the position of inferiors. Brutus and Caesar: what is so special about the word Caesar? Why should that name be proclaimed more loudly than yours? Write the two side by side, and yours is as handsome a name; speak them, and yours fits the mouth just as well; weigh them, and yours is just as heavy; use them in a spell, and Brutus will raise a ghost as quickly as Caesar will. Now, by all the gods together, what food does this Caesar of ours eat that he has grown so huge? Our age should be ashamed. Rome, you have lost your stock of noble families.' Difficult words: *bestride* (stand with a leg on each side of), *Colossus* (a giant statue; here the famous one at Rhodes), *petty* (small, insignificant), *peep about* (peer around timidly), *underlings* (inferiors, subordinates), *sounded* (proclaimed, spoken aloud), *become* (suit), *conjure* (summon spirits by magic), *start* (raise, rouse), *meat* (food in general), *breed* (stock, lineage).

Subtext: The speech has three movements, and each attacks Brutus from a different side. The Colossus humiliates: it makes Caesar not merely great but monstrously disproportionate, and makes every other Roman, Brutus included, a small creature scuttling about beneath him. The word dishonourable is aimed with care, since Brutus has just sworn that he loves honour more than life; Cassius is telling him that under Caesar even his grave will be shameful. The lines about the stars then turn humiliation into responsibility. If the cause of Rome's condition were fate, nothing could be done and no one would be to blame; Cassius insists that the cause is human, which means that the cure is human too. He includes himself, "ourselves", "we", so the reproach does not sound like an accusation of Brutus but like a shared confession. The third movement is the subtlest: the game with the two names. Cassius never says 'you should rule instead of Caesar'; he says only that there is nothing in the sound or weight of the name Caesar that makes it superior, and lets Brutus feel the implication. The verb *conjure* reaches past the living Brutus to the dead one, the ancestor whose name could indeed raise a spirit in Rome, and Cassius will name him openly a few lines later. The closing exclamations turn personal envy into civic grief, so that the speech ends not with Cassius's wound but with Rome's.

LITERARY INTERPRETATION: whether the envy or the grief is the truer motive is one of the oldest debates about the play; the extract contains evidence for both, and an honest answer says so.

Character: Cassius is a brilliant persuader and a passionate republican, but a passion for equality shades here into resentment at being outshone, and the speech lets us hear both. He is quick, physical in his imagination, scornful and grand by turns, and he is at his most eloquent when he is most personal. Brutus, silent throughout, is characterised by what he does not do: he does not interrupt, protest, or defend Caesar, and when he finally speaks he admits that he has some idea what Cassius is driving at. The listener who lets such a speech run to its end has already half consented. Caesar, absent, is characterised too, as a giant who has grown by eating something no one else was offered, an image that makes his greatness seem unnatural rather than earned.

Theme: Fate and free will, in the play's most quoted statement that men, not stars, make their condition, spoken in the same scene as a prophecy that will prove true. Power and its disproportion, the republic's horror at a city that holds only one man. Honour, in the "dishonourable graves" that await those who submit. Jealousy and the politics of names, since the speech argues that reputation is arbitrary and can be redistributed. Republican nostalgia, in the lament for an age that has lost "the breed of noble bloods". Individual against state, since Cassius's case is that one individual has swallowed the state.

Device: The opening is a simile, Caesar "Like a Colossus", developed into a visual image of giant legs and tiny men, and heightened by hyperbole; the world itself becomes "narrow" beside him. "Men at some time are masters of their fates" is a sententia or aphorism, and the two lines on the stars are an antithesis, our stars against ourselves, which makes the argument feel as balanced as a law. The passage on the names is a sustained tricolon with anaphora-like parallel imperatives, "Write them", "Sound them", "Weigh them", followed by a fourth, "conjure with 'em", so that the names are tested in four ways like coins and found equal.

There is a metaphor of magic in conjure and "start a spirit", and a metaphor of unnatural feeding in "Upon what meat doth this our Caesar feed", which makes Caesar's growth bestial. The last two lines are apostrophe, direct address to the abstractions Age and Rome, and exclamations that lift the voice from argument to lament; "breed of noble bloods" is alliterative and bitterly ironic, since Cassius himself belongs to that breed. Underneath everything runs rhetorical questioning, five questions in nineteen lines, each designed to be answered by the listener in Cassius's favour. In the lines immediately after, the pun on Rome and room, which many editors note were pronounced alike in Shakespeare's day, caps the speech with a bitter joke.

Historical context: HISTORICAL RECORD: The Colossus of Rhodes was a huge bronze statue of the sun-god Helios set up at the harbour of Rhodes in about 280 BC and counted among the Seven Wonders of the ancient world; it had fallen in an earthquake long before Caesar's time. The picture of it straddling the harbour mouth with ships passing between its legs is a medieval legend, not ancient fact, and Shakespeare's image depends on that legend. Lucius Junius Brutus led the expulsion of King Tarquin the Proud in 509 BC, by tradition the founding act of the Roman Republic, and Marcus Brutus claimed descent from him; this is the Brutus who could, in Cassius's words, "start a spirit". In February 44 BC Caesar had been made dictator for life, breaking the old six-month limit on the office, and had already held unprecedented honours; the shouts off-stage, in Plutarch's account, greeted Antony's offer of a diadem at the Lupercalia. Cassius had been pardoned by Caesar after the civil war and made praetor, but received the less prestigious praetorship while Brutus received the urban one, and ancient writers treat this as a grievance. Plutarch also reports that Caesar said he feared not fat, long-haired men but pale, thin ones, meaning Brutus and Cassius, which Shakespeare dramatises moments after this speech. Historically, too, Cassius followed Epicurean philosophy, which denied that the gods or the stars govern human affairs; the line about the stars sits naturally in his mouth. **LITERARY INTERPRETATION:** the talk of astrology ("our stars") is Elizabethan rather than Roman in flavour, and the audience of 1599 would have heard a familiar debate about whether the heavens fix a man's fortune.

Scene connection: The Colossus answers Flavius's hawk at the end of Scene 1: there Caesar was to "soar above the view of men", here he towers over them, and both images turn the fear of Caesar into a problem of height and scale. Cassius's "dishonourable graves" picks up Brutus's own oath about honour and death from Extract 5 and threatens him with the one thing he said he did not fear, a death without honour. The claim that the fault is in ourselves is answered in the same scene by Caesar's judgement that "Yond Cassius has a lean and hungry look. / He thinks too much. Such men are dangerous.", a judgement that is itself a kind of fate closing in. In Scene 3 Cassius repeats the method with Casca, describing a man "no mightier than thyself or me / In personal action, yet prodigious grown", and he turns the argument about names into action with the forged letters that will praise Brutus's name and glance at Caesar's ambition. Brutus's reply, that he would rather be a villager than call himself a son of Rome under such conditions, is his first step; the orchard soliloquy of Act 2, where he reasons his way to Caesar's death, is the second. And the confident denial of the stars returns with heavy irony on the battlefield in Act 5, where Cassius admits that he has come partly to credit the omens he once dismissed, and dies on his birthday.

Keywords: simile; Colossus; hyperbole; sententia; aphorism; antithesis; fate versus free will; tricolon; anaphora; rhetorical question; apostrophe; exclamation; metaphor of conjuring; metaphor of feeding; underlings; republican nostalgia; envy versus principle; lineage; pun.

QUESTIONS Extract 6 — ICSE-style questions

- (i) Who is speaking, to whom, and where? What has just been heard, and how has the listener explained it? [3]
- (ii) Explain the image of the Colossus. Who are the "petty men", and what does Cassius mean by "dishonourable graves"? [3]
- (iii) Explain the lines "The fault, dear Brutus, is not in our stars, / But in ourselves, that we are underlings." How does this view of human life compare with the Soothsayer's warning earlier in the scene? [3]
- (iv) What does Cassius do with the two names Brutus and Caesar in this extract? Identify the devices he uses and explain what he hopes to achieve. [3]
- (v) Cassius has been described as 'a patriot driven by envy'. Using this extract and the stories about Caesar that come just before it, say how far you agree with this description. [4]

Reference to the context (Class IX style)

- (a) "Rome, thou hast lost the breed of noble bloods!" Who says this, and in what circumstances? Name the figure of speech and explain what the speaker is lamenting.
- (b) "Men at some time are masters of their fates." Who is speaking to whom? Explain the statement and say why it is important to the speaker's argument.

Multiple-choice questions

- The Colossus to which Cassius compares Caesar was: (a) a Roman general (b) a giant statue at Rhodes (c) a god of war (d) a mountain near Rome
- In the extract, underlings means: (a) children (b) soldiers (c) inferiors or subordinates (d) rebels
- Immediately after this extract, Cassius reminds Brutus of: (a) the Soothsayer's warning (b) the death of Pompey (c) his ancestor who would not tolerate a king in Rome (d) the storm over the city

MODEL ANSWER Model answer (i)

Cassius is speaking to Brutus in a public place in Rome on the feast of Lupercal. The two men are alone; Caesar and his followers have gone to the games, and Cassius has been working on Brutus's discontent, telling him how he once saved Caesar from drowning in the Tiber and watched him shake with fever in Spain. A second shout and a flourish of trumpets have just been heard from the games. Brutus has explained the noise as applause for some new honours being heaped upon Caesar, and it is this remark that prompts Cassius's speech.

Why this answer earns marks: Speaker, listener and place are given at once (context), the situation is fixed by reference to what Cassius has just been saying (recall and connection), and the question's two final parts, what was heard and how Brutus explained it, are both answered with Brutus's own phrase. The answer ends by linking the remark to the speech, which shows the student understands why the extract begins as it does.

MODEL ANSWER Model answer (ii)

Cassius compares Caesar to the Colossus, the giant statue at Rhodes which legend pictured standing astride a harbour so that ships sailed between its legs. Caesar, he says, straddles the whole world in the same way, and the world has become narrow, too small for anyone but him. The petty men are all other Romans, Cassius and Brutus included, reduced to the size of insects walking about between the giant's legs. The dishonourable graves are the shameful deaths that await such men: if they live out their lives as Caesar's inferiors, the only thing left for them to find is a place to be buried without honour. The phrase is aimed at Brutus, who has just declared that he loves honour more than he fears death; Cassius is warning him that under Caesar he will lose the one and still suffer the other.

Why this answer earns marks: The image is explained in both halves, the statue and what it stands for (terminology: simile, explained). The petty men are identified, with the important detail that Cassius includes himself. The dishonourable graves are glossed accurately and then connected to Brutus's oath a few lines earlier, which is the analytical point that lifts the answer above a glossary.

MODEL ANSWER Model answer (iii)

Cassius means that the blame for Rome's condition does not lie in destiny, in the position of the stars at a man's birth, which astrologers believed fixed his fortune. It lies in men themselves: Romans are inferiors because they have agreed to be inferiors. The statement is a claim for free will, and it serves Cassius's purpose exactly, because if the fault is human then the remedy is human too, and Brutus cannot excuse inaction by calling Caesar's greatness fate. The view stands in sharp contrast to the Soothsayer's warning. The Soothsayer speaks as the voice of fate: a fixed day is coming, and the only choice is whether to heed it. Cassius speaks as the voice of will: nothing is fixed, and men make their own fates. Shakespeare places the two voices in the same scene so that the audience, who know what the ides will bring, can hear the irony. The conspirators will act as free men and will walk straight into the day the Soothsayer named.

Why this answer earns marks: The lines are paraphrased with the key cultural idea, astrology, explained (understanding). The function of the statement in Cassius's argument is stated (analysis). The comparison asked for is made directly, fate against will, with both positions characterised fairly, and the answer closes by naming the dramatic irony that results from putting them together (terminology and connection).

MODEL ANSWER Model answer (iv)

Cassius sets the two names side by side and tests them as if they were coins. He asks what is so special in the word Caesar, and why it should be proclaimed more loudly than Brutus. Then he puts the names through four trials in a sustained parallel structure: written together, Brutus looks as fair; spoken, it suits the mouth as well; weighed, it is as heavy; used in a spell, Brutus will raise a spirit as quickly as Caesar. The devices are rhetorical question, parallelism or tricolon with repeated imperatives, and a metaphor of magic in the word conjure. His aim is to make Caesar's supremacy look arbitrary, a matter of mere sound, so that Brutus will feel that nothing but his own submission separates him from Caesar. He also hopes to wake the ancestor: the name Brutus can start a spirit because it belongs to the man who drove out Rome's kings, and Cassius names him openly a few lines later.

Why this answer earns marks: The question asks what Cassius does, which devices he uses and why; the answer gives all three in order. The devices are named precisely and illustrated from the text rather than merely listed, and the purpose is explained at two levels, the immediate one of making supremacy look arbitrary and the deeper one of invoking the ancestor, with a connection to the lines that follow the extract.

MODEL ANSWER Model answer (v)

The description fits Cassius closely, provided that both halves of it are taken seriously. The patriot is real. In this extract his grief is for Rome, not only for himself: the age is shamed, the city has lost its breed of noble bloods, and the argument about the stars is a call to Romans to recover their freedom by their own will. He includes himself among the underlings and the petty men, which is the language of shared responsibility rather than private spite. Yet the envy is just as real, and it shows most clearly in the stories that precede the extract. Cassius dwells on the moment Caesar cried for help in the Tiber and on the fever in Spain when this god shook and begged for drink like a sick girl, and his fury is that so feeble a man has got the start of the majestic world and must now be bowed to. His complaint is not that Caesar is unjust but that Caesar is no better than Cassius, and the questions about the names, which prove only that Caesar is not superior, continue the same thought. The two motives are not in competition; they feed each other. Cassius hates Caesar's elevation because he is a republican and because he is Caesar's equal who has been made to feel small, and his eloquence comes from the wound. I agree with the description, with one refinement: envy supplies his energy and patriotism supplies his argument, and Brutus, who hears only the argument, is persuaded by the one while being moved by the other.

Why this answer earns marks: The answer treats the quotation in the question as a claim to be tested, not accepted. It supplies evidence for patriotism from the extract and evidence for envy from the preceding stories, as the question requires, with accurate paraphrase of both. It then does the hardest thing a 4-mark evaluation asks, relating the two motives to each other rather than merely listing them, and ends with a personal judgement stated in a single precise sentence that returns to Brutus and the extract's purpose.

MODEL ANSWER Model answers — reference to the context and MCQs

(a) Cassius says this to Brutus, when the two are alone during the Lupercal games, at the climax of his speech about Caesar's monstrous greatness. The line is an apostrophe, a direct address to the city as if it were a person, and an exclamation. Cassius laments that Rome, once famous for producing many great men in every generation, has lost its stock of noble families and now holds only one man; the republic of equals has shrunk to a single giant and a crowd of underlings.

(b) Cassius is speaking to Brutus. He means that there are times when men hold their destiny in their own hands and can shape it by their actions. The statement is central to his argument because he must persuade Brutus that Caesar's rise is not fate but the result of Roman submission; if men can master their fates, then Brutus can and must act. It also tells us about Cassius himself, a man who refuses to believe in powers beyond human control, and it sets up the play's long argument between free will and the prophecy of the ides.

Why these answers earn marks: Each fixes speaker, listener and moment, then names the device where asked, then explains meaning and purpose. Answer (b) goes one step further by relating the line to the speaker's character and to the play's theme, which is how a 'reference to the context' answer shows understanding beyond recall.

MCQ key: 1 (b); 2 (c); 3 (c). In question 3, option (a) is a common error, because students remember the Soothsayer from the same scene; but it is the ancestor Brutus, not the Soothsayer, whom Cassius invokes to close his argument.

What These Six Extracts Have Trained

Look back at the six and you will see that they are not six random passages but a graded course. Extracts 1 and 2 taught you to read a public quarrel: who has authority, who has wit, what the crowd is for. Extract 3 taught you to unpack a single governing image, the hawk, and to see a scene's close as a promise about the future. Extract 4 taught you to follow a sequence of reactions step by step and to hear dramatic irony. Extract 5 taught you to watch a conversation as a contest, and to notice which speaker supplies the key words. Extract 6 taught you to break a long speech into movements and to weigh motive against argument. Those are the six skills a drama extract question tests, in any act.

REVISION The six-extract checklist

Before you leave this chapter, be able to do each of the following from memory, in a sentence or two each.

1. Say where each extract falls in the Act and what happens immediately before and after it.
2. Name the governing device of each: prose against verse; rhetorical question and climax; the falconry metaphor; dramatic irony and repetition; the mirror metaphor; the Colossus simile and the antithesis of stars and selves.
3. Give one keyword for the theme of each extract and one for the character it reveals most sharply.
4. Quote one short line from each extract accurately, with its speaker.
5. Explain how each extract reappears later in the play, in one sentence.
6. State honestly where this material sits in the syllabus: Class IX for Act 1 itself, and the foundation for every Act 3 to 5 question in the Class X board paper.

CROSS-REFERENCE **Where to go next**

'Extract-Based Training (Part Two): The Second Half of Scene 2 and Scene 3' continues with Caesar's judgement of Cassius, Casca's report of the crown, Cassius's soliloquy and the storm. 'Cassius — The Manipulation Masterclass' gives the full account of the techniques compressed into Extracts 5 and 6, and 'Brutus in Act 1 — Honour, Conflict and Vulnerability' develops the reading of the honour oath. For the Colossus and the mirror as devices, see 'The Act 1 Literary-Device Bank'; for the Lucius Junius Brutus story and the Colossus of Rhodes, see 'Roman History Before Act 1'.

CHAPTER 19

Extract-Based Training (Part Two): The Second Half of Scene 2 and Scene 3

What this chapter does: it takes the six passages from the second half of Act 1 Scene 2 and from Scene 3 that teachers and examiners return to most often, and trains you to answer on them the way an ICSE evaluator wants — precisely, from the text, and with a sense of why each line exists. For every extract you get the verified words, a thirteen-label commentary that climbs from plain fact to advanced interpretation, a full ICSE-pattern question set with Class IX-style reference-to-the-context questions and MCQs, and marked model answers that show exactly where the marks come from. Read it slowly, with a pen in your hand. This is a workout, not a summary.

Before You Begin: The Thirteen Labels and the Five Levels

In Part One of this training (the chapter 'Extract-Based Training (Part One): Scene 1 and the First Half of Scene 2') you met the method: print the extract, walk through thirteen fixed labels, then answer an ICSE-pattern question set. This chapter uses the identical method on harder material — the passages in which Caesar judges Cassius, Casca reports the crown, Cassius reveals his forgery plan, the storm breaks, and the conspiracy takes shape. The labels are not decoration. Each one is a mark-earning move that an evaluator recognises, and together they walk you up the five levels of understanding that this whole book is built on.

Labels	Level	What the evaluator is testing	Typical question stem
Context, Speaker, Listener, Before, After	Level 1 — What happened?	Recall and accurate placement in the scene	'Where does this take place? What has just happened?'
Meaning, Keywords	Level 2 — What does it mean?	Understanding; paraphrase in your own words	'Explain the phrase...'
Subtext, Character, Device	Level 3 — Why did Shakespeare write it this way?	Analysis of motive, character and craft	'What does this reveal about...?'
Theme, Historical context, Scene connection	Level 4 — How does it connect to the whole play?	Application across scenes and acts	'How is this borne out later...?'
The [4] sub-question	Level 5 — How do I use it in an ICSE answer?	Evaluation and supported personal response	'Do you think...? Give a reason.'

One habit above all: never write 'the Meaning' before you have fixed 'the Context'. Evaluators can tell within two lines whether a candidate knows where the extract sits in the scene. A student who begins 'Caesar says this after returning from the games, having refused the crown three times' has already signalled Level 1 mastery; a student who begins 'Caesar is a proud man' has signalled nothing yet.

ICSE EXAM BOX Be honest with yourself about where Act 1 sits in your examinations

Act 1 is prescribed for Class IX; it is examined in school through 'reference to the context' questions and, increasingly, through the newer [3][3][3][4] extract pattern that mirrors the board paper. The Class X board paper (Paper 2, Literature in English) sets its drama extracts from Acts III, IV and V. So no extract in this chapter will be printed in your board paper. Yet the 2025 board paper asked candidates what Brutus meant, in Act 5 Scene 1, by the work that the ides of March began — a question no candidate can answer well without Scene 2 and Scene 3 of Act 1 — and Antony's funeral oration in Act 3 Scene 2 returns directly to the crown that Casca reports here. Treat this chapter, then, as two things at once: direct practice for Class IX assessment, and the foundation that earns you marks in every Act 3–5 answer about Caesar's ambition, Cassius's manipulation, or Brutus's conflict. Nothing here is a prediction of any paper.

CROSS-REFERENCE Where the supporting chapters are

The scene-by-scene teaching that these extracts assume is in 'Act 1 Scene 2 (Part Two) — Caesar Returns, Casca Reports, Cassius Plots' and 'Act 1 Scene 3 — The Storm: Omens, Fear and the Conspiracy Takes Shape'. The devices named under **Device**: are defined fully in 'The Act 1 Literary-Device Bank'; the evaluative vocabulary under **Keywords**: is expanded in 'The ICSE Keyword Vault for Act 1'; and the mark scheme logic behind every **Why this answer earns marks**: note is set out in 'ICSE Examiner Mode: How Marks Are Earned'.

A word about the question sets. In the 2025 board paper each drama extract carried five sub-questions marked [3], [3], [3], [3] and [4]. Notice how those sub-questions were built: a [3] question frequently contained two or three short parts ('Why does Brutus say...? What conditions...? What do these words imply?'), each part worth roughly one mark, and the [4] question asked for an opinion with a reason plus a further recall or comparison part. The question sets below copy that architecture deliberately. When you practise, answer every part, label your parts (a), (b), (c) if it helps, and never spend eight lines on a one-mark part.

Extract 1 — Caesar Reads Cassius: "Let me have men about me that are fat"

EXTRACT Act 1 Scene 2 — Caesar to Antony, as the procession returns from the games

Caesar: *Let me have men about me that are fat, Sleek-headed men, and such as sleep a-nights. Yond Cassius has a lean and hungry look. He thinks too much. Such men are dangerous. Antony: Fear him not, Caesar; he's not dangerous. He is a noble Roman, and well given. Caesar: Would he were fatter! But I fear him not. Yet if my name were liable to fear, I do not know the man I should avoid So soon as that spare Cassius. [...] I rather tell thee what is to be feared Than what I fear; for always I am Caesar. Come on my right hand, for this ear is deaf, And tell me truly what thou think'st of him.*

Context: Act 1 Scene 2, the day of the Lupercal. Caesar's procession has returned from the games and is crossing the stage on its way out. Brutus has just observed that "The angry spot doth glow on Caesar's brow" and that Calpurnia and Cicero look shaken. Caesar draws Antony aside for this private exchange in the middle of a public crowd — the two men are, in effect, talking behind their hands while Brutus and Cassius watch from a distance, waiting to catch Casca.

Speaker: Caesar, with one short interjection from Antony. This is Caesar's longest speech in Act 1 and his only extended private conversation in the act.

Listener: Antony — the man who, according to Casca a few moments later, was the one who offered Caesar the crown. Brutus and Cassius are on stage but out of earshot, which matters: the audience hears Caesar's judgement of Cassius while Cassius stands there unaware of it.

Before: Cassius has spent the whole middle of the scene working on Brutus — the mirror image ("I, your glass"), the Tiber story, the fever in Spain, the Colossus, the argument from names ("Brutus' will start a spirit as soon as 'Caesar.'"). Brutus has asked for time and left Cassius with "chew upon this". Offstage the crowd has shouted three times. Then the procession re-enters and Brutus reads the faces before anyone speaks.

After: Caesar and his train exit. Casca remains because Brutus has pulled him by the cloak, and delivers his report of the crown (our Extract 2). Notice the design: the audience receives Caesar's private opinion of Cassius, then immediately receives Casca's private opinion of Caesar. Scene 2 is a scene of assessments — everyone is reading everyone else.

Meaning: Caesar tells Antony that he prefers to be surrounded by contented men — fat, "Sleek-headed" (smooth-haired, well-groomed, at ease), and able to sleep at night ("a-nights"). Cassius, over there ("Yond Cassius"), looks thin and unsatisfied — "lean and hungry" — and he thinks too much; men like that are dangerous. Antony reassures him: Cassius is not dangerous, he is a noble Roman and "well given" (of good disposition). Caesar wishes Cassius were fatter, then insists he does not fear him — but if his name were "liable to fear" (open or subject to fear), Cassius is the man he would avoid first. The lines the extract skips explain why: Cassius "reads much", is "a great observer", and "looks / Quite through the deeds of men"; he "loves no plays", "hears no music", and "Seldom he smiles" — and when he does, it is as if he mocked himself for smiling. Such men are never at ease while they see someone greater than themselves. Caesar then closes: he is describing what ought to be feared, not what he fears, because he is always Caesar — and he asks Antony to move to his right side because his left ear is deaf, and to tell him honestly what he thinks of Cassius.

Subtext: Two things run beneath the surface. First, Caesar's reading of Cassius is exactly right — the audience has just watched Cassius do everything Caesar describes — and yet Caesar refuses to let his own insight alter his conduct. The line "Would he were fatter! But I fear him not" is the hinge: the wish admits the danger, the denial cancels it. Second, "for always I am Caesar" is the statement of a man who has begun to treat his name as a guarantee. Shakespeare places the boast one line before a confession of physical infirmity: "this ear is deaf". The god who cannot fear cannot hear either. A strong reading (though not the only one) is that Caesar's pivot to the deaf ear is not incidental staging but the play's quiet joke — he asks Antony to "tell me truly" what he thinks of Cassius, but Antony has already told him, and was wrong, and Caesar is now turning his working ear towards the flatterer.

Character: Caesar emerges as a superb judge of men and a poor judge of himself. The shrewdness is genuine: he notices Cassius's reading, his observation, his refusal of pleasure, his mirthless smile — a psychological portrait of the ascetic malcontent that Cassius's own speeches have confirmed. But the shrewdness is swallowed by the public role; Caesar speaks of himself in the third person ("always I am Caesar") as though the office had replaced the man. Antony is shown as loyal, generous and easy — "Fear him not" — a man who

takes people at face value, which the whole play will test. Cassius, seen from outside for the first time, is confirmed as the thinker and watcher he has shown himself to be — which means Caesar's error is not in perception but in pride.

Theme: Appearance versus reality (Caesar sees the reality and prefers his self-image); leadership and its blind spots; the public self versus the private man; fate and character (Caesar's downfall is prepared by a decision he takes knowingly); ambition observed from the top rather than from below.

Device: Dramatic irony — the audience knows Cassius is dangerous and hears Caesar dismiss the danger. Antithesis structures the speech: fat against lean, sleeping against thinking, men who love plays against the man who hears no music, "what is to be feared" against "what I fear". Illeism — referring to oneself in the third person — in "always I am Caesar", which the play repeats whenever Caesar is most vulnerable. Physiognomy, the old belief that the body reveals the mind, underlies "lean and hungry look". And the deaf ear is a physical symbol: an infirmity placed exactly where a boast of invulnerability has just been made. Note also that this is verse, formal and balanced, immediately before Casca's jagged prose.

Historical context: HISTORICAL RECORD — Plutarch reports that Caesar said he did not fear fat, long-haired men but the pale, thin ones, meaning Brutus and Cassius; Shakespeare has taken the remark and turned it into a scene. Cassius and Brutus were both praetors in 44 BC, and Brutus received the more prestigious urban praetorship — ancient sources make this a grievance of Cassius, which sits behind Shakespeare's "Caesar doth bear me hard" later in the scene. Antony was Caesar's consular colleague in 44 BC. The deafness is different: no ancient source gives Caesar a deaf ear, and scholars treat it as Shakespeare's addition. That makes it doubly important for you — a detail Shakespeare chose rather than inherited is a detail he wanted you to notice.

Scene connection: Everything Caesar says here is verified within a hundred lines. Cassius's soliloquy (Extract 4) shows the man who "thinks too much" thinking his way to forgery; Scene 3 shows him baring his chest to the lightning and declaring that "dangers are to me indifferent". Caesar's confidence that he cannot be threatened by his own name is the same confidence that, in Act 3 Scene 1, keeps him in the Senate House until the daggers are out. Antony's misjudgement here is also the first note of the Antony–Cassius antagonism that shapes Acts 3 to 5: Cassius, who reads men "Quite through", will want Antony dead; Brutus will spare him.

Keywords: shrewd, perceptive, physiognomy, complacent, hubris, self-mythologising, dramatic irony, infirmity, misjudgement, foreshadowing, public persona, ascetic.

QUESTIONS Practice set — Extract 1

Read the extract above and answer the following questions.

- (i) Where does this exchange take place, and from what has Caesar just returned? What has Brutus noticed about Caesar and his followers moments before Caesar speaks? What does Cassius suggest Brutus should do "As they pass by"? [3]
- (ii) Explain in your own words what kind of men Caesar wants about him. What does the phrase "lean and hungry look" suggest about Cassius? Why, according to Caesar, is such a man "dangerous"? [3]
- (iii) In the lines omitted from this extract, Caesar gives further reasons for distrusting Cassius. State any three of them. Which of these reasons does the rest of Act 1 most clearly confirm? [3]
- (iv) What does Antony's reply reveal about his character? How is Antony's judgement of Cassius proved wrong before the end of Act 1? [3]
- (v) What is ironic about Caesar's words "for always I am Caesar" being followed by "this ear is deaf"? Do you think Caesar's refusal to fear Cassius is a strength or a weakness in a leader? Give a reason for your answer, supported by the text. [4]

Class IX-style reference to the context:

- (a) "Yond Cassius has a lean and hungry look. / He thinks too much. Such men are dangerous." — Who speaks these words and to whom? What is the occasion? Explain their meaning and say what they reveal about the speaker.
- (b) "I rather tell thee what is to be feared / Than what I fear; for always I am Caesar." — Explain these lines with reference to the context. What weakness in the speaker do they expose?

Multiple-choice questions:

1. Caesar wants men around him who are 'fat' and 'sleek-headed' because such men are (a) better soldiers (b) contented and therefore not plotting (c) more entertaining company (d) easier to bribe
2. Antony describes Cassius as (a) "a great observer" (b) "a noble Roman, and well given" (c) "quick mettle" (d) "a dreamer"
3. Caesar asks Antony to move to his right side because (a) it is the place of honour (b) Antony must guard him from Cassius (c) Caesar's left ear is deaf (d) the crowd is pressing on his left

MODEL ANSWER Model answer (i)

Caesar and Antony are in a public place in Rome on the feast of Lupercal; Caesar's procession is passing through on its way home from the games, where Antony has run his course and where (as Casca will report) a crown was offered to Caesar three times. Just before Caesar speaks, Brutus has observed that "The angry spot doth glow on Caesar's brow", that the followers look "like a chidden train", that Calpurnia's cheek is pale, and that Cicero has the fiery, "ferret" eyes he wears when crossed by senators. Cassius has told Brutus to "pluck Casca by the sleeve" as they pass, so that Casca, in his "sour fashion", can tell them what happened.

Why this answer earns marks: It places the extract exactly (Lupercal, the returning procession), answers each of the three parts separately, and supports two of them with short, accurate quotations. An evaluator awards the three marks quickly because nothing has to be searched for.

MODEL ANSWER Model answer (ii)

Caesar wants to be surrounded by comfortable, contented men — well-fed, well-groomed, able to sleep soundly at night — because a satisfied man has no reason to plot. The "lean and hungry look" suggests that Cassius is thin, restless and unsatisfied, hungry not for food but for something he lacks — power, recognition, or Caesar's downfall. Caesar believes such a man is dangerous because "He thinks too much": a man who broods, observes and is never at ease is the kind of man who turns his discontent into action.

Why this answer earns marks: The paraphrase is in the candidate's own words, the metaphor of hunger is actually explained rather than repeated, and the third part links the adjective to Caesar's stated reason. Explaining a phrase means unpacking the image; this answer does that.

MODEL ANSWER Model answer (iii)

In the omitted lines Caesar says that Cassius "reads much", that he is "a great observer" who "looks / Quite through the deeds of men", that he "loves no plays" and "hears no music" as Antony does, and that he "Seldom he smiles" — and when he does, it is as if he mocked himself for smiling. Caesar adds that such men are never at ease while they see someone greater than themselves. The rest of Act 1 most clearly confirms the last of these: Cassius's speeches to Brutus are consumed by the injustice that Caesar has "become a god" while Cassius "must bend his body", and his soliloquy shows a man who reads other men accurately enough to plan how to seduce Brutus.

Why this answer earns marks: Three reasons are stated with textual precision (more than three, in fact, which protects the candidate if one is judged weak), and the second part does not merely name a reason but shows it being confirmed with evidence from elsewhere in the act. That cross-referencing is what separates a two-mark from a three-mark answer.

MODEL ANSWER Model answer (iv)

Antony's "Fear him not, Caesar; he's not dangerous. / He is a noble Roman, and well given" reveals a man who is loyal, generous in his judgements, and inclined to take people at their public face value; he sees a fellow noble and assumes good nature. He is also a soothing presence for Caesar rather than a challenging one. His judgement is proved wrong within the same scene, when Cassius alone on stage announces that he will forge letters in "several hands" to work on Brutus and that "we will shake him, or worse days endure", and again in Scene 3, when Cassius wins Casca to the conspiracy and sends Cinna out with the forged papers.

Why this answer earns marks: It infers character from the exact words rather than asserting it, it names two qualities plus a role (the reassurer), and it answers 'how is he proved wrong' with two specific events in the correct order. The evaluator can tick recall, inference and connection.

MODEL ANSWER Model answer (v)

The irony is that Caesar claims a godlike constancy — he is not a man who fears, he is simply "Caesar", a name that stands above fear — and in the very next breath confesses an ordinary human weakness: one ear cannot hear. The boast of being above human limits is undercut by a bodily limit, and the deaf ear becomes a symbol of a man who will not hear warnings — he has already dismissed the Soothsayer as "a dreamer". There is further irony in the fact that he turns his good ear towards Antony, who has just misjudged Cassius, and asks him to "tell me truly". In my view, Caesar's refusal to fear Cassius is a weakness, because the refusal is not based on information — his information is excellent — but on image: he says "Would he were fatter!", which admits the danger, and then overrides his own judgement to protect the idea of himself as fearless. A leader who can see a threat and chooses not to act on it, in order to seem invulnerable, has made himself more vulnerable, and the play confirms this when the man he correctly suspects leads the conspiracy against him.

Why this answer earns marks: The four marks are spread deliberately: two for the irony (the boast against the infirmity, plus the extra layer of turning the ear to Antony), one for a clear, committed opinion, and one for a reason anchored in a quotation ("Would he were fatter!") and in the outcome of the play. An evaluator rewards a personal response that is argued, not merely stated.

REVISION Answer key — Extract 1 (reference to the context and MCQs)

Reference to the context (a): Caesar to Antony, as the procession returns from the games on the Lupercal; the "angry spot" is on Caesar's brow after the crown episode. Caesar reads Cassius's thinness and restlessness as signs of a brooding, discontented mind; the lines reveal a shrewd observer of men who nevertheless treats his insight as an intellectual exercise rather than a warning. Reference to the context (b): Caesar distinguishes between describing what is fearful in general and admitting fear in himself; the third-person "Caesar" shows a man who has fused himself with his public title, and the refusal to fear what he has just called dangerous exposes pride that overrides judgement. MCQs: 1 (b); 2 (b); 3 (c).

Extract 2 — Casca Reports the Crown: "he would fain have had it"

EXTRACT**Act 1 Scene 2 — Casca to Brutus and Cassius, after Caesar's procession has left**

Casca: *Why, there was a crown offered him; and, being offered him, he put it by with the back of his hand, thus, and then the people fell a-shouting. [...]* **Brutus:** *Tell us the manner of it, gentle Casca.* **Casca:** *I can as well be hanged as tell the manner of it. It was mere foolery; I did not mark it. I saw Mark Antony offer him a crown (yet 'twas not a crown neither; 'twas one of these coronets), and, as I told you, he put it by once; but for all that, to my thinking, he would fain have had it. Then he offered it to him again; then he put it by again; but to my thinking, he was very loath to lay his fingers off it. And then he offered it the third time. He put it the third time by, and still as he refused it the rabblement hooted and clapped their chopped hands and threw up their sweaty nightcaps and uttered such a deal of stinking breath because Caesar refused the crown that it had almost choked Caesar, for he swooned and fell down at it.*

Context: Act 1 Scene 2, immediately after Caesar's train has gone. Brutus has pulled Casca by the cloak, and Casca — surprised that Brutus, who was in the procession, needs to ask — explains what happened at the games while Brutus and Cassius were talking. Between the two halves of the extract lie the quick exchanges in which Brutus asks what the second and third shouts were for and Casca answers "Why, for that too", and confirms that the crown was offered three times and refused "every time gentler than other".

Speaker: Casca, in prose. Every other noble in the scene speaks verse; Casca's choice of prose is itself a characterising device, the 'sour fashion' Cassius promised.

Listener: Brutus and Cassius — the two men most anxious to know whether Rome has just acquired a king. Brutus asks the eager, factual questions ("Was the crown offered him thrice?"); Cassius supplies the count ("They shouted thrice").

Before: The three offstage shouts punctuated Cassius's temptation of Brutus, and Brutus interpreted them fearfully: "I do fear the people / Choose Caesar for their king." Then Caesar returned looking angry and, in Extract 1, privately named Cassius as the man to be feared.

After: Cassius asks, "What, did Caesar swoon?" and Casca describes the fit in the market-place — "foamed at mouth and was speechless" — which leads into Extract 3: the "falling sickness" pun, Cicero's Greek, and the news that Marullus and Flavius have been "put to silence".

Meaning: Casca says a crown was offered to Caesar and Caesar pushed it away "with the back of his hand, thus" — Casca mimes the gesture as he speaks — at which the people shouted. Pressed for the manner of it, he claims he would as soon be hanged as describe it, that it was nonsense ("mere foolery") and he paid no attention ("I did not mark it"). Then he describes it in detail. Antony offered Caesar a crown — though, Casca sneers, it was not a real crown but one of these little "coronets" — and Caesar refused it; but in Casca's opinion ("to my thinking") he "would fain have had it" — would gladly have accepted it. Offered again, he refused again, but was "very loath" — extremely reluctant — to take his fingers off it. Offered a third time, he refused a third time, and each time he refused, the mob ("rabblement") hooted, clapped their rough, cracked ("chopped") hands, threw up their sweaty caps and let out such a quantity of foul breath because Caesar had refused that it nearly suffocated him — for he fainted ("swooned") and fell down.

Subtext: Casca is not reporting; he is interpreting, and he tells you so twice with "to my thinking". Strip that phrase out and the facts are: a crown offered three times, refused three times, applause each time, a collapse. Put it back and the account becomes a charge of hypocrisy — Caesar wanted the crown and staged the refusals. Notice too what Casca does to the crowd: he cannot admit that ordinary Romans cheered a principled refusal, so he turns their joy into a physical assault of smell and sweat that literally knocks Caesar down. The comic causation — Caesar fainting from the people's breath — is a joke, but a political one: Casca finds both the ruler and the ruled contemptible. And his opening pose of boredom ("I did not mark it") is contradicted by the precision of what follows; a man who noticed the reluctance in Caesar's fingers was watching very closely indeed.

Character: Casca appears blunt, cynical and snobbish, with a gift for deflating grandeur — the coronet, the sweaty nightcaps, the swoon. Yet he is also a shrewd observer whose scepticism about Caesar's motives makes him natural material for Cassius; Brutus's later remark that he was "quick mettle when he went to school" tells us the bluntness is a manner, not a limit. Caesar, seen through Casca, is a man performing humility while (perhaps) desiring the crown, and a man whose body fails him in public. Antony is the instrument of the offer — whether as a loyal friend testing the crowd or as a partner in a piece of theatre, the text does not say. Brutus, through his questions, is revealed as anxious and dependent on others' eyes for what he did not see.

Theme: Ambition and its concealment; appearance versus reality; public opinion and the fickleness of the crowd; politics as performance; the unreliability of report.

Device: Reported action — an offstage event delivered through a biased narrator, which is the central device of this passage. Repetition builds the structure ("Then he offered it... then he put it by again... And then he offered it the third time") and the doubled "to my thinking" flags the narrator's bias. Anticlimax and bathos deflate the ceremony: a crown becomes "one of these coronets"; the divine Caesar faints from bad breath. The sensory imagery is deliberately coarse — tactile ("chopped hands"), visual ("sweaty nightcaps"), olfactory ("stinking breath") — and hyperbole turns applause into near-suffocation. The gesture in "with the back of his hand, thus" is a stage direction hidden in the dialogue: the actor playing Casca reproduces Caesar's hand. And the whole thing is prose, set against the verse that surrounds it, which makes Casca sound like a man who refuses to dignify what he saw.

Historical context: HISTORICAL RECORD — Plutarch describes the Lupercalia of 15 February 44 BC: Antony, running as one of the Luperci while serving as consul, offered Caesar a diadem wreathed in laurel; the crowd applauded thinly at the offer and loudly at the refusal; Caesar finally ordered the diadem carried to the Temple of Jupiter on the Capitol. In Plutarch the offer and refusal happen twice; Shakespeare's Casca makes it three times, a number with a stronger rhythm on stage. Shakespeare also adds what Plutarch does not supply — the cynical inner reading, "he would fain have had it". The word "coronets" is worth a moment: Romans loathed the title of king (rex) so intensely that even the object had to be diminished; Casca's sneer echoes an ancient Roman anxiety. Whether the historical Caesar wanted the diadem is debated by historians, and the play deliberately leaves it open too.

Scene connection: This report completes the three shouts Brutus and Cassius heard but could not interpret. It also completes Scene 1: the "coronets" and the crowd's cheering are the same populace the tribunes scolded, now cheering Caesar's refusal exactly as they cheered his triumph. Looking forward, Antony will remind the Roman crowd in his funeral oration in Act 3 Scene 2 that Caesar three times refused a crown at the Lupercal, using the identical event to prove that Caesar was not ambitious — the same facts, the opposite reading. Casca's "to my thinking" is thus the first battle in a war of interpretation that the whole play fights.

Keywords: reported action, unreliable narrator, cynicism, political theatre, anticlimax, bathos, mob, fickle, class contempt, scepticism, ambiguity, prose.

PROFESSOR'S INSIGHT How examiners reward 'reported action' awareness

The crown is never seen. Everything you know about it comes from Casca, a witness who announces his bias ("to my thinking") and his contempt for the crowd, and who has already been introduced to you by Cassius as a man who speaks in a "sour fashion". Weak answers write 'Caesar refused the crown three times but secretly wanted it' as though the play had shown this. Strong answers write 'According to Casca, Caesar refused the crown three times; Casca believes he wanted it' — and then go further, asking why Shakespeare kept the event offstage at all. Three effects are worth knowing. First, ambiguity: because we never see Caesar's face, his desire for the crown remains an open question, and the play can keep Caesar poised between tyrant and victim. Second, alignment: the audience is placed exactly where Brutus and Cassius stand — dependent on a report — so we experience the conspiracy's own epistemic problem, deciding a man's guilt on hearsay. Third, thematic rehearsal: Julius Caesar is a play about how events are read — Cicero will say in Scene 3 that "men may construe things after their fashion" — and Casca's report is the first great demonstration of construing. An ICSE evaluator marking a [4] question on this passage is looking for a candidate who can separate what Casca says happened from what Casca thinks it meant, and who can name a reason for Shakespeare's choice. That separation is not pedantry; it is the difference between reading the play and reading a summary of it.

QUESTIONS Practice set — Extract 2

Read the extract above and answer the following questions.

- (i) Who has asked Casca to speak, and how has he been detained? Why is Casca surprised to be asked? What three shouts did Brutus and Cassius hear earlier in the scene, and what does Casca say they were for? [3]
- (ii) Explain in your own words the phrases "he put it by", "he would fain have had it" and "very loath to lay his fingers off it". What do these phrases, taken together, suggest about Caesar's true wish? [3]
- (iii) Who offered the crown to Caesar? Why does Casca correct himself with the words "'twas not a crown neither; 'twas one of these coronets"? What does his description of the crowd reveal about his attitude towards the common people? [3]
- (iv) Casca says, "It was mere foolery; I did not mark it." How does the rest of his report contradict this claim? What does this contradiction tell us about Casca? [3]
- (v) Shakespeare chose not to stage the offering of the crown but to have Casca report it. Suggest two effects of this decision. Do you trust Casca's account of Caesar's behaviour? Give a reason for your answer. [4]

Class IX-style reference to the context:

- (a) "Why, there was a crown offered him; and, being offered him, he put it by with the back of his hand, thus, and then the people fell a-shouting." — Who is the speaker and who are his listeners? What has just happened on stage? Explain the significance of the phrase "with the back of his hand, thus".
- (b) "the rabblement hooted and clapped their chopped hands and threw up their sweaty nightcaps" — Who is being described, and on what occasion? What does the language reveal about the speaker's opinion of them?

Multiple-choice questions:

1. According to Casca, the crown was offered to Caesar (a) once (b) twice (c) three times (d) four times
2. The person who offered Caesar the crown was (a) Brutus (b) Cassius (c) Antony (d) Cicero
3. Casca's remark that it was "one of these coronets" is best described as (a) a factual correction showing his respect for accuracy (b) a sneer that diminishes the ceremony (c) evidence that Caesar was legally crowned (d) a compliment to Antony's generosity

MODEL ANSWER Model answer (i)

Brutus has asked Casca to speak; Casca has stayed behind because Brutus pulled him by the cloak as the procession passed, following Cassius's advice to "pluck Casca by the sleeve". Casca is surprised because Brutus was part of Caesar's train — "Why, you were with him, were you not?" — and so ought to know what happened; Brutus replies that if he did, he would not need to ask. Earlier in the scene Brutus and Cassius heard three shouts from the crowd; Casca explains that all three were for Caesar's refusals of the crown — the first when "he put it by", and the second and third, in his curt phrase, "for that too".

Why this answer earns marks: Each of the three parts is answered in turn, with the detail of the cloak and sleeve, Casca's actual question, and the three shouts correctly attached to the three refusals. The evaluator sees that the candidate knows the mechanics of the scene, not just its gist.

MODEL ANSWER Model answer (ii)

"He put it by" means Caesar pushed the crown aside, refusing it. "He would fain have had it" means that in Casca's judgement Caesar would gladly have accepted it. "Very loath to lay his fingers off it" means Caesar was extremely reluctant to let go of the crown, as though his hand lingered on it even while refusing. Together they suggest that Caesar's refusals were a performance for the crowd and that his real wish was to be crowned — though the candidate should note that this is Casca's interpretation, twice signalled by "to my thinking", rather than something the audience witnesses.

Why this answer earns marks: Three phrases, three clear paraphrases in the candidate's own words, and a conclusion that draws them together. The final sentence adds the 'reported action' awareness that a discriminating evaluator rewards — the candidate shows that they know the difference between Casca's facts and Casca's opinion.

MODEL ANSWER Model answer (iii)

Antony offered the crown. Casca corrects himself because he wants to deflate the whole ceremony: a coronet is a small, lesser crown, and by insisting on the diminished object he suggests that the offer was a piece of theatre rather than a true coronation — and perhaps also that Caesar's supporters did not dare offer a real crown to a people who hated kings. His description of the crowd — a "rabblement" with "chopped hands", "sweaty nightcaps" and "stinking breath" — reveals contempt for the common people; he sees them as a foul-smelling, mindless mob whose applause is worthless, not as citizens exercising judgement.

Why this answer earns marks: The factual part is stated at once; the explanation of "coronets" offers two reasons (a deflating sneer and a political caution), showing analytical range; and the attitude is inferred from quoted words rather than asserted. Naming the sensory details is what turns a general statement about 'contempt' into evidence.

MODEL ANSWER Model answer (iv)

Casca claims to have paid no attention, yet he then reports the event with remarkable precision: he counts the offers and refusals, notices that each refusal was gentler than the last, records that Caesar was reluctant to let his fingers leave the crown, and even reproduces Caesar's gesture with his own hand. A man who did not mark it could not describe it so exactly. The contradiction tells us that Casca's boredom is a pose — a way of seeming above the vulgar spectacle — and that beneath the sour manner he is an acute and interested observer. It also warns us to read him carefully: his blunt style is a disguise for sharp political judgement, which is exactly why Cassius wants him and why Brutus later recalls that he was "quick mettle when he went to school".

Why this answer earns marks: The contradiction is proved with four specific details from the report, not merely claimed. The inference about Casca is then developed in two directions — his pose and his real capacity — and connected to how other characters see him. That is what 'what does this tell us' invites: inference supported by text.

MODEL ANSWER Model answer (v)

Two effects of reporting the crown rather than staging it. First, Caesar's motive stays ambiguous: we never see his face as he refuses, so the question of whether he wanted the crown is left open, and the play can keep Caesar balanced between ambitious tyrant and wronged man. Second, the audience is placed in the same position as Brutus and Cassius, who must judge Caesar on hearsay; we share their dependence on a witness, which is precisely the situation of the conspirators throughout the play — they act on interpretation, not on proof. I do not fully trust Casca's account. His facts may be accurate — the three offers, the applause, the fainting — but his reading of Caesar's inner wish is openly labelled "to my thinking", he despises the crowd whose applause he describes, and he pretends indifference while watching closely, all of which mark him as a biased narrator. A cautious reader accepts Casca's events and suspends judgement on his motives.

Why this answer earns marks: Two distinct effects are named and explained (two marks), a clear position is taken on trust (one mark), and the reason is built from three pieces of textual evidence rather than a feeling (one mark). The distinction between accepting the facts and doubting the interpretation shows the highest level of reading the extract allows.

REVISION Answer key — Extract 2 (reference to the context and MCQs)

Reference to the context (a): Casca to Brutus and Cassius, just after Caesar's procession has left; Brutus has pulled him by the cloak to ask why Caesar looks sad. The phrase "with the back of his hand, thus" tells us Casca mimes Caesar's gesture — a stage direction inside the speech — so that the offstage crown is re-enacted, mockingly, by a hand on stage. Reference to the context (b): the common people of Rome at the Lupercal games, cheering Caesar's refusals of the crown; the coarse physical detail (hooting, cracked hands, sweaty caps) reveals Casca's aristocratic disgust and his refusal to credit the crowd with judgement. MCQs: 1 (c); 2 (c); 3 (b).

Extract 3 — The Falling Sickness, Greek, and Silence

EXTRACT Act 1 Scene 2 — Cassius, Casca and Brutus, continuing Casca's report

Cassius: But soft, I pray you. What, did Caesar swoon? **Casca:** He fell down in the market-place and foamed at mouth and was speechless. **Brutus:** 'Tis very like; he hath the falling sickness. **Cassius:** No, Caesar hath it not; but you and I And honest Casca, we have the falling sickness. **Casca:** I know not what you mean by that, but I am sure Caesar fell down. If the tag-rag people did not clap him and hiss him, according as he pleased and displeased them, as they use to do the players in the theatre, I am no true man. [...] **Cassius:** Did Cicero say anything? **Casca:** Ay, he spoke Greek. **Cassius:** To what effect? **Casca:** Nay, an I tell you that, I'll ne'er look you i' th' face again. But those that understood him smiled at one another and shook their heads. But for mine own part, it was Greek to me. I could tell you more news too: Marullus and Flavius, for pulling scarves off Caesar's images, are put to silence. Fare you well.

Context: Act 1 Scene 2, the tail of Casca's report. Cassius has caught the word "swooned" at the end of Extract 2 and stops Casca to ask about it. The passage runs from the fit in the market-place to the last item of Casca's news, after which Cassius invites him to supper and Casca leaves.

Speaker: Three speakers share the passage — Cassius asking, Casca reporting, Brutus interpreting — but it is Casca's prose that carries the news and Cassius's verse that carries the argument.

Listener: Each man is listening for something different. Cassius listens for ammunition; Brutus listens for facts and offers the kindest available explanation; Casca listens to himself and refuses to be drawn.

Before: Casca has just described the three refusals of the crown and Caesar's collapse — he "swooned and fell down at it". In the lines the extract omits, he adds that Caesar, seeing the crowd glad at his refusal, "plucked me ope his doublet and offered them his throat to cut", and that on recovering he asked the crowd to blame his "infirmity" — while "Three or four wenches" cried "Alas, good soul!" and forgave him.

After: Cassius asks Casca to supper "tonight" (refused: "I am promised forth") and to dinner "tomorrow" (accepted, with Casca's characteristic conditions). Casca exits; Brutus and Cassius assess him; Brutus leaves; and Cassius, alone, delivers the soliloquy that is Extract 4.

Meaning: Cassius interrupts — "But soft" (wait a moment) — to check that Caesar actually fainted. Casca confirms it plainly: Caesar fell in the market-place, foamed at the mouth and could not speak. Brutus says this is very likely ("Tis very like"), because Caesar suffers from "the falling sickness", the Elizabethan name for epilepsy. Cassius turns the diagnosis inside out: it is not Caesar who has the falling sickness, but Brutus, Cassius and "honest Casca" — meaning that they, and Rome, are the ones who have fallen, sunk into servility before one man. Casca declines to interpret the remark — he says he does not know what Cassius means — and restates the plain fact: Caesar fell. He then compares the crowd to a theatre audience: the ragged, motley ("tag-rag") people clapped and hissed Caesar exactly as they are accustomed ('use') to clap and hiss actors ('players'), depending on whether he pleased or displeased them — and if that is not so, Casca says, he is no honest man. Asked whether Cicero said anything, Casca reports that Cicero "spoke Greek". Asked what he meant, Casca refuses — if he told them that, he would never be able to look them in the face again — but notes that those who understood Cicero smiled at each other and shook their heads; for his own part, Casca says, it was Greek to him, incomprehensible. Finally, almost as an afterthought, he adds that Marullus and Flavius have been "put to silence" — silenced, removed from public voice — for stripping the decorative "scarves" from Caesar's statues.

Subtext: Cassius's pun is the most economical piece of propaganda in the act: a medical fact about Caesar is converted, in one line, into a moral indictment of everyone who lets Caesar stand over them. Brutus offers the humane reading; Cassius supplies the political one; the audience is asked to choose. Casca's "I know not what you mean by that" is left open by the text. One reading is that a blunt soldier genuinely misses the wordplay; a stronger reading is that Casca, in a public place, in the presence of a man he does not yet know to be a conspirator, is refusing to be drawn into treasonous talk — he retreats to "I am sure Caesar fell down", a fact no one can be punished for repeating. The theatre comparison carries its own sting: if the people are an audience, then Caesar is a player, and the crown scene was a performance — which is exactly what Casca has been implying. The Greek episode adds a class layer: Rome's educated elite exchanged an opinion of the show over the heads of the crowd, in a code the crowd could not break, and their smiles and head-shakes are a quiet vote of no confidence. Casca claims membership of the uneducated ("it was Greek to me"), which we may doubt, since Brutus remembers him as "quick mettle when he went to school"; the pose of philistinism is another of his masks. And then the news that ends the passage. Two tribunes — officers whose very persons were sacred — have been silenced for touching a statue, and Casca reports it in the tone of a man mentioning the weather, before saying good night. The nonchalance is the horror.

Character: Cassius: quick, bitter, opportunistic, unable to hear a fact without turning it into an argument for revolt. Brutus: literal, fair-minded, inclined to the generous explanation — the man who will later insist on the conspiracy's purity is here the man who diagnoses rather than accuses. Casca: guarded and sardonic, a witness

who mocks everything and commits to nothing — yet whose final item of news, delivered so flatly, is the most damning thing anyone says about Caesar in the scene. Caesar: physically frail, publicly humiliated, and — through the silencing of the tribunes — quietly ruthless.

Theme: Appearance versus reality (the divine Caesar foaming on the ground); public opinion and the crowd as audience; liberty against tyranny (the silenced tribunes); the body politic — a diseased Rome in Cassius's pun; the gap between the educated few and the many.

Device: Pun and wordplay on "the falling sickness" — literal epilepsy against political prostration. Extended metaphor of the theatre: crowd as audience, Caesar as player, politics as performance, which also winks at the Elizabethan audience who were themselves clapping and hissing. Euphemism and understatement in "put to silence", where the mild phrase covers an act of repression. Irony in Casca's professed ignorance of Greek. Contrast of media: Cassius's pointed verse against Casca's flat, refusing prose. And the passage coins an idiom that English still uses — 'it's all Greek to me' — which is worth knowing but not worth more than a sentence in an answer.

Historical context: HISTORICAL RECORD — Plutarch and Suetonius both record that Caesar suffered from epilepsy; modern historians debate the diagnosis, but Shakespeare took it straight from his source. Cicero was Rome's greatest orator and a lover of Greek learning; Greek was the language of philosophy and culture among the Roman elite, so Casca's detail is historically apt even though this particular moment is Shakespeare's invention. The tribunes Gaius Epidius Marullus and Lucius Caesetius Flavus really did remove a diadem from Caesar's statue and arrest men who hailed him as king, and Caesar had them deposed from office (Suetonius adds that they were expelled from the Senate). Historically this happened in January 44 BC, before the Lupercalia; Shakespeare compresses it into the same day. What "put to silence" means is left open by the play — deposition, banishment or death — and you should say so rather than choosing for Shakespeare. Remember, too, that tribunes were sacrosanct: to silence one was to strike at the office that had protected ordinary Romans for four and a half centuries.

Scene connection: This passage pays off Scene 1 exactly: Flavius ordered "Disrobe the images / If you do find them decked with ceremonies", Marullus asked nervously "May we do so?", and here is the answer. Casca's account of Caesar's fit corroborates, from a second witness, the picture of physical weakness that Cassius painted for Brutus in the fever-in-Spain story — the god who "did shake" and cried for drink "As a sick girl". Cicero's disapproving Greek prepares us for his sceptical presence in Scene 3 (Extract 5). And the theatre metaphor is the seed of Act 3 Scene 2, where the Roman crowd will be swung first one way and then the other by two orators, precisely like an audience responding to rival players.

Keywords: pun, wordplay, body politic, servility, theatre metaphor, performance, euphemism, repression, sacrosanct, corroboration, philistinism, nonchalance.

QUESTIONS Practice set — Extract 3

Read the extract above and answer the following questions.

(i) What has Casca just described happening to Caesar, and where did it happen? What explanation does Brutus give for it? What news about Marullus and Flavius does Casca add, and what had the two men done to deserve their punishment? [3]

(ii) Explain Cassius's words "No, Caesar hath it not; but you and I / And honest Casca, we have the falling sickness." In what sense do the three men have the disease? How does Casca respond to the remark? [3]

(iii) What comparison does Casca draw between the Roman crowd and the audience in a theatre? What does the comparison suggest about the crowd, and what does it suggest about Caesar? [3]

(iv) What did Cicero do at the games, according to Casca? How did those who understood him react, and what does their reaction suggest about their opinion of the day's events? What does Casca mean when he says "it was Greek to me"? [3]

(v) How does the news that Marullus and Flavius "are put to silence" connect this scene with Act 1 Scene 1? Do you think Casca's casual manner of reporting this news makes it more disturbing or less disturbing for the audience? Give a reason for your answer. [4]

Class IX-style reference to the context:

(a) "No, Caesar hath it not; but you and I / And honest Casca, we have the falling sickness." — Who says this, to whom, and in reply to what? Explain the play on words and what it reveals about the speaker's purpose.

(b) "Marullus and Flavius, for pulling scarves off Caesar's images, are put to silence." — Who reports this and to whom? Who were Marullus and Flavius, and what had they done earlier in the play? What does their fate reveal about Caesar's power?

Multiple-choice questions:

- "The falling sickness" is the Elizabethan name for (a) plague (b) epilepsy (c) fainting from hunger (d) a broken leg
- According to Casca, Cicero (a) offered Caesar the crown (b) fainted in the market-place (c) spoke in Greek (d) argued with Antony
- Casca compares the common people to (a) sheep following a shepherd (b) an audience clapping and hissing actors (c) soldiers obeying a general (d) children at a festival

MODEL ANSWER Model answer (i)

Casca has just described Caesar fainting in the market-place: he "fell down", "foamed at mouth and was speechless" after refusing the crown for the third time. Brutus explains it medically — "he hath the falling sickness", that is, epilepsy. Casca adds, as a final piece of news, that the tribunes Marullus and Flavius have been "put to silence" — silenced and stripped of their public voice — for "pulling scarves off Caesar's images", the decorations hung on Caesar's statues for the festival.

Why this answer earns marks: All four factual demands are met (the event, the place, Brutus's explanation, the tribunes' offence and fate), with the glossing of "the falling sickness" and "scarves" showing understanding rather than mere copying. The evaluator can award three marks without hesitation.

MODEL ANSWER Model answer (ii)

Cassius takes Brutus's medical explanation and turns it into a political one. Caesar, he says, does not have the falling sickness; it is the three of them who have it — because they, and all Rome with them, have fallen: they have sunk into servility, bowing before a single man. The disease is not epilepsy but the loss of Roman liberty and self-respect, and Cassius includes himself and Brutus in the diagnosis to shame them into action. Casca refuses to take the bait: "I know not what you mean by that", he says, and returns to the plain, safe fact that Caesar fell down — either because he genuinely misses the pun or, more probably, because he is too cautious to discuss treason with a man he does not yet trust.

Why this answer earns marks: The pun is explained on both levels (literal and political), the purpose of the remark is identified (to shame), and Casca's response is not only stated but interpreted with two alternatives — the candidate shows awareness that the text leaves his motive open. That is Level 3 analysis in a Level 2 question, and evaluators notice.

MODEL ANSWER Model answer (iii)

Casca says that the "tag-rag people" clapped and hissed Caesar "according as he pleased and displeased them", exactly as they are accustomed to treat "the players in the theatre". About the crowd, the comparison suggests that they are fickle, easily moved and without political judgement: they respond to a performance, moment by moment, rather than weighing what a crown for Caesar would mean for Rome. About Caesar, it suggests that he is a performer — that the refusal of the crown was a piece of acting staged for applause — and that his power rests on pleasing an audience that could turn to hissing at any moment.

Why this answer earns marks: The comparison is located precisely in the text, then applied separately to the two things the question names, with a clear consequence drawn for each. Splitting the analysis exactly as the question splits it is the simplest way to make sure every mark is visibly earned.

MODEL ANSWER Model answer (iv)

Casca reports that Cicero "spoke Greek" at the games. Casca will not say what Cicero said — he claims he could never look them in the face again if he did — but he notes that those who understood "smiled at one another and shook their heads". Their reaction suggests quiet disapproval and knowing scorn: the educated Romans recognised the crown episode for the piece of theatre it was, and exchanged their verdict in a language the crowd could not follow. When Casca says "it was Greek to me", he means that he did not understand a word of it — the origin of the modern idiom — though, since Brutus later recalls that Casca was "quick mettle when he went to school", his claim of ignorance may be another of his sardonic poses.

Why this answer earns marks: Each of the three parts is answered with the relevant words of the text, the inference about the smiles and head-shakes is spelled out rather than left implicit, and the final part adds a note of interpretation about Casca's reliability. That last touch distinguishes understanding from recall.

MODEL ANSWER Model answer (v)

In Act 1 Scene 1 the tribunes Marullus and Flavius drove the commoners from the streets and resolved to strip Caesar's statues of their decorations — Flavius ordered "Disrobe the images / If you do find them decked with ceremonies", and Marullus hesitated because it was "the feast of Lupercal". Casca's news tells us the consequence: the two men who defended the Republic's memory of Pompey have been silenced by the man they opposed. The connection completes a chain of cause and effect across the two scenes and shows Caesar acting, offstage, with a ruthlessness his public modesty conceals. In my view the casual manner makes the news more disturbing, not less. Casca drops it as "more news", between the Greek anecdote and "Fare you well", as though the silencing of two sacred officers of the people were a trivial item of gossip. The flatness tells the audience that in Caesar's Rome such acts have become ordinary, and it leaves us to supply the alarm that the speaker withholds — which is more chilling than any outcry would be.

Why this answer earns marks: Two marks come from the precise connection to Scene 1, made with quotation and an explicit statement of cause and effect; one mark from a committed judgement; one from a reason that is argued from the position and tone of the line in the speech. The answer also shows the examiner that the candidate understands what a tribune was, without turning into a history essay.

REVISION Answer key — Extract 3 (reference to the context and MCQs)

Reference to the context (a): Cassius to Brutus (and Casca), replying to Brutus's diagnosis that Caesar "hath the falling sickness"; the pun turns epilepsy into political collapse — the Romans, not Caesar, have fallen — and reveals Cassius's habit of converting every fact into a goad towards rebellion. Reference to the context (b): Casca to Brutus and Cassius, at the end of his report; Marullus and Flavius are the tribunes of Scene 1 who rebuked the commoners for celebrating Caesar's triumph and set out to strip his statues; their silencing shows Caesar's power to remove even sacrosanct officers and to punish dissent quietly. MCQs: 1 (b); 2 (c); 3 (b).

Extract 4 — Cassius Alone: "Well, Brutus, thou art noble"

EXTRACT Act 1 Scene 2 — Cassius, alone on stage, after Brutus has gone

Cassius: *Well, Brutus, thou art noble; yet I see Thy honourable mettle may be wrought From that it is disposed. Therefore it is meet That noble minds keep ever with their likes; For who so firm that cannot be seduced? Caesar doth bear me hard, but he loves Brutus. [...] I will this night, In several hands, in at his windows throw, As if they came from several citizens, Writings, all tending to the great opinion That Rome holds of his name, wherein obscurely Caesar's ambition shall be glanced at. And after this, let Caesar seat him sure, For we will shake him, or worse days endure.*

Context: The last fifteen lines of Act 1 Scene 2. Casca has left for his supper, Brutus and Cassius have exchanged their opinions of him, and Brutus has gone home with an appointment for tomorrow — "Come home to me, and I will wait for you." The stage, which began the scene crowded with a festival procession, is now empty except for one man, and he turns to the audience. This is the only soliloquy in Act 1, and the first in the play.

Speaker: Cassius — and for the first time Cassius without an audience to work on. Everything he has said so far in the scene has been said to Brutus and shaped for Brutus. Here he speaks for himself.

Listener: Nobody on stage; the audience in the theatre. The Elizabethan convention, which you can take as a working rule for this play, is that a character alone on stage tells the truth as he understands it. Soliloquy is not a lie to the audience. That is why this passage is so valuable to you: it is the one place in Act 1 where Cassius's own account of his motives and methods can be checked against what he has just been saying aloud.

Before: The long temptation of Brutus (Extracts in Part One of this training), the return of Caesar, Casca's report (Extracts 2 and 3), and then a short conversation about Casca himself: Brutus thinks him grown "a blunt fellow", Cassius defends him — "This rudeness is a sauce to his good wit" — and Brutus leaves with Cassius's parting instruction ringing: "Till then, think of the world."

After: The scene ends on a rhyming couplet, and the act's time-scheme jumps. Scene 3 opens a month later, on the stormy night before the ides of March, with Casca and Cicero (Extract 5); by its end Cassius has recruited Casca, given Cinna the forged letters to plant, and announced that Brutus is "Three parts" won. In Act 2 Scene 1 Brutus will read one of these letters in his orchard and finish it in his own head — so the plan hatched here is the plan that actually works.

Meaning: Cassius addresses the absent Brutus. 'Well, Brutus, you are noble; yet I see that your honourable nature ("mettle" — temperament, spirit; the old spelling is 'metal', and the pun on metal that can be beaten into shape is live) can be worked ("wrought") away from what it is naturally inclined to ("disposed"). Therefore it is fitting ("it is meet") that noble minds should always keep company with their own kind, because who is so firm that he cannot be led astray ("seduced")? Caesar bears a grudge against me ("doth bear me hard"), but he loves Brutus.' The two lines the extract omits make the comparison explicit: 'If I were Brutus and he were Cassius, he would not win me over ("humour me" — indulge, coax) as I am winning him.' Then the plan. 'Tonight I will throw in at his windows, in several different handwritings ("several hands"), as if they came from a number of different citizens, writings all pointing to ("tending to") the high opinion Rome holds of his name, in which Caesar's ambition will be hinted at ("glanced at") indirectly ("obscurely"). After that, let Caesar sit as securely as he likes ("seat him sure" — often glossed as a riding image, keeping one's seat in the saddle), for we will shake him — or suffer worse days.'

Subtext: Read the first sentence twice. "Thou art noble" is praise; "yet I see / Thy honourable mettle may be wrought" turns the praise into a vulnerability. Cassius admires Brutus's honour exactly as a metalworker admires good iron — for what can be made of it. The maxim that follows, "noble minds keep ever with their likes", is spoken by the man who has spent the scene making sure that Brutus does not keep with his likes but with Cassius. He knows, in other words, that he is the bad company he is warning against, and he says so without shame. The rhetorical question "who so firm that cannot be seduced?" is half boast and half philosophy: there are no incorruptible men, only men not yet worked upon. Then the comparison with Caesar — "he loves Brutus" — lets a private grievance surface for a moment: Caesar's favour goes to Brutus, not to Cassius, and the forged letters will exploit precisely the reputation that Cassius lacks and Brutus has. The plan itself is a confession. The letters will seem to come from "several citizens"; they will not; they will praise Brutus and only hint at Caesar; they are designed, that is, to make Brutus believe that Rome is asking him to act. The 'voice of the people' that persuades Brutus in Act 2 is Cassius's handwriting.

Character: This is the clearest window into Cassius in the whole play, and it shows a mind that is at once acute, resentful and self-aware. Acute, because his diagnosis of Brutus — noble, therefore malleable through his nobility — is exactly how Brutus will be moved. Resentful, because "Caesar doth bear me hard" and the imagined role-reversal betray personal wounds beneath the republican speeches. Self-aware, because he never pretends to himself that the letters are honest. Whether he is simply a cynic is a different question, and the text leaves it open. Many critics read the soliloquy as proof that the conspiracy is founded on fraud; others point to

the final line, "or worse days endure", as a sign that Cassius genuinely believes Rome's alternative is worse — a man can be a manipulator and a patriot at once. What you cannot do is read this speech and still call Cassius a straightforward idealist. For Brutus, the speech is a verdict delivered in his absence: he is a man whose virtue can be used as a handle.

Theme: Manipulation and the ethics of persuasion; honour as a weakness as well as a strength; appearance versus reality (anonymous letters that are not what they seem); friendship and its betrayal (Cassius trades on Brutus's trust); jealousy (Caesar's love for Brutus); the manufacture of public opinion.

Device: Soliloquy — the convention by which a character's private mind is made audible; in this play Shakespeare uses it sparingly, which makes each one weigh more. Apostrophe — Cassius addresses the absent Brutus directly — "thou art noble" — in the familiar form that sounds intimate and is here faintly predatory. Metaphor of metalwork in "mettle may be wrought", with the pun on 'metal'; metaphor of seduction in "seduced", which casts the political persuasion as a courtship; a riding or sitting image in "seat him sure". Rhetorical question ("who so firm...?"). Antithesis in "Caesar doth bear me hard, but he loves Brutus". The closing rhyming couplet ("sure" / "endure") is the Elizabethan signal that a scene is ending, and the hard rhyme gives the threat the sound of a decision already taken. Finally, dramatic irony of the deepest kind: for the rest of the play the audience knows what Brutus does not — that the letters he will read in Act 2 were written here.

Historical context: HISTORICAL RECORD — Plutarch's *Life of Brutus* reports that anonymous messages appeared in Rome urging Brutus to act: on the statue of his ancestor Lucius Junius Brutus, who had driven out the last king in 509 BC, and on the praetor's tribunal where Brutus sat as urban praetor in 44 BC, with words to the effect of 'Brutus, are you asleep?' and 'You are no true Brutus'. Plutarch presents these as the work of citizens who wanted Brutus to lead; it is Shakespeare who makes Cassius their forger. That change is the whole point of the soliloquy, and you should be able to name it. HISTORICAL RECORD also explains "bear me hard": in 44 BC both men were praetors, but Brutus received the more prestigious urban praetorship, and the ancient sources treat Cassius's disappointment as a real grievance. "Several hands" would have been a practical detail for an Elizabethan audience used to letters as the main medium of political intrigue — forged correspondence was a known weapon in the politics of the 1590s, though you should not claim that Shakespeare had any particular case in mind.

Scene connection: Backwards, the soliloquy explains the scene you have just watched: the mirror image ("I, your glass"), the Tiber story and the Colossus were not spontaneous but the opening moves of the man who now plans the next ones. Forwards, it is the hinge of the whole conspiracy plot. Scene 3 shows the letters handed to Cinna ("look you lay it in the praetor's chair... throw this / In at his window; set this up with wax / Upon old Brutus' statue") — the same three delivery points that Plutarch gives for the real messages. Act 2 Scene 1 shows a letter read and misread by Brutus. And the question Cassius raises — whether honourable men can be honourably persuaded by a lie — hangs over Brutus's claim in Act 2 and Act 3 that the conspirators act purely, and over the quarrel between the two men in Act 4. Caesar's judgement in Extract 1, that Cassius "thinks too much", is here confirmed by the thinking itself.

Keywords: soliloquy, convention, manipulation, forgery, malleable, exploit, grievance, self-aware, cynical, idealist, dramatic irony, couplet, pretext.

PROFESSOR'S INSIGHT Why the only soliloquy in Act 1 belongs to Cassius

Shakespeare could have given Brutus the first soliloquy — the troubled man "with himself at war" is the obvious candidate, and he gets one at the start of Act 2. Instead the first private voice the audience hears is the manipulator's, and the choice shapes how you watch everything after it. Once you have heard Cassius plan the letters, you cannot see Brutus read one in his orchard without knowing it is forged; Brutus's most solemn moment of decision is, for the audience, a moment of being deceived. That is dramatic irony used not for a single laugh or shock but as a structural condition of the play. A second effect concerns sympathy. Soliloquy usually draws an audience towards a character — we are trusted with his secrets — and yet the secret here is a plan to deceive a friend. The result is a peculiar double feeling that the whole tragedy depends on: we are inside Cassius's intelligence and outside his morality at once. Weak answers call the speech 'evil'. Strong answers notice that it is lucid, that its diagnosis of Brutus is correct, and that its last line admits fear of "worse days" — and then argue about what that mixture means. An examiner marking a [4] question on this passage is rewarding exactly that willingness to hold two judgements together with evidence for each.

QUESTIONS Practice set — Extract 4

Read the extract above and answer the following questions.

- (i) Where is Cassius, and why is he alone? What has he just arranged with Brutus for the following day? What opinion of Casca has Brutus just expressed, and how has Cassius answered it? [3]
- (ii) Explain in your own words the lines "Thy honourable mettle may be wrought / From that it is disposed." What does Cassius mean by "noble minds keep ever with their likes", and why is it ironic that he should say so? [3]
- (iii) What plan does Cassius announce in this speech? Mention three details of how the "Writings" are to be prepared and what they are to contain. [3]
- (iv) What does the line "Caesar doth bear me hard, but he loves Brutus" reveal about Cassius's motives? How does the rest of the speech show that Cassius intends to make use of Caesar's love for Brutus? [3]
- (v) A soliloquy lets the audience hear what a character really thinks. What do we learn here about Cassius that Brutus does not know? In your opinion, is Cassius acting mainly out of patriotism or mainly out of personal resentment? Give a reason for your answer, with reference to the text. [4]

Class IX-style reference to the context:

- (a) "Well, Brutus, thou art noble; yet I see / Thy honourable mettle may be wrought / From that it is disposed." — Who speaks these lines and in what circumstances? Explain their meaning. What do they reveal about the speaker's view of the person addressed?
- (b) "And after this, let Caesar seat him sure, / For we will shake him, or worse days endure." — Who says this? What is meant by "this"? Explain the lines and comment on their position in the scene.

Multiple-choice questions:

- Cassius plans to throw writings in at Brutus's windows "In several hands" in order to (a) make the letters easier to read (b) make them seem to come from many different citizens (c) save time (d) hide his own poor handwriting
- According to Cassius, the writings will refer to Caesar's ambition (a) openly and directly (b) not at all (c) "obscurely" (d) in Greek
- The speech ends with (a) a question (b) a stage direction (c) a prose sentence (d) a rhyming couplet

MODEL ANSWER Model answer (i)

Cassius is still in the public place in Rome where the Lupercal procession passed; he is alone because Casca has gone off to his supper and Brutus has just left for home. Brutus has agreed to speak further with Cassius tomorrow — he will either come to Cassius's house or receive him at his own: "Come home to me, and I will wait for you." Just before leaving, Brutus remarked that Casca had grown "a blunt fellow", though he "was quick mettle when he went to school"; Cassius answered that Casca is still quick in carrying out "any bold or noble enterprise", and that his rough manner, "this tardy form", is only a sauce that makes men digest his words with better appetite.

Why this answer earns marks: The candidate places Cassius exactly, gives the reason for his solitude, states the arrangement with a short quotation, and reports both halves of the exchange about Casca. Four facts for three marks leaves a margin for safety.

MODEL ANSWER Model answer (ii)

Cassius means that Brutus's honourable nature — his temperament or spirit, with a pun on metal that can be hammered into a new shape — can be worked upon and bent away from what it naturally inclines to. In other words, Brutus's very nobility makes him capable of being led into something he would not choose on his own. By "noble minds keep ever with their likes" Cassius means that noble men should associate only with other noble men, since anyone, however firm, can be led astray by the wrong company. The irony is that Cassius himself is the wrong company: he has spent the whole scene drawing Brutus away from his 'likes' and towards a conspiracy, so he is describing, as a general truth, the very thing he is doing to Brutus.

Why this answer earns marks: Both lines are paraphrased in plain English with the key words glossed, and the irony is not merely asserted but explained by pointing to what Cassius has actually been doing. The pun on 'metal' is a bonus that shows close reading without taking over the answer.

MODEL ANSWER Model answer (iii)

Cassius plans to forge letters to Brutus and deliver them that night. First, he will write them "In several hands" — in different handwritings — so that they appear to come from "several citizens" rather than from one man. Second, he will throw them "in at his windows" so that they reach Brutus anonymously (in Scene 3 we learn of two further delivery points: the praetor's chair and old Brutus's statue). Third, their contents will dwell on "the great opinion / That Rome holds of his name" — flattering Brutus with Rome's regard — while Caesar's ambition is only hinted at "obscurely", so that Brutus will feel that Rome is calling him to act against Caesar without being told so outright.

Why this answer earns marks: The plan is named at once, and three distinct details are separated and each tied to a quoted phrase and its purpose. Explaining why each detail is there (anonymity, the appearance of a public voice, indirect suggestion) shows understanding of the method, which is what the question is really testing.

MODEL ANSWER Model answer (iv)

The line reveals that Cassius's hostility to Caesar is partly personal. Caesar "doth bear me hard" — holds a grudge against him, treats him coldly — while he "loves Brutus"; the contrast carries a note of jealousy and wounded pride that sits beneath Cassius's talk of liberty. In the lines that follow Cassius imagines the roles reversed — if he were Brutus and Caesar's favourite, Cassius would not be able to work on him — which shows that he sees Caesar's love as the very thing that makes Brutus valuable and vulnerable. He then designs the letters to exploit it: they will appeal to Brutus's reputation, "the great opinion / That Rome holds of his name", using the public respect that Caesar's favour has helped to build in order to turn Brutus against the man who favours him.

Why this answer earns marks: The motive is inferred from the exact words and named precisely (grudge, jealousy), and the second part follows the logic of the speech from the role-reversal to the letters, showing how the love is to be used. The candidate reads the speech as an argument, not a list of statements.

MODEL ANSWER Model answer (v)

We learn that Cassius knows exactly what he is doing to Brutus and does not believe his own flattery: he regards Brutus's honour as something that "may be wrought", he admits that his persuasion is a kind of seduction, and he intends to deceive him with forged letters written in "several hands" so that Brutus will mistake one man's plot for the voice of Rome. Brutus knows none of this; he believes he is being spoken to by an honest friend and, in Act 2, will believe he is being summoned by his fellow citizens. In my opinion Cassius acts mainly out of personal resentment, though not only that. The soliloquy, where he has no reason to pretend, gives his grievance in the plainest words of the scene — "Caesar doth bear me hard, but he loves Brutus" — and his earlier speeches to Brutus kept returning to his own humiliation, "Cassius is / A wretched creature and must bend his body". Yet the last line, "or worse days endure", shows a real fear for Rome's future, so the fairest conclusion is that private resentment supplies the energy and republican principle supplies the justification.

Why this answer earns marks: The first part separates what the audience knows from what Brutus knows, with three pieces of evidence. The second part commits to a view, supports it with two quotations from different parts of the scene, and then acknowledges the counter-evidence without surrendering the position. That balanced, text-based judgement is exactly what the [4] evaluative mark is for.

REVISION Answer key — Extract 4 (reference to the context and MCQs)

Reference to the context (a): Cassius, alone on stage at the end of Act 1 Scene 2 after Brutus has left; he judges that Brutus's honourable nature can be worked upon and bent away from its natural inclination, and the lines reveal that he admires Brutus's nobility chiefly as a weakness to be exploited. Reference to the context (b): Cassius; "this" is the planting of forged letters in Brutus's windows that night; once the letters have done their work, Caesar may sit as securely as he likes, for the conspirators will topple him or else suffer worse times under him. The rhyming couplet closes the scene and the act's first movement, sealing the plan with the sound of a decision. MCQs: 1 (b); 2 (c); 3 (d).

Extract 5 — Casca and Cicero in the Storm: "men may construe things after their fashion"

EXTRACT**Act 1 Scene 3 — Casca to Cicero, in a street at night, with thunder and lightning**

Casca: *Are not you moved, when all the sway of earth Shakes like a thing unfirm? O Cicero, I have seen tempests when the scolding winds Have rived the knotty oaks, and I have seen Th' ambitious ocean swell and rage and foam To be exalted with the threat'ning clouds; But never till tonight, never till now, Did I go through a tempest dropping fire. Either there is a civil strife in heaven, Or else the world, too saucy with the gods, Incenses them to send destruction. [...]*

Cicero: *Indeed, it is a strange-disposèd time. But men may construe things after their fashion, Clean from the purpose of the things themselves.*

Context: The opening of Act 1 Scene 3. The stage direction calls for thunder and lightning, and the scene begins with Cicero meeting Casca in the street and asking two questions: whether he has brought Caesar home, and why he is breathless and staring. Casca's reply is the first speech of the extract. A month has passed since Scene 2 without the play saying so — Cicero's question a few lines later, "Comes Caesar to the Capitol tomorrow?", fixes this as the night before the ides of March.

Speaker: Casca, then Cicero. Notice at once that Casca speaks verse. In Scene 2 he was the only noble who spoke prose — flat, mocking, refusing to be impressed. Here, in the storm, he speaks in elevated blank verse full of personification and alliteration. The text does not explain the change; many critics read it as fear stripping away his pose, others as Shakespeare using the register the scene needs regardless of consistency. Either way, you should notice it and be ready to comment on it.

Listener: Cicero — Rome's greatest orator and a man of learning, who in Scene 2 was reported to have spoken Greek at the games and to have looked at Caesar with "ferret and such fiery eyes". He is the only character in Act 1 who hears a list of omens and declines to interpret it. He leaves before Cassius arrives and plays no further part in the conspiracy; when Cassius later proposes recruiting him in Act 2, Brutus will refuse.

Before: Scene 2 ended with Cassius's soliloquy and the plan of the forged letters (Extract 4). Between the scenes, offstage and unmentioned, the letters have presumably begun their work — by the end of this scene Cassius will say that Brutus is "Three parts" won. Casca's bringing Caesar home tells us he has been in Caesar's company that evening, which is how he knows that Caesar has sent word to Cicero about tomorrow.

After: Cicero asks whether Casca has seen anything "more wonderful", and Casca gives his catalogue of prodigies: a slave whose left hand "did flame and burn / Like twenty torches joined" without being scorched; a lion met "Against the Capitol" which "went surly by" without harming him; a hundred terrified women who swore they saw "Men all in fire walk up and down the streets"; and "the bird of night" — the owl — sitting at noon in the market-place, "Hooting and shrieking". He insists that when such prodigies "conjointly meet" no one should say they are natural: "I believe they are portentous things / Unto the climate that they point upon." Cicero answers with the two lines that close the extract, asks about tomorrow, remarks that this "disturbèd sky / Is not to walk in", and goes. Cassius enters, and the scene turns into Extract 6.

Meaning: Casca asks Cicero whether he is not shaken when the whole established order of the earth ('sway' — rule, dominion, balance) shakes like something unsteady ('unfirm'). He has seen storms in which scolding winds split ('rived') the gnarled ('knotty') oaks, and he has seen the ocean, ambitious to climb, swell and rage and foam as if to be raised up ('exalted') to the level of the threatening clouds; but never until tonight has he walked through a storm that rains fire. He offers two explanations, both supernatural: either the gods are fighting one another — "a civil strife in heaven" — or the world has grown so insolent ('saucy') towards the gods that it has provoked ('Incenses') them to send destruction. After the catalogue of omens, Cicero replies with careful courtesy: yes, it is a strangely ordered ('strange-disposèd') time; but men may interpret ('construe') things according to their own inclination ('after their fashion'), completely apart from ('Clean from') what the things themselves actually mean ('the purpose of the things themselves').

Subtext: Casca's two explanations are both political metaphors wearing religious dress. "Civil strife in heaven" is civil war among the gods — and civil war is exactly what Rome has just lived through and is about to live through again. A world "too saucy with the gods" is a world in which a man has risen too high — and Cicero, who looked at Caesar with fiery eyes, does not need to be told who. Casca never names Caesar in this scene until Cassius forces him to, but his storm is already a political storm. Cicero's reply is the subtlest moment in Act 1, and you must get it right. He does not say the omens mean nothing; he does not say the time is ordinary — "Indeed, it is a strange-disposèd time" grants Casca his alarm. What he says is that the meaning men find in such things is their own: a frightened man reads a storm as a threat, an ambitious man as an opportunity, a conspirator as a summons. Within a hundred lines Cassius will prove him right by reading the

same storm as a portrait of Caesar and a licence to act. Cicero's lines are therefore a warning placed exactly before the thing they warn against — and they are also, a strong reading suggests, Shakespeare's instruction to the audience about how to watch the rest of the play: everyone in it construes, and the construing is the tragedy.

Character: Casca here is frightened, superstitious and eloquent — a different man from the sneering prose-speaker of Scene 2, or the same man with the mask off. The fear is real: he has not put up his sword, he is breathless, he reasons from the omens to a coming catastrophe. Yet it is this frightened man whom Cassius, minutes later, will recruit by shaming him for his fear. Cicero is the detached intellectual: courteous, sceptical, unwilling to be hurried into meaning, and at the same time practical — his real interest is whether Caesar goes to the Capitol tomorrow. His scepticism is admirable and also, within the play, useless; he sees clearly and does nothing, and Shakespeare removes him from the stage before the conspiracy forms. Caesar, who never appears in the scene, is present in every image: the fire from the sky, the lion at the Capitol, the owl at noon.

Theme: Superstition and omens against reason and scepticism; fate and free will (do the prodigies foretell, or do men make them foretell?); appearance versus reality in its sharpest form — the gap between things and the meanings men give them; the disorder of nature mirroring disorder in the state; fear as the raw material of politics.

Device: Pathetic fallacy and the Elizabethan doctrine of correspondences — the storm in the heavens matches the coming storm in the state, a pattern Shakespeare uses again in *Macbeth* and *King Lear*. Personification throughout: "scolding winds", "Th' ambitious ocean", a sky that drops fire, gods who are incensed. Alliteration binds the pictures together — "swell and rage and foam", "Shakes like a thing unfirm". Hyperbole and accumulation in the catalogue of prodigies ('twenty torches', 'a hundred ghastly women'). Rhetorical question in the opening line. Antithesis in Cicero's couplet — things against the construing of things, their "purpose" against men's "fashion" — expressed as an aphorism, a compact general truth that stands apart from the scene and can be quoted alone. Dramatic irony: Cicero's warning against misconstruction is immediately followed by the play's great misconstruer, Cassius. And the shift from prose to verse in Casca is itself a device of register, if you choose to read it so.

Historical context: HISTORICAL RECORD — Plutarch and other ancient writers list portents before Caesar's death: lights in the sky, strange noises at night, birds of ill omen in the Forum, and the memorable detail of men on fire who were not burned; Shakespeare's catalogue draws on this stock of prodigies and adds the lion. Cicero's historical reputation fits his lines here — he was Rome's most famous orator and a writer on philosophy, including a work on divination that treats the reading of omens with scepticism — though you should not claim that Shakespeare had read it. The real Cicero was not a conspirator; he welcomed Caesar's death but was not told of the plot in advance, and he was killed on the orders of the triumvirs in December 43 BC. The ELIZABETHAN CONTEXT also matters: audiences in 1599 lived with a widespread belief that disorder in the heavens signalled disorder in the state, and with real anxiety about the succession to an ageing, childless queen. Audiences may have felt the storm as more than scenery. The dating is Shakespeare's compression: Scene 3 is the night of 14 March 44 BC, and the Capitol to which Caesar is to come tomorrow is Shakespeare's relocation of an assassination that historically took place in the Curia of Pompey.

Scene connection: Backwards, Casca's fear completes the picture of him begun in Scene 2 — the cynic was never as untouched as he pretended — and Cicero's smiling, head-shaking Greek is here translated into plain Latin: he distrusts how people read things. Forwards, within the scene, Cassius will take the identical prodigies and construe them "after their fashion" as a description of Caesar (Extract 6). In Act 2 Scene 1 Brutus will read a forged letter and construe it as the voice of Rome; in Act 2 Scene 2 Calpurnia and Caesar will construe the

same night's omens in opposite ways, and Decius Brutus will reinterpret Calpurnia's dream to lure Caesar out; in Act 3 Scene 2 Antony will construe Caesar's wounds for the crowd. Cicero's couplet is the key that opens every one of those scenes.

Keywords: omen, prodigy, portent, superstition, scepticism, construe, interpretation, pathetic fallacy, correspondences, aphorism, register, detachment, foreboding.

PROFESSOR'S INSIGHT

Cicero's two lines are the most useful sentence in Act 1 for a Class X candidate

No extract from this scene will appear in your board paper, but Cicero's remark will serve you in almost any Act 3–5 answer that touches interpretation, deception or the crowd — and most of them do. Consider how often the later play turns on someone construing: Brutus reading a forged letter as Rome's plea; Decius Brutus turning Calpurnia's dream of blood into a vision of Rome revived; Antony turning a corpse into an argument; the plebeians turning a poet named Cinna into a conspirator because of his name; Cassius, at Philippi, reading the birds over his army as a sign of doom. A candidate who can write 'Shakespeare has already warned us through Cicero in Act 1 that men may construe things after their fashion' and then show how a later character does exactly that has demonstrated two things evaluators prize: knowledge of the whole play, and a grasp of the design behind the plot. Be careful with the quotation. It is often misremembered as 'construe things after their own fashion' — the word 'own' is not there. Learn the two lines exactly, and learn where they come from: Cicero, to Casca, in the storm, the night before the ides. A misattributed quotation earns less than no quotation at all, because it tells the evaluator that the candidate is working from memory of a summary rather than from the text.

QUESTIONS Practice set — Extract 5

Read the extract above and answer the following questions.

- (i) Where does this scene take place, and at what time of day? How much time has passed since the previous scene, and how does the audience learn this? What two questions has Cicero asked Casca just before Casca speaks? [3]
- (ii) Explain in your own words Casca's two explanations for the storm in the lines "Either there is a civil strife in heaven, / Or else the world, too saucy with the gods, / Incenses them to send destruction." How might each explanation be applied to the political situation in Rome? [3]
- (iii) In the lines omitted from the extract, Casca describes several "prodigies". Describe any three of them. What conclusion does Casca draw from the fact that they "conjointly meet"? [3]
- (iv) Explain Cicero's words "men may construe things after their fashion, / Clean from the purpose of the things themselves." How does Cicero's attitude to the storm differ from Casca's? [3]
- (v) How does Cassius, later in the same scene, prove Cicero's remark true? Do you think Shakespeare wants the audience to share Casca's fear or Cicero's scepticism? Give a reason for your answer, with reference to what happens later in the play. [4]

Class IX-style reference to the context:

- (a) "Are not you moved, when all the sway of earth / Shakes like a thing unfirm?" — Who asks this question and of whom? What is the occasion? Explain the lines and comment on the change in the speaker's manner since we last saw him.
- (b) "But men may construe things after their fashion, / Clean from the purpose of the things themselves." — Who says this, to whom, and in response to what? Explain the meaning of the lines and their importance for the play as a whole.

Multiple-choice questions:

1. Casca says that he has never before experienced a tempest (a) with thunder (b) at night (c) "dropping fire" (d) at the Capitol
2. Which of the following is NOT one of the prodigies Casca reports? (a) a slave's hand burning without being scorched (b) a lion near the Capitol (c) an owl in the market-place at noon (d) a comet over the Tiber
3. Cicero's response to Casca's account of the omens is best described as (a) terrified (b) sceptical and detached (c) angry (d) enthusiastic

MODEL ANSWER Model answer (i)

The scene takes place in a street in Rome, at night, during a violent storm of thunder and lightning. About a month has passed since the Lupercal of Scene 2: the audience learns this not from any announcement but from Cicero's question "Comes Caesar to the Capitol tomorrow?", which fixes the night as the eve of the ides of March, the date the Soothsayer named. Cicero has just asked Casca whether he brought Caesar home — "Brought you Caesar home?" — and why he is breathless and staring so.

Why this answer earns marks: Place, time and weather are given; the time-gap is both stated and explained from the text, which is what 'how does the audience learn this' demands; and both of Cicero's questions are reported, one with the exact words. The link to the Soothsayer shows that the candidate sees the act as a whole.

MODEL ANSWER Model answer (ii)

Casca offers two supernatural explanations. The first is that there is "a civil strife in heaven" — the gods themselves are at war with one another, and the storm on earth is the overflow of their quarrel. The second is that the world has become "too saucy with the gods" — so insolent and presumptuous towards them — that it has provoked them into sending destruction as punishment. Applied to Rome, the first explanation mirrors the civil wars that have torn the Republic — Caesar against Pompey, and the new division now forming between Caesar's friends and his enemies — so that heaven's civil strife reflects Rome's. The second fits Caesar himself: a man who has risen above his fellow citizens, is treated as a god and is about to be offered a crown may be the 'sauciness' that has angered heaven — or, from Caesar's side, the insolence could be the plotting against him. Casca does not name Caesar, but both explanations point towards him.

Why this answer earns marks: Each explanation is paraphrased with its key word glossed, and each is then mapped onto Rome in a specific way, with the candidate noting that the second explanation can cut either way. That final caution shows the evaluator that the candidate is reading, not forcing, the political parallel.

MODEL ANSWER Model answer (iii)

Casca reports that a common slave held up his left hand, which "did flame and burn / Like twenty torches joined", yet the hand felt no fire and "remained unscorched"; that near the Capitol he met a lion, which "glazed upon me and went surly by" without attacking him; that a hundred terrified women, "Transformèd with their fear", swore they had seen "Men all in fire walk up and down the streets"; and that the previous day "the bird of night" — the owl — sat in the market-place at noon, "Hooting and shrieking". From the fact that these prodigies all occur together — "conjointly meet" — Casca concludes that no one should dismiss them as natural events with natural causes; he believes they are "portentous things", omens of disaster for the region or country ("the climate") towards which they point.

Why this answer earns marks: Four prodigies are described accurately (more than the three asked for), each with the detail that makes it strange, and the conclusion is given in Casca's own logic — the coincidence of the signs, not any single sign, is what convinces him. Glossing "the bird of night" and "climate" shows the candidate understands the words rather than copying them.

MODEL ANSWER Model answer (iv)

Cicero means that people interpret events according to their own temperament and wishes, and that the meaning they find may be entirely different from — "Clean from" — the true nature or purpose of the events themselves. A storm is simply a storm; a frightened man makes it a threat, a hopeful man a promise. His attitude differs from Casca's in two ways. Casca is certain that the prodigies are messages from the gods and reasons straight from them to coming destruction; Cicero grants that the time is strange — "Indeed, it is a strange-disposed time" — but refuses to say what, if anything, it means. And where Casca is overwhelmed by fear, Cicero remains detached and practical, turning at once to the real question of the night: whether Caesar will come to the Capitol tomorrow.

Why this answer earns marks: The aphorism is explained in plain language with a concrete illustration, and the contrast is drawn on two axes — belief and temperament — each supported by a phrase from the extract. Separating 'what he thinks' from 'how he behaves' gives the answer the structure that makes three marks easy to award.

MODEL ANSWER Model answer (v)

As soon as Cicero has gone, Cassius enters and reads the identical storm in the opposite way. Where Casca sees "dreadful heralds" sent by the gods to make men "fear and tremble", Cassius calls it "A very pleasing night to honest men", claims to have bared his breast to the lightning, and then construes the whole night as a portrait of one man — a man who "thunders, lightens, opens graves, and roars / As doth the lion in the Capitol" — so that the omens become an argument for killing Caesar. The same facts, a different fashion of construing: Cicero's warning is proved true within minutes. In my view Shakespeare wants the audience to hold both responses rather than choose. The omens are not empty — Caesar does die on the ides, and the Soothsayer is right — so Casca's fear is justified by events; but the play also shows, again and again, men bending signs to their own purposes, as Decius Brutus bends Calpurnia's dream in Act 2 and Antony bends Caesar's wounds in Act 3, so Cicero's scepticism about interpreters is justified too. The portents are real; the readings of them are human and fallible. That is why the play puts the two speeches side by side.

Why this answer earns marks: The first part answers 'how' with specific quotations from Cassius and a clear statement of the reversal. The second part takes a position that is argued rather than merely chosen, and supports it from two different acts of the play, which is exactly what 'with reference to what happens later' invites. A candidate who simply picked Casca or Cicero would earn less than one who explains why the play needs both.

REVISION Answer key — Extract 5 (reference to the context and MCQs)

Reference to the context (a): Casca to Cicero, in the street on the stormy night before the ides of March; he asks how Cicero can remain unmoved when the whole order of the earth shakes like something unsteady. The sneering prose-speaker of Scene 2 now speaks fearful, elevated verse — the pose of indifference has gone. Reference to the context (b): Cicero to Casca, after Casca's catalogue of prodigies and his insistence that they are portents; Cicero replies that men read events according to their own inclinations, often quite apart from what the events actually mean. The lines foreshadow the whole play's pattern of misinterpretation — Cassius reading the storm, Brutus reading the letters, Caesar and Calpurnia reading the omens, the crowd reading Antony. MCQs: 1 (c); 2 (d); 3 (b).

Extract 6 — Cassius Wins Casca: "Be factious for redress of all these griefs"

EXTRACT

Act 1 Scene 3 — Cassius and Casca, in the storm, after Casca has agreed that every bondman can cancel his captivity

Cassius: *And why should Caesar be a tyrant, then? Poor man, I know he would not be a wolf But that he sees the Romans are but sheep; He were no lion, were not Romans hinds. Those that with haste will make a mighty fire Begin it with weak straws. What trash is Rome, What rubbish, and what offal when it serves For the base matter to illuminate So vile a thing as Caesar! [...]* **Casca:** *You speak to Casca, and to such a man That is no fleering telltale. Hold. My hand. Be factious for redress of all these griefs, And I will set this foot of mine as far As who goes farthest.*

Context: Act 1 Scene 3, roughly its middle. Cicero has gone; Cassius has entered, identified Casca "by your voice", and spent some sixty lines turning the storm into an argument. The extract begins at the moment Cassius's argument reaches its sharpest point and ends with Casca's handshake. The lines between the two speeches — Cassius's pretended alarm at having spoken treason before "a willing bondman", and his declaration "But I am armed, / And dangers are to me indifferent" — are discussed below under **Meaning:**.

Speaker: Cassius, then Casca. This is the Cassius of the soliloquy now at work on his second victim, and because we have heard the soliloquy we can watch the method rather than be taken in by it.

Listener: Casca — the frightened man of Extract 5, whom Cassius has already told "You are dull, Casca" and accused of lacking "those sparks of life / That should be in a Roman". The shaming has prepared him: a man told that his fear is un-Roman will be eager to prove his courage.

Before: Cassius has told Casca that he walked bareheaded and unbuttoned ("unbracèd") through the storm and offered his chest to the lightning. He has then redirected the omens: heaven has made these monstrous things "instruments of fear and warning / Unto some monstrous state", and there is a man "Most like this dreadful night" who is "no mightier than thyself or me / In personal action, yet prodigious grown". Casca has guessed the name — "'Tis Caesar that you mean, is it not, Cassius?" — and reported the rumour that the senators mean tomorrow to make Caesar king everywhere "save here in Italy". Cassius has answered with the speech of the dagger: he knows where he will wear it, "Cassius from bondage will deliver Cassius", and no tower, wall, dungeon or chain "Can be retentive to the strength of spirit", for life can always "dismiss itself". Casca has agreed: "So every bondman in his own hand bears / The power to cancel his captivity."

After: Cassius declares "There's a bargain made" and tells Casca that he has already moved "Some certain of the noblest-minded Romans" to join an enterprise "Of honourable-dangerous consequence", and that they wait for him at "Pompey's Porch". Cinna arrives; Cassius gives him the forged papers to plant in "the praetor's chair", "In at his window" and "Upon old Brutus' statue"; and the scene ends with Casca's speech about Brutus — "that which would appear offence in us / His countenance, like richest alchemy, / Will change to virtue and to worthiness" — and Cassius's resolve to "be sure of him" before day.

Meaning: 'Then why should Caesar be a tyrant at all?' Cassius asks — if every man can free himself by his own hand, Caesar's power exists only because men allow it. 'Poor man, I know he would not be a wolf, except that he sees the Romans are nothing but sheep; he would be no lion if Romans were not deer ('hinds' — female deer, timid prey; the word could also mean peasants or servants, and both senses sting). Those who want to

make a great fire quickly start it with weak straws. What trash Rome is, what rubbish and what refuse ('offal' — waste, the discarded parts of a carcass), when it serves as the base, worthless fuel ("base matter") to light up and make glorious ("illuminate") so vile a thing as Caesar!' In the omitted lines Cassius checks himself with a show of alarm: 'But O grief, where have you led me? Perhaps I am saying this in front of a man who is content to be a slave ("a willing bondman"); then I know I shall have to answer for it ("My answer must be made"). But I am armed, and dangers mean nothing to me.' Casca replies: 'You are speaking to Casca, and to the kind of man who is no sneering ("fleering" — grinning, mocking) tell-tale. Here — my hand. Form a party ("Be factious" — be active in raising a faction) to put right ("redress") all these grievances, and I will go as far as the man who goes farthest.'

Subtext: The argument has a hidden pivot. Up to this point Cassius has attacked Caesar; here he turns and attacks Rome — and, by implication, Casca. Caesar is only a wolf because the Romans are sheep; he is only a lion because Romans are deer; Rome is trash, rubbish, offal. The insult is the recruitment. If Casca is not to be one of the sheep, he must do something, and the only something on offer is the conspiracy. The fire image carries a second, quieter meaning: Caesar's blaze was kindled with "weak straws", that is, with the acquiescence of worthless men — but Cassius is also, at this very moment, kindling a fire of his own, and he too begins with the weak material to hand, a frightened man in a storm. Then the pretended retreat: "But, O grief, / Where hast thou led me?" — as if passion had carried him into treason unawares. Nothing in Cassius is unaware. The feigned slip is a test, and it is also bait: it offers Casca the dignity of reassuring a brave man. "But I am armed" closes the trap — Cassius dares Casca to betray him, which no Roman who has just been called a sheep can now do. Casca's reply gives Cassius exactly what the trap was built to extract: not merely silence ("no fleering telltale") but commitment — the hand, and the promise to go "As who goes farthest". Casca does not ask what the enterprise is. He has joined it before it has been described.

Character: Cassius: the master persuader in his most aggressive mode — contemptuous, theatrical, calculating. With Brutus in Scene 2 he flattered and reasoned; with Casca he shames and dares. The difference tells you that Cassius tailors his method to the man, which is the mark of the true manipulator. Yet his contempt for Rome — "What trash is Rome" — sounds too furious to be entirely tactical; many readers hear real disgust, and the line raises a question the play never settles: does Cassius love Rome, or only hate Caesar's Rome? Casca: proud, impulsive, more courageous than his fear suggested, and politically shallow — he pledges himself to go farthest without asking where. His speech has the directness of a soldier ("Hold. My hand."), and history confirms the portrait: it was Casca who struck the first blow on the ides. Caesar, absent again, is described as a "Poor man" — a sarcasm that nonetheless admits something true: Caesar's power is a relationship, not a possession, and it depends on the people who consent to it.

Theme: Tyranny and its causes — the ruled as much as the ruler; liberty and servitude ("bondman", "yoke", "captivity"); manipulation and persuasion; honour and manliness as levers of politics; public opinion (Rome as "base matter"); conspiracy as a bargain between men.

Device: Animal imagery — the wolf and sheep, the lion and hinds — a pair of antitheses that reduce the political question to predator and prey, and that answer Casca's own lion at the Capitol in Extract 5. Extended metaphor of fire: Caesar's greatness is a blaze, Rome the "weak straws" and "base matter" that fuel it; the metaphor is also an unwitting self-portrait of the conspiracy being lit before our eyes. Accumulation and rhetorical escalation in "What trash... / What rubbish, and what offal", with the climax "So vile a thing as Caesar!" Rhetorical question in the opening line. Apostrophe and feigned self-interruption — "But, O grief, / Where hast thou led me?" — a calculated pause that is itself a persuasive device. Sarcasm in "Poor man". Alliteration in "fleering telltale"; the heavily stressed monosyllables of "Hold. My hand." mark the gesture of the oath. And a stage picture: two men clasping hands in a lightning storm, which the audience reads without a word being needed.

Historical context: HISTORICAL RECORD — Publius Servilius Casca Longus was a real conspirator and, according to the ancient sources, the first to strike Caesar; he became tribune in 43 BC and died after Philippi. The rumour Casca has just reported — that Caesar was to be given the title of king everywhere outside Italy — appears in the ancient biographers as talk circulating in Rome before the ides; whether any such proposal was really to be put to the Senate is uncertain, and Shakespeare treats it as hearsay ("they say"). "Pompey's Porch" is the portico of the Theatre of Pompey, built in 55 BC, part of the complex in whose Senate-house Caesar was actually killed — so the conspirators in the play meet, unknowingly, at the real scene of the crime, which Shakespeare has moved to the Capitol. The historical Cassius was an Epicurean, a philosophy sceptical of divine signs; the Cassius of this scene reads the storm as a message, though he does so for Casca's benefit rather than his own. Cassius's claim that "life, being weary of these worldly bars, / Never lacks power to dismiss itself" reflects the Stoic admiration for suicide as the final freedom — LITERARY INTERPRETATION notes that it also quietly foretells how both he and Brutus will die after Philippi in 42 BC.

Scene connection: Backwards, the wolf-and-sheep argument is the Colossus argument of Scene 2 re-made for a cruder listener: there Cassius said "we petty men / Walk under his huge legs"; here the petty men are sheep and deer. "The fault, dear Brutus, is not in our stars, / But in ourselves" is the philosophical form of what "the Romans are but sheep" says with contempt. Forwards, Casca's handshake and his promise to go farthest are honoured in Act 3 Scene 1, where he strikes first; and Cassius's confession that he may have spoken before "a willing bondman" is echoed in the conspirators' later fear of betrayal. The alchemy speech that follows this extract — Brutus's reputation turning the conspiracy's "offence" into "virtue" — states the reason Brutus is needed and the fatal assumption behind the whole plot: that a good name can make a killing good. Antony will test that assumption to destruction in Act 3 Scene 2.

Keywords: tyranny, servility, bondman, predator and prey, animal imagery, fire metaphor, base matter, feigned, bait, recruitment, impulsive, bargain, alchemy, reputation.

QUESTIONS Practice set — Extract 6

Read the extract above and answer the following questions.

- (i) Who has just left the stage before Cassius enters, and what has Casca just agreed with Cassius about what "every bondman" can do? What rumour about the Senate's plans for the following day has Casca reported? [3]
- (ii) Explain in your own words the lines "Poor man, I know he would not be a wolf / But that he sees the Romans are but sheep; / He were no lion, were not Romans hinds." What is Cassius saying about the cause of Caesar's power? [3]
- (iii) Explain the image of the fire in "Those that with haste will make a mighty fire / Begin it with weak straws." What does Cassius mean by calling Rome "trash", "rubbish" and "offal"? Why does he insult Rome rather than Caesar at this point? [3]
- (iv) In the lines omitted from the extract, Cassius pretends to fear that he has spoken too freely. What does he say, and what does he hope to gain by saying it? How does Casca's reply show that the tactic has worked? [3]
- (v) After this extract, Casca says of Brutus that "that which would appear offence in us / His countenance, like richest alchemy, / Will change to virtue and to worthiness." Explain what Casca means. Do you think the conspirators are right to believe that Brutus's reputation will protect them? Give a reason for your answer, with reference to the play. [4]

Class IX-style reference to the context:

- (a) "What trash is Rome, / What rubbish, and what offal when it serves / For the base matter to illuminate / So vile a thing as Caesar!" — Who speaks these words and to whom? What is the occasion? Explain the lines and say what they reveal about the speaker's state of mind.
- (b) "Be factious for redress of all these griefs, / And I will set this foot of mine as far / As who goes farthest." — Who says this and to whom? What has just been said to provoke this reply? Explain the lines and say what they reveal about the speaker.

Multiple-choice questions:

1. Cassius says Caesar would not be a wolf if the Romans were not (a) lions (b) sheep (c) wolves themselves (d) eagles
2. Casca describes himself as a man who is no (a) "willing bondman" (b) "fleering telltale" (c) "common slave" (d) "noble Roman"
3. According to Cassius, the other conspirators are waiting for him at (a) the Capitol (b) Brutus's house (c) "Pompey's Porch" (d) the market-place

MODEL ANSWER Model answer (i)

Cicero has just left the stage, having told Casca that the "disturbèd sky / Is not to walk in". Cassius has argued that a man can always free himself from tyranny by his own hand, since no prison "Can be retentive to the strength of spirit" and life can dismiss itself at will; Casca has agreed that "every bondman in his own hand bears / The power to cancel his captivity" — every slave carries in his own hand the means to end his slavery. Casca has reported the rumour that the senators mean tomorrow to make Caesar a king, so that he will wear his crown "by sea and land / In every place save here in Italy".

Why this answer earns marks: Three separate facts are required and all three are given, each anchored in the text; the paraphrase of the "bondman" line shows understanding of the argument Casca has accepted, and the rumour is reported with its crucial qualification about Italy. Nothing is vague.

MODEL ANSWER Model answer (ii)

Cassius says, with heavy sarcasm in "Poor man", that Caesar would never behave like a wolf — a predator preying on the city — if he did not see that the Romans behave like sheep, timid and obedient; and he would be no lion if the Romans were not deer, creatures made to be hunted. In other words, the cause of Caesar's power is not Caesar's strength but the Romans' weakness. A tyrant exists only because his subjects consent to be ruled; take away the sheep and there is nothing for the wolf to be. This is the practical conclusion of the argument Casca has just accepted — that every bondman can cancel his own captivity — turned into an accusation against the Romans, and by implication against Casca himself.

Why this answer earns marks: The two animal pairs are unpacked separately and the tone ("Poor man") is noticed, which shows attention to how the lines are spoken, not only what they say. The second part states Cassius's thesis in one clear sentence and connects it to the preceding argument, demonstrating that the candidate follows the logic of the whole speech.

MODEL ANSWER Model answer (iii)

The fire image means that anyone who wants to build a great blaze quickly starts it with weak, worthless material — dry straw catches at once. Applied to Rome, Caesar's greatness is the "mighty fire", and the Romans are the "weak straws" whose easy compliance has set it alight. Cassius then intensifies the image: Rome is "trash", "rubbish" and "what offal" — waste, refuse, the discarded parts of a butchered animal — because it has let itself be used as "base matter", cheap fuel, whose only function is to make Caesar shine. He insults Rome rather than Caesar at this point because his purpose is recruitment, not analysis: abusing Caesar would merely invite agreement, whereas abusing Rome forces Casca to decide whether he is one of the sheep, the straws, the rubbish. The insult leaves Casca only one way to prove that he is not — to act.

Why this answer earns marks: The image is explained first literally and then in its application, the three nouns are glossed rather than repeated, and the final part answers a 'why' question with Cassius's strategy, supported by the effect the insult has in the scene. Reading the rhetoric as a tactic is the mark of a Level 3 answer.

MODEL ANSWER Model answer (iv)

Cassius exclaims "But, O grief, / Where hast thou led me?" as though his passion had carried him into treason without his noticing, and says that perhaps he has spoken "Before a willing bondman" — a man content with slavery — in which case he knows he will have to answer for his words; but he is armed, and "dangers are to me indifferent". He hopes to gain two things. The pretended slip tests Casca — if Casca were likely to betray him, his reaction would show it now — and it dares him: a man who has just been called a sheep cannot bear to be taken for a "willing bondman", and so is pushed to prove his courage. Casca's reply shows the tactic has worked completely: he protests that he is "no fleeing telltale", offers his hand as a pledge, and promises to go "As who goes farthest" in redressing Rome's grievances — all before Cassius has told him what the enterprise is.

Why this answer earns marks: The omitted lines are reported accurately and in order, the purpose is analysed on two levels (test and dare), and Casca's response is read not merely as agreement but as proof of the specific effect Cassius intended, with the telling observation that Casca commits himself blind. Each part earns its mark visibly.

MODEL ANSWER Model answer (v)

Casca means that Brutus is so loved and respected by the people — "he sits high in all the people's hearts" — that his support, his very face or approval ("countenance"), will transform the conspiracy in the public eye. What would look like a crime ("offence") if the others did it alone will, with Brutus's name attached, appear as virtue and worthiness, just as the alchemist was believed to turn base metal into gold. The image admits that the deed is base; only Brutus can gild it. In my view the conspirators are wrong to rely on this, and the play says so. Brutus's reputation does protect them briefly — the crowd in Act 3 Scene 2 is ready to honour him after his speech — but the same reputation leads Brutus to insist on sparing Antony and letting him speak, and Antony turns the "honourable" Brutus into a byword for betrayal within a single oration. Reputation can change how a deed looks; it cannot change what the deed is, and once Antony shows the crowd Caesar's body, no alchemy holds. Casca's image, meant as reassurance, is in fact the conspiracy's fatal miscalculation stated in advance.

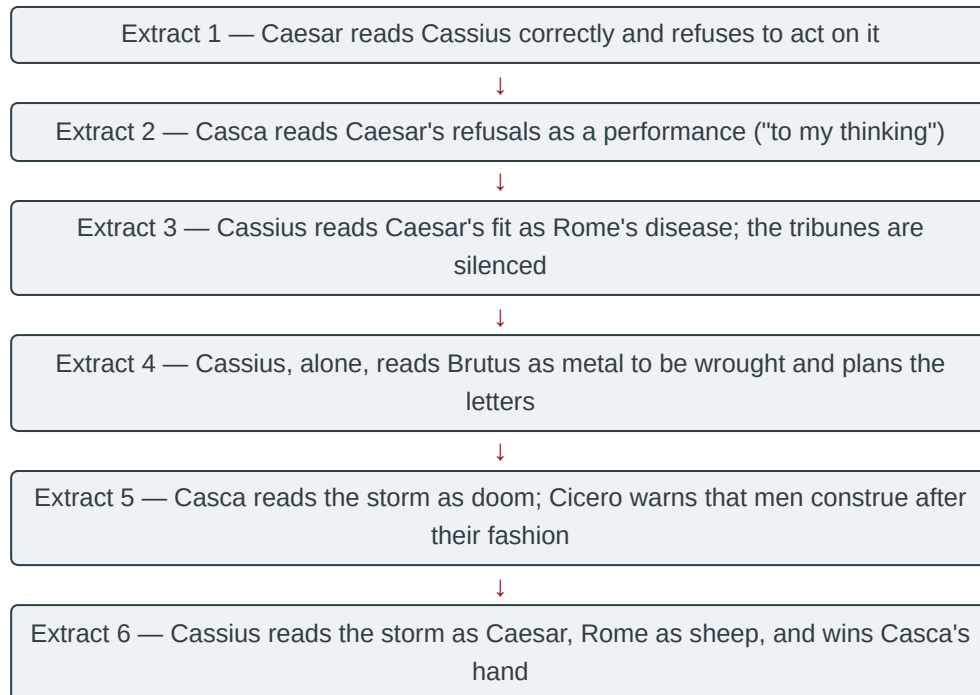
Why this answer earns marks: The image is explained with its key words glossed and its implication drawn out (the deed is admitted to be base). The opinion is clear, and the reason is argued from the course of the play with specific reference to Act 3, acknowledging the short-term truth of Casca's claim before showing its long-term failure. That is an evaluative answer anchored in evidence, which is what the [4] demands.

REVISION Answer key — Extract 6 (reference to the context and MCQs)

Reference to the context (a): Cassius to Casca, in the storm on the night before the ides, after Casca has agreed that every bondman can free himself; Cassius turns from attacking Caesar to abusing Rome as worthless fuel that exists only to make Caesar glorious. The lines reveal a mind in a state of bitter, contemptuous passion — real or performed or both — in which disgust at Rome's servility is at least as strong as hatred of Caesar. Reference to the context (b): Casca to Cassius, replying to Cassius's pretended fear that he has spoken treason before "a willing bondman"; Casca pledges his hand and his full commitment to any faction formed to right Rome's wrongs, promising to go as far as the boldest. The lines reveal pride, impulsive courage and political shallowness — he commits before he knows the plan. MCQs: 1 (b); 2 (b); 3 (c).

Using the Six Extracts Together

You have now worked through the six passages that carry the second half of Scene 2 and the whole of Scene 3. Before you close the chapter, see them as one design rather than six exercises, because the questions that earn most — the [4] questions here, and the Act 3–5 questions in the board paper that reach back to Act 1 — reward exactly that kind of seeing.



Every link in that chain is an act of interpretation, and most of them are wrong, biased or self-serving. That is not an accident of the extracts I chose; it is the subject of these two scenes. Caesar misreads his own safety; Casca misreads, or at least slants, the crown; Cassius deliberately misreads everything for others while reading Brutus with perfect accuracy for himself; and Cicero, the one man who names the problem, walks off into the night. When a question asks you what Act 1 'prepares' or 'foreshadows', this is the deepest honest answer: it prepares a play in which the characters will keep construing — a letter, a dream, a corpse, a name, a flight of birds — and will keep dying of their constructions.

ICSE EXAM BOX Three habits to carry out of this chapter

First, the fact-opinion split. Whenever a passage is reported rather than shown — the crown, the fit, the Greek, the senators' plan for a crown outside Italy — write 'according to Casca' or 'Casca says' before the fact and 'in Casca's view' before the opinion. It costs you four words and it is the single most reliable signal of a careful reader that an evaluator can receive. Second, the soliloquy test. When you are asked what a character 'really' thinks or wants, go first to any soliloquy — in Act 1 that means Cassius's — and quote it, because a soliloquy is the one kind of evidence whose sincerity the convention guarantees. Third, the construing sentence. Learn Cicero's two lines exactly, know who says them to whom and when, and practise attaching them to a later scene in one sentence. None of this guarantees a particular question; all of it raises the quality of whatever answer you write, in Class IX on Act 1 itself and in Class X on the acts that Act 1 makes possible.

CROSS-REFERENCE Where to go next

The full scene-by-scene teaching behind these extracts is in 'Act 1 Scene 2 (Part Two) — Caesar Returns, Casca Reports, Cassius Plots' and 'Act 1 Scene 3 — The Storm: Omens, Fear and the Conspiracy Takes Shape'. Cassius's methods across both scenes are treated as a single system in 'Cassius — The Manipulation Masterclass'. The omens, fate and superstition raised by Extracts 5 and 6 belong to 'Themes of Act 1 (Part Two)'. For the way the forged letters, the handshake and the alchemy speech pay off in Acts 2 to 5, use 'The Scene Connection Engine and Where Act 1 Reappears Later'. And when a word in these extracts still stops you — 'unbracèd', 'thews', 'retentive', 'conceited' — the chapter 'Difficult Shakespearean English: The Act 1 Vocabulary System' is built for exactly that.

REVISION Twelve-line revision card for Extracts 4–6

Extract 4: Cassius alone; "Thy honourable mettle may be wrought"; "who so firm that cannot be seduced?"; "Caesar doth bear me hard, but he loves Brutus"; letters "In several hands" from "several citizens", Caesar's ambition "glancèd at"; couplet "seat him sure" / "worse days endure"; Plutarch's citizens' messages become Cassius's forgeries. Extract 5: night before the ides, a month after Scene 2; Casca in verse, afraid; "a tempest dropping fire"; "civil strife in heaven" or a world "too saucy with the gods"; prodigies — burning hand, lion, men in fire, owl at noon; Cicero: "men may construe things after their fashion, / Clean from the purpose of the things themselves". Extract 6: wolf and sheep, lion and hinds; "weak straws"; "What trash is Rome"; feigned alarm before "a willing bondman"; "But I am armed"; Casca: "no fleering telltale", "Hold. My hand.", "Be factious for redress of all these griefs"; Pompey's Porch; Cinna and the three letter-points; alchemy — Brutus's "countenance" turns "offence" to "virtue".

CHAPTER 20

Difficult Shakespearean English: The Act 1 Vocabulary System

What this chapter does: it takes the single biggest obstacle between you and this play, the language itself, and turns it into a system you can operate. Part 1 teaches the grammar that makes Shakespeare sound foreign (thou, hath, wherefore, inverted word order, missing words) using only Act 1 examples. Part 2 is a scene-by-scene word bank of every genuinely difficult word or phrase in Act 1. Part 3 exposes the 'false friends', words that look modern but mean something else. Part 4 shows you, step by step, how a trained reader decodes three real passages, and then asks you to do it yourself. By the end, Shakespearean English should feel less like a wall and more like a lock you have the key to.

Before You Begin: Three Kinds of Difficulty, One Method

Let us be honest about what has been going wrong since Class 9. You open the play, you meet a line such as "What dost thou with thy best apparel on?", and something in your brain switches off. It is not because you are weak at English. It is because you are meeting three different problems at once and nobody has separated them for you.

Problem one is grammar. Shakespeare wrote in what scholars call Early Modern English, the English of roughly 1500 to 1700. It is *not* Old English (that is the language of *Beowulf*, and no untrained modern reader can follow a word of it). Early Modern English is our own language with a slightly different engine: a second set of pronouns (thou, thee, thy), extra verb endings (hath, doth, dost), question words that have since died (wherefore), and a freer word order. Once you know the engine, the sentences start moving.

Problem two is vocabulary. Some words have simply gone (awl, neat's leather, coronet). Others are still alive but have changed their meaning, and these are far more dangerous, because they do not look difficult. When Cassius tells Brutus "be not jealous on me", he is not talking about envy. When Casca says the lion went by "Without annoying me", he does not mean the lion was mildly irritating. Part 3 of this chapter is devoted entirely to these traps.

Problem three is compression. Shakespeare wrote most of this play in blank verse, ten-syllable lines with a regular beat. Verse forces a writer to pack meaning tightly: to leave out small words, to put the important word where the beat falls, and to use one metaphor where prose would use a paragraph. So even when you know every word, a line like "The fault, dear Brutus, is not in our stars, / But in ourselves, that we are underlings" asks you to unpack a whole theory of human responsibility from two lines.

The method. For the rest of this book, and for every Shakespeare passage you ever meet in an examination, read in three passes.

PASS 1 — Read to the punctuation, not to the line-end. Read aloud if you can. Get the shape of the sentence.



PASS 2 — Find the main verb. Then ask 'who is doing this?' Rebuild the subject-verb-object order in your head.



PASS 3 — Swap the old forms (thou → you, hath → has, wherefore → why) and unpack the metaphor. Only now translate.

Never translate word by word. Translate sentence by sentence. A word-by-word reader of "Set honour in one eye and death i' th' other" produces nonsense; a sentence-by-sentence reader sees a man weighing two things at once and choosing to look at both without flinching.

One more encouragement before we begin. If you speak Hindi, Urdu, Bengali, Marathi, Tamil or almost any other Indian language, you already possess an instinct that modern English has lost: you know that the word for 'you' changes depending on how close you are to the person and how much respect you owe them. Shakespeare's English had exactly that instinct. You are, in this one respect, better equipped to read him than a native speaker of modern English.

Part 1: The Grammar of Shakespeare's English

1.1 Thou, thee, thy, thine, ye and you: the second person

Modern English has one word, *you*, for everybody: one person or twenty, a friend or a judge. Shakespeare's English had two sets, and the choice between them was meaningful.

Form	Grammatical job	Modern equivalent	Act 1 example
thou	subject, one person	you	"Speak, what trade art thou?" (Flavius to the Carpenter)
thee	object, one person	you	"I rather tell thee what is to be feared" (Caesar to Antony)
thy	possessive, before a consonant	your	"Where is thy leather apron and thy rule?" (Marullus)
thine	possessive, before a vowel or standing alone	your, yours	Not used in Act 1. The same rule governs <i>mine</i> : Casca says "mine honest neighbours" and "mine own part" because the next word begins with a vowel or an <i>h</i> .
thyself	reflexive, one person	yourself	"A man no mightier than thyself or me" (Cassius to Casca)
ye	subject, several people (older form)	you (all)	"Ye gods, it doth amaze me" (Cassius; the Folger text prints "You gods")
you	several people, OR one person addressed politely	you	"Brutus, I do observe you now of late." (Cassius)

Original word: thou / thee / thy. **Simple meaning:** you / you / your, addressed to one person. **Contextual meaning:** the *familiar* or *downward* form, used to a child, a servant, a close friend, a lover, a god in prayer, or an inferior one wishes to put in his place. **Modern equivalent:** the nearest living English equivalent is a first name or a nickname used where a title would be expected; in Hindi the parallel is *tu* or *tum* against *aap*. **Why it matters:** every time a Shakespearean character chooses *thou* rather than *you*, he is telling the audience what he thinks of the person in front of him. It is a stage direction hidden inside the grammar.

Original word: you / ye. **Simple meaning:** you, addressed to several people, or to one person with respect.

Contextual meaning: the *polite* or *level* form between equals, and the form owed to superiors. **Modern equivalent:** plain modern *you*, but carrying the weight that *Sir* or *Madam* carries today. **Why it matters:** because it is the default among the Roman nobles, the moments when a noble drops into *thou* stand out sharply.

WHAT THE SWITCHING SIGNALS IN ACT 1

The distinction is not rigid. By 1599 it was already loosening, and Shakespeare uses it flexibly, sometimes for metre. But in Act 1 the pattern is consistent enough to teach, and it rewards attention.

The tribunes and the workmen (Scene 1). Flavius opens the play with a plural: "Hence! Home, you idle creatures, get you home!" That *you* is simply plural, aimed at the whole crowd. But the moment he singles out one man, he drops to *thou*: "Speak, what trade art thou?" Marullus does the same to the Carpenter, "Where is thy leather apron and thy rule?", and then, interestingly, begins with the polite form to the Cobbler: "You, sir, what trade are you?" Watch what happens as the Cobbler's puns test his patience. Marullus's next line is "But what trade art thou? Answer me directly." The pronoun has dropped from *you* to *thou* in the space of two speeches, and the insult follows at once: "What trade, thou knave? Thou naughty knave, what trade?" (the Folger text gives this to Flavius; some editions give it to Marullus) and "Mend me, thou saucy fellow?" The grammar tracks the temperature. The Cobbler, by contrast, never once says *thou* to a tribune. He says "Nay, I beseech you, sir, be not out with me." He knows his place, even while he mocks it.

Cassius and Brutus (Scene 2). Through their whole long conversation, Cassius addresses Brutus as *you*: "Brutus, I do observe you now of late", "Tell me, good Brutus, can you see your face?", "I know that virtue to be in you, Brutus". Brutus answers in kind: "Into what dangers would you lead me, Cassius". These are two senators, equals, speaking with the courtesy of their class. **LITERARY INTERPRETATION:** the polite pronoun is part of Cassius's method. He is flattering a proud man, and flattery requires distance and deference. Then Brutus leaves, and Cassius is alone: "Well, Brutus, thou art noble. Yet I see / Thy honourable mettle may be wrought / From that it is disposed." Now, for the first time, Brutus is *thou* and *thy*. Two readings are available, and the text does not choose between them. One is that soliloquy conventionally uses *thou* for an absent person, as a poet addresses the moon. The other, sharper reading is that Cassius, with Brutus gone, drops the mask of deference and speaks of his friend as a thing to be handled, a piece of metal to be "wrought". A good answer can mention both.

Caesar and everyone else (Scene 2). Caesar says *thou* to the Soothsayer, "What sayst thou to me now?", which is a great man speaking down to a nobody. He says *thou* to Antony as well: "As thou dost, Antony", "I rather tell thee what is to be feared", "tell me truly what thou think'st of him". Here the downward pronoun means something different: intimacy from a superior, the tone of a commander to a trusted lieutenant. Antony, for his part, answers "Caesar, my lord" and never presumes to *thou* him back. Notice, too, that Caesar addresses his own wife with the formal pronoun, "Stand you directly in Antonius' way", which is a public order, not a private word. And in Cassius's remembered story of the Tiber, Caesar the young man says "Dar'st thou, Cassius, now / Leap in with me into this angry flood": the *thou* of a dare between young rivals, which Cassius, decades later, still resents.

Cassius and Casca (Scene 3). Cassius mostly says *you* to Casca, even when he is scolding him: "You are dull, Casca". But at the emotional peak of his speech, when he is about to name Caesar without naming him, he shifts: "Now could I, Casca, name to thee a man / Most like this dreadful night" and "A man no mightier than thyself or me". **LITERARY INTERPRETATION:** the pronoun closes the distance at exactly the moment Cassius needs Casca to feel like a fellow conspirator rather than an acquaintance. Once the bargain is struck he returns to the level form: "Now know you, Casca, I have moved already".

Thou to the gods, to abstractions and to Rome. Prayer and apostrophe (speaking to something that cannot answer) take *thou*. Cassius cries "Age, thou art shamed! / Rome, thou hast lost the breed of noble bloods!" and, to his own grief, "But, O grief, / Where hast thou led me?" This is not disrespect; it is the intimacy of a man speaking to what he loves or fears.

PROFESSOR'S INSIGHT The pronoun is a stage direction

A modern reader skims over *thou* and *you* as if they were the same word in two spellings. An Elizabethan audience heard them as we hear a change of tone. The nearest modern experience is a conversation in Hindi in which someone who has been calling you *aap* suddenly says *tu*: everyone in the room notices, and everyone understands that something has happened, whether it is affection, anger or contempt. Shakespeare had this instrument and used it constantly. In Act 1 it lets him do three things without adding a single word of dialogue. It ranks people: the tribunes are above the workmen, Caesar is above everyone, and the grammar says so before any insult is spoken. It measures anger: Marullus's slide from "You, sir" to "thou knave" is a temper rising in real time. And it exposes hypocrisy: Cassius says *you* to Brutus's face and *thou* to his back. When you write about Cassius's manipulation (see the chapter 'Cassius — The Manipulation Masterclass'), this grammatical detail is exactly the kind of textual evidence that separates a competent answer from an excellent one, because it shows you have read the words rather than the summary.

1.2 Verb endings: art, hast, dost, hath, doth and the -est / -eth system

Shakespeare's verbs carried endings that modern English has dropped. The rule is simple once stated.

- After **thou**, the verb takes **-est** or **-st**: thou art, thou hast, thou dost, thou think'st, thou dar'st, thou mean'st, thou sayst, thou wilt, thou shalt.
- After **he** / **she** / **it**, the verb could take **-eth**: he hath, he doth. But by 1599 the modern **-s** ending had already won for almost every other verb. In Act 1 Caesar says of Cassius "He thinks too much", "He reads much", "He loves no plays", "he hears no music", "Seldom he smiles". Not one of these is *thinketh* or *readeth*. The old ending survives in Act 1 only in *hath* and *doth*, which were so common that they resisted change.

Original word	Simple meaning	Contextual meaning (Act 1)	Modern equivalent	Why it matters
art	are (with thou)	"Thou art a cobbler, art thou?"; "Age, thou art shamed!"	you are	Recognising <i>art</i> as a form of <i>to be</i> unlocks half the questions in Scene 1.
hast	have (with thou)	"Rome, thou hast lost the breed of noble bloods!"; "Where hast thou led me?"	you have	Do not confuse it with <i>haste</i> ("in haste"), which sits two lines away in Scene 3.
dost	do (with thou)	"What dost thou with thy best apparel on?"; "As thou dost, Antony"	you do	Often a plain helping verb in questions: 'What are you doing with...?'
sayst, think'st, dar'st, mean'st	say, think, dare, mean (with thou)	"What sayst thou to me now?"; "what thou think'st of him"; "Dar'st thou, Cassius"; "What mean'st thou by that?"	you say, think, dare, mean	The apostrophe marks a swallowed <i>e</i> ; the word is one syllable for the metre.
wilt, shalt	will, shall (with thou)	Not used in Act 1; common later in the play and throughout Shakespeare	you will, you shall	Learn them now so they do not ambush you in Acts II to V.

Original word	Simple meaning	Contextual meaning (Act 1)	Modern equivalent	Why it matters
hath	has	"he hath the falling sickness"; "What hath proceeded worthy note today"; "heaven hath infused them with these spirits"	has	Six times in Act 1. Simply read <i>has</i> and move on.
doth	does	"When he doth run his course"; "he doth bestride the narrow world"; "Caesar doth bear me hard"	does	Eight times in Act 1. Often it is just a metrical helper: "he doth bestride" means 'he bestrides'.
-eth	third-person ending	Absent from Act 1 apart from <i>hath</i> and <i>doth</i>	-s	Proof that Shakespeare's grammar is closer to yours than it first appears.

The 'do' that means nothing. Modern English uses *do* for questions, negatives and emphasis. Shakespeare also used it as a neutral filler to complete the metre. When Cassius says "Brutus, I do observe you now of late" or Brutus says "I do lack some part / Of that quick spirit that is in Antony" or "I do fear the people / Choose Caesar for their king", the *do* adds no emphasis at all. Read straight through it: *I observe, I lack, I fear*. Equally, Shakespeare could leave *do* out where we would need it: "the eye sees not itself" (we would say *does not see*), "Knew you not Pompey?" (*Did you not know*), "I know not what you mean" (*I do not know*), "Fear him not, Caesar" (*Do not fear him*). Once you stop expecting *do* where it is missing and stop hearing emphasis where it is present, a surprising number of lines become ordinary sentences.

1.3 Question words and direction words: wherefore, hence, hither, thither, whence, whither

Modern English keeps *where*, *here* and *there* and adds prepositions to them: *from where*, *to here*, *to there*. Shakespeare's English had single words for each of these jobs, and one of them, *wherefore*, is the most misread word in the whole of Shakespeare.

Original word	Simple meaning	Contextual meaning (Act 1)	Modern equivalent	Why it matters
wherefore	why, for what reason	"Wherefore rejoice?"; "But wherefore art not in thy shop today?"; "But wherefore do you hold me here so long?"; "But wherefore did you so much tempt the heavens?"	why	Four times in Act 1, and it never means <i>where</i> . Marullus's "Wherefore rejoice?" is not asking for a location but demanding a justification for the entire holiday.
hence	away from here; from this time or cause	"Hence! Home, you idle creatures, get you home!"	get away from here	The first word of the play is an order to disperse. The tribunes' whole project is to send the crowd <i>hence</i> ; the whole play's tragedy is that crowds cannot be sent away for long.
hither	to here	Not used in Act 1	(come) here	Common later in the play and elsewhere in Shakespeare.
thither	to there	Not used in Act 1	(go) there	Pairs with <i>hither</i> .
whence	from where	Not used in Act 1	where from	Often survives in the redundant modern phrase 'from whence'.

Original word	Simple meaning	Contextual meaning (Act 1)	Modern equivalent	Why it matters
whither	to where	Not used in Act 1	where to	Distinguish it from <i>whether</i> , which Flavius contracts to "whe'er".
whereof, wherein, therein	of which, in which, in that	"By means whereof this breast of mine hath buried / Thoughts of great value"; "wherein obscurely / Caesar's ambition shall be glanced at"; "Therein, you gods, you make the weak most strong"	of which, in which, in that respect	These compounds glue long sentences together. Split them: <i>where + of = of which; there + in = in that</i> .
where (meaning 'instances in which')	that, in cases where	"I have heard / Where many of the best respect in Rome ... Have wished that noble Brutus had his eyes"	I have heard that	An Elizabethan use that trips students who expect a place.

1.4 Small words with big jobs

These are the words that make a Shakespearean sentence *sound* archaic. Individually each is trivial; together they are the accent of the play. Learn them once and they stop being noise.

Original word	Simple meaning	Contextual meaning (Act 1)	Modern equivalent	Why it matters
ere	before	"But ere we could arrive the point proposed"; "ere day / We will awake him"	before	Never confuse with <i>e'er</i> (ever) or <i>err</i> (make a mistake).
yon, yond, yonder	that, over there	"Yond Cassius has a lean and hungry look"; "swim to yonder point"	that (one) over there	Caesar's <i>yond</i> is a pointing finger: he is looking at Cassius from a distance and judging him by his shape.
anon	soon, at once	Not used in Act 1	in a moment	Standard Shakespearean; learn it for later acts.
nay	no	"Nay, I beseech you, sir, be not out with me."; "Nay, an I tell you that, I'll ne'er look you i' th' face again."	no	Often opens a correction: 'no, listen...'
ay	yes	"Ay, do you fear it?"; "Ay, marry, was 't"; "Ay, he spoke Greek."	yes	Pronounced like <i>I</i> . Cassius's "Ay, do you fear it?" seizes on Brutus's admission instantly.
prithee, I pray you, I beseech you	please (I pray thee)	<i>Prithee</i> is not used in Act 1. Its full forms are: "I pray you, do."; "But soft, I pray you."; "Nay, I beseech you, sir"	please; I beg you	<i>Beseech</i> is stronger and humbler than <i>pray</i> : the Cobbler begs, Cassius merely requests.
'tis, 'twas	it is, it was	"'Tis just."; "'Tis very like; he hath the falling sickness."; "'twas not a crown neither; 'twas one of these coronets"	it is, it was	The apostrophe replaces the dropped <i>i</i> . Read straight through.
o'er, e'er, ne'er	over, ever, never	<i>O'er</i> and <i>e'er</i> are not used in Act 1; "I'll ne'er look you i' th' face again"	over, ever, never	One-syllable squeezes for the metre.

Original word	Simple meaning	Contextual meaning (Act 1)	Modern equivalent	Why it matters
wh'e'er	whether	"See wh'e'er their basest mettle be not moved."	whether	The Folger contraction; the MIT text prints <i>whether</i> . Same word, same meaning.
i' th', th'	in the, the	"Set honour in one eye and death i' th' other"; "Th' eternal devil"	in the, the	Swallowed vowels; the line still scans as ten syllables.
'em	them	"conjure with 'em"	them	Casual, as in modern speech.
on 't, was 't	of it, was it	"I am glad on 't."; "Ay, marry, was 't"	of it, was it	<i>On</i> often means <i>of</i> in Shakespeare ("jealous on me" = suspicious of me).
ha'	have	"I ha' not since put up my sword"	have	Casca, breathless, swallows the consonant.
marry	indeed, why yes (originally an oath 'by Mary')	"Ay, marry, was 't"; "Marry, before he fell down"	indeed; well, actually	A prose speaker's filler; Casca uses it twice. Nothing to do with weddings.
an	if	"An I had been a man of any occupation"; "Nay, an I tell you that"	if	Not the article. If <i>an</i> is followed by a clause, read <i>if</i> .
aught	anything	"If it be aught toward the general good"	anything	Opposite is <i>naught</i> (nothing).
lief	gladly, willingly	"I had as lief not be as live to be / In awe of such a thing as I myself."	I would just as soon	'I had as lief X as Y' = 'I would as willingly X as Y'.
fain	gladly	"he would fain have had it"	he would gladly have taken it	Casca's whole cynical reading of Caesar rests on this one word.
durst	dared	"I durst not laugh"	dared not	Past tense of <i>dare</i> .
whiles	while, as long as	"Whiles they behold a greater than themselves"	while	An extra s, nothing more.
soft	wait, hold on	"But soft, I pray you. What, did Caesar swoon?"	wait a moment	An interjection, not the adjective.
yea	yes, indeed, even	"yea, to chimney tops"	even, indeed	Marullus piles up the list: walls, battlements, towers, windows, <i>even</i> chimney tops.
withal	besides, moreover; with	"but withal I am indeed, sir, a surgeon to old shoes"	in addition	The Cobbler puns: <i>withal</i> sounds like <i>with awl</i> , the tool of his trade.
save	except	"In every place save here in Italy"	except	Not the verb <i>rescue</i> .
but	only, merely	"Where Brutus may but find it"; "If Caesar carelessly but nod on him"	just, only	When <i>but</i> sits before a verb, test <i>only</i> before <i>however</i> .
still	always, continually	"still as he refused it the rabblement hooted"	every time	Not <i>nevertheless</i> and not <i>motionless</i> .

Original word	Simple meaning	Contextual meaning (Act 1)	Modern equivalent	Why it matters
like	likely	""Tis very like"; "as this time / Is like to lay upon us"	likely	Brutus's ""Tis very like" means 'that is very probable'.
wont, use	accustomed	"as I was wont to have"; "as they use to do the players in the theatre"	used to	<i>Use</i> as a verb of habit is the origin of modern 'used to'.

1.5 Inversion: when the words come in the wrong order

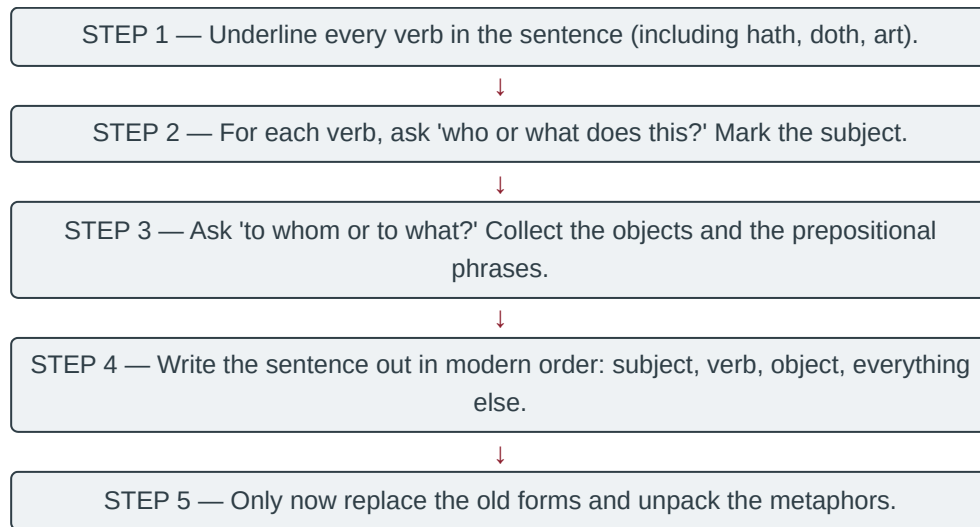
Modern English is strict about order: subject, verb, object. Elizabethan English was freer, partly because its grammar was closer to Latin, partly because verse needs flexibility to put the strong word on the strong beat. There are four patterns you need to recognise in Act 1.

Pattern A: questions without 'do'. The verb simply moves in front of the subject. "Knew you not Pompey?" is 'Did you not know Pompey?'. "Comes Caesar to the Capitol tomorrow?" is 'Is Caesar coming...?'. "Brought you Caesar home?" is 'Did you bring...?'. "Why, saw you anything more wonderful?" is 'Did you see...?'. "Are not you moved" is 'Are you not moved'. **Method:** find the verb at the front, put a modern *did* or *is* before the subject, and the question reappears.

Pattern B: the emphatic word first. Brutus says "Vexèd I am / Of late with passions of some difference." The modern order is 'I am vexed of late'; Shakespeare moves *vexed* to the front because the vexation is the news. Cassius says "Accoutred as I was, I plungèd in": the fact that he was fully dressed and armed comes first because it is the point of the boast. Marullus says "Many a time and oft / Have you climbed up to walls and battlements": the adverb of frequency is thrown to the front and the verb follows it before the subject, as still happens in formal English ('Never have I seen...'). Cassius's "Then must I think you would not have it so" works the same way: *then* comes first, so *must* leaps ahead of *I*. And Caesar's "And therefore are they very dangerous" puts *are* before *they* because *therefore* has taken the front seat.

Pattern C: the verb pushed to the end. This is the Latin habit, and Cassius, the most rhetorical speaker in Act 1, uses it at his grandest moment: "I, as Aeneas, our great ancestor, / Did from the flames of Troy upon his shoulder / The old Anchises bear". The verb *bear* arrives last, after the subject, the comparison, the place, the manner and the object have all been laid out. Then comes "so from the waves of Tiber / Did I the tired Caesar", where the verb is not even repeated: you are meant to supply *bear* from the line before. Similarly, in his soliloquy Cassius says "I will this night / In several hands in at his windows throw, / As if they came from several citizens, / Writings", holding the object, *Writings*, back for two whole lines so that the listener feels the scheming before learning what is being thrown.

Pattern D: the phrase 'this our Caesar'. "Upon what meat doth this our Caesar feed / That he is grown so great?" Modern English would say 'this Caesar of ours'. Elizabethan English could stack a demonstrative and a possessive together. The effect is contemptuous familiarity: *this Caesar of ours*, as one might say *this little dictator of ours*.



Practise on "Did I the tired Caesar." Verb: *did* (with *bear* understood). Subject: *I*. Object: *the tired Caesar*. Modern order: 'I bore the tired Caesar.' The line is now transparent, and you can turn to the interesting question, which is why Cassius compares himself to Aeneas and Caesar to a helpless old man.

1.6 Omitted words and squeezed forms

Verse leaves things out. So does fast speech. Act 1 has both, and a reader who expects every word to be present will keep tripping.

Ellipsis (words left out). When Cassius asks Brutus to come and watch the race, Brutus answers "Not I." That is the whole sentence: 'I will not go' compressed to two words. When Brutus asks Casca what the second shout was for, Casca says "Why, for that too." (supply 'the shout was'). Cassius's "'Tis just." means 'that is exactly right'. When Cassius calls "Who's there?" in the dark, Casca answers "A Roman." and Cassius replies "Casca, by your voice.", meaning 'I know you are Casca by your voice'. Cicero asks "Comes Caesar to the Capitol tomorrow?" and Casca answers "He doth", which stands for 'he does come'. Cassius tells Casca that the Roman fire in him is missing "Or else you use not", where the object 'it' is understood. In "But ere we could arrive the point proposed", the preposition *at* is missing after *arrive*, because Elizabethan *arrive* could take a direct object. Brutus asks his friends not to "construe any further my neglect / Than that poor Brutus, with himself at war, / Forgets the shows of love to other men", which unpacks as 'do not interpret my neglect as anything more than the fact that I am at war with myself'.

Loose agreement. Elizabethan grammar allowed a singular verb with a plural subject when it felt natural to the speaker. Cassius says "Three parts of him / Is ours already" and asks Cinna "Is Decius Brutus and Trebonius there?"; Cinna says "There's two or three of us have seen strange sights" (also dropping *who* before *have*). These are not errors to correct; they are the living grammar of 1599. Do not lose confidence when a verb does not 'agree'.

Squeezed forms. The metre needs ten syllables, so vowels vanish. Here is the full Act 1 set in one place.

Squeezed form	Full form	Act 1 example
'tis, 'twas	it is, it was	"'Tis Caesar that you mean, is it not, Cassius?"
i' th', th'	in the, the	"death i' th' other"; "Th' ambitious ocean"
'em	them	"conjure with 'em"
on 't, was 't	of it, was it	"I am glad on 't."
ha'	have	"I ha' not since put up my sword"

Squeezed form	Full form	Act 1 example
whe'er, ne'er	whether, never	"See whe'er their basest mettle be not moved."
think'st, dar'st, mean'st	thinkest, darest, meanest	"what thou think'st of him"
threat'ning	threatening (two syllables)	"the threat'ning clouds"
a-nights, a-shouting	at night, shouting	"such as sleep a-nights"; "the people fell a-shouting"
ope	open	"he plucked me ope his doublet"

TEXT NOTE The little accent marks: touchèd, Vexèd, glancèd

In the Folger text you will see words printed with a grave accent: "touchèd", "Vexèd", "plungèd", "glancèd", "unbracèd", "disposèd", "Transformèd", "disturbèd". This mark is an editor's signal, not Shakespeare's spelling and not a literary device. It tells the reader to pronounce the *-ed* as a separate syllable so that the line keeps its ten beats: *touch-èd*, *vex-èd*. Where the *-ed* is silent, the same editors print an apostrophe or nothing. The MIT/Globe text you may have met in an ICSE edition prints the plain form (touched, vexed) and leaves the pronunciation to you. Meaning is unaffected. Never write in an answer that 'the poet uses the device of the accented *-ed*'; there is no such device. If a question asks about rhythm, the honest point is that Shakespeare's line requires the extra syllable, and the accent merely records that fact.

CROSS-REFERENCE Where the grammar becomes analysis

This chapter gives you the tools; other chapters put them to work. The thou/you switch in Cassius's soliloquy is developed in 'Cassius — The Manipulation Masterclass'. The compressed rhetorical questions of Marullus are analysed as devices in 'The Act 1 Literary-Device Bank'. Every quotation used above is catalogued with its speaker and context in 'The Act 1 Quotation Bank'. When you reach 'Extract-Based Training (Part One)' and 'Extract-Based Training (Part Two)', come back to sections 1.5 and 1.6 whenever an extract refuses to yield: nine times out of ten the problem is inversion or a missing word, not a missing word from your vocabulary.

Part 2: Act 1 Word Bank by Scene

How to use these tables. Do not try to memorise them. Read each scene in your text with the relevant table open beside it, and tick the words you actually stumbled on. Those, and only those, go on your revision cards. The 'Why it matters' column is the one examiners care about: it tells you what a word is *doing* in the play, which is the difference between a dictionary and a study of literature. Words are listed in the order they occur in the scene. Quotation marks around a phrase mean it is Shakespeare's exact wording.

Scene 1: the street

Word/phrase	Simple meaning	Meaning in context	Modern equivalent	Why it matters
Hence	away from here	Flavius's first word: an order to disperse	'Clear off!'	The play opens with authority trying, and failing, to control a crowd.

Word/phrase	Simple meaning	Meaning in context	Modern equivalent	Why it matters
idle creatures	lazy, unoccupied people	workmen who should be at their benches	'you layabouts'	<i>Creatures</i> dehumanises. The tribunes never see the people as fellow citizens.
mechanical	belonging to a manual trade	"Being mechanical" = 'since you are working men'	'working-class'	Shakespeare's standard word for artisans, used here as a class label and a reproach.
labouring day	working day	a day that is not a holiday	'a weekday'	"Is this a holiday?" is the real quarrel: who has the right to declare one?
sign of your profession	the tools or dress that mark a trade	"without the sign / Of your profession"	'your work clothes'	An Elizabethan expectation, not a Roman one. Shakespeare's London shows through the Roman costume.
rule	measuring stick	the Carpenter's ruler	'ruler'	Marullus demands tools as proof of honest labour.
apparel, attire	clothing	"thy best apparel"; "your best attire"	'your Sunday best'	Best clothes on a working day are a political statement. The tribunes attack the clothes three times.
in respect of	in comparison with	"in respect of a fine workman, I am but, as you would say, a cobbler"	'compared to'	Mock-modesty. <i>Cobbler</i> also meant 'bungler', so he seems to insult himself while dodging the question.
safe conscience	clear conscience	a trade he can practise honestly	'an honest trade'	Sets up the soles/souls joke: a mender of souls has the safest conscience of all.
soles	bottoms of shoes (sounds like <i>souls</i>)	"a mender of bad soles"	'shoe soles / wicked souls'	The famous pun. The Cobbler claims a priest's job while doing a cobbler's.
knave	rogue, low fellow (originally 'boy, servant')	"thou knave"	'you scoundrel'	Insult from above; the pronoun <i>thou</i> travels with it.
naughty	wicked, worthless	"Thou naughty knave"	'you good-for-nothing'	Far stronger than the modern nursery word. See Part 3.
beseech	beg	"I beseech you, sir, be not out with me."	'I beg you'	Humble register chosen to soothe an angry superior.
be not out with me; if you be out, I can mend you	do not be angry with me; if you are worn out (like shoes) I can repair you	<i>out</i> = angry, and also = worn out	'don't fall out with me'	The Cobbler makes the ruler the one in need of repair: a tiny reversal of power.
saucy	insolent, presumptuous	"thou saucy fellow"	'impudent'	Real anger, not modern cheekiness. See Part 3.
cobble	mend roughly	"Why, sir, cobble you."	'patch you up'	Straight-faced answer to fury; the prose wit of the commons against the verse dignity of the tribunes.

Word/phrase	Simple meaning	Meaning in context	Modern equivalent	Why it matters
awl; withal	a pointed tool for piercing leather; besides, moreover	"all that I live by is with the awl"; "but withal I am indeed, sir, a surgeon to old shoes"	'awl'; 'all the same'	A triple pun: <i>awl</i> , <i>all</i> , <i>withal</i> . Shakespeare shows the commoner as verbally quicker than his rulers.
meddle with	busy oneself with	"I meddle with no tradesman's matters nor women's matters"	'I don't interfere in'	Many editors hear a bawdy second meaning. The tribunes miss it; the audience does not.
surgeon to old shoes; recover	shoe-doctor; mend, re-cover with leather, restore to health	"when they are in great danger, I recover them"	'I bring them back to life'	A sustained medical metaphor, comic here, serious later when Rome itself needs a surgeon.
proper men	fine, handsome men	"As proper men as ever trod upon neat's leather"	'as fine men as ever walked'	False friend: not <i>correct</i> men. See Part 3.
neat's leather	cowhide (<i>neat</i> = cattle)	to walk on neat's leather = to wear shoes	'in leather shoes'	Nothing to do with tidiness.
triumph	victory procession	"to rejoice in his triumph"	'victory parade'	HISTORICAL RECORD: a triumph honoured victory over foreign enemies; Caesar's honoured victory over Romans. Marullus's fury rests on this.
conquest; tributaries	territory won; conquered peoples paying tribute	"What conquest brings he home? / What tributaries follow him to Rome"	'what has he actually conquered? where are the captive nations?'	Two questions expose the triumph as hollow: no land won, no foreigners chained.
grace ... in captive bonds	adorn, honour ... in chains	"To grace in captive bonds his chariot wheels"	'to decorate his chariot with chained prisoners'	Bitter irony: human beings as ornaments, and this time there are none.
senseless things	objects without feeling	"you worse than senseless things!"	'worse than lumps of stone'	<i>Blocks</i> and <i>stones</i> : the crowd as inert matter that can be carved by whoever holds the chisel.
battlements	fortified tops of walls	"climbed up to walls and battlements"	'ramparts'	Part of the picture of a whole city climbing to see Pompey.
livelong	whole, entire	"The livelong day, with patient expectation"	'the whole day long'	Intensifies the crowd's former devotion, to shame its present one.
universal shout	a shout from everyone	"Have you not made an universal shout"	'a roar from the whole city'	<i>An universal</i> : Elizabethan article before a sounded <i>u</i> . Do not 'correct' it in a quotation.
replication	echo, reverberation	"To hear the replication of your sounds"	'the echo'	Rare Latinate word: the shout so loud the river echoed it. A register far above the Cobbler's.

Word/phrase	Simple meaning	Meaning in context	Modern equivalent	Why it matters
concave shores	hollowed, curving riverbanks	"Made in her concave shores"	'the curved banks'	The banks become an amphitheatre. Hyperbole; the Tiber is personified as <i>her</i> .
cull out	pick out, select	"cull out a holiday"	'declare yourselves a holiday'	The crowd chooses its own festival, which the tribunes see as usurped authority.
strew	scatter	"strew flowers in his way"	'scatter flowers'	The gesture once given to Pompey now goes to Pompey's conqueror.
Pompey's blood	Pompey's kin (his sons) and his bloodline	"in triumph over Pompey's blood"	'over Pompey's family'	HISTORICAL RECORD: the Spanish campaign ended at Munda (45 BC) against Pompey's sons. <i>Blood</i> also hints at literal bloodshed.
intermit	hold off, suspend	"Pray to the gods to intermit the plague"	'to hold back'	Latin <i>intermittere</i> . The plague is the punishment Marullus thinks ingratitude deserves.
needs must light on	must inevitably fall upon	"That needs must light on this ingratitude"	'that is bound to fall on'	<i>Needs</i> = of necessity; <i>light</i> = alight, land. Two small words, both false friends.
sort	class, rank	"Assemble all the poor men of your sort"	'men of your class'	Elizabethan class vocabulary. In Scene 2 <i>sort</i> means 'manner' ("in such a sort").
exalted	raised high	"kiss the most exalted shores of all"	'the highest banks'	Hyperbole: weep enough to flood the Tiber.
wh'e'r ... basest mettle	whether ... lowest quality (metal or spirit)	"See wh'e'r their basest mettle be not moved."	'see whether even their base natures are stirred'	Pun on <i>metal</i> and <i>mettle</i> : the people are base metal, moved by whichever hand works them. See Part 3.
tongue-tied	silenced	"They vanish tongue-tied in their guiltiness."	'speechless with guilt'	The witty Cobbler is silenced in a moment. The crowd shifts at a word: the play's central political fact.
disrobe the images; decked with ceremonies	strip the statues; hung with ceremonial decorations	"Disrobe the images / If you do find them decked with ceremonies."	'strip the festival trappings off the statues'	<i>Ceremonies</i> here are physical objects (scarves, ornaments), not rituals. This is the act for which the tribunes are "put to silence".
feast of Lupercal	the Lupercalia festival	"You know it is the feast of Lupercal."	'it's a holy day'	HISTORICAL RECORD: 15 February fertility festival. Marullus hesitates to offend religion; Flavius does not.
trophies	marks of victory	"Let no images / Be hung with Caesar's trophies."	'victory decorations'	Flavius overrides religious scruple with political urgency.

Word/phrase	Simple meaning	Meaning in context	Modern equivalent	Why it matters
the vulgar	the common people	"drive away the vulgar from the streets"	'the commoners'	A noun, not the adjective <i>rude</i> . The tribunes' contempt is in the grammar.
thick	crowded together	"where you perceive them thick"	'wherever they cluster'	The people are always a mass, never individuals.
growing feathers ... fly an ordinary pitch	new plumage ... fly at a normal height	"These growing feathers plucked from Caesar's wing / Will make him fly an ordinary pitch"	'clip his wings and he will stay at our level'	Falconry: <i>pitch</i> is the height a hawk climbs to before its dive. Caesar is a bird of prey; the tribunes propose to pluck him.
servile fearfulness	slavish fear	"And keep us all in servile fearfulness."	'cowering like slaves'	The republican nightmare in two words; it becomes Cassius's <i>bondage</i> in Scene 3.

Scene 2: the public place

Word/phrase	Simple meaning	Meaning in context	Modern equivalent	Why it matters
course	race, run	"When he doth run his course"; "the order of the course"	'the race'	Antony runs in the Lupercal race; the word also means 'course of action', and Brutus refuses to watch either.
barren ... sterile curse	childless ... the affliction of childlessness	"The barren, touchèd in this holy chase, / Shake off their sterile curse."	'childless women, touched during this sacred race, become fertile'	Caesar's first order is about an heir. The childless dictator is a political problem, and he knows it.
Set on; ceremony	proceed; ritual	"Set on and leave no ceremony out."	'carry on, and observe every ritual'	Caesar the sceptic who ignores a soothsayer is also Caesar the traditionalist who omits no rite.
press	crowd	"Who is it in the press that calls on me?"	'in the crowd'	Not a newspaper. The Soothsayer's voice comes out of an anonymous mass.
shriller	higher and more piercing	"a tongue shriller than all the music"	'sharper than the band'	A single thin voice cuts through the state music: fate is quieter than power, and still heard.
ides	the mid-month marker day (15 March)	"Beware the ides of March."	'the fifteenth'	HISTORICAL RECORD: Kalends, Nones and Ides were the three fixed days of the Roman month. Class 10 papers assume you know what it refers to.
dreamer	one who sees visions; a fantasist	"He is a dreamer. Let us leave him. Pass."	'a crank'	Caesar's dismissal is the play's first act of fatal overconfidence.
gamesome	fond of sport, playful	"I am not gamesome."	'I'm not the sporty type'	Brutus's first words define him against Antony: grave where Antony is festive.

Word/phrase	Simple meaning	Meaning in context	Modern equivalent	Why it matters
quick spirit	lively energy	"that quick spirit that is in Antony"	'that liveliness'	<i>Quick</i> = alive, lively, not fast. See Part 3.
hinder	obstruct	"Let me not hinder, Cassius, your desires."	'don't let me hold you back'	Courteous withdrawal; Cassius refuses to let him go.
of late; wont	recently; accustomed	"I do observe you now of late"; "as I was wont to have"	'lately'; 'used to'	Cassius opens by claiming a change in Brutus: the manipulator's first move is to name a problem.
bear ... a hand over	treat, handle (as a rider handles a horse)	"You bear too stubborn and too strange a hand / Over your friend"	'you are riding your friend too hard'	Horseman's metaphor: Brutus is holding the reins too tightly.
veiled my look; countenance	hidden my expression; face, expression	"If I have veiled my look, / I turn the trouble of my countenance / Merely upon myself."	'if I have seemed distant, my troubled face is about me, not you'	<i>Countenance</i> recurs in Scene 3 with a second meaning, 'approval'.
passions of some difference	conflicting emotions	"Vexèd I am / Of late with passions of some difference"	'torn by contradictory feelings'	<i>Passion</i> = any strong feeling, not romance. This is the whole of Brutus's inner conflict in five words.
conceptions only proper to myself	thoughts belonging to me alone	same speech	'private thoughts'	<i>Proper</i> = one's own. Brutus's privacy is exactly what Cassius intends to invade.
soil	stain, blemish	"give some soil" to his behaviour	'a smudge on my manners'	A moral stain in miniature; Brutus is anxious about appearances.
construe	interpret	"Nor construe any further my neglect"	'don't read more into it'	A key word of the whole play: everyone in Act 1 is construing something. Cicero uses it in Scene 3.
cogitations	thoughts	"Thoughts of great value, worthy cogitations"	'weighty reflections'	Cassius's grand Latinate diction dresses a plot as philosophy.
mistook your passion	misread your feelings	"I have much mistook your passion"	'I misjudged your mood'	Cassius pretends to have withheld his plans out of tact.
shadow	reflection, image	"That you might see your shadow."	'your true image'	Not darkness: the mirror-image. The whole mirror passage depends on it.
glass; discover	mirror; reveal	"I, your glass, / Will modestly discover to yourself / That of yourself which you yet know not of."	'I will be your mirror and show you what you don't know about yourself'	<i>Discover</i> = uncover, not find. The false mirror is Cassius's central metaphor for manipulation.
jealous on me	suspicious of me	"And be not jealous on me, gentle Brutus."	'don't mistrust me'	False friend (Part 3). <i>Gentle</i> = noble, not soft.

Word/phrase	Simple meaning	Meaning in context	Modern equivalent	Why it matters
laughter / laugher	(Folger) object of laughter; (MIT) one who laughs idly	"Were I a common laughter"	'if I were a fool people laughed at / a cheap joker'	An edition variant; both readings mean 'a man not to be taken seriously'.
stale ... my love with ordinary oaths; protester	cheapen my friendship with routine vows; one who professes friendship	"To stale with ordinary oaths my love / To every new protester"	'if I swore friendship to every newcomer'	<i>Protest</i> = declare, not object. Cassius denies being a flatterer while flattering.
fawn; scandal	flatter servilely; slander (verb)	"I do fawn on men and hug them hard / And after scandal them"	'suck up to people and then badmouth them'	He describes the exact behaviour he is about to practise on Brutus.
rout	disorderly crowd, rabble	"I profess myself in banqueting / To all the rout"	'to every drunk at the party'	Aristocratic contempt for the many, shared by every noble in Act 1.
aught; the general good	anything; the public welfare	"If it be aught toward the general good"	'if it is anything for the public good'	<i>General</i> = of everyone. Brutus's condition for listening; the state, not himself.
indifferently	impartially, without preference	"I will look on both indifferently"	'I will weigh both equally'	Not carelessly. Brutus claims to hold honour and death in perfect balance. See Part 3.
speed	prosper, make succeed	"let the gods so speed me as I love / The name of honour"	'may the gods help me as surely as I love honour'	In Caesar's mouth earlier, "in your speed" means haste. Two meanings in one scene.
outward favour	external appearance, face	"As well as I do know your outward favour."	'as well as I know your face'	<i>Favour</i> = features. Cassius says he knows Brutus's inner virtue as well as his outer face.
chafing	fretting, rubbing angrily against	"The troubled Tiber chafing with her shores"	'the river fretting against its banks'	The river shares the speaker's irritation: nature mirrors mood, as the storm will in Scene 3.
accoutred	fully dressed and equipped	"Accoutred as I was, I plunged in"	'in full kit'	Cassius boasts he swam in armour. The Folger spells it <i>Accoutered</i> .
buffet; lusty sinews	strike, fight against; strong muscles	"we did buffet it / With lusty sinews"	'we fought the current with strong arms'	Physical vigour is Cassius's measure of a man; by this measure Caesar failed.
stemming ... with hearts of controversy	making headway against ... with competitive spirit	"And stemming it with hearts of controversy"	'pushing through it in a spirit of rivalry'	<i>Controversy</i> = contest. The swim was a race, and Cassius won.
Anchises; Aeneas	Aeneas's aged father; the Trojan founder of the Roman line	"I, as Aeneas, our great ancestor, / Did from the flames of Troy upon his shoulder / The old Anchises bear"	'like Aeneas carrying his old father out of burning Troy'	Cassius casts himself as Rome's founding hero and Caesar as a helpless old man.

Word/phrase	Simple meaning	Meaning in context	Modern equivalent	Why it matters
bend his body ... nod	bow ... give a careless nod	"must bend his body / If Caesar carelessly but nod on him"	'has to bow if Caesar so much as nods at him'	The gap between the swimmer he rescued and the god he must bow to is Cassius's wound.
fit	attack of illness	"when the fit was on him"	'during the attack'	Caesar's fever in Spain: the god has a body.
coward lips ... from their colour fly	pale lips ... lost their colour	"His coward lips did from their colour fly"	'his lips went white'	Personification: the lips desert like cowardly soldiers deserting a flag.
bend; lustre	glance; brightness	"that same eye whose bend doth awe the world / Did lose his lustre"	'the gaze that frightens the world went dull'	<i>Bend</i> = direction of a look. The all-seeing eye is exposed as weak.
feeble temper	weak constitution	"A man of such a feeble temper"	'so frail a man'	<i>Temper</i> = physical make-up, not mood.
get the start of; bear the palm	outstrip; take the prize	"So get the start of the majestic world / And bear the palm alone."	'outrun the whole world and take the trophy alone'	Racing and victory metaphors: Cassius resents losing a contest.
applauses	outbursts of applause	"these applauses are / For some new honours that are heaped on Caesar"	'this cheering'	Brutus reads the offstage sound correctly, and it frightens him.
bestride ... Colossus	stand astride ... the giant statue at Rhodes	"he doth bestride the narrow world / Like a Colossus"	'he straddles the world like a giant statue'	The world is <i>narrow</i> because Caesar is huge: an image you must be able to explain in your own words.
petty; peep about	small, insignificant; look timidly around	"we petty men / Walk under his huge legs and peep about"	'we little men creep about between his legs'	Self-contempt as a lever: Cassius shames Brutus into action.
underlings	subordinates, inferiors	"But in ourselves, that we are underlings."	'that we let ourselves be inferiors'	The play's clearest statement of free will against fate.
conjure; start a spirit	summon by magic; raise a ghost	"conjure with 'em, / 'Brutus' will start a spirit as soon as 'Caesar.'"	'use the names as spells and Brutus's will summon a spirit just as fast'	Names are magic words; Cassius treats reputation as sorcery.
Upon what meat doth this our Caesar feed	what food makes this Caesar of ours so great	same	'what does he eat, to have grown so big?'	Sarcasm that reduces a god to a diet.
Rome ... room	(pun) the city; space	"Now is it Rome indeed, and room enough / When there is in it but one only man."	'now Rome really is roomy, with only one man in it'	<i>Rome</i> and <i>room</i> were pronounced alike: a pun inside a lament.
brooked; keep his state	tolerated; hold his royal court	"would have brooked / Th' eternal devil to keep his state in Rome / As easily as a king"	'would as soon have let the devil hold court in Rome as a king'	The ancestor Brutus who expelled the kings. Cassius weaponises the name.

Word/phrase	Simple meaning	Meaning in context	Modern equivalent	Why it matters
nothing jealous; aim	not at all doubtful; guess	"That you do love me, I am nothing jealous. / What you would work me to, I have some aim."	'I don't doubt your love; I can guess what you want from me'	Brutus is not fooled; he chooses to be persuaded slowly.
entreat; moved	beg; urged, persuaded	"so with love I might entreat you, / Be any further moved"	'please don't press me further'	<i>Moved</i> = pushed emotionally, as in "Are not you moved" in Scene 3.
meet	fitting, suitable	"Both meet to hear and answer such high things"	'a proper time to hear'	An adjective, not the verb. Cassius uses it again: "it is meet / That noble minds keep ever with their likes".
chew upon	think over	"chew upon this"	'digest this'	Brutus's homely metaphor; note how food and appetite recur in this scene.
villager; repute	rustic, country-dweller; consider	"Brutus had rather be a villager / Than to repute himself a son of Rome / Under these hard conditions"	'I'd rather be a peasant than call myself a Roman under such conditions'	A conditional commitment that Cassius hears as a promise.
show of fire	sign of spirit	"struck but thus much show of fire from Brutus"	'struck this much of a spark'	Flint-and-steel metaphor: Brutus is stone, Cassius is striking.
sour fashion; worthy note	bitter manner; worth noticing	"after his sour fashion, tell you / What hath proceeded worthy note today"	'in his grumpy way, tell you what happened that was worth noticing'	<i>Fashion</i> = manner. Casca's character is announced before he speaks.
chidden train	a scolded retinue	"all the rest look like a chidden train"	'like a group that has just been told off'	Brutus reads faces: the whole court has been rebuked.
ferret ... eyes; crossed in conference	red, angry eyes (like a ferret's); contradicted in debate	"such ferret and such fiery eyes ... Being crossed in conference by some senators"	'red-eyed with rage, as when senators argue with him'	Cicero the orator hates being opposed; a hint of the tension in the Senate.
sleek-headed; a-nights	smooth-haired, contented; at night	"Sleek-headed men, and such as sleep a-nights"	'well-groomed men who sleep soundly'	Caesar's theory of politics: the contented are safe, the lean and sleepless are not.
well given	well disposed, of good character	"He is a noble Roman, and well given."	'a decent man'	Antony misjudges Cassius completely.
spare	lean, thin	"that spare Cassius"	'that thin Cassius'	Not <i>extra</i> . Physique as political diagnosis.
liable to fear	subject to fear	"if my name were liable to fear"	'if Caesar could feel fear'	Caesar speaks of himself in the third person, as a name, not a man.

Word/phrase	Simple meaning	Meaning in context	Modern equivalent	Why it matters
in such a sort; heart's ease	in such a manner; peace of mind	"smiles in such a sort / As if he mocked himself"; "never at heart's ease / Whiles they behold a greater than themselves"	'smiles as if he despised himself'; 'never content while anyone is above them'	Caesar's portrait of Cassius is exact, and he ignores it.
chanced; sad	happened; serious, grave	"what hath chanced today / That Caesar looks so sad"	'what happened to make Caesar look so grave'	<i>Sad</i> = solemn, not unhappy. See Part 3.
put it by	pushed it aside, refused it	"he put it by with the back of his hand"	'waved it away'	The gesture Casca imitates ("thus"). Whether the refusal was sincere is the question of the scene.
marry	indeed (a mild oath)	"Ay, marry, was 't"	'yes, indeed it was'	Casca's prose is full of such fillers; they mark him as blunt and colloquial.
fain; loath	gladly; reluctant	"he would fain have had it"; "he was very loath to lay his fingers off it"	'he'd have loved to take it'; 'he hated letting go of it'	The two words carry Casca's whole accusation of hypocrisy.
coronet	a small crown	"'twas one of these coronets"	'a little crown'	A coronet is not a royal crown: the offer was a test, and Casca knows it.
rabblement; chopped hands; nightcaps	mob; chapped, rough hands; working men's caps	"the rabblement hooted and clapped their chopped hands and threw up their sweaty nightcaps"	'the mob cheered, clapping their rough hands and throwing their sweaty caps in the air'	Casca's disgust at the people's bodies is class contempt made physical.
swooned	fainted	"he swooned and fell down at it"	'he passed out'	Caesar's body fails in public; the god falls.
durst	dared	"I durst not laugh for fear of opening my lips and receiving the bad air"	'I didn't dare laugh in case I breathed the stink'	Casca's comedy is cruelty.
falling sickness	epilepsy	"he hath the falling sickness"	'epilepsy'	HISTORICAL RECORD: Plutarch reports Caesar's seizures. Cassius turns it into a metaphor: Rome has fallen.
tag-rag people; players; the common herd	ragged rabble; actors; the mass of ordinary people	"If the tag-rag people did not clap him and hiss him ... as they use to do the players in the theatre"	'the rabble cheered and booed him like actors on a stage'	Politics as theatre: the people are an audience and Caesar performs.
plucked me ope his doublet	tore open his jacket	"he plucked me ope his doublet and offered them his throat to cut"	'ripped open his coat and offered his throat'	<i>Doublet</i> is an Elizabethan garment. The <i>me</i> is a colloquial 'I tell you'. Caesar's theatrical gesture of self-sacrifice.

Word/phrase	Simple meaning	Meaning in context	Modern equivalent	Why it matters
a man of any occupation; taken him at a word	a working man; accepted his offer literally	"An I had been a man of any occupation, if I would not have taken him at a word, I would I might go to hell among the rogues."	'if I'd been a tradesman I'd have taken him up on it'	Casca imagines the assassination a month before it happens.
infirmity	weakness, illness	"he desired their Worships to think it was his infirmity"	'blame it on his illness'	Caesar's apology to the crowd flatters them with the title <i>Worships</i> .
wenches; heed	young women (here, common girls); notice	"Three or four wenches where I stood cried"; "there's no heed to be taken of them"	'some girls near me cried out'; 'ignore them'	The crowd forgives Caesar instantly; Casca despises them for it.
put to silence; scarves	silenced (removed from office, or worse); decorative bands	"Marullus and Flavius, for pulling scarves off Caesar's images, are put to silence."	'have been shut up'	The tribunes of Scene 1 are disposed of in half a line. The text leaves the exact punishment open.
promised forth	already engaged elsewhere	"No, I am promised forth."	'I've got a prior engagement'	Casca's brusqueness is consistent.
blunt; quick mettle	dull, plain-spoken; lively spirit	"What a blunt fellow is this grown to be! / He was quick mettle when he went to school."	'how dull he's become; he was full of life at school'	Brutus misreads Casca; Cassius corrects him.
execution; tardy form	performance, carrying out; sluggish manner	"in execution / Of any bold or noble enterprise, / However he puts on this tardy form"	'when it comes to actually doing a bold deed, whatever this slow act of his'	<i>Execution</i> has no hint yet of killing; it will.
rudeness; sauce; stomach	roughness; relish; appetite	"This rudeness is a sauce to his good wit, / Which gives men stomach to digest his words / With better appetite."	'his bluntness is the seasoning on his intelligence; it makes people swallow what he says'	A whole meal metaphor in three lines; <i>rudeness</i> is a false friend (Part 3).
think of the world	consider the state of things	"Till then, think of the world."	'meanwhile, think about the state we're in'	Cassius's parting instruction plants the seed he will water with forged letters.
honourable mettle ... wrought ... disposed	noble temperament ... worked, shaped ... inclined	"Thy honourable mettle may be wrought / From that it is disposed."	'your noble nature can be bent away from its natural inclination'	Metal-working metaphor: Brutus is iron to be forged. The MIT text prints <i>metal</i> .
keep ever with their likes; seduced	always associate with their equals; led astray	"noble minds keep ever with their likes; / For who so firm that cannot be seduced?"	'the noble should stick to their own kind, because anyone can be corrupted'	Cassius admits, alone, that he is corrupting Brutus.
bear me hard	bears a grudge against me	"Caesar doth bear me hard, but he loves Brutus."	'Caesar has it in for me'	Personal resentment beneath republican principle.

Word/phrase	Simple meaning	Meaning in context	Modern equivalent	Why it matters
humour	influence by indulging one's mood; cajole	"He should not humour me."	'he wouldn't be able to win me round'	False friend (Part 3): nothing to do with comedy.
several hands	different handwritings	"In several hands in at his windows throw"	'in various handwritings'	<i>Several</i> = separate (Part 3). The forgery is planned in detail.
tending; obscurely; glanced at	pointing towards; indirectly; hinted at	"Writings, all tending to the great opinion / That Rome holds of his name, wherein obscurely / Caesar's ambition shall be glanced at"	'letters all suggesting how highly Rome thinks of him, with veiled hints at Caesar's ambition'	The method of manipulation is indirectness: never accuse, only hint.
seat him sure	make his position secure	"let Caesar seat him sure, / For we will shake him, or worse days endure"	'let Caesar sit tight; we'll shake him off, or suffer for it'	A rider's metaphor; the scene ends on a rhyme, the audible click of a decision.

Scene 3: the storm

Scene 3 is the hardest of the three for vocabulary, and for a reason worth knowing before you start. Scene 1 is mostly prose and insult; Scene 2 is persuasion between friends. Scene 3 is verse spoken in a thunderstorm by frightened or exalted men, and its words are drawn from three specialised registers at once: the language of omens (prodigies, portentous, heralds, tokens), the language of nature breaking its own laws (ordinance, preformed faculties, quality and kind) and the language of slavery and freedom (bondage, bondman, yoke, sufferance, captivity). Once you see the three registers, the scene stops being a fog of hard words and becomes three vocabularies arguing with one another.

Word/phrase	Simple meaning	Meaning in context	Modern equivalent	Why it matters
Brought you Caesar home?	did you escort Caesar home?	"Brought you Caesar home?"	'Did you see Caesar home?'	Cicero's first words place us a month after Scene 2, on the night before the Ides. Nothing in the dialogue announces the gap; the vocabulary of 'tomorrow' does.
sway of earth	the whole swaying frame of the world; also 'rule, government'	"all the sway of earth / Shakes like a thing unfirm"	'the solid earth itself'	<i>Sway</i> carries a second sense, 'dominion'. The ground is shaking and so, the audience suspects, is the state.
unfirm	unsteady, insecure	"a thing unfirm"	'something flimsy'	The world has become a loose object. Shakespeare's prefix <i>un-</i> does what we would do with <i>in-</i> .
scolding winds; rived	roaring, rebuking winds; split apart	"the scolding winds / Have rived the knotty oaks"	'gales that have split the gnarled oaks'	<i>Rive</i> survives only in <i>riven</i> . Casca has seen ordinary violence before; tonight is not ordinary.
ambitious ocean; exalted	the sea reaching upwards; lifted high	"Th' ambitious ocean swell and rage and foam / To be exalted with the threat'ning clouds"	'the sea heaving up to meet the storm clouds'	<i>Ambitious</i> applied to the sea is the first sounding of the word that will be used of Caesar in Act 3. The storm rehearses the play's central charge.

Word/phrase	Simple meaning	Meaning in context	Modern equivalent	Why it matters
tempest dropping fire	a storm raining fire	"Did I go through a tempest dropping fire."	'a storm that rained fire'	SHAKESPEARE'S TEXT gives fire from the sky; Plutarch's omens are different in detail. The image is Shakespeare's choice, and it makes heaven look like a city under siege.
civil strife in heaven	war among the gods	"Either there is a civil strife in heaven"	'a civil war among the gods'	<i>Civil</i> is the loaded word: Rome has just finished a civil war and is about to begin another.
saucy; Incenses	insolent; enrages, inflames	"the world, too saucy with the gods, / Incenses them to send destruction"	'mankind has been so impudent that the gods are furious'	<i>Saucy</i> is the tribunes' word for the Cobbler, now applied to the whole human race. Casca's instinct is that disorder is a punishment.
wonderful	causing wonder or astonishment	"Why, saw you anything more wonderful?"	'anything even more astonishing?'	A false friend (Part 3): Cicero means marvellous and frightening, not delightful.
by sight	by appearance	"you know him well by sight"	'you'd recognise him'	Casca anchors the marvel in a familiar face: this is a specific slave, not a rumour.
Not sensible of fire	unable to feel the fire	"Not sensible of fire, remained unscorched"	'feeling no heat'	<i>Sensible</i> = capable of sensation (Part 3). The hand burns like a torch and is not consumed.
put up my sword	sheathed my sword	"I ha' not since put up my sword"	'I've kept my sword drawn ever since'	A small realistic touch: Casca walked the streets armed, and still is.
Against the Capitol	opposite, in front of the Capitol	"Against the Capitol I met a lion"	'near the Capitol'	<i>Against</i> = facing. The lion is loose in the political heart of the city.
glazed; surly	stared glassily; sullen, ill-tempered	"Who glazed upon me and went surly by"	'glared at me and slouched past'	The Folger prints <i>glazed</i> (stared glassily); the MIT/Globe text prints <i>glared</i> . The sense is the same: a fixed, hostile stare. The beast ignores the man, as if men no longer matter.
annoying	harming, injuring	"Without annoying me"	'without hurting me'	The sharpest false friend in Act 1 (Part 3). The old sense is physical injury.
drawn upon a heap	gathered in a huddle	"there were drawn / Upon a heap a hundred ghastly women"	'a hundred women huddled together'	<i>Drawn</i> = assembled; <i>heap</i> = crowd. The grammar is loose because Casca is breathless.
ghastly	ghost-like, deathly pale with terror	"a hundred ghastly women"	'women white as ghosts'	Not 'awful' in the modern loose sense; the word still contained <i>ghost</i> .

Word/phrase	Simple meaning	Meaning in context	Modern equivalent	Why it matters
Transformèd with their fear	changed in appearance by terror	"Transformèd with their fear, who swore they saw / Men all in fire"	'their faces changed by fear'	Fear alters bodies in this scene: hands, faces, Cassius's bared chest.
bird of night	the owl	"the bird of night did sit / Even at noonday upon the marketplace"	'an owl'	An owl by day in the busiest public space: the natural order inverted exactly where the political order is decided.
prodigies	unnatural, ominous events	"When these prodigies / Do so conjointly meet"	'these freak occurrences'	The key noun of the scene. Latin <i>prodigium</i> = a sign sent by the gods.
conjointly	all together, at the same time	same line	'all at once'	Casca's argument: one marvel might be chance; several together cannot be.
portentous	foreboding, full of omen	"they are portentous things / Unto the climate that they point upon"	'they are omens'	From <i>portent</i> . A portent points at something: the preposition <i>upon</i> keeps the pointing finger visible.
climate	region, country	same line	'the land they point at'	Not weather. The omens are addressed to a particular country, Rome.
strange-disposèd	strangely inclined, abnormal	"it is a strange-disposèd time"	'a strangely arranged time'	<i>Disposed</i> = arranged by some disposing power; Cicero hints that something is arranging events without saying what.
construe ... after their fashion; Clean from the purpose	interpret ... in their own way; entirely away from the real meaning	"men may construe things after their fashion, / Clean from the purpose of the things themselves"	'people read things however they like, quite missing what the things actually mean'	<i>Clean</i> = completely. The play's most important sentence about interpretation, and the word <i>construe</i> carries it, as it carried Brutus in Scene 2.
did bid	ordered, instructed	"he did bid Antonius / Send word to you"	'he told Antony to send word'	<i>Bid</i> is a strong verb of command; Caesar does not ask.
disturbèd sky / Is not to walk in	a troubled sky is no weather to be out in	"This disturbèd sky / Is not to walk in."	'this is no night to be out'	Cicero removes himself from the plot by removing himself from the storm.
menace	threaten	"Who ever knew the heavens menace so?"	'when did the sky ever threaten like this?'	A verb here. Casca's question is answered by Cassius with a theory, not a fear.
so full of faults	so riddled with wrongs	"Those that have known the Earth so full of faults"	'anyone who knows how corrupt the world is'	<i>Faults</i> means moral failings; Cassius reads the storm as a mirror of political rot.
Submitting me unto	exposing myself to	"Submitting me unto the perilous night"	'putting myself at the mercy of the night'	The reflexive <i>me</i> where we say <i>myself</i> .

Word/phrase	Simple meaning	Meaning in context	Modern equivalent	Why it matters
unbracèd	with doublet unfastened, chest bare	"And thus unbracèd, Casca, as you see, / Have bared my bosom to the thunder-stone"	'with my shirt open to the lightning'	Elizabethan dress again. Cassius offers the gods his chest as Caesar offered the crowd his throat; the parallel is deliberate.
thunder-stone	thunderbolt	same line	'the lightning bolt'	HISTORICAL RECORD: Elizabethans believed a stone fell with the lightning. The word is a fossil of that belief.
cross blue lightning	forked, zigzag lightning	"when the cross blue lightning seemed to open / The breast of heaven"	'forked lightning'	<i>Cross</i> = crossing, zigzag. Heaven has a breast as Cassius has a bosom: the sky and the man face each other.
tempt the heavens	provoke, test the gods	"But wherefore did you so much tempt the heavens?"	'why did you dare the gods like that?'	<i>Tempt</i> = put to the test (as in 'tempt fate'). Casca is pious; Cassius is not.
the part of men	the proper role of human beings	"It is the part of men to fear and tremble"	'it's only right for men to be afraid'	<i>Part</i> = role, as in a play. Cassius will shortly redefine what the part of a Roman man is.
tokens; heralds; astonish	signs; messengers who announce; stun as if by thunder	"When the most mighty gods by tokens send / Such dreadful heralds to astonish us"	'when the gods send such dreadful messengers to stun us'	<i>Astonish</i> comes from a word meaning 'to strike with thunder': here the metaphor is literal.
dull	slow of feeling, insensible	"You are dull, Casca"	'you're slow, Casca'	Not boring. Cassius accuses Casca of failing to feel what a Roman should feel.
want; use not	lack; do not exercise	"those sparks of life / That should be in a Roman you do want, / Or else you use not"	'you either lack a Roman's fire or you don't use it'	<i>Want</i> = lack (Part 3). The insult is framed as a diagnosis so that Casca will want to prove it wrong.
put on fear; cast yourself in wonder	assume a frightened look; throw yourself into amazement	"You look pale, and gaze, / And put on fear, and cast yourself in wonder"	'you go pale and stare and act terrified'	<i>Put on</i> implies fear is a costume. Cassius treats emotion as something chosen.
impatience	inability to endure; agitation	"the strange impatience of the heavens"	'the sky's wild agitation'	Heaven cannot <i>bear</i> something. Cassius is building towards what it cannot bear.
from quality and kind	away from their natures and species	"Why birds and beasts from quality and kind"	'why animals act against their natures'	<i>Kind</i> = nature (as in <i>mankind</i>). Behaviour against kind is the Elizabethan definition of the unnatural.
calculate	prophecy, cast horoscopes	"Why old men, fools, and children calculate"	'why old men, idiots and children are all making prophecies'	Those least qualified to reason are reasoning about the future: order has flipped.

Word/phrase	Simple meaning	Meaning in context	Modern equivalent	Why it matters
ordinance	the ordained natural order	"Why all these things change from their ordinance"	'depart from the laws laid down for them'	From <i>ordain</i> . Not weapons (that is <i>ordnance</i>).
preformèd faculties	inborn powers, natures fixed in advance	"Their natures, and preformèd faculties, / To monstrous quality"	'their built-in natures, into something unnatural'	The most abstract phrase in Act 1. Nature has a programme, and it has been overwritten.
monstrous quality; monstrous state	unnatural character; abnormal condition (and, punningly, a deformed commonwealth)	"To make them instruments of fear and warning / Unto some monstrous state"	'to warn of some monstrous situation'	<i>State</i> means condition and also the political state. Cassius lets the pun do his accusing for him.
infused	poured in, filled	"heaven hath infused them with these spirits"	'heaven has filled them with these powers'	Literal sense of pouring; the omens are vessels filled with meaning.
prodigious grown; fearful; eruptions	grown into a portent; terrifying; outbreaks, disturbances	"yet prodigious grown, / And fearful, as these strange eruptions are"	'grown into a monstrous omen, terrifying like these outbreaks'	<i>Fearful</i> = causing fear, not feeling it (Part 3). Caesar is described in the vocabulary of the storm so that the two become one thing.
thews	muscles, sinews	"Have thews and limbs like to their ancestors"	'the same muscles and limbs as their ancestors'	Bodies are unchanged; only minds have shrunk. The whole speech rests on this contrast.
woe the while	alas for these times	"But, woe the while, our fathers' minds are dead"	'alas for the age we live in'	An exclamation, not a sentence. Treat it as a sigh and read on.
yoke and sufferance; womanish	servitude and patient endurance; effeminate	"Our yoke and sufferance show us womanish."	'our willingness to be harnessed and put up with it makes us look like women'	LITERARY INTERPRETATION: Cassius equates manhood with resistance and submission with women, a prejudice of his age and his character; the play tests it later through Portia.
establish; save	set up formally; except	"Mean to establish Caesar as a king, / And he shall wear his crown by sea and land / In every place save here in Italy"	'to make Caesar king everywhere except Italy'	<i>Save</i> is a preposition. The rumour itself is unverified in the play; it is Casca's hearsay, and Cassius seizes on it.
bondage	slavery	"Cassius from bondage will deliver Cassius."	'I will free myself from slavery'	The word turns Flavius's "servile fearfulness" from Scene 1 into a single noun that justifies suicide, or murder.
Therein	in that respect	"Therein, you gods, you make the weak most strong"	'in that way the gods make the weak strongest'	<i>There + in</i> . The weak are strong because they can always die.

Word/phrase	Simple meaning	Meaning in context	Modern equivalent	Why it matters
retentive to	able to hold back, to imprison	"Can be retentive to the strength of spirit"	'can hold the spirit prisoner'	A Latinate adjective where we would use a verb: 'cannot retain'. Decoded in Part 4.
worldly bars	the prison bars of this world (the body, circumstance)	"But life, being weary of these worldly bars"	'the cage of earthly life'	The world is a prison; the metaphor is Stoic in flavour, though Cassius was historically an Epicurean.
dismiss itself	release itself, end itself	"Never lacks power to dismiss itself"	'can always end itself'	Suicide spoken of as a servant dismissing itself from duty: the calmest and coldest phrase in the scene.
at pleasure	whenever I choose	"That part of tyranny that I do bear / I can shake off at pleasure"	'I can throw it off whenever I like'	Freedom redefined as the power to die. Cassius's suicide at Philippi fulfils the sentence.
bondman; cancel his captivity	slave; annul his imprisonment	"So every bondman in his own hand bears / The power to cancel his captivity."	'every slave holds in his own hand the power to end his slavery'	<i>Cancel</i> is a legal term: slavery as a contract any man can tear up by dying. Casca matches Cassius's metaphor instantly, a sign he is won.
hinds	female deer; also peasants, menials	"He were no lion, were not Romans hinds."	'he'd be no lion if Romans weren't deer'	A double sense: deer for the lion to eat, and servants for the master to rule. Both insult the Romans, not Caesar.
weak straws	flimsy kindling	"Those that with haste will make a mighty fire / Begin it with weak straws."	'a big fire is started with thin straw'	The Romans are the kindling that lets Caesar blaze. The metaphor shifts blame from tyrant to people.
trash; rubbish; offal; base matter; illuminate	waste; refuse; butcher's leavings; low fuel; light up (and 'make glorious')	"What trash is Rome, / What rubbish, and what offal when it serves / For the base matter to illuminate / So vile a thing as Caesar!"	'what garbage Rome is, if it serves as the fuel that makes a thing as vile as Caesar shine'	<i>Base matter</i> is the alchemist's term for low metal; the image returns, reversed, in Casca's "richest alchemy" at the end of the scene.
willing bondman	a contented slave	"I perhaps speak this / Before a willing bondman"	'perhaps I'm saying this to a man who is happy to be a slave'	A calculated risk, or a calculated performance of risk: Cassius pretends to fear he has said too much.
My answer must be made	I shall have to answer for it	"then, I know / My answer must be made"	'I'll have to face the consequences'	<i>Answer</i> = legal defence. Cassius speaks as if already on trial.
indifferent	of no importance to me	"And dangers are to me indifferent."	'I don't care about the danger'	False friend (Part 3): not 'mediocre'.

Word/phrase	Simple meaning	Meaning in context	Modern equivalent	Why it matters
fleering telltale	sneering informer	"That is no fleering telltale"	'no grinning snitch'	<i>Fleer</i> = to grin mockingly. Casca swears he will not betray; the word choice shows his contempt for those who would.
Hold. My hand.	here, take my hand	"Hold. My hand."	'Here's my hand on it.'	Three words seal the conspiracy: the handshake is the contract.
factionous; redress; griefs	active in forming a faction; remedy; grievances	"Be factionous for redress of all these griefs"	'form a party to put right all these wrongs'	<i>Factionous</i> is nearly always a word of blame in Shakespeare; Casca uses it as praise. <i>Griefs</i> = grievances, not sorrows.
moved	persuaded, stirred to action	"Now know you, Casca, I have moved already / Some certain of the noblest-minded Romans"	'I've already won over certain of the noblest Romans'	The same verb Casca used of the earthquake ("Are not you moved"). Cassius moves men as the storm moves the earth.
undergo; honourable-dangerous	undertake; honourable and dangerous at once	"To undergo with me an enterprise / Of honourable-dangerous consequence"	'to take on with me a venture that is both honourable and dangerous'	<i>Undergo</i> = undertake, not suffer. The hyphenated compound fuses the two words the conspirators will never again manage to keep together.
stay for me	wait for me	"they stay for me / In Pompey's Porch"	'they're waiting for me'	<i>Stay</i> = wait. HISTORICAL RECORD: the portico of Pompey's theatre, beside the hall where Caesar was in fact killed.
stir	movement, activity	"There is no stir or walking in the streets"	'nobody is about'	The streets that were thronged in Scene 1 are empty: the people have withdrawn, and the plotters have the city.
complexion of the element / In favour 's like	the appearance of the sky resembles	"the complexion of the element / In favour 's like the work we have in hand"	'the look of the sky is like the deed we're planning'	<i>Element</i> = sky; <i>favour</i> = face, appearance. Cassius reads the storm as a portrait of the conspiracy.
Stand close	keep hidden	"Stand close awhile, for here comes one in haste."	'hide a moment'	<i>Close</i> = concealed. Conspirators learn the vocabulary of hiding.
gait	manner of walking	"'Tis Cinna; I do know him by his gait."	'I know his walk'	In the dark, men are known by voice and walk: Casca "by your voice", Cinna by his gait. Identity is uncertain all night.
incorporate / To our attempts	joined as one body into our undertaking	"one incorporate / To our attempts"	'one of us'	Latin <i>corpus</i> , body. The conspiracy is a body with members, a figure Brutus will develop in Act 2.
stayed for	awaited	"Am I not stayed for, Cinna?"	'Aren't they waiting for me?'	Cassius asks twice. His eagerness is the one crack in his composure.

Word/phrase	Simple meaning	Meaning in context	Modern equivalent	Why it matters
Be you content	do not worry	"Be you content. Good Cinna, take this paper"	'Relax, Cinna'	A command in the old subjunctive form. Cassius already has Brutus in hand, or says he does.
praetor's chair	the official seat of a praetor (a senior magistrate)	"look you lay it in the praetor's chair, / Where Brutus may but find it"	'put it on Brutus's official seat where only he will find it'	HISTORICAL RECORD: Brutus was urban praetor in 44 BC. The forged letter goes to his office, not his home: it addresses the public man.
Repair to; hie; bestow	go to; hurry; place, deposit	"Repair to Pompey's Porch, where you shall find us."; "Well, I will hie / And so bestow these papers as you bade me."	'go to the porch'; 'I'll hurry and plant these papers as you told me'	<i>Repair</i> has no sense of mending here; <i>bestow</i> means 'put in place', not 'give'. Three archaic verbs in three lines.
Three parts of him / Is ours	three quarters of him belong to us	"Three parts of him / Is ours already, and the man entire / Upon the next encounter yields him ours."	'he's three-quarters ours; one more meeting and he's completely ours'	Brutus as a fraction being filled: the arithmetic of seduction.
sits high in all the people's hearts	is greatly loved by the people	"O, he sits high in all the people's hearts"	'the people adore him'	Casca, who despised the people an hour ago, now wants their good opinion. The conspirators need the crowd they scorn.
appear offence; countenance	look like a crime; approval, backing (and 'face')	"that which would appear offence in us / His countenance, like richest alchemy, / Will change to virtue and to worthiness."	'what would look like a crime if we did it, his support will turn into virtue'	<i>Countenance</i> = face and sanction at once. Brutus's face is the alchemy that will gild the murder.
alchemy	the art of turning base metal to gold	same line	'a magic that turns lead into gold'	Answers Cassius's "base matter". Rome is base metal; Brutus is the philosopher's stone.
conceited	conceived, understood, expressed	"You have right well conceived."	'you've put that exactly right'	Not vanity (Part 3). Cassius praises Casca's image because it is his own thought in better words.
ere day	before daybreak	"and ere day / We will awake him and be sure of him"	'before dawn we'll wake him and make sure of him'	<i>Be sure of</i> = secure, pin down. The scene ends with Brutus as a prize to be collected before morning.

CROSS-REFERENCE The three registers, taken further

The omen vocabulary of this scene (prodigies, portentous, tokens, heralds) is the raw material for 'Themes of Act 1 (Part Two)', where fate, superstition and free will are treated at length. The bondage vocabulary (yoke, sufferance, bondman, captivity) belongs with the theme of liberty in 'Themes of Act 1 (Part One)'. The scene as drama, including why Cicero leaves before Cassius enters and how Casca is converted in under a hundred lines, is the subject of 'Act 1 Scene 3 — The Storm: Omens, Fear and the Conspiracy Takes Shape'.

Part 3: False Friends

A false friend is a word you recognise and therefore do not look up. That is precisely what makes it dangerous. When you meet *tributaries* or *thews* you know you are in difficulty and you reach for a glossary. When you meet *jealous*, *annoying* or *proper*, you sail on with a modern meaning in your head, and the sentence quietly turns into nonsense without telling you. Every word in this section still exists in modern English, and every one of them meant something different, or something wider, in 1599. Most of the shifts follow one of three patterns, and knowing the pattern helps you guess the next false friend you meet.

- **Narrowing.** The old word was broad; the modern word keeps one slice. *Jealous* once meant any kind of suspicion or watchful anxiety; we keep only the romantic slice. *Sad* meant serious or settled; we keep only the unhappy slice. *Quick* meant alive; we keep only the speed.
- **Weakening.** The old word was strong; the modern word is mild. *Annoying* meant to harm; now it means to irritate. *Naughty* meant wicked; now it describes a toddler. *Saucy* meant insolent; now it means cheekily charming.
- **Drifting.** The word has slid to a neighbouring sense. *Humour* moved from a bodily fluid, to the mood it produced, to indulging that mood, and only afterwards to comedy. *Conceit* moved from a concept to the specific concept of one's own excellence. *Nice* drifted so far that it no longer means anything much at all (it does not occur in Act 1, but it haunts the rest of Shakespeare, where it usually means 'fussy' or 'precise').

The Act 1 false-friend table

Word	What you think it means	What it means in Act 1 (with the line)	The trap
jealous	envious, possessive in love	<i>suspicious, doubtful, mistrustful.</i> Cassius: "And be not jealous on me, gentle Brutus." Brutus: "That you do love me, I am nothing jealous."	A student who reads envy here makes Cassius ask Brutus not to envy him, which is absurd. Cassius is asking not to be <i>suspected</i> ; Brutus replies that he has no <i>doubt</i> of Cassius's love. The whole exchange is about trust, and the false friend hides it. Note also <i>on</i> for <i>of</i> .
humour	comedy, funniness	<i>to indulge, cajole, win round by playing to someone's mood.</i> Cassius, alone: "He should not humour me."	Cassius means that if their positions were reversed, Brutus could not talk him round. Read as 'amuse', the line becomes a complaint that Brutus is not funny, which destroys the soliloquy's logic. The Folger prints <i>humor</i> .

Word	What you think it means	What it means in Act 1 (with the line)	The trap
mettle / metal	courage, spirit (mettle); iron, gold (metal)	<i>both at once</i> . In 1599 they were one word with one spelling. Flavius: "See whe'er their basest mettle be not moved." Cassius: "Thy honourable mettle may be wrought"; "He was quick mettle when he went to school."	Modern spelling forces a choice Shakespeare did not make. In each line the sense of temperament <i>and</i> the sense of a workable metal are present: the crowd is base metal to be stirred, Brutus is honourable metal to be forged ("wrought"), Casca was lively metal at school. The MIT text prints <i>metal</i> in Cassius's soliloquy; both are right.
quick	fast	<i>alive, lively, full of life</i> . Brutus: "that quick spirit that is in Antony". Cassius: "He was quick mettle when he went to school."	Brutus is not saying Antony is speedy; he is saying Antony has an aliveness that Brutus lacks. The old sense survives in 'the quick and the dead' and in a fingernail's <i>quick</i> .
want	desire	<i>lack, be without</i> . Cassius to Casca: "those sparks of life / That should be in a Roman you do want".	Read as desire, the line says Casca <i>wants</i> Roman fire, which is nearly the opposite of the insult. Cassius says Casca <i>lacks</i> it. In Shakespeare, test <i>lack</i> before <i>wish for</i> ; the old sense survives in 'for want of'.
rude / rudeness	impolite	<i>rough, unpolished, uncultivated</i> . Brutus: "This rudeness is a sauce to his good wit".	Brutus is not calling Casca bad-mannered; he is calling his style rough-hewn, and saying the roughness makes his intelligence more palatable. The modern reading turns a compliment into a complaint.
saucy	cheeky, playfully impertinent	<i>insolent, presumptuous towards a superior</i> . Flavius: "Mend me, thou saucy fellow?" Casca: "the world, too saucy with the gods".	In 1599 this was a serious charge: it accused a social inferior of forgetting his place. Flavius is furious, not amused. Casca's phrase means mankind has become <i>insolent</i> towards heaven, an offence worth a storm.
nice	pleasant, kind	<i>not used in Act 1</i> . Elsewhere in Shakespeare: fastidious, precise, trivial.	Listed so that it does not ambush you in the later acts or in another play. If you meet it, never read 'pleasant'.
conceit / conceited	vanity / vain	<i>idea, conception / conceived, expressed</i> . Cassius to Casca: "You have right well conceited."	Cassius is not calling Casca arrogant. He is saying Casca has <i>understood and put into words</i> exactly the right idea. <i>Conceit</i> was simply the noun from <i>conceive</i> .
indifferent / indifferently	mediocre; carelessly	<i>impartial, of no particular concern; impartially, with equal weight</i> . Brutus: "I will look on both indifferently". Cassius: "And dangers are to me indifferent."	Brutus does not promise to look at honour and death carelessly; he promises to weigh them <i>equally</i> , without preferring his own life. Cassius is not saying danger is mediocre; he is saying it does not matter to him either way.
several	many, more than two	<i>separate, different, distinct</i> . Cassius: "In several hands in at his windows throw, / As if they came from several citizens".	'Several hands' is not 'many hands' but 'different handwritings': Cassius will disguise his writing so that each forged letter looks like a different man's. The old sense survives in the legal phrase 'jointly and severally'.
sensible	reasonable, practical	<i>capable of feeling, able to sense</i> . Casca: "Not sensible of fire, remained unscorched."	The slave's hand is not 'reasonable about fire'; it <i>feels</i> no fire. The old word belongs to <i>sense</i> and <i>sensation</i> , not to good sense.

Word	What you think it means	What it means in Act 1 (with the line)	The trap
annoying	mildly irritating	<i>harming, injuring, molesting</i> . Casca: "Without annoying me."	The lion walked past <i>without hurting him</i> . If you read irritation, the marvel evaporates and so does the fear. The French cousin <i>ennuyer</i> kept a different slice of the same old word.
proper	correct, respectable	<i>handsome, fine</i> (of people); <i>one's own, belonging to oneself</i> (of things). Cobbler: "As proper men as ever trod upon neat's leather". Brutus: "Conceptions only proper to myself".	Two old senses, neither modern. The Cobbler's customers are <i>fine-looking</i> men; Brutus's thoughts are <i>his own</i> . The second sense survives in 'property' and in 'proper noun' (a name that belongs to one thing).
naughty	mischievous (of a child)	<i>wicked, worthless, good for nothing</i> . Flavius: "Thou naughty knave".	From <i>naught</i> , nothing: a <i>naughty</i> man is a man of no worth. The tribune is not scolding a child; he is dismissing a man as rubbish, and the Cobbler's reply treats the insult with the seriousness it was meant to carry.
idle	lazy	<i>lazy, but also empty, trivial, unemployed</i> . Flavius: "Hence! Home, you idle creatures, get you home!"	The modern sense is close enough that you will not misread the line, but the old word was stronger and wider: the workmen are <i>useless, doing nothing of value, not at work</i> . It is a class insult, not a comment on energy.
wonderful	very good, delightful	<i>causing wonder, astonishing (and often frightening)</i> . Cicero: "Why, saw you anything more wonderful?"	Cicero is asking whether Casca saw anything <i>more astonishing</i> than the storm; nothing in the word is pleasant. The modern praise-sense did not yet exist.

Smaller traps already met in Part 2

These were explained in the word bank; they are gathered here so that you can test yourself on them without the tables. Cover the right-hand side and try each one.

Word	Modern reflex	Act 1 sense
sad ("Caesar looks so sad")	unhappy	serious, grave
still ("still as he refused it")	nevertheless, or motionless	always, every time
fearful ("this fearful night")	frightened	frightening
mere ("It was mere foolery")	only, nothing more than	pure, absolute (and also 'only')
mark ("I did not mark it")	a sign or a grade	notice, pay attention to
press ("in the press")	newspapers	crowd
shadow ("see your shadow")	darkness	reflection
discover ("discover to yourself")	find	reveal
soft ("But soft, I pray you")	gentle	wait
like ("Tis very like")	similar	likely
meet ("meet to hear")	encounter	fitting
spare ("that spare Cassius")	extra	lean
sort ("men of your sort"; "in such a sort")	kind	class; manner

Word	Modern reflex	Act 1 sense
countenance ("His countenance, like richest alchemy")	face	approval, backing
repair ("Repair to Pompey's Porch")	mend	go
vulgar ("the vulgar")	crude	the common people
griefs ("redress of all these griefs")	sorrows	grievances

ICSE EXAM BOX How false friends cost marks, and how they earn them

EXAM-ORIENTED ADVICE. The most common vocabulary error in extract answers is not failing to know a hard word; it is confidently mistranslating an easy one. A student asked to explain "be not jealous on me" who writes about envy has not merely lost the vocabulary mark; the examiner now doubts everything else in the answer, because the student has shown that he or she did not understand what the two men were talking about. The reverse is also true. If a Class 10 extract from Act 3 or 4 contains a word you recognise from this table, and you translate it correctly in your own words ('here *several* means separate', 'here *want* means lack'), you demonstrate exactly the understanding of meaning that CISCE's stated skills reward, in two lines, at no risk. Be honest with yourself about the syllabus: Act 1 is examined in Class 9, and the board paper sets Acts 3 to 5. But the false friends do not change between acts. These are not Act 1 peculiarities; they are ordinary Shakespearean usage, and you will meet the same traps in the examined acts and in every other Shakespeare text you ever read. The student who learned them here reads those acts with an advantage the summary-readers never acquire.

Part 4: Reading Practice

Everything above is equipment. This section shows the equipment in use. Three passages follow, one from each scene, chosen because each presents a different kind of difficulty: the first is hard because of grammar and compression, the second because of metaphor, the third because of register and Latinate vocabulary. For each, I will do exactly what I asked you to do at the start of this chapter: three passes, no word-by-word translation, and only then the literary question. Read the passage aloud first. Then cover my working and attempt your own before reading on.

Passage 1 (Scene 1): Marullus turns on the crowd

Marullus: *Wherefore rejoice? What conquest brings he home? / What tributaries follow him to Rome / To grace in captive bonds his chariot wheels? / You blocks, you stones, you worse than senseless things! / O you hard hearts, you cruel men of Rome, / Knew you not Pompey?*

Pass 1, the shape. Read to the punctuation. There are six sentences in six lines, and five of them are questions. Nobody is expected to answer; a tribune does not ask a crowd for information. So the shape tells you the mode before you understand a word: this is a man demanding, not asking. The sixth sentence is not a question but a list of names: "You blocks, you stones". A list of insults in the middle of a list of questions is the sound of someone losing his temper.

Pass 2, the verbs and their subjects. *Rejoice* has no subject written: it is 'why do you rejoice?' with the *do* you omitted (section 1.6). *Brings* has the subject *he*, inverted after the question word: 'what conquest does he bring home?' *Follow* has the subject *tributaries*, which comes after *what*, so the order is 'what tributaries follow him?' *Grace* is an infinitive of purpose: 'in order to decorate'. *Knew* is inverted with *you*: 'did you not know Pompey?' Once each verb has its owner, every question stands up straight.

Pass 3, swap and unpack. *Wherefore* is *why*, not *where* (section 1.3). *Tributaries* are conquered peoples who pay tribute; *captive bonds* are the chains of prisoners; to *grace* is to adorn; *senseless* means without senses, not foolish. Now the metaphors. The crowd are called *blocks* and *stones*: not merely stupid but inert, material that has no will and takes whatever shape it is given. Then "worse than senseless things": a stone cannot be blamed for feeling nothing, but a man can. Then the paradox *hard hearts*: hearts that have turned to the stone just named.

Plain English: 'Why are you celebrating? What territory has he conquered? Which conquered nations are following him to Rome in chains to decorate his chariot? You lumps, you stones, you things with less feeling than objects! You hard-hearted, cruel Romans, did you not know Pompey?'

What a trained reader notices. Three things, each worth a sentence in an answer. First, the questions have a logic: *conquest* and *tributaries* are the two things a triumph is supposed to display, and Marullus names them in order to show that both are missing. **HISTORICAL RECORD:** a Roman triumph was for victory over foreign enemies, and Caesar's Spanish victory was over Pompey's sons, fellow Romans. Second, *Knew you not Pompey?* is placed last and is the only question that reaches into the past; it introduces the long memory speech that follows. Third, the inversion *Knew you* instead of 'did you know' is not decoration. It puts the verb of knowing first, as if to accuse the crowd of forgetting before the sentence has even named what they forgot.

Passage 2 (Scene 2): Cassius on the Colossus and the stars

Cassius: *Why, man, he doth bestride the narrow world / Like a Colossus, and we petty men / Walk under his huge legs and peep about / To find ourselves dishonourable graves.*

Cassius: *Men at some time are masters of their fates. / The fault, dear Brutus, is not in our stars, / But in ourselves, that we are underlings.*

Pass 1, the shape. The first block is one sentence running over four lines; the second is two sentences, each a complete statement. So the speech moves from a long picture to short conclusions. That movement, image then argument, is the rhythm of Cassius's whole method of persuasion, and recognising it is the first step to analysing him rather than merely understanding him.

Pass 2, the verbs and their subjects. *Doth bestride*: subject *he* (Caesar); the *doth* is a metrical helper and means nothing (section 1.2), so read 'he bestrides'. *Walk* and *peep*: subject *we petty men*. *To find* is purpose: we peep about *in order to* find. In the second block, *are masters*: subject *men*; *is not*: subject *the fault*. Nothing is inverted here; the difficulty is not grammar.

Pass 3, swap and unpack. *Bestride* is to stand with one leg on each side. The *Colossus* was the giant statue at Rhodes; **HISTORICAL RECORD:** the picture of it straddling the harbour so that ships sailed between its legs is a medieval legend, not ancient fact, and Shakespeare uses the legend. The world is *narrow* not because it has shrunk but because Caesar is so large that it fits between his feet. *Petty* means small and insignificant; *peep about* means to look timidly here and there; *dishonourable graves* are graves of men who did nothing worth remembering. In the second block, *fates* and *stars* belong to astrology, the belief that the heavens fix a man's destiny at birth. *Underlings* are inferiors, subordinates.

Plain English: 'Why, man, he straddles the narrow world like a giant statue, and we little men walk between his huge legs and look timidly about, searching for graves to lie in without honour. Men are sometimes in charge of their own destinies. The fault, dear Brutus, is not in the stars we were born under but in ourselves, because we allow ourselves to be inferiors.'

What a trained reader notices. The two blocks contradict each other, and the contradiction is the point. In the first, Caesar is a statue: enormous, fixed, apparently permanent, while the men below are tiny and mobile. In the second, Cassius says that nothing about this is fixed at all: the sky did not make Caesar great, and Brutus and Cassius made themselves small. **LITERARY INTERPRETATION:** many critics read "The fault, dear Brutus, is not in our stars" as the play's clearest statement of free will against fate. One strong reading is that Cassius means it sincerely and that the storm scene, where he reads omens as eagerly as Casca, shows how inconsistent his position is. The text leaves open whether he believes the sentence or merely finds it useful. Notice, finally, the one word of tenderness in the whole speech, *dear*, placed exactly where the accusation lands: 'the fault, *dear* Brutus, is in ourselves'. A manipulator softens the blow at the moment of delivering it.

Passage 3 (Scene 3): Cassius on the prison of the world

Cassius: *Nor stony tower, nor walls of beaten brass, / Nor airless dungeon, nor strong links of iron, / Can be retentive to the strength of spirit; / But life, being weary of these worldly bars, / Never lacks power to dismiss itself.*

Pass 1, the shape. Two sentences joined by *But*. The first takes three lines to arrive at its verb: four things are listed, each introduced by *nor*, before the sentence tells you what they cannot do. This is Pattern C from section 1.5, the Latin habit of holding the verb back, and it means you must hold four nouns in your head and wait. Reading aloud helps: the four *nors* fall like hammer blows, and the ear expects a verb at the end.

Pass 2, the verbs and their subjects. *Can be retentive*: the subject is the whole list, *tower, walls, dungeon, links*. The *nor ... nor ... nor ... nor* means 'neither this, nor this, nor this, nor this'; modern English would begin with *neither* and we would expect only two items. *Lacks*: subject *life*. *Being weary* is a participle describing *life*: 'life, when it is weary'. *To dismiss itself* is what life has the power to do.

Pass 3, swap and unpack. *Retentive to* is the Latinate difficulty: it means 'able to retain, to hold in'. A dungeon that is *retentive to the strength of spirit* is one that can imprison a strong spirit. *Beaten brass* is brass hammered into plates; *links of iron* are chains. *Worldly bars* are the bars of the prison that is this world: the body, circumstance, tyranny. *Dismiss itself* is the cold heart of the passage: life can *release itself from service*, which is to say a man can kill himself. Cassius never uses the word suicide. The whole speech is built so that the audience arrives at the idea without hearing it named.

Plain English: 'No stone tower, no walls of hammered brass, no airless dungeon, no strong iron chains can imprison a strong spirit; because a life that is tired of these worldly prison bars always has the power to end itself.'

What a trained reader notices. The register has risen as high as Act 1 goes. Where the Cobbler punned on *soles* and Casca grumbled about *sweaty nightcaps*, Cassius is now speaking the language of Roman Stoic philosophy, in which the freedom to die was the last freedom no tyrant could remove. **HISTORICAL RECORD:** the real Cassius was an Epicurean, not a Stoic; the text gives him Stoic sentiments because they suit the moment, and you should not claim this is a portrait of his historical philosophy. Two further points. First, the speech is a hinge: Cassius says he will free *himself* by dying, but the dagger he has just mentioned ("I know where I will wear this dagger then") will in the event be turned on Caesar, not on himself, until Philippi, when the sentence comes true after all. Second, the piled-up negatives (*nor, nor, nor, nor, never*) make a positive. Four prisons are denied so that one power can be affirmed. That is how rhetoric works, and if you can describe the mechanism in your own words, you have moved from translation to criticism.

REVISION Now you: a passage to decode alone

Try the method on Cicero's reply to Casca, which is only two lines long and contains no rare words at all: "But men may construe things after their fashion, / Clean from the purpose of the things themselves."

Pass 1: one sentence; find the comma. **Pass 2:** the verb is *construe*, the subject is *men*; what is being construed? **Pass 3:** *construe* means interpret (you met it in Brutus's mouth in Scene 2); *after their fashion* means in their own manner; *clean* means completely. Now write the plain English in one sentence, and then answer the literary question: why does Shakespeare give the play's calmest statement about misreading to the one senator who then walks away from the plot? Check your plain English against the word bank for Scene 3. If you can do this unaided, you no longer need this chapter; you need only the play.

PROFESSOR'S INSIGHT Why the hard words are hard for good reasons

It is tempting to believe that Shakespeare is difficult because he is old, and that if he had written in 2026 he would be easy. The Cobbler disproves this: his prose is four hundred years old and you can follow it with a glossary of six words. The real difficulty lies in three deliberate choices, and once you see them as choices, the difficulty becomes information. The first is compression. Blank verse gives a speaker ten syllables a line, and a character in a hurry, or in a rage, will pack those syllables until they strain: "Did I the tired Caesar" carries a whole sentence in five words, and the strain is Cassius's resentment made audible. When a line feels crammed, ask what pressure is cramming it. The second is metaphor. Shakespeare rarely says a thing when he can show it as another thing: the people are stones, Caesar is a Colossus and a wolf, Brutus is metal to be wrought, Rome is kindling. These are not ornaments laid over a plain meaning; they *are* the meaning, and a reader who strips them away to find the 'real' sense is left holding nothing. When a word seems to belong to the wrong subject, you have found a metaphor, and the question is what it reveals about the speaker. The third is register. Shakespeare gives each speaker a vocabulary that places him: *replication* and *concave shores* for a tribune straining after dignity, *sweaty nightcaps* for a cynic, *retentive* and *preformèd faculties* for a conspirator dressing murder as philosophy. The hard word tells you who is speaking and what he wants you to think of him. So the honest answer to 'why is this so hard?' is usually 'because the character is under pressure, is thinking in pictures, or is performing a role', and each of those is something an examiner will reward you for noticing. The difficulty is not between you and the play; it is in the play, where Shakespeare put it, for you to find.

CROSS-REFERENCE Where to go from here

The words you ticked in the Part 2 tables belong on revision cards alongside the quotations in 'The Act 1 Quotation Bank'. The decoding method of Part 4 is exactly what the extract sub-questions in 'Extract-Based Training (Part One)' and 'Extract-Based Training (Part Two)' require under time pressure, and the examiner's view of a well-explained phrase is set out in 'ICSE Examiner Mode: How Marks Are Earned'. The devices named in passing here, the rhetorical question, the piled negative, the metaphor of metal and fire, are catalogued and taught in 'The Act 1 Literary-Device Bank'. The final shape of all of it is in 'The Final Act 1 Master Map and What Shakespeare Is Doing'.

CHAPTER 21

The Final Act 1 Master Map and What Shakespeare Is Doing

This is the chapter you return to when the twenty chapters before it have done their work. Part A folds everything you have learnt about Act 1 into a single connected map: one grid for the three scenes, four master tables, a relationship map and four chain diagrams, every cell built from verified wording. Part B steps back from the detail and asks the question a scholar asks: what is Shakespeare actually doing with these three scenes, and why does the order he chose move an audience so powerfully? You finish by seeing the whole tragedy's logic already present inside Act 1, and with honest advice on carrying this knowledge into Acts 3 to 5 and into the examination hall.

How to Use the Map

A map is not a territory. The tables below compress teaching that the scene chapters and the character masterclasses gave you at full length; they do not replace it. Use the map in three ways. First, as a checking tool: after you finish a scene, run your finger along its row and ask whether every cell is something you could explain aloud without notes. Second, as a planning tool: every row of the keyword and device tables is, in effect, a ready-made paragraph, because it already binds a point to a quotation and to a theme. Third, as a last-week revision tool: the chain diagrams in the Scene Connection Spine are the fastest way to rebuild the whole act in your head in ten minutes.

One rule governs the whole chapter. Everything printed inside double quotation marks is Shakespeare's verified wording from Act 1. Everything in single quotation marks is a paraphrase, a label, an exam phrase, or a line from a later act that this book does not verify word for word. That distinction matters in an examination, where a misquoted line costs credibility even when the idea is sound.

CROSS-REFERENCE Where the full teaching lives

Every compressed cell here expands somewhere else in the book. For the scenes, go to 'Act 1 Scene 1 — The Street', 'Act 1 Scene 2 (Part One)', 'Act 1 Scene 2 (Part Two)' and 'Act 1 Scene 3 — The Storm'. For the people, go to 'Caesar in Act 1 — A Character Masterclass', 'Cassius — The Manipulation Masterclass' and 'Brutus in Act 1 — Honour, Conflict and Vulnerability'. The tables in this chapter are deliberately shorter than 'The Act 1 Literary-Device Bank', 'The ICSE Keyword Vault for Act 1' and 'The Act 1 Quotation Bank': those chapters hold the full stock; this one shows how the stock connects. For the forward-looking links, 'The Scene Connection Engine and Where Act 1 Reappears Later' is the long version of the ledger and spine printed here.

PART A — The Final Act 1 Master Map

1. The Master Grid

Read this grid across, not down. Each row is a scene; each column is a different way of seeing the same scene. The point of laying them side by side is that a strong answer moves horizontally: an event becomes a character point, the character point exposes a theme, the theme is anchored by a quotation, and the historical column tells you what Shakespeare changed and therefore what he meant.

Events	Characters	Themes	History	Key quotations
SCENE 1 — a street, daytime, the feast of Lupercal. The tribunes Flavius and Marullus break up a holiday crowd that has come out to celebrate Caesar's triumph. The Cobbler fences with them in punning prose. Marullus shames the crowd for forgetting Pompey. The tribunes set off to strip the decorations from Caesar's statues.	Flavius and Marullus (tribunes of the people, speaking verse); the Carpenter and the Cobbler (commoners, speaking prose). Caesar and Pompey are present only as names — the first sign that this play will build its title character out of other people's talk.	Fickleness of the crowd; public opinion as a political weapon; republican fear of one man rising above the rest; ingratitude and loyalty; class marked by language.	Shakespeare fuses Caesar's Spanish triumph of October 45 BC (resented because it celebrated victory over Romans, Pompey's sons at Munda) with the Lupercalia of 15 February 44 BC. The historical tribunes Marullus and Flavius removed a diadem from Caesar's statue in January 44 BC and were deposed; the play moves their defiance onto this single day.	"Wherefore rejoice? What conquest brings he home?" — "You blocks, you stones, you worse than senseless things!" — "These growing feathers plucked from Caesar's wing / Will make him fly an ordinary pitch"
SCENE 2 — a public place, the same day. Caesar orders Antony to touch Calpurnia during the holy race; the Soothsayer warns of the ides of March and is dismissed as a dreamer. Left alone, Cassius works on Brutus while offstage shouts mark the crown-offering. Caesar returns angry and reads Cassius's character to Antony. Casca reports the coronet refused three times, Caesar's fainting fit, and the silencing of the tribunes. Cassius, alone, plans forged letters.	Caesar, Antony, Calpurnia, the Soothsayer, Brutus, Cassius, Casca; Cicero, Decius Brutus and Portia are present but silent. In the Folio stage direction, which the Folger edition keeps, Marullus and Flavius follow the procession — so we watch the tribunes walk on before we hear they have been silenced.	Power and public image; superstition against political calculation; fate against free will; honour as Brutus's governing word; friendship under strain; envy; manipulation and the mirror; appearance against reality; mob psychology; politics as theatre.	The Luperci ran through the city striking bystanders with goat-hide thongs to promote fertility; Antony ran as a Lupercus while consul. Plutarch has the diadem offered and refused twice, and Casca says three times. Caesar's epilepsy is in Plutarch; his deaf ear is Shakespeare's invention. In 44 BC Brutus held the more prestigious urban praetorship, which ancient sources make a grievance of Cassius.	"Beware the ides of March." — "poor Brutus, with himself at war" — "The fault, dear Brutus, is not in our stars, / But in ourselves, that we are underlings." — "He thinks too much. Such men are dangerous." — "For who so firm that cannot be seduced?"

Events	Characters	Themes	History	Key quotations
SCENE 3 — a street, the stormy night before the ides of March; a month has passed without announcement. Casca reports the prodigies to a sceptical Cicero. Cassius, who has walked in the lightning with his doublet open, reads the storm as a portrait of Caesar. News arrives that the Senate intends to crown Caesar tomorrow. Casca gives his hand to the faction; Cinna is sent to plant letters where Brutus will find them; the conspirators plan to gather at Pompey's Porch and secure Brutus before dawn.	Casca (now speaking verse), Cicero, Cassius, Cinna; Metellus Cimber, Decius Brutus and Trebonius are named as already waiting. Brutus, absent, is the scene's real subject.	Omens and the supernatural; interpretation and the danger of reading signs to suit yourself; fear of tyranny; liberty and self-mastery; manliness and shame; conspiracy; honour as political cover.	Plutarch and Suetonius record portents before the assassination; Shakespeare concentrates them into one night of fire. Pompey's Porch is the portico of the Theatre of Pompey (55 BC); historically Caesar died in the Curia attached to it, not on the Capitol as the play will have it. Cicero was never part of the conspiracy, and the historical Cassius, an Epicurean, was by philosophy a sceptic about omens — which makes his reading of the storm in the play a piece of rhetoric, not belief.	"men may construe things after their fashion, / Clean from the purpose of the things themselves." — "Cassius from bondage will deliver Cassius." — "His countenance, like richest alchemy, / Will change to virtue and to worthiness." — "We will awake him and be sure of him."

HISTORICAL CONTEXT One day that was really five months

Historical record: the Spanish triumph belongs to October 45 BC, the tribunes' removal of the diadem from Caesar's statue to January 44 BC, the Lupercalia to 15 February 44 BC, and the storm-night to 14 March 44 BC. **Shakespeare's text:** Scenes 1 and 2 happen on a single day, and Scene 3 is 'tomorrow' before the Capitol meeting. **Why the compression matters for the architecture:** by pressing five months into one day and one night, Shakespeare makes cause feel like immediate consequence. The commoners' holiday, the tribunes' fear, the crown-offering and the first seduction of Brutus all happen while the same sun is up; then a single night of omens delivers the conspiracy ready-formed. Nothing in the act is allowed to cool. When you write about the pace of Act 1, this is the fact to cite: the compression is deliberate, and it is the reason the act feels like a slope rather than a series of steps.

2. Keyword ↔ Quotation ↔ Theme

An ICSE answer earns its analysis marks by naming a quality with the right word, proving it with the right words of the text, and then saying which larger idea it serves. This table trains that three-step reflex. The keyword is what you would call the quality in your own sentence; the quotation is your evidence; the theme is the drawer in which the point belongs. Difficult words are glossed in brackets the first time they appear.

#	Keyword	Quotation (speaker, scene)	Theme it unlocks
1	Fickleness	"You blocks, you stones, you worse than senseless things!" (Marullus, Scene 1)	Mob psychology; public opinion as something to be scolded and steered
2	Republicanism	"These growing feathers plucked from Caesar's wing / Will make him fly an ordinary pitch" (Flavius, Scene 1; 'pitch' = the height a falcon flies)	Power and liberty; the republican wish to keep every man at an ordinary height
3	Superstition	"The barren, touchèd in this holy chase, / Shake off their sterile curse." (Caesar, Scene 2)	Superstition against reason; Caesar's private anxiety about having no heir

#	Keyword	Quotation (speaker, scene)	Theme it unlocks
4	Omen and dismissal	"Beware the ides of March." answered by "He is a dreamer. Let us leave him. Pass." (the Soothsayer and Caesar, Scene 2)	Fate and free will; pride that cannot afford to look afraid; the warning that frames the whole play
5	Inner conflict	"poor Brutus, with himself at war" (Brutus, Scene 2)	Moral conflict; the private battlefield before any public one
6	Self-knowledge	"the eye sees not itself / But by reflection, by some other things." (Brutus, Scene 2)	Appearance against reality; the opening Cassius will exploit
7	Manipulation	"I, your glass, / Will modestly discover to yourself / That of yourself which you yet know not of." (Cassius, Scene 2; 'glass' = mirror, 'discover' = reveal)	Manipulation and political rhetoric; flattery disguised as service
8	Honour	"Set honour in one eye and death i' th' other / And I will look on both indifferently" (Brutus, Scene 2)	Honour; the value Brutus places above his own life
9	Envy	"And this man / Is now become a god, and Cassius is / A wretched creature" (Cassius, Scene 2)	Jealousy; the personal grievance under the political argument
10	Free will	"Men at some time are masters of their fates. / The fault, dear Brutus, is not in our stars, / But in ourselves, that we are underlings." (Cassius, Scene 2; 'underlings' = inferiors)	Free will against fate; responsibility as a spur to action
11	Ambition	"he doth bestride the narrow world / Like a Colossus" (Cassius, Scene 2; 'bestride' = stand astride)	Power and ambition; the monstrous scale of one man
12	Ancestry	"There was a Brutus once that would have brooked / Th' eternal devil to keep his state in Rome / As easily as a king." (Cassius, Scene 2; 'brook'd' = tolerated)	Republicanism and inheritance; the name Brutus as an obligation
13	Suspicion	"Yond Cassius has a lean and hungry look. / He thinks too much. Such men are dangerous." (Caesar, Scene 2)	Leadership and judgement; Caesar sees the right danger and does nothing
14	Public image	"I rather tell thee what is to be feared / Than what I fear; for always I am Caesar." (Caesar, Scene 2)	Appearance against reality; the mask that speaks of itself in the third person
15	Political theatre	"as they use to do the players in the theatre" (Casca, Scene 2)	Appearance against reality; public life as a performance judged by an audience
16	Seduction	"For who so firm that cannot be seduced?" (Cassius, Scene 2)	Manipulation; betrayal of friendship stated openly in soliloquy
17	Disorder	"Either there is a civil strife in heaven, / Or else the world, too saucy with the gods, / Incenses them to send destruction." (Casca, Scene 3; 'saucy' = insolent)	Omens; the heavens as a mirror of the state
18	Scepticism	"men may construe things after their fashion, / Clean from the purpose of the things themselves." (Cicero, Scene 3; 'construe' = interpret)	Appearance against reality; interpretation as a political act
19	Liberty	"Cassius from bondage will deliver Cassius." (Cassius, Scene 3)	Liberty and individual against state; the self as the last free territory
20	Legitimacy	"His countenance, like richest alchemy, / Will change to virtue and to worthiness." (Casca, Scene 3; 'countenance' = approval, face)	Honour used as political cover; Brutus as the conspiracy's public face

A student who owns these twenty pairings, with the theme attached, can build a paragraph on almost any Act 1 question. Notice how many of the themes recur: appearance against reality appears five times across all three scenes, because it is the act's master theme, the one every other theme passes through.

3. Literary Device ↔ Example ↔ Effect

A device named without its effect earns almost nothing; a device named with its effect and tied to meaning earns the analysis mark. The third column is therefore the one to study. Notice too how the devices cluster: Scene 1 is built on rhetorical questions and insult; Scene 2 on metaphors of seeing, eating and disease; Scene 3 on animals, fire and alchemy. The imagery changes as the act darkens.

Device	Example (speaker, scene)	Effect
Pun	"a mender of bad soles" (the Cobbler, Scene 1)	Comic prose that lets a commoner outwit his superiors; the soles/souls play quietly suggests (a literary interpretation, not a fact) that Rome's souls also need mending.
Rhetorical question	"Wherefore rejoice? What conquest brings he home?" (Marullus, Scene 1)	Shame delivered as interrogation; the crowd cannot answer, which is the point. The same weapon will be turned on the same crowd by later orators.
Metaphor of insult	"You blocks, you stones, you worse than senseless things!" (Marullus, Scene 1)	Turns living citizens into inert matter; establishes the play's recurring view of the people as material to be shaped.
Personification	"That Tiber trembled underneath her banks" (Marullus, Scene 1)	The river itself remembers the shout for Pompey; the past adoration is made physical so that present forgetting looks like a betrayal of nature.
Anaphora (repeated opening)	"And do you now put on your best attire? / And do you now cull out a holiday?" (Marullus, Scene 1; 'cull out' = pick out)	Each repeated 'And do you now' adds a count to the charge sheet; accusation gathers weight through rhythm.
Extended metaphor (falconry)	"These growing feathers plucked from Caesar's wing / Will make him fly an ordinary pitch" (Flavius, Scene 1)	Caesar becomes a bird whose flight must be clipped; the image of a man rising above other men is planted for the Colossus to inherit.
Metaphor of the mirror	"I, your glass, / Will modestly discover to yourself" (Cassius, Scene 2)	Manipulation disguised as a favour: Cassius claims only to reflect Brutus, while in fact he draws the picture.
Classical allusion	"I, as Aeneas, our great ancestor, / Did from the flames of Troy upon his shoulder / The old Anchises bear" (Cassius, Scene 2)	Cassius casts himself as Rome's founding hero and Caesar as the helpless old father he carried; the allusion reverses the public ranking of the two men.
Simile	"he doth stride the narrow world / Like a Colossus, and we petty men / Walk under his huge legs" (Cassius, Scene 2)	Scale is the argument: Caesar is monstrous, every other Roman shrunk; the simile makes envy feel like measurement.
Antithesis	"The fault, dear Brutus, is not in our stars, / But in ourselves" (Cassius, Scene 2)	Balances fate against responsibility and comes down on the side of action; the play's central debate in a single line.
Dramatic irony	"for always I am Caesar" followed by "Come on my right hand, for this ear is deaf" (Caesar, Scene 2)	The boast of permanence is undercut within two lines by a bodily defect; the audience sees the gap between image and man that Caesar cannot.

Device	Example (speaker, scene)	Effect
Metaphor of eating	"Upon what meat doth this our Caesar feed / That he is grown so great?" and "chew upon this" (Cassius and Brutus, Scene 2)	Power and thought are both made into digestion: Caesar has fed on Rome, and Brutus must now chew on Cassius's words.
Imagery of disease	"No, Caesar hath it not; but you and I / And honest Casca, we have the falling sickness." (Cassius, Scene 2)	A bitter pun: Caesar's epilepsy becomes Rome's political sickness, the 'falling' of free men who bow.
Animal imagery	"he would not be a wolf / But that he sees the Romans are but sheep; / He were no lion, were not Romans hinds." (Cassius, Scene 3; 'hinds' = female deer)	The tyrant is made by the servility of his victims; the blame is shifted from Caesar onto Rome, which is exactly what Cassius needs Casca to feel.
Metaphor of alchemy	"His countenance, like richest alchemy, / Will change to virtue and to worthiness." (Casca, Scene 3)	Brutus's reputation is a chemical that turns crime into virtue; the conspirators themselves admit that their honour is borrowed.

CROSS-REFERENCE The full bank

This table holds fifteen entries chosen for their connective power. 'The Act 1 Literary-Device Bank' gives the complete stock, with more examples of each device and with the prose-verse contrast, soliloquy and the storm's pathetic fallacy treated at length.

4. The Foreshadowing Ledger

Foreshadowing is not a decoration in this play; it is its structural principle. Act 1 is a ledger of debts that the later acts pay. Learn the seeds here and every later payoff will feel earned rather than sudden — and in an Acts 3 to 5 examination, the ability to say 'this was planted in Act 1' is one of the clearest signs of a student who knows the whole play.

TEXT NOTE How later-act lines are printed

This book verifies Act 1 word for word against two editions; it does not verify Acts 2 to 5. Later-act lines in the ledger are therefore given in single quotation marks as reference points from the standard text, not as certified quotations. Before you quote any of them in an examination, check the wording in your own prescribed edition.

Act 1 seed (verified)	Where in Act 1	Payoff later in the play	What to notice
"Beware the ides of March."	The Soothsayer to Caesar, early in Scene 2	On the morning of the assassination Caesar reminds the Soothsayer that the ides have come and is told they have not yet gone (Act 3 Scene 1); Brutus later calls the civil war 'the work the ides of March begun' (Act 5 Scene 1).	The warning is dismissed as a dream and returns as history; the whole play unfolds inside its span.
The crowd celebrates Caesar and is scolded into silence	Scene 1, the commoners before the tribunes	The Forum crowd swings from Brutus to Antony within one scene (Act 3 Scene 2) and tears Cinna the poet apart for his name (Act 3 Scene 3).	Scene 1 is a rehearsal of Act 3 Scene 2: the same people, the same reversibility, a far higher cost.

Act 1 seed (verified)	Where in Act 1	Payoff later in the play	What to notice
"Marullus and Flavius, for pulling scarves off Caesar's images, are put to silence."	Casca's report, late in Scene 2	Caesar's ruthlessness toward dissent becomes the conspirators' justification; and the price of opposing power openly is shown before anyone proposes opposing it secretly.	The tribunes tried the lawful, public version of resistance; the conspiracy is the unlawful, private version.
"this ear is deaf"; "he hath the falling sickness"; "As a sick girl"	Caesar and Cassius, Scene 2	The Caesar who calls himself constant as the northern star (Act 3 Scene 1) is stabbed moments later; the body fails the image completely.	Every reminder of Caesar's body in Act 1 prepares the audience to see a man, not a god, fall.
"I will this night / In several hands in at his windows throw"	Cassius's soliloquy, end of Scene 2	Brutus receives and reads the forged letters in his orchard and takes them as Rome's voice (Act 2 Scene 1).	The noblest decision in the play is built partly on a lie; the conspiracy's claim to honour is compromised at its root.
"Caesar doth bear me hard, but he loves Brutus."	Cassius's soliloquy, end of Scene 2	Caesar's dying words are addressed to Brutus (Act 3 Scene 1); Antony calls Brutus's the most unkind cut (Act 3 Scene 2).	The love Cassius names as his tool is the love whose betrayal makes the murder a tragedy rather than a coup.
"Cassius from bondage will deliver Cassius."	Cassius to Casca, Scene 3	Cassius dies by his own hand at Philippi (Act 5 Scene 3), with the sword that struck Caesar.	The Stoic boast of Scene 3 is kept literally; Cassius is the one character whose Act 1 promise about himself proves exactly true.
"His countenance, like richest alchemy, / Will change to virtue and to worthiness."	Casca to Cassius, end of Scene 3	Brutus insists the conspirators be sacrificers rather than butchers (Act 2 Scene 1); Antony's funeral oration turns 'honourable men' into an accusation (Act 3 Scene 2).	The alchemy works for one act; Antony reverses the chemical reaction in public.
"I do lack some part / Of that quick spirit that is in Antony." and "He loves no plays, / As thou dost, Antony"	Brutus and Caesar, Scene 2	The pleasure-loving Antony becomes the play's most dangerous orator and a triumvir (Act 3 Scene 2 onward).	Act 1 teaches the audience to underrate Antony exactly as the conspirators do.
"Would he were fatter! But I fear him not."	Caesar to Antony, Scene 2	Caesar reads Cassius correctly and still walks to the Senate, flattered there by Decius Brutus (Act 2 Scene 2).	Insight without action is Caesar's fatal pattern; he sees the knife and refuses to seem to see it.
The storm and the prodigies	Casca and Cassius, Scene 3	Calpurnia's dream and the priests' warnings (Act 2 Scene 2); Caesar's ghost (Act 4 Scene 3); Cassius abandoning his scepticism before Philippi (Act 5 Scene 1).	The supernatural enters in Scene 3 as weather and ends as a visitor; signs are ignored, misread, and finally believed too late.
"Comes Caesar to the Capitol tomorrow?" and "Repair to Pompey's Porch"	Cicero and Cassius, Scene 3	Caesar is killed at the Capitol in the play, and Antony reminds the crowd that he fell at the base of Pompey's statue (Act 3 Scene 2).	Shakespeare moves the historical murder to the Capitol but keeps Pompey close: Caesar dies under the gaze of the rival whose blood Marullus mentioned in Scene 1.
"Brutus had rather be a villager / Than to repute himself a son of Rome"	Brutus to Cassius, Scene 2	Brutus tells the Forum that he loved Rome more than he loved Caesar (Act 3 Scene 2).	The public speech of Act 3 is the private sentence of Act 1 said aloud.

Act 1 seed (verified)	Where in Act 1	Payoff later in the play	What to notice
"Set honour in one eye and death i' th' other"	Brutus to Cassius, Scene 2	Brutus chooses death over capture at Philippi (Act 5 Scene 5).	Brutus states the terms of his own ending before the conspiracy has even been named to him.
"However he puts on this tardy form."	Cassius on Casca, Scene 2	Casca strikes the first blow in the Senate (Act 3 Scene 1).	The 'tardy' cynic of Act 1 is the quickest hand in Act 3; Cassius's judgement of men is sound.

5. The Character Relationship Map

Relationships in Act 1 are never mutual: A sees B in a way B does not know. That asymmetry is the engine of the plot, because the person who sees more manipulates the person who sees less. Read this map as a set of one-way arrows, and notice how many of them point at Brutus.

Who	Sees whom	How they see them	Key line (Act 1)
Caesar	Antony	A trusted instrument and companion in pleasure	"He loves no plays, / As thou dost, Antony; he hears no music"
Caesar	Cassius	A thinker, a watcher, the one man to fear	"He reads much, / He is a great observer, and he looks / Quite through the deeds of men."
Caesar	The Soothsayer	An irrelevance	"He is a dreamer. Let us leave him. Pass."
Caesar	Himself	A public institution rather than a man	"for always I am Caesar"
Antony	Cassius	Harmless, a gentleman	"He is a noble Roman, and well given."
Cassius	Caesar	A frail man wrongly made a god; later, filth given light	"'Tis true, this god did shake." and "So vile a thing as Caesar!"
Cassius	Brutus	Noble, and therefore workable	"Thy honourable mettle may be wrought / From that it is disposed." ('wrought' = shaped)
Cassius	Casca	Slow, but useful	"You are dull, Casca" and later "one incorporate / To our attempts"
Cassius	The Roman people	Sheep who make their own wolf	"he sees the Romans are but sheep"
Brutus	Caesar	Loved, and feared as a future king	"I would not, Cassius, yet I love him well."
Brutus	Cassius	A friend whose love he trusts and whose aim he half-guesses	"That you do love me, I am nothing jealous. / What you would work me to, I have some aim." ('aim' = guess)
Brutus	Casca	A schoolfellow grown blunt	"He was quick mettle when he went to school."
Brutus	Himself	A man divided	"poor Brutus, with himself at war"
Casca	Caesar	A performer who wanted the crown he refused	"he would fain have had it" ('fain' = gladly)
Casca	The crowd	A stinking, applauding audience	"the tag-rag people"
Casca	Brutus	The face that will make crime look like virtue	"he sits high in all the people's hearts"
Casca	Cicero	Incomprehensible, and mocked for it	"it was Greek to me"

Who	Sees whom	How they see them	Key line (Act 1)
Cicero	The omens	Signs that men read to suit themselves	"men may construe things after their fashion"
The tribunes	The commoners	Ungrateful matter	"You blocks, you stones"
The tribunes	Caesar	A bird that must be kept from soaring	"Who else would soar above the view of men"
Cinna	Brutus	The prize the faction still lacks	"if you could / But win the noble Brutus to our party"
The commoners	Caesar	A reason for a holiday	"we make holiday to see Caesar and to rejoice in his triumph"

Three observations turn this map into an argument. First, Caesar sees Cassius clearly and Brutus not at all; the play's tragedy runs through that blind spot. Second, everyone who looks at Brutus sees a resource: Cassius sees mettle to be wrought, Casca sees alchemy, Cinna sees a party incomplete without him. Nobody in Act 1 sees Brutus as a friend to be protected from what is coming. Third, the only character who sees the act of seeing itself is Cicero, and he is the one man the conspirators will later leave out.

6. The Scene Connection Spine

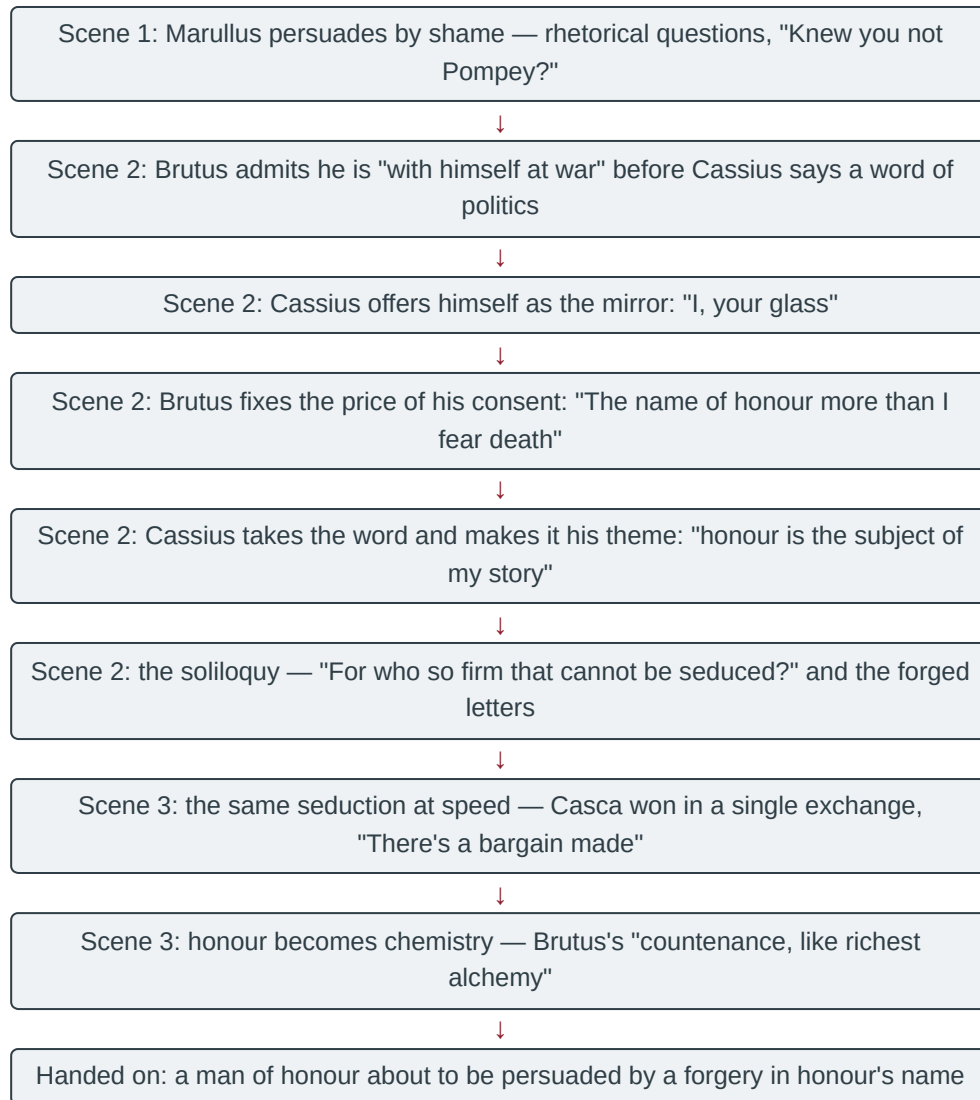
Four threads run the whole length of Act 1. Each chain below follows one thread from its first appearance to the point where Act 1 hands it on to the rest of the play. If you can reproduce these four chains from memory, you know the architecture of the act; the essay in Part B explains why the architecture is shaped this way.

Thread 1 — Power and public image.



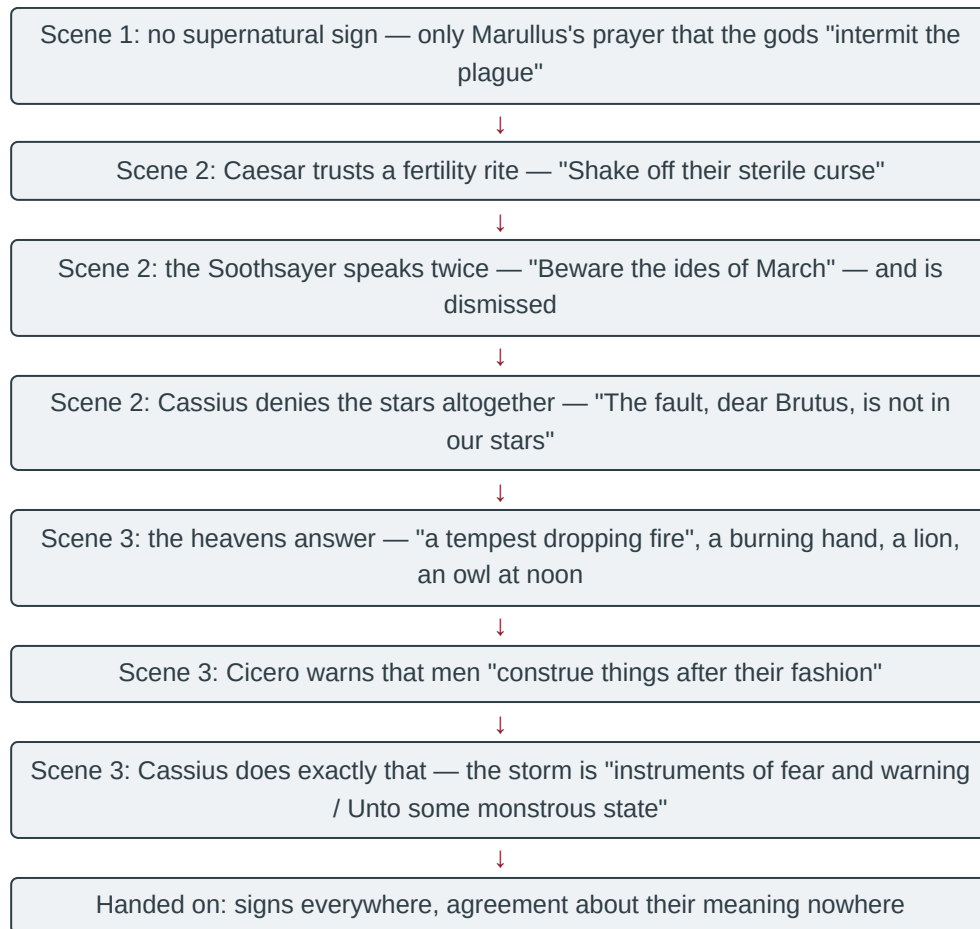
The thread's logic is that Caesar's image grows louder as the evidence against it accumulates. The audience never meets a Caesar who is simply great; every appearance is framed by someone else's fear, envy or contempt, and every boast is paired with a frailty.

Thread 2 — Persuasion and honour.



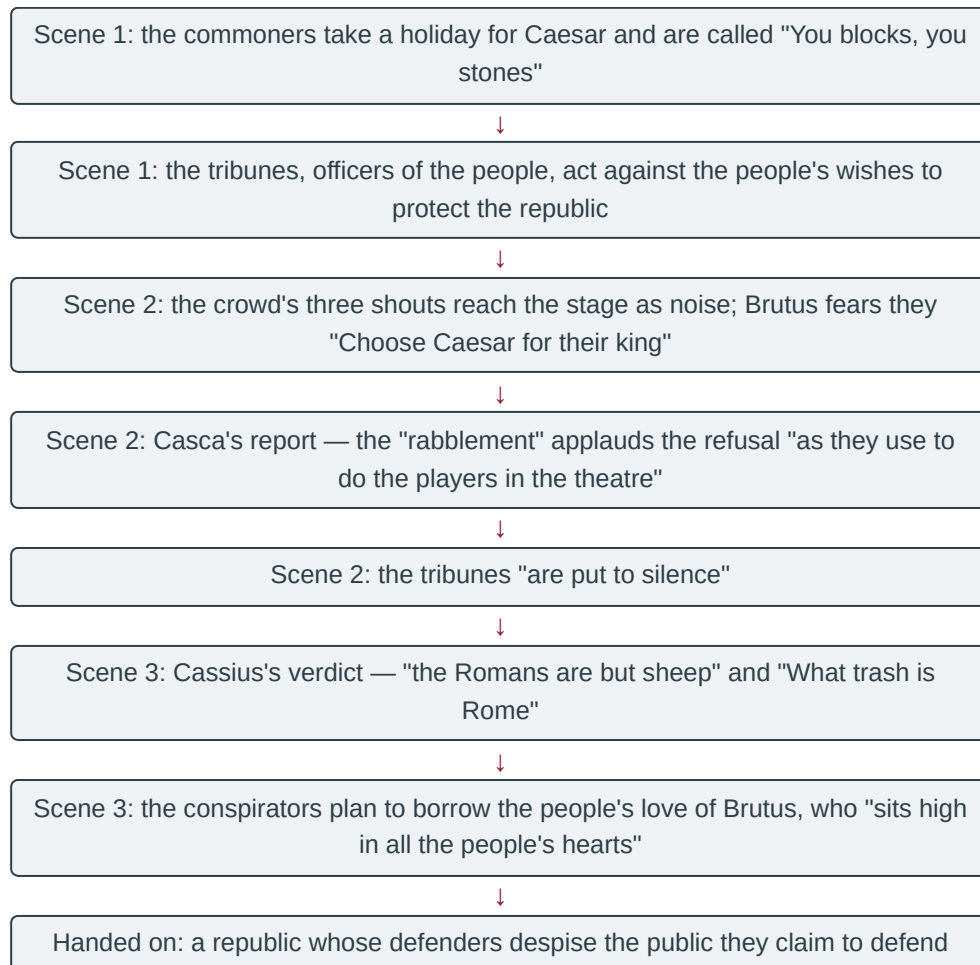
Persuasion in Act 1 always works by finding what the listener already values and returning it to him in a new shape. Marullus returns the crowd's love of Pompey as guilt; Cassius returns Brutus's honour as a duty to act; and Cassius returns Casca's fear as a question of manhood.

Thread 3 — Omens and fate.



Notice the reversal at the centre of the thread. In Scene 2 the man who denies fate is Cassius; in Scene 3 the man who insists the storm has a meaning is also Cassius. The play is not asking whether omens are true. It is showing that omens are used, and that the user changes his philosophy to fit his purpose.

Thread 4 — Crowd and republic.



This is the thread ICSE students most often miss, because it lives between the lines. The men who speak for liberty in Act 1 — the tribunes, Cassius, Casca — have nothing but contempt for the people whose liberty they invoke. That contradiction is the republican cause's hidden weakness, and Act 3 will expose it in the Forum.

ICSE EXAM BOX How the map earns marks in a Class X paper

Exam-oriented advice. Be clear about the syllabus: Act 1 is prescribed for Class IX and is examined in school; the Class X board paper sets its drama extracts from Acts III, IV and V. Nothing in this chapter should be revised as if an Act 1 extract will appear on the board paper. But the Class X paper assumes Act 1 constantly. A sub-question that asks why Brutus joined the conspiracy, what Cassius's motives were, why Caesar ignored warnings, why the crowd is so easily turned, or what a phrase like 'the work the ides of March begun' refers to, is an Act 1 question wearing Act 3 to 5 clothing. The Foreshadowing Ledger is the tool for such moments: find the seed, name the scene, and quote a short verified phrase. Use the Class IX-style extract practice in 'Extract-Based Training (Part One)' and '(Part Two)' for Act 1 itself, and 'ICSE Examiner Mode: How Marks Are Earned' for the marking logic.

PART B — What Shakespeare Is Doing: The Dramatic Architecture of Act 1

The Shape of the Descent

A first-time reader experiences Act 1 as three scenes. A director experiences it as a single movement with eight stations, each darker and more private than the last. The chain below is that movement. Read it once as a list; then read the analysis that follows, which explains every transition and why each is placed where it is.



Transition by Transition

From public celebration to political discontent. The very first word of the play is "Hence!" — an order to disperse. Shakespeare shows a celebration only in the act of breaking it up. We never see the triumph itself: no chariot, no captives, no laurel; we see men in their "best apparel" being asked why they are not at work. This is a deliberate refusal. A lesser dramatist would open with Caesar's procession and let the audience share the crowd's excitement. Shakespeare opens with the excitement already under attack, so that the audience meets the celebration and the objection to it at the same moment and has to choose. And notice who objects: not aristocrats, but tribunes, the officers whose whole constitutional purpose was to protect the plebeians. The play's first political paradox is that the people's guardians are furious with the people. **Literary interpretation:** the discontent is dramatised as a quarrel about clothing and trade — "Where is thy leather apron and thy rule?" — because Shakespeare wants politics to arrive as something ordinary and bodily before it becomes something spoken in verse.

From discontent to fear of power. Marullus's speech looks backward, to Pompey; Flavius's closing speech looks forward, and this is the shift that matters. The tribunes are not angry about anything Caesar has done. They are afraid of what he *would* do: "Who else would soar above the view of men / And keep us all in servile

fearfulness." The crime the whole conspiracy will punish is, from its first statement, a hypothetical one, expressed in the conditional mood. When Brutus in his orchard reasons that Caesar may change once crowned, he is repeating the grammar of Flavius. Shakespeare plants that grammar in the mouths of two minor officials so that the audience has already accepted the argument's shape before the great men make it. The falconry image also fixes the act's vertical geometry: high against low, soaring against ordinary, one man against all. Every later picture of Caesar — the Colossus with "petty men" beneath, the lion in the Capitol — will be a variation on the height Flavius wants to clip.

From fear of power to Caesar's public image. Caesar has been talked about for an entire scene before he appears, and when he does appear his first word is not a statement but a name: "Calpurnia." This is a man whose speech is command. He speaks of himself in the third person — "Caesar is turned to hear" — as though he were quoting an institution. And the first thing he does is arrange a fertility rite for a childless marriage. Shakespeare gives us, in a dozen lines, a public figure of total authority whose one visible anxiety is that he has no heir: the god is worried about his body. Then the Soothsayer speaks. Caesar asks to see the man's face, hears the warning a second time, and pronounces judgement: "He is a dreamer. Let us leave him. Pass."

Literary interpretation: the dismissal is not stupidity. It is the public image doing what a public image must do — refuse, in front of the press of people, to be seen to fear. Caesar cannot afford to look afraid of a voice from the crowd, and so he must pass. The audience, which knows the date on which this play ends, watches the image win a small victory over the man at exactly the moment it should have lost.

From Caesar's public image to Cassius's private resentment. The stage direction is the whole transition: 'All but Brutus and Cassius exit'. The procession, the music, the crowd and Caesar all leave, and for the first time the play is quiet enough for two men to talk. Offstage, the celebration continues, and its shouts reach the stage as interruptions — "What means this shouting?" — so that the public world is present as sound while the private world speaks. What Cassius offers is a counter-portrait of the man who has just left. The Tiber swim in which "Caesar cried 'Help me, Cassius, or I sink!'"; the fever in Spain in which "this god did shake"; the tongue that cried for drink "As a sick girl". Shakespeare has placed the public Caesar and the private Caesar back to back, in the same scene, in the same hour, and asked the audience to hold both. But he has also made the witness unreliable: Cassius's evidence is soaked in envy, in the outrage of a man who "must bend his body / If Caesar carelessly but nod on him". The audience is therefore given two Caesars and two reasons to distrust each portrait — which is exactly the condition of political judgement in the real world.

From Cassius's resentment to Brutus's moral conflict. It is essential to see that Brutus's conflict does not begin with Cassius. Before Cassius has said anything political, Brutus has described himself as "with himself at war", vexed by "passions of some difference", turning "the trouble of my countenance / Merely upon myself". Cassius does not create the conflict; he supplies it with a vocabulary and a direction. The pivot of the whole play is one small word in one short line: "I would not, Cassius, yet I love him well." Everything before the word *yet* belongs to the republic; everything after it belongs to friendship; and the tragedy is the distance between the two halves of that sentence. Shakespeare then does something structurally bold: he ends the scene not on Brutus's uncertainty but on Cassius's certainty. The soliloquy tells the audience what Brutus does not know — that the letters will be forged, that Cassius has judged Brutus's "honourable mettle may be wrought". The audience now knows more than the play's most honourable man. That superior knowledge, held from the end of Scene 2 to the orchard scene, is the source of the dramatic irony that makes Brutus's deliberations so painful to watch.

From Brutus's conflict to supernatural omens. Between Scene 2 and Scene 3 a month passes without a word of explanation; the sun that shone on the Lupercal goes down on the night before the ides. The moral disorder that has so far been confined to one man's mind is now written across the sky: "a civil strife in heaven", fire in the streets, a slave's hand burning "Like twenty torches joined", "the bird of night" screaming at noon. **Literary interpretation:** many critics read the storm as the externalising of Brutus's inner war and of

Rome's political sickness — nature falling out of order as the state prepares to. The text leaves open whether the gods are really speaking. What the text does not leave open is that the characters disagree about how to read them. Cicero, the one man in the act who thinks about thinking, gives the play its most intelligent sentence on interpretation: "men may construe things after their fashion, / Clean from the purpose of the things themselves." Then he leaves, and Cassius walks on to prove him right. The storm becomes, in Cassius's mouth, a portrait of one man, "Most like this dreadful night", and a divine endorsement of what Cassius already intended to do.

From omens to political conspiracy. The last movement is the fastest. Scene 3 replays the seduction of Brutus in a compressed and cruder key. Where Cassius spent a hundred lines on Brutus's honour, he spends a few dozen on Casca's manhood — "Our yoke and sufferance show us womanish" — and wins him with a handshake: "Hold. My hand." Then the circle widens by name: Cinna arrives; Metellus Cimber, Decius Brutus and Trebonius are already waiting; there is a meeting place, "Pompey's Porch", a set of letters, a target and a deadline. The conspiracy that did not exist as an organisation when the act opened now has members, logistics and a plan. And it closes not on Caesar, whom the Senate will crown "tomorrow", but on the man it still lacks: "For it is after midnight, and ere day / We will awake him and be sure of him."

Why the Progression Works

The eight stations would be effective in almost any order; what makes them overwhelming in this order is a set of alternations that Shakespeare keeps running underneath the plot. Each alternation is a rhythm, and rhythm is how a dramatist controls an audience's attention without the audience noticing.

Public and private. Act 1 breathes in and out. Scene 1 is wholly public: a street, a crowd, officials. Scene 2 begins public — procession, music, the people "in the press" — then empties to two men, then fills again as Caesar's train returns, then empties to three, then to one. Scene 3 is private throughout: night, a deserted street, conversations held in twos and threes, a meeting arranged behind a portico. The act moves from a public square in daylight to a whispered plan after midnight, and the alternation inside Scene 2 trains the audience to feel that the private conversations are where the truth is spoken and the public moments are where it is hidden. That training pays off in Act 3, where the Forum, the most public space in the play, becomes the place where truth is manufactured.

Day and night. Scenes 1 and 2 take place under one sun; Scene 3 under thunder. Shakespeare could have set the conspiracy's formation by daylight, as Plutarch's conspirators certainly met by day. He chose the night before the ides because night licenses two things the plot needs: the supernatural, which cannot be staged convincingly at noon, and secrecy, which turns a political grievance into a plot. Cassius's line that the night is "A very pleasing night to honest men" is the act's darkest joke, and it depends on the audience feeling the change of light.

Prose and verse. In Scene 1 the commoners speak prose and the tribunes verse; the social hierarchy is audible before it is explained. In Scene 2 Casca's report of the crown-offering is in prose while everything around it is verse, so his cynicism sounds like a different medium breaking into the play — gossip cutting across poetry. Then in Scene 3 the same Casca speaks verse. **Literary interpretation:** one strong reading is that the storm lifts him into the register of the men he is about to join; another is that Shakespeare simply needed the scene's terror to be spoken in verse. Either way, the student who notices that Casca changes medium between the two scenes has noticed something an examiner rarely sees mentioned.

Crowd and individual. The act begins with a crowd and ends with a name. Scene 1 gives us the people in the plural — "you idle creatures", "you blocks, you stones"; Scene 2 lets the crowd become sound only, three shouts heard offstage and then described by a man who despised them; Scene 3 has no crowd at all, only "a

hundred ghastly women" in a report and a handful of conspirators in the dark. As the crowd fades, the individual sharpens, until the whole political world of Rome has narrowed to a single question about a single man. The play will reverse this in Act 3, when the individual is killed and the crowd returns to judge.

The delayed appearance of Caesar. Caesar is named in the second line of the play and does not enter until the second scene. By then the audience has heard him praised by the Cobbler, denounced by Marullus, feared by Flavius, and seen his statues threatened. When he finally speaks, he speaks fewer than thirty lines before leaving again. The delay turns Caesar into the object of everybody's speech and the subject of nobody's — a man defined by descriptions. This is the technique of the whole play: Caesar is present for a fraction of it, and the fraction is small enough that the audience judges him mostly through other people's words. The delayed entrance is the first lesson in how to watch him.

Reported action. The most important public event in Act 1, the offering and refusal of the coronet, happens offstage and reaches us through Casca. Shakespeare had every means to stage it; he chose report. The choice does three things at once. It keeps Caesar's public triumph out of the audience's eyes, so that our image of it is Casca's contemptuous one — "mere foolery" — rather than our own. It makes the crowd's applause into something described rather than shared, so that we cannot be swept along with it. And it puts the act of interpreting Caesar at the centre of the scene: Casca's "to my thinking, he would fain have had it" is not a fact about Caesar but a judgement, and the audience must decide whether to trust it. Even the tribunes' punishment is reported, in a single sentence — "are put to silence" — so that the price of opposing Caesar arrives as news rather than as spectacle.

The widening circle. Count the opposition as the act proceeds. Two tribunes in Scene 1, acting alone, and silenced by the end of Scene 2. Two friends in Scene 2, one of whom has not yet agreed to anything. Three men in Scene 3 once Casca gives his hand, then four with Cinna, then the names of Metellus Cimber, Decius Brutus and Trebonius waiting at Pompey's Porch, then "Some certain of the noblest-minded Romans" whose number is never given. The structure is a stone dropped in water: the rings widen and the water darkens. By the last speech the audience is not watching a grievance but an organisation.

The closing line. "We will awake him and be sure of him." The last line of Act 1 is a promise about the future, in the first person plural, about a man who is asleep. Every element is doing work. 'We' — the conspiracy now has a collective voice. 'Awake' — Brutus is literally sleeping while his fate is arranged, and figuratively must be woken to a duty the others have decided he has. 'Be sure of him' — certainty is what the plotters need and what Brutus, "with himself at war", has never had. The act ends on the gap between the plotters' confidence and the audience's knowledge that this particular certainty will be bought with forged letters.

PROFESSOR'S INSIGHT Why Act 1 ends on Brutus, not Caesar

The last proper name spoken in Act 1 is Brutus — "See Brutus at his house" — and the final four lines are entirely about him, though they never name him again: he is *him*, three times, the object of every verb. Caesar, by contrast, is last mentioned as a man the Senate "Mean to establish" as king "tomorrow"; he has become an event on a calendar. **Literary interpretation:** the play bears Caesar's name, but Act 1 tells us with its final breath who the drama is about. Caesar's death is a midpoint; Brutus's decision is the action, and it is his decision, not the assassination, that Act 1 has been engineering from Cassius's first "Brutus, I do observe you now of late." There is a further irony that only a reader of the historical record catches. Plutarch tells us that anonymous messages urged the real Brutus to wake — that he was accused of sleeping while Rome needed him. Shakespeare turns that historical graffiti into Cassius's forged letters, and then gives Cassius the word 'awake' at the very moment he plans to deliver them. The act closes on a sleeping man who is about to be woken by a lie in the name of Rome, and the audience alone knows both halves of that sentence.

PROFESSOR'S INSIGHT Why nothing happens in Act 1 and yet everything is decided

List the events of Act 1 as a newspaper would: a holiday is broken up; a coronet is refused; a man faints; two officials are removed from office; there is a storm; some friends talk. No one dies, no one fights, no law is passed, no crown is worn. Judged by deeds, the act is almost empty. Judged by decisions, it is the fullest act in the play. Caesar decides to dismiss the Soothsayer. Brutus decides, in the only sentence that matters, that he "would not" have Caesar king. Cassius decides to forge letters. Casca decides to give his hand. The Senate, we are told, has decided to offer a crown "tomorrow". The date is fixed, the place is fixed, the target of persuasion is chosen and the method of persuasion is settled. **Literary**

interpretation: Shakespeare has written an act composed almost entirely of speech acts — promises, warnings, oaths, dismissals, seductions — because the real event of this tragedy is not the killing but the deciding, and deciding happens in words. By the time the daggers appear in Act 3, they are only carrying out what Act 1 has already spoken. This is why a student who knows Act 1 well can explain Acts 3 to 5 with authority: the later acts execute; Act 1 chooses.

Reading the Architecture in Five Levels**LEVEL 1 — What happened?**

Three scenes on two days a month apart. A holiday crowd is dispersed by tribunes who resent Caesar's triumph. Caesar dismisses a prophet's warning, is offered a coronet three times offstage and refuses it, faints, and is described by Cassius to Brutus as a frail man wrongly made a god. Brutus admits he would not have Caesar king. Cassius plans forged letters. A month later, on a night of omens, Casca joins Cassius's faction, Cinna is sent with the letters, and the conspirators plan to secure Brutus before dawn.

LEVEL 2 — What does it mean?

The act shows a republic whose defenders fear a future tyranny more than any present crime, and whose people love the very man those defenders fear. It shows that Caesar's greatness is a public image maintained by refusing to seem afraid, and that the image is held together over a failing body. It shows that honour can be turned into a lever, that omens are read to suit the reader, and that a conspiracy needs a good man's face more than it needs another dagger.

LEVEL 3 — Why did Shakespeare write it this way?

Because he wanted the audience to judge Caesar through other people's words before seeing him; to feel the political argument as something ordinary before hearing it as poetry; to be given superior knowledge over Brutus so that the orchard scene would hurt; and to experience the conspiracy's growth as a descent from noon to midnight, from square to portico, from crowd to individual. The order of the eight stations is a machine for turning a spectator into an anxious participant.

LEVEL 4 — How does it connect to the whole play?

Every mechanism of the later acts is demonstrated here in small: the crowd's reversibility (Act 3 Scene 2), the misreading of signs (Act 2 Scene 2, Act 5), persuasion by mirror (Brutus's orchard soliloquy, Antony's oration), the gap between Caesar's image and his body (Act 3 Scene 1), and honour as a political chemical that Antony will reverse. The tribunes' failed public resistance is the model the conspirators reject in favour of secrecy; Cassius's Stoic boast and Brutus's honour-or-death sentence are the terms of their deaths at Philippi.

LEVEL 5 — How do I use it in an ICSE answer?

Act 1 will not appear as a board extract; it appears inside the reasons an Act 3 to 5 extract asks for. When a sub-question asks 'why', trace the motive to its Act 1 seed, name the scene, and prove it with a short verified phrase: Cassius's envy through "this god did shake", Brutus's divided loyalty through "yet I love him well", Caesar's fatal pride through "for always I am Caesar", the crowd's fickleness through "You blocks, you stones". One seed, one scene, one quotation, one theme — that is a full analysis mark earned in three sentences.

THE PLAY IN MINIATURE: How Act 1 Already Contains the Whole Tragedy

There is a way of reading Act 1 in which it is not the beginning of the play but a small complete version of it. Look at the pattern of the act as a pattern rather than a story: a warning is ignored; a friend is seduced; a lie is told in a good cause; a bond is made in the dark. Now watch that same four-beat pattern repeat, enlarged, across the rest of the tragedy.

The ignored warning of Scene 2 — "Beware the ides of March" waved away with "He is a dreamer" — becomes Calpurnia's dream and the priests' sacrifice waved away in Act 2 Scene 2, then Artemidorus's letter unread at the Senate door in Act 3, and finally, on the other side, Cassius at Philippi doubting his own philosophy of signs too late. The play's people never stop being warned and never stop deciding what the warning means according to what they already want; Cicero's sentence about construing things "after their fashion" is the tragedy's epigraph, spoken in its first act by a man who will be left out of everything.

The seduced friend of Scene 2 becomes the seduced crowd of Act 3 Scene 2. The technique is the same: Cassius offers to be Brutus's "glass" and shows him a Brutus he did not know; Antony offers the crowd Caesar's will and shows them a Caesar they had forgotten loving. In both cases the persuader claims merely to reveal, and in both cases the revelation has been arranged. And in both cases the persuaded party believes it has reached its own conclusion — Brutus in his orchard, the crowd in the Forum — which is the mark of a manipulation that has succeeded.

The good lie of Scene 2 — the letters thrown "in at his windows" so that Rome may seem to speak — becomes the whole moral problem of the conspiracy: a killing that must be presented as a sacrifice, hands washed in blood as a ceremony, an assassination described to the people as a liberation. Casca's "richest alchemy" names the chemistry exactly: the conspiracy needs Brutus not for his dagger but for his reputation, and reputation is a public appearance. The tragedy of Brutus is that he becomes the honourable face of an act whose first step was a forgery he never saw through.

The bond in the dark — "Hold. My hand." and "There's a bargain made" — becomes the oath Brutus refuses to swear in Act 2 and the quarrel of Act 4, in which the bargain between Brutus and Cassius comes apart. Act 1 shows a faction forming by handshake; the later acts show that a faction held together by one man's honour and another man's grievance cannot survive success.

Finally, the act's deepest structure is the split between Caesar's image and Caesar's body, and this is the shape of the tragedy as a whole. In Act 1 the gap is small and comic: a deaf ear, a fever, a faint in the marketplace. In Act 3 the gap is the play: the man who claims to be constant as a star is a body on the floor within a hundred lines. And then something Act 1 could not show happens — the image survives the body. Caesar dead is more powerful than Caesar alive; his ghost walks, his name wins Philippi, and the republicans who killed a man discover that they could not kill an idea. Act 1 gave the audience two Caesars and asked which was real. The rest of the play answers: the one that outlived the other.

A LAST WORD TO THE STUDENT

You began this book as someone who found Shakespeare's English difficult and his politics remote. If you have worked through the twenty chapters before this one, you now own Act 1 in a way most students never own any act of any play: word by word, motive by motive, seed by seed. Here is how to carry it forward.

Do not carry it as a summary. Carry it as a set of causes. Every time Acts 3 to 5 show you an effect — Brutus's hesitation, Cassius's bitterness, Caesar's fatal walk to the Senate, the crowd's turn, the ghost, the two suicides — ask which Act 1 seed produced it, and answer in a sentence with a verified phrase attached. That habit turns a memory of the plot into an understanding of the design, and design is what the highest marks reward.

Be honest with yourself about the examination. Act 1 is the Class IX portion; the Class X board paper draws its extracts from Acts III, IV and V. You will not be asked to explain the Cobbler's puns in the board hall. But you will be asked, in some form, why these people did what they did, and there is no answer to that question that does not run through Act 1. The Foreshadowing Ledger and the Scene Connection Spine in this chapter are built for exactly that moment.

And carry one more thing, which no examiner marks. Act 1 is a study of how decent people talk themselves into disaster: by trusting a mirror, by reading the sky for permission, by confusing a grievance with a principle, by needing an honourable face for a dishonourable method. Shakespeare wrote it in 1599 about Rome in 44 BC, and it has not aged a day. You have learnt to read it. That is not a school skill. That is a way of seeing, and it is yours now.

REVISION **The act in ten lines**

1. Scene 1: holiday broken up; the tribunes fear a bird that "would soar above the view of men".
2. Scene 2: Caesar's image — command, third person, "He is a dreamer".
3. Scene 2: Brutus is "with himself at war" before Cassius speaks politics.
4. Scene 2: Cassius as mirror — "I, your glass" — and the honour lever.
5. Scene 2: the private Caesar — "this god did shake"; the coronet refused thrice, reported by Casca.
6. Scene 2: Caesar reads Cassius rightly and does nothing — "for always I am Caesar".
7. Scene 2: soliloquy — "For who so firm that cannot be seduced?"; forged letters planned.
8. Scene 3: the storm; Cicero on construing; Cassius reads the sky as Caesar.
9. Scene 3: Casca's hand, Cinna's errand, Pompey's Porch, the widening circle.
10. Scene 3: "be sure of him" — the act ends on Brutus, asleep, about to be woken by a lie.

CHAPTER 22

Sources, Method and Quality Audit

What this chapter does: it shows you exactly how this book was built and checked, so that you can trust what it says and know where its limits lie. A study book that asks you to quote accurately should itself show its working.

The source hierarchy this book followed

The book was written under a strict order of authority. Where two sources disagreed, the higher one won, and the disagreement is explained rather than hidden.

Priority	Source	How it was used
1	Shakespeare's text of <i>Julius Caesar</i>	Every quotation in this book was checked, by an automated comparison and by human-style re-reading, against two independent public-domain texts: the Folger Shakespeare Library edition and the Globe-edition text (Moby/MIT and Project Gutenberg).
2	The student's prescribed ICSE edition	Not supplied. Editions used in ICSE schools (many based on A. W. Verity's Cambridge text) print the same words with minor spelling differences; this book therefore prints no line numbers and notes name variants (Marullus/Murellus; Calpurnia/Calphurnia).
3	Official CISCE material	The ICSE 2025 Literature in English board paper (structure, instructions, mark allocation) and the CISCE prescribed-books information for the 2027 examination year (Class IX: Acts I and II; Class X: Acts III, IV and V). Assessment skills are described in the Council's own terms (recall, understanding, application, analysis, evaluation) without inventing wording.
4	Academic Shakespeare resources	The Folger Shakespeare Library's edition and introduction; the Internet Shakespeare Editions' text of North's Plutarch; scholarly consensus on date (1599), publication (First Folio, 1623) and source (North's Plutarch, 1579).
5	Roman-history sources	Plutarch's <i>Life of Caesar</i> (in translation), Suetonius as reported in reference works, and modern reference articles on the Roman Republic, the Senate, tribunes, the triumph, the Lupercalia, the Ides, and the lives of Caesar, Pompey, Brutus, Cassius, Antony, Casca, Cinna, Decimus Brutus, Calpurnia and the tribunes Marullus and Flavius.
6	Study guides (LitCharts, SparkNotes, Shakespeare Navigators)	Consulted only to cross-check interpretations and word glosses. Nothing was copied or paraphrased line by line; the analysis, structure and examples in this book are independent.

The four labels

Throughout the book four labels keep different kinds of statement apart:

- **SHAKESPEARE'S TEXT** — what the play actually says.
- **HISTORICAL RECORD** — what ancient sources and modern historians say happened.
- **LITERARY INTERPRETATION** — a reading of the text that reasonable scholars might dispute; the book says so when they do.
- **EXAM-ORIENTED ADVICE** — how to turn understanding into marks; never a prediction of a specific question.

Where the sources disagree, and what the book did

TEXT NOTE Text and history

1. **The tribune's name.** The 1623 Folio prints 'Murellus' in Act 1 Scene 1 and 'Marullus' later; Plutarch has Marullus. Most editions (Folger, Globe) print Marullus; some (Oxford, Arden) keep Murellus. This book uses Marullus and notes the variant.
2. **Caesar's wife.** The Folio and Folger print 'Calphurnia'; the Globe text and most ICSE editions print 'Calpurnia'. This book uses Calpurnia.
3. **How many times the crown was offered.** Plutarch describes Antony offering the diadem twice; Shakespeare's Casca says three times. The book treats the three offers as SHAKESPEARE'S TEXT and Plutarch's two as HISTORICAL RECORD.
4. **Caesar's deafness.** No ancient source records it; scholars treat "this ear is deaf" as Shakespeare's addition. The book never presents it as history.
5. **The site of the assassination.** Historically the Curia of Pompey; Shakespeare's characters speak of the Capitol. The book keeps both clear.
6. **Time.** The triumph (October 45 BC), the tribunes' removal of diadems (January 44 BC) and the Lupercalia (15 February 44 BC) are separate historical events that Shakespeare compresses into a single day; a month then passes silently before Scene 3 (the night before 15 March).
7. **Cassius's motive.** Whether Cassius acts from republican principle, personal envy, or both is a genuine interpretive question; the book presents the range of readings rather than a verdict.
8. **The tragic hero.** Critics disagree whether Brutus or Caesar is the play's tragic centre; the book presents this as an open question.

The honest syllabus position

For the ICSE (Class X) board examination in Literature in English, the prescribed portion of *Julius Caesar* is Acts III, IV and V. Acts I and II belong to Class IX. This book teaches Act 1 because the Class X paper depends on it constantly — motives, foreshadowing, character histories and 'what happened earlier' sub-questions all reach back to it — and because a student who struggled with Act 1 in Class IX cannot read Acts III–V with confidence until that foundation is secure. No question in this book is described as guaranteed, and nothing here predicts the board paper.

Quality audit

The following checks were carried out on the completed book before it was released to you.

Check	Result
All three Act 1 scenes covered	Yes: three dedicated scene chapters (Scene 2 in two parts), each with the twenty-point structure, line-by-line teaching and a revision sheet
Important passages accurately represented	Yes: every Shakespeare quotation in all chapters was compared automatically against the Folger and Globe texts (over 4,000 quotation segments; 0 unmatched)
No invented quotations	Confirmed by the same automated comparison
No invented historical facts	Historical statements were constrained to a verified brief drawn from Plutarch and modern reference works, and were re-checked on the chapters that passed through the adversarial review
No invented line numbers	Confirmed: the book prints no line numbers; a sweep found no line-number references
Shakespearean wording verified	Yes (Folger text, British spellings from the Globe text)
Historical facts separated from dramatic invention	Yes: the four labels are used throughout; compression, the deaf ear, the Capitol, and the three offerings are flagged wherever they appear
Study guides used only as secondary reference	Yes: consulted for cross-checking; nothing copied
Roman history connected to relevant passages	Yes: the history chapter uses the fact → audience → Shakespeare → ICSE chain for every topic
Character motivations analysed	Yes: Caesar, Cassius and Brutus masterclasses plus the supporting-cast chapter
Themes analysed	Yes: twenty-two themes across two chapters
Literary devices explained	Yes: device bank with finder table
Important textual vocabulary identified	Yes: keyword vault (Type A) and vocabulary system
Analytical ICSE keywords identified	Yes: keyword vault (Type B) with weak-to-strong conversions
Cross-scene connections included	Yes: scene connection engine
Future-act connections included	Yes: 'Where Act 1 reappears later'
Extract practice included	Yes: twelve extracts with ICSE-style questions and model answers
Model answers included	Yes, each with 'why this answer earns marks'
Weak vs strong answers included	Yes: examiner-mode chapter and character chapters

Check	Result
Scene revision sheets included	Yes, one per scene
Final master map included	Yes
Adversarial fact-check pass	Completed on the front matter, Roman history, Caesar and Brutus chapters; the remaining chapters passed the automated quotation and consistency checks and were written under the same binding fact brief, but did not receive a second human-style review. Treat an isolated historical detail in those chapters with the ordinary caution you would give any study guide.

A note on limits

- The book quotes short passages only, for analysis and teaching; it does not reproduce the play. Read the scenes themselves in your prescribed edition alongside each chapter.
- Where this book and your prescribed edition differ in a spelling or a comma, follow your edition in the examination room.
- Where an interpretation is labelled as such, you are free to disagree with it in an answer — provided you argue from the text.